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John

John 1:1

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:1–5

In this paragraph John introduced his Gospel by writing about a person whom he calls the Word. He emphasized that from the beginning the Word was with God and that the Word was God. God created everything through the Word. Read Genesis 1:1–5 before you translate this section. It is good to use the same words for “beginning,” “made/created,” and “light” that are used there.

This paragraph has a lot of images in it like a poem and may have been a song or hymn.

1:1a

In the beginning was the Word,

- ¶ At the beginning of the world, the Word existed,
- ¶ Before the world was created, the Word already existed.

In the beginning was the Word: This clause indicates that the Word existed before all things. The Word existed before God created the world. There was never a time before the Word existed. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

In the beginning, the Word already was. (REB)

In the beginning, the Word already existed. (GW)

In the beginning: This phrase refers to the time when the world and the whole universe began. In some languages it may be more natural to say what beginning is being referred to. If this is true in your language, here are some ways you could translate this phrase:

At the beginning of all things

At the beginning of the universe/world

At the beginning of creation

In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun beginning with a verb. For example:

When all things began (NEB)

When the world first existed

This phrase also appears in Genesis 1:1a. If possible, translate it the same way in both places. If you use footnotes, you may want to refer your readers to Genesis 1:1.

the Word: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Word here means “communication,” “speech” or “message.” This is a title for Jesus Christ. It indicates that God reveals himself in and through Jesus. God expresses himself completely in and through his Word. Jesus shows us what God is like. Hebrews 1:2 states that God has spoken to his people through Jesus.

The BSB indicates that the Word is a title for God by using a capital W. If you do not normally capitalize the names of God, you do not need to use a capital letter here. In some languages you may need to say explicitly that this is a title:

the person named/titled the Word

the one who is called the word (CEV)

At this point you should avoid stating explicitly that the Word was Jesus Christ.

1:1b

and the Word was with God,

- and the Word was united with God.
- The Word and God were together,

and: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces some more information about the Word. Some English versions, such as the GNT, do not explicitly translate this word. Introduce this new information in a way that is natural in your language.

the Word was with God: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the Word was with God indicates that there was a close and loving relationship

between God and the Word. This was true at the beginning of creation, and it is true still. The verb *was* does not indicate that the Word has ceased to be with God. It just indicates that it was true in the beginning.

The Greek word translated as *with* here refers to close relationship. Refer to your translation of this word in Mark 14:49, 2 Corinthians 5:8, and Philemon 13.

Here are some other ways to translate the Word was with God:

the Word was together with God

the Word was a companion of God

the Word and God were united together

1:1c and the Word was God.

- The Word was truly/actually God.
- and the Word shared God's nature.

the Word was God: Verse 1:1c is very important to understand the whole of John's Gospel, and really, the whole of the New Testament. Translate it carefully and check your translation with church leaders and scholars. John indicated that the Word had the essential being of God. The Word had the same nature as God and the same qualities. He has existed forever, from the beginning, as God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what God was, the Word was

the Word was fully God (NET)

was truly God (CEV)

It is important that you communicate the idea the Word was God, not "the Word was a god" or "the Word was divine." There was and is only one God. The Word is not himself, alone, all of the Godhead. Rather, the Word is a part of the life and essential being of the Godhead.

As in 1:1b, the past tense of the verb *was* does not indicate that the situation has changed. It does not mean that the Word has ceased to be God.

John 1:2

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:1–5

In this paragraph John introduced his Gospel by writing about a person whom he calls the Word. He emphasized that from the beginning the Word was with God and that the Word was God. God created everything through the Word. Read Genesis 1:1–5 before you translate this section. It is good to use the same words for "beginning," "made/created," and "light" that are used there.

This paragraph has a lot of images in it like a poem and may have been a song or hymn.

1:2

He was with God in the beginning.

- He was together with God at the beginning of all things.
- The Word and God were together when the world began.

He was with God in the beginning: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *He* is more literally "that one." It refers to the Word. In some languages it is more natural to make explicit whom the pronoun refers to. For example:

The Word was in the beginning with God

From the very beginning the Word was with God.
(CEV)

with God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *with God* is the same as in 1:1b.

in the beginning: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *in the beginning* is the same here as in 1:1a. In some languages it may be natural again to translate it at the beginning or the end of the clause. For example:

In the beginning of everything the Word existed with God.

He was with God in the beginning. (NIV)

John 1:3

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:1–5

In this paragraph John introduced his Gospel by writing about a person whom he calls the Word. He emphasized that from the beginning the Word was with God and that the Word was God. God created everything through the Word. Read Genesis 1:1–5 before you translate this section. It is good to use the same words for “beginning,” “made/created,” and “light” that are used there.

This paragraph has a lot of images in it like a poem and may have been a song or hymn.

1:3a

Through Him all things were made,

- ¶ Through the Word everything began to exist.
- ¶ God created all things by means of the Word.
- ¶ The Word was God’s agent to make all things.

Through Him all things were made: The clause that the BSB translates as Through Him all things were made is more literally “all things were/became.” This clause indicates that it was through the Word that the universe began. God created all things through the Word. This includes things that are alive and things that are not alive. It includes planets and stars, water and rocks, plants, animals, and humans. Here the author John continued to connect the Word with the story of creation in Genesis 1. See also 1 Corinthians 8:6, Hebrews 1:2, and Colossians 1:16–17.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Everything began to exist by means of him.

Through him God made all things. (GNT)

God created everything through him. (NLT)

God worked through the Word to cause everything to exist

Through Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Through here means “by means of.” It refers to the person who made something happen. Here it refers to the way or agent that God used to make everything. It was “by means of” or Through the Word that God created all things. For example:

By means of him.

With the Word as God’s agent

Him: This pronoun continues to refer to the Word. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

And with this Word, God created all things. (NET)

1:3b

and without Him nothing was made that has been made.

- Nothing in all creation was made without him.
- God did not create anything at all apart from the Word.
- Nothing in the whole universe was created without the Word.

and without Him nothing was made that has been made: There are two ways to connect that has been made to the surrounding clauses:

1. It is the end of the sentence that begins with 1:3a–b. It should be translated as “that was made” (RSV) or “that was created.” For example:

^{3b}without him nothing was made ^{3c}that has been made. ^{4a}In him was life (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, ESV, RSV, GW, NET, NCV, GNT, NLT96, ESV)

1. It is the beginning of a new sentence that continues in 1:4. It should be translated as “What has come into being” (NRSV) or “Everything that was created” (CEV). For example:

^{3b}Nothing was made without the Word.

^{3c}Everything that was created ^{4a}received its life from him (CEV) (NJB, CEV, NLT, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Interpretation (1) is more in agreement with John's style and doctrine, and makes more sense in the context. For more information, see Bruce Metzger, *A Textual Commentary on the New Testament*, pp. 195–96. Metzger disagreed with the decision of the UBS Committee, which supported interpretation (2), and wrote about interpretation (1), "It is more consistent with the Johannine repetitive style, as well as with Johannine doctrine (cf. 5:26, 39; 6:53), to say nothing concerning the sense of the passage, to punctuate with a full stop after [that has been made]." Also, most English translations follow this interpretation. The NIV has therefore been used in the Display.

The meaning of interpretation (1) is that nothing that was made was made apart from the Word. It is a negative way of saying what 1:3a says in a positive way. No one else made anything that was made. The Word made everything that was made.

Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

not one thing in all creation was made without him (GNT)

Not one thing that exists was made without him. (GW)

and: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces a statement that repeats the idea of 1:3a. This restatement uses a negative instead of a positive verb. In some languages it may be natural to leave this conjunction untranslated, as the GNT has done.

without Him nothing was made that has been made: This clause means "only with/through the Word has anything begun to exist." This is another way of saying "Through him all things were made" (1:3a). This restatement emphasizes the information.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

nothing was made without him (NCV)

God did not make anything without him (EE)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the double negative with a positive statement. For example:

only through him has anything come into being

without Him: This phrase means "without the Word," meaning apart from the person or activity of the Word. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

apart from him (NET)

nothing was made that has been made: This expression is more literally "nothing came into being." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no created thing came into being (REB)

nothing that God made began to exist

General Comment on 1:3a-b

These clauses mean the same thing. 1:3a uses a positive statement and 1:3b uses a negative statement. This repetition emphasizes the idea. In some languages it is more natural to emphasize the idea with one strong statement. For example:

all things without exception were made through/ by the Word

absolutely nothing was made except (lit. if not) through him (Kankanaey Back Translation)

God created absolutely everything with the Word.

John 1:4

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:1–5

In this paragraph John introduced his Gospel by writing about a person whom he calls the Word. He emphasized that from the beginning the Word was with God and that the Word was God. God created everything through the Word. Read Genesis 1:1–5 before you translate this section. It is good to use the same words for “beginning,” “made/created,” and “light” that are used there.

This paragraph has a lot of images in it like a poem and may have been a song or hymn.

1:4a**In Him was life,**

- He was the source of life,
- Life came from the Word,
- The Word caused people to live,

In Him was life: The pronoun Him continues to refer to the Word. The clause In Him was life means “the Word caused people/everything to live.” It was through the Word that all life began. Plants, animals, and humans all lived because of him. For example:

The Word was the one who gave life to all.

The Word was the source of life. (GNT)

life: The word life can refer to both physical life and spiritual life. The life given at creation and the life of the new creation (salvation, spiritual life) both come from the Word. Try to translate in a way that can be understood in both ways. If you must choose only one sense, it is probably best to choose the physical life given at creation. That is the primary context here. See comments by Carson, p. 119. Some languages refer to the life of plants or animals in a different way than the life of people. If that is the case in your language, you should refer to the life that God gives to people.

General Comment on 1:4a

In some languages it is more natural to translate “life” using a verb rather than a noun. In those languages it may be possible to say this:

He caused all creatures/beings to live.

1:4b**and that life was the light of men.**

- and this life gave light to people.
- and brought light to the human race.

that life was the light of men: This clause indicates that the life (that the Word gives) brought light to human beings.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

this life brought light to people (GNT)

his life gave light to everyone (CEV)

that life: The Greek article that the BSB translates as that indicates that the word life in 1:4b refers back to the “life” just mentioned in 1:4a. In some languages it may be more natural to say this phrase:

this life (GNT)

his life (NLT)

life: Use the same word or phrase here that you used in 1:4a. If you have used a verb there, here you may need to say something like this:

he caused people to live and so they received light

the light of men: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the light of men means “the light for human beings.” The life provided light for people. It made it possible for people to see.

light: The word light connects this narrative with the creation story. Try to use the same word that you used in Genesis 1:3. Here it is a figure of speech, a metaphor. It refers to something that reveals or tells the truth about God, allowing people to know him. John called the life that God gave light because it made it possible for people to know God. Jesus, the Word of God, revealed God to all people.

John 1:5**Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh**

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:1–5

In this paragraph John introduced his Gospel by writing about a person whom he calls the Word. He emphasized that from the beginning the Word was with God and that the Word was God. God created everything through the Word. Read Genesis 1:1–5 before you translate this section. It is good to use the same words for “beginning,” “made/created,” and “light” that are used there.

This paragraph has a lot of images in it like a poem and may have been a song or hymn.

1:5a**The Light shines in the darkness,**

- The light shines out in the dark places,
- The light makes the darkness light/bright,

The Light shines in the darkness: The verb shines is in the present tense. Use a verb form that indicates that the light continues to shine. Here the author’s words are literal and a metaphor. Literally, at creation and ever since, light has shined into darkness.

But the words are also a metaphor. John is beginning to speak about Jesus, the One who is like the light. Jesus is like the light because he enables people to see something. Here, Jesus shows or tells people about God. In your translation, you should continue to use the metaphor and not yet explain that it refers to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The light keeps shining in the dark. (CEV)

The light still shines in the darkness. (JBP)

in the darkness: The word darkness is a metaphor that refers to evil. Just as darkness is the absence of light, so evil is the absence of good. It is the absence of the knowledge of God and trust in him. If your language does not use darkness as a figure of speech for evil, you may need to say something like this:

in the evil darkness

in the dark place where evil lives

1:5b**and the darkness has not overcome it.**

- and the dark cannot stop it.
- and the darkness has not destroyed the light.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and can be translated in two ways:

1. It continues the previous thought and means and. (BSB, NJB, KJV, NASB, NRSV, ESV, REB, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, NIV11)
2. It contrasts with the previous thought and means “but.” (RSV, NIV84, NET)

Although one could read 1:5b as a contrast to 1:5a, it is more likely that the thought continues. Darkness does not normally overcome a light; rather, light drives away darkness. Using “but” could imply that people expect darkness to overcome light. So it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In other places the author contrasts light and darkness in this way (see John 3:19, 8:12, and especially 12:35).

the darkness has not overcome it: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as overcome:

1. It means overcome or “gain control of.” For example:

the darkness has not overpowered it (NCV) (BSB, RSV, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV, ESV, GW, NIV2011)

1. It means “understood.” For example:

the darkness has not understood it (NIV84) (NIV84, NASB, KJV)

Some English translations (REB, NET) say “mastered,” which can be understood in either sense. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the darkness has not conquered it

the darkness can never extinguish it (NLT)

Here again darkness is a metaphor referring to evil and deliberately not knowing God. It is personified, meaning that it is spoken about like it was a person and could act. In some languages it is more natural to explain some of this figure of speech. For example:

The evil powers/forces of darkness tried to destroy the one who is the light, but they could not.

John 1:6**Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh**

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in

1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:6–9

This paragraph explains who John the Baptist was and why God sent him. John came to announce the coming of the one who was the light, Jesus Christ.

1:6

There came a man who was sent from God. His name was John.

- ¶ There came/appeared a man whom God sent. His name was John.
- ¶ A man called John was sent from/by God.
- ¶ God sent a man named John.

There came a man who was sent from God: This clause refers to John the Baptist. He was sent from God in the sense that God commanded him to preach to the people. John obeyed God and began preaching. He called the people to repent and believe in Jesus.

The expression here does not mean that John lived with God before coming to the world. If a literal translation has this meaning, you may need to say this:

There was a man sent by God

There came a man: This expression here introduces a new and major person in the narrative. It refers to John, who started to preach about A.D. 29. Introduce this person in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

A man came (NET)

There appeared a man (REB)

who was sent from God: The verb sent is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

There came a man who was sent from God. (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God sent a man (GW)

God sent his messenger (GNT)

His name was John: In some languages you will need to distinguish between this John (John the Baptist) and the author of the book (the Apostle John). You may want to include this information in the text. For example:

whose name was John (He was the baptizer.)

John the Baptist. (NLT)

It is also possible to explain this difference in a footnote. For example:

This refers to John the Baptist, not to the author of the book. See Mark 1:4.

General Comment on 1:6

In some languages, a literal translation may suggest that God's name was John. To avoid this misunderstanding, you may need to reorder this information so that John's name appears early in the verse. For example:

There appeared a man named John. He was sent from God. (REB)

A man named John came/appeared. God had sent him.

John 1:7

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:6–9

This paragraph explains who John the Baptist was and why God sent him. John came to announce the coming of the one who was the light, Jesus Christ.

1:7a

He came as a witness to testify about the Light,

- John came to be a witness, to tell what he saw about the light,
- He came/went to the people declaring what he knew about the/that light.

He came: The pronoun He refers to John the Baptist, who was introduced in 1:6. In some languages it may be more natural to repeat his name. For example:

John came... (GW)

came: John came to the people of Israel and preached to them. He did not come into the world from heaven. If you need to say where John came, it may be natural to say this:

he came to the people

he went to the people

as a witness to testify about the Light: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to testify is from the same Greek word as the noun witness. Repeating the word emphasizes it. In some languages it is natural to emphasize the statement without repeating the word. For example:

John came to declare the truth about the light
(GW)

He came to tell people the truth about the Light
(NCV)

as a witness: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as a witness refers to someone who tells about something he himself has seen or heard. The use of this word implies that this person is reliable. It is a word often used in a courtroom setting. It is good if you can use a legal term. See the notes on Luke 21:13, where the same word appears.

to testify about the Light: This is a purpose clause. John came in order to testify. To testify is to tell others about something or someone the speaker knows personally. John gave honest information about the Light, Jesus Christ.

Light: The word Light is a metaphor. It refers to the Word, Jesus Christ, the one who reveals God and his truth. Try to use the same word or phrase that you used in 1:4b. See the note there.

1:7b

so that through him everyone might believe.

- in order that all people might believe through him.
- John's purpose was to help everyone to have faith in that light.

so that: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that introduces John's purpose in coming and preaching to the people. In some languages it is more natural to use other conjunctions. For example:

in order that

through him everyone might believe: John the Baptist came and preached to the people so that they would believe in the light. He wanted everyone who heard him to believe. Everybody did not believe, but many did. Here are some other ways that this phrase has been translated:

so that all should hear the message and believe
(GNT)

so that through him all people could hear about the Light and believe (NCV)

through him: This phrase here means "through John the Baptist." God used John to help people believe in Jesus Christ, the one who is the light. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through his message (GW)

by means of what he testified

believe: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

lead all people to have faith (CEV)

become believers (REB)

General Comment on 1:7a–b

It is important that your readers understand that the pronouns “he” and “him” here refer to John the Baptist. In some languages it may be more natural to make this clear. For example:

^{7a}God sent a man named John, who came to tell about the light ^{7b}and to lead all people to have faith. (CEV)

John 1:8

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

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Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:6–9

This paragraph explains who John the Baptist was and why God sent him. John came to announce the coming of the one who was the light, Jesus Christ.

1:8a

He himself was not the Light,

- John himself was not the light.
- John was not the actual light.

He himself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He himself refers back to John the Baptist. The RSV translates it simply as “he.” In some languages it is more natural to use the name John here. For example:

John was not the Light (NCV, GW)

was not the Light: John the Baptist was not the one who gave light to all people, who directly revealed God. This does not imply that he did not speak honestly, or that he was not a good man. He was a great and good man.

1:8b

but he came to testify about the Light.

- Rather, he/John came to declare what he knew about the light.
- He came only to tell others about the one who was the light.

but he came to testify about the Light: This clause indicates that although John was not as important as the Light itself, he did have an important mission. His mission and purpose was to tell others about the Light. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

he came only as a witness to the light (NIV)

he was just a witness to tell about the light

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (1:8a) to a positive statement (1:8b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

John was not the Light, but he came to tell people the truth about the Light. (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

John was not the light itself, rather/instead he came to confirm the truth about the light.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

He himself was not the light; he came to tell about the light. (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

John came to declare the truth about the light; he was not the light himself.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

to testify about the Light: This phrase indicates that John the Baptist came to tell people who the Light was. See how you translated testify in 1:7a. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to tell what he witnessed about the light

John 1:9

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:6–9

This paragraph explains who John the Baptist was and why God sent him. John came to announce the coming of the one who was the light, Jesus Christ.

1:9

The true Light who gives light to every man was coming into the world.

- The real/genuine light that gives light to every person was about to enter the world.
- For the true light was about to come upon the earth. This man would enable all people to know about God.

The true Light who gives light to every man was coming into the world: This refers to the Word, Jesus Christ, in contrast to John the Baptist. He was the true light, he gives light to everyone, and he was coming into the world. Here is another way to translate this clause:

The true light that gives light to all was coming into the world! (NCV)

The true Light: The Greek word that the BSB translates as true here means “real” or “genuine.” For example:

the real light (NJB)

Light: See the note on Light in 1:4b and how you translated this in 1:4b, 1:5a, and 1:8a–b.

who gives light to every man: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as gives light can be understood in two ways:

1. it means to give light to someone so that they can see. For example:

which gives light to everyone (ESV) (BSB, NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NET, NLT)

1. it means to shine on someone so that they can be seen. For example:

which shines on everyone (GW) (GW, GNT, CEV)

The KJV is ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations. However, it is good if people can understand that the light enables them to see themselves as well as other things. The true light allows everyone to see that they themselves are sinful. The true light also allows everyone to understand something of God and his greatness and goodness.

In some languages you may need to explain the metaphor of light by translating gives light in this way:

who reveals true things to all people

was coming into the world: This refers to Jesus Christ’s public ministry. Jesus had already been born, and was in fact only a few months younger than John the Baptist. However, he had not yet begun preaching to the people.

John 1:10

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:10–13

When Jesus came into the world, some people accepted him but many did not.

1:10a

He was in the world,

- ¶ He was present in the world,
- ¶ The Word entered the world.

He was in the world: He refers to the Word. In some languages it may help to make this explicit. For example:

The Word was in the world. (GNT)

Scholars disagree about the time this clause refers to. Many think that this refers to Jesus' presence in the world in Old Testament times. Then verse 11 says that he came to his own, which refers to Jesus' birth on earth. Many other scholars, however, think that this clause refers to his life on earth in the gospels. Verse 10 shows the reaction of the Gentiles, while verse 11 shows the reaction of the Jews. The Greek is not clear what time is meant. If possible, translate in a way that allows for both understandings.

in the world: The phrase that the BSB translates as in the world refers mainly to the world as the place where people live.

1:10b

and though the world was made through Him,

- and through him the world began to exist,
- God created the world by means of the Word,
- The Word was God's agent to make the world through him,

the world was made through Him: This refers back to 1:3a-b. See the notes there. Here is another way to translate this clause:

the world was made through him (RSV)

the world was made by him (NCV)

God had made the world through his Word

1:10c

the world did not recognize Him.

- but the world did not realize who he was.
- and yet its people did not know/accept him as the one who created them.

the world did not recognize Him: The clause the world did not recognize Him means "the people in the world did not know who Jesus was." They did not recognize him as the Word, their Creator. In some languages it is more natural to include "people" here. For example:

The people of the world did not recognize him as the one who created them.

General Comment on 1:10a-c

1:10c tells something that is surprising or not expected in view of the information in 1:10a-b. The BSB indicates this by using the word "though." Here are other ways to indicate this surprise:

He was in the world; but the world, though it existed only because of him, did not recognize him.

The Word was in the world, and though God made the world through him, yet the world did not recognize him. (GNT)

He came into the very world he created, but the world didn't recognize him. (NLT)

John 1:11

Section 1:1-18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:10-13

When Jesus came into the world, some people accepted him but many did not.

1:11a

He came to His own,

- He came to his own property,
- The Word came to his own land/country,

He came to His own: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as His own is more literally "his own things/property." This is ambiguous and can refer to the whole earth or specifically to the land of Israel/Judea. In your translation, it is good to be ambiguous. You may be able to follow one of these examples:

He came to the place that he owns

He came to his own country (GNT)

He came to his own home (RSV)

1:11b**and His own did not receive Him.**

- but his own people did not accept him.
- but few of the people from his own country believed in him.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* here introduces an event that one might not expect. Other translations, such as the NIV, translate the conjunction as “but.” You should translate this conjunction in the way that is most natural for your language.

His own did not receive Him: The phrase *His own* refers to the Jews. Most of Jesus’ own people, the Jews, did not accept what he had to say. Verse 1:12a shows that there were some who did accept. If a literal translation here implies that none of the Jews received him, you may need to say this:

not many of his people accepted him

did not receive Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *receive* in this context means “welcome.” That is, it means “receive with pleasure or as a guest.” For example:

did not welcome him (CEV)

did not accept him (NRSV)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate *did not receive* with a positive expression. For example:

they rejected him (NLT)

John 1:12**Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh**

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:10–13

When Jesus came into the world, some people accepted him but many did not.

1:12a–c

See the General Comment after 1:12c for a way to reorder this verse.

1:12a**But to all who did receive Him,**

- However, to all the people who accepted him,
- Yet to all who did welcome him,

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *But* shows that there is a contrast. The contrast is between the many who did not receive the Word, and the others who did receive him. Here are other ways to translate this word:

However (GW)

Yet (NIV)

to all who did receive Him: This refers to those who accepted Jesus and what he taught. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to all who did accept him (REB)

all: This word refers to all kinds of people. It includes Jews and non-Jews, and men and women.

1:12b**to those who believed in His name,**

- to the people who believed in his name,
- the people who trusted him,

who believed in His name: This is another way of referring to those “who did receive him” (1:12a). The way they received the Word was by believing on him. These are not two separate actions. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to those who put their trust in him (REB)

believed in: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

put their faith in him (CEV)

put their trust in him (REB)

trusted/believed him

His name: This phrase is a way of referring to the person himself. The name represented the person. See TRT footnote 51. In this case, His name refers to the Word, Jesus Christ. In some languages it may be more natural to use a pronoun here. For example:

put their faith in him. (CEV)

believed him (NLT)

General Comment on 1:12a–b

The actions in 1:12a and 1:12b are one and the same, expressed in two different ways. Make this clear in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

But to all who have received him—those who believe in his name—he has given the right to become God’s children (NET)

1:12c

He gave the right to become children of God—

- he gave the right to become God’s children.
- he gave the privilege of being the children of God.

He gave the right: The Greek word that the BSB translates as right means “the ability” or “the authority.” The Word gave those who accepted him the ability to become God’s children. This implies that they actually did become God’s children, not just that it was possible. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he gave the right (NIV)

he permitted/enabled

he gave them the privilege

to become: The word become refers to becoming something different. Before this these people were not God’s children in the same sense. There was a change.

children of God: This phrase is an important metaphor. It refers to people who belong to God and

are related to him in a special way. He cares for them and has authority to rule them.

General Comment on 1:12a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

However, he gave the right to become God’s children to everyone who believed in him. (GW)

In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech. For example:

Some people received him and believed on his name. God said to them, “You are now my children.”

God said to the people who believed in this person, “You are now in my family.”

John 1:13

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:10–13

When Jesus came into the world, some people accepted him but many did not.

1:13a–c

In this verse John emphasized that becoming a child of God is not like being born as a human baby. It is not the result of a physical (sexual) act. He emphasized the difference by saying it in three ways. Here are the three ways that spiritual birth is different from human birth:

1. Spiritual birth does not come from being born in a certain family. (1:13a)
2. Spiritual birth does not come from human decision or a husband’s will. (1:13b)
3. Spiritual birth comes from God. (1:13c)

See the notes below for more discussion on the meaning of the parts of this verse. Also see the General

Comment after 1:13c for a way to reorder the information in this verse.

1:13a
children born not of blood,

- They received this right not because of their human parents,
- They did not become children of God through natural birth,

children born not of blood: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as not of blood is more literally “not from/of bloods.” The plural form “bloods” probably refers to an ancient belief. People believed that the birth of a baby was the result of mixing the father’s blood and the mother’s blood. John was indicating that people do not become children of God because of who their parents are. For example:

children not born in the natural/physical way

The way that they became children of God was not the way that people give birth to children on earth

In many languages it will be good to start a new sentence here. For example:

They did not become God’s children by natural means. (GNT)

They did not become his children in any human way. (NCV)

They did not inherit that right from their parents.

1:13b
nor of the desire or will of man,

- nor because of human desire or because a man wanted it,
- or through human plan and purpose,

nor of the desire or will of man: The two Greek phrases that the BSB translates as the desire and will of man both refer to sexual desire and activity. In this context there is no suggestion that there is anything wrong or sinful involved. Make sure that your translation is suitable for public reading. Here are other ways to translate these phrases:

nor of human decision or a husband’s will (NIV)

or by human desire or a husband’s decision (NET)

resulting from physical desire or plan

In some languages it is more natural to combine these two phrases. For example:

because of any human desires (CEV)

1:13c
but born of God.

- but because God made/caused them to be his children.
- but because of God’s will and action to be their Father.

but born of God: This expression is a short way of saying “but they were born of God.” You may want to follow those translations that make this explicit and begin a new sentence here. For example:

They were born of God. (NCV)

Their birth was from God. (GW)

God himself was the one who made them his children. (CEV)

General Comment on 1:13a–c

The BSB has reordered the Greek text and placed the main verb phrase, “born,” in 1:13a. In the Greek this verb is in 1:13c. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek order. Or it may be natural to place the verb in both 1:13a and 1:13c. Most English translations translate the verb in both places. For example:

They did not become his children in any human way—by any human parents or human desire. They were born of God. (NCV)

They were not God’s children by nature or because of any human desires. God himself was the one who made them his children. (CEV)

They did not become God’s children by natural means, that is, by being born as the children of a human father; God himself was their Father. (GNT)

John 1:14

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention

Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:14–18

This paragraph declares that the Word became a human being and lived on earth. John the Baptist announced his coming and his greatness. The Word is revealed as Jesus Christ.

1:14a

The Word became flesh and made His dwelling among us.

- ¶ The Word was born as a human being and he lived among us^(excl).
- ¶ The Word became a human being and he lived with us^(excl).

The Greek begins with a conjunction that introduces a return to the subject of the Word (1:1–4). Although the BSB and some other English translations do not translate this conjunction, the NRSV translates this conjunction as “And.” You should introduce this returned subject in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are some other possible ways to translate this word:

Now (NET)

So (NLT)

The Word became flesh: Refer to the notes and your translation of The Word in 1:1a. The phrase became flesh means “became a human being.” This Word who was God became a man. Because he became a man, he had a physical body and a human mind and emotions. However, he did not cease to be God.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The Word became a human being. (GNT)

The Word became human. (GW)

the Word became a man of flesh and blood (ES/BAGD)

made His dwelling among us: The Greek words that the BSB translates as made His dwelling among us indicate that Jesus lived as a man among other people in first-century Palestine.

Here is another possible way to translate this phrase:

made his home among us (NLT)

among us: The pronoun us here could refer either to those who saw Jesus in his earthly life or to all of mankind. However, the word “we” in 1:14b can only refer to those who saw Jesus, so both pronouns should be translated as an exclusive pronoun.

1:14b

We have seen His glory,

- We^(excl) have seen his glory,
- We^(excl) saw his wonderful majesty,

We have seen His glory: The pronoun We refers to all who saw Jesus Christ at the time when he lived on earth. It is therefore exclusive. The apostles and others saw who Jesus was and what he did. He showed them that he was God.

You may choose to start a new sentence here. For example:

We have seen his glory (NIV)

His glory: In the Old Testament, God’s glory often refers to the impressive bright light that people saw when God was with them. This brightness represented how powerful and impressive God was. When it is applied to Jesus, the word glory sometimes refers in general to his divine character or qualities. Here John was probably thinking of Jesus’ power and greatness as shown in his miraculous signs. See KBT glory 2(b).

Here are other ways to translate this phrase in its context:

We^(excl) have seen how full of glory he is.

We^(excl) saw his greatness/majesty.

1:14c

the glory of the one and only Son from the Father,

- the glory of the unique One who came from the Father,

- the majesty of the one and only Son of God the Father,

the glory of the one and only Son from the Father:

This phrase indicates that Jesus had himself the same glory that belonged to his father. The expression of in this context means “that is the glory of” and not “that is like the glory of.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the glory of the Father’s one and only Son (NLT)

such glory as befits the Father’s only Son (REB)

the glory that the Father shares with his only Son (GW)

the one and only Son from the Father: There are two ways to interpret this phrase:

1. It refers to Jesus as the Son of God. English translations that follow this interpretation capitalize Father and Son. For example:

the only Son of the Father (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NET, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It is generic and refers to any only son. For example:

a father’s only son (NRSV)

(NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

one and only Son: The Greek word that the BSB translates as one and only Son is formed from two root words: “only” and “kind.” It means “unique.” It usually refers to an only child, male or female. It can also refer figuratively to a child who has a special relationship to his parents. Here it indicates that Jesus’ relationship to God is unique. Jesus reveals God’s glory in a unique way among mankind. He shares God’s nature and qualities completely.

The Greek term does not explicitly indicate that Jesus is God’s “son,” but it implies that. So you may want to include it in your translation. You may have a word or phrase that describes an only child or son. Or you may have a word or phrase that describes a son who is special to his father. If you have one of those expressions, you might want to use it here. If you do not have

a special word or idiom for this, here are other ways to translate it:

the unique Son

the one and only Son

1:14d

full of grace and truth.

- full of kindness and truth.
- and he was perfect love/mercy and complete faithfulness.
- who is always gracious/loving and can be trusted.

full of grace and truth: This phrase full of grace and truth describes Jesus’ nature as having the characteristics of both grace and truth. In some languages it may not be natural to use the word full in this context. Here are other possible ways to translate this phrase:

From him all the kindness and all the truth of God have come down to us. (CEV)

he displayed/demonstrated complete grace and truth

he was all mercy/sympathy and faithfulness

In some languages it may be more natural to use verbs, adjectives, or adverbs to translate the nouns grace and truth. That is, Jesus always acted in a way that was kind/gracious and true. For example:

He was always gracious/loving and faithful.

who is ever merciful and true

grace: Here, grace refers to the qualities of love and kindness. It is a love that does not depend on the excellence or goodness of the one who is loved. It only depends on the one who loves.

Here are other ways to translate it:

unfailing love (NLT)

love that does not fail/end

loving kindness

truth: The word truth refers to reality. It indicates that Jesus truly reveals what is real, which includes who God is. He does not deceive people but is reliable and faithful. For example:

faithfulness (NLT)

he can be trusted

John 1:15

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:14–18

This paragraph declares that the Word became a human being and lived on earth. John the Baptist announced his coming and his greatness. The Word is revealed as Jesus Christ.

1:15

Here John interrupted his description of Jesus the Word by telling what John the Baptist said about him. Some English versions indicate this interruption by putting this verse in parentheses. Consider whether or not it is natural to use parentheses in your language.

1:15a

John testified concerning Him.

- John told the truth about the one who was the Word.
- John told the people what he knew about the Word.

John testified concerning Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testified refers to telling about what the speaker witnessed. See the note on 1:7a, where the same word appears. (The phrase testified concerning is a verb phrase that means “testified about.” It does not mean that John spoke to him, Jesus, about what he witnessed.) The Greek verb here in 1:15a is in the present tense. However, in many languages it may be more natural to use the past tense, as the BSB did. For example:

John told the people what he knew about the Word.

John declared the truth about him. (NCV)

John spoke about him. (CEV)

Him: The person about whom John testified was the Word: Jesus Christ. If you need to make this explicit, refer to “the Word,” as in 1:14a.

1:15b

He cried out, saying,

- He called out,
- He proclaimed to the people this message:

In Greek, 1:15a and 1:15b are connected with the common conjunction that the NRSV translates as “and.” The BSB does not translate this conjunction and starts a new sentence. You may also use “when,” and translate 1:15a–b like this:

John declared the truth about him when he said loudly.... (GW)

Connect 1:15a and 1:15b in the way that is natural in your language.

cried out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cried out here means “spoke loudly.” Use a word that refers to the public proclaiming of an important, even urgent, message.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

proclaimed (REB)

shouted to the crowds (NLT)

preached

1:15c–e

“This is He of whom I said, ‘He who comes after me has surpassed me because He was before me.’”:

This sentence is a quote that includes a quote. John the Baptist quoted something he had said earlier. See the General Comment at on 1:15c–e for more information about translating a quote that includes a quote.

1:15c

“This is He of whom I said,

- “This was the man I was talking about when I said,
- “I was referring to this man when I said that

- “This is the one/man I meant him when I said that

This is He of whom I said: John was referring to the Word, Jesus Christ. He was identifying someone he described earlier. In many languages it will be more natural to use the present tense: “This is he.” For example:

This is the One whom I told you^(plur) about.

This is the One I was talking about. (GNT)

1:15d

‘He who comes after me has surpassed me

- ‘He who comes after me is greater than I am
- he who came behind me would be more important than me

He: This pronoun refers to Jesus, the Word.

who comes after me: This clause indicates that Jesus came after John in time. John was about six months older than Jesus (see the narrative in Luke 1, especially Luke 1:26). John began his public ministry before Jesus did. When John said this, Jesus had not yet begun his ministry.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He comes after me (REB)

Someone is coming after me (NLT)

There is someone coming after me who...

has surpassed me: The phrase that the BSB translates as has surpassed me means “is greater than I am” or “is more important than I am.” For example:

who is far greater than I am (NLT)

is superior to me (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

1:15e

because He was before me.”

- because he existed before I did.”
- because he was living/alive before I was born.”

because He was before me: This clause indicates the reason why Jesus was greater than John. Although he was six months younger than John, Jesus existed before John was born. He existed with God as the Word. In your translation, try to imply that this refers

to Jesus always living rather than his age on earth. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for he existed long before I did (NET)

before I was born, he already was (REB)

General Comment on 1:15c–e

This verse includes a quotation that includes a quotation. In some languages it may be natural to avoid this quotation that includes a quotation by using indirect speech. For example:

^{15c}This is the one about whom I spoke when I said that ^{15d}one would come after me. And he would be one who is greater than I am, ^{15e}because he existed before me.

John 1:16

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:14–18

This paragraph declares that the Word became a human being and lived on earth. John the Baptist announced his coming and his greatness. The Word is revealed as Jesus Christ.

1:16

Here in 1:16 John the Gospel writer returned to his description of Jesus. It should be clear in your translation that his words begin again here. They are not the words of John the Baptist anymore. It may help to begin a new paragraph here.

1:16a

From His fullness

- Out of the plentiful supply of his grace,
- Because the Word is completely generous,

In the Greek text this verse begins with a word often translated as “because.” The NJB translates it as “Indeed,” which means “Truly.” Here it introduces the

grounds for what both John the Baptist and the writer John said about the Word in the previous verses. The BSB and other English translations do not explicitly translate it. Other English translations translate it as “because” or “for.” You should introduce what John writes about the Word in a way that is natural in your language.

From His fullness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as From here means “out of.” The word fullness means “completeness” or “plenty.” Out of the great amount of the Word’s grace, mentioned in 1:14d, we have received many blessings.

Here are other ways to translate From His fullness:

From his abundance (NLT)

From the plentiful supply of his grace

Because he is very kind/gracious

1:16b

we have all received grace upon grace.

- we^(incl) all have received one gift after another gift.
- he has given many gracious gifts to us^(incl).
- he has given us^(incl) kindness after/upon kindness.

we have all received grace upon grace: Verse 1:16b indicates that we have received many blessings from the Word who became human. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a pronoun referring to the Word as the subject. For example:

he has blessed us all, giving us one blessing after another (GNT)

grace upon grace: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as grace upon grace is more literally “grace in place of grace.” There are two interpretations of this phrase:

1. It means that we receive many blessings—one after another. For example:

one blessing after another (NIV) (GNT, NIV, NRSV, NCV, NLT, CEV, NASB, REB, ESV, NET, GW)

1. It means that one gift is taken away and replaced by another kind of gift. For example:

one gift replacing another (NJB) (KJV, NJB)

In interpretation (1), the earlier gifts are not removed as other gifts are given. In interpretation (2), there is only one gift at a time. It is implied that the earlier gifts are removed. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as do most Bible scholars. This fits the context better.

General Comment on 1:16a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine 1:16a and 1:16b. For example:

^{16a–b}Each of us has received one gift after another because of all that the Word is. (GW)

^{16a–b}Now we have all received from his fullness one gracious gift after another. (NET)

John 1:17

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:14–18

This paragraph declares that the Word became a human being and lived on earth. John the Baptist announced his coming and his greatness. The Word is revealed as Jesus Christ.

1:17a

For the law was given through Moses;

- For the law was given long ago through Moses,
- God gave the law to his people through Moses.

For the law was given through Moses: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the law refers to the Torah. The Torah was the collected laws, rules, commands, and instructions in the OT. Many hundreds of years before Jesus was born, God communicated his law to the people of Israel. He used the prophet Moses as his messenger to do that. These laws are recorded in the first five books of the Old Testament. They include the Ten Commandments and also many other laws and instructions. See KBT Law 2.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here is the same word that appeared at the beginning of verse 16. It is often translated as “because” or “for.” Scholars say that it introduces further grounds for verse 14, or grounds for verse 16, or an explanation of verse 16. Some English translations, such as the GNT, do not translate this word explicitly. However, many translations (BSB, NIV, NET, NASB, ESV, REB, NLT) translate it as “for.”

Introduce the next clause in a way that is natural in your language.

was given: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was given is passive. Here are some ways to translate it:

- as a passive verb. For example:

the Teachings were given through Moses (GW)

- as an active verb. God is the implied actor. For example:

God gave his law through Moses.

God caused Moses to give the laws to the people.

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language.

1:17b

grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.

- but/and grace and truth came to us^(incl) through Jesus Christ.
- God showed us^(incl) mercy and revealed to us his truth/faithfulness through/in Jesus the Messiah.

In the Greek text, there is no conjunction to connect 1:17a and 1:17b. Many English translations include the word “but” (CEV, KJV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, NCV). This is done to indicate the contrast between the law coming through Moses (1:17a) and grace and truth coming through Jesus Christ (1:17b). You may want to indicate this contrast if that is natural in your language. However, your translation should not imply that there was no grace or truth in the law that came through Moses.

grace and truth came through Jesus Christ: The Greek clause grace and truth came through Jesus Christ indicates that Jesus Christ brought grace and truth to the human race. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus Christ brought us undeserved kindness and truth. (CEV)

It is through Jesus Christ that we^(incl) learned about God’s love and faithfulness that do not fail.

Jesus Christ showed us^(incl) how kind and faithful God is.

grace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as grace refers to God’s favor and kindness to people that do not deserve them. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as an adjective:

[Jesus Christ showed us that God is] kind/gracious to those who do not deserve it.

truth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as truth here refers to God’s faithfulness. He is faithful to himself, to his own righteous character, and also to his people. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as an adjective:

true/faithful

Christ: The word Christ is a title. It is not just one of Jesus’ names. This title refers to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” which means “the anointed one.” In Old Testament times, kings and priests were anointed with oil (oil was put on their head). That was done to show that God had chosen and appointed them as leaders.

Here are some ways to translate Christ:

- Transliterate the word Christ (or “Messiah”) if the word is known in your area and means “savior.” Indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Krais

the Kirisita

the Massie

- Translate the meaning of Christ with a descriptive phrase. For example:

the One God Appointed

The savior God promised

God's chosen one

the King who rescues his people

- It is better to use both a transliteration of Christ or "Messiah" and include a phrase that explains the meaning. In this way, people will learn the meaning of Christ. (You may choose to include the descriptive phrase only for the first uses of the term. Then later you may use only Christ or Messiah.) For example:

the Krai, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Messias, the King-who-rescues

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

"Christ" and "Messiah" both mean the same thing. "Christ" is based on a Greek word, and "Messiah" is based on the same word/title in Hebrew. They both refer to the king and savior whom God had promised to send to his people. The word means "anointed," which means to pour oil on someone to show that God chose him for a special purpose.

It may also help to explain the meaning more completely than that in a glossary.

See also KBT Christ, Messiah, sense 1(a).

John 1:18

Section 1:1–18: The Word became flesh

In this section the author introduces the subject of his book, Jesus Christ. However, he does not mention Jesus by name until near the end of this section, in 1:17. Instead, he uses figurative language, referring to him as the Word and the light.

Here are other possible section headings:

The Word brought life and light to all people

Jesus is the Word and the light

Paragraph 1:14–18

This paragraph declares that the Word became a human being and lived on earth. John the Baptist announced his coming and his greatness. The Word is revealed as Jesus Christ.

1:18a

No one has ever seen God,

- No human being has ever seen God.

No one has ever seen God: The pronoun No one refers to any human on earth. No human being living on earth has ever seen God. See Exodus 33:20.

1:18b

but the one and only Son, who is Himself God

- However, the unique One, who himself is God,
- The One and Only Son, himself God,
- The only Son, who is truly God, (CEV)

the one and only Son, who is Himself God: The original Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the one and only Son, who is Himself God is probably "the unique/only one, himself God." There is a textual issue here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have "the unique/only one/ ^LSon^J, ^Lhimself^J God." For example: the only God (ESV) (BSB, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, NET, GNT, NLT, NCV, CEV) (2) Some Greek manuscripts have "the unique/only Son." For example: the only Son (NJB) (KJV, NJB, probably REB, GW) It is recommended that you follow option (1), which has the strongest Greek manuscript evidence. It is given a B rating by the UBS Greek New Testament, indicating that this is the probable reading. However, it may still be natural to make explicit the implied information that Christ was unique as Son, as in 1:14c and as several English translations have done. The Greek word for "unique/only one" is also used in 1:14c, where the RSV translates it as "only Son." See the note there. You will probably want to translate it the same way here. Here again this word indicates that Jesus' relationship to God is unique. He alone among all mankind completely shares the glory of God.

Even though the Greek term does not explicitly indicate that Jesus is unique as God's "Son," this is implied. You may want to make this explicit in your translation, as the BSB has done. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the only One, himself God (NET)

the unique One, who is himself God (NLT)

the only Son, himself God

the divine and only Son (JBP)

1:18c

and is at the Father's side, has made Him known.

- is at the Father's side, and he has made the Father known.
- who is very close to the Father, has shown us^(incl) who the Father is.

is at the Father's side: The phrase at the Father's side means "in close relationship to the Father." The Word is with God his Father, and God loves and honors him.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

near to the Father and dear to him

closest to the Father (CEV)

very close to the Father (NCV)

has made Him known: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has made...known means "has completely explained" or "has caused people to know." It is through Jesus that people can know God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

has revealed God to us (NLT)

has shown us what God is like (CEV)

Him: The pronoun Him refers to God the Father.

John 1:19

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:19–23

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to John to ask him who he claimed to be. They believed that he had no right to baptize if God had not sent him. He told them that he was preparing people to believe in the Messiah, the Chosen One. He quoted from Isaiah the prophet about a voice shouting in the wilderness to describe himself.

1:19a

And this was John's testimony

- ¶ This was what John said about what he witnessed
- ¶ Here is what John testified/answered

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And introduces the next event in the story. In some languages it may be more natural not to translate it. You should introduce this new event in the story in a way that is natural in your language.

this was John's testimony: The word this refers forward to the testimony John gave in 1:20, "I am not the Christ." (The word testimony means a statement where you tell what you know.) See the General Comment after 1:20 for a possible way to reorder this information.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This was John's answer (GW)

Here is the truth John told (NCV)

testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony can also be translated as "statement about what one saw." See the note on 1:7a, where the same word refers to a person, John the Baptist himself. Here it refers to John the Baptist's message. In some languages it is more natural to use a verb phrase instead of a noun. For example:

John told what he witnessed, saying....

John declared the truth in this way:

1:19b

when the Jews of Jerusalem sent priests and Levites

- when the leaders of the Jewish nation sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem
- when the religious leaders in Jerusalem sent priests and other Levites from there

when the Jews of Jerusalem sent priests and Levites: The phrase the Jews here probably refers to the Jewish religious leaders. They lived and worked in the city of Jerusalem. In some languages it is more natural to make it explicit that these Jews were leaders based in Jerusalem. For example:

the Jewish leaders in Jerusalem sent priests and Levites (NIV)

The Jewish authorities in Jerusalem sent some priests and Levites (GNT)

The leaders in Jerusalem sent priests and temple helpers (CEV)

The priests and the Levites were probably from Jerusalem, in addition to the Jewish leaders. In your translation, you should indicate that they all lived in Jerusalem. Also indicate that the leaders sent a group of priests and Levites from Jerusalem to question John. John was not in Jerusalem, but in a desert where nobody lived.

priests: Jewish priests were men who served God in the temple in Jerusalem. They served as mediators between God and the Jewish people. They offered animal sacrifices to God for the people. The priests also did other religious rituals and were in charge of the ceremonies in the temple. Here are some other ways to translate priests:

sacrificers

men who offer sacrifices

men who are representatives of people to God

See also KBT priest, meaning 1.

Levites: The Levites were men who helped the priests in the temple. They were descendants of Levi and therefore were members of the tribe of Levi. Priests were Levites, but also had to be descendants of Aaron, Moses' brother. So all priests were Levites, but not all Levites were priests. In the Bible, the word Levites refers to the descendants of Levi who were not priests. See Levite in KBT. Here are other ways to translate this word:

members of the tribe/clan of Levi

descendants of Levi

Temple assistants (NLT)

1:19c

to ask him, "Who are you?"

- to John to ask, "Who are you^(sing)?"
- to ask John who he was. (CEV)

to ask him, "Who are you?": The pronouns him and you both refer to John the Baptist. The Jewish leaders wanted to know what his authority was; in other words, what right did he have to baptize people.

In some languages it may be better to use indirect speech for this question. For example:

to ask him who he was (NIV)

to ask John who he was (CEV)

Refer to the General Comment after 1:23 on indirect speech in 1:19-23.

John 1:20

Section 1:19-28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:19-23

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to John to ask him who he claimed to be. They believed that he had no right to baptize if God had not sent him. He told them that he was preparing people to believe in the Messiah, the Chosen One. He quoted from Isaiah the prophet about a voice shouting in the wilderness to describe himself.

1:20a

He did not refuse to confess, but openly declared,

- He did not refuse to answer, but freely admitted,
- John explained clearly/honestly and openly,
- He made it very clear that

He did not refuse to confess, but openly declared:

The word confess here means to declare something to be true. It does not mean that John admitted that he sinned. The Greek text says the same thing three times. It says it twice as a positive statement (“confessed...confessed”) and once as a negative statement (“did not deny it”). However, in some languages it may be natural to emphasize this in a different way and say it only once or twice, like the BSB does. For example:

He did not fail to confess, but confessed freely
(NIV)

He quickly declared the truth

He told them plainly (CEV)

1:20b

“I am not the Christ.”

- “I am not the Messiah/Christ.”
- “I am not the Messiah, the Chosen/Appointed One.”
- he was not the Christ, the Promised Savior.

I am not the Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Christ is a title. The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had promised to send to save Israel. Both the Greek word Christ and the Hebrew word “Messiah” mean “anointed one.” To anoint someone means “to put oil on someone to indicate that they have a special purpose.” When the term is used for Jesus as the Messiah, it refers to the person that God appointed for a special purpose. See the note on Christ at 1:17b.

General Comment on 1:19–20

The event in John 1:19a is the same one described in 1:20a and occurs after 1:19b–c. In some languages it may be natural to translate these verses in the order in which they happened. For example:

^{19b}The leaders in Jerusalem sent priests and temple helpers ^{19c}to ask John who he was. ^{19a–20}He told them plainly, “I am not the Messiah.” (CEV)

John 1:21

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:19–23

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to John to ask him who he claimed to be. They believed that he had no right to baptize if God had not sent him. He told them that he was preparing people to believe in the Messiah, the Chosen One. He quoted from Isaiah the prophet about a voice shouting in the wilderness to describe himself.

1:21a

“Then who are you?” they inquired.

- So they asked him, “Then who are you?”^(sing)
- The priests and temple helpers questioned him: “So who are you?”^(sing)
- The priests and helpers in the House of God then asked him to identify himself.

Then who are you?: The priests and Levites asked this question to introduce their next question, “Are you Elijah?” John had told them who he was not, but they still needed to learn who he was.

Here is another way to translate this question:

Who are you, then? (GNT)

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then can also be translated as “therefore” or “so.” It is a short way of saying “if that is the situation,” or “if you are not the Christ.”

they inquired: The pronoun they refers to the priests and Levites. In some languages it is more natural to say this explicitly. For example:

These priests and Levites asked

1:21b

“Are you Elijah?”

- Are you^(sing) the prophet called Elijah?”
- Are you^(sing) the prophet Elijah who has returned?”
- Was he the messenger from God called Elijah who was supposed to return?

Are you Elijah?: The priests and Levites thought that John might be the prophet Elijah, who lived about eight hundred years before. They thought this because there was a prophecy that Elijah would come before the Messiah (see Malachi 4:5–6). Also, John was dressed like Elijah had dressed. You may want to explain this in a footnote.

The men were not asking if John’s name was Elijah. They knew his name was John. They were asking if he was fulfilling the prophecy by doing the work of Elijah.

In some languages it may be good to include the information that Elijah was a prophet from long ago. For example:

And they said, “Are you^(sing) Elijah, the prophet from long ago?”

And these priests and Levites asked if he were Elijah, the prophet who was to announce the Messiah.

1:21c

He said, “I am not.”

- John said, “I am not Elijah.”
- John replied, “I am not that one/man.”
- He denied this, too.

He said: The pronoun He refers to John the Baptist. In some languages it is more natural to make that explicit. For example:

John answered (GNT)

I am not: John stated that he was not Elijah. In some languages the name Elijah should be included in the answer. For example:

I am not Elijah.

1:21d

“Are you the Prophet?”

- “Are you^(sing) the prophet who is to come?”

- Then they asked, “Are you^(sing) the prophet whom Moses wrote about?”
- Then they asked him if he was the prophet who was to come in the future.

Are you the Prophet?: This is another question that the men asked John. In some languages it may be natural to introduce it with a phrase such as “They asked”:

Then they asked, “Are you the Prophet?” (GW)

And when they asked if he were the Prophet.... (CEV)

“Are you the Prophet?” they asked. (NCV)

the Prophet: The men were referring to a particular prophet, a prophet who was to be in some way “like Moses.” See KBT Prophet 1(c), The prophet. This person was predicted in Deuteronomy 18:15, 18–19. Moses lived over a thousand (1000) years before. However, the Israelites expected someone “like Moses” to return at the time of the Messiah. In some languages, it is more natural to include some of this information, because the first-century audience knew about it. For example:

Again they asked, “Are you^(sing) perhaps the prophet who is written about in the Law?”

And they said, “Is it possible that you^(sing) are the special prophet whom God will send to us?”

Prophet: A Prophet was a man who spoke as a representative of God. He told people what God revealed to him. God gave some prophets power to do miracles. These miracles helped people realize that God sent the prophet.

Here are some ways to translate Prophet:

a messenger/representative for God

a man who speaks God’s words

God’s message-speaker

It is good to use a general term that does not only refer to predicting the future. Although prophets did predict the future, they also gave people other messages from

God. They especially told them to stop sinning and to obey God.

When choosing a term for Prophet, consider how you will distinguish it from other words that are similar in meaning, such as “angel,” “apostle,” and “preacher.”

1:21e

He answered, “No.”

- John answered the men, “No, I am not the Prophet.”
- This he also denied.

He answered, “No.”: The pronoun He refers to John the Baptist. In some languages it is natural to include both John’s name and what he was denying. For example:

John answered, “No, I am not the prophet.”

John 1:22

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:19–23

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to John to ask him who he claimed to be. They believed that he had no right to baptize if God had not sent him. He told them that he was preparing people to believe in the Messiah, the Chosen One. He quoted from Isaiah the prophet about a voice shouting in the wilderness to describe himself.

1:22a

So they said to him,

- Then they asked him,
- So the priests and Levites told him

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So can also be translated as “therefore.” Here are some other way to translate this word:

Then they said to him (NRSV)

Finally they said (NIV)

they said to him: The pronoun they refers to the priests and Levites. The pronoun him refers to John the Baptist. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

the priests and helpers in the temple said to John

See the General Comment after 1:22d for a way to translate this as indirect speech.

1:22b

“Who are you?”

- “So/Then who are you?^(sing)
- that they needed to know who he was

Who are you?: The ones asking questions were not asking for John’s name. They wanted to know his mission or social importance and why he thought he had the right to baptize. They probably felt disappointed that they could not get a satisfactory answer. In some languages it is natural to imply that they were disappointed. For example:

You^(sing) must tell us who you really are.

1:22c

We need an answer for those who sent us.

- Give us^(excl) an answer for the men who sent us.
- We^(excl) need something to tell those leaders who sent us^(excl) here.
- so that they could give an answer to the religious leaders who had sent them.

We need an answer for those who sent us: The ones asking questions insisted that John answer them so that they could tell the religious leaders what he said. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We have to take an answer back to those who sent us. (GNT)

We must give an answer to those who sent us. (REB)

those who sent us: The phrase those who sent us refers back to the religious leaders. In some languages it is more natural to identify them here. For example:

We^(excl) need an answer to give to those religious leaders who sent us.

1:22d

What do you say about yourself?"

- Who do you^(sing) say you are?"
- Who do you^(sing) declare to be?"
- So they again asked John who he said he was.

What do you say about yourself?: This question means about the same as the question in 1:22b. The priests and Levites wanted to know who John said he was. Translate this in a way that implies that they were becoming upset or impatient. For example:

What have you to say about yourself? (NJB)

General Comment on 1:22b–d

In some languages it may be more natural to combine the questions in 1:22b and d:

^{22b,d}You^(sing) must tell us^(excl) what/who you really are, ^{22c}so that we can tell those who sent us.

General Comment on 1:22a–d

In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

^{22a}Finally the priests and Levites ^{22b,d}demanded to know who he said he was. ^{22c}They told him that they had to give an answer to the religious leaders who had sent them.

John 1:23

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:19–23

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to John to ask him who he claimed to be. They believed that he had no right to baptize if God had not sent him. He told them that he was preparing people to believe in the Messiah, the Chosen One. He quoted from Isaiah the prophet about a voice shouting in the wilderness to describe himself.

1:23a

John replied

- John replied to them,
- John told the priests and Levites,

John replied: John answered by quoting words from Isaiah 40:3 in the LXX (the Greek translation of the OT). In the Hebrew text of Isaiah 40:3, the straight path was to be built in the desert: "In the desert prepare a way for the Lord." However, in the LXX, the voice calling out was in the desert: "The voice of one calling in the desert...." John was quoting from the LXX. These words had been first written in Hebrew hundreds of years before. See the General Comment at the end of 1:23 for a way to reorder this verse.

1:23b

in the words of Isaiah the prophet:

- "Isaiah the prophet was speaking of me.
- "It is just as Isaiah the prophet said/wrote long ago.

in the words of Isaiah the prophet: Isaiah was a Hebrew prophet who lived about seven hundred years before Christ. His words are recorded in the book of Isaiah in the Old Testament.

There are two ways to interpret the place where the words in the words of Isaiah the prophet belong:

1. They belong inside the quotation marks. John the Baptist was the one who said these words. He said that he was quoting Isaiah. For example:

John said, "I'm a voice crying out in the desert, 'Make the way for the Lord straight,' as the prophet Isaiah said." (GW) (NET, NASB, NJB, ESV, RSV, GW)

1. They belong outside the quotation marks. John the gospel writer was the one who said these words. He said that John the Baptist's words were from Isaiah. For example:

John answered by quoting the prophet Isaiah: "I am 'the voice of someone shouting in the desert: Make a straight path for the Lord to travel!' " (GNT) (BSB, CEV, NCV, NIV, NLT, NRSV, REB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). About the same number of translations and commentaries agree with each interpretation. But the Greek word order seems to be more suitable for interpretation (1).

prophet: A prophet was a man who spoke as a representative of God. He told people what God revealed to him. See the note at 1:21d.

1:23c–d

I am a voice of one calling in the wilderness, ‘Make straight the way for the Lord.’: John the Baptist was quoting from Isaiah 40:3. He said that he was the fulfillment of the prophecy. The words I am are not part of the quotation. They are John’s own words. You may show this by where you place single quotation marks. For example:

“I am ‘the voice of someone shouting in the desert: Make a straight path for the Lord to travel.’” (GNT)

1:23c

“I am a voice of one calling in the wilderness,

- I am only ‘the one calling/crying out in the wilderness:
- ‘The voice shouting in the desert’—It is mine/me!
- I fulfill this saying: ‘A person/man shouts in the desert,

I am a voice of one calling in the wilderness: John indicated that he fulfilled Isaiah’s prophecy that someone would shout a message in the wilderness (desert).

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am only someone shouting in the desert (CEV)

I am the one who fulfills this saying/word: “A voice will cry out in the wilderness....”

It is I who fulfills what the prophet said: “Someone will shout in the wilderness....”

I: This pronoun refers to John the Baptist.

a voice: John used the word voice figuratively here to mean “a person talking.” Consider if it is natural to refer to a person as a voice. If not, you may need to say this:

I am the one who shouts/calls in the desert

calling: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as calling here means “shouting” or “speaking loudly.”

the wilderness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wilderness here refers to an empty place or place where nobody lived. Here is another way to translate this word:

desert (NIV)

1:23d

‘Make straight the way for the Lord.’”

- Make^(plur) a straight way/path for the Lord!”
- I am telling people to prepare for the Lord to arrive.
- ‘Straighten out your lives and get ready for the Lord!’”

Make straight the way for the Lord: This clause means “Straighten (Make straight) the road for the Lord to travel on.” It is a metaphor that compares preparing one’s life for the Lord to preparing a road for a king to travel on. In the metaphor, the road is curved and not flat and needs to be made straight and level. This is like a life that is sinful and needs to be corrected.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate it:

General Comment on 1:23a–d

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the point of similarity explicit. For example:

Just as you^(plur) straighten/correct a road for the king, so you must straighten/correct your lives for the coming of the Lord!

- Indicate something of the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Straighten your ways/lives! Get ready for the Lord to come!

Prepare yourselves for the Lord to come to you!

In the Greek text the mention of Isaiah the prophet comes at the end of the verse. This is reflected in the NRSV translation. However in some languages it may be more natural to reorder the parts of this verse, like the BSB does. For example:

^{23a} John replied, ^{23b-d}“I am the one that Isaiah the prophet referred to when he said/wrote that a voice shouts in the desert. The voice says, ‘Prepare a straight path for the Lord!’”

General Comment on 1:19–1:23

These verses contain several short speeches. John 1:23 includes quotations inside quotations. In some languages it is more natural to use indirect quotes. For example:

The Jewish religious leaders sent priests and Levites to find out who John was. He told them clearly he was not the Christ. Then they asked him if he were Elijah or the Prophet. John replied no to both questions. The priests and Levites finally told him they had to know who he was. They had to know in order to give a report to the religious leaders. John answered by quoting from Isaiah the prophet. He was the one shouting in the wilderness to tell people to get ready for the Lord to come.

John 1:24

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:24–28

In this paragraph the Pharisees questioned John about his right to baptize people. John answered by saying that someone was standing among them who was much greater than he was.

1:24

Then the Pharisees who had been sent

- ¶ There were some Pharisees among those who had been sent,

- ¶ Some Pharisees were in the group that the Jewish leaders sent to question John.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then here introduces an explanation. The GNT and some other English translations do not translate this word. The Greek word can also be translated as “also.” For example:

Some Pharisees had also been sent to John. (CEV)

You should introduce this explanation in the way that is most natural in your language.

the Pharisees who had been sent: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the Pharisees who had been sent can also be translated as “they had been sent from the Pharisees.” There are at least two ways to understand this expression:

1. At least some of the men who were sent were Pharisees. For example:

Then the Pharisees who had been sent asked him (NLT) (BSB, NIV, KJV, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The Pharisees sent these people. For example:

The messengers, who had been sent by the Pharisees (NJB) (NJB, RSV, GNT)

The NASB, ESV, NET, and NRSV can be understood either way. Here is what these translations all say:

they had been sent from the Pharisees

You may be able to translate this in a way that can be understood either way. However, if this is not possible, you may follow interpretation (1) or the national translation. The difficulty with both alternatives above is that in Jesus’ time most priests and Levites were Sadducees and not Pharisees. That was also true of the Jewish religious leaders in general. Probably, the Pharisees did not have the authority to send a group of priests and Levites as representatives. Nor is it probable that all of the men sent to question Jesus were Pharisees. But it is very possible that some of them were. So you may want to follow this example:

Some Pharisees who had been sent asked him

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey

all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees using the sounds of your language. You may need to indicate that it refers to a group of people. For example:

Farises

Farisi members

Parise followers

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

If you translate Pharisees in this second way, you will probably want to use a shorter translation after this. You probably do not want to include the full explanation every time you translate the word. You may want to follow one of the first set of examples in the rest of John.

You may want to add a footnote explaining more about the Pharisees, especially if you translated the word the first way. Here is a sample footnote:

The Pharisees was a Jewish religious group. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully.

See Pharisee in KBT.

who had been sent: This is a passive verb phrase. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Some of those who had been sent were Pharisees.
(GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The religious leaders had sent some Pharisees.

- Use a noun referring to a group of people sent on a mission. For example:

some Pharisees in the group of representatives

See the General Comment at the end of 1:25b on how to combine verses 24 and 25.

John 1:25

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:24–28

In this paragraph the Pharisees questioned John about his right to baptize people. John answered by saying that someone was standing among them who was much greater than he was.

1:25a–b

Why then do you baptize, if you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet?: This is a real question. The Pharisees were asking for information, but they were also implying a rebuke like a rhetorical question might. They were implying that John had no right to baptize people. They wanted him to explain why he was baptizing people.

It is best to translate this as a real question. But you should imply that the Pharisees did not approve of John baptizing and wanted him to explain his actions. For example:

^{25a-b}If you aren't the Messiah or Elijah or the Prophet, what right do you have to baptize? (NLT)

^{25a-b}If you are not the Messiah, nor Elijah, nor the prophet, then why are you baptizing? (REB)

The two examples above have reordered 1:25a and 1:25b. See the General Comment on 1:25a–b at the end of 1:25b for other examples of this.

1:25a

asked him, “Why then do you baptize,

- and they asked him, “Why then do you^(sing) baptize people
- They said to John, “What right do you^(sing) have to baptize?

Why then do you baptize: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then can also be translated as “therefore” or “so.” Some English translations leave it implicit. For example:

Why are you baptizing people...? (CEV)

baptize: The verb baptize means to use water in a special ceremony to show that God makes his people pure. In some verses, the verbs “wash” and “clean” are used to translate the Greek verb baptizo (“baptize”). Luke 11:38 says, “But the Pharisee was surprised to see that Jesus did not first wash (baptize) before the meal.” (The Greek verb here is baptizo, but English translations translate it as “wash.” The context refers to a ritual washing, not just removing dirt.). Mark 7:4 and Matthew 23:25 both speak of washing/cleaning cups and other kitchen things. The verb in Mark is baptizo while the verb in Matthew is katharizo (clean). Again, a ritual cleansing is involved. Mark 7:4 says, “And there are many other traditions for them to observe, including the washing (baptizing) of cups, pitchers, kettles, and couches for dining.” Matthew 23:25 says, “You clean (katharizo) the outside of the cup and dish.” However, the above references do not indicate that “wash/cleanse” is the only meaning of the rite of baptism as practiced by John and by the early Christians. And certainly Jesus’ baptism of people with the Holy Spirit indicated more than purification. In this context the ritual represented purification from sin. It did not mean that the person was cleaned to remove dirt. Baptism was a ceremony that marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people.

Here are some ways to translate the word baptize in this context:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually wash

accept people as new Christians with water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

show that people have been made pure with God’s ceremonial bath

wash people in a ceremony/ritual with water to show the beginning of their lives as God’s pure people

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

You may need to use footnotes or a glossary to explain the meaning more completely.

See baptize, baptism in KBT.

1:25b

if you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet?”

- if/because you^(sing) are not the Christ, the Chosen One, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet?”
- As you have said, you^(sing) are not the Christ/Messiah, the Appointed One, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet.”
- Because you are not the Christ, the Promised Savior, nor Elijah, nor the promised prophet what gives you the right to do this?”

if you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet:

John had already said that he was not the Christ (that is, the Messiah), nor Elijah, nor the Prophet. The Pharisees accepted this as correct. They agreed with him about this. So it may be more natural to translate this clause like this:

because you are not the Messiah/Christ or Elijah or the prophet

the Christ: The term Christ is a title. It is not just one of Jesus’ names. This title refers to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and Savior. See how you translated this in 1:20b and the note on “Christ” at 1:17b.

Elijah: See how you translated this name in 1:21b.

the Prophet: See how you translated this term in 1:21d.

General Comment on 1:25a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 1:25a and 1:25b. For example:

^{25b}“Then because you are not the Christ, nor Elijah, nor the Prophet, ^{25a}by what right do you baptize?” they asked.

^{25b}“If you are not the Christ or Elijah or the Prophet, ^{25a}why do you baptize people?” (NCV)

General Comment on 1:24–25

In some languages it may be more natural to translate these verses using an indirect quote, possibly using more than one sentence. For example:

²⁴The Pharisees in the group of representatives ²⁵asked John to explain why he baptized people. He had admitted that he was not the Messiah, nor Elijah, nor the prophet so there had to be another reason.

John 1:26**Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah**

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:24–28

In this paragraph the Pharisees questioned John about his right to baptize people. John answered by saying that someone was standing among them who was much greater than he was.

1:26a–b

“I baptize with water,” John replied, “but among you stands One you do not know: John was declaring that he was not the important one. He was talking about someone in that group of people. That person was unknown right then but would be important later.

The contrast between John and the One you do not know should be made clear. It may be natural to include a word meaning “but.” For example:

John answered, “I baptize with water, but there is one here with you that you don’t know about.” (NCV)

John told them, “I baptize with water, but right here in the crowd is someone you do not recognize.” (NLT)

1:26a**“I baptize with water,” John replied,**

- “I baptize with/using water,” John answered them,
- John answered, “I only baptize with water,

I: This pronoun refers to John the Baptist.

baptize with water: This phrase refers to doing a special ritual that uses water to show that God makes his people pure. In this context the ritual represented purification from sin. See notes on 1:25a and baptize in KBT.

John replied: The Greek text, unlike the BSB, includes the pronoun “them,” referring to the Pharisees mentioned in 1:24. In some languages it may be natural to use the pronoun. For example:

John answered them (NRSV)

John replied to the Pharisees

1:26b**“but among you stands One you do not know.**

- “ but there stands among you^(plur) one whom is unknown to you.
- but here among you^(plur) is someone whom you do not know.

among you stands: This phrase here means “is present.” For example:

But here with you (CEV)

but right here in the crowd (NLT)

One you do not know: This phrase refers to Jesus. The people may have known his name, but they did not know that he was the Messiah.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to those asking the question and the crowd who were listening to John.

John 1:27

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:24–28

In this paragraph the Pharisees questioned John about his right to baptize people. John answered by saying that someone was standing among them who was much greater than he was.

1:27a

He is the One who comes after me,

- He is the one who comes/appears after me.
- Even though I came first,

Some translations, including BSB, NIV, GNT, NLT, and CEV, begin a new sentence here. But the Greek text continues the sentence begun in 1:26 (see the NRSV). You may do so also if it is natural in your language. For examples of other ways to divide the sentences, see the General Comment on 1:26–27.

He is the One who comes after me: Jesus was coming after John in the sense that his ministry would begin after John's. John had already begun his ministry, but Jesus had not yet begun his ministry. So consider what verb tense is most natural in your language. For example:

Even though I came first (CEV)

I preached before him, he will preach next.

1:27b

the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie.”

- I do not deserve to undo/remove his sandals.”
- I do not deserve to act as his slave/servant.”

the straps of whose sandals I am not worthy to untie:

In NT times people normally wore sandals on their feet. These sandals were fastened with thongs (leather strings or strips/straps). Slaves normally untied the thongs of the sandals of their masters. John was saying that he was not worthy (did not deserve) to serve Jesus as a slave. In some languages you may need to make this explicit. For example:

I am not even worthy to be his slave. (NLT)

General Comment on 1:26–27

There are different ways to divide the sentences in these verses. Consider what sentence length is natural in this context. Here are some other examples:

‘I baptize in water,’ John replied, ‘but among you, though you do not know him, stands the one who is to come after me. I am not worthy to unfasten the strap of his sandal.’ (REB)

John answered them, “I baptize with water. Among you stands one whom you do not recognize, who is coming after me. I am not worthy to untie the strap of his sandal!” (NET)

John 1:28

Section 1:19–28: John the Baptist said that he was not the Messiah

In this section John the Baptist told messengers from the Jewish leaders that he himself was not the Messiah. He had come to prepare people for the coming of someone else, someone much greater than he was. He was referring to Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist said that he prepared people for someone much greater than him

John the Baptist told about his mission

John the Baptist was not the Messiah

Paragraph 1:24–28

In this paragraph the Pharisees questioned John about his right to baptize people. John answered by saying that someone was standing among them who was much greater than he was.

1:28a**All this happened at Bethany beyond the Jordan,**

- All of this conversation took place in Bethany, on the east side of the Jordan River,
- It was in Bethany, which is on the east side of the Jordan River, that John said this.

All this happened: The pronoun this refers to the events of 1:19–27.

at Bethany beyond the Jordan: Scholars do not know where the Bethany mentioned here was. There is a textual issue here. Many Greek manuscripts have Bethany as do most English translations. Some Greek manuscripts have “Bethabara.” The KJV follows those manuscripts. John may have referred to a very small settlement, or he may have referred to the region of Betanea in the northeastern part of the country. Because this is not certain, it is better not to include information such as “the town of...” or “the region of...”

beyond the Jordan: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as beyond refers to being on the other side of the Jordan. The Jordan is a river that runs north-south. The main events in this story all take place on the west side of the Jordan, where Jerusalem is found. You may want to make clear which side of the river John refers to. For example:

on the east side of the Jordan River (NIV)

1:28b**where John was baptizing.**

- where John was baptizing people.
- It was here that John was baptizing people.

where John was baptizing: The verb was baptizing indicates that John baptized people there regularly over a period of time.

General Comment on 1:28a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 1:28a and b. For example:

John said this as he was baptizing east of the Jordan River in Bethany. (CEV)

John 1:29**Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God**

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God’s sacrifice for sin. John declared that Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:29a**The next day John saw Jesus coming toward him and said,**

- ¶ On the following/next day, John saw Jesus coming toward him, and he said,
- ¶ The day after this, John saw Jesus coming to him. John said to the people,

The next day John saw Jesus coming toward him:

Verse 1:29a introduces a significant point in the narrative. Try to emphasize this clause in some way. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

It was the day after this that John saw Jesus approaching him.

The next day: This phrase marks a new part of the story.

and said: John was speaking to the people in the crowd. In some languages it is more natural to include this information. For example:

Then John said to the people nearby

1:29b**“Look, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!”**

- “Look^(plur), this/he is the Lamb from God! He is the one who removes the sin of all people.
- “Pay^(plur) attention! This man is the Lamb that God has provided to take away the sins of the people of the whole world.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look is a way of telling people to give attention to something. John was telling all of the people there to look at Jesus.

Here are some other ways that this word has been translated:

There is (GNT)

Here is (NRSV)

the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!: John introduced Jesus by declaring that he was the one who would take away (remove) the sin of the world. The pronoun who refers back to the phrase the Lamb of God, not to the word God. The Lamb takes away sin.

the Lamb of God: This phrase is a title for Jesus. It probably means “the Lamb provided by God.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Lamb from God

the Lamb whom God has given/provided

This is a metaphor with more than one level of meaning. For example, the ancient Hebrews sacrificed lambs. See Genesis 4:4, Leviticus 1:10, and Isaiah 53:7. And at Passover time, each Jewish family took a lamb, killed it, and ate it. They also put the lamb’s blood on their door frames (what is around the door when it is shut). See Exodus 12:1–14. And Jesus himself died at Passover time. But the Jews also spoke of a lamb that would come in the end times. He would come as a soldier to remove sin. See Carson, p. 149. He mentions 1 Enoch 90:9–12, Testament of Joseph 19:8, and Testament of Benjamin 3:8. See also Revelation 5:6, 12, 7:17, 21:22–23.

We cannot know exactly what John the Baptist meant by this metaphor, nor what the Apostle John meant when he wrote it. So it is best to translate it literally. If this is not natural in your language, you may want to translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

This man is like a lamb from God. He removes the sin....

Lamb: A Lamb is a young sheep under a year old. Use the form that refers to a male lamb. If there are no sheep in your area, you may need to explain what

they are. You should not use another animal instead of sheep because of the importance of sheep in the Bible.

who takes away the sin of the world: This clause means “he will remove the sin of all people.” See 1 John 3:5, where a similar expression appears. John the author understood that Jesus as the Lamb of God would remove the world’s sin. He removed the world’s sin by dying on the cross as a sacrifice for sin. Also see Isaiah 53:7, where God’s suffering servant is compared to a lamb.

But some scholars suggest that the speaker, John the Baptist, was thinking about something else. They say that he was thinking about a lamb who is a conquering soldier. He would conquer and destroy sin (see Revelation 17:14). See also Revelation 5:6, 12–13, where the ideas of a sacrificial and a victorious lamb are combined.

But it is also possible that John the Baptist understood how Jesus would take away our sin. Even before he was born, he recognized that Jesus was special (see Luke 1:41–44). But we do not really know what John the Baptist meant. So you should translate literally, without indicating in what way “the Lamb” takes away the sin of the world.

In some languages you may not be able to say that an abstract idea like sin is removed. You may need to describe what it means that Lamb of God would take away the sin of the world. For example:

he will endure the punishment for people’s sin so that they do not have to

he will forgive the sin of people in the world

who will judge the world’s wicked people and save his people in the world from their sin

takes away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as takes away can also be translated as “removes” or “carries off.” As the Lamb of God, Jesus took away the sin of the world by dying as a sacrifice for their sins. Because of Jesus’ death, God would forgive the sin of the world. John the author understood this.

But John the Baptist did not know this yet. John the author is telling John the Baptist’s words, so you should not make this idea explicit. Instead, it is better to translate takes away with a general expression meaning “removes” or “destroys.” Jesus would end the sin of the world. He would defeat and destroy

the power of evil over humanity. Sin would no longer control people. No longer would people want to sin.

Here are other ways to translate this verb:

removes

destroys

carries off

sin: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sin is in the singular. The word here refers to wrongdoing in general, not to one specific sin. So you may need to translate it in the plural, “sins.”

The word sin refers to offenses against God or another person. Sin is the act of disobeying God’s law. Specific sins include acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. In Greek, the verb that English translations translate as sin is also a term that writers have used when writing about shooting arrows to mean “miss the target.” When a person sins, he “misses” the target, that is, he fails to reach God’s standard. A person can also offend God by not doing what God wants him to do.

Try to translate sin with a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sin. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sin.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes that are not against God’s will.

Here are some translation examples:

wrong action/behavior

offenses against God

evil deeds

In some languages it may be natural to translate sin with a phrase that includes a verb. For example:

the wrong/evil things that people do

See KBT Sin A.3. See how you translated “sins” in Matthew 1:21 and Mark 2:5.

the world: The word world here means “the people who live in the world.” The Lamb of God removes the sin of anyone in the world who receives him and believes in him. He does not just remove the sin of Jews.

John 1:30

Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God’s sacrifice for sin. John declared that Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:30a

This is He of whom I said,

- He is the one I meant when I said,
- I was speaking about him when I told you^(plur) that

This is He of whom I said: This and He and whom all refer to Jesus. Jesus was related to John the Baptist (Luke 1:36), so John surely recognized him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This is the one I was talking about when I said (GNT)

He is the one I told you about when I said (CEV)

Here is the man I was referring to when I told you that

1:30b

‘A man who comes after me has surpassed me

- ‘Someone is coming after me who is greater than me
- a man who comes behind me is more important than I am,

A man who comes after me has surpassed me: John continued to talk about Jesus. Jesus was born after John and began his ministry after John, and he was

greater than John. See the notes on 1:15d, where the same clause is quoted. You should translate the clause the same way in both verses. For example:

After me comes a man who is greater than I am.
(NET)

Behind me comes one who has passed ahead of me. (NJB)

has surpassed me: This clause means that Jesus is more important than John the Baptist. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

who is far greater than I am (NLT)

He is greater than I am (CEV)

is more important than I am

1:30c because He was before me.'

- because he existed before I did.'
- because he was living/alive before I was born.

because He was before me: This clause states the reason why Jesus ranked ahead of John: Jesus existed before John was born. This is why he is greater than John. Because Jesus was younger than John, this implies that he existed with God before he was born. See the notes on 1:15e. Translate the clause the same way here and in 1:15e. For example:

because he existed before me (NET)

because he was alive before I was born (CEV)

John 1:31

Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God's sacrifice for sin. John declared that Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:31a I myself did not know Him,

- I myself did not recognize him.
- Until now, I did not recognize him as the Christ/Messiah,

I myself did not know Him: We can assume that John knew Jesus, because he was a relative (their mothers were related, perhaps cousins, as seen in Luke 1:36). However, previously he did not know that Jesus was the promised Messiah. For example:

I did not know who he was (GW)

I did not recognize him as the Messiah. (NLT)

1:31b–c
the reason I came baptizing with water was that He might be revealed to Israel: The Greek words that the BSB translates as the reason here indicate purpose. John's purpose in baptizing people was to reveal Jesus the Messiah to the people of Israel. At first John himself may not have realized that this was his purpose. God showed it to him when he baptized Jesus. Here are other ways to translate 1:31b–c:

I came baptizing with water so that he could be revealed to Israel. (NET)

I came to baptize with water to show him to the people of Israel. (GW)

I came baptizing with water in order to make him known to the people of Israel. (GNT)

1:31b but the reason I came baptizing with water was

- But the reason I came baptizing people with water was
- but I baptized people with water

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces something that is not expected. John did not know that Jesus was the Messiah (1:31a). So we do not expect that he will reveal the Messiah to Israel (1:31b). Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural for your language.

I: This pronoun refers to John the Baptist. He baptized with water as a way of preparing people for the coming of the Messiah.

baptizing with water: This phrase means to wash people with a special ritual that uses water. Baptizing people indicated that God had made them morally pure. See the note on 1:26.

1:31c

that He might be revealed to Israel.”

- so that the people of Israel would see/understand who he is.”
- so that the people of Israel would recognize him.”

that He might be revealed to Israel: The pronoun He refers to the man who was greater than John. He was the man who was the Chosen Savior or Messiah. John was to tell the people of Israel that the Messiah had arrived.

The verb phrase He might be revealed is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that he might be manifested to Israel (NASB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that the people of Israel would know who he is (NCV)

Translate this using the verb form that is most natural in your language.

John 1:32

Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God’s sacrifice for sin. John declared that Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:32a

Then John testified,

- Then John told what he had witnessed.
- Then John told how he knew who Jesus was. He said:

Then John testified: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testified indicates that John honestly reported what he had seen and heard. In some languages it is more natural to use a phrase or clause to make this clear. For example:

John told the people what he had seen and heard

1:32b

“I saw the Spirit descending from heaven like a dove and resting on Him.

- “I saw the Spirit come down from heaven like a dove,” he said. “The Spirit remained on Jesus.
- “I saw the Spirit come down from heaven as a dove and stay/rest on Jesus.

I saw the Spirit descending from heaven: The pronoun I refers to John the Baptist. He saw God’s Spirit come from God to earth.

the Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Spirit here refers to God’s Holy Spirit. See KBT 2(b).

like a dove: The Spirit came in the shape and manner of a dove. He was not a dove, and he did not become a dove. But he was like a dove in some way. See also Matthew 3:16, Mark 1:10, and Luke 3:22. This is not a metaphor, because there was really something that looked like a dove. Therefore, your translation should refer to an actual bird.

dove: A dove is a small white or gray colored bird similar to a pigeon. It has a gentle voice and was a symbol of being gentle and morally pure. It is also mentioned in Genesis 8:8–12. A dove or pigeon may not be known in your area or these birds may imply something bad. If either is true, you may translate this word like this:

- Use a general word for bird. For example:

like a small bird

- Use a bird that is known in your culture and that is similar to a dove/pigeon. It should be a bird that people consider good and harmless.

You may want to add a footnote that explains how Jews thought about doves. For example:

To the Jews, a dove was a symbol of someone who was pure and gentle.

and resting on Him: This clause indicates that the Holy Spirit stayed with Jesus. As the dove came to stay on Jesus, so the Spirit remained with Jesus.

John 1:33

Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God's sacrifice for sin. John declared that Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:33a

I myself did not know Him,

- I would not have known who he was,
- I only recognized Jesus as the Messiah

I myself did not know Him: The only reason that John recognized that Jesus was the Messiah was because God told him. Until he baptized Jesus, John did not realize that Jesus was the one who came to save the people. For example:

Before this I didn't know who he was. (CEV)

John probably knew Jesus' name, as they were related. But he had previously not recognized that Jesus was the Christ or Messiah, God's Chosen Savior. In some languages it is more natural to make that explicit. For example:

Until then I did not know that Jesus was the Christ/Messiah.

1:33b

but the One who sent me to baptize with water told me,

- except God, who sent me to baptize with water, told me that
- because God, who sent me to baptize with water, had told me that

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but introduces a strong contrast. It implies that after this next event, John did know who Jesus was.

the One who sent me to baptize with water: This phrase refers to God, who told John to baptize. In some languages you may need to make this explicit. For example:

God, who sent me to baptize with water (GNT)

told me: This clause indicates that God had previously spoken to John. He had given John instructions about how to recognize the Coming One, the Christ.

1:33c

'The man on whom you see the Spirit descend and rest

- the man on whom I see the Holy Spirit come down and stay
- the man on whom I would see the Holy Spirit come down and remain

The man on whom you see the Spirit descend and

rest: The subject of this sentence, The man, refers to Jesus. However, God did not tell John that it was Jesus. So in your translation you should not identify him by name. For example:

The man on whom you see the Spirit come down and rest (REB)

descend and rest: The Holy Spirit came down on Jesus and then stayed on or with him. It is important that both of these actions are present in your translation.

1:33d

is He who will baptize with the Holy Spirit.'

- is the person who will baptize people with the Holy Spirit.
- was the one who would baptize people with the Holy Spirit.

is He who will baptize with the Holy Spirit: In some languages it is more natural to include an object and say whom this man will baptize. For example:

this man is the One who will baptize people with the Holy Spirit

will baptize: The verb baptize indicates a ceremony or ritual of washing. In water baptism, this ritual involves using water. Water is a symbol of cleansing. In baptism with the Holy Spirit, the Holy Spirit cleanses and makes the person pure.

Holy Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Holy Spirit refers to the Spirit of God. The Holy Spirit is God, together with God the Father and God the Son. He is Spirit in that he is a living being who does not have a physical body. He is Holy in the sense that he comes from God and is God, unique, distinct from every other being. He is perfect in every way and is completely pure and sinless.

Here are some ways to translate Holy Spirit:

Spirit/Breath of/from God

Holy/Sacred Spirit

Do not imply that the Holy Spirit is like the ghost of a dead person or that God has died.

See Holy in KBT, A 2.

General Comment on 1:33

This verse contains a quotation that includes a quotation. John quoted God's words when he talked to the people. In some languages it may be natural to translate the included quotation as an indirect quote. For example:

^{33a}I myself did not know who Jesus was. ^{33b}But God, who sent me to baptize with water, told me about him. ^{33c}He said that I would see the Spirit descend and remain on him. ^{33d}That would tell me that he was the one who would baptize with the Holy Spirit.

^{33a}I myself did not know/recognize Jesus to be the Messiah. ^{33b}But the one who sent me to baptize with water told me about him. He said that ^{33c}the one on whom I witness the Spirit come down and rest ^{33d}is the one who will baptize with the Holy Spirit.

John 1:34

Section 1:29–34: John the Baptist saw Jesus and said that he was the Lamb of God

This section is the most important part of what John the Baptist said about Jesus. Here John identified Jesus as God's sacrifice for sin. John declared that

Jesus was the one on whom the Spirit came down, and that Jesus was the Son of God.

Here are other possible section headings:

John the Baptist saw Jesus and told people that he was the Lamb of God

John the Baptist told about who Jesus was

Jesus was the Lamb of God

1:34

I have seen and testified that this is the Son of God."

- I have seen this and I tell you^(plur) that this man is the Son of God."
- I saw/witnessed the Spirit descend on Jesus and declare that Jesus is truly the Son of God."

I have seen and testified: In this verse, John the Baptist refers back to what he said in 1:32. He repeats it to emphasize a point.

I have seen: This clause here indicates that John personally saw what God said would happen. He saw the Spirit come down on Jesus in the form of a dove. He heard God declare that Jesus was his beloved Son (Matthew 3:17, Mark 1:11, Luke 3:22). So he knew that Jesus was the one whom God was talking about. In some languages you may need to indicate what John had seen. For example:

I saw this happen (CEV)

I saw this happen to Jesus (NLT)

testified: The Greek verb testified means "report what you saw and heard." It is the same verb that appears in 1:32a.

this is the Son of God: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the Son of God. For example:

the Son of God (RSV) (BSB, NIV84, NRSV, GNT, ESV, KJV, NASB, CEV, GW, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have "the Chosen One of God." For example:

the Chosen One of God (NJB) (NJB, NET, NLT, REB, NIV2011)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because it has the best manuscript and English translation support. The reading “Son of God” is supported by the UBS Greek text, with a B rating. Most older commentators support that reading, though Carson (1991, p. 152) favors “chosen one of God.” In 1998 an important Greek manuscript was published (P106) that said “chosen one of God.” This reading has since been adopted by the 2011 NIV. Also see Kostenberger p. 71 and note on p. 88 and footnote 122. He lists the commentators favoring “Son of God” as Bultmann, Borchert, Ridderbos, Beasley-Murray, and Laney. These were all prior to the discovery and publication of P106. More recently, Keener also follows this reading. The reading “Chosen One of God” is followed by Carson, Morris, Burge, Barrett, Brown, and Schnackenburg. Many commentators also support it. However, if the major language translation in your area follows option (2), you may choose to follow that. Both the Son of God and “the Chosen One of God” were titles for the Messiah. See Psalm 2:7, 12, and Isaiah 42:1 and Luke 23:35.

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title was often used to refer to a savior who would be a descendant of King David. God would send this savior to rescue his people. This person was often referred to as the “Messiah” or “Christ.”

The title the Son of God also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. The relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship of human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. The Son of God existed eternally as the Son with his Father.

In areas where people do not understand the title Son of God in this way, you may want to include a footnote that explains the correct meaning. Here is a suggested footnote:

This title refers to Jesus. It indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It does not mean that God the Father had a sexual relationship with Mary that resulted in her becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus. Mary became pregnant with Jesus in a miraculous way by the Holy Spirit of God.

In some languages, it is natural to speak of a son as a “child,” without specifying male or female. If that is true in your language, you may use a more general term. For example:

Child of God A translation of the title “the Son of God” must include a familial term such as “son” or “child.” Translations such as “the man who is God,” “the divine man,” or “the God man” are not acceptable, because they do not retain familial language. Examples of acceptable translation options include “the Son who comes from God,” and “the divine/unique/eternal Son of God.”

Other verses will usually make clear that Jesus was a male child. If you use a phrase such as “the male child of God,” be sure that it does not imply that God had another child who was female.

General Comment on 1:33–34

In some languages it is more natural to reorder these verses. For example:

Then John said to the people, ^{33b}“God sent me to baptize with water. He told me that I would see ^{33c}the Holy Spirit come down and rest on a man. ^{33d}That man is the one who will baptize with the Holy Spirit. ^{33a}I did not know who that would be ³⁴but then I saw it happen to Jesus. I tell you this is the Son of God.”

John 1:35

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus’ first disciples. Two of John the Baptist’s disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus’ first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:35–39

Two of John’s disciples heard that Jesus was the Lamb of God and began to follow him. Jesus asked them what they wanted, and they told him they wanted to

know where he was staying. Jesus then invited them to come and see.

1:35

The next day John was there again with two of his disciples.

- ¶ The following day John was there again with two of his disciples.
- ¶ The next day John was at the river again with two of his followers.

The next day: This phrase introduces a new part of the story. This phrase was also used in 1:29a.

John was there again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as John was there again indicates that John the Baptist was present during this next part of the story also. In some languages it is more natural to indicate where John was standing. For example:

John was again standing/present at that place

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to a learner who is in a special relationship with a teacher. The learner commits himself to his teacher in order to learn and follow his teaching and example. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use a term that refers to someone who learns from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learner is often with his teacher. For example:

learner/student

apprentice Be careful not to use a term that can only refer to a student in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to someone who follows a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and actually following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

follower

one who is committed/faithful (to a teacher/leader)

See also disciple in KBT.

John 1:36

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus' first disciples. Two of John the Baptist's disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus' first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:35–39

Two of John's disciples heard that Jesus was the Lamb of God and began to follow him. Jesus asked them what they wanted, and they told him they wanted to know where he was staying. Jesus then invited them to come and see.

1:36a

When he saw Jesus walking by,

- When he saw Jesus going by,
- He saw Jesus going by

When: The Greek begins with a conjunction that the NRSV translates as "and." Other translations, such as the BSB, start a new sentence instead. You should translate this conjunction in the way that is most natural for your language.

1:36b

he said, "Look, the Lamb of God!"

- he said, "Look^(plur), there is the Lamb of/from God!"
- and told his disciples/followers, "There is the Lamb that God has provided!"
- and told his disciples/followers that Jesus was the Lamb that God sent.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look asks people to give attention and emphasizes the next statement. It is the same word as in 1:29b. See how you translated it there.

the Lamb of God: This is a title for Jesus Christ. See how you translated this title in 1:29b.

John 1:37

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus' first disciples. Two of John the Baptist's disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus' first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:35–39

Two of John's disciples heard that Jesus was the Lamb of God and began to follow him. Jesus asked them what they wanted, and they told him they wanted to know where he was staying. Jesus then invited them to come and see.

1:37

And when the two disciples heard him say this, they followed Jesus.

- The two men/followers heard this and began to follow Jesus.
- When John's two disciples heard him say that, they followed Jesus.

the two disciples: These were the two followers of John the Baptist mentioned in 1:35. Refer back to them in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

John's two disciples heard what he said

heard him say this: The pronoun him refers to John the Baptist. The two men heard John say that Jesus was the Lamb of God (1:36b). In some languages it is more natural to indicate something of what John said. For example:

heard John say this about Jesus

they followed Jesus: Here the verb followed indicates that the men physically walked behind Jesus. Here is another way to translate this clause:

went with Jesus (GNT)

John 1:38

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus' first disciples. Two of John the Baptist's disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus' first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:35–39

Two of John's disciples heard that Jesus was the Lamb of God and began to follow him. Jesus asked them what they wanted, and they told him they wanted to know where he was staying. Jesus then invited them to come and see.

1:38a

Jesus turned and saw them following.

- Jesus turned around and saw them following him.
- Jesus noticed the two men following him.

Jesus turned and saw them following: Jesus turned and faced these disciples. Previously they were behind him.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus looked around and saw them following.
(NLT)

1:38b

“What do you want?” He asked.

- He asked them, “What do you^(dual) want?”
- He turned and asked them, “What are you^(dual) looking for?”

“What do you want?” He asked: This was the first time that these two men followed Jesus. Jesus asked them what they wanted that would cause them to follow him. This is not a severe reply or a rebuke. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What do you want? (NET)

Are you looking for something? Can I help?

1:38c

They said to Him, “Rabbi” (which means Teacher), “where are You staying?”

- These disciples of John said “Where are you^(sing) staying, Rabbi?” (Rabbi can be translated as “teacher.”)
- John’s disciples said to Jesus, “We^(excl/dual) would like to know where you^(sing) are staying, Rabbi.” (The word Rabbi means “teacher.”)

They said to Him: The pronoun They refers to the two disciples. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit here. For example:

John’s disciples said...

“Rabbi” (which means Teacher): The author John explained the meaning of the title that John’s disciples used for Jesus.

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” When John wrote his Gospel, this word was a title of respect. People used it for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a school teacher.

(which means Teacher): These words are in parentheses because they are John’s explanation of the word “Rabbi.” They are not part of what the disciples said. In some languages it may be natural to mark this information as parenthetical in a different way. For example:

—which means Teacher— (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

(This word means “Teacher.”) (GNT)

(This word in our^(incl) language means “Teacher.”)

where are You staying?: This phrase is a request to learn where Jesus was living at that time. It implies that the men wanted to learn more from Jesus.

General Comment on 1:38c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

They answered, “Where do you live, Rabbi?” (This word means “Teacher.”) (GNT)

John 1:39

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus’ first disciples. Two of John the Baptist’s disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus’ first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:35–39

Two of John’s disciples heard that Jesus was the Lamb of God and began to follow him. Jesus asked them what they wanted, and they told him they wanted to know where he was staying. Jesus then invited them to come and see.

1:39a

“Come and see,” He replied.

- “Come^(dual),” Jesus answered, “and you^(dual) will see.”
- Jesus told them^(dual), “You^(dual) are welcome to come and see.”

Come and see: This Greek word that the BSB translates as Come here indicates that Jesus was persuading or inviting the two men to come with him. If the simple command Come sounds rude, you may want to say this:

You^(dual) are welcome to come and see.

Please come and see.

The implied subject of both verbs is “you two” and refers to the two disciples.

see: The Greek word that the BSB translates as see here can mean to find out, understand, or discover. However, here it seems to mean literally “see.” Jesus wanted the disciples to see for themselves where he was staying. Here is another way to translate this word:

and I will show you.

He replied: The He refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make this more explicit. For example:

Jesus told them (GW)

1:39b

So they went and saw where He was staying,

- They^(dual) went with Jesus and saw where he was staying
- So the two of them followed Jesus to the place where he was staying.

So they went and saw where He was staying: The pronoun they refers to these two disciples of John. The pronoun He refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

So the two men went with Jesus and saw where he was staying (NCV)

1:39c

and spent that day with Him.

- and spent the day with him.
- Then they stayed with him the rest of that day.

and spent that day with Him: This refers to the rest of the day—the late afternoon and evening. It may be more natural to translate this in this way:

and spent the rest of the day with him

So they stayed on for the rest of the day. (CEV)

1:39d

It was about the tenth hour.

- It was about four o'clock in the afternoon.
- This conversation took place late in the afternoon.

It was about the tenth hour: In that culture the day began at sunrise, about 6 o'clock in the morning. The sun set around 6 p.m. The daylight hours were divided into twelve (12) units, so the tenth hour was about 4 p.m.

It is not clear in the Greek what happened about the tenth hour. Some think that it refers to the time that Jesus invited John's two disciples to come with him. Others think that it refers to the time when they arrived or finished talking at Jesus' place. Some think that because it was late in the day, the disciples spent the night there. Because the Greek is not clear what

about the tenth hour refers to, it is recommended that your translation does not make it clear.

General Comment on 1:39b–d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 1:39b–d and state the time of day earlier. For example:

^{39d}It was already about four o'clock in the afternoon ^{39b}when they went with him and saw where he lived. ^{39c}So they stayed on for the rest of the day. (CEV)

^{39d}It was about four o'clock in the afternoon ^{39b}when they went with him to the place where he was staying, ^{39c}and they remained with him the rest of the day. (NLT)

^{39b}So then they followed Jesus to his home. ^{39d}It was late afternoon. ^{39c}They stayed there with him that day.

John 1:40

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus' first disciples. Two of John the Baptist's disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus' first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:40–42

This paragraph tells how Andrew and Simon Peter became disciples of Jesus. Peter is one of the more important characters in the Gospel of John. Introduce him as you introduce an important character in a story.

1:40a

Andrew, Simon Peter's brother,

- ¶ Andrew, the brother of Simon Peter,
- ¶ There was a man named Andrew. (He was the brother of Simon Peter.)

1:40b

was one of the two who heard John's testimony and followed Jesus.

- was one of the two men who had heard what John said and had followed Jesus.
- He was one of these/those two disciples who listened to John and followed Jesus.

1:40a–b

Andrew, Simon Peter's brother: Andrew may have been younger than or older than Simon Peter. We do not know. But Simon Peter was the better known among the Christians for whom John was writing. At the time of this story, Jesus had not yet given Simon the name Peter. The mention of Simon Peter here is therefore parenthetical and it may be natural to place it in parentheses:

Andrew (Simon Peter's brother)

In some languages you may need to include a verb. At the time when John wrote this Gospel, it is probable that both Andrew and Peter were dead. So it is best to use the past tense:

Andrew, who was Simon Peter's brother

Simon Peter's: Simon Peter was one of Jesus' closest disciples. He later became a major leader in the early church. He is also known for denying Jesus when he was arrested. His original name was Simon. In 1:42, Jesus said that he would be called Cephas, which is Peter in Greek. If people will think that Peter is Simon's last name, you may want to make it clear that both names are used as his first name. For example:

the brother of Simon, who was also called Peter

one of the two who heard John's testimony and followed Jesus: Two disciples of John the Baptist had begun following Jesus (1:35–39). In some languages it is more natural to include what John the Baptist had said. For example:

one of the two men who heard John speak about Jesus and followed Jesus

one of the two who began following Jesus when they heard John call Jesus the Lamb of God

John 1:41**Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples**

This section tells about some of Jesus' first disciples. Two of John the Baptist's disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus' first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:40–42

This paragraph tells how Andrew and Simon Peter became disciples of Jesus. Peter is one of the more important characters in the Gospel of John. Introduce him as you introduce an important character in a story.

1:41a**He first found his brother Simon**

- The first/next thing Andrew did was to find his brother Simon
- Andrew immediately went to find his brother.

He first found his brother Simon: The Greek word that the BSB translates as first here means "before doing anything else," "at once." For example:

At once he found his brother Simon. (GNT)

found his brother Simon: Andrew found his brother. In your translation, you should not imply that Simon was lost. Andrew simply learned where he was and joined him, that is, went to where he was. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

went to his brother Simon

his brother Simon: In 1:40a the author has already stated that Simon and Andrew were brothers. In some languages it may not be natural to repeat this information again so soon. If this is the case in your language, you may want to follow the NJB:

The first thing Andrew did was to find his brother (NJB)

Here John refers to Simon Peter as Simon, his original name, instead of the combination Simon Peter.

1:41b

and told him, “We have found the Messiah” (which is translated as Christ).

- and tell him, “We^(excl) have found the Messiah.” (This word in Greek is “Christ.”)
- He told him/Simon that they^(dual) had found the Messiah, (that is, the Christ, the Chosen One).

“We have found the Messiah” (which is translated as Christ): The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Christ and the Hebrew word Messiah both mean “the anointed one.”

Here is another way to translate 1:41b:

‘We have found the Messiah’ (which is the Hebrew for Christ) (REB)

We have found the Messiah: The Jewish people had been waiting for the Messiah for hundreds of years. They hoped that he would save them from the foreign nations that oppressed them. To see the Messiah would be the most joyful part of their lives. So this is a very important message. Andrew understood and believed what John the Baptist said about Jesus.

In your translation, you should avoid indicating that the Messiah was lost and therefore had to be found. If a literal translation has this meaning, you may want to say this:

We saw the Messiah.

We have discovered who the Messiah is!

the Messiah: This phrase is a title. The Jews used this title to refer to a person whom God had appointed and promised to send. He would be King and Savior. See Isaiah 9:6, Zechariah 9:9, 12:10. Also see Christ, Messiah in KBT.

You may want to include a footnote to explain the meaning of the Messiah. For example:

The title “the Messiah” refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send to his people. It means the same as “the Christ.”

which is translated as Christ: The BSB places this clause in parentheses because it is background, parenthetical information. To help his readers, the writer

John explained in Greek the meaning of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” If people do not know what Christ means, but know the title Christ, you may want to say this:

This word means “Christ.” (GNT)

(which means Christ, “the anointed one”)

John 1:42

Section 1:35–42: Jesus chose his first disciples

This section tells about some of Jesus’ first disciples. Two of John the Baptist’s disciples started to follow Jesus after John told them that he was the Lamb of God. One of them was Andrew and he brought his brother Simon to meet Jesus. Jesus told Simon that his new name would be Peter.

Here are other possible section headings:

The first disciples began to follow Jesus

A few men began to follow Jesus

Jesus’ first disciples/followers

Paragraph 1:40–42

This paragraph tells how Andrew and Simon Peter became disciples of Jesus. Peter is one of the more important characters in the Gospel of John. Introduce him as you introduce an important character in a story.

1:42a

Andrew brought him to Jesus,

- And he brought Simon to meet Jesus.
- And then Andrew brought his brother to Jesus.

Andrew brought him to Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Andrew is literally the pronoun “he.” Andrew led or took Simon to Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to identify Andrew like the BSB does.

1:42b

who looked at him and said, “You are Simon son of John.

- Jesus gazed at Simon and said, “You^(sing) are Simon and your father is John.
- Looking at his/Andrew’s brother, Jesus said, “You are called Simon, John’s son.

who looked at him and said: The pronoun him refers to Simon.

You are Simon son of John: Jesus used the phrase that people normally used to identify Simon. As there were many Simons living at that time, people identified him as the son of a man named John. This does not refer to the author John or to John the Baptist. Check that your readers do not think that Jesus was saying Simon was the son of John the Baptist. John the Baptist was last mentioned in 1:40b, so some may think that he is the John referred to here. To make it clear that this was a different John, you may say something like this:

You are Simon, and your father is named John.

In some languages it may seem very strange for Jesus to tell a man who he is. In those languages you may need to translate the name as a direct form of address. For example:

Simon son of John, you will be called Cephas.
(CEV)

1:42c

You will be called Cephas”

- You^(sing) will be called Cephas”
- But I will call you^(sing) Cephas.”

You will be called Cephas: This clause indicates that Jesus was giving Simon a new name, Cephas. Because there is a contrast with 1:42b, you may supply the word “but.” For example:

but you will be called Cephas (GNT)

This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be called Cephas (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

I will call/name you Cephas.

From now on your name is Cephas. (JBP)

1:42d

(which is translated as Peter).

- (which, when translated, is Peter).
- (The Greek form of Cephas is Peter, meaning “rock”).

which is translated as Peter: This clause is not part of Jesus’ speech. It is the author’s explanation of the Aramaic name Cephas. The Greek name Peter means “rock,” that is, bedrock, which is a huge area of solid rock under the dirt. It was a symbol of something that endures and is permanent and steady. Rock is permanent and endures, and Jesus was saying that Simon would be like that. He was giving Simon this name as a symbol of what he would become.

This is a passive clause. There are several ways to translate it:

- using a passive verb. For example:

This name can be translated as “Peter.” (CEV)

- using an active verb. For example:

which means “Peter” (GW)

It may help to let readers know that both Peter and Cephas mean “rock.” For example:

(that is, Peter, ‘the Rock’). (REB)

that is, Peter, meaning “a rock” (JBP)

Perhaps in your language the word “rock” is not a symbol for being permanent. Instead it could indicate that Cephas was stubborn or difficult. If that is true in your language, you may want to translate literally here. Include only the name Peter in the text, and then in a footnote explain that Peter meant “rock.” Also explain that this was a symbol that Peter would be steady as a disciple.

After this verse, Peter is called Peter or Simon Peter. The only exception is when Jesus called him “Simon, son of John” three times in 21:15–17. And even there, what Jesus said is introduced by “Jesus said to Simon Peter.”

John 1:43

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:43a

The next day Jesus decided to set out for Galilee.

- ¶ The following day Jesus decided to go to Galilee.
- ¶ The day after that Jesus decided to leave for the area/region called Galilee.

The next day: The time phrase The next day introduces a new part of the story. See the notes on 1:29a and 1:35, where the same phrase appears.

Jesus decided to set out for Galilee: The Greek text has a singular masculine subject for the verb decided. The BSB has supplied the subject Jesus. Jesus did not leave alone; his disciples were with him. So you may need to say this:

The next day Jesus decided that they would go to Galilee.

to set out: The verb set out here means to begin a journey. The travelers certainly walked.

for Galilee: Galilee is the name of a district north of Judea. In some languages it is more natural to say this:

the district called Galilee

the region/area called Galilee

1:43b

Finding Philip, He told him, “Follow Me.”

- He found Philip and Jesus said to him “Come, follow^(sing) me.”
- He went to a man called Philip and invited him to become one of his followers/disciples.

Finding Philip, He told him: This is the first time Philip has been mentioned. Introduce him in a way that is natural in your language. It is not clear whether Jesus found Philip before he went to Galilee or after he went.

Finding Philip: Jesus found Philip and went to him. Philip was not lost. In some languages you may need to say this:

Saw a man called Philip and went to him

Follow Me: The Greek phrase Follow Me is an invitation for Philip to come with Jesus and learn from him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Come with me! (GNT)

Become my disciple

John 1:44

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:44

Now Philip was from Bethsaida, the same town as Andrew and Peter.

- Philip, like Andrew and Peter, was from the town of Bethsaida.
- Philip’s hometown was Bethsaida. Andrew and Peter also came from Bethsaida.

Now Philip was from Bethsaida, the same town as Andrew and Peter:

Bethsaida was probably a fishing village on the northeast shore of the Sea of Galilee. Here are other ways to translate this:

Philip, like Andrew and Peter, was from the town of Bethsaida (NIV)

Philip was from Bethsaida, the town where Andrew and Peter lived (GNT)

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now is not a time word. Here it introduces some parenthetical information. You should introduce this information in a way that is natural in your language.

Andrew and Peter: These are the disciples first mentioned in 1:40. Peter is the same person as Simon Peter in that verse.

John 1:45

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:45a

Philip found Nathanael

- Philip found a man called Nathanael
- Philip then went to his friend Nathanael.

Philip found Nathanael: Nathanael may be the same person as the apostle Bartholomew mentioned in the other three Gospels (Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18, Luke 6:14). However, there is no direct evidence of this, apart from the link with Philip in the lists of the twelve (12) apostles. You should not mention it in the text.

1:45b

and told him, “We have found the One Moses wrote about in the Law, the One the prophets foretold—

- and told him, “We^(excl) have found the One/man whom Moses and the prophets wrote about in God’s Word.
- He said to Nathanael, “You^(sing) know how Moses wrote in the Law about the Messiah! You know how the prophets wrote about him too! Now we^(excl) have discovered who he is!

and told him: The pronoun him refers to Nathanael. In some languages it is more natural to use both names. For example:

and Philip said to Nathanael

We have found the One Moses wrote about in the Law, the One the prophets foretold: Moses lived

perhaps thirteen hundred or fourteen hundred (1300 or 1400) years before Christ. The Jews respected him as the author of the Law. The prophets all lived several hundred years before Christ. In some languages it is natural to indicate that these were ancient figures. For example:

We^(excl) have found the person that Moses long ago wrote about in our^(incl) Law. The prophets also wrote about him.

We have found the One: The Messiah was not lost, but nobody knew who or where the Messiah was. See the note on 1:41b. You may want to translate this in a way that shows that the men had identified the Messiah. For example:

We have found the very person Moses and the prophets wrote about. (NLT)

We: This pronoun is exclusive and does not include Nathanael. Probably, Philip had talked with Peter and Andrew, and the pronoun includes at least those three men.

the Law, the One the prophets: The phrases the Law and the prophets together refer to the entire Jewish or Hebrew Scriptures. Today Christians refer to this as the “Old Testament,” but it was not called that during Jesus’ lifetime. That was because the New Testament was not yet written and there were not two testaments to distinguish. In some languages it may be natural to translate these phrases in this way:

the books containing our laws...the books of prophecies

the Law: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Law here refers to the first five books of the Hebrew Scriptures, Genesis through Deuteronomy. They contain historical material, prophecies, and poetry as well as laws. Philip was probably thinking about the prophet that Moses wrote about in Deuteronomy 18:15, 18–19.

the prophets: A prophet was a man who spoke as a representative of God. He told people what God revealed to him. When Philip referred to the prophets, he meant the ones whose writings are in the Hebrew Scriptures. See the note on “prophet” at 1:21d and 1:23b. There are many passages in the prophets that predict the coming of the Messiah.

1:45c**Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph.”**

- He is Jesus of/from Nazareth, the son of Joseph.”
- His name is Jesus, the son of Joseph, and he comes from Nazareth village.”

of Nazareth: Jesus came from Nazareth. He was not born there, but he grew up there. Nazareth was probably a very small settlement, only a village. In some languages you may need to indicate this. For example:

from the village of Nazareth

the son of Joseph: In Jesus’ culture, people did not have a surname or family name. Instead, they were identified by their given name and their father’s name. Joseph had cared for Jesus and brought him up as his son.

John 1:46**Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him**

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:46a**“Can anything good come from Nazareth?” Nathanael asked.**

- “Nazareth! Can something/someone good come from there?” Nathanael asked.
- Nathanael said, “I cannot imagine anything of value coming from Nazareth.”
- Nathanael asked him if there could be anything good from Nazareth.

Can anything good come from Nazareth?: This is a rhetorical question. Nathanael used it to make fun of Nazareth. He did not think that Nazareth was a good place. The implied answer to the question is “No, nothing good can come from Nazareth.”

There are two ways to translate this scorn:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

‘Nazareth!’ Nathanael exclaimed. ‘Can anything good come from Nazareth?’ (REB)

From Nazareth? Can anything good come from that place? (NJB)

- Use a statement. For example:

Everyone knows that nothing good can come from Nazareth.

Nothing from Nazareth is useful.

Translate this scorn in a way that is most natural in your language. It may have been a common proverb or saying. People from other towns perhaps said this in order to scorn Nazareth. They thought that Nazareth was just an unimportant country village.

good: In this context the word good means useful, deserving, or valuable.

1:46b**“Come and see,” said Philip.**

- “Come^(sing) and meet him,” said Philip.
- Philip told him to come/go and meet Jesus.

Come and see: Philip invited Nathanael to meet Jesus. The commands Come and see are in the singular and refer to Nathanael. Here are some other ways to translate these commands:

Come and meet Jesus

Come and see for yourself (NLT)

John 1:47**Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him**

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:47a

When Jesus saw Nathanael approaching, He said of him,

- Jesus saw Nathanael approaching him and said about him,
- Nathanael went to meet Jesus. Jesus saw him approaching and said to the others,

There is implied information here: Nathanael decided to go and see Jesus, and then set out. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

So Nathanael went to meet Jesus.

When Jesus saw Nathanael approaching, He said of him: The pronoun He refers to Jesus and him refers to Nathanael. In some languages it may be natural to use one or both of these names. For example:

As Jesus saw Nathanael come toward him, Jesus spoke to the other disciples about Nathanael.

1:47b

“Here is a true Israelite, in whom there is no deceit.”

- “This man is a true Israelite. He does not deceive/lie.”
- “Here is a real/genuine Israelite, a sincere man.”

Here is a true Israelite: When Jesus said the words Here is a true Israelite, he was saying something good about Nathanael. He was saying that Nathanael deserved to be called an Israelite.

Here are other ways to translate this statement:

Here is an Israelite who deserves the name

Now here is a true man of Israel (JBP)

Here is a real Israelite. (GNT)

How here is a genuine son of Israel. (NLT)

in whom there is no deceit: Jesus was saying that Nathaniel was not a liar or a hypocrite. Nathanael said what he believed and did not try to trick others. The

word deceit refers to an act of deceiving or not telling the truth. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

There is no deceit in him. (JBP)

And he isn't deceitful. (CEV)

in whom there is nothing false (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this using a positive statement. For example:

a man who is completely honest

who is sincere (GW)

John 1:48

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:48a

“How do You know me?” Nathanael asked.

- Nathanael asked Jesus, “Where did you^(sing) hear about me?”
- “How did you^(sing) learn who I am?” Nathanael asked.

How do You know me?: This is a real question. Nathanael asked Jesus how he knew what sort of person he was. It is implied that he had never met Jesus before.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

How can you know me? (JBP)

How do you know about me? (NLT)

1:48b

Jesus replied, “Before Philip called you, I saw you under the fig tree.”

- Jesus said to Nathanael, “I saw you^(sing) while you were still under the fig tree, before Philip called you.”
- “I saw you^(sing) before Philip called you. You were under the fig tree,” Jesus told him.

Before Philip called you, I saw you under the fig

tree: Jesus was pointing out that he knew something that a person did not know without help from God. This was a sign (evidence) that he was from God. He knew what Nathanael had been doing before Philip had invited him to go and meet Jesus. John does not say what Nathanael was doing under the fig tree, but in some languages you may need to include some information. For example:

I saw you sitting/resting under the fig tree.

Here is another way to translate this sentence that may be more natural in some languages:

I saw you in the shade of the fig tree.

the fig tree: This phrase refers to the specific fig tree that Nathanael had been under. The fig tree was a common tree in Israel. It normally produced small fruit called “figs” that they could eat. If speakers of your language are not familiar with the fig tree, here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the tree with a fruit called “fig”

the fruit tree

General Comment on 1:48b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in 1:48b. For example:

I saw you under the fig tree before Philip called you. (NRSV)

John 1:49**Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him**

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen

him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:49a

“Rabbi,” Nathanael answered, “You are the Son of God!”

- Then Nathanael said, “Teacher, you^(sing) are the Son of God!”
- Nathaniel declared, “Teacher, you^(sing) must be God’s Son!”

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” People used this word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a schoolteacher. See the notes on 1:38c, and use the same word in both verses.

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to Jesus.

the Son of God: This phrase was a title that Jews often used to refer to the coming savior who would be a descendant of King David. This person was also called the “Messiah” or “Christ.” This title also indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God.

See how you translated the Son of God at 1:34. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

1:49b

You are the King of Israel!”

- You^(sing) are the King of Israel!”
- You^(sing) must be the King of Israel that God promised!”

the King of Israel: The expression King of Israel was another title for the Messiah. Jewish people were expecting a king who would destroy those who oppressed them. He would rule over Israel and bring about peace and justice (for example, see Psalms 45, 72, Zechariah 9:9–10). See Matthew 27:42 and Mark 15:32, where the same title appears.

John 1:50

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:50a

Jesus said to him, “Do you believe just because I told you I saw you under the fig tree?”

- Jesus said to him, “Do you^(sing) believe just because I told you I saw you under the fig tree?”
- Jesus answered, “You^(sing) believe in me just because I told you about seeing you under that fig tree!”

Do you believe just because I told you I saw you under the fig tree?: Most English translations understand that this sentence is a rhetorical question. It likely expresses Jesus’ surprise that Nathanael believed on him so quickly and easily. There are two ways of translating this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you believe just because I told you I saw you when you were under the fig tree? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

You believe me just because I said: I saw you under the fig tree. (NJB)

You believe because I told you I saw you under the fig tree. (NIV)

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is natural in your language for expressing surprise. The GNT and the NJB, in the examples above, have both supplied the word “just.” It may be natural to include the word “simply,” which can mean “just” or “only.” For example:

Do you believe simply because I told you I saw you under the fig tree? (NCV)

you: The pronoun you is singular and refers to Nathanael.

General Comment on 1:50a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in 1:50a and first give the reason Nathanael believed. For example:

Because I told you that I saw you under the fig tree, do you believe? (NET)

1:50b

You will see greater things than these.”

- You^(sing) are going to see much greater miracles than that.”

You will see greater things than these: The greater things that Jesus mentions probably refer to the miracles Jesus would do in future weeks and months. The word things does not refer to larger or more important objects, but to events. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You are going to see greater things than that. (NJB)

You will see something even greater. (CEV)

You: This pronoun is still singular and refers to Nathanael.

these: The plural pronoun these is not in the Greek, but the BSB supplies it to help people understand the meaning. However, it refers specifically to Jesus telling Nathanael about the fig tree. So it may be more natural to use a singular pronoun. For example:

that (NIV)

this (NLT)

John 1:51

Section 1:43–51: Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to follow him

This section tells how Philip and Nathaniel became disciples of Jesus. Jesus showed them his power to know all things. He told Nathaniel that he had seen him under a fig tree. That showed Nathaniel that Jesus was the Son of God and King of Israel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus called Philip and Nathanael to be his disciples/followers

Jesus invited two more men to follow him

Philip and Nathanael became disciples

1:51a

Then He declared, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- He then added, “I tell you^(plur) something true/important.
- Jesus also said to them, “I promise you^(plur) this:

Then He declared: This phrase indicates that Jesus continued talking to Nathanael.

Truly, truly, I tell you: The phrase that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you can also be translated as “Very truly, I tell you,” as in the NRSV. Jesus often used this phrase to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and completely reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it. Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or something the speaker predicts. Here it introduces a promise.

In some languages you may need to translate the phrase in different ways in different contexts. Do not translate in a way that implies that Jesus had not been telling the truth at other times.

Here are some ways that English translations have translated the phrase in this context:

In all truth I tell you (NJB)

I am telling you the truth (GNT)

I tell you for certain that... (CEV)

you: The personal pronoun you is plural here. Jesus was speaking to the entire group of disciples gathered there, not just to Nathanael.

1:51b–c

1:51b–c is similar to the dream recorded in Genesis 28:12. In his dream the patriarch Jacob saw a ladder leading up to heaven and God’s angels ascending (going up) to and descending (going down) from heaven. Read the passage in Genesis before translating this verse. You may want to use similar words in both passages in order to help readers make the connection.

1:51b

you will all see heaven open

- You^(plur) will see heaven open
- You^(plur) will see heaven standing/wide open

you will all see heaven open: The pronoun you is plural here also. The phrase will...see heaven open is a figure of speech. Jesus was indicating that the disciples would receive a revelation from God. It would be like seeing into the spiritual world. See also Acts 7:56 and Revelation 4:1, where the same expression appears. If a literal translation does not give the correct meaning, you may need to say something like this:

it will look like heaven opens

it will be for you like heaven opening up

heaven: The word heaven in this context refers to the spiritual world, where God lives. People understood heaven to be above the earth

1:51c

and the angels of God ascending and descending on the Son of Man.”

- and God’s angels going up to heaven and down to earth by means of the Son of Man.”
- and upon the Son of Man, as upon stairs, God’s angels will go up to heaven/God and come down to earth.”

the angels of God ascending and descending on the

Son of Man: Verse 1:51c tells what the revelation from God would be: the Son of Man will link or connect heaven and earth. The whole clause is a metaphor. Angels would not literally walk on Jesus (the Son of Man). But God’s truth would be revealed through Jesus because he is the connection between heaven and earth. In some languages you may need to say where the angels ascend (go up) and descend (go down). For example:

on the Son of Man the angels of God will ascend to heaven and descend to earth

the angels of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Using a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God

good/holy spirit-beings sent from God

- Using a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already use a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. You may need to indicate the correct meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

Be sure that your term for “angel” is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.” See angel 1. in KBT.

on the Son of Man: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on the Son of Man:

1. it indicates that the Son of Man replaces the ladder in Jacob’s dream. For example:

on the Son of Man, the one who is the stairway between heaven and earth (NLT)

(NLT, probably NJB, CEV note)

1. it indicates that the Son of Man replaces Jacob in the dream. For example:

to the Son of Man (GW)

(GW)

Most English translations translate literally and say on or “upon” the Son of Man. These translations can be considered ambiguous. And that is a good option. But if you need to choose, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), which agrees with many commentators. Interpretation (1) is followed by the UBS Handbook, p. 52, Keener, pp. 489–491, Barrett, p. 187, F.F. Bruce, pp. 62–63, Brown, pp. 89–91, and Tasker, p. 54, who says “[Nathanael] now learns that Jesus is the real ladder by which the gulf between earth and heaven is bridged.” Interpretation (2) is followed by Carson, pp. 63–64, and Beasley-Murray, p. 28.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he was a representative for all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some possible translations:

the Human-born

the Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be suitable where readers are familiar with a literal title in another translation.

In some languages you may need to use a form like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

See Son of Man in KBT.

John 2:1

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus’ mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus’ disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:1–2

This paragraph introduces the setting for the story of the wedding at Cana.

2:1a

On the third day a wedding took place at Cana in Galilee.

- ¶ Two days later, a wedding took place in the town of Cana in the province of Galilee.
- ¶ Two days after that, a man and a woman got married in the village of Cana in the region of Galilee.

On the third day a wedding took place at Cana in Galilee: This sentence introduces the place and time of this event in the story of Jesus. Translate it in a way that is natural for beginning such a narrative.

third day: The Hebrew way of counting days was from sunset to sunset. A part of any day was counted as a whole day. So Jesus talked to Nathaniel on one day. John does not tell us what happened the next day. But on the day after that there was a wedding. Express this in the way most natural in your language. For example:

Two days later (GNT)

The day after the next day

a wedding took place: A wedding is a celebration that marks the beginning of a new marriage. In Jewish culture at that time, the parents first promised that their son and daughter would marry one another. Then several weeks or months later the bridegroom brought his bride home. This was celebrated by a week of feasting, with many guests invited. This celebration is the wedding referred to here. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

a wedding was celebrated

a man and woman celebrated their marriage

Cana in Galilee: Cana was a small town in the province or area of Galilee. In some languages it may be more natural to include this information here. For example:

the village of Cana in the province of Galilee

the town of Cana in Galilee (NCV)

2:1b

Jesus' mother was there,

- Jesus' mother was present at the wedding.
- Jesus' mother had been invited to the wedding and had arrived there.

Jesus' mother was there: Jesus' mother Mary was present at the wedding celebration. She is an important person in this story.

General Comment on 2:1a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 2:1a and b. For example:

Three days later Mary, the mother of Jesus, was at a wedding feast in the village of Cana in Galilee. (CEV)

John 2:2**Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine**

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:1–2

This paragraph introduces the setting for the story of the wedding at Cana.

2:2

and Jesus and His disciples had also been invited to the wedding.

- Jesus and his disciples also were invited to the wedding and were present there.
- Jesus and his disciples were also guests at the wedding.

Jesus and His disciples had also been invited to the wedding: This clause introduces the other important people in this story. Jesus and his disciples had received invitations to the wedding. It is implied that they accepted the invitation and went to the wedding.

Like Mary, they were present at the celebration. This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Jesus was also invited to the wedding with his disciples. (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The bridegroom's family had also invited Jesus and his disciples to the wedding.

Jesus and his disciples had also received invitations.

Jesus and his disciples were also among the guests. (REB)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” in a learner-teacher relationship. The learner follows his teacher in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example.

For information on how to translate the term “disciple” see 1:35 in the Notes. Also see disciple in KBT.

John 2:3

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:3–5

Jesus' mother noticed that the wine was gone and tried to convince Jesus to do something. He indicated

that it was not the right time for him to act. However, Jesus' mother told those around to obey him.

2:3a

When the wine ran out, Jesus' mother said to Him,

- ¶ When the wine was gone/finished, Jesus' mother said to him,
- ¶ While the wedding celebration was happening, the guests drank all the wine. Jesus' mother told him,

When the wine ran out: This is the situation when the action started in the story. The people at the wedding festivities (celebration) had drunk all the wine that the bridegroom's family had provided. There was none left. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When there was no more wine

When all the wine was used (NASB)

When the wine was gone (NIV)

In many languages it may be more natural to start the action of a story with a separate, independent clause. For example:

The wine supply ran out during the festivities.
(NLT)

The people/guests drank/finished all the wine.

wine: In this culture, wine was the common drink during meals among the Jews of Jesus' day. Wine is an alcoholic drink. It is made from the juice of a fruit called grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine.

In some areas, people may not be familiar with grapes or with wine. If that is true in your area, here are some other ways to translate wine:

- Use a general term for an alcoholic drink.
- Use a specific term that can also be used to refer to alcoholic drinks in general. For example:

millet beer

palm wine

something like palm wine

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

alcoholic grape juice

fermented grape/fruit juice

Jesus' mother said to Him: Jesus' mother spoke to him when and because all the wine had been drunk. You may want to make the reason-result relationship explicit in your translation. For example:

so Jesus' mother told him (NLT)

and that is why Jesus' mother said to him

2:3b

“They have no more wine.”

- “The people have no wine left.”
- “There is no more wine to serve the guests/people.”

They have no more wine: Jesus' mother knew Jesus could help with the need for more wine. She knew this was a serious problem for the hosts. She was implicitly asking Jesus to help.

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that this is an implied request. For example:

Jesus' mother said to him, “Look! The people do not have any wine to drink.”

Jesus' mother said to him, “There is no wine for people. Please help them.”

They: There are two ways to interpret the reference of the pronoun They.

1. The pronoun They refers to the guests. It means that the guests had nothing to drink. For example:

Jesus' mother said, “The guests have no wine to drink.”

1. The pronoun They refers to the hosts, the bridegroom's family. It means that the host and people in charge had nothing to offer the guests to drink. For example:

Jesus mother said, “The hosts have no wine to serve to the guests.”

Both interpretations represent the same situation. Either is acceptable.

wine: See how you translated this word in the last verse.

John 2:4

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:3–5

Jesus' mother noticed that the wine was gone and tried to convince Jesus to do something. He indicated that it was not the right time for him to act. However, Jesus' mother told those around to obey him.

2:4a

“Woman, why does this concern us?” Jesus replied.

- Jesus answered her, “Why are you^(sing) telling that to me, dear/respected woman?”
- Jesus replied, “Do^(sing) not ask me to help in this matter.
- “You should not ask me to help,” Jesus told his mother.

Woman: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Woman does not imply lack of affection or of respect. Use an expression that is a natural and polite way for a grown man to address an older woman. For example:

Ma'am

Dear woman (NIV)

why does this concern us?: This is a rhetorical question. There are two ways of understanding it:

1. Jesus used it mainly as a soft command. Jesus was telling his mother she should not ask him to help with this problem. For example:

You must not tell me what to do. (GNT) (NIV, RSV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, CEV, NCV, KJV)

1. Jesus used it mainly as a statement. Jesus was saying that the problem with the wine should not be important to either him or his mother. For example:

that's not our problem (NLT) (NLT, NASB, NRSV)

In both interpretations, a mild rebuke is implied. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English translations do. Here are other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

why are you saying this to me? (NET)

Why are you trying to get me to help with this?

Is this a problem you need to bring to me? No.

Jesus replied: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus replied comes before the question Jesus asked Mary. Place the speech introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus said to her, "Woman, what concern is that to you and to me? My hour has not yet come." (NRSV)

Jesus said to her, "Why did you come to me? My time has not yet come." (GW)

2:4b

"My hour has not yet come."

- This is not yet the right hour for me."
- It is not yet time for me to act."
- "This is not the day for me to show my glory/power."

My hour has not yet come: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My hour refers to the right time or occasion for Jesus to do something. The text does not say what he might do. It could refer to the time for Jesus to die, or the time to show that he was the Messiah. It is better not to make this explicit. Mary would not have known what hour Jesus was referring to. She may have assumed that he referred to the time for doing something about the lack of wine.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My time has not yet come. (NIV)

The right time for me has not arrived yet.

In some languages time or hours are not spoken of as "coming." In those languages it may be natural to say:

This is not yet the right hour for me to act.

This is not my time.

John 2:5

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:3–5

Jesus' mother noticed that the wine was gone and tried to convince Jesus to do something. He indicated that it was not the right time for him to act. However, Jesus' mother told those around to obey him.

2:5a

His mother said to the servants,

- Then his mother said to the servants,
- Jesus' mother told the servants anyway,
- But his mother told the servants

His mother said to the servants: It seems that Jesus' mother did not understand that Jesus' answer refused her request for help. She must have thought that at the right time Jesus would do something. Some translations imply this by supplying a conjunction. For example:

Jesus' mother then told the servants (GNT)

2:5b

“Do whatever He tells you.”

- “Whatever Jesus tells you^(plur) to do, do it.”
- “Obey/Follow^(plur) all his instructions.”
- to do whatever Jesus told them to do.

Do whatever He tells you: Jesus' mother told the servants that they should obey Jesus. For example:

Do whatever Jesus tells you to do (CEV)

John 2:6

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:6–10

This is the climax (the most important part) of the story. The servants filled six large water jars with water. When they poured some out, it had become very good wine.

2:6a

Now six stone water jars had been set there

- ¶ Near them were six water jars made from stone.
- ¶ Six stone water pots were sitting/placed there.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information that describes the scene at the wedding. It is not a time word here. Many English translations do not translate this word. You should introduce the following information in a way that is natural in your language.

six stone water jars had been set there: These jars or pots were made by hollowing out large rocks. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Standing nearby were six stone water jars (NLT)

Six stone water jars were sitting near them

had been set there: While the BSB translates this clause literally as passive as in Greek, in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example:

stood nearby (NIV)

2:6b

for the Jewish rites of purification.

- The Jews used these jars to hold water for their ceremonial washings.
- They were the kind used for the Jewish rites/ceremonies of purification.

for the Jewish rites of purification: This phrase gives some background information about the jars. John was addressing people who were not Jews, and he explained a Jewish custom to them. It was the Jewish custom to wash in a certain way before joining in religious rituals. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the kind used by the Jews for ceremonial washing (NIV)

They were used for Jewish purification rituals. (GW)

rites of purification: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rites of purification is more literally “purification.” A rite is a ceremony or ritual. In this context, the Jewish people washed in order to make themselves ceremonially pure. This washing was not intended to remove dirt but to prepare the person to approach God to worship. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this noun phrase using a verb. For example:

washing themselves in the way that their religion said they must (CEV)

General Comment on 2:6a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the information about ceremonial washing at the beginning of verse 6. For example:

^{6b}The Jews have rules about ritual washing, ^{6a}and for this purpose six stone water jars were there. (GNT)

2:6c

Each could hold from twenty to thirty gallons.

- Each jar could hold twenty (20) or thirty (30) gallons of water.
- They were big enough to contain about one hundred liters of liquid/water.

Each could hold from twenty to thirty gallons:

The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as twenty to thirty gallons is more literally “two or three measures.” The BSB translates this in terms of gallons, but you could express this in terms of liters instead. Each pot could hold (contain) 80–120 liters of water. Use the measuring system that is natural in your language.

John 2:7

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus’ mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus’ disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:6–10

This is the climax (the most important part) of the story. The servants filled six large water jars with water. When they poured some out, it had become very good wine.

2:7a

Jesus told the servants, “Fill the jars with water.”

- Jesus said to the servants, “Fill the jars with water.”
- Jesus told the servants to pour water into the pots until they were full.

Jesus told the servants, “Fill the jars with water.”:

The pots may have once been full, but as people washed, they emptied them. Jesus wanted to make sure all of them were full.

In some languages it is more natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

Jesus told the servants to fill the jars/pots with water.

Jesus told the servants to fill them to the top with water. (CEV)

2:7b

So they filled them to the brim.

- So they filled them with water to the top.
- So they poured water into each pot until they were completely full.

So they filled them to the brim: The pronoun they refers to the servants. The servants filled the water pots.

filled...to the brim: The phrase “fill to the brim” is an English idiom meaning to fill completely, to the very top.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

They filled each pot until it was completely full of water.

So they filled them up to the very top. (NET)

John 2:8

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus’ mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus’ disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:6–10

This is the climax (the most important part) of the story. The servants filled six large water jars with water. When they poured some out, it had become very good wine.

2:8a

“Now draw some out,” He said,

- Then he said to them, “Now pour^(plur) some out
- Then Jesus told the servants, “Now take^(plur) some of what is in the jars
- The Jesus told the servants to dip out some liquid from the pots

“Now draw some out,” He said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as draw...out means to get, take, or pour some liquid out of a container. For example:

Now take some water (CEV)

2:8b

“and take it to the master of the banquet.”

- and take^(plur) it to the man in charge of the feast.”
- and carry^(plur) it to the banquet leader.”
- and take it to the man in charge for him to taste.

and take it to the master of the banquet: The pronoun it refers to the water. The servants were to pour some of the water into a cup and give it to the chief steward.

the master of the banquet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as master of the banquet refers to the man in charge of the food for the wedding. He may have been a guest, a friend, or a servant like a butler. We do not know. The implied information is that this man would need to taste the drink so he could tell his opinion about it.

Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

the chief steward (NRSV)

the person in charge (GW)

the man in charge of the feast (CEV)

2:8c

They did so,

- The servants brought it
- They took/gave some to him.
- They did what Jesus asked them to do.

In Greek this phrase begins with a conjunction that introduces the servants’ response to Jesus’ command. Some English versions use a connector like “so.” Connect the events in a natural way in your language.

John 2:9

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus’ mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus’ disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:6–10

This is the climax (the most important part) of the story. The servants filled six large water jars with water. When they poured some out, it had become very good wine.

2:9a

and the master of the banquet tasted the water that had been turned into wine.

- to the man in charge of the feast, and he tasted it—the water had become wine!
- The water had changed into wine. The banquet leader tasted it,
- When the man in charge of the feast tasted it, it was wine,

and the master of the banquet tasted the water that had been turned into wine: The most important information in this clause is that the water had become wine. This is also the most important part of the story. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as an independent clause. For example:

The master of the banquet tasted the water—and it had been changed into wine!

that had been turned into wine: There are several ways to translate this clause. For example:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

that had been changed into wine

that had been turned into wine (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

that Jesus had changed into wine

the water that was now wine (NLT)

Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language for describing an important action.

The text does not say exactly when the water turned into wine. You should not supply this information.

2:9b

He did not know where it was from,

- He did not know where the wine had come from.
- but he did not know where it came from,

He did not know where it was from: The steward did not know that this wine was originally water that Jesus had transformed. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

He did not know where the wine came from (NCV)

not knowing its source (REB)

He did not realize where it had come from (NIV)

2:9c

but the servants who had drawn the water knew.

- But of course the servants who had poured out the water knew.
- although the servants who got/brought the water knew what Jesus had done.

but the servants who had drawn the water knew: This is parenthetical information. Although the BSB does not indicate this, the NRSV shows this by using parentheses. You should indicate that this is a parenthetical comment in a way that is natural in your

language. For example, you might want to use dashes instead of parentheses:

—though the servants who had drawn the water knew— (NJB)

General Comment on 2:9b–c

2:9c is in contrast to 2:9b. The man in charge of the feast did not know where the wine had come from. The servants did know. Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

but the servants who had brought the water knew (NCV)

2:9d

Then he called the bridegroom aside

- So the man in charge of the feast asked the bridegroom to come to him
- The banquet leader asked to speak to the bridegroom.

Then he called the bridegroom aside: The word that the BSB translates as called here means “sent for” or “asked to come.” The man in charge of the feast asked the bridegroom to come and talk to him.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he called the bridegroom over (NLT)

bridegroom: The term bridegroom refers to the man who marries the bride in a wedding ceremony.

General Comment on 2:9a–d

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the clauses of verse 9. For example:

^{9c}And the servants who had taken/dipped the water out of the pots/jars knew where the wine had come from, ^{9b}but the man in charge did not know. ^{9a}Therefore when he tasted the water that Jesus had changed into wine, ^{9d}he called the bridegroom...

General Comment on 2:9a–d

In the Greek, as in the BSB, this is one long sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to break this into two or more sentences. For example:

The person in charge tasted the water that had become wine. He didn't know where it had come

from, although the servers who had poured the water knew. The person in charge called the groom.... (GW)

John 2:10

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:6–10

This is the climax (the most important part) of the story. The servants filled six large water jars with water. When they poured some out, it had become very good wine.

2:10a and said,

- and told him,
- He said to the bridegroom,

and said: In some languages it may be more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He said to the bridegroom

2:10b

“Everyone serves the fine wine first,

- “Everyone serves the best wine first.
- “It is the custom to serve the expensive wine at the beginning of the feast.
- “Most people/hosts serve the wine with the best taste first,

Everyone serves the fine wine first: This is a bit of exaggeration to emphasize the point. Normally a bridegroom (or other host) served the best wine at the beginning of the meal.

the fine wine: The phrase the fine wine here means “the wine that has the best taste.” This would probably be the most expensive wine. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

A host always serves the best wine first. (NLT)

People always gives the good wine to their guests first.

2:10c

and then the cheap wine after the guests are drunk.

- They serve the cheaper/regular wine after the guests are drunk.
- They only serve the cheaper/ordinary wine when people have already had a lot to drink.
- and then when people are too drunk to notice the difference, they bring out the wine that is not as good.

and then the cheap wine: The phrase then the cheap wine is a short way of saying “then they will serve the cheap wine.”

the cheap wine: The word that the BSB translates as cheap refers to wine that is not as good quality. It is cheaper and its taste is not as good. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the inferior wine (NRSV)

the other wine (CEV)

after the guests are drunk: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as drunk refers to what happens when people drink too much alcohol. The guests would drink enough that their senses were not clear. They would not be able to think well. They would not know or care too much about the quality of the wine. So the host could serve the poorer wine.

In many languages there will be an idiom or euphemism that describes this state. For example:

when everyone has had a lot to drink (NLT)

after the guests have had plenty (CEV)

General Comment on 2:10a

In some languages it is more natural to translate this verse in the order of the events. For example:

When people are drunk, the host serves cheap wine. (GW)

Later, after the guests have been drinking awhile, they serve the cheaper wine. (NCV)

2:10d

But you have saved the fine wine until now!"

- But you^(sing) have reserved the best wine until now."
- But you^(sing) have served the best quality drink at the end!"

But you have saved: The word that the BSB has translated as saved means "saved for future use" or "not used yet." This good wine had not been served to the guests until now.

you: The pronoun you is singular and refers to the bridegroom.

the fine wine until now: The phrase the fine wine here means "the better wine" or "the best wine." It does not imply that the other wine was of poor quality. This wine that Jesus had made tasted better than the wine the guests drank before. Here is another way to translate this clause:

But you have saved the best wine for now. (GW)

General Comment on 2:10a–d

A literal translation of these words may imply that the leader of the feast criticized the bridegroom. In one sense, this is true. However, he mainly praised the bridegroom. He praised him for the excellent wine that Jesus made. Translate this verse in a way that the readers of your translation will understand this.

John 2:11

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus' mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus' disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:11

This verse forms the conclusion of this first miracle. It tells the result of Jesus' doing the miracle. The result was that the disciples put their faith in him in a stronger way. The miracle proved to them that he was the Messiah.

2:11a

Jesus performed this, the first of His signs, at Cana in Galilee.

- ¶ This is the first miracle that Jesus did. He did it in Cana of Galilee.
- ¶ It was in the town of Cana in the province of Galilee that Jesus did his first powerful sign/work.

Jesus performed this, the first of His signs, at Cana in Galilee:

The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Jesus performed this, the first of His signs is more literally "Jesus did this the beginning of the signs." This indicates that the first sign that Jesus gave was in Cana, in Galilee. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This was the first of Jesus' signs: it was at Cana in Galilee. (NJB)

This was Jesus' first miracle, and he did it in the village of Cana in Galilee. (CEV)

Jesus did this as the first of his miraculous signs, in Cana of Galilee. (NET)

signs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as signs refers to miraculous events that point to some truth beyond themselves. In this context the miracle that Jesus did pointed to his greatness. See KBT Miracle, Sign, Wonder, Mighty Work A.1.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

great deeds that reveal

powerful works that teach

miracles that tell something

at Cana in Galilee: Cana was a small town and Galilee a province. See the notes on 2:1a. It may be natural to make one or both of these facts explicit. For example:

in the village of Cana in Galilee (CEV)

2:11b

He thus revealed His glory,

- And in this way Jesus showed his glory,
- By it he demonstrated how great he was,
- By doing this amazing deed, Jesus allowed people/others to see his glory/greatness,

He thus revealed His glory: This expression indicates that Jesus showed people how great, wonderful, and glorious he was. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

showed his glory (NCV)

demonstrated/displayed how glorious he was

thus: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as thus is more literally “and.” This conjunction does not introduce a second and different event but rather it introduces another way to understand the same event. The miracle can be seen both as a sign and as a revelation of Jesus’ glory. For example:

the first of the signs which revealed his glory (REB)

glory: The Greek word the BSB translates as glory refers to something wonderful that reveals the presence of God. It is also visible evidence of the power of God. By this miracle Jesus showed that he was God’s Messiah. See how you translated glory in John 1:14. See also KBT glory, A2(b).

Here are other ways to translate this word:

greatness

divine majesty

2:11c

and His disciples believed in Him.

- and as a result, his disciples believed in him.
- and his disciples then trusted him.
- and his followers believed that he deserved their trust.

and His disciples believed in Him: Jesus’ disciples believed as a result of seeing this miracle. They saw Jesus’ glory, and so they trusted in him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and his disciples put their faith in him (NIV)

and as a result, his followers trusted in him

believed in: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b and 1:12b. See the examples above for other ways to translate this idea here.

General Comment on 2:11a–c

In the Greek, this is one long sentence (see the NRSV). In some languages it may be natural to break it into two or more sentences. For example:

So in Cana of Galilee Jesus did his first miracle. There he showed his glory, and his followers believed in him. (NCV)

This was Jesus’ first miraculous sign. He did it in the town of Cana in the province of Galilee. There he revealed how great he was, and his disciples trusted in him.

John 2:12

Section 2:1–12: Jesus changed water into wine

In this section Jesus, his disciples, and his mother went to a wedding. The guests there drank all the wine that the host had provided. Jesus’ mother told Jesus that there was no more wine, and then she told the servants to obey Jesus.

Jesus told the servants to fill the water jars with water. When they did that, he told them to serve some to the man in charge of the wedding. The man tasted it and said that the bridegroom had saved the best wine until the end of the wedding. This miracle convinced Jesus’ disciples to believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus did a miracle at a wedding

The wedding at Cana

Paragraph 2:12

This paragraph serves as a transition between the story about Jesus changing water into wine and the story about Jesus chasing traders out of the temple courtyard.

2:12a**After this,**

- ¶ Later on
- ¶ When the feast was finished,

After this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After this indicates that at this point there is a transition between stories. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

After the wedding (NLT)

2:12b**He went down to Capernaum with His mother and brothers and His disciples,**

- Jesus went to Capernaum with his mother, brothers, and disciples.
- together with his mother, his younger brothers, and his followers, Jesus traveled to the town/village of Capernaum.

He went down to Capernaum with His mother and brothers and His disciples: Capernaum is on lower ground than Cana, so Jesus would have traveled down a hill to get there. However, in some languages it is not natural to say whether someone is traveling up or down. If that is true in your language, you may want to leave this information implicit. For example:

Jesus and his mother, brothers, and disciples went to Capernaum (GNT)

Capernaum: Capernaum was a village in Galilee on the northern shore of Lake Galilee. Scholars think that probably about 1500 people lived there. It was about 16 miles (26 kilometers) from Cana. This village is often mentioned in the Gospel stories. See, for example, Matthew 4:13, Mark 2:21, and Luke 7:1.

brothers: Church groups differ in what they believe about Jesus' brothers. There are three main views:

- (1) They were the sons of Joseph and Mary, born after Jesus.
- (2) They were Jesus' cousins.
- (3) They were children of Joseph from a previous marriage. That is, they were Jesus' step-brothers.

The Hebrew and Aramaic words for "brother" do not distinguish between brothers and cousins. It is good to use a general word for "brother" that could apply to any of the views above. For example, you may have a word that could refer to these three kinds of people:

- (a) brothers with the same father and mother,
- (b) brothers with the same father but different mothers, and
- (c) cousins who are children of a parent's brother or sister.

If you must use a more specific word, it is recommended that you consult with all major church groups in your language area. You will want to choose a word that is acceptable to the churches.

If your language must distinguish between "older" and "younger" brothers, it is recommended that you use a term for "younger brothers" here. If your language does not use terms that distinguish brother and sister, it may be more natural to use general terms. For example:

siblings

younger-siblings

2:12c**and they stayed there a few days.**

- They stayed there for a few days.
- They stayed in Capernaum for a few days.

and they stayed there a few days: It may be more natural to make the words stayed there implicit. For example:

After the wedding he went to Capernaum for a few days with his mother, his brothers, and his disciples. (NLT)

John 2:13**Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple**

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:13–17

This paragraph tells how Jesus demonstrated his authority over what happened in the temple. He sent away from the temple people who were buying and selling animals and exchanging money. He knew God had given him this authority to cleanse the temple.

2:13a

When the Jewish Passover was near,

- ¶ Just before the Jewish festival called Passover,
- ¶ The Jewish people were soon/about to celebrate their feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

When the Jewish Passover was near: This clause indicates the time this incident took place. It was a few days before the Jews celebrated the feast called the Passover in Jerusalem. Jesus and his disciples would have spent a few days traveling from Capernaum to Jerusalem.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When it was almost time for the Jewish Passover (NIV)

It was nearly time for the Jewish Passover celebration (NLT)

Not long before the Jewish festival of Passover (CEV)

the Jewish Passover: Passover is the name of a Jewish festival. It reminds the Jews of the time when they were slaves in Egypt. God went to kill the first-born sons of the Egyptians so that they would allow the Jews to leave Egypt. The term Passover refers to the fact that God passed over (did not enter) the houses of the Jews. That means that he did not harm their sons

(see Exodus 12:1–27 and the suggested footnote below for more details).

Here are some of the ways to translate the Jewish Passover:

the Jewish Passover Feast (NCV)

the Jewish celebration called the Passover

the festival called Death-Passed-Over-Us that the Jews celebrate

You may want to include a footnote or glossary entry in your translation to help your readers understand more about this feast. For example:

The Feast of Passover was a festival that the Jewish people celebrated each year in Jerusalem. It reminded them of the time when God freed their ancestors from slavery in Egypt. God commanded the Israelites to kill lambs and put some of the blood on their doorposts. [Doorposts are what are next to the door when it is closed.] Then God went to kill the firstborn sons of the Egyptians. But when he saw blood on the houses of the Israelites, he passed over their houses and did not kill their firstborn sons (see Exodus 12:1–27).

2:13b

Jesus went up to Jerusalem.

- Jesus and his disciples went up to Jerusalem.
- Jesus and his followers went to the city of Jerusalem.

Jesus went up to Jerusalem: Jerusalem was built on a hill. So anyone traveling to the city had to walk up a hill to get there. In some languages it is important to say whether people go up or down when they travel. In other languages, this will be unusual or confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you can just say:

Jesus went/traveled to Jerusalem

John 2:14

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not

think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:13–17

This paragraph tells how Jesus demonstrated his authority over what happened in the temple. He sent away from the temple people who were buying and selling animals and exchanging money. He knew God had given him this authority to cleanse the temple.

2:14a

In the temple courts He found men selling cattle, sheep, and doves,

- In the temple courtyard he saw people selling cows, sheep, and doves,
- In the house of God area, Jesus saw men/merchants selling cows, sheep, and doves for sacrifices.

In the temple courts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the temple here refers to the temple courtyard. The courtyard was an open space that surrounded the temple building. It did not have any roof. See KBT Temple A.1. These traders were selling in one of the temple courtyards that was called the Court of the Gentiles. This was the place where people could go to worship God if they were not Jews. Translate it so it is clear that the traders were not in the temple building itself. For example:

In the Temple area (NLT)

In the temple courts (NIV)

He found men selling cattle, sheep, and doves: The people were selling these animals and birds for sacrifices. In some languages it is more natural to tell why the animals were being sold. For example:

In the temple courts he found men selling animals and birds to be used as sacrifices.

found: The word found in this context means “saw.” It does not imply that these people were lost.

cattle: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cattle refers to both cows and bulls of all ages. Sometimes the English word “cows” is used in this general way, but it properly refers only to females. In your translation try to use a word that includes cows, bulls, and oxen, both old and young.

sheep: Sheep are animals that are raised on farms for meat and for wool. If there is no word for sheep in your language, you may need to borrow the word. If people are not familiar with sheep in your area, you may want to include a picture in your translation.

doves: The word doves refers to birds from the same family as pigeons. Jewish law said that people could use them as sacrifices to God. See, for example, Leviticus 12:6, 8. See how you translated “dove” in 1:32.

2:14b

and money changers seated at their tables.

- and men who exchanged money sitting there at their work-tables/desks.
- He also saw people/dealers sitting there exchanging foreign coins/money for temple/Jewish coins/money.

and: The conjunction and here introduces a second thing that Jesus saw. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence and say:

Jesus also saw

He saw others (NCV)

money changers seated at their tables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as money changers refers to men who exchanged people’s money with Jewish money. They charged people a fee to do that. People could not use Roman coins in the temple because Roman coins had the emperor’s image on one side. It was necessary to use Jewish coins, so the money changers gave them Jewish coins in exchange for Roman coins. In your translation it should be clear that these men exchanged the coins rather than doing something to change or alter them. For example:

dealers at tables exchanging foreign money (NLT)

seated at their tables: The Greek word that the BSB translates as seated at their tables is more literally “sitting.” It is implied that the money changers were sitting in order to do their business of exchanging money. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

sitting there (GW)

busy at their work

tables: You may want to follow the BSB here and supply a word that indicates where the money changers were sitting. Supply a word that refers to a simple wooden item where the dealers could place their money. For example:

desks

booths

John 2:15

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:13–17

This paragraph tells how Jesus demonstrated his authority over what happened in the temple. He sent away from the temple people who were buying and

selling animals and exchanging money. He knew God had given him this authority to cleanse the temple.

2:15a

So He made a whip out of cords

- Then Jesus made a whip from cords
- Jesus made a whip out of thin/small ropes,

So He made a whip out of cords: The word cords here refers to thin ropes. Jesus bound or tied these thin ropes together to make a whip. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

He made a whip from small ropes. (GW)

So he took some rope and made a whip. (CEV)

2:15b

and drove all from the temple courts, both sheep and cattle.

- and forced all the sheep and cattle from the temple yard.
- and he made/caused all the animals to leave the house of God, sheep and cows alike.

and drove all from the temple courts, both sheep and cattle: There are two ways of understanding what is included in the word all:

1. The phrase only refers to the sheep and cattle. For example:

and forced all of them, both the sheep and cattle, to leave the Temple (NCV) (NIV, NRSV, NCV, GNT)

1. The phrase refers to the traders as well as the sheep and cattle. For example:

he chased everyone out of the temple, together with their sheep and cattle (CEV) (NET, ESV, NASB, CEV, RSV, KJV, REB, GW, NJB, NABRE)

There are problems with the grammar of both interpretations, but it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). If Jesus chased out all the traders in 2:15, then it is hard to understand why the dove sellers are still there in 2:16. However, if he drove out all the sheep and cattle, their owners would certainly chase them. Then they would no longer be in the temple in 2:16. However, if the major language translation in your area includes the traders, you may want to do that also.

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as drove all from the temple courts means that Jesus caused or forced the sheep and cattle to leave the temple. He used the whip that he made to help him do that.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he...drove all from the temple courts, both sheep and cattle (NIV)

and chased all the sheep and cattle out of the Temple

both sheep and cattle: See the notes explaining these animals in 2:14a. Also see how you translated the words there.

2:15c

He poured out the coins of the money changers and overturned their tables.

- He scattered the money changers' coins on/over the floor and turned their tables upside down.
- He turned over the tables of the people exchanging money, and their money spilled/scattered.

He poured out the coins of the money changers and overturned their tables: These two clauses are probably in reverse chronological order. Jesus turned over the tables first, and this caused the coins to scatter onto the ground. In some language it is more natural to reverse the order here. For example:

He upset the tables of the money-changers, scattering their coins. (REB)

he overturned the tables of the moneychangers and scattered their coins (GNT)

John 2:16

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:13–17

This paragraph tells how Jesus demonstrated his authority over what happened in the temple. He sent away from the temple people who were buying and selling animals and exchanging money. He knew God had given him this authority to cleanse the temple.

2:16a

To those selling doves He said, “Get these out of here!”

- He told the people selling doves, “Get^(plur) these birds out of here!”
- He told those who sold birds for sacrifice, “Carry^(plur) these birds out!”

Get these out of here!: Jesus commanded the sellers of birds to carry them out of the temple. The doves were kept in cages, and the sellers could pick up the cages and take them out of the temple. Here are other ways to translate this command:

Take them out of here! (GNT)

Get those doves out of here! (CEV)

Pick up this stuff, and get it out of here! (GW)

2:16b

How dare you turn My Father’s house into a marketplace!”

- You^(plur) should not be turning my Father’s house into a market!”
- You^(plur) are making my Father’s house a market/bazaar! Stop!”

How dare you turn My Father’s house into a marketplace!: Jesus used this command as a strong rebuke. Jesus did not want people to make money buying and selling things in God’s holy temple. They were doing that, and he told them to stop. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a command. For example:

Don't make my Father's house a place for buying and selling! (NCV)

Stop treating my Father's house like a bazaar/market!

- Use a rebuke. For example:

How dare you turn my Father's house into a market! (NIV)

Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language. If you translate it as a command, make sure that it is clear that Jesus did not approve of what the businessmen/traders were doing. If you translate it as a rebuke, make sure that it is clear that the traders must stop their activities. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two clauses or sentences. For example:

You are doing wrong to make my Father's house into a market! Stop it!

My Father's house: This phrase refers to the temple. The temple was a place where God was present in a special way. It was holy, and Jesus required God's people to act in a way that respected it as holy.

John 2:17

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

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There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:13–17

This paragraph tells how Jesus demonstrated his authority over what happened in the temple. He sent away from the temple people who were buying and selling animals and exchanging money. He knew God had given him this authority to cleanse the temple.

2:17a

His disciples remembered that it is written:

- And his disciples remembered that the Scriptures say,
- His followers remembered what is written in the Holy Book. The Messiah/Christ said to God,

His disciples remembered that it is written: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as it is written here introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. This is a quotation from Psalm 69:9. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

His disciples remembered that the scripture says (GNT)

Then his disciples remembered this prophesy from the Scriptures (NLT)

2:17b

“Zeal for Your house will consume Me.”

- “Concern for your^(sing) house will destroy/overcome me.”
- “My love for your^(sing) house is so strong it burns in me like a fire.”

Zeal for Your house will consume Me: This clause is a quotation from Psalm 69:9. It seems that Psalm 69 is a prophecy about the Messiah, who is speaking. The Messiah says that he is fully devoted to the temple; his devotion (being devoted, zeal) will overcome him and even cause his death. The disciples remembered these words but may not have understood their full meaning at that time.

Zeal for Your house: In this quotation the Messiah is speaking to God. He expresses his strong devotion to the temple, God's house on earth. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

My devotion to your house (GNT)

My strong love for your Temple (NCV)

My love for your house (CEV)

Zeal: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as Zeal here refers to a strong positive emotion of love, caring, and devotion. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this noun using a verb. For example:

I am completely devoted to your house

I love your house so much that

Your house: This phrase here refers to the temple in Jerusalem. It was God's house in the sense that it was the place where God was present in a special way.

will consume Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as consume means "burn up," that is, "destroy." This probably mainly refers to Jesus' death. However, at the time the disciples would not have understood it in this way. It would be good to translate this verb with an idiom that expresses the effect of an intense emotion.

Here are other ways that English translations have translated this phrase:

My devotion to your house, O God, burns in me like a fire (GNT)

I am eaten up with zeal for your house (NJB)

Me: The pronoun Me in the psalm refers to the Messiah, and in John refers to Jesus, who is the Messiah. The reference should not be made explicit in the quotation itself. However, you may want to explain in a footnote that in Psalm 69:9 the Messiah is speaking to God.

John 2:18

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:18–22

The Jewish religious leaders were upset that Jesus had sent the money changers away from the temple. They demanded that he show them a miracle to prove that he had authority from God to do this. Jesus told them that if they destroyed this temple, he would raise it in three days. The Jews did not understand that he was talking about his body.

2:18a

On account of this, the Jews demanded,

- ¶ Then the Jewish leaders asked him,
- ¶ So then the rulers of the Jewish people said to Jesus:

On account of this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as On account of this can also be translated as "therefore" or "so." John used it here to introduce what happened next in the story. Some English translations, such as the NCV, do not translate it. You should translate this word in a way that is natural for your language.

the Jews: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Jews here refers to the Jewish religious leaders. In some languages it is more natural to supply the implied information that these Jews are religious leaders. See how you translated this term in 1:19. Here is an example of a translation that supplies implied information:

The Jewish leaders (CEV)

2:18b

"What sign can You show us to prove Your authority to do these things?"

- "What miracle can you^(sing) do that will prove to us^(excl) that you have the right to do what you did?"
- "Do^(sing) a miracle for us^(excl) as a sign so we can know you have the right to act like that!"
- "If God gave you authority to send the temple merchants away, show us^(excl) a miracle to prove it!"

What sign can You show us to prove Your authority to do these things?: This is a real question. We know that because Jesus answered it. However, the Jewish leaders also used it as a challenge or command. They meant, “You^(sing) must do a miracle to prove that God has given you authority to throw the traders out of the temple.” It is implied that the Jewish leaders did not believe that Jesus had the right to force the traders to leave.

There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a question. For example:

What miraculous sign can you show us to prove your authority to do all this? (NIV)

- Use a statement or command. For example:

Show us a miracle to prove you have the right to do these things. (NCV)

Translate this question in the way that is most natural in your language that also expresses a challenge.

sign: This word here refers to a miracle, a wonderful event that indicates some truth beyond itself. See the note on “signs” at 2:11a.

John 2:19

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:18–22

The Jewish religious leaders were upset that Jesus had sent the money changers away from the temple. They demanded that he show them a miracle to prove that he had authority from God to do this. Jesus told them that if they destroyed this temple, he would raise it in three days. The Jews did not understand that he was talking about his body.

2:19a

Jesus answered, “Destroy this temple,

- Jesus answered them, “Tear^(plur) down this temple,
- Jesus said: “If you want to see a miracle, destroy^(plur) this house of God,

Destroy this temple: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Destroy this temple is in the form of a command. Most scholars understand it that way and many say that it is also a challenge to the Jewish leaders.2:19 A few scholars understand this clause as a condition, with the meaning, “If you destroy this temple, in three days I will raise it up.” But English translations translate it as a command. The main point was that if they destroyed it, Jesus would restore it in three days.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Tear down this Temple (GNT)

Go ahead and destroy this temple

Destroy: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Destroy means to ruin something by breaking it into pieces. Try to use a verb that can refer to both buildings and people. If this is not possible, use a verb that refers mainly to the destruction of buildings. For example:

Tear/Break down

this temple: The Greek word the BSB translates as temple refers to the sanctuary, the place where God lives in a special sense. It is a different word from that in 2:14; this is the term used for the temple building itself. See KBT temple A.2. Jesus used this word as a figure of speech to refer to his body. The people who heard him did not understand this, so you need to translate it literally. For example:

Jesus replied, “Tear down this temple....” (GW)

Jesus answered, “So destroy God’s building/
house....”

2:19b

and in three days I will raise it up again.”

- and I will restore it again in/within three days.”
- and on the third day I will build it up again.”

in three days: This expression here refers to the third day, the day after the next day. It was the Jewish practice to count any part of a day as a day. Jesus was killed on Friday, the first day. He remained dead on Saturday, the second day. He rose again early on Sunday, the third day. In some languages it is more natural to call Friday afternoon to Sunday morning two days, a day and a half, or a day and two nights. But the phrase three days is used often in the Scriptures, and so it is good to keep the number three. For example:

within three days (before three days pass)

on the third day

It may be helpful to include a footnote here. For example:

The Greek text more literally says “in three days.”
The Jewish people counted even part of a day as a full day.

I will raise it up again: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as raise...up has two possible meanings: “restore” and “make alive.” Jesus was purposely using it in an ambiguous way that could refer both to the temple and to himself. The Jewish leaders thought that Jesus was claiming that he could rebuild the Jerusalem temple in three days. Jesus, however, was predicting that he would rise from the dead in three days. Try to find a way to say this that can have both these meanings. For example:

I will restore it.

If it is not possible to keep the meaning ambiguous, use a word that refers mainly to rebuilding buildings. For example:

I will build it again. (GNT)

John 2:20

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:18–22

The Jewish religious leaders were upset that Jesus had sent the money changers away from the temple. They demanded that he show them a miracle to prove that he had authority from God to do this. Jesus told them that if they destroyed this temple, he would raise it in three days. The Jews did not understand that he was talking about his body.

2:20a

“This temple took forty-six years to build,” the Jews replied,

- The Jewish leaders replied, “Men/workers have been building this temple for forty-six (46) years,
- The Jewish leaders scorned him, saying, “It took forty-six (46) years to build this house of God,

This temple took forty-six years to build: This expression means “men have been building this temple for forty-six (46) years.”

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It has taken forty-six years to build this temple.
(REB)

Workers have been constructing/building this temple for forty-six (46) years.

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple refers to the temple building itself, as in 2:19a. Use the same expression in both verses.

2:20b

“and You are going to raise it up in three days?”

- so how will you^(sing) raise it in/within three days?”
- and you^(sing) cannot build it back up in just three days!”

and You are going to raise it up in three days?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jewish leaders used it to say that they did not believe it, that it was impossible. They thought that Jesus was talking about the temple building. The temple took forty-six (46) years to build. So the leaders were amazed that Jesus said he could rebuild it in three days. To them this was completely impossible. So they asked this question not only because of surprise but also to rebuke him. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you really believe you can build it again in three days? (NCV)

What makes you think you can rebuild it in three days? (CEV)

- Use a statement that rebukes Jesus. For example:

You could not possibly rebuild it in three days!

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express both surprise and rebuke.

General Comment on 2:20a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 2:20a and 2:20b. For example:

^{20b}How could you raise this temple in three days?

^{20a}It took forty-six (46) years to build!

John 2:21

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish

religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:18–22

The Jewish religious leaders were upset that Jesus had sent the money changers away from the temple. They demanded that he show them a miracle to prove that he had authority from God to do this. Jesus told them that if they destroyed this temple, he would raise it in three days. The Jews did not understand that he was talking about his body.

2:21

But Jesus was speaking about the temple of His body.

- But Jesus was really talking about his body as a temple.
- But the house of God that Jesus referred to was his own body.

But Jesus was speaking about the temple of His body: This is a comment by the author, explaining Jesus' words for the benefit of his readers. The author states that in 2:19, Jesus referred to his own body, not the temple building.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But the temple Jesus spoke about was his own body. (GW)

But when Jesus said “this temple,” he meant his own body. (NLT)

But Jesus was talking about his body as a temple. (CEV)

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what the Jewish leaders thought (that Jesus spoke about the building) and what Jesus actually meant (Jesus spoke about his physical body). You should translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

the temple of His body: The expression the temple of His body here means “the temple which is Christ’s body.” It indicates that the phrase the temple refers to Jesus’ body. His body was a temple in the sense that God lived there or was present there in a special way.

the temple: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as temple means the temple building itself. It is the same word as in 2:19 and 2:20.

John 2:22

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:18–22

The Jewish religious leaders were upset that Jesus had sent the money changers away from the temple. They demanded that he show them a miracle to prove that he had authority from God to do this. Jesus told them that if they destroyed this temple, he would raise it in three days. The Jews did not understand that he was talking about his body.

2:22a

After He was raised from the dead, His disciples remembered that He had said this.

- When God raised Jesus from the dead, his disciples remembered what he had said.
- Later, after Jesus died and returned to life, his followers remembered his words,

After He was raised from the dead: This refers to an event that at this point in the gospel was still in the future. However, the event was in the past when John wrote. It is implied that Jesus would first die. Then he would live again, for God would raise/lift him from among the dead. Jesus did not remain lying in a tomb.

He was raised from the dead: The verb was raised is passive. The implied actor is God, who raised Jesus to life. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use an active verb. For example:

After God raised Jesus from the dead

- Use an intransitive verb (a verb with no object). For example:

After he came back to life (GW)

- Use a passive verb. For example:

when he was raised from death (GNT)

- Use a noun. For example:

After his resurrection (REB)

Translate this clause in the form that is most natural in your language.

His disciples remembered that He had said this: The word this refers to what Jesus said in 2:19: “Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

his disciples remembered what he had told them (CEV)

his disciples remembered that he had said this (GW)

his disciples were reminded of what he had said

2:22b

Then they believed the Scripture and the word that Jesus had spoken.

- Then they believed what was written in the Scriptures and what Jesus said.
- and they believed both God's word and what Jesus had said.

they believed the Scripture: The Greek phrase that the BRB translates as the Scripture is more literally "the writing (something that is written)." In the New Testament this phrase refers to anything written in the Hebrew Scriptures, the Old Testament. These writings had authority because God guided people to write them.

the Scripture spoken of here is probably the OT Scriptures in general, though it could be referring to Psalm 69:9. Here are some other ways to translate the Scripture:

the message of God that someone wrote

the writings which are the word of God

God's Holy book

the word that Jesus had spoken: This clause refers again to what Jesus said in 2:19. Now they understood what he meant and trusted it. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

So they believed the Scripture and this statement that Jesus had made. (GW)

Then they believed both God's Word and what Jesus had said.

John 2:23

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:23–25

Jesus did many miracles in Jerusalem at the Passover feast. This caused many people to believe in him.

2:23a

While He was in Jerusalem at the Passover Feast,

- ¶ While Jesus was in Jerusalem for the Passover Feast,
- ¶ It was the time of the annual Jewish feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us. Jesus went to Jerusalem to celebrate it.

While He was in Jerusalem at the Passover Feast:

John mentioned in 2:13 that Jesus went to Jerusalem. At the beginning of this new paragraph, it may be natural to make it explicit that the pronoun he refers to Jesus. For example:

While Jesus was in Jerusalem during the Passover Festival (GNT)

Passover Feast: Passover is the name of a Jewish festival. The term Passover refers to the fact that God passed over the houses of the Jews without harming them. See how you translated this word in 2:13a.

2:23b

many people saw the signs He was doing and believed in His name.

- many people believed/trusted in him because they saw the miracles he did.
- Many people saw the miracles Jesus did there, and they believed in him.

many people saw the signs He was doing and believed in His name:

These people believed in Jesus because they saw him do miracles. In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these two clauses and put them in chronological order. For example:

Many people saw the signs that he was doing and believed in his name.

the signs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as signs here refers to miracles or deeds that showed

Jesus' greatness and power. See the note on signs at 2:11a. Here is another way to translate this word:

miraculous signs (NIV)

believed in: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b, 1:12b, and 2:11c. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

many put their trust in him (REB)

many people put their faith in Jesus (CEV)

His name: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as His name is an idiom that means "him." It refers to Jesus himself. See the above examples for other ways to translate this phrase.

John 2:24

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:23–25

Jesus did many miracles in Jerusalem at the Passover feast. This caused many people to believe in him.

2:24a

But Jesus did not entrust Himself to them,

- But Jesus did not trust them with himself,
- But Jesus did not believe that they would be faithful to him,

But Jesus did not entrust Himself to them: John indicated that Jesus did not trust people or rely on them. He knew how quickly they could change and that they were not reliable. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus, however, did not believe that they would be faithful to him

But Jesus on his part would not entrust himself to them (NRSV)

But: The conjunction But here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the people's trust in him (2:23b) and his refusing to trust them (2:24a). Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Jesus is more literally "Jesus himself." This expression emphasizes the contrast. You should emphasize the contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

entrust: The Greek word that the BSB translates as entrust can mean "believe," but here the sense is "to trust someone to protect or care for something." Jesus did not trust them to faithfully defend him. He could not trust them enough to be their friend (see John 15:14–15). It is the same root word as in 2:23b.

2:24b

for He knew them all.

- because he understood them all.
- because he knew the character/nature of everyone.

for He knew them all: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for introduces an explanation for the statement in 2:24a. The reason Jesus did not entrust himself to the people was that he knew everyone. Jesus understood what all people were like. Translate this introduction to an explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because he knew them all (GNT)

because he knew human nature (NLT)

because he knew exactly how people thought

In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly what Jesus knew. For example:

for he knew how people are not reliable

General Comment on 2:24a–b

In some languages it is more natural to reorder this verse. Those languages would first say the reason why Jesus did not entrust himself to people. For example:

^{24b}But Jesus knew what was in their hearts, ^{24a}and he would not let them have power over him. (CEV)

General Comment on 2:23–24

There is a contrast in these verses between Jesus and the people. It may be more natural in some languages to emphasize this contrast by reordering the information and repeating the word “trust.” For example:

^{23a–b}Because of the miraculous signs Jesus did in Jerusalem at the Passover celebration, many began to trust in him. ^{24a}But Jesus didn’t trust them, ^{24b}because he knew human nature. (NLT)

If it is natural in your language to emphasize the contrast in this way, you may want to follow the NLT.

John 2:25

Section 2:13–25: Jesus sent the sellers away from the temple

In this section Jesus drove out (threw out) people who were selling animals and exchanging money in the temple courtyard. He was angry that they were using the temple to make money for themselves. The Jewish religious leaders were very upset at this. They did not think that Jesus had the authority to drive out these traders and money changers.

It is good to translate this section before you decide on a heading for it. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus drove/threw out traders/sellers from the temple

Jesus cleansed the temple

Jesus stopped people from selling animals in the temple

There are similar passages to this section in Matthew 21:12–13, Mark 11:15–17, and Luke 19:45–46.

Paragraph 2:23–25

Jesus did many miracles in Jerusalem at the Passover feast. This caused many people to believe in him.

2:25a

He did not need any testimony about man,

- He did not need anyone to tell him about people,
- No one had to tell him what people are like.

He did not need any testimony about man: This phrase indicates that no one had to tell Jesus about people. Jesus did not need someone to explain to him what people were like.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

didn’t need anyone to tell him about human nature (GW)

No one had to tell him what people were like. (CEV)

man: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as man refers to people in general. In many languages it may be natural to translate it using a plural noun or pronoun. For example:

them (GNT)

people (NCV)

2:25b

for He knew what was in a man.

- because he knew what was in their hearts/minds.
- He knew how they thought.

for He knew what was in a man: This expression tells the reason why Jesus did not need anyone to tell him what people were like (2:25a). The reason was that he already knew their inner thoughts and motives.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

he could tell what someone had within (NJB)

because he knew what was in people’s minds (NCV)

because he himself knew what was in their hearts (GNT)

John 3:1

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:1–2

Jesus' miracles impressed one of the Pharisees very much. His name was Nicodemus. He went to see Jesus at night, possibly so that other Jewish leaders would not know that he saw Jesus. He might have feared what they would think about him if they knew.

3:1a

Now there was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus,

- ¶ There was a man by the name of Nicodemus, a member of the Jewish group called the Pharisees.
- ¶ There lived at that time a man called Nicodemus, who belonged to the strict religious group called the Pharisees.

Now there was a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus: This is the beginning of the story. It tells who Nicodemus was. Introduce him in a way that is natural in your language.

Now: The common Greek conjunction *de* that the BSB translates as *Now* here introduces a new person in the story. It is not a time word. Introduce this new person in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

There was a man named Nicodemus who was one of the Pharisees (CEV)

One of the Pharisees, called Nicodemus (REB)

a man of the Pharisees named Nicodemus: This phrase means that Nicodemus belonged to the Pharisee group or party. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a man named Nicodemus who was a Pharisee (CEV)

who belonged to the party of the Pharisees (GNT)

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws carefully and exactly. See the note at 1:24 for examples of how to translate the word. Also see how you translated the word there.

See Pharisee in KBT.

3:1b

a leader of the Jews.

- He was an important man among the Jews.
- He was a member of the Jewish ruling/governing council.

a leader of the Jews: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as a leader of the Jews probably indicates that Nicodemus was a member of the Sanhedrin. The Sanhedrin was the highest governing body among the Jewish people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

an important Jewish leader (NCV)

a member of the Jewish council (GW)

a Jewish religious leader (NLT)

John 3:2

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:1–2

Jesus' miracles impressed one of the Pharisees very much. His name was Nicodemus. He went to see Jesus

at night, possibly so that other Jewish leaders would not know that he saw Jesus. He might have feared what they would think about him if they knew.

3:2a

He came to Jesus at night

- He came to Jesus during the night,
- After dark one day/evening, he/Nicodemus went to talk with Jesus.

He came to Jesus at night: The pronoun He refers to Nicodemus. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the time of day at the beginning of the clause. For example:

One night Nicodemus came to Jesus (NCV)

After dark one evening, he came to speak with Jesus (NLT)

One night he went to Jesus (GNT)

3:2b

and said, “Rabbi, we know that You are a teacher who has come from God.

- and he said to Jesus, “Teacher, we^(excl) know you^(sing) have come from God to teach us^(excl).
- He said, “Respected teacher, we^(excl) know that God has sent you^(sing) to teach us^(excl).

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” When John wrote his Gospel, people used this word as a title of respect for a religious teacher or leader. If you do not have a word that refers to a religious teacher, you can just use the word “teacher” or “master.” If possible, use a word that implies that the teacher is respected.

Use an expression in your language that is natural and shows proper respect. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this expression in this way:

We^(excl) respect you^(sing) as...

See the notes on 1:38, where the same word appears. You should translate it the same way here and there.

we know: The pronoun we here is exclusive because it does not include Jesus. It refers to Nicodemus and others who believed as he did. Nicodemus was one of a group of people who believed that Jesus had come from God.

You are a teacher who has come from God: The expression a teacher who has come from God indicates

that Jesus had divine authority to teach. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are a teacher sent by God (REB)

God has sent you as a teacher (GW)

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus.

a teacher: The word teacher can be translated using a verb. For example:

God has sent you^(sing) to teach us^(excl) about himself.

God has sent you to teach us^(excl) what he wants us^(excl) to know.

3:2c

For no one could perform the signs You are doing if God were not with him.”

- We know that because you could not perform such miracles unless God were with you.”
- You^(sing) could not do such amazing things without God.”
- “We^(excl) know that because only with God’s help can anyone do miracles like yours.”

For no one could perform the signs You are doing if God were not with him: Nicodemus was stating that God was present with Jesus. Jesus’ miracles proved that that was true. Nicodemus was not expressing doubt that God was with Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

Your miraculous signs are evidence that God is with you. (NLT)

Only a man in/with whom God lives could do the signs that you do.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For means “because.” Jesus did miracles, and therefore Nicodemus realized that God was present with him. In some languages it may be natural to leave this word implicit. For example:

“Rabbi,” he said, “we know that you are a teacher sent by God; no one could perform these signs of yours unless God were with him.” (REB)

the signs: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the signs refers to the miracles that Jesus had done, such as changing water into wine. These miracles were signs of the fact that Jesus had come from God. See the note on 2:11a, where the same word appears. You may translate this word this way:

miracles (GW)

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus.

are doing: The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as are doing refers to repeated action or a habit. Jesus had done various amazing things at different times.

if God were not with him: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as if God were not with him is more literally “unless God is with him” (RSV). Here are other ways to translate this expression:

unless God were with you (CEV)

apart from the presence of God (NRSV)

General Comment on 3:2c

In some languages it may be more natural to use the second person pronoun singular (you) everywhere in 3:2c. For example:

You could not work these miracles, unless God were with you. (CEV)

The miracles/signs that you do prove/show that God is with you.

John 3:3

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:3a

Jesus replied, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- ¶ Jesus replied, “I tell/assure you^(sing) of this truth:
- ¶ Jesus answered him, “Listen^(sing) to me carefully.

Jesus replied: This is the start of a new paragraph. So in some languages it may be helpful to make it explicit that Jesus is speaking to Nicodemus. For example:

Jesus answered Nicodemus

The Greek uses two verbs here, which can be translated as “answered” and “said.” Most English translations, as the BSB, just use one verb, because that is more natural in English. However, it may be more natural in some languages to use two verbs. For example:

Jesus answered and said to him (NABRE)

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus often used the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you. He used the phrase to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen carefully to it.

Sometimes it introduces a serious warning or something that he predicted. Here it warns that a person must become new before they can enter God’s kingdom. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase in different ways in different contexts. Here you should indicate that this is an introduction to a warning.

The same phrase appears in 1:51. See the note there. Do not translate this phrase in a way that implies that Jesus did not tell the truth at other times. Here are some possible translation models:

I am telling you the truth (GNT)

I tell you the truth

I tell you for certain (NCV)

I assure you

you: The pronoun you is singular and refers to Nicodemus.

3:3b

no one can see the kingdom of God unless he is born again.”

- unless people are born again they cannot belong to God’s kingdom.”
- people cannot belong to God’s kingdom unless they are born again.”
- A person can participate/share in the kingdom of God only when he is born again.”

no one can see the kingdom of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as see the kingdom of God means “enter the kingdom of God.” It refers to becoming one of God’s people and living in his kingdom, under his rule.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

become one of God’s people whom he rules

live in God’s kingdom

join God’s kingdom

the kingdom of God: This phrase refers to God’s activity of ruling and caring for his people as their king. It does not refer to a land or country that God rules. Rather, it refers to the relationship that God has with his people. He leads, protects, and cares for them. They obey, trust, and submit to him as their king. See KBT Kingdom of God, Kingdom of Heaven.

See how you translated this phrase in, for example, Luke 6:20. There are at least two ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a noun. For example:

God’s rule

God’s rule as king

God’s government

- Use a verb. For example:

God ruling his people

unless he is born again: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as born again is ambiguous. There are two ways to understand it:

1. It means to be born again, that is, born a second time. For example:

born again (GNT) (BSB, NIV, KJV, GNT, RSV, NASB, ESV, NLT, NCV)

1. It means to be born from above, that is, born from God, or with a spiritual birth. For example:

born from above (NJB) (NRSV, NJB, NET, GW, CEV)

Either meaning is acceptable. Both have strong support, and the author was probably deliberately ambiguous. It may be possible to say “born in a new way” (see CEV footnote) in order to retain both ideas. If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That interpretation makes a better connection with Nicodemus’ next question in 3:4. The NASB is therefore used here in the Notes and in the Display.

General Comment on 3:3b

This verse part means “You must be born again to become a member/part of God’s kingdom.” Refer to the notes on the double negative in 3:2c. As there, so here it may be more natural to use a positive statement. For example:

You must be born again before you can see God’s kingdom!

Only if a person is born again can he see the kingdom of God.

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder the clauses in 3:3b. For example:

people cannot belong to God’s kingdom unless they are born again.

A person can become a member of the kingdom of God only when he is born again.

Translate these clauses in a way that is most natural in your language.

John 3:4

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:4a

“How can a man be born when he is old?” Nicodemus asked.

- Nicodemus said to Jesus, “Is it possible for a grown man to be born?”
- “It is impossible for an adult to be born/reborn,” Nicodemus told Jesus.

How can a man be born when he is old?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and disbelief. Nicodemus was surprised that Jesus suggested being born again. There are two ways to translate this expression of surprise:

- Use a rhetorical question: For example:

But if a person is already old, how can he be born again? (NCV)

- Use a statement: For example:

I don’t believe anyone who is already old can be born again.

It is impossible for an old person to be born/reborn.

Translate this expression of surprise in a way that is natural in your language.

In his rhetorical question, Nicodemus implied a general truth, but one that also applied to himself. He understood that Jesus implied that he needed to be born again. But as a leader of the Jews, he was a mature man, probably over forty (40). It may be more natural to make it explicit that this general truth applied to himself. For example:

I am already old. How can I am be born now?

How can anyone old like me be born?

3:4b

“Can he enter his mother’s womb a second time to be born?”

- Can he go back inside his mother and begin life over again?”
- “He cannot enter his mother’s womb again. So there is no way for him to be born a second time!”

Can he enter his mother’s womb a second time to be born?: This is another rhetorical question. Nicodemus used it to express surprise and disbelief. Nicodemus was saying that it is impossible to be born physically a second time. An adult cannot enter his mother’s womb, which is where a baby grows in his mother before birth. There are at least two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

He cannot enter his mother’s body again. So how can a person be born a second time? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

He certainly cannot enter his mother’s womb and be born a second time! (GNT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language. It is important to use language that is acceptable in your culture for public reading. It may be necessary to use a euphemism for womb. For example, the NCV in the quote above has translated his mother’s womb as “his mother’s body.”

General Comment on 3:4a–b

The rhetorical questions in 3:4a and 3:4b are both used as statements that express Nicodemus’ doubts about what Jesus said. He did not understand what Jesus meant, and it sounded impossible. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the questions into one. For example:

How can a grown man ever be born a second time?
(CEV)

Another possible way to translate this verse is to follow the NLT. It still uses two questions, but the first is a real question that indicates Nicodemus did not understand Jesus' words:

"What do you mean?" exclaimed Nicodemus.
"How can an old man go back into his mother's womb and be born again?" (NLT)

John 3:5

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:5a

Jesus answered, "Truly, truly, I tell you,

- Jesus answered him, "I tell/assure you^(sing) of this truth:
- Jesus told him, "Listen^(sing) to me carefully.

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus used these words to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. The pronoun you is singular here. See the note on 3:3a, where the same expression is used.

3:5b

no one can enter the kingdom of God

- nobody can live in God's kingdom
- Everyone who wants God to rule him/them

no one can enter the kingdom of God: This expression introduces a necessary condition for entering the kingdom of God. In order to enter the kingdom of God, the following condition (which is stated in 3:5c) must

be met. Consider how it is natural to introduce this condition. For example:

If anyone wants to enter the kingdom of God

If you are going to enter the kingdom of God

In order to enter the kingdom of God

enter the kingdom of God: This expression means the same thing as "see the kingdom of God" in 3:3b. See the note there. The expression means to become one of God's people, people who confess that God is their king and obey him. It refers to experiencing or living in God's kingdom, under God's rule.

the kingdom of God: This phrase refers to God's rule. God rules as a good and just king who loves, protects, and blesses his people. See how you translated this expression at 3:3b.

3:5c

unless he is born of water and the Spirit.

- unless he is born again of water and Spirit.
- needs to be born again, cleansed by water and the Holy Spirit.

unless he is born of water and the Spirit: This expression states the condition for entering the kingdom of God. A person must be born of water and Spirit. Consider how it is natural to express a condition which must be fulfilled before something else becomes possible. For example:

born of water and the Spirit: There are two main ways to understand the connection between water and Spirit in this phrase:

1. They refer to the same event. The phrases born of water and born of...the Spirit both refer to how God cleanses and gives new life to people.
2. They refer to two different events. There are various suggestions as to what these events are. One suggestion is that born of water refers to baptism while born of...the Spirit refers to the new birth. Another suggestion is that born of water refers to physical birth and born of...the Spirit to second or spiritual birth.

Most English translations imply the first interpretation by following the Greek and using the phrase born of only once. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That is because the form of the Greek phrase connects the two nouns water and Spirit together. Water is likely a figure of speech represent-

ing the cleansing power of the Holy Spirit. Baptism also is a symbol of this cleansing.

born of water: The phrase born of water here means “born by or through water.” This is probably a metaphor that refers to cleansing from sin. See Ezekiel 36:25. Some interpreters think that it refers to baptism, either John’s baptism or Christian baptism. However, it is not recommended that you make this explicit. It is probably implied, because baptism represents cleansing from sin.

born of...the Spirit: The words born of belong with Spirit as well as “with water.” A person must be born of (or “from”) Spirit as well as of (or “from”) water. This probably indicates that it is the Holy Spirit who must give a person new birth, or new life. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

it is necessary that the Holy Spirit give him a new life

born by means of the power of the God’s Spirit

General Comment on 3:5b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 3:5b–c and state the condition first. For example:

^{5a}Jesus answered, “Truly, truly, I say to you,
^{5c}unless one is born of water and the Spirit, ^{5b}he cannot enter the kingdom of God. (ESV)

3:5b–c contains a double negative, as in 3:3b and 3:2c. See how you translated the double negatives in those verses. In some languages it is more natural to both reorder the clauses and change the double negative to a positive. For example:

^{5a}Jesus said, “I seriously assure you that ^{5c}you must be born of/by water and the Spirit ^{5b}in order to enter God’s kingdom.

John 3:6

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:6a

Flesh is born of flesh,

- Whoever is born of/from human life/nature possesses/has the life/nature of a human,
- Human parents can only give birth to human beings,
- Human parents produce human children.

Flesh is born of flesh: This expression speaks of natural human life and how one generation passes it to the next. Parents and children share the same sort of life; human beings always give birth to other human beings. In English the normal way to speak about natural human life is to use the phrase “flesh and blood.” So this clause can be translated in English like this:

Flesh and blood give birth to flesh and blood. (GW)

is born: This is a passive verb phrase. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

That which is born of the flesh is flesh. (ESV)

- Use an active verb, with the parents as subject the first time the word “flesh” is used. For example:

Flesh gives birth to flesh. (NIV)

Human life comes from human parents. (NCV)

flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flesh here refers to human nature and natural human life. It does not imply any sin. In this context the word includes the physical, emotional, and mental aspects of human life. It does not include the spiritual aspect of life. See KBT flesh 2A, and see how you translated flesh in John 1:14a.

3:6b

but spirit is born of the Spirit.

- and whoever is born of/from God's Spirit possesses/has the life/nature of a spirit.
- but the Holy Spirit gives birth to spiritual beings.
- But God's Spirit produces spirit children.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* here introduces a second truth in the sentence. This second truth both contrasts with and completes the truth in the previous expression. Use the conjunction that is natural in your language.

spirit is born of the Spirit: This clause compares and contrasts with “Flesh is born of flesh” in 3:6a. So the two clauses should follow a similar pattern to emphasize the differences. For example:

Flesh gives birth to flesh, but the Spirit gives birth to spirit. (NIV)

Human beings come from human parents, and spiritual beings come from the Holy Spirit.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit of God. The word spirit refers to the new nature of a human being which is not flesh. He is a new spiritual person. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is the Spirit who gives birth to spirit

but the Holy Spirit gives birth to a spiritual being

but spiritual beings come from the Spirit

John 3:7

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:7a–b

Verse 3:7 includes a quotation of what Jesus said in verse 3:3b. The BSB translates that quotation as “You must be born again.” However, those words in the Greek can also mean “You must be born from above.” It was recommended in the note for 3:3b that you follow the first interpretation.

Do not be amazed that I said, ‘You must be born again.’: This verse includes a quotation inside a quotation. Jesus quoted what he had just said in 3:3b. There is a change in the grammar, but no change in the meaning. See the General Comment on 3:7a–b.

3:7a

Do not be amazed that I said,

- Do not be amazed^(sing) at these/those words of mine:
- Stop^(sing) being so surprised that I told you^(sing)

Do not be amazed: This is a command to Nicodemus. It implies that what Jesus said amazed Nicodemus. It amazed him because he did not understand what Jesus meant. Jesus wanted him to stop being amazed. For example:

Stop^(sing) wondering at what I said.

You should not be surprised (NIV)

that I said: Jesus was referring back to what he said to Nicodemus in 3:3b.

3:7b

‘You must be born again.’

- You^(plur) need to be born again.
- that you^(plur) must be born again.

You must be born again: The Greek pronoun *You* is plural here. Jesus was saying that people in general must be born again. For example:

All of you must be born again.

All of you must allow God to give you new birth/lives.

born again: As in 3:3b, this Greek phrase can mean “born again” or “born from above.” Follow the same interpretation that you followed in 3:3b.

General Comment on 3:7a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the inner quotation “you must be born again” as an indirect quotation. For example:

Do not be surprised because I tell you that you must all be born again. (GNT)

John 3:8

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:3–8

Jesus told Nicodemus that he needed to be born again; that is, he needed God to give him new life. Nicodemus did not understand what he meant.

3:8a–d

The wind blows where it wishes...So it is with everyone born of the Spirit: This is a comparison. The action of the Holy Spirit is first described in a metaphor as The wind blowing. Then the metaphor is explained. Here are ways that the Spirit can be compared to The wind:

1. Both come and go freely.
2. No one knows where they will come from or where they will go.
3. However, there is evidence that they are active and change or affect things or people.

Here are other ways to translate this comparison:

Even though people cannot understand how someone is born again, it still happens. It is like the wind. We do not know where it comes from and where it goes, because it decides where it goes, but we hear it anyway. It's the same with all who are born by the Holy Spirit.

The wind blows wherever it wants. Just as you can hear the wind but can't tell where it comes from or where it is going, so you can't explain how people are born of the Spirit. (NLT)

In some languages you may want to reverse these parts of the verse. See the General Comment after 3:8d.

wind...Spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wind here refers to the movement of air. In Greek (and Hebrew) the words for wind and Spirit/“spirit” are the same. So in the original Greek this comparison involved a play on words (using a word with more than one meaning). In most languages it will not be possible to translate this play on words. However, a footnote may help by saying that in Greek the words for wind and Spirit are the same.

3:8a

The wind blows where it wishes.

- The wind blows anywhere it wants/likes.
- The wind travels freely all around.

The wind blows where it wishes: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wishes is more literally “wants.” In some languages, people cannot say that the wind wants or chooses something. So it may be necessary to translate this clause a different way. For example:

The wind blows anywhere/freely.

No one tells the wind where to blow.

3:8b

You hear its sound,

- You^(sing) can hear its sound,
- People can hear the wind blowing,

You hear its sound: This is part of the metaphor or comparison. People hear the noise the wind makes when it blows, as it affects things in the world. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you can hear the wind (NLT)

You can hear its sound (NJB)

you hear the sound it makes (NET)

You: The singular pronoun You here is indefinite and does not refer to any particular person. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

One hears its sound

People hear its sound

3:8c

but you do not know where it comes from or where it is going.

- but do not know where it comes from or where it is going to.
- but they do not know its source and its destination.

but you do not know where it comes from or where it is going: In your translation, you should probably use the same subject (in the BSB you) that you used in 3:8b. So if you followed one of the last examples in 3:8b, here are ways to translate this clause:

but no one can tell where it comes from or where it is going

but people do not know where it came from or where it goes

or: People do not know either the source or the destination (place it goes to) of the wind. Both are unknown. So in some languages it may be natural to translate or as “and.” For example:

but do not know where it comes from and where it is going (NET)

General Comment on 3:8b–c

The verbs “you hear” and “you do not know” are both active. However, the subject is indefinite. So in some languages it may be more natural to use a passive verb for one or both of these verbs. For example:

Its sound is heard, but its source and destination are unknown.

3:8d

So it is with everyone born of the Spirit.”

- It is the same with all who receive new birth/life from God’s Spirit.”
- It is like that with everyone to whom the Spirit gives birth.”

So it is with everyone born of the Spirit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So it is means “in the same way.” This sentence compares the way the wind blows to the way God changes people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It is like that with people to whom God’s Spirit gives new life.

The same is also true with a person who is born from/by the power of the Spirit of God.

everyone born of the Spirit: This is a passive expression. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

everyone who is born from the Spirit (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

everyone to whom the Holy Spirit gives new birth/life

the Spirit: As in 3:5c, this refers to God’s Spirit, the Holy Spirit.

John 3:9

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus’ speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus’ own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus’ own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus’ own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:9

"How can this be?" Nicodemus asked.

- ¶ "How can that happen?" Nicodemus asked.
- ¶ "How are these things possible?" Nicodemus asked.

How can this be?: Nicodemus was confused. He did not understand Jesus' statement about being born of the Spirit. He used his question as a request. Nicodemus wanted Jesus to explain what he had said: How can someone be born again, born of the Spirit? Here are other ways to translate this question:

How can this happen? (NCV)

How are these things possible? (NLT)

Nicodemus asked: Because this verse begins a new paragraph, it may be helpful to say explicitly that it was Jesus that Nicodemus was talking to. For example:

Nicodemus said to Jesus

John 3:10

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends.

Different translations end Jesus' speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

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2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:10a–b

"You are Israel's teacher," said Jesus, "and you do not understand these things?:" The two clauses in 3:10a–b together form a rhetorical question that Jesus used as a rebuke. He was not asking whether Nicodemus was really a teacher. Nor was he asking whether Nicodemus understood his teaching.

He knew that Nicodemus was a teacher, and he knew that Nicodemus did not understand. He was saying that, because he was a teacher, Nicodemus should have understood. That was the rebuke. There are several ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can you be a teacher of Israel and not know these things? (CEV)

- Use a statement of rebuke. For example:

As a teacher in Israel, you should understand these things.

- Use an exclamation. For example:

You a teacher of Israel and yet you do not know about such things!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

you: This pronoun refers to Nicodemus and is singular both times it is used.

3:10a

"You are Israel's teacher," said Jesus,

- "You^(sing) are a respected teacher to Israel," said Jesus.
- Jesus said to him, "You^(sing) are a teacher of Israel

"You are Israel's teacher," said Jesus: Jesus was assuming and stating that Nicodemus was a teacher

of Israel. This is the ground of the rebuke that follows. It may therefore be natural to say:

because you are a teacher of Israel

as a teacher of Israel

Israel's teacher: The Greek noun phrase that the BSB translates as Israel's teacher is more literally "the teacher of Israel." This probably indicates that Nicodemus had influence as an important religious teacher of the people of Israel. He was a respected representative of the Jewish people, with authority to teach them the Torah. He was probably a member of the Sanhedrin. See the note on "a leader of the Jews" in 3:1b.

teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a man who had authority to teach things about God. Do not use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

3:10b

"and you do not understand these things?"

- "How/Why do you^(sing) not understand these things?
- and should know these things!

and you do not understand these things?: Jesus was rebuking Nicodemus for not understanding what he was talking about. The Hebrew Scriptures taught that God's Spirit changed people and gave them new life. Nicodemus should have remembered that from passages such as Ezekiel 36:26–27 and Ezekiel 37:1–14.

these things: This phrase refers back to what Jesus had just talked about (3:3, 3:5–8). It refers to being born again, born of the Spirit. In some languages it is more natural to supply that idea here. For example:

How can you not understand what I mean when I talk about being born of the Spirit?

General Comment on 3:10a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the comments in this verse. For example:

^{10b}You^(sing) should understand these things

^{10a}because you are a respected teacher of the people of Israel.

John 3:11

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus' speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:11a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I am telling you^(sing) clearly:
- Listen^(sing) to what I say.

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus used the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you to introduce a statement that he wanted to emphasize. See 3:3a.

you: This pronoun is singular. Jesus was speaking specifically to Nicodemus.

3:11b–c

we speak of what we know, and we testify to what we have seen:

The two ideas we speak of what we know and we testify to what we have seen are very similar. This repetition is a way that the Hebrew lan-

guage emphasizes what is said. In some languages the ideas may need to be combined. For example:

I tell you for certain that we know what we are talking about because we have seen it ourselves.
(CEV)

3:11b

we speak of what we know,

- We^(excl) speak about things we do know.
- We^(excl) know what we are talking about,

we speak of what we know: The word we is exclusive. It does not include Nicodemus. In this context there are several ways to interpret this pronoun:

1. we means “Jesus and his followers”
2. we just means “I,” that is, Jesus.
3. we means “John the Baptist and Jesus.”
4. we means “the Father and the Son.”
5. we means “Jesus and believers,” that is, the church.

Scholars have very different interpretations. It is recommended that you translate this as we exclusive, without saying exactly to whom it refers.

3:11c

and we testify to what we have seen,

- We^(excl) tell about things that we have seen.
- because we^(excl) have seen it ourselves.

testify to what we have seen: This expression means “tell about what we have seen.” The pronoun we is again exclusive. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

report what we have seen (GNT)

General Comment on 3:11b–c

There is not much difference between the two verbs “speak” and “testify” in this context. In some languages it is more natural to say it just once. For example:

^{11b-c}we know what we are talking about because we have seen it ourselves (CEV)

3:11d

and yet you people do not accept our testimony.

- But you^(plur) do not accept what we^(excl) report.
- But you^(plur) people refuse to accept what we^(excl) say.

and yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as yet here shows contrast and surprise. Jesus

certainly knew what the truth was. In spite of this, the people did not accept the testimony. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

but still (NIV)

you people do not accept: The pronoun you is plural here. Jesus probably referred to the people that Nicodemus included in his “we” in 3:2. These people did not believe that Jesus was in fact the Messiah. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

you won’t believe (NLT)

our testimony: The pronoun our is exclusive here. It does not include Nicodemus. For the various possibilities of whom it does include, see the note on 3:11b.

testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony refers to a report about what someone witnessed. Here is another way to translate this word:

what we^(excl) tell you (NCV)

John 3:12

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus’ speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:12a

If I have told you about earthly things and you do not believe,

- I told you^(plur) about things on earth and yet you do not believe.
- You^(plur) do not believe the things I have told you about things that happen on earth.

If I have told you about earthly things and you do not believe: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as earthly things refers to things that happen here on earth. In this context Jesus probably meant what he had just been talking about with Nicodemus. Even though the new birth comes from heaven, it is something that happens on earth.

If I have told you about earthly things: Jesus was saying that this was what he had done. He was not suggesting it as a possibility only. So it may be natural to translate this clause in one of these ways:

- Use a statement without the conditional If. For example:

I have told you about things here on earth.... (CEV)

- Use a clause that assumes the truth of the condition. For example:

because I have told you earthly things...

3:12b

how will you believe if I tell you about heavenly things?

- Is it possible that you^(plur) will believe when/what I tell you about things in heaven?
- Definitely you^(plur) will not believe if I tell you truths about heaven.

how will you believe if I tell you about heavenly things?: This is a rhetorical question. It emphasizes a statement that implies a rebuke. Jesus was saying that Nicodemus (and others) would not believe if he spoke of heavenly things.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

how can you possibly believe if I tell you about heavenly things? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

So you will not believe me if I tell you about things of heaven. (CEV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

you: This is a plural form. Jesus was probably again referring to the same group of Pharisees that Nicodemus talked about in 3:2b.

heavenly things: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as heavenly things refers to truths or ideas relating to God and the spiritual world. These truths would include the ones in the following verses.

John 3:13

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus' speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)

3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:13a-b

No one has ascended into heaven except the One who descended from heaven—the Son of Man: This verse is a reference to Proverbs 30:4a, which reads “Who has ascended to heaven and come down?” The question in Proverbs is asking who has brought wisdom from God to earth. Here Jesus answered this question by saying that he himself had been in heaven and had come down from heaven. In that way he brought the knowledge of heavenly things to earth. See the notes on John 1:18. See also John 1:51, where the angels of God are said to “ascend” and “descend” on the Son of Man.

3:13a

No one has ascended into heaven

- No one has gone up into heaven
- Only one has been able to enter heaven,

No one has ascended into heaven: This clause is difficult to understand. It probably indicates that no one (but Jesus) had ever been in heaven and come down to earth. As such he was the only one who could truly tell what he had seen and knew of God. The word ascended means “went up.”

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no one has ever gone up to heaven (GNT)

no one has ever gone to heaven and returned (NLT)

heaven: The word heaven here refers to the place where God lives.

3:13b

except the One who descended from heaven—the Son of Man.

- except the Son of Man who came from heaven.
- the Son of Man, I who came down from heaven.

except the One...the Son of Man: Jesus was referring to himself. There is a textual issue in this verse. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have just the Son of Man. For example: the Son of Man (NIV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NRSV, CEV, REB, GNT, NLT, GW, NCV, NJB) (2) Other Greek manuscripts have the Son of Man who is in/from heaven. For example: [even] the Son of man which is

in heaven. (KJV) (KJV, REB) You should follow option (1) because it has the best manuscript support. Also, most English translations follow this option. In some languages it may be more natural to use a form like “I” or “me” to make that clear. For example:

I, the Son of Man, am the only one

I who became man/human

me, the Son of Man

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people
2. He came from God and had authority from God

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some possible translations:

the Human-born

the Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Mankind

Translators have also used expressions that are more literal. These more literal expressions may be suitable where readers are familiar with a literal expression in another translation.

See how you translated this term in 1:51.

See Son of Man in KBT.

General Comment on 3:13a-b

“No one...except” is a double negative with a positive emphasis. It indicates that Jesus, the Son of Man, is the only person to have been in heaven and come down to earth. In some languages it is more natural to translate with a positive statement. For example:

The only one who has ever gone up to heaven is the One who came down from heaven—the Son of Man. (NCV)

Who has gone to heaven? I, the true man from God, am the only one, because I came from heaven.

John 3:14

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus' speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:14a–b

In this verse the Greek begins with the common conjunction that is often translated as "and." Here it introduces an illustration that continues and advances Jesus' argument. Some English translations, such as the NRSV, explicitly translate it. You should introduce Jesus' illustration in a way that is natural in your language.

Just as...so: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Just as...so indicate a comparison of one idea to another. Jesus compared his dying on the cross to Moses healing people by putting a metal snake up on a stick. Whoever looked at the snake was healed. Just as God gave physical life to those who looked at the snake, so he gives spiritual life to those who trust Jesus. Jesus was lifted up on the cross so anyone can see and believe.

In some languages you may want to indicate the comparison in another way. For example:

As..., in the same way... (GNT)

It will happen like the time when...

3:14a

Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness,

- Just as Moses lifted up the snake when the people of Israel were in the desert,
- Long ago in the wilderness, Moses made a metal/bronze snake and raised it high on a pole/post.

Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness:

This is a reference to a story in the Old Testament. Moses lived over two thousand years before Jesus was born. He rescued the Israelites from being slaves in Egypt and led them into the desert. The people rebelled against God and Moses, and God sent snakes to bite them. Then they prayed to God and he told Moses to make a bronze snake to heal the people. See Numbers 21:4–9 for the complete story.

In some languages you may need to put the story in a footnote or supply some implied information. For example, here is a way to supply some implied information:

And what will happen to me is like what happened to the artificial/metal snake which Moses made. He raised it up on a pole/stick when they were walking through the place where no one lived.

lifted up: The verb that the BSB translates as lifted up refers to Moses putting the metal snake on top of a pole. He put it up like that so that everyone could see it.

the snake: The word snake here refers to a statue or image made out of metal to look like a snake. It may be necessary to make it explicit that this was not a real snake. For example:

the bronze snake (GNT)

the metal/artificial snake

in the wilderness: This phrase refers to the time when the people of Israel traveled through the desert region of Sinai. A wilderness or desert is an area where there are few plants and where few people live. Here such

an area is referred to as the wilderness because it was a well-known place in a well-known story.

General Comment on 3:14a

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 3:14a and start with the place where the event happened. For example:

When the people of Israel were in the desert,
Moses lifted up the metal snake on a pole.

3:14b

so the Son of Man must be lifted up,

- so the Son of Man must be lifted up onto a cross.
- In that way I, the Son of Man, must be raised up onto a cross to die.

so the Son of Man must be lifted up: This clause indicates that it was necessary for Jesus to die on the cross. It is important that you try to use the same verb here and in the first part of the comparison, 3:14a. For example:

so the Son of Man must be put/raised up

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is the same as in 3:13b. Translate it the same way in both verses.

must: The Greek word that the BSB translates as must indicates necessity. It was necessary for this to happen. It fulfilled God's plan. For example:

It is necessary that the Son of Man be lifted up.

be lifted up: The verb phrase be lifted up here refers to the soldiers putting Jesus' on the cross to die. This is a passive verb. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the Son of Man must also be lifted up (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so people must lift up the Son of Man onto a cross

Use the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

General Comment on 3:14a–b

This is a comparison. It says that a future event is similar to a past event. The Greek text, along with most English translations, mentions the past event first. But in some languages it may be natural to reverse the order. For example:

^{14b}And the Son of Man must be lifted up, ^{14a}just as that metal snake was lifted up by Moses in the desert. (CEV)

John 3:15

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:9–15

In this paragraph, in verse 10, Jesus began to talk about his authority. He claimed that he had the right to teach about God because he had come from God. In ancient Greek, quotation marks were not used, so it is not always easy to tell where a quotation ends. Different translations end Jesus' speech at different points. Here are the possibilities:

1. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:21. (NASB, NRSV, ESV, NIV84, REB, NJB, NLT, NCV)
2. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:15. (RSV, NET, GW, NIV11)
3. Jesus' own words end at the end of 3:13. (GNT)

It is not clear where the KJV and CEV end the quotation. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and end Jesus' speech at the end of verse 21.

3:15

that everyone who believes in Him may have eternal life.

- Then all people who believe that he died for them may have forever life from God.

- That will happen so that whoever believes in him/me may receive life from God that never ends.

that everyone who believes in Him may have eternal life: This is a result clause. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. God gives eternal life to all those who believe in Jesus Christ. In some languages it will be more natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Then everyone who believes in him will have eternal life. (REB)

Then everyone who has faith in the Son of Man will have eternal life. (CEV)

believes in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b and 1:12b. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

has faith in the Son of Man (CEV)

trusts in him

in Him: Scholars have two different interpretations about what word or words this phrase is connected to:

1. It is connected to “believes.” For example:

so that everyone who believes in him may have eternal life (GNT) (BSB, NET, NRSV, RSV, ESV, CEV, GNT, KJV, GW, NLT)

1. It is connected to “have eternal life.” For example:

that everyone who believes may have eternal life in him (NIV) (NASB, NIV, NCV, REB, NJB)

The Greek preposition that is translated in is never used anywhere else in John to connect to “believes.” However, the word is a synonym of the word that is normally used. And even if in Him does not connect to “believes,” it is implied that one believes in Jesus. Therefore, the meanings of the two interpretations are very close. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations.

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life enables us to have a close relationship with God and it will never end. This is an important idea in John and it is recommended that you translate it the same way every time. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

John 3:16

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:16–18

God sent his Son into the world to save people from being condemned.

3:16

People often memorize this verse, learning it so that they can remember it exactly. Your translation of this verse should be clear and natural. It should also sound good when it is spoken aloud, and it should be easy to memorize. The sentences should be neither too long nor too short. Also, the words should be fairly simple and not easily confused with other words. Ask a few people of different ages to memorize it to see if there are any problems.

It is not clear where Jesus’ speech ends and John begins to comment (if he did this at all). Most English translations indicate that Jesus’ speech continues through verse 21. However NIV, NET, and GW indicate that 3:16 begins John’s comments. And GNT indicates

that Jesus' speech ends at the end of 3:13 and John's comments begin in 3:14. Wherever Jesus' speech ends, it is all God's Word. It is probably best to follow most English translations and continue the quotation of Jesus' speech through verse 21. However, if the major language translation in your area begins John's comments here, you may want to follow that example.

3:16a

For God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son,

- ¶ "For God intensely/greatly loved the world and so he gave his unique/one Son.
- ¶ "God sent his one and only Son to the people of the earth because he loved them very much.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here means "because" and introduces an explanation of what Jesus had said in 3:15. People may receive eternal life because God loved the people of the world and acted to save them. Some translations leave this word implicit.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

That is because

Yes, (ERV)

God so loved the world that He gave His one and only Son: This expression indicates that God's love for the world's people influenced him to give his Son to save them. God sent his Son into the world to save its people because he cared very much for them. Giving his Son was the way in which God showed his great love.

so loved...that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so can indicate both the way something is done and how much it is done. The way that God showed his great love for the world was by sending his Son. Some English translations indicate the way God showed his love and some indicate how much he loved. For example:

For God loved the world so much that (GNT)

God loved the world this way: (GW)

God loved the people on earth very much. Therefore...

Introduce what God did for the world in a way that is most natural in your language. Emphasize that God acted because he loved the world. By giving his Son he showed his great love.

loved: In many languages there are different words for "love." Try to choose a word that refers to love that is unselfish. Love like this means that the one loving will lose something when he shows love. The love here is the love of someone who is stronger and greater toward someone who is weaker. You may be able to use a word that refers to the way a parent loves a child. Nowhere else in the New Testament does it say that God loves the world.

In some languages, the past tense word loved may imply that God no longer loves the world. If that is true in your language, you may want to use a present tense verb. For example:

God loves the people who live on earth very much

Because God's love for the people of this world is great

God loves the people everywhere in the world

world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as world here refers to the people in the world. For example:

God loved the people of this world (CEV)

He gave: God gave his Son when he caused him to be born as a human so that he would die for us. God handed him over to be a sacrifice for sins. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

he sent

His one and only Son: This phrase here means "God's unique Son." God calls himself the Father of all, but Jesus is uniquely his Son. He is God's Son in a way in which no one else is.

The title Son indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

For more information, see the note on “the Son of God” at 1:34.

If you have indicated that Jesus is talking here, it is important that people understand that he is talking about himself. You may need to make it explicit that Jesus spoke about himself. For example:

he sent me, his only son

one and only: The Greek word that the BSB translates as only also appears in 1:18b. See the note there and refer to your translation of that verse. Here is another way to translate this word:

one and only (NCV)

3:16b

that everyone who believes in Him shall not perish but have eternal life.

- He did that so that all who believe in him should not be separated from God forever but have forever life.
- He planned that everyone who trusts in his Son will live forever with God. They will not be punished.

that everyone who believes in Him shall not perish but have eternal life: This is a purpose clause. It expresses God’s purpose in giving his Son. The pronoun Him refers to God’s only Son, Jesus.

believes in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b, 1:12b, and 3:15. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

has faith in him (CEV)

trusts in him

perish: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as perish here refers to suffering eternal death, spiritual death. Spiritual death is when a person is separated from God forever and punished.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

be separated from GodYakan BT

be separated from God to be punishedKankanaey BT.

lose his life forever

be punished forever

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (“may not perish”) to a positive statement (“may have eternal life”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

may not be lost, but have eternal life (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

he will not be separated from God for punishment; rather/instead he will have life that does not end

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

will not be eternally separated from God. He will have eternal life.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

will have eternal life and never really die (CEV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

have eternal life: This verb phrase means the same thing as the previous verb phrase, “shall not perish.” It is expressed in a positive rather than a negative way. This repeating emphasizes what Jesus was saying. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

may live eternally

will live forever with God

eternal life: This phrase refers to life with God that never ends. See how you translated this phrase in 3:15.

John 3:17

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:16–18

God sent his Son into the world to save people from being condemned.

3:17a–b

For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through Him:

The two parts of this sentence say similar things, the first part negatively and the second positively. In some language it is more natural to reorder them. See the General Comment on 3:17a–b.

3:17a

For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world,

- For God did not send the Son to the people of the world to judge them,
- For God did not send his Son into the world to judge/condemn its people.
- God sent his Son into the world, not to condemn the world, (GW)

For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world: This part of the sentence indicates what God's purpose was not: God's purpose and desire were not to condemn the world. Translate this verse so it is clear that God did send his Son into the world, but his purpose was not to condemn the world. Here are other ways to translate this purpose:

It was not to judge the world that God sent his Son into the world. (REB)

God sent his Son into the world not to judge the world. (NLT)

For God did not send his Son into the world to be its judge. (GNT)

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For introduces an explanation. Most English translations translate it as “for” here (ESV, NASB, NET, NIV, NLT, GNT). Others do not translate the word (CEV, GW, NCV, REB). It is recommended that you translate the word using the natural way to introduce an explanation in your language.

His Son: The phrase His Son refers to God's Son, as in 3:16a. In some languages it may be necessary to make this more explicit, like the BSB does.

condemn: To condemn someone is to declare that they are guilty of some wrongdoing. Here is another way to translate this word:

judge guilty (NCV)

world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as world refers to the people of the world. See also the note on 3:16a.

3:17b

but to save the world through Him.

- but to rescue them through/by the Son.
- He sent his Son to save them from their sins.
- but to save the world. (GW)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement in 3:17a to a positive statement in 3:17b. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

It was not to judge the world that God sent his Son into the world, but that through him the world might be saved. (REB)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

God did not send his son here to earth in order to sentence the people. Rather he sent him here to earth that he save the people. 3:17 Otomi BT.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

God did not send his Son into the world to condemn its people. He sent him to save them! (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

God sent his son to the world to save the people there, not to judge them.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

to save the world through Him: This is a purpose clause. It tells God's purpose in sending Jesus into the world.

save the world through Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as save is actually passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

that through him the world might be saved (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

be its savior (GNT)

save: The word that the BSB translates as save here means to be rescued, delivered, or freed from sin. The result is that God will not judge or condemn a person that he has saved. That means that he will not punish that person.

the world: Here again the world refers to the people of the world. For example:

God did not send his Son into the world to condemn its people. He sent him to save them! (CEV)

through Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as through Him here means "because of what he/Jesus did." Jesus lived, died, and rose again for us so that we might be saved from sin and evil. In some languages you may need to make some of this clear. For example:

he sent his Son to be the one who saves the world

God's purpose/intention in sending his Son into the world is to save/deliver/rescue people from their sins.

John 3:18

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:16–18

God sent his Son into the world to save people from being condemned.

3:18a

Whoever believes in Him is not condemned,

- People who believe in the Son are not condemned,
- God does not judge guilty anyone who trusts his Son,

Whoever believes in Him is not condemned: This refers to any and all people who believe in Jesus, including the readers or listeners. In some languages it is more natural to translate this idea using a second person pronoun. For example:

You^(plur) who believe in him will not be condemned.

believes in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b, 1:12b, 3:15 and 3:16b. The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

have faith in God's Son

trust in him

put their faith in him

is not condemned: This is a passive verb phrase. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

People who believe in God's Son are not judged guilty. (NCV)

- Use an active verb with God as the subject. For example:

God will not condemn those who trust his Son.

Use the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

General Comment on 3:18a

In some languages it may be more natural to use a negative in the subject rather than the verb. For example:

No one who has faith in him will be condemned. (CEV)

No one who puts his faith in him comes under judgement (REB)

3:18b

but whoever does not believe has already been condemned,

- but people who do/will not believe are already condemned.
- but he/God has already judged guilty anyone who refuses to believe in his Son.

but whoever does not believe has already been condemned: The Greek word that the BSB translates as whoever does not believe refers to people who refuse to believe in God's Son. The object of their disbelief, Jesus, is not stated but is implied from 3:18a. In some languages it is more natural to supply an object. For example:

But everyone who doesn't have faith in him has already been condemned (CEV)

does not believe: The word believe includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See

how you translated this idea in 3:18a. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

does not have faith

do not trust in him

do not put their faith in him

the unbeliever (REB)

has already been condemned: The word condemned is a passive verb. It indicates that God has judged these people as guilty. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

But those who don't believe are already condemned (GW)

Those who do not believe have already been judged guilty (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God has already condemned anyone who will not believe in his Son.

3:18c

because he has not believed in the name of God's one and only Son.

- They are condemned because they have not believed in God's unique/one Son.
- He judged them guilty for not trusting God's one and only Son to save him.

because he has not believed in the name of God's one and only Son: This clause gives the ground or basis for God condemning these people. Those who refuse to believe in God's Son are condemned by God because they do not believe. Here is another way to translate this clause:

for not having faith in God's only Son (CEV)

has not believed: See the note on the word believed in 3:18a and b and how you translated the idea there. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

has not trusted

has not put their faith

has not put his trust (REB)

they don't believe (GW)

in the name of: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the name of refers to the person himself. In some languages it is more natural to say it more directly. For example:

in God's only Son (REB)

in God's one and only Son (NCV)

God's one and only Son: The phrase God's one and only Son refers to God's unique Son, Jesus himself. He shares in God's actual nature and character. See the note on "his only Son" at 3:16.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase here:

the one and only Son of God (NET)

God's one and only Son (NLT)

John 3:19

Section 3:1-21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:19-21

Jesus used the metaphors of light and darkness to describe the basis for God's judgment. The basis is whether we love the darkness or love the light.

Jesus is represented as light. Light usually refers to that which is good. That is why those who love the darkness do evil deeds and hate the light. Those who

love the darkness do not want their sins to be known. They also do not want to accept Jesus or allow him to shine truth in their lives. However, those who follow the truth come to Jesus. Jesus will then reveal that they did their good deeds only because of God.

3:19a

And this is the verdict:

- ¶ "The judgment is based on this:
- ¶ "This is why God judges people:

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces an explanation. Jesus explains the basis of the judgment that he talked about in 3:17-18. Some English translations, such as the NIV and GNT, do not explicitly translate it. The NET translates it as "Now" because that is a common way to introduce an explanation in English. It is not a time word in this context. You should introduce Jesus' explanation in a way that is natural in your language.

this is the verdict: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as this is the verdict refers forward to 3:19b-d. It indicates that what follows is the ground or basis of God's judgment on people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

this is the basis for judging (NET)

the judgment is based on this fact (NLT)

This is how the judgment works (GNT)

verdict: The word verdict refers to a judge deciding whether someone is guilty or innocent. In this case the judge is God himself. In some languages the noun verdict needs to be translated as a verb phrase. For example:

God is judging/declaring people guilty because...

This is why people are condemned: (GW)

They are judged by this fact: (NCV)

3:19b

The Light has come into the world,

- The light has come to the people of the world,
- The one who is light has come into the world to reveal truth.

The Light has come into the world: The word Light here is a metaphor and refers to Jesus, the Son of God.

Jesus was speaking, but he did not directly say that he was the light. So try to keep the reference to the light indirect, in the third person. Jesus was like a light because he was good. He also revealed the truth about things, both the good and the evil. If this metaphor is not understood in your language, you may need to follow one of these translation suggestions:

- Make explicit or explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Light has come into the world through the one who reveals/shows the truth about everything.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make it explicit that it refers to the Son of God. For example:

The Son of God is like a light coming into the world.

See how you translated the metaphor Light in 1:4b.

3:19c

but men loved the darkness rather than the Light

- but people/they desired darkness and not light,
- And yet people wanted to stay/live in the dark and did not want to turn/come to him who is the light,
- But people have chosen the darkness instead of the light,

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces something that is not expected. Instead of loving the light, which we might expect, people loved the darkness. So here is the basis for God's judgment: although the light came into the world, they did not love the light. In some languages it may be natural to make it clearer that what is said next is not expected.

men loved the darkness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as men here means "people in general." However, it does not mean all people without exception, because some people did trust Jesus. In some languages it is therefore more natural to say:

They wanted darkness (NCV)

many people loved darkness

loved the darkness: This is a metaphor. It compares people who deliberately refuse to believe in Jesus to people who love darkness.

Darkness hides people who are doing evil. In the same way, people hoped that by staying far from Jesus (the light), they could hide their sin. They wanted to continue sinning. They also wanted to avoid God. So they did not come to hear and believe Jesus.

If this metaphor is not understood in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

loved the darkness of their sin

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning explicit. For example:

loved their sins, which was like loving darkness

- State the meaning directly. For example:

loved sin

the darkness: See how you translated the term darkness in 1:5a, and see the note there.

rather than the Light: There is an interpretation issue here. There are two ways to understand the Greek word that the BSB translates as rather:

1. It means "rather" or "instead." For example:

people loved darkness instead of light (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, KJV, GNT, RSV, NRSV, NASB, ESV, GW, NCV)

1. It means "more than." For example:

they love the dark more than the light (CEV) (NLT, CEV)

NJB and REB could be understood either way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations and Bible scholars. People loved and chose darkness instead of light.

Here again Light is a metaphor referring to Jesus. He is like a light in that he is good and reveals the truth about things to people. But people did not love him. Refer to your translation of 3:19b and the note there.

3:19d

because their deeds were evil.

- because their actions were evil.
- because they were/are doing evil/wrong things.

because their deeds were evil: This is the reason why people loved darkness more than light. In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun deeds with a verb. For example:

because they were doing evil things (NCV)

General Comment on 3:19a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder this verse. For example:

^{19b}The light has come into the world, ^{19a, d}and God judges the people who do evil things as guilty because ^{19c}they love the dark rather than the light.

^{19b}He arrived among the people of the world bringing light from God. ^{19c}But people wanted darkness and not light, ^{19d}because their actions were evil.

^{19a}That is why God judges/punishes them.

John 3:20

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:19–21

Jesus used the metaphors of light and darkness to describe the basis for God's judgment. The basis is whether we love the darkness or love the light.

Jesus is represented as light. Light usually refers to that which is good. That is why those who love the darkness do evil deeds and hate the light. Those who love the darkness do not want their sins to be known. They also do not want to accept Jesus or allow him to shine truth in their lives. However, those who follow the truth come to Jesus. Jesus will then reveal that they did their good deeds only because of God.

3:20a

Everyone who does evil hates the Light,

- For all those who do evil things hate the light
- Everyone who does what is evil/wrong hates light.

Everyone who does evil hates the Light: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Everyone who does evil here refers to everyone who does bad things. For example:

Every person who does bad things hates the light

Those who do evil things hate the light (GNT)

hates the Light: This expression here refers to hating the Son of God, who is the light. Jesus was referring to himself, but he did not explain this. So it is better that you do not make it explicit.

Jesus revealed/uncovered people's evil deeds, and so people who did evil hated him. See the note on 3:19b. This is a figure of speech, a metaphor. In some languages a figure of speech like this is not clearly understood. Here are some other ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Retain the figure of speech but make explicit that Light refers to a person. For example:

hate the one who is the light

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

hate the one who is like the light

- Explain the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

hate the one who brings light, who shows/tells them the truth

3:20b

and does not come into the Light

- and do not come into/toward the light.
- They avoid it

does not come into the Light: These people do not want to be near the light. That means that they do not want to come to Jesus and listen to his words. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

avoid it (REB)

refuse to go near it (GNT)

refuse to enter/approach the light

3:20c

for fear that his deeds will be exposed.

- They do not want their actions to be seen/revealed.
- because they are afraid it will show what they have done.

for fear that his deeds will be exposed: This clause states a negative purpose. It indicates the reason why those who do evil do not come to the light: they want to avoid something. They do not want anyone to see the things that they have done. (The word exposed means that their deeds are uncovered or revealed.) It is implied that these deeds are evil. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

they do not want their evil deeds to be shown up (GNT)

Consider how your language naturally indicates the reason that people try to avoid a situation that they do not want. For example:

so that their deeds will not be exposed (NET)

for fear their sins will be exposed (NLT)

his deeds: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deeds can be translated as a verb phrase instead. For example:

what they have done (CEV)

will be exposed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as be exposed means “made visible” or “be uncovered.” In this context, the light is what will expose the evil actions. The verb phrase be exposed is passive here. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to prevent his actions from being shown up (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

because it clearly shows what they have done (CEV)

because they fear that the light will reveal the bad/wrong acts that they are doing

Use the verb form that is the most natural in your language.

General Comment on 3:20a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the parts of this verse. For example:

^{20c}Those who do evil do not want it to be known.

^{20a}Therefore they hate the one who is the light,

^{20b}and do not want to go near him.

John 3:21

Section 3:1–21: A Pharisee named Nicodemus questioned Jesus

This section tells about how a Pharisee called Nicodemus went to visit Jesus. Jesus told Nicodemus that all people need God to change them. Nicodemus could be sure that Jesus was speaking the truth because Jesus came from God.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told a Pharisee that he needed to change

Everyone must be born again

All people need God to give them a new birth/life

Paragraph 3:19–21

Jesus used the metaphors of light and darkness to describe the basis for God’s judgment. The basis is whether we love the darkness or love the light.

Jesus is represented as light. Light usually refers to that which is good. That is why those who love the darkness do evil deeds and hate the light. Those who love the darkness do not want their sins to be known. They also do not want to accept Jesus or allow him to shine truth in their lives. However, those who follow the truth come to Jesus. Jesus will then reveal that they did their good deeds only because of God.

3:21a

But whoever practices the truth

- However, those who do what is right
- But the people who follow God’s true way

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces the opposite situation to that of 3:19–20. It tells of those who love the light.

whoever practices the truth: The phrase the truth here refers to a good or moral way of life. A person who practices the truth is one who lives in a way that is faithful to God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

those who follow the true way (NCV)

those who do what is right (NLT)

3:21b comes into the Light,

- come into/toward the light.
- come to the one who is the light.

comes into the Light: Again Light is a metaphor for Jesus, the Son of God, who shows us who God is. As in 3:20b, to comes into the Light is to come to Jesus and listen with faith to his words. Translate it here as you did in 3:20b.

3:21c so that it may be seen clearly

- They do that so that others will clearly see
- Then everyone will/can know

so that it may be seen clearly: The verb phrase it may be seen is in the passive. It means “people/others may see it.” Faithful people are not afraid that others will see their lives and actions. There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that it may be seen plainly (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

because they want others to know that (CEV)

so others can see that (NLT)

so that it may be clearly apparent

Translate this clause using the verb form that is most natural in your language.

3:21d that what he has done has been accomplished in God.”

- that it is God who enabled them to do those things.”
- that they have been living/working in this good/true way because God is in all that they do.”

what he has done has been accomplished in God:

This clause indicates that these faithful people have acted in union with God or associated with him. In Greek the words done and accomplished come from the same root. In some languages repeating things like that may not be natural. It may be better to say:

it was all done in/through God

the power/strength of God was the source of what they did

The verb has been accomplished is passive. Here are ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

his works have been done through God

- Use an active verb. For example:

God is in all they do. (REB)

God is really the one doing what they do (CEV)

they did all they did in union with God

God has helped them to act in this good/true way

in God: There are at least three different interpretations about what this phrase means:

1. It means that these things were done in God’s strength. For example:

God is really the one doing what they do (CEV)
(CEV, NCV, REB, NIV84)

1. It means that these things were done in order to obey God. For example:

what they did was in obedience to God (GNT) (GNT, NLT, GW)

1. It means that these things were done in God’s presence. For example:

what they have done has been done in the sight of God (NIV) (NIV11)

Many English translations, like BSB, just say that these deeds have been done in God. That phrase is ambiguous and can be understood in any of the above ways. In some languages it may be possible to use an expression like that. If that is true in your language, it is good to use that term. If you must choose one of the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This agrees with John's thought in 15:5, for example. And many commentaries support this interpretation.

John 3:22

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:22–26

John's disciples began to discuss ceremonial washing. They told John that Jesus was baptizing more people than he was. John said that Jesus was superior to him and should get more disciples.

3:22a

After this, Jesus and His disciples went into the Judean countryside,

- ¶ Later on, Jesus and his disciples went into the farm area of Judea.
- ¶ At another time, Jesus and his followers left Jerusalem and went down into the province of Judea.

After this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After this indicates a change in the time setting of the story. For example:

On another occasion

Later (GW)

Jesus and His disciples went into the Judean countryside: This clause tells the place setting for the next

part of the story. The Greek more literally says Jesus and His disciples “went into the land of Judea,” as in the RSV. Jesus had earlier been in Jerusalem. See 2:13, 2:23. Jerusalem was a city in the province or region of Judea. So it may be natural to translate the clause in this way:

Jesus and his disciples left Jerusalem and went into the Judean countryside (NLT)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” in a learner-teacher relationship. The disciple followed his teacher in order to learn from him and live based on his teaching and example. See how you translated this word in 1:35.

Judean countryside: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Judean countryside refers to that part of Judea that was outside the towns. It included farms, villages, and wild country.

3:22b

where He spent some time with them and baptized.

- In this area he spent some time with his disciples and baptized people.
- Here he and his followers stayed and also baptized other people.

where He spent some time with them: The word He refers to Jesus and the word them to his disciples or followers. Here is another way to translate this clause:

where he stayed with his followers (NCV)

spent some time: The Greek text does not indicate how much time Jesus spent (how long Jesus stayed) in the Judean countryside. It is good to use a general expression. For example:

where he stayed (NCV)

If you must indicate how long Jesus stayed there, it is recommended that you indicate that it was several weeks.

and baptized: In some languages it is more natural to include the object, people. For example:

and baptized people (NCV)

baptized: The verb baptized means to wash a person with water in a religious ritual. This religious ritual represented purification from sin. It was a sign that

someone had repented. It also marked the beginning of a person's life as one of God's pure people.

Here are some ways to translate the word baptized in this context:

- Use a descriptive term. For example:

ritually wash

accept people as believers in/with water

- Use a term for a similar ritual that is already used in your culture. You may need to indicate that in this context it has a special connection with God. For example:

show that God has purified people with a ceremonial bath

wash people for God

- Use a term that is already accepted by the local churches. In some areas this term may have been borrowed from the national language or transliterated from Greek or English.

You may need to use footnotes or a glossary to explain the meaning more completely.

See the note and how you translated this term in 1:25a. See also KBT baptize, baptism A2.

John 3:23

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:22–26

John's disciples began to discuss ceremonial washing. They told John that Jesus was baptizing more people

than he was. John said that Jesus was superior to him and should get more disciples.

3:23a

Now John was also baptizing at Aenon near Salim,

- At this time John the Baptist was also baptizing people at Aenon near Salim
- As for John the baptizer, he was baptizing people there at the town called Springs near the town called Peace.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces a new event in the story. It is not a time word. Some English translations, such as the NRSV, do not translate it explicitly. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

John was also baptizing: John was baptizing at the same time as Jesus, but at a different place. Try to indicate this in your translation. For example:

As for John, where he was baptizing was there at Aenon.

John: This name refers to John the Baptist. Refer to John 1:6, and see the note there. John was the one who told his disciples who Jesus was (see 1:19–36).

Aenon near Salim: Both Aenon and Salim were apparently towns but they were not well known and were probably small.

Aenon: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Aenon means “fountains.” This was probably a place of many springs.

Salim: The word that the BSB translates as Salim means “peace.”

3:23b

because the water was plentiful there,

- because there was lots/plenty of water there.
- He baptized there because the area had an plentiful supply of water.

because the water was plentiful there: The clause water was plentiful means that there was plenty of water. There is some implied information here: John chose this spot because water was necessary for baptism. Check that your readers understand this.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

where there was plenty of water (NJB)

because water was plentiful in that region (REB)

3:23c**and people kept coming to be baptized.**

- People continued to come to receive baptism.
- Many people went to him there and he baptized them.

and people kept coming to be baptized: This clause indicates that different people from the region continued to come to John so that he would baptize them. Each person was baptized one time; check that your translation does not suggest that people were baptized several times.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

People were going there and being baptized.
(NCV)

people were coming there for John to baptize them (CEV)

to be baptized: This is a passive verb. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb, like the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

he was baptizing them (GNT)

- Use a noun. For example:

people kept coming to him for baptism (NLT)

See how you translated baptized in 3:22b.

John 3:24**Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him**

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:22–26

John's disciples began to discuss ceremonial washing. They told John that Jesus was baptizing more people than he was. John said that Jesus was superior to him and should get more disciples.

3:24**(For John had not yet been thrown into prison.)**

- This took place before Herod put John in prison.
- (This happened before Herod made John a prisoner.)

For: In the Greek text 3:24 is connected to 3:23 with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *For*. It indicates that the clause that follows is background information that explains when this event happened. (The parentheses also help to indicate this.) Several translations do not explicitly translate this word but instead use parentheses. Indicate that the following clause is background information in whatever way is natural in your language.

John had not yet been thrown into prison: This statement is not part of the main story. It is a reference to what would happen later. The story is told in Matthew 14:3, Mark 6:17–20, and Luke 3:19–20. The author assumed that his readers already knew this story. In some languages it may be more natural to put this information before 3:23. See the General Comment on 3:23–24 following this note.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as *been thrown* is passive. King Herod was the one who ordered his soldiers/guards to put John in prison. (The word *thrown* is a figure of speech meaning that they put him in prison. They probably did not literally throw John into prison. But it does imply that they used force.)

There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

John had not yet been put in prison. (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

This was before the authorities put John in prison.

It would be good to have a footnote saying why the authorities later put John in prison. Matthew 14:3–12, and Mark 6:14–29 tell the story of John being put in prison. For example:

King Herod later put John in prison because John criticized Herod for marrying his brother's wife.

General Comment on 3:23–24

The information that John the Baptist was not yet in jail is background information and not on the story line. In some languages it is more natural to put 3:24 before 3:23. For example:

^{23–24}John had not yet been put in jail. He was at Aenon near Salim, where there was a lot of water, and people were coming there for John to baptize them. (CEV)

John 3:25

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:22–26

John's disciples began to discuss ceremonial washing. They told John that Jesus was baptizing more people than he was. John said that Jesus was superior to him and should get more disciples.

3:25

Then a dispute arose between John's disciples and a certain Jew over the issue of ceremonial washing.

- Some of John's disciples and a Jew began to discuss how to make a person pure/clean.
- John's followers argued/disagreed with another Jew about how to make a person pure.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Then* here introduces a new event in the story. Some English translations, such as the NCV, do not translate it explicitly. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language.

a dispute arose between John's disciples and a certain Jew over the issue of ceremonial washing:

This clause indicates that John's disciples and another Jew discussed or argued about purification. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Some of John's disciples began arguing with a Jew about the matter of ritual washing. (GNT)

There was a disagreement between John's disciples and a certain Jew over ceremonial cleansing.

John's followers got into an argument with a Jewish man about ceremonial washing. (CEV)

dispute: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *dispute* here refers to a conversation in which people held different opinions. See the translations of *dispute* in the examples in the note above.

John's disciples: A disciple is a follower or learner. See the note on 3:22a. You should probably translate *disciples* using the same word in both verses.

a certain Jew: John's disciples were also Jews. So it may be clearer to translate the phrase in this way:

another Jew

There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the singular noun *Jew*. This is followed by nearly every major English translation. For example:

with a Jewish man (CEV) (BSB, NIV, GNT, CEV, GW, NASB, NET, NCV, NJB, NLT, RSV, NRSV, ESV).

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the plural noun "*Jews*." For example:

with some Jews (REB) (REB, KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because it has better manuscript support. Also, most English translations follow this option. However, if the major language translation in your area follows option (2), you may choose to follow it.

ceremonial washing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *ceremonial washing* refers to the purification ritual that the Jewish people did. They did it to make something pure to use in worship. Here it could refer to washing one's body or clothes, or it could refer to baptism. Because they asked John the Baptist about Jesus baptizing in verse 26, many think that *ceremonial washing* here refers to baptism. However, it is an unusual way to refer to baptism. It is the same word that is used in 2:6b, where the BSB translates it as "*rites of purification*." See the note there.

Here is another way to translate this word:

cleansing rituals

John 3:26

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:22–26

John's disciples began to discuss ceremonial washing. They told John that Jesus was baptizing more people than he was. John said that Jesus was superior to him and should get more disciples.

3:26a

So John's disciples came to him and said,

- The disciples came over to John. They said,
- John's followers told him about this. They said,

Apparently the disciples came to John to ask a question related to what they discussed about purification. Perhaps baptism was part of their discussion or the word "purification" referred to baptism.

3:26b

"Look, Rabbi, the One who was with you beyond the Jordan,

- "Teacher, remember that man who was with you^(sing) when you were on the other side of the Jordan.
- "Sir, you know that man who was with you^(sing) when we^(incl) were on the other side of the Jordan River.

Look, Rabbi, the One who was with you beyond the Jordan: These men referred back to the events recorded in John 1:19–34. It appears that they wanted John to be jealous of Jesus. They were not happy that Jesus was getting more disciples than John. Consider how it is natural to refer to someone in a situation like that. For example:

Teacher, remember the man who was with you on the other side of the Jordan River...? (NCV)

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translated as Look calls attention to what is being said. In some languages it is more natural to say "behold" or "pay attention."

Rabbi: This word is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means "my great one." When John wrote his gospel, people used this word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a teacher at a school. Use an expression that is natural and shows proper respect.

See how you translated this term in 3:2b and 1:38, and see the notes there.

beyond the Jordan: This phrase refers to the east side of the Jordan River. In some languages it may be natural to make one or both of these points explicit. For example:

the east side of the Jordan (GNT)

the other side of the Jordan River (NCV)

3:26c

the One you testified about—

- He was the one you^(sing) told us^(excl) who he was.
- He was the one about whom you^(sing) knew and you declared/explained that he was the Lamb of God.

the One you testified about: John's followers used this expression to make clear whom they were talking about. Perhaps they also wanted to remind John of what he had done for Jesus. Maybe they did not think that it was right that Jesus had more disciples than John after John helped him.

Jesus was the one about whom John had testified (told what he knew). John testified that Jesus was the Son of God. See John 1:15, 1:29–34. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

the man to whom you bore witness (NJB)

the one you identified as the Messiah (NLT)

you spoke about a man (CEV)

testified: The verb testified means "told what he knew was true." In this context John has said positive things about Jesus. John had spoken well of Jesus and had

declared that he was “the Lamb of God” and “the Son of God.” See the note on “testimony” at 1:19a.

3:26d–e

He is baptizing, and everyone is going to Him: These clauses indicate that John’s disciples were not happy about what was happening. Previously, John had been the only one who baptized people. Now Jesus was becoming popular and was baptizing people.

3:26d

He is baptizing,

- Now he is baptizing people
- See here, he is now also baptizing people.

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to supply the name. For example

Jesus is baptizing

baptizing: The verb baptizing means to wash a person with water in a special religious ritual. In this context the ritual represented purification from sin. It did not mean that the person was washed to remove dirt. Baptism also marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people. See how you translated this word in 3:22c.

See also baptize, baptism in KBT.

3:26e

and everyone is going to Him.”

- and all the people are going to him.”
- Many more people are going to him instead of coming to us^(incl).”

everyone is going to Him: This clause is a hyperbole, an exaggeration. It emphasizes that many people were going to Jesus. But not every person in the area was going to Jesus. You may need to indicate in some way that the speaker is exaggerating. For example:

everyone in the world is running to him

absolutely everybody is going to him!

In other languages it may be necessary to remove the exaggeration. For example:

more and more people are going to him!

look at how many people are going to him!

going to Him: The implied idea is that people were going to Jesus to be baptized. In some languages it

may be more natural to make this explicit. For example:

now all the people are going to him and are being baptized

look at all the people going to him to be baptized!

In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that these people were not going to John and his disciples. For example:

everybody is going to him instead of coming to us. (NLT)

John 3:27

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John’s disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John’s baptism or Jesus’ baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:27–30

John declared that he was not the Messiah. The Messiah, he said, was much more important than he was.

3:27

John replied, “A man can receive only what is given him from heaven.”

- ¶ John said to them, “A person only has what God gives.
- ¶ John told them, “God is the one who gives a person his role/status/importance.

A man can receive only what is given him from heaven: This sentence is in the form of a proverb. It indicates that all we are and all we have is a gift from God. John the Baptist was saying that God gave him his ministry. It was not the same as the ministry that God had given the Messiah.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

No one can receive anything unless God gives it from heaven. (NLT)

No one can have anything unless God gives it to him. (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

A man can get only what God gives him. (NCV)

only what is given him from heaven: This is a passive clause. It means “except what God gives.” There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

except what is given him from heaven (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

only what God gives him (NCV)

unless God in heaven allows it (CEV)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language.

from heaven: This phrase is a Jewish way of speaking about God that shows respect. The Jews often avoided referring directly to God. In some languages it is more natural to indicate that this refers to God. For example:

No one can receive anything unless God gives it from heaven. (NLT)

John 3:28

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John’s disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John’s baptism or Jesus’ baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:27–30

John declared that he was not the Messiah. The Messiah, he said, was much more important than he was.

3:28a

You yourselves can testify that I said,

- You personally have heard me say that
- You^(plur) know that I told you^(plur) that

You yourselves can testify that I said: The phrase You yourselves is an emphasized way of referring to John’s listeners. They had actually heard what he had said earlier. For example:

You personally know how clearly I said this

You yourselves heard me say (NCV)

You...can testify: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as You...can testify here indicates that John’s listeners personally heard what John said. They were present when it happened. So they could tell others what they heard. And they could be trusted as reliable, as people others could depend on.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You...heard me say (NCV)

You...can tell what you heard

that I said: John was referring to what he said in 1:20b. The verb said introduces a direct quotation. For examples of how to translate this as an indirect quotation, see the General Comment following 3:28b. In some languages it is more natural to tell whom John was talking to. For example:

that I said to them

how I told you (CEV)

3:28b

‘I am not the Christ,

- I am not the Messiah/Christ.
- it is not I who am the Messiah, the Anointed/Appointed One.
- I am not the Promised Savior.

I am not the Christ: The Greek text here has a little more emphasis than in 1:20b. Try to translate this in a strong and clear way. For example:

I am definitely not the Messiah/Christ.

the Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Christ can also be translated as “the Messiah.” The phrase is used as a title. The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as King and Savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning. Refer to your translation of the Christ in 1:20b and see KBT Christ, Messiah.

General Comment on 3:28a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 3:28a and b. For example:

^{28b}I am not the Messiah, ^{28a}as you yourselves have heard me say.

3:28c

but am sent ahead of Him.’

- I am the one who has been sent to go in front of him. (NJB)
- Rather, God sent me to tell others about him before he came.

but am sent ahead of Him: This clause indicates that God had sent John before Jesus the Messiah. God sent John ahead so that John could prepare people for the Messiah. The clause implies that John’s ministry is not as important as that of the Messiah himself. So some translations supply the word “only.” For example:

I am only here to prepare the way for him. (NLT)

I am only the one sent ahead of him. (CEV)

but: The conjunction but expresses contrast. Although John was not the Messiah, God had sent him before the Messiah to prepare for his coming.

am sent: The verb am sent is passive. It implies that God sent John. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

I have been sent (NRSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

but God has sent me here

ahead of Him: This phrase means “before the Christ,” that is, preparing people to hear what the Messiah would say. For example:

to prepare people for the coming of the Christ/
Messiah

General Comment on 3:28a–c

This verse contains a quotation inside another quotation. John quoted his own earlier words. In some languages it may be natural to use an indirect quotation here. For example:

You personally heard me say that I am not the Messiah but just the one God sent to announce his coming.

John 3:29

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John’s disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John’s baptism or Jesus’ baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:27–30

John declared that he was not the Messiah. The Messiah, he said, was much more important than he was.

3:29a–c

These two sentences contain a metaphor. There is a bridegroom, a bride, and a friend of the bridegroom. These represent Jesus, God’s people, and John the Baptist. See the General Comment at the end of 3:29c for ways to help make the meaning clear. As you translate this metaphor, consider the customs of your own culture. The main point of this metaphor is that the bridegroom (Jesus) is more important than his friend (John the Baptist).

3:29a**The bride belongs to the bridegroom.**

- The bridegroom is the one who marries/takes the bride.
- At a wedding the groom is the important one, the one who marries the bride.

The bride belongs to the bridegroom: This illustration or metaphor is about a wedding. It does not refer to a specific wedding, but to weddings in general. The point is that the bridegroom is the important man at any wedding. He is the one who marries the bride. Refer to Mark 2:19–20 to see how you translated bridegroom there.

Here are other ways to translate this metaphor:

The bridegroom is the one to whom the bride belongs. (GNT)

He who has the bride is the bridegroom. (NRSV)

At a wedding the groom is the one who gets married. (CEV)

3:29b**The friend of the bridegroom stands and listens for him,**

- The bridegroom's friend stands nearby and listens for his voice
- The best man just waits and listens for him.

The friend of the bridegroom: The friend of the bridegroom is like the best man in Western culture. He helped the bridegroom prepare for his wedding. This is a picture of John the Baptist, who prepared the way for Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The bridegroom's friend (REB)

The friend who helps the bridegroom (NCV)

The friend who serves the bridegroom

stands and listens for him: The exact meaning of this expression is not clear. The friend waits and listens for the bridegroom, but it does not say where or why he waits. He may be at the bride's house or at the bridegroom's house.

Nor is it clear what the bridegroom says. The important point is that the best man is less important

than the bridegroom. He acts in a humble way, just standing and listening. Probably he is listening for the bridegroom to arrive. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

stands by and listens to/for him

waits and listens for his coming

3:29c**and is overjoyed to hear the bridegroom's voice.**

- and is happy when he hears the bridegroom's voice.
- He is very happy when he hears the bridegroom come.

is overjoyed to hear the bridegroom's voice: The bridegroom's friend is very happy just to hear the bridegroom speak. This shows that the bridegroom is much more important than his friend. His friend is content to be less important. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

He is very glad/happy that he gets to hear the bridegroom's voice.

rejoices greatly at the bridegroom's voice (NRSV)

General Comment on 3:29b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in this sentence. For example:

^{29b–c}The best man is glad just to be there and to hear the groom's voice. (CEV)

3:29d**That joy is mine, and it is now complete.**

- In that same way I am now completely happy.
- I too am very happy that the bridegroom has come to his bride.
- I am like that friend and so now I rejoice, because the Messiah has come to his people.

The Greek begins this sentence with a word that refers back to the previous statement. The NRSV translates it as "For this reason." John indicated that he was like the bridegroom's friend, and that he was happy just as the friend was. He was happy that the one whom he had waited for had come. He was also happy that he had heard his voice. He was even happy that now people were going to Jesus to be baptized, rather than to him. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

This is how my own happiness is made complete.
(GNT)

That's why I am so glad. (CEV)

In the same way I am really happy. (NCV)

General Comment on 3:29a–d

In 3:29d, John explains part of the metaphor—he is happy like the bridegroom's friend is happy. However, it may still be necessary to explain more of the metaphor in your translation. Your readers need to understand that the bridegroom is a metaphor/illustration of the Messiah. Also, they should understand that he has come to his people just as the bridegroom comes to his bride. You may need to make some of this explicit. For example:

^{29a}It is the bridegroom who marries the bride and that is who the Messiah is like. ^{29b}I am just like a friend who helps the bridegroom. This friend listens to know that the bridegroom has come ^{29c}and then he is glad. ^{29d}I too am now full of joy that the Messiah has come.

John 3:30

Section 3:22–30: John the Baptist told his disciples that Jesus was greater than him

John's disciples had an argument with another Jew. They argued about whether John's baptism or Jesus' baptism was better. John told his disciples that he was just there to tell people that Jesus was the Savior. So Jesus should get more followers. Jesus was superior to him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

John the Baptist told the truth that he knew about Jesus

Paragraph 3:27–30

John declared that he was not the Messiah. The Messiah, he said, was much more important than he was.

3:30

He must increase; I must decrease.

- The Messiah/Christ must increase in honor, while I must decrease in honor."

- It is necessary for me to become less important and for the bridegroom, Jesus, to become more important."

He must increase; I must decrease: The verb increase means "to make larger," and the verb decrease means "to make smaller." This verse indicates that it was necessary that Jesus begin to receive more honor (increase in status). It was also necessary that John the Baptist begin to receive less honor (decrease in status). It is implied that it was necessary because God wanted it to happen. It was God's will that Jesus the Messiah begin to get more disciples than John.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

He must increase in importance, while I must decrease in importance. (GW)

Jesus must become more important, while I become less important. (CEV)

John 3:31

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things. God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God's anger. On the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God's Son, have eternal life.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

Those who believe in God's Son have eternal life

Paragraph 3:31–36

The Greek text does not have quotation marks, so it is not certain when John the Baptist stops speaking. There are two possible ways to understand where John the Baptist stops speaking:

1. John stops speaking at the end of 3:30. (NRSV, GNT, ESV, NIV2011, REB, NET, probably CEV)
2. John stops speaking at the end of 3:36. (BSB, NIV84, NJB, NASB, GW, NLT, NCV) The KJV does not use

quotation marks and so does not indicate when the speaker changes.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). These Notes end John the Baptist's words at the end of verse 30. This is the view of many commentators. Kostenberger (p. 133) cites Dodd, Morris, Carson, Borchert, Beasley-Murray, Burge, Witherington, and Schnackenburg. The author probably wrote this paragraph in his own words. It is recommended that you translate these verses as the author's words. But if other translations in your area have translated them as John the Baptist's own words, that is acceptable.

In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:31a

The One who comes from above is above all.

- ¶ The Chosen One who comes from God is greater than everything.
- ¶ Jesus is the one who comes from God and is greater than everyone else.

The One who comes from above: This expression refers to Jesus. Translate this expression so that this is clear. For example:

God's Son comes from heaven and is greater than everything. (CEV)

comes from above: This phrase indicates that Jesus came from heaven, that is, from the place where God lives.

is above all: This phrase means that Jesus is more important than anything or anyone else. He is superior to all other beings.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

is greater than all (GNT)

3:31b

The one who is from the earth belongs to the earth and speaks as one from the earth.

- A human being from the earth belongs to the earth and can only say what he knows as someone from the earth.
- John is just a human and teaches/speaks only what he knows as a person from earth.

The one who is from the earth belongs to the earth and speaks as one from the earth: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as The one who is from the

earth belongs to the earth and speaks as one from the earth includes the same Greek phrase three times. That Greek phrase is more literally "of/from the earth." So the entire clause is more literally "the one being of/from the earth is of/from the earth and of/from the earth he speaks." Unlike Jesus, who was from heaven, those from the earth had never seen heaven. They could only tell what they knew as people from earth.

The author was referring to anyone and everyone apart from Jesus, including John the Baptist. For example:

Everyone who comes from the earth belongs to the earth and speaks about earthly things. (CEV)

speaks as one from the earth: There are at least three different interpretations about what this phrase means:

1. It means that people from the earth can only speak with the knowledge of people from the earth, as in the BSB and NIV.
2. It means that they speak about earthly things. For example:

we speak of earthly things (NLT) (NET, NASB, CEV, GNT, NCV, NLT, KJV, RSV, NRSV, GW)

1. It means that they speak in earthly ways. For example:

speaks in an earthly way (ESV) (ESV, REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It interprets the Greek phrase the same way that it was interpreted earlier in the clause. Also, many commentators support this interpretation.

John spoke about things that he could know as a human. The things he said were not wrong, or sinful, but they came from the earth rather than heaven. 3:31 John often uses the word "world" in a negative sense, referring to the sinful world system. But he uses the word "earth" in a neutral sense, without implying anything good or bad. He did not speak as Jesus did, coming from heaven with God's direct authority and knowledge. He was a human and he could only speak what he knew as a human from earth. He had not come from heaven, that is, from God.

3:31c

The One who comes from heaven is above all.

- The one who comes from God is the greatest one of all.
- But Jesus is from God, and he is in charge of everything everywhere.

The One who comes from heaven is above all: There is a textual problem in this sentence:

1. Many Greek manuscripts read “the one who comes from heaven is above all.” For example:

The person who comes from heaven is superior to everyone. (GW) (BSB, NRSV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NIV, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts read “the one from heaven.” The rest of the sentence is in verse 32: “testifies to what he has seen and heard.” For example:

He who comes from heaven bears witness... (NJB) (NJB, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations. It is more likely that a few words were omitted in some Greek manuscripts than that some were added, because they are a repetition of what is in 3:31a.

The One who comes from heaven: This expression means the same as “The one who comes from above” in 3:31a. It refers to Jesus. He is the one from heaven, that is, from the place where God lives.

heaven: The word heaven refers to the place where God lives.

is above all: The expression is above all is the same as in 3:31a. See the note there.

John 3:32

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things. God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God’s anger. On the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God’s Son, have eternal life.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

Those who believe in God’s Son have eternal life

Paragraph 3:31–36

The Greek text does not have quotation marks, so it is not certain when John the Baptist stops speaking. There are two possible ways to understand where John the Baptist stops speaking:

1. John stops speaking at the end of 3:30. (NRSV, GNT, ESV, NIV2011, REB, NET, probably CEV)
2. John stops speaking at the end of 3:36. (BSB, NIV84, NJB, NASB, GW, NLT, NCV) The KJV does not use quotation marks and so does not indicate when the speaker changes.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). These Notes end John the Baptist’s words at the end of verse 30. This is the view of many commentators. Kostenberger (p. 133) cites Dodd, Morris, Carson, Borchert, Beasley-Murray, Burge, Witherington, and Schnackenburg. The author probably wrote this paragraph in his own words. It is recommended that you translate these verses as the author’s words. But if other translations in your area have translated them as John the Baptist’s own words, that is acceptable.

In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:32a

He testifies to what He has seen and heard,

- He tells us what he has seen and heard in heaven.
- Jesus tells us what he has seen and heard in heaven.

He testifies: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testifies means “tells what he witnessed.” It implies that what he says is true. Jesus told about things he personally knew and he told the truth.

to what He has seen and heard: Jesus saw and heard the truth about God in heaven. He knew what God was like because he had been with God. In some languages it may be necessary to make a reference to heaven explicit. For example:

because he has actually seen and heard it in heaven

3:32b

yet no one accepts His testimony.

- But not many believe what he says.
- However, only a few accept that what he said is true.

yet no one accepts His testimony: This is a figure of speech called a hyperbole, an exaggeration. Here it indicates that many or most people did not accept Jesus' testimony (what he testified). There were in fact some who accepted what Jesus had to say, but they were not the majority. In some languages it may be necessary to remove the figure of speech and say this explicitly. For example:

but how few believe what he tells them! (NLT)

John 3:33

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things. God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God's anger. On the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God's Son, have eternal life.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

Those who believe in God's Son have eternal life

Paragraph 3:31–36

The Greek text does not have quotation marks, so it is not certain when John the Baptist stops speaking. There are two possible ways to understand where John the Baptist stops speaking:

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them as John the Baptist's own words, that is acceptable.

In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:33

Whoever accepts His testimony has certified that God is truthful.

- The person who trusts it confirms/shows that God is telling the truth.
- But those who accept/believe, they confirm/prove that God's words are true.

Whoever accepts His testimony has certified that God is truthful:

The person who believes Jesus' testimony is declaring his trust in God. He is showing that he trusts God, that he knows that God deserves his trust.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

To accept his witness is to declare that God speaks the truth.

But everyone who does believe him has shown that God is truthful. (CEV)

accepts His testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as accepts here means "received" or "believed." A person who accepts Jesus' testimony welcomes and believes what Jesus says about what he witnessed and believes it to be true.

certified: The Greek word that the BSB translated as certified means "guaranteed." It is to confirm or agree that something is true. In some languages it is more natural to talk about "proving" or "confirming." For example:

has proven that God is true (NCV)

has confirmed clearly that God is truthful (NET)

But whoever believes Jesus' testimony says: "The word of God is definitely true."

John 3:34

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things.

God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God's anger. On the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God's Son, have eternal life.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

Those who believe in God's Son have eternal life

Paragraph 3:31–36

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In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:34a

For the One whom God has sent speaks the words of God,

- That is because the one whom God has sent speaks what God tells him to,
- They confirm/prove that because Jesus is the one whom God has sent and he speaks what God tells him to say.

For the One whom God has sent: This phrase refers to Jesus, God's Son, who speaks the words of God. God sent him from heaven to earth. If this is not clear, it may be necessary to make it explicit. For example:

For the one whom God has sent from heaven

speaks the words of God: This phrase means "says what God tells him to say." Here is another way to translate this phrase:

speak God's message (CEV)

3:34b

for God gives the Spirit without limit.

- because God has given him the Spirit with no limits.
- That is true because God has given all the power of the Holy Spirit to Jesus.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for here introduces a reason. God gave his Spirit to Jesus without measure, so Jesus spoke the words of God.

Here is another way to translate this word:

because (GNT)

God gives the Spirit without limit: God gave the Holy Spirit to his Son Jesus without any limits. He generously and completely gave the Spirit to Jesus. It may be natural to say whom God gave the Spirit to. If this is true in your language, you should refer back to the one "whom God has sent" in 3:34a. For example:

God gives him the Spirit without limit (NLT)

the Spirit: This noun phrase here refers to God's Spirit, the Holy Spirit.

without limit: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as without limit means "without any limits." In some languages it may be natural to use a positive expression. For example:

he completely gives the Spirit

God gives him the fullness of his Spirit (GNT)

John 3:35

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things. God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God's anger. On

the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God's Son, have eternal life.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

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Paragraph 3:31–36

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In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:35a

The Father loves the Son and

- God the Father loves the Son.
- God the Father loves his Son and

The Father loves the Son: The expression The Father refers to God the Father and the expression the Son refers to Jesus, the Son of God.

the Son: This phrase is a short form of "the Son of God," which is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did

not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the phrase "the Son of God" in 1:34. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

3:35b

has placed all things in His hands.

- He has given him power over all things.
- has given him all authority over everything.

has placed all things in His hands: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as has placed all things in His hands is a figure of speech. It indicates that the Son is in charge of all that happens. For example:

has given him complete authority

has given him power over everything (NCV)

has put everything in his power (GNT)

John 3:36

Section 3:31–36: Jesus is the one who came from heaven

John the gospel writer says that Jesus is greater than everyone else. He is greater because he came from heaven and knows the truth about heavenly things. God the Father sent Jesus and given him authority over all things. However, people did not accept what Jesus said and so they will experience God's anger. On the other hand, those who believe in Jesus, God's Son, have eternal life.

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Jesus was more important than John the Baptist

God sent Jesus to tell his message

Those who believe in God's Son have eternal life

Paragraph 3:31–36

The Greek text does not have quotation marks, so it is not certain when John the Baptist stops speaking. There are two possible ways to understand where John the Baptist stops speaking:

1. John stops speaking at the end of 3:30. (NRSV, GNT, ESV, NIV2011, REB, NET, probably CEV)
2. John stops speaking at the end of 3:36. (BSB, NIV84, NJB, NASB, GW, NLT, NCV) The KJV does not use

quotation marks and so does not indicate when the speaker changes.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). These Notes end John the Baptist's words at the end of verse 30. This is the view of many commentators. Kostenberger (p. 133) cites Dodd, Morris, Carson, Borchert, Beasley-Murray, Burge, Witherington, and Schnackenburg. The author probably wrote this paragraph in his own words. It is recommended that you translate these verses as the author's words. But if other translations in your area have translated them as John the Baptist's own words, that is acceptable.

In this paragraph the author states that Jesus is superior to John the Baptist.

3:36a

Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life.

- The person who trusts in the Son will have forever life from God.
- All people who trust in the Son live forever with God.

Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life: This is one of the most important ideas in the chapter. In some languages it is more natural to put in something to emphasize the idea. For example:

Whoever believes in the Son has truly/really got the life that continues forever.

Whoever believes in the Son: This refers to anyone and everyone who trusts Jesus. So in some languages it may be more natural to use a plural noun or pronoun. For example:

All those people who believe in the Son

Everyone who has faith in the Son (CEV)

believes in the Son: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b, 1:12b, 3:15, 3:16b, and 3:18. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

has faith in the Son (CEV)

trusts in the Son

puts their faith in the Son (REB)

the Son: See how you translated this phrase in 3:35a.

eternal life: These people have spiritual life from God, life that continues forever. See the note at 3:15, where the same phrase is used. See also how you translated the phrase there.

3:36b

Whoever rejects the Son will not see life.

- But the person who rejects the Son, he will not live forever.
- However, no one who refuses to believe the Son will ever see/receive this life.

Whoever rejects the Son will not see life: This expression refers to anyone and everyone who rejects the Son. The people who reject the Son are those who disobey him and refuse to believe what he says. By rejecting their Savior, they reject eternal life. For example:

all those who disobey the Son will never see/enter that life

none who disobey will see/receive eternal life

no one who rejects him will ever share in that life (CEV)

see life: This phrase here means to experience the true spiritual life mentioned in 3:36a, life with God forever. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

experience eternal life (NLT)

share in that life (CEV)

3:36c

Instead, the wrath of God remains on him."

- God will continue to be angry with him.
- Instead, God will continue to reject him/them in his anger.

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Instead* here connects a negative statement ("will not see life") to a positive statement ("must endure God's wrath"). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction "but" as in the NRSV.

will not have life, but will remain under God's punishment (GNT)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

will not see life. Instead, he will see God's constant anger. (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

will never have life. God's anger stays on them. (NCV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

will continue to experience God's anger and not enjoy eternal life

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

the wrath of God remains on him: This Greek that the BSB translates literally as the wrath of God remains on him means “God will continue to be angry with him.” It indicates that God will continue to reject people who do not want to believe. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

God's wrath rests upon him (REB)

remains under God's angry judgment (NLT)

God will be angry with them forever (CEV)

John 4:1

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:1–3

These verses tell the background to the story of Jesus' conversation with a woman at a well. The Pharisees knew that Jesus' disciples were baptizing more people than John, and they were jealous because he was popular. So Jesus decided to leave Judea and travel north through Samaria back to Galilee.

See the General Comment at the end of verse 3 for other ways to order these verses.

4:1

When Jesus realized that the Pharisees were aware He was gaining and baptizing more disciples than John

- ¶ Jesus learned that the Pharisees had heard that he/Jesus was gaining and baptizing more disciples than John was.
- ¶ Many people were now following Jesus and receiving baptism from him, and fewer were now following John. The Pharisees came to know about this, and Jesus learned that they knew.

When Jesus realized that the Pharisees were aware: The Pharisees heard some news, and then Jesus learned that they had heard it. What the Pharisees heard and what Jesus learned were both correct.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

when Jesus knew that the Pharisees had heard (NET)

Jesus found out that the Pharisees had learned

This is a complicated idea and it may be necessary to break it up into two sentences. For example:

Jesus learned that the Pharisees had heard some news. They had heard that...

Jesus realized: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say Jesus realized. For example:

Jesus heard (NJB) (BSB, NJB, ESV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, NCV, REB, NIV11)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say the Lord realized. For example:

the Lord (RSV) (KJV, NASB, RSV, NIV84)

The UBS Greek NT has “Jesus,” giving it a C rating, which indicates a high degree of doubt. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), but either option is acceptable. Both options refer to the Lord Jesus. You may want to follow the national or major translation used in your area.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws carefully and exactly. See the note at 1:24 for examples of how to translate the word. Also see how you translated the word there and in 3:1.

He was gaining and baptizing more disciples than John: This quotation indicates that more people were beginning to follow Jesus than were beginning to follow John. It is a comparison. Consider how it is a natural to make such a comparison in your language.

Here are other ways to translate this quotation:

Jesus gathered more learners/disciples and he baptized more of them than John did

There were now many people following Jesus. However, not as many people followed John. And many people were receiving baptism from Jesus. Not as many people were receiving baptism from John.

He: The pronoun here refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to use “Jesus” here. The subject is the same as in the first clause in 4:1. For example:

he (CEV)

gaining and baptizing more disciples: The direct object disciples belongs with both verbs, gaining and baptizing. Jesus was gaining...disciples, that is, persuading people to follow him. People wanted to follow him when they heard him teach and saw him do miracles. Jesus did not force them to become his disciples. These people who wanted to become his disciples were then baptized.

baptizing: The verb “baptize” means to use water in a special ceremony to show that God makes his people pure. In this context the ritual represented purification from sin. It did not mean that the person was cleaned to remove dirt. Baptism was a ceremony that marked the beginning of a person’s life as one of God’s pure people.

See the note at 1:25a for more explanation and ways to translate the word “baptize.” See also how you translated the word there. See baptize, baptism A.2 in KBT.

more disciples than John: This is a short way of saying “more disciples than John was gaining and baptizing.”

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to someone who has committed himself to a teacher. He does that in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example. In the New Testament a disciple referred specifically to a person who was learning from a religious teacher. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went.

See the note at 1:35 for ways to translate the word disciples. See also how you translated this word in 1:35 and 2:2.

John: This refers to John the Baptist. He is first mentioned in 1:6.

General Comment on 4:1

The BSB has translated 4:1 as indirect speech. It is also possible to translate it as direct speech. For example:

Now when Jesus learned that the Pharisees had heard, “Jesus is making and baptizing more disciples than John” (NRSV)

General Comment on 4:1

There are three main events described here. These are the events in chronological order (the order in which they happened):

1. Jesus’ disciples baptized more disciples than John the Baptist did.
2. The Pharisees heard about this.
3. Jesus learned that the Pharisees knew about this.

In some languages it may be natural to translate 4:1 in a more chronological order. For example:

^{1a}The Pharisees heard ^{1b}that Jesus was gaining and baptizing more disciples than John.... ^{1a}When the Lord learned of this,... (NIV)

In order to translate in a natural order, it may be necessary to combine 4:1–3. See the General Comment on 4:1–3 at the end of 4:3.

John 4:2

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:1–3

These verses tell the background to the story of Jesus' conversation with a woman at a well. The Pharisees knew that Jesus' disciples were baptizing more people than John, and they were jealous because he was popular. So Jesus decided to leave Judea and travel north through Samaria back to Galilee.

See the General Comment at the end of verse 3 for other ways to order these verses.

4:2

(although it was not Jesus who baptized, but His disciples),

- (However, it was not Jesus who baptized these people. His disciples did.)
- In fact Jesus himself was not the one who baptized people, but/instead his disciples were baptizing people.
- Actually his followers were baptizing people and not Jesus himself/personally.

4:2 gives some parenthetical information that corrects a possible misunderstanding of the previous verse. Jesus himself was not baptizing anyone. His disciples were the ones who were baptizing people.

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

(Actually Jesus was not baptizing people. His disciples were.) (GW)

(Actually, Jesus himself did not baptize anyone; only his disciples did.) (GNT)

But Jesus himself did not baptize the people, rather his disciples baptized them.

although: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *although* introduces the correction of a possible misunderstanding. Readers might think that Jesus himself was baptizing people. This was not so. His disciples were the ones doing that. Introduce this correction in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

although in fact (NIV)

Actually (GW)

But the truth was that it was not Jesus who was doing the baptizing, but rather his disciples only.

it was not Jesus who baptized, but His disciples:

This clause explains what actually happened. Place the verb baptized with the subject that is natural in your language. For example:

although in fact it was not Jesus who baptized, but his disciples (NIV)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* here connects a negative statement ("it was not Jesus himself") to a positive statement ("his disciples who baptized"). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction *but* as in the NRSV.

although in fact it was not Jesus who baptized, but his disciples (NIV)

- Use a conjunction other than *but*. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

although it was not Jesus himself who baptized. Instead, his disciples did it

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

(Actually, Jesus was not baptizing people. His disciples were.) (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

though in fact it was his disciples who baptised, not Jesus himself (NJB)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

His disciples: This phrase identifies who were baptizing people instead of Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to make it clear whose disciples were baptizing. For example:

Jesus' disciples

John 4:3

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:1–3

These verses tell the background to the story of Jesus' conversation with a woman at a well. The Pharisees knew that Jesus' disciples were baptizing more people than John, and they were jealous because he was

popular. So Jesus decided to leave Judea and travel north through Samaria back to Galilee.

See the General Comment at the end of verse 3 for other ways to order these verses.

4:3

He left Judea and returned to Galilee.

- Then Jesus left the area called Judea and went back to the area called Galilee.
- So Jesus with his disciples left the province of Judea to return to the province of Galilee.

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. If you do that, it would be good to supply a connecting word such as “so” or “then.” For example:

So he left Judea and returned to Galilee. (NLT)

He left Judea and returned to Galilee: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as returned is more literally “went away again.” Jesus left the province of Judea, where he had gone in 2:13, and started his journey back to Galilee. Galilee was a province that was north of Judea.

He: The Greek does not mention Jesus' disciples here. In some languages it is more natural to mention his disciples here. For example:

When Jesus knew that, he and his disciples left Judea and went home again to Galilee.

returned to Galilee: Jesus began to journey north, from Judea in the south to Galilee further north. He and his disciples probably all walked. They did not complete their trip at this time. So in your translation you should not indicate that they reached Galilee.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

set out once more for Galilee (REB)

began to travel/walk back to Galilee

headed for Galilee again

General Comment on 4:1–3

The first three verses are one sentence in Greek. In many languages it may be natural to have more than one sentence and put the clauses in a different order. You should order this information in the way that is

most natural in your language. Several English translations reorder the ideas in these verses. For example:

News now reached the Pharisees that Jesus was winning and baptizing more disciples than John; although, in fact, it was his disciples who were baptizing, not Jesus himself. When Jesus heard this, he left Judea and set out once more for Galilee. (REB)

The Pharisees heard that Jesus was making and baptizing more followers than John, although Jesus himself did not baptize people, but his followers did. Jesus knew that the Pharisees had heard about him, so he left Judea and went back to Galilee. (NCV)

Jesus knew that the Pharisees had heard that he was making and baptizing more disciples than John. (Actually, Jesus was not baptizing people. His disciples were.) So he left the Judean countryside and went back to Galilee (GW)

John 4:4

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:4–6

This paragraph tells why Jesus was sitting by a well in Samaria. Jesus was returning to Galilee with his disciples. On the way he passed through Samaria. When they reached Jacob's well, he sat down to rest.

4:4

Now He had to pass through Samaria.

- ¶ It was necessary for Jesus to pass through Samaria.
- ¶ On the way Jesus needed to travel through the province/region of Samaria.

Now: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces a new thought. It does not indicate time. Some English translations do not translate it explicitly. Introduce this new thought in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

And (ESV)

He had to pass through Samaria: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as had to pass through Samaria indicates that it was necessary for Jesus to go through Samaria. This was the short and natural route between Judea and Galilee. It was not, however, necessary to go this way. Therefore many scholars think that here the idea of necessity refers to God's plan and purpose. See the notes on 3:14b and 3:30, where the word "must" refers to this same idea.

pass through Samaria: Samaria was not Jesus' final destination (place he was going to). He was just passing through this area on his way from Judea to Galilee. Samaria was north of Judea but south of Galilee. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

go through Samaria (NRSV)

cross Samaria

Samaria: Samaria was a province or region. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

the area called Samaria

John 4:5

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The

women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:4–6

This paragraph tells why Jesus was sitting by a well in Samaria. Jesus was returning to Galilee with his disciples. On the way he passed through Samaria. When they reached Jacob's well, he sat down to rest.

4:5a

So He came to a town of Samaria called Sychar,

- On his way he came to the Samaritan town called Sychar.
- As he/they traveled through Samaria, Jesus/they arrived at a town called Sychar.

So He came to a town of Samaria called Sychar:

Jesus was traveling with his disciples. If a literal translation indicates that he was alone, you may need to explicitly include the disciples. For example:

In Samaria Jesus with his disciples came to the town called Sychar.

So they arrived at a town in Samaria called Sychar.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *So* means “therefore.” In some languages it may be natural to leave this word implied. For example:

and on his way came to a Samaritan town called Sychar (REB)

a town of Samaria called Sychar: The town of Sychar in Samaria is mentioned only here, so it was probably not large. It may have been only a village or small town. For example:

In Samaria he came to a town named Sychar. (GNT)

4:5b

near the plot of ground that Jacob had given to his son Joseph.

- This town was near the land that Jacob had given to his son Joseph.
- That town was close to the land/field that, before Jacob died long ago, he gave to his child Joseph.

near the plot of ground that Jacob had given to his son Joseph:

Jacob was the son of Isaac, who was the son of Abraham. He was the ancestor of both the Jews and the Samaritans. For more information on this plot of ground, or “field,” see Genesis 33:19 and Joshua 24:32.

Jacob and Joseph lived in the distant past, almost two thousand years before the events in this chapter. In some languages it is more natural to indicate this is some way. For example:

It was near the field that Jacob had long ago given to his son Joseph. (CEV)

It was near the field that our^(excl) ancestor Jacob once gave to his son Joseph.

John 4:6

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:4–6

This paragraph tells why Jesus was sitting by a well in Samaria. Jesus was returning to Galilee with his disciples. On the way he passed through Samaria. When they reached Jacob's well, he sat down to rest.

4:6a**Since Jacob's well was there,**

- There was a well named after Jacob on that land/field.
- A well called Jacob's well was still there.

Jacob's well was there: This well had belonged to the OT person Jacob. He dug this well, or told others to dig it, long ago. You may be able to imply that this refers to something in the distant past. For example:

The well that Jacob had dug was still there. (CEV)

The well that used to belong to Jacob was there.

well: A well is a deep hole in the ground that has water in the bottom. People can lower buckets into the well to get water.

4:6b**Jesus, weary from His journey, sat down by the well.**

- Jesus, because he was tired after his journey, sat down by the well.
- Jesus was tired from his trip, so he sat down next to the well.
- Jesus sat down by the well because he was tired from traveling.

Jesus, weary from His journey, sat down by the well:

This clause continues to set the scene for the conversation in the rest of this section. It explains why Jesus was sitting by the well when a woman arrived. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using two clauses. For example:

Jesus was tired from his long trip, and so he sat down beside the well. (NCV)

weary from His journey: The phrase that the BSB translates as weary from His journey explains why Jesus rested. The travel made Jesus tired. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus was tired from his long trip (NCV)

because the journey had made him tired

His journey: This phrase refers to the fact that Jesus had traveled a long way. In some languages it may be natural to translate journey as a clause. For example:

he had walked/traveled a long way

General Comment on 4:6b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 4:6b. You may want to first say what Jesus did and then why he did it. For example:

Jesus sat down by the well because he was tired from traveling. (GW)

4:6c**It was about the sixth hour.**

- It was the middle of the day.
- The sun was high in the sky.

It was about the sixth hour: The BSB translates literally the Greek clause as about the sixth hour. In New Testament times people started counting the hours of the day at sunrise, about 6 a.m. In some languages it is more natural to say it in a different way. For example:

the sun was in the center of the sky

it was the middle of the day

It was about noon. (NRSV)

John 4:7**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:7a

When a Samaritan woman came to draw water,

- ¶ A woman from Samaria came to get some water.
- ¶ Meanwhile/Then a woman from/of that Samaria region came to take some water from the well.

a Samaritan woman: This phrase refers to a woman who was a member of the Samaritan people group and lived in the region of Samaria.

came: The woman came to the well. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

came to the well (NCV)

to draw water: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to draw water indicates the woman's purpose in coming to the well. The woman's purpose was to draw water, meaning to get or remove water. She probably pulled the water up from the bottom of the well in a bucket. Then she carried it home in a jar. This was the way people usually got water in Jesus' time. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to get some water (GW)

to draw water from the well (CEV)

4:7b

Jesus said to her, "Give Me a drink."

- Jesus said to her, "Would you^(sing) give me a drink?"
- Jesus said, "Please give^(sing) me some water."
- Jesus asked her for a drink of water.

Jesus said to her: The pronoun her refers to the woman who came to the well. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus said to this woman

said: Jesus asked the woman to give him a drink of water. Translate this verb using a word that is natural for making a polite request. For example:

asked (CEV)

Give Me a drink: Jesus made this request politely. In some languages it is more polite and natural to say it in one of these ways:

Please give me a drink. (NLT)

Would you please give me a drink of water? (CEV)

General Comment on 4:7b

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 4:7b as indirect speech. For example:

Jesus asked her for a drink of water.

John 4:8**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:8

(His disciples had gone into the town to buy food.)

- (He asked the woman because his disciples had left, going into the town to buy food.)
- (His disciples were not there because they were in town buying food.)

In Greek, this verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated as "because." The BSB does not translate this word, but leaves it implicit. This word

introduces the reason why Jesus asked the woman, and not his disciples, for water.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Jesus asked the woman because

Translate this conjunction in the way that is the most natural way in your language to introduce a reason.

(His disciples had gone into the town to buy food.):

This is a parenthetical comment, giving the reason why Jesus asked the woman, and not his disciples, for a drink. The disciples had come with Jesus to this place but had then left him alone in order to get food. This reason is a comment by John the author, It is not part of the conversation. It is not part of the story line. The BSB shows this by putting the comment in parentheses.

Use whatever way is natural in your language to indicate that this is the author's comment that gives a reason.

See the General Comment on 4:6–8 for an example of how to put this information in chronological order.

General Comment on 4:6–8

In some languages it may be natural to put the background information before the conversation between Jesus and the woman. For example:

⁶⁻⁸The well that Jacob had dug was still there, and Jesus sat down beside it because he was tired from traveling. It was noon, and after Jesus' disciples had gone into town to buy some food, a Samaritan woman came to draw water from the well.

Jesus asked her, "Would you please give me a drink of water?" (CEV)

John 4:9

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The

women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:9a

"You are a Jew," said the woman.

- The woman from Samaria asked him, "You^(sing) are a Jew
- Then the woman of Samaria said to him, "I am surprised that you as a Jewish man

"You are a Jew," said the woman: It may be more natural in some languages to indicate that the woman was responding to Jesus' request in 4:7b or that she was asking a rhetorical question. For example:

"You are a Jew," she replied, "and I am a Samaritan woman...." (CEV)

The Samaritan woman asked him (GW)

You: This pronoun refers to Jesus.

4:9b

"How can You ask for a drink from me, a Samaritan woman?"

- and I am a woman from Samaria. So why are you asking me for a drink of water?"
- should ask me, a Samaritan woman, for water!"

How can You ask for a drink from me, a Samaritan woman?:

This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise that Jesus had asked the Samaritan woman for a drink. Most Jewish people hated and avoided the Samaritans. The woman was telling Jesus that she was surprised at his request. Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can a Jewish man like you ask a Samaritan woman like me for a drink of water? (GW)

Why are you, a Jew, asking a Samaritan woman like me for a drink?

- Use a statement. For example:

I am surprised that you ask me for a drink, since you are a Jewish man and I am a Samaritan woman. (NCV)

It is very strange that a Jew like you is asking a Samaritan woman for water.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for expressing surprise. You may want to use two or three sentences. For example:

What! You, a Jew, ask for a drink from a Samaritan woman? (REB)

You are a Jew...and I am a Samaritan woman! How can you ask me for a drink of water...? (CEV)

You are a Jew. How is it that you ask me, a Samaritan, for something to drink? (NJB)

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to Jesus.

4:9c

(For Jews do not associate with Samaritans.)

- (For Jews have no dealings with Samaritans.) (RSV)
- The reason she was surprised was that the Jews did not do anything with the people of Samaria.

(For Jews do not associate with Samaritans.): This clause tells the reason why the woman was surprised and asked the question in 4:9b. This reason is a comment by John the author, It is not part of the conversation or the story line. The BSB shows this by putting the comment in parentheses. The NJB separates this sentence with a dash.

Use whatever way is natural in your language to indicate that this is the author's comment that gives a reason.

For: In Greek, this sentence begins with a conjunction that the BSB translates as For. Some English versions do not translate this word, but leave it implicit. This word introduces the reason that the woman was surprised.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

She said this because

Jews do not associate with Samaritans: This clause explains why the woman was surprised at Jesus' request. There are two ways to understand this comment:

1. It means that the Jewish people avoided even talking with the Samaritans. For example:

For Jews do not associate with Samaritans. (NIV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, ESV, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It means that the Jews did not eat from the same dishes as the Samaritans. They considered the Samaritans to be ritually unclean. For example:

Jews will not use the same cups and bowls that Samaritans use. (GNT) (GNT, REB, NET, probably NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This has a broad meaning and can include refusing to share dishes and utensils. The RSV is therefore used in the Display.

Samaritans: The word Samaritans refers to people from the district of Samaria. The Samaritans were the descendants of Jews who had married foreigners. They did not worship God in Jerusalem as the Jews did, and the Jews considered the Samaritans to be foreigners.

You may want to supply a footnote saying that the Jews hated the Samaritans and did not believe that they were God's people.

General Comment on 4:9a–d

In some languages it is more natural to reorder this information and put the explanation first: For example:

The woman was surprised, ^{9d}for Jews refuse to have anything to do with Samaritans. ^{9a}She said to Jesus, ^{9b}“You are a Jew, ^{9c}and I am a Samaritan woman. Why are you asking me for a drink?” (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to both reorder this quote and express it as indirect speech. For example:

^{9d}Because Jews do not normally have anything to do with Samaritans, the woman was surprised.

^aShe asked Jesus ^bwhy he, a Jew, ^casked her, a Samaritan, for a drink.

John 4:10

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:10a

Jesus answered, “If you knew the gift of God

- Jesus replied to her, “It would be good if you^(sing) knew two things. You should know that God wants to give you something
- Jesus said to her, “If only you^(sing) understood what God wants to give you!

If you knew the gift of God: Jesus wanted the woman to know this gift and want it. At this time, she did not even know what Jesus was talking about. In your translation, imply or state explicitly that the woman did not yet know about the gift of God. For example:

If only you knew what God gives (REB)

You don’t know what God wants to give you (CEV)

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to the woman.

the gift of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the gift of God refers to what God gives freely.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what God gives (GNT)

what God wants to give you (CEV)

4:10b

and who is asking you for a drink,

- and who I am, the one requesting a drink of water.
- If only you knew who I am, I who am asking you^(sing) for a drink!

and who is asking you for a drink: In this clause, Jesus was referring to himself. The woman did not know who Jesus really was, that he was the Messiah of God. She only saw him as a Jewish traveler.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and who you are speaking to (NLT)

and you don’t know who is asking you for a drink (CEV)

and who I am, I who am asking you for a drink

4:10c

you would have asked Him,

- Then you^(sing) would ask me to give you water
- Then you would have said to me, ‘Give me a drink.’

you would have asked Him: This is not something that happened. This is what might have happened but did not. It did not happen because the woman did not know the gift of God or who Jesus was. If she knew those things, then she would have asked. Consider how to express a situation like this in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be necessary to say this in the present tense. For example:

you would ask him (GNT)

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to the woman.

Him: This pronoun refers to Jesus. Jesus referred to himself in the third person. In some languages it may be necessary to use the first person here. For example:

you would ask me (CEV)

4:10d and He would have given you living water.”

- and I would give you^(sing) water that makes you live.”
- And/Then I would have given you^(sing) the water that causes you to live.”

and He would have given you living water: This is something that did not happen. It did not happen because the woman did not ask Jesus. But if she had known God’s gift and who Jesus was (things she did not know), then she would have asked Jesus. And if she asked Jesus, he would have given her living water.

However, none of that happened. It could have happened, but it did not. The conditions in 4:10a–c were not fulfilled.

As in 4:10c, you may need to make it explicit that He refers to Jesus himself. For example:

and I would have given you living water

living water: This phrase here means “the water that makes people really live” or “the water that gives life.” For example:

the water that gives life (CEV)

life-giving water (GNT)

General Comment on 4:10a–d

In some languages it is more natural to reorder this information. You might want to indicate that Jesus wanted the woman to know these things and then use an “if” clause as a summary statement. For example:

Jesus said to her, “I wish that you^(sing) understood what God wants to freely give you. And I wish that you knew who I am, I who ask you for a drink. If you knew those things, you would ask me for a drink. And I would give you the water that gives life.”

John 4:11

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:11a

“Sir,” the woman replied,

- “Sir,” the woman answered him,
- The woman replied, “Sir,

“Sir,” the woman replied: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir is a polite form of address. Use whatever term is natural in your language for showing respect to a religious teacher.

4:11b

“You have nothing to draw with

- “you^(sing) have nothing to use to get the water,
- you^(sing) do not have a bucket to pull up the water

4:11c

and the well is deep.

- and this is a deep well.
- and this well is a deep one.

4:11b–c

You have nothing to draw with: This clause indicates that Jesus did not have a container to use to get water out of the well. He probably did not have a rope to pull it up with either.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you don’t have anything to use to get water (GW)

you have nothing to dip with

the well is deep: Apparently this well did not have a way to walk or climb down to the water. It was a straight hole. People who needed water lowered a container into the well on a rope.

4:11d**Where then will You get this living water?**

- Where/How would you^(sing) get water that would give a person life?
- I do not understand how you^(sing) would get this water that causes the one who drinks it to live.

Where then will You get this living water?: This is a real question. Even though the woman did not understand how Jesus could give her water, she really wanted some.

General Comment on 4:11a–d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. You may want to place the quote introducer in the middle of the woman's speech. For example:

"Sir," the woman said, "you have nothing to draw with, and the well is deep. Where can you get this living water?" (NIV)

"But sir, you don't have a rope or a bucket," she said, "and this well is very deep. Where would you get this living water?" (NLT)

"But sir, because you don't have a bucket to get the water and the well is very deep, how will you get this water?" the woman asked him.

John 4:12**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:12a**Are You greater than our father Jacob,**

- Are you^(sing) more important than our^(incl) ancestor Jacob,
- You^(sing) are surely not as great as our^(incl) ancestor Jacob,

Are You greater than our father Jacob: This is the first part of a rhetorical question. It expects a negative answer. It shows surprise and is possibly a rebuke to Jesus. The woman thought that Jesus was not as great as their ancestor Jacob and therefore he could not supply better water.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question to express this surprise:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you a greater man than our father Jacob...?
(NJB)

do you^(sing) think you're greater than our ancestor Jacob...? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

You^(sing) cannot be as great as our^(incl) ancestor Jacob.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is the most natural in your language.

greater: In some languages it is not natural to use a comparison. In those languages you will need to imply a comparison in a way that is natural. For example:

Our ancestor Jacob was important/great. You are not important/great.

than our father Jacob: The phrase our father Jacob refers to Jacob, the son of Isaac and grandson of Abraham. He lived about two thousand years before this event. Jacob was an ancestor of both the Jews and the Samaritans.

our: This pronoun is inclusive because both the Jews and the Samaritans descended from Jacob.

4:12b**who gave us this well**

- who gave our^(incl) people this well?
- who caused this well to be dug.

who gave us this well: Jacob gave the well to the people in the sense that he provided it for them. He either dug it or ordered his servants to dig the well. It may be more natural in your language to start a new sentence here. For example:

Our ancestor Jacob dug this well for us. (CEV)

4:12c**and drank from it himself, as did his sons and his livestock?”**

- He and his sons and livestock all drank from it.”
- He drank from it and so did his family and animals.”

and drank from it himself, as did his sons and his livestock?: This phrase indicates that Jacob and his extended family and livestock all drank water from this well.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and drank from it himself, as did his sons and his livestock (ESV)

This phrase implies that Jacob and his family were satisfied with the well, and that its water was good and plentiful. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

How can you offer better water than he and his sons and his animals enjoyed? (NLT)

from it: Jacob and his family drank water from the well, but not directly from the well itself, which was deep. So it may be natural to translate this phrase in a way that makes this clearer. For example:

that is where he and his children drew water which they and their livestock drank

his sons: This phrase here refers to Jacob's family members. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

his family (CEV)

his livestock: The Greek word that the BSB translates as livestock refers to all kinds of tame or farm animals. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

his animals (GW)

General Comment on 4:12a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

^{12b}Our ancestor Jacob dug this well for us, ^{12c}and his family and animals got water from it. ^{12a}Are you greater than Jacob? (CEV)

^{12b}It was our ancestor Jacob who gave us this well; ^{12c}he and his sons and his flocks all drank from it. ^{12a}You don't claim to be greater than Jacob, do you? (GNT)

4:12a–c

(reordered) Our ancestor Jacob gave us this well and he and his sons and his animals all got water to drink from it. You are not really greater than Jacob, are you?

John 4:13**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:13–14

Jesus did not directly answer the woman's question about who was greater. Instead he implied that his water was better. His water was not like the water that came from the well. People who drank his water would not become thirsty again.

4:13

Jesus said to her, “Everyone who drinks this water will be thirsty again.”

- Jesus replied to her, “Everyone who drinks this water will be thirsty later.
- Jesus answered, “When a person drinks the water from this well, he will soon want/need to drink water again.

Jesus said to her: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Jesus said to her is more literally “Jesus answered and said to her.” Because Jesus is answering the woman's question, you may want to indicate that what Jesus said was an answer. For example:

Jesus replied (NET)

Jesus answered her (GW)

Everyone who drinks this water will be thirsty again: In this clause, Jesus says that people who drank the well water would soon need to drink again. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Those who drink this water will get thirsty again. (GNT)

Anyone who drinks this water will soon become thirsty again. (NLT)

John 4:14**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The

women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:14a

But whoever drinks the water I give him will never thirst.

- But whoever drinks the water I give him will never be thirsty again.
- However, everyone who drinks the water that I supply will never need to drink it again.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But indicates contrast between the results of two different actions. The two actions are drinking the well's water and drinking the water that Jesus will give. Those who drink the well's water will get thirsty again. Those who drink Jesus' water will never be thirsty again and will have eternal life. The contrast shows that Jesus' water was better than the well water.

whoever drinks the water I give him will never thirst: This clause does not mean that those people would never want to drink water again, although that is what the woman thought. Jesus was talking about a spiritual thirst or desire. When people receive living water (spiritual life) from Jesus, it will satisfy them.

They may thirst for more of God, but they know that he has already given them what they really thirst for. The Greek word that the BSB translates as never is a strong negative word that emphasizes what Jesus said. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

But the water I give them takes away thirst altogether. (NLT)

But no one who drinks the water that I give will ever be thirsty again. (CEV)

4:14b–c

Indeed, the water I give him will become in him a fount of water springing up to eternal life: Jesus continued to use a metaphor to describe what would happen to those who drink his water that gives life. (See the note at 4:10d for more information on “living water.”) In this sentence he said that the water would keep coming forever like a spring that never stops. That shows that this water gives eternal life. If this metaphor is difficult to understand in your language, you may need to use a simile instead. For example:

The water I give is like a flowing fountain that gives eternal life. (CEV)

Because the water that I give, it will become like a spring in his body which never becomes dry which gives him life that lasts forever.

4:14b

Indeed, the water I give him will become

- That is because the water that I give him will become
- In fact, the water that I supply them will be like
- But the water that I give to them will be like

Indeed: The Greek text includes a conjunction that is usually translated as “but,” but the BSB translates emphatically as Indeed. Here, the Greek conjunction connects a negative statement (“those who drink of the water that I will give them will never be thirsty”) to a positive statement (“The water that I will give will become in them a spring of water gushing up to eternal life”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but.”

...whoever drinks some of the water that I will give him will never be thirsty again, but the water that I will give him will become in him a fountain of water springing up to eternal life (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

...those who drink the water that I will give them will never become thirsty again. In fact, the water I will give them will become in them a spring that gushes up to eternal life. (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction as in the NRSV. For example:

...no one who drinks the water I give will ever be thirsty again. The water I give is like a flowing fountain that gives eternal life. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Those who drink the water that I will give, it will become like a spring in his body that always flows and gives forever life. He will never be thirsty again.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

the water I give him will become: The Greek text emphasizes the word I. Jesus was contrasting himself and the water that he will give with Jacob and the water that he gave.

In some languages it may be natural to say to whom Jesus will give this water. For example:

the water I will give them will become (GW)

4:14c

in him a fount of water springing up to eternal life.”

- a spring of water that gushes/rises up inside him to eternal life.”
- an inner spring of fresh water. It will bring them spiritual life that never ends.”
- a flowing fountain inside them that will cause them to live forever with God.”

in him: This phrase refers to the spirits or souls of the people who drink or receive the water Jesus offers. Their bodies would die, but their souls/spirits would live forever. If it is not natural to say in him, use an expression that indicates that this water will affect these people. For example:

for them

a fount of water springing up: This phrase refers to fresh (not salty) water that jumps or rises up (gushes) out of the ground. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

a spring of water welling up (NIV)

a fresh, bubbling spring (NLT)

to eternal life: This phrase indicates that this water brings eternal life. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. It is life that never ends. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated the phrase there. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

General Comment on 4:14a–c

In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek and translate 4:14a using a singular subject meaning “whoever.” For example:

but whoever drinks the water I give him will never thirst. Indeed the water I give him will become in him a spring of water welling up to eternal life. (NIV)

but anyone who drinks the water I give will never be thirsty again. For it will jump up like a fountain inside that person and bring eternal life.

John 4:15

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:7–15

A Samaritan woman came to the well where Jesus was resting. Jesus asked her for water to drink, and then he offered her living water that would lead to eternal life.

4:15a

The woman said to Him, “Sir, give me this water

- The woman said to him, “Sir, give that water to me
- And the woman said, “Sir, please let me drink some of that water that you are talking about.

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir is a title of respect. It is the same word as in 4:11a.

give me this water: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as give me this water is a request for a drink. Translate it in a way that is polite and natural in your language. For example:

Sir, please give me a drink of that water! (CEV)

4:15b

so that I will not get thirsty and have to keep coming here to draw water.”

- so I will not get thirsty again. Then I will not have to continue coming here to get water.”
- I want it so that I will no longer get thirsty or have to come to this well for water.”

so that I will not get thirsty and have to keep coming here to draw water: The woman misunderstood Jesus. She thought he was talking about literal water and being literally thirsty. She wanted to drink Jesus’ water so that she would not be thirsty again. She did not want to have to come back to the well for water.

This is a negative purpose clause. There were two things the woman wanted to avoid: being thirsty and returning to the well again and again. These two things may be connected either by a word meaning “or” or by a word meaning “and.” For example:

and then I shall not be thirsty, nor have to come all this way to draw water (REB)

Then I’ll never be thirsty again, and I won’t have to come here to get water. (GW)

John 4:16

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:16–18

This paragraph tells how the woman began to believe that Jesus was a prophet: Jesus let her know that he knew her history.

4:16a

Jesus told her, “Go, call your husband

- ¶ Jesus said to the woman, “Go^(sing) and ask your husband to come with you,
- ¶ Jesus told her to get her husband

Jesus told her: This quote introducer indicates that Jesus spoke again to the Samaritan woman. See the General Comment on 4:16a–b for another possible word order.

Go, call your husband: The Greek word that the BSB translates as call means “invite.” In some languages it is more natural to use a different verb. For example:

Go get your husband (NCV)

4:16b

and come back.”

- and then come back here.”
- and return with him.

and come back: Jesus implied that he wanted the woman to bring her husband back with her. In some

languages it is more natural to make that information explicit here. For example:

and bring him here (GW)

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as come here is singular and refers to the woman. However, in some languages, you might need to use a plural verb or pronoun to indicate that the woman’s husband should also come.

General Comment on 4:16a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to place the quote introducer in the middle or at the end of the sentence. For example:

‘Go and call your husband,’ said Jesus, ‘and come back here.’ (REB)

John 4:17

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:16–18

This paragraph tells how the woman began to believe that Jesus was a prophet: Jesus let her know that he knew her history.

4:17a

“I have no husband,” the woman replied.

- “I do not have a husband,” replied the woman.
- The woman told him that she did not have a husband.

“I have no husband,” the woman replied: The woman replied honestly that she had no husband. She was not legally married. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

“I do not have a husband,” replied the woman

She answered, “I am not married.”

4:17b

Jesus said to her, “You are correct to say that you have no husband.

- “You^(sing) are telling the truth when you say you have no husband,” Jesus said.
- “That is correct/true,” Jesus responded. “You do not have a husband.

Jesus said to her, “You are correct to say that you have no husband....”: Jesus quoted the woman’s words in 4:17a.

The verb said introduces a direct quotation that continues through 4:18c. Included in this quotation is another direct quotation. When Jesus spoke he included a quotation of what the woman said in 4:17a. It may be more natural to avoid having a direct quotation inside another direct quotation. For example:

Jesus said to her, “You are right when you say that you have no husband.” (NIV)

“That’s right,” Jesus replied, “you’re telling the truth. You don’t have a husband....” (CEV)

“What you say is right,” Jesus answered. “You have no husband.”

You are correct: Jesus was telling the woman that she was speaking the truth. He was agreeing with her. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You are correct

You are speaking truly/accurately

John 4:18

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he

spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

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Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:16–18

This paragraph tells how the woman began to believe that Jesus was a prophet: Jesus let her know that he knew her history.

4:18a

In fact, you have had five husbands,

- “The fact is that you^(sing) have had five husbands,
- That is correct/true because although five men have married you,

In fact: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as In fact means “because.” Here it introduces Jesus’ grounds for saying the woman was right. He knew that she had had five husbands before. He also knew that at that time she was living with another man who was not her husband. In some languages it is more natural to say this in a different way. For example:

For (NRSV)

The fact is (NIV)

you have had five husbands: This clause means that the woman had had five husbands one after another, not at the same time. In some languages it may be more natural to say:

You have been married to five men (GNT)

Five men have married you^(sing)

4:18b

and the man you now have is not your husband.

- and the man with whom you^(sing) are living is not your husband.
- the man with whom you now live is not your husband.

the man you now have is not your husband: The phrase the man you now have refers to the man she was living with at that time. It apparently refers to another man, a sixth man, not one of the five husbands. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the man you live with now is not really your husband (GNT)

you aren't even married to the man you're living with now (NLT)

4:18c

You have spoken truthfully."

- You^(sing) have spoken the truth."
- You told the truth."

You have spoken truthfully: This repeats the information from 4:17b, "you are right in saying." Other ways to translate this include.

You've told the truth. (GW)

You certainly spoke the truth! (NLT)

General Comment on 4:17–18

In some languages it may be more natural to combine 4:17–18. For example:

¹⁷⁻¹⁸"That's right," Jesus replied, "you are telling the truth. You don't have a husband. You have already been married five times, and the man you are now living with isn't your husband." (CEV)

John 4:19

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The

women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:19–26

The woman next asked Jesus about where people should worship God. The Samaritans said it was right to worship on Mount Gerizim, but the Jews worshiped in Jerusalem. Jesus said that where people worship is not important. It is how they worship that is important.

Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:19a

"Sir," the woman said,

- ¶ The woman said to Jesus, "Sir,

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir is more literally "lord." It is a polite form of address for an important person. See 4:11a.

the woman said: The Greek contains a phrase that the NRSV translates literally as "to him" in order to indicate that Jesus was the one whom the woman was talking to. In some languages it may be natural to that this explicitly. For example:

The woman said to him (NRSV)

4:19b

"I see that You are a prophet.

- I recognize/realize that you^(sing) are a prophet.
- you^(sing) truly must be God's messenger!

I see that You are a prophet: The woman realized that Jesus was someone important. She thought he was a prophet because he knew things about her that she had not told him.

I see: The word see here means “understand” or “recognize.” The woman realized that Jesus’ knowledge was greater than that of an ordinary human. She believed that God had revealed to Jesus about her five husbands.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

You must be a prophet. (NLT)

prophet: A prophet is a person who speaks as God’s representative. He receives messages from God for people. In this way he may know things that people cannot know naturally.

Here are some ways to translate prophet:

a messenger/representative for God

a man who speaks God’s words

God’s message-speaker

Consider how you will translate words that are similar in meaning, such as “angel,” “apostle,” and “preacher.”

See how you translated this word in 1:21d. See also prophet 1(a) in KBT.

General Comment on 4:19a–b

Place the quote introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

‘Sir,’ replied the woman, ‘I can see you are a prophet.’ (REB)

“I see you are a prophet, sir,” the woman said. (GNT)

John 4:20

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

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4:20a

Our fathers worshiped on this mountain,

- Our^(excl) ancestors worshiped God on this mountain.
- Now, Mount Gerizim is where our^(excl) Samaritan ancestors worshiped God.

Our fathers worshiped on this mountain: The woman was referring to an old argument the Jews had with the Samaritans. The Samaritans did not worship God at the temple in Jerusalem. Instead, they worshiped God on Mount Gerizim in Samaria. They had worshiped there for hundreds of years, even after their temple was destroyed in 128 B.C.

Our: The pronoun Our is exclusive. The woman was distinguishing between the ancestors of the Samaritans and their customs and those of the Jews. If your language does not have inclusive and exclusive pronouns, you may want to indicate that the woman was only talking about Samaritans. For example:

My ancestors (CEV)

fathers: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as fathers refers to both male and female ancestors.

worshiped: The word worshiped leaves implicit that it was God whom they worshiped. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

worshiped God

on this mountain: The phrase this mountain refers to Mount Gerizim. The well where the woman and Jesus were talking was very near the mountain.

4:20b

but you Jews say that the place where one must worship is in Jerusalem.”

- But you^(plur) insist/declare that the place where we^(incl) must worship is in Jerusalem.”
- But you Jews state that the Jerusalem temple is where people/everyone should worship God. Which/Who is right?”

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between where the Samaritans worshiped and where the Jews said that people must worship..

you Jews say that the place where one must worship is in Jerusalem: The Jews said that the Samaritans were wrong to worship on Mount Gerizim. They said that people should only worship God in Jerusalem.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you^(plur) insist that people need to worship in Jerusalem

you Jews say that Jerusalem is the right place to worship

you Jews say: The pronoun you is plural and includes Jesus and the Jews as a group. The woman did not believe that what they were saying was true. Here is one way to indicate this unbelief:

you Jews believe

the place where one must worship is in Jerusalem: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the place where one must worship is in Jerusalem means “It is in Jerusalem that God requires people to worship him.” In other words, God does not allow worship anywhere else. For example:

we are required to worship in Jerusalem

Jerusalem is the place where we should worship God (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to supply the word “only” to make the meaning clear. For example:

Jerusalem is the only place to worship (CEV)

in Jerusalem: This phrase refers to the temple in the city of Jerusalem. In some languages it may be necessary to mention the temple. For example:

at the temple in Jerusalem

General Comment on 4:20a–b

This sentence is in the form of a statement, but a question is implied. The woman was asking Jesus about the ancient disagreement between the Jews and Samaritans. She wanted to know what he thought. So in some languages it is more natural to translate this as a question. For example:

So tell me, why is it that you Jews insist that Jerusalem is the only place of worship, while we Samaritans claim it is here at Mount Gerizim, where our ancestors worshiped? (NLT)

John 4:21

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

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Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:21–24

These verses are Jesus' answer to the Samaritan woman. In it he contrasts worshiping at a specific place and worshiping "in spirit and truth." He indicates that the place where you worship is not important. Instead, what God desires is spiritual worship that is based on the truth.

4:21a

"Believe Me, woman," Jesus replied,

- Jesus replied, "Ma'am/Miss, what I am telling you^(sing) is true.
- Jesus said, "Trust what I say, sister.

Believe Me, woman: In some languages it may be natural to reorder this clause. For example:

Believe me, woman (NIV)

Believe Me: In this context this phrase means "accept that what I say is true."

woman: The Greek word that the BSB translates as woman is a polite form of address. It is the same word that Jesus used to address his mother in 2:4. Use the way of addressing a woman that is polite in your language. For example:

dear woman (NLT)

sister

madam/ma'am

4:21b

"a time is coming when you will worship the Father neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem.

- Soon you^(plur) will worship God in another way that may/need be neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem.
- There will soon be a day/time when it will not matter if you worship the Father on this mountain or in Jerusalem.

a time is coming: This clause indicates that something new would soon begin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Things will soon change.

The day is happening/arriving.

the hour is coming (NRSV)

when you will worship the Father neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem: This clause indicates that worship will not need to be in a specific place.

People might still worship God in Jerusalem and on Mount Gerizim, but the place was not important. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

the time is coming when worshipping the Father will not be a matter of "on this hill-side" or "in Jerusalem" (JBP)

the time is coming when it will no longer matter whether you worship the Father on this mountain or in Jerusalem (NLT)

you will worship: The verb worship means to show reverence and honor to God. Here the verb is in the second-person plural and refers to people in general. It may be more natural in your language to not use a second-person plural pronoun. For example:

people will...worship (GNT)

the Father: This phrase refers to God, our heavenly Father. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

worship the/our Father God

John 4:22

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

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Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:22a

You worship what you do not know;

- You^(plur) worship someone that you^(plur) do not know;
- You people of Samaria do not know the God you^(plur) worship.

You worship what you do not know: Jesus was indicating that the Samaritan people did not truly know God. The Samaritans praised and honored God but did not really know or understand him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You Samaritans do not really know whom you worship (GNT)

You Samaritans worship something you don't understand (NCV)

You: This pronoun is plural here and refers to the Samaritans. They were a group of people who were descended from both Jewish people and Gentiles (Assyrians). So they worshiped in a mixed way and the Jews did not like them. In some languages it will help to make explicit that Jesus was speaking about all Samaritans, not just the woman. For example:

You Samaritans (NIV)

You people (NET)

worship: The Greek word the BSB translates as worship means to praise and honor God.

what you do not know: Jesus was referring to God. The Samaritans did not truly know God.

4:22b

we worship what we do know, for salvation is from the Jews.

- while we^(excl) do know God because God will save the world through the Jews.
- However, we^(excl) Jewish people understand who God is, and the way that God will redeem/deliver people will come from us^(excl).

we worship what we do know: Jesus indicated that the Jews' faith in God was established on a solid basis. That basis consisted of historical facts and God's revealing himself to the Jews. They truly knew something of the one true God. Translate this in a way that makes a clear contrast with "what you do not know" in 4:22a. For example:

we Jews know whom we worship (GNT)

We understand what we worship. (NCV)

we: This pronoun is exclusive. It refers to Jesus and the Jews, but not to the woman and the Samaritans. It may be necessary to make this more explicit. For example:

we Jews (NLT)

for: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as for means "because." It introduces the reason why the Jews knew the one they worshiped.

salvation is from the Jews: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as salvation is from the Jews indicates that it is through the Jewish people that God saves the world. God would reveal himself and his salvation to the Jews, and the Savior himself (Jesus) was Jewish. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Jesus was himself a Jew. For example:

But we Jews do know the God we worship, and by using us, God will save the world. (CEV)

but we Jews know whom we worship, because it is from the Jews that salvation comes (GNT)

John 4:23

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

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The woman next asked Jesus about where people should worship God. The Samaritans said it was right to worship on Mount Gerizim, but the Jews worshiped in Jerusalem. Jesus said that where people worship is not important. It is how they worship that is important.

Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:23a

But a time is coming and has now come

- Soon and even now
- The time/day is arriving

But: This Greek connector that the BSB translates as But indicates that there is a contrast. The contrast is between what the situation had been and what it would be soon, and even was already starting. Now even the Samaritans can know God, and the place of worship does not matter. What matters is that worship comes from the spirit or the heart.

a time is coming and has now come: This Greek expression is talking about both the future and the present moment. Jesus was talking about the time after his death and resurrection. It was now here because Jesus was already on earth and had started his ministry. So events had started that would lead to his death and resurrection. Here are some other ways to say this expression that may be more natural in some languages:

the time is arriving

in the future, which you can see now

4:23b

when the true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and in truth,

- God's true worshipers will worship God the Father anywhere/everywhere. They will do that in a spiritual and true way,
- when people who truly worship God the Father will do so not do so in a special/particular place. Instead, they will worship from their spirits/hearts and based on the truth.

the true worshipers: This phrase refers to people who genuinely worship God, in an honest and real way. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using a verb phrase. For example:

those who truly worship

will worship: The Greek verb here is in the future tense. Jesus was speaking about a time that would soon begin.

in spirit: There are two possible ways to understand the Greek word translated spirit here.

1. It refers to the human spirit or inner self. For example:

when true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and in truth (NLT)

(BSB, REB, NJB, GW, REB, NCV, NET, RSV, KJV, NIV84, NASB, ESV, NLT)

1. It refers to the Holy Spirit. For example:

when by the power of God's Spirit people will worship the Father as he really is, offering him the true worship that he wants (GNT)

(GNT, CEV, NIV2011)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most translations and scholars.

In some languages you may not want to translate "worship the Father" in spirit literally. Scholars have suggested these two ideas about what the phrase means.

1. It means to worship God in a spiritual way, not in a physical or material way. Worship is to come from a person's heart or inner self. It is not just physical actions, such as kneeling or saying certain words. Certainly, Jesus said that worship would not be limited to a particular place. It could also mean that idols were not acceptable. For example:

with their inner being

out of their heart

1. It means that only those who have been born again can truly worship. Jesus said to Nicodemus in 3:6, "What is born of the flesh is flesh, and what is born of the Spirit is spirit." So to worship in spirit may mean that one must be born of the Spirit. Then he can have the right spirit to worship. For example:

out of their spirit

in a spiritual way

Either understanding is acceptable. English translations use the word spirit rather than "inner being" or "heart." However, if you do not talk about living people having spirits in your language, you may use a word like "inner being" or "heart."

in truth: In some languages you may not want to translate "worship the Father" in truth literally. Scholars have suggested these two ideas about what the phrase means.

1. It means to worship God sincerely. It is true or genuine worship because the worshiper truly wants to worship him. For example:

sincere will be his worship of him

their worship is true/genuine

1. It means that one's worship is based on the truth about God. The worshiper must believe the truth that Jesus revealed and worship in a way that agrees with that truth. For example:

based on the truth which comes from him

that agrees with God's true character

Either understanding is acceptable.

General Comment on 4:23b

In some languages it may be natural to make explicit that the Father is the one that "true worshipers" worship. Then later in the sentence a pronoun may be used as the object of the verb "worship." For example:

when those who truly worship the Father will worship him in spirit and truth

4:23c

for the Father is seeking such as these to worship Him.

- because God looks for people like that to worship him.
- Those are the worshipers God seeks/desires.

for the Father is seeking such as these to worship Him:

Jesus told the woman that God wanted people to worship him in spirit and in truth. God did not want any other kind of worship, or any other kind of worshiper. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for they are the kind of worshipers the Father seeks (NIV)

These are the worshippers the Father wants. (REB)

for: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for means “because.” It introduces the reason why people will worship this way: God wants them to. In some languages this word can be left implicit. For example:

that is the kind of worshipper the Father seeks
(NJB)

the Father: The word Father refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to make that explicit:

God the Father

is seeking: The Greek word that the BSB translates as seeking here means “wants, desires.” The verb form shows that God continues to want or desire these worshipers. It also implies that God is doing something to get what he wants. God continues to want this and he actively searches for people like this to worship him. God wants people to honor and praise him in a true and spiritual way. Here is another way to translate this verb:

The Father is looking for those who will worship him that way. (NLT)

such as these: The phrase such as these means “(people) like these” or “this kind of worshiper.”

John 4:24

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

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Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:24

God is Spirit, and His worshipers must worship Him in spirit and in truth.”

- God is a spiritual being, and people who worship him must worship him in a spiritual and true way.”
- God is spirit. Therefore, those who worship him must do so from their spirits/hearts and based on the truth.”

This verse repeats some information from 4:23.

God is Spirit, and His worshipers must worship Him in spirit and in truth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and after God is Spirit introduces a result. God is spirit and so worshipers must worship in spirit and truth. There is a connection between the nature of God and the way we must worship. Here are some other ways to indicate that connection between the two clauses in this verse:

God is spirit. So the people who worship him must worship in spirit and in truth. (ERV)

God is completely inner-being, having no body. Therefore it is necessary to worship him with the inner-being and truth.

God is spiritual, and he has no body. Therefore, all who worship him must worship him not with the body, but with their whole heart/spirit. Also, their worship of him must be true.

Indicate this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

God is Spirit: This clause indicates that God is not visible. He is real, living, and personal, but he is not

physical. He has a spiritual nature. And so people must worship him in a spiritual way.

Some cultures may consider invisible beings to be evil. So make sure that the word you use for Spirit can refer to a great being who is holy and loving. In some languages where spirits are evil it may be necessary to indicate that God is good, even though he is spirit. For example:

Our good God is spirit.

A few translations use a capital letter S for Spirit. Some of those translations are following interpretation (2) of “spirit” in 4:23b, which we do not recommend, and use a capital letter there as well. Others seem to use a capital letter because God is the one being described as a spirit. But it may be confusing to use a capital letter here because it could imply that God and the Holy Spirit are the same. However, God is more than the Holy Spirit, so we should use a small s to avoid implying that God was only the Holy Spirit.

His worshipers: These are people who worship or honor God. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verbal phrase than a clause. For example:

those who worship him (NRSV)

must worship Him in spirit and in truth: This phrase is a statement about something that people need to do. People need to worship God in spirit and truth, not merely with external activities.

in spirit and in truth: This is the same phrase that appeared in 4:23b. See the note there for an explanation. You should translate the phrase the same way here and in 4:23b.

John 4:25

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

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Paragraph 4:19–26

The woman next asked Jesus about where people should worship God. The Samaritans said it was right to worship on Mount Gerizim, but the Jews worshiped in Jerusalem. Jesus said that where people worship is not important. It is how they worship that is important.

Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:25a

The woman said, “I know that Messiah” (called Christ) “is coming.

- ¶ The woman replied, “I know that the Messiah is coming.” (She was referring to the one called Christ, anointed one.)
- ¶ “I have heard that the Messiah will come soon,” answered the woman. (He is the Christ, the anointed/chosen one.)

Messiah: The word Messiah is a Hebrew title that means “Anointed One.” The Jews used this title to refer to the King and Savior whom God had appointed and promised to send. See Christ, Messiah in KBT.

(called Christ): It is not clear in the Greek text who explains the meaning of Messiah. There are two possibilities:

1. John the author is the one who explains that the Messiah is called Christ. For example:

“I know that the Messiah is coming. When he comes, he will tell us everything.” (Messiah is the one called Christ.) (GW)

(BSB, NET, NIV, NCV, REB, NRSV, GW)

1. The woman is the one who explains that the Messiah is called Christ. For example:

“I know that the Messiah will come. He is the one we call Christ. When he comes, he will explain everything to us.” (CEV)

(ESV, NASB, CEV, NLT, RSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as do many scholars. The woman probably did not think that she needed to explain the word “Messiah” to a Jew.

Christ: Here the word Christ is used as a title. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning, “anointed one.” See “Messiah” in 1:41b and the note there. See also Christ, Messiah in KBT.

4:25b

When He comes, He will explain everything to us.”

- When he comes, he will inform/tell us^(excl) about everything.”
- “After he arrives, he will make everything about God known to us^(excl).”

When He comes: This clause refers to the coming of the Messiah. The woman did not know that the Messiah had already come, and that Jesus was in fact the Messiah. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that He refers to the Messiah. For example:

When the Messiah comes (NCV)

He will explain everything: The Greek word that the BSB translates as explain means “to inform,” “to announce,” or “to tell.” Some English translations translate this verb as “proclaim” (NRSV). The word may imply the idea of explain, but it is recommended that you translate the regular meaning of the word. For example:

he will tell us everything (NET)

He will declare all things to us (NASB)

he will make everything known to us

Jesus the Messiah had already told the people many things. However, the woman did not know that Jesus

was the Messiah. So you should use the future tense, as she did.

to us: The pronoun us is exclusive here and refers to the Samaritans in general. In some languages you may need to make that explicit. For example:

When the Messiah comes, he will proclaim/explain everything to us^(excl) Samaritans.

John 4:26

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:19–26

The woman next asked Jesus about where people should worship God. The Samaritans said it was right to worship on Mount Gerizim, but the Jews worshiped in Jerusalem. Jesus said that where people worship is not important. It is how they worship that is important.

Jesus also said that the Samaritans really did not know whom they worshiped. The Jewish people knew whom they worshiped, and it was through them that all people will be saved. The woman mentioned the Messiah or Chosen Savior who was coming. Jesus told her that he was the Messiah. This is a very important part of the story.

4:26

Jesus answered, “I who speak to you am He.”

- Then Jesus stated, “I who speak to you, I am that one.”

- Then Jesus declared, “I myself, the very man talking to you, I am the Messiah.”

I who speak to you am He: Jesus told the woman that he was the Messiah. This is the climax (most important part) of the story. It is important that you make it clear that Jesus was declaring that he was the Messiah. For example:

I am that one...and I am speaking to you now.
(CEV)

I AM the Messiah! (NLT)

I, the one speaking to you—I am he. (NIV)

John 4:27

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:27–30

The disciples returned to the well and were surprised to find Jesus talking to the Samaritan woman. The woman then left her water jar at the well and hurried to her town to tell the people there about Jesus. Then the people went to the well to meet Jesus.

4:27a

Just then His disciples returned

- ¶ Right then Jesus’ disciples returned
- ¶ At that moment Jesus’ followers arrived.

Just then His disciples returned: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Just then introduces something that happened right away. For example:

At this time the disciples returned with food

At that very moment his disciples came back (NET)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to learners or followers who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to follow his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this term in 1:35.

4:27b

and were surprised that He was speaking with a woman.

- and were very surprised to see him talking with a woman.
- They were quite amazed to find/see him speaking with a woman!

were surprised that He was speaking with a woman:

The disciples did not expect Jesus to talk to women. Jewish tradition advised men, and especially rabbis, to not to talk to women other than their wives. The Greek word that the BSB translates as surprised means “astonished” or “amazed.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

were astonished that he was speaking with a woman (NRSV)

They were shocked to find him talking to a woman (NLT)

4:27c

But no one asked Him, “What do You want from her?” or “Why are You talking with her?”

- But no one asked, “What do you^(sing) want from her?” or “Why are you speaking to her?”
- But not one of them asked him why he wanted to talk to a woman.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But introduces something that is not what one expects. The disciples wanted to know why Jesus was talking with the woman, but they did not ask him about it.

no one asked Him: The phrase no one refers to none of the disciples.

What do You want from her?: There are two ways to understand the question What do You want from her?:

1. It was directed at Jesus and means “Why are you talking with her?” For example:

But none of them asked him, “What do you want from her?” (GW)

(BSB, NLT, CEV, GW, NASB, NJB)

1. It was directed at the woman and means “Why are you speaking with Jesus?” For example:

But none of them said to her, “What do you want?” (GNT) (GNT)

The KJV, RSV, REB, NET, NIV, and NCV are ambiguous but more naturally refer to Jesus, which the following question clearly does. Either interpretation is possible. However, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars.

You: The pronoun You is singular. If you follow interpretation (1), it refers to Jesus.

or: The Greek word that the BSB translates as or here introduces another question that the disciples did not ask.

Why are You talking with her: The disciples wondered why Jesus was talking with the woman. This probably means about the same thing as the previous question, “What do you want?”

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus.

General Comment on 4:27c

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 4:27c as indirect speech, perhaps combining the two questions. For example:

But none of them asked him what he wanted or why he was talking with her. (CEV)

but none of them asked him why he was doing it or what they had been discussing. (NLT)

but none of them asked what Jesus wanted and/or what was the reason that he was talking with her

John 4:28

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:27–30

The disciples returned to the well and were surprised to find Jesus talking to the Samaritan woman. The woman then left her water jar at the well and hurried to her town to tell the people there about Jesus. Then the people went to the well to meet Jesus.

4:28

Then the woman left her water jar, went back into the town, and said to the people,

- The woman left her water jar/pot behind and returned to town. She said to the people of the town,
- The woman left her jar behind and went back to the town of Sychar. She told the people there,

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is more literally “therefore” or “so.” Here it introduces what the woman did next as a result of her conversation with Jesus.

the woman left her water jar: The woman left her water jar at the well. Perhaps she wanted to hurry, or forgot it, or perhaps she did not want to bring it back again to get water.

The water jar was made of clay that someone baked to become dry and hard. Here are other ways to translate this jar:

water pot

water vessel

went back into the town: The woman went back to the town where she lived. The town's name was Sychar. See the note on 4:5a.

the people: This refers to the people in Sychar, the town's people.

John 4:29

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:27–30

The disciples returned to the well and were surprised to find Jesus talking to the Samaritan woman. The woman then left her water jar at the well and hurried to her town to tell the people there about Jesus. Then the people went to the well to meet Jesus.

4:29a

“Come, see a man who told me everything I ever did.

- “Come and meet a man who has told me all about what I have done.
- “Come with me to meet someone! He told me everything about my past life/deeds.

Come, see a man who told me everything I ever did:

This woman was inviting the people of Sychar to come and meet Jesus. She exaggerated about Jesus telling her everything she had ever done. She exaggerated in order to make them interested. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Come and see a man who has told me everything I ever did. (REB)

Let us go see a person who told me all that I have done.

4:29b

Could this be the Christ?”

- Could this be the Messiah?”
- I wonder if he may be the Christ that we are expecting.”

Could this be the Christ?: This is a rhetorical question. The woman was hoping that this was the person they had been waiting for. However, she was not sure.

There are two ways of translating this expression of hope:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Could he be the Messiah? (CEV)

- Use a statement: For example:

He could be the Messiah. Come and meet him.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Christ means “anointed one.” The Jews used this title to refer to the king and savior whom God had appointed and promised to send. See the note on Christ at 4:25a.

General Comment on 4:28–29

In some languages it is more natural to use indirect speech in the verses 4:28–29b. For example:

The woman left her water jar at the well and went to town. She told the people to come and meet someone who knew all about her. She wondered if he could be the Messiah.

John 4:30

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people

hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:27–30

The disciples returned to the well and were surprised to find Jesus talking to the Samaritan woman. The woman then left her water jar at the well and hurried to her town to tell the people there about Jesus. Then the people went to the well to meet Jesus.

4:30

So they left the town and made their way toward Jesus.

- The people came from town and went to meet him.
- So they came out of the town and went to see Jesus.

So they left the town and made their way toward Jesus: The pronoun they refers to the town's people whom the woman spoke to. In some languages you may not want to use a pronoun. For example:

The people left the town to go to the place where Jesus was.

Everyone in town went out to see Jesus. (CEV)

John 4:31

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:31

Meanwhile the disciples urged Him, “Rabbi, eat something.”

- ¶ Meanwhile Jesus' disciples urged him, “Rabbi, take something to eat.”
- ¶ During that time, Jesus' followers said to him, “Teacher, you should eat now.”

Meanwhile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Meanwhile here indicates that the action in the next verses happened at the same time as the action in the previous verses. The disciples spoke with Jesus at the same time that the woman went to town and told her neighbors about Jesus.

Here is another way to translate this word:

While this was happening (CEV)

the disciples urged Him: The verb urged here indicates that the disciples asked or encouraged Jesus several times to do something.

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn and follow his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went.

See how you translated this term in 1:35 and 4:27a.

Rabbi, eat something: The disciples encouraged Jesus to eat some of the food they had bought in town.

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is a transliteration of a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” When John wrote this Gospel, people used this word as a title of respect

for an important religious teacher or leader. It does not refer to a school teacher.

If you do not have a word that expresses this idea of a religious teacher, you can just use the word “teacher” or “master.” If possible, use a word that implies that the teacher is respected. For example:

Teacher

My teacher/master

Honorable/Respected one

Use an expression in your language that is natural and shows proper respect. See how you translated it in Matthew 23:7-8 and Mark 11:21.

John 4:32

Section 4:1-42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31-38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:32

But He told them, “I have food to eat that you know nothing about.”

- But he answered them, “I have different food to eat, food that is not known to you^(plur).”
- But Jesus told them, “I do not need to eat because I am already satisfied with another kind of food. You do not know about that food.”

But He told them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here introduces Jesus’ negative reply to the disciples’ urging. He did not want to eat some food.

I have food to eat that you know nothing about:

Jesus implied that he did not want any food because he was satisfied with another kind of food. He was referring to spiritual food, not physical food. In some languages it is more natural to supply the implied information that Jesus was already satisfied. A different kind of food had satisfied him. For example:

It is enough, because I have eaten something that you do not know about.

I am already satisfied with food you do not know about.

John 4:33

Section 4:1-42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:33

So the disciples asked one another, “Could someone have brought Him food?”

- Then his disciples asked each other, “Could someone else have brought him food? Surely not!”
- Therefore his followers said to each other, “It is not likely that someone else brought him something to eat.”

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So can also be translated “therefore.” The disciples were surprised at what Jesus had said.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

Then (NIV)

That is why

Could someone have brought Him food?: This is a rhetorical question. Its purpose is to express surprise at Jesus’ words in 4:32. The disciples are suggesting the possibility that someone else brought Jesus food. The question expresses doubt about that possibility and expects that no one brought him food.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a question, as in the BSB.
- Use a statement. For example:

It is unlikely that someone else brought food to him.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 4:34**Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria**

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people

hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:34

Jesus explained, “My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me and to finish His work.”

- Jesus answered, “Obeying God who sent me and finishing the work he gave me is like my food.
- Jesus told them, “What I mean by my food is that I follow the will of God. He was the one who sent me to come here, and I finish the job that he sent me to do. That satisfies me like food.”

My food is to do the will of Him who sent Me:

Jesus used a metaphor to indicate that obeying God satisfied him like food.

Here are different ways to translate this clause:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

This is what I eat, my doing the will of God, who sent me.

Doing what God, the one who sent me, wants is what feeds me.

- Change the metaphor into a simile. For example:

It is like I am eating when I do the will of him who sent me

- Change the metaphor to a simile and include some explanation of the simile. For example:

Fulfilling the will of God who sent me is like my food because that is what gives me strength

My food: This phrase is a metaphor that refers to something that provided necessities to Jesus. You may say that in other ways. For example:

It is like what I eat

For me it is meat and drink (REB)

Him who sent Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Him who sent Me refers to God, who sent Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

My food is to do what God wants! He is the one who sent me. (CEV)

I feel satisfied when I am doing what God told me to do. God is the one who sent me to earth.

to finish His work: This phrase means to finish doing all that God wants. There are three ways of understanding this phrase:

1. It refers in general to being completely obedient to God.
2. It refers particularly to Jesus' death on the cross.
3. It refers to the specific work there at Sychar.

It is recommended that you translate this phrase literally so that all three options are included. Here are other ways to translate it:

to fulfill the work which he enables me to do

finishing the work he has given me (JBP)

to do what he wants me to do until it is completed

John 4:35

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people

hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:35–38

These verses contain an extended metaphor. Jesus was talking about crops and harvest time. However, he wanted his listeners to understand that he was referring to a spiritual harvest. The spiritual harvest was people who were ready to believe in him. The people were like a field at harvest time.

The point of comparison is that the wait for the harvest is over. The people are ready now to believe and enter the kingdom of God. They are like a field that is ready to be harvested. In some languages this metaphor may not be clearly understood. It may be necessary to translate it as a simile and maybe indicate some of the meaning. See the examples in the Display.

4:35a

Do you not say, 'There are still four months until the harvest'?

- You^(plur) know the saying, 'It is still four months until the harvest,' do you not?
- There is a proverb saying that after a worker plants there are still four months before he cuts the ripe grain.
- He quoted this proverb: "You^(plur) plant first and then there are still four months before you reap the crop."

Do you not say, 'There are still four months until the harvest'?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus knew

that this was what people said. They already understood that first you plant and then four months later you reap a harvest (cut the grain). But Jesus wanted the people to think in a different way. He then introduced a new idea.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question:

Don't you say, 'There are four more months and then comes the harvest?' (NET)

Is it not true that you say that there are still four months and then it is time to harvest?

- Use a statement. For example:

You may say that there are still four months until harvest time. (CEV)

There is your saying which says, 'There are still four months, and then harvest time will arrive.'

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is most natural in your language.

Do you not say: The pronoun you is plural. It refers to either the disciples or to people in general. What they said was probably a common saying that people in general said. But the disciples probably said it as well.

General Comment on 4:35a

This sentence contains a quotation inside a quotation. First there is the quotation of what Jesus said. Then Jesus quoted something the disciples or people in general said. This inner quotation was probably a common saying or proverb. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

Don't you have a saying, 'It's still four months until harvest?' (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the inner direct quotation as an indirect quotation. For example:

You say that harvest time is still four months from now.

4:35b-c

Here is where the metaphor really begins. (See the Note above on 4:35-38.) To help your readers understand the extended metaphor, see the examples in the Display. Also, here are two other ways to begin this metaphor:

But I tell you to look, and you will see that the fields are already ripe and ready to harvest. The people who are coming are like those fields. They are ready to believe in me.

Look at the people who are coming here. You can compare them to crops that are ripe and ready to be harvested....

4:35b

I tell you, lift up your eyes and look at the fields,

- But I tell you^(plur), look at what you can see here.
- However, I am telling you^(plur) to look around at the people coming here.
- "But," he told them, "It is not like that here/today. Look at the people who are coming to me!"

I tell you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as I tell you is more literally "See I say to you." (The NRSV and other translations use "But" because there is a contrast with the saying that Jesus mentioned in 4:35a.) Jesus was telling his listeners that it was important to concentrate on what he would say next. For example:

Look, I tell you (ESV)

Listen carefully

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples.

lift up your eyes and look at the fields: The Greek clause the BSB translates as lift up your eyes is a figurative way to say "understand this" or "become aware." It is another way to emphasize that the disciples should pay attention. In some languages it is more natural to say "open your eyes" or "look up." For example:

look up and see (NET)

open your eyes and look (NIV)

take a good look at the fields (GNT)

fields: Use a word for fields that refers to fields where grain grows. The grain could be barley or wheat, or whatever grain is common in your area.

4:35c

for they are ripe for harvest.

- See^(plur) how these people are like fields that are ready to be harvested!
- They are like a field ready for reaping.
- You can see/notice that they are ready to believe, already ready to be reaped for God like a ripe field.

for they are ripe for harvest: This clause is a metaphor. The people coming to Jesus were like fields or crops at harvest time. The people were ready to believe in Jesus like crops are ready to be harvested when they are ripe. In some languages a metaphor like this is not clearly understood. It may be necessary to suggest the meaning. For example:

see how the people are like fields of grain, ready for the harvest

look at the true/spiritual harvest! It is ready now!

look at these many people. They are like plants that are ready to be harvested because now is the time for them to believe in me.

ripe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ripe is more literally “white.” It refers to the color of the grain fields when the grain is ready to be harvested. It may be helpful to make this explicit. For example:

they are white and ready for harvest (TLV)

Perhaps the grain in your area is “yellow” or another color when it is ripe. If that is true, you may use that other color instead of “white.”

John 4:36

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:36a

Already the reaper draws his wages

- Even now the reaper receives a wage.
- The one who brings them to me is given a reward, like a worker getting paid for harvesting a crop,

Already the reaper draws his wages: There is an interpretation issue here. There are two words that the word Already could be connected to.

1. The word Already connects with (or modifies) the word draws and belongs to verse 36. For example:

Already the one who reaps is receiving wages (ESV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, NRSV, ESV, GW, CEV)

1. The word Already connects with (or modifies) the word white (or ripe) and belongs to verse 35. For example:

the fields are already white for harvest! (NET)

(REB, KJV, RSV, NET, NLT, NCV)

The NJB translates Already in both verses. The UBS Greek text supports interpretation (1), as do most commentaries. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) as well.

the reaper: A reaper is someone who harvests crops. This is a metaphor. People (like the Samaritan woman)

who bring people to Jesus are like people who reap or harvest a field. The point of comparison is that they both gather things that are ready. A reaper gathers a crop, while a person who shares the gospel gathers people into God's kingdom.

In some languages a metaphor like this is not clearly understood. It may be necessary to explain the metaphor. For example:

The one who gathers the harvest/people to bring to me

Those who cause others to come to me

And he who harvests, that is, he who caused them to understand so that they might believe in me

draws his wages: This is a metaphor. It refers to receiving a benefit or reward for one's work. The reaper is like someone who tells others about Jesus and persuades them to believe in him. Those evangelists are like people who earn wages, because they receive benefit (in the form of blessings) from their work. In some languages a metaphor like this is not clearly understood.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor into a simile. For example:

A person who leads others to me is like a reaper receiving his wages.

He who harvests gets a wage. In a similar way he who causes people to believe in me will get a reward.

- Make the meaning of the figure of speech explicit. For example:

The person who gathers others and brings them to me is receiving a reward from God.

God will give you a reward when you cause people to believe in me.

4:36b

and gathers a crop for eternal life,

- And even now he harvests a crop consisting of people who will receive eternal life.

- and those people that that person brings to me are given spiritual life that never ends.

and gathers a crop for eternal life: This is a metaphor referring to the harvest. The metaphor gathers a crop refers to leading people to Jesus. Those who believe and follow Jesus receive eternal life.

There are several ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the figure of speech. For example:

he harvests the crop for eternal life (NIV)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

The people they bring to me are given life forever. They are like the crop that a farmer gathers.

As a farmer harvests a crop, so they are leading people to me to receive eternal life.

- Keep the metaphor and explain the meaning. For example:

the fruit they harvest is people brought to eternal life (NLT)

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. It is life that never ends. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated the phrase there and in 4:14c. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

4:36c

so that the sower and the reaper may rejoice together.

- So/Therefore the sower and the reaper are glad together.
- The person who tells others about me and the person who brings/leads them to me will be glad together, like a person who sows/plants a field and a person who harvests a field.

- This will bring/cause joy for both the one who first told the good news and the one who led people to believe.

so that the sower and the reaper may rejoice together: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that indicates the purpose of the reaper gathering fruit. He does that so that both he and the sower may rejoice together. A sower is one who plants seeds. A reaper is one who harvests the crop. At harvest time, both the sower and the reaper can be glad when they see the result of their work.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

So the person who plants the grain and the person who harvests it are happy together (GW)

The word sower is a metaphor for the person who speaks God's message. The word reaper is a metaphor for the person who helps others accept the message. In some languages a metaphor like this may not be clearly understood. It may be necessary to change the metaphor to a simile and explain the meaning. For example:

The one who tells others about me is like a person who sows seed. And the one who helps people to accept me is like the one who reaps the crop. They will rejoice together.

John 4:37

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:37

For in this case the saying 'One sows and another reaps' is true.

- That is because what people say, 'One person plants seeds and another harvests crops,' is true in this situation. That is what happened when
- The saying that one person plants and another person harvests is true in this comparison.

For in this case: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as For in this case is more literally "For in this." For means "because" and indicates that what follows explains why the sower and reaper may rejoice together (4:36). The reason is that they are not the same person.

The Greek phrase translated this case points forward to 4:38. The saying in 4:37 ("one sows and another reaps") is true in the situation that Jesus describes in 4:38. That means that the disciples reaped (harvested), but someone else sowed (planted). Indicate that the following saying refers to 4:38 in a way that is natural in your language.

the saying 'One sows and another reaps' is true:

Another common saying or proverb was that one person sows seed and another reaps the harvest. Not everyone does the same thing. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the saying proves true, "Some plant the seed, and others harvest the crop." (CEV)

You know the saying, 'One plants and another harvests.' And it's true. (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the saying as indirect speech. For example:

the saying is true in this case that one person sows/plants and another one harvests

John 4:38

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:31–38

The disciples came to Jesus and suggested that he eat something. Jesus told them that he had food to eat that they did not know about. The disciples wondered if someone else had given him food. But Jesus said that doing what his Father wanted satisfied him more than food. He also told them that the people there were like a field that was ready for them to harvest.

4:38a–c

This verse continues the harvest metaphor. It refers to benefiting from someone else's work. The person who harvests the crop gets the benefit even if he did not plant the seeds. In this metaphor, the disciples were compared to harvesters. Instead of a crop, they would harvest people, meaning that they would convince people to believe in Jesus. They did that although they did not do the work of first explaining about Jesus to those people.

In some languages a metaphor like this is not clearly understood. If this is the case in your language, here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile.

What I sent you to do is like reaping what you have not worked for. Others worked hard and you have received the benefit.

- Keep the metaphor but suggest or indicate the meaning. For example:

I sent you to harvest what you did not work for. Others have worked to sow spiritual seed and you have been able to reap the results.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning explicit. For example:

These people heard from other people the message about me. But I sent you to gain the reward from others' work, like a person who harvests a crop that he did not plant.

4:38a

I sent you to reap what you have not worked for;

- I sent you^(plur) to reap/harvest what you did not plant.
- I sent you^(plur) to convince people to believe in me, people whom you had not prepared. It is like a person harvesting a field that he did not plant.

I sent you to reap what you have not worked for:

This sentence indicates that Jesus sent his disciples to gather a harvest that they did not plant. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

I have sent you to reap a harvest in a field where you did not work. (GNT)

4:38b

others have done the hard work,

- Other people have done the difficult work,
- Other people are the ones who did the hard preparation.

others have done the hard work: In some languages it is more natural to say explicitly what the hard work was. For example:

Others have done the hard work of sowing/planting.

4:38c

and now you have taken up their labor."

- and you^(plur) have gained a profit from what they have done."
- You^(plur) benefit from what they did."

and now you have taken up their labor: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as you have taken up their labor refers to benefiting or gaining a profit

from the work of others. Here is another way to translate this clause:

you profit from their work (GNT)

General Comment on 4:38a–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in this verse. For example:

^{38a–c} I have sent you to harvest crops in fields where other people have done all the hard work.

John 4:39

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:39–42

The people of the town listened to the woman and believed in Jesus. They came to meet him and asked him to stay for a few days. At the end of that time they declared that they now knew for certain that he was the Christ.

4:39a

Many of the Samaritans from that town believed in Jesus

- ¶ Many Samaritan people from that town believed in Jesus
- ¶ Many of the people from that town in Samaria believed in Jesus

Many of the Samaritans from that town believed in Jesus: This is an important point of the story. Many

Samaritan people of Sychar believed in Jesus after the woman told them about him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Many were the Samaritans from that town who trusted in him.

A lot of Samaritans in that town put their faith in Jesus. (CEV)

Samaritans: The word Samaritans refers to people from the district of Samaria. See how you translated this word in 4:7a.

from that town: The reference here is to the town of Sychar. See the notes on 4:5a and 4:28. These particular Samaritans lived in Sychar. In some languages it is more natural to supply the name of the town. For example

from the town of Sychar

believed in Jesus: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was, accepting him as the Messiah, and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:7b and 1:12b. For example:

put their faith in Jesus (CEV)

trusted in him

4:39b

because of the woman's testimony, "He told me everything I ever did."

- because the woman had testified, "He told me all about my past/life."
- because the woman told the people that Jesus told her all her past deeds.

because of the woman's testimony, "He told me everything I ever did.": The Greek word that the BSB translates as because of introduces a cause or reason. It indicates that the woman's words caused many of the Samaritans to trust Jesus. Here are other ways to translate 4:39b:

because the woman had said, "He told me everything I ever did!" (NLT)

because of what that woman was testifying, saying “He told everything that I have done.”

The noun testimony introduces a direct quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to translate the woman’s words as an indirect quote. For example:

Many Samaritans from the town believed in Jesus because of what the woman said. She said to them that Jesus had told her all about her past deeds/actions.

testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony is a verb and means “testify (tell what one knows or has seen).” In many languages it is more natural to translate it as a verb. For example:

because the woman had said (CEV)

because of the report of the woman who testified (NET)

He told me everything I ever did: This statement is an exaggeration. Make sure that your readers will understand that the woman was exaggerating because she was excited. For example:

He told me all kinds of things about my life!

There was nothing from my past that he could not tell me!

He let me know that he knew all about what I have done.

In translating this statement, it is good to remember that the woman was ashamed of her life. She was not proud of it, and she was not boasting about her achievements.

John 4:40

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:39–42

The people of the town listened to the woman and believed in Jesus. They came to meet him and asked him to stay for a few days. At the end of that time they declared that they now knew for certain that he was the Christ.

4:40a

So when the Samaritans came to Him,

- For that reason, when the people from Samaria came to Jesus,
- Then the people of Samaria arrived at the place where Jesus was

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces the result of the Samaritans’ belief. Because of their belief, they wanted Jesus to stay with them. Here are other ways to translate this connection:

Because of their belief

Therefore

As a result

when the Samaritans came to Him: The phrase that the BSB translates as came to Him indicates that the Samaritans walked to where Jesus was. Consider whether it is more natural to say came or “went.” For example:

So when the Samaritans went to Jesus (GW)

4:40b

they asked Him to stay with them,

- they encouraged him to remain with them.
- and said to him, “Please stay a while with us^(excl).”

they asked Him to stay with them: The pronouns they and them refer to the Samaritans. They wanted Jesus to remain for a while in their town, Sychar. Here is another way to translate this clause:

they begged him to stay in their town

4:40c

and He stayed two days.

- He then remained there for two days.
- So he stayed two days with them.

and He stayed two days: Jesus stayed two days with those Samaritans, in Sychar.

General Comment on 4:40

In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech here. For example:

The Samaritans came to Jesus and said to him, "Please stay in our town a while." So he stayed for two days.

John 4:41

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:39–42

The people of the town listened to the woman and believed in Jesus. They came to meet him and asked him to stay for a few days. At the end of that time they declared that they now knew for certain that he was the Christ.

4:41

And many more believed because of His message.

- And because of what he said, many more people believed in Jesus.
- And as they listened to his message, many more people began to believe that Jesus was the Christ.

many more believed: During the time Jesus was in Sychar, he continued to talk to the people about God. This caused many more of the people to believe in him. In some languages, it is more natural to supply the object of the Samaritans' belief, that they believed in Jesus. For example:

There were many more who believed in Jesus

believed: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was, accepting him as the Messiah, and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 4:39. Here are other ways of translating this word:

became believers (REB)

put their faith in Jesus (CEV)

trusted in him

because of His message: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because of introduces the reason why more Samaritans started to believe in Jesus. They believed because of what Jesus told them while he was staying with them. For example:

Many more Samaritans believed because of what Jesus said. (GW)

His message: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as His message means "what Jesus said." In some languages it may be more natural to say:

because of his words (NIV)

because of what they heard him say (CEV)

John 4:42

Section 4:1–42: Jesus spoke with a woman from Samaria

In this section Jesus spoke to a Samaritan woman who had come to get water from a well. Jesus asked her for a drink of water. The woman was surprised that he spoke to her. Jesus was a Jew, and most Jewish people hated the Samaritans. But Jesus stayed and talked with the woman.

Jesus told the woman that he could give her living water, and he told her that he was the Messiah. The women went back to her town and brought many of the other Samaritan people to Jesus.

It is good to translate the section before giving it a title. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus brought good news to the hated Samaritan people

The conversation at the well

Paragraph 4:39–42

The people of the town listened to the woman and believed in Jesus. They came to meet him and asked him to stay for a few days. At the end of that time they declared that they now knew for certain that he was the Christ.

4:42a

They said to the woman, “We now believe not only because of your words;

- They said to the woman, “Now we^(excl) believe in him not because of what you^(sing) told us,
- The people from Sychar said to the woman, “Now we^(excl) believe in Jesus, not just because you^(sing) told us about him,
- The people from the town told the woman that it was no longer because of what she said that they believed in Jesus.

They said to the woman: The pronoun They refers to the people of Sychar. In some languages it is more natural to put in this information. For example:

The people of the town of Sychar said to the woman

We now believe not only because of your words:

This clause indicates that there was a change in the people’s reason for believing. Before they met Jesus, they believed because of what the woman said. After

they met Jesus, they believed because they heard Jesus themselves. In some languages it may be necessary to make it more explicit that their reason for believing had changed. For example:

First we believed in Jesus because of your speech, but now we believe because.... (NCV)

Now we believe, not just because of what you told us.... (NLT)

We now believe: The pronoun We is exclusive here, as the people were contrasting themselves with the woman. However, your translation should not imply that the woman did not believe. She believed, but for a different reason. You may need to make it clear that the woman also believed. For example:

we^(excl) also believe

believe: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was, accepting him as the Messiah, and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 4:39 and 4:41. Here are other ways of translating this word:

have faith in Jesus (CEV)

trust in him

4:42b

we have heard for ourselves,

- but because we^(excl) ourselves heard him.
- but also because we^(excl) listened to him ourselves.
- No, it was because they heard him themselves,

The Greek text begins this clause with a conjunction that is usually translated as “for,” but the BSB leaves it implied. Here, the Greek conjunction indicates the reason why the Samaritans’ belief changed. Here is another way to translate this word:

because (GNT)

we have heard for ourselves: This clause gives the reason why the Samaritans started to believe for a different reason. Earlier, they had believed because of what the woman said. But when they heard Jesus

themselves, they had a stronger reason to believe and that made their faith stronger. In some languages it may be necessary to make the object of the verb heard explicit. For example:

We have heard him ourselves (CEV)

We^(excl) ourselves have heard what he has said

we: This pronoun is exclusive and in this context refers to the people of the town, but not the woman. The woman had always believed because she heard Jesus herself, so her reason to believe did not need to change.

4:42c

and we know that this man truly is the Savior of the world.”

- And we^(excl) now know that he really is the savior/deliverer of the people of the world.”
- That convinced us that it is true that he will save people everywhere.”
- and they realized that he was truly the one who would save people everywhere.

we know that this man truly is the Savior of the world: This is the most important idea in what the town's people say. It also forms the climax (most important point) of this section. Try to translate this with emphasis. For example:

we are convinced that he is the Saviour of the world (REB)

we know: The pronoun we continues to be exclusive here. However, the town's people did not disagree with the woman but agreed strongly with her. They also believed that Jesus was the Messiah (4:29b). So it may be natural to say:

we^(excl) now also know

the Savior of the world: This is the only time the title Savior is used of Jesus in the Gospel of John. 1 John 4:14 uses the phrase the Savior of the world, and Luke 1:67 and 2:11 use the title Savior for Jesus. Old Testament verses (for example, 2 Samuel 22:3 and Psalm 106:21) and Luke 1:47 use the title for God.

The title indicates here that Jesus is the one who saves or rescues/delivers people from evil or danger. In the New Testament the emphasis is on saving people from spiritual and eternal danger. That means

rescuing people from the spiritual dangers of sin and the punishment from God that results from sinning. See KBT Save, Salvation Savior, C. In some languages it may be natural to translate Savior using a verb form. For example:

the one who will save the people of the world

the one who delivers people everywhere from evil

of the world: The Samaritans used this phrase to say that Jesus is the savior of all groups of people in the world. He was not just the savior of the Jews. They did not mean that Jesus saves every person in the world. See the examples above for other ways to translate this phrase.

John 4:43

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official's son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official's son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:43

After two days, Jesus left for Galilee.

- ¶ Two days later, Jesus started to go to Galilee.

- ¶ After Jesus and his disciples had been there two days, they left and traveled home to Galilee province.

After two days: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After two days marks the order of events in time. It also indicates that a new story is beginning. Consider how it is natural to mark the beginning of a new story. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

At the end of the two days (NLT)

When the two days were over (NRSV)

two days: This phrase refers to the two days that Jesus stayed in Sychar, as mentioned in 4:40.

Jesus left for Galilee: Although the Greek uses a third person singular verb that refers to Jesus, Jesus' disciples went with him. In some languages it may be necessary to include this information. For example:

Jesus and his company/disciples left there and they went on to Galilee.

Galilee: Galilee was the name of the region where Jesus grew up. See Luke 2:4, 39, 51. It was one of the Roman provinces of Palestine. It is more natural in some languages to include that information. For example:

going to Galilee land

continued to the province of Galilee

John 4:44

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official's son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official's son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:44

Now He Himself had testified that a prophet has no honor in his own hometown.

- (This was because Jesus himself had already said that a prophet does not receive honor in his home country.)
- Jesus had already/earlier said, "No one honors God's messenger in his own place/home."

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information. In some languages it is more natural to leave this word untranslated or use parentheses. For example:

(Jesus had said before that a prophet is not respected in his own country.) (NCV)

Jesus said previously that there is no prophet whom others in his town respect.

It is hard to know the connection between this verse and verse 43. Scholars give many suggestions about this connection. A big question is why Jesus would go to Galilee if they would not honor him there. In 4:1–3, we saw that Jesus left Judea because he was popular there. He wanted to avoid conflict with the Pharisees. Perhaps that was his motive here. Or perhaps he wanted to prove that a prophet has no honor in his country. Or perhaps, because he had received honor in Judea, he now needed to minister in Galilee.

He Himself had testified that a prophet has no honor in his own hometown: This is an indirect quotation of something Jesus had said earlier (see notes on Matthew 13:57; Mark 6:4; Luke 4:24). In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech. For example:

Jesus had said, "A prophet has no honor in his own country."

As Jesus was referring to prophets in general, it may be natural to use the plural form. For example:

Jesus had said, “Prophets are honored everywhere, except in their own country.” (NCV)

had testified: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as had testified indicates that Jesus had told the truth about something that he knew from personal experience. It is a form of the same word that is translated as “testimony” in 4:39b. See the note there. Here are other ways to translate this verb here:

had said (GNT)

declared that (REB)

a prophet: A prophet is a person who receives a message directly from God. He then tells people what God revealed to him.

Here are some ways to translate prophet:

a messenger from God

a man/person who speaks God’s words

God’s message-speaker

Consider how you will translate words that are similar in meaning, such as “angel,” “apostle,” and “preacher.” See KBT Prophet 1(a) and see how you translated this word in 1:21d and 4:19b.

has no honor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honor means “honor,” “respect,” or “status.” In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb, either active or passive. For example:

no one honors

is not respected (GNB)

his own hometown: It is difficult to know whether his own hometown refers here to Galilee or to Judea. It is best to translate this phrase literally.

John 4:45

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a govern-

ment leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:45a

Yet when He arrived, the Galileans welcomed Him.

- So when he arrived in Galilee, the people there were happy that he had come to see/visit them.
- The people of Galilee received him there with honor/respect,

Yet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Yet is usually translated as “therefore” or “so.” Many English translations, including the NRSV, do not translate the word here. Perhaps they agree with those who think the word just introduces the next event. However, some English translations do include the word. For example:

So when he came to Galilee, the Galileans welcomed him, having seen all that he had done in Jerusalem at the feast, for they too had gone to the feast. (RSV)

It may seem confusing to say that a prophet has no honor in his country and then say, “So when he came to Galilee, the Galileans welcomed him....” But maybe faith that was based on his miracles did not completely honor him (see 4:48). Translate this Greek word in a way that is natural in your language.

when He arrived, the Galileans welcomed Him:

The pronouns He and Him refer to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to translate the Galileans as “the people there.” For example:

When he arrived in Galilee, the people there welcomed him. (GNT)

In some languages, the word welcomed may include the implication that someone has arrived. So it may sound strange to also explicitly say that someone arrived. In those languages it may be natural to leave the words when He arrived implicit. For example:

The people of Galilee welcomed him with joy/honor

4:45b**They had seen all the great things He had done in Jerusalem at the feast,**

- They had seen what Jesus did in Jerusalem at the Passover feast,
- because they had seen the miracles that he did in Jerusalem during the feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

They had seen all the great things He had done in Jerusalem at the feast: This clause tells the reason why the Galileans welcomed Jesus.

They had seen: They refers to many of the Galileans. A number of them had gone to Jerusalem and saw what Jesus did there.

all the great things He had done in Jerusalem: The author was indicating that these Galileans had seen all the miracles that Jesus did in Jerusalem. In some languages it is necessary to make this explicit. For example:

all the miracles that he did in Jerusalem

the many signs that he had given/done in Jerusalem

at the feast: The Greek text says just the feast. This feast, the Passover, is mentioned and named in 2:13, 23. See the notes there. You can use the name of the specific feast or just say feast or “festival.” For example:

at the Passover Feast (NIV)

4:45c**for they had gone there as well.**

- because they also went to Jerusalem for the feast.
- For they also had gone there to celebrate the feast.

for they had gone there as well: This clause explains why these people had seen the miracles in Jerusalem. They also had attended the feast.

General Comment on 4:45b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder these clauses, mentioning the feast before saying what the Galileans saw there. For example:

^{45c}They were also at the feast in Jerusalem ^{45b}and saw all the miracles that he did there.

^{45c}because they had gone to the Passover Festival in Jerusalem ^{45b}and had seen everything that he had done during the festival (GNT)

John 4:46**Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son**

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:46a

So once again He came to Cana in Galilee, where He had turned the water into wine.

- Then Jesus went back to Cana of Galilee, where he had made wine from water.
- Jesus returned to Cana, the town in Galilee province where earlier he caused the water to become wine.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So indicates that the author is returning to the story. It means “therefore,” but you should use a word or phrase that indicates a return to the story. Or leave it untranslated if that is natural in your language. For example:

While Jesus was in Galilee, he returned to the village of Cana (CEV)

Jesus went again to visit Cana in Galilee where he had changed the water into wine. (NCV)

Now he came again to Cana in Galilee where he had made the water wine. (NET)

He: The pronoun He refers to Jesus.

came to Cana in Galilee: Cana is a town in the area of Galilee. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus returned to the village of Cana in Galilee

where He had turned the water into wine: This refers back to the miracle that is described in 2:1-10. Refer back to this miracle in a way that is natural in your language.

turned...into: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as turned...into means to transform something or change something so that it becomes something else. Jesus took water and it became wine.

In some languages it is more natural to say this phrase a different way. For example:

where he had made the water wine (NET)

caused the water to become wine

wine: The word wine refers to an alcoholic drink. It was the common drink during meals among the Jews of Jesus’ day. It is made from the juice of a fruit called

grapes. When grape juice ferments, it becomes wine. Use the same term for wine both here and in 2:3a.

4:46b

And there was a royal official whose son lay sick at Capernaum.

- And one of the men working for the chief/king had a son who was sick. This son was in Capernaum.
- There was a government officer who had a son who was sick in Capernaum.

And: This word just shows transition from Jesus coming into Cana to introducing a new person in the story. The Greek word that the BSB translates literally here as And is translated that way in several translations (KJV, RSV, NIV, NASB, ESV). Others (NET, GNT, CEV, NCV, NLT, GW, REB) leave this word untranslated. Translate this transition in a way that is natural in your language.

there was a royal official: There are two ways to understand the Greek word that the BSB translates as there was:

1. The Greek word means “there existed.” Therefore, it introduces a new person into the story. For example:

And there was a certain royal official (NIV)
(BSB, NRSV, NIV, KJV, NASB, NJB)

1. The Greek word means that the royal official was at a particular place. In that sense, it could be translated “was there.” For example:

An officer in the royal service was there (REB)
(REB, GNT, GW, RSV, ESV, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The author does introduce a new person here, so it is better to understand the word in that way. Introduce this new person in a way that is natural in your language.

royal official: This phrase probably refers to someone who served Herod Antipas. Herod Antipas was the son of Herod the Great (mentioned in Luke 1:5 and Matthew 2). possibly a military officer. Herod was the tetrarch (ruler) of Galilee at that time, and was often called “the king.” He governed under the Roman emperor. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

One of the king’s important officers (NCV)

A man working for the Roman ruler

whose son lay sick: The Greek verb that the BSB translated as lay sick means to be sick or unwell. In some languages it is more natural not to mention that he was lying down. For example

his son was sick (NCV)

And there was a court official whose son was ill in Capernaum. (NJB)

at Capernaum: This was a town near Cana in Galilee. In some languages it may be good to say explicitly:

in the town of Capernaum

General Comment on 4:46b

It is clear in the Greek text that the royal official's son was in Capernaum. However, different English translations say different things about where the official was when Jesus arrived in Cana. There are three ways that translations talk about where the official was:

1. The translation does not specify where the official was. For example:

And there was a certain royal official whose son lay sick at Capernaum. (NIV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, KJV, NASB, NJB, TLV)

1. The translation says that the royal official was in Capernaum. For example:

And at Capernaum there was an official whose son was ill. (ESV) (RSV, ESV, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The translation says that the royal official was in Cana. For example:

Then Jesus went back to Cana in Galilee, where he had turned the water into wine. A government official was there whose son was sick in Capernaum. (GNT) (REB, GNT, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and not specify where the official was. The Greek text does not clearly specify where the official was. If you must specify where the official was, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (2). Most translations that specify where he was follow that interpretation.

John 4:47

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official's son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official's son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:47a

When he heard that Jesus had come from Judea to Galilee,

- When this man heard that Jesus had come to Galilee from Judea,
- Some people told this man/officer that Jesus had come to Galilee again,

When he heard that Jesus had come from Judea to Galilee: Some people told this man that Jesus had arrived in Galilee. We do not know how he heard that Jesus had come there. In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech. For example:

someone told him, "Jesus came from Judea back to Galilee."

Jesus had come from Judea to Galilee: Galilee refers to a province or area, as does Judea. Jesus had come from Judea, the province where Jerusalem was, and gone to his home province of Galilee.

4:47b

he went and begged Him to come down and heal his son,

- he went to Jesus. Then he pleaded with him to come to Capernaum and heal his son
- and he went to the town of Cana to meet Jesus. He said to Jesus, “Please come to Capernaum with me. Please heal my child for me.

he went: This clause means “the royal official went to Jesus.” For example:

he went to Jesus (NCV)

and begged Him to come down and heal his son: Capernaum was on lower ground than Cana, Keener p. 632 says, “The request for Jesus to ‘come down’ reflects the fact that Capernaum, on the lake and nearly seven hundred feet below the level of the Mediterranean sea, was lower in elevation than Cana.” so traveling there involved going down. The important point is that the official wanted Jesus to go to Capernaum to heal his son. This is implied information. You can supply this information to make the story easier to understand. For example:

asked him to go to Capernaum and heal his son (GNT)

4:47c

who was about to die.

- because the boy was very sick and would soon die.
- He is dying.”

In Greek this clause begins with a word that is usually translated as “for” or “because.” It introduces the reason why the official begged Jesus to heal his son. Connect the events in a natural way in your language.

who was about to die: The phrase about to die means that the son was so ill that he would probably die soon. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

his son was almost dead (NCV)

he was already dying

who was close to death (NIV)

General Comment on 4:47b

The verb “begged” here introduces an indirect quotation. In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech. For example:

So the official went to Jesus and said to him, “Please come to Capernaum and heal my son. He is almost dead.”

John 4:48**Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son**

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:48a

Jesus said to him,

- Jesus answered him,
- Jesus told him,

Jesus said to him: The Greek connector that the BSB and many English translations leave untranslated means “therefore” or “so.” Some other translations use another connector. For example:

So Jesus said to him (NET)

Translate this connector in a way that is natural in your language.

4:48b

“Unless you people see signs and wonders, you will never believe.”

- “Unless you see miraculous signs you^(plur) will not believe in me.”
- “You^(plur) people need/require miracles in order to trust me.”
- “Without seeing more amazing signs, you^(plur) people will never believe me.”

Unless you people see signs and wonders, you will never believe: This sentence indicates that the people had to see miracles before they would believe in Jesus. If the people did not see miracles, they would not believe in Jesus. This is a double negative and means that only people who saw miracles would believe. This double negative is used to emphasize the statement.

In some languages it is more natural to translate a double negative as a positive. For example:

Jesus said to him, “You people must see signs and miracles before you will believe in me.” (NCV)

Jesus was saying that the only way that they would believe is if they saw signs and wonders. If they did not see signs and wonders they would not believe. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

If people don’t see miracles and amazing things, they won’t believe. (GW)

You people must see signs and miracles before you will believe in me. (NCV)

None of you will ever believe unless you see miracles and wonders. (GNT)

you people: Jesus used the plural form of the pronoun you. He was speaking to the official and to others there. The BSB translates this as you people. If you have a plural form of the pronoun you in your language, you should use it here.

see signs and wonders: The phrase signs and wonders means “wonderful signs” or “miracles.” Jesus used signs to show people that he was the Messiah. See Miracle, Sign, Wonder, Mighty Works in KBT.

you will never believe: This is a strong negative. Jesus was saying that this would certainly not happen.

In some languages you will need to specify what the people will not believe. For example:

Jesus said, “If you do not see the signs that I do, then you will never believe in me.”

believe: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was, accepting him as the Messiah, and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 4:39, 4:41, and 4:42. Here are other ways of translating this word:

have faith (CEV)

trust in me

John 4:49**Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son**

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:49

“Sir,” the official said, “come down before my child dies.”

- The official said, “Sir, please come down and heal my son before he dies.”
- That man pleaded with him to go with him quickly so that his child would not die.

Sir: This is a polite form of address. Use a form of address that is natural for a respected religious teacher. See the note on 4:11a, where the same Greek word is used. Here is another way to translate this word:

Lord (NLT)

the official said: The verb said introduces an important request. The man was humble and urgent as he spoke. Here is another way to translate this verb:

pleaded (NLT)

come down before my child dies: The official wanted Jesus to go with him to Capernaum, where the child was. You may want to translate come down in the same way that you did in 4:47b. Here are other ways to translate this request:

come with me before my child dies (GNT)

please come now before my little boy dies (NLT)

General Comment on 4:47, 4:49

The official asked Jesus to come and heal his son at least twice. The first time (4:47) the author records it as indirect speech, and the second time (4:49) as direct speech. It is acceptable to use either indirect or direct speech both times, whichever is more natural in your language.

John 4:50**Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son**

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance. Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:50a

“Go,” said Jesus. “Your son will live.”

- Jesus replied, “Your son is healed. Go on your way now.”
- Jesus told him that he could go home. His son was well.

Go: This is a command. It is a command to leave and return home. However, it was not cruel or unkind. For example:

You may go. (NIV)

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Go is second person singular. Jesus was just talking to the royal official.

Your son will live: The Greek verb that BSB translated as will live is more literally “is living.” It implies that Jesus had already healed his son. In some languages it is more natural to use the present tense. For example:

your son lives (NASB)

Your son is healed/well.

4:50b

The man took Jesus at His word and departed.

- The man believed Jesus and left for home.
- That man trusted/accepted what Jesus said and started to go home.

The man took Jesus at His word: The royal official believed what Jesus said, that his son would live. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The man believed what Jesus told him. (NCV)

The man believed Jesus' words. (GNT)

and departed: This phrase indicates that the official left Jesus and began his journey home. He did not ask Jesus to go with him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and started back home (CEV)

and went home (NCV)

and left (GW)

John 4:51

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official's son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official's son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:51a

And while he was still on the way,

- As he was on the way,
- Before he had arrived at his house,

And while he was still on the way: The official had not reached home yet. He was still traveling home,

toward Capernaum, which was near Lake Galilee. He went back alone because he believed that his boy was well. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

along the road (CEV)

4:51b

his servants met him with the news that his boy was alive.

- his servants met him. They told him that his boy was healed.
- the men who worked for him met him. They told him, "Your child is well."

his servants met him: The official's slaves had already left his house to meet him, and they met him while he was still traveling. The word servants refers to people who were owned by another person. They worked for their owner/master without receiving wages. They had few or no rights of their own.

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to translate this word:

people who belonged to someone else

owned people

workers

with the news that his boy was alive: There is a textual issue in this verse.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have an indirect quotation and say "his boy." For example:

with the news that his child was going to live (REB) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV, RSV, GW, NET, NLT, REB, NJB)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have a direct quotation and say "your boy." For example:

and told him, "Your son is better!" (CEV) (KJV, CEV, GNT, NCV)

The UBS Greek text has selected reading (1) with the indirect quote, with a B rating. Their thinking is that the original text used an indirect quotation. However, there is no meaning difference between the two

forms. Therefore it is recommended that you translate this quotation in the way that is most natural in your language.

his boy was alive: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as his boy was alive means that the boy was much better and would not die. For example:

his child was going to live (REB)

“Your son is better!” (CEV)

John 4:52

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official’s son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:52a

So he inquired as to the hour when his son had recovered,

- He asked them when the boy improved,
- He asked them “When did my boy get well?”

So he inquired as to the hour when his son had recovered: This is an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this as direct speech. For example:

The man asked, “What time did my son begin to get well?”

4:52b

and they told him, “The fever left him yesterday at the seventh hour.”

- and they replied, “His fever/temperature went down yesterday at one o’clock in the afternoon.”
- The servants answered him, “He improved one hour after noon.”

and they told him: The pronoun they here refers to the slaves.

The fever left him yesterday at the seventh hour:

The servants knew exactly when the fever was healed. Consider how it is natural to say that someone’s body temperature has suddenly become normal again. For example:

his temperature went down yesterday at one in the afternoon

yesterday at one in the afternoon his temperature suddenly became normal

Yesterday afternoon at one o’clock his fever suddenly disappeared! (NLT)

at the seventh hour: The Greek text that the BSB translates literally as at the seventh hour in today’s system is 1 p.m. The Jewish day at that time started at sunrise, about 6 a.m. It is also in the middle of the day. Translate this in the way the people in your language group call that time.

John 4:53

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official’s son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

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Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:53a

Then the father realized that this was the very hour in which Jesus had told him, “Your son will live.”

- Then the father realized that his son’s healing took place exactly when Jesus had said to him, “Your son is healed.”
- Then the father of the child remembered that that was exactly the time when Jesus told him that his boy was well.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces a result or conclusion. It indicates that the father came to a conclusion about Jesus. Some English versions do not translate this conjunction. Introduce this sentence in a natural way in your language. For example:

So (NASB)

the father realized that this was the very hour in which Jesus had told him, “Your son will live.”: This is the climax (most important point) of the story. It was one o’clock in the afternoon when Jesus spoke to the official, the exact time when the boy became well. Translate this in whatever way you normally emphasize an important point. For example:

the father of the child remembered that that was exactly when Jesus said to him, “Your child is well.”

the father realized that that was the exact time that Jesus told him that his son would live

General Comment on 4:53a

In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech for the father’s thoughts. For example:

Then the father realized, “That was the same time Jesus said to me, ‘Your son will live!’”

Then the boy’s father said to himself, “One o’clock is the time when Jesus told me the boy would get better!”

4:53b

And he and all his household believed.

- So he and all the people in his home believed in Jesus.
- Therefore he believed/trusted in Jesus and all the people living in his house also believed/trusted.

And he and all his household believed: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as And introduces an additional result indicated by the Greek word at the beginning of the verse. (See the first part of the note at 4:53a.) If you translated that earlier Greek word with something like “Then,” “So,” or “Therefore,” you could translate the word here as “and.” For example:

So the father knew that it was at that hour in which Jesus said to him, “Your son lives”; and he himself believed and his whole household.. (NASB)

household: The word household means all those living in the house. It includes everyone in the official’s family and those working for him as well. For example:

his entire family (CEV)

all the people who lived in his house (NCV)

believed: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was, accepting him as the Messiah, and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 4:39, 4:41, and 4:42. Here are other ways of translating this word:

put their faith in Jesus (CEV)

became believers (REB)

trusted in Jesus

What these people believed is left implied in both the BSB and the Greek. In some languages it is more natural to supply that they believed in Jesus. For example:

So the man and all the people who lived in his house believed in Jesus. (NCV)

John 4:54

Section 4:43–54: Jesus healed an official's son

After Jesus left Samaria, he returned to Galilee, his home province. There he healed the son of a government leader. This healing was unusual because Jesus never saw the sick boy. He healed him from a distance.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus did his second miracle in Galilee

Jesus caused an official's son to get well

Jesus healed someone who was far away

Paragraph 4:43–54

The people welcomed Jesus back because some of them had seen him heal people in Jerusalem. Then a government official asked Jesus to heal his son. At first Jesus seemed to not want to heal him. He said that people wanted to see more and more miracles before they believed in him.

The official pleaded for his son again. Finally, Jesus told him that his son would not die. The official went home and discovered that Jesus had healed his son from a distance. The official and all his people in his house became believers in Jesus.

4:54

This was now the second sign that Jesus performed after coming from Judea into Galilee.

- This healing was Jesus' second miracle, which he did in Galilee after returning from Judea.
- Jesus did this second miracle in Galilee after he returned from Judea.

This was now the second sign that Jesus performed after coming from Judea into Galilee: The first sign was when Jesus turned water into wine in Cana of Galilee. After that, Jesus went to Jerusalem in Judea. Then he did this second sign after his return to Galilee from Judea. This verse does not mean that Jesus did two signs after he returned from Judea. It just means

that he did his second sign after he returned from Judea. For example:

This is the second miraculous sign that Jesus did in Galilee. He performed it after coming from Judea to Galilee. (NJB)

Jesus did this as his second miraculous sign when he returned from Judea to Galilee. (NET)

sign: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sign refers to a miraculous event that points to some truth beyond itself. In this context the miracle that Jesus did pointed to his greatness. See the note at 2:11a for translation suggestions. You should translate the word in the same way in both verses. (The same Greek word also appears in 2:18, 23; 3:2; and 4:48.)

John 5:1

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph introduces the story of how Jesus healed a lame man near the Bethesda pool.

5:1

Some time later there was a feast of the Jews, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem.

- ¶ Later, the Jews had/celebrated a festival, and Jesus went up to Jerusalem to be present for/at it.
- ¶ Afterward Jesus traveled to the city of Jerusalem to celebrate/attend one of the Jewish feasts.

Some time later: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Some time later is a time setting for a new story. Use a phrase that is natural at the start of a new story. For example:

Afterward (NLT)

Later (NCV)

After this (NRSV)

a feast of the Jews: This phrase means “a Jewish religious feast.” The Jews went to Jerusalem several times a year for special religious ceremonies that included a large meal for each family. There is no clear evidence that tells us which feast this was. All English translations refer to it in a general way as a Jewish feast or festival. For example:

one of the Jewish festivals (REB)

a special Jewish feast

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as and here introduces something that Jesus did because there was a Jewish festival. It can also be translated using another connector. For example:

so

Jesus went up to Jerusalem: The city of Jerusalem was built on a hill. So anyone going to the city had to walk up the hill to a higher place. See how you translated this word in 2:13.

In some languages, it is natural to say whether people travel up or down. In other languages, this will be unusual or confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you do not need to include the idea of going up. For example:

Jesus went to Jerusalem (CEV)

General Comment on 5:1

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the connection between the festival and Jesus’ journey to Jerusalem. For example:

Later, Jesus went to Jerusalem for a Jewish festival. (GW)

John 5:2

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph introduces the story of how Jesus healed a lame man near the Bethesda pool.

5:2a

Now there is in Jerusalem near the Sheep Gate a pool

- In Jerusalem there is a pool near the Sheep Gate
- There is a pool in Jerusalem next to the Sheep Gate.
- Near the gate in the wall of Jerusalem called the Sheep Gate there is a pool/bath,

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces some background information about the city of Jerusalem. It is not a time word. In some languages it is more natural to leave this conjunction untranslated. For example:

Inside the city, near the Sheep Gate (NLT)

In Jerusalem there is a pool (NCV)

near the Sheep Gate: The Greek text that the BSB translates as the Sheep Gate is more literally just “the sheep.” There are several possibilities as to what should be supplied here:

1. the word Gate. For example:

near the Sheep Gate (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NASB, RSV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. the word “Pool.” For example:

next to the Sheep Pool (NJB)

1. the word “market.” For example:

by the sheep market (KJV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations. A Sheep Gate is also mentioned in Nehemiah 3:1, 32.

This was a gate or door in the northeast wall of the city. It was probably named Sheep Gate because it was the gate where the sheep entered the city. After they entered the city, they went to the market where people bought them for sacrifices. This place was quite close to the Temple, where the priests sacrificed the sheep.

Sheep: See the note explaining this animal in 2:14a. Also see how you translated the word there.

a pool: Next to the Sheep Gate there was a pool. The Greek word that the BSB translates as pool refers to a large container of water where one can bathe or swim. The water in this pool was probably used for washing the sheep. This pool was not natural; people had built it. Here is another way to translate pool:

bath

5:2b

with five covered colonnades

- and it has five porches.
- Five shaded areas surrounded this pool.
- The pool/bath is surrounded by five porches, whose roofs are held up by poles.

with five covered colonnades: The word with starts a phrase that refers to the pool in 5:2a. This pool was surrounded by five covered colonnades. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

This pool is surrounded by five porticoes.

Around the pool are five porticoes.

colonnades: The Greek word that the BSB translates as colonnades refers to open spaces under roofs supported by pillars or poles. A portico is like a porch on a house, the section outside the door that has a roof but no outside walls. See the picture below, although you can only see the columns or pillars and not the roof. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

roofed buildings

huts for shade

porches

5:2c

which in Hebrew is called Bethesda.

- In the Aramaic language this pool is called Bethesda.
- This pool is called Bethesda in the Jewish language.
- Hebrew speakers call this pool Bethesda.

which in Hebrew is called Bethesda: There is a textual problem here. There is more than one way to write the name of the pool:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say Bethesda. For example:

is called Bethesda (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, REB, GW, NLT, NJB, NIV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say Bethzatha. For example:

called Bethzatha (NET) (NRSV, NET, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts say Bethsaida, but no major English translation follows that reading.

Both options (1) and (2) have strong support. It is recommended that you follow option (1) and say Bethesda. This reading is supported by the Hebrew form of the name in one of the Qumran scrolls. See D. A. Carson, p. 241, who says that the name Bethesda “is almost certainly right.” It is also possible to follow the reading of the local major-language translation. The UBS Greek New Testament supports the reading Bethzatha, but gives it a D rating, which indicates that it is very uncertain.

in Hebrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Hebrew can refer to either Hebrew or Aramaic. (Hebrew was the language of the Old Testament; Ara-

maic was the related language spoken by most Jews in Jesus' time.) Here it refers to Aramaic. When translating this word you may:

- Use "Aramaic" in the text. For example:

in Aramaic (ESV)

You could then supply a footnote saying that the word is more literally "Hebrew."

- Use Hebrew in the text. For example:

in Hebrew (GNT)

in the Hebrew language

You could then supply a footnote saying that here the word refers to Aramaic, a language related to Hebrew.

- Refer to the language without naming it. For example:

in the Jewish language (NCV)

in the language that the Jews spoke

You may follow any of the above examples. Or you may want to follow the national or major language translation used in your area.

is called: This verb is passive. There are several ways to translate it.

General Comment on 5:2a–c

- Use a passive verb. For example:

is called Bethesda (BSB, NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

a pool that people/they call Bethesda

whose Hebrew name is Bethesda (REB)

- Do not use a verb. For example:

the pool of Bethesda (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

^{2a,c}In Jerusalem there is a pool with five covered porches. ^{2b}This pool is called Bethesda in the Jewish language. ^{2a}It is near the Sheep Gate.

John 5:3

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph introduces the story of how Jesus healed a lame man near the Bethesda pool.

5:3a

On these walkways lay a great number of the sick,

- Many disabled people lay there.
- Large numbers of the sick used to lie there,

On these walkways lay a great number of the sick:

The phrase On these means inside the porticoes. The people lay there by the pool day after day. It was their custom or habit. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

A large crowd of sick people were lying on the porches (GNT)

Many disabled people lay in the huts

the sick: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the sick is a general term. Literally it says "weak ones," referring to sick or disabled people, including the blind, the lame, and the paralyzed. Try to use a word that includes all these physical problems. For example:

disabled people

General Comment on 5:3a

In some languages it is more natural to reorder this clause. For example:

A great number of invalids used to lie on these porches.

5:3b

the blind, the lame, and the paralyzed.

- Some were blind, some were lame, and some were paralyzed.
- those who could not see, could not walk, or could not move.

the blind, the lame, and the paralyzed: This phrase gives three examples of the invalids who were lying by the pool. In some languages it may be helpful to make this clear. For example:

Some were blind, others were lame, and others were paralyzed.

the lame: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lame refers to people who could not walk, or walked with difficulty. Here is another way to translate this word:

People who could not walk well.

the paralyzed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as paralyzed refers to a person who could not move part of his body. It means “dry” or “withered.” Its meaning has some of the same meaning of the previous word, “lame.” Here is another way to translate this word:

withered (NASB)

General Comment on 5:3a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine 5:3a–b. For example:

Here a great number of disabled people, blind, lame, and paralyzed, used to lie.

Crowds of sick people—blind, lame, or paralyzed—lay on the porches. (NLT)

[[5:3c–4c]]

[[awaiting the moving of the waters. For from time to time an angel descended into the pool and stirred the water. As soon as it was stirred, the first to enter the pool would be healed of his disease.]]:

These words are not in the earliest Greek manuscripts. They were probably added later to explain verse 7. The KJV puts them in the text, the NASB puts them inside square brackets [], and the JBP puts them in parentheses (). The other English translations do not include them. Some English translations like the BSB have a footnote indicating that some later Greek manuscripts include this section.

It is recommended that you do not include this section in the text. The UBS Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament 3rd edition omits verse 4 with an A rating, indicating that this is nearly certain to be correct. It states: “Ver. 4 is a gloss, whose secondary character is clear from (1) its absence from the earliest and best witnesses... (2) the presence of asterisks or obeli to mark the words as spurious in more than twenty (20) Greek witnesses... (3) the presence of non-Johannine words or expressions... (4) the rather wide diversity of variant forms in which the verse was transmitted....” If you use footnotes, you may want to include them in a footnote. Brief notes are included here to help you translate them for the footnote. The translation is that of the BSB footnote.

5:3c

[[awaiting the moving of the waters.

- [[These people waited for the waters to move.
- [[These people stayed there until the pool’s water was disturbed.

awaiting the moving of the waters: The invalids (sick and disabled people) watched the water to see if it would move in an unusual way. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

they were waiting for the water to move

John 5:4

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man

went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:1–4

This paragraph introduces the story of how Jesus healed a lame man near the Bethesda pool.

5:4a

For from time to time an angel descended into the pool and stirred the water.

- They did that because sometimes an angel of the Lord God would come down to move the water.
- They hoped/believed that an angel from the Lord God would come down from heaven and disturb the water of the pool.

For: The Greek word that the BSB footnote translates as *For* here introduces an explanation. The explanation explains why the sick and disabled people were waiting for the stirring of the water. They believed that an angel stirred the water and that they could be healed by stepping into the pool.

Here is another way to translate this word:

because

from time to time: The Greek phrase that the BSB footnote translates literally as *from time to time* means “occasionally.” For example:

...would sometimes come down to stir it... (CEV footnote)

an angel: The Greek phrase that the BSB footnote translates as *an angel* here refers to a spirit being who serves God. See KBT. Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

a messenger from God/heaven

a good/holy spirit-being

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.

- In some areas the churches may already use a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If the term does not communicate the right meaning, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

descended into the pool and stirred the water: In this phrase the verb *descended* means “used to come down.”

People believed that an angel sometimes came down from God to stir or move the water. This was tradition or a story that the people believed. Translate this phrase so that you imply that this may not be fact. For example:

they thought that an angel from God would come down and stir up the water

5:4b

As soon as it was stirred, the first to enter the pool would be healed of his disease.]]

- The first person who got into the pool after the angel moved it would be healed of his disease.]]
- When/If that happened, the first person to step into the pool would become well.]]

the first to enter the pool: The Greek phrase that the BSB footnote translates as *the first to enter* refers to the person who entered the water before the other sick and disabled people. In some languages it may be natural to make that clear. For example:

the person who entered the water before the others

would be healed: This is a passive clause. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb. For example:

he would become well/healthy

of his disease: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *disease* also includes physical conditions such as blindness that make one disabled. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from his physical problem

from whatever illness or disability that he was suffering

John 5:5

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:5–7

Jesus met a man who had been lame for thirty-eight (38) years. Jesus asked the man if he wanted to get well.

5:5

One man there had been an invalid for thirty-eight years.

- ¶ One man who was lying there had been lame/disabled for thirty-eight (38) years.
- ¶ There was a man by the pool who had been lame for 38 years.

One man there: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as One man is more literally “a certain man.” This expression here introduces a major character in this incident. In some languages there are other ways of introducing a major character in a story. For example:

Now a certain man was present there

Among them was a man (REB)

Beside the pool was a man (CEV)

had been an invalid for thirty-eight years: The Greek word that the BSB translates as an invalid is the same word as in 5:3a. It includes weakness or disability (lack of ability) of any sort. In some languages it is more natural to refer to the specific illness, saying that the man was lame. For example:

who had been lame for 38 years

John 5:6

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:5–7

Jesus met a man who had been lame for thirty-eight (38) years. Jesus asked the man if he wanted to get well.

5:6a

When Jesus saw him lying there

- Jesus saw him lying there
- Jesus noticed this man lying by the pool

When Jesus saw him lying there: Jesus noticed the lame man lying by the pool. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus saw him lying there (GNT)

Jesus saw the man lying there (GW)

5:6b

and realized that he had spent a long time in this condition,

- and understood that he had been in this condition for a long time,
- and realized that he had been unable to walk for many years.

and realized: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as realized can also mean “came to know.” For example:

knew (NRSV)

The text does not say how Jesus knew this. Perhaps someone told him, or perhaps God revealed it to him. It is best not to make explicit how Jesus knew.

he had spent a long time in this condition: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as he had spent a long time does not include a word meaning in this condition. The BSB has supplied it. There are in fact two ways to interpret the Greek text:

1. It refers to the man’s condition, his illness. For example:

the man had been sick for such a long time (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, NLT, CEV, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, NCV, GW, NET)

1. It refers to the place where the man was lying. For example:

he had already been there a long time (ESV) (NRSV, ESV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations.

5:6c

He asked him, “Do you want to get well?”

- so he asked the man, “Do you want to be healed/cured?”
- Jesus/He asked the man, “Would you like to get well?”

He asked him: Jesus asked the lame man a question. In some languages it may be natural to make one or both of the pronouns explicit. For example:

So Jesus asked the man (GW)

General Comment on 5:6c

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 5:6c as indirect speech. For example:

So Jesus asked the man if he wanted to get well.

John 5:7**Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath**

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:5–7

Jesus met a man who had been lame for thirty-eight (38) years. Jesus asked the man if he wanted to get well.

5:7a

“Sir,” the invalid replied, “I have no one to help me into the pool

- “Sir,” the lame man replied, “I cannot get well because no one is here to help me get/go into the pool
- The lame man answered, “Yes, sir, I would. But there is no one with me to help/lift me into the pool

Sir: This is a polite form of address. The Greek word can also mean ‘Lord,’ but here it was probably just a way for the lame man to be polite. He did not appear to think yet that there was anything special about Jesus.

I have no one to help me into the pool: The lame man indicated to Jesus that he was unable to get into the pool ahead of other people. He needed help to get into the pool. He implied that he did want to get well by explaining why he was not already well. In some languages it is more natural to make this implied information more explicit. For example:

I do but I cannot, because I have no one to put me into the pool, sir.

Yes, sir, I want to, but there is no one to take me to the water.

5:7b

when the water is stirred.

- when the water is moved.
- when the water becomes disturbed.

when the water is stirred: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is stirred means “to move about.” See the note on 5:4b. This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

General Comment on 5:7a–b

- Use a passive verb. For example:

when the water is troubled (RSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

when the angel stirs the water

when the water bubbles up (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 5:7a and 5:7b. For example:

Yes but it is impossible. ^{5:7b}When the water moves/stirs, ^{5:7a}I need someone to help me into the pool. But I have no one.

5:7c

While I am on my way, someone else goes in before me.”

- While I try to get there, another person goes down before me.”
- I try to get in by myself, but somebody else always gets into the pool before me.”

While I am on my way: The verb that the BSB translates as am on my way means “am coming.” The lame man was in the process of coming to the water. He had tried to get into the water without help, but he was unable to get there fast enough. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I try to get in, but... (CEV)

While I am trying to get into the water... (NET)

someone else goes in before me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as goes in is more literally “descends (goes down).” It refers to people getting into the water. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Someone else always gets there ahead of me. (NLT)

someone else steps into the pool before me (REB)

somebody else always enters the water before I do

General Comment on 5:7a–c

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 5:7a–c as indirect speech. For example:

The sick man told Jesus that he tried to get into the pool before the others, but someone always got there first.

John 5:8

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:8–9b

Jesus told the sick man to pick up his bed and walk. The man obeyed. He was well.

5:8a

Then Jesus told him, “Get up,

- ¶ Jesus said to the man, “Stand up,
- ¶ Then Jesus told the lame man, “Get up!

Then Jesus told him: Jesus told the sick man to do three things. In some languages it may be helpful to use a specific verb like “commanded” instead of the more general verb told. For example:

Then Jesus ordered him

Get up: The Greek verb that the BRB translates as Get up is a command. Other ways to translate this include

Stand up (NRSV)

Rise (RSV)

5:8b

pick up your mat, and walk.”

- pick up your^(sing) mat and walk.”
- Roll up your sleeping mat, and walk/go!”

pick up your mat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mat refers to a piece of thin material that people slept on. Sometimes people would carry sick or disabled people on a mat. It was something that the sick man in this story could roll up and carry. Jesus wanted the man to pick up the mat and take it with him.

Here is another way to translate this command:

take up your mat

walk: In some languages it may be natural to mention that the man was to take the mat with him. For example:

walk with your mat

John 5:9

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:8–9b

Jesus told the sick man to pick up his bed and walk. The man obeyed. He was well.

5:9a

Immediately the man was made well,

- Immediately the man was healed/cured.
- At that moment, the man got better.

Immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Immediately introduces an important event in the story. Jesus healed the man when he gave his command, so the man was able to obey what Jesus commanded in 5:8. The healing took place at that very moment.

Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

Instantly (NLT)

Right then (CEV)

the man was made well: The Greek word that the BSB translates as was made well means “became healthy” or “became strong.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The man was cured (NJB)

The man became strong

5:9b

and he picked up his mat and began to walk.

- He picked up his mat and walked away.
- He rolled up his sleeping mat and began to walk home.

he picked up his mat and began to walk: The man did what Jesus told him to do. You should probably use

the same words here that you used in 5:8. That will show that the man did exactly what Jesus told him to do. However, here the verbs are past tense rather than command forms. For example:

The man picked up his sleeping mat and walked.

The Greek text of 5:9b does not include the verb translated as “get up” in 5:8. However in some languages it may be necessary to include it. For example:

The man was immediately cured. He got up, picked up his sleeping mat and walked away.

Paragraph 5:9c–13b

The Jewish leaders met the man whom Jesus healed. He was carrying his sleeping mat. The leaders considered that to be work. They asked him why he was carrying his mat when the law said not to work on the Sabbath. He told them that the man who had healed him told him to carry his mat. The leaders asked who that was. The man did not know.

5:9c

Now this happened on the Sabbath day,

- ¶ This took place on a Sabbath, the day of rest,
- ¶ Jesus had healed the man on the Sabbath, the day Jews do/must not work.

Now this happened on the Sabbath day: This sentence tells the reader that Jesus healed the man on the day of the week called the Sabbath. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now introduces background information. It is not a time word. Translate it using the natural way in your language to introduce background information. For example:

The day this happened was a Sabbath day. (NCV)

But this miracle happened on the Sabbath (NLT)

Sabbath: The word Sabbath is the Jewish name for the seventh day of the week. The Sabbath was the day of the week when the Jews rested and worshiped God. The Law of Moses said that the Jews must not do any work on that day (see Deuteronomy 5:12–15).

Here are some ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it using the sounds of your language. You may want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

The sabbat, the Jews’ day for resting

Be careful that the term you choose is not confused with Sunday, the day when Christians worship. The Jewish Sabbath began at sunset on Friday and ended at sunset on Saturday. You may want to include a footnote to give more information. For example:

The Sabbath is a name for the seventh day of the week. It is the day when the Jewish Law required them to worship God and rest from work.

John 5:10

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:9c–13b

The Jewish leaders met the man whom Jesus healed. He was carrying his sleeping mat. The leaders considered that to be work. They asked him why he was carrying his mat when the law said not to work on the Sabbath. He told them that the man who had healed him told him to carry his mat. The leaders asked who that was. The man did not know.

5:10a

so the Jews said to the man who had been healed,

- and so the Jewish authorities said to the man who had been healed,

- Therefore, when the Jewish officials saw him carrying his mat, they said to him,

so the Jews said: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so means “therefore.” It indicates a result.

There is some background information here that John’s original readers knew, so he did not include it. First, the Jewish Law required that people rest on the Sabbath. Also, the Jews believed that the man was working when he carried his mat. It is also implied that the Jews saw the man carrying his mat. The Jews themselves explain in 5:10c about the Jewish Law. So here you may want to only include the implied information that they saw the man carrying his mat. For example:

When the Jewish leaders saw the man carrying his mat, they said to him.... (CEV)

the Jews: Although the Greek text and the BSB only say the Jews here, John was referring to “the leaders of the Jews.” In some languages to say the Jews would imply that Jesus was not a Jew. This term was often used for Jewish leaders who were against Jesus. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

the Jewish leaders (NLT)

the man who had been healed: The verb had been healed is passive. There are several ways to translate it here:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the man who was cured (NLT)

the man who was made strong

- Use an active verb. For example:

the man whom Jesus had healed

the man whom Jesus made strong

- Refer to the man in a different way. For example:

When the Jewish leaders saw the man carrying his mat, they said to him (CEV)

5:10b

“This is the Sabbath!”

- “This is the/a Sabbath day.
- “Today is the Sabbath, the rest/worship day.

This is the Sabbath!: Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It is the Sabbath.

Today is our^(incl) day for resting.

See the note on 5:9c. See how you translated the term Sabbath in that verse.

5:10c

It is unlawful for you to carry your mat.”

- It is against the law to carry your mat on this day.”
- Our^(incl) religious law says that you^(sing) must not carry your sleeping mat today.”

It is unlawful for you to carry your mat: This clause means that the Jewish leaders thought that the man should not carry his mat. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It is against the law for you to carry your bed.
(REB)

No one is allowed to carry a mat on the Sabbath!
(CEV)

You must/should not carry your mat today.

unlawful: The Greek word that the BSB translates as unlawful means “ought not to,” “should not” or “must not.” The Jewish leaders said that the man should not carry his mat. They meant that the law did not allow him to do that. The word unlawful in the BSB means “not allowed by the law” or “forbidden by the law.”

The law of that day was the laws given to Moses by God. They are recorded in Exodus through Deuteronomy in the Old Testament. There were laws that said that the Jews must not work on the Sabbath. See Exodus 20:8-11; Deuteronomy 5:12-15.

The Old Testament law did not say anything about carrying mats on the Sabbath. However, Jewish leaders had added many additional laws to make sure that people kept the law of Moses. They explained what they thought the law meant by work. It was those laws that did not allow the man to carry his mat.

General Comment on 5:9–10

The Jews told the man that it was the Sabbath in 5:10b because the Jewish law commanded rest on the Sabbath. Here is a good model for making this connection clear:

^{9c}But this miracle happened on the Sabbath, ^{10a}so the Jewish leaders objected. They said to the man who was cured, ^{10b}“You can’t work on the Sabbath! ^{10c}The law doesn’t allow you to carry that sleeping mat!” (NLT)

John 5:11

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:9c–13b

The Jewish leaders met the man whom Jesus healed. He was carrying his sleeping mat. The leaders considered that to be work. They asked him why he was carrying his mat when the law said not to work on the Sabbath. He told them that the man who had healed him told him to carry his mat. The leaders asked who that was. The man did not know.

5:11a

But he answered,

- But he replied/said to them,

But: The word that the BSB has translated as But introduces what the man said to defend his action. He said that it was not his fault or responsibility. In some languages it is more natural not to use a conjunction here. For example:

He replied, “The man who healed me said to me, ‘Pick up your sleeping mat and walk.’” (NLT)

he answered: The pronoun he refers to the man whom Jesus had healed. In some languages it is more natural not to use a pronoun. For example:

the man

the man who was healed

5:11b

“The man who made me well told me,

- “The man who healed me told me,
- “The man who cured me told me

The man who made me well: This expression refers to Jesus. However, the man who had been healed at this point did not know his name. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

the man who cured me (REB)

the man who made me strong

well: See note on 5:9a. The verb well is the same Greek word as in 5:9a.

5:11c

“Pick up your mat and walk.”

- ‘Pick up your^(sing) mat and walk.’”
- to carry my sleeping mat home with me.”

Pick up your mat and walk: See the note on 5:8b and try to use the same terms here.

General Comment on 5:11

This verse contains an embedded quotation, a quotation inside another quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to use indirect speech for Jesus’ words. For example:

But he replied, “The man who healed me told me to pick up my mat and walk.” (CEV)

John 5:12

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They

believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:9c–13b

The Jewish leaders met the man whom Jesus healed. He was carrying his sleeping mat. The leaders considered that to be work. They asked him why he was carrying his mat when the law said not to work on the Sabbath. He told them that the man who had healed him told him to carry his mat. The leaders asked who that was. The man did not know.

5:12

“Who is this man who told you to pick it up and walk?” they asked.

- So they asked him, “Who is the man who told you^(sing) to pick up your mat and walk?”
- Then the Jewish leaders asked him who had told him to walk home and carry his sleeping mat.

Who is this man who told you to pick it up and walk?: See the notes on 5:11c and try and use the same terms here.

it: The Greek word the BSB translates as it refers to the mat that the man had been lying on.

they asked: The pronoun they refers to the Jewish leaders. See note 5:10a under “the Jews.” Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 5:12b

This sentence includes an embedded quotation, a quotation inside another quotation. In some languages, it may be more natural to use indirect speech. For example:

“Who is the man who told you to carry your mat?” they asked.

They asked him who had told him to pick up his mat.

John 5:13

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:9c–13b

The Jewish leaders met the man whom Jesus healed. He was carrying his sleeping mat. The leaders considered that to be work. They asked him why he was carrying his mat when the law said not to work on the Sabbath. He told them that the man who had healed him told him to carry his mat. The leaders asked who that was. The man did not know.

5:13a

But the man who was healed did not know who it was,

- The man who was healed did not know who had healed him
- But the man said, “I do not know who it was,”

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But introduces some background information that explains the conversation. Some English translations, like the BSB, use a word that indicates contrast because you might expect that the man knew Jesus’ name. And yet he did not know his name. Translate the word in a way that is natural in your language for introducing this background information. For example:

Now the man who had been healed did not know who it was (NRSV)

the man who was healed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as healed is a different word from that in 5:10 or 5:11. However, in this context it means the same thing. For example:

that man

the one who was cured

the man who had been made strong

did not know who it was: The man who was healed did not know the name of the man who had healed him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

had no idea who it was (JBP)

did not know who Jesus was (GNT)

did not know who had healed him

5:13b

for Jesus had slipped away while the crowd was there.

- because many people were there and Jesus had left quietly.
- because a crowd was there and Jesus had left without anyone noticing him.

for Jesus had slipped away while the crowd was there: There were a lot of people in that place, and so Jesus was able to leave without people seeing him. There are three ways that English translations have translated this clause:

1. Most English translations just say that Jesus slipped away (went away quietly). They do not say whether he went away from the crowd or into the crowd. For example:

because there were many people in that place, and Jesus had left (NCV) (BSB, REB, NCV, KJV, NEB, GNT, NASB, GW)

1. Other translations say or imply that Jesus went into the crowd and seemed to disappear in the crowd. For example:

for Jesus had disappeared into the crowd (NLT) (NLT, NRSV, NIV, NJB)

1. A few translations say or imply that Jesus chose to withdraw (go away) because the place was crowded. For example:

and Jesus had left because of the crowd (CEV) (NET, RSV, ESV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because it is closer to the Greek and most English translations follow it. The Greek does not really say whether Jesus went into the crowd or away from the crowd. However, if a major language translation follows interpretation (2), you may follow that. The Greek also does not say that he went away because of the crowd. He was able to leave because a crowd was there and people would not see him leave. However, he did not leave because of the crowd.

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for means “because.” It introduces the reason why the man could not ask Jesus his name or identify him for the Jews. He could no longer see Jesus. Here is another way to translate this word:

because (NCV)

had slipped away: The Greek word that the BSB translates as had slipped away indicates that Jesus left the area quietly, without people noticing. For example:

Jesus had quietly gone away.

John 5:14

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:14–18

Jesus found the man he had healed and told him to stop sinning. The man immediately went to the Jewish leaders and told them who had healed him.

The Jewish leaders came to Jesus and asked him to tell them who he was. Jesus told them that God was his Father. Jesus said that his work, like his Father's work, continues on and does not stop on the Sabbath. The Jewish leaders were upset with him because he implied that he was equal to God.

5:14a

Afterward, Jesus found the man at the temple and said to him,

- ¶ Later Jesus saw him at the temple and said to him,
- ¶ Afterward at the temple area/court, Jesus saw the man whom he had healed. Jesus said to him,

Afterward: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Afterward is the same as the one in 5:1. It does not indicate how much later the next event happened. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

A little later (REB)

Jesus found the man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as found means “saw, noticed.” It does not mean that the man was lost. It probably implies that Jesus was searching for the man. In some languages it is more natural to say that Jesus saw or met him. For example:

Jesus met the man (CEV)

the man: This refers to the man who had been healed. In some languages it would be more natural to say:

the man who was healed

that one he had healed

temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple here refers to the general area of the temple. That included the courtyard that surrounded the temple building. The temple was a place where the Jews understood that God was present in a special way. They worshiped and sacrificed to him there. See the note on 2:14a, where the same word is used and it also

refers to one of the temple courtyards. Here are some ways to translate the word temple in this context:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of sacrifice

courtyard of God's house

just outside the holy/sacred house

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to adjust it. For example:

the temple of the Lord

courtyard of God's temple

See temple 1 in KBT for more information about the temple and how to translate it.

5:14b

“See, you have been made well.”

- “Look, you^(sing) are well/healthy now!
- “Listen, you have been healed!

See: The Greek word the BSB translates as See is a short word that calls attention to the following statement. It does not mean “look.” Translate it in a way that is natural in your language for emphasizing the next statement. For example:

Listen, you are well now; so stop sinning or something worse may happen to you. (GNT)

you have been made well: In the BSB this is a passive verb. The Greek text uses an active verb and says, “you have become healthy.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You are now well. (CEV)

you are strong/healthy again

you: This pronoun refers to the man who was healed. It is singular.

well: This is the same word as in 5:9a.

5:14c

Stop sinning, or something worse may happen to you.”

- Do not keep sinning or you may experience worse/greater trouble/suffering.”
- Stop sinning so that you will not receive/have even greater difficulties/troubles.”

Stop sinning: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Stop sinning is a command. Jesus warned the man to stop doing wrong. It does not imply that the man was doing something wrong at that moment. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not sin any more (NRSV)

Give up your sinful ways (REB)

sinning: This verb here means “doing something bad” or “disobeying God.” See the note about the noun form of the word in John 1:29b. See also how you translated the noun in that verse.

or something worse may happen to you: The phrase that the BSB has translated as or introduces a warning about what could happen. If the man did not stop sinning, there could be a bad consequence. Jesus urged the man to avoid this consequence. He did not place a curse on him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that nothing worse happens to you (NRSV)

so that something worse does not happen to you (NCV)

worse: The word worse means “something worse than being lame.” Jesus was warning the man about what could happen. God might cause him to suffer worse than what he had suffered before.

John 5:15

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:14–18

Jesus found the man he had healed and told him to stop sinning. The man immediately went to the Jewish leaders and told them who had healed him.

The Jewish leaders came to Jesus and asked him to tell them who he was. Jesus told them that God was his Father. Jesus said that his work, like his Father’s work, continues on and does not stop on the Sabbath. The Jewish leaders were upset with him because he implied that he was equal to God.

5:15a

And the man went away

- The man walked away
- The man left Jesus

And the man went away: The verb went away here indicates that the healed man walked away from Jesus and left the temple.

5:15b

and told the Jews that it was Jesus who had made him well.

- and told the Jewish leaders that Jesus was the one who had healed him.
- and went to the Jewish leaders and said, “The one who healed me was Jesus.”

and told the Jews that it was Jesus who had made him well: It is implied that someone mentioned Jesus’ name. The healed man now knew who Jesus was. He reported this to the authorities.

the Jews: The phrase the Jews refers to the Jewish religious leaders. See the note on this phrase at 5:10a.

General Comment on 5:15b

What the man told the Jews is recorded in indirect speech. In some languages it may be more natural to use direct speech. For example:

The man told the Jewish leaders, “It was Jesus who healed me.”

He said to the Jewish officials, “The person who made me strong is Jesus.”

John 5:16

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:14–18

Jesus found the man he had healed and told him to stop sinning. The man immediately went to the Jewish leaders and told them who had healed him.

The Jewish leaders came to Jesus and asked him to tell them who he was. Jesus told them that God was his Father. Jesus said that his work, like his Father's work, continues on and does not stop on the Sabbath. The Jewish leaders were upset with him because he implied that he was equal to God.

5:16a

Now because Jesus was doing these things on the Sabbath,

- He was breaking their rules about the Sabbath.
- Since he healed people on the Sabbath day,

5:16b

the Jews began to persecute Him.

- Therefore, the Jewish leaders began to persecute Jesus.
- the Jewish officials oppressed Jesus.

5:16a–b

Now: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces a result. It is not a time word. The result of the Jewish leaders finding out that Jesus healed the man was that they started persecuting Jesus. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So (NIV)

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the Jewish leaders persecuted Jesus.

Jesus was doing these things on the Sabbath: The phrase Jesus was doing these things refers to Jesus' healing the lame man. It implies that Jesus had also been doing other similar deeds on the Sabbath. The leaders believed that in that way he was breaking the law about not working on the Sabbath. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit the meaning of these things. For example

he kept healing people on the day of worship (GW)

breaking the Sabbath rules (NLT)

the Sabbath: See the note on 5:9c.

the Jews began to persecute Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as persecute means that the Jewish leaders began to oppose and oppress Jesus. They did not like the fact that he had healed someone on the Sabbath. Here is another way to translate this clause:

the Jews began to cause Jesus to suffer

the Jews: The term Jews here refers mainly to the Jewish religious leaders or officials. See 5:10 and 5:15b.

General Comment on 5:16

In some languages, it may be natural to reverse the clauses. For example:

Therefore the Jews started persecuting Jesus, because he was doing such things on the sabbath. (NRSV)

John 5:17

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man

went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:14–18

Jesus found the man he had healed and told him to stop sinning. The man immediately went to the Jewish leaders and told them who had healed him.

The Jewish leaders came to Jesus and asked him to tell them who he was. Jesus told them that God was his Father. Jesus said that his work, like his Father's work, continues on and does not stop on the Sabbath. The Jewish leaders were upset with him because he implied that he was equal to God.

5:17a

But Jesus answered them,

- But Jesus told them,
- Jesus responded to them by saying,
- But Jesus' answer to them was this, (JBP)

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces Jesus' response to the Jewish leaders' persecution. Jesus defended himself against their belief that he should not be healing people on the Sabbath. He argued that it was the right thing to do. Some translations, such as the NIV, leave this conjunction untranslated. Introduce Jesus' argument in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus answered them: Jesus was responding to the behavior of the Jewish leaders rather than answering a specific question. So it may be natural to translate this phrase without using the word answered. For example:

Jesus said to them (NIV)

So he told them (NET)

5:17b

"To this very day My Father is at His work,

- "My Father is always working, even now,
- "God, my Father, has never stopped working,

To this very day My Father is at His work: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as is at His work is

more literally "is working until now." It implies that because God works even on the rest day, Jesus can also work on that day. The Jewish Scriptures say that God rested from his work on the seventh day of creation (Genesis 2:2–3). But Jesus was saying that God continued to work through all of history. He never stopped acting in his world, helping and providing for people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My Father never stops working (NCV)

My Father has never stopped working (CEV)

My Father is working right now (GW)

My Father: This phrase refers to God. Jesus was implying that he considered that God was his father. If this is not clear, it may be necessary to say:

My Father God

is at His work: The word work does not here refer to physical labor or effort. It refers to what God does to help people. God was continuing to act in the world.

5:17c

and I too am working."

- and like him I continue to work."
- and so I keep on working too."

and I too am working: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and joins God's work and Jesus' work. Both were doing the same work.

By saying this, Jesus implied two things:

- The Father's work, like his own, was to help people
- It was because the Father was working that he, the Son, must work.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My Father is still working, and I also am working. (NRSV)

My Father is working right now, and so am I. (GW)

My Father continues to work helping people, and I must do the same.

John 5:18

Section 5:1–18: Jesus healed a lame man by a pool on the Sabbath

In this section Jesus healed a lame man who was lying by a pool of water. Because Jesus healed him on a Sabbath day, the Jewish leaders became angry. They believed that healing a person was work and that Jews should not work on the Sabbath.

The man who was healed did not know who had healed him. Then Jesus met this man in the temple. He told him that he should not sin anymore. The healed man went to the Jewish leaders and told them that it was Jesus who had healed him.

Here are some other possibilities for a section heading:

Jesus healed a lame man on the Sabbath.

Jewish leaders criticized Jesus for healing a man on the holy/rest day.

Paragraph 5:14–18

Jesus found the man he had healed and told him to stop sinning. The man immediately went to the Jewish leaders and told them who had healed him.

The Jewish leaders came to Jesus and asked him to tell them who he was. Jesus told them that God was his Father. Jesus said that his work, like his Father's work, continues on and does not stop on the Sabbath. The Jewish leaders were upset with him because he implied that he was equal to God.

5:18a

Because of this, the Jews tried all the harder to kill Him.

- Therefore, the Jewish leaders tried even harder to kill him.
- Because he said this, the Jewish leaders wanted even more to kill him.

Because of this, the Jews tried all the harder to kill Him: The phrase Because of this refers back to what Jesus had just said in 5:17b–c. The Jewish leaders were already angry and persecuting Jesus. After they heard him claim that God was his Father, they were even angrier. For example:

So the desire of the Jewish leaders to kill him increased.

This saying made the Jews all the more determined to kill him. (GNT)

tried all the harder to kill Him: The Jewish leaders were looking for a way to have the government punish him with death. They were not actually attacking Jesus with a knife or physically harming him in another way. In your translation, make sure that it does not sound as though they made harder physical efforts. Instead, they concentrated harder on it, they talked about it more, and they plotted or planned together secretly more. For example:

tried all the harder to find a way to kill him (NLT)

all the harder: This phrase means “even more.” For example:

For this reason the Jewish leaders were trying even harder to kill him (NET)

5:18b–c

The words “Not only...but” connect 5:18b with 5:18c. In some languages it may be natural to make the connection clearer. For example:

^{18b} In addition to disobeying the Sabbath rules,
^{18c}he had spoken of God as his Father.... (NLT)

^{18a}This made them try still harder to kill him.
^{18b}They said, “First Jesus was breaking the law about the Sabbath day. ^{18c}Now he says that God is his own Father....” (NCV)

5:18b

Not only was He breaking the Sabbath,

- That was because not only was he disobeying the law about the Sabbath,
- They were angry because Jesus did not obey their rest day rules,

Not only was He breaking the Sabbath: In verse 5:18a, John explained that the Jews wanted to kill Jesus even more because of what Jesus said in 5:17b–c. This clause gives the reason why the Jewish leaders want to kill Jesus before Jesus said the words in 5:17b–c. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here, as the BSB does. For example:

They said, “First Jesus was breaking the law about the Sabbath day....” (NCV)

was He breaking the Sabbath: This phrase tells the original reason that the Jewish leaders had for wanting to kill Jesus. It refers to the healing of the lame man. They thought that Jesus had broken (disobeyed) the Sabbath himself, by healing the man. They also thought that he had told the man to break it by carrying his mat. But Jesus did not really disobey God's law about the Sabbath. He just disobeyed some of the leaders' rules about the Sabbath.

breaking the Sabbath: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as breaking the Sabbath means "disobeying the law about the Sabbath." In some languages it may be necessary to make this more explicit. If this is true in your language, here are ways that you can translate this expression:

he had disobeyed the law of the Sabbath (CEV)

he broke the law about the day of worship/rest

5:18c

but He was even calling God His own Father,

- but he was also saying that God was his own Father.
- and also because he said that God was his Father.

but He was even: This Greek word that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement in 5:18b to the positive statement in 5:18c. Here the negative statement ("Not only was He breaking the Sabbath") is completed by the positive statement ("He was even calling God His own Father"). The words "Not only" in 5:18b indicate that there is an additional reason why the Jews wanted to kill Jesus. John tells the additional reason in 5:18c and emphasizes it. Translate the connection between the two clauses in a way that is natural in your language. Here are some possibilities:

- Do not use a connector. For example:

For he not only broke the Sabbath, he called God his Father, thereby making himself equal with God. (NLT)

- Follow the BSB and use but. For example:

not only had he broken the Sabbath law, but he had said that God was his own Father and in this way had made himself equal with God (GNT)

- Find another way to introduce an additional reason for the Jews to hate Jesus. For example:

They said, "First Jesus was breaking the law about the Sabbath day. Now he says that God is his own Father, making himself equal with God!" (NCV)

The additional reason in 5:18c tells why Jesus' statement made the Jewish leaders want to kill Jesus more. This second reason is more serious. You may want to indicate that in your translation. For example:

but he was even calling God his own Father (NIV)

calling God His own Father: This refers back to what Jesus said in 5:17b. The Jewish leaders considered that Jesus had committed a great sin by saying that God was his Father. They did not believe that it was true, and so they considered his statement to be blasphemy (speech that insulted God).

5:18d

making Himself equal with God.

- In that way he was making himself equal with God.
- By saying that, he said that he had the same status/importance as God.

making Himself equal with God: The phrase making Himself equal with God means "saying/implying that he was equal with God." To be someone's son implies that he is equal in some way with that person because they have the same nature. The Jewish leaders understood that Jesus was placing himself above other men, on a level with God himself. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

by doing that he was saying that he was equal with God

and in this way had made himself equal with God (GNT)

General Comment on 5:18c-d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 5:18c and 5:18d. For example:

^{18b}Not only did he break the laws about the day of worship, ^{18d}but also he made himself equal to God ^{18c}when he said repeatedly that God was his Father. (GW)

General Comment on 5:18a-d

This verse is a rather complicated result-reason statement. In many languages it is more natural to reorder the verse and put the reason before the result. Here are some ways to do that in English:

So, according to the Jewish leaders, not only did Jesus disobey the Sabbath law, but he also was saying that God was his own Father. That meant that he thought that he was equal to God. Therefore, the Jewish leaders sought even more for a way to kill him.

That statement made the Jewish leaders even angrier. Before Jesus had disobeyed the Sabbath by healing the man on that day. Now he called God his own Father, which was like saying that he was equal with God. Therefore, the Jewish leaders tried even harder to find a way to kill him.

5:18a-d (reordered) So not only was Jesus not keeping the Sabbath rules/laws, but he also made himself equal to God by calling him “Father.” Therefore, the Jewish leaders were more determined to kill him.

John 5:19

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:19–23

In this paragraph, Jesus explained who he was and what he had a right to do. He declared that God the Father had given him authority and honor. He said that he could only do what he saw the Father doing. He also said that the Father would use him to judge all the people in the world.

In this paragraph, Jesus referred to himself in the third person as “the Son.” In some languages this may make the readers think he was referring to someone else. It may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus was referring to himself. It may also be natural and helpful to at least sometimes say “my Father” rather than “the Father.” For example:

^{5:19} Jesus answered them, “Listen! I speak the truth. I am the Son, and/but I can do nothing by myself. I can do only what I see my Father doing. For whatever my Father does, that is what I also do. ^{5:20}For my Father loves me and shows me everything he does. He will show me how to do even greater deeds than these, and you will be amazed. ^{5:21}Just as my Father raises the dead and gives them life, so I as the Son give life to those I choose. ^{5:22}My Father himself does not judge people. He has given me the complete right to judge people, ^{5:23}so that all will honor the Son in the same way that they honor the Father. Whoever refuses to honor the Son does not honor my Father, for he sent me.”

5:19a

So Jesus replied, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “I speak the truth.
- ¶ In response Jesus said, “I honestly assure you that

So Jesus replied: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as So Jesus replied is more literally “So Jesus answered and said to them.” The Jewish leaders had accused him of breaking the Sabbath and making himself equal to God in verse 18. So Jesus responded to what they said to accuse him. Jesus spoke specifically to the Jewish leaders, but it appears that he also spoke to everyone else.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Jesus told the people (CEV)

Jesus explained (NLT)

Jesus answered their criticism and said

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus often used the phrase that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you to emphasize the following statement. It indicates that the statement was important and totally reliable, and that people should listen to it carefully. See how you translated this expression at 1:51. In some languages you may need to translate the phrase different ways in different contexts.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Truly, truly, I say to you (ESV)

I tell you for certain that (CEV)

I assure you that

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders who questioned Jesus and others who were there.

5:19b

the Son can do nothing by Himself,

- God's Son cannot do anything by himself.
- I, the Son, do not act/work independently of my Father.

the Son: Jesus was referring to himself. He called God his Father in 5:17b. See the General Comment at the end of 5:19–25.

The phrase the Son in this context is short for “the Son of God,” which is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the Son at 3:35. For further information, see the note on the phrase “the Son of God” at 1:34.

can do nothing by Himself: This phrase indicates that Jesus did not act independently of his Father. He did only what God wanted him to do, and he always acted in union with God, following God's will. It does not mean that he did not have the strength to do something without the Father's help. Rather, it means that he always submitted to the Father and could never act apart from him.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

can do nothing on his own (NRSV)

cannot do anything on his own (GW)

I who am the Son cannot do anything on my own

5:19c

unless He sees the Father doing it.

- He does only what he sees his Father is doing,
- Whatever I see my Father doing, that is also what I do,

unless He sees the Father doing it: This clause is a way of emphasizing that Jesus always acted in union

with God his Father. He only followed what the Father did.

He: Jesus was referring to himself here. In some languages it is more natural to use a first-person pronoun (“I” in English).

5:19d

For whatever the Father does, the Son also does.

- because all that the Father does, that is also what the Son does.
- because I, the Son, do exactly what the Father does.

Jesus continued to refer to himself in the third person as the Son. See the note in 5:19b and how you translated this term there.

For whatever the Father does, the Son also does:

There are two ways to interpret the word that the BSB translates as also

1. It describes what Jesus does. He does the same things that the Father does. For example:

the Son does exactly what the Father does (GW)
(BSB, GNT, CEV, GW, NIV, NCV, REB, NJB, NLT)

1. It describes the way that Jesus does what he sees the Father doing. He does those same things in the same way. For example:

for whatever the Father does, these things the Son also does in like manner (NASB) (NASB)

Three translations (NRSV, NET, KJV) use the word “likewise,” which can mean either “also” or “in the same way.” So it is ambiguous which interpretation they follow. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and follow interpretation (1).

Here is another way to translate this sentence:

The works/deeds that the Father does, I the Son do those same things.

Jesus continued to refer to himself using the third person the Son. You may want to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

I who am the Son also do those things

John 5:20

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus' authority

Paragraph 5:19–23

In this paragraph, Jesus explained who he was and what he had a right to do. He declared that God the Father had given him authority and honor. He said that he could only do what he saw the Father doing. He also said that the Father would use him to judge all the people in the world.

In this paragraph, Jesus referred to himself in the third person as “the Son.” In some languages this may make the readers think he was referring to someone else. It may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus was referring to himself. It may also be natural and helpful to at least sometimes say “my Father” rather than “the Father.” For example:

^{5:19}Jesus answered them, “Listen! I speak the truth. I am the Son, and/but I can do nothing by myself. I can do only what I see my Father doing. For whatever my Father does, that is what I also do. ^{5:20}For my Father loves me and shows me everything he does. He will show me how to do even greater deeds than these, and you will be amazed. ^{5:21}Just as my Father raises the dead and gives them life, so I as the Son give life to those I choose. ^{5:22}My Father himself does not judge people. He has given me the complete right to judge people, ^{5:23}so that all will honor the Son in the same way that they honor the Father. Whoever refuses to honor the Son does not honor my Father, for he sent me.”

5:20a

The Father loves the Son

- That is true because the Father loves the Son
- My Father loves me, his Son,

5:20a-b

In the Greek text 5:20a-b includes a conjunction which means “for” or “because” (“For/Because the Father loves the Son and shows him all that he himself is doing”). The BSB does not make it explicit, but many other translations do. For example:

For (NIV)

Because

In this context this conjunction introduces the reasons why he did (or could do) whatever he saw the Father doing. Introduce these reasons in a way that is natural in your language.

The Father loves the Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The Father loves the Son indicates that God loves Jesus. Jesus was speaking, and therefore it may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus referred to himself. For example:

my Father loves me

The Father: This phrase refers to God. In some languages it is necessary to make this explicit. For example:

my Father God

the Son: See the note in 5:19b and how you translated this term there.

5:20b

and shows Him all He does.

- and demonstrates to the Son all that he, his Father, is doing.
- and he causes/allows me to see everything he does.

and shows Him all He does: This phrase indicates that God the Father shows his Son, Jesus Christ, all that he, the Father, does. The Son learns by watching his Father working. This is the second reason why Jesus could do whatever he saw the Father doing (5:19d).

In some languages it may be natural to make explicit the reference of one or both pronouns. For example:

shows the Son all that he himself does (NCV)

lets me, the Son, see all that the Father does

causes/allows the Son to see whatever he does

5:20c

And to your amazement, He will show Him even greater works than these.

- Yes, he will show him even greater deeds/things than these miracles in order to amaze you^(plur).
- And he will show me miracles that are even more powerful than the miracles I have already done. He will do that so that you will be amazed.

And to your amazement: In the Greek this clause is a purpose clause. However, in some languages it may be more natural to leave implicit that this is a purpose clause. You could then follow one of these examples:

works that will astonish you (NJB)

Then you will truly be astonished. (NLT)

and you will all be amazed (GNT)

He will show Him even greater works than these: God would also show Jesus how to do deeds that are greater than healing people.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he will show him even greater things than these (NJB)

The Father will show me even greater things for me to do

will show: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as will show means “to demonstrate how to do something.” A person skilled at something does this when he teaches someone else. It is the same verb as in 5:20b.

greater works than these: The phrase greater works means “greater acts.” It compares the miracles Jesus was going to do with the miracles he had already done. In some languages it may be natural to say:

miracles that will be more amazing than the ones that I have done

more powerful deeds than those deeds that I have already done

than these: The word these refers to the miracles Jesus had already done.

John 5:21

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:19–23

In this paragraph, Jesus explained who he was and what he had a right to do. He declared that God the Father had given him authority and honor. He said that he could only do what he saw the Father doing. He also said that the Father would use him to judge all the people in the world.

In this paragraph, Jesus referred to himself in the third person as “the Son.” In some languages this may make the readers think he was referring to someone else. It may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus was referring to himself. It may also be natural and helpful to at least sometimes say “my Father” rather than “the Father.” For example:

^{5:19}Jesus answered them, “Listen! I speak the truth. I am the Son, and/but I can do nothing by myself. I can do only what I see my Father doing. For whatever my Father does, that is what I also do. ^{5:20}For my Father loves me and shows me everything he does. He will show me how to do even greater deeds than these, and you will be amazed. ^{5:21}Just as my Father raises the dead and gives them life, so I as the Son give life to those I choose. ^{5:22}My Father himself does not judge people. He has given me the complete right to judge people, ^{5:23}so that all will honor the Son in the same way that they honor the Father. Whoever refuses to honor the Son does not honor my Father, for he sent me.”

5:21a

For just as the Father raises the dead and gives them life,

- For example, just as the Father raises dead people and gives them life,
- Yes, in the same way that my Father God causes those who died to live,

For: The conjunction that the BSB and many English translations translate literally as For introduces an example of an amazing thing that the Son will do. Others do not translate this word. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language when you introduce an example.

just as: This conjunction marks a comparison. In this case it is comparing God the Father raising people to life and Jesus doing it also.

the Father: The noun Father is referring to God. In some languages it is more natural to say “my Father.”

raises the dead and gives them life: The Greek expressions that the BSB translates as raises the dead and gives them life indicate that God will cause dead people to live again.

Here are other ways to translate these expressions:

the Father brings back the dead and gives them life (GW)

the Father gives life to those he raises from the dead (NLT)

the dead: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the dead could be translated as a phrase like “people who have died.” For example:

the Father causes people who have died to live again

5:21b

so also the Son gives life to whom He wishes.

- in the same way the Son also gives life to anyone he wants.
- I, God’s Son, also cause people to live. I do that for everyone whom I choose.

the Son gives life to whom He wishes: This clause indicates that the Son has authority like the Father’s authority. He can give life to those who have died, to any that he chooses.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the Son gives life to whom he is pleased to give it (NIV)

the Son: See the note at 5:19b. Also see how you translated this phrase there. In some languages it may again be necessary to use a first-person pronoun. For example:

I, the Son, give life to anyone I choose

John 5:22

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:19–23

In this paragraph, Jesus explained who he was and what he had a right to do. He declared that God the Father had given him authority and honor. He said that he could only do what he saw the Father doing. He also said that the Father would use him to judge all the people in the world.

In this paragraph, Jesus referred to himself in the third person as “the Son.” In some languages this may make the readers think he was referring to someone else. It may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus was referring to himself. It may also be natural and helpful to at least sometimes say “my Father” rather than “the Father.” For example:

^{5:19} Jesus answered them, “Listen! I speak the truth. I am the Son, and/but I can do nothing by myself. I can do only what I see my Father doing. For whatever my Father does, that is what I also do. ^{5:20} For my Father loves me and shows me everything he does. He will show me how to do even greater deeds than these, and you will be amazed. ^{5:21} Just as my Father raises the dead and gives them

life, so I as the Son give life to those I choose.
^{5:22}My Father himself does not judge people. He has given me the complete right to judge people,
^{5:23}so that all will honor the Son in the same way that they honor the Father. Whoever refuses to honor the Son does not honor my Father, for he sent me.”

5:22a

Furthermore, the Father judges no one,

- That is true because the Father does not judge anyone,
- That is true because God my Father does not judge anyone.

Furthermore: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Furthermore is often translated as “for” or “because.” Some English translations (NRSV, CEV, RSV, TLV, GW) do not translate this conjunction. In translations that do translate this conjunction, there are two ways to interpret it.

1. It gives a reason or explanation for why the Son gives life to whomever (anyone) he wants. For example:

For the Father judges no one, but has given all judgment to the Son (ESV) (ESV, KJV, NASB, NJB)

1. It introduces another area where God is going to do new things through Jesus. For example:

Moreover (NIV)

Again (REB)

In addition (NLT) (BSB, NIV, REB, NLT, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), because that is the most common meaning of the conjunction. Also, it makes sense in this context. The ESV has been used as the Source Line in the Display.

the Father judges no one: The word judges means “decides and declares whether someone is good or bad.” It can be either positive or negative, either “approves” or “condemns.”

5:22b

but has assigned all judgment to the Son,

- but he has given to his Son the right/authority to judge all people.
- He has appointed me as his Son to do all judging.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects the negative statement in 5:22a (“For the Father judges no one”) with the positive statement in 5:22b (“has given all judgment to the Son”). Verse 5:22a tells what God does not do, while 5:22b tells what he has done instead. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

The Father doesn’t judge anyone, but he has made his Son the judge of everyone. (CEV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

In addition, the Father judges no one. Instead, he has given the Son absolute authority to judge (NLT)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Nor does the Father himself judge anyone. He has given his Son the full right to judge (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

God has given me, the Son, the entire job of judging people. He will not judge people himself.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

has assigned all judgment to the Son: The phrase assigned all judgment means “appointed the whole task of judging.” God had given to Jesus the responsibility of judging all people. And Jesus again referred to himself in the third person as the Son.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he has given the Son absolute authority to judge (NLT)

he has appointed me as his Son to be the judge of everyone

the Son: See the note in 5:19b and how you translated this term there.

John 5:23

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

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Jesus' authority

Paragraph 5:19–23

In this paragraph, Jesus explained who he was and what he had a right to do. He declared that God the Father had given him authority and honor. He said that he could only do what he saw the Father doing. He also said that the Father would use him to judge all the people in the world.

In this paragraph, Jesus referred to himself in the third person as “the Son.” In some languages this may make the readers think he was referring to someone else. It may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus was referring to himself. It may also be natural and helpful to at least sometimes say “my Father” rather than “the Father.” For example:

^{5:19}Jesus answered them, “Listen! I speak the truth. I am the Son, and/but I can do nothing by myself. I can do only what I see my Father doing. For whatever my Father does, that is what I also do. ^{5:20}For my Father loves me and shows me everything he does. He will show me how to do even greater deeds than these, and you will be amazed. ^{5:21}Just as my Father raises the dead and gives them life, so I as the Son give life to those I choose. ^{5:22}My Father himself does not judge people. He has given me the complete right to judge people, ^{5:23}so that all will honor the Son in the same way that they honor the Father. Whoever refuses to honor the Son does not honor my Father, for he sent me.”

5:23a

so that all may honor the Son just as they honor the Father.

- He did that so that all people may honor/respect the Son like they honor/respect the Father.
- He wants everyone to give glory/honor to me, his Son, just like they do to him.

so that all may honor the Son just as they honor the

Father: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that here means “in order that.” It introduces God the Father’s purpose in giving all judgment to the Son. The Father gave Jesus the responsibility of judging people in order that they would honor Jesus like they honor the Father. (Jesus again refers to himself as the Son.) For example:

so that all will honor the Son in the same way as they honor the Father (GNT)

The Father did that because he wants all people to honor me, his Son, just like they honor him.

all: The pronoun all refers to all people. For example:

so that all people (NET)

everyone will honor the Son (GW)

honor: The verb honor means “to respect and praise someone.” In this context it includes honoring someone in thought (knowing his great worth), word (praising him), and deed (kneeling before him and obeying him).

the Son: See the note in 5:19b and how you translated this term there.

just as: The Greek word that the BSB translates as just as indicates a comparison. The honor people give to the Son will be the same or similar to the honor they give to the Father. The honor that people give to both may be the same in amount. Or it may be given in the same way. It is recommended that you just say that the two honors are the same or like one another. If possible, avoid saying how they are the same. For example:

so that their respecting/honoring the Son will be like their respecting/honoring of his Father

Because he wants that all people should honor me just like they honor him

it is his will that all should pay the same honour to the Son as to the Father (REB)

General Comment on 5:23a

In some languages it may be natural to say how people honor the Father before saying that people will honor the Son in the same way. For example:

so that as everyone honors the Father, they may honor the Son like that

Just as they honor/praise God my Father, so everyone will honor/praise the Son.

5:23b

Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who sent Him.

- Whoever refuses to give honor to the Son refuses to give honor to the Father who sent him. (NJB)
- Because my Father sent me, the Son, the person who does not honor me does not honor my Father.

Whoever does not honor the Son does not honor the Father who sent Him: Because God sent Jesus, anyone who refuses to honor Jesus also does not honor God. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

When anyone refuses to honor the Son, that is the same as refusing to honor the Father who sent him. (CEV)

Anyone who does not honor the Son is certainly not honoring the Father, who sent him. (NLT)

Whoever does not honor the Son: This refers to people who refuse to accept or respect the Son. (Again, Jesus refers to himself in the third person as the Son.) In some languages it may be natural to translate it with a plural subject. For example:

people who do not honor the Son...

by refusing to honor the Son, you^(plur)...

Those who do not worship/honor me, neither do they...

the Son: See the note in 5:19b and see how you translated this term there.

John 5:24

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus' authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they

will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:24a

Truly, truly, I tell you, whoever hears My word

- ¶ I seriously assure you that the person who hears what I say
- ¶ Pay attention^(plur) to my words! When people hear what I say

Truly, truly, I tell you: See note in 5:19a. See how you translated it there and in 1:51. This phrase appears many times in the Gospel of John. Consider whether in your language it is more natural to translate it the same way each time, or use different ways. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I tell you for certain (CEV)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders who were questioning Jesus.

whoever hears My word: This refers to any person who hears Jesus' message. In some languages it is more natural to put this general idea in the plural instead of the singular. For example:

everyone who hears my message (CEV)

those who listen to my message (NLT)

hears My word: The word hears means "listens to." Here it implies that the person listens carefully and believes what Jesus said.

5:24b

and believes Him who sent Me

- and believes the one who sent me here
- and believe God, who sent me here,

believes Him who sent Me: Many times in John we see the phrase "believes in Jesus." However, here there is no word translated "in" and God is the one whom people believe. Jesus was saying that anyone who believes God (believes what he says) will receive eternal life. It is implied that if someone believes God, then he will also accept Jesus, his son.

The phrase Him who sent Me refers to God. Make sure the reference is clear. For example:

believes God who sent me

5:24c

has eternal life and will not come under judgment.

- possesses/receives eternal life. He will not endure/suffer judgment.
- they already live the spiritual life that never ends. God will not judge them guilty.

has eternal life and will not come under judgment:

Both of the verbs has and will not come are in the present tense in the Greek. The present tense in Greek has a continuous quality. That means here that both ideas are true now, but they also will continue to be true in the future. In some languages it may be best to use two sentences. For example:

has eternal life. That person will not be judged guilty now or ever.

has eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life has already begun and it will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

possesses forever life from God

has already begun to live the spiritual life that never ends

has already started living forever with God

will not come under judgment: This clause means that this person is not judged guilty nor will he ever be. He is not condemned now and he will never be condemned. Because this person has already passed from death to life (see 5:24d), he can no longer be condemned. The text does not say whether God or Jesus is the judge here, so it is best not to identify the judge. For example:

He is not condemned, now or forever

that person is not judged as guilty

he does not experience/suffer judgment/condemnation

5:24d

Indeed, he has crossed over from death to life.

- That person has gone from death to life.
- Instead they have changed from being dead to being alive.

Indeed: In Greek, 5:24d connects to 5:24c with a conjunction that the BSB translates as *Indeed*. This conjunction connects what does not happen to the believer (5:24c) and what does happen to him (5:24d). The believer is not condemned, but instead he has passed from death to life. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

That person will not be judged guilty but has already left death and entered life. (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than “but” as in the BSB. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

He will not be judged. Instead, he will not be dead anymore and will live forever.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

will never be condemned. They have already gone from death to life. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

He has already left death and been given eternal life, and he will not be condemned.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

he has crossed over from death to life: The verb that the BSB translates as *has crossed over* means “has changed” or “has transferred.” This expression indicates that people who were in the condition of death are now in the condition of life. This refers to spiritual death and life: these people were not dead physically but spiritually, and now they live spiritually.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

has already left death and entered life (NCV)

They have already gone from death to life. (CEV)

from death to life: The noun *death* here refers to spiritual death, the state or condition of being separated from God. The noun *life* here refers to spiritual life, the state or condition of being united with God. In some languages it may be natural to use adjectives or verbs. For example:

this person is no longer dead and has begun to truly live

John 5:25

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the

Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:25a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I speak words that are true.
- Listen^(plur) to this truth.

Truly, truly, I tell you: See note in 5:19a. See how you translated this phrase in 1:51 and 5:19a. For example:

And I assure you that (NLT)

5:25b

the hour is coming and has now come

- Soon this will happen, beginning even now.
- The day/time is near and in fact has already arrived

the hour is coming and has now come: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the hour is coming refers to a future event. In saying the hour...has now come, Jesus was saying that this future event had begun already.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the day is coming, and actually it has already arrived

the time is coming, and is already here (NCV)

This phrase is also used in 4:23. See the Note there as well as the way you translated the phrase in that verse. It would be good to translate it the same way in both verses.

5:25c

when the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God,

- Those who are dead will hear the Son of God speaking,
- when spiritually dead people will hear what I, the Son of God, say.

the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God: This is figurative language. The phrase the dead is being used to refer to those who are spiritually dead. As Jesus spoke, spiritually dead people heard him, and those who believed, lived. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that this is figurative language and/or supply the meaning. For example:

people who are as if they are dead, separated from God, will hear the voice of God's Son

hear the voice of the Son of God: The phrase the voice of the Son of God refers to the words of Jesus. The people will hear what Jesus, the Son of God, will say. For example:

hear the words/message of the Son of God

hear: This word here implies understanding and believing what Jesus said. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

when those who are dead hear the words which the Son of God speaks and believe

the Son of God: Jesus was referring to himself. If this is not clear, it may be helpful to supply this information. For example:

the dead will hear my voice—the voice of the Son of God (NLT)

The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the Son of God at 1:34. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

5:25d

and those who hear will live.

- and those who listen will live.
- And there will be true/spiritual life for those/all who listen!

those who hear will live: The word live here is figurative and means “to become spiritually alive.” These people will begin to know God and live in him as they listen to the message. The word hear implies that they believe and accept Jesus’ words.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

those who hear it will come to life (GNT)

life will be given to those who listen

the listeners will receive true/real life

John 5:26

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This

that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:26a

For as the Father has life in Himself,

- That will happen because just like the Father is the source of life,
- That will happen because the way that life comes from God my Father,

For as the Father has life in Himself: This is the first half of a comparison which is completed in 5:26b. See the General Comment on 5:26a–b for ideas of how to translate this comparison.

the Father has life in Himself: This clause indicates that God the Father is the one who is the source of all life. All life comes from him; he alone creates/gives life. He was not created or given life by someone else but has always existed. He is the source of everything that lives. Refer to the notes on 1:14a–b. There the author writes of the Word that “in him was life” and “the life was the light of all people.” Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

The Father is the source of life (GW)

the Father is himself the source of life (GNT)

The Father has the power to give life (CEV)

5:26b

so also He has granted the Son to have life in Himself.

- so he has enabled the Son to be the source of life.
- in that way he made life to come from me his Son.

so also He has granted the Son to have life in Himself: This is the second half of the comparison. God the Father has given to the Son the same life-giving power that he has. The Son also is the source of life and is eternally self-existent (meaning that he has always existed without any outside cause). As in 5:25c, Jesus was talking about himself. See the note there.

He has granted the Son to have life in Himself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translated as granted the Son is more literally “gave to the Son.” God enables or causes his Son to have and give life. When you translate this, you should not imply that at one time the Son did not have life in himself. The Father has always had life in himself and the Father has always granted the Son to have life in himself.

In some languages a verb such as He has granted implies that there was a time before the Son had life. If that is true in your language, you may want to make it clearer that Jesus always had life:

by his gift the Son also has life in himself (REB)

Jesus continued to refer to himself in this verse using the third person (the Son). In some languages, you may need to make it clear that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

Because my Father is the one who gives life. And the same is true with me, because he gave me the authority to give life.

the Son: See the note in 5:19b and how you translated this term there.

General Comment on 5:26a–b

The Greek words that BSB translates with the conjunctions For...so compares two things and says that they are equal.

Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Just as the Father is himself the source of life, in the same way he has made his Son to be the source of life. (GNT)

The Father has the power to give life, and he has given that same power to the Son. (CEV)

John 5:27

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus' authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they

will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:27a

And He has given Him authority to execute judgment,

- And God gave his Son the right/responsibility to judge the people
- And God said to me, “You^(sing) my Son may judge the people

And He has given Him authority to execute judgment: This clause indicates that God has given Jesus the right to declare who is righteous and who is wrong. (The phrase to execute judgment means “to make a judgment” or “to judge.”) In some languages it is more natural to say whom he judges, supplying the object, “all people.” For example:

And he has given him authority to judge everyone because he is the Son of Man. (NLT)

And he has given his Son the right to judge everyone. (CEV)

And the Father has given me his Son the right to tell everyone whether they are right or wrong.

See the General Comment on 5:27 about translating this phrase using direct speech.

5:27b

because He is the Son of Man.

- because he is the Man whom God Sent.
- because you^(sing) are the True Man from Heaven.”

because He is the Son of Man: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as because He is the Son of Man indicates a reason. It is because Jesus is the Son of Man that God gave him the right to judge people.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is a title that refers to Jesus. Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

In this context the second meaning is more important.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

In some languages it may be necessary to use words like “I” or “me” to indicate that Jesus referred to himself. For example:

I/me, the Son of Humanity

I who became man/human

See Son of Man in KBT.

See how you translated this term in 1:51. See the notes there.

General Comment on 5:27

In some languages it may be necessary to translate this as direct speech. For example:

God my Father has said to his Son, “You^(sing) should/may judge the people because you are the Son of Man.”

John 5:28

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus’ authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:28a

Do not be amazed at this,

- You^(plur) should not be surprised at what I have told you.
- These/My words should not surprise you,

Do not be amazed at this: This clause is a command. Jesus continued to speak to the Jewish leaders, so you will need to use a plural pronoun or verb. The word this probably refers back to the previous verses, to what Jesus had just said.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not let that surprise you

Don't be surprised at what I have just said. (GW)

5:28b

for the hour is coming when all who are in their graves will hear His voice

- That is because the time/day will come when all the dead in their graves will hear the Son's voice.

- because in the future, everyone who has died will hear me calling

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for here means “because.” It introduces a reason people should not be surprised at what Jesus said.

the hour is coming: This refers to a time that is still in the future. See how you translated this phrase in 5:25b.

all who are in their graves: This expression means “all those people who have died.” A “grave” is a place where a dead person is buried, under the surface of the ground or in a cave. Jesus used this expression to speak about all dead people, not just those in graves. If people do not understand that, you may want to use a more general word. For example:

The time will come when all of the dead will hear the voice of the Son of Man (CEV)

will hear His voice: The voice refers to Jesus' voice as God's Son. These people will hear what the Son will say. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

they will hear me call all the dead people back to life

See 5:24a and how you translated this idea there.

John 5:29

Section 5:19–29: Jesus told the Jewish leaders that the Father gave him authority

Jesus told the Pharisees that he had authority from God the Father. He only did what he saw the Father doing. He declared that God had given him the right to raise people from the dead and to judge them.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus proclaimed his authority/right to heal the man on the Sabbath/rest day.

Jesus explained to the Jewish leaders his authority for breaking their rules.

Jesus' authority

Paragraph 5:24–29

In this paragraph Jesus spoke of his authority to give life. He first referred to himself in the first person (using “I” and “me” in 5:24). He said that he is the one

who will cause righteous people to live again. He then referred to himself in the third person, as “the Son of Man,” in 5:25–29. God the Father gave him the right to judge all people.

In your translation, make sure that readers will understand that Jesus was speaking of himself through this whole passage. You may need to use first person pronouns to make it explicit that Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

²⁴“I tell you the truth. Whoever believes what I say and also believes the one who sent me, he has life that will not end. He will not be condemned to be punished, because his being separated from God is already finished and he has life forever. ²⁵This that I say is also the truth. All people, it is like they are dead, because they are separated from God. But the time has already arrived when even those who are spiritually dead will hear me, the Child of God, speak. And those who believe what they have heard, they will truly live. ²⁶Because my Father is the one who gives life. And it is the same with me, because he has given me the authority to give life. ²⁷He has also given to me his Child the authority to judge, because I am the Child of a Person. ²⁸Do not be surprised at what I said, because one day, all the dead will hear my words ²⁹and leave their graves. Those who have done good things will come to life so that they will receive eternal life. But those who have done evil things, they will come to life so they will be condemned to be punished.

5:29a

and come out—those who have done good to the resurrection of life,

- They will come out of their graves/tombs alive. The ones who have done good things will receive eternal life,
- and will live again. Those people who have acted/lived in a good way will return to true/eternal life.

and come out: The dead people who hear Jesus’ voice come out of their graves. The phrase implies that they will first become alive. This does not refer to dead people walking around. In order to avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to say:

will rise/live and come out

In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly from where/what the dead will come out. Refer to your translation of 5:28b. For example:

come out of their graves (GNT)

have done good: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as have done good refers to doing what is right, what pleases God. This includes how a person thinks and speaks as well as how he acts.

to the resurrection of life: This phrase here means “will come out of their graves and live again.” Jesus will call these people from their graves in order that they might live with God forever. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will rise to live (NIV)

will rise and have life forever (NCV)

General Comment on 5:28b–29a

In some languages the break between verses may seem awkward. It may be more natural to include “and will come out” in 5:28b. For example:

^{28b}for the hour is coming when the dead will leave their graves at the sound of his voice: ^{29a}those who did good will come forth to life.... (NJB)

5:29b

and those who have done evil to the resurrection of judgment.

- while the ones who have done evil things will rise to be condemned.
- However, those people who have acted/lived in an evil way will return to punishment.

have done evil: This phrase refers to acting, thinking, and speaking in a way that does not please God.

to the resurrection of judgment: Jesus was indicating that the resurrection of these people will result in their being condemned. Jesus will call these people from their graves in order that they might be judged guilty. See how you translated “resurrection of life” in 5:29a. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

will rise to be condemned (NIV)

judgment: This is an abstract noun referring to the action of being condemned. It means that Jesus/God will judge them guilty. There are at least two other ways to translate this word:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to be judged guilty (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

to experience judgment (NLT)

John 5:30

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:30–32

Jesus declared that he did not act independently of God his Father. In whatever he did, he was following and obeying his Father. His Father was his witness that he did this.

5:30a

I can do nothing by Myself;

- ¶ I cannot do anything by myself.
- ¶ It is not possible for me to act alone.

I can do nothing by Myself: In this verse Jesus changed from referring to himself in the third person (the Son, him) to the first person (I, my). He declared that he had authority because of his union with God. His connection with God was what gave him the authority to judge people and to do miracles. He completely depended on God. He always acted in union with and in obedience to his Father.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I can do nothing independently.

I do not decide what to do by myself.

I cannot act alone.

5:30b

I judge only as I hear.

- I judge based on what God tells me,
- When God tells me about deciding if someone is guilty, I decide in that way.

I judge only as I hear: This phrase means “I judge the way God tells me to.” In some languages it is more natural to say explicitly whom Jesus hears: God the Father. For example:

As I listen [to the Father], I make my judgments.
(GW)

I judge as God tells me. (NLT)

5:30c

And My judgment is just,

- and what I judge is right.
- I decide justly/fairly if someone is guilty

And My judgment is just: Jesus was indicating that he is a just judge. His decisions are always fair and right. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

My judgments are right. (GW)

In some languages it is more natural to express the noun phrase My judgment as a verb: For example:

I judge with fairness. (CEV)

just: The word just here means “fair,” “right,” or “accurate.” Jesus judges in a good way. He is not corrupt, so he does not do things for his own benefit. Also, he does not practice favoritism (giving only some people special favors). Use an expression that describes the work of a judge who follows the law to decide cases and does not accept bribes.

5:30d

because I do not seek My own will, but the will of Him who sent Me.

- That is because I do not want to please myself but to please God who sent me here.
- because I try to do what God who sent me here wants/desires. I do not try to do what I want/desire.

because: This conjunction here introduces the reason why Jesus’ judgments are just.

I do not seek My own will, but the will of Him who sent Me: The verb seek here means “aim, want.” To

seek someone's will is to try to do what that person wants or wishes.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am not trying to do what I want, but only what he who sent me wants. (GNT)

I don't try to do what I want but what the one who sent me wants. (GW)

I don't try to please myself, but I try to please the One who sent me. (NCV)

but: In the previous clause, Jesus said what he did not seek, which is a negative statement. In this clause, he said what he does seek, which is a positive statement. The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects the negative statement to the positive statement. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

because I am not trying to do what I want, but only what he who sent me wants (GNT)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

My purpose is not to do what I want. Instead, my purpose is to do what the one who sent me wants.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I am not trying to do what I want. I am trying to obey the one who sent me.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I carry out the will of the one who sent me, not my own will (NLT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

the will of Him who sent Me: The phrase Him who sent Me refers to God the Father. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

The Father sent me...I obey him (CEV)

John 5:31

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:30–32

Jesus declared that he did not act independently of God his Father. In whatever he did, he was following and obeying his Father. His Father was his witness that he did this.

5:31

If I testify about Myself, My testimony is not valid.

- If I tell what I know about myself, what I say is not acceptable.
- If I talk about myself, that proves nothing.
- If I testify on my own behalf, what I say is not to be accepted as real proof. (GNT)

If I testify about Myself: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testify means “to tell what one has witnessed.” See the notes on 1:7a and 3:32a, where the same word is used. The word can refer to giving evidence in a legal trial, though that is not its meaning here. Jesus was just talking about his telling people about himself.

Yet the legal situation is still relevant here. Jewish law did not allow people to testify about themselves. Two or more witnesses were necessary before a judge could properly judge someone. The IVP Background Commentary says, “Here Jesus cites the Old Testament principle, central to later Jewish law..., that two witnesses are necessary to prove a (capital) case (Deut 17:6; 19:15).” So people might not believe what Jesus said about himself if no one else said the same thing. It may be helpful to emphasize this point. For example:

If I alone testify about Myself (NASB)

In some languages it may not be natural to use legal terms in this context. If that is true in your language, here are other ways to translate this clause:

If I speak for myself (CEV)

If only I tell people about myself (NCV)

My testimony is not valid: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as My testimony is not valid means “what I say cannot be considered acceptable and reliable.” It indicates that the testimony of a person about himself, or that of one witness, cannot be accepted as legal evidence. It is not valid (acceptable) evidence in a court of law, even if it is true. Jesus did not mean that he would tell a lie.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If I were to testify on my own behalf, my testimony would not be valid. (NLT)

what I say is not to be accepted as real proof (GNT)

Translate this clause in a way so that people will not think that Jesus would tell a lie.

My testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony refers to a public statement about something or someone that one knows. See the note on 1:19a, where the same word is used. It is the noun form of the verb translated as “testify” in the previous clause.

John 5:32

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:30–32

Jesus declared that he did not act independently of God his Father. In whatever he did, he was following and obeying his Father. His Father was his witness that he did this.

5:32a

There is another who testifies about Me,

- But someone else tells what he knows to confirm what I said,
- There is another who speaks for me, God himself.

another: The Greek word that the BSB translates as another here probably refers to God. Try to imply this without making it explicit. If your readers will think that this refers to another human, perhaps John the Baptist, it may be necessary to say explicitly:

another, the Father

This word is emphasized in the Greek text, so it is suggested that you emphasize it in your translation. For example:

However, there is another one who testifies about me.

who testifies about Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who testifies about Me means “who publicly declares that I am right.” The word testifies is the same verb that is used in 5:31. Here is another way to translate this clause:

But there is someone else who speaks for me (CEV)

there is another who tells about me (NCV)

5:32b

and I know that His testimony about Me is valid.

- and I know that his words about me are true.
- And I know that what he/God says/declares about me is acceptable/reliable.

I know that His testimony about Me is valid: This clause refers to God the Father’s testimony about Jesus. God publicly declared Jesus to be the Messiah, the Chosen Savior, and Jesus knew that what he declared was true and acceptable. See John 1:32–34. God testified to Jesus when he sent the Spirit upon him at his baptism.

His testimony about Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as testimony refers to a public statement about something or someone that one knows. Here, it refers to God's statement about Jesus. It is the same word as in 1:32.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the things he says about me (NCV)

everything/what God says about me

valid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as valid is the same word that was used in 5:31. Here, it says that God's statement about Jesus was correct and acceptable. God the Father's testimony was acceptable because he was testifying about someone else, not about himself. What God said was also true, so it may be easier to use the word 'true' here than in 5:31. See the note on 5:31 for more information on this word in this context. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I know that his testimony about me is true
(NIV2011)

I know that everything God says about me is true/
acceptable

John 5:33

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth
about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about
Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:33–35

Jesus continued to discuss his witnesses, those who could speak in support of his claims. In this paragraph

he said that John the Baptist was a witness to the truth.

5:33a

You have sent to John,

- ¶ You^(plur) sent messengers to John to find out who he was.
- ¶ Through messengers, you^(plur) asked John who he was.

You have sent to John: The Jewish leaders sent messengers to John the Baptist to find out who he was. See 1:19–28.

You: This pronoun is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders who were questioning Jesus.

John: Jesus was referring to John the Baptist. Refer to him as you did in 1:19.

5:33b

and he has testified to the truth.

- He spoke the truth about me.
- He told them/you^(plur) about me and what he said was true.

he: This pronoun refers to John the Baptist. In some languages it is more natural to supply the name "John" here. For example:

John told you what was true about me.

has testified: See how you translated "testify" in 5:31. Here is another way to translate this word:

he has told you the truth (NCV)

to the truth: The phrase the truth here refers to what John the Baptist said about Jesus. The Translators Handbook says, "It may be more satisfactory to translate 'he spoke what was true about me' or 'he spoke about me and that was true' or 'what he said was true.'" He said Jesus was the Lamb of God and was greater than John. These things were true, accurate, faithful, and reliable. In some languages it is more natural to supply the information that John was speaking about Jesus. For example:

his testimony about me was true (NLT)

In some languages it is natural to translate the abstract noun truth with a clause. For example:

You have sent people to John, and he has spoken words that are true.

John 5:34

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:33–35

Jesus continued to discuss his witnesses, those who could speak in support of his claims. In this paragraph he said that John the Baptist was a witness to the truth.

5:34a

Even though I do not accept human testimony,

- I do not actually need a person to speak about me.
- I do not rely/depend on people telling about me.

Even though I do not accept human testimony: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as *Even though I do not accept human testimony* is more literally “not that the testimony that I receive is from man.” Jesus was saying that he did not need human testimony. That was not what he depended on to know who he was. The Translators Handbook says, “In some languages one may render this clause ‘I really do not need other people’s words in order to prove who I am’ or ‘It is really not necessary that people say what they know about me.’” And that is not the reason why he mentioned John the Baptist’s testimony.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But I don’t depend on human testimony. (GW)

I have no need of human witnesses. (NLT)

Even though: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Even though* here connects the negative statement in 5:34a to the positive statement in 5:34b. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive state-

ment. In 5:34a, Jesus said what was not the reason he mentioned John the Baptist’s testimony. In 5:34b, he said what was the reason that he mentioned John’s testimony. The reason he did was to help his listeners spiritually, so that his listeners would believe and receive salvation. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

I don’t depend on what people say about me, but I tell you these things so that you may be saved. (CEV)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Although I don’t accept human testimony, I say these things so that you can be saved. (CEB)

not that I depend on human testimony; no, it is for your salvation that I mention it (NJB)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

But I don’t depend on human testimony. I’m telling you this to save you. (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I tell you about this human testimony for you to be saved, not that I need it myself.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

testimony: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *testimony* refers to a public statement about something or someone that one knows. See how you translated it in 1:19a and 5:31–32.

5:34b

I say these things so that you may be saved.

- However, I tell you^(plur) about what John said in order that you may receive salvation.
- But I mention what John said so you will believe me and then God will save you^(plur).

I say these things: This clause introduces the reason why Jesus talked about John’s testimony. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

but I mention John's testimony

but I tell you about what John has said

so that you may be saved: The conjunction so that here means "in order that." It introduces a purpose clause. Jesus' purpose in reminding people of John's testimony was to help them believe in him and thus receive salvation. For example:

in order that you may be saved (GNT)

This is a passive clause. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so you might be saved (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

in order that you may receive salvation

so God will save you

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to those who were listening to Jesus.

John 5:35

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:33–35

Jesus continued to discuss his witnesses, those who could speak in support of his claims. In this paragraph

he said that John the Baptist was a witness to the truth.

5:35a–b

This verse contains a metaphor. Jesus compared John the Baptist to a lamp. A lamp enables people to see in the dark. In the same way, John enabled people to see (understand) God the Father and his Son, the Messiah. He taught truth about God and Jesus Christ.

In some languages a metaphor like this may not be clearly understood. If this is the case in your language, you may need to:

- Change the metaphor into a simile. For example:

John was like a burning and shining lamp, and you were happy to enjoy his light for a while. (NCV)

John was like a lamp, burning and shining, and you were willing for a while to enjoy his light. (GNT)

- Indicate something of the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

Like a shining lamp, John brought light into dark places by speaking truth. For a short time you liked listening to his words.

John was like a lamp that shone, and you enjoyed his shining in your minds/thoughts with his teaching for a while.

5:35a

John was a lamp that burned and gave light,

- John was like a lamp that burned brightly
- John clearly/honestly told who I am like a lamp that gives light to those around.

John was a lamp that burned and gave light: This expression is a metaphor. The two expressions burned and gave light both describe the lamp. It was an oil lamp with a flame that gave light as it burned. In some cultures such lamps may be unknown. In those languages it may be possible to say:

John was a lamp lit and shining (NJB)

John was a lamp that gave a lot of light (CEV)

John was like an oil lamp that was shining

5:35b

and you were willing for a season to bask in his light.

- and you^(plur) were glad to enjoy his light briefly as you listened to his words.
- For a time you^(plur) liked listening to his message.

and you were willing for a season to bask in his light: This continues the metaphor of light. The people listening to John were happy to hear what he said, just as people are happy to have light. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for a time you were content to enjoy the light that he gave (NJB)

you were glad to enjoy his light for a while (GW)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the Jewish people in general. It implies that some of those who heard John were present and were listening to Jesus.

for a season: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as for a season means “for an hour.” It indicates that the time was short without really saying how short it was. Here are some other ways you may translate this phrase:

for a time (NIV)

for a short time (NET)

John 5:36

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:36–38

In this paragraph Jesus told about other witnesses who supported his claims, witnesses greater than John the Baptist.

5:36a

But I have testimony more substantial than that of John.

- ¶ “But a witness for me will say something greater than what John said.
- ¶ “But there is a stronger/greater witness than John who speaks for me.

But: This conjunction here introduces a statement that makes the previous statement less important or significant. Although people had welcomed John’s testimony, Jesus had a more important testimony. The topic now changes to this more important testimony.

I have testimony more substantial than that of John: This clause means “Someone gives testimony about me that is more important than the testimony that John gave about me.” Jesus was not saying that John’s testimony was not important, but that there was testimony even more important and reliable.

In some languages it is more natural to compare the ones giving the testimonies (the witnesses) rather than the testimonies. For example:

I have a witness greater than John

I have testimony: This clause refers to the testimony that someone else gives about Jesus, confirming what he said. In some languages it is more natural to use a verb phrase instead of a noun like testimony. For example:

But there is something which confirms/proves to you the truth of what I said that is better/stronger than what John said.

See the note on testimony at 5:31 and 5:34a.

more substantial than that of John: The Greek word that the BSB translates as more substantial here means “more important” or “superior.”

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

higher than John’s (REB)

stronger than that of John

something that testifies more favorably on my behalf than John's testimony (GW)

5:36b

For the works that the Father has given Me to accomplish—

- That is because of the works/tasks that my Father told me to finish/fulfill.
- God my Father wants me to do certain tasks,

For: The Greek word that the BSB literally translates as For means “for” or “because.” Some English translations do not make it explicit, but other translations do. For example:

For (NIV)

Because

In this context this conjunction introduces Jesus' grounds for saying in 5:36a that he had a testimony greater than John's testimony. Introduce these grounds in a way that is natural in your language.

the works that the Father has given Me to accomplish: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the works here refers to Jesus' deeds, and especially his miracles. Jesus was claiming that God the Father wanted him to act in the way he had acted. Jesus had healed the paralyzed man because God had told him to do so.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the things that the Father has given me to do (CEV)

the deeds that the Father has told me to finish

5:36c

the very works I am doing—testify about Me that the Father has sent Me.

- They are exactly/specifically the works/tasks that I am doing, and they are my witnesses that show that my Father has sent me.
- and these are the very/exact tasks that I do. So they are themselves the evidence that God my Father sent me here.

the very works I am doing: This phrase indicates that Jesus was doing the tasks God the Father had told him to do. The miracle of healing the paralyzed man (5:5–9) was one such work.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The deeds I am now doing (NET)

The things I do (NCV)

testify about Me that the Father has sent Me: The expression testify...that the Father has sent Me means “give evidence that my Father God sent me to this world.” Jesus' healing miracles showed clearly who he was and who had sent him.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

testify for me that it was my Father God who sent me

speak for me and prove that the Father sent me (CEV)

testify about Me: This expression indicates that Jesus' deeds give evidence that he was speaking the truth. They show that Jesus was truly sent from God, with God's authority. The phrase about Me means “for me” or “for my benefit.” The whole phrase is a figure of speech. In some languages it may not be possible to speak of works/deeds as testifying for someone. If that is the case in your language, here are other ways to translate this phrase:

my works are evidence that I speak the truth

my deeds are my proof

The things I do...prove that... (NCV)

has sent Me: In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit where the Father sent Jesus. For example:

has sent me here

has sent me into the world

John 5:37

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the

Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:36–38

In this paragraph Jesus told about other witnesses who supported his claims, witnesses greater than John the Baptist.

5:37a

And the Father who sent Me has Himself testified about Me.

- And the Father who sent me has spoken the truth about me.
- The Father has spoken for me, the one whom he sent.

And the Father who sent Me has Himself testified about Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And here introduces another witness. Jesus was claiming that his Father God had also personally testified about him. For example:

The Father who sent me also speaks for me (CEV)

has Himself testified about Me: God spoke to show his approval of Jesus on various occasions. See John 1:32–33. In this way God himself was a witness for Jesus. His testimony proved that Jesus was speaking the truth. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

has given proof about me (NCV)

God had already testified at the time Jesus was speaking, and his words continued to be true and effective. So in some languages it may be natural to use a present tense verb. For example:

testifies on my behalf (GNT)

bears witness to me himself (NJB)

General Comment on 5:37a

In some languages it may be natural to translate this sentence with two independent clauses. For example:

The Father is the one who sent me, and he has himself testified about me.

5:37b

You have never heard His voice nor seen His form,

- You^(plur) have never heard him say anything or seen what he looks like.
- You^(plur) have never heard him speak or been able to see him.

You have never heard His voice nor seen His form:

This clause means “you have not heard God speak nor have you seen God.” See the note on 1:18a, “No one has ever seen God.” Here Jesus emphasized that his listeners did not truly know God.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You have never heard his voice or seen what he looks like (NCV)

You have never heard his voice or seen him face to face (NLT)

You: The pronoun You is plural and refers here again to the Jewish religious leaders.

His form: The Greek word that the BSB translates as form here refers to what is visible, like a person’s body or face.

John 5:38

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:36–38

In this paragraph Jesus told about other witnesses who supported his claims, witnesses greater than John the Baptist.

5:38a

nor does His word abide in you,

- You^(plur) clearly do not believe what he says
- You^(plur) do not listen to what he says.

nor does His word abide in you: The Greek clause that BSB translates as nor does His word abide in you means “you do not believe God’s word.” The word abide means “stay” or “live.” The idea here is that they do not love God’s Word or consider it special. As a result, they did not give it a special place to live in their lives or hearts. The religious leaders studied God’s Word and said that they followed it, but Jesus said that they did not really follow it.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

his word has found no home in you (REB)

You do not keep his message in your hearts. (GNT)

His teaching does not live in you (NCV)

His word: The phrase His word here means “the word/message from God.”

5:38b

because you do not believe the One He sent.

- because you^(plur) do not believe me whom he sent.
- This is shown/proved because you^(plur) do not believe me, the one that he sent.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because connects this clause with the previous clause. It introduces evidence that the Jewish leaders did not believe in God’s word. See the General Comment on 5:38a–b.

you do not believe the One He sent: The pronoun you is plural. The Jewish leaders did not want to believe Jesus, God’s messenger. Jesus did not say that they did not believe in him, but rather that they did not believe him. That means that they did not believe what he said. And that would also mean that they did not believe or trust in Jesus.

the One He sent: Jesus was referring to himself. It may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

you do not believe me—the one he sent to you (NLT)

you do not believe me, his messenger

General Comment on 5:38a–b

5:38b gives the evidence that what Jesus said in 5:38a was true. Consider how you can translate this logical connection. For example:

^{38a}Clearly you do not believe God’s message,
^{38b}because you do not believe the one whom he sent.

^{38b}Because you refuse to believe/accept the messenger God sent, ^{38a}it is clear that you do not believe/accept his message.

John 5:39

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders’ failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God’s praise.

5:39a

You pore over the Scriptures

- ¶ You^(plur) carefully study the Scripture
- ¶ You^(plur) study well God’s Word

You pore over the Scriptures: The Greek word that the BSB translates as pore over means “to study in a detailed or careful way.” The Jewish religious leaders read the Scriptures very carefully. For example:

You carefully study the Scriptures (NCV)

You study the Scriptures in detail (GW)

the Scriptures: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Scriptures is more literally “the writings (things that someone writes).” This refers to the Hebrew holy books that form part of the Bible, what we now call the Old Testament. See Scriptures, the Writings, It Is Written 2(a) in KBT.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the holy writings

God’s word/message

5:39b

because you presume that by them you possess eternal life.

- because you^(plur) think that it tells you how to get eternal life.
- because you^(plur) believe that it gives you spiritual life that never ends.

because: The Greek word the BSB translates as because introduces the reason why the religious leaders studied the scriptures.

you presume that by them you possess eternal life: The Jewish leaders believed that they would receive eternal life as they studied and obeyed the scriptures. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you think they give you eternal life (NLT)

you think that in them you will find eternal life (GNT)

you ^L wrongly think that if you do that, you will get life with no end

you presume: The Greek word that the BSB translates as presume here means “to regard something as true.” It may or may not be correct. Jesus did not say that the Jews’ thinking was completely wrong, but neither did he say that it was completely right. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

supposing that in having them you have eternal life (REB)

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life never ends. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there and in 5:24c. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

5:39c

These are the very words that testify about Me,

- The Scripture tells about me.
- These are the writings that tell about me,

These are the very words that testify about Me: The scriptures that the Jews studied testified about Jesus. See the notes on 1:45b, where Philip also says this. For testify, see the notes on 5:31, 5:36c, and 5:37a. Jesus was saying that the scriptures were a testimony. The scriptures’ testimony confirmed that he told the truth when he said that he was God’s Messiah.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is these same scriptures that testify about me (NET)

and it is those scriptures that speak about me

John 5:40

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders' failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God's praise.

5:40

yet you refuse to come to Me to have life.

- Yet you^(plur) refuse to come to me in order to receive eternal life.
- yet you^(plur) do not want to trust me for that life.

yet you refuse to come to Me to have life: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as yet introduces a result that one does not expect. The religious leaders were refusing to believe in Jesus even though the Scriptures testified about him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and you still do not want to come to me so that I will give life to you

But you are not willing to come to me so that you may have life (NET)

you refuse: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you refuse is more literally “you do not want.” It includes the idea of not being willing to do something, of choosing against something. For example:

you are not willing (GNT)

to come to Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as come to Me refers to a spiritual way of going to Jesus. That way involved believing and trusting him as the Messiah.

to have life: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to have life indicates a purpose. The purpose of coming to Jesus is to receive the life mentioned in 5:39b. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to have life (GNT)

for eternal life (CEV)

to receive that life (REB)

John 5:41**Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself**

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders' failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God's praise.

5:41

I do not accept glory from men,

- I do not receive glory/honor from people.
- I do not care whether people praise me.

I do not accept glory from men: This clause means “I am not trying to obtain glory from human beings.” Jesus was not speaking and acting the way he did in order to receive human glory or praise.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Human glory means nothing to me. (NJB)

I am not looking for human praise. (GNT)

glory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glory here means “praise,” “honor,” or “approval.” See KBT Glory A.3(a).

John 5:42**Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself**

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the

Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders' failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God's praise.

5:42a

but I know you,

- But I am aware/sure of this,
- But I know what you^(plur) are like.

but: The conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces an implied contrast. The contrast is between Jesus not wanting human praise and the Jewish leaders wanting praise (see 5:44b). It is also an implied contrast between Jesus' love for his Father (see 14:31) and the Jews' lack of love. Introduce this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

I know you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as I know you indicates that Jesus was saying that he understood the religious leaders. He knew that, unlike him, they did want people's praise. Jesus knew the kind of people they were and wanted them to change. He was warning them. See the General Comment following 5:42b. For example:

But I know what kind of people you are. (GW)

But I know that with you it is different (REB)

5:42b

that you do not have the love of God within you.

- you^(plur) do not have any love for God.
- You^(plur) do not love God.

you do not have the love of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the love of God here means "love for God." Jesus was saying that the religious leaders did not love God. In some languages it is more

natural to translate the noun love with a verb. For example:

none of you love God (CEV)

within you: The pronoun you is plural here. In some languages, love is thought to be found in a certain body part, such as the heart or mind. In those languages, it may be more natural to refer to that part of the body. For example:

in your hearts (NIV)

in your thoughts

General Comment on 5:42a–b

In the BSB verse 42 is translated as part of one sentence that began in the previous verse. Here are other ways to use part of one sentence:

because I know that you do not have God's love in your thoughts/heart

but I do know that none of you love God. (CEV)

In other languages it may be natural to use two sentences when you translate this verse. For example:

But I know what kind of people you are. You don't have any love for God. (GW)

but I know you. I know that you do not have the love of God in your hearts. (NIV)

John 5:43

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders' failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God's praise.

5:43a–b

I have come in My Father's name, and you have not received Me: This is a proof that the religious leaders did not love God. Because Jesus came from God, they would welcome him as God's messenger if they loved God.

5:43a

I have come in My Father's name,

- I have come with authority from my Father,
- God my Father sent me here to speak for him,
- I come to you as my Father's representative,

I have come in My Father's name: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as in My Father's name indicates that Jesus came with God's authority. God sent Jesus to be his representative on earth. He appointed Jesus to speak and act for him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have come with my Father's authority. (GNT)

I have come with the authority my Father has given me. (GW)

have come from my Father and speak for him (NCV)

I have come: Jesus had come from God to earth. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate either where Jesus came from or where he came to. For example:

God sent me here

I have come to you (NLT)

5:43b

and you have not received Me;

- and you^(plur) refuse to welcome me.
- and you^(plur) reject me.

you have not received Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you have not received Me means "you reject me." Jesus was not feeling sorry for him-

self but pointing out what the Jewish leaders were doing. They were rejecting the one that God sent. For example:

you have no welcome for me (REB)

you have rejected me (NLT)

5:43c–d

but if someone else comes in his own name, you will receive him: In these clauses Jesus speaks of anyone who might come and preach without anyone sending them. He is speaking in general of those whom God has not sent. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms here. For example:

Yet if others come in their own name, you gladly welcome them. (NLT)

See General Comment on 5:43c–d for a suggestion of how to reorder these clauses.

5:43c

but if someone else comes in his own name,

- But if someone else comes with just his own authority,
- However, if anyone else comes without anyone sending him,

but if someone else comes in his own name: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as if someone else comes in his own name refers to someone who comes only on his own authority. No one else sent him. For example:

But when another person comes, speaking only for himself (NCV)

When, however, someone comes with his own authority (GNT)

5:43d

you will receive him.

- you^(plur) will welcome him.
- him you^(plur) accept/believe.

you will receive him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you will receive him means "you^(plur) will receive/welcome that person." The word receive is based on the same root word as "received" in 5:43b, where they did not accept Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will accept him (NRSV)

you gladly welcome them (NLT)

General Comment on 5:43c–d

In some languages it is more natural to reorder these clauses. For example:

^{43d}you will accept someone else ^{43c}who on his own authority says he is from God

^{43d}you will welcome people ^{43c}who come on their own (CEV)

John 5:44

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:39–44

Jesus condemned the religious leaders' failure to believe in him. He said they were more interested in receiving praise from one another than they were in receiving God's praise.

5:44a–c

How can you believe if you accept glory from one another, yet do not seek the glory that comes from the only God?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it as a rebuke. He was saying that the leaders could not believe because they received other people's praise but did not want God's praise. It may be implied that they wanted people's praise. A similar idea is in John 12:43, which says, "For they loved praise from men more than praise from God." Jesus implied that they were wrong to not believe and to desire man's praise more than God's.

Here are three ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can you believe when you accept each other's praise and don't look for the praise that comes from the only God? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

No wonder you can't believe! For you gladly honor each other, but you don't care about the honor that comes from the one who alone is God. (NLT)

- Use both a rhetorical question and a statement. For example:

How could you possibly believe? You like to have your friends praise you, and you don't care about praise that the only God can give! (CEV)

Translate this rebuke in the way that is most natural in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in this verse, with the conclusion at the end. For example:

^{44b}You like to receive praise from one another, ^{44c}but you do not try to win praise from the one who alone is God; ^{44a}how, then, can you believe me? (GNT)

5:44a

How can you believe

- How can you^(plur) believe me
- You^(plur) cannot believe me

How can you believe...?: This expression here implies that the religious leaders were not able to believe Jesus. For example:

No wonder you can't believe! (NLT)

believe: This word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him.

In some languages it may be natural to make the object of belief explicit. For example:

how, then, can you believe me? (GNT)

how could you believe in me?

5:44b

if you accept glory from one another,

- when you^(plur) receive each other's praise
- because you^(plur) want people to praise/approve you.

if you accept glory from one another: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you accept glory from one another indicates that the Jewish leaders receive honor from each other. The rhetorical question may imply that they wanted the approval and praise of other people. Certainly their attitude is different from Jesus, who did not accept glory from humans. (See 5:41.) It was because of this they could not believe Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

since you look to each other for glory (NJB)

you accept honor from one another (REB)

You like to receive praise from one another (GNT)

if you accept: The Greek word that the BSB translated as if you accept is more literally "taking/receiving." It does not refer to a specific time but to a general attitude. It was because of their attitude that these religious men could not believe in Jesus. What other men thought about them was more important to them than what God thought about them.

Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

because you accept/receive

when you accept (NRSV)

glory: In many languages it may be natural to translate glory as a verb rather than a noun. For example:

you gladly honor each other (NLT)

you like to have your friends praise you (CEV)

5:44c

yet do not seek the glory that comes from the only God?

- instead of trying/wanting to get praise from the one and only God?
- And yet you do not care whether the true/one God will praise you.
- And you do not try to receive the praise/approval of the only true God.

yet do not seek the glory that comes from the only God: This clause indicates that the religious leaders were not interested in obtaining praise from God.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and are not concerned with the glory that comes from the one God (NJB)

and care nothing for the honor that comes from him who alone is God (REB)

but you do not try to get the praise that comes from the only God (NCV)

the only God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the only God refers to God as the only true God. Here is another way to translate this expression:

the one who alone is God (NRSV)

General Comment on 5:44b–c

These clauses form an implied comparison. They indicate that the religious leaders wanted glory/praise from people more than they wanted glory/praise from God. For example:

you want people to praise you more than you want God to praise you

you are much more eager to receive glory from other people than to receive glory from God

John 5:45

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:45–47

Moses had written in the Scriptures that God would send another prophet like him. He also wrote that the people must believe and obey that other prophet. In this paragraph, Jesus implied that he was that other prophet, but the people refused to accept him.

5:45a

Do not think that I will accuse you before the Father.

- ¶ But I am not the one who will accuse you^(plur) before God my Father.
- ¶ But I will not accuse you on the day of judgment.

Do not think that I will accuse you before the Father: In this clause, Jesus was referring to the last judgment. He was indicating that it was not he who would tell God that the religious leaders were wrong. He was implying that someone would accuse them, but it would not be him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause (a “tribunal” is a legal court):

Don’t think that I will stand before the Father and say you are wrong. (NCV)

Do not imagine that I shall be your accuser at the Father’s tribunal. (REB)

Do not think that I will accuse you: The Jewish leaders were not to think this because it was not true. In some languages it may be more natural to leave the phrase Do not think implicit. For example:

Yet it isn’t I who will accuse you before the Father. (NLT)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders.

before the Father: The word Father refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to say “my Father.” For example:

to my Father (GNT)

5:45b

Your accuser is Moses, in whom you have put your hope.

- The one who will accuse you is Moses, the one in whom you hope/trust.
- Moses will accuse you^(plur), even though you hope that he will give/bring you life.

Your accuser is Moses, in whom you have put your

hope: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Your accuser is Moses is the most important part of Jesus’ argument. The Jewish leaders had been saying that they followed Moses, but Jesus said that they were disobeying Moses. Moses had told them to believe in him, that is, in Jesus. So Moses was their real accuser. For example:

Moses, the one you trust, is already accusing you. (GW)

The one who says you are wrong is Moses, the one you hoped would save you. (NCV)

Your accuser is Moses: In some languages it is more natural to change the noun accuser into a verb phrase. For example:

Moses will accuse you! (NLT)

The one who accuses you is Moses (NET)

in whom you have put your hope: Moses was the one the Jewish leaders hoped would bring them eternal life. He wrote the first five books of the Old Testament. The Jewish leaders hoped that if they obeyed what he wrote, God would approve of them and give them eternal life. See the note on 5:39b. But Jesus said that Moses is the one who will accuse them of sin. This clause is emphasized. For example:

Yes, Moses, in whom you put your hopes. (NLT)

your hope: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as your hope refers to the religious leaders’ hope. They hoped that they would obtain God’s favor and blessing if they obeyed Moses’ law. In some languages it may be natural to translate hope as a verb. For example:

the one you hoped would save you (NCV)

the one you trust (GW)

General Comment on 5:45a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 5:45a–b. For example:

You have put your hope in Moses, yet he is the very one who will accuse you. (CEV)

John 5:46

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:45–47

Moses had written in the Scriptures that God would send another prophet like him. He also wrote that the people must believe and obey that other prophet. In this paragraph, Jesus implied that he was that other prophet, but the people refused to accept him.

5:46a

If you had believed Moses, you would believe Me,

- That is because if you^(plur) believed what Moses wrote, you would believe me,
- You did not believe Moses, but if you had believed him, you would have believed in me.
- He will accuse you because anyone who believes Moses, also believes me.

The Greek text includes a word at the beginning of this verse that means “because.” The idea is that Moses would accuse the Jewish leaders because they did not believe him. And Jesus knows that they did not believe Moses because if they had believed Moses, they would believe him. English translations leave this word implied, but you may want to make it explicit. For example:

because if you truly believed Moses, then you would also believe me

He will accuse you of not believing him because if you believed him, you would believe me

If you had believed Moses, you would believe Me:

These clauses form a logical argument. The first clause is a condition that had not been fulfilled, that is contrary to fact. Jesus was saying that the religious leaders did not really believe Moses. If they had believed what Moses wrote, they would have listened to Jesus, but they did not. The fact that they did not believe Jesus showed that they did not believe Moses.

In some languages it may be necessary to imply or state explicitly that the leaders believed neither Moses nor Jesus. For example:

If you really believed Moses, you would believe me. (GW)

If you did believe what Moses wrote, you would believe me. But you do not believe him/us.

In some languages a condition that is contrary to fact (never happened) may be unnatural or hard to understand. It may be necessary to say it in a positive way:

Those who believe Moses will believe me also.

had believed...would believe: Here the idea of these words is believing what Moses wrote and what Jesus said. That is made clear in 5:47.

5:46b

because he wrote about Me.

- because Moses wrote about me.
- That is because it was Moses who wrote about me.

because: The Greek word that BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why those who believe Moses must also believe Jesus. Here is another way to translate this word:

for (NRSV)

he wrote about Me: This clause means “Moses wrote about Jesus.” Moses wrote about the coming of a prophet in Deuteronomy 18:15–19. Jesus was saying that he was that prophet. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Moses wrote about me. (GW)

John 5:47

Section 5:30–47: Jesus told about others who told the truth about himself

Jesus told the Pharisees about those who testified about him. Those witnesses were John the Baptist, the works that the Father gave him to do, and the Father himself. The Father spoke about him in the Old Testament.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told about what testified about the truth about him

There were those who confirmed the truth about Jesus

Witnesses for Jesus

Paragraph 5:45–47

Moses had written in the Scriptures that God would send another prophet like him. He also wrote that the people must believe and obey that other prophet. In this paragraph, Jesus implied that he was that other prophet, but the people refused to accept him.

5:47a–b

But since you do not believe what he wrote, how will you believe what I say?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it as a strong statement and a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the religious leaders for not believing what Moses wrote and not believing what he said either. Refusing to believe Jesus meant that they also refused to believe Moses.

Here are three ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

But since you don't believe what he wrote, how will you believe what I say? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

And because you do not believe what Moses wrote, you will not believe what I say.

You really do not believe what he wrote so you do/can not believe what I say.

- Use both a statement and a rhetorical question. For example:

You do not believe what Moses wrote. So how can you believe what I say?

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

5:47a

But since you do not believe what he wrote,

- But because you^(plur) do not believe what he wrote,
- But because you^(plur) do not trust his writings,

But: The Greek conjunction the BSB translates as But marks contrast. The contrast is between what would happen if they believed Moses (in 5:46) and what would happen if they did not believe Moses (5:47). Even though the Jewish leaders said that they believed Moses, Jesus said that they did not really believe him. And because they did not really believe Moses, they could not believe Jesus.

since: This conjunction introduces a condition that was fulfilled. Here is another way to translate this word:

because

you do not believe what he wrote: Jesus was saying that the religious leaders did not believe what Moses had written about the prophet who would come. (See the note on “he wrote about me” at 5:46b).

he: This pronoun refers to Moses. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

if you don't believe what Moses wrote (NCV)

5:47b

how will you believe what I say?”

- how can you^(plur) ever believe what I say?”
- you^(plur) will not believe what I say.”

how will you believe what I say: This clause indicates that because they did not meet the condition, the religious leaders could not believe in Jesus. Unless they believed what Moses wrote, they would not be able to believe Jesus' words. For example:

how can you believe what I say (NCV)

you will not/never be able to believe what I say

John 6:1

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:1–4

This paragraph gives the setting for the miraculous feeding of many people. It tells approximately where Jesus was and when this took place.

6:1a

After this,

- ¶ Some days/time after this happened,
- ¶ Later,

After this: This phrase indicates a time that is not specific. We do not know how much time passed before this next event.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Some time later

6:1b

Jesus crossed to the other side of the Sea of Galilee

- Jesus went/sailed across Lake Galilee
- Jesus and his disciples crossed the lake called Galilee,

Jesus crossed to the other side of the Sea of Galilee:

The place that Jesus went to is also not specific. The phrase the other side probably refers to the northeast side, but this is not certain. The text does not mean that Jesus was already on the shore of the Sea of Galilee. At the end of chapter 5, he was in Jerusalem, which is not by the Sea of Galilee. To avoid implying that Jerusalem was on the Sea of Galilee, it may be necessary to say that he went there. For example:

Jesus returned to Galilee and crossed the lake.

Jesus: Jesus did not cross the sea alone. If a literal translation implies that he was traveling alone, you may need to say explicitly:

Jesus and his disciples

crossed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as crossed can refer to any method of going or moving away from somewhere. Try to use as general a word as possible, one that could include walking and sailing. For example:

went away (ESV)

the Sea of Galilee: This phrase refers to a fresh-water lake in the province or region of Galilee. It was about 13 miles long and 7 miles wide (20 km. by 11 km.). Refer to the notes on Matthew 4:19 and Mark 1:16, where this lake is also mentioned. See how you spelled Galilee in John 2:1 and 4:43.

6:1c

(that is, the Sea of Tiberias).

- (that is, Lake Tiberias, as it is also called).
- which is also known as Tiberias Lake.

(that is, the Sea of Tiberias): The Sea of Tiberias was another name for the Sea of Galilee. This chapter in John is the only time this name is mentioned in the New Testament. The name came from one of the Roman emperors, Tiberius. The city Tiberias, on the coast of the Sea of Tiberias, was also named after him. This is parenthetical information. In some languages it may be natural to put it in parentheses. For example:

(or, Lake Tiberias, as it is also called) (GNT)

John 6:2

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:1–4

This paragraph gives the setting for the miraculous feeding of many people. It tells approximately where Jesus was and when this took place.

6:2a

A large crowd followed Him

- Very many people followed him

A large crowd followed Him: This clause indicates that a lot of people were going around with Jesus. They continued to watch him and listen to him.

6:2b

because they saw the signs He was performing on the sick.

- because they saw the miracles that he did to help sick people.
- because these people had seen how Jesus healed the sick.

because they saw the signs He was performing on the sick: The people were following Jesus because they saw how he did miracles to cure sick people.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because they saw the amazing things that he did for the people who were sick

because they had seen his miracles of healing the sick (GNT)

signs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as signs refers here to Jesus' actions that enabled others to know something about him. In this context, Jesus' healing of sick people revealed who he was. He was the one sent from God to be the Messiah, the chosen Savior.

John 6:3

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:1–4

This paragraph gives the setting for the miraculous feeding of many people. It tells approximately where Jesus was and when this took place.

6:3

Then Jesus went up on the mountain and sat down with His disciples.

- Then Jesus climbed a hill and sat down with his disciples.
- With his disciples as his companions, Jesus went up on the side of the hill and sat down.

Then Jesus went up on the mountain and sat down with His disciples: In some languages it may be natural to translate this sentence using one dependent clause and one independent clause. For example:

Having gone up the side of the mountain, Jesus sat down with his disciples around him.

The disciples probably went up the mountain with Jesus rather than going up separately. In some languages it may be better to say that more clearly. For example:

Jesus went with his disciples up the mountain and they sat down there.

the mountain: This phrase indicates that this was a specific high area that the writer knew about. The Greek word that the BSB translates as mountain can also be translated as "hill." In this context the word probably refers to the high ground east of the Sea of Galilee. This would be the area now known as the Golan Heights. See the note in NET. It does not refer here to a mountain high enough to have snow on top. So in many language groups it may be natural to say:

Jesus climbed a hill (GNT)

Jesus went up on the mountainside (NET)

His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to "learners" who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learner commits himself to his teacher to learn and follow his teaching and

example. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this term at 1:35 and 4:27a.

The disciples referred to here were probably Jesus' twelve (12) closest disciples. John refers to the other people that came as "a large crowd" in 6:5.

John 6:4

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:1–4

This paragraph gives the setting for the miraculous feeding of many people. It tells approximately where Jesus was and when this took place.

6:4

Now the Jewish Feast of the Passover was near.

- It was almost time for the Jewish feast called Passover.
- It was the time of year when the Jews would soon celebrate the feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

Now the Jewish Feast of the Passover was near: This sentence is parenthetical information. You may want to put it in parentheses. For example:

(Now the Jewish feast of the Passover was near.)
(NET)

The Passover is the name of a Jewish festival that took place once a year. The term Passover refers to the time in Exodus 12 when God passed over the houses of the Hebrews (later called Jews). The firstborn children of the Egyptians were killed that night, but he did not harm anyone in the Hebrews' houses. He passed over their houses when he saw the blood of a lamb on the doorposts (boards around the door).

This is the second Passover mentioned in the Gospel of John. The first is mentioned in 2:13a, 23. See the note there, and the suggested footnote. Use the same term for Passover here and there.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

It was nearly time for the Jewish Passover celebration. (NLT)

It was almost the time for the Jewish Passover Feast. (NCV)

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now is not a time word. In this context it introduces background information. Introduce the background, parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

the Jewish Feast of the Passover: This phrase indicates that the Passover was a feast celebrated by the Jewish people.

John 6:5

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:5–9

This paragraph tells why there was a need for Jesus to act. Many thousands of people were hungry. To buy food for them all would have cost a lot of money. It is implied, though not stated, that Jesus and the disciples were not wealthy. They did not have large amounts of money to give away or spend.

6:5a

When Jesus looked up and saw a large crowd coming toward Him,

- ¶ Then Jesus saw a large group/number of people coming toward him.

- ¶ Jesus noticed very many people moving toward him.

When Jesus looked up and saw a large crowd coming toward Him: The Greek text of 6:5a includes a word that is often translated as “therefore.” The BSB does not explicitly translate this word, but other translations do. For example:

Lifting up his eyes, then, and seeing that a large crowd was coming toward him.... (ESV)

Therefore Jesus, lifting up His eyes and seeing that a large crowd was coming to Him.... (NASB)

So when Jesus looked up and saw the large crowd coming to him

In some languages it may be natural to translate 6:5a as a separate sentence. For example:

Jesus looked up and saw that a large crowd of people was coming toward him.

looked up and saw: This phrase indicates that Jesus noticed something. It does not mean that Jesus was previously looking down at the ground.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

looked around and saw (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to use only one verb. For example:

Jesus saw (CEV)

a large crowd: Use a word or phrase that refers to several thousand peaceful people gathered together.

6:5b

He said to Philip,

- He said to Philip,
- He asked his disciple Philip,

He said to Philip: This phrase introduces a question that Jesus used to encourage Philip to think about a problem. It may be more natural in some languages to make it explicit that Jesus would ask a question. For example:

Jesus asked Philip

Philip: Philip was last mentioned in 1:43–45. He was one of Jesus’ twelve (12) disciples. Because he was last mentioned several chapters earlier, it may help to remind readers and listeners who he was. Here are examples of how you can do that:

Philip, one of his disciples

the disciple named Philip

6:5c

“Where can we buy bread for these people to eat?”

- “Where can we^(incl) buy bread so these people can eat?”
- “Where will we^(incl) buy enough food to feed all these people?”

“Where can we buy bread for these people to eat?”:

This question implies that Jesus wanted to get food for the crowd. He could see that they needed to eat.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

Where can we buy enough bread for all these people to eat? (NCV)

Where will we get enough food to feed all these people? (CEV)

we: This pronoun is inclusive in this context. Jesus was referring to himself and the disciples.

bread: This word refers to the most common food eaten in Israel at that time. Because of that, it was sometimes used to refer to food in general. In this context the word bread can be understood as referring to food in general. The people needed something to eat, and bread was the most common food for ordinary people at that time. Most bread was made from wheat, but it could also be made from barley or other grains.

In some cultures bread is not a common or important food. If that is true in your culture, it is recommended that you translate bread with a general word for food.

John 6:6

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed

that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32-39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:5-9

This paragraph tells why there was a need for Jesus to act. Many thousands of people were hungry. To buy food for them all would have cost a lot of money. It is implied, though not stated, that Jesus and the disciples were not wealthy. They did not have large amounts of money to give away or spend.

6:6a-b

But He was asking this to test him, for He knew what He was about to do: This sentence explains why Jesus asked his question in 6:5c. He did not really want to find out where to buy bread. He knew that he would multiply what food they did have. But he did want Philip to answer the question. He wanted to see if Philip believed that he could feed them (and maybe if he sympathized with the people). He was like a teacher who asks a question to see what his students know.

The idea of Jesus not asking the question to get information is only implied. So in some languages it may be necessary to include implied information or somehow explain the logic here. For example:

He did not ask Philip that question so he would know what to do, because he already knew what he would do. Instead, he said this to test him.

Jesus knew what he would do, but he asked that so that he could test Philip and see what he would answer.

This sentence gives an explanation, so it can be considered parenthetical information. You may want to use parentheses to indicate that it is an explanation. For example:

(He said this to test Philip; actually he already knew what he would do.) (GNT)

6:6a

But He was asking this to test him,

- Jesus asked this question in order to test him/Philip
- Jesus only said this to see what Philip believed about him.

But He was asking this to test him: Jesus asked Philip the question in 6:5c to test Philip and not to get information. Because people normally ask a question to get information, in some languages you may need to indicate that this question is different. For example:

Jesus just said this to test Philip

He said this only to put Philip to the test. (NJB)

6:6b

for He knew what He was about to do.

- because he himself had already decided what he would do.
- Jesus/He already knew how he would feed the people.

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for means "because." Here it introduces the reason why Jesus did not need to get information from Philip. For example:

because (NCV)

He knew what He was about to do: John here indicated that Jesus already knew that he would do a miracle to supply bread for the crowd. He knew it before he asked Philip the question in 6:5c.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he really knew what he would do

Jesus already knew what he planned to do. (NCV)

John 6:7

Section 6:1-15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32-39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:5–9

This paragraph tells why there was a need for Jesus to act. Many thousands of people were hungry. To buy food for them all would have cost a lot of money. It is implied, though not stated, that Jesus and the disciples were not wealthy. They did not have large amounts of money to give away or spend.

6:7a

Philip answered, “Two hundred denarii would not buy enough bread

- Philip replied to him, “Even if we^(incl) had two hundred silver coins, we could not buy enough bread
- Philip answered, “Suppose that someone works for 200 days. All his wages would not be enough to buy

Philip answered: Philip replied to Jesus. Translate this speech introducer in a natural way in your language.

Two hundred denarii would not buy enough bread:

The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as Two hundred denarii. A denarius was a silver coin. It was the average day’s wage for a common worker. So the Greek expression refers to the amount of money that it took a worker more than six months to earn.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Two hundred silver coins worth of bread would not be enough (NET)

It would take more than half a year’s wages to buy enough bread (NIV)

6:7b

for each of them to have a small piece.”

- for everyone to have just a little!”
- even a little food for all these people!”

for each of them to have a small piece: This phrase means “for each person to be able to eat a small amount.” It implies that nobody would be satisfied. It may be natural to say:

for everyone to receive even a small amount

for each person to have only a little piece (NCV)

for each one to have a bite! (NIV)

General Comment on 6:7a–b

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of this verse. For example:

^{7a}Philip answered, ^{7b}“For everyone to have even a little, ^{7a}it would take more than two hundred silver coins to buy enough bread.” (GNT)

John 6:8

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people’s hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:5–9

This paragraph tells why there was a need for Jesus to act. Many thousands of people were hungry. To buy food for them all would have cost a lot of money. It is implied, though not stated, that Jesus and the disciples were not wealthy. They did not have large amounts of money to give away or spend.

6:8

One of His disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter’s brother, said to Him,

- One of Jesus’ disciples named Andrew, Simon Peter’s brother, said to Jesus,
- Simon Peter’s brother Andrew was another of Jesus’ disciples. He said to Jesus,

One of His disciples, Andrew, Simon Peter’s brother, said to Him: Andrew spoke to Jesus. See 1:40, where the disciple Andrew is first mentioned. Because Philip, mentioned in 6:5b and 6:7a, was also a disciple, it may be natural to say:

Another one of his disciples, Andrew, who was Simon Peter’s brother, said (GNT)

brother: The New Testament never states explicitly whether Andrew or Simon Peter was the older brother. See the note on 1:40a–b.

John 6:9

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:5–9

This paragraph tells why there was a need for Jesus to act. Many thousands of people were hungry. To buy food for them all would have cost a lot of money. It is implied, though not stated, that Jesus and the disciples were not wealthy. They did not have large amounts of money to give away or spend.

6:9a

“Here is a boy with five barley loaves and two small fish.

- “Here is a young boy with five barley breads/loaves and two fish.
- “A boy here has brought five pieces of barley grain bread and two little fish.

Here is a boy with five barley loaves and two small fish: The boy had bread made from barley flour. This was cheaper than wheat flour and was what poor people normally ate.

boy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as boy refers to a young male—a child or youth.

barley: This word refers to a grain used to make bread. It was like wheat, but was cheaper, so poor people usually ate barley loaves. Here are some ways to translate this word:

grain called barley

a grain like wheat that is called barley

barley grain

loaves: These loaves were probably small rounds of bread, not large loaves weighing a pound or more that people buy today. However, this was a generous amount of food for one person.

small fish: This refers to small cooked fish, probably dried or salty.

6:9b

But what difference will these make among so many?”

- But what is the use of that when there are so many people?”
- But they would be nothing for such a crowd.”

But what difference will these make among so many?: This is a rhetorical question. Andrew used it to emphasize his statement. It means “they are not nearly enough for so many people.” There are at least two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

but what good are these for so many people?
(NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

But they will certainly not be enough for all these people. (GNT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language to emphasize a statement.

John 6:10

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:10–13

This paragraph records Jesus' response to the problem. He did a miracle to provide enough food for everyone.

6:10a**“Have the people sit down,” Jesus said.**

- ¶ Jesus replied, “Tell the people to sit down.”
- ¶ Jesus told his followers to ask the people to sit down

Have the people sit down: Jesus wanted the disciples to ask or tell the people to sit down. He did not mean that they should force the people to sit, but just ask or tell them.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Please tell the people to sit down

Tell everyone to sit down (NLT)

6:10b**Now there was plenty of grass in that place,**

- There was plenty/lots of grass in the place where they were standing,
- (they were all standing in a grassy meadow/field).

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now is not a time word. It introduces some parenthetical background information that explains why the people could sit on the ground. Many English translations do not translate this word explicitly. A couple of translations put the background information in parentheses. You should introduce or indicate the following background information in a way that is natural in your language.

there was plenty of grass in that place: This is background information. It describes the place where the crowd was gathered. The ground was covered with grass, so it was a good area for sitting down.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This was a very grassy place. (NCV)

The ground was covered with grass. (CEV)

(There was a lot of grass there.) (GNT)

grass: In some languages there may not be a common word for grass. If your language is like that, use a general word for groundcover (plants that naturally covers the ground). The grass was still growing and no one had cut it. In other languages, there may be several different words referring to different kinds of grass. In that case, use a word referring to wild grass

that covers the ground and which people can sit on and be comfortable.

6:10c**so the men sat down, about five thousand of them.**

- and they sat down. There were about 5,000 men there.
- So the people sat down, and there were about 5,000 men.

so: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so means “therefore.” Here it indicates that the disciples did in fact ask the people to sit down. Some translations leave this conjunction implicit.

the men sat down, about five thousand of them: The Greek text more literally says that about five thousand (5000) men sat down. The Greek word for men is normally used for males only. See Matthew 14:21, where women and children are explicitly excluded.

General Comment on 6:10a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder or combine the information in these clauses. For example:

“Tell everyone to sit down,” Jesus said. So they all sat down on the grassy slopes. (The men alone numbered about 5,000.) (NLT)

The ground was covered with grass, and Jesus told his disciples to have everyone sit down. About five thousand men were in the crowd. (CEV)

Jesus said, “Have the people sit down.” The people had plenty of grass to sit on. (There were about 5,000 men in the crowd.) (GW)

John 6:11**Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness**

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people’s hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:10–13

This paragraph records Jesus' response to the problem. He did a miracle to provide enough food for everyone.

6:11a

Then Jesus took the loaves

- Jesus picked up the breads/loaves
- Jesus received the bread in his hands

Then Jesus took the loaves: The word took here indicates that Jesus received the bread from the boy and held it in his hand. Your readers should understand that the boy wanted to give Jesus the bread. He gave it to Jesus willingly.

6:11b

and the fish,

- Jesus also distributed the fish,
- and the fish he also shared/divided.

and the fish: There is implied information in this phrase. The phrase means that Jesus thanked God for the fish and gave it to the people as well.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

He did the same with the fish. (NCV)

He also thanked God for the fish and distributed it to the people

6:11c

gave thanks,

- and gave thanks to God.
- He said, "Thank you, Father God, for this bread/food."

gave thanks: In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly that Jesus gave thanks to God for the food. For example:

Then Jesus took the loaves of bread, thanked God for them (NCV)

Some languages may need to use direct speech instead of an expression like gave thanks. For example:

Then Jesus said to God, "Thank you for this bread."

6:11d

and distributed to those who were seated

- Then he gave it to those who had sat down,
- Jesus shared/divided the bread/food among the people who were sitting there.

and distributed to those who were seated: Jesus distributed the bread by asking the disciples to hand it out to the people who were sitting down. See Matthew 6:19. Sometimes a literal translation means that Jesus gave out the bread to everyone himself. If that is true in your language, you may need to include some implied information. For example:

he told the disciples to distribute them to those who were seated

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus...gave them to the people who were sitting there (NCV)

he passed the bread to the people (CEV)

6:11e

as much as they wanted.

- and everyone received as much food as they wanted.
- The people ate all the bread and fish that they wanted.

as much as they wanted: This phrase means that everyone ate as much bread and as much fish as they wanted. You may want to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

All the people ate as much as they wanted. (GW)

John 6:12

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:10–13

This paragraph records Jesus' response to the problem. He did a miracle to provide enough food for everyone.

6:12a**And when everyone was full,**

- After the people had eaten all they wanted,
- When they were full,

And when everyone was full: This clause refers to the people having had enough food to eat to satisfy them. There are various ways to express this. For example:

When they had all had enough to eat (NCV)

When they had eaten enough (JBP)

When the people were full (GW)

6:12b**He said to His disciples, “Gather the pieces that are left over,**

- he said to his disciples, “Pick up the leftovers.
- Jesus told his followers to collect/save the remaining food.

Gather the pieces that are left over: These could have been fragments (pieces) left in the original baskets, or pieces of food remaining in people's hands. This is not made clear. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Gather the leftover pieces of fish and bread. (NCV)

6:12c**so that nothing will be wasted.”**

- Do not waste anything.”
- He did not want them to waste any of it.

so that nothing will be wasted: This is a purpose clause. Jesus wanted the disciples to make good use of his miraculous gift. He did not want them to lose (waste) any of the food.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

let us not waste a bit (GNT)

so that nothing may be lost (NRSV)

John 6:13**Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness**

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:10–13

This paragraph records Jesus' response to the problem. He did a miracle to provide enough food for everyone.

6:13a**So they collected them**

- So the disciples collected the leftover food.
- Then his/Jesus' followers picked up the remaining food.

So they collected them: The disciples did what Jesus told them to do (6:12b) and collected the leftover food (food that remained after everyone ate). They did this so that people or animals could eat it later. In this way the food was not lost or wasted. Here is another way to translate this clause:

So they picked up the pieces (NLT)

6:13b**and filled twelve baskets**

- They filled twelve baskets
- They put into twelve baskets, until there was no room for any more,

6:13c**with the pieces of the five barley loaves left over by those who had eaten.**

- with the pieces of the five barley breads/loaves that were left from the people's meal
- the bread remaining from the five barley breads that the disciples divided among the people to eat.

6:13b–c

and filled twelve baskets with the pieces of the five barley loaves left over by those who had eaten: The disciples put the leftover (remaining) bread in baskets.

The fish is not mentioned. These leftovers filled twelve (12) baskets.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and filled twelve baskets with the pieces of the five barley loaves that were left uneaten (REB)

and filled twelve baskets with scraps left by the people who had eaten from the five barley loaves (NLT)

baskets: These baskets were containers made from grass or reeds woven together. We do not know how big they were. Use a general term for a basket used for carrying grain or bread. The same Greek word is used in Matthew 14:20, Mark 6:43, and Mark 8:19.

General Comment on 6:13a–c

Some translations move the statement about filling the twelve baskets to the end of the sentence. For example:

^{13a}So they gathered them up, ^{13c}and from the fragments of the five barley loaves, left by those who had eaten, ^{13b}they filled twelve baskets (NRSV)

Another way to translate 6:13a–c is to combine the information:

^{13a–c}They took the leftover pieces of bread and put them into baskets. In this way they filled twelve baskets.

John 6:14

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people's hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:14–15

This paragraph tells how people reacted after Jesus did the miracle to feed them.

6:14a

When the people saw the sign that Jesus had performed, they began to say,

- ¶ When the people saw that Jesus had done a/this miracle, they started to say/comment,
- ¶ The people there saw what an amazing thing Jesus had done. So they said to one another,

When the people saw the sign that Jesus had performed, they began to say: The people reacted when and because they saw the miracle. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

Having seen the sign that Jesus had done, the people began to say....

The people saw the sign that Jesus did. So/Then they began to say....

sign: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sign refers to a miracle that has a special meaning. In this context the miracle that Jesus did revealed his greatness. See how you translated this word in 2:11. Also see KBT Miracle, Sign, Wonder, Mighty Work A.1.

Here are other ways to translate sign:

a great deed that reveals

a powerful work that teaches

a miracle that tells something

6:14b

“Truly this is the Prophet who is to come into the world.”

- “This is really the prophet who was to come into the world.”
- “Jesus must be the prophet whom we have expected to come into the world.”

Truly this is the Prophet who is to come into the world:

The people spoke of a specific prophet—the Prophet. This was the prophet that the Jewish scriptures (our Old Testament) said that God would send to his people. Over a thousand years before, the prophet Moses said that this prophet, a prophet like himself, would come. See Deuteronomy 18:15, 18. The people had earlier wondered if John the Baptist was this

prophet. See John 1:21. They were now saying that Jesus was the Prophet.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This is indeed the prophet who is to come into the world. (NRSV)

Surely, he is the Prophet we have been expecting! (NLT)

He must truly be the Prophet who is coming into the world. (NCV)

Truly: This word means “surely” or “indeed.” See translation examples using those words in the previous note.

who is to come: In your translation, make sure that your choice of verb and tense for who is to come is natural. The speakers and their ancestors had been waiting for the prophet to come. Now (when they said this) they believed that he had arrived. They no longer had to wait. See the above notes for examples.

John 6:15

Section 6:1–15: Jesus fed over 5000 people in the wilderness

In this section Jesus did a great miracle. He fed thousands of people with just a small amount of food. He showed that he could create material substances, just as God did when he created the world. He also showed that he cared about people’s hunger and could provide food for them. See also Matthew 15:32–39.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus provided food for a big crowd

Jesus did a miracle to increase some bread and fish

Paragraph 6:14–15

This paragraph tells how people reacted after Jesus did the miracle to feed them.

6:15a

Then Jesus, realizing that they were about to come and make Him king by force,

- Jesus knew that they wanted to come and grab him to make him their king.
- Because Jesus knew that they would come and seize him to make him their king,

Then Jesus, realizing that they were about to come and make Him king by force: The text does not say how Jesus realized this. Perhaps he heard them talking to one another, or perhaps God revealed it to him. You should not make this explicit.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Jesus realized that the people were about to come and force him to become their king. So he left and went to the mountain alone.

Jesus realized that they would try to force him to be their king. So he went up on a mountain, where he could be alone. (CEV)

make Him king by force: The people wanted to grab Jesus physically to force him to be their king. They apparently hoped that they could make Jesus become their military commander. They had seen his supernatural (not human) power in his miracle. So they thought that he could use that power to remove the Roman rulers from their land.

king: A king was the political leader or ruler of a nation. In the Jewish context, the king was also the top military commander. In your translation, use a word that implies or allows for the fact that this ruler was the chief commander of the army.

6:15b

withdrew again to a mountain by Himself.

- So he went away once more to the hills by himself.
- he left and returned alone to the hill/mountain area.

withdrew again to a mountain by Himself: This clause tells what Jesus did as a result of what he knew. He withdrew (went away) from the people and went to the mountain. See the General Comment on 6:15a–b. Some English translations include the word “So” in this clause to indicate this result. For example:

so he left and went into the hills alone (NCV)

So he went up on a mountain, where he could be alone. (CEV)

Jesus returned to the mountain that was mentioned in 6:3. At that previous time he had been with his disciples. Now he was by Himself (alone). Translate this clause in a way that avoids implying that Jesus had been alone the previous time. The NCV and CEV

(above) avoid this by leaving the word again untranslated. Here is another example:

So he returned to the mountain by himself. (GW)

withdrew: There is a textual problem here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts say “withdrew, went away.” For example:

left (NCV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “fled (ran away).” For example:

fled (NJB) (NJB)

The NLT (“slipped away”) is ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations. The UBS Greek New Testament gives option (1) a B rating, indicating that this is the probable text but there is some doubt.

a mountain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as mountain here refers to a hill or an area with many hills. It did not refer to a high mountain here. See the note on 6:3. Use the same word in both verses.

General Comment on 6:15a–b

The Greek text here implies that Jesus’ action in 6:15b was the result of what he realized in 6:15a. The BSB strongly implies this idea. Other translations make it more explicit. For example:

Jesus knew that they were about to come and seize him in order to make him king by force, so he went off again to the hills by himself. (GNT)

John 6:16

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph sets the scene for Jesus’ miracle of walking on the water.

6:16

When evening came, His disciples went down to the sea,

- ¶ Toward night, Jesus’ disciples went down to the lake,
- ¶ After it started to get dark, Jesus’ followers walked to the lake of Galilee.

When evening came: This refers to the late afternoon, before it got completely dark. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

That evening (CEV)

In the evening (NCV)

Late in the day

His disciples went down to the sea: The Sea of Galilee is fresh water. So it may be natural to refer to it as a lake, and to name the lake. For example:

his disciples went down to Lake Galilee

Also, in many languages it may be natural to refer explicitly to Jesus. For example:

Jesus’ disciples went down to the lake. (GNT)

John 6:17

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph sets the scene for Jesus’ miracle of walking on the water.

6:17a

got into a boat, and started across the sea to Capernaum.

- climbed into a boat, and set out across the lake to Capernaum.
- There they entered a fishing boat and began to cross the lake, heading/sailing toward the town of Capernaum.

a boat: In the context, the term boat refers to a fishing boat with wooden oars and a square sail. It was likely twenty (20) to thirty (30) feet long and made of oak and/or cedar wood.

started across the sea to Capernaum: Again, the word sea refers to Lake Galilee. The disciples intended to cross the lake and began to do so.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

set off by boat to cross to Capernaum (REB)

began to cross the lake toward Capernaum

6:17b

It was already dark,

- By this time it was dark/night,
- Darkness/Night had already arrived,

6:17c

and Jesus had not yet gone out to them.

- and Jesus had not joined them yet.
- but Jesus had not yet met them.

6:17b–c

It was already dark, and Jesus had not yet gone out to them: This comment by the author indicates that the disciples were alone in the boat. Some commentaries say that this implies that the disciples expected Jesus to join them in the boat before they left. Other commentaries say that this just means that Jesus had not yet walked on water to them. So we do not really know what the implication is. If possible, leave any implication of this clause ambiguous.

John 6:18

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:16–18

This paragraph sets the scene for Jesus' miracle of walking on the water.

6:18

A strong wind was blowing, and the sea grew agitated.

- The waves became high because there was lots of wind.
- A strong wind blew and caused the sea to get rough.

A strong wind was blowing, and the sea grew agitated: The BSB translates the result (rough sea) before the cause (strong wind). In some languages it may be natural to translate the cause before the result. For example:

a strong wind was blowing and the sea grew rough (REB)

By then a strong wind was blowing and stirring up the water (GNT)

It was very windy and so there were high/big waves on the lake.

A strong wind was blowing: This clause tells why the sea became rough. The wind created waves on the lake.

the sea grew agitated: This clause indicates that the surface of the lake became very disturbed or rough. Big waves appeared, making it difficult for the disciples to sail the boat.

John 6:19

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph Jesus showed his authority over the natural world. He was able to do what no mere human can do, walk on the surface of water.

6:19a

When they had rowed about three or four miles,

- ¶ After they had traveled about five or six kilometers on the water,
- ¶ After the disciples took the boat five or six kilometers,

When they had rowed about three or four miles: It is also possible to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Jesus' disciples rowed for three or four miles.

rowed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as rowed means to “cause an object to move by a strong force.” In this context it refers to pushing the boat through the water with wooden oars/paddles. Use the expression that is most natural in your language.

about three or four miles: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as about three or four miles is more literally “twenty-five (25) or thirty (30) stadia.” Here is another way to translate this phrase:

five or six kilometers

6:19b

they saw Jesus approaching the boat, walking on the sea—

- they saw Jesus walking on the water, approaching their boat.
- they noticed the figure of Jesus coming toward them. He was walking on top of the lake/water,

they saw Jesus approaching the boat, walking on the sea: It may be natural to translate this clause as two sentences. For example:

they saw Jesus walking on the sea. He was coming near the boat. (GW)

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the two actions that they saw. For example:

They saw Jesus approaching the boat, walking on the water of the lake.

The disciples saw a person without recognizing that it was Jesus. In some languages a literal translation

may indicate that they recognized it was Jesus. It may be natural to say instead:

They saw the figure of Jesus walking on the sea and approaching their boat.

They saw someone walking on the sea and approaching the boat. It was actually Jesus.

walking on the sea: Jesus was walking on the surface of the lake water. For example:

walking over the sea/lake

walking on the surface/top of the lake

walking on the water (NCV)

6:19c

and they were terrified.

- They were afraid.
- and they were afraid of him.

and they were terrified: John records that the disciples were terrified (afraid) without giving a reason. Mark 9:49 explains that the disciples were afraid because they thought that they were seeing a ghost or spirit. If you must indicate what caused their fear, here you should supply a general reason. For example:

they were terrified at the sight

this frightened them greatly

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they became terrified (GW)

they were frightened (NET)

John 6:20

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph Jesus showed his authority over the natural world. He was able to do what no mere human can do, walk on the surface of water.

6:20

But Jesus spoke up: “It is I; do not be afraid.”

- But he said to them, “It is I, Jesus. Do not fear.”
- But Jesus encouraged/calmed them by telling them who he was.

It is I; do not be afraid: Jesus reassured the disciples by telling them who he was. It may be natural to make that more explicit. For example:

I am Jesus! Don’t be afraid! (CEV)

John 6:21

Section 6:16–21: Jesus walked on the water of Lake Galilee

In this brief section the disciples saw Jesus walking on the surface of Lake Galilee. See the parallel passages in Matthew 14:22–27 and Mark 6:45–52.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus walked on water

Jesus walked to his disciples on the water

Paragraph 6:19–21

In this paragraph Jesus showed his authority over the natural world. He was able to do what no mere human can do, walk on the surface of water.

6:21a

Then they were willing to take Him into the boat,

- After that they let him come into the boat,
- Then they told him, “Come/Climb into the boat.”

Then they were willing to take Him into the boat:

The BSB follows the Greek and is not clear about whether Jesus actually got into the boat. The disciples were certainly willing to help him climb into the boat, and the whole verse implies that this happened. So it may be natural to follow those English translations that indicate that Jesus did enter the boat. (However, do not imply that the disciples rescued Jesus.) For example:

Then they willingly took him into the boat. (GNT)

They welcomed him onto the boat. (NLT)

So they gladly took him on board. (JBP)

6:21b

and at once the boat reached the shore where they were heading.

- and suddenly the boat arrived on the shore that they were moving toward.
- He did so and at once they arrived at the place where they wanted to go.

and at once the boat reached the shore where they were heading: This also was a miracle. The boat reached the shore at once, at the right place.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

immediately the boat reached the place they were heading for (GNT)

At once the boat came to land at the place where they wanted to go. (NCV)

John 6:22

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:22–24

This paragraph explains that the people were confused about where Jesus had gone. He had not gone in the disciples’ boat, and yet he was not still with them.

These verses, especially 6:22, may be difficult to translate. 6:22 implies the people saw something that was in the past. Also, in the Greek text, 6:22 is one long sentence. It may be more natural to break it into two or more sentences, as the NRSV does. See another example in the General Comment on 6:22a–c.

6:22a

The next day, the crowd that had remained on the other side of the sea realized that only one boat had been there,

- ¶ The following day the large group of people that had remained on the opposite shore of the lake realized that only one boat had been there.
- ¶ The following day the crowd whom Jesus had fed were still on the lake shore. They said, “There was only one boat here.

the crowd that had remained on the other side of the sea: The crowd had not entered the boats and followed Jesus and the disciples across the lake. They remained where they were. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete sentence:

The crowd had remained where they were, on the opposite side of the lake.

realized that only one boat had been there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as realized here means “recognized” or “understood.” There were two things that the people understood, explained here and in 6:22b. Here, the people remembered what they saw the day before, and realized what it meant.

Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

Next day the crowd which had stayed on the other side of the lake realized that there had been only one boat there. (GNT)

they remembered that just one boat had been there the previous night

The people who had stayed on the east side of the lake knew that only one boat had been there. (CEV)

only one boat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as boat is more literally “small-boat.” It refers to the same boat that was mentioned in 6:17 and the rest of the story. Because of that, most English translations use the same word here as before.

6:22b

and that Jesus had not boarded it with His disciples,

- They knew that Jesus had not gone in the boat with his disciples,
- Jesus did not cross the lake with his disciples in that boat.

and that Jesus had not boarded it with His disciples:

This clause explains the second thing that the people understood. The first thing, that there was only one boat earlier, was explained in 6:22a.

6:22c

but they had gone away alone.

- but the disciples had gone away without Jesus.
- They left without him. So where is he?”

but they had gone away alone: The word alone here means “without Jesus.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The disciples had gone away without him. (GW)

they had left without him (NCV)

General Comment on 6:22a–c

There are several ways to make this verse easier to understand. Consider what example may be best to follow in your language:

The next day the crowd that had stayed on the far shore saw that the disciples had taken the only boat, and they realized Jesus had not gone with them. (NLT)

The next day the people who had stayed on the other side of the lake knew that Jesus had not gone in the boat with his followers but that they had left without him. And they knew that only one boat had been there. (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate what the people realized/thought as direct speech. For example:

The following day the crowd was still on the same side of the lake. They said to one another, “There was only one boat here. Jesus did not get into that boat—his disciples left without him. Where is he?”

John 6:23

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:22–24

This paragraph explains that the people were confused about where Jesus had gone. He had not gone in the disciples’ boat, and yet he was not still with them.

These verses, especially 6:22, may be difficult to translate. 6:22 implies the people saw something that was in the past. Also, in the Greek text, 6:22 is one long sentence. It may be more natural to break it into two or more sentences, as the NRSV does. See another example in the General Comment on 6:22a–c.

6:23a–b

This verse is parenthetical. It serves to explain how the people got to the other side of the lake in 6:24b. You may want to indicate that this verse is parenthetical or contains background information. If so, indicate that in a way that is natural in your language.

6:23a**However, some boats from Tiberias landed near the place**

- Some other boats from Tiberias landed near the place
- Other boats from the town called Tiberias arrived there, near

However, some boats from Tiberias landed near the place: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the word “other” instead of However. For example:

Other boats, which were from Tiberias, came to shore near the place (GNT) (ESV, GNT, NASB, GW)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have the word However. For example:

But some boats from Tiberias came to shore near the place (NET) (BSB, NET, NCV, REB, RSV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have both “but” (or “however”) and “other.” For example:

Other boats, however, had put in from Tiberias, near the place (NJB) (NJB, KJV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have the word Then. For example:

Then some boats from Tiberias landed near the place (NIV) (NRSV, NIV)

It is recommended that you follow alternative (1). It has early manuscript support and makes the most sense in the context. Because the BSB does not follow that alternative, GNT will be supplied as a Source Line in the Display.

Here are other ways you can translate this clause:

There came other small boats from Tiberias near to the place (NASB)

Other boats from Tiberias arrived near the place (GW)

some boats: This refers to fishing boats similar to the one that Jesus’ disciples had used. See the note on “a boat” at 6:17a.

Tiberias: Tiberias was a town named after the Roman emperor Tiberius. See also 6:1c. It may be helpful to say explicitly that Tiberias was a town:

other boats came from the town of/called Tiberias

6:23b**where the people had eaten the bread after the Lord had given thanks.**

- where the people had eaten the bread/food after the Lord had thanked God the Father for it.
- where the Lord Jesus thanked God for the food and the people ate it.

where the people had eaten the bread after the Lord had given thanks: This comment refers back to 6:10–11. The people were still at that place.

The clause after the Lord had given thanks connects to the previous clause, about the people eating the bread. It does not connect to the clause about the boats coming. The people ate the bread after the Lord gave thanks. In some languages it may be natural to translate the two events (giving thanks and eating) in chronological order. For example:

where the Lord gave thanks for the bread and the people ate it

where the Lord had blessed the bread and the people had eaten (NLT)

There is a textual problem here:

1. Most Greek manuscripts include the clause after the Lord had given thanks, and most English translations include it. For example:

near the place where the people had eaten the bread after the Lord had given thanks (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the clause after the Lord had given thanks, and a few English translations do not include it. However, they include a footnote with the missing clause. For example:

near the place where the bread had been eaten
(NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow (1) and include the clause along with nearly all English translations.

John 6:24

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:22–24

This paragraph explains that the people were confused about where Jesus had gone. He had not gone in the disciples’ boat, and yet he was not still with them.

These verses, especially 6:22, may be difficult to translate. 6:22 implies the people saw something that was in the past. Also, in the Greek text, 6:22 is one long sentence. It may be more natural to break it into two or more sentences, as the NRSV does. See another example in the General Comment on 6:22a–c.

6:24a

So when the crowd saw that neither Jesus nor His disciples were there,

- Seeing/Realizing that Jesus and his disciples had all left,
- The people understood that both Jesus and his followers had left that place. So

So when the crowd saw that neither Jesus nor His disciples were there: This verse tells the result of what the people realized in verse 22. The result is indicated by the word So. The people realized (6:22a) that neither Jesus nor his disciples had remained in that place. The Greek word that the BSB translates as saw is the same word that was used in verse 22. Again it means “realized” or “understood.”

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

So when the many people understood that Jesus was not there, nor his disciples

So when the crowd realized that neither Jesus nor his disciples were there (NET)

6:24b

they got into the boats and went to Capernaum to look for Him.

- the crowd got into the boats and went to the town of Capernaum to search for Jesus.
- they crossed the lake in these boats to the town of Capernaum in order to find Jesus.

they got into the boats and went to Capernaum to look for Him: The people in the crowd entered the fishing boats from Tiberias. The word they probably does not refer to every person from the crowd, but to many of them. Perhaps it refers to all that the boats could hold.

the boats: This phrase refers to the “boats from Tiberias” mentioned in 6:23a. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

those boats (GNT)

went to Capernaum: This involved a journey by boat, which means that the people sailed or rowed [pulled long wooden oars/paddles in the water to push the boat forward]. So it may be natural to say:

sailed/rowed to Capernaum

John 6:25

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:25–27

These verses form the beginning of Jesus’ teaching about the bread of life.

6:25a

When they found Him on the other side of the sea,

- They found him/Jesus on the other side of the lake,
- There they saw him

When they found Him on the other side of the sea:

This clause indicates that the people arrived on the opposite shore and looked for Jesus. They saw him there. In many languages it will be natural to make it explicit that it was Jesus whom the people found. For example:

When the people found Jesus on the other side of the lake (GNT)

they found Him: Jesus was not lost, but the people did not know where he was. Use an expression that is suitable in your language. For example:

they learned the place where he was

And when they arrived on the other side of the lake, they saw him

It is implied that the people went to the place where Jesus was. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

they found where Jesus was and went to him

the other side of the sea: This phrase here refers to the area where Capernaum was, northwest of the Sea of Galilee. It is not the same as “the other side of the sea” in 6:22a. So it may be helpful to make it clear which side is referred to. For example:

the west side of the lake (CEV)

6:25b
they asked Him, “Rabbi, when did You get here?”

- and the people asked Jesus, “Teacher, when did you^(sing) arrive here?”
- and asked him, “Teacher! When did you^(sing) reach/arrive here?”

they asked Him, “Rabbi, when did You get here?”: This is a real question. It expresses surprise as well as asking for information. The people were surprised to see Jesus because they knew that Jesus did not get in the boat with his disciples. So they did not expect to see him there. They surely wanted to know how Jesus got there, but they did not ask that. Instead, they asked him when he got there.

You may want to indicate some surprise in your translation. But we do not know that they thought a miracle had happened. They probably thought that he had walked around the lake. Here are other ways to translate this question:

and asked, “Rabbi, when did you get here?” (NLT)

“Teacher! When did you arrive?” they asked Jesus.

Rabbi: Rabbi means “teacher” or “my great one.” See how you translated it in 1:38.

John 6:26

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:25–27

These verses form the beginning of Jesus’ teaching about the bread of life.

6:26a

Jesus replied, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- Jesus replied to them, “What I tell you is true:
- Jesus told them, “Listen to these true words.

6:26b

it is not because you saw these signs that you are looking for Me,

- You^(plur) are seeking me, not because you^(plur) saw signs which show you who I am,
- You^(plur) are not looking for me because you recognize who I am from the signs/miracles I did.

6:26c

but because you ate the loaves and had your fill.

- but because you^(plur) ate the bread and were full/satisfied.
- No, you are looking for me because you ate all that you wanted of the food that I provided.

6:26a–c

Truly, truly, I tell you, it is not because you saw these signs that you are looking for Me, but because you ate the loaves and had your fill: Jesus was rebuking the people for thinking that food was more important than spiritual things. They were more interested in getting food than in understanding the meaning and importance of Jesus’ miracle/sign. In your translation, try to imply that Jesus was rebuking the people.

Here are other translation examples:

I tell you the truth, you aren’t looking for me because you saw me do miracles. You are looking for me because you ate the bread and are satisfied. (NCV)

Believe me...you are looking for me now not because you saw my signs but because you ate that food and had all you wanted. (JBP)

This sentence is a comment about the reasons for people's actions. In some languages it may be natural to state the reasons that people had before stating the reasons that they did not have. For example:

I am telling you the truth: you are looking for me because you ate the bread and had all you wanted, not because you understood my miracles. (GNT)

In some languages you may need to put the cause of an action before the action itself. For example:

The truth is that you ate all the bread that you wanted, so now you are looking for me. You are not looking for me because you saw the signs that I did.

Consider how speakers of your language talk about reasons for doing something. It may be natural to include a rhetorical question. For example:

So why were you looking for me? It was not because you saw signs. It was because you ate as much bread as you wanted!

Truly, truly, I tell you: This phrase emphasizes what Jesus was about to say. See the notes on 1:51a, where the same phrase is used.

you ate the loaves and had your fill: This clause means that the people had as much bread to eat as they wanted. See 6:11e and 6:12a.

John 6:27

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:25–27

These verses form the beginning of Jesus' teaching about the bread of life.

6:27a

Do not work for food that perishes,

- Do not work^(plur) to get food that will go bad,
- You should not be devoting your energies to getting ordinary food, because it does not last.

Do not work for food that perishes: This expression means “Do not work to get food that will spoil.” This

is a command. It sounds like Jesus said that people should never work for food, but it is a figure of speech, a hyperbole. Jesus knew that most people must work to earn money to buy food. He was not telling people not to work. He was telling them to spend their lives wisely, working hard to get what is truly valuable.

In some languages a literal translation of Do not work may communicate that people should not work for wages. If your language is like that, you may need to follow one of these examples:

Do not work hard only for the food that does not last.

Do not concentrate your thoughts on food that spoils, but rather on the food that lasts

Jesus was saying that people should not spend all their time and energy to get ordinary food. They should not make food (and other material things, which become ruined) their main goal in life.

food that perishes: This clause refers to the fact that after a few days most ordinary food becomes dry or moldy. When that happens, people cannot safely eat it. This was especially true in Jesus' time, when there was no way to keep food cold. But Jesus was referring to all types of food, even food like flour that lasts or keeps a long time. Here are some other ways to say this:

food that spoils (GNT)

food that does not last/endure

In some languages it may be necessary to translate this as a separate clause. For example:

Do not work to get physical/material food. It will be spoiled/ruined!

6:27b

but for food that endures to eternal life,

- but work for the food that gives you^(plur) eternal life,
- Instead, work for the food that does last and leads to spiritual life that never ends.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement in 6:27a to the positive statement in 6:27b. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. In 6:27a, Jesus said what the people should not do, and in 6:27b, he said

what they should do. They should not work for food that spoils. Instead, they should work for food that endures. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction *but* as in the BSB. For example:

You should work, not for this perishable food, but for the food that lasts, the food of eternal life. (REB)

Do not look for the food that quickly spoils, but rather work hard so that you might get the food which gives eternal life.

- Use a conjunction other than *but*. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Do not work for food that goes bad; instead, work for the food that lasts for eternal life. (GNT)

Don't work for food that spoils. Instead, work for the food that lasts into eternal life. (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Don't work for the food that spoils. Work for the food that stays good always and gives eternal life. (NCV)

don't be so concerned about perishable things like food. Spend your energy seeking the eternal life (NLT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

You should work to obtain the food that endures for eternal life, not for the food that spoils.

Work for what lasts and what leads to life that never ends. Do not use all your efforts to get food that will spoil.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

for food that endures to eternal life: Jesus was referring to spiritual food. This food endures or remains and gives eternal life. It will never spoil and the life it

gives will last forever. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Work for food that gives eternal life. (CEV)

eternal life: The word *eternal* refers to something that does not end. The phrase *eternal life* refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

6:27c

which the Son of Man will give you.

- the food which the Son of Man will give you^(plur).
- I, the Son of Man, will give you that food.

which the Son of Man will give you: Jesus was talking about himself. He, the Son of Man, will give the food that endures. So it may be natural to say:

which I, the Son of Man, will give you

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some possible translations:

the Human-born

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Humanity/Humans

Translate this title as you did in other verses, for example, in 1:51; 3:13, 14. See also KBT, Son of Man.

6:27d

For on Him God the Father has placed His seal of approval.”

- God the Father has set the seal of his approval on him/me.”
- You can know that because God the Father has shown that he approves of me.”

For on Him God the Father has placed His seal of approval: This is a metaphor. The Greek word that the BSB translates as placed His seal of approval can mean “to put a seal on a document to show one’s approval.” Here, it means that God the Father has shown his approval of Jesus. Jesus did not say how the Father showed his approval.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. People may not understand that it is a figure of speech. Here are other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It is as though God the Father has set his seal on him/me.

- Keep the figure of speech (either as metaphor or simile) and make its meaning explicit. For example:

For God the Father has given me the seal of his approval. (NLT)

- Translate the meaning without a figure of speech. For example:

because my Father God has shown that he approves of me

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For means “because” and here introduces an explanation. Jesus, the Son of Man, will be the one to give food that endures for eternal life because he is the one whom the Father approves of. Some translations leave this word implicit. Here is another way to translate this word:

because

John 6:28**Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life**

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people

must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:28–31

In the previous paragraph Jesus claimed that God approved of him. Now the people who were listening asked Jesus what they could do to do the works of God. Jesus told them to believe in him. The people then asked what miraculous sign he would show them.

6:28

Then they inquired, “What must we do to perform the works of God?”

- ¶ So the people asked Jesus, “What does God want us^(excl) to do?”
- ¶ Then the people asked Jesus, “What deeds should we do so that God will accept us?”

Then: This new paragraph connects to the previous paragraph with a conjunction that indicates a result. It is often translated as “therefore.” The BSB translates it as Then. The question that follows was a response to what Jesus had just said.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

So (GNT)

Therefore (NASB)

they inquired: The quotation that follows is a question. So it may be natural to indicate that here. For example:

they asked him (GNT)

If you started a new paragraph here, it may be natural to make it explicit that they refers to the people. For example:

the people asked

What must we do to perform the works of God?: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated literally as perform the works of God here refers to doing what pleases God.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

What can we do in order to do what God wants us to do? (GNT)

What are the things God wants us to do? (NCV)

We want to perform God's works too. What should we do? (NLT)

What exactly does God want us to do? (CEV)

we: The pronoun we is exclusive in this context. It does not include Jesus. The speakers understood that God already approved of him (6:27d).

perform: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perform means "to work" or "to do."

the works of God: This phrase refers to the deeds that God wants people to do (not to the deeds that God does). In some languages it may be necessary to translate this noun phrase using a verb phrase. For example:

what God wants us to do (GNT)

John 6:29

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself "the bread of life" and said that people must "eat" his flesh and "drink" his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:28–31

In the previous paragraph Jesus claimed that God approved of him. Now the people who were listening asked Jesus what they could do to do the works of God. Jesus told them to believe in him. The people then asked what miraculous sign he would show them.

6:29

Jesus replied, "The work of God is this: to believe in the One He has sent."

- Jesus replied to them, "What God wants you^(plur) to do is to believe in the one/man he sent."
- Jesus replied, "The deed that pleases God is to trust me, because I am the one God sent to you."

The work of God is this: to believe in the One He has sent: The word work is in the singular, although the question in 6:28 used the plural, "works." Jesus was saying that there is only one thing that God wants people to do.

Here are other ways to translate what Jesus said:

The work God wants you to do is this: Believe the One he sent (NCV)

What God wants you to do is to believe in the one he sent (GNT)

This is the only work God wants from you. Believe in the one he has sent. (NLT)

believe in: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this phrase in 1:12. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

have faith in (CEV)

trust in

the One He has sent: This clause refers to Jesus himself. It explains why believing in him is the work of God. God had sent him, so they should believe in him. In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly that this is the reason that this is the work of God. For example:

because God has sent him

It is apparent from the question that follows in 6:30 that his listeners understood that Jesus was referring to himself. If your readers may not understand this, you may need to say explicitly:

me whom he has sent

John 6:30

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself "the bread of life" and said that people must "eat" his flesh and "drink" his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:28–31

In the previous paragraph Jesus claimed that God approved of him. Now the people who were listening asked Jesus what they could do to do the works of God. Jesus told them to believe in him. The people then asked what miraculous sign he would show them.

6:30a

So they asked Him, “What sign then will You perform,

- Then the people asked him, “What miracle will you do that will show us^(excl) who you are,
- Then the people said to him, “Do another miracle to show us^(excl) that God has sent you.

6:30b

so that we may see it and believe You?

- so we^(excl) will believe you because we saw the miracle?
- Do that so we^(excl) will see the miracle and we will believe you^(sing).

6:30a–b

So they asked Him: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces a result. Here, the result is the people’s response to what Jesus had just said. Some English translations do not translate this word. Do what is natural in your language to introduce a result or a response.

What sign then will You perform, so that we may see it and believe You?: This is a rhetorical question. The people used it to challenge Jesus. The people challenged him to show them a miracle. They had just seen the miracle of feeding the five thousand (5000), but they wanted to see a different miracle. Or possibly they were hungry again and just hoped that Jesus would provide another meal.

There are at least two ways to translate this challenge:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What miracle will you perform so that we may see it and believe you? (GNT)

- Use a statement. Make it clear that the purpose of the sign was that the people would believe. For example:

Give us^(excl) a sign so that we will believe you^(sing).

Show us a sign so that we can believe you.

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is more literally “therefore.” It introduces what the people thought Jesus should do if he wanted them to believe on him. Some English translations do not explicitly translate this word. If it is more natural in your language, you may leave it implicit, or you may use another word. For example:

So

so that we may see it and believe You?: The phrase so that in this context introduces the purpose of doing a miracle.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

so that when we see it, we can believe you

believe You: Here the phrase is not “believe in you” as was the idea in 6:29. Although Jesus spoke about believing in him, the people just spoke about believing him (what he said). Perhaps they did not understand that God wanted them to trust in Jesus, not just believe what he said.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

believe what you say

believe that you are from God

6:30c

What will You do?

- Show^(sing) us^(excl) something more.
- Do a great deed/miracle!

What will You do?: The people were asking what new miracle Jesus would do for them. It was an unfriendly question that continued the challenge in 6:30a–b.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

What can you do? (NLT)

John 6:31**Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life**

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:28–31

In the previous paragraph Jesus claimed that God approved of him. Now the people who were listening asked Jesus what they could do to do the works of God. Jesus told them to believe in him. The people then asked what miraculous sign he would show them.

6:31a

Our fathers ate the manna in the wilderness,

- Our^(incl) ancestors ate manna while they were in the wilderness,
- Moses gave our^(incl) ancestors manna bread to eat when they were walking around in the desert.

Our fathers ate the manna in the wilderness: This clause refers to the event that Exodus 16 records. The event is that God supplied manna for the people of Israel to eat while they traveled through the wilderness.

Our fathers: The word Our includes Jesus and those speaking to him, so it is an inclusive pronoun. The word translated literally as fathers includes both men and women. These ancestors lived almost 1500 years earlier.

ate the manna: The Hebrews ate this manna for forty (40) years. Use a verb tense that indicates that this was a regular event that took place for a long time. See Exodus 16:35.

the manna: The word manna is a Hebrew word that means “what is it?” Manna was a white substance that God provided for the Israelites to eat in the wilderness. It appeared on the ground every morning except the Sabbath. It tasted like biscuits or crackers with honey and was used to make bread. See Exodus 16:31 and Numbers 11:8.

Bible translations usually transliterate (copy the sounds of) the word manna. You may also want to include some description. For example:

food called manna

manna, the food that God provided

6:31b

as it is written: ‘He gave them bread from heaven to eat.’”

- as the Scriptures say, ‘He gave them bread that came from heaven to eat.’”
- Moses wrote in God’s book that he fed them with bread/food from heaven.”

as it is written: This phrase indicates that the following words are from the Jewish Scriptures, what Christians call the Old Testament. This quotation is from the Psalms (Psalm 78:24, 105:40).

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

This is written in the Scriptures. (NCV)

It happened just as the Scriptures say (CEV)

He gave them bread from heaven to eat: It is not clear in this verse whether the pronoun He refers to Moses or to God. In Psalm 78:24 it is clear that the one who gave them bread was God. John 6:32b, however, strongly implies that the people thought that Moses was the one who gave the bread. It is recommended that you translate using a pronoun that can refer either to Moses or to God.

bread: In biblical times, bread was the most important food that people ate. The word bread was sometimes used to refer to food in general. However, in many language areas, bread is not that important. If bread is not important in your language area, you may want to use a more general word. For example:

He fed them food which came from heaven.

heaven: This word refers to the place where God lives. See Matthew 5:16, and KBT Heaven, Sky A2.

John 6:32

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:32–34

Jesus began to tell the people about spiritual food. But the people were still thinking about Jesus feeding the five thousand (5000). They thought that Jesus had some special bread that he could give them.

6:32a

Jesus said to them, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- ¶ Jesus told them, “I tell you^(plur) the truth,
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “I tell you^(plur) for certain that

The Greek text begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “therefore.” The BSB and many English translations do not explicitly translate the word. In this context, the conjunction introduces Jesus’ response to the people’s comment. Translate it using a natural way to introduce a response in your language.

Truly, truly, I tell you: This phrase emphasizes what Jesus was about to say. See the notes on 1:51a, where the same phrase is used. Notice, however, that here Jesus was introducing a correction or rebuke. He was rejecting his listeners’ wrong understanding of how their ancestors received manna.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I tell you for certain that... (CEV)

6:32b

it was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven,

- Moses did not provide you^(plur) the bread from heaven.
- it was not Moses who gave this bread/food that came from heaven.

6:32c

but it is My Father who gives you the true bread from heaven.

- But my Father God is the one who gives you the true bread from heaven.
- No/Rather, it is my Father God who provides you with true/real food from heaven.

6:32b-c

it was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven, but it is My Father who gives you the true bread from heaven: Jesus was correcting the crowd. There are several things he was correcting:

- “he” in the quotation in 6:31b does not refer to Moses. God, not Moses, was really the one who gave the bread.
- It is better to understand God giving the bread from heaven now, in the present. Jesus changes gave (31b and 32b) to gives (32c).
- The manna was not the true heavenly bread, but physical food. Jesus was talking about heavenly or spiritual food.

In your translation, try to make it clear that Jesus was not making only one correction. This is hard to do in English. Most English translations concentrate on one of the corrections. However, it may be possible to indicate that there is more than one correction by using more than one sentence. For example:

Moses didn't give you bread from heaven. My Father did. And now he offers you the true bread from heaven. (NLT)

What I tell you now is true. It was not Moses who gave food from heaven but rather my Father. And what they ate, it was not the true food from heaven that God gives to you today.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement in 6:32b to

the positive statement in 6:32c. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. In 6:32b, Jesus said that it was not Moses who gave them bread from heaven, and in 6:32c, he said that it was his Father who gives them the true bread from heaven. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB. For example:

Moses didn't give you bread from heaven, but my Father gives you the true bread from heaven. (GW)

it wasn't Moses who gave the bread from heaven to you, but my Father gives you the true bread from heaven (CEB)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Moses was not the one who gave the bread which came from heaven; rather it is my Father who gives it. He truly gives to you the bread which comes from heaven.

Moses did not give you heavenly bread. Instead, my Father is the one giving you true heavenly bread.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Moses wasn't the one who gave you bread from heaven. My Father is the one who gives you the true bread from heaven. (CEV)

What Moses gave you was not the bread from heaven; it is my Father who gives you the real bread from heaven. (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

It is God my Father who gives the true bread from heaven. You are wrong to think that it was Moses who gave you bread from heaven.

It is my Father who gives you true bread from heaven, not Moses. He did not give you bread from heaven.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

My Father: Jesus was referring to God. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

God my Father

true bread: In Greek, there is emphasis on the word true. You may also want to emphasize that word. For example:

what he gives you is true food

John 6:33

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:32–34

Jesus began to tell the people about spiritual food. But the people were still thinking about Jesus feeding the five thousand (5000). They thought that Jesus had some special bread that he could give them.

6:33a

For the bread of God is He who comes down from heaven

- The bread that God gives comes down from heaven (REB)
- That is because the food that God gives comes from heaven

6:33b

and gives life to the world.”

- giving life to the people of the world.”
- and gives true life to people/humanity.”

6:33a–b

For the bread of God is He who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as He who can also be translated as “that which.” As a result, there are two ways to interpret 6:33a–b:

1. Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

the bread that God gives is he who comes down from heaven and gives life to the world (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV84, KJV, ESV, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Jesus was referring to heavenly food in general. For example:

For the bread of God is that which comes down out of heaven, and gives life to the world. (NASB) (NASB, RSV, NRSV, NIV11)

It is recommended that you keep the reference ambiguous. That will help explain why those who heard Jesus did not understand that Jesus was referring to himself. Here is one way to keep this ambiguous:

The bread that God gives comes down from heaven and brings life to the world. (REB)

Again, if bread is not an important food in your language area, you may need to use a general word instead of bread. For example:

Because the true food that God gives, it comes from heaven and can give life to all people.

John 6:34

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:32–34

Jesus began to tell the people about spiritual food. But the people were still thinking about Jesus feeding the five thousand (5000). They thought that Jesus had some special bread that he could give them.

6:34

“Sir,” they said, “give us this bread at all times.”

- The people answered Jesus, “Sir, please give us this bread from now on.”
- “Sir, continuously provide us with this food,” the people replied.

“Sir,” they said, “give us this bread at all times.”:

This is a polite request rather than a command. So in some languages it may be natural to supply a word meaning “please.”

Sir: This is a polite term used to address an adult male. It is often translated as “Lord” when it refers to Jesus. However, it does not imply that the speakers believed that he was the Son of God. It is the same term that is used in 4:15, 19, and 5:7.

at all times: The Greek word that the BSB translates as at all times here means “all our lives” and “as often as we need it.” This word is emphasized in the Greek. Here are other ways to translate this word:

give us this bread all the time! (NET)

give us this bread and don't ever stop! (CEV)

Give us that food which you speak about, and not just today but rather every day.

John 6:35

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread that gives life.

6:35a

Jesus answered, “I am the bread of life.

- ¶ Then Jesus declared, “I am the bread that gives life.
- ¶ Jesus said, “I myself am the bread that causes you^(plur)/people to live with God forever.

I am the bread of life: Jesus described himself with a metaphor. He compared himself to bread. He was like bread because both give life. Jesus gives true, spiritual life, while bread gives us physical life.

It is necessary to keep the figure of speech here because that is what confuses the people in 6:52. However, if the meaning of this metaphor is not clear in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I am like the bread of life.

I am like bread/food that gives/brings life.

- Use a metaphor or simile and make the similarity clear. For example:

I am the bread/food that gives new/spiritual life

Like bread/food gives physical life, I give people spiritual life.

bread of life: The phrase bread of life means “bread that gives life.” Ordinary food like bread makes it possible for people's bodies to live, and Jesus makes it possible for people's spirits to live.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

bread that gives life! (CEV)

bread: Jesus used this word because bread was the main food of the Jews, so it was essential for life. That means that Jesus was saying that he was essential for spiritual life. In Jesus' time, bread was made from wheat or barley. See 6:9a.

If bread is not an important food in your language group, you may need to use a general word. For example:

food

6:35b

Whoever comes to Me will never hunger,

- No one/person who comes to me will ever be hungry.
- Those people who trust in me will never be spiritually hungry.

Whoever comes to Me will never hunger: This clause is also a metaphor because it refers to someone being hungry for spiritual things, lacking spiritual food. No one who trusts or believes in Jesus will lack spiritual food. Jesus will satisfy them. Most English translations translate this as a metaphor. For example:

No one who comes to me will ever be hungry again. (NLT)

It is also possible to translate this using a conditional clause. For example:

If someone comes to me, he will never be hungry.

If the meaning of this metaphor is not clear in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

No one who comes to me will be like a hungry person.

- Use a metaphor or simile and make the similarity clear. For example:

Whoever comes to me will never be hungry, lacking spiritual food/bread.

No one who comes to me will be like a hungry person who does not have enough spiritual food/bread.

If anyone comes to me he will not be hungry because I will always give him spiritual life.

Whoever: This refers to anyone and everyone who trusts in Jesus. So it may be natural to use the plural:

those who come to me will never be hungry

comes to Me: This refers to trusting or believing in Jesus. The parallel statement in 6:35c, “whoever believes in Me,” makes it clear what comes to Me means here.

hunger: The English word hunger describes someone who desires or needs food or another necessity. Here it also implies that the person cannot get what he needs for his spiritual life.

6:35c

and whoever believes in Me will never thirst.

- And no one/person who believes in me will ever be thirsty.
- And those people who trust in me will never be spiritually thirsty.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* here introduces a different metaphor that means the same thing as the metaphor in 6:35b.

whoever believes in Me will never thirst: Here it is implied that Jesus is “the water of life” as well as “the bread of life.” See the notes on 4:10d. Most English translations translate this as a metaphor. For example:

no one who has faith in me will ever be thirsty
(CEV)

If the meaning of this metaphor is not clear in your language, here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

No one who believes in me will be like a thirsty person.

- Use a metaphor or simile and make the similarity clear. For example:

Whoever believes in me will never be thirsty, lacking spiritual water.

No one who believes in me will be like a thirsty person who does not have enough spiritual water.

If anyone believes in me he will not be thirsty because I will always give him spiritual life.

See how you translated 6:35b and follow a similar pattern here. Also, see the General Comment on 6:35b–c for a way to combine these two clauses.

whoever: It may again be natural to use the plural:

all who believe in me will never thirst

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this phrase in 1:12 and 6:29. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

has faith in me (CEV)

trusts in me

thirst: In this context the word thirst refers to an unpleasant, even painful, desire for water when none is available. See the note on “hungry” in 6:35b.

General Comment on 6:35b–c

In some languages it may be more natural to combine these clauses. For example:

Whoever comes to me to believe, he will never be hungry or thirsty for spiritual bread/food and water.

John 6:36

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people

must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread that gives life.

6:36a–b

In this verse Jesus reminded the people of something he had said to them earlier. Perhaps Jesus was referring to what he had said in verse 26. Or perhaps he was referring to what he had said in 5:37–38. Or he might have referred to something that he had said that is not in the gospel of John. He repeated it here because what he had said earlier was still true.

Here are other ways to translate this verse:

Yet I have told you that you have seen me and do not believe. (JBP)

I have told you already that you have seen me and still do not have faith in me. (CEV)

6:36a

But as I stated, you have seen Me

- But, as I explained to you^(plur), you have seen me
- However, it is as I told you. You have seen what I have done.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between those who believe in Jesus (6:35c) and his listeners, who do not believe.

6:36b

and still you do not believe.

- and yet you^(plur) still do not accept me.
- However, even though you have seen that, you do not believe that I am the Christ/Messiah.

still: The BRB has supplied the word still. Although the people had seen Jesus and his miracles (see 6:26b), they still did not believe/trust in him. The word still helps to show that one would expect them to believe after they saw Jesus.

do not believe: Although the words “in me” are not present here as in 6:35c, they are implied. See the note there on “believes in me.” Here Jesus said that the people who were talking with him did not believe in that way. It is also implied that Jesus spoke about believing in himself. In some languages it may be more natural to make whom they did not believe in explicit.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

do not have faith in me (CEV)

do not trust in me

don’t believe in me (GW)

General Comment on 6:36a–b

In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech for quoting what Jesus had previously said. For example:

But as I told you, ‘You have seen me and yet do not believe.’

But you know what I said, ‘Although you have seen me, you still do not believe.’

General Comment on 6:36a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 6:36a and 6:36b. For example:

^{36b}But you haven’t believed in me ^{36a}even though you have seen me. (NLT)

John 6:37

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread that gives life.

6:37a

Everyone the Father gives Me will come to Me,

- All that the Father God gives me will come to me in faith
- However, the people that God gives me are those who will trust/believe me.

Everyone the Father gives Me will come to Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Everyone here refers to people as a group, to anyone and everyone. See the General Comment following 6:37b.

Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

everyone whom my Father gives me will come to me (GNT)

those the Father has given me will come to me
(NLT)

The Father gives me my people. Every one of them
will come to me. (NCV)

6:37b

and the one who comes to Me I will never drive away.

- and everyone who believes in me, I will never reject.
- And I will always accept anyone who trusts/believes in me.

and the one who comes to Me I will never drive away: This clause means that Jesus will welcome all those who come to him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The one who comes to me I will never send away.
(NET)

I will never turn away anyone who comes to me.
(GNT)

I will never drive away: This phrase means “I will never refuse to accept.” In some languages it may be more natural to translate this with a positive statement. For example:

I will always accept them (NCV)

General Comment on 6:37a–b

The phrase “Everything that” in 6:37a and the phrase “anyone who” in 6:37b refer to the same people. Make sure that this is clear in your translation. In some languages you may need to make this clear. For example:

However, those the Father has given me will come to me, and I will never reject them. (NLT)

John 6:38

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread that gives life.

6:38a

For I have come down from heaven,

- That is because I have come down from heaven
- That will happen because I came from heaven

For I have come down from heaven: In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

The reason that I say this is because I came from heaven (NET)

heaven: The word heaven refers to the place where God lives. See KBT Heaven, Sky A2 and the note on 6:31b. Jesus was implying that he came from God.

6:38b

not to do My own will, but to do the will of Him who sent Me.

- not to do what I want, but to do what the one who sent me here wants me to do.
- to obey God who sent me into the world. I did not come to do what I want to do.

not to do My own will, but to do the will of Him who sent Me: This expression tells the purpose of Jesus coming to earth. It expresses the purpose with a negative statement and then a positive statement.

not to do My own will: Jesus did not come to earth to please himself or act as he wished. In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun phrase My own will as a verb phrase. For example:

not to do what I want (JBP)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement “not to do my own will” to the positive statement “(to do) the will of him who sent me.” This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB. For example:

to do not my own will but the will of him who sent me (GNT)

not to do what I want, but to do what the one who sent me wants

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

not for the purpose of doing just my own will,
rather I came to do the will of him who sent me

it was not to do what I want. Instead, I came to
do what the one who sent me wants.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I haven't come from heaven to do what I want to
do. I've come to do what the one who sent me
wants me to do. (GW)

I have not come down from heaven to do what I
myself choose to do. No, my Father has sent me. I
have come to do what he wants me to do. (EASY)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

to do the will of God who sent me, not to do my
own will (NLT)

to do what God wants me to do, not what I want
to do (NCV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is
most natural in your language.

to do the will of Him who sent Me: This phrase tells
why Jesus came to earth. He came to please and obey
God, to do what God wanted. As with “not to do my
own will” in the previous phrase, it may be natural to
translate the noun phrase the will of Him as a verb
phrase. For example:

I have come to do what the one who sent me
wants me to do

John 6:39

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language
about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He
called himself “the bread of life” and said that people
must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words
caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread
that gives life.

6:39a

And this is the will of Him who sent Me,

- And this is what he who sent me wants me to do.
- And God who sent me wants me

And this is the will of Him who sent Me: This clause
introduces an explanation of what God the Father
wanted him to do. See how you translated “will” in
6:38b.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Here is what the One who sent me wants me to
do (NCV)

And this is the will of God (NLT)

and he wants (CEV)

6:39b

that I shall lose none of those He has given Me,

- He wants me to lose none of the people whom he
has given to me,
- to protect/save everyone whom he gave me

that I shall lose none of those He has given Me:

This clause indicates that God wanted Jesus to protect
every one of his people. Jesus pleases his Father by
protecting them all. The Greek here is more literally
“that everything that he has given me, I should not
lose it.” The word “everything” is the same word that
was used in 6:37a. Here again it refers to all people
that the Father has given to Jesus. For example:

that none of the ones he has given me will be
lost (CEV)

that I should not lose any of all those he has given
me (GNT)

I must not lose even one whom God gave me
(NCV)

lose: The Greek word that the BSB translates as lose
here refers to allowing something or someone to
perish (die forever).

Here are other ways to translate this word:

fail to save/preserve any of those he has given me

permit/allow none of those that he has given me to die

6:39c

but raise them up at the last day.

- but to raise them all up to live on the last day.
- and to give them life at the end of the world.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement in 6:39b to the positive statement in 6:39c. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB. For example:

And it is the will of him who sent me that I should not lose any of all those he has given me, but that I should raise them all to life on the last day. (GNT)

I must not lose anyone God has given me. But I must raise them up on the last day. (ERV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

and he wants to make certain that none of the ones he has given me will be lost. Instead, he wants me to raise them to life on the last day. (CEV)

The will of my Father who sent me is that I will not allow any of those that he delivered to me to be lost. Rather, I will cause them to be brought back to life on the last day.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

The one who sent me doesn't want me to lose any of those he gave me. He wants me to bring them back to life on the last day. (GW)

He does not want me to lose any of the people that he has given to me. Not even one of them. He wants me to raise all of them up to life on the last day. (EASY)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

He wants me to raise everyone whom he has given me on the last day and not lose anyone.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

raise them up at the last day: The word raise here refers to making people alive again after they died physically (see 5:28–29). Jesus will cause all his people to live again.

them: The pronoun them refers to all those whom God has given to Jesus.

the last day: This phrase refers to the end of the world and the time when Jesus will judge everyone (see Matthew 7.22, 25.31–46). But it is also the day when Jesus will raise his people, which is what Jesus was talking about here.

John 6:40

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:35–40

Jesus told the people that he himself was the bread that gives life.

6:40a

For it is My Father's will that everyone who looks to the Son

- Because my Father wants everyone who sees the Son
- Because my Father God wants everyone who looks in faith to me, his Son,

6:40b

and believes in Him shall have eternal life,

- and believes in him to have spiritual life that lasts forever.
- and believes in me/him, to live forever with God.

6:40a–b

For it is My Father's will: As in 6:38 and 6:39, it may be natural to translate the noun will as a verb. For example:

For what my Father wants is (GNT)

This is what my Father wants. (CEV)

For: This Greek conjunction that the BSB and most English translations translate literally as For means “because.” Verse 40 can be understood as a reason for verse 39. You should introduce this clause in a way that is natural in your language.

that everyone who looks to the Son and believes in Him shall have eternal life: The phrase the Son refers to Jesus himself, the speaker. You may want to make that clearer in your translation. For example:

that all who see me, the Son, and believe in me
may have eternal life

that all who believe when they see me, the Son,
may have eternal life

looks to the Son and believes in Him: In this context the phrase looks to the Son means to turn to or come to the Son in faith. See 6:35b, where “comes” is used in a similar way. So looks to and believes in Him are here parallel, which means that they have similar meanings.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as looks to here is a different word from what was in 6:36. The word used here means “to look at or examine something.” It can imply that one then understands or knows what one looks at. Here is another way to translate this word:

that all who know/understand who I am and who
believe in me

the Son: This phrase is a short form of “the Son of God,” which is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated this phrase at 5:19. For further information, see the note on the phrase “the Son of God” at 1:34.

believes in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts

about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this phrase in 1:12, 6:29, and 6:35c.

Here are other ways to translate this idea:

have faith in him (CEV)

trust in him

shall have eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there and in 6:27b.

Here are some other ways to translate this whole phrase:

may have forever life from God

may have spiritual life that never ends

may live forever with God

6:40c and I will raise him up at the last day.”

- And I will raise them up to live on that last day.”
- I will cause them to live again when all things come to an end.”

and I will raise him up at the last day: As in 6:39c, this refers to Jesus raising to life those who have died physically (see also 5:28–29). In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

I will raise them up at the last day. (NLT)

I: Jesus changed from talking about himself using the third person (“the Son”) to using first person here. The Greek text emphasizes the word I. You may want to emphasize the word if it is natural in your language. For example:

I Myself will raise him up on the last day (NASB)

raise...up: This is the same verb as in 6:39c, and you should probably translate it the same way in both verses.

the last day: As in 6:39c, this refers to the end of the world when Jesus will judge everyone. However, it is also the day when Jesus will raise his people, which is what Jesus was talking about here.

John 6:41

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:41–42

This paragraph tells how the people who were listening to Jesus reacted to what he said. They were not happy.

6:41a

At this, the Jews began to grumble about Jesus

- ¶ Then the Jewish people there began to complain/grumble about Jesus,
- ¶ Then some of the people who were listening began to criticize Jesus

At this: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as At this can also be translated as “therefore.” Here are other ways to translate this word:

Then (NRSV)

So (ESV)

Therefore (NASB)

the Jews began to grumble about Jesus: Jesus’ listeners were not happy about what Jesus had said. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The Jews began to criticize Jesus (GW)

So those who opposed Jesus began to grumble about him

the Jews: Probably everyone in the crowd was a Jew. (Some English translations therefore translate the term as “the people”). However, it is not likely that everyone would complain about Jesus. John uses the term the Jews to refer to Jewish leaders (see 1:19), Jews from the area of Jerusalem (see 11:19), and to Jews in general (see 2:6). Here, John seems to be using

the term to refer to those people who were hostile (opposed) to Jesus.

Here are some ways to translate this term following that understanding:

the Jews who were hostile to Jesus (NET)

Some of the Judeans (TLV)

6:41b

because He had said, “I am the bread that came down from heaven.”

- because he said, “I am the bread/food who has come down from heaven.”
- for saying that he himself was the bread/food that came from heaven.

I am the bread that came down from heaven: Refer back to your translation of 6:33a–35a. Use the same expressions for bread and came down from heaven there and here.

General Comment on 6:41a–b

In some languages it may be natural to use indirect speech here. For example:

The people started grumbling because Jesus had said that he was the bread that had come down from heaven. (CEV)

John 6:42

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:41–42

This paragraph tells how the people who were listening to Jesus reacted to what he said. They were not happy.

6:42a

They were asking, “Is this not Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know?”

- They said, “We know him and his parents. He is Jesus, the son of Joseph.
- They said/thought that they knew who he was—the son of Joseph. And they knew who Joseph was, and who Jesus’ mother was too.

They were asking: The tense of the Greek verb used here indicates one of two things. Either the people said this more than once, or more than one person said it.

Is this not Jesus, the son of Joseph, whose father and mother we know?: This is a rhetorical question. They used it to make a statement. The people were saying that they knew who Jesus was and who Jesus' parents were. So they implied that he could not have come from heaven.

Here are some ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't he Jesus, the son of Joseph? Don't we know his father and mother? (CEV)

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

This is Jesus, the son of Joseph. We know his father and mother. (NCV)

- Use a statement and a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't this Jesus, the son of Joseph? We know his father and mother. (NLT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

whose father and mother we know: The word whose here refers to Jesus. The people knew Joseph and Mary, who were Jesus' parents. In your translation, make sure that this is clear. A literal translation may suggest that the people knew Joseph's mother and father. To avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to start a new sentence, as in the CEV, NCV, and NLT examples above.

6:42b

How then can He say, 'I have come down from heaven?'

- Why is he saying that he has come down from heaven?"
- He should not say that he came down from heaven."
- So they refused to believe that he came from heaven.

How then can He say, 'I have come down from heaven?': This is a rhetorical question. The Jews used it to disagree with what Jesus said. They were saying

that Jesus should not say that he came from heaven. They thought that his statement was false. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can he say, 'I came down from heaven?' (NLT)

How can it be true that he has come down from heaven?

- Use a statement. For example:

So he cannot say, 'I have come down from heaven.'

We^(incl) cannot believe him when he says that he came down from heaven.

then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as then here introduces a logical conclusion to 6:42a. The speakers know Jesus' parents, and therefore he should not claim to come from heaven. Many English translations do not translate this word explicitly. Introduce this conclusion in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So how can he say...?

from heaven: The Jewish people sometimes said heaven as a way to show reverence when speaking about God. Heaven is where God lives. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase. See KBT Heaven, Sky 2A and the note on 6:31b.

General Comment on 6:42b

This sentence contains a quote inside a quote. In some languages it may be natural to use indirect speech for the quotation of Jesus' words. For example:

How can he say that he has come down from heaven? (CEV)

He should not say that he came down from God/heaven.

John 6:43

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself "the bread of life" and said that people

must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:43

“Stop grumbling among yourselves,” Jesus replied.

- ¶ Jesus replied. “Do not complain/grumble to one another.
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “Stop complaining to each other.

Stop grumbling among yourselves: This is a command. Jesus was commanding the people to stop complaining about what he was saying. See 6:41a. For example:

Do not complain among yourselves. (NRSV)

among yourselves: The Jews did not tell their complaints to Jesus, but only to each other (among themselves).

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to one another (NET)

to each other (NCV)

Jesus replied: If you translated the rhetorical question in 6:42 as a statement, it may be natural to use a word besides replied here. For example:

Jesus said

John 6:44

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:44a

“No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him,

- People do not come to me unless the Father who sent me here brings/leads them.
- It is my Father God who sent me into the world, and only he makes it possible for anyone to believe in me.

No one can come to Me unless the Father who sent Me draws him:

This clause means that God draws people (causes them to come) to him. God leads or calls people to trust Jesus. This clause contains a condition: If the Father does not lead a person to Jesus, that person cannot come.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If a person is drawn/pulled to me by the Father who sent me, he can come to me.

The only people who can come to me are those whom the Father, the one who sent me, causes to come.

Consider whether it is more natural to translate the subject No one in the singular or the plural. See the General Comment on 6:44a–b.

unless the Father who sent Me draws him: This expression indicates that God the Father must cause or help someone to come to Jesus. Without God the Father, a person will not come. In your translation, it should be clear that the Father does not physically pull or drag a person. Rather, he influences or convinces a person in a spiritual way so that they want to come.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

unless the Father who sent me brings them to me (GW)

unless the Father who sent me makes them want to come (CEV)

if my Father who sent me does not lead/bring them

General Comment on 6:44a

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two sentences. For example:

The Father is the One who sent me. No one can come to me unless the Father draws him to me. (NCV)

The Father, the one who sent me, is the one who must draw/bring people to me. If he does not draw/bring them, they will not come.

6:44b

and I will raise him up at the last day.

- I will raise them to life on the last day.
- Then when the world comes to an end, I will cause that person to live again.

and I will raise him up at the last day: Jesus indicated that he will give the one who trusts him eternal life when he believes. But they would still die physically. So at the end of the world (the last day) he will cause that person to live again. Then he would completely enjoy eternal life and never die again. See 5:28–29 and 6:39–40.

General Comment on 6:44a–b

Jesus was referring to anyone and everyone who comes to Jesus. Consider if it is more natural in your language to use singular nouns or plural nouns. The BSB has used singular nouns (“No one” and “him”). But you may choose to use plural nouns instead. For example:

People cannot come to me unless the Father who sent me draws them to me; and I will raise them to life at the last day. (GNT)

John 6:45

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:45a

It is written in the Prophets:

- In the book of the prophets it says,
- One of the prophets wrote

It is written in the Prophets: This clause introduces a quotation, though not an exact quotation, of Isaiah 54:13. Jesus only quoted one prophet, but the Prophets refers to the section of the Jewish Bible which includes the writings of many prophets.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

One of the prophets wrote (CEV)

This is written in the book of the prophets

6:45b

‘And they will all be taught by God.’

- ‘All of them will be taught by God.’
- that God himself will teach all his people.

And they will all be taught by God: In Isaiah 54, the pronoun they refers to the people of Jerusalem. Here in John it refers to God’s people in general, anyone and everyone who comes to Jesus.

The verb be taught is in the passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

They will all be taught by God. (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will teach all of them. (CEV)

Translate this clause in the way that is more natural in your language.

6:45c

Everyone who has heard the Father and learned from Him comes to Me—

- All people who hear what God the Father says and learn from him will come to me.
- All those who learn by listening to what God the Father says will believe in me.

Everyone who has heard the Father and learned from Him comes to Me: This sentence explains what is meant by “drawn by the Father” in 6:44a. The Father teaches people about Jesus. This is what leads them to come to Jesus.

has heard the Father and learned from Him: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates in the perfect tense as has heard the Father and learned are in a simple past tense. The NIV says “listens and learns,” using the present tense. It is a general statement,

so translate it using a tense that is natural in your language for general statements. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

listens to the Father and learns from him (CEV)

John 6:46

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:46a

not that anyone has seen the Father

- This does not mean that regular people have seen God the Father.
- But no one has seen God the Father

not that anyone has seen the Father: This clause is in contrast to 6:45c. Although people have heard and learned from God the Father, no human being has seen him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

No one has seen the Father (NIV)

This does not mean that anyone has seen the Father (GNT)

6:46b

except the One who is from God;

- Only the person/man who has come from God
- except the man from God.

except the One who is from God: This expression means that only one person has seen the Father. It tells the exception to the general truth of 6:46a. That one person who has seen the Father, the one who comes from him, is Jesus.

Here is another way to translate this expression.

Only the one who is from God (GW)

because only the one who came from God

from God: God here refers to the Father. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear by not using a different term for the Father. For example:

from him (CEV)

6:46c

only He has seen the Father.

- has seen God the Father.
- Only he has seen him.

He has seen the Father: In your translation, it should be clear that the Father is God. If a literal translation causes readers to think that they are different beings, you may need to say:

he has seen him

General Comment on 6:46b–c

Jesus used third person pronouns, but he was referring to himself. If a literal translation would mean that he was referring to someone else, you may need to use first-person pronouns:

except me. I have come from God my Father and have seen him.

General Comment on 6:46a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder this verse and translate it as a positive statement. For example:

The only one who has seen the Father is the one who has come from him. (CEV)

John 6:47

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:47a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I tell you the truth,
- I assure you that

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus was emphasizing what he was about to say. This is the same phrase that he used in 1:51a. See the note there.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

I am telling you the truth (GNT)

I tell you for certain (CEV)

6:47b

he who believes has eternal life.

- the person who believes has spiritual life that lasts forever.
- the person who believes in him/me will live forever with God.

he who believes has eternal life: The phrase he who believes refers to anyone and everyone who believes in Jesus. Consider whether it is most natural in your language to translate this phrase using a singular or a plural subject.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

everyone who has faith in me has eternal life (CEV)

the one who believes has eternal life (NET)

all who believe in me have eternal life

believes: When the word believes is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying “believes in Jesus.” So this word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

has faith in me (CEV)

trusts in me

believes in me

has eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there and in 6:27b and 40b. Here are some other ways to translate this whole phrase:

has forever life from God

has spiritual life that never ends

will live forever with God

John 6:48

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:48

I am the bread of life.

- ¶ “I am the bread/food that gives life.
- ¶ “I am like bread/food that enables you^(sing) to live spiritually.

I am the bread of life: This is a metaphor. Jesus compared himself to bread. The point of comparison is that he gives spiritual life, just as bread gives physical life. This metaphor is also used in 6:35a. See the note there and how you translated this clause there. Here are other ways that you can translate this verse:

I am the bread that gives life! (CEV)

I am like food that gives spiritual life.

John 6:49

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:49a**Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness,**

- Your^(plur) ancestors ate manna in the desert,
- Your^(plur) ancestors ate the manna bread while they walked around in the desert.

Your fathers ate the manna in the wilderness: This clause refers back to 6:31 and the story in Exodus 16. It is the first part of a comparison that Jesus made between manna (material bread/food) and himself (true bread that gives spiritual life).

Your fathers: This phrase refers to those Israelites who lived at the same time as Moses.

manna: This word refers to a white substance that God provided for the Israelites to eat in the wilderness. It tasted like biscuits or crackers with honey and was used to make bread. See the note on 6:31a.

Bible translations usually transliterate (copy the sounds of) the word manna. You may also want to include some description. For example:

food called manna

manna, the food that God provided

6:49b**yet they died.**

- but they died.
- They died anyway.

yet: Translating this Greek conjunction literally as “and” may imply that the Israelites died because they ate the manna, which is not true. Here are some ways to avoid that implication:

but they died (GNT)

and they still died

they died: This clause indicates that even though their ancestors ate manna, bread from heaven, they still died. In contrast, if people receive him, they will not die spiritually.

The people that ate the manna did not die instantly. They died over a period of many years. For example:

and later they died (CEV)

John 6:50**Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life**

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:50a**This is the bread that comes down from heaven,**

- But there is bread/food that comes down from heaven
- However, God in heaven sent this different bread/food

This is the bread that comes down from heaven:

This clause continues the figure of speech that compares and contrasts manna/bread and Jesus. Here Jesus referred to himself and he again used the metaphor of bread. See the notes on 6:35a and 6:48 and how you translated the metaphor there.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But the bread that comes down from heaven is of such a kind that... (GNT)

I am speaking of the bread that comes down from heaven (REB)

from heaven: As in 6:42b, the phrase from heaven is a way of saying “from God who is in heaven.”

6:50b**so that anyone may eat of it and not die.**

- so that someone may eat it and never die.
- so that when people eat it, they will not die.

so that anyone may eat of it and not die: This clause indicates that the bread, Jesus, came from heaven so that a person who believed on him should not die spiritually. See the parallel between this clause and 6:47b. Jesus is the bread that gives true life (see 6:48).

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Anyone who eats this bread will never die. (NCV)

so that no one who eats it will ever die (CEV)

eat of it: This is a metaphor. However, church groups understand it in different ways. Many church groups say that it refers to trusting Jesus and his provision. Others say that this phrase refers to communion. It is necessary that you translate this phrase literally and continue the metaphor of Jesus as bread. If you try to explain the metaphor in your translation, the Jews' confusion in verse 52 will not make sense.

General Comment on 6:50a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine these clauses. For example:

anyone who eats the bread from heaven, however,
will never die (NLT)

John 6:51

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:43–51

In this paragraph Jesus answered those who criticized him. He told them that only God could cause them to have faith in him. If they believed on him, they would receive eternal life.

6:51a

I am the living bread that came down from heaven.

- I am that bread/food which gives life that has come to earth from heaven.
- I myself am that bread/food from heaven/God that gives spiritual life.

I am the living bread that came down from heaven:

This sentence indicates that Jesus explicitly said that he was the bread that God gave. The Greek text emphasizes the word I.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I am that bread from heaven! (CEV)

I am that food which gives life, which came from heaven.

living bread: The word living indicates that Jesus did not talk about ordinary bread. Instead, he talked about spiritual bread, bread that has life in it and can give

life to others. It means about the same as “bread of life” in 6:35a and 6:48. See the note at 6:35a and how you translated the word bread there. Compare the phrase living bread to the phrase “living water” in 4:10d, and see the note there.

6:51b

If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever.

- If anyone eats of this bread/food, he will live always.
- When people eat this bread/food, they will live forever.

If anyone eats of this bread, he will live forever:

The BSB translates the Greek expression literally as if anyone eats of this bread.

Here are another way to translate this clause:

Everyone who eats it will live forever (CEV)

In this clause, Jesus continued to speak using metaphors. He was this bread that he spoke about. And many say that to eat of this bread means to believe or receive Jesus. Others say that this expression refers to communion. However, it is necessary to translate this clause using the metaphors. That way, the Jews' confusion in verse 52 will make sense. They would not be confused if Jesus did not speak using metaphors.

6:51c

And this bread, which I will give for the life of the world, is My flesh.”

- This bread is my flesh, and I give/offer it to supply/provide life to the people of the world.”
- The bread/food that I will give is my flesh/body. I will give it so that the people of the world may live spiritually.”

And this bread, which I will give for the life of the world, is My flesh:

This clause continues the metaphor of bread. Jesus said that he would give his flesh so that people might live. He would do that on the cross, but he did not explain that.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The bread that I shall give is my own flesh, given for the life of the world. (REB)

this bread, which I will offer so the world may live, is my flesh (NLT)

My flesh is the life-giving bread that I give for the people of the world. (CEV)

for the life of the world: This phrase means “in order that the people of the world might live (spiritually).” Here is another way to translate this phrase:

so that the people of the world may have life
(NCV)

My flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My flesh refers to Jesus’ physical body. Here Jesus explained further the metaphor of “the bread.”

John 6:52

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus’ extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus’ response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus’ expressions in your translation.

6:52a

At this, the Jews began to argue among themselves,

- ¶ Then the Jewish people argued intensely between themselves,
- ¶ Then the people who were listening quarreled very much with each other.

At this, the Jews began to argue among themselves: The word argue indicates that the people did

not understand the metaphor of eating the bread. They began to argue with one another about what Jesus might mean.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Then the people began arguing with each other about what he meant. (NLT)

This started an angry argument among them.
(GNT)

the Jews: As in 6:41a, the phrase the Jews probably refers to the people who opposed Jesus at that time. Translate this phrase in a way that indicates that it is the same group as in 6:41a.

6:52b

“How can this man give us His flesh to eat?”

- some asking, “How can this person say that he will give us his flesh to eat?”
- Some said, “He cannot give us his flesh/body to eat, can he? Of course not.”

How can this man give us His flesh to eat?: This is a rhetorical question. It makes this a strong statement that giving one’s own flesh to eat is impossible, something that people cannot even think about. Jesus did not mean that they should eat his body, but the people thought that he might have said that. And that possibility disturbed them.

Even though the question is rhetorical, it also implies a real question: “Whatever does he mean?” or “What can he be talking about?” There are several ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can he give us his flesh to eat? (CEV)

- Use a strong statement or exclamation. For example:

He cannot give us his flesh to eat!

- Use two sentences, one making the implied question explicit. For example:

It is not possible for him to give us his flesh to eat. What is he talking about?

this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this man is more literally “this one.” The people

were not speaking with respect. They were referring to Jesus in an insulting way. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

this person

this one

John 6:53

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus’ extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus’ response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus’ expressions in your translation.

6:53a

So Jesus said to them, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- So Jesus said to them, “I am telling you the truth.
- Jesus told them, “Listen carefully to what I say.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* here introduces what Jesus said in response to the criticisms.

Truly, truly, I tell you: This phrase emphasizes what Jesus was about to say. See the notes on 1:51a, where the same phrase is used. See also 6:26a and 6:32a.

6:53b

unless you eat the flesh and drink the blood of the Son of Man,

- If you^(plur) do not eat the flesh of the Son of Man and do not drink his blood
- You must feed on my flesh/body, the flesh/body of the Son of Man, and also drink my/his blood. If you do that,

unless you eat the flesh and drink the blood of the Son of Man: This clause states two conditions. The two conditions use two figures of speech to say those conditions.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If you do not eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood (GNT)

you must eat the Son of Man’s flesh and drink his blood. If you do not....

eat the flesh and drink the blood: Church groups understand this expression in different ways. See the explanation above at Paragraph 6:52–59. It is necessary to translate this expression literally. That is because of the different understandings and because those who heard Jesus thought that what he said was difficult.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some possible translations:

the Human-born

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Humanity/Humans

Translate this title as you did in other verses, for example, 1:51; 3:13, 14. See also KBT, Son of Man.

6:53c

you have no life in you.

- you^(plur) do not have true/eternal life.
- you will truly live.

you have no life in you: This clause indicates that apart from Christ people do not really live. They do not live in a true or spiritual way. You may need to make this more explicit. For example:

Otherwise, you won't have real life in you. (NCV)

you won't live unless you eat the flesh and drink the blood of the Son of Man (CEV)

General Comment on 6:53b–c

In some languages it may be natural to put 6:53c at the beginning of 6:53b. For example:

^{53c}You will not have true life ^{53b}if you do not eat the flesh and drink the blood of the Son of Man.

John 6:54

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus' extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus' response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus' expressions in your translation.

6:54a

Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has eternal life,

- Those people who eat my flesh and also drink my blood have spiritual life that lasts forever.
- Everyone who eats my flesh/body and drinks my blood, will live forever with God.

Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood has

eternal life: This clause continues the metaphor of Jesus as food. The point of the comparison is that Jesus gives life, just as food does. But the life that Jesus gives is eternal. It is recommended that you keep this figure of speech. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

But if you do eat my flesh and drink my blood, you will have eternal life (CEV)

But anyone who eats my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life (NLT)

has eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there and in 6:27b and 40b. Here are some other ways to translate this whole phrase:

have forever life from God

have spiritual life that never ends

will live forever with God

6:54b

and I will raise him up at the last day.

- And I will raise them up to live at the end of the world.
- I will make him live forever on the day that I judge the world.

and I will raise him up at the last day: Jesus indicated that he will resurrect all those who eat his flesh and drink his blood. He will do that on the last day (at the end of the world). See also 6:39c.

John 6:55

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus' extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus' response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words "eat" and "drink" figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words "eat" and "drink" should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus' expressions in your translation.

6:55**For My flesh is real food, and My blood is real drink.**

- Because my flesh is true/real food, and my blood is real/true drink.
- Because my flesh/body is what truly feeds you^(plur), and my blood is what truly satisfies/ends your^(plur) thirst.

For My flesh is real food, and My blood is real drink:

Jesus indicated that he himself is the only true or real food that gives life. He gives life to those who trust him, now in this world and forever.

It is recommended that you translate these clauses literally. Here are other ways to translate them:

For my flesh is real food and my blood is real drink. (NJB)

Because my body and my blood are the true food and drink.

John 6:56**Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life**

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself "the bread of life" and said that people must "eat" his flesh and "drink" his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus' extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus' response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words "eat" and "drink" figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words "eat" and "drink" should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus' expressions in your translation.

6:56a**Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood**

- If someone eats my flesh and drinks my blood
- Anyone who eats my flesh and drinks my blood

Whoever eats My flesh and drinks My blood: This phrase refers to those who believe in Jesus. Because church groups understand what Jesus said in different ways, it is recommended that you continue to translate literally. See how you translated the same phrase in 6:54a.

6:56b**remains in Me, and I in him.**

- he will live in me, and I will live in him.
- is in union with me, and I am in union with him.
- will live in close fellowship with me, and I with him.

remains in Me, and I in him: This expression is a short way of saying "they remain in me, and I remain in them." The word remains means "stays." In this context it refers to staying in a trusting relationship with Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

continues to stay in me and I continue to stay in him

live in me, and I live in them (GW)

you are one with me, and I am one with you (CEV)

General Comment on 6:56a–b

The subject of 6:56 is everyone who believes in Jesus. It is possible to use either a singular or a plural third person form or a second person form. Consider which is most natural in your language. For example:

Anyone who eats my flesh and drinks my blood remains in me, and I in him. (NLT)

Those who eat my flesh and drink my blood live in me, and I live in them. (GNT)

If you eat my flesh and drink my blood, you are one with me, and I am one with you. (CEV)

John 6:57

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus’ extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus’ response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus’ expressions in your translation.

6:57a

Just as the living Father sent Me

- As the Father who lives has sent me here

- God the living Father has sent me to you/earth,

Just as the living Father sent Me: This clause is the basis for the truth of the clause in 6:57b. Jesus said that God the Father is the one who sent him. In some languages it may be necessary to say from where and to where God sent him. For example:

sent me from heaven to earth

Just as: The phrase Just as introduces the first part of a comparison. The word Just here means “exactly.”

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

As (NJB)

In the same way that...

the living Father: This phrase indicates that God the Father is alive and is the source of life for all. This is the only time this phrase is used in the Bible. However, in Matthew 16:16, Peter referred to Jesus as “the son of the living God.”

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the Father who has life (GW)

My Father God who sent me, he is the true source of life

6:57b

and I live because of the Father,

- and I live through the Father,
- and my life depends on the Father.

I live because of the Father: In this clause, Jesus indicated that God the Father was his source of life.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

I get life from my Father God

General Comment on 6:57a–b

Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

The living Father sent me, and because of him I live also. (GNT)

The living Father sent me, and I have life because of him. (CEV)

I live because of the living Father who sent me (NLT)

6:57c

so also the one who feeds on Me will live because of Me.

- so the one who eats me will live through me.
- In the same way all who eat me will have life that depends on me.

so also the one who feeds on Me will live because of Me: This is the second part of the comparison that began in 6:57a (just as...so). It compares the way a person lives because of Jesus to the way Jesus lives because of God the Father.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

In the same way whoever eats me will live because of me. (GNB)

General Comment on 6:57a–c

In the Greek text, as in the BSB, 6:57a–c forms one long sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to break this up into two sentences. For example:

The living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father. So whoever eats me will live because of me. (NCV)

The living Father sent me, and he causes me to live. Now I will cause anyone who eats my flesh to live.

John 6:58

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus’ extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus’ response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would

have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.

2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus’ expressions in your translation.

6:58a

This is the bread that came down from heaven.

- Here is the bread/food who came down from heaven.
- This true bread/food that has come down from God in heaven

This is the bread that came down from heaven:

This clause is almost the same as 6:50a in the Greek, except for the verb tense. See the note on 6:50a. In this clause, Jesus was referring to himself. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

I am the true bread that came down from heaven. (NLT)

6:58b

Unlike your fathers, who ate the manna and died,

- It is not like the bread/food that your^(plur) ancestors ate, because they later died.
- is not like the bread/food from God that your ancestors ate. They died,

Unlike your fathers, who ate the manna and died:

Jesus was indicating that the bread that he gives is different from the manna that the Israelites ate. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

This bread is not like the bread that your ancestors ate. They died....

Unlike: This phrase makes it explicit again that Jesus was not like the manna that the Jews’ ancestors ate. A few translations leave this phrase implicit, but they are in the Greek and nearly all English translations include them. It is recommended that you make this phrase explicit in some way. For example:

it is not like (GNT)

your fathers: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as your fathers. However, most cultures do not talk about “the fathers/ancestors” because ancestors are related to a specific person or group. Here Jesus talked about the ancestors of the Jews.

Most English translations translate this phrase as “your ancestors.” However, a few translate it as “the fathers” (RSV, ESV, NASB) or (because Jesus was also a Jew) “our ancestors” (NJB, REB). The phrase “our ancestors” is more friendly than “your ancestors,” but maybe Jesus was not gentle here. He used “your ancestors” in 6:49, so it would be suitable to use that phrase here. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

and: Even though the Israelites ate the manna, they died. So it may be natural to say:

but (GNT)

died: The Israelites did not die at once. They died later, some after many years. For example:

They later died (GNB)

General Comment on 6:58a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate “This is the bread that came down from heaven, not like that which your ancestors ate” without saying “This is.” For example:

The bread that comes down from heaven isn’t like what your ancestors ate. They died.... (CEV)

This bread is not like the bread that your ancestors ate. They all later/eventually died

6:58c

the one who eats this bread will live forever.”

- But a person who eats this bread/food will always live.”
- but all who eat this my bread/food will never die.”

the one who eats this bread will live forever:

Jesus continued to refer to himself as bread and the source of life. The life that comes from him will last forever. That is different than the life that came from the manna that the people’s ancestors ate. It is recommended that you continue to translate with the metaphor, as do all the major English translations.

General Comment on 6:58b–c

There is implied information here. Even though the Israelites ate the manna, they died. You may want to make this information explicit:

Anyone who eats this bread will not die as your ancestors did (even though they ate the manna) but will live forever. (NLT)

General Comment on 6:58a–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 6:58a–c. For example:

^{58b}I am not like the bread your ancestors ate. They ate that bread and still died. ^{58a}I am the bread that came down from heaven, ^{58c}and whoever eats this bread will live forever. (NCV)

John 6:59

Section 6:22–59: Jesus is the bread that gives life

In this section Jesus spoke in figurative language about how he himself is the source of eternal life. He called himself “the bread of life” and said that people must “eat” his flesh and “drink” his blood. These words caused a lot of argument.

Paragraph 6:52–59

This paragraph continues Jesus’ extended metaphor comparing himself to bread/food. The people did not understand what he meant by eating the bread/food. In Jesus’ response he talked about eating his flesh and drinking his blood. Church groups understand the meaning of what Jesus said in different ways. Here are the two major interpretations:

1. Jesus used the words “eat” and “drink” figuratively. He meant that people must believe in the Son of Man and receive him personally so that they would have life. He is spiritual food and spiritual drink, giving spiritual life and strength to those who trust him.
2. Jesus was referring to communion and so the words “eat” and “drink” should be understood more literally. He meant that people must take communion to have spiritual life and strength.

Some of the disciples that heard Jesus understood his words literally. And today, church groups understand this passage in different ways. So it is recommended that you translate it more literally. Do not explain Jesus’ expressions in your translation.

6:59**Jesus said this while teaching in the synagogue in Capernaum.**

- Jesus told this to the people in the synagogue in Capernaum while he was teaching there.
- Jesus was in the synagogue in the town of Capernaum when he taught the people these things.

synagogue: This word refers to a building where Jews gathered to pray, read Scripture, teach their beliefs, and worship God. The Jews also gathered in synagogues for cultural activities. Most Jewish communities had a synagogue.

Here are some ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-houses of the Jews

meeting-places of the Jews

buildings for worship

houses for gathering together

You will need a different term to translate synagogue than you use for temple. There was only one temple, and it was in the city of Jerusalem.

If the word synagogue is already known in your area, you may write it following the sounds of your language. You may want to include a word or phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

sinagog house/building

Consider using a footnote that contains some of the information above. Such a footnote may help people who read your translation. See Luke 7:5 and Acts 15:21.

Capernaum: The town of Capernaum is also mentioned in 2:12, Matthew 4:13, Mark 1:21, and Luke 4:23. Refer to it in the same way in all these verses.

John 6:60**Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life**

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus' teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:60a**On hearing it, many of His disciples said,**

- ¶ When Jesus' disciples heard his words, many of them said,
- ¶ Jesus' disciples heard what he said. Many of them said,
- ¶ After hearing what Jesus had taught/said,

On hearing it, many of His disciples said: All of Jesus' disciples heard what he said. But not all of them said what follows. Make this clear in a way that is natural in your translation. For example:

His disciples heard it/this. Many of them said...

When the followers of Jesus heard this, many of them said... (NCV)

it...His: This is the beginning of a new section and paragraph. So it may be natural to make explicit who and what these pronouns refer to. For example:

his teaching/words...Jesus'

disciples: The word disciples here refers to Jesus' followers in general, not to the twelve apostles.

6:60b**"This is a difficult teaching.**

- "This is a difficult/hard teaching.
- "It is hard to believe this/your^(sing) teaching.
- many of his disciples criticized it.

This is a difficult teaching: The disciples were saying that this teaching was hard or difficult to accept (see 6:60c). They were not complaining that it was hard to understand.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

What he said is hard to accept.

This is a hard teaching. (NIV)

General Comment on 6:60a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 6:60a–b as two independent clauses or sentences. For example:

Jesus' disciples listened to what he was teaching. Then many of them began to say, "This teaching is difficult to accept."

Jesus' disciples heard what he said, but many of them complained/grumbled that his teaching was difficult.

The idea is that this metaphor offended people. It was not acceptable.

6:60c

Who can accept it?"

- How can we accept it?"
- We cannot agree with it."
- They declared that it was not acceptable.

Who can accept it?: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Who can accept it? is more literally "who can hear it?" It is the same verb that is used in 6:60a. Here there are three ways to understand this clause:

1. It means "who can accept it?" For example:

How could anyone accept it? (NJB) (BSB, NIV, NCV, NLT, NJB, NABRE, NRSV)

1. It means "who can listen to it?" For example:

How can anyone listen to such talk? (REB) (ESV, NASB, GNT, KJV, REB, RSV)

1. It means "who can understand it?" For example:

Who can understand it? (NET) (NET, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is followed by many English translations and seems to make the best sense in this context. Even interpretation (2) can be understood to imply that they could not listen to it because they could not accept it. People left Jesus because they were offended and could not accept his teaching.

This is a rhetorical question. Its purpose is to make the statement that no one could accept this teaching. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can anyone accept it? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

It is not acceptable.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 6:61

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus' teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:61a–b

This verse is one long sentence in Greek and in the BSB. It contains two clauses. The first clause gives the reason for why Jesus asked the question in the second clause. In some languages it may be more natural to put the clauses in separate sentences. Or you may want to make it clearer that Jesus asked the question in 6:61b because of what he knew in 6:61a.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse:

Jesus was aware that his disciples were criticizing his message. So Jesus asked them, “Did what I say make you lose faith? (GW)

Jesus knew that his disciples were grumbling. So he asked, “Does this bother you? (CEV)

Without being told, Jesus knew that they were grumbling about this, so he said to them, “Does this make you want to give up? (GNT)

6:61a

Aware that His disciples were grumbling about this teaching,

- But Jesus was aware that his disciples were complaining about his teaching.
- Jesus knew his followers were grumbling about what he had said.
- Jesus understood/realized that his followers were criticizing his words.

Aware that His disciples were grumbling about this teaching: This clause gives the reason that Jesus asks the question in 6:61b. Even though he did not hear what the disciples said in 6:60b–c, he knew what they said.

Aware: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Aware is more literally “knowing in himself.” It indicates that Jesus knew without anyone telling him. For example:

Without being told, Jesus knew (GNT)

No one told Jesus, but he knew

grumbling: The Greek verb that BSB translates as grumbling is the same one that was used in 6:41a. Use the same verb in both verses.

6:61b

Jesus asked them, “Does this offend you?”

- He said to them, “Why does this offend you^(plur)?”
- He said to his followers, “You^(plur) should not be offended at what I say.

Does this offend you?: This is a rhetorical question that Jesus used as a rebuke. He also used this question to introduce another rhetorical question in the next verse. The Greek word that the BSB translates as offend means to cause someone to be angry, or to lose faith. Here Jesus was asking his disciples if his teaching made them so angry that they would stop

following him. (And many of his disciples did stop following him. See verse 66.)

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Did what I say make you lose faith? (GW)

Does this make you want to give up? (GNT)

Are you angry about this teaching?

- Use a statement. For example:

You should not be offended.

Do not be angry.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 6:62

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus’ followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus’ teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus’ followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus’ teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:62

Then what will happen if you see the Son of Man ascend to where He was before?

- What will you^(plur) think if you see the Son of Man go up/back to where he came from?

- Suppose you^(plur) see me, the Son of Man, return to heaven?

Then what will happen if you see the Son of Man ascend to where He was before?: Like 6:61b, this is a rhetorical question. Jesus was asking his followers to consider what they would think if they saw him go back to heaven.

Here are other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Suppose, then, that you should see the Son of Man go back up to the place where he was before? (GNT)

Then what will you think if you see the Son of Man ascend to heaven again? (NLT)

If you saw the Son of Man ascend to heaven again, what would you say about that?

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some possible translations:

the Human-born

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Humanity/Humans

Translate this title as you did in other verses, for example, 1:51; 3:13, 14. See also KBT, Son of Man.

Jesus was referring to himself. If a literal translation would mean that he was referring to someone else, it may be necessary to say:

me, the Son of Man

ascend: This word refers to when Jesus would ascend (go up) to heaven after he was resurrected.

where He was before: This clause refers to heaven. Jesus lived in heaven before he came to earth. Here he

referred to returning to heaven after his resurrection. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

heaven where he came from (CEV)

John 6:63

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus’ followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus’ teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus’ followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus’ teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:63a

The Spirit gives life;

- The Spirit is the one who gives life.
- You^(plur) receive true life from the Holy Spirit.
- It is God’s Spirit who gives eternal/unending life.

The Spirit gives life: There are two ways to interpret this expression:

1. The phrase The Spirit refers to the Holy Spirit. God’s Spirit gives true life, spiritual life. For example:

What gives life is God’s Spirit (GNT) (BSB, NASB, ESV, NIV, NET, NLT, GNT, CEV, NCV)

1. The phrase The Spirit refers to the human spirit. Without the spirit, there is no natural human life. For example:

It is the spirit that gives life. (NJB) (KJV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, NABRE, REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations. In the Scriptures God's Spirit is often mentioned as the source of life (for example, John 3:5–8).

6:63b
the flesh profits nothing.

- Human flesh can do nothing.
- Human strength/effort does not give any life.

the flesh profits nothing: The clause that the BSB translates as the flesh profits nothing indicates that a person using his own strength cannot achieve what the Spirit achieves. A human being, and anything a human achieves, cannot give him true, or spiritual, life.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the flesh has nothing to offer (NJB)

the flesh can achieve nothing (REB)

The flesh will not help you (JBP)

the flesh: The Greek word that the BSB translates as flesh can refer to the physical human body. However, in this context in John it refers to human strength or effort. It is what a person can do without God's help or strength. Jesus was saying that humans cannot understand what he said without the Spirit. Jesus was not referring to his own flesh or body, which he had already said was life-giving (6:51c). If using the same word that you used in 6:51c would have this wrong meaning, you should use a different word or phrase. For example:

human strength (CEV)

Human effort (NLT)

human power (GNT)

General Comment on 6:63a–b

The statements that “the Spirit...gives life” (NJB) and “the flesh is useless” contrast God's Holy Spirit and humanity. In your translation, make sure that there is a clear contrast. For example:

What gives life is God's Spirit; human power is of no use at all. (GNT)

It is the Spirit that gives life. The flesh doesn't give life. (NCV)

The one who gives life is God's Spirit, not human strength. Human strength cannot help you with that at all.

6:63c
The words I have spoken to you are spirit and they are life.

- The words I have spoken to you^(plur) are for the spirit. They are/give life.
- What I have said to you is spiritual and will cause you/people to live.

The words I have spoken to you are spirit and they are life: As in 6:63a, the Greek word that the BSB translates as spirit can be interpreted in two ways:

(1) It refers to the human spirit.

The words I have spoken to you are spirit and they are life. (NJB) (BSB, NET, ESV, NASB, NIV84, KJV, REB, RSV, NRSV, GW, NJB, NABRE)

(2) It refers to God's Holy Spirit.

The words I have spoken to you—they are full of the Spirit and life. (NIV11) (NIV11, CEV, GNT)

Here it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English translations do. Because it is the Holy Spirit that gives life (6:63a), the words that Jesus spoke are for a person's spirit.

The Greek text emphasizes the word I. That emphasis indicates that Jesus' words were different from what others said. Those who believed what he said would receive life. However, those who depended on their flesh could not accept what he said and did not receive life.

are spirit and they are life: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as are spirit and they are life can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It refers to two separate ideas: (a) Jesus' words are spirit, meaning that they are spiritual words or for the spirit, and (b) Jesus' words give life. For example:

The words I have spoken to you are spirit and they are life. (NIV84) (BSB, KJV, NASB, NIV, NJB, REB, NET, NCV, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NLT)

1. It refers to one idea: Jesus' words are from the life-giving Spirit, or bring spiritual life. For example:

The words I have spoken to you bring God's life-giving Spirit. (GNT) (GNT, GW, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations. In the Greek text the verb, translated are, is repeated, suggesting two separate ideas ("the words...are spirit and are life"). However, the two ideas are related, and it is not necessary to repeat the verb if it is not natural in your language.

are life: Jesus' words are life in the sense that they give life to those who believe. In some languages it may be natural to translate life as a verb and say:

cause/enable people to live

John 6:64

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus' teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:64a

However, there are some of you who do not believe."

- However, some of you^(plur) do not believe me."
- But there are some of you^(plur) who do not trust/accept my words/message."

However, there are some of you who do not believe: Although Jesus' words bring life, this clause

indicates that not everyone believed his message. Even among the larger group of his disciples, some people doubted him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Yet there are some of you who have no faith. (REB)

But some of you do not believe me. (NLT)

However: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as However here introduces a contrast. Although Jesus' words were from God's Spirit, not all his disciples trusted him.

do not believe: When the word believe is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying "believe in Jesus." So this word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 6:47b. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

refuse to have faith in me (CEV)

do not trust in me

do not believe in me

do not believe me (NLT)

6:64b–c

This is a parenthetical statement that explains Jesus' comment in 6:64a. You should introduce and present it in a way that is natural in your language. You may want to use parentheses. For example:

(Jesus knew from the very beginning who were the ones that would not believe and which one would betray him.) (GNT)

6:64b

(For Jesus had known from the beginning which of them did not believe

- That is because Jesus knew from the beginning which of them did not believe in him,
- Jesus said this because since he began to teach/minister he knew who would not believe.

For Jesus had known from the beginning which of them did not believe: This statement indicates that Jesus knew if people believed in him (or believed his teaching) even before they criticized his teaching.

Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

For Jesus had already known from the beginning who those were who did not believe. (NET)

Jesus said this, because from the beginning he knew who would have faith in him. (CEV)

from the beginning: This phrase probably refers to the time when disciples first began to follow Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from the first (NRSV)

from when he started to teach people

all the time that he was making/teaching disciples

did not believe: This phrase has the same meaning as “do not believe” in 6:64a. See the note there and how you translated that phrase.

6:64c

and who would betray Him.)

- and he knew which one/disciple would betray him.
- He also realized who would hand him over to his enemies.

and: The conjunction and here introduces a second thing that Jesus knew from the first, from the time when he began to make disciples.

who would betray Him: The second thing that Jesus knew from the first was that one of his disciples would betray him. This disciple was Judas Iscariot. The name is not included here, and you should not include it in your translation. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

who it was who would betray him (NET)

which one would betray him (GNT)

betray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as betray here refers to handing over someone to his

enemies. In this case Judas would lead the Jewish authorities to Jesus so that they could arrest him.

John 6:65

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus’ followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus’ teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus’ followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:60–65

Jesus’ teaching made many of his followers unhappy. They did not understand how he could be the living bread, or how they could eat him. In this paragraph Jesus responded to their complaints. He insisted that he came from God and that his words brought life from God.

6:65a

Then Jesus said, “This is why I told you that no one can come to Me

- He said, “This is why I told you^(plur) that people cannot come to me
- He said to his disciples, “It is because of this that I told you^(plur) that in order to believe in me

6:65b

unless the Father has granted it to him.”

- unless the Father makes it possible.
- you^(plur) need God to allow/enable you^(plur).

6:65a–b

This is why: The phrase This is why probably refers back to Jesus’ comment in 6:64a. He had told his followers there that some of them did not believe him. Because some did not believe, Jesus told them here that they could believe only if the Father allowed it. Then they would understand why some did not believe.

I told you that no one can come to Me: This probably refers to Jesus’ words in 6:44.

unless the Father has granted it to him: The word granted means “given.” This expression indicates that God must cause or allow someone to come to Jesus. A

person cannot believe if God does not enable him to believe.

The Greek is a passive clause. It can be translated in two ways:

1. Use a passive verb. For example:

if this is not provided/given by the Father

1. Use an active verb. For example:

unless the Father has allowed him to come (NET)

Translate this clause in the way that is most natural in your language. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

unless the Father has enabled him (NIV)

unless the Father provides the way (GW)

unless the Father makes it possible for them to do so (GNT)

if my Father does not allow it

General Comment on 6:65a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to change the order of the clauses in what Jesus said. You may want to put an “if” clause with “not” first instead of using an “unless” clause. For example:

Jesus said, “That is the reason I said, ‘If the Father does not bring a person to me, that one cannot come.’” (NCV)

John 6:66

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus’ followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus’ teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus’ followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus’ words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:66a

From that time on many of His disciples turned back

- ¶ Then many of Jesus’ disciples left him
- ¶ When/After Jesus said these things, many of his followers stopped following him.

From that time on: The phrase that the BSB translates as From that time on can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It refers to time. It means “after Jesus had said this.” For example:

After this (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV, KJV, ESV, REB, NJB, NET, NLT, NCV)

1. It refers to cause. It means “because of what Jesus had said.” For example:

As a result of this (NASB) (NASB, NRSV, GW, GNT, CEV)

Both of these interpretations have strong support. It was both after and because of what Jesus had said that many disciples left him. It may be possible to translate this in a way that is ambiguous (like the English “At this”). If you must choose between the two, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations.

many of His disciples turned back: This clause indicates that many of Jesus’ followers rejected or abandoned him. They stopped learning from him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

many of his disciples went away (REB)

many of his followers left him (NCV)

6:66b

and no longer walked with Him.

- and stopped traveling with him.

- And they did not go with him on his journeys anymore.

no longer walked with Him: This clause means about the same as 6:66a. These people stopped going with Jesus. They no longer wanted to learn from him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

stopped following him (NCV)

did not go with him anymore

John 6:67

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus' words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:67

So Jesus asked the Twelve, "Do you want to leave too?"

- Therefore Jesus asked the twelve disciples, "Do you^(plur) also want to leave me?"
- Then Jesus asked the group he chose, his twelve followers/apostles, "Are you^(plur) going to abandon me as well?"

So Jesus asked the Twelve: Here Jesus spoke specifically to his twelve (12) closest followers. These men would later be known as the twelve apostles. This is the first time in his Gospel that John has referred to this group. Refer to the notes on Mark 3:16.

You should refer to the Twelve in a way that makes it clear that these were twelve of the disciples. Or you may want to make a footnote. For example:

Jesus chose twelve of his followers to be near him and learn from him in a special way. They are called "the twelve" or "the twelve apostles." See Mark 3:16–19, which tells the twelve's names.

Do you want to leave too?: Jesus asked his closest followers for their reaction to what he had said. In the Greek this question is in a form that expects or hopes for the answer "no." For example:

You don't want to go away too, do you? (NET)

The Greek text emphasizes the word you. That emphasis indicates that he hoped that they especially would not want to leave him. Here are some English examples of how to do this:

What about you, do you want to go away too? (NJB)

And you—would you also like to leave? (GNT)

John 6:68

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus' words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:68a

Simon Peter replied, "Lord, to whom would we go?"

- Simon Peter replied to him: "Lord, who else is there for us to follow?"
- Simon Peter said, "Master, we^(excl) will not abandon you because we know that there is no one else we^(excl) can go to.

Simon Peter replied: This clause indicates that Simon Peter spoke for the whole group. He knew (or thought he knew) what they all thought.

Lord, to whom would we go?: This is a rhetorical question. Peter used it to emphasize that there was no one else whom the twelve (12) could follow. It implies that the twelve would not stop following Jesus. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a question. For example:

Lord, where would we go? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Lord, there is no one else that we can go to! (CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

It may be necessary to make explicit Peter's implied answer to Jesus' question in 6:67, that the twelve would not stop following Jesus. For example:

No! There is no one else to go/turn to!

6:68b

You have the words of eternal life.

- You^(sing) alone speak the message that gives/brings us spiritual life that never ends.
- Only you^(sing) tell us how to live forever with God.

You have the words of eternal life: This clause gives the grounds or reason for Peter's decision to continue following Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Your words give eternal life. (GW)

You speak the words that lead to eternal life.

You may want to make explicit the relationship between the clauses in 6:68a-b, indicating that this clause gives a reason. For example:

because only you teach how to have eternal life.

the words of eternal life: This phrase refers to Jesus' teaching about eternal life. Jesus had told them how to receive eternal life, and they believed him.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the message of eternal life (NJB)

the words that give eternal life (NCV)

eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there and in 6:27b and 40b.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

John 6:69

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus' words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:69

We believe and know that You are the Holy One of God."

- We^(excl) believe and are sure that you^(sing) are the Holy One from God."
- We^(excl) believe you and now know that you^(sing) are the Holy One whom God sent to us."

We believe and know that You are the Holy One of God: This sentence indicates what the disciples believed about Jesus. The phrase believe and know indicates that the twelve (12) began to believe and

know in the past. It also indicates that they continued to believe and know.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

And now we believe and know that you are the Holy One who has come from God. (GNT)

the Holy One of God: In this context, Peter called Jesus the Holy One of God because he is divine and comes from God. This title indicated that they believed that God had set Jesus apart for a special mission.

Here are other ways to translate this title:

the Holy One who has come from God (GNT)

the Holy One whom God sent

In some languages it may not be possible to use the word One to refer to a person. It may be necessary to use a more specific term. That term would refer either to the fact that he is divine or that God sent him. For example:

You are the Holy Person/Man from God.

You are the Holy Son of God.

Holy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Holy refers to something or someone that is dedicated to God or set apart for him. It can also mean “morally perfect” or “divine.” John only uses the word to describe God the Father (17:11), the Holy Spirit (1:33; 14:26; 20:22), and Jesus (here).

John 6:70

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus’ followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus’ teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus’ followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus’ words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:70a

Jesus answered them, “Have I not chosen you, the Twelve?”

- Then Jesus told them, “Have I not chosen you^(plur), the twelve?”
- Then Jesus replied to his disciples, “I chose each one of you^(plur) twelve disciples,

Have I not chosen you, the Twelve?: This is a rhetorical question. It is in a form that expects the answer “yes.” Jesus used it to say that he had chosen the twelve (12) disciples. There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a question. For example:

Have I not chosen the twelve of you? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

I chose the twelve of you (NLT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

6:70b

Yet one of you is a devil!”

- But one of you^(plur) is the devil!”
- but one of you^(plur) is controlled by the devil.”

Yet one of you is a devil: Jesus indicated that even though he had chosen the twelve disciples, he knew that one of them was evil. He did not say who this man was.

a devil: This phrase indicates that one of the disciples was controlled by the devil. Jesus was not saying that he was literally a devil.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the devil (NET)

a servant of Satan (EASY)

under the control of Satan (T4T)

John 6:71

Section 6:60–71: Jesus had the words of eternal life

This section describes Jesus' followers dividing into groups. Many of them rejected Jesus' teaching that he was the bread of life, and they stopped following him. But the twelve (12) apostles, with Simon Peter speaking for them, understood that Jesus brought them true words from God that give life.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Simon Peter recognized that Jesus had the words of eternal life

Many of Jesus' followers stopped following him

Paragraph 6:66–71

This paragraph tells the result of Jesus' words. His disciples reacted in one of two ways: they rejected him or believed him.

6:71

In this verse, John the author gives an explanation of what Jesus said in 6:70a-b. He tells what would happen later, which no one except Jesus knew at the time of this event.

6:71a-b

He was speaking about Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot. For although Judas was one of the Twelve, he was later to betray Jesus: The conjunction *For* here introduces Jesus' grounds for calling Judas a devil. The word *For* here means "because." Some English translations do not translate this word, but leave the connection implied.

Here are some other ways to translate this verse and indicate the grounds:

The one he was talking about was Judas the son of Simon Iscariot, because even though he was one of his twelve disciples, he would later betray Jesus.

Jesus was talking about Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot. He would later betray Jesus, even though he was one of the twelve disciples. (CEV)

He was speaking of Judas, son of Simon Iscariot, one of the Twelve, who would later betray him. (NLT)

6:71a

He was speaking about Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot.

- He referred to Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot,
- He meant Judas, who was the son of Simon Iscariot.

He was speaking about Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot:

This clause tells the name of the disciple to whom Jesus referred in 6:70a.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus was talking about Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot. (NCV)

He meant Judas son of Simon Iscariot. (REB)

6:71b

For although Judas was one of the Twelve, he was later to betray Jesus.

- because even though he was one of the twelve, Judas would later betray Jesus.
- That was because Judas would hand Jesus over to his enemies although Jesus had chosen him to be one of the twelve disciples.

although Judas was one of the Twelve, he was later to betray Jesus: This statement indicates that Judas would betray Jesus. How this happened is recorded in Matthew 26:14-16, 47-50. In some languages it may be necessary to make the names explicit:

Judas would betray Jesus even though he was one of the twelve (12) disciples

although Judas was one of the Twelve: This phrase is a short way of saying "although he was one of the Twelve disciples." It gives the reason why what happened was unexpected or surprising. Although Judas was one of the twelve (12) disciples, who were mentioned in 6:67 and 6:70a, he would betray Jesus. One would not expect that one of Jesus' closest companions would betray him.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

even though he was one of the twelve disciples (GNT)

although Judas was one of the twelve

Judas was one of the twelve, but later... (NCV)

betray Jesus: In this context the word betray means to hand someone over to his enemies. Judas would bring Jewish leaders to Jesus to arrest him and put him on a cross to die.

Here are other ways to translate this word:

turn against Jesus (NCV)

give Jesus to his enemies

John 7:1

Section 7:1–9: Jesus’ brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus’ brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus’ brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus’ brothers

Paragraph 7:1–5

Jesus realized that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. He wanted to stay away from the public as much as possible. But it was almost time for the festival of Booths, celebrated annually in Jerusalem. His brothers encouraged him to attend.

7:1a

After this, Jesus traveled throughout Galilee.

- ¶ Then Jesus traveled around in Galilee.
- ¶ Later Jesus walked around teaching/serving in the region/province of Galilee.

After this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After this begins a new event in the narrative. See the note on 2:12a, where the same phrase occurs. The phrase does not indicate whether the new story takes place soon after or long after the previous event. However, the festival of Booths (7:2) was about six months after the Passover (6:4). So the events in chapter 7 probably took place about six months after the events in chapter 6. Introduce this new event in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

After that (REB)

Jesus traveled throughout Galilee: Jesus walked around Galilee, visiting and teaching people and staying in various towns and villages. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Jesus traveled in Galilee (GNT)

Galilee: Galilee is a region or province of Palestine. Translate it as you did in 1:43a, where it is first mentioned. For example:

the area/region called Galilee

7:1b

He did not want to travel in Judea,

- He wanted/decided to stay away from Judea
- He deliberately avoided Judea

He did not want to travel in Judea: There is a textual issue in this clause.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a phrase that means “he did not want to.” For example:

He did not want to travel in Judea (BSB) (ESV, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, GW, GNT, NCV, NLT, REB, NIV, NET, CEV, NABRE)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have a phrase that means “he was not able to.” For example:

he could not travel round Judaea (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the best manuscript support, and most English translations follow this option. The UBS Committee chose this reading and gave it an A rating, indicating it is almost certain.

The clause He did not want to travel in Judea indicates that Jesus wanted to avoid Judea. He did not want to travel or stay there. The Greek word that the BSB translates as travel means “walk around” or “go to different places.” Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He wanted to stay out of Judea. (NLT)

he decided to avoid Judaea (REB)

purposely staying away from Judea (NIV)

Judea: Judea is the province or region of Palestine where Jerusalem is located. See the note on “the Judean countryside” at 3:22b. In some languages it is more natural to supply here the information that Judea was a region or area. For example:

He deliberately stayed away from the area called Judea.

7:1c

because the Jews there were trying to kill Him.

- because the Jewish leaders were waiting for a chance to kill him.
- because the Jews there were looking for an excuse for the authorities to punish him with death.

because: The conjunction because here introduces the reason Jesus stayed away from Judea.

the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the Jewish religious leaders. These leaders mainly lived and taught in Jerusalem, in Judea. Refer to the notes on 2:18a and your translation of the Jews there.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

the Jewish leaders (NET)

were trying to kill Him: These Jewish leaders were looking for an excuse to punish Jesus with death. They were waiting for him to say or do something that would enable them to accuse him of a crime.

Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

were looking for a chance to kill him (REB)

were waiting to take his life (NIV)

wanted to kill him (NET)

to kill Him: The Jewish leaders did not want to kill Jesus themselves. They wanted the Roman authorities to order his execution (killing as punishment). So it may be natural to translate this phrase in one of these ways:

to cause him to be killed/executed

to persuade the authorities to punish him with death

John 7:2

Section 7:1–9: Jesus’ brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus’ brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus’ brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus’ brothers

Paragraph 7:1–5

Jesus realized that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. He wanted to stay away from the public as much as possible. But it was almost time for the festival of Booths, celebrated annually in Jerusalem. His brothers encouraged him to attend.

7:2

However, the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles was near.

- The Jewish Feast of Booths/Tabernacles would happen soon.
- It was almost time for the Jews to celebrate the Feast of Shelters.

However: The Greek word that the BSB translates as However here introduces some background information. The Greek word sometimes indicates a minor contrast, so some English translations like the BSB translate the word as However or “But” (NIV, NLT, REB). Jesus wanted to avoid Judea but people would expect him to go to the festival of Booths. Other English versions translate the word as “Now.” Other English translations do not translate this word (GNT, CEV, NCV, GW). Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles was near: This clause indicates that the Feast of Tabernacles would be celebrated in the near future—probably in a few days or a couple of weeks.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But soon it was time for the Jewish Festival of Shelters (NLT)

It was almost time for the Jewish festival of Booths

the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles: This phrase refers to an important Jewish feast. It was held at the time of the autumn harvest and lasted for one week. During this festival the people stayed in booths or shelters made from tree branches. They did this to remember how they had lived in tents in the desert after they left Egypt. See Deuteronomy 16:13–15.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Jewish festival of Booths (NRSV)

the Jewish Feast of Shelters (NCV)

John 7:3

Section 7:1–9: Jesus' brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus' brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus' brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus' brothers

Paragraph 7:1–5

Jesus realized that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. He wanted to stay away from the public as much as possible. But it was almost time for the festival of Booths, celebrated annually in Jerusalem. His brothers encouraged him to attend.

7:3a

So Jesus' brothers said to Him,

- So Jesus' brothers said to him,
- Jesus' brothers told/advised him,

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here connects this verse to the previous verse. Because the festival of Booths would happen soon, Jesus' brothers encouraged him to go to Judea. John's readers knew that the festival of Booths was held in Judea, so he did not have to say that. See the General Comment on 7:2–7:3a for other ways to connect these verses.

Jesus' brothers said to Him: Jesus' brothers wanted Jesus to act in a certain way. They wanted to persuade him to do something that they thought would be good for him. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Jesus' brothers advised him

Jesus' brothers: This phrase probably refers to Jesus' half-brothers, the sons of Mary and Joseph. These brothers were all younger than Jesus. See the note on 2:12b, where the same phrase is used.

to Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

said to Jesus

General Comment on 7:2–7:3a

The background information in 7:2 helps explain why Jesus' brothers said what they did in 7:3. Here are other ways to show the connection between 7:2 and 7:3a:

As the Jewish feast of Shelters drew near, his brothers said to him (NJB)

But when the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles was near, Jesus' brothers said to him (NIV)

It was almost time for the Festival of Shelters, and Jesus' brothers said to him (CEV)

7:3b

“Leave here and go to Judea,

- “You^(sing) ought/need to leave this place and visit Judea.
- “You^(sing) should not stay here. Go and attend the feast in the region/province of Judea.

Leave here and go to Judea: This is a gentle command. Jesus' brothers tried to persuade him to go to Jerusalem in Judea, where the Jewish people would celebrate the festival.

Here are other ways to translate this command:

Why don't you go to Judea? (CEV)

You should leave here and go to Judea. (NCV)

You ought to leave this place and go to the festival/feast in Judea.

here: The Greek word that the BSB translates as here refers to the region of Galilee, as contrasted with the region of Judea. Here is another way to translate this word:

this place (GNT)

7:3c

so that Your disciples there may see the works You are doing.

- Then those disciples of yours will also be able to see the miracles that you do.
- Then your followers there too can see your powerful/great deeds.

so that Your disciples there may see the works You are doing: The conjunction that the BSB translates as so that means “in order that.” Jesus’ brothers suggested that it would be good for Jesus to demonstrate his power in Judea. Then his disciples there could also see his miracles. Perhaps they knew that many of Jesus’ followers there had recently turned away from him (see 6:60, 66).

Here is another way to translate this clause:

where your followers can see your miracles (NLT)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” or “followers” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn and live according to his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. But the disciples in this verse had remained in Judea and so did not follow him to Galilee.

See how you translated this term at 1:35, 3:22, and 6:3.

there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as there in this context probably means “there also,” or “in Judea also.” Jesus had disciples in both Galilee and Judea, and most of them were in Galilee. If a literal translation would imply that Jesus’ disciples were all in Judea, it may be necessary to make it clearer. For example:

there also

may see the works You are doing: Jesus’ brothers implied that his disciples should see what he was

doing because his works were miracles. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clear that these works were powerful works or miracles. For example:

may see the great things you are doing (REB)

can see your miracles (NLT)

John 7:4

Section 7:1–9: Jesus’ brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus’ brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus’ brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus’ brothers

Paragraph 7:1–5

Jesus realized that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. He wanted to stay away from the public as much as possible. But it was almost time for the festival of Booths, celebrated annually in Jerusalem. His brothers encouraged him to attend.

7:4a

For no one who wants to be known publicly acts in secret.

- A person who wants everyone to know who he is does not act in secret.
- If you^(sing) want people to know who you are, you should not keep your deeds/miracles a secret.

For: The Greek conjunction that that BSB translates as For here introduces the reason Jesus’ brothers gave him for their advice. The word For means “because” here. Several English translations leave this conjunction implied and begin a new sentence here. For example:

No one who wants to become a public figure acts in secret. (NIV)

no one who wants to be known publicly acts in secret: This negative statement is a strong way to make a positive statement: everyone who wants to become famous acts openly (publicly). Jesus’ brothers

implied that Jesus wanted to be widely known and so he should act publicly. They wanted him to go to Judea, where the capital city Jerusalem was. Then more people would see the miracles he was doing.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no one who wants to be publicly known acts in secret (NJB)

No one does anything in secret, if they want others to know about them. (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the information in this clause. For example:

No one hides what he is doing if he wants to be well known. (GNT)

You need to act so the public can see you if you want to become famous.

In some languages it is more natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

for everyone who wants to be famous acts openly/ publicly

no one who wants to be known publicly: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as no one who wants to be known publicly means “no one who wants many people to know about him.”

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

no one who seeks to make a reputation for himself (NET)

when he wants to be known publicly (GW)

Jesus’ brothers were implying that Jesus was one of these people, someone who wanted to be widely known. You may want to make this clear. For example:

You can’t become famous if you hide like this! (NLT)

acts in secret: Jesus had not actually been acting in secret (secretly). He had been acting openly, but in the villages and small towns of Galilee. His brothers were implying that Galilee was a less important province/

region than Judea. They wanted Jesus to go to the important city of Jerusalem so that more important people would see his works. The NET footnote says: No one who seeks to make a reputation for himself does anything in secret means, in effect: “if you’re going to perform signs to authenticate yourself as Messiah, you should do them at Jerusalem.” (Jerusalem is where mainstream Jewish apocalyptic tradition held that Messiah would appear.) Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

does things secretly (GW)

hides what he does

7:4b

Since You are doing these things, show Yourself to the world.”

- You^(sing) are doing miracles, so let the others in the world see you do them.”
- Do your miracles in places where everyone can see/ notice you^(sing).”

Since You are doing these things, show Yourself to the world: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Since You are doing these things implies that Jesus was in fact doing these things. So it may be natural to make that clear. For example:

You are doing these things, so let the world see them.

let the world know what you are doing (CEV)

these things: This phrase refers to the miracles Jesus was doing. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

such wonderful things (NLT)

show Yourself to the world: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as show Yourself to the world means “cause everyone to see/know what you are doing.” Jesus’ brothers were advising him to let more people (and, especially, more important people) see what he could do. For example:

you should reveal yourself to the world (NJB)

let the whole world know about you (GNT)

you should let the world see you (GW)

the world: This phrase refers to people in general. Jesus' brothers were thinking of the people of Judea, in contrast to the small group of people in Galilee. They wanted more people to see Jesus' miracles. So it may be natural to more clearly refer to people. For example:

everyone

all the people

John 7:5

Section 7:1–9: Jesus' brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus' brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus' brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus' brothers

Paragraph 7:1–5

Jesus realized that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. He wanted to stay away from the public as much as possible. But it was almost time for the festival of Booths, celebrated annually in Jerusalem. His brothers encouraged him to attend.

7:5

For even His own brothers did not believe in Him.

- For even Jesus' own brothers did not trust in him.
- Jesus' brothers said this because even they did not believe that he was the Messiah.

For even His own brothers did not believe in Him:

This sentence is background information, so the BSB has placed this clause in parentheses. The background information explains why Jesus' brothers said what they did in 7:3–4. They said that because they did not believe that Jesus was the Messiah. So they did not understand what Jesus' purpose and plan on earth was. It is also possible to translate this clause using a negative with the verb instead of with the noun brothers. For example:

(Even Jesus' brothers did not believe in him.)
(NCV)

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here means “because.” It introduces an explanation of why Jesus' brothers just said what they did.

even His own brothers: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as even indicates surprise. The author indicated that one would expect that Jesus' brothers believed in him. It is natural to expect that Jesus' brothers believed, even if others did not.

did not believe in Him: Jesus' brothers did not accept that he was the Messiah, the Chosen Savior sent from God. The word believe includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b and 6:40b.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

had no faith in him (REB)

had not yet become his followers (CEV)

John 7:6

Section 7:1–9: Jesus' brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus' brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus' brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus' brothers

Paragraph 7:6–9

Jesus told his brothers that this was not the right time for him to go to Jerusalem.

7:6a

Therefore Jesus told them, “Although your time is always at hand,

- ¶ So Jesus said to them, “Any time is fine/good for you^(plur),

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “It does not matter when you^(plur) go,

Therefore Jesus told them: In the Greek text this expression connects to the previous sentence with a conjunction that is often translated “therefore.” It introduces Jesus’ response to his brothers. Jesus explained to them why he did not want to go to Jerusalem at that time. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

So Jesus replied (NET)

Although your time is always at hand: This clause could indicate that Jesus’ brothers could go to the festival any time they wanted. Or it could indicate that in general it did not matter when they did things.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for you any time is the right time (NJB)

Any time is right for you. (GNT)

your: The pronoun your refers to Jesus’ brothers and is plural.

7:6b

My time has not yet come.

- but the right time for me to do that has not come yet.
- but this is not the right time for me to go.

My time has not yet come: This clause indicates that this was not the right time for Jesus to act. See the note on the similar phrase “My hour has not yet come” at 2:4b. Jesus rejected his brothers’ suggestion that he should go to Judea at that time and show himself to the world.

The words My time could refer to his time to go to Judea, his time to die, or his time to reveal that he was the Messiah. The text does not explain what Jesus meant by My time, so it is recommended that you do not explain it either.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My time has not yet arrived (NET)

It is not yet the right time for me. (JBP)

My time: The Greek word that the BSB translates as time here refers to a moment in time, the correct moment for an action, an opportunity.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The right time for me (NIV93)

has not yet come: In some languages it is not possible to talk of time as “coming.” Instead it may be possible to say:

is not now

is not yet here (NIV11)

John 7:7

Section 7:1–9: Jesus’ brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus’ brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus’ brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus’ brothers

Paragraph 7:6–9

Jesus told his brothers that this was not the right time for him to go to Jerusalem.

7:7a

The world cannot hate you,

- The people of the world cannot hate you^(plur),
- The people of the world have no need/reason to hate you^(plur),

The world cannot hate you: The phrase The world refers in a general way to the people in the world. This is the first time in John that Jesus speaks of the world as his enemy. Before this he talked about loving and saving the world.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

the people of the world cannot hate you

cannot hate you: This verb clause indicates that people in general had no reason to hate Jesus’ brothers. They did not think that Jesus’ brothers were their enemies; so they did not hate and reject them. This was

true because the brothers' attitude agreed with their own, not because the people were good and loving.

7:7b

but it hates Me,

- but they do hate me
- but as for me, they do hate me

but: The conjunction but here indicates a contrast. Jesus contrasted the world's attitude to his brothers and its attitude to him.

it hates Me: The pronoun it refers to the people of the world. If you used a plural noun like "people" in 7:7a, you will need to use a plural pronoun here. For example:

but they hate me

7:7c

because I testify that its works are evil.

- because I declare against them that I know that their deeds are evil.
- because I tell them that they are doing wrong.

because: This conjunction introduces the reason why the people of the world hated Jesus.

I testify that its works are evil: The clause I testify means "I tell publicly," or "I tell what I witnessed." See the notes on 1:7a and 1:15a, where the same verb is used.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I give evidence that its ways are evil (NJB)

I keep telling it that its ways are bad (GNT)

I accuse it of doing evil (NLT)

its works are evil: Jesus declares that what people do is evil. The pronoun its refers to the people of the world that do not believe in Jesus. If you translated "The world" in 7:7a with a plural noun (such as "people"), you will need to use a plural pronoun here. For example:

they do evil things (CEV)

John 7:8

Section 7:1–9: Jesus' brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus' brothers told him that he

should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus' brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus' brothers

Paragraph 7:6–9

Jesus told his brothers that this was not the right time for him to go to Jerusalem.

7:8a

Go up to the feast on your own.

- You^(plur) go on to the Feast.
- You^(plur) yourselves can go to the Feast.

Go up to the feast on your own: The subject of this clause (you, plural) is implied in English. However, the Greek text emphasizes it, and the English emphasizes the idea with on your own. This emphasizes the contrast with the subject "I" in 7:8b, which the Greek also emphasizes.

The phrase the feast refers to the feast of Booths or Tabernacles. See how you translated this term in 7:2. Jesus was encouraging his brothers to leave Galilee and celebrate this feast in Jerusalem without him. Here is another way to translate this clause:

You go on/ahead to the feast.

Go up: The verb that the BSB translates as Go up refers to the fact that the city of Jerusalem was built on a hill. Anyone going to the city had to walk up the hill to a place that was higher up. This expression was therefore a way of referring to a pilgrimage (a journey with a religious purpose). See the note at 2:13, and see how you translated this term there.

7:8b

I am not going up to this feast,

- I am not going up to the Feast right now
- As for me, I am not going with you^(plur)

I am not going up to this feast: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include a word that means not. For example:

I am not going (GNT) (BSB, CEV, NET, REB, GNT, NLT, ESV, NASB, RSV, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts include a word that means “not yet.” For example:

I will not go yet to this feast (NCV) (KJV, NIV, NCV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because most English translations follow it. However in this context the meaning is almost the same, as is implied by the following clause. If the major language translation in your area follows option (2), you may choose to follow it. The UBS Committee only gave the reading in option (1) a C rating, meaning they are not very sure which reading is better. It may also be possible to indicate Jesus’ meaning by saying the following:

I am not going with you.

See also the General Comment on 7:8b–c for a way to reorder these clauses.

going up: The verb going up is from the same Greek verb as in 7:8a.

7:8c

because My time has not yet come.”

- because this is still not the right time for me.”
- because the time for me to go to Jerusalem is not quite here yet.”

because: The conjunction because introduces the reason Jesus did not want to go to the festival at that time.

Here is another way to translate this word:

for (NRSV)

My time has not yet come: Jesus again said that his time had not yet fully (completely) come. As in 7:6a, it is not clear what he meant by that statement. So again it is recommended that you do not explain what he meant. See the note on 7:6a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for me the right time has not yet come (NIV93)

for it is not yet time for me to go (JBP)

My time: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as My time means “my opportunity” or “the right time for me.” For example:

the right time has not come for me (GNT)

has not yet come: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has not yet come is different from the verb in 7:6a but means the same thing. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is not quite yet

is not now

General Comment on 7:8b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 7:8b–c. That would imply that Jesus would go to the festival when it was the right time. For example:

^{8c}My time hasn’t yet come, ^{8b}and I am not going. (CEV)

^{8c}This is not the right time for me, ^{8b}and so I am not going with you.

John 7:9

Section 7:1–9: Jesus’ brothers did not believe in him

Every year Jewish men went to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival of Booths. Jesus’ brothers told him that he should go, but he did not want to go at that time. They thought that he should show himself to the world, but they did not believe in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus’ brothers want him to go to the festival in Jerusalem

The unbelief of Jesus’ brothers

Paragraph 7:6–9

Jesus told his brothers that this was not the right time for him to go to Jerusalem.

7:9

Having said this, Jesus remained in Galilee.

- Having said this, he stayed in Galilee.
- And Jesus stayed in the province/area of Galilee for a while after he said this.

Having said this, Jesus remained in Galilee: In some languages it is more natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

Jesus stayed in Galilee after saying this.

Having said this: The word *this* refers to what Jesus just said to his brothers. There is a textual issue here. However, there is no real difference in meaning. Some Greek manuscripts have “to them” in this phrase. The KJV and the NASB follow those manuscripts. Many Greek manuscripts do not have “to them” in this phrase. The majority of English translations follow those manuscripts. For example: *Having said this* (NIV) In some languages it is natural to make either the subject or the object explicit. For example:

After Jesus said this to them

Jesus remained in Galilee: Jesus did not go with his brothers to Jerusalem for the festival. He remained in the province of Galilee, north of Judea, for a while longer, probably a few more days. In some languages it may be natural to indicate here that Galilee was a region or province. For example:

he stayed in the province of Galilee

John 7:10

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem
After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:10–13

Jesus went secretly to the festival. The Jewish leaders were watching for him so that they could accuse him and arrest him. Some of the people there thought that Jesus was good and others opposed him.

7:10a

But after His brothers had gone up to the feast,

- ¶ But, after his brothers left for the festival of Booths,
- ¶ Still, when his brothers had gone to Jerusalem to celebrate the Feast of Tabernacles/Shelters,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* marks a contrast with the previous verse. Jesus did in fact go to the festival, but not at that time. He went in private and after his brothers had left. Here is another way to translate this word:

However (NIV)

after His brothers had gone up to the feast: Jesus’ brothers left Galilee without him and traveled to Jerusalem to celebrate the festival. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

when his brothers had gone up to the feast (NET)

after his brothers left for the festival (NLT)

the feast: The phrase *the feast* refers to the Feast of Booths or Tabernacles. See how you translated this term in 7:2.

7:10b

He also went—not publicly, but in secret.

- Jesus went to the festival also. He did not go in public but like he was being secret/private.
- Jesus went to the feast as well, without people knowing he was going there.

He also went: The pronoun *He* refers to Jesus. Jesus went to the festival, as well as his brothers, but he went later. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

then Jesus also went to the feast

then Jesus himself also went up (NET)

not publicly: The phrase that the BSB translates as *not publicly* means “without letting people see him.” Jesus did not tell people he was going or take a large group of followers with him. He went quietly and secretly. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

without telling anyone (CEV)

but in secret: The phrase that the BSB translates as *but in secret* indicates that Jesus traveled without

telling people who he was. He did not want to attract attention by having many people follow him.

There is a textual issue here.

1. Most Greek manuscripts have words that NRSV translates as “as it were.” However, only a few English translations follow these manuscripts. For example:

but as if, in secret (NASB) (NASB, NRSV, KJV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not have the words that the NRSV translates as “as it were.” Most English translations follow these manuscripts. For example:

but secretly (NJB) (BSB, NET, ESV, NIV, CEV, GNT, NCV, NLT, REB, NJB, RSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has the support of most Greek manuscripts, even though most English translations do not follow it. Scholars have decided that the words were probably part of the original Greek text, although they are not very sure. So if major language translations in your area follow option (2), you may follow that option instead.

General Comment on 7:10b

The phrases “not publicly” and “in secret” are parallel. They mean the same thing, and in some languages it is more natural to combine them. For example:

Jesus went also. But he did not let people see him. (NCV)

General Comment on 7:10a–b

In some languages it is more natural to reverse the order of 7:10a and 7:10b. For example:

^{10b}However, Jesus went up to the feast quietly and in private ^{10a}after his brothers left.

John 7:11

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:10–13

Jesus went secretly to the festival. The Jewish leaders were watching for him so that they could accuse him and arrest him. Some of the people there thought that Jesus was good and others opposed him.

7:11a

So the Jews were looking for Him at the feast

- During the festival the Jewish leaders looked for him
- The Jewish leaders were trying to find him there,

So: In the Greek text this clause connects to the previous sentence with a conjunction that the BSB translates as So. It introduces a result of Jesus’ coming secretly: the Jewish leaders were forced to ask where he was. Some translations does not explicitly translate this conjunction, but you should do so if it is natural in your language.

the Jews were looking for Him at the feast: The Jewish leaders expected that Jesus would be at the festival and they wanted to know where he was. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

at the Feast the Jews were watching for him (NIV)

The Jewish leaders tried to find him at the festival (NLT)

During the festival the leaders looked for Jesus (CEV)

the Jews: This is a term often used in John to refer to the Jewish religious leaders who opposed Jesus. In 7:12a John used the phrase “the crowds” to refer to all the Jews. That means that the Jews here probably refers to just a group of Jews, the leaders. See how you translated this term in 7:1c. In some languages it is more natural to be more explicit. For example:

the Jewish leaders (NET)

for Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus.

7:11b

and asking, “Where is He?”

- and asked people, “Where is that man/Jesus?”
- and they asked people to tell them where he was.

and asking, “Where is He?”: In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quote here. For example:

asking where he was (REB)

kept asking if anyone had seen him (NLT)

and asking: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as and asking is more literally “and they were saying.” This phrase here introduces a question, so it may be more natural to use a word like asking, as the BSB does. In some languages you may also need to explicitly say who they were talking to. For example:

and asking people

Where is He?: The Greek question that the BSB translates as Where is He? is more literally “Where is that one?” Some commentaries say that this is a slightly insulting way to refer to Jesus. It implies that the leaders did not think that he was good. Consider how it is natural to imply this in your language. For example:

Where is that man? (NIV)

Where is that person?

In other languages it may be necessary to name Jesus. For example:

Where is that Jesus?

John 7:12

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:10–13

Jesus went secretly to the festival. The Jewish leaders were watching for him so that they could accuse him and arrest him. Some of the people there thought that Jesus was good and others opposed him.

7:12a

Many in the crowds were whispering about Him.

- There was much complaining about Jesus in the crowds.
- And the people grumbled a lot about Jesus.

This verse begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “and” (as in the NRSV). This conjunction connects the events in 7:11 and 7:12. Both events happened at the same time. In some languages it may be necessary to translate this conjunction explicitly.

Many in the crowds were whispering about Him:

This clause indicates that people were grumbling a lot about Jesus. Many of them were not happy about what he said and did. They argued about who he was. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

There was much whispering about him in the crowd. (GNT)

There was a lot of grumbling about him among the crowds. (NET)

in the crowds: The phrase the crowds refers to the large numbers of people gathered at the feast. In some languages it is more natural to say “among the many people.”

were whispering about Him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as whispering means “grumbling” or “disagreement.” It refers particularly to low or quiet grumbling, implying that they were unhappy.

7:12b-c

Some said, “He is a good man.” But others replied, “No, He deceives the people.”: The word But in this context indicates the first half of a contrast. The contrast is between what some were saying and what others were saying. In some languages it may be natural to leave it untranslated. For example:

Other people said, “No, He deceives the people.”

Another way to show the contrast is by using a word like “while” or “but” after the first clause. For example:

Some were saying, “Jesus is a good man,” while others were saying, “He is lying to everyone.” (CEV)

Some argued, “He’s a good man,” but others said, “He’s nothing but a fraud who deceives the people.” (NLT)

In some languages it is more natural to use indirect quotations here. For example:

Some of them said/thought that Jesus was a good person and others said/thought that he was deceiving the ordinary people.

7:12b

Some said, “He is a good man.”

- Some people said, “Jesus is a good man,”
- Some people said that Jesus was a good person.

He is a good man: The clause He is a good man indicates that these people approved of Jesus. The Greek word meaning good refers to someone who is morally good and righteous, and has excellent character.

7:12c

But others replied, “No, He deceives the people.”

- but other people replied, “That is not true. He is deceiving the people.”
- Others argued that he was leading the ordinary/common people the wrong way.

But others replied, “No, He deceives the people.”: The clause others replied indicates that there was another group of people who disagreed with the first.

No: This word begins the other people’s response to the ones who said that Jesus was a good man. They disagreed and argued with the first group. In some languages it may be helpful to make this explicit:

No, he is not a good man.

No, he isn’t. (GW)

He deceives the people: This clause wrongly accuses Jesus of pretending to be something he was not. They thought that he was encouraging people to believe a lie, that he was the Messiah. However, that was really the truth.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he is leading the people the wrong way

He is lying to everyone. (CEV)

the people: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the people here refers in general to the ordinary Jewish people. The speakers probably did not think of themselves as belonging to the crowd. They seemed to think that they were wiser than the crowd, perhaps because they went to school longer than ordinary people.

Here are some ways that you may be able to imply this attitude:

the common people (NET)

the general public

John 7:13

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:10–13

Jesus went secretly to the festival. The Jewish leaders were watching for him so that they could accuse him and arrest him. Some of the people there thought that Jesus was good and others opposed him.

7:13a-b

Yet no one would speak publicly about Him for fear of the Jews: In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 7:13a and 7:13b. For example:

^{13b}But the people were afraid of their leaders,
^{13a}and none of them talked in public about him.
(CEV)

7:13a

Yet no one would speak publicly about Him

- But everyone refused to say anything publicly about Jesus

- However, no one discussed Jesus in public,

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet indicates contrast. The people wondered about Jesus, but no one wanted to say anything publicly.

Here are other ways to indicate the contrast:

But (NLT)

However (NET)

no one would speak publicly about Him: This clause indicates that people quietly whispered their opinions but did not say anything in public. Some think that this statement only applied to those who approved of Jesus (see Krause and NLT), but there is nothing in the Greek that says that. Most translations and commentaries apply the words “no one” to those who approved of Jesus and also those who opposed him.

no one: These words refer to the many people who had come to Jerusalem. None of these people would say anything about Jesus in public.

would speak publicly: This phrase means that no one in the crowd chose to speak in public. To speak publicly means to speak in public where anyone could hear them. They did not want the Jewish leaders to hear them. That is why they were careful about who they talked to and how loudly they talked.

about Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to use the proper name here. For example:

about Jesus (NCV)

7:13b

for fear of the Jews.

- because they were afraid of the Jewish leaders.
- because they were afraid that the Jewish leaders would punish them.

for fear of the Jews: The ordinary people were afraid that their religious leaders would be angry with them if they heard them talk about Jesus. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this phrase as a verb clause. For example:

because they were afraid of the Jews (GW)

the Jews: As in 7:1c and 7:11a, this phrase refers to the Jewish leaders. The people who were afraid were

also Jews. What John said is that the crowd of ordinary Jews was afraid of the Jewish leaders. For example:

the people were afraid of their leaders (CEV)

for they were afraid of getting in trouble with the Jewish leaders (NLT)

John 7:14

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:14a

About halfway through the feast, Jesus went up to the temple courts

- ¶ When half the feast was finished, Jesus went up to the temple,
- ¶ While the Jewish people were in the middle of celebrating the Feast of Booths, Jesus entered the temple courts.

About halfway through the feast, Jesus went up to the temple courts: Jesus had traveled to Jerusalem for the Jewish festival of Booths after his brothers. He did not go to the temple and begin to teach until half of the festival was finished. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When the feast was about half over, Jesus went to the temple. (NCV)

Then, midway through the festival, Jesus went up to the Temple. (NLT)

the feast: This phrase refers to the Feast of Booths or Tabernacles. See how you translated this term in 7:2.

Jesus went up: The verb phrase went up refers to going to a higher place, like a hill. The temple was on high ground. See the note on “go” at 7:8a.

to the temple courts: The phrase that the BSB translates as the temple here refers to the temple courts, an area where Jesus could teach. See the note on 2:14a, where the same phrase is used.

7:14b and began to teach.

- and he began to teach there.
- He taught the people there.

and began to teach: This clause indicates that Jesus began to teach the people in the temple courts. In some languages it is more natural to make the subject and/or object explicit. For example:

and Jesus began teaching the people there

John 7:15

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the

Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:15a

The Jews were amazed and asked,

- The Jewish leaders were amazed and asked,
- The Jewish leaders were surprised. They said to one another,

The BSB leaves implicit a Greek word in this clause that is usually translated as “therefore.” Most other English translations also leave the word implicit, although a few translations use “then” or “therefore” to translate it. Translate this Greek word in a way that is natural in your language.

The Jews: This phrase refers to the Jewish leaders here. See how you translated this term in 7:1, 7:11 and 7:13. Make sure it is clear that you are referring to the same people in those verses. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The Jewish authorities (GNT)

the Jewish leaders (NET)

The leaders (CEV)

were amazed: This expression is more literally “were astonished” in the Greek text. The expression indicates that the Jewish leaders were amazed at Jesus’ teaching. They did not expect that he would know so much and be able to teach so well. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

were amazed (NIV)

were greatly surprised (GNT)

asked: The verb asked here introduces a rhetorical question. In some languages it may be more natural to translate it in one of these ways:

and asked each other

7:15b

“How did this man attain such learning without having studied?”

- “How did this man learn so much about the Law/Scriptures without studying with/under us^(incl)?”
- “This man has never studied in our^(incl) schools. How does he know all this?”

How did this man attain such learning without having studied?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jewish leaders used it as an expression of surprise. The Jewish leaders were surprised at Jesus' excellent understanding of their religion.

There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How is it that this untrained man has such learning? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

This man certainly knows a lot about the Law/Torah for someone who has never studied it!

- Use both a question and a statement. For example:

How does this man know so much? He has never been taught! (CEV)

Translate this expression of surprise in a way that is natural in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

The rabbis have never taught this man the Law/Scriptures! Yet he knows so much about it!

How did this man attain such learning: The phrase such learning here means "such great learning." It refers to the fact that Jesus' teaching showed that he understood well the Jewish Law and the Hebrew Scriptures. The people speaking wondered how he got this understanding. In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit what Jesus had learned (the Jewish Law). For example:

How did this man learn so much about our^(incl) Law?

In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun learning as a verb. For example:

How does this man know so much...? (GNT)

without having studied: This clause indicates why the Jewish leaders were surprised. They were surprised at Jesus' learning because he had not been

taught the Law by the rabbis. He had not studied to be a professional teacher of the Torah. The clause does not mean that Jesus had not learned anything, like how to read.

John 7:16

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:16a

"My teaching is not My own," Jesus replied.

- Jesus answered them, "My message is not my own ideas.
- Jesus replied to them, "What I teach is not what I invented myself.

My teaching is not My own: This clause means "I am not teaching things that I invented myself." Jesus was saying that the source of his teaching was not his own mind or thinking. In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun teaching as a verb. For example:

What I teach doesn't come from me (GW)

The things I teach are not my own ideas.

7:16b

"It comes from Him who sent Me.

- This message comes from God, who sent me here.

- Rather, God sent me here and he tells me what I should say.

The Greek conjunction that the BSB does not translate here connects a negative statement (7:16a) to a positive statement (7:16b). The negative statement says what is not true, while the positive statement says what is true. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement.

Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. For example:

- Use a conjunction like “but” as in the NRSV. For example:

What I teach doesn’t come from me but from the one who sent me. (GW)

- After the negative statement, use a conjunction other than “but” to indicate the positive statement. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

My teaching is not mine, rather/instead it is his who sent me.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

My teaching is not mine. It is his who sent me.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

The one who sent me told me what to teach. What I teach did not come from my own mind.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

It comes from Him who sent Me: This expression is a short way of saying “my teaching is from the one who sent me.” In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete clause or sentence. For example:

What I teach comes from the one who sent me. (CEV)

God is the one who sent Jesus to the world. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

it comes from God who sent me (NLT)

John 7:17

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:17a

If anyone desires to do His will,

- When someone decides to do God’s will,
- Those who want to obey God

If anyone desires to do His will: This expression refers to anyone and everyone who decides to obey God, and does obey him. The word desires here means “decides or determines to do something.”

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Whoever chooses to do the will of God (REB)

Those who choose to obey God

If anyone wants to do God’s will (NET)

to do His will: This phrase refers to obeying God. In some languages it is more natural to express His will as a phrase with a verb. For example:

do what God wants (NCV)

7:17b

he will know whether My teaching is from God

- he will understand whether what I say is from God
- will realize/discover that what I say is from God.

7:17c**or whether I speak on My own.**

- or whether I speak my own thoughts.
- It is not my own ideas.

7:17b–c

he will know whether My teaching is from God or whether I speak on My own: This part of the sentence indicates that the people referred to in 7:17a receive spiritual wisdom. They are able to know if Jesus' message was from God or not. And Jesus implied that his teaching was truly from God.

A literal translation of 7:17b–c may wrongly imply that Jesus was not sure that his teaching came from God. It may be necessary to make the correct meaning explicit. For example:

they will know that my teaching comes from God and not from men (NCV)

know: In this context the verb know refers to understanding a situation correctly. These people will make the right choice between two possible ways of understanding Jesus and his message.

Here are other ways to translate this verb:

distinguish

realize

My teaching: In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun teaching using a verb. For example:

what I teach (GNT)

is from God: This phrase means “is given by God.” What Jesus taught was what God told him to say. God sent him and gave him the message. Here is another way to translate this phrase

comes from God (GNT)

whether I speak on My own: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as speak on My own refers to speaking one's own ideas, or on one's own authority. It is the opposite of speaking because someone is obeying God and depending on him. See the note on 5:19b, “the Son can do nothing by Himself.”

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if I teach my own thoughts (GW)

whether I speak on my own authority (GNT)

General Comment on 7:17

Verse 17 is one long sentence with many clauses. In some languages it may be clearer if you use more than one sentence. For example:

If anyone chooses to do God's will, then he will know the source of what I teach. He will know whether God is the source of my teaching or whether it comes from my own mind.

John 7:18**Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem**

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:18a**He who speaks on his own authority seeks his own glory,**

- People who speak/declare their own thoughts want others to praise them,
- A person who expresses his own ideas is trying to find honor for himself,

He who speaks on his own authority seeks his own glory: This clause refers to people who teach their own ideas or on their own authority. Their teaching does not come from God and God did not send them. Jesus said that people who did that sought their own glory.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Those who teach their own ideas are trying to get honor for themselves. (NCV)

Those who speak on their own authority are trying to gain glory for themselves. (GNT)

This clause refers to anyone and everyone who speaks their own words and ideas. Those people's motives are selfish because they want other people to praise them. So, the examples above use a plural subject, "Those who." In some languages it may be natural to translate it in the singular, as in the BSB.

seeks his own glory: This phrase means "want others to praise them." These people say what they do so that others will admire and praise them. In some languages it may be natural to translate glory as a verb. For example:

want others to praise/honor them

want to be praised/honored

7:18b

but He who seeks the glory of the One who sent Him is a man of truth;

- but he whose desire/motive is to bring glory to the one who sent him is honest.
- but the true/genuine man wants people to praise/honor God who sent him.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here indicates a contrast between the people described in 7:18a and the one described here. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here.

He who seeks the glory of the One who sent Him is a man of truth: This clause refers to true teachers in general. But Jesus also implied that he was an example of that kind of teacher. He himself was a man who wanted glory for the one who sent him. In some languages a literal translation may imply that Jesus was speaking only of others, not himself. If this is true

in your language, it may be necessary to explicitly say that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

I want to honor the one who sent me. That is why I tell the truth.... (CEV)

seeks the glory of the One who sent Him: The expression seeks the glory of means to try to bring praise or honor to someone. In this context, Jesus wanted to honor God. It would be good to emphasize the contrast with 7:18a by using the same expression that you used there. See the note and translation examples there.

the One who sent Him: This expression refers to God, who sent Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

God who sent me

is a man of truth: The word truth here describes someone who tells the truth. Jesus implied that he could be trusted because he spoke what is true. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is honest (GNT)

speak the truth (NCV)

7:18c

in Him there is no falsehood.

- There is nothing false in what he says.
- And that man does not deceive others at all.

in Him there is no falsehood: This clause is another way of saying that he is completely true or genuine. Repeating this idea is a way to emphasize that there is absolutely nothing untrue in him. The Greek word that the BSB translates as falsehood normally means "unrighteousness" and a few English translations translate it that way. However, most English translations use words like "false," "dishonest (not honest)," or "lie." The Greek word probably means more than just telling lies here. It probably includes at least some of the meaning of "unrighteousness." But perhaps that is implied in the word "dishonest." If one is not dishonest, it probably means that he is righteous.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he does not deceive at all

he does not tell lies

General Comment on 7:18b–c

The clause “in Him there is no falsehood” is the negative of the positive statement in 7:18b, “is a man of truth.” The negative and positive statements are parallel; they mean the same thing and repeating the idea emphasizes it.

Here are some other ways to translate these parallel statements:

but a person who seeks to honor the one who sent him speaks truth, not lies (NLT)

but he who seeks the glory of the one who sent him is a man of truth; there is nothing false about him (NIV)

John 7:19

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:19a

Has not Moses given you the law?

- Has not Moses given you^(plur) the law?
- It was Moses who long ago gave you^(plur) the law of God.

Has not Moses given you the law?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to make a strong statement. Jesus wanted to emphasize that Moses gave

the Law to the Jewish people. There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Moses gave you the Law, didn’t he? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Moses gave you the law. (NLT)

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language.

Moses: The Hebrew prophet and leader Moses lived hundreds of years before Christ. His name also occurs in 1:17a.

given you the law: The word law here refers to the rules that God gave to his people through Moses. This law is recorded in the first five books of the Hebrew Scriptures. It consisted of many separate different laws/rules. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clearer. For example:

set/collection of laws/rules

7:19b

Yet not one of you keeps it.

- However, no one of/among you^(plur) keeps this/that law.
- But you^(plur) all fail to follow/obey it.

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet marks a surprising contrast. Moses gave the law, so we expect that people would obey it. However, they did not obey the law.

Here is another way to translate this word:

But (GNT)

not one of you keeps it: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as keeps it is more literally “does the law.” It refers to obeying the commands that Moses received from God.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

not one of you obeys the law (GNT)

none of you does what Moses taught you (GW)

7:19c**Why are you trying to kill Me?"**

- Why are you^(plur) trying to kill me?"
- In fact, you^(plur) want me to be killed."

Why are you trying to kill Me?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus was saying that the Jewish leaders wanted to kill him. See 5:18a and 7:1c and the notes there. This was an example of how they did not obey the law, which said "You shall not murder" (Exodus 20:13; Deuteronomy 5:17).

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you want to kill me? (NJB)

- Use a statement. For example:

In fact, you are trying to kill me. (NLT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 7:20**Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem**

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:20a**"You have a demon," the crowd replied.**

- "There is a demon in you^(sing)," the people answered.
- "You^(sing) are possessed by a demon," all the people said.

You have a demon: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as You have a demon means "an evil spirit controls you." The crowd was saying that an evil spirit caused Jesus to think that people wanted to kill him.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

A demon has come into you. (NCV)

You are demon-possessed! (NIV)

It is a demon making you think/say that!

a demon: The Greek word that the BSB translates as demon refers to a spiritual being who serves Satan. See how you translated this word in Matthew 11:18, Mark 3:14–15, and Luke 8:27–30.

the crowd replied: The phrase the crowd refers to a large number of people, who were speaking together. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the people answered (NCV)

7:20b**"Who is trying to kill You?"**

- "Who do you think is trying to kill you^{(sing)?}"
- "There is no one trying to kill you^(sing)."

Who is trying to kill You?: This is a rhetorical question. The people used it to make a strong statement. The people were saying that Jesus was wrong, that no one was trying to kill him.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What makes you think someone wants to kill you? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

We are not trying to kill you. (NCV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 7:20a–b

In some languages a literal translation of the BSB may cause listeners to wrongly understand what the crowd said. They may wrongly think that the crowd said, “You have a demon who is trying to kill you.” In order to avoid this wrong understanding, it may be helpful to reverse the order of the clauses. For example:

^{20b}Who is trying to kill you? ^{20a}You have a demon!

John 7:21

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:21a

Jesus answered them, “I did one miracle,

- Jesus said to the crowd, “I did one miracle,
- Jesus replied to the crowd, “When I did that one miracle on the Sabbath,

I did one miracle: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as one miracle here refers to the miracle that Jesus did when he healed the paralyzed man on the Sabbath (which 7:23 makes clear). That miracle is described in 5:1–10. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus did the work on the Sabbath. For example:

I did one miracle on the Sabbath (NLT)

In your translation, avoid implying that Jesus had done only one miracle, or only one miracle on the Sabbath. He was referring back to one specific miracle. In some languages it may be natural to make it clear that Jesus was referring to a specific miracle:

I did that one work/miracle

7:21b

and you are all amazed.

- and you^(plur) are all amazed.
- it amazed you^(plur) all.

and you are all amazed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as amazed here refers to feeling surprised or shocked (surprised in an unpleasant way). The Jewish people were shocked that Jesus did a healing miracle on the Sabbath.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it amazed you (CEV)

General Comment on 7:21a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the clauses in 7:21a–b. For example:

^{21b}You are all astonished ^{21a}at that one miracle that I did.

^{21b}You are all shocked ^{21a}that/when I did that one miracle.

John 7:22

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus’ teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach

in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:22a

But because Moses gave you circumcision,

- However, because Moses gave you^(plur) the practice of circumcision
- Moses commanded/ordered you^(plur) to circumcise your sons,

because: In the Greek text 7:22a connects with 7:21 with a phrase that is often translated as “because of this” and the BSB translates as because. There are different ways to interpret this here:

1. It belongs with verse 22 and refers forward, meaning “because of this Moses gave circumcision.” John always uses this Greek phrase at the beginning of clauses and never at the end. It seems to say here that Moses commanded circumcision on the Sabbath so that Jesus could heal on the Sabbath. Moses’ law would show that Jesus was allowed to heal on the Sabbath. For example:

For this reason Moses has given you circumcision..., and on the Sabbath you circumcise a man. (NASB) (BSB, NASB, KJV, NIV, NET)

1. It belongs with verse 21 and means “at it” or “by it” (they were “surprised by the miracle Jesus did”). For example:

all of you are surprised by it. Moses gave you the teaching about circumcision.... (GW) (GW, RSV, ESV, NJB, CEV, NABRE)

This phrase is difficult to interpret and translate. Many translations (GNT, NCV, NRSV, REB, and NLT) leave this phrase untranslated or implied. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), or else leave the phrase untranslated/implied, as the BSB has done. It is also possible to follow the major national translation used in your area. Here is another way to follow interpretation (1):

Therefore Moses gave you circumcision..., and you circumcise a boy on the Sabbath.

Moses gave you circumcision: The clause gave you circumcision means “commanded the Hebrew/Jewish people to circumcise their males.” Circumcision is included in the law of Moses. See, for example, Leviticus 12:3.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Moses gave you the practice of circumcision (NET)

Moses ordered you to circumcise your sons (GNT)

circumcision: The noun circumcision refers to the practice of cutting off the loose skin of a boy’s or man’s sex organ. They did this to mark them as members of God’s people. Translate this in a way that does not offend or embarrass people. Some languages use a more general phrase such as “make a mark by cutting the skin.” If you use a general expression, it may be necessary to include a footnote or a note in the glossary. Explain the expression so that people can understand exactly what circumcision is.

Here is an example of a possible footnote:

Circumcision was a symbol of the covenant that God made with Abraham and Abraham’s descendants. They were supposed to circumcise every male child on the eighth day after he was born (Genesis 17:9–14, 21:4; Leviticus 12:3). See the Translator’s Reference Translation on TW.

7:22b

you circumcise a boy on the Sabbath

- you^(plur) circumcise a boy even on the/a Sabbath.
- and so you^(plur) are willing to do this ceremony on the/a Sabbath.

you circumcise a boy on the Sabbath: The Jewish people circumcised boys on the eighth day after their birth. If a boy was born on a Sabbath (Saturday), they circumcised him on the next Sabbath. They did not wait to circumcise the boy later to avoid doing it on the Sabbath, a day of rest. They thought it was more important to circumcise the boy than to obey the Sabbath law.

The Greek text emphasizes the phrase on the Sabbath. It does that because the important thing was the day that they circumcised, not just that they circumcised. The day was important because it proved Jesus’ argument.

In some languages a literal translation may indicate that all boys were circumcised on the Sabbath. To avoid this wrong meaning it may be necessary to say:

you circumcise even on the sabbath (REB)

you are willing/prepared to cut a boy's skin on the Sabbath

a boy: Normally someone circumcised a baby boy when he was eight days old. So in some languages it may be natural to say specifically:

a male child (NET)

your son (NLT)

a baby (NCV)

the Sabbath: This phrase here and in the following verse refers to any Sabbath day, not just one particular Sabbath. So in some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase without a definite article (the). For example:

a Sabbath

The word Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. It was the special day in the week when they rested and worshiped God. It was against the law to do any work on that day.

Here are some ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the sabat, the Jews' rest day

See how you translated Sabbath at 5:9c.

7:22c

(not that it is from Moses, but from the patriarchs.)

- (or, rather, the earlier ancestors did),
- (though your^(plur)/our^(incl) ancestors/forefathers before him were actually the ones to do/command this first),

(not that it is from Moses, but from the patriarchs.):

The BSB placed this clause in parentheses to indicate that it is not part of the main argument. Jesus, or perhaps the author, was correcting the idea that the practice of circumcision began with Moses.

Here are other ways to translate this parenthetical comment:

though actually it did not come from Moses, but from the patriarchs (NIV)

although it was not Moses but your ancestors who started it (GNT)

Moses commanded you to circumcise your males, a command that he inherited from his ancestors

The patriarchs lived several hundred years before Moses. In your translation, make sure that it is clear that the patriarchs lived before Moses. For example:

not that it began with him, it goes back to the patriarchs (NJB)

(Actually, this tradition of circumcision began with the patriarchs, long before the law of Moses.) (NLT)

the patriarchs: This phrase refers to the ancestors of the Jewish people, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. If your language has a special term for the people who started a nation, it is good to use that here. But if no term like that is common in your language, you can use a more general term for ancestors. For example:

your ancestors (GNT)

your earlier ancestors/forefathers

John 7:23

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders

were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:23a

If a boy can be circumcised on the Sabbath

- Considering that a boy can be circumcised on the/a Sabbath
- You can circumcise someone^(masc) on the/a Sabbath

If a boy can be circumcised on the Sabbath: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *If a boy can be circumcised on the Sabbath* means “Because you circumcise boys on the Sabbath.” It refers to the situation in 7:22b, where a baby born on the Sabbath is circumcised on the next Sabbath.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

If someone can be circumcised on the Sabbath (NJB)

For if the correct time for circumcising your son falls on the Sabbath, you go ahead and do it (NLT)

7:23b

so that the law of Moses will not be broken,

- to avoid disobeying the law of Moses,
- in order to keep the law of Moses.

so that the law of Moses will not be broken: This is a purpose clause. It indicates that the purpose of circumcising on the Sabbath is to avoid breaking (disobeying) the law of Moses. The law of Moses required the people of Israel to circumcise their sons on the eighth day after their birth. In some languages it may

be natural to translate this as a positive purpose. For example:

in order to obey the Law of Moses (CEV)

The verb phrase will not be broken in this context means “may not be disobeyed.” It is a passive verb.

Here are some ways to translate this verb phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that Moses' Law is not broken (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

to avoid breaking the law of Moses (REB)

to follow Moses' Teachings (GW)

Translate this verb in the way that is most natural in your language.

7:23c

why are you angry with Me for making the whole man well on the Sabbath?

- why are you^(plur) angry with me because I gave a man full healing on the/a Sabbath?
- So you^(plur) should not be angry with me because I made someone^(masc) completely well on the/a Sabbath.

why are you angry with Me for making the whole man well on the Sabbath?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it as a rebuke. Jesus was saying that the people should not be angry with him for healing a man on the Sabbath. They should not be angry with Jesus because they do the same thing that they accuse him of doing.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

why are you angry with me for making someone completely healthy on a Sabbath? (NJB)

why are you angry with me for healing the whole man on the Sabbath? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

You^(plur) should not be angry with me for healing a man's whole body on the Sabbath.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your own language.

making the whole man well: There is an implied contrast between this clause and the act of circumcision, which affected only part of the body. Jesus had made the paralyzed man entirely well, so that his whole body was cured.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I made a man's whole body well (ESV)

I made a man completely well (NET)

the whole man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as man is the same word that the BSB translates as "boy" in 7:23a. It is good to use the same word in both places to help the reader understand the sentence's logic. However, the word man in 7:23a refers to a baby boy, and in 7:23c to an adult man. Consider what term you could use that would naturally refer to both a baby and an adult male. For example:

someone^(masc)

General Comment on 7:23a–c

In the Greek, as in the BSB, 7:23a–c forms one long sentence, a rhetorical question. In some languages it may be natural to divide this sentence into two or more separate sentences. For example:

For if the correct time for circumcising your son falls on the Sabbath, you go ahead and do it so as not to break the law of Moses. So why should you be angry with me for healing a man on the Sabbath? (NLT)

John 7:24

Section 7:10–24: Jesus went to the Feast in Jerusalem

After Jesus stayed in Galilee a while, he went up quietly by himself. The crowds there disagreed about whether Jesus was a good man. He began to teach the people gathered at the temple and the Jewish leaders were amazed at his teaching. Jesus explained that his teaching came from God. Then he made them angry by saying that none of them kept the law.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus began to teach at the festival of Booths

Jesus' teaching came from God

Paragraph 7:14–24

Jesus went up to the festival of Booths/Tabernacles in Jerusalem while it was happening. He began to teach in the temple. His teaching amazed the Jewish leaders because he never had a religious education like theirs. Jesus stated that his teaching was not his own but came directly from God. He said that the leaders were wrong to criticize him for healing people on the Sabbath. They themselves also worked on the Sabbath sometimes, when they did a circumcision ceremony.

7:24a

Stop judging by outward appearances,

- Stop^(plur) judging by what you^(plur) see on the surface.
- You^(plur) should not judge by external standards.

Stop judging by outward appearances: Jesus was rebuking the people for making judgments based on what things look like on the outside (their appearance). He was saying that they were wrong to criticize him for healing someone on a Sabbath. This is a negative command, a command to stop doing something.

In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a positive command. For example:

Look beneath the surface (NLT)

by outward appearances: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by outward appearances means "based on what things or actions look like on the outside." It refers to the outer appearance of something as opposed to the reality.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

by the way things look (NCV)

by external standards (GNT)

7:24b

and start judging justly."

- Instead judge with justice/fairness."
- Judge according to the truth."

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here connects a negative statement (7:24a) to a positive statement (7:24b). The negative statement says what is not true, while the positive statement says what is true. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis.

Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use a conjunction like “but” as in the NRSV. For example:

You must not judge by the appearance of things but by the reality! (JBP)

- After the negative statement, use a conjunction other than “but” to indicate the positive statement. For example:

Stop judging by outward appearance! Instead, judge correctly. (GW)

Stop judging by external standards, and judge by true standards. (GNT)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Don’t judge by appearances. Judge by what is right. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Judge correctly, not just based on what things look like on the outside.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

start judging justly: This clause means to judge fairly (with justice). It is in contrast to the judgment based on external appearance that Jesus condemned in 7:24a.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

judge by true standards (GNT)

judge by what is really right (NCV)

be just in your judgements (REB)

John 7:25

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:25–27

No one stopped Jesus preaching, and some people from Jerusalem noticed that. They began to wonder if the Jewish leaders did not stop him because they changed their ideas about him. But the people knew who Jesus was and where he came from. They thought that they would not know where the Messiah was from.

7:25a

Then some of the people of Jerusalem began to say,

- ¶ Then some of the people living in Jerusalem said,
- ¶ At this point some inhabitants/citizens of Jerusalem started to talk/ask about Jesus. They said,

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is more literally “therefore.” Here it introduces what the people said about Jesus as a result of what he just said. Here are other ways to translate this word:

So (NASB)

some of the people of Jerusalem began to say:

This clause introduces how some people who lived in Jerusalem reacted to Jesus’ teaching. What they said, the quotation that follows, is a rhetorical question. So it may be natural to use a word like “ask” when you translate this clause. For example:

some of the people of Jerusalem began to ask (NIV)

7:25b

“Isn’t this the man they are trying to kill?”

- “Our^(incl) leaders are trying to kill this man, are they not?
- “This is the man the authorities seek to kill!

Isn’t this the man they are trying to kill?: This is a rhetorical question that expects the answer “yes.” The people used it to express surprise. The people were confused because they did not understand why the authorities (the Jewish leaders) allowed Jesus to teach in public. They expected that the authorities would arrest him, but they had not.

They did not doubt that the authorities were actually trying to kill Jesus. They knew that this was true, and they were not surprised about it. Instead, they were surprised that the authorities allowed Jesus to teach publicly.

There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Isn't this the man they want to kill? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

This is the man they are trying to kill. (NCV)

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language. If using a question implies that people did not know whether the authorities wanted to kill Jesus, it is recommended that you use a statement. See the second meaning line in the Display.

they are trying to kill: The verb are trying can also mean “want.” The Greek is not clear whether they already did something to try to kill Jesus or they just wanted to. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that the subject, they, refers to the Jewish leaders. These leaders were not trying to kill Jesus personally, so it may be necessary to say:

the authorities/leaders are trying to cause him to be punished by death

our^(incl) leaders want/seek his death

General Comment on 7:25a–b

A new paragraph begins at this point, and this may mark the beginning of a passage read in church or public. It is therefore good to indicate that the “man” referred to is Jesus. For example:

^{25a}Some of the people living in Jerusalem then began to discuss Jesus, saying, ^{25b}“This is the man they want to have killed!...”

^{25a}Some of the people of Jerusalem began to say, ^{25b}“This Jesus is the one the authorities/leaders want to punish with death!...”

John 7:26

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:25–27

No one stopped Jesus preaching, and some people from Jerusalem noticed that. They began to wonder if the Jewish leaders did not stop him because they changed their ideas about him. But the people knew who Jesus was and where he came from. They thought that they would not know where the Messiah was from.

7:26a

Yet here He is, speaking publicly,

- And look, he is speaking publicly,
- Yet he is teaching in public right here,

Yet here He is, speaking publicly: This clause emphasizes the fact that Jesus was teaching publicly (in public).

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Look! He is talking in public (GNT)

But he is teaching where everyone can see and hear him (NCV)

Yet here He is: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Yet here He is directs attention to Jesus and what the speakers say about him. See the note on “See” at 5:14b and the notes on 3:26d, where there is a similar expression (just without the “and”).

Here is another way to translate this expression:

But look at this! (GW)

speaking publicly: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as speaking publicly refers to public speech, speech that can be heard by anyone. Jesus

was not trying to avoid the authorities hearing him by teaching his disciples in secret.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

speaking for everyone to hear (CEV)

7:26b

and they are not saying anything to Him.

- yet they do not say anything to stop him.
- and no one has said anything to challenge/rebuke him.

and they are not saying anything to Him: The pronoun they refers to the Jewish authorities. They were not trying to stop Jesus from preaching, so it appeared that they allowed it.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and they say nothing against him (GNT)

and no one has said a word to him

7:26c

Have the rulers truly recognized that this is the Christ?

- Is it possible that our^(incl) leaders/rulers decided that he really is the Messiah?
- Maybe/Perhaps they have concluded that this man really is the Christ whom God has sent/chosen.

Have the rulers truly recognized that this is the Christ?: This is a rhetorical question. The people used it to express that they were uncertain. They were confused. Their leaders said that they did not believe that Jesus was the Christ, yet they did not stop him from preaching. The people wondered if they had changed their minds about Jesus.

There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you suppose the authorities know that he is the Messiah? (CEV)

Have the authorities really concluded that he is the Christ? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Maybe the leaders have decided he really is the Christ. (NCV)

Surely our leaders haven't decided that this really is the Christ! (JBP)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for expressing that someone is uncertain.

the Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Christ means "anointed one." Many English versions translate the phrase as "the Messiah" based on the Hebrew word. Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God appointed and promised to send as king and savior.

Here are some ways to translate Christ or Messiah:

- Translate the meaning. For example:

appointed one

Chosen Savior

- Transliterate it. For example:

Messia

Kristos

- Transliterate Christ or Messiah and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Messia, the appointed one

Cristo, the savior God promised

the Christ who comes from God

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to explain it in a footnote. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title "Christ" refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send.

See how you translated the Christ in 1:20 and 4:29b. See also Christ, Messiah in KBT.

John 7:27

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:25–27

No one stopped Jesus preaching, and some people from Jerusalem noticed that. They began to wonder if the Jewish leaders did not stop him because they changed their ideas about him. But the people knew who Jesus was and where he came from. They thought that they would not know where the Messiah was from.

7:27a

But we know where this man is from.

- But we^(incl) know where this man comes from.
- But we^(incl) know that this man comes from Nazareth.

See the General Comment on 7:27a–c for a way to reorder the clauses in this verse.

But we know where this man is from: This clause indicates that the people all knew that Jesus was from the town called Nazareth in Galilee. This was his home town, and he was often called “Jesus of Nazareth.” (See John 1:45, and also Mark 1:9, 24.) In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly where Jesus was from. For example:

But we know this man is from Nazareth

But: This conjunction here indicates that the people were challenging the suggestion in 7:26c that Jesus might actually be the Messiah. They knew where Jesus came from, which would not be true if he was the Messiah.

we: This pronoun is inclusive here. The people of Jerusalem were talking to each other.

this man: This phrase refers to Jesus. The people referred to Jesus in a way that did not show respect.

7:27b

When the Christ comes,

- However, when the real/true Messiah arrives,
- It will be different when the Christ, the chosen Savior, actually arrives.

In Greek this clause begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “but.” It introduces a contrast between what they thought was true about Jesus and what they believed about the Messiah. They thought that they knew where Jesus was from, but they believed that they would not know where the Messiah was from. That made them doubt that Jesus was the Messiah. It may be helpful to make this clear. For example:

But how could that be? (CEV)

When the Christ comes: This clause refers to a time that they thought was still in the future. They did not think that Jesus was the Messiah, so they thought that the Messiah had not yet come. In some languages it may be good to make this idea clearer. For example:

when the Messiah will come

when the real Christ comes (NCV)

7:27c

no one will know where He is from.”

- we^(incl) will not know where he comes from.”
- People will not know his origin.”

no one will know where He is from: This clause explains something many Jewish people at that time believed about the Messiah. They thought no one would know his origin. The Messiah would just come or appear and no one would know where he had come from. For example:

he will simply appear; no one will know where he comes from (NLT)

General Comment on 7:27b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 7:27b and 7:27c. For example:

No one knows where the Messiah will come from. (CEV)

General Comment on 7:27a–c

The Greek text states first what is known (where Jesus is from) and then what is unknown (where the Messiah is from). The BSB follows the order of the Greek. How-

ever in some languages it is more natural to reverse the order of 7:27a and b-c. For example:

^{27b}But when the Messiah comes, ^{27c}no one will know where he is from. ^{27a}And we all know where this man comes from. (GNT)

^{27b-c}No one knows where the Messiah will come from, ^{27a}but we know where this man comes from. (CEV)

John 7:28

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:28–31

Jesus continued teaching in the temple. He declared that he was from God and that he knew God. Some of the people listening were angry and wanted to arrest him, but many others believed that he was the Messiah.

7:28a

Then Jesus, still teaching in the temple courts, cried out,

- ¶ Jesus was still teaching in the temple courts. He proclaimed,
- ¶ While Jesus was still teaching the people in the temple courts, he called out,

Then Jesus, still teaching in the temple courts, cried out: Jesus continued to teach in the temple courtyard. See 7:14.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Then Jesus cried out as he was teaching in the temple... (NRSV)

While Jesus was teaching in the Temple, he called out... (NLT)

Then Jesus, in the middle of his teaching, called out... (JBP)

still teaching in the temple courts: Jesus continued to teach in the temple. He was not in the main building but in the courtyard. See the notes on 7:14a, b and use the same terms for teaching and temple here and there.

cried out: The Greek verb the BSB translates cried out indicates that Jesus spoke out loudly so that everyone could hear him. In some languages it may be natural to use a different verb. For example:

Jesus proclaimed

Jesus shouted

7:28b

“You know Me, and you know where I am from.”

- “Do you^(plur) really know who I am and where I come from?
- “So you^(plur) think that you know me! And you think that you know where I came from!

You know Me, and you know where I am from: There are two ways to interpret this sentence.

1. It is a rhetorical question with the implied answer that they did not know him or where he came from. For example:

Do you really know me and know where I am from? (GNT) (CEV, GNT, RSV, ESV07, NET footnote) Although the NET translates this as a positive statement, the footnote indicates that it is best to understand it as ironic, indicating that the people did not really know Jesus.)

1. It is a statement asserting that the people knew Jesus. For example:

Yes, you know me, and you know where I am from. (NIV) (BSB, NRSV, ESV16, NET, NIV, KJV, NASB, NJB, REB, GW, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This makes better sense with the context. 7:28 Even many of the translations that follow interpretation (2) start the next sentence with “Yet” or “But.” That indicates that they did not know everything, similar to a rhetorical question here. The rhetorical question indicates that although the people thought that they

knew where Jesus was from, they did not know everything. He really came from God, even though he grew up in Nazareth in Galilee. The GNT has therefore been used as the Source Line in the Display.

Here are other ways to translate this rhetorical question:

Do you really think you know me and where I came from? (CEV)

So you^(plur) think you know who I am and where I come from.

7:28c

I have not come of My own accord,

- I am not here by my own authority,
- I did not come here based on my own decision.

The Greek text of 7:28c begins with a common conjunction that is often translated as “and.” The BSB does not translate this conjunction. Several translations translate it as “but,” which indicates that the Jews do not know as much as they think that they do. Introduce Jesus’ next statement in a way that is natural in your language.

I have not come of My own accord: Jesus was saying that he did not decide himself to come to the world. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I didn’t decide to come on my own. (GW)

But I have not come by my own authority. (NCV)

of My own accord: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as of My own accord means “on my own authority” or “by my own decision.” There is a similar phrase in 7:17c (“speak on my own”), 5:19b (“the Son can do nothing by Himself”), and 5:30a (“I can do nothing by Myself”). See the notes there.

7:28d

but He who sent Me is true.

- but the true one sent me.
- Rather, I am sent by God, the one who is true.

but He who sent Me is true: Jesus declared that he came to earth because he was sent by one who was true. Here, true means that God the Father, He who sent Me, is real or genuine.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Rather, I came because he who is real sent me

but one who is true sent me

but: The conjunction but here indicates a contrast between coming on one’s own and being sent by another. The Greek does not explicitly say, “I have been sent by another,” but it is implied. Be sure that your translation does not indicate a contrast between Jesus and the one who sent him. Jesus was also true. If a literal translation of this conjunction implies that Jesus was not also true, you may need to not translate the conjunction. That is what the NLT, NCV, and REB have done.

He who sent Me: This phrase refers to God. The reaction of the crowd shows that they understood this. If your readers will not understand this, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

God who sent me here

7:28e

You do not know Him,

- You^(plur) do not know him,
- However, you^(plur) yourselves do not know God.

You do not know Him: The pronoun You is plural and refers to the people Jesus was talking to. The pronoun Him refers to God again. The Greek text emphasizes both pronouns. The people knew about God but did not know him well or personally.

John 7:29

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:28–31

Jesus continued teaching in the temple. He declared that he was from God and that he knew God. Some of the people listening were angry and wanted to

arrest him, but many others believed that he was the Messiah.

7:29

but I know Him, because I am from Him and He sent Me.”

- but as for me, I do know him, because I come from him and he told me to come.”
- I am the one who knows God because I came from him. He sent me to you.”

but I know Him: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun I to make a contrast with “you” in 7:28e. The BSB includes the word but to make the contrast clear.

Jesus again said that he knew God. In some languages it may again be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

I do know God.

because I am from Him and He sent Me: The clauses I am from Him and He sent Me are parallel. Together they mean “I was sent by God.” This explains why Jesus was able to say that he knew God.

Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

because I come from him and he sent me here (JBP)

because I came from him, and he is the one who sent me to you

because he sent me and I have come from him

John 7:30

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:28–31

Jesus continued teaching in the temple. He declared that he was from God and that he knew God. Some of the people listening were angry and wanted to arrest him, but many others believed that he was the Messiah.

7:30a

So they tried to seize Him,

- Therefore they tried to seize him
- So after Jesus said this, the leaders tried to arrest him

So they tried to seize Him: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is more literally “therefore.” In this context it indicates that because of what Jesus said, some people there tried to arrest him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

At this they tried to seize him (NIV)

When Jesus said this, the leaders tried to arrest him

they tried to seize Him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as they tried to seize Him is more literally “they were seeking to seize him,” as in the NASB. The Greek does not make clear whom the pronoun they refers to. It could be the crowd (verse 20), people from Jerusalem (verse 25), or the chief priests and Pharisees (verse 32). Because of that, it is best to translate the word they literally. If that is not natural in your language, you may use another ambiguous word. For example:

The Jews tried to arrest him (GW)

The Greek text does not say in what way these people tried to seize Jesus. Perhaps they talked about it together and made plans that did not succeed. Perhaps it did not refer to an official arrest by police or other authorities.

7:30b

but no one laid a hand on Him,

- but not one of them could grab him,
- but none of them touched him,

but no one laid a hand on Him: The conjunction but introduces something unexpected: although the men tried to arrest Jesus, they could not do it. The phrase laid a hand on means “touched” or “grabbed.” So the men were not able to touch or grab Jesus. Here is another way to translate 7:30a–b:

The Jews tried to arrest him but couldn't (GW)

laid a hand on Him: This clause refers to arresting or seizing someone, probably using violence. Even though the men tried to arrest Jesus, they were not successful at this point.

7:30c

because His hour had not yet come.

- because the right time for him was still in the future.
- because it was not yet the time God had appointed for him.

because His hour had not yet come: The conjunction because introduces the reason why the people could not arrest Jesus then. It was not the right moment or hour for him to be arrested. See the note on 2:4b and 7:6a.

John 7:31

Section 7:25–31: People wondered if Jesus was the Messiah

Many people began to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The authorities tried to arrest Jesus, but it was not yet the time that God would allow that to happen.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah

Many believed in Jesus, but the leaders tried to arrest him

Paragraph 7:28–31

Jesus continued teaching in the temple. He declared that he was from God and that he knew God. Some of the people listening were angry and wanted to arrest him, but many others believed that he was the Messiah.

7:31a

Many in the crowd, however, believed in Him

- However many people in the crowd believed in Jesus.
- But among the crowd there were many people who believed in him.

Many in the crowd, however, believed in Him: Many people there in Jerusalem did believe in Jesus. The phrase believed in Him includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about

Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b and 7:5.

Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Many among the crowds at the Temple believed on him (NLT)

A lot of people in the crowd put their faith in him (CEV)

however: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as however here introduces a contrast with the people who tried to seize Jesus. A few English translations do not translate this word, but leave it implied. Here are other ways to translate this word that require placing it at the beginning of the verse:

Yet (NRSV)

But (NCV)

7:31b–c

When the Christ comes, will He perform more signs than this man?: This question gives the reason that many people believed that Jesus was the Messiah. He had done so many miracles that he must be the Messiah. But the question talks about Jesus and the Messiah as though they were different people. So if it is translated literally, it can be misunderstood to mean that Jesus was not the Messiah. You may need to make it clear that they believed that Jesus was the Messiah. For example:

and they said, "This man must be the Messiah. Because surely no one can do more amazing things than what he has done."

7:31b

and said, "When the Christ comes,

- These people said, "When the Christ arrives,
- They said to one other, "When the Christ appears on earth,

and said: These people were talking to one another about Jesus. The quotation that follows is an example of the kind of things they said. In some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase in this way:

They said to each other

When the Christ comes: This clause refers to time when the Messiah would come. The people who were speaking believed that Jesus was the Messiah. But they were speaking in a general way.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When the Christ appears (ESV)

When ^{Lour^(incl)} Chosen/Appointed Savior comes
^{Lto us^(incl)}

the Christ: Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew title “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning. See the note on 7:26c, and translate the Christ the same way in both verses.

7:31c

will He perform more signs than this man?”

- will he do any more signs/miracles than this man Jesus does?”
- he will not do any more signs/miracles than Jesus has already done.”

will He perform more signs than this man?: This is a rhetorical question. It implies the answer “no.” The people used it to make a strong statement, an exclamation. They were saying that the Messiah/Christ would certainly not do more signs than Jesus had done. In other words, Jesus’ signs showed that he was the Messiah.

There are two ways to translate this exclamation:

- Use a rhetorical question implying the answer “no.” For example:

would you expect the Messiah to do more miraculous signs than this man has done? (NLT)

he will not do more miracles than this man has done, will he?

- Use a statement. For example:

he will certainly not do more miracles than this man has done!

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is most natural in your language.

The conjunction than indicates comparison. The people compared the number of signs that Jesus had done with the number that the Messiah might do. They did not think that the Messiah would do more signs, so Jesus must be the Messiah. Translate this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

will he be superior to this Jesus in doing miracles?

will he do more miracles than the miracles of this man Jesus?

this man: The Greek pronoun that the BSB translates as this man refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

this man Jesus

John 7:32

Section 7:32–36: Temple guards went to arrest Jesus

The religious leaders continued to oppose Jesus. They sent temple police to arrest him. Jesus told them that he was leaving and they would not be able to find him. He was talking about returning to his Father in heaven. But people did not understand this.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jewish leaders sent men to arrest Jesus

The Jewish leaders were confused by what Jesus said

7:32a

When the Pharisees heard the crowd whispering these things about Jesus,

- ¶ The Pharisees heard the crowd whispering these things about Jesus.
- ¶ The Pharisees heard the people grumbling among themselves about Jesus.

When the Pharisees heard the crowd whispering these things about Jesus:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as whispering here means “speaking quietly” or “muttering.” The people in the crowd were not talking to the Pharisees. However, some Pharisees heard them saying these things (things like that) about Jesus. Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, it is recommended that you mention Jesus’ name. For example:

The Pharisees heard the crowd whispering these things about Jesus. (GNT)

Some of the Pharisees heard people in the crowd whispering things like that about Jesus.

the Pharisees: the Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

men of the Parises

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

See how you translated this term in 1:24. See Pharisee in KBT. You may also want to include an explanation of “Pharisee” in the glossary of your translation.

7:32b

they and the chief priests sent officers to arrest Him.

- So the chief priests and the Pharisees sent temple police to arrest/seize him.
- Then they and the leading priests sent the temple guards to take Jesus to prison.

In Greek this clause begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and.” It introduces what the Pharisees did as a result of what people said in 7:31b–c.

Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

so (GNT)

Then (NIV)

they and the chief priests sent officers to arrest Him: The religious leaders ordered the temple police to make an official arrest. They wanted to arrest Jesus to force him to stop teaching the people. Because the

Pharisees were mentioned in the previous clause, it may be natural to not repeat the group’s name. For example:

they and the chief priests sent some guards to arrest him (GNT)

they got together with the chief priests and sent some temple police to arrest him (CEV)

the chief priests: The phrase the chief priests refers to the leading or head priests. These men were important religious authorities, members of the main council of the Jews. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the leading priests (NCV)

officers: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as officers refers to men who served at the temple in various ways, including as guards.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

some Temple guards (NCV)

some guards (GNT)

temple police (NRSV)

John 7:33

Section 7:32–36: Temple guards went to arrest Jesus

The religious leaders continued to oppose Jesus. They sent temple police to arrest him. Jesus told them that he was leaving and they would not be able to find him. He was talking about returning to his Father in heaven. But people did not understand this.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jewish leaders sent men to arrest Jesus

The Jewish leaders were confused by what Jesus said

7:33a

So Jesus said, “I am with you only a little while longer,

- Jesus said, “I will be with you^(plur) for only a short time,

- Jesus said to the crowd, “For a brief time I am here with you.

So Jesus said: The text does not say whom Jesus spoke to, whether the people or the leaders or the temple police. English translations follow the Greek and do not indicate whom Jesus spoke to. From the context it appears that he spoke to the Jewish people in general. So if it is more natural to indicate the hearers in your languages, you may say that he spoke to the people. For example:

But Jesus told the people

I am with you only a little while longer: Jesus told the people that he would live there with them for a little while longer. This implies that he would not be with them for a long time.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am not much longer here with all of you^(plur).

It will not be long before I leave you^(plur).

I will stay with you^(plur) for a brief time.

only a little while longer: Jesus was going to be with the people for only a short time more. He would be crucified about six months later.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

for only a short time (NIV)

only a little longer (NLT)

7:33b

and then I am going to the One who sent Me.

- and after that I will go back to the one who sent me.
- Then I will return to God, who sent me to you^(plur).

and then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and then introduces what will happen after the “little while” mentioned in 7:33a is over.

I am going to the One who sent Me: The pronoun One refers to God the Father. Jesus knew that he would return to God who sent him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I go to the one who sent me. (NIV)

I will return to the one who sent me. (CEV)

John 7:34

Section 7:32–36: Temple guards went to arrest Jesus

The religious leaders continued to oppose Jesus. They sent temple police to arrest him. Jesus told them that he was leaving and they would not be able to find him. He was talking about returning to his Father in heaven. But people did not understand this.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jewish leaders sent men to arrest Jesus

The Jewish leaders were confused by what Jesus said

7:34a

You will look for Me, but you will not find Me;

- You^(plur) will look for me, but you^(plur) will not be able to find me.
- Although you^(plur) will try to find me, you^(plur) will not succeed.

You will look for Me: The pronoun You is plural and refers in general to those who were listening to Jesus. It is implied that they will want Jesus to help them in some way.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

You will look for me. (GNT)

but: The conjunction that the BSB has translated as but is usually translated as “and.” In this context it introduces something that is not expected. Although the people would look for Jesus again, they would not find him. He would be gone. Introduce this unexpected event in a way that is natural in your language.

you will not find Me: The people would not be able to find Jesus. In your translation, avoid implying that Jesus was lost. He would go to his Father in heaven, and that was why the people would not be able to find him.

7:34b

and where I am, you cannot come.”

- Where I will be, you^(plur) will not be able to come.”
- You^(plur) will not be able to come to me.”

and where I am, you cannot come: The Greek text emphasizes the pronouns I and you to emphasize the contrast between Jesus and the people. This clause

indicates that the people that Jesus spoke to would not be able to go to where Jesus would be. This refers to a future time, and it may be natural to use future verbs. For example:

you cannot go where I will be (GNT)

you will not be able to come to me

come: In some languages it is more natural to use “go” in this context. See the GNT example in the previous note.

John 7:35

Section 7:32–36: Temple guards went to arrest Jesus

The religious leaders continued to oppose Jesus. They sent temple police to arrest him. Jesus told them that he was leaving and they would not be able to find him. He was talking about returning to his Father in heaven. But people did not understand this.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jewish leaders sent men to arrest Jesus

The Jewish leaders were confused by what Jesus said

7:35a

At this, the Jews said to one another, “Where does He intend to go that we will not find Him?”

- The Jewish leaders said to one another, “Where does this man want/plan to go that we^(incl) cannot find him?”
- The Jewish rulers asked each other, “Where does Jesus plan to go to prevent/keep us^(incl) from finding him?”
- The Jewish leaders said to each other, “Surely there is nowhere that this person can go where we cannot find him.”

At this, the Jews said to one another: The term Jews here refers to the religious leaders, particularly the chief priests and Pharisees mentioned in 7:32b. They were talking among themselves, discussing Jesus’ words. See how you translated the term Jews in 1:19 and 7:1. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The Jewish authorities said among themselves (GNT)

Where does He intend to go that we will not find Him?: This is a rhetorical question showing scorn and disbelief (refusing to believe him). The leaders did not ask this question in order to learn the answer. Instead, they were saying that Jesus did not make sense. They did not think that he could go somewhere that they could not find him. The Greek text emphasizes the words that are translated He and we to again emphasize a contrast.

There are at least two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Where is he going that we will not find him?
(NABRE)

- Use a statement. For example:

So he thinks he can go somewhere we will never find him!

Where does He intend to go: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Where does He intend to go is more literally “Where is this one going very soon.”

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Where is he planning to go (NLT)

He: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as He is more literally “this one.” It is a different phrase from that in 7:11b, but it also is slightly insulting.

that we will not find Him: This is a purpose clause. The Jews thought that Jesus would go somewhere so that people would or could not find him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to keep us from finding him (CEV)

so we cannot find him (NCV)

7:35b–c

Will He go where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks, and teach the Greeks?: This is a rhetorical question expecting the answer “no.” The authorities did not think that it was probable that Jesus would go to the where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks, but it was the most likely explanation that they could think of. This rhetorical question again expresses the leaders’ disbelief.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

He is not going to go to the Jewish people dispersed among the Greeks and teach the Greeks, is he? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

It seems unlikely that he wants to go to the Jews scattered abroad and teach the Greeks.

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is natural in your language to express disbelief.

7:35b

Will He go where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks,

- Will he go to where our^(incl) people live dispersed/scattered among the Gentiles/pagans
- Does he mean that he will go to the Jewish people who live abroad, among foreigners
- We could find him even if he went to the Jews who live in Gentile places

Will He go where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks: This clause introduces the possibility that Jesus would leave Palestine and go to Jewish communities in other places.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Is he thinking of leaving the country and going to the Jews in other lands? (NLT)

Is he going to some foreign country where our people live...? (CEV)

Will he go to the Greek cities where our people live? (GNT)

Will He go: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Will He go is more literally “going very soon.” The leaders were really asking about what Jesus meant. They did not understand him when he said that he would go where they could not find him. They did not think that that was possible. In some languages it may be helpful to make it clear that they wanted to know what he meant. For example:

Does he mean that he will go

where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks:

The term where the Jews are dispersed among the Greeks refers to the places where Jewish people lived in Gentile countries. They lived dispersed (scattered) in various countries of the ancient world.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Jewish people dispersed among the Greeks (NET)

the Jewish people living among the Greek people

the Greek cities where our people live (NCV)

In translating this phrase, remember that the speakers were all Jewish. So it may not be natural to refer to the Jews in the third person. For example:

our^(incl) people dispersed among the Greeks

where our people live scattered among the Greeks (NIV)

among the Greeks: The phrase the Greeks refers in general to the Greek-speaking peoples of that time. It does not refer specifically to people from the country of Greece (which was not yet a country). Here it refers to non-Jews in the ancient Mediterranean world. The Jews in general hated them. See the notes on Acts 14:2, Romans 1:8, and 1 Corinthians 1:18, and see how you translated Greeks there.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

among the Gentiles (REB)

7:35c

and teach the Greeks?

- and teach the Gentile people?
- and teach those foreign people?
- and taught the Gentiles.

and teach the Greeks: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It refers to teaching Gentiles who spoke Greek, perhaps those who converted to the Jewish religion. For example:

and teach Gentiles (REB) (NLT, KJV, NIV, REB)

1. It refers to teaching Jews who spoke Greek, the Dispersion mentioned in 7:35b.

Some English translations are ambiguous, the CEV deliberately so. The CEV footnote says: “Greeks: Perhaps Gentiles or Jews who followed Greek customs.” It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most commentaries and scholars. See Kostenberger, page 239, and footnote 47. There was a different term for Greek-speaking Jews: see, for example, Acts 6:1.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and teach the Gentiles that are there?

Maybe he will even teach the Greeks! (NLT)

John 7:36

Section 7:32–36: Temple guards went to arrest Jesus

The religious leaders continued to oppose Jesus. They sent temple police to arrest him. Jesus told them that he was leaving and they would not be able to find him. He was talking about returning to his Father in heaven. But people did not understand this.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jewish leaders sent men to arrest Jesus

The Jewish leaders were confused by what Jesus said

7:36a

What does He mean by saying,

- What did he mean when he said,
- What could he mean when he said

What does He mean by saying...?: This question indicates that the Jewish authorities did not understand what Jesus meant. They were confused by what he said. Consider how it is natural to express this confusion in your language. Also consider whether it is natural to use the present tense to refer to something that has just been said. In some languages it may be more natural to use the past tense in this question.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

What did he mean when he said...? (NIV)

What is he talking about?

What is he trying to tell us?

7:36b

‘You will look for Me, but you will not find Me,’

- ‘You^(plur) will look for me, but you^(plur) will not be able to find me?’
- that we^(incl) would try to find him but would not succeed?

You will look for Me, but you will not find Me: This is a direct quotation of Jesus’ words in 7:34a. Translate it so that this is clear. See the General Comment on 7:36a–c for a way to avoid having a quotation inside another quotation. It may be more natural to use an indirect quotation. If that is true, you will need to change the pronouns and say something like this:

that we^(incl) will search for him and will not find him

7:36c

and, ‘Where I am, you cannot come?’”

- And what did he mean when he said, ‘Where I will be, you^(plur) will not be able to come?’”
- And what could he mean when he said that we^(incl) cannot go where he will go?”

Where I am, you cannot come: This is again an exact quotation of Jesus’ words, this time from 7:34b. It may be more natural to use an indirect quotation. For example:

that where he is, we^(incl) cannot come/go

General Comment on 7:36a–c

This verse includes two quotations inside a quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate the inner quotations as indirect quotes, as the GNT did. The GNT also reordered the verse, placing the question of 7:36a at the end:

^{36b}He says that we will look for him but will not find him, ^{36c}and that we cannot go where he will be. ^{36a}What does he mean? (GNT)

John 7:37

Section 7:37–39: Jesus promised living water

During the festival of Booths the Jewish people remembered how God provided what they needed. He provided water for them in the past and continued to do so. Each day of the festival, the priests took some water from the pool of Siloam. Then they poured

it out before the Lord at the base of the altar. This represented God's gift of water and life. This ritual reminded the people that God had given them water and that he would also give them the Holy Spirit. On this occasion Jesus stood up and claimed that he fulfilled the hope expressed in this ritual.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told those who were thirsty to come to him

Jesus spoke about the Holy Spirit

7:37a

On the last and greatest day of the feast,

- ¶ On the final and most important day of the festival,
- ¶ On the last, most important day of the Feast of Booths/Shelters,

On the last and greatest day of the feast: This phrase refers to the most important part of the Feast. It probably refers to the seventh day, but it is best not to make this explicit.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

On the last and most important day of the festival (GW)

7:37b

Jesus stood up and called out in a loud voice,

- Jesus stood up and declared publicly,
- Jesus stood up and proclaimed,

Jesus stood up: Jesus apparently watched the priests pour out the water before the Lord. Many English translations imply that he had been sitting down and then stood up to speak, as in the BSB.

called out in a loud voice: This phrase indicates that Jesus spoke loudly so that all the people around could hear him. See the note on 7:28a. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and said in a loud voice (NIV)

and shouted out (NET)

7:37c–38c

If anyone is thirsty, let him come to Me and drink. Whoever believes in Me, as the Scripture has said: 'Streams of living water will flow from within him.' The original Greek text did not include punctu-

ation. Greek manuscripts punctuate these clauses in different ways, leading to different meanings. English translations vary in which manuscripts they follow. There are two main options:

1. The subject of the verb drink is any person who is thirsty. The Greek words that the BSB translates as Whoever believes in Me begin a new sentence. For example:

If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink. Whoever believes in me.... (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NIV, GNT1976, REB, GW, CEV, NCV, ESV)

1. The subject of the verb drink is Whoever believes in Me. For example:

Let anyone who is thirsty come to me! Let anyone who believes in me come and drink! (NJB) (NRSV, GNT1992, NET, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). This reflects the punctuation of the best early Greek manuscripts. It is also followed by modern editions of the Greek text and many scholars. This is the option supported by many commentaries, including Carson (pages 323–325). He writes: "There is no [other] instance of *ho pisteuon* attaching itself to a previous conditional clause, as the second interpretation requires. The textual evidence supports the first view, including the important papyrus P66, and all modern critical editions of the Greek New Testament adopt it. So, too, do virtually all the Greek Fathers." See also Tasker, page 109, and Kostenberger, pages 240–241, and Barrett, pages 326–327. The second option is supported by Keener, vol. 1, page 729, and Raymond Brown, pages 320–321, who lists many other scholars on both sides.

7:37c

"If anyone is thirsty, let him come to Me and drink.

- "If someone is thirsty, he may/should come to me and drink.
- "All of you^(plur) who are thirsty to know God, come to me and drink.

If anyone is thirsty, let him come to Me and drink:

This is an invitation. Jesus was speaking to anyone and everyone who fulfills the condition in the first clause, meaning anyone who is thirsty. He quoted from Isaiah 55:1 but added the words to Me. You may want to write a footnote to refer the reader to Isaiah 55:1. If you have already translated Isaiah 55:1, it is good to translate it in a similar way.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

If you are thirsty, come to me and drink! (CEV)

Whoever is thirsty may come to me to drink.

All who are thirsty can come to me and drink.

This is a metaphor. This metaphor uses physical thirst to represent spiritual thirst. Being thirsty for water represents people desiring God. Their desire for water is a desire for something necessary and good, something that gives life. In a similar way people can be spiritually thirsty, desiring to know the God who gives life.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. If that is true in your language, here are some other ways to translate it::

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

If someone desires God like they desire water when they are thirsty, let him come to me to meet their desire.

- Use a metaphor or simile and make the similarity clear. For example:

If anyone is thirsty for God, let him come to me and drink.

If anyone thirsts to know God as though God is water, come to me and quench/satisfy your thirst.

John 7:38

Section 7:37–39: Jesus promised living water

During the festival of Booths the Jewish people remembered how God provided what they needed. He provided water for them in the past and continued to do so. Each day of the festival, the priests took some water from the pool of Siloam. Then they poured it out before the Lord at the base of the altar. This represented God's gift of water and life. This ritual reminded the people that God had given them water and that he would also give them the Holy Spirit. On this occasion Jesus stood up and claimed that he fulfilled the hope expressed in this ritual.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told those who were thirsty to come to him

Jesus spoke about the Holy Spirit

7:38a

Whoever believes in Me,

- The one/person who believes in me,
- And you^(plur) who believe in me

Whoever believes in Me: This refers to anyone and everyone who believes on Jesus Christ. For example:

If anyone believes in me (NCV)

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:5, and 7:31a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Have faith in me (CEV)

trusts in me

7:38b

as the Scripture has said:

- as scripture says/states,
- it is written in God's Word,

as the Scripture has said: This clause probably refers to Isaiah 58:11, which says, "You will be like...a spring whose waters never fail" (NIV). But it is not an exact quotation, and several OT passages talk about God giving water to his people. Those passages include Ezekiel 47:1–12 and Zechariah 14:8.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

As the scripture says (GNT)

according to God's written word

7:38c

'Streams of living water will flow from within him.'

- 'From his heart will flow streams of life-giving water.'
- 'From inside him/you will pour/flow the water that brings life.'

Streams of living water will flow from within him:

This is a further development of the metaphor in 7:37c. Refer to the story of the woman at the well, 4:10–15, to see how Christ used this metaphor earlier. Here, as there, it refers to the Holy Spirit as the one who brings true and plentiful life. It is good to keep the metaphor because Scripture uses it in other places.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Rivers of living water will flow from his heart.
(NLT)

You will have life-giving water flowing from deep inside you. (CEV)

in his heart will be that which gives life which will be like water that flows from a spring

Streams of living water will flow: This expression indicates that the living water will flow and be plentiful. In some languages it may be natural to leave the idea of Streams implicit. Instead, you can indicate that the water is plentiful in the verb flow or in an adjective. For example:

shall flow/rush plentiful life-giving water

water flowing (CEV)

Streams of living water: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as living in this context means “life-giving,” something that gives life. See also 4:14c and the notes there, and the note on living water at 4:10d. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

streams of life-giving water (GNT)

from within him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as from within him is more literally “out of his stomach.” The pronoun “his” in the Greek probably refers to whoever believes in Jesus (7:38a). There are actually two ways to interpret the pronoun “his” here: (1) It refers to the person who believes in Jesus. For example: If anyone believes in me, rivers of living water will flow out from that person’s heart, as the Scripture says (NCV) (BSB, NLT, CEV, NIV, RSV, REB, NRSV, GW, ESV, GNT76, KJV, NASB) (2) It refers to Jesus himself. For example: As the scripture says, ‘Streams of life-giving water will pour out from his side.’” (GNT92) (GNT92) It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. By using a plural pronoun,

NIV forces that interpretation. It is recommended that you use a singular pronoun here like all other English translations (CEV uses “you,” which could be singular or plural in English). The NIV uses a plural pronoun here because there are many who believe in Jesus. However, the Greek text has a singular pronoun to refer to “the one believing in me.” The BSB, like nearly all English translations, uses a singular pronoun.

The most probable Scripture that this refers to is Isaiah 58:11. There the pronoun is “you” (“You will be like...a spring”). See the previous note at 7:38b.

Here is another way to translate this phrase:

From his heart (NJB)

within him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as within him is more literally “his stomach.” At that time, people saw the stomach as the center of one’s feelings and desires. Today, most English speakers see the heart that way, so some English translations translated the phrase as “his heart.” Other English translations just refer to inside a person without saying a specific body part. For example:

there will flow what gives true life, coming from inside him, like a spring of water

you will have life-giving water flowing from deep inside you (CEV)

Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language. You may mention a specific body part that people see as the center or source of feelings and desires. Or you may just refer to the water coming from inside a person.

General Comment on 7:38a–c

This verse can be difficult to understand because the phrase “as the Scripture has said” interrupts the flow of the sentence. It separates the subject (“Whoever believes in me”) from what Jesus said about him. It may be clearer to change the order of the sentence. For example:

^{38b}Scripture says this about ^{38c}the one who believes in me. ^{38a}‘Rivers of water that give life will flow from his heart.’

John 7:39

Section 7:37–39: Jesus promised living water

During the festival of Booths the Jewish people remembered how God provided what they needed. He provided water for them in the past and continued to do so. Each day of the festival, the priests took some water from the pool of Siloam. Then they poured it out before the Lord at the base of the altar. This represented God's gift of water and life. This ritual reminded the people that God had given them water and that he would also give them the Holy Spirit. On this occasion Jesus stood up and claimed that he fulfilled the hope expressed in this ritual.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus told those who were thirsty to come to him

Jesus spoke about the Holy Spirit

7:39

Verse 7:39 gives some parenthetical information. It is a comment by the author John that is not part of the main story line. Indicate this in the way that is most natural in your language. For example, you can put the whole verse in parentheses:

(Now he said this about the Spirit, whom those who believed in him were going to receive, for the Spirit had not yet been given, because Jesus was not yet glorified.) (NET)

7:39a

He was speaking about the Spirit,

- Jesus was talking about the Spirit,
- Jesus spoke about God's Holy Spirit,

The Greek begins with this verse with a conjunction that introduces the author's explanation of the metaphor in 7:38c. Some translations like the BSB leave this word implicit, while others use a different word. For example:

Here he was speaking about the Spirit (JBP)

He was speaking about the Spirit: In this clause, the author John explained what Jesus said. He commented that Jesus spoke about the Holy Spirit, not literal water.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus was talking about the Holy Spirit (CEV)

When he said "living water," he was speaking of the Spirit (NLT)

Jesus was referring to the Spirit of God

He was speaking: The expression He was speaking refers back to what Jesus just said about rivers of living water. In some languages it may be natural to make one or both of the pronouns explicit. For example:

Jesus said this

he said "living water" (NLT)

the Spirit: The Spirit here refers to God's Holy Spirit. See how you translated this in 1:32b.

7:39b

whom those who believed in Him were later to receive.

- whom the people who believed in him would receive.
- whom the people who trusted in him would later receive.

whom those who believed in Him were later to receive: This clause indicates that at a later time believers would receive the Holy Spirit. This happened at Pentecost, ten days after Jesus went back to heaven (see Acts 2). At the time Jesus spoke, believers had not received the Spirit.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

which believers in him would later receive (REB)

who would be given to everyone that had faith in him (CEV)

In some languages it is more natural to make this clause a separate sentence. For example:

Later, people who believed in Jesus would receive the Holy Spirit.

whom: The word whom refers back to "the Spirit" in 7:39a. If you use a pronoun to translate this word, use a pronoun that is suitable for referring to God.

those who believed in Him: This phrase includes the idea that the believers believed the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea that they trusted Jesus instead of trusting themselves or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:31a, and 7:38a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

everyone that had faith in him (CEV)

those who trusted in him

7:39c

For the Spirit had not yet been given,

- At that time, God's Spirit had not yet been given,
- God's Spirit had not yet come,

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces an explanation of the previous statement. It explains why believers had not yet received the Holy Spirit.

the Spirit had not yet been given: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the Spirit had not yet been given indicates that the Holy Spirit had not yet come to live in believers. The Spirit has always existed as God, as a member of the Trinity. In many languages a literal translation will suggest that the Holy Spirit did not exist at that time. It is recommended that you make it explicit that this refers to the coming of the Spirit, or God's gift of the Spirit. For example:

Up to that time the Spirit had not been given.
(NIV)

The Spirit had not yet been given to anyone. (CEV)

God had not yet given/sent His Holy Spirit to believers.

the Spirit: The phrase the Spirit refers to God's Holy Spirit, as in 7:39a.

7:39d

because Jesus had not yet been glorified.

- because Jesus had not yet been given glory.
- because Jesus had not yet returned to heaven to receive honor from God the Father.

because Jesus had not yet been glorified: This clause introduces the reason why the Spirit was not

yet present in believers. Jesus had not yet received glory and honor from his Father. That means that Jesus had not yet been raised from the dead and taken up to heaven. In some languages it may be necessary to say this more explicitly. For example:

because Jesus had not yet been raised to glory
(NCV)

because Jesus had not yet been honored by God
raising him to heaven

had not yet been glorified: This is a passive verb. The implied subject is God. God had not yet glorified (honored) Jesus by raising him from the dead and causing him to go up to heaven. It is implied that this would happen at some time, but it had not happened when Jesus spoke.

Here are two ways to translate this verb phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

since Jesus had not yet been glorified (NIV)

Jesus had not yet been given his full glory (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus had not yet entered into his glory (NLT)

God had not yet caused Jesus to receive his full glory.

Translate this phrase in the way that is most natural in your language. In your translation, avoid implying that Jesus had no glory at that time. Also avoid implying that God the Father did not value or honor him. Although the Father had not yet raised Jesus from the dead to receive his full glory, he always honored him as his Son.

glorified: The verb glorified means "praised" or "honored." See how you translated the related noun "glory" in 1:14b, c and 2:11b, and see the notes there.

General Comment on 7:39b–d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

The Spirit had not yet been given, because Jesus had not yet been raised to glory. But later, those

who believed in Jesus would receive the Spirit.
(NCV)

John 7:40

Section 7:40–44: People disagreed about Jesus

The people disagreed about who Jesus was. Some thought that he might be the Messiah and others said that it was impossible because he was from Galilee.

Here are some other possible section headings:

People in the crowd disagreed about who Jesus was

People argued about Jesus

7:40a

On hearing these words, some of the people said,

- ¶ The people/crowd heard what Jesus said. Some of them said,
- ¶ When the people heard his words, some of them began to say,

On hearing these words: The phrase these words means “what Jesus had said.” In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that this refers to Jesus. For example:

When the people heard Jesus’ words (NCV)

7:40b

“This is truly the Prophet.”

- “This man is certainly the Prophet.”
- “Jesus must be the Prophet that Moses wrote about long ago.”

This is truly the Prophet: These people believed that Jesus was the prophet that Moses said would come. This prophet would be like Moses himself. See the notes on 1:21d and 6:14b.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

“Surely this man is the Prophet we’ve been expecting.” (NLT)

This must certainly be the Prophet. (REB)

John 7:41

Section 7:40–44: People disagreed about Jesus

The people disagreed about who Jesus was. Some thought that he might be the Messiah and others said that it was impossible because he was from Galilee.

Here are some other possible section headings:

People in the crowd disagreed about who Jesus was

People argued about Jesus

7:41a

Others declared, “This is the Christ.”

- Others said, “This man is the Messiah.”
- Other people who heard him said, “He is the Christ, the Chosen Savior.”

Others declared: This clause means “other people in the crowd.” These people were also among those who had heard Jesus’ words.

This is the Christ: The word Christ is a title. Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God appointed and promised to send as king and savior. The word Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah.” The two words have the same meaning.

See how you translated this term in 7:26c, 27b and 31b. See also Christ, Messiah in KBT.

7:41b

But still others asked, “How can the Christ come from Galilee?”

- But other people asked, “Will the Messiah really come from Galilee?”
- But other people objected to this. They said, “The Christ will not appear/come out of the area/province of Galilee.”

But still others asked: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as But still others asked introduces a disagreement with the statement in the previous sentence, that Jesus was the Messiah. Some other people in the crowd disagreed with the suggestion that Jesus was the Messiah.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Still other people asked (GW)

But others argued (REB)

How can the Christ come from Galilee?: This is a rhetorical question. The people used it to say that the Messiah would surely not come from Galilee (the implied answer is “The Messiah does not come from Galilee”). They believed that the Messiah would not come from Galilee, and they knew Jesus was from Galilee.

There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How can the Messiah come from Galilee? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

The Christ will not come from Galilee. (NCV)

- Use a statement and a rhetorical question. For example:

But he can't be! Will the Messiah come from Galilee? (NLT)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 7:42

Section 7:40–44: People disagreed about Jesus

The people disagreed about who Jesus was. Some thought that he might be the Messiah and others said that it was impossible because he was from Galilee.

Here are some other possible section headings:

People in the crowd disagreed about who Jesus was

People argued about Jesus

7:42a–b

Doesn't the Scripture say that the Christ will come from the line of David and from Bethlehem, the village where David lived?: This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “yes.” The people used it to emphasize that the Messiah would be a descendant of David and come from Bethlehem. The scripture said this would happen, and so it was required. They did not think that these things were true of Jesus.

There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Does not the Scripture say that the Christ will come from David's family and from Bethlehem, the town where David lived? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

The Scripture says that the Christ will come from David's family and from Bethlehem, the town where David lived. (NCV)

- Use a rhetorical question and a statement. For example:

The Scriptures say that the Messiah will be a descendant of David, don't they? And he will come from Bethlehem, where David was born.

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language.

7:42a

Doesn't the Scripture say that the Christ will come from the line of David

- Do you^(plur) not know that the Scriptures say that the Messiah will be descended from King David,
- No, it is written in God's Word/Book that the Christ will be a descendant of King David,

Doesn't the Scripture say: In this clause, the speakers were saying that something was written in the Hebrew Scriptures, what we now call the Old Testament.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Is it not written in scripture

Does not God's book declare/prophesy that

Our^(incl) holy writings state that

the Scripture: The phrase the Scripture here refers to the Hebrew scriptures in general. The content that follows comes from several different Old Testament books, including 2 Samuel, Psalms, and Micah.

the Christ will come from the line of David: This clause means “the Messiah is a descendant of David.”

The Scriptures said that the Chosen Savior, the Christ/Messiah, would be a descendant of King David. David was the second king of Israel and ruled about a thousand years before Christ. The Hebrew scriptures tell that one of his descendants would rule over Israel forever. See 2 Samuel 7:12–13 and Psalm 89:3–4.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the Messiah will be a descendant of King David (GNT)

the Messiah is to be of the family of David (REB)

David will be an ancestor of the Messiah

7:42b and from Bethlehem, the village where David lived?"

- and that he will be from Bethlehem, David's village/town?"
- and that he will be born in Bethlehem, David's home town."

and from Bethlehem: This phrase means "the Christ (Messiah) will be born in the town of Bethlehem." The prophets had predicted that the Messiah would be born in that town. See Micah 5:2 or Micah 5:1 in those translations that follow the Hebrew text, such as the NJB. and Matthew 2:5–6.

The people speaking here apparently had a different view of the Messiah from those speaking in 7:27c. (There they said, "no one will know where [the Messiah] is from"). The Jewish people did not all understand the Scriptures in the same way.

the village where David lived: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as the village where David lived is more literally "the village where David was." It refers to the small town in Judea where David was born and grew up. See 1 Samuel 17:12.

Here are other ways to translate this expression:

the village where King David was born (NLT)

David's hometown (CEV)

John 7:43

Section 7:40–44: People disagreed about Jesus

The people disagreed about who Jesus was. Some thought that he might be the Messiah and others said that it was impossible because he was from Galilee.

Here are some other possible section headings:

People in the crowd disagreed about who Jesus was

People argued about Jesus

7:43

So there was division in the crowd because of Jesus.

- So the people disagreed with each other because of Jesus.
- Therefore the people could not agree with each other about Jesus.

So there was division in the crowd because of Jesus:

This sentence means that the people in the crowd did not agree about Jesus. Some thought that he was the Messiah and others did not, so there was division (different groups that disagreed).

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Thus he was the cause of a division among the people. (REB)

So the people did not agree with each other about Jesus. (NCV)

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So introduces the result of the different views of Jesus that were explained in 7:40–42.

there was division in the crowd: The noun phrase division in the crowd here indicates that people held different views and were arguing about them. It does not refer to being physically separated. In some languages it may be natural to translate this noun phrase using a verb. For example:

the people were divided because of Jesus (NIV)

the people could not agree about him (NJB)

because of Jesus: This phrase indicates the reason for the division. The people were angry at each other because they had different opinions about Jesus.

John 7:44

Section 7:40–44: People disagreed about Jesus

The people disagreed about who Jesus was. Some thought that he might be the Messiah and others said that it was impossible because he was from Galilee.

Here are some other possible section headings:

People in the crowd disagreed about who Jesus was

People argued about Jesus

7:44a

Some of them wanted to seize Him,

- Some people wanted to arrest him,
- Some of the people wanted the authorities to seize/capture him

Some of them wanted to seize Him: The phrase Some of them means “some people in the crowd.” These were the people who did not believe that Jesus was the Messiah. They wanted to stop him from teaching the people by getting the police to arrest him. They did not want to arrest Jesus themselves, but rather they wanted the temple police to arrest him. For example:

Some even wanted him arrested (NLT)

7:44b

but no one laid a hand on Him.

- but no one touched him.
- but they did not do anything to him.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces something that happened that is the opposite of what you might expect. Even though some people wanted to have Jesus arrested, no one did so.

no one laid a hand on Him: This idiom means “they did not arrest/capture him.” The temple police were there listening to Jesus (see 7:32b), but they did not arrest him. In some languages it may be more natural to not use an idiom like this. For example:

he was not touched

that did not happen

John 7:45

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus’ teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:45–49

The temple police returned to the council without Jesus. The council members were not pleased and wanted to know why they did not arrest Jesus. The guards told them that what Jesus said was so wonderful they could not arrest him.

7:45a

Then the officers returned to the chief priests and Pharisees,

- ¶ So the temple police returned to the chief priests and Pharisees,
- ¶ When the Temple guards returned without having arrested Jesus, (NLT)

Then the officers returned to the chief priests and Pharisees:

This clause refers back to something that happened earlier. In 7:32b the chief priests and Pharisees had sent these officers to arrest Jesus. Use the same terms here that you used there, so that the readers will understand the connection.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then is often translated as “Therefore.” In this context it introduces the next in a series of events. In some languages it may not be necessary to translate it explicitly (see the GNT).

the officers: The term officers refers to the temple servants. Their job included protecting the temple. This is the same Greek word that was used in 7:32b. See the note there and how you translated the word in that verse.

to the chief priests and Pharisees: The chief priests and Pharisees were two groups of Jewish religious leaders. See the note on priests at 1:19b and Pharisees at 1:24 and 7:32a.

the chief priests: The phrase the chief priests refers to the leading or head priests. These men were important religious authorities, members of the main council of the Jews. See how you translated this phrase in 7:32. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the leading priests (NCV)

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws carefully and exactly. See the note at 7:32 for examples of how to translate the word. Also see how you translated the word there.

7:45b

who asked them, “Why didn’t you bring Him in?”

- who asked them, “Why did you^(plur) not bring/capture Jesus?”
- the religious leaders asked them why they had failed to do so.

who asked them: The pronoun who refers to the chief priests and Pharisees, the Jewish religious leaders. They asked the temple police a question.

Why didn’t you bring Him in?: This question indicates that the religious leaders asked the temple police why they did not arrest Jesus and bring him to them. Their question implies a rebuke: they thought the police should have arrested him as they ordered them to do. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that they were referring to Jesus. For example:

Why didn’t you bring Jesus? (NCV)

Why did you not arrest Jesus?

John 7:46

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus’ teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:45–49

The temple police returned to the council without Jesus. The council members were not pleased and wanted to know why they did not arrest Jesus. The guards told them that what Jesus said was so wonderful they could not arrest him.

7:46

“Never has anyone spoken like this man!” the officers answered.

- The temple police answered, “No one ever spoke the way Jesus does.”
- The guards told them that no one ever spoke with such wisdom/authority as Jesus.

Never has anyone spoken like this man!: This clause explains why the temple police did not arrest Jesus. They said that he spoke in a different way than everyone else. He spoke more wisely and with greater authority than anyone else they had heard (see, for example, Mark 1:22). They thought that there was something special about him.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

No one ever spoke the way this man does. (NIV)

No one ever spoke as this man speaks. (REB)

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit in what way Jesus spoke that was different from others. For example:

The words he says are greater than the words of any other person who has ever spoken! (NCV)

“We have never heard anyone say such amazing things!” (ERV)

John 7:47

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus’ teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:45–49

The temple police returned to the council without Jesus. The council members were not pleased and wanted to know why they did not arrest Jesus. The guards told them that what Jesus said was so wonderful they could not arrest him.

7:47

“Have you also been deceived?” replied the Pharisees.

- The Pharisees replied, “Jesus has deceived you^(plur) as well, has he?”
- So the Pharisees said, “Do not tell us that you also believe Jesus’ lies!”
- “So you have let Jesus deceive/fool you also!” answered the Pharisees.

In Greek this verse begins with a connector that is often translated as “Therefore” or “So.” Here it could mean that or just introduce what happened next. Many English translations like the BSB leave the meaning implicit. Translate this connector in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So (NABRE)

Have you also been deceived?: This is a rhetorical question. The Greek text emphasizes the word you. The Pharisees used it as a rebuke. They were upset that the police had not arrested Jesus. They were saying that it seemed that Jesus deceived the police, although they thought that that should not have happened.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Have you believed his lies too?

“You mean he has deceived you also?” (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

So Jesus has fooled you also! (NCV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

replied the Pharisees: This phrase introduces the Pharisees’ answer to the temple police. The BSB has placed this introduction at the end of the quotation. See the General Comment on 7:47.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a strict Jewish religious group or party. See how you translated this word in 7:32, 45.

General Comment on 7:47

The BSB put the quote introduction at the end of the verse. In some languages it may be natural to put this introduction at the beginning of the verse, in the middle of the quotation. For example:

Then the Pharisees replied, “Surely you have not been deceived too, have you?” (NRSV)

John 7:48

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus’ teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:45–49

The temple police returned to the council without Jesus. The council members were not pleased and wanted to know why they did not arrest Jesus. The guards told them that what Jesus said was so wonderful they could not arrest him.

7:48

“Have any of the rulers or Pharisees believed in Him?”

- Has any leader or Pharisee believed in him? No!
- “None of us^(excl) rulers have believed in him. None of the members of the party/group that obeys the Law, the Pharisees, have believed in him.

Have any of the rulers or Pharisees believed in Him?: This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “no.” The Pharisees used it to emphasize that none of the religious leaders believed in Jesus. It is also a rebuke because it implies that the temple police should not disagree with the Jewish leaders.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question, and possibly make the answer explicit. For example:

Is there a single one of us rulers or Pharisees who believes in him? (NLT)

Have any of the leaders or the Pharisees believed in him? No! (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Not one of the chief priests or the Pharisees has faith in him. (CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a strict Jewish religious group or party. See how you translated this word in 7:32, 45, 47.

believed in Him: This phrase includes the idea that someone believed the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. It also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting themselves or someone else. Here the Pharisees probably meant that no authority or Pharisee believed that Jesus was the Messiah or trusted in him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:31a, and 7:38a.

Here is another way to translate this phrase here:

has faith in him (CEV)

John 7:49

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus' teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:45–49

The temple police returned to the council without Jesus. The council members were not pleased and

wanted to know why they did not arrest Jesus. The guards told them that what Jesus said was so wonderful they could not arrest him.

7:49a–b

But this crowd that does not know the law, they are under a curse: The Pharisees thought that they were much better than ordinary Jews and talked about them with scorn. They thought that the ordinary people only believed in Jesus because they were foolish and had little education. They said two things about ordinary people: (1) they were not educated about the law and (2) therefore God would punish them. Make sure that it is clear that the phrase this crowd and the plural pronoun they refer to the same people. It is good to imply that the curse is the result of not knowing the law. For example:

But these people, who know nothing about the law, are under God's curse. (NCV)

But those people who believe in him do not know the law and they will be punished.

7:49a

But this crowd that does not know the law,

- This crowd has, but they know nothing of the law.
- The common/unimportant people who believe in him are those who know nothing about Moses' law.

But this crowd that does not know the law: The conjunction But introduces a contrast. None of the leaders believed that Jesus was the Messiah, but many of the common people did. In some languages it may be natural to make this point of contrast explicit. For example:

Those many people who believe, they know nothing about our law.

But those people who believe in him do not know the law

this crowd: The phrase this crowd refers to the people there in Jerusalem in general. The religious leaders did not respect the ordinary people because they were not educated. You may be able to show this by using a term here that shows a lack of respect. For example:

this mob (NIV)

these common/ordinary/unimportant people

that does not know the law: This clause indicates that the Pharisees thought that the common people did not understand the law nearly as well as the leaders. The leaders exaggerated here, because all the Jewish people knew much of the law. But the leaders implied that because of their lack of knowledge, Jesus could deceive them.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

who know nothing about the law (NCV)

they do not understand the law

the law: This phrase refers to the law of Moses. For example:

Moses' Teachings (GW)

the law of Moses (GNT)

7:49b

they are under a curse."

- There is a curse on those people."
- God curses those/such people.

they are under a curse: The clause they are under a curse indicates that the leaders believed that God was very angry with the ordinary Jewish people. God was so angry with them that he planned to destroy them. They were thinking of Deuteronomy 27:26, "Anyone will be cursed who does not agree with the words of these teachings and does not obey them." (NCV)

This is a passive clause. There are at least three ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they are damned (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the law has cursed them

God has cursed them

- Use a noun. For example:

there is a curse on them (NIV)

are under God's curse (CEV)

God's curse is on them! (NLT)

under a curse: The Greek word that the BSB translates as under a curse means the opposite of "blessed." When God cursed someone, it meant that he judged him and decided that he would punish him. That person was then under a curse. In many places people will curse someone using magic. In your translation, avoid any reference to practices of magic or actions of witches. The idea in this verse is that God was angry with the people and would punish them.

John 7:50

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus' teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:50–52

One of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus. He said that they should not condemn a man without letting him explain himself.

7:50a

Nicodemus, who had gone to Jesus earlier

- ¶ Nicodemus, who had visited Jesus earlier
- ¶ Nicodemus, who talked with Jesus earlier

Nicodemus, who had gone to Jesus earlier: The clause who had gone to Jesus earlier tells what Nicodemus did before. It refers back to John 3:1–21. It may be good to include a footnote with a reference to John 3.

7:50b

and who himself was one of them, asked,

- and was one of the Jewish authorities, said,
- and who was one of the religious leaders, challenged the others.

and who himself was one of them: This clause indicates that Nicodemus was also a ruler of Israel, probably a member of the ruling council called the Sanhedrin. In John 3:1 it says that he was one of the Pharisees. It is good to make this explicit so that

people will not think that he was one of the crowd. For example:

one of the rulers (NET)

One of the Pharisees (GNT)

asked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as asked here introduces a rhetorical question that made a statement. Translate it in a way that is suitable for this context. If you do not use a rhetorical question in 7:51, you will need to use a word other than asked here. For example:

said to them (NJB)

General Comment on 7:50a–b

In some languages it may be natural to put the information about who Nicodemus was in a separate sentence. For example:

^{50a}Nicodemus, who had gone to see Jesus before,

^{50b}was in that group. He said.... (NCV)

^{50b}One of the Pharisees there was ^{50a}Nicodemus, the man who had gone to see Jesus before. ^{50b}He said to the others.... (GNT)

John 7:51

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus' teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:50–52

One of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus. He said that they should not condemn a man without letting him explain himself.

7:51

“Does our law convict a man without first hearing from him to determine what he has done?”

- “Does our^(incl) law judge a person guilty before listening to him to find out what he is doing?”
- “Our^(incl) law does not decide that a person is guilty before that person has a chance to explain his actions,” he said.

Does our law convict a man without first hearing from him to determine what he has done?:

This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “no” and emphasizes the negative statement. Nicodemus emphasized that the law did not allow someone to decide that a person was guilty without letting him defend himself.

There are at least two ways of translating this emphasis of a negative statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Does the law allow us to find a man guilty before we hear him defend himself in court?

Does our law condemn anyone without first hearing him to find out what he is doing? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Our laws do not let us condemn people before we hear what they say about their actions.

According to our Law we cannot condemn people without hearing them and finding out what they have done. (GNT)

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language.

our law: The phrase our law refers to the law of Moses. The pronoun our is inclusive as all those present were Jews.

convict: The verb convict here means to issue a negative judgment, meaning to decide that someone is guilty. (For examples, see above.)

hearing from him to determine what he has done:

The Greek expression that the BSB translates as hearing from him to determine what he has done is more literally “hear from him and learn what he does.” The pronouns him and he refer to the accused people (those whom others accused of doing something wrong).

determine what he has done: This clause means to learn what the accused people did, and why. When talking about legal matters, there may be special phrases that are suitable. It may be natural to make it clearer that the accused people are the ones speaking. For example:

let them explain their deeds/actions

General Comment on 7:51

The Greek text uses singular forms for the object of the verb “judge” and the following pronouns. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek. For example:

Our law does not judge a man without hearing him and knowing what he has done. (NCV)

John 7:52

Section 7:45–52: The Jewish leaders did not believe in Jesus

The temple police were amazed at Jesus’ teaching and did not arrest him. The council members were not pleased and said that none of the Jewish leaders believed in him. However, one of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Jewish leaders argued that people should not believe in Jesus

One Jewish leader defended Jesus

Paragraph 7:50–52

One of the council members, Nicodemus, defended Jesus. He said that they should not condemn a man without letting him explain himself.

7:52a

“Aren’t you also from Galilee?” they replied.

- The other rulers answered, “Are you^(sing) from Galilee also?”
- The other religious leaders scorned/mockd him. They said, “You^(sing) sound like you are from Galilee and are on his side.

“Aren’t you also from Galilee?” they replied: This is a rhetorical question. The Greek text emphasizes the word you. The Jewish leaders used it as a rebuke to scorn or mock Nicodemus. The other Jewish leaders were saying that Nicodemus was speaking as though

he also came from Galilee. They thought that that would explain why he defended Jesus.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you from Galilee, too? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Nicodemus, you must be from Galilee! (CEV)

Translate this rebuke in the way that is most natural in your language.

7:52b

“Look into it, and you will see that no prophet comes out of Galilee.”

- Study the Scriptures and you^(sing) will find no mention of a prophet from Galilee.”
- But if you^(sing) read the Scriptures carefully, you will learn not to expect a prophet from the area/province of Galilee.”

Look into it, and you will see that no prophet comes out of Galilee:

The Pharisees were saying that Jesus could not be a true prophet because he was from Galilee. For another example of how other Jewish people scorned Galilee, see John 1:46. Nathanael indicated that you could not expect anything good to come out of the Galilean village of Nazareth. They were implying that Nicodemus did not know the Scriptures well, or he would know that. This sentence shows the Pharisees’ scorn for Nicodemus. See 7:41b, and the note there, for a similar idea.

Look into it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look into it is a command that is second person singular, referring only to Nicodemus. It is a command to examine or study carefully. It implies that Nicodemus should study the prophecies in the Hebrew Scriptures (our Old Testament).

Here are ways to make this explicit:

Study the Scriptures (GNT)

Read the Scriptures (CEV)

you will see that: The pronoun you is second person singular and refers only to Nicodemus. The verb will see refers to learning something. The Pharisees said that Nicodemus would learn something when he read the scriptures.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you will learn that (NCV)

you will find that (NIV)

no prophet comes out of Galilee: The Pharisees said that Nicodemus would learn that the scriptures never said that a prophet would come from Galilee. However, the Pharisees were wrong. Some prophets, such as Jonah, came from Galilee. See 2 Kings 14:25 (Gath Hepher was a village in Galilee).

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you cannot expect a prophet to come from Galilee
UBS Translator's Handbook, Newman and Nida, page 255.

prophets do not arise in Galilee (NJB)

Galilee does not produce prophets

prophet: A prophet was a man who spoke as God's representative. He told people what God revealed to him. Here are some ways to translate prophet:

a representative of God

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

It is good to use a general term that does not only refer to predicting the future. Although prophets did predict the future, they also gave people other messages from God.

See how you translated this term in 1:21 and 7:40b. See also prophet 1(a) in KBT.

out of Galilee: The word Galilee is referring to the province or region called Galilee. See how you referred to this province in 2:1a.

John 7:53

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

The earliest and most reliable manuscripts and other ancient documents do not contain this section, John 7:53–8:11. Some English translations, including the

GNT, put it in brackets or parentheses. Others, including the NIV, put it in the text. However, they also say that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus' life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 7:53–8:2

This paragraph explains the setting of what happened next and introduces the next event in the story. It tells what Jesus did when his opponents tried to cause trouble for him.

7:53

Then each went to his own home.

- ¶ Then each man returned to his own home.
- ¶ When they finished talking all the Jewish leaders went home.

Then each went to his own home: This clause concludes the narrative of what happened when Jewish authorities got together. They finished talking and everyone left.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces something that happened after the previous conversation. Some English translations translate it as "And" while others leave it implicit. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

each: This phrase means "all those present," that is, all the chief priests, Pharisees, and temple police.

John 8:1

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 7:53–8:2

This paragraph explains the setting of what happened next and introduces the next event in the story. It tells what Jesus did when his opponents tried to cause trouble for him.

8:1

But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives.

- ¶ But Jesus went to the Mountain called Olives.
- ¶ Jesus left them and went to the Hill of Olive Trees.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But indicates a development in the story. It also indicates some contrast. The other men went home, but Jesus went to the Mount of Olives.

Jesus went to the Mount of Olives: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as the Mount of Olives refers to a hill where people had planted olive trees. It was just east of Jerusalem on the other side of the Kidron Valley. It is also mentioned in Matthew 21:1, Mark 11:1,

and Luke 19:37. Translate it the same way in all the verses.

The top of the Mount of Olives was about 805 meters (2540 feet) above sea level. Some languages may not consider that high enough to be a mountain. It may be more natural to refer to it as a hill. For example:

Olive Tree Hill

hill called Olive Place
Western Bukidnon Manobo
Back Translation

John 8:2

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 7:53–8:2

This paragraph explains the setting of what happened next and introduces the next event in the story. It tells what Jesus did when his opponents tried to cause trouble for him.

8:2a**Early in the morning He went back into the temple courts.**

- In the early morning he came/went back to the temple,
- He returned to the temple area/courts at dawn.

Early in the morning: The phrase Early in the morning is more literally “At dawn” and refers to the time when the sun rises .

He went back into the temple courts: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. Jesus returned to the temple in Jerusalem, where he was the day before (see 7:14a). Here is another way to translate this clause:

he went back to the Temple (GNT)

the temple courts: This phrase here refers to an open area or courtyard that surrounded the temple building. See the note on 2:14a, where the same Greek word is used.

8:2b**All the people came to Him,**

- and many people went to him.
- A crowd gathered near him,

All the people came to Him: This clause indicates that many people approached Jesus. They wanted to be near him to listen to his teaching. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Everyone there gathered around him.

A crowd soon gathered. (NLT)

8:2c**and He sat down to teach them.**

- He sat down and started to teach them.
- and/so he sat down to teach the people.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces what Jesus did as a result of what people did in 8:2b. In some languages it may be natural to use a word that makes the idea of result more explicit. For example:

So (GW)

and then

He sat down to teach them: The Greek verb that BSB translates as He sat down indicates that Jesus was getting ready to teach. The Jews in Jesus’ day normally sat down to teach or preach. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he sat down and started teaching them (GNT)

he sat and taught them (NCV)

John 8:3**Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery**

The earliest and most reliable manuscripts and other ancient documents do not contain this section, John 7:53–8:11. Some English translations, including the GNT, put it in brackets or parentheses. Others, including the NIV, put it in the text. However, they also say that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus’ life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:3–6b

The Jewish religious leaders set a trap for Jesus. They wanted to force Jesus to say something that they could use against him in a trial. They asked him to decide what to do about a woman who they found committing adultery. (That means that she was having sexual activity with someone who was not her husband.)

8:3a**The scribes and Pharisees, however, brought to Him a woman caught in adultery.**

- ¶ The teachers of the law and the Pharisees brought to him a woman who had been caught committing adultery.
- ¶ Some teachers of the law and Pharisees came up to him. They were leading a woman whom someone had seen in bed with a man who was not her husband.

The scribes and Pharisees: The scribes and Pharisees were the authorities on the Jewish religious law. This phrase also occurs in Matthew 23:2, 13, 15, and in reverse order in Luke 15:2. See how you translated it there. Because not all the scribes and Pharisees came to Jesus, it may be natural to say:

Some of the scribes and Pharisees

scribes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as scribes refers to men who studied, interpreted, and taught the Law of Moses. The original work of these men was to make copies of the laws of Moses by hand. In New Testament times, that was no longer their main task. They remained the recognized experts on the law though.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

teachers of the law of Moses (CEV)

teachers of religious law (NLT)

experts on the law

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. Some, or possibly most, of the scribes were also Pharisees.

Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

men of the Parises

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious sect/
group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

See how you translated Pharisees in 4:1 and 7:48, and translate it the same way here.

brought to Him a woman caught in adultery: In this context the word brought indicates that the men had ordered or forced the woman to come with them. They led her to Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to say where the men brought her. For example:

brought to him/Jesus a woman who had been
caught in adultery

a woman caught in adultery: This phrase indicates that someone had seen this woman lying with a man who was not her husband. Use an expression that is suitable for public use and for public reading in church.

The verb phrase caught is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

a woman who had been caught in bed with a man
who wasn't her husband (CEV)

a woman who had been seen in an immoral act

- Use an active verb. For example:

we^(excl) have caught this woman in bed with an-
other man

someone has seen this woman committing adul-
tery

adultery: The Greek word that the BSB translates as adultery indicates that the woman was married to someone else. It does not indicate whether or not the man was married.

8:3b**They made her stand before them**

- After forcing/causing her to stand in front of everyone,
- They stood her in the middle of the group.

They made her stand before them: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as before them is more literally “in the middle.” The religious leaders forced the woman to stand in front of the people who were there listening to Jesus. They wanted to accuse her publicly. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and made her stand there in the middle

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

They made her stand in front of everyone. (GW)

They put her in front of the crowd. (NLT)

John 8:4

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:3–6b

The Jewish religious leaders set a trap for Jesus. They wanted to force Jesus to say something that they could use against him in a trial. They asked him to decide what to do about a woman who they found committing adultery. (That means that she was having sexual activity with someone who was not her husband.)

8:4

and said, “Teacher, this woman was caught in the act of adultery.

- they said to Jesus, “Teacher, this woman was seen committing adultery.
- Then they said to Jesus, “Teacher, we^(excl) saw this woman in bed with a man who is not her husband.

and said: The speech indicator said introduces a direct quotation and is first in the sentence. In some languages it may be more natural to put it in another place. It may also be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

“Teacher,” they said to Jesus, “this woman was caught in the act of adultery....” (NLT)

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach about God. In some languages the suitable way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir

Master

Do not use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

this woman was caught in the act of adultery: This is an accusation. The men accused the woman of committing adultery. They said that someone had seen her do it. They did not say who her male partner was or why they did not bring him also.

This clause is similar to that in 8:3a but adds the words in the act. These words emphasize that the men had definite proof of the adultery. There was no doubt that she was guilty.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

this woman was caught sleeping with a man who isn’t her husband (CEV)

this woman was caught: This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

this woman has been caught in the act of adultery
(ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

We caught this woman in the act of adultery. (GW)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language.

John 8:5

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:3–6b

The Jewish religious leaders set a trap for Jesus. They wanted to force Jesus to say something that they could use against him in a trial. They asked

him to decide what to do about a woman who they found committing adultery. (That means that she was having sexual activity with someone who was not her husband.)

8:5a

In the Law Moses commanded us to stone such a woman.

- In the Law Moses ordered us^(incl) to stone to death women like this.
- Moses' Law says that we^(incl) must throw stones at women who do such things to kill them as punishment.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that introduces some background information. In some languages it is more natural to leave this word implied, which the BSB did.

In the Law: The phrase the Law refers to the set of laws that God gave Moses for the people of Israel to follow. Because the speakers and the listeners were all Jews (descendants of Israel), in some languages it may be natural to say it was their law. For example:

in ^(incl)our law

Moses commanded us to stone such a woman:

Moses lived about fifteen hundred (1500) years before the time of Christ. In 1:17 the author mentions that God gave the Jewish law through him. Moses was also the author of the books of the law. Deuteronomy 22:22, found in the books of the law, commanded that the Jews punish adulterers with death.

to stone: This verb means to throw stones at someone in order to kill that person. This was the normal method people in ancient Israel used to punish someone with death. This particular method of punishment is not mentioned in Deuteronomy 22:22.

such a woman: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as such a woman means "women who commit adultery." The command in Deuteronomy 22:22 required the death of both the man and the woman who committed adultery. However, the religious leaders did not mention this. Nor did they bring the man who committed adultery with the woman with them.

8:5b

So what do You say?"

- So what do you^(sing) say/advise?"
- So/And you^(sing)—what do you say/think that we^(incl) should do to her?"

So: The Greek conjunction that BSB translates literally as So means “Therefore.” It could just indicate a shift from the background information in 8:5a to the question that they had. Many English translations do not translate this conjunction.

Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Therefore

what do You say?: In the Greek the pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus. It is emphasized in the Greek. The speakers contrasted Moses and Jesus. For example:

and you—what do you say?

In some languages it is natural to indicate an object for the verb say. For example:

What do you say we should do? (NCV)

What do you say about it? (REB)

John 8:6

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:3–6b

The Jewish religious leaders set a trap for Jesus. They wanted to force Jesus to say something that they could use against him in a trial. They asked him to decide what to do about a woman who they found committing adultery. (That means that she was having sexual activity with someone who was not her husband.)

8:6a

They said this to test Him,

- The men were using this question to trap Jesus,
- The religious leaders asked Jesus this trick question

They said this to test Him: The pronoun They refers to the religious leaders who had brought the woman to Jesus.

The religious leaders wanted Jesus to say something that would cause trouble for him. The Law of Moses said that both the woman and the man must die. However, the Roman government then did not allow the Jews to execute (punish by killing) anyone without permission. See John 18:31–32. So if Jesus said that the woman must die, the religious leaders could accuse him of disobeying Roman law. If Jesus said that she should not die, then they could accuse him of disobeying the Law of Moses.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They were using this question as a trap (NIV)

They asked Jesus this question, because they wanted to test him (CEV)

They were asking this to trick Jesus (NCV)

8:6b

in order to have a basis for accusing Him.

- in order to obtain evidence for accusing him.
- so they could accuse him of speaking against the law.

in order to have a basis for accusing Him: The Greek word that the BSB translated as basis means “to accuse someone, possibly in a law court.” The leaders wanted a reason, or excuse, to accuse Jesus of saying something wrong. They wanted to be able to accuse

him of speaking against either the law of Moses or Roman law.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that they might have some charge to bring against him (NRSV)

they wanted to...bring some charge against him (CEV)

General Comment on 8:6a–b

In some languages it may be necessary to explain what the religious leaders hoped to do. They hoped to force Jesus to say something that they could use to accuse him. For example:

They were trying to trap him into saying something they could use against him. (NLT)

Paragraph 8:6c–9

Jesus did not at first answer the people who asked him about the sinful woman. He bent down and wrote something in the sand. Then he said that the person who had not sinned could throw the first stone. Beginning with the oldest, each of those who accused the woman left her. They knew that they too had sinned.

8:6c

But Jesus bent down and began to write on the ground with His finger.

- ¶ But Jesus, he bent over and using his finger he wrote on the ground.
- ¶ However, Jesus leaned forward and began to write in the dirt with his finger.

But: In the Greek text this verse connects to the previous verse with a conjunction that the BSB translates literally as But. It indicates here that something happened that was not expected. The religious leaders asked a question, but rather than answer it as we would expect, Jesus did not answer it. Instead he wrote on the ground.

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus bent down and began to write: Jesus was sitting down and he bent over so he could write on the ground. This implies that he did not look at the religious leaders. He seemed to ignore them.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

Jesus, bending over, wrote

on the ground with His finger: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as on the ground with His finger indicates that Jesus used his finger to make letters on the ground. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

in the dust with his finger (NLT)

John 8:7

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:6c–9

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8:7a

When they continued to question Him,

- When the men/accusers kept asking him the same question,
- The teachers of the law and the Pharisees continued to question him.

When they continued to question Him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as When they continued to question Him is more literally “but as they remained asking questions.” It indicates that the religious leaders continued to ask Jesus what his opinion was. Even though Jesus seemed to ignore them, they did not go away.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When they continued to ask Jesus their question (NCV)

They kept on asking Jesus about the woman (CEV)

8:7b

He straightened up and said to them,

- he straightened himself and said to them,
- Finally/Eventually Jesus stood up and replied,

He straightened up: The Greek word that the BSB translates as He straightened up probably indicates that Jesus stood up from his bent over position. It is the opposite of the word translated as “bent down” in 8:6c.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

he stood up (RSV)

and said to them: The words and said to them introduce a direct quotation of Jesus’ words to the religious leaders. In some languages it may be more natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He said/replied to them

8:7c–d

Let him who is without sin among you be the first to cast a stone at her: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let...cast is a command in the third person. Jesus did not directly answer the question he had been asked. Instead, he said that someone who had never sinned should be the one to begin to punish the woman.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

If any one of you is without sin, let him be the first to throw a stone at her. (NIV)

“If any of you have never sinned, you may throw the first stone at her!”

8:7c

“Let him who is without sin among you

- “If any of you^(plur) has not sinned,
- “Anybody among you^(plur) who has never sinned
- “If one of you^(plur) has never done wrong,

him who is without sin among you: Jesus challenged the woman’s accusers to consider their own lives. He did not say that some of them were actually sinless. He expected that all the accusers would realize that they were sinful. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

anyone here who has never sinned (NCV)

whichever of you is free from sin (REB)

8:7d

be the first to cast a stone at her.”

- you^(sing) throw a stone at her first.”
- should be the first person to throw a stone at her.”
- you^(sing)/he may throw the first stone.”

be the first to cast a stone at her: The clause that the BSB translates as be the first to cast a stone at her means “let him throw a stone at her first.” In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a verb phrase. For example:

may throw the first stone at her (GNT)

at her: The pronoun her refers to the woman. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

at this woman

John 8:8

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

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that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus' life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:6c–9

Jesus did not at first answer the people who asked him about the sinful woman. He bent down and wrote something in the sand. Then he said that the person who had not sinned could throw the first stone. Beginning with the oldest, each of those who accused the woman left her. They knew that they too had sinned.

8:8

And again He bent down and wrote on the ground.

- Again he bent over and wrote something on the ground.
- Then once more he leaned down to write something on the ground.

And again He bent down and wrote on the ground:

The conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces the next event in the story, which is similar to 8:6c. In some languages it may be natural to follow the NIV and leave it implicit. Or it may be natural to use another word to indicate the next event. For example:

Then once again he bent down and wrote on the ground. (REB)

John 8:9

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

The earliest and most reliable manuscripts and other ancient documents do not contain this section, John 7:53–8:11. Some English translations, including the GNT, put it in brackets or parentheses. Others, including the NIV, put it in the text. However, they also say that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus' life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:6c–9

Jesus did not at first answer the people who asked him about the sinful woman. He bent down and wrote something in the sand. Then he said that the person who had not sinned could throw the first stone. Beginning with the oldest, each of those who accused the woman left her. They knew that they too had sinned.

8:9a

When they heard this,

- On hearing this,
- When the religious leaders heard what Jesus said,

When they heard this: The pronoun they refers to the people who accused the woman. They heard what Jesus said. In some languages it may be natural to make they or this (or both of them) explicit. For example:

When they heard what he said (REB)

When the men who accused the woman heard Jesus' words

8:9b
they began to go away one by one,

- they left, one after another,
- they began to leave, one man/person at a time.

they began to go away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as began to go away means “began to leave.” The men did not leave all at once but gradually. For example:

the scribes and Pharisees left (GW)

one by one: The phrase one by one means that the accusers left one at a time. They did not all leave as a group. For example:

one at a time (NIV)

8:9c
beginning with the older ones,

- starting with the older ones,
- The older men went away first.

beginning with the older ones: This phrase indicates that the older men went away before the younger men. There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say just “beginning with the elders.” For example:

the older ones first (GNT) (ESV, NASB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, REB, NABRE)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “beginning with the elders, until the last.” For example:

beginning with the eldest, until the last one had gone (NJB) (NJB, KJV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations. The UBS Committee chose option (1) with an A rating, which indicates that it is almost certain.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase

starting with the older ones (NET)

beginning with the older men (GW)

beginning with the oldest (NLT)

8:9d
until only Jesus was left, with the woman standing there.

- until only Jesus was left with the woman who was standing there.
- Finally Jesus was alone, along with the woman standing in front of him.

until only Jesus was left, with the woman standing there: This clause here indicates that the accusers had all gone and only Jesus and the woman remained. Probably the crowd that was listening to Jesus teach was still there. In order to avoid a wrong meaning, you may need to leave out only. For example:

leaving Jesus behind with the woman, who stood in front of him

until only Jesus was left in the middle of the crowd with the woman (NLT)

with the woman standing there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as there is more literally “in the middle.” The woman was left where the accusers had placed her in front of Jesus and the crowd.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

with the woman, who remained in the middle (NJB)

General Comment on 8:9a–d

This is a complex sentence with several short clauses. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as two shorter sentences. For example:

When they heard this, they all left, the older ones first. Jesus was left alone, with the woman still standing there. (GNT)

One by one, beginning with the older men, the experts in Moses' Teachings and Pharisees left. Jesus was left alone with the woman. (GW)

John 8:10

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

The earliest and most reliable manuscripts and other ancient documents do not contain this section, John 7:53–8:11. Some English translations, including the

GNT, put it in brackets or parentheses. Others, including the NIV, put it in the text. However, they also say that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus' life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:10–11

Jesus allowed the sinful woman to go in peace. He told her that he did not condemn her and that she should stop sinning.

8:10a

Then Jesus straightened up and asked her,

- ¶ Jesus straightened himself and asked her,
- ¶ Jesus stood up. He asked the woman,

Then Jesus straightened up: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as straightened up here indicates that Jesus stood up and faced the woman. Some later Greek manuscripts add the words “and saw none but the woman.” This reading is followed by the KJV. The shorter text as in the BSB is given an A rating by the UBS Greek New Testament, and it is recommended that you follow it. It is a participle form of the word used in 8:7b. It is recommended that you use a form of the word you used in that verse. For example:

Jesus stood up (CEV)

8:10b

“Woman, where are your accusers?”

- “Ma’am/Sister, where has everyone gone?”

- “Where are your accusers?”

Woman: Jesus addressed the sinful woman with a word that the BSB translates as Woman. This was a common and polite way to address an adult female. See also the note on 2:4a, where Jesus used the same word to address his mother. In some languages such a form of address may not be natural or polite. In those languages there are two other ways you could translate this word:

- Use another polite form of address. For example:

ma’am

sister

- Do not translate this word but leave it implicit. Several English translations have done this. For example:

Jesus stood up and asked her, “Where is everyone...?” (CEV)

Translate this word in a way that is most natural in your language.

where are your accusers?: Jesus asked the woman where the men who accused her were. Jesus and the woman both knew the answer, that they had left. So in a sense this is a rhetorical question. Jesus was commenting on the fact that the men who accused her had all left. There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Where is everyone? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

They have gone away.

They have all left.

8:10c

Has no one condemned you?”

- Have none of them condemned you^{(sing)?}”
- Have none of those men remained/stayed to judge that you^(sing) should be punished?”

Has no one condemned you?: This is another rhetorical question. Jesus commented on something that

they could both see, that none of the woman's accusers had remained to condemn her. But because Jesus expected and received an answer, it is good to translate it as a question. For example:

Didn't even one of them condemn you? (NLT)

Is there no one left to condemn you? (GNT)

condemned: The verb condemned here means "decided that a person is guilty and must receive punishment." Here the punishment would be death. No one remained to say that the woman must die.

you: The pronoun you refers to the woman and is therefore singular and feminine.

General Comment on 8:10a–c

The BSB has placed the speech introducer "said to her" before the quotation itself. In some languages it may be natural to place it in the middle of the quotation. For example:

Jesus stood up. "Woman, where are they?" he asked. "Is there no one to condemn you?"

John 8:11

Section 7:53–8:11: Jesus protected a woman who committed adultery

The earliest and most reliable manuscripts and other ancient documents do not contain this section, John 7:53–8:11. Some English translations, including the GNT, put it in brackets or parentheses. Others, including the NIV, put it in the text. However, they also say that it is almost certainly not part of the original text of John. Yet the passage is very old and may well contain a real narrative of an event in Jesus' life.

All English translations include it in some way. So you should also include this section so that readers can learn it and refer to it. In addition to the above ways to include it, you can also put it in a footnote.

In this passage, some scribes and Pharisees brought a woman to Jesus who had been caught committing adultery. They said that the law commanded them to stone an adulterer to death and asked Jesus about it. Jesus said that the person who had no sin should throw the first stone. They all left except the woman, and Jesus told her that he did not condemn her and to not sin again.

Here are other possible section titles:

Jesus saved/defended a sinful woman

Jesus refused to condemn a sinful woman

A woman adulterer received forgiveness

Paragraph 8:10–11

Jesus allowed the sinful woman to go in peace. He told her that he did not condemn her and that she should stop sinning.

8:11a

"No one, Lord," she answered.

- "No, sir," she replied.
- The woman replied, "None of them."

No one: The pronoun No one indicates that none of the men who accused the woman had remained to condemn and punish her. Translate this in a way that is a natural response to the question in 8:10c. For example:

None of them

No (CEV)

Yes, that is so.

No one has condemned me.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Lord was a polite way to address a man. See 5:7a, where the same word is used, although the BSB translates it as "Sir." Place this word in the sentence where it is natural in your language.

8:11b

"Then neither do I condemn you," Jesus declared.

- And Jesus said, "Then I do not condemn you^(sing) either.
- "I do not judge that you^(sing) should be punished either," said Jesus.

Then neither do I condemn you: This clause indicates that Jesus refused to condemn the woman to death. He did not say that the woman had not sinned, but neither did he say that she should die. It is implied that he forgave her instead.

8:11c

"Now go and sin no more."

- Go now and stop sinning."
- "You^(sing) may go. Do not ever commit sins again."

Now go: This verb phrase is a command that gave permission to the woman to leave and go home. She was free to go. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

You may go

and sin no more: The clause that the BSB translates as sin no more means “stop sinning.” It implies that the woman was in fact guilty of the sin that they accused her of. However, it does not imply that she had sinned in this way regularly or as a habit.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

don’t sin anymore (CEV)

do not sin again (NRSV)

John 8:12

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus’ testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:12

Jesus said he was the light of the world. He declared that those who follow him will always live in the light.

8:12a

Once again, Jesus spoke to the people and said,

- ¶ When Jesus talked to them again, he said,
- ¶ Then Jesus addressed the people again. He said,

Once again, Jesus spoke to the people: This passage probably originally followed 7:52. See the note on Section 7:53–8:11. In chapter 7, Jesus taught in the temple during the festival of Booths. Now he again addressed the people gathered there in the temple.

Here is another way to translate this clause:

When Jesus spoke to the people again, he said (NJB)

to the people: This phrase probably refers to the people who had gathered for the festival. Some think that Jesus spoke to the Pharisees here because they respond in the next verse (see GNT). However, Jesus spoke to the people in chapter 7, not just the Pharisees. So the phrase “Once again” suggests that he again spoke to the people. If possible, use a pronoun because it is not clear who he spoke to here. However, in some languages it may be necessary to make it more explicit. For example:

to the people (NIV)

8:12b

“I am the light of the world.

- “I am the world’s light.
- “I am the light for the people of the world.

I am the light of the world: The phrase light of the world means that the light is for the benefit of the world. This phrase is a metaphor. Jesus compared himself to light. Just as light makes it possible to see physical objects, so Jesus makes it possible to see or understand God and spiritual things.

If the meaning of this metaphor is not clear in your language, here are other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I am like the light which shines for the world

- Use a metaphor or simile and make clear how Jesus was like the light of the world. For example:

I am the light which gives light to the minds of people in the world

I am like a light which shines in the minds of people, and gives them understanding

Refer to your translation of light in 1:4–5, 7–9. For the Old Testament background of this metaphor, see Psalms 27:1, 36:9, 119:105.

the light: When Jesus said that he was the light for the whole world, he meant that he was unique. Jesus

said that he was the light, not just a light, not one among many lights. He was the only true source of the knowledge of God. In your translation, try to maintain this emphasis.

the world: The phrase the world refers to the people in the world. Jesus is the light for all people all over the world. In some languages it is more natural to make this more explicit. For example:

to people in the whole world

for all people everywhere

8:12c

Whoever follows Me will never walk in the darkness,

- The person who follows me will never walk in darkness,
- My followers will not live in the dark.
- Those who trust and obey me will not have to live their lives in the dark without God.

Whoever follows Me will never walk in the darkness: The pronoun Whoever refers to anyone and everyone who trusts and obeys Jesus. It is possible to use a singular or plural form. For example:

The one who follows me (NET)

All/Those who follow me

follows Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as follows means “to go with someone, to go along behind them.” Figuratively it began to mean “to go with someone as their disciple, which means one learns from him and obeys him.” See John 1:43.

will never walk in the darkness: The verb phrase walk in the darkness is a metaphor that means to live in sin and not know God. People who follow Jesus will always have God in their lives, so they will never walk in darkness. For example:

will never live in darkness (NCV)

will never live in the dark (GW)

in the darkness: Here, darkness is a metaphor which means “evil” or “the absence of God and all that is good.” See the note on this word at 1:5a. In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may

be difficult to understand. However, it is important to use the idea of darkness because it is an important idea in the Bible.

Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

they will never live like people who are in the dark

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the meaning explicit. For example:

will never be like those who are in darkness who do not know God

8:12d

but will have the light of life.”

- but they will have the light that gives life.”
- They will have the light that brings true/eternal life.”

but will have the light of life: The Greek conjunction that BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (8:12c) to a positive statement (8:12d). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Here it emphasizes that Jesus’ followers will have the light that leads to true life, eternal life. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis.

Here are some ways to indicate the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

The one who follows me, he does not walk in darkness. Rather/Instead he has in him the light which gives life.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Follow me, and you won’t be walking in the dark. You will have the light that gives life. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Whoever follows me will have the light of life and will never walk in darkness. (GNT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

the light of life: This phrase is a metaphor that refers to the light that produces true life. This light was Jesus himself. Jesus makes it possible for people to know God and so to have true life, eternal life. It is important to use the idea of light because it is an important idea in the Bible.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the light that leads to life (NLT)

the light that gives life (CEV)

my light which shows them how to have eternal life (T4T)

John 8:13

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:13a-b

You are testifying about Yourself; Your testimony is not valid: The second clause in this sentence is the conclusion of the first clause. The Pharisees were saying that because Jesus testified for himself, his testimony (what he testified) could not be valid. (The word valid here means “acceptable in a court of law.”) It was not valid because a Jewish rule said that no one could testify for himself. In some languages you may want to make this implied connection explicit. For example:

“You testify for yourself, so/therefore your testimony cannot be accepted.”

What you say is not reliable because you are the one who gives evidence about yourself.

8:13a

So the Pharisees said to Him, “You are testifying about Yourself;

- ¶ Then some Pharisees said to Jesus, “You^(sing) are giving a testimony/witness about yourself.
- ¶ Then some religious leaders who belonged to the Pharisee group/party said to Jesus, “You^(sing) should not act as your own witness.

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So means “therefore” or “so.” Many English translations leave this word implied. Connect the events in a natural way in your language.

the Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws carefully and exactly. See how you translated this term in 8:3a.

You are testifying about Yourself: The BSB translates literally the Greek phrase as about Yourself. The Pharisees were saying that Jesus was a witness who told about himself, and confirmed what he himself said. There was a Jewish rule that said that a man could not testify (give evidence) about himself. Try to use an expression for someone who might testify in a court of law to defend his own statements. For example:

Here you are, appearing as your own witness (NIV)

You are the only one speaking for yourself (CEV)

When you talk about yourself, you are the only one to say these things are true. (NCV)

8:13b

Your testimony is not valid.”

- What you^(sing) say is not acceptable as true/proof.”
- What you^(sing) say about yourself cannot be accepted.”

Your testimony is not valid: This clause is very similar to what Jesus said others thought about himself in 5:31. See the note there and how you translated that verse.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what you say proves nothing (GNT)

We cannot accept what you say. (NCV)

We cannot accept your testimony as true.

Your testimony: The phrase Your testimony refers to what Jesus said about himself in 8:12. He said there that he was the light of the world.

is not valid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as valid is more literally “true.” There are two ways to interpret the word here:

1. In this context it means “accepted as true” or “acceptable as proof.” The Jewish leaders could not accept Jesus’ words about himself as proof of who he was. For example:

We cannot accept what you say. (NCV) (NIV, GNT, REB, NRSV, NLT, NCV, TLV)

1. It means “true.” For example:

and what you say isn’t true! (CEV) (NJB, NET, ESV, NASB, CEV, KJV, RSV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and almost all Bible experts. The two ideas are closely related and probably both are included in what they said. The Pharisees said that there was not valid evidence, and so they did not think that what Jesus said was true.

General Comment on 8:13a–b

There is some implied information in this sentence. It is implied that Jesus was the only one who testified in support of what he said in 8:12. It may be necessary to supply this information so that the sentence is clearer. For example:

When you talk about yourself, you are the only one to say these things are true. We cannot accept what you say. (NCV)

John 8:14

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid

because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus’ testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:14a

Jesus replied, “Even if I testify about Myself, My testimony is valid,

- Jesus answered them, “Even if I give a testimony/witness about myself, what I say is acceptable as true/proof,
- Jesus replied to them, “Even though I act as my own witness, what I say about myself should be accepted as true/reliable,

See the General Comment on 8:14a–c for a different way to order the clauses in this verse.

Jesus replied: This clause means that Jesus answered the Pharisees. In some languages it is natural to supply an object. For example:

Jesus told them (NLT)

Jesus replied to the Pharisees

Even if I testify about Myself, My testimony is valid:

Jesus accepted that it was true that he testified on his own behalf (about himself). He rejected the expected conclusion that his testimony was therefore not valid (valid here means “acceptable in a law court”). In your translation of these clauses, use phrases that connect back with 8:13. For example:

¹³Then the Pharisees said to Him, “You are testifying about Yourself, so Your testimony is not valid.”

¹⁴Yeshua answered them, “Even if I testify about Myself, My testimony is valid....” (TLV)

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these clauses. For example:

My testimony is valid, even though I do testify on my own behalf (REB)

Even if: The Greek conjunction that BSB translates as Even if means “although” or “even though.” Jesus was saying that the clause that this conjunction introduces was true. But the conjunction also means that expected conclusion (that his testimony was not valid) is not true with Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

Although....

Even though (NJB)

My testimony is valid: Use the same words for testimony and valid that you used in 8:13b. People did not expect that a person’s testimony about himself was valid. But Jesus’ testimony was valid.

8:14b

because I know where I came from and where I am going.

- because I know where I came from and where I will go.
- for I am sure of where I am from and where I will return.

because: The Greek conjunction that BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Jesus could say his own testimony was valid. A few translations (CEV, NCV) leave this conjunction implicit. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

I know where I came from and where I am going:

Jesus knew that God had sent him to earth from heaven and that he would return to God in heaven. However, he did not say this explicitly, and you should not make it explicit in your translation.

where I am going: Even though the verb phrase am going is present tense, it has a future meaning. Jesus was talking about where he would go later. So it may be clearer and more natural in many languages to use a future tense verb. For example:

where I will go (EASY)

8:14c

But you do not know where I came from or where I am going.

- But you^(plur) do not know where I came from or where I will go.
- However, you^(plur) do not know where I am from and where I will return.

But: The conjunction But indicates a contrast between what Jesus knew and what the religious leaders knew. He knew where he came from and would go to, but they did not know where he was really from.

you do not know where I came from: The religious leaders did not know that Jesus had come from God. The Greek text emphasizes the word you to emphasize the contrast between Jesus and the leaders. Jesus knew where he came from and where he would go, but the leaders did not know.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as came is present tense, but here it has a past meaning. It refers to the fact that Jesus came from heaven, so you may want to use a past tense verb in your translation.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you know neither where I come from (REB)

or where I am going: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as or here introduces a second thing that the religious leaders did not know. They also did not know where Jesus would go. (Again, the present tense am going has a future meaning.) Jesus would go back to God, but he did not say so here. In some languages it may be more natural to use a different conjunction. For example:

and where I will go

nor where I will go

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 8:14a–c

In some languages it may be necessary to reorder the clauses in this verse. For example:

I know where I came from and where I will go. Therefore my testimony is valid even though I testify about myself. You, however, do not know where I came from nor where I will go.

John 8:15

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:15a

You judge according to the flesh;

- You^(plur) judge in a human/worldly way.
- You^(plur) are judging using human wisdom.

You judge according to the flesh: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as according to the flesh refers to judging in a worldly way or by the way things look, without God's help. For example:

You judge by worldly standards. (REB)

You make judgments in a purely human way. (GNT)

You people judge by outward appearances. (NET)

You: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun You. The word is plural and refers to the religious leaders. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

You religious leaders

judge: The verb judge means “decide if someone is right or wrong.” Jesus criticized the religious leaders by saying that they did not judge correctly.

8:15b

I judge no one.

- I do not judge anyone.
- I am not judging anyone.

I judge no one: The Greek text that the BSB translates as I judge no one is more literally “I do not judge anyone.” Jesus contrasted himself with the Pharisees who judged according to the flesh. The Greek text emphasizes the words “I” and “anyone” as a way to emphasize the contrast.

The word judge is in the present tense. Jesus did not say that he would never judge, but that he did not judge at that time. Be careful to translate this clause in a way that would not imply that Jesus would never judge. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not judge anyone (NLT)

I am not judging anyone (NCV)

John 8:16

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:16a

But even if I do judge, My judgment is true,

- But if I judge someone, my decisions are true/right,
- But if I do judge a person, I judge fairly,

But even if I do judge, My judgment is true: There are two ways to interpret these clauses:

1. It refers to something that could or would happen. For example:

But if I judge, my judgment will be true. (NJB)
(BSB, NJB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, NCV)

1. It refers to something that would not happen. For example:

but if I were to do so, my judgment would be true
(GNT) (GNT, CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), in parallel with 8:14a. The expression even if I do judge is a condition that will be fulfilled. Jesus did not judge at that time, but he will judge.

My judgment is true: his clause indicates that Jesus' decisions are true, right, and just. For example:

my decisions are right (NIV84)

my judgment is valid (NRSV)

my judgment is correct

8:16b

because I am not alone;

- because I am not alone when I judge, (NET)
- because I do not judge by myself.

because: The Greek conjunction that BSB translates as because introduces the reason why Jesus' judgment was always valid and just. Here is another way to translate this word:

for (NRSV)

I am not alone: The BSB translates the Greek expression literally as I am not alone. The idea of judging is implied. Someone will be with Jesus when he judges, and he will help him and inform him. For example:

I am not alone in this (GNT)

I am not alone when I judge (NET)

8:16c

I am with the Father who sent Me.

- rather, I judge with the Father, who sent me.
- I judge as God the Father helps/supports me. He sent me here.

In Greek conjunction this clause begins with a conjunction that connects a negative statement (8:16b) to a positive statement (8:16c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction "but" as in the NRSV.
- Use a conjunction other than "but." This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I am not the only one to judge, rather/instead it is me and the one who sent me.

- Do not use a conjunction as in the BSB.
- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

My Father judges with me; it is not just me alone.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

I am with the Father who sent Me: This expression indicates that Jesus and the Father judge together. For example:

I and the Father who sent me do so together (NET)

I make my judgment with the Father who sent me
(GW)

The Father who sent me is with me (GNT)

the Father who sent Me: The phrase the Father here refers to God the Father. However there is a textual problem:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say "the Father who sent me." For example:

the Father, who sent me (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, ESV, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, NIV, CEV, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say "he who sent me." For example:

he who sent me (RSV) (RSV, REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek New Testament gives this an A rating, which indicates that it is almost certain.

John 8:17

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:17

Even in your own Law it is written that the testimony of two men is valid.

- It is written in your own law that the testimony given by two witnesses/people is acceptable as true/proof.
- Your own law says that when two people give evidence, it should be accepted as true/reliable.

Even in your own Law it is written that the testimony of two men is valid: This clause indicates that Moses' law required at least two witnesses to prove a charge (accusation). See Deuteronomy 19:15. One witness was not sufficient to prove that someone was guilty.

Even in your own Law it is written: In some languages it may be natural to make your own Law the subject of the clause. For example:

Your own law says that (NCV)

Your law requires (CEV)

in your own Law: The phrase your own Law refers to the Jewish law, the law of Moses. The pronoun your is emphasized, and you may want to emphasize the word in your translation.

it is written: This phrase introduces a quotation from the Old Testament. It implies that the following statement has authority. All Jews agreed that what was written in Scripture had authority.

the testimony of two men is valid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as valid is more literally "true," as in 8:13b and 8:14a. This clause indicates that when two people agree about something in their testimony, it should be accepted. That means that people should believe that it is true and reliable. One witness was not sufficient. The testimony of one person might be true, but it was not accepted as legal proof. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the witness of two people is reliable

if two people agree about something, their witness is accepted as fact (NLT)

when two witnesses say the same thing, you must accept what they say (NCV)

John 8:18

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:13–18

The Jewish religious leaders challenged what Jesus said. They said that his witness to himself was worthless. Jesus defended his witness by saying that his

Father, God himself, was also a witness. God the Father also said that what Jesus said was true.

8:18a

I am One who testifies about Myself,

- I am giving a testimony about myself.
- And I myself am one witness who can confirm who I am.

I am One who testifies about Myself: The BSB translates the Greek clause literally as I am One who testifies about Myself. Jesus was saying that he was the first witness. He testified that he told the truth when he said that he was from God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am one who testifies for myself. (NIV)

I am one of the witnesses who speaks about myself. (NCV)

about Myself: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as about Myself. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

about me (NET)

for myself (NIV)

I testify that what I say is true

8:18b

and the Father, who sent Me, also testifies about Me.”

- The Father who sent me also gives a testimony about me.”
- My Father who sent me is also a witness.”

the Father, who sent Me, also testifies about Me: Jesus declared that the second witness was God himself. God the Father joins with Jesus to confirm that Jesus was from God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

my other witness is the Father, who sent me (NIV)

and my Father, who sent me, testifies that I tell the truth

John 8:19

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus’ testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:19–20

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to tell them where his Father was. Jesus told them that if they knew him, they would know his Father. This implied that he was himself God.

8:19a

“Where is Your Father?” they asked Him.

- ¶ Then the Pharisees asked, “Where is your^(sing) father?”
- ¶ The religious leaders challenged/mockered Jesus, “Let us see your^(sing) father.”

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated “therefore.” The English word “then” can have that meaning as well. Some English translations use the word “then” and some others use “therefore” or “so.” Other translations like the BSB do not translate this conjunction. The conjunction introduces the Pharisees’ response to what Jesus said about his Father. Introduce the Pharisees’ response in the way that is natural in your language.

Where is Your Father?: This is a rhetorical question. The Pharisees used it to challenge Jesus without showing respect. The leaders were challenging Jesus to show them his second witness. They did not believe that Jesus’ Father was God. They thought on a human level and wondered about Jesus’ physical father. Perhaps they knew that his mother Mary was not married when she became pregnant with Jesus. They also implied that Jesus’ father was not around.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question as in the BSB.

- Use a statement. For example:

Show us your father!

We can/do not see your father!

Translate this challenge in the way that is most natural in your language. You may want to translate it in a way that shows that they were mocking Jesus. For example:

And your father is where?

they asked Him: The pronoun they refers to the Pharisees and the pronoun Him refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to make one or both of the pronouns explicit. For example:

the Pharisees said to Jesus

8:19b

“You do not know Me or My Father,” Jesus answered.

- Jesus replied, “You^(plur) do not know me or my Father.
- Jesus answered them, “You^(plur) do not truly/really know either me or my Father.

You do not know Me or My Father: Of course the people Jesus spoke to knew who Jesus was and they knew who God was. But they did not know or understand very well either Jesus or God his Father. In some languages it may therefore be natural to translate this clause like this:

You do not truly/really know either me or my Father.

You: The pronoun You is plural because it refers to the religious leaders.

My Father: The phrase My Father is referring to Jesus’ father, God himself.

Jesus answered: In the Greek, the quote introducer Jesus answered comes before what Jesus said. Place it where it is most natural in your language. For example:

Jesus answered, “You know neither me nor my Father.” (NRSV)

8:19c

“If you knew Me, you would know My Father as well.”

- If you^(plur) really knew me, then you would also know my Father.”
- Because knowing me means that you know my Father.”

If you knew Me, you would know My Father as well:

Jesus implied that he was God. Anyone who knows him knows God. Someone who does not know him does not know God. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

Knowing me means knowing my Father as well.

To truly know me means that you know my Father too.

If you knew Me: This clause refers to a condition that was not fulfilled. It indicates that the religious leaders did not really know Jesus. These leaders said they knew where Jesus came from, but they did not realize that he came from God. Translate this clause in a way that makes it clear that this is not a fulfilled condition. The religious leaders did not truly know Jesus. For example:

If you really knew me

If you had known me (JBP)

you would know My Father as well: This clause refers to something that was not true. The condition in the previous clause was not fulfilled and so the consequence did not happen. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

you would have known him (JBP)

John 8:20

Section 8:12–20: Jesus is the light of the world

In this section Jesus returned to teaching in the temple during the festival of Booths. He declared that he was the light of the world. The Pharisees said that what Jesus said was not valid because he testified about himself. Jesus said that his testimony was valid because he knew where he came from and where he was going. And he said that his Father testified about him too, but they did not know either him or his Father.

Here are some other examples of headings for this section:

Jesus said that he was light for the world

Jesus' testimony that he was the light of the world was valid

Paragraph 8:19–20

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to tell them where his Father was. Jesus told them that if they knew him, they would know his Father. This implied that he was himself God.

8:20a

He spoke these words while teaching in the temple courts, near the treasury.

- He said these words while teaching in the temple near the offering box.
- Jesus said this as he was still teaching in the temple area/courts. He was near the place where the people placed their gifts/offerings.

In this verse, John explains that Jesus was talking in the temple courts. Yet even though he was speaking in public, they did not arrest him.

He spoke these words: The pronoun He refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

Jesus made these statements (NLT)

while teaching in the temple courts, near the treasury: Jesus was still teaching in the temple area, where he started to teach in 7:14. You may want to indicate that this teaching had started earlier by supplying the word “still.” For example:

while he was still teaching in the place where the temple treasures were stored (CEV)

in the temple courts, near the treasury: This phrase probably refers to the Court of the Women where people gave gifts for the temple. People placed their gifts in the offering boxes there. (A treasury is a place where one receives or stores money or valuable items.) For example:

in the Temple, in the room where the offering boxes were placed (GNT)

in the temple area near the place where the offerings were put (NIV)

8:20b

Yet no one seized Him, because His hour had not yet come.

- However, no one arrested him, because his time had not yet arrived.
- The authorities did not arrest him, because it was not yet the right/appointed time.

Yet no one seized Him: This clause indicates that no one stopped Jesus' teaching. The Jewish and Roman authorities did not arrest him.

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet can be understood in two ways:

1. It introduces an event that was not expected. Although Jesus was preaching in the temple in a public area, no one stopped him. For example:

Yet no one seized him (NIV) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It introduces the next event in the narrative and can also be translated as “And.” For example:

And no one arrested him (GNT) (GNT, KJV, NASB)

The NJB, GW and NET do not translate this conjunction. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations.

because His hour had not yet come: The phrase His hour refers to the time for Jesus to be arrested and then put to death. See how you translated this phrase in 2:4b and 7:30. God did not allow people to touch or harm Jesus at this time. Here is another way to translate this clause:

because his time had not yet come (NIV)

In some languages “time” and “hours” do not “come.” In those languages it may be natural to say:

it was not yet his hour

it was not yet the right time for this to happen to him

John 8:21

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when

they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:21–24

Jesus warned the religious leaders that they would die with their sins not forgiven because they did not believe in him. He reminded them that they belonged to this world but he did not. He said that he was God.

8:21a

Again He said to them, “I am going away,

- ¶ Jesus again said to them, “I will go away,
- ¶ Once again Jesus told them that he was about to leave.

John starts the story again after his explanation in verse 20.

Again: This word reminds the reader that Jesus had said this before (John 7:34). Here is another way to translate this word:

Once more (NIV)

He said: The speech indicator said introduces a direct quotation. Place this speech indicator where it is natural in your language. Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, you may want to say:

Jesus said (NIV)

to them: The pronoun them refers to the Pharisees or Jewish leaders (8:13a). It may be natural to make this explicit:

to the Pharisees

I am going away: This phrase refers to Jesus' death and return to God. His listeners did not understand this, so you should not make this explicit. The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun I. And although the verb am going away is present tense, it refers to what Jesus would do in the future. You may want to use a future tense verb to make that clear. For example:

I will leave you (NCV)

8:21b

and you will look for Me,

- and you^(plur) will search for me.
- “You^(plur) will try to find me,” he said,

you will look for Me: This clause here possibly indicates that Jesus' listeners would want to find the Messiah. After Jesus' return to his Father, they would still look for and wait for the Messiah. Or they might realize too late that Jesus was the Messiah. The text does not say why they would try to find Jesus. This clause is the same as that in 7:34a.

8:21c

but you will die in your sin.

- But you^(plur) will die while still carrying the guilt of your sin,
- “but you^(plur) will die with your sin not forgiven.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but can be interpreted here in two ways:

1. It introduces something that is not expected. For example:

but (GNT) (NRSV, GW, REB, NET, GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. It introduces a clause that continues the previous thought. For example:

and (NIV) (NIV, KJV, NJB, NASB, RSV, ESV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because the clause it introduces is not expected.

you will die in your sin: The Greek phrase that BSB translates as you will die in your sin means that those religious authorities would die with their sin not forgiven. The Greek word for sin, like the BSB, is singular. The word sin may be collective here, referring to all their various sins. But some scholars think that Jesus was thinking about one particular sin, which was rejecting the Messiah. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will die with your sins unforgiven (CEV)

you will die while you still carry your sin

8:21d

Where I am going, you cannot come.”

- and where I go, you^(plur) are not able to come/go.”

- I will go where you^(plur) will not be able to come to me.”

Where I am going, you cannot come: This sentence is closely related to the previous clause. Because the leaders would die in their sin, they could not go to Jesus. It may be natural to show this connection by continuing the same sentence. For example:

and where I will go, you cannot come

Refer to your translation of 7:34c, where Jesus said something similar. In some languages it may be natural to reverse the clauses. For example:

You cannot go where I am going. (GNT)

John 8:22

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:21–24

Jesus warned the religious leaders that they would die with their sins not forgiven because they did not believe in him. He reminded them that they belonged to this world but he did not. He said that he was God.

8:22a

So the Jews began to ask, “Will He kill Himself,

- Then the Jewish leaders asked each other, “Will he kill himself?
- The religious authorities began asking if Jesus was going to kill himself. They said,

So the Jews began to ask: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So is usually translated as “therefore.” Here it introduces the response of the

religious leaders because of what Jesus had said. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

This made the Jews ask (NIV)

the Jews: The phrase the Jews in this context seems to refer to the Pharisees, Jewish religious leaders, who were mentioned in 8:13a.

began to ask: The verb began to ask here introduces a question that the religious leaders asked one another. They were not speaking to Jesus. For example:

asked each other

said to one another

Will He kill Himself...?: This question indicates that the speakers wondered if Jesus meant that he was going to (would) commit suicide (kill himself). They were not sure. They suggested this as an explanation of what Jesus meant. Translate this suggestion in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Does this mean that he will kill himself? (GNT)

Perhaps he will kill himself. (REB)

Does he intend to kill himself? (CEV)

8:22b

since He says, ‘Where I am going, you cannot come’?”

- What does he mean when he says that we^(incl) cannot go where he will go?”
- “That might explain why he said, “I will go where you^(plur) will not be able to come to me.”
- “Perhaps that is why he said that we^(incl) cannot go where he will go.”

since He says: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as since He says refers to the reason the Pharisees suggested Jesus might kill himself. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Is that why he says...? (NIV)

Where I am going, you cannot come: This is a quotation of Jesus' words in 8:21d. Translate it using the same words in both verses. Although here, because there is a quotation inside another quotation, it may

be more natural to translate this sentence as indirect speech. For example:

Is that what he means by saying we cannot go where he is going? (CEV)

He says that we cannot go where he is going. (GNT)

John 8:23

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:21–24

Jesus warned the religious leaders that they would die with their sins not forgiven because they did not believe in him. He reminded them that they belonged to this world but he did not. He said that he was God.

8:23a

Then He told them, “You are from below;

- Jesus said to them, “You^(plur) are from/of this earth/world,
- Jesus said to the religious leaders, “You^(plur) belong to this world below.

Then He told them: The Greek text introduces this phrase with a conjunction that the BSB translates as Then. Many English translations do not translate this conjunction explicitly. You should introduce this phrase in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus answered (CEV)

Jesus said (NCV)

And He was saying to them (NASB)

You are from below: This clause indicates that the religious leaders belonged to this world (see 8:23c) instead of belonging to God. They were naturally worldly in the way they thought and acted. In your translation, do not imply that Jesus referred to hell or a valley or other low-lying place. Here are examples of how to translate this clause:

You people are from here below. (NCV)

You belong to this world below. (REB)

8:23b

I am from above.

- I am from heaven.
- I belong to the world above.

I am from above: This clause indicates that Jesus came from God in heaven. It was true that he was born on earth, but that was not his true origin. In your translation, do not imply that he came from a high place or a mountain. It may be necessary to say:

I belong to the world above. (REB)

General Comment on 8:23a–b

The Greek text emphasizes the pronouns You and I to emphasize the contrast between Jesus and the Pharisees. Translate these clauses so that the contrast is clear. For example:

You belong to this world here below, but I come from above. (GNT)

8:23c

You are of this world;

- Your^(plur) home is this world.
- You^(plur) belong to this evil/fallen world,

You are of this world: Jesus was saying that the religious authorities were connected to this present evil world instead of being connected to God. They belonged to this world system, not to God and his kingdom. Here is another way to translate this clause:

You belong to this world. (NLT)

this world: The Greek word that the BSB translates as world refers to this sinful world system, all that is opposed to God. This world is ruined and lost because of

sin. See the word cosmos in the Greek-English Lexicon, BAGD, p. 446.

8:23d

I am not of this world.

- This is not my home.
- but I do not.

I am not of this world: This clause means that Jesus belonged to God and not to this evil world. He was not another sinful human being. This was not his true home. His origins were in heaven, in God. Here is another way to translate this clause:

I am not from this world. (NET)

General Comment on 8:23c–d

Again the Greek text emphasizes the pronouns you and I to emphasize the contrast between Jesus and the Pharisees. Translate these clauses so that they are in clear and direct contrast. For example:

You belong to this world; I do not. (NLT)

You belong to this world but I do not. (JBP)

Your home is in this world, mine is not. (REB)

John 8:24

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:21–24

Jesus warned the religious leaders that they would die with their sins not forgiven because they did not believe in him. He reminded them that they belonged to this world but he did not. He said that he was God.

8:24a

That is why I told you that you would die in your sins.

- I told you^(plur) that you^(plur) would die while still carrying the guilt of your sins.
- I have already told you^(plur) that you^(plur) will die with your sins not forgiven.

That is why: The Greek text includes a conjunction that is normally translated as “therefore.” The BSB translates this phrase as That is why. Some translations do not explicitly translate this conjunction, though many other English translations do. For example:

So I told you that you would die in your sins. (NCV)

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

I told you that you would die in your sins: Jesus referred back to what he said to the religious leaders in 8:21c. See how you translated his words there. Although in 8:21c, the singular word “sin” is used, while the plural form sins is used here. Here Jesus referred to all the sins that people did.

8:24b

For unless you believe that I am He, you will die in your sins.”

- And you^(plur) will die while still carrying the guilt of your sins if you^(plur) do not believe that I am the one/One.”
- And if you^(plur) refuse to believe me when I tell you who I am, that is what will happen.”

For: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as For here introduces the reason why Jesus told the religious authorities that they would die in their sins. He said this because it was true unless they believed what Jesus said about himself. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because

unless you believe that I am He: Here the word believe refers to believing that something is true. It does not include the idea of trusting in Jesus except that trust is a natural result of believing the truth about Jesus. Jesus was saying that they would die in their sins if they did not believe that I am He. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

if you do not believe that I am he (NIV2011)

unless you believe that I AM who I claim to be
(NLT)

I am He: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as I am He is more literally “I am.” There are two ways to understand this in this context:

1. It refers to Jesus’ own claims (what he declared) about himself. For example:

I am the one I claim to be. (NIV84) (NIV84, REB, GW, CEV)

1. It refers to the holy name of God, “I am who I am.” See Exodus 3:14, where God revealed himself to the people of Israel by this name. This interpretation says that Jesus claimed to be God. For example:

I Am Who I Am (GNT) (GNT, NASB, NJB)

The BSB, KJV, ESV, NIV2011, NCV, NET, RSV, and NRSV can be understood either way. The NLT includes both ideas. It is probably good to translate this clause so that both interpretations are possible. Jesus probably implied (but did not state) that he was God and was from above. But the Pharisees did not fully understand that until the end of the chapter. So you should not be very clear here that Jesus said that he was God.

you will die in your sins: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you will die in your sins here is exactly the same clause as the one translated “you would die in your sins” in 8:24a. In some languages it may be more natural to not repeat the clause. For example:

Therefore I told you that you would die with your sins not forgiven, because that is what will happen if you do not believe that I am the one.

The reason that I told you that you would die without your sins forgiven is because that will be true unless you believe that I am he.

General Comment on 8:24b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these clauses. For example:

For unless you believe that I am he you will die in your sins (NET)

John 8:25

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus’ coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God’s children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine “I am” title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:25a

“Who are You?” they asked.

- ¶ They asked, “Who do you^(sing) say that you are?”
- ¶ So the religious leaders said to him, “Tell us^(excl) who you really are.”

“Who are You?” they asked: In the Greek text these words, the quote introducer, occur at the beginning of 8:25. They introduce a question. Place the words they asked where it is natural in your language. For example:

They said to him, “Who are you?” (NRSV)

Who are You?: This question asks about the meaning of Jesus’ words in 8:24b: “unless you believe that I am he.” The speakers wondered who Jesus said that he was.

they: Jesus had spoken to the Jewish leaders mentioned in 8:22a. The pronoun they here refers to these people. It may be natural to make this explicit:

The Jewish leaders asked him

8:25b

“Just what I have been telling you from the beginning,” Jesus replied.

- “Just what I have been claiming all along,” Jesus replied. (NIV84)
- “I am the one that I have always said that I am,” Jesus answered.
- Jesus said to them, “I have been telling you^(plur) who I am since I began to teach.

“Just what I have been telling you from the beginning,” Jesus replied: Place the phrase Jesus replied where it is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus said to them, “Why do I speak to you at all?
(NRSV)

Just what I have been telling you from the beginning: The Greek sentence that the BSB translates as Just what I have been telling you from the beginning is the most difficult to understand in John. There is a small textual problem here also. There are two main ways to interpret this sentence:

1. Nearly all English translations, including the BSB, and most scholars understand it to say, “What I told you from/at the beginning.” In this interpretation, Jesus answered the question in 8:25a. (BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, RSV, ESV, REB, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)
2. The NRSV and some scholars understand it to say, “Why do I speak to you at all?” For example:

Why do I speak to you at all? (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with almost all English translations. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I am exactly who I told you at the beginning. (CEV)

The one I have always claimed to be. (NLT)

John 8:26

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told

them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus’ coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God’s children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine “I am” title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:26a

“I have much to say about you and much to judge.

- “I have much to say in judgment of you^(plur).
- I could condemn you^(plur) a great amount but I will not.

I have much to say about you and much to judge:

Jesus indicated that he could strongly condemn the religious leaders. However, he implied that he would not do so, at least not at that time. In some languages it is more natural to say:

I have a lot I could say about you and a lot I could condemn you for. (GW)

I have many things to say and to judge about you (NET)

much to say...and much to judge: The two verbs to say and to judge do not represent two different actions. They describe one activity. It may be natural to indicate this by following one of these models:

There is a lot more I could say to condemn you.
(CEV)

I have much to say in judgment of you. (NIV)

8:26b

But the One who sent Me is truthful,

- But he who sent me is true
- The one who sent me to this earth is reliable/faithful,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. However, the contrast is not clear. Jesus has just said that he had many things to say to condemn them. The contrast seems to be that he had much to say, but he would only say what the Father wanted him to. So Jesus implied that he would not say all he could say (he would only say what God wanted).

If you translate this verse literally, it may indicate in many languages that God is true but not Jesus. In order to avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to make explicit that Jesus will not say all he has to condemn. For example:

I have much to say about you and much to condemn, but I won't. (NLT)

Also the note on 8:26c and the General Comment on 8:26b–c include other examples that do not imply that Jesus is not true.

the One who sent Me is truthful: Jesus declared that his Father is true, which means that he is truthful (honest). God always speaks the truth, and he will therefore judge correctly. Here is another way to translate this clause:

he who sent me is reliable (NIV)

8:26c

and what I have heard from Him, I tell the world."

- and I will tell the world the things that I have heard/learned from him."
- and I only tell people what he has told me."

and what I have heard from Him, I tell the world: Jesus said exactly what God told him to say. What Jesus said was therefore true and reliable. Several English translations make it explicit that Jesus declares only what he heard from the Father. This helps to make it clear that the contrast in 8:26b–c is between what Jesus does and does not say. If it is natural in your

language, you may want to make this explicit. For example:

I tell the world only what I have heard from him.
(GNT)

the world: This phrase refers to the people in the world, and includes the people that Jesus was talking to. Here are some ways to make that clearer:

the people of the world (CEV)

people (NCV)

all people here on earth

General Comment on 8:26b–c

In some languages it may be necessary to reverse 8:26b and 8:26c in order to make the contrast clear. In your translation, make sure that the contrast is between what Jesus will and will not say, not between Jesus and the truthful (honest) one who sent him. For example:

But ^{26c}I tell people only the things I have heard from the One sent me, ^{26b}and he speaks the truth.
(NCV)

^{26c}For I say only what I have heard from the one who sent me, ^{26b}and he is completely truthful.
(NLT)

John 8:27

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God's children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine "I am" title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:27

They did not understand that He was telling them about the Father.

- The religious leaders did not realize that Jesus was telling them about his heavenly Father.
- Jesus spoke about God, his heavenly Father, but the people listening did not understand/know that.

They did not understand that He was telling them about the Father: This is a background or parenthetical note by the author John. He informed his readers about something they might not understand—that the religious leaders did not realize that Jesus was referring to God the Father. In your translation, it may be necessary to indicate that the Father refers to God, not to any earthly father. For example:

They did not realize/know that he was talking about his heavenly Father.

John 8:28**Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death**

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God's children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine "I am" title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:28a

So Jesus said, "When you have lifted up the Son of Man,

- Therefore Jesus said, "When you^(plur) have lifted up/high the Son of Man,
- So Jesus said to them, "When you^(plur) have raised high the Son of Man on the cross,

So Jesus said: The conjunction that the BSB translates as So means "therefore." It introduces something Jesus said in response to his listeners' failure to understand what he was talking about.

When you have lifted up the Son of Man: This clause refers to something that would happen in the future. It refers to the time when Jesus would be put on a cross to die. See how you translated this in 3:14a, b, and see the notes there. A literal translation may give the wrong meaning that Jesus would fall down and people would help him stand up. In order to avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to explicitly mention the cross:

When you have lifted up the Son of Man on the cross (NLT)

the Son of Man: This phrase comes from the description of the person in Daniel 7:13–14. See the notes on 1:51c and 3:14b and how you translated the phrase in those verses. Jesus used this term to refer to himself, which indicates that he was the true man from God.

8:28b

then you will know that I am He,

- then you^(plur) will recognize that I am the one/One,
- then you^(plur) will know/understand who I am.

you will know that I am He: The verb phrase you will know indicates that the people would come to understand something they did not understand before. The expression I am He is the same as in 8:24b. See the note there, and translate this clause the same way in

both verses. If you have translated the book of Isaiah, see how you translated a similar expression in Isaiah 41:4 and 43:10, 13. Jesus again implied that he was God. Here are other ways that you can express this implication:

you will know that I am what I am (REB)

you will know that I am the one (GW)

8:28c

and that I do nothing on My own,

- and that I do not do anything by myself,
- You will realize/understand that I do not act based on my own decision,

I do nothing on My own: This clause indicates that Jesus did not act on his own authority. Neither did he do what he alone decided. He did only what God told him to do. For example:

I do nothing on my own authority. (ESV)

I do nothing from my own thoughts.

8:28d

but speak exactly what the Father has taught Me.

- but I say just what the Father has taught me.
- but I say what I have learned from the Father.

but speak exactly what the Father has taught Me:

The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* here connects a negative statement (8:28c) to a positive statement (8:28d). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction *but* as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than *but*. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I do nothing on my own, rather/instead I say what the Father teaches me.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I don't do anything on my own. I say only what my Father taught me. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I only say what my Father taught me. I do not do anything on my own authority.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

John 8:29

Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus' coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God's children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine "I am" title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:29a

He who sent Me is with Me.

- The one who sent me is with me now/always;
- He who sent me is my companion.

He who sent Me is with Me: The phrase *He who sent Me is with Me* refers to God the Father. God the Father is always with Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The one who sent me is with me now. (JBP)

He who sent me is present with me (REB)

8:29b**He has not left Me alone,**

- he has not left me by myself,
- He has not abandoned me,

He has not left Me alone: This clause indicates that God had never abandoned Jesus. He remained with him at all times.

8:29c**because I always do what pleases Him.”**

- because I always do what pleases him.”
- because I always do the things that he wants me to do.”

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why God never left Jesus. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

for (NRSV)

I always do what pleases Him: This clause indicates that Jesus always acted in union with God his Father. This is the reason why God was always present with him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because I always do what pleases him (GNT)

because I always do those things that please him (NET)

General Comment on 8:29b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 8:29b–c. For example:

^{29c}I always do what is pleasing to him, ^{29b}so he has not left me alone. (NCV)

John 8:30**Section 8:21–30: Jesus predicted his death**

In this section Jesus told the Pharisees about his death, but they did not understand him. He also told them that he came from heaven. And he said that the Father had sent him and told him what to say and was always with him. He also told them that unless they believed in him, their sins would not be forgiven when they died if they did not believe in him. However, Many who heard him believed in him.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The Pharisees did not understand what Jesus said about his death or his Father

Jesus’ coming death and his relationship with his Father

Paragraph 8:25–30

Jesus continued to say that he was from God. He told the religious leaders that if they really believed what he taught, they would know what was true. If they were God’s children, they would love him. They could not believe him because they did not belong to God.

Jesus, however, honored his Father God. He did not seek glory for himself but God sought it for him and glorified him. Finally Jesus said that he existed before Abraham, and he used the divine “I am” title for himself. Then the Jews picked up stones to kill him but he escaped.

8:30**As Jesus spoke these things, many believed in Him.**

- While Jesus said this, many people believed in him.
- Many who heard Jesus say these things believed in him. (GNT)

As Jesus spoke these things, many believed in Him:

This verse implies that it was many of those who heard Jesus speak who believed in him. So in some languages it may be natural to say that explicitly:

many who heard him say these things believed in him (NLT)

believed in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:31a, and 7:38a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

put their faith in him (CEV)

believed on him

trusted in him

General Comment on 8:30

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

many believed in him as he said these things

many believed in him while they listened to what he said

John 8:31

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:31–33

Jesus spoke to those who said that they believed in him. He said that to follow and obey him was the way to freedom. Some who heard him rejected this, saying that as the children of Abraham they were already free.

8:31a

So He said to the Jews who had believed Him,

- ¶ To the Jewish people who had believed him, Jesus said,
- ¶ Jesus said to those who believed him,

So He said to the Jews who had believed Him: The phrase the Jews who had believed Him refers to those people that were mentioned in 8:30. These people now believed in Jesus. Because everyone there was Jewish, and no contrast is intended with Gentiles, some translations do not mention the Jews. For example:

So Jesus said to those who believed in him (GNT)

believed Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as believed Him is slightly different than the phrase that the BSB translated as “believed in Him” in 8:30. However, the meaning is basically the same, and some English versions, such as the NRSV, translate the two phrases in the same way. Most scholars agree that the two phrases have the same meaning in these verses and refer to the same people.

See the note in 8:30 and how you translated the phrase there.

had faith in him (CEV)

who had believed

trusted in him

8:31b

“If you continue in My word,

- “If you^(plur) continue to believe/obey my teaching,
- “Remain faithful to what I say/teach,

If you continue in My word: This is a conditional clause. It refers to continuing to believe and obey Jesus’ message. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If you continue to follow my teaching (NET)

If you continue believing/obeying my teaching

If you live by what I say (GW)

8:31c

you are truly My disciples.

- then you^(plur) are really/actually my disciples.
- and you^(plur) will be my true followers.

you are truly My disciples: This clause indicates that it is followers who believe and obey who are really Jesus’ disciples. They are disciples in fact and in reality. They do not just call themselves disciples. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are really my disciples (NET)

you^(plur) are my true followers

General Comment on 8:31b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 8:31b–c. For example:

^{31c}You are truly my disciples ^{31b}if you remain faithful to my teachings. (NLT)

John 8:32

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:31–33

Jesus spoke to those who said that they believed in him. He said that to follow and obey him was the way to freedom. Some who heard him rejected this, saying that as the children of Abraham they were already free.

8:32a

Then you will know the truth,

- Then you^(plur) will know the truth,
- You^(plur) will understand what is true,

Then you will know the truth: In this context the conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces a second result of the conditional clause in 8:31b.

know the truth: This expression here means to recognize or understand what is true about God. It implies that previously the listeners/disciples did not know the truth. For example:

you will come to know the truth (NJB)

8:32b

and the truth will set you free.”

- and this truth will release you^(plur).
- and believing what is true will free you^(plur) from slavery.”

and the truth will set you free: Jesus implied that his listeners were not free. He implied that they were slaves. (Slaves are people who are owned by someone else, who work without wages and have no rights.) In some languages it may be necessary to indicate or imply what kind of freedom Jesus referred to. He

referred to freedom from slavery (being slaves) to sin. For example:

the truth will make you free people

the truth will free you from slavery

John 8:33

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:31–33

Jesus spoke to those who said that they believed in him. He said that to follow and obey him was the way to freedom. Some who heard him rejected this, saying that as the children of Abraham they were already free.

8:33a

“We are Abraham’s descendants,” they answered.

- They answered him, “We^(excl) are the sons/children of Abraham
- The Jewish leaders replied, “We^(excl) are descended from Abraham.

We are Abraham’s descendants: The pronoun We is best treated as exclusive here. It is true that the speakers knew that Jesus was a son of Mary, and therefore a descendant of Abraham. However, they were not sure about his father. They spoke about themselves rather than him, as they responded to the “you” in the previous verse. (Jesus did not say, “the truth will make us^(incl) free.”) They said that as children of Israel they did not need to be set free. They believed that they were already spiritually free and that they belonged to God.

they answered: There are two ways to understand whom the pronoun they refers to here:

1. It refers to Jesus' opponents that have been the ones who talked to him in all of chapters 7 and 8.
2. It refers to the Jews who believed in him in verses 30 and 31. That is the most recent plural noun that they could refer to.

Scholars are divided on the issue. Augustine, Barnes, Beasley-Murray, Bernhard, Cornerstone Commentary, Hunn, Klink, and Lenski favor interpretation (1), while Carson, Dodds, Godet, Hendriksen, Meyer, Michaels, Morris, Plummer, Ridderbos, Robertson, Vincent, and Westcott favor interpretation (2). Interpretation (2) appears to be a natural way to understand the pronoun. However, it seems more probable that they refers to Jesus' opponents.

In verse 37, Jesus said that they were trying to kill him and that there was no place in them for his word. That does not sound like he was talking to the believers mentioned in 8:30–31. And in several places in John there are pronouns which refer to people not yet mentioned. Later, in verses 48 and 52, John identifies the ones who have been talking with Jesus. It is the same term that he uses for Jesus' opponents.

When you translate the pronoun, it is recommended that you use the pronoun they as all English translations do. However, if you must make the pronoun clear, it is recommended that you refer to Jesus' opponents.

8:33b

“We have never been slaves to anyone.

- and we^(excl) have never been slaves, not to anyone.
- No one has ever made us^(excl) their slaves!

We have never been slaves to anyone: The Jewish speakers denied two things: they denied that they were slaves to anyone, and they denied that they had ever been slaves. Translate this as a statement that is emphasized. It is good to suggest a tone of anger. For example:

and have never been anyone's slaves! (NET)

and we have never in our lives been any man's slaves (JBP)

slaves: This word refers to people who were owned by another person. They worked for their owner/master and did not receive wages. They had no rights of their own (or very few rights).

In some cultures, slaves may not be known. In other cultures, the word for slave may imply different customs than in biblical culture. If that is true in your language, here are some ways to translate this word:

people who belonged to someone else

owned people

people who are forced to serve someone

Another way to translate this idea is to use a verb instead of a noun. (Actually, the Greek uses a verb form.) For example:

no one has ever forced us to serve them

8:33c

How can You say we will be set free?”

- So why do you say, ‘You will be released?’”
- How can you say that we^(excl) must be freed!”

How can You say we will be set free?: This is a rhetorical question. They used it to criticize or rebuke. The speakers were upset that Jesus wanted to set them free. They considered that they were already spiritually free, that they already followed God in a good way. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

What do you mean, then, by saying, ‘You will be free?’” (GNT)

How can you say that we shall be set free? (NIV)

- Use a statement that criticizes or rebukes Jesus. For example:

It does not make sense to say that we can be set free.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

we will be set free: This refers to what Jesus had said in 8:32b, “The truth will make you free.” You should translate the expression as it is here, and not make it agree exactly with what Jesus originally said. The verb set free is passive, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

General Comment on 8:33c

- Use a passive verb. For example:

you will be made free (NRSV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

you will be free (GNT)

John 8:33c contains a direct quotation inside another direct quotation. The inner direct quotation is not an exact word-for-word report of what Jesus had said (in 8:32b). In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quotation. The speakers will therefore refer to themselves as “we^(excl)” rather than “you.” For example:

So why do you say we will be free? (NCV)

John 8:34

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:34–38

Jesus spoke about freedom and slavery (being slaves). He said that as the Son he could give people true freedom.

8:34a

Jesus replied, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- ¶ I Jesus answered, “I assure you^(excl) of this:
- ¶ I Jesus said to them, “I tell you^(excl) this serious truth,

Truly, truly, I tell you: Jesus often used this phrase to emphasize what he said next. See, for example, 3:3, 3:5, and 6:53. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

I tell you the truth (NIV93)

I assure you (NLT)

8:34b

everyone who sins is a slave to sin.

- everyone who sins is like a slave. Sin is his master.

- all people who continue to sin are allowing sin to control them.

everyone who sins is a slave to sin: There is a textual problem here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts include the words to sin or “of sin.” (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NIV, RSV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, NCV)
2. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the words to sin. For example:

everyone who commits sin is a slave (NJB) (REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because most English translations follow it. The UBS Committee gave this reading a C rating, which indicates much doubt about the correct text. However, even if the words were not included, they were implied. You may want to follow the reading of your national or major-language Bible translation

In some languages it may be natural to use plural forms here:

all who commit sin are slaves

who sins: This phrase refers to a person who continues to sin regularly and as a habit.

a slave to sin: This phrase is a metaphor. It indicates that this person is forced to obey something (here, forced to obey sin). He or she cannot stop sinning. It is good to keep this figure of speech, but in some languages it may be necessary to do one of the following:

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

Everyone who continues to sin is like a slave of sin

- Explain something of the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

all people who continue to sin are slaves, controlled by their desire to sin

a slave: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slave can refer to either a slave or a servant. A slave is forced to work and may receive little or no pay, while a servant usually works freely and receives pay. Here, use a word that means slave, a person who is not free to choose whether to obey the master.

John 8:35

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:34–38

Jesus spoke about freedom and slavery (being slaves). He said that as the Son he could give people true freedom.

8:35a

A slave is not a permanent member of the family,

- And a slave has no permanent place in the family,
- Now such slaves do not have an enduring place in the home,

The Greek text connects this verse to the previous verse with a common conjunction that can be translated as “and” or “but.” Most English translations, including BSB, do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Connect these verse parts in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Now (NIV)

And (CEV)

A slave is not a permanent member of the family:

This refers to the fact that the slave is not a family member in the house where he works. He lives in the same house but is not related to the others and has no rights there. He has no permanent (lasting) place in that home, with that family. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The slave does not remain in the house forever.
(ESV)

The slave is not a permanent part of the family.

A slave: The Greek word that the BSB translates as slave refers to a person who is forced to work for someone else without pay. Use the same word that you used in 8:34b. The text here does not refer to one specific slave but to slaves in general. So it may be natural to say:

slaves (CEV)

the family: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the family refers to a house as a home and those who live in that home. Slaves were considered to be members of that family as long as they lived and worked there. Once they left, they were no longer members of that household. They then became members of a different household. So it may be necessary to make this idea clearer. For example:

the home that he works in

the household whom he serves

8:35b

but a son belongs to it forever.

- but the son belongs in the family forever.
- the son, however, always has a place there.

but: In the Greek there is no conjunction that connects 8:35a and 8:35b. The two statements stand in direct contrast, and some English translations like the BSB indicate this with a conjunction. Connect these two clauses in a way that is natural in your language.

a son belongs to it forever: This clause has been interpreted in two ways:

1. It continues the metaphor and refers to the son of the master of the household. For example:

but a son belongs to the family forever (NCV) (NIV, RSV, GNT, NLT, GW, NCV, ESV, NRSV, NASB, NET, REB)

1. It refers to Jesus as the Son of God. For example:

though the Son will always remain in the family
(CEV) (REB, KJV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars and translations. Jesus was still using a metaphor here. However, it is good to use words that also apply to Jesus, the Son of God,

because he is the reality that the metaphor points to. For example:

the son belongs to it for ever (REB)

the son remains forever (NET)

a son: In some languages you may not be able to talk about a son without saying whose son he is. If that is true in your language, here is another way to express this phrase:

the master's son

John 8:36

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:34–38

Jesus spoke about freedom and slavery (being slaves). He said that as the Son he could give people true freedom.

8:36a

So if the Son sets you free,

- So if the Son of God releases you^(plur),
- So if I, the Son, frees you^(plur),

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* here introduces a conclusion Jesus makes from what he just said. The son of a family always has rights as a member of that family. Therefore, because Jesus is the Son of God, he has the right to free people from slavery (being slaves).

if the Son sets you free: This conditional clause refers to the Son of God releasing people from slavery. They will then be free in the sense that they will not be forced to serve a master against their will. They will be

free not to sin. This clause implies that the people to whom Jesus spoke were slaves. They needed someone to set them free. Here are some other ways that this clause may be translated:

if the Son makes you free (NRSV)

If the Son gives you freedom (CEV)

if the Son frees/releases you

the Son: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated as the Son is the same phrase as “the son” in 8:35b. However, here Christ begins to speak directly of himself as the Son of God instead of using a metaphor. The BSB has indicated this by using a capital S in Son. You may do the same if it is natural in your language. It is also possible to continue to say “the son” and allow the context to indicate the change in meaning. Or here is another way to make the meaning clear:

God's Son

This phrase is a short form of “the Son of God,” which is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated this phrase at 5:19. For further information, see the note on the phrase “the Son of God” at 1:34.

8:36b

you will be free indeed.

- you will be truly/really free.
- you will have true freedom.

you will be free indeed: This phrase emphasizes that this person will no longer be a slave. He or she will have true freedom. The word *indeed* means “actually” or “truly” and is used for emphasis. Emphasize this in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

you will be really free (NET)

you will be absolutely free (GW)

you are truly free (NLT)

John 8:37

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:34–38

Jesus spoke about freedom and slavery (being slaves). He said that as the Son he could give people true freedom.

8:37a

I know you are Abraham's descendants,

- Yes, I know that you^(plur) are sons/children of Abraham.
- I recognize/agree that you^(plur) are descended from Abraham.

I know you are Abraham's descendants: This clause indicates that Jesus knew that the religious leaders were from Abraham's family. He knew this, and they knew this. Jesus accepted that this was true. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I know that you are from Abraham's family. (CEV)

I know you are Abraham's children. (NCV)

Yes, I realize that you are Abraham's descendants. (NLT)

8:37b

but you are trying to kill Me

- But you^(plur) are trying to kill me
- However, you^(plur) seek to kill me

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but indicates contrast. Yes, they were Abraham's

descendants, but they did things that Abraham did not do. What they did was very different than anything Abraham would do. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

yet (NRSV)

However (GW)

you are trying to kill Me: This clause indicates that the religious leaders wanted the authorities to punish Jesus with death. See the note on 7:1c. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are ready to kill me (NIV)

you want to kill me (CEV)

8:37c

because My word has no place within you.

- because there is no room in your^(plur) hearts for my message.
- because you^(plur) refuse to accept what I am saying.

because: This conjunction here introduces the reason the religious leaders were so opposed to Jesus that they wanted to kill him.

My word has no place within you: This clause is a figure of speech. It means that the religious leaders would not listen to what Jesus said. He told them many times that he wanted to save them. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

there's no room in your hearts for my message (NLT)

you don't like what I'm saying (GW)

you refuse to accept what I say

John 8:38

Section 8:31–38: Jesus taught truth that frees people

In this section Jesus said that if his believers continued in his word, they would be true disciples. They would know the truth and the truth would make them free. But some people argued that they were never slaves. To them, Jesus said that those who sin are slaves of sin, but the Son could make them free. However, he said that they wanted to kill him because they rejected what he said.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The truth sets people free

Sin makes people slaves, but the Son makes them free

Paragraph 8:34–38

Jesus spoke about freedom and slavery (being slaves). He said that as the Son he could give people true freedom.

8:38a

I speak of what I have seen in the presence of the Father,

- I am telling you^(plur) what I have I seen when I was with the Father,
- What my Father has shown me, that is what I tell you^(plur).

I speak of what I have seen in the presence of the

Father: Jesus implied that he had been with his Father God before he came to earth. There in God's presence he learned certain things, and it was these things that he now taught. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

What I'm saying is what I have seen in my Father's presence. (GW)

I am telling you the things I have seen while with the Father. (NET)

What I speak of is what I have seen at my Father's side. (NJB)

in the presence of the Father: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek texts have "my Father's presence" and some have the presence of the Father. Because the meaning of the two expressions is the same, use what is most natural in your language.

8:38b

and you do what you have heard from your father."

- but you^(plur) do what you have heard your father tell you."
- and also you^(plur), what your father told you to do, that is what you do."

and you do what you have heard from your father:

There are two ways to understand this clause:

1. It says that these people were doing what they learned from their own (spiritual) father. For example:

but you do what your father has told you (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, KJV, NASB, NJB, RSV, ESV, CEV, NCV, NLT, GW)

1. It says that Jesus wanted these people to do what they heard from God. For example:

you should do what you have heard from the Father (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), as most English translations do.

you do what you have heard: The religious leaders had learned. There is a textual problem here. The KJV follows Greek manuscripts that read "what you have seen." Most English translations follow those manuscripts that read "what you have heard." This is the reading supported by the Greek UBS New Testament, which gives it a C rating, indicating that there is some doubt. certain things from their spiritual father. Because Jesus did not say that they had heard this in a literal sense, it may be natural to say:

what you have learned (NJB)

following the advice of your father (NLT)

you: The Greek text emphasizes the words "I" and you in this verse. This emphasis indicates a contrast between what Jesus did and what his hearers did. Here are ways that you can indicate this emphasis or contrast:

But you do what you've heard from your father. (GW)

as for you, you do what your father told you to do

from your father: These notes recommend that you understand the expression your father to refer here to Satan, the spiritual father of Jesus' enemies. Satan was their spiritual father because they obeyed him rather than God. In this context father is not a reference to God our heavenly Father. However, do not mention Satan in your translation until Jesus mentions him in 8:44.

John 8:39

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:39–41

The people who had recently believed in Jesus were Jewish and therefore said that they were Abraham's children. Jesus said that their actions proved that what they said was false.

8:39a

“Abraham is our father,” they replied.

- ¶ They answered him, “Abraham is our^(excl) father.” (NIV)
- ¶ The Jewish leaders said to Jesus, “We^(excl) are Abraham's children.”

Abraham is our father: Abraham was the ancestor of the people of Israel. The Jewish people were all descended from him. Jesus' opponents believed that just because they were descended from Abraham, they were God's people, members of God's family.

our father: The pronoun our is probably exclusive here. The Jewish leaders were contrasting themselves with Jesus. They did not know or care who his father was. The word father here means “ancestor” or “forefather.” If the word father confuses people, you may use the word “ancestor.” For example:

Abraham is our ancestor/forefather

they replied: The pronoun they continues to refer to the Jewish leaders who were Jesus' opponents. (See the note at 8:33a. The pronoun they is not made clear until 8:48.) In some languages it may be natural to make explicit who the pronoun they refers to and to whom they were speaking. For example:

The Jewish leaders answered Jesus

General Comment on 8:39a

Place the speech introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

They answered him, “Abraham is our father.” (NRSV)

8:39b

“If you were children of Abraham,” said Jesus, “you would do the works of Abraham.

- Jesus said to them, “If you^(plur) were Abraham's children, you would do the things Abraham did.
- “If you^(plur) were really God's children,” said Jesus, “you would act like Abraham.

If you were children of Abraham...you would do the works of Abraham: There is a textual issue in this verse.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have If you were...you would do This indicates that the Jewish leaders were not truly Abraham's children, and they did not do what Abraham did. For example:

If you really were...you would do (GNT) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NLT, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. Other Greek manuscripts have “If you are...then do.” The second verb is a command. For example:

If you are Abraham's children, do as Abraham did. (NJB) (NASB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because most English translations follow it. However, if the major language translation in your area follows option (2), you may want to follow that instead. The UBS Greek New Testament gives option (1) a C rating, which indicates much doubt.

In option (1), Jesus said that the religious leaders were not Abraham's children (descendants). This was shown by their behavior. They did not act like Abraham. They were, of course, descended from Abraham in the phys-

ical and biological sense. But they were not his “true” sons in the sense of being like him, similar to him in character and faith. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

if you were really the children of Abraham, you would do the things Abraham did (NCV)

if you were really the children of Abraham, you would follow his example (NLT)

if in fact you were true sons of Abraham, you would show it by acting/behaving like him

If you used a word like “ancestor” in 8:39a, you will probably want to use a word like “descendants” here instead of children. For example:

if you were really Abraham’s descendants, you would do what Abraham did

said Jesus: Again place this quote introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

“If you were Abraham’s children,” Jesus said, “then you would do the things Abraham did.” (NIV)

John 8:40

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham’s children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus’ teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:39–41

The people who had recently believed in Jesus were Jewish and therefore said that they were Abraham’s children. Jesus said that their actions proved that what they said was false.

8:40a

But now you are trying to kill Me,

- As it is, you want to kill me,
- Instead, you^(plur) seek to kill me,

But now: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But now reintroduces the information that the religious leaders were trying to kill Jesus. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

As it is (NIV)

you are trying to kill Me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as you are trying to kill Me is the same clause as in 8:37b. You should try to translate the clause the same way in both verses. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you are determined to kill me (NIV)

you want to kill me (GW)

8:40b

a man who has told you the truth that I heard from God.

- a person who told you the truth which I heard from God.
- although what I have been telling you is the truth that God told me.

a man who has told you the truth: This phrase refers to Jesus himself. He had told them the truth and continued to do so. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

I am a man who has told you the truth (GW)

that I heard from God: These words indicate that God had told Jesus what to say. In some languages it may be natural to make God the subject:

that God told me

General Comment on 8:40a–b

It may be natural to reorder the information in these clauses. For example:

^{40b}All I have ever done is to tell you the truth I heard from God, ^{40a}yet you are trying to kill me. (GNT)

8:40c

Abraham never did such a thing.

- Abraham did not do things like that.
- Abraham did not try/want to kill people!

Abraham never did such a thing: This clause indicates that Abraham did not want to kill people who told God's truth. He welcomed and accepted God's messengers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

That is not how Abraham acted. (REB)

Abraham did not do such things. (NIV)

John 8:41

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:39–41

The people who had recently believed in Jesus were Jewish and therefore said that they were Abraham's children. Jesus said that their actions proved that what they said was false.

8:41a

You are doing the works of your father."

- As for you^(plur), you are following what your own father does."
- But you^(plur) are imitating/copying your real father."

You are doing the works of your father: The Greek text emphasizes the word You. The word is plural and refers to the religious leaders who opposed Jesus. Jesus here implied that their true father was not Abraham, or God, but Satan, the evil one. However, you should not make that explicit in your translation here. Jesus did not make it explicit until verse 44. Here is another way to translate this clause:

No, you are imitating your real father. (NLT)

8:41b

"We are not illegitimate children," they declared.

- "As for us^(excl), we^(excl) are not illegitimate," they said.
- Then they said to Jesus, "Us^(excl)? We^(excl) are true/legitimate children/sons.

"We are not illegitimate children," they declared:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates as We are not illegitimate children is more literally "We were not born of sexual immorality" (NASB). The speakers said that they were legal, legitimate (born to a married couple) sons. Their parents were married. They therefore had a full right to call Abraham their ancestor and to claim God's blessing and approval. Translate this clause with an expression that is natural in your language and suitable to read in public. In some languages it may be most natural to translate this as a positive statement:

We are legitimate children.

We are true/legal sons.

We: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun We in the sentence. The emphasis suggests that the speakers contrasted themselves with Jesus, who they thought might be illegitimate (not legitimate). If you have a choice between an inclusive and an exclusive first-person pronoun, you should use an exclusive one here.

8:41c

"Our only Father is God Himself."

- God alone is our^(excl) Father."
- Our^(excl) only Father is God himself."

Our only Father is God Himself: This clause indicates that the speakers thought that because they were Jews they were God's children. They again implicitly contrasted themselves with Jesus. Apparently they

suspected that Joseph was not his biological father. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The only Father we have is God himself. (NIV)

God is our Father, and God alone. (REB)

General Comment on 8:41b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 8:41b–c. For example:

^{41c}“God himself is the only Father we have,” ^{41b}they answered, “and we are his true sons.” (GNT)

John 8:42

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham’s children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus’ teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:42a

Jesus said to them, “If God were your Father, you would love Me,

- ¶ Jesus told them, “If it were true that God is your^(plur) Father, you would love me,
- ¶ “You^(plur) would love me if God were your real Father,” Jesus replied.

If God were your Father: The conjunction *If* introduces a condition that was not fulfilled. It indicates that the idea is not true. God was not their Father. For example:

If God were really your Father (NCV)

you would love Me: This clause refers to something that did not happen. These people did not love Jesus. This showed that God was not their Father.

General Comment on 8:42a

In some languages it may be more natural to reverse the clauses in 8:42a. For example:

“You would love me if in fact God were your Father,” Jesus replied.

8:42b

for I have come here from God.

- because it is from God that I came and I am now here.
- “That is because I left God’s presence to come here to you.

for: The word *for* here introduces the reason that they would love Jesus if they were God’s children.

I have come here from God: This clause means that God sent Jesus into the world. This is why those who love God as their Father love Jesus also. In some languages it may be possible to put the emphasis on God. For example:

it is from God that I have come

General Comment on 8:42b

In the Greek, this verse part is more literally, “for I have come from God and am here.” In some languages, it may be natural to combine the two clauses in 8:42b, as the BSB has done. In other languages, it may be natural to follow the Greek and use two clauses. For example:

for I came from God. Here I am. (CEB)

I came from God and now I am here with you. (EASY)

8:42c

I have not come on My own, but He sent Me.

- I did not come here by my own choice, but God sent me.
- I did not decide by myself that I should come to earth. It was God who sent me to you.

I have not come on My own: This clause means that Jesus did not decide to come to earth by himself. For example:

I have not come by my own decision

I did not come by my own authority (NCV)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (“I have not come on My own”) to a positive statement (“He sent Me”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. (The emphasis on “on my own” and “he” adds to the emphasis on the positive statement.) Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I did not come here by my own decision, rather/ instead he is the one who sent me.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I am not here on my own. He sent me.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

He decided to send me; I am not here because I decided to come.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

He sent Me: The word He refers to God. In some languages it is natural to make this explicit. For example:

God sent me (NCV)

John 8:43

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham’s children and that God was their

Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus’ teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:43a

Why do you not understand what I am saying?

- Why is it that you^(plur) do not understand me?
- You^(plur) do not understand what I am telling you

Why do you not understand what I am saying?:

This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. Jesus rebuked the religious leaders because they did not understand what he said. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why is my language not clear to you? (NIV)

- Use a statement: For example:

You don’t understand what I say. (NCV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Why can’t you understand what I am talking about? (CEV)

what I am saying: This phrase refers to the words that Jesus used, while “My message” in 8:43b refers to the meaning or message or content of what he said. Jesus

said that they could not even understand the words that he spoke because they rejected his message. For example:

Why do you not understand what I say? It is because you cannot bear to listen to my message. (GNT)

8:43b

It is because you are unable to accept My message.

- It is because you^(plur) are unable to receive my message.
- because you^(plur) do not want to hear my teaching.

It is because: This phrase introduces the reason that the listeners could not understand what Jesus said.

you are unable to accept My message: The Greek words that the BSB translates as you are unable to accept are more literally “you are unable to hear.” In this context this seems to mean that the people were not morally able to truly hear Jesus’ message. They were not deaf physically, but they were deaf spiritually. They could not really hear his message because they refused to truly listen. For example:

you cannot bear to listen to my message (GNT)

you are unable/unwilling to listen to my word

you refuse to listen to my message

In some languages it may be possible to use the metaphor of being deaf. If you do this, check carefully that your readers will understand that this refers to being spiritually or morally deaf, not to being physically disabled. For example:

you are deaf with regard to my word

you are totally/quite deaf as far as my message is concerned

My message: This phrase refers to the content or message of Jesus’ words.

John 8:44

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham’s children and that God was their

Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus’ teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:44a

You belong to your father, the devil,

- You^(plur) belong to your father, who is the devil,
- The ruler of demons, your^(plur) real father, that is who you come from.

You belong to your father, the devil: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun You. Jesus indicated that these people showed by their behavior that they were like the devil. They were closely related to him in their character and values. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Your father is the devil (CEV)

For you are the children of your father the devil (NLT)

the devil: This phrase here refers to the chief of all evil spirits, Satan. He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Because both the devil and “Satan” refer to the same being, in some languages you may want to use the same word or phrase to translate both terms.

Here are some ways to translate the devil:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons.
- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

the leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

See how you translated this in Matthew 4:1 and Luke 4:2.

8:44b

and you want to carry out his desires.

- and you^(plur) are willing to obey your father's wishes.
- And what he wants you to do, that is what you^(plur) want to do.

you want to carry out his desires: This clause indicates that these people were willing and happy to obey their father, the devil. It implies that they actually obeyed him, not just that they chose or wanted to do so. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you desire to do what your father wants (GW)

you do exactly what he wants (CEV)

8:44c

He was a murderer from the beginning,

- He has murdered people since the beginning of creation
- The devil has always murdered people.

He was a murderer from the beginning: This clause probably refers to the devil's attempts to destroy the human race beginning when God created people. He lied to Eve in order to cause the death of Adam and Eve and their descendants. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

From the very beginning he was a murderer. (GNT)

He has always been a murderer. (CEV)

8:44d

refusing to uphold the truth,

- and does not remain in the truth
- He does not base/establish himself in/on what is true

refusing to uphold the truth: This phrase here indicates that the devil has not based or grounded (established) himself in truth. He does not believe or speak the truth, particularly the truth about God. It is difficult to know whether the original Greek text said "was not standing in the truth" or "has not stood in the truth." The UBS Greek New Testament indicates that there is

a high degree of doubt. The meaning is basically the same, so it is best to translate using the tense that is most natural in your language. He is the enemy of truth. For example:

does not follow the truth

he was never grounded in the truth (NJB)

He has always hated the truth. (NLT)

8:44e

because there is no truth in him.

- because he has nothing in common with truth.
- because nothing is true in him.

because there is no truth in him: This clause means that the devil's habit is to not speak the truth. For example:

There is nothing truthful about him. (CEV)

8:44f

When he lies, he speaks his native language,

- When the devil lies, he is talking in the way that is natural for him,
- His lies reveal his nature

When he lies: This verb phrase implies that the devil lies regularly or as a habit. It is possible to translate this as a noun phrase. For example:

His lies are according to his nature

His lies reveal/show his true nature

he speaks his native language: The devil tells lies because of who he is. He is by nature a liar, and his lies display his true nature. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he is only doing what is natural to him (GNT)

he speaks out of his own character (ESV)

he shows what he is really like (NCV)

8:44g

because he is a liar and the father of lies.

- because he is a liar and he is the origin/source of lies.
- because he is a liar and all lies come from him.

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as because here introduces the basis or reason for Jesus' conclusion about Satan in 8:44f. The reason Jesus could say that Satan's lies are according to his nature is that Satan is truly a liar. That is his nature.

he is a liar and the father of lies: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the father of lies is a figure of speech. It means that all lies come from Satan. For example:

he is a liar and he is the source of lies

because he is a liar and the origin of all lies

John 8:45

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:45

But because I speak the truth, you do not believe Me!

- But I tell you^(plur) the truth, and that is why you do not believe me.
- Yet you^(plur) refuse to believe the things that I say, simply because they are true.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. The contrast is that they believe the devil, who is a liar, but they do not believe Jesus, who speaks truth.

because I speak the truth, you do not believe Me!:

The word because here introduces the reason why those people did not believe Jesus: he told the truth. They had chosen to follow the devil, the liar, and so they would rather believe a lie. Here is another way to translate this logical connection:

I tell the truth, and that is why you do not believe me. (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the clauses. For example:

you don't believe me because I tell the truth (GW)

the reason you^(plur) do not believe me is that I speak truth

I speak the truth: The Greek text emphasizes the word I to contrast Jesus with the father of lies. For example:

But as for me, I tell you the truth

you do not believe Me!: Here the word believe refers to believing what Jesus said. Here is another way to translate this clause:

you do not believe what I say

John 8:46

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him.

Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:46a

Which of you can prove Me guilty of sin?

- Can any of you^(plur) prove me guilty of sin? No.
- None of you^(plur) can truly say that I have sinned.

Which of you can prove Me guilty of sin?: This is a rhetorical question that Jesus uses as a rebuke. Jesus was saying that none of them could show that he was guilty of any sin. He implied that this was because he had not sinned. He rebuked the religious leaders because they doubted what he said. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Can any of you prove that I am guilty of sin? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

None of you can show that I am guilty of sin.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language. If you use a rhetorical question, it may be natural to supply an answer. For example:

Can any of you convict me of sin? No.

Be careful not to imply that the people could not convict Jesus of sin because he had hidden his sin. Make sure that it is clear that no one could convict Jesus of sin because he had not sinned. For example:

Which of you can truthfully accuse me of sin? (NLT)

Which one of you can prove that I am guilty of sin? (GNT)

sin: The word sin here refers to sin in general, any evil deed or word, not to a particular sin. Jesus denied that he had sinned at all. He was saying that he never sinned.

8:46b

If I speak the truth, why do you not believe Me?

- I am telling the truth, so why do you^(plur) not believe me?
- You^(plur) should believe me, because I am telling the truth.

If I speak the truth, why do you not believe Me?:

This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to urge people to believe him. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question, as in the BSB.
- Use a statement. For example:

If/Because I tell the truth, you should believe me.

If I speak the truth: The word If here means “since” in the sense of “because.” Jesus did not suggest that there was any doubt about him always telling the truth. For example:

since I am telling you the truth (NLT)

because I tell the truth

why do you not believe Me?: Here the word believe refers to believing what Jesus said. Of course, believing what Jesus said would naturally lead to trusting him. Here is another way to translate this clause:

why do you not believe what I say?

General Comment on 8:46b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

Why will you not believe me? After all, what I say is true.

You^(plur) should believe in me because I am telling you^(plur) the truth.

John 8:47

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:42–47

Jesus said that he came from God and spoke the truth. His opponents were from the devil, who was a murderer and a liar. The fact that they did not accept Jesus proved that they were not from God.

8:47a

Whoever belongs to God hears the words of God.

- The person who belongs to God accepts what God says.
- God's children/people listen to what he tells them.

Whoever belongs to God: This phrase is more literally "the one who is of God." In this context it probably refers to anyone who belongs to God. There is an implied contrast with the people that Jesus spoke to. They showed that they did not belong to God by refusing to listen to the words of God that Jesus spoke. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

He who belongs to God (NIV)

Anyone who belongs to God (NLT)

hears the words of God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hears here is the same word that was translated "accept" in 8:43b. The expression hears

the words of God means that this person accepts and obeys what God says to him. For example:

hears what God says (NIV)

listens gladly to the word of God (NLT)

accepts what God says (NCV)

8:47b

The reason you do not hear is that you do not belong to God."

- You^(plur) do not accept what God says because you do not belong to God."
- You^(plur) do not listen because you are not the children/people of God."

The reason you do not hear is that you do not belong to God:

These clauses describe the opposite situation from 8:47a. People who do not belong to God do not accept or listen to God's words. (The Greek word that the BSB translates as hear here is the same word that was used in 8:47a.) Jesus said that his listeners were such people. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

But you refuse to listen, because you don't belong to God. (CEV)

The reason why you will not listen is that you are not from God. (NJB)

But you don't accept what God says, because you don't belong to God. (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

You, however, are not from God, and that is why you will not listen. (GNT)

You are not God's children, and that is why you will not listen. (REB)

John 8:48

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They

did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:48–51

Jesus' opponents became angry and began to insult him. They said that he had a demon. Jesus continued to say that he knew God and that God honored him just as he honored the Father. Jesus said that people who kept his word will not die.

8:48

The Jews answered Him, "Are we not right to say that You are a Samaritan and You have a demon?"

- ¶ The Jewish people there/listening answered him, "Are we^(excl) not correct when we say that you are a Samaritan and possessed by a demon?"
- ¶ Jesus' opponents said to him, "You^(sing) are not a true Jew but a Samaritan! There must be an evil spirit in you!"

The Jews answered Him: The phrase The Jews refers to those Jews who opposed Jesus and argued with him. Jesus and his disciples were all Jews, so this phrase did not refer to all the Jews there. It may be natural to make that clearer. For example:

The people there/listening answered him

Jesus' opponents said to him

Are we not right to say that You are a Samaritan and You have a demon?: This is a rhetorical question that implies that the answer is "Yes." Jesus' opponents used it to rebuke him. Jesus' opponents rebuked Jesus because he told them that they were not God's children/people.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Were we not right in saying that you are a Samaritan and have a demon in you? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

We were right to say that you are a Samaritan and that you have a demon in you! (CEV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

How right we are to call you a Samaritan and demon-possessed!

a Samaritan: The word Samaritan means a person from Samaria. But Jesus was not from Samaria, and the term here is used as an insult. The Jews hated the Samaritans. They were seen as less than pure Jews and believers of false doctrine. To communicate this it may be necessary to add a descriptive phrase. The phrase should be an insult, but must be suitable to read in public. For example:

a hated Samaritan

as worthless/wrong as the Samaritans

have a demon: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as have a demon indicates that Jesus' opponents thought that there was a demon that influenced or controlled Jesus. A demon is an evil spiritual being, a spirit controlled by Satan. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

possessed by a demon (NET)

a demon controls him

John 8:49

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:48–51

Jesus' opponents became angry and began to insult him. They said that he had a demon. Jesus continued to say that he knew God and that God honored him just as he honored the Father. Jesus said that people who kept his word will not die.

8:49a

“I do not have a demon,” Jesus replied,

- “I am not possessed by a demon,” said Jesus.
- Jesus answered them, “There is no evil spirit in me.

I do not have a demon: Jesus denied what his accusers said in 8:48. They said that a demon caused him to speak as he did. Jesus said that what they accused was false. Translate this clause as one that clearly denied the insult in 8:48. For example:

I have no demon (GNT)

I am not possessed by a demon (NET)

No...I have no demon in me (NLT)

Jesus replied: The BSB places the words Jesus replied after the quotation of his words. Place this quote introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus answered, “I do not have a demon” (NRSV)

8:49b

“but I honor My Father,

- “Rather, I honor my Father
- I am honoring my Father,

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (8:49a) to

a positive statement (8:49b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I do not have a demon, rather/instead I honor my father.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I don't have a demon in me. I honor my Father (CEV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

I honor My Father: The word honor here indicates that Jesus respected and obeyed God, who was his Father.

8:49c

and you dishonor Me.

- and/while you^(plur) insult me.
- but you^(plur) are saying evil/insulting things about me.

and: This conjunction connects and contrasts what Jesus did and what his opponents did. In some languages it may be natural to translate it in a way that makes the contrast more explicit. For example:

I honor my Father, but you dishonor me. (GNT)

I honor my Father—and yet you dishonor me (NET)

Nearly all English translations that use “but” in 8:49b use and here and leave the contrast here implied. You should translate this conjunction in the way that is most natural in your language.

you dishonor Me: The word dishonor here means to say evil things about someone so that others will not respect that person. Jesus' opponents tried to make others hate him by saying that he was possessed or controlled by a demon. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you refuse to honor me (CEV)

you are trying to dishonour me (JBP)

you are saying evil/shameful things about me

John 8:50

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:48–51

Jesus' opponents became angry and began to insult him. They said that he had a demon. Jesus continued to say that he knew God and that God honored him just as he honored the Father. Jesus said that people who kept his word will not die.

8:50a

I do not seek My own glory.

- However, I am not seeking honor for myself.
- But I do not want people to honor/praise me,

In the Greek text 8:50a connects to 8:49c with the common conjunction that is often translated as "but," but is left implied in the BSB. Although he told the Jews that they dishonored him, he did not seek honor. The contrast is not obvious and most English translations leave the conjunction untranslated or implicit. However, there is something unexpected that this conjunction introduces. He did not tell them that they dishonored him so that they would honor him as we might expect. Instead, he did not seek honor. You should translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

and you do not honor me. But I am not trying to get anyone to honor me

and you do not honor me. But I do not say that to get you to honor me because I am not looking for anyone to honor me

I do not seek My own glory: This clause indicates that Jesus was not trying to make himself look famous and important. See 5:41, where Jesus said, "I do not accept glory from men." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am not trying to get praise for myself. (NET)

I have no wish to glorify myself (NLT)

I: The Greek text strongly emphasizes the word I which refers to Jesus. That could imply a contrast that suggests that his opponents did seek their own glory.

My own glory: The word glory here means "praise" or "honor." For example:

honor for myself (CEV)

8:50b

There is One who seeks it,

- There is someone else who seeks/wants honor for me,
- God wants people to honor/praise me,

There is One who seeks it: This clause implies that God is the one who seeks glory for Jesus. In some languages a literal translation may suggest that someone else was trying to take Jesus' glory for himself. In those languages it may be necessary to say it more explicitly:

there is one who wants me to be honored (CEV)

8:50c

and He is the Judge.

- and he is the one who judges with justice.
- and he judges in my favor.

He is the Judge: The clause that the BSB translates as He is the Judge is more literally "he is the one judging." It implies that God judges justly, correctly, and that he judges in Jesus' favor. For example:

He is the true judge. (NLT)

there is one...who judges in my favor (GNT)

John 8:51

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:48–51

Jesus' opponents became angry and began to insult him. They said that he had a demon. Jesus continued to say that he knew God and that God honored him just as he honored the Father. Jesus said that people who kept his word will not die.

8:51a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I assure you^(plur) of this truth:
- Pay^(plur) attention to me/this:

Truly, truly, I tell you: This expression introduces important information Jesus wanted to emphasize. See also the notes on 3:3a and 3:5a. The expression here is the same as there, except that here the pronoun you is plural. Here is another way to translate this expression:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

8:51b

if anyone keeps My word, he will never see death."

- if anyone accepts/obeys my teaching/message, he will never die.
- those who trust/follow what I say will never die."

if anyone keeps My word: This expression refers to someone who accepts and does what Jesus says. For example:

Whoever obeys what I say (GW)

if anyone follows my teaching

he will never see death: This expression means that this person will never die. The statement is emphasized and can be more literally translated as "will never see death forever." Jesus was referring to spiritual death, the eternal death that means that one is separated from God. But his listeners did not understand this, and you should not make this explicit. For example:

will never die (NLT)

General Comment on 8:51

In some languages it may be natural to use the second-person pronoun as the subject. For example:

if you obey my words, you will never die (CEV)

John 8:52

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:52a

“Now we know that You have a demon!” declared the Jews.

- ¶ The Jewish people listening/there said, “Now we^(excl) know that you^(sing) are possessed by a demon.
- ¶ Jesus' opponents said, “That proves that you^(sing) have an evil spirit in you!

Many Greek manuscripts connect this sentence to the previous sentence with a conjunction that is often translated as “therefore.” For example:

At this (NIV)

Not all Greek manuscripts include this conjunction, but it is implied. You should translate it in the way that is natural in your language. If it is more natural, you may leave it implied, as the BSB has done.

Now we know that You have a demon: Jesus' opponents had already said that he had a demon (8:48). Now they felt sure that that was true (even though it was not). They thought that what Jesus had just said proved he had a demon. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Now we are sure that you have a demon. (CEV)

This proves to us^(excl) that you have a demon.

This makes us certain that you have a demon.

we: The pronoun we is exclusive in this context. It does not include Jesus.

You have a demon: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as You have a demon indicates that the speakers thought that an evil spirit controlled or possessed Jesus. They thought that what he had said could not be true, and that an evil spirit had caused him to think and say it. See the note on 8:48. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

you are possessed (REB)

you are possessed by a demon (NLT)

you have a demon in you! (NCV)

the Jews: This phrase continues to refer to those people there at the temple who were against Jesus. See 8:48.

8:52b

“Abraham died, and so did the prophets,

- Abraham and the prophets all died.
- Abraham and the prophets of God are all dead.

Abraham died, and so did the prophets: These clauses imply that even though Abraham and the prophets served God, they still died. All the Jewish people admired Abraham as the first ancestor of their people and the friend of God. Yet, although he was such a great man, he died. The prophets were also great men, and they also died.

the prophets: A prophet was someone who told the people words that he heard from God, God's message. See how you translated this word in 1:21d and 4:19b.

8:52c

yet You say that anyone who keeps Your word

- However, you^(sing) say, ‘If someone accepts/obeys my word,
- However, you^(sing) say that those who hold to your message

yet You say: The word yet introduces a contrast between what had happened in the past and what Jesus said would happen in the future. In the past good people had died, but in the future those who followed Jesus would not die. The speakers did not think that what Jesus said could be true.

anyone who keeps Your word: This expression refers to someone who accepts and obeys Jesus' teaching. See how you translated this in 8:51b. For example:

‘Whoever does what I say....’ (GW)

‘If anyone obeys my teaching....’ (NET)

8:52d

will never taste death.

- he will never have the experience of dying.’
- will never die.

will never taste death: This phrase means the same as “will never see death” in 8:51b. Use the expression that is natural in your language. There may be an idiom that is natural in this context, or you may translate this phrase without an idiom. For example:

will never meet death

will never die (GNT)

General Comment on 8:52c–d

These clauses include a quotation inside another quotation. The speakers quoted Jesus' words in 8:51. They did not use exactly the same words, but the meaning is the same. In some languages it may be natural to use an indirect quotation for the inner quotation. For example:

yet you say that whoever obeys your teaching will never die. (GNT)

How can you say that no one who obeys your words will ever die? (CEV)

John 8:53

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:53a

Are You greater than our father Abraham? He died,

- Are you^(sing) more important than our^(excl) father Abraham? He died
- You^(sing) seem to think you are greater than our^(excl) father Abraham.

Are You greater than our father Abraham? He died:

In Greek this is a question about Abraham that also includes a statement about him. In many languages it may be natural to break this up into two independent clauses or sentences like the BSB. In other languages, it may be natural to make this one sentence. For example:

Are you greater than our father Abraham, who died? (NRSV)

Our father Abraham died; you do not claim to be greater than Abraham, do you? (GNT)

Are You greater than our father Abraham?: This is a rhetorical question that implies that the answer is "No." The Jewish leaders who opposed Jesus used it as a rebuke. They rebuked Jesus because he said that people who followed him would not die. They understood that this statement implied that he was greater than Abraham. Therefore, their question implied that Jesus was not greater than Abraham.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

You aren't greater than our father Abraham...are you? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

You are definitely not as great as our father Abraham.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

greater: This word here means more important, more significant spiritually, and more righteous.

our father Abraham: Abraham had lived about two thousand years before. He was the first ancestor of the Jewish people. They all honored him highly. His death is recorded in Genesis 25:7–11.

8:53b

as did the prophets.

- and the prophets died also.
- Abraham and the prophets of God have all died.

as did the prophets: This refers to the prophets whose lives are recorded in the Hebrew Scriptures, the Old Testament. Although they were good men, honorable and righteous, they all died.

8:53c

Who do You claim to be?"

- Who are you^(sing) claiming/saying that you are?"
- Who do you^(sing) think/suppose that you are?"

Who do You claim to be?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jewish leaders who opposed Jesus used it as a rebuke. They rebuked Jesus because they thought that he thought that he was more important or special than he actually was. (Jesus did not actually think like that.) They were angry at his claim (saying something that he did not prove) that people who trusted him will not die. They understood that he implied that he was not an ordinary man. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Who do you think you are? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

You must think that you are very important!

You clearly think you are someone special!

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

John 8:54

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:54a

Jesus answered, "If I glorify Myself, My glory means nothing.

- Jesus replied, "If I praise myself, my/that praise means nothing.
- Jesus said to them "If it were me that honored myself, that would be worthless.

If I glorify Myself: This clause refers to something that did not happen, a condition that was not fulfilled. Jesus did not in fact glorify himself. He did not give himself praise, honor, or glory. The Greek text emphasizes the word I to contrast with his Father glorifying him in 8:54b. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

If I were to seek my own glory (NJB)

If I praised myself

If it were me that honored myself

My glory means nothing: This clause indicates that praise that one gives to oneself has no meaning. It is unimportant or worthless. Because Jesus did not glorify himself, this clause refers to a situation that was not real. This would be the situation if Jesus praised himself—but he did not. Use an expression that refers to something that could be the case, but is not. For example:

my glory would be worth nothing (NJB)

that honor would be worthless

it would mean nothing (CEV)

8:54b

The One who glorifies Me is My Father,

- The one who praises me is my Father,

- My Father is the one who honors me.

The One who glorifies Me is My Father: Jesus said that God his Father was the one who glorified him, who gave him honor. There is a contrast to the idea in 8:54a that Jesus gave himself honor. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The one who honors me is my Father. (GNT)

My Father is the one who gives me glory. (GW)

8:54c

of whom you say ‘He is our God.’

- about whom you^(plur) say ‘He is our^(excl) God.’
- And he is the one you^(plur) worship as your God

of whom you say ‘He is our God’: This phrase gives some further information about Jesus’ Father. He is the God of the Jews, (the God whom the Jewish people worship). There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the quotation in direct speech and say “our God.” For example:

the one of whom you say, ‘He is our God’ (NJB)
(BSB, ESV, NASB, NRSV, NET, NLT, REB, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the quotation in indirect speech and say “your God.” For example:

you say he is your God (NCV) (KJV, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, GNT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Committee gave this reading a B rating. The Committee noted that both readings have good manuscript support, but thought that the change would have probably gone from a direct quotation to an indirect quotation. However, the meaning of the two options is the same. You should use whichever form of speech is most natural in your language here. For example:

about whom you people say, ‘He is our God’ (NET)

The one who honors me is my Father—the very one you say is your God. (GNT)

He is our God: This clause indicates that Jesus’ Father, the one who gave Jesus glory, was the God of the Jews. And Jesus and the other Jews all believed that he was the only true God. Other peoples worshiped different

gods, but the Jewish people only worshiped the one God.

In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb indicating in what sense Jesus’ Father was our God. For example:

He is the God whom we^(excl) worship/honor

He is the God to whom we^(excl) pray

General Comment on 8:54b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 8:54b–c. For example:

My Father, ^{54c}whom you say is your God, ^{54b}is the one who praises me.

John 8:55

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham’s children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus’ teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus’ opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:55a

You do not know Him,

- And you^(plur) do not know God,
- even though you^(plur) really do not know him.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that introduces information that is in direct contrast to what Jesus' opponents just said. This information is unexpected. They knew about God, but they did not really know him. They were not personally close to him. Translate this clause in a way that indicates this unexpected contrast. For example:

but you don't even know him (NLT)

although you do not know him (NJB)

8:55b

but I know Him.

- but as for me, I know God.
- However, I do know God.

but I know Him: The words I know Him form a contrast to what Jesus had just said about the religious leaders. Jesus himself did know God. He knew him personally and closely. It may be natural to indicate the contrast with a verb that is emphasized. Or you can emphasize the word I as the Greek text does. For example:

But I do know him. (GW)

but as for me, I know him

8:55c

If I said I did not know Him,

- If I said that I did not know him,
- If I said, 'I do not know him,'

If I said I did not know Him: This clause refers to a situation that is not real. Jesus did not say that he did not know God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if I were to say that I do not know him (NET)

if I said otherwise (NLT)

to say that I do not know him would make me a liar

In some languages it may be natural to translate the inner quotation by using a direct quotation. For example:

if I said, "I do not know him/God"

8:55d

I would be a liar like you.

- I would be a liar just like you^(plur).
- then I would be a liar, in the same way that you^(plur) are liars.

I would be a liar like you: This clause also describes a situation that is not real. Jesus was not a liar. His opponents were liars because they said they knew God when in fact they did not. Here is another way to translate this clause:

I would be as great a liar as you! (NLT)

8:55e

But I do know Him, and I keep His word.

- But I do know him and I obey what he says.
- However, I know him and obey him.

But I do know Him: Jesus repeated for emphasis that he knew God. The English verb phrase I do know communicates this emphasis. Consider how it is natural to emphasize this in your language.

and I keep His word: This clause indicates that Jesus heard, received and obeyed God's word. See how you translated the same verb in 8:51b.

John 8:56

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:56a

Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see My day.

- Your^(plur) ancestor Abraham was happy at the thought of seeing the day/time when I would come;
- Your^(plur) forefather Abraham was joyful/glad to think that he would see me come to earth.

Your father Abraham rejoiced that he would see My day: Jesus referred to the fact that God had promised to send a Savior, the Messiah. Abraham believed God and trusted that the Messiah would come. This made him very happy. Jesus implied that he was the Messiah that Abraham expected. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Your father Abraham rejoiced at the thought of seeing my day. (NIV)

Your ancestor Abraham was very glad to know/think that he would see me come.

As for your father, Abraham, his great joy was that he would see my coming. (JBP)

Your father Abraham: The BSB translates the Greek words literally as Your father Abraham. All the Jewish people were descended from Abraham. He lived about two thousand years before Christ. If you use footnotes, it would be good to write a footnote that indicates this. For example:

Abraham was the ancestor of all the Jewish people. He lived about two thousand years before Jesus Christ.

rejoiced: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as rejoiced is a strong word that means “was very happy, full of joy.” This verb is also used in 5:35b, and in Luke 1:47b, where Mary rejoices that she would become the mother of the Messiah. Use an expression that describes how people rejoice when they think about a future happy event, such as a wedding or a baby's birth.

he would see My day: The phrase My day here means “the time when I come.” Abraham looked forward

to seeing the Messiah when he came to earth. He expected God to send a Savior and he was happy because he thought that he would see that happen. For example:

he looked forward to my coming (NLT)

he would see me when I came

8:56b

He saw it and was glad.”

- He saw that day/time and was very happy.”
- He saw me come and was full of joy.”

He saw it and was glad: This clause indicates that Abraham did see the coming of Jesus, the Messiah. Probably it means that he saw it by faith, but Jesus did not explain this. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He saw that day and was glad. (NCV)

he did see it and was happy/joyful

and was glad: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was glad is a different verb than “rejoiced” in 8:56a. However, it has the same meaning in this context. In your translation, you may want to use a word that describes how people are happy after a good event. Abraham was happy because he saw Christ's “day.”

John 8:57**Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus**

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:57

Then the Jews said to Him, “You are not yet fifty years old, and You have seen Abraham?”

- The Jewish leaders replied, “You^(sing) have seen Abraham? That is impossible because you are not yet fifty (50) years old.”
- The Jewish leaders said to Jesus, “You^(sing) are not even fifty (50) years old, so you cannot have seen Abraham!”

You are not yet fifty years old, and You have seen Abraham?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jewish leaders who opposed Jesus used it as a rebuke. They rebuked him because he implied that he had seen Abraham. There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

You are not fifty (50) years old yet, so how can you have seen Abraham?

- Use a statement. For example:

Because you are not yet fifty (50) years old, you cannot have seen Abraham.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language. It may be natural to break it into two sentences. For example:

“You are not even fifty years old!” they said. “How could you have seen Abraham?” (CEV)

General Comment on 8:57

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses. For example:

You have never seen Abraham! You are not even fifty years old. (NCV)

How can you say you have seen Abraham? You have not lived even fifty (50) years.

John 8:58

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:58a

“Truly, truly, I tell you,” Jesus declared,

- Jesus answered them, “I assure you^(plur):
- Jesus told them, “This is a true saying:

Truly, truly, I tell you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you introduces something important that Jesus would say. It is the same expression as is used in 8:51a. For example:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

In all truth I tell you

8:58b

“before Abraham was born, I am!”

- even before Abraham was born, I am.”
- I exist/live before Abraham existed/lived.”

before Abraham was born, I am!: Jesus said that he existed before Abraham was born. By this he implied that he was not just a human being and that he had existed before he was born on earth. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

before Abraham came into existence, I am! (NET)

before Abraham began to exist/live, I exist/live!

I am: This phrase refers to the name by which God revealed himself in Exodus 3:14:

God said to Moses, "I AM WHO I AM." He said further, "Thus you shall say to the Israelites, 'I AM has sent me to you.'" (NRSV)

When Jesus used this phrase, he indicated that he was God. If you use footnotes, it is good to include a footnote about this and refer your readers to Exodus 3:14.

John 8:59

Section 8:39–59: Abraham saw Jesus

In this section Jesus continued to speak to those who did not believe in him. Although they said that they were Abraham's children and that God was their Father, they did not do what those people would. They did not accept Jesus' teaching and wanted to kill him. So he said that their real father was the devil, who was a murderer and a liar.

They replied that he was a Samaritan and had a demon. Jesus denied that and said that if they accepted what he said, they would never die. They said that Abraham died and asked if he was greater than him. Jesus replied that he knew Abraham and existed before him. Then they wanted to throw stones at Jesus, but he hid.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Those who rejected Jesus had the devil for a father

Jesus existed before Abraham

Paragraph 8:52–59

Jesus' opponents were angry that he said that he was able to protect people from death. When Jesus then said that he had existed before Abraham, they became so angry that they tried to kill him.

8:59a

At this, they picked up stones to throw at Him.

- At this the people picked up stones to kill him.
- Then they picked up stones to kill him for blasphemy.

At this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as At this here introduces what Jesus' opponents did as a result of what Jesus had just said. They understood that Jesus said that he was God and reacted strongly to it.

they: This word refers to the people Jesus was talking with, the Jewish leaders who opposed him.

picked up stones to throw at Him: This phrase indicates that these people wanted to kill Jesus. They started to pick up stones from the ground so that they could throw them at him and kill him. This was the traditional penalty for blasphemy. See Leviticus 24:16. These people understood that Jesus said that he was God. They thought that this was not true, and that Jesus therefore blasphemed, speaking evil about God. In some languages it may be good to write a footnote here, and tell why the people wanted to throw stones at Jesus. For example:

The people wanted to kill Jesus because he said that he was God. They believed that this was blasphemy, speech against God.

8:59b

But Jesus was hidden

- But Jesus hid himself
- But they could not kill Jesus because they could not see him,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a surprising result of their action in the previous clause. The people picked up stones to stone Jesus, but they did not stone him. He hid so they could not do it.

Jesus was hidden: Jesus in some way hid himself from the angry crowd. The text does not say how this happened. It is best to translate this literally.

8:59c

and went out of the temple area.

- and went away from the temple.
- and Jesus left the temple courtyard.

and went out of the temple area: There is a textual issue here. The TRT and the NET state that some Greek manuscripts add something like "He went/walked through the middle of them/the crowd and

so disappeared.” The KJV follows those manuscripts. Many Greek manuscripts do not add this sentence. The majority of English translations follow those manuscripts. This phrase indicates that Jesus left the temple area safely. The people did not stone him.

John 9:1

Section 9:1-12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:1-5

Jesus and his followers saw a man who had been blind since he was born. Jesus’ followers thought this must have happened because of someone’s sin. So they asked Jesus whose sin had caused this man’s blindness. But Jesus said that no one had sinned to cause his blindness. Rather, he was born blind so that God’s power would be revealed.

9:1a

Now as Jesus was passing by,

- ¶ As he went on his way (REB)
- ¶ As Jesus was walking with his disciples,

Now as Jesus was passing by: This clause introduces a new story. It indicates in a very general way that Jesus was traveling. For example:

As he went on his way (REB)

As he went along (NIV)

As he passed by (ESV)

The disciples ask a question in 9:2 but they are not mentioned as present in 9:1. In some languages it may be natural to mention that they are present in 9:1a. For example:

As Jesus was walking along with his disciples

9:1b

He saw a man blind from birth,

- Jesus noticed a man who had been born blind.
- he/they noticed a man who had been blind from the day/time he was born.

He saw a man blind from birth: The word He refers to Jesus. Jesus noticed a blind man. This man had been blind ever since he was born. The fact that he had been blind since birth is background information that Jesus and the disciples knew.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he saw a man who had never been able to see

he noticed a blind man. This man had been blind since he was born.

blind from birth: This man had been blind all his life. Consider how it is natural to speak of this in your language. For example:

blind from the time he was born

blind even as a baby

blind all his life

born blind (GNT)

John 9:2

Section 9:1-12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:1–5

Jesus and his followers saw a man who had been blind since he was born. Jesus' followers thought this must have happened because of someone's sin. So they asked Jesus whose sin had caused this man's blindness. But Jesus said that no one had sinned to cause his blindness. Rather, he was born blind so that God's power would be revealed.

9:2a

and His disciples asked Him, “Rabbi, who sinned, this man or his parents,

- Jesus' disciples asked him, “Honorable sir, is it because this man sinned or his parents sinned
- Jesus' followers said to him, “Teacher, is it this man's own sin or his parents' sin

and His disciples asked Him: Jesus' disciples asked Jesus a question about the blind man. In some languages, you might need to use Jesus' name to make it clear whose disciples they were. For example:

Jesus' disciples asked (CEV)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to the “learners” or “followers” of a teacher. These learners committed themselves to living according to the teaching and example of their teacher. In the New Testament the word disciples refers specifically to people who were learning from a religious teacher. They often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. Here are some ways to translate disciples:

- Use a term that refers to people who learn from a teacher or an expert. It is helpful if the term also implies that the learner is often with his teacher. For example:

learners Be careful not to use a term that refers only to students in a school or classroom.

- Use a term that refers to people who follow a teacher or leader by obeying his teaching. It is helpful if this term also implies learning from the teacher and physically following the teacher wherever he goes. For example:

followers

See how you translated this word in 1:35 and 2:2.

Rabbi: Rabbi is a Hebrew word that means “my great one.” When John wrote this Gospel, people used this

word as a title of respect for an important religious teacher or leader. See Matthew 23:7–8.

If you do not have a word for a religious teacher, you can simply use the word “teacher” or “master.” If possible, use a word or phrase that implies that the teacher is respected. For example:

honored/honorable one

my/our teacher/master

Use an expression that is natural and shows proper respect. See how you translated this word in 3:2b and 4:31. It is good to use a different word from the word you use to translate “teacher” (8:4) and “sir” or “Lord” (4:11a, 49, 6:68a).

who sinned, this man or his parents: These words indicate that the disciples assumed that the man became blind because someone sinned. They suggested two possible options: the man's own sin had caused his blindness, or the man's parents' sin had caused it. Consider how it is natural to suggest possible causes for a bad situation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Did he or his parents sin? (GW)

did this man sin, or did his parents sin?

Was it this man who sinned? Or was it his parents who sinned?

sinned: The verb sinned refers to disobeying God's laws, doing what does not please God. The speakers assumed that someone had offended God, and that God had therefore caused this man to be born blind. The text does not explain how a baby that was not yet born could have sinned. However, some Jewish rabbis thought that this was possible.

9:2b

that he was born blind?”

- that he has been blind from the time he was born?”
- that caused him to be blind from his birth?”

that he was born blind: The Greek word that the BSB translates as that here introduces a result clause. This clause indicates what happened as a result of someone's sin. Here are other ways to indicate this connection:

whose sin caused him to be born blind? (GNT)

who committed the sin that caused him to be born blind (NET)

was it because he or his parents sinned that he was born blind?

General Comment on 9:2a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of clauses in the question. For example:

^{2b}Teacher, why was this man born blind? ^{2a}Was it because he or his parents sinned? (CEV)

^{2b}Teacher, whose sin caused him to be born blind?
^{2a}Was it his own or his parents' sin? (GNT)

John 9:3

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God's works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:1–5

Jesus and his followers saw a man who had been blind since he was born. Jesus' followers thought this must have happened because of someone's sin. So they asked Jesus whose sin had caused this man's blindness. But Jesus said that no one had sinned to cause his blindness. Rather, he was born blind so that God's power would be revealed.

9:3a

Jesus answered, "Neither this man nor his parents sinned,

- Jesus said "It is not this man's sin nor his parents' sin that caused his blindness.

- Jesus replied, "This blindness was not caused by sin, either his own or his parents'.

Neither this man nor his parents sinned: This clause indicates that neither the man's sin nor his parents' sin caused him to be born blind. Translate this in a way that provides a natural answer to the question in 9:2a–b. This clause does not mean that the man and his parents had never sinned. It just means that their sin was not the cause of the man's blindness. To avoid people wrongly understanding this clause, it may be necessary to say:

It was not the sin of this man or his parents that caused him to be blind

His blindness has nothing to do with his sins or his parents' sins. (GNT)

No one's sin caused his blindness!

9:3b

but this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him.

- Rather, he was born blind so that the work of God might be shown/displayed in his life.
- No, he has been blind from birth so that others can/ will see God's power at work in healing him.

but: The Greek text connects the clauses in 9:3b to the previous clause with a word that the BSB translates literally as but. This word connects a negative statement (9:3a) to a positive statement (9:3b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but like the BSB. For example:

Neither this man nor his parents sinned, but he was born blind so that the acts of God may be revealed through what happens to him. (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Neither this man's sin nor his parents' sin caused his blindness, rather/instead he was born blind so that God's works might be shown in him.

- Do not use a conjunction as in the NRSV. Here is another example:

His blindness has nothing to do with his sins or his parents' sins. He is blind so that God's power might be seen at work in him. (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Neither! He was born blind so that God's works may be revealed in him, not because he or his parents sinned.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

this happened so that the works of God would be displayed in him: The Greek text does not include the clause this happened, although it is implied by the context. The BSB has supplied it to make the meaning clear. Supply an expression that is natural in this context. For example:

This man was born blind so that God's power could be shown in him. (NCV)

He is blind so that God's power might be seen at work in him. (GNT)

so that the works of God would be displayed in him: The Greek word that is translated so that introduces either the purpose or the result of the man being blind. The purpose or result was to show God's works, that is, God's deeds or acts, and therefore God's power. Here are other ways to show this connection:

because of his blindness, you will see God work a miracle for him (CEV)

to show the power of God at work in him (JBP)

the works of God: This phrase here refers to something God does that shows his power. In the Greek it is plural, but in some languages it may be natural to use the singular. For example:

the work of God

God's power (GNT)

would be displayed: This verb phrase is passive. It means that people will be able to see God, or God's power, at work. There are at least two ways to translate this verb phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

could be shown (NCV)

could be seen (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that others would see God's power at work

to display/show the power of God at work

Use the verb form that is natural in your language in this context.

in him: The pronoun him refers to the blind man. God did a miracle in him by healing his eyes. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this phrase in one of these ways:

through him

in his life (NIV)

through what happens to him (NET)

John 9:4

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God's works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:1–5

Jesus and his followers saw a man who had been blind since he was born. Jesus' followers thought this must have happened because of someone's sin. So they asked Jesus whose sin had caused this man's blindness. But Jesus said that no one had sinned to

cause his blindness. Rather, he was born blind so that God's power would be revealed.

9:4a

While it is daytime, we must do the works of Him who sent Me.

- While it is still day, we^(incl) must do the work of the one who sent me.
- God has sent me here, and we^(incl) must do the work he has given us^(incl) while it is still daytime/daylight.

While it is daytime, we must do the works of Him who sent Me:

The word we probably refers to Jesus and his disciples. Some Greek manuscripts have "I" here instead of we. The KJV follows those manuscripts. Also, some manuscripts have "us" instead of "me" in the phrase "him who sent me" later in the verse, and NLT follows those manuscripts. Although there is doubt about the original reading, all other English translations agree with BSB. It seems likely that the people who copied the other manuscripts were trying to make the pronouns agree in this verse. So it is recommended that you follow BSB, although if a major language translation in your country has "I" here, you may want to follow that. They were required to do God's works while they had the opportunity. If your language has inclusive and exclusive pronouns, it is best to use an inclusive pronoun we here.

While it is daytime: This clause implies that it will not always be day. The time a person can work is limited, as daytime is limited. For example:

as long as it is daytime (NET)

daytime: This word here is a metaphor. In this metaphor, "day" represents the time when Jesus was living on earth. The similarity is that both "day" and Jesus' time on earth are times when it is good to work because light is present. Jesus himself was the light for the world (see 8:12b). It may help your readers understand this figure of speech if you make explicit that "day" refers to the hours of light. For example:

daylight (REB)

we must do the works of Him who sent Me: These clauses indicate that Jesus and his disciples were required to do God's works. God sent Jesus to the world and told Jesus to do certain miracles (works) to show God's power. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We must do the work of him who sent me (GNT)

We must do what the one who sent me wants us to do (GW)

must do: Jesus was already doing what God had sent him to do. He was healing the sick and preaching the gospel. This was not something he was about to start doing. So in some languages it may be natural to make this clearer. For example:

must keep on working

must continue doing (NCV)

the works of Him who sent Me: This phrase indicates the deeds that God himself does and wanted Jesus and his disciples to do. In this context, Jesus did the work of God, the one who sent him, when he healed the blind man. Your translation of works should not only refer to physical labor. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that God is the one who sent Jesus. For example:

the works/deeds of God who sent me

what God who sent me wants/commands

General Comment on 9:4a

In some languages it may be natural to translate the expression "while it is daytime" at the end of the verse. That may make it clearer that "while it is daytime" refers to our working and not God sending. For example:

We must work the works of him who sent me while it is day (NRSV)

9:4b

Night is coming, when no one can work.

- Soon it will be night/dark and no one will be able to do any work.
- When we reach the time of night/darkness, nobody will be able to do/complete it.

Night is coming, when no one can work: The reason why no one could work at night was because it was dark. If people regularly work at night in your culture, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

the hours of darkness are coming when no one can work

Night is coming: The words Night is coming mean “it will soon be night.” In some languages it is not natural to speak of night as coming. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

night is near

night is on the way

it will soon be night

Night: This word here is a metaphor. In this metaphor the evil time when Jesus would die and leave them is referred to as Night. Both night and when Jesus would leave are times when it is hard to work because there is no light. When Jesus would no longer be in the world as its light, there would be spiritual darkness. It may help your readers to understand this figure of speech if you translate Night in this way:

the dark/darkness

General Comment on 9:4b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 9:4b. For example:

The night when no one can do anything is coming.
(GW)

John 9:5

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:1–5

Jesus and his followers saw a man who had been blind since he was born. Jesus’ followers thought this

must have happened because of someone’s sin. So they asked Jesus whose sin had caused this man’s blindness. But Jesus said that no one had sinned to cause his blindness. Rather, he was born blind so that God’s power would be revealed.

9:5a

While I am in the world,

- While I am present in the world
- As long as I am living here on earth,

While I am in the world: This clause refers to the whole time that Jesus lived on earth. For example:

while I am here in the world (NLT)

9:5b

I am the light of the world.”

- I am the world’s light.”
- I am the light for all people on earth.”

I am the light of the world: The clause is a metaphor. This metaphor is also found in Isaiah 42:6, where the Messiah is said to be “a light to the nations.” In this metaphor Jesus compares himself to light. Like light, he makes it possible for people to see. He gives spiritual light to the people of the world, showing them who God is.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

General Comment on 9:5a–b

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I am like the light of the world.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

I am like the light of the world because I enable people to see.

- Indicate or suggest some of the meaning. For example:

I am the one who is the true light of the world.

I bring/give true/spiritual light to the people of the world.

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:5a and b. For example:

^{5b}I am the world's light ^{5a}as long as I am in it. (JBP)

John 9:6

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God's works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:6a

When Jesus had said this, He spit on the ground,

- ¶ After saying this, Jesus spat on the ground.
- ¶ Then Jesus spit on the dust/earth

When Jesus had said this: These words introduce what Jesus did next. Introduce this in a way that is natural in your language here. For example:

After Jesus said this (GW)

Jesus said this and then

Then (NLT)

He spit on the ground: The word spit means to force saliva (the liquid in one's mouth) out of your mouth. Use an expression that is natural and polite.

9:6b

made some mud,

- He used the saliva to make some mud,
- and mixed it together to make a paste.

made some mud: These words indicate that Jesus mixed his saliva with the dust or dirt on the ground. Refer to the wet mixture, or mud, in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

paste (REB)

clay (NET footnote)

9:6c

and applied it to the man's eyes.

- which he put on the man's eyes.
- He smeared the paste over the man's closed eyes

and applied it to the man's eyes: Jesus put the mixture over the man's eyes when they were closed. In some languages it may be necessary to make this clear. For example:

spread it over the man's closed eyes

applied: The Greek word that the BSB translates as applied is more literally “anointed” or “smeared/spread on” or “rubbed on.” Use a verb that refers to rubbing a small amount of mud or clay on someone's skin.

the man's eyes: This phrase refer to the man who was born blind.

General Comment on 9:6a–c

There are four verbs in 9:6a–c and you may want to begin a new sentence after 9:6a or 9:6b. For example:

After Jesus said this, he spit on the ground. He made some mud and smeared it on the man's eyes. (CEV)

John 9:7

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God's works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:7a

Then He told him, “Go, wash in the Pool of Siloam” (which means “Sent”).

- He told him, “Go, wash your^(sing) face in the pool of Siloam” (Siloam means Sent).
- and said to him, “Go to the pool called Siloam and wash off the paste” (the word/name Siloam means “sent”).

Then He told him: Jesus spoke to the blind man. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

He told him (NLT)

Go, wash in the Pool of Siloam: The word Go indicates that Jesus wanted the man to leave him and walk to the pool of Siloam. There Jesus wanted him to wash the mud off his face. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit that the man was to wash his face:

Go and wash your face in the Pool of Siloam (GNT)

in the Pool of Siloam: The words the Pool of Siloam refer to a pool of water that was near the temple in Jerusalem. The name of this pool was Siloam. This pool is also mentioned in Isaiah 8:6, where it is called “Shiloah.”

(which means “Sent”): This clause explains the name “Siloam.” This is a comment by the author, not by Jesus. The BSB therefore places it in parentheses. Translate it in a way that is natural in your language for background information. For example:

(this word means Sent) (NIV)

(Siloam means “sent”) (NLT)

(which is translated “sent”) (NET)

9:7b

So the man went and washed, and came back seeing.

- Then the blind man went and washed the mud off, and came home. And he was now able to see!
- So the man went to the pool, washed his face and went home—no longer blind!

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So can also be translated as “therefore.” Here it introduces what the man did as a result of what Jesus had just said.

the man went and washed: The pronoun the man refers to the man who was born blind. Refer to him in a way that is clear and natural in your language.

It may also be natural to supply information about where the man went and what he washed. For example:

the man went to the pool and washed his face

and came back seeing: The Greek words that the BSB translates as came back seeing are more literally “went seeing.” The context implies that he went home rather than back to Jesus. For example:

came home seeing (NIV)

General Comment on 9:7b

The man became able to see after he washed and before he went home. In some languages it may be natural to translate the verbs in the order in which they happened. For example:

Then he went to the pool and washed his face.
Then he was able to see, and he went back home.

John 9:8

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:8a

At this, his neighbors and those who had formerly seen him begging began to ask,

- His neighbors and others who had previously seen him beg asked,
- Those that knew him before, his neighbors and those who used to see him beg, said to one another,

his neighbors: This phrase refers to the people who lived near the man Jesus had healed. In some languages you may need to indicate whose neighbors they are.

those who had formerly seen him begging: This phrase refers to people who were not his neighbors who had seen the man begging in the past. They may have seen the man begging many times, over many years. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

others who used to see him beg

began to ask: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as began to ask is more literally “were saying.” Probably several people asked this question. Here is another way to translate this verb:

asked (NIV)

asked each other (NLT)

9:8b

“Isn’t this the man who used to sit and beg?”

- “Is this the man who sat here and begged before?”
- “Could this be the same person we^(incl) saw beg?”

Isn’t this the man who used to sit and beg?: The form of this question implies that the answer is that this was the man who often sat and begged. The question was asked because there was some doubt. It also expresses surprise that this might be the same man. Translate this in a natural way in your language to ask a question with an attitude of surprise. For example:

Does this not look like the man who used to sit and beg?

Could this be the same man we saw sitting here begging?

used to sit and beg: This phrase refers to what the man did before as a habit. Before he was healed, he often sat and begged. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

was always sitting there begging

sits and begs

General Comment on 9:8b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this question as an indirect quotation. For example:

wondered if he really could be the same man (CEV)

were asking each other whether he was the one who sat and begged before

John 9:9

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:9a**Some claimed that he was,**

- Some said, “Yes, that is the same man.”
- Some of the people said, “Yes, that is the man who used to beg.”

Some claimed that he was: The word Some refers to some of the people mentioned in 9:8a. They were people who were familiar with the blind beggar. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Some of them said (GW)

he was: In this sentence the people were saying that this man was the same as the blind beggar. Use the expression that is natural in your language to identify someone in this way. For example:

He’s the one. (GW)

It is him all right. In English the correct form “It is he” is almost never used in conversation. Since this is a conversation, use conversational forms that are natural in your language.

General Comment on 9:9a

In some languages it may be natural to translate this short comment as an indirect quotation. For example:

Some said he was (NLT)

Some thought it was the same man.

Some agreed that he was.

9:9b**but others said, “No, he just looks like him.”**

- Other people said, “No, that is someone else/different who looks like him.”
- Others said, “He/This is not the man who used to beg. He just/only looks like him.”

but others said: The word others refers to some other people who had known the blind man, not the ones who spoke in 9:9a.

No: The word No indicates that they did not think that this was the man who used to beg. Use an expression that is natural for disagreeing with or rejecting a suggestion.

he just looks like him: These people thought that this man and the blind man looked very much alike. They were not the same individual but they just looked like one another. For example:

he only looks like him (NIV)

but he’s very like him (JBP)

rather they just look alike

General Comment on 9:8b

In some languages it may be natural to translate some or all of this direct quotation as an indirect quotation. For example:

But the others denied it. “He is only like him,” they said.

But others disagreed. They thought that he just looked like the blind man.

while other said he only looked like him (CEV)

9:9c**But the man kept saying, “I am the one.”**

- He himself said, “I am the man who was blind.”
- But the man himself insisted, “I really am that man/beggar.”

But the man kept saying: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the man kept saying emphasizes the phrase the man. This emphasis contrasts the man with the other people who were discussing him. For example:

But he himself insisted (NIV)

The man himself said (NCV)

I am the one: In this clause, the man was identifying himself as the blind beggar. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am that man. (CEV)

That was me. In spoken English the correct grammatical form “It/That was I” is almost never used. Use the conversational form that is natural in your language.

John 9:10

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:10

“How then were your eyes opened?” they asked.

- So they asked him, “How then were your^(sing) eyes healed?”
- Then the people asked, “How can you^(sing) see now?”

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that is usually translated as “therefore.” The man said that he used to be blind; therefore, the people asked how he was able to see. The conjunction introduces the people’s response to what the man said. Some English translations like the BSB do not explicitly translate it.

You should introduce the people’s response in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So (NET)

How then were your eyes opened?: This expression means “How did you become able to see?” It does not imply that earlier the man’s eyes were shut, but rather that he was blind. The verb in this expression is passive, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

how was your blindness cured? (JBP)

how...were you made to see? (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Who healed you? What happened? (NLT)

how can you see? (CEV)

How did you receive your sight? (GW)

What caused you to be able to see?

then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as then is more literally “therefore.” It is not certain that it was present in the earliest Greek manuscripts. In some languages it may be more natural to leave it implied, as some English translations have done. Or here is another way to translate this question:

If you are that man, how were your eyes healed?

they asked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they asked is in a tense that indicates that they asked more than once. In your translation, you may imply that they asked repeated questions. For example:

they were saying to him (NASB)

John 9:11

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God’s works. People disagreed

about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called “a light to the nations,” who will “open the eyes of the blind.” (The phrase “open the eyes of the blind” means “heal the eyes of the blind” or “enable someone to see.”) Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:11a

He answered, “The man they call Jesus made some mud and anointed my eyes,

- The man replied, “The man people call Jesus made some mud and put it on my eyes.
- The man answered, “The man whose name is Jesus made a paste and smeared it over my closed eyes.

He answered: The word He refers to the man who had been blind.

The man they call Jesus: This phrase identifies who healed the blind man. The verb call is passive and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Someone named Jesus (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The man they call Jesus (NIV)

The man whose name is Jesus

made some mud and anointed my eyes: The man described how Jesus healed him. See how you refer to these actions in 9:6.

9:11b

and He told me to go to Siloam and wash.

- He told me to go to Siloam Pool and wash it off.

- Then he told me to go and wash my face in the pool called Siloam.

and He told me to go to Siloam and wash: These words indicate that Jesus told the blind man to go and wash in the pool called Siloam. See the General Comment to see how to translate this expression using indirect speech. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

^{11a}He answered, “Someone named Jesus made some mud and spread it on my eyes. ^{11b}He told me to go and wash it off in Siloam Pool....”

wash: The word wash indicates that Jesus wanted the man to wash the mud off his eyes. See how you translated 9:7a, b. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit that Siloam was the name of a pool. For example:

wash it off in Siloam Pool (CEV)

General Comment on 9:11b

This clause contains a quotation inside a quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate the inner direct quotation as an indirect quotation. For example:

told me to go to Siloam and wash my face. (GNT)

9:11c

So I went and washed and received my sight.”

- So I went and washed, and then I could see.”
- So I went to Siloam, and when/after I washed my face I was able to see.”

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened as a result of Jesus’ command to the blind man.

I went: The blind man obeyed Jesus and went to Siloam pool. It may be necessary to say explicitly where the man went. For example:

I went to the pool

washed and received my sight: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as washed and received my sight is more literally “washing, I saw.” It indicates that when the blind man washed the mud off his eyes, he could immediately see. For example:

as soon as I washed, I could see (GNT)

when I washed, I gained my sight (NJB)

When I did, I could see. (CEV)

John 9:12

Section 9:1–12: Jesus healed a man who was blind since his birth

This section tells how Jesus healed a man who had been blind all his life. His disciples asked Jesus who had sinned to make him blind, but Jesus said that he was blind to reveal God's works. People disagreed about whether this man who could see was the same one who was blind.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus cured a man who had always been blind

Jesus caused a blind man to begin to see

A man who had never seen anything began to see

Paragraph 9:6–12

In Isaiah 42:6, 7 the Messiah is called "a light to the nations," who will "open the eyes of the blind." (The phrase "open the eyes of the blind" means "heal the eyes of the blind" or "enable someone to see.") Here Jesus showed that he was the Messiah, the light of the world, by healing the blind man. People began to ask the man questions about this, and he told them honestly what happened.

9:12a

"Where is He?" they asked.

- "Where is this man now?" the people asked him.
- So the people said, "Well, where is this Jesus?"

Where is He?: The people wanted to know where Jesus had gone. For example:

Where is he now? (NLT)

Where is that man? (NET)

they asked: The pronoun they refers to the neighbors and other people that were introduced in 9:8. What the people said was a question, so it may be natural to say:

they asked him

9:12b

"I do not know," he answered.

- The man answered, "I do not know where he is."
- "I do not know where he went," the man replied.

"I do not know," he answered: The healed man said he did not know where Jesus went. Place the quote introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

He said, "I do not know." (NRSV)

John 9:13

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:13–17

The people decided to take the man whom Jesus healed to their religious leaders, the Pharisees. The Pharisees believed that healing people was work, so it was wrong to heal people on the Sabbath, the day of rest. They were not sure what to think about Jesus. Some thought that his miracles showed that he was from God. Others thought that because he disobeyed their Sabbath law, he was an evil person.

9:13

They brought to the Pharisees the man who had been blind.

- ¶ The people led to the Pharisees the man who used to be blind.

- ¶ The people then took the man who was previously blind to meet their religious leaders belonging to the Pharisee group.

They brought to the Pharisees the man who had been blind: This clause begins a new phase in the story. The people in the story move to a different place. The neighbors and friends who were talking to the former beggar now led him to the Pharisees. Refer to them in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The people led the man who had formerly been blind to the Pharisees.

brought to the Pharisees: The people told the healed man that he should go with them to talk to the Jewish leaders. The text does not say whether or not he went willingly. Try to translate this phrase using an ambiguous expression that does not indicate whether they forced the man to go. For example:

led to the Pharisees

the Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi people/members

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

men belonging to the Farise religious sect/group

See how you translated this word in 1:24 and see the note there.

the man who had been blind: This expression refers to the man whom Jesus healed. The phrase had been blind means that he was blind before that time, but not anymore. Refer to him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the man who had formerly been blind (NRSV)

the man who was healed of blindness

John 9:14

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:13–17

The people decided to take the man whom Jesus healed to their religious leaders, the Pharisees. The Pharisees believed that healing people was work, so it was wrong to heal people on the Sabbath, the day of rest. They were not sure what to think about Jesus. Some thought that his miracles showed that he was from God. Others thought that because he disobeyed their Sabbath law, he was an evil person.

9:14

Now the day on which Jesus had made the mud and opened his eyes was a Sabbath.

- (And the day on which Jesus made the mud and healed the man's eyes was a Sabbath.)
- It should be noted that Jesus made the paste and healed the man on the Sabbath, the Jewish rest/holy day.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some important background information. In this context it is not a time word. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

(It should be noted that...) (JBP)

the day on which Jesus had made the mud and opened his eyes: Again, the phrase opened his eyes does not mean that the man's eyes were shut and Jesus caused him to open them. Rather it means that the man was blind and Jesus healed him. Jesus healed the man on the day that the Jewish people were not supposed to work. Refer to this miracle using the terms that you used earlier in the chapter. For example:

when Jesus made the clay and made him able to see

was a Sabbath: The Sabbath is the name of the seventh and last day of the week for the Jews. This was the special day in the week when they rested and worshiped God. There were many rules about what they were allowed and not allowed to do on the Sabbath. There were rules that said they should not heal someone or make mud on the Sabbath. The Pharisees were very strict about all their rules, including rules about the Sabbath. Though Jesus did not obey all their rules, he always obeyed God's laws. Here are some ways to translate Sabbath:

the Jewish rest day

the day for resting

the day to rest and worship God

If the word Sabbath is already known in your area, you may write it according to the sounds of your language. You may also want to include a phrase to explain the meaning. For example:

the Sabat, the Jews' rest day

See how you translated Sabbath at 5:9c.

John 9:15

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because

he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:13–17

The people decided to take the man whom Jesus healed to their religious leaders, the Pharisees. The Pharisees believed that healing people was work, so it was wrong to heal people on the Sabbath, the day of rest. They were not sure what to think about Jesus. Some thought that his miracles showed that he was from God. Others thought that because he disobeyed their Sabbath law, he was an evil person.

9:15a

So the Pharisees also asked him how he had received his sight.

- Then the Pharisees also asked him how he became able to see.
- So the religious leaders asked the man how he was no longer blind.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So in this context introduces a result. The people had brought the blind man to the Pharisees and told them that Jesus had healed him on a Sabbath. As a result the Pharisees began to question the blind man. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Therefore (NIV)

the Pharisees also asked him how he had received his sight: The Pharisees were concerned when they heard that the man was healed on a Sabbath. In order to get more information, they began to question the man.

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a strict Jewish religious group or party. See the note and how you translated this word in 9:13.

also: The word also here means the Pharisees questioned the man in addition to the people who ques-

tioned him in 9:10–12. Both sets of people questioned the man. For example:

the Pharisees too asked him how he had gained his sight (REB)

asked him: This phrase indicates that the Pharisees asked more than one question. They began a series of questions.

how he had received his sight: This phrase refers to the way the blind man had become able to see. The Pharisees wanted to know what had caused this, or how Jesus had done it.

received his sight: This phrase refers to the man's receiving the ability to see. In some languages it is more natural to translate the noun sight using a verb. For example:

become able to see (JBP)

started to see

9:15b

The man answered, “He put mud on my eyes,

- The man replied, “He put mud on my eyes.
- The man told them that Jesus had put a paste on/ over his closed eyes.

The man answered: The healed man responded to the Pharisees. Refer to these men in the way that is natural in your language.

He put mud on my eyes: The expression put mud on my eyes refers to Jesus' action described in 9:6c. A different verb is used, but the meaning is the same.

9:15c

and I washed, and now I can see.”

- I washed it off and now I can see.”
- “When I washed the paste from my eyes, I began to see,” he said.

and I washed, and now I can see: The Greek text says more literally “and I washed and I see.” Use the same verbs that you used in 9:7b, 11c. Connect these verbs in the way that is natural in your language for this context. For example:

and I washed, and I can see (NJB)

I washed my face, and now I can see. (GNT)

when I washed it off, I could see! (NLT)

John 9:16

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:13–17

The people decided to take the man whom Jesus healed to their religious leaders, the Pharisees. The Pharisees believed that healing people was work, so it was wrong to heal people on the Sabbath, the day of rest. They were not sure what to think about Jesus. Some thought that his miracles showed that he was from God. Others thought that because he disobeyed their Sabbath law, he was an evil person.

9:16a

Because of this, some of the Pharisees said, “This man is not from God,

- Some Pharisees said, “This man has clearly/obviously not come from God,
- Some of the leaders said, “This Jesus cannot be from God,

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a strict Jewish religious group or party. See the note and how you translated this word in 9:13.

This man is not from God: This clause indicates that the Pharisees concluded that Jesus was not from God. Their reason for this conclusion is in the next clause

(9:16b). See the General Comment on 9:16a–b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This man cannot be from God (REB)

This man clearly did not come from God.

9:16b

for He does not keep the Sabbath.”

- because he does not keep the Sabbath as a rest day.”
- because he does not obey the Sabbath law that forbids us^(incl) to work.”

for: The word for introduces the Pharisees’ reason for concluding that Jesus was not from God. Here is another way to translate this word:

because (NET)

He does not keep the Sabbath: This clause means “he does not obey the Sabbath law.” The Pharisees had rules for obeying the Sabbath law, one of the ten commandments. The law said that they should not work on the Sabbath, and the Pharisees decided what actions were work. Jesus did not obey all their rules and so they thought that he had disobeyed the Sabbath law. However, Jesus perfectly kept God’s law.

Jesus healed someone on the Sabbath, and the Pharisees thought that that was work. This action is the evidence that the Pharisees used to conclude that Jesus was not from God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he is working on the Sabbath (NLT)

he does not obey the Sabbath law (GNT)

General Comment on 9:16a–b

This verse presents the conclusion of some of the Pharisees’ that Jesus was not from God. Then it presents the reason they made this conclusion. Consider how it is natural to present such a logical statement. In some languages it may be natural to state the reason before the conclusion. For example:

^{16b}This man does not observe the Sabbath, ^{16a}and so he cannot be from God.

^{16b}Because he does not obey the Sabbath law, ^{16a}he cannot be from God.

Here is another possible way to show the logical thinking of the Pharisees:

^{16a}This man Jesus doesn’t come from God. ^{16b}If he did, he would not break the law of the Sabbath. (CEV)

9:16c

But others said, “How can a sinful man perform such signs?”

- But others asked, “How can a sinner do such miraculous signs?”
- Some of the other Pharisees/leaders said, “A sinner could not do the miracles that Jesus does.”

But: The word But introduces the different response of a second group that contrasts with what the first group said. This second group was impressed by Jesus’ miracles.

others said: The word others refers to some different Pharisees. They asked a rhetorical question, so you might want to use a different verb than said. For example:

others asked (NIV)

How can a sinful man perform such signs?: This is a rhetorical question. These Pharisees used it to make a strong statement. They were saying that a sinful person could not perform (do) miracles the way Jesus had. They implied that they concluded that Jesus must be a good person.

There are two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How could such signs come from a sinful man? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

A man who is a sinner can’t do miracles like these. (NCV)

Translate this statement in a way that is natural in your language.

a sinful man: A sinful man is someone who sins or does not obey the law. These Pharisees were saying

that Jesus could not be a sinner. The first group implied that Jesus was a sinner when they said that he did not obey their Sabbath law. However, though he did not follow all the Pharisees' rules, he always obeyed God's law.

perform such signs: This expression means “do miracles like these.” These signs were Jesus' miraculous healings, such as the giving of sight to the blind man. See how you translated the word signs in 2:11a, and see the note there.

9:16d

And there was division among them.

- And the Jewish leaders were divided in their opinion about Jesus.
- So/Then the Jewish leaders disagreed among themselves.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces the result of the discussion in 9:16a-c. It may therefore be natural to translate it like this:

So (NIV)

there was division among them: This clause means that the Jewish leaders had different ideas about who Jesus was. In some languages it may be natural to make it clearer why they were divided. For example:

they were divided in their opinion (GW)

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the Pharisees could not agree among themselves (CEV)

they took different sides (REB)

General Comment on 9:16 a-d

In some languages it may be more natural to reorder 9:16a-d and begin with the summary statement. For example:

^{16d}The Pharisees could not agree about Jesus. ^{16a-c}Some said....

^{16d}The Pharisees were divided in their opinion of Jesus. ^{16a-c}Some of them said....

John 9:17

Section 9:13-34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:13-17

The people decided to take the man whom Jesus healed to their religious leaders, the Pharisees. The Pharisees believed that healing people was work, so it was wrong to heal people on the Sabbath, the day of rest. They were not sure what to think about Jesus. Some thought that his miracles showed that he was from God. Others thought that because he disobeyed their Sabbath law, he was an evil person.

9:17a

So once again they asked the man who had been blind, “What do you say about Him,

- Therefore they again asked the man who had been blind, “What do you^(sing) say about him
- Then they asked the man born blind again, “Who do you^(sing) think Jesus is

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces a result-what the Pharisees did when they could not agree among themselves. Here is another way to translate this word:

Therefore

once again they asked the man who had been blind: The Pharisees once more spoke to the man who had

been healed. They asked him another question. Here are some other ways to translate these words:

They asked the man who had been born blind another question (GW)

They asked the man again (NCV)

they: The pronoun they here refers to the Pharisees, the Jewish religious leaders.

the man who had been blind: This phrase refers to the man who had been blind but was now healed. Refer to him in a natural way. Make sure that your readers will understand that he was no longer blind. For example:

the man (CEV)

the man who had been born blind (GW)

What do you say about Him: The Jewish leaders wanted the healed man to tell them what sort of person that he thought Jesus was. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What's your opinion about this man? (NLT)

What do you think about him?

Who do you think he is?

9:17b
since it was your eyes He opened?"

- because he healed your^(sing) eyes?"
- because you^(sing) are the one whose eyes he healed?"

since it was your eyes He opened: The Greek text connects this sentence to the previous sentence with a conjunction that means "because." This conjunction indicates that the Pharisees questioned the man because he was the one who was healed. (The word opened here means "healed.") The BSB uses since to indicate this connection.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

because he enabled you to see

General Comment on 9:17a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 9:17a–b. For example:

^{17b}You say he cured you of your blindness—^{17a}well, what do you say about him? (GNT)

9:17c

"He is a prophet," the man replied.

- The man answered, "He/Jesus is a prophet."
- The man said to them, "I believe/think that he/Jesus is a prophet of God."

He is a prophet: This clause means "Jesus is a prophet." A prophet is someone whom God sends to speak God's message to people. The healed man thought that Jesus was a messenger and representative of God like that. Here are some ways to translate prophet:

a messenger/representative for God

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

See Prophet 1.a. in KBT and see how you translated prophet elsewhere in John, for example, 1:21d, 45, 4:19.

the man replied: The pronoun the man refers to the man who was healed. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

he answered

John 9:18

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:18a

The Jews still did not believe that the man had been blind and had received his sight

- ¶ The Jewish leaders did not believe that the man was previously blind and received sight/healing
- ¶ The Jewish authorities refused to believe that this man had been healed from blindness,

The Greek text includes a conjunction that is usually translated “therefore.” Most English translations, including the BSB, do not explicitly translate this conjunction here. However, some scholars think that the conjunction should be translated here. It does seem that there is a development in the story here.

Some scholars think that the conjunction should be translated as “therefore” or “so.” (The man thought that Jesus was a prophet so the Pharisees did not believe that he had been blind.) Others think that it indicates a weak contrast. (The man believed that Jesus was a prophet but the Pharisees did not.) Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

But the Jewish leaders would not believe that the man had once been blind. (CEV)

So the Pharisees did not believe that he had really been blind and then could see.

Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

The Jews still did not believe that the man had been blind and had received his sight: The Jewish leaders did not believe the healed man. They were not convinced that he had been blind before. And if he had not been blind, then he was not healed.

The Jews: Here the phrase The Jews refers to the Jewish leaders who were opposed to Jesus. They are likely the same group of people who are called “the

Pharisees” in 9:15a. The phrase does not refer to all the Jews.

still did not believe that the man had been blind: The Jewish leaders refused to accept that the man that was talking with them used to be blind. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

would not believe that the man had been blind (REB)

were not willing to believe that he had been blind (GNT)

had received his sight: The Jewish leaders accepted that the man could see. But they did not believe that this was the result of Jesus healing him. They thought that he was lying and was always able to see. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

had gained his sight (NET)

could now see (GNT)

General Comment on 9:18a

In some languages a literal translation may imply that the leaders did not believe that the man could see. In those languages it may be natural to mention only that the man had previously been blind. For example:

But the Jewish leaders would not believe that the man had once been blind. (CEV)

9:18b

until they summoned his parents

- until they sent for the man’s parents
- until they told his parents to come to them to question them.

until: This word here indicates that the Jewish leaders did not believe before they talked to the parents. Then they accepted that the man was telling the truth about his blindness. The word until connects to both the rest of 9:18b and also 9:19a. That means that two things had to happen before they believed. First, they had to call the parents and second, they had to ask them about their son.

they summoned his parents: The Jewish leaders wanted to ask the man’s parents about what had happened. So they sent someone to go and bring his parents to them. Refer to the man in a way that is

natural in your language. It may be best to use a shorter form. For example:

sent for the man's parents (NIV)

told/ordered his parents to come

General Comment on 9:18a–b

The man referred to as “he” in 9:18a is identified in 9:18b as “the man who had received his sight.” In many languages this long phrase used to identify the man may not be natural or clear. And in 9:18a the text says that this man had received his sight. So it may not be necessary to repeat this information in 9:18b. For example:

The Jewish authorities, however, were not willing to believe that he had been blind and could now see, until they called his parents. (GNT)

But the Jewish leaders would not believe that the man had once been blind. They sent for his parents (CEV)

^{18b}Until they talked to the man's parents, ^{18a}the Jews didn't believe that the man had been blind and had been given sight. (GW)

John 9:19

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:19a

and asked, “Is this your son, the one you say was born blind?”

- and questioned them. They asked, “Is this your son? Is this the one you say was born blind?”
- When they arrived, the Jewish authorities asked them, “You say that your son was born blind. Is this man really that son?”

and asked: The Jewish leaders questioned the parents of the man who had been healed. Identify these people in a way that is natural in your language. This was the second thing that had to happen before the Jewish leaders believed that earlier the man was blind. It is implied that the parents also had to reply before they believed. In some languages it may be natural to imply that calling the parents in 9:18b included asking them questions. Then you can start a new sentence here. For example:

They asked his parents (GW)

Is this your son, the one you say was born blind?:

The Jewish leaders asked the parents to identify the man in front of them. They wanted to know if he was who he said he was, the beggar who was born blind. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Is this the son that you said was born blind? (CEV)

Is this man really the son of yours who you say was born blind? (NJB)

It may be natural to translate this as two questions. For example:

Is this your son? Was he born blind? (NLT)

The couple may have had several sons. We do not know. Possibly they did, but it is best to assume that he was the only one that was born blind. In some languages it may therefore be natural to say something like this:

Is he one of your sons? Is he the one/son that was born blind?

9:19b

So how is it that he can now see?"

- So how can he see now?"
- If so, how is he able to see now?"

So how is it that he can now see?: This is a real question. The religious leaders asked what caused the man to be able to see. They seemed to assume that he was their son and had been blind. The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is often translated as "therefore." The idea is that they say that their son was blind, so how can he see now? Here are other ways to translate this question:

If so, how can he now see? (NLT)

John 9:20

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:20a

His parents answered, "We know he is our son,

- His parents replied, "We^(excl) are sure that he is our^(excl) son,
- His parents answered the Jewish leaders, "Yes, certainly this is our^(excl) son;

His parents answered: Refer to the parents in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The parents

The man's parents

We know he is our son: This clause indicates that the parents admitted that the man was their son. There was no doubt about that. Here is another way to translate this clause:

We are certain that this is our son (CEV)

9:20b

and we know he was born blind.

- and, yes, he was born blind.
- and he has been blind since he was born.

and we know he was born blind: The word and here introduces a second thing that the parents said that they knew. They knew and were willing to say that the man was born blind. In some languages it may be natural to repeat the verb we know from 9:20a.

John 9:21

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:21a

But how he can now see or who opened his eyes, we do not know.

- But we^(excl) do not know how he began to see or who healed his eyes.
- But we^(excl) do not know how he got his sight. We^(excl) also do not know who made him able to see.

But: The word that the BSB translates as But indicates a contrast. The contrast is between what the parents knew and what they did not know. They said that they did not know what happened to cause their son to be able to see.

how he can now see: The man's parents refused to say how the man had received his sight. Verse 9:22 implies that they had heard what happened but were afraid to say. They were apparently not telling the truth here.

or who opened his eyes, we do not know: The word or here introduces something else that the parents said that they did not know. In some languages it may be natural to leave the word or untranslated. For example:

But we don't know how he can now see. We don't know who opened his eyes. (NCV)

Again, the phrase opened his eyes does not mean that the man's eyes were shut and Jesus caused him to open them. Rather it means that the man was blind and Jesus healed him.

9:21b

Ask him. He is old enough to speak for himself."

- You^(plur) should ask him. He is an adult and he can speak for himself."
- You^(plur) will have to ask him. He is not a child and can tell you about himself."

Ask him: The parents wanted to avoid saying that Jesus had given sight to their son. They were afraid that the leaders might punish them for saying something good about Jesus. So they told the religious leaders to ask the man himself. Here is a translation that implies that the parents wanted to avoid saying what they knew about Jesus:

You'll have to ask him. (GW)

In some languages it may be necessary to say what the leaders were to ask the son. For example:

Ask him about it.

Ask him how he is able to see.

He is old enough: This clause means that the man Jesus had healed was an adult. He was legally able to testify (tell what he knew) about what happened in a law court. In Jesus' culture that meant that he was at least thirteen (13) years old.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he is a mature adult (NET)

he is not a child anymore

to speak for himself: This sentence indicates that the son could himself tell the religious leaders what happened to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he can answer for himself (GNT)

let him speak for himself (REB)

John 9:22

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:22a

His parents said this because they were afraid of the Jews.

- The man's parents said this because they were afraid of the Jewish authorities,
- His parents spoke like this because they were afraid of the religious leaders,

His parents said this because they were afraid of the Jews: These clauses begin the author's explanation of why the man's parents answered the way that they did. It gives background or parenthetical information. The man's parents were afraid of what the Jewish leaders would do if they said that Jesus had healed their son. Some English translations put 9:22–23 in parentheses to indicate that it is background information and not part of the main story. You should indicate this in a way that is natural in your language.

the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the Jewish leaders who were against Jesus. It does not refer to all Jews because the parents of the man were themselves Jews.

9:22b

For the Jews had already determined that anyone who confessed Jesus as the Christ would be put out of the synagogue.

- because the authorities had decided that anyone who said that Jesus was the Messiah would be forbidden to worship in the synagogue.
- who had already warned that they would throw out of their community all who said that Jesus was the Christ.

For the Jews had already determined that anyone who confessed Jesus as the Christ would be put out of the synagogue: These clauses explain why the parents were afraid. The Jewish religious leaders had already decided to reject or expel (throw out) anyone who said that Jesus was the Messiah. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

for already the Jews had decided that anyone who acknowledged that Jesus was the Christ would be put out of the synagogue (NIV93)

who had already agreed that anyone who said he believed that Jesus was the Messiah would be expelled from the synagogue (GNT)

because they had already made an agreement that if anyone said that Jesus was the Messiah they would remove him from the synagogue

the Jews: The words the Jews here refer to the Jewish religious leaders. These were the people in charge of the synagogue worship. Because these people were just mentioned in 9:22a, it may not be necessary to say this explicitly again. For example:

they were afraid of the Jewish leaders, who had announced that anyone saying Jesus was the Messiah would be expelled from the synagogue (NLT)

anyone who confessed Jesus as the Christ: This phrase refers to those who declared that Jesus was the Messiah, the Christ. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

if anyone said that Jesus was the Messiah, he

anyone who said Jesus was the Messiah (CEV)

the Christ: This phrase is a title that Jewish people used for the savior that God had promised to send. Christ is the Greek word that means "anointed one." The title refers to the man God had appointed to save Israel from their enemies. See how you translated this in John 1:20 and 4:25, and see Christ, Messiah in KBT.

would be put out of the synagogue: This expression here indicates that people who believed that Jesus was the Messiah would be punished by the synagogue. Scholars disagree about whether this was a temporary and limited punishment (banned from being a leader) or something more serious. If more serious, they might not even allow that person to worship in the synagogue. The verb phrase would be put out is passive. It means "would be thrown out" or "would be expelled." There are at least two ways to translate this verb phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

should be banned from the synagogue (REB)

would be expelled from the synagogue (GNT)

- Use an active verb. The religious leaders themselves would put such people out of the synagogue. For example:

The Jews had already agreed to put anyone who acknowledged that Jesus was the Christ out of the synagogue. (GW)

Translate this expression using the verb form that is most natural in your language. The idea is that if anyone believed that Jesus was the Messiah, their privileges at the synagogue were limited or removed. In your translation, avoid implying that these people were in the synagogue building and would be forced to leave.

the synagogue: In every town and village in Israel, people met together regularly for religious purposes. The building where the Jews gathered was called the synagogue. The organization of the people who met there was also called the synagogue. The main activities that took place in their meetings were reading and teaching the Scriptures, praying, and worshipping God.

People who said they believed in Jesus were forbidden to join in at least some of these activities in any synagogue. So in this context the phrase the synagogue refers to Jewish religious activities in general, not to one specific building. In some languages it may be necessary to use a plural form to make this clear. For example:

their synagogues

their religious community

Jewish gatherings/meetings

See also how you translated the word synagogue in 6:59.

John 9:23

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees

thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:18–23

The Pharisees decided to ask the parents of the blind beggar about the healing. The parents realized that their answers could cause them trouble and refused to answer the questions.

9:23

That was why his parents said, “He is old enough. Ask him.”

- That was why the man's parents said, “He is an adult; you^(plur) should ask him.”
- This is why they answered as they did.

That was why his parents said: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as That was why here introduces a result. Because of the parents' fear of the Jews (9:22), they said, “He is of age; ask him.” John repeats that quotation here from what they had said in 9:21b. It indicates that it was because the parents were afraid that they spoke as they did. For example:

Therefore his parents said (NRSV)

It was this fear which made his parents say (JBP)

He is old enough. Ask him: This sentence is repeated from 9:21b, though the clauses are reversed. In some languages repeating these clauses may not be natural. It may be possible to translate them in this way:

That was why his parents spoke as they did.

See also the General Comment on 9:22–23.

General Comment on 9:22–23

In some languages it may be natural to combine 9:22–23 and remove some of what is repeated in BSB. For example:

^{9:22–23}The man's parents said this because they were afraid of their leaders. The leaders had already agreed that no one was to have anything to do with anyone who said Jesus was the Messiah. (CEV)

John 9:24

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:24a

So a second time they called for the man who had been blind

- ¶ Therefore they summoned the man who had been blind a second time.

- ¶ So again the religious leaders called the man in for questioning.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So here introduces what the Jewish religious leaders did when the man's parents refused to answer them clearly.

a second time they called for the man who had been blind: The Jewish leaders summoned the man (called him to come to them) again. He apparently was not present at that time. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The leaders called the man back (CEV)

A second time they summoned the man who had been blind (NIV)

Then they told/ordered the blind man who was healed to come a second time

9:24b

and said, "Give glory to God!"

- They said to him, "Tell the truth before God!"
- "Swear by God that you^(sing) will speak the truth!" they said.

Give glory to God!: The expression that the BSB translates literally as Give glory to God was a serious promise to tell the truth. The Jewish leaders wanted the man to make an oath. They were commanding him to speak the truth to them. For example:

Swear by God to tell the truth! (NCV)

Promise before God that you will tell the truth! (GNT)

Speak the truth before God. (REB)

Answer honestly with God as your witness.

9:24c

We know that this man is a sinner."

- We^(excl) know that this person is a sinner."
- "We^(excl) are sure that this Jesus is sinful."

We know that this man is a sinner: The Jewish leaders wanted to convince the man who had been blind that Jesus was not a good person. They told him what

they thought in order to influence him to think the same thing.

We: The pronoun We is exclusive here. The Jewish leaders wanted to persuade the healed man to agree with them.

this man: The phrase that the BSB translates literally as this man refers to Jesus. In this context it is good to avoid using an expression that shows respect. The speakers did not admire Jesus. You may refer to Jesus in a way that implies this. For example:

this person

a sinner: A sinner is someone who sins or does not obey the law. Here the Pharisees called Jesus a sinner because he did not obey their Sabbath law (see 9:16). However, though he did not follow all the Pharisees' rules, he always obeyed God's law.

John 9:25

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:25a

He answered, "Whether He is a sinner I do not know."

- The man who had been healed said, "I do not know if he is a sinner or not."
- The man whom Jesus had healed answered them, "Whether Jesus is a sinful man, I do not know."

He answered: The pronoun He refers to the man who had been blind. Translate this so that it is clear who is speaking. For example:

"I don't know whether he is a sinner," the man replied. (NLT)

Whether He is a sinner I do not know: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as Whether can also be translated as "if." For example:

I don't know if he is a sinner. (NCV)

The word Whether in this context is introducing one of two alternatives. The second alternative, that Jesus is not a sinner, is left implied in the BSB. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit. For example:

Whether he is a sinner or not, I don't know. (NIV)

General Comment on 9:25a

In some languages it may be natural to translate this sentence following the order of the clauses in the Greek. For example:

He replied, "Whether he is a sinner or not, I don't know." (NIV)

9:25b

There is one thing I do know: I was blind, but now I see!"

- I do know this, that I was blind but now I see."
- But I know one thing that happened—I used to be blind and now I can see."

There is one thing I do know: The man indicated that although he did not know who Jesus was, there was something he did know. The Greek text emphasizes the one thing that he does know. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

All I know is this (REB)

But I definitely know one thing.

But one thing I am sure of (JBP)

The man was of course sure of many things, but he was talking about things relevant to their question. In order to avoid wrong meanings, it may be possible to make it clearer. For example:

I certainly know this:...

All I know about this event is that:...

I was blind, but now I see!: This is more literally “I was blind and now I see.” The BSB used the word but to indicate that what happened was surprising and unusual. In spite of the fact that he was blind, the man could now see. Here are other ways to indicate this contrast:

I used to be blind, but now I can see. (GW)

John 9:26

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man’s healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted

him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:26a

“What did He do to you?” they asked.

- Then they asked the man, “What did Jesus do to you^{(sing)?}?”
- So the leaders asked him again, “What did Jesus do

What did He do to you?: The leaders wanted the man to tell them how Jesus had healed him. Perhaps they wondered if it could be considered as work and therefore forbidden on the Sabbath.

they asked: The Greek text more literally says “Therefore they said to him.” The Greek word that is usually translated “therefore” here indicates a development in the story. What the leaders said was a question, so this phrase can be translated to indicate this.

9:26b

“How did He open your eyes?”

- How did he make you^(sing) able to see?”
- to heal you^{(sing)?}”

How did He open your eyes?: This clause indicates that the religious leaders wanted the man to tell them how Jesus had made him able to see. The question does not imply that the man’s eyes were shut before, but that he was blind.

Here are other ways to translate this question:

How did he give you sight? (GW)

How did he cause you to see? (NET)

How did he heal your eyes? (CEV)

John 9:27

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man’s healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that

Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:27a

He replied, “I already told you, and you did not listen.

- He replied, “I told you^(plur) already and you^(plur) refused to listen to it.
- The man answered them, “I already told you^(plur) once and/but you^(plur) did not believe me.

I already told you, and you did not listen: The man who had been healed said that he had told the religious leaders what happened once before (see 9:15). At that time they did not listen, meaning that they refused to accept and believe what he said. The man was apparently becoming annoyed. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that he was annoyed by the use of a rhetorical question. For example:

“Look!” the man exclaimed. “I told you once. Didn’t you listen?” (NLT)

“I’ve told you before,” he replied. “Weren’t you listening?” (JBP)

Try to indicate that the man was becoming impatient. However, do not translate his words as being rude, because he was a young man speaking to the religious leaders.

you did not listen: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you did not listen is more literally “you^(plur) did not hear.” The religious leaders actually heard but they refused to accept what the man said. They did

not believe that it was true. See 9:19a. Here is another way to translate this clause:

you refused to listen (CEV)

In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly what the leaders would not listen to. For example:

you would not listen to what I said

you refused to listen to me

9:27b

Why do you want to hear it again?

- Why do you^(plur) want to hear it another time?
- It is surprising that now you^(plur) want me to tell you^(plur) again.

Why do you want to hear it again?: This is a rhetorical question. The man used it to express surprise. The man who was healed was surprised that the Jewish leaders wanted to hear about his healing again. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you want to hear the story again? (GW)

- Use a statement or exclamation. For example:

And now you^(plur) want to hear my story one more time!

I am amazed that you want to hear about it again!

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language to indicate surprise.

9:27c

Do you also want to become His disciples?”

- You^(plur) do not want to become his disciples too, do you^(plur)?”
- Are you^(plur) perhaps thinking of becoming followers of Jesus, like me?”

Do you also want to become His disciples?: This is a rhetorical question. It implies that the answer will be “no.” The man knew that the religious leaders probably did not want to become Jesus’ disciples. He used this rhetorical question to rebuke them and maybe even make fun of them. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you want to become his followers, too? (NCV)

You are not thinking of becoming his disciples too, are you?

- Use a statement. For example:

Maybe you^(plur) too would like to become his disciples.

Perhaps you too are thinking of following him.

also: The word also in this context means “in addition to me,” meaning in addition to the man who was healed. The man was implying that he was one of Jesus’ disciples. The Jewish leaders certainly understood that in 9:28b. The word does not imply that the Jewish leaders were already the disciples of someone else and wanted to also be Jesus’ disciples. To avoid this wrong meaning it may be natural to translate this word in one of the following ways:

like me

as I am

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to the followers of a religious teacher. See how you translated this word in 9:2a.

John 9:28

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man’s healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:28a

Then they heaped insults on him and said,

- Then the Jewish leaders strongly insulted him.
- That made the religious leaders angry so they insulted him

Then they heaped insults on him: The Greek verb that the BSB translate as heaped insults here means “insulted” or “spoke in a way that abused.” The Jewish leaders told the healed man that they thought very badly of him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they abused him with their speech

The leaders insulted the man (CEV)

9:28b

“You are His disciple;

- They said, “You^(sing) are disciples of that man/person!
- by saying, “You^(sing) follow this man,

You are His disciple: The pronoun His refers to Jesus. The Jewish leaders did not use Jesus’ name or title, but instead referred to him in an insulting way. You may want to make this insulting tone more explicit. For example:

You are this fellow’s disciple (NIV)

You are the disciple of that person!

disciple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciple refers to a “learner” or “follower” of a religious teacher. See 9:2a and 9:27c.

9:28c

we are disciples of Moses.

- We^(excl), however, are disciples of Moses.
- but we^(excl) follow Moses' teachings/Law.

In Greek this clause begins with a conjunction that introduces a contrast. The leaders contrasted themselves to the man who had been healed. He, they said, was a disciple of Jesus, while they were disciples of Moses. They implied that it was only possible to be a disciple of one man: Jesus or Moses. They also implied that Moses was superior to Jesus. Here is a way to translate this conjunction:

but we are disciples of Moses (NRSV)

we: The pronoun we is exclusive and refers to the Jewish leaders but not to the man who had been blind. The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun to contrast the Pharisees to the man who was born blind. Emphasize this pronoun in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

As for us, we^(excl)

disciples of Moses: This phrase refers to those who follow and learn from Moses. Moses lived about fifteen hundred (1500) years before Jesus. He gave Israel its law, recorded in the Old Testament books Genesis through Deuteronomy. The Jewish leaders said that they learned from and obeyed this law and in this way learned from and obeyed Moses. To avoid implying that Moses was still alive at that time, you may need to say something like this:

we follow/obey Moses' law/teachings

John 9:29

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:29a

We know that God spoke to Moses,

- We^(excl) know that God spoke his word/message to Moses,
- We^(excl) are sure that God spoke to Moses giving us^(incl) his message/law.

We know that God spoke to Moses: The pronoun We is best translated as exclusive here. The Jewish leaders continued to contrast themselves with the man whom Jesus healed. It is true that the man also believed that God spoke to Moses, but the Jewish leaders ignored this. They emphasized that they themselves believed that Moses' law was God's message to them.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We are sure that God spoke to Moses. (CEV)

We know that God gave his word/message to Moses.

We know this about Moses, that long ago God spoke to him giving him the law.

9:29b

but we do not know where this man is from."

- but as for that person, we^(excl) do not know where he came from."
- However, we^(excl) have no idea where this other person came from."

but: The word but indicates a contrast. The contrast is between Moses, who they knew heard from God, and Jesus, who they knew little about.

we do not know where this man is from: The Jewish leaders certainly did not think that Jesus came from God. In spite of the miraculous signs that he had done,

they did not believe that he was from God. So here they must have meant that they did not know what place on earth that he came from. Here is another way to translate this clause:

We do not know where this man comes from!
(NET)

we: The pronoun we continues to be exclusive and refers to the Jewish leaders who were opposed to Jesus.

this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this man is more literally “this one.” The Greek text emphasizes that word to contrast Jesus with Moses. They thought that Moses was far better than Jesus. The religious leaders did not honor Jesus but scorned him. Use an expression that implies the speakers did not respect the person they referred to. For example:

this fellow (NIV)

this other person

John 9:30

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man’s healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:30–33

The man who had been blind was brave in his response to the religious leaders. He was not rude but he clearly rejected what the Jewish leaders believed. Instead he trusted Jesus and what Jesus had done for him.

9:30a

“That is remarkable indeed!” the man said.

- The man replied to them, “That is most unusual/surprising!”
- The healed man said to the leaders, “How very strange!”

That is remarkable indeed!: The man was astonished (amazed) that the Jewish leaders refused to admit that Jesus was from God after he healed his eyes. He had trouble believing that they thought like that. Their thoughts were remarkable (extraordinary) and strange (unusual). Translate this sentence using an expression that expresses surprise and implies that he had trouble believing them. For example:

Now that is remarkable (NIV)

What a strange thing that is! (GNT)

How strange! (CEV)

I am astonished!

the man said: The words the man refers to the man who had been blind. He replied to the Jewish leaders who were questioning him.

9:30b

“You do not know where He is from,

- You^(plur) do not know where he came from,
- You^(plur) have no idea where Jesus is from,

You do not know where He is from: The word You is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders who were opposed to Jesus. The man quoted what they had said in 9:29b. Translate this using the same or similar expressions so that this is clear.

9:30c

and yet He opened my eyes.

- but he healed me.
- even though he made me able to see.

and yet He opened my eyes: The man confirmed that Jesus had healed him (that is what He opened my eyes means here). Use the same expression that you used in 9:17b, 21a, or 26b. For example:

and yet he caused me to see (NET)

and yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB has translated as and yet indicates something that is not expected. The thing that is not expected is that the Jewish leaders did not know where Jesus came from. People expected that if someone healed a blind man, the Jewish leaders would know where he came from. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

but (GNT)

even though

General Comment on 9:30b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 9:30b–c. For example:

^{30c}He healed my eyes, and yet ^{30b}you don't know where he comes from? (NLT)

John 9:31

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:31a

We know that God does not listen to sinners,

- We^(incl) know that God does not listen to sinful people.
- We^(incl) all know that God does not answer people who disobey him.

We know that: This phrase here introduces a well-known truth. Everybody among the Jews accepted that God did not listen to sinners. The pronoun We can therefore be considered inclusive of the leaders and the blind man. For example:

We all know (NCV)

God does not listen to sinners: This clause means that God does not answer the prayers of sinful people, people who do not obey him. He hears them, but he does not accept them or give them what they request. The man implied that if Jesus was a sinner, God would not have answered his request to heal the man. However, because Jesus was not a sinner, God answered his request.

9:31b

but He does listen to the one who worships Him and does His will.

- God listens to a/the person who worships and obeys him.
- But if people worship and obey him, God will answer their prayers.

but He does listen to the one who worships Him and does His will: This clause states that God does listen to a godly man. This means that he answers his prayers. It also implies that Jesus was a godly man, because God answered his prayer to heal the blind man. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he listens to the godly man who does his will (NIV)

but rather he does listen to people who honor him and who do what he wants them to do

General Comment on 9:31a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the positive statement first. For example:

^{31b}We know that God listens only to people who love and obey him. ^{31a}God doesn't listen to sinners. (CEV)

John 9:32

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:32

Never before has anyone heard of opening the eyes of a man born blind.

- Not since the beginning of the world has anyone heard of someone healing the eyes of a person who has been blind all his life.
- In all of history no one has ever told/reported that someone enabled a person born blind to see.
- And this is the first time in history that anyone has ever given sight to someone born blind. (CEV)

Never before has anyone heard of opening the eyes of a man born blind: The man who had been healed continued his argument that Jesus was from God. He emphasized that Jesus had done a great miracle. He said that no one had ever heard of such a miracle happening before. (The phrase opening the eyes here means “healed the eyes.”) His point was not that no one had heard about such a miracle, but that such a miracle had never happened. No one had heard of it because it had not happened before. For example:

And this is the first time in history that anyone has ever given sight to someone born blind. (CEV)

Never before: The phrase that the BSB translates as Never before is more literally “from the age,” meaning “from ancient times.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Since the beginning of the world (GNT)

Since God created the world

through all of history

has anyone heard of: The verb phrase has anyone heard of is passive in Greek. It means that no one had heard that such a miracle happened. No one had heard about such a miracle because no one had reported that such a miracle happened. There are two ways to translate this expression:

General Comment on 9:32

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it has never been heard (NASB)

no person has ever been reported

- Use an active verb like the BSB. For example:

Nobody has ever heard of.... (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

To open the eyes of a man born blind—that is unheard of since time began. (REB)

John 9:33

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:33

If this man were not from God, He could do no such thing."

- If Jesus were not from God, he could not do anything like that."
- Unless Jesus has come from God, he could not do a miracle like that."
- Jesus must be from God to have done it."

If this man were not from God, He could do no such thing: The man who had been blind gave reasons why what the Pharisees said about Jesus could not be true. For if it had been true and Jesus were not from God, Jesus could not have healed him. But Jesus had healed him, so Jesus must be from God. Therefore what the Pharisees said must be false. Consider how reasons for the man's belief can be said most clearly and naturally in your language. For example:

if this man were not from God, he wouldn't have been able to do anything (NJB)

If this man did not come from God, he couldn't do such a thing. (JBP)

If this man were not from God: The word If imagines a situation that was not true: that Jesus did not come from God. If this imagined situation had been true, then Jesus would not have been able to do miracles. In some languages it may be natural to translate this in a positive way. For example:

Unless this man came from God (GNT)

this man: This phrase refers to Jesus. The Greek text more literally says "this one." In this context, however, the speaker is not showing a lack of respect.

He could do no such thing: This clause indicates that Jesus would not have been able to do any miracles. He would not have been able to heal a blind person. For example:

he couldn't do anything like that (GW)

he couldn't have done it (NLT)

General Comment on 9:33

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this verse. For example:

Jesus couldn't do anything unless he came from God. (CEV)

Jesus could not have done such a miracle if God had not sent him.

John 9:34

Section 9:13–34: The Pharisees investigated the blind man's healing

This section tells that Jesus healed the blind man on the Jewish rest day, the Sabbath. The Pharisees thought that healing people was work and so they did not allow it on the Sabbath.

They questioned the man about how he received his sight. They refused to believe that he was born blind and called his parents to come to identify him. Then they told the man that Jesus must be a sinner because he had worked on the rest day. But the man said that

Jesus must be a prophet of God. The Pharisees were so angry at this that they forced him to leave.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The Pharisees questioned the man born blind

The Pharisees believed that Jesus was a sinner because he healed on a Sabbath

The investigation of the healing

Paragraph 9:24–34

The Pharisees tried to frighten the man that Jesus had healed so that he would agree with them. They wanted him to say that he did not believe that Jesus was from God. But the man continued to defend Jesus. He also challenged them about why they did not see that God was working when Jesus healed him.

9:34a

They replied, “You were born in utter sin,

- They replied, “You^(sing) were born full of sin;
- They replied, “You^(sing) have been extremely sinful from the day you were born.

They replied: In some languages it may be natural to make the reference of one or both the pronouns explicit. For example:

The Jewish/religious leaders replied to him

You were born in utter sin: In this clause, the religious leaders insulted the man. They indicated that they thought that the man had been a great sinner at the time he was born. It is also implied that he was still such a sinner. See the disciples’ question in 9:2 and the note there.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You have been a sinner since the day you were born! (CEV)

You were born full of sin! (NCV)

You were born a total sinner! (NLT)

You have been nothing but a sinner from the day you were born!

9:34b

and you are instructing us?”

- how dare you^(sing) teach us^(excl)!”
- You^(sing) should not think that you can be our^(excl) teacher!”

and you are instructing us?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jewish leaders used it to rebuke the man. They rebuked him for telling them what they should believe. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think you can teach us anything? (CEV)

- Use a statement or exclamation. For example:

You^(sing) should not try to teach us^(excl) anything!

how dare you lecture us! (NIV)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language. The contrast between the blind man (you) and the Jewish leaders (us) should be clear. The leaders were proud and did not think that a sinful man could teach them anything. And they thought that the man whom Jesus healed was a sinful man.

9:34c

And they threw him out.

- And they threw him out. (NCV)
- So they sent him out.

And: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as And here introduces what the religious leaders did after rebuking the man that Jesus healed. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

Then (REB)

So (NET)

they threw him out: It is not clear what this clause indicates. It could indicate that the Jewish leaders threw the man out of the building. Or it could indicate that they banned him from the synagogue. Verse 9:22b talks about banning people from the synagogue if they believed that Jesus was the Messiah, but a different verb is used here. Nearly all English translations translate this clause literally and keep the meaning ambiguous. It is recommended that you do the same. For example:

So they put him out. (NASB)

John 9:35

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:35a

When Jesus heard that they had thrown him out,

- ¶ Jesus heard from others that the Jewish leaders threw him out.
- ¶ Jesus heard from other people that the Jewish leaders had sent him out.

When Jesus heard that they had thrown him out:

Someone told Jesus that the Jewish authorities (leaders) threw out the man that he had healed (see 9:34c). In some languages it may be natural to make some of this explicit. For example:

Jesus heard that the Jews had thrown the man out of the synagogue (GW)

Jesus learned that the Jewish leaders forced the man to leave.

If it is not natural to repeat this information from the previous sentence, 9:34c, it may be possible to leave it implied. For example:

When Jesus heard what had happened (GNT)

9:35b

He found the man and said, “Do you believe in the Son of Man?”

- He found him, and then he said to him, “Do you^(sing) believe in the Son of Man?”
- Jesus went looking for him and asked him, “Do you^(sing) have faith in the Son of Man, the Messiah?”

He found the man: It is implied that Jesus first looked for the man or inquired about him. You may want to make that more explicit. For example:

he went and found the man (CEV)

Do you believe in the Son of Man?: This is a real question. Jesus asked the man if he believed in the Son of Man, the Messiah. Jesus was referring to himself, but the man did not know this yet. Therefore, you should not indicate or imply that Jesus was referring to himself here.

believe in: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:12b and 8:30. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

have faith in (CEV)

trust in

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the son of the human/person.” This was the title used in Daniel 7:13. It implies two things about this person:

1. He was a true human being and represented all people
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some expressions that translators have used:

the man whom God sent

the true man from God/heaven

See how you translated this in 3:13, 14.

John 9:36

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:36a

“Who is He, Sir?” he replied.

- The man replied, “Who is he, sir?”
- The man asked Jesus, “Sir, who is the/this Son of Man?”
- The man answered, “Sir, (CEV)

9:36b

“Tell me so that I may believe in Him.”

- Tell me so I can believe in him.”
- Tell me who he is because I want to believe in him.”
- if you^(sing) will tell me who he is, I will put my faith in him.” (CEV)

9:36a–b

“Who is He, Sir?” he replied. “Tell me so that I may believe in Him.”: The man addressed Jesus with respect and humility. He had never seen Jesus before but had perhaps recognized his voice as the man who healed him. He was willing to believe whatever Jesus told him about the Son of Man, the Messiah.

The Greek text does not include the words Tell me. The BSB has supplied them to make the meaning clear. Here are other ways to translate these sentences:

And who is he, sir, that I may believe in him? (NET)

Tell me who he is, sir, that I may put my faith in him. (REB)

Sir, if you will tell me who he is, I will put my faith in him. (CEV)

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir is a polite way of addressing a man. It can also be translated as “lord” or “Lord.” However, the man did not recognize Jesus as his Lord yet, so it is better to translate it as something like “sir.” See how you translated this word in 5:7a.

believe in Him: This expression has the same meaning as the expression “believe in the Son of Man” in 9:35b. See the note there and how you translated that expression.

John 9:37

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:37a

“You have already seen Him,” Jesus answered.

- Jesus said, “You^(sing) now have seen him.
- Jesus replied, “You have not only seen him.

You have already seen Him: Jesus indicated to the man that the person he was looking at, Jesus himself, was the Son of Man. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You have now seen him (NIV)

You are now/already looking at him.

9:37b

“He is the One speaking with you.”

- He is speaking with/to you^(sing).”

- but I, the one speaking with you^(sing), am he.”

He is the One speaking with you: Jesus clearly declared that he himself was the Son of Man. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

indeed, it is he who is speaking to you (REB)

The Son of Man is the one talking with you (NCV)

In some languages it may be necessary to use a first-person pronoun, because Jesus was talking about himself. For example:

and I, the person speaking to you right now, am he

John 9:38

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:38a

“Lord, I believe,” he said.

- The man said, “Lord, I believe in you.”
- “I have faith in you^(sing), Lord,” the man said.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is also used in 9:36a, where it is translated as “sir.” The man now understood and believed that Jesus was the Messiah, so most English translations translate it here as Lord.

I believe: These words indicate that the man believed that Jesus was the Son of Man, the Messiah. In some languages it is more natural to supply an object, indicating what or whom he believed. For example:

I believe in you.

believe: This word has the same meaning as “believe in” in 9:35b and 9:36. It includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated this idea in 1:12b and 9:35b. Here are other ways to translate this idea here:

put my faith in you (CEV)

trust in you

believe in you

he said: The pronoun he refers to the man whom Jesus had healed. Indicate this in a way that is natural in this context. For example:

The man said (CEV)

9:38b

And he worshiped Jesus.

- And he worshiped Jesus.
- And he knelt/bowed down to worship Jesus.

he worshiped Jesus: In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly whom the pronouns refer to. For example:

the man worshiped Jesus (NCV)

worshiped Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as worshiped means to bow down to the ground before someone. Bowing before someone in this way was a sign of great respect for that person. It does not have to mean that the man recognized and worshiped Jesus as God. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

knelt down before Jesus (GNT)

John 9:39

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see

would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:39a

Then Jesus declared, “For judgment I have come into this world,

- Jesus said, “People will be judged because I came to this world,
- Jesus said, “I came into this world so that the world could be judged. (NCV)

For judgment I have come into this world: Jesus indicated that he came to the world for the world to be judged. This was the result or perhaps the purpose of his coming. But Jesus did not say here that he would be the judge, and in 3:17 and 12:47 he said that he did not come to judge. Therefore, it is important that you do not say here that Jesus came to judge. (You should not follow GNT where it says, “I came to this world to judge.”)

The idea seems to be that Jesus came and offered salvation. As a result, some people believed him and were saved and others rejected him and were judged. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I came into this world so that the world could be judged. (NCV)

People will be judged because I came to this world

For judgment: The word judgment here refers to deciding whether someone is guilty or innocent. People are divided into two groups: believers and unbelievers. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase For judgment. Here are some ways that you can indicate this emphasis:

It is for judgment that I have come into this world (REB)

The reason that I came to this world is so that people will be judged/separated

In some languages it may be natural to make explicit who would judge and who would be judged. It is important that you do not say that Jesus would judge. That is because John 3:17 and 12:47 both say that he did not come to judge. For example:

Because I came into this world, God will judge the people here

I came to this world that God may judge/separate people

9:39b–c

so that the blind may see and those who see may become blind: These clauses describe both the purpose and the result of the judging. This judgment has two results, one positive and one negative. Spiritually blind people become able to see, but people who can already see spiritually (or think they can) become blind.

Although Jesus had just healed a man who was literally blind, here he spoke mainly about people who were spiritually blind. For example, Jesus did not come so that people who could physically see would become blind. However, Isaiah 6:9–10 does talk about God’s messenger causing people to become spiritually blind. Jesus quoted these words in Matthew 13:14–15, applying them to his own ministry. You may want to write a footnote to explain what Jesus meant in these clauses. Consider how you can help your readers understand that Jesus spoke figuratively here. For example:

As for those who do not know God, they are compared to a blind person, I will remove their blindness. But those who say that they know God, I will show that they are still blind. Adapted from the Kankanaey Back Translation.

9:39b

so that the blind may see

- so that the blind people will see
- I came so that those who cannot see will be able to see,

so that the blind may see: The words so that here introduce the purpose of Christ’s coming into the world. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

I came so that the blind would see (NCV)

I am here to give sight to the blind (CEV)

the blind may see: Although Jesus did heal physically blind people, this phrase refers mainly to people who are spiritually blind. That is because 9:39c can only refer to people becoming spiritually blind. The phrase the blind refers to those who know that they need help to see the truth. Christ is the light of the world, and only people who believe in him can truly see (see 9:5b). If it is not understood that Jesus spoke mainly figuratively, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

those who do not know God, who are compared to people who do not see, may become able to see

the person who knows that his ability to understand is made blind, I will heal him so that he can understand well

the people who do not see/know the truth about God, and so are like those who cannot see, will see

9:39c

and those who see may become blind.”

- and those who think they see will become blind.”
- but as for those who say that they can see, they will become blind.”

and those who see may become blind: This clause indicates the second purpose of Jesus' coming to earth. When the Jewish leaders rejected the light (Jesus), they showed that they were spiritually blind. In other words, Jesus' coming caused them to become even blinder than they were before. This had to happen because they rejected the only true light, the light of the world (9:5b). In your translation it may be necessary to indicate some of the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

and those who say “We know God,” I will show that they are blind

and those who say that their ability to understand spiritual things has not become blind, his ability to understand will become more blind

and the people who say that they see because they think that they see/know the truth about God, they will become blind

those who see: This phrase here refers to the Jewish leaders, who felt confident that they could see. They could see physically, and they thought that they could see spiritually. They thought that they clearly understood God. They thought that they knew what God was like and what his rules were, and they were proud about that. They were proud of their knowledge of God and his law, but they did not truly know God. For example:

those who think they see (NLT)

may become blind: This phrase is a metaphor. With this metaphor Jesus compared not believing to being blind. These people reject the only true light, because they think they do not need it. In this way they confirm their own spiritual blindness.

General Comment on 9:39a–c

In your translation it should be clear that the judgment spoken of in 9:39a is described in 9:39b, c. Here are ways to indicate this:

I came into this world so that the world could be judged. I came so that the blind would see and so that those who see will become blind. (NCV)

It is for judgment that I have come into this world—to give sight to the sightless and to make blind those who see. (REB)

John 9:40

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:40a

Some of the Pharisees who were with Him heard this,

- Some Pharisees who were nearby heard what Jesus said.
- Some Jewish leaders called Pharisees who were with Jesus heard him say this

Some of the Pharisees who were with Him heard this: Jesus was talking to the man who had been blind, but some of the Pharisees heard what he said. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Some of the Pharisees near him overheard this (JBP)

Some Pharisees who were there with him heard him say this (GNT)

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise people

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious group

members of the religious party called the Farasi

See how you translated this word in 9:13, 15a, 16a.

9:40b

and they asked Him, “Are we blind too?”

- They said to Jesus, “You^(sing) do not really think that we^(excl) are blind, do you?”
- and asked if he thought that they were blind too.
- and said to him, “You^(sing) cannot think that we^(excl) are blind too!”

Are we blind too?: This question refers to spiritual blindness because the Pharisees did not have to ask if they were physically blind. It is a rhetorical question. The Pharisees used it to express surprise and disagreement. The question expected a “No” answer and emphasized that they were not blind. They used the rhetorical question to rebuke Jesus for implying that they were blind. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think we’re blind? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

Surely you^(sing) do not think that we^(excl) are blind!

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that emphasizes that the Pharisees did not think that they were blind.

we blind: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as we is more literally “we also.” It emphasizes that the Pharisees’ were amazed that Jesus would include them among the blind.

John 9:41

Section 9:35–41: The blind man could see but the Pharisees could not see who Jesus was

This section tells how the blind man whom Jesus healed believed in him. Jesus said that he came so those who do not see could see, and those who see would become blind. Jesus then told some Pharisees who heard him that because they said that they could see, their sin was not forgiven.

Here are some other examples for a heading for this section:

The man whom Jesus healed saw who Jesus was

Jesus makes the blind to see and those who see to be blind

Spiritual blindness

9:41a

“If you were blind,” Jesus replied, “you would not be guilty of sin.

- Jesus said, “If you admitted that you^(plur) were truly/ really blind, you^(plur) would not be guilty of sin.

- Jesus said, “If you^(plur) confessed your^(plur) true/spiritual blindness, God would not judge you^(plur) to be sinful/guilty.

“If you were blind,” Jesus replied, “you would not be guilty of sin: This sentence refers to an unreal situation. It states what was not the actual situation. It seems to imply that the Pharisees were not blind. However, Jesus was really saying that they did not admit that they were blind. That contrasts with “you claim you can see ” in 9:41b. If they would admit that they were blind, then God would forgive them. Consider how it is natural in your language to refer to such unreal situations. You may want to see how you translated the unreal situation in 9:33.

If you were blind: The word If in this context introduces an unfulfilled condition. The condition that was not fulfilled is that they were not blind in the sense of those who did not see in 9:39b. They did not realize that they needed Jesus’ help in order to see spiritual truth. So because they thought that they could see, Jesus could not heal their spiritual blindness. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

If you admitted that you are really blind

If you confessed your spiritual/real blindness

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Pharisees and other religious leaders opposed to Jesus.

would not be guilty of sin: The phrase be guilty of sin here refers to God considering someone guilty, that is, responsible for their sin. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

would not be guilty (GNT)

you wouldn’t be sinners (GW)

9:41b

But since you claim you can see, your guilt remains.”

- But now that you^(plur) say, “We^(excl) can see,” you^(plur) remain sinful/guilty.
- But since you^(plur) say/boast that you^(plur) can see the truth, you^(plur) are still guilty.
- But God will not forgive your^(plur) sin when you^(plur) say that you^(plur) can see without my light.

But since you claim you can see, your guilt remains: The religious leaders claimed that they already had spiritual sight, meaning that they understood and

knew God and his will. Because they believed that they could already see, they would not accept healing for their blindness. Their pride made it impossible. They refused to ask for spiritual healing, for help and forgiveness, and so they remained guilty of their sin. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

But now you say, ‘We see,’ so you continue to be sinners. (GW)

but now that you say, ‘We see,’ your guilt remains (ESV)

But since: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as But since here introduces the real situation. It also contrasts the unreal situation (and its consequence) in 9:41a with the real situation (and its consequence) in 9:41b. The word since introduces what is true. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

However, because you say that you can see, you are still guilty.

But the truth is that you say, ‘We see,’ so you are still guilty.

you claim: The word you is masculine plural and refers to the Jewish leaders who were speaking to Jesus.

your guilt remains: This clause indicates that the Jewish leaders continued to be guilty of their sin. They had not asked for or received forgiveness.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

this means that you are still guilty (GNT)

you continue to be sinners (GW)

God does/can not forgive your sins

General Comment on 9:41b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

But you remain guilty because you claim you can see. (NLT)

John 10:1

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:1a

“Truly, truly, I tell you,

- Jesus said, “I tell you^(plur) this important truth,
- Then Jesus continued, “Listen^(plur) to my true word/message:

This is the beginning of a new section and paragraph. Because public Bible readings may begin here, it is good to indicate that Jesus is speaking. For example:

Jesus said, “I am telling you the truth....” (GNT)

Truly, truly, I tell you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Truly, truly, I tell you introduces something important that Jesus said. Jesus wanted to emphasize the truth and importance of his next words. See the notes on 3:3a, 3:11a, and see how you trans-

lated this expression there. Avoid implying that Jesus did not always tell the truth. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

Believe me when I tell you that (JBP)

10:1b

whoever does not enter the sheepfold by the gate,

- the person/man who does not enter the sheep pen by the door,
- Those who do not come into the sheep courtyard by walking through the entrance

whoever does not enter the sheepfold by the gate:

These words introduce an illustration or extended metaphor taken from the customs of sheep farming in ancient Israel. If sheep are not known in your culture, it may be necessary to provide footnotes or pictures. See 2:14a for one picture that you can use.

whoever: The Greek word that the BSB translates as whoever can refer to any person, man or woman. In this context it more naturally refers to men. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the person who (NCV)

those who

he who (ESV)

does not enter the sheepfold by the gate: The normal way to enter a sheepfold was to go through the gate. The only other way was to climb over the wall.

the sheepfold: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as sheepfold is more literally “courtyard of the sheep.” The courtyard was probably attached to a house and was surrounded by a stone wall. As a sheepfold it was where the sheep stayed at night. People who owned sheep kept them safe by locking them in there at night. Apparently, sheep belonging to several owners were kept together in one sheepfold, guarded by one gatekeeper (guard). Use a term that can refer to a large pen or courtyard like this. For example:

sheep pen (NIV)

place where sheep are protected

See the note explaining “sheep” in 2:14a. Also see how you translated the word there.

the gate: The Greek word that the BSB translates as gate is more literally “door.” It refers to the entrance to the sheepfold or pen, an entrance that could be closed and locked. Use the normal word for such an entrance. For example:

door (NET)

10:1c

but climbs in some other way,

- but gets in a different way, by climbing the wall,
- but instead climb over the wall

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (10:1b) to a positive statement (10:1c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

a person does not enter by the correct entrance;
rather he climbs over the wall

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Thieves and bandits do not enter the sheep pen through the door. They climb over the wall in a different place.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

A person who climbs into the sheep pen instead
of going through the gate

the person who climbs over the wall of a sheep-
fold, rather than enter through the gate

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

climbs in some other way: Instead of walking into the pen through the gate or door, this person climbs in over the wall. A person normally opened the gate and walked into the pen through it. The person climbing over the wall does something that is not normal

or right. In some languages a literal translation may imply that a person would normally climb over the gate. It may be possible to avoid this wrong meaning by saying the following:

but enters another way, by climbing

In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that this person climbs over the wall. For example:

but gets in another way, by climbing over the wall

but instead climbs in over the wall

10:1d

is a thief and a robber.

- is a thief and a robber.
- are nothing but sheep stealers.

is a thief and a robber: By climbing over the wall, this man shows that he really is a robber. He demonstrates that he intends to steal by entering the sheep pen without permission. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is nothing but a thief and a robber (REB)

must surely be a thief and a robber (NLT)

a thief and a robber: A thief is a person who steals secretly, and a robber is someone who steals violently and publicly. But in this context the words thief and robber mean the same thing, someone who steals. They do not refer to two different people. If a literal translation suggests two different people, it may be better to combine them. For example:

a sheep stealer

General Comment on 10:1b–d

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 10:1b–d. You may want to indicate at the beginning that the subject of the sentence is the sheep stealer. For example:

The thief and the robber do not go through the gate but instead climb over the wall to enter the sheepfold.

only thieves and robbers climb over the wall instead of going through the door to enter the courtyard where the sheep sleep

John 10:2

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:2

But the one who enters by the gate is the shepherd of the sheep.

- The man who enters the sheep pen by the gate is the shepherd of his sheep.
- It is the real shepherd who walks through the door into the courtyard of the sheep.

But: In the Greek text, this sentence connects to the previous sentence with the common conjunction that indicates contrast. The BSB translates this conjunction literally as *But*. The contrast is between those who climb the wall of the pen and those who enter through the gate.

the one who enters by the gate is the shepherd of the sheep: In this next part of the extended metaphor, Jesus contrasted the shepherd to the thieves he just mentioned. Unlike the thieves and robbers, the shepherd enters the sheepfold by walking through the gate. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

The man who goes in through the gate is the shepherd of the sheep. (GNT)

But it is the shepherd of the sheep who goes in by the door.

enters: In some languages it may be necessary to say what the shepherd enters. For example:

enters the sheepfold

goes into the sheep pen

the shepherd of the sheep: This phrase refers to the man who takes care of the sheep, who leads, protects, and provides for them. Verses 12–16 show that the shepherd that Jesus spoke about was the sheep's owner and not a hired worker. If possible, avoid using a term that refers to a paid worker. However, the most important idea that must be included is that this person takes care of the sheep. If you do not have a word for shepherd, you may need to use a phrase that describes him. For example:

the one who cares for the sheep

the sheep farmer

the sheep: See the note explaining sheep in 2:14a. Also see how you translated the word there. In Jesus' figure of speech, the sheep represent his followers, but he did not make that explicit here. Only later did it become clear that the sheep are his followers.

John 10:3

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:3a

The gatekeeper opens the gate for him,

- The person on guard opens the gate for the shepherd,
- The one who guards the door lets him in,

The gatekeeper opens the gate for him: The gatekeeper kept the gate shut during the night and let the shepherd enter in the morning. The Greek text more literally says “The gatekeeper opens for him,” and the object the gate is implicit. The BSB has supplied the phrase the gate. Supply an object if that is natural in your language. For example:

The one who guards the door opens it for him. (NCV)

The doorkeeper opens the door for him. (NET)

The doorkeeper allows him to enter the sheep pen.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as gatekeeper means “doorkeeper” or “one who guards at the door.” The word refers to the man who guarded the sheep

and the sheepfold at night, providing security. Here are other ways to translate this word:

doorkeeper (NASB)

The one who guards the door. (NCV)

for him: The Greek text emphasizes the word that the BSB translates as for him. That implies a contrast between the shepherd and other people that the gatekeeper does not open the gate for. For example:

To him the doorkeeper opens (NASB)

He is the one whom the guard allows to enter the gate.

General Comment on 10:2–3a

In some languages it may be natural to say that the gatekeeper opens the gate before saying that the shepherd enters the sheepfold. For example:

²⁻³But the gatekeeper opens the gate for the shepherd, and he goes in through it. (CEV)

10:3b

and the sheep listen for his voice.

- and the sheep listen to the shepherd’s voice.
- and the sheep recognize his voice

the sheep listen for his voice: The sheep hear their shepherd call to them. They recognize his voice, and so they listen and respond to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the sheep listen to the voice of the shepherd (NCV)

the sheep listen to their shepherd

sheep: See how you translated this word in 10:2.

10:3c

He calls his own sheep by name

- The shepherd calls each of his own sheep by their name
- as he uses each sheep’s name to tell them to come to him.

He calls his own sheep by name: The pronoun He refers to the shepherd. He speaks to his sheep, telling

them to come to him. He has given each of his sheep a name, and he uses these names as he calls them.

his own sheep: This phrase refers to the sheep that this shepherd owns. Apparently not all the sheep in the pen are his. Many shepherds in Israel at that time would keep their sheep together in one pen. So each shepherd led only his sheep out of the pen.

by name: This phrase indicates that the shepherd has given a name to each of his sheep. He knows each one as an individual. This illustrates his care for the sheep.

General Comment on 10:3b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 10:3b–c. First say that the shepherd calls to his sheep and then that they hear him. For example:

^{3c}He calls his own sheep by name ^{3b}and they listen to him.

10:3d and leads them out.

- and he leads them out/away.
- He leads his sheep out of the pen.

leads them out: The word leads indicates that the shepherd walks in front of the sheep. He does that to show them the way to go and protect them from any problems.

General Comment on 10:3

In the Greek text 10:3 is one long sentence, which the BSB has divided into two. Most English translations do the same. When you translate this verse, make the sentences a natural length in your language.

John 10:4

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:4a

When he has brought out all his own,

- When the shepherd has led out all his sheep,
- When he has led all of his sheep out of the pen,

When he has brought out all his own: The shepherd takes all of his sheep out of the sheep pen and does not leave any behind. Apparently some of the sheep in the sheep pen belong to other shepherds, and he does not lead those out. He leads out all the sheep that belong to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When he has led out all of his sheep (CEV)

After he has brought out all his sheep (GW)

all his own: The words all his own mean “all his own sheep,” that is, every sheep the shepherd owns.

10:4b

he goes on ahead of them,

- he goes in front of them,
- he walks in front of them to guide them.

he goes on ahead of them: The shepherd walks in front of the sheep and shows them the right way to go. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he walks ahead of them (GW)

he leads/guides them

10:4c

and his sheep follow him because they know his voice.

- and his sheep follow the shepherd because they recognize his voice.
- The sheep recognize their shepherd's voice and so they walk behind him.

his sheep follow him because they know his voice:

The sheep walk along behind their shepherd, going wherever he goes. They are willing to follow because they recognize the sound of his voice. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

they follow, because they know his voice (CEV)

they go behind him, because they recognize his voice

his sheep: See how you translated the word sheep in 10:2. The phrase his sheep refers to the sheep that belong to the shepherd and follow him.

because: This word introduces the reason the sheep follow their shepherd. They recognize his voice and trust him.

they know his voice: This clause means that they recognize the sound of the shepherd's voice. They have heard it many times before.

John 10:5

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:5a

But they will never follow a stranger;

- But they will never follow a stranger; (NIV)
- If a stranger tries to lead them, they will not walk behind him.

But: The Greek text introduces this clause with a word that the BSB translates literally as But. It indicates a contrast. The sheep follow the shepherd but they do not follow the stranger. Indicate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

they will never follow a stranger: The sheep will not follow someone they do not know. The Greek text emphasizes the word never in the verb phrase will never follow.

a stranger: This clause refers to any and every stranger. In some languages it may be natural to use a plural form. For example:

The sheep will not follow strangers. (CEV)

The Greek text emphasizes the word stranger. This contrasts a stranger that the sheep do not follow with the shepherd that the sheep do follow. For example:

A stranger they simply will not follow (NASB)

But a stranger is someone that they will never follow

10:5b

in fact, they will flee from him because they do not recognize his voice.”

- rather, they will run away from him because they do not recognize his voice.
- They will run away from him because they know that it is not the voice of anyone that they know.

in fact: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as in fact here connects a negative statement (10:5a) to a positive statement (10:5b). This kind of sentence

emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.
- Use a conjunction other than “but” as the BSB does. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

They won’t follow a stranger. Instead, they will run away from a stranger....

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

They will not follow a stranger; they will run away from him (REB)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

They will run away from a stranger and not follow him

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

they will flee from him: The word they refers to the sheep. Use an expression that describes how frightened sheep scatter and run from someone that they do not know.

because: This word here introduces the reason why the sheep will run away.

they do not recognize his voice: This clause indicates that the sheep do not recognize the sound of a stranger’s voice. They run away because they do not trust him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they do not recognize a stranger’s voice (NIV)

they don’t know his voice (NCV)

his voice: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as his voice is literally “the voice of strangers.” In some languages it may be natural to use a plural form. For example:

the voices of strangers

General Comment on 10:5b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 10:5b as a separate sentence and reverse the order of the clauses. For example:

They don’t recognize a stranger’s voice, and they run away. (CEV)

John 10:6

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:1–6

In this paragraph, Jesus described the situation of sheep in a sheep pen surrounded by a wall. He talked about thieves and bandits, who climb into the sheep pen to steal the sheep. The sheep do not follow them. He also described the shepherd who comes in through the gate. The shepherd calls his sheep to come with him and they follow him. Jesus did not say here who he compared himself to, but he will do that in the next paragraphs.

10:6a

Jesus spoke to them using this illustration,

- Jesus told them this illustration/parable
- Although Jesus told them this comparison,

Jesus spoke to them using this illustration: The words Jesus spoke to them using this illustration here indicate that what Jesus said in 10:1–5 is a figure of speech. An illustration is a form of language in which words do not have their normal or literal meaning. The figure of speech in 10:1–5 is an extended metaphor that Jesus explained in the next verses. Consider how people in your culture would describe such a figure of speech. See the note in the introduction to Section 10:1–42. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus told the people this story (NCV)

This was a parable that Jesus told them (REB)

Jesus used this figure of speech with them (NRSV)

to them: The pronoun them refers to the people there. See the General Comment on 10:6a–b.

10:6b

but they did not understand what He was telling them.

- but they did not understand what he/it meant.
- they did not understand what he wanted to tell them.

but: The word but introduces something that is not expected. Even though Jesus spoke to the people, they did not understand what he meant.

they did not understand what He was telling them:

The words did not understand indicate that the people did not understand the meaning of the figure of speech. They understood the words and the literal meaning of the shepherd, the sheep, the thieves, and the door of the sheep pen. However, they did not understand that Jesus used those words to represent certain people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they did not understand what he was talking about (CEV)

but they did not understand what it meant (NCV)

they: The pronoun they refers to the people who were listening to Jesus. See the General Comment on 10:6a–b.

General Comment on 10:6a–b

In some languages it may be natural to make the pronouns “them” and “they” more explicit. They refer to the people who were listening to Jesus. For example:

Those who heard Jesus use this illustration didn’t understand what he meant. (NLT)

John 10:7

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story

or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:7–10

The people did not understand what Jesus meant in verses 1–5, so Jesus made his meaning clearer. He compared himself to two things in the illustration. In this paragraph, he said that he was the gate to the sheep pen. In the next paragraphs he said that he was the good shepherd. Also, the sheep represent Jesus’ followers, and thieves represent the religious leaders who rejected Jesus.

10:7a

So He said to them again, “Truly, truly, I tell you,

- ¶ So Jesus explained further, “I tell you^(plur) this important truth,
- ¶ So Jesus told/gave them another illustration, “I am telling you^(plur) what is true:

So He said to them again: Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, you may want to make explicit whom Jesus spoke to. For example:

Jesus said to the people there

So: The word So here introduces what Jesus said next. The people did not understand him, so he made things clearer. Here is another way to translate this word:

Therefore (NIV)

He said to them again: The Greek word that BSB translates as again does not always mean “again.” Because Jesus did not repeat what he said before, the word could just mean that Jesus added to what he already said. So you might not want to use the word

“again” if it implies that he said the same thing. Here are other ways that you can translate this phrase:

Jesus further said

he explained (NLT)

Truly, truly, I tell you: This expression introduces something important that Jesus said. Jesus wanted to emphasize the truth and importance of his next words. See how you translated this expression in 10:1a.

10:7b

I am the gate for the sheep.

- I am the door for the sheep to enter the pen.
- I am the entrance into the sheep courtyard.

I am the gate for the sheep: The words I am are emphasized in Greek and refer to Jesus. They indicate that Jesus alone, rather than anybody else, is the gate for the sheep. Consider how it is natural to indicate this emphasis in your language. For example:

It is I who am the gate for the sheep

This is a metaphor. Jesus compared himself to the gate or door of a sheep pen. There are at least two ways that they are similar: (1) they are the only right way to enter somewhere, and (2) the place entered is a good, safe place. In the metaphor, the sheep enter the sheepfold (sheep pen) through the gate. This represents people entering the kingdom of God through Jesus himself.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I am like the gate to the sheep pen.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

I am the way to God just as the gate is the way for the sheep into the sheep pen.

- Translate in a way that implies Jesus was speaking of spiritual reality. For example:

I am the real/true gate for the sheep

I am the spiritual door for the sheep

In some cultures they do not have gates to sheepfolds. It may be natural to say, for example:

I am the door for the sheep (NET)

I am the entrance to the sheep pen

the gate for the sheep: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the gate for the sheep is more literally “the door of the sheep.” The door led to a pen or courtyard where the sheep slept at night. For example:

the door of the sheepfold (REB)

the gate that the sheep enter through

See how you translated the word gate in 10:1b, 10:2, and 10:3a.

John 10:8

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:7–10

The people did not understand what Jesus meant in verses 1–5, so Jesus made his meaning clearer. He compared himself to two things in the illustration. In this paragraph, he said that he was the gate to the

sheep pen. In the next paragraphs he said that he was the good shepherd. Also, the sheep represent Jesus' followers, and thieves represent the religious leaders who rejected Jesus.

10:8a

All who came before Me were thieves and robbers,

- The others who came before me saying that they were the door were thieves and robbers,
- All others who came earlier and said that they were the entrance were sheep stealers.

All who came before Me were thieves and robbers:

Jesus said that those who came before him and who said that they were the gate were really thieves. They said that they were the Messiah or had a different way to salvation (the sheepfold), but they were wrong. These are the people mentioned in 10:1a–d.

All: This word does not refer to everyone who came before Jesus, because that would include Moses and the prophets. Jesus did not say that they were thieves! Rather, there is some implied information here. Jesus apparently meant something like “All who came before me and said that they were the gate.” Remember that they did not go in through the true gate (see 10:1). You may need to include some of the implied information if people misunderstand this sentence without it. For example:

All who lived before me and who did not enter through the gate are sheep-thieves. (Otomi Back Translation)

Many teachers have preceded me who said that they had a different way into the sheep pen. They were just crooks!

thieves and robbers: The words thieves and robbers mean about the same thing. The idea is repeated for emphasis. See 10:1d, where the same words are used in the singular. You may want to translate them the same way that you did there. Here it is clearer that the thieves are not just those stealing sheep but represent those trying to destroy people. For example:

just criminals

thieves and criminals

10:8b

but the sheep did not listen to them.

- but/and the sheep did not obey/follow them.

- They called the sheep, but the sheep did not respond to them.

but: This word indicates something that is not expected. Although it is implied that the thieves tried to deceive the sheep, the sheep did not listen to them. It is implied that because the sheep did not listen, the thieves were not able to steal them. It may be necessary to make some of this implied information explicit. For example:

They called the sheep but...

They wanted the sheep to follow them but...

the sheep did not listen to them: The words the sheep continue the metaphor. The people of God did not listen to the false religious teachers. They knew that Jesus was the door and that they should only go in or out through him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the sheep didn't respond to them (GW)

the true sheep did not listen to them (NLT)

to them: The word them refers to the false teachers, who were trying to call the sheep. In some languages it may be natural to say:

to them when they called

to their commands/call

to their voices/words

John 10:9

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:7–10

The people did not understand what Jesus meant in verses 1–5, so Jesus made his meaning clearer. He compared himself to two things in the illustration. In this paragraph, he said that he was the gate to the sheep pen. In the next paragraphs he said that he was the good shepherd. Also, the sheep represent Jesus' followers, and thieves represent the religious leaders who rejected Jesus.

10:9a

I am the gate.

- I am the door,
- I am the true entrance.

I am the gate: This clause is the same as in 10:7, without the words “for the sheep.” Jesus implied that he was the gate or door for people also. He is the entrance into the home of his people, the way to go into God's kingdom. People must enter the kingdom through him. This is a metaphor (one of the seven “I am” statements in John). There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

I am the door (REB)

- Use a simile. For example:

I am just like the gate

- Use a figure of speech and indicate that the word gate is not being used literally. For example:

I am the true/spiritual gate/door

See how you translated the word gate in 10:1b, 10:2, 10:3a, and 10:7.

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. This emphasis contrasts Jesus with those in 10:8a who were thieves and robbers. They were not the gate, but apparently said that they knew a different way to God. Here are some ways to show this emphasis and contrast:

I, on the other hand, am the door.

But I am the only door.

10:9b

If anyone enters through Me, he will be saved.

- whoever enters through me will be protected/rescued from harm.
- Whoever comes to God through me will become safe.

If anyone enters through Me, he will be saved:

The extended metaphor continues in this clause. The meaning of this clause is that those who enter the kingdom of God through Jesus will receive salvation. (The Greek text emphasizes the words through Me.) Try to use language that can refer to both people and sheep so that readers can easily understand the meaning.

anyone: This word refers to anyone and everyone who enters through Jesus. It is possible to use either singular or plural forms. For example:

Whoever enters by me will be saved (NRSV)

Those who enter the sheep pen through me will be saved. (GW)

enters through Me: This phrase here refers to trusting Jesus as the way to salvation. Jesus was still using the gate metaphor. Use a phrase that is natural for speaking about going through a door of some kind. For example:

enters by me (NRSV)

In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly what the sheep or people enter. Use a word that your readers will understand as representing a safe and good place. For example:

enter the sheep pen through me (GW)

he will be saved: This verb phrase refers to receiving protection from danger. Literally, this indicates that the sheep will be protected from danger. Figuratively, it indicates that God will protect people from spiritual danger and death and give them eternal life. Try to use an expression that readers can understand both literally and figuratively.

This is a passive phrase. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

will be protected

will be kept from harm

- Use an active verb. For example:

will live safely

will be safe (NJB)

will find salvation

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

10:9c

He will come in and go out and find pasture.

- He will be able to come in the pen and go out, and find all the food/grass that he needs.
- He will safely/freely come and go and get everything that he needs.

He will come in and go out: This expression indicates that the sheep will move around freely. They will be able to get what they need: rest, exercise, food and water. This metaphor indicates that people who trust Jesus will live freely and safely. This does not mean that people will sometimes leave the kingdom of God and then come back in. A metaphor cannot mean something that disagrees with another part of scripture. The idea here is that people are free. For example:

will be able to come in and go out (NCV)

will come and go freely (NLT)

find pasture: A pasture is a field where animals can eat the grass. During the night the sheep were in the sheep pen and during the day they were in the pasture, eating freely. The phrase find pasture means that the sheep will find grass to eat.

This phrase is a metaphor. In this metaphor, Jesus compared the way God provides for believers to sheep finding food in a pasture. God supplies our needs just as the shepherd supplies the needs of his sheep by allowing them to eat grass. In some languages a literal

translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

- Supply information indicating that the pasture is a good place to be, a place where one's needs are provided for. For example:

find good pastures (NLT)

find his food (JBP)

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

It will be like sheep finding grass to eat in a pasture.

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

Those who come through me will receive all their needs, like sheep finding good pastures.

- In some places there are no specific pastures. You may want to speak in more general terms of animals eating freely of food that is desirable. For example:

eat in grassy/fertile fields

eat green/good grass

John 10:10

Section 10:1-21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:7–10

The people did not understand what Jesus meant in verses 1–5, so Jesus made his meaning clearer. He compared himself to two things in the illustration. In this paragraph, he said that he was the gate to the sheep pen. In the next paragraphs he said that he was the good shepherd. Also, the sheep represent Jesus' followers, and thieves represent the religious leaders who rejected Jesus.

10:10a

The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy.

- The thief comes in order to steal the sheep and kill them and destroy the flock and that is all.
- A thief only wants to bring ruin on the sheep/flock, stealing and killing them.

The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy:

This sentence indicates why the thieves and robbers come to the sheep pen. Their only purpose is to steal the sheep and kill them. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

The thief's purpose is to steal and kill and destroy.
(NLT)

The only reason that the thief goes to the sheep pen is to steal, kill, and destroy.

The thief: This phrase is also a metaphor and refers to someone who wants to destroy God's people. He is like a thief who wants to kill sheep to eat. It refers to any thief. For example:

A thief (CEV)

Thieves

comes only to steal and kill and destroy: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as comes only to indicates that the thief has no other purpose than to do harmful things. He does not want to help anyone but to harm or destroy them. A literal translation of the word only may be unnatural here, as there are three purposes mentioned (steal, kill, and destroy). If that is the case in your language, here are other ways to translate this sentence:

A thief comes to steal and kill and destroy (NCV)

The purposes of the thief is to steal and kill and destroy and that is all.

kill: The Greek word that the BSB translates as kill refers mainly to the killing of animals.

destroy: The Greek word that the BSB translates as destroy is a general word meaning "ruin" or "destroy." The thief ruins/destroys by stealing and killing, so it may be natural to mention this first. For example:

bring ruin, stealing and killing

10:10b

I have come that they may have life,

- I came in order to give them life,
- But I have come to earth so that you^(plur) may live

I have come that they may have life: Jesus came to earth with the purpose of giving life to his sheep, that is, his followers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I came in order to give them life

I came to bring them life (JBP)

In some languages it is not natural to think of life as a possession, something that people have. Instead it may be possible to use a verb:

I have come so that they may live.

they: The pronoun they refers to the sheep, the people of God. It does not refer to the thieves, that is, the religious leaders opposed to Jesus. If using the pronoun they does not make this clear, it may be necessary to say:

I have come in order that you might have life.
(GNT)

I came that my sheep may have life. (GW)

life: The word life in the gospel of John usually refers to eternal, spiritual life. That life is described as knowing God the Father and his Son Jesus (see 17:3). Here, because Jesus was also talking about sheep, it is best to not explain what the word life means.

10:10c

and have it in all its fullness.

- a life that is completely full.
- and live with more than enough of all that you need.

and have it in all its fullness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as in all its fullness means “in a way that is more than enough.” This phrase indicates that Jesus came to give his people full, spiritual life that is more than enough. This refers to things like good relationships with Jesus and the Father, and enjoying God’s spiritual blessings. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and have it abundantly (NRSV)

and have it to the full (NIV)

and may enjoy the very good life that has no lack

and may really live with plenty of everything that they need

General Comment on 10:10b–c

These clauses are connected by the conjunction “and” but they refer to the same thing. 10:10c is more specific and describes the life mentioned in 10b, making it even better. In some languages it may be natural to combine these clauses, using just one verb. For example:

My purpose is to give them a rich and satisfying life. (NLT)

I came to give life—life in all its fullness (NCV)

John 10:11

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:11–16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:11a

I am the good shepherd.

- ¶ Jesus said, “I am the good shepherd.”
- ¶ Jesus continued, “I am like a good shepherd to you^(plur).

Jesus continued speaking to the people. Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, it may be good to indicate this here. For example:

Jesus said/continued

I am the good shepherd: In this metaphor, Jesus compared himself to someone who takes good care of sheep. Here are some ways that Jesus is like a good shepherd:

- They both have responsibility for caring for others.
- They both take good care of the ones that they are responsible for. They keep them safe and provide for their needs.
- They both lead and guide the ones that they are responsible for.

It is important to keep this figure of speech, as it is used many times in the Bible. See, for example, Psalm 23. However in some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. It may be necessary to explain it in some way. For example:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

I am like a good shepherd

- Make the point of comparison explicit. For example:

I take care of my followers as a good shepherd takes care of his sheep

- Make explicit that Jesus is the good shepherd of people. For example:

I am your good shepherd.

I am the good shepherd of my people.

the: The definite article the indicates that Jesus is the only good shepherd in the sense that is meant here. He is the only one who saves us. Only he dies for us to save us. He is not just one among many.

good: The Greek word that the BSB translates as good means “fine, excellent.” In this context it indicates that the shepherd is faithful and works hard. He devotes himself to the welfare of the sheep.

shepherd: The word shepherd refers to someone who takes care of sheep and protects them from harm. As in 10:2, avoid using a word referring to a paid employee. The shepherd in this context is the owner of the sheep.

10:11b

The good shepherd lays down His life for the sheep.

- The good shepherd sacrifices his life for the sheep.
- As the good shepherd, I am willing to die for the benefit of the sheep.

The good shepherd lays down His life for the sheep:

The phrase The good shepherd continues to refer to Jesus. He was willing to die for his sheep, because he loved them. In some languages it may be natural to combine this sentence with the previous one and not repeat The good shepherd. For example:

who is willing to die for the sheep (GNT)

lays down His life: This phrase indicates that the good shepherd was willing to die. As the good shepherd, Jesus allowed wicked men to kill him so that he could save the sheep, his people. For example:

gives his life (GW)

sacrifices his life (NLT)

In some languages a life is not something that one can “lay down” or give. It may instead be possible to say:

dies willingly

allows others to kill him

is willing to be killed

for the sheep: The word for means “for the benefit of.” Jesus, the good shepherd, laid down his life for the benefit of his sheep, his people. He died to save them, so that they could live.

John 10:12

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:11–16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:12a

The hired hand is not the shepherd, and the sheep are not his own.

- The hired man is not the shepherd and the sheep are not his own/property.
- The man who is paid to take care of the sheep is not the true/real shepherd because the sheep do not belong to him.

The hired hand is not the shepherd, and the sheep are not his own: These words contrast The hired hand and the shepherd. It is therefore important that the term you use for the shepherd can refer to a man who owns the sheep. In some languages it may be natural

to emphasize the contrast by translating this as a separate sentence. For example:

The worker who is paid to keep the sheep is different from the shepherd who owns them. (NCV)

The hired hand: This phrase refers to a person who is employed to take care of the sheep. The owner of the sheep pays this person to look after the sheep. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The hired man

The paid worker

The man who receives money/wages to care for the sheep

The phrase The hired hand is used as a metaphor for the false religious teachers. Here are some ways that they are similar:

- They are mainly interested in their own financial gain.
- They do not protect those they are responsible for.
- They try to escape in times of danger.

It is good to continue to translate this extended metaphor literally. But consider how you can help your readers understand that Jesus used an illustration. He did not actually criticize paid farm workers. (Nor did he criticize all religious teachers who receive pay/wages.) The main point is that he is not concerned about the sheep, which is not like the shepherd.

is not the shepherd, and the sheep are not his own:

The two phrases is not the shepherd and the sheep are not his own both describe the hired man. They are saying the same thing in two different ways. The shepherd was the one who owned the sheep, not the hired man. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear. For example:

who is not the shepherd who owns the sheep
(NIV)

is different from the shepherd who owns them
(NCV)

and the sheep are not his own: The sheep do not belong to the hired man. It is implied that this is why he does not care about their welfare very much. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he is not the owner of the sheep

the sheep do not belong to him

10:12b

When he sees the wolf coming, he abandons the sheep and runs away.

- So then when he sees a wolf coming, he abandons the sheep and runs away.
- So when a wild dog comes, the paid/hired man escapes and abandons the sheep.

When he sees the wolf coming, he abandons the sheep and runs away:

The subject of these actions is the hired man from 10:12a. The hired man is not willing to face danger for the benefit of the sheep. He does what is best for himself and runs away from the wolf, leaving the sheep in danger. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He sees a wolf coming and, leaving the sheep, he runs away.

When he sees a wolf coming, the hired worker abandons the sheep and runs off.

sees the wolf coming: This phrase indicates that the hired man sees a wolf, any wolf, coming toward the sheep pen. Jesus did not refer to a specific wolf. For example:

sees a wolf coming (NCV)

when they see a wolf coming (CEV)

wolf: A wolf is a wild dog that is a danger both to sheep and people. In some cultures wolves are unknown. If this is the case in your language area, it may be helpful to do one of the following:

- Include a picture of a wolf and a footnote explaining that wolves were a threat to both sheep and people.
- Use a phrase that describes a wolf. For example:

wild dog

fierce dog

- Use a general word for a dangerous animal like a predator, which hunts other animals for food. For example:

predator

- Substitute another dangerous animal. This should be an animal known both to your culture and to the culture of Jesus' time. For example:

bear

lion

he abandons the sheep and runs away: The hired man runs away, leaving the sheep behind. He is only interested in earning money, not in protecting the sheep from danger. In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the verbs abandons and runs away. For example:

and escapes, leaving the sheep in danger

he runs away from the wolf, abandoning the sheep

General Comment on 10:12 a-b

In some languages it is more natural to say first that the hired man does not defend the sheep and then say why. For example:

^{12b}A hired hand will run when he sees a wolf coming. He will abandon the sheep ^{12a}because they don't belong to him and he isn't their shepherd. (NLT)

10:12c

Then the wolf pounces on them and scatters the flock.

- Then the wolf seizes the sheep and scatters them.
- The wild dog attacks the flock and makes the sheep run away in all directions.

Then the wolf pounces on them and scatters the flock: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as the first Then here introduces the two results of what just happened. The wolf does two things to the flock (group of sheep). Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

and then the wolf attacks and scatters the sheep (NJB)

Then the wolf attacks the flock and scatters it. (NIV)

the wolf pounces on them: This clause indicates the first result of the hired man running away. The wolf seizes or grabs some of the sheep in order to kill and eat them. For example:

he will now kill-and-eat (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

and scatters the flock: The conjunction and connects the two results of the hired man running away. The second result is that the wolf scatters the flock. That means that the sheep do not stay together but run away in different directions.

John 10:13

Section 10:1-21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:11-16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:13a

The man runs away

- The hired man does not stay with the sheep
- The paid worker/employee escapes from the danger

10:13b**because he is a hired servant and is unconcerned for the sheep.**

- because he is only a hired man and he is not concerned about the sheep.
- because he works only for his pay, and the sheep do not matter to him.

10:13a-b

The man runs away because he is a hired servant and is unconcerned for the sheep: The Greek text is more literally “because he is a hired hand and does not care about the sheep.” The word because introduces the reason why the hired man runs away (flees) (10:12a-b). So the BSB begins a new sentence here and supplies the words The man runs away. In many languages it may be natural to supply a similar clause. In the following examples the words that were supplied are underlined:

He flees because he is a hired hand and cares nothing for the sheep. (ESV)

The man runs away because he is a hired man and cares nothing for the sheep. (REB)

The hired hand runs away because he’s working only for the money and doesn’t really care about the sheep. (NLT)

because he is a hired servant and is unconcerned for the sheep: The word because introduces the reason the man ran away: he does not care about protecting the sheep. He is not concerned about their safety. He only took care of the sheep because he wanted his wages. You may want to make this implied information explicit. For example:

The hired hand is concerned about what he’s going to get paid and not about the sheep. (GW)

is unconcerned for the sheep: The English phrase is unconcerned for is confusing here because it has more than one possible sense. In some contexts it would mean that the hired man did not feed or look after the sheep. But that was his job, and that is not what the Greek phrase means. What the Greek means is that the hired man was not concerned about the sheep. They were not important to him, so when danger came he abandoned them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

cares nothing for the sheep (NIV)

is not concerned about the sheep (NET)

the sheep do not really matter to him

the sheep are not important to him

General Comment on 10:13a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 10:13a-b. For example:

Because he is a hired hand and is not concerned about the sheep, he runs away. (NET)

General Comment on 10:12-13

Jesus was talking about hired workers in general. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms, as the CEV has done. The CEV translation also provides a model for how to break up this long sentence into several shorter sentences:

Hired workers are not like the shepherd. They don’t own the sheep, and when they see a wolf coming, they run off and leave the sheep. Then the wolf attacks and scatters the flock. Hired workers run away because they don’t care about the sheep. (CEV)

John 10:14**Section 10:1-21: Jesus is the good shepherd**

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:11–16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:14a

I am the good shepherd.

- I am the good shepherd of my people.
- I am like a good shepherd.

I am the good shepherd: This clause is the same as in 10:11a. See the notes on 10:11a and translate it in both places in the same or a similar way.

10:14b–15a

10:14b–15a contains a double comparison. The way Jesus knows his people is compared to the way God the Father knows Jesus. Also, the way Jesus' people know him is compared to the way Jesus knows God. In some languages it may be better to reorder this to compare just one thing to one other thing. For example:

I know my sheep as the Father knows me. My sheep know me as I know the Father. (GW)

I know my sheep, as the Father knows me. And my sheep know me, as I know the Father. (NCV)

10:14b

I know My sheep and My sheep know Me,

- I know my sheep, and my sheep know me—
- I well know my people and my people know me well too,

I know My sheep and My sheep know Me: The phrase My sheep refers to Jesus' own people, represented in the metaphor by the sheep. Some translations like the BSB supply a noun here, but the Greek is literally "my own."

know: This word here refers to knowing someone personally. The good shepherd knows and recognizes each of his sheep, which is why he can call each one by name. And Jesus knows well each of his people as an individual, recognizing and accepting everyone who follows him. And they know him in that way also. They recognize his voice, his calling, and his leading.

John 10:15

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:11–16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:15a

just as the Father knows Me and I know the Father.

- just like the/my Father God knows me and I know the/my Father.
- in the same way that God my Father knows me well and I know him.

just as the Father knows Me and I know the Father:

The words just as introduce a comparison. The comparison is between the relationship of the Father and Jesus (10:15a), and the relationship of Jesus and his people (10:14b). (Jesus' people are represented as his sheep in the metaphor.) Jesus implied that the relationship between himself and the Father is close and loving. The same is true of the relationship between Jesus and his people. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

in the same way as the Father knows me and I know the Father

the Father: The words the Father refer to God the Father.

10:15b

And I lay down My life for the sheep.

- And I die willingly for the benefit of the sheep.
- So I am willing to die to save the sheep, my people.

And I lay down My life for the sheep: This clause indicates that Jesus was willing to die for his sheep, the people of God. That means that he died for the sake (benefit) of his people because his death paid for our sins. See how you translated a similar clause in 10:11b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

And I am giving my life for the sake of the sheep.
(JBP)

And I give up my life to save my sheep. (Otomi
Back Translation)

I am willing to die for them. (GNT)

General Comment on 10:14–15

The GNT reordered 10:14–15, mentioning the relationship of the Father and Jesus before the relationship between Jesus and his own people/sheep. The GNT also refers to the sheep explicitly in 10:14 and uses a pronoun, “them,” in 10:15. Consider if this order of information may be more natural in your language:

^{14–15}I am the good shepherd. As the Father knows me and I know the Father, in the same way I know my sheep and they know me. And I am willing to die for them.

John 10:16

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Paragraph 10:11–16

Jesus changed the metaphor in this paragraph. In this new metaphor, the shepherd represents Jesus, the sheep again represent believers, and the hired hand represents bad Jewish leaders. The contrast here is that Jesus cares well for the sheep while the bad leaders only think about themselves.

10:16a

I have other sheep that are not of this fold.

- I have other sheep who are not from this sheep pen.
- There are others belonging to me who do not live in this sheep pen.

I have other sheep that are not of this fold: Jesus continued his extended metaphor about sheep-farming, comparing himself to a shepherd, a sheep-farmer. Here, Gentile believers are compared to sheep belonging to the same shepherd but living in a different fold (pen). However, you should not mention Gentiles in your translation. Here are some ways that the other sheep and Gentile believers are similar:

- These believers also belong to Jesus, as these other sheep belong to the same shepherd.
- Until that time they were separated from the others, with different homes.
- Jesus intended to include or unite the groups, as a shepherd might combine different groups of sheep that he owns.

Here are other ways to translate this figure of speech:

I have other sheep that do not come from this sheepfold. (NET)

There are other sheep belonging to me that are not in this sheep pen. (GNT)

I also have other sheep that are not from this pen. (GW)

It is good to keep the main images of this metaphor. However, it may be possible to help your readers understand that it is a figure of speech. You may be

able to use a word that can refer to where people live as well as sheep. For example:

I have other sheep with a different home

this fold: This phrase refers to the sheep pen where the sheep stayed at night and were safe. The Greek word translated as fold is the same word that the BSB translates as “sheepfold” in 10:1b. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

this sheep pen (NIV)

this pen (GW)

10:16b

I must bring them in as well,

- It is necessary for me to bring them as well.
- God wants me to include/lead these people as well,

I must bring them in as well: The phrase as well here means “in addition to the sheep belonging to this fold.” Jesus used this figure of speech to say that he had to bring Gentiles to know him as Savior. It was what God wanted him to do, and so he needed to do it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I must bring them also (NRSV)

I must lead these too (NJB)

10:16c

and they will listen to My voice.

- They also will listen to what I say,
- and these people will also follow me.

they will listen to My voice: This clause indicates that these other sheep will follow Jesus as their shepherd. They will trust and obey him as their shepherd. In some languages it may be natural to say:

they will listen to what I say

they will listen to me

10:16d

Then there will be one flock and one shepherd.

- and all my sheep will be one flock with one shepherd.
- So then there will be only one group of sheep and I alone will be their shepherd.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the final result of Jesus bringing other sheep. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

and (GNT)

So (NRSV)

there will be one flock: The word flock here means “group of sheep.” There is a textual problem here:

1. Some manuscripts say there will be. For example:

there will be one flock of sheep (CEV) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, NIV, KJV, ESV, REB, NJB, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some manuscripts say “they will become.” For example:

they will become one flock (GNT) (GNT, NASB, probably GW)

The two options mean almost the same thing, that all the sheep that follow Jesus will be united in one group. This is a figurative way of saying that all nations and peoples who believe in Jesus will belong together. It is recommended that you say this in the way that is most natural in your language. If both options are acceptable, you may want to follow the major-language translation used in your area.

one flock: A flock is a group of one kind of animals, here sheep. Use the word that describes a group of sheep that live and belong together, that one shepherd cares for (looks after). It may be natural to say:

only one flock (NJB)

one flock of sheep (CEV)

one shepherd: This phrase is a short way of saying “and there will be one shepherd.” Jesus will be that one shepherd. He will guide and care for believers from every people group and nation. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and one shepherd (NET)

with one shepherd (GNT)

John 10:17

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:17–18

Jesus explained clearly that he was going to die and then live again. This was what the Father commanded.

10:17a

The reason the Father loves Me is that I lay down My life

- ¶ “The reason my Father loves me is because I sacrifice/give my life
- ¶ “God my Father loves me because I willingly die

The reason the Father loves Me is that I lay down My life:

These clauses indicate that the Father loves the Son because the Son is willing to die. It is implied that the Son is willing to die for his people, his sheep. That is what he said in 10:11 and 10:15. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

The Father loves me because I am willing to give up my life (GNT)

the Father: This phrase refers to God who is Jesus’ Father.

lay down My life: This phrase means “willingly die” or “allow others to kill me.” See how you translated this phrase in 10:11 and 10:15. For example:

I give my life (GW)

I sacrifice my life (NLT)

I will allow others to kill me

10:17b

in order to take it up again.

- so that I can receive it again.
- with the purpose/aim of becoming alive once more.

in order to take it up again: This phrase indicates that Jesus died with the purpose of taking up his life (getting it back) again. His purpose in dying was to live again. That was not his only purpose, because he mainly died to save people, but it was an additional purpose. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

so that I may receive it back again (CEV)

it: The word it refers to Jesus’ life. It may be more natural to translate this using a verb. For example:

in order that I might live again

so that I will then become alive again

John 10:18

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

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Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:17–18

Jesus explained clearly that he was going to die and then live again. This was what the Father commanded.

10:18a

No one takes it from Me, but I lay it down of My own accord.

- Nobody takes my life from me, but I lay it down willingly.
- Nobody forces me to die. I am willing to sacrifice my life.

No one takes it from Me, but I lay it down of My own accord: Jesus declared that he would die voluntarily (willingly). The Jewish and Roman authorities did not really control him. No one could kill him (take his life from him) without his permission.

No one takes it from Me: This clause indicates that no one was going to take Jesus' life from him (kill him) without his permission. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

No one can take my life from me. (NLT)

No one can end my life

No one can decide to kill me

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement to a positive statement. The negative statement is “No one takes it from me” and the positive statement is “I lay it down of my own accord.” This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

No one can just decide to take my life, rather/ instead I give it to him.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

No one takes my life away from me. I give it up of my own free will. (GNT)

No one can take my life from me. I sacrifice it voluntarily. (NLT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I willingly give my life and no one can take it from me.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

I lay it down of My own accord: Jesus died willingly (of his own accord). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am laying it down of my own free will. (REB)

I give it up willingly! (CEV)

I die willingly.

No one will kill me unless I allow them to kill me.

General Comment on 10:18a

The Greek text and the BSB use the present tense to refer to an event that was future when Jesus spoke. In some languages it may not be possible or natural to use the present tense here. It may be necessary to use future tense. For example:

No one can make the decision to end my life. I will lay it down of my own will.

10:18b

I have authority to lay it down and authority to take it up again.

- I have the right to sacrifice my life and the right to receive it back again.
- I have authority both to allow others to kill me and also to come back to life again.

I have authority to lay it down: The Greek word that the BSB translates as authority refers to the right or authority to do something. Jesus had the authority, meaning the right, to lay down his life (willingly die). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have power to lay it down (NRSV)

I have the right to give it up (GNT)

I have the right to allow others to kill me

and authority to take it up again: Jesus also had the right to choose to live again, that is, to rise from the dead. For example:

and I have power to take it up again (NRSV)

and I have the right to take it back (GNT)

and I also have the right to rise to life again

General Comment on 10:18b

In some languages it may be natural to make the second clause longer by repeating the words “I have.” For example:

I have authority to lay it down, and I have authority to take it up again.

10:18c

This charge I have received from My Father.”

- This is what my Father ordered/commanded me to do.”
- My Father God told me, ‘I want you^(sing) to do this.”

This charge I have received from My Father: Jesus indicated that he was obeying God his Father. It was his Father’s will that he die and rise again. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This command I received from my Father. (NIV)

This is what my Father has commanded me to do. (GNT)

This is an order that I have received from my Father. (JBP)

This charge: This phrase refers to God’s command that Jesus give up his life and receive it again.

from My Father: This phrase indicates that the command came from God, who is Jesus’ Father. In many languages, a capital letter in Father makes that clear. Or you may need to make this explicit in another way. For example:

My Father God told/commanded me to do this.

General Comment on 10:18c

In some languages it may be natural to translate God’s command to Jesus as a direct quotation. For example:

My Father told/commanded me, “This is what I want you to do.”

John 10:19

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

First Jesus compares himself to the door of the sheep pen because he is the way to salvation. Then he compares himself to the good shepherd because he leads and cares for his people as a shepherd does his sheep.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus is the shepherd of his people

Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:19–21

This paragraph tells how the people responded to what Jesus said. They reacted in different ways, some approving of Jesus and some opposing him.

10:19

Again there was division among the Jews because of Jesus’ message.

- ¶ Again Jesus’ words created a division/disagreement among the Jewish people.
- ¶ These words caused the people to start arguing about Jesus once again.

Again there was division among the Jews because of Jesus’ message:

The things Jesus said caused the people who were listening to him to argue among themselves. They could not agree about who Jesus was. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

At these words the Jews were again divided. (NIV)

When he said these things, the people were again divided in their opinions about him. (NLT)

Again: The word Again indicates that this had happened before. The people listening to Jesus had already argued about Jesus because of what he said, in 6:52 and 9:16. See the notes there.

there was division among the Jews: These words here indicate that the people who heard Jesus disagreed and argued with one another about him. There were some who approved of him and some who opposed him. For example:

the Jews did not agree with each other (NCV)

there was a division among the people (GNT)

the Jews: This phrase here probably refers to all the people listening to Jesus, including both the leaders and the ordinary people. They were all Jewish, so it is possible to translate this in these ways:

the Jewish people (NET)

the people (NLT)

because of Jesus' message: The phrase Jesus' message refers to what Jesus just taught in John 10:1-18. Because of what he said, the people disagreed about him. In some languages it is more natural to express this idea using a verb. For example:

because of what Jesus said (GW)

When he said these things (NLT)

John 10:20

Section 10:1-21: Jesus is the good shepherd

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Jesus told the parable/story of the good shepherd and his sheep

Jesus compared himself to a shepherd and the door/gate to a sheep pen

Paragraph 10:19-21

This paragraph tells how the people responded to what Jesus said. They reacted in different ways, some approving of Jesus and some opposing him.

10:20a

Many of them said, "He is demon-possessed and insane."

- Many of them said, "He is possessed by a demon and is crazy."
- Many people said, "An evil spirit is controlling Jesus. It made him quite mad."

Many of them said: These words introduce the opinion of one group of listeners. This first group was opposed to Jesus.

He is demon-possessed and insane: This expression is more literally "he has a demon and is crazy." These people rejected what Jesus said as the words of a crazy man (someone who does not think normally). They believed that one way evil spirits could affect a person was to make him mad/crazy. In some languages it is more natural to say that evil spirits caused him to be crazy. For example:

A demon has come into him and made him crazy. (NCV)

is demon-possessed: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as is demon-possessed indicates that the people thought that a demon controlled Jesus. A "demon" is an evil spirit. The people thought that a demon could possess (have power over) someone and control their thoughts and actions. Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

He is possessed by a demon and has lost his mind! (NET)

A demon has come into him and made him crazy. (NCV)

an evil spirit has entered him and made him mad

Use an expression that is natural in your language to refer to an evil spirit controlling a person. See how you translated this expression in 7:20a and 8:48.

and insane: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as insane. Use an expression that is natural in your language to describe someone who is unable to think normally. This person does not know what is real and what is not real. It should be an expression that insults the person. For example:

raving mad (NIV)

has lost his mind (NET)

He's crazy! (GW)

10:20b

Why would you listen to Him?"

- Why should/would you^(plur) listen to him?"
- Do not waste your time listening to him!"

Why would you listen to Him?: This is a rhetorical question. These people used it as a rebuke. They were scolding the other people for listening to Jesus. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you listen to him? (GNT)

What is the use/purpose of listening to what he says anymore?

What is the point/value of listening to him?

- Use a statement. For example:

It is useless to listen to him!

Let's not listen to him. (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

John 10:21

Section 10:1–21: Jesus is the good shepherd

In this section Jesus talked about how he related to his people, his followers. He compared himself to the door of the sheep pen and to the shepherd. This comparison

is something like a parable, but there is no actual story or narrative. It is more like a word picture, or a series of word pictures linked by the theme of sheep farming. It can also be described as an extended metaphor.

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Paragraph 10:19–21

This paragraph tells how the people responded to what Jesus said. They reacted in different ways, some approving of Jesus and some opposing him.

10:21a

But others replied, "These are not the words of a man possessed by a demon."

- Others said, "A man possessed by a demon does not speak words like these."
- But others said, "No person who is controlled by an evil spirit talks like this."

But others replied: This phrase introduces the words of those Jewish people who were impressed by Jesus. They disagreed with the people who just said that Jesus had a demon. They argued against them, giving a reason why what they said could not be true.

These are not the words of a man possessed by a demon: This sentence disagrees with what the others said about Jesus. The speakers argued that Jesus could not be possessed by a demon because of what he said. In some languages it is more natural to translate the phrase the words with a verb. For example:

A man with a demon could not talk like this! (GNT)

A man who is crazy with a demon does not say things like this. (NCV)

No one talks like this if he's possessed by a demon. (GW)

10:21b**Can a demon open the eyes of the blind?”**

- Can a demon heal the eyes of a blind person?”
- And an evil spirit cannot enable a person to heal a blind man.”

Can a demon open the eyes of the blind?: This is a rhetorical question. The expected answer is “No.” The people used it to emphasize a negative statement. It indicates that a demon could not give sight to blind people. It is implied that only God could do this, or someone whom God had sent. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Can a demon give sight to the blind? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

No one like that could give sight to a blind person!
(CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

John 10:22**Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus**

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:22–24

The Jewish leaders now challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was.

10:22a**At that time the Feast of Dedication took place in Jerusalem.**

- ¶ Then the time came for the Feast of Dedication at Jerusalem.
- ¶ Soon it was the time when the Jews went to Jerusalem to celebrate the dedicating/freeing of the temple.

At that time the Feast of Dedication took place in

Jerusalem: This sentence introduces a new event in the story. It indicates the time of year and where these new events happened. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Then came the Feast of Dedication at Jerusalem.
(NIV)

It was the time of the feast of Dedication in Jerusalem. (NJB)

the Feast of Dedication: This celebration was a feast remembering the time when the Jews freed Jerusalem and its temple from their enemies. It celebrated the rededication of the temple in 164 B.C. It is also called the Feast of Lights, or Hanukkah. The feast is mentioned to indicate the time (December) of the story. You may want to explain about the feast in a footnote. For example:

The Jews remembered when long ago (167 B.C.) an enemy placed an altar in the temple to worship an idol. The Jews rebelled, drove the enemy away, and had an eight-day celebration three years later to clean the temple.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the Festival of the Dedication of the Temple (GNT)

Hanukkah, the Festival of Dedication (NLT)

See how you translated Feast in 7:2a, where a different festival is mentioned.

took place: The expression took place here means “happened.” Use the expression that is natural in your

language to indicate the time of a feast or festival. For example:

was being celebrated (GNT)

10:22b

It was winter,

- It was the cold season,
- It/This was the time of the cold rains.

It was winter: This clause tells the time of year. It was the coldest part of the year. For example:

It was the cold season

General Comment on 10:22a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse 10:22a–b. For example:

^{22b}It was winter, ^{22a}and the Festival of the Dedication of the Temple was being celebrated in Jerusalem. (GNT)

^{22b}That winter, ^{22a}Jesus was in Jerusalem for the Temple Festival. (CEV)

John 10:23

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:22–24

The Jewish leaders now challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was.

10:23

and Jesus was walking in the temple courts in Solomon's Colonnade.

- and Jesus was walking in the temple area called Solomon's Porch.
- One day Jesus was walking in the courtyard of God's house in the area called the shelter/porch of King Solomon.

Jesus was walking in the temple courts in Solomon's Colonnade:

At the time of this event, Jesus was walking around in the temple area in Jerusalem. The words Solomon's Colonnade describe the exact part of the temple where he was walking. For example:

Jesus was walking in the temple area, in Solomon's Portico (ESV)

Jesus was walking on Solomon's porch in the temple courtyard (GW)

in Solomon's Colonnade: Solomon's Colonnade was a covered area or porch on the east side of the temple. A Colonnade is a porch, a roof supported by pillars or poles often attached to a house or building. See how you translated the plural "colonnades" in 5:2. This Colonnade was named after the king of Israel who built the temple almost a thousand years before. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in Solomon's Porch (NCV)

in the area called Solomon's Shelter

General Comment on 10:22–23

In some languages it may be natural to reorder some of the information and mention Jesus earlier. For example:

²²That winter, Jesus was in Jerusalem for the Temple Festival. ²³One day he was walking in that part of the temple known as Solomon's Porch... (CEV)

John 10:24

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:22–24

The Jewish leaders now challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was.

10:24a

So the Jews gathered around Him and demanded,

- The people who were there gathered around him and said,
- The people surrounded him and challenged him,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So here introduces what happened while Jesus was walking in the temple area. It could indicate a result or just the first event in this story. Most English translations do not explicitly translate this word. Here are other ways to translate this word:

then (NASB)

when (GNT)

and (CEV)

the Jews gathered around Him: The phrase the Jews in this context refers to the Jews there who were opposed to Jesus. They gathered around Jesus in an unfriendly way, in order to criticize him. Here is another way to translate this clause:

The people surrounded him (NLT)

and demanded: This phrase here introduces a rhetorical question. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and asked (GNT)

10:24b

“How long will You keep us in suspense?”

- “How much longer will you^(sing) keep us^(excl) anxiously waiting?
- “Do not keep us^(excl) waiting for an answer any longer.

How long will You keep us in suspense?: This is a rhetorical question. The Jews used it as both a mild rebuke and a demand for information. They felt that Jesus had not been open or frank with them. They were tired of waiting for him to tell them who he really was. The phrase keep us in suspense means “make us anxiously wait (for an answer).” There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How long will you make us wonder about you?
(NCV)

- Use a command or request. For example:

Do not keep us in suspense any longer.

- Use a rebuke. For example:

You should not make us wait so long.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

us: The word us refers to the people who were questioning Jesus and is therefore exclusive.

10:24c

If You are the Christ, tell us plainly.”

- If you^(sing) are the Messiah, tell us^(excl) in plain words.”

- Tell us^(excl) clearly. Are you^(sing) the Christ, the promised Savior?”

If You are the Christ: The word If here introduces a conditional clause that may or may not be true.

the Christ: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and both words mean “the anointed one.” The Jews used this title to refer to the person whom God had promised to send as king and savior. See the notes on 1:20, 4:25, 29, and 7:26. Translate it the same way in all these verses. You may want to include a footnote or a glossary entry to explain this title. For example:

The word/title Christ refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send.

tell us plainly: The people wanted to know if Jesus thought that he was the Messiah. They wanted him to tell them plainly (clearly and definitely). Here is another way to translate this clause:

tell us clearly

tell us in plain words

us: The pronoun us here is exclusive, excluding Jesus. It just refers to the ones speaking, the ones opposing Jesus.

General Comment on 10:24b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this sentence. For example:

Tell us plainly: are you the Messiah? (REB)

Tell us the plain truth: are you the Messiah? (GNT)

John 10:25

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God

was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:25a

“I already told you,” Jesus replied, “but you did not believe.

- ¶ Jesus said, “I did tell you^(plur), and/but you do not believe me.
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “I told you^(plur) already and yet you still do not believe me.

I already told you: This clause indicates that Jesus already told the people who he was. It is good to translate this clause with emphasis. For example:

I did tell you (NIV)

Jesus replied: These words introduce Jesus’ response to those who had just challenged him. In some languages it is more natural to say whom he answered. For example:

Jesus answered them (GW)

but: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces something that is not expected.

you did not believe: This clause indicates that the people listening to Jesus did not believe what he said. The problem was not that Jesus had not told them if he was the Messiah. The problem was that they did not believe him. In some languages it is natural to say whom or what they would not believe. For example:

but you don’t believe me (GW)

you refused to believe me (CEV)

10:25b

The works I do in My Father's name testify on My behalf.

- The miracles I do by my Father's authority are my witness.
- I am doing miracles by God's power and that should show/tell you^(plur) who I am.

The works I do in My Father's name testify on My behalf: Jesus indicated that the miracles he did were evidence of who he was. They showed that he told the truth when he said that he was the Messiah or Savior. Here is another way to translate this clause:

The deeds I do by my Father's authority speak on my behalf. (GNT)

The works I do...testify on My behalf: Jesus returned to the metaphor of the law court that he used in 5:36. He spoke of his works as though they were witnesses in a trial, giving evidence that he spoke the truth. This is a figure of speech. There are two ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the figurative language. For example:

The works that I do...bear witness about me. (ESV)

- Translate the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

The proof is the work I do.... (NLT)

The miracles I do...show who I am. (NCV)

Translate this in a way that makes the meaning clear in your language.

The works I do: This phrase refers to Jesus' healing miracles. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

The miracles I do (NIV)

in My Father's name: This phrase means "by God's authority and power." The miracles that Jesus did showed that he was the Messiah because only God's power could do those things. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

by my Father's authority (CEV)

John 10:26

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:26

But because you are not My sheep, you refuse to believe.

- But you^(plur) do not believe me, because you^(plur) do not belong to my flock of sheep.
- But you^(plur) are not my sheep, and so you^(plur) do not believe me.

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But introduces a strong contrast with the previous clause. Although the people saw the evidence of Jesus' miracles, they did not believe him.

because: This word here introduces the real reason that Jesus' opponents did not believe.

you are not My sheep: This clause returns to the metaphor of Jesus as the shepherd, the sheep farmer. It indicates that these unbelieving people were not sheep that belonged to Jesus' flock (group of sheep). They thought that because they were Jewish, they

were God's people. Jesus implied that they were wrong. Here are other ways to translate this clause

you do not belong to my sheep (NRSV)

you are not sheep of my flock (REB)

Some old Greek manuscripts include an additional clause "just as I told you." Modern English translations do not include the clause because scholars do not think it was part of the original text. However, the KJV includes it ("as I said unto you"). So you may want to include the clause if a major translation in your area includes it.

you refuse to believe: This clause refers to believing Jesus or believing what Jesus said. In some languages it may be natural to supply an object for the verb believe. For example:

you don't believe me (NLT)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to Jesus' opponents. The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. The problem was that his opponents (you) did not believe, not that Jesus did not tell them.

General Comment on 10:26

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 10:26. For example:

but you do not believe, because you do not belong to my sheep (NRSV)

John 10:27

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:27a

My sheep listen to My voice;

- My sheep listen to what I say.
- My sheep listen when I speak to them.

My sheep listen to My voice: The phrase My sheep is again a figurative way to refer to people who belong to Jesus. They listen and respond to him.

listen to My voice: The phrase My voice refers to what Jesus says, his words. See the notes on 10:3b, and see how you translated this expression there. For example:

listen to me

give attention to what I say

10:27b

I know them, and they follow Me.

- And I know them well and they follow me.
- And as for me, I know them all, and they follow after me.

The Greek text introduces the next clause with a word that is often translated as "and." The BSB and some other English translations do not include this word because it is not natural in English. It would be good to include this conjunction if it is natural in your language. For example:

and I know them (NET)

I know them: Jesus was saying that he personally knows well each one of his sheep, meaning his people. See 10:3c and 10:14b. Here is another way to translate this clause:

I know them well

they follow Me: The word they refers again to Jesus' sheep, meaning his people. They follow Jesus by obeying him. See the note on 10:4c, where Jesus said the sheep follow him as their shepherd. Continue to indicate the meaning of this metaphor in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

my people follow me like sheep following their shepherd

John 10:28

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:28a

I give them eternal life, and they will never perish.

- I give them spiritual life that never ends, and so they will never die spiritually.
- I cause them to live forever with God; all through the coming/eternal ages they will never be separated from God.

I give them eternal life: The word I refers to Jesus. Here he began to use less figurative language and say directly that he will cause them to live eternally.

Instead of referring to Jesus' sheep (as in 10:27a), they refers directly to those that the sheep represent, his people. It may be necessary to make this change explicit in some way. For example:

I give them, my people, eternal life

I give eternal life to them/those who are my people

eternal life: This phrase refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. This life will never end. See the note at 3:15 and how you translated this phrase there. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

forever life from God

spiritual life that never ends

living forever with God

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces a second idea in this sentence. The two ideas say the same thing, one in a positive way and the other in a negative way. It may be possible to not translate this conjunction explicitly. For example:

and I give them eternal life. They will never be lost.... (GW)

they will never perish: This clause is more literally "they will not ever die through the ages." It indicates that Jesus' people, those who follow him, will not perish through all the ages to come. It is a strong expression indicating that Jesus' people will never know, through all eternity, being apart from God. Emphasize this idea in a way that is natural in your language. See also how you translated the word "perish" in 3:16. For example:

through all eternity they will not die

General Comment on 10:28a

The two clauses "I give them eternal life" and "they will never perish" refer to the same event or situation. Jesus indicated that he would cause his people to live forever spiritually. He said this in two ways for emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to combine

these clauses into one, emphasizing the statement in a different way. For example:

I will cause them to live forever without ever dying.

I will keep them from ever perishing, for all eternity.

10:28b

No one can snatch them out of My hand.

- Nobody can take them out of my care.
- They are safe because no one can remove them from me.

No one can snatch them out of My hand: The phrase My hand is a figure of speech referring to Jesus himself. There is no one anywhere who can take his people away from him. Consider if this figure of speech will be clear and natural in your language. Here is one way to explain this figure of speech:

no one will snatch them from my care (REB)

snatch: To snatch is to grab or take something violently from someone against their will. Here is another way to translate this word:

steal (NCV)

John 10:29

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:29a

My Father who has given them to Me is greater than all.

- My Father, who has given these people to me, is greater than everyone.
- My Father gave them to me. He is more powerful than anyone else.

My Father who has given them to Me is greater than all: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say that the Father is greater than all else. For example:

My Father gave my sheep to me. He is greater than all. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NJB, REB, NET, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. Some manuscripts say that the gift is greater than all else. For example:

What my Father has given me is greater than everything. (GNT) (NRSV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), following the BSB and most English translations. However, experts in the Greek text agree that the exact original text is quite uncertain. The UBS Greek New Testament gives it a D rating, indicating considerable uncertainty. If the translations in your area follow option (2), you may want to do the same.

In this verse part, Jesus said that God the Father gave him his sheep (his people). He also said that God was greater than anyone or anything else. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

for my Father has given them to me, and he is more powerful than anyone else (NLT)

My Father who has given them to Me: God has given these people to Jesus to care for, providing for their needs.

is greater than all: This clause means that God rules over everything else and has more power than anyone else. Nobody can defeat him. So his people are safe and secure.

10:29b

No one can snatch them out of My Father's hand.

- No one can take/grab these people out of my Father's care.
- My Father God will protect/preserve them from everyone.

No one can snatch them out of My Father's hand:

In this metaphor, God has given people to Jesus, but they are still in God's hands. This indicates that they are safe, and that God is protecting them. Refer to your translation of 10:28b. In some languages a literal translation would have no meaning or would wrongly indicate that God has physical hands. If that is true in your language, you may want to explain the metaphor. For example:

no one can snatch them out of the Father's care
(REB)

John 10:30

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:25–30

Jesus answered those who were challenging him. He told them clearly that he was one with his Father.

10:30

I and the Father are one.”

- I and the Father are united.”
- I and the/my Father are like one person.”

I and the Father are one: Jesus was saying that he and God are united together. Some translations follow the Greek order of words, with the first person pronoun at the beginning. You should use the order that is natural in your language. For example:

I am one with the Father (CEV)

In some languages it may be impossible to say that two are one. If that is true in your language, you may translate this sentence in one of the following ways:

The Father and I are like one person

The Father and I have joined together to become like one person.

John 10:31

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:31–33

The religious authorities wanted to kill Jesus because he said that he was one with God the Father. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God).

10:31

At this, the Jews again picked up stones to stone Him.

- ¶ Again the people picked up stones to stone him to death.
- ¶ Jesus' opponents once more prepared to kill Jesus by throwing stones at him.

At this, the Jews again picked up stones to stone Him: Jesus' opponents wanted to kill Jesus for saying that he was one with God. They felt that he was just a human being and should not make himself equal with God. They believed that that was blasphemy, the sin of speaking against God.

the Jews: This phrase here probably refers to Jesus' opponents as it did in 10:24a. You can refer to Jesus' opponents in your translation or use a more general term. For example:

his Jewish opponents (NIV)

the people (GNT)

again: The word again means that the Jews have done this before, as seen in 8:59a. Place this word where it is natural in your language. For example:

Again some of the people picked up stones to kill Jesus. (NCV)

picked up stones to stone Him: This was a method of killing someone as punishment. It was the punishment for blasphemy. See the notes on "picked up stones to throw at him" in 8:59a. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that the purpose of stoning was to kill Jesus. For example:

brought some rocks to stone Jesus to death (GW)

picked up rocks...to stone Jesus to death (NET)

John 10:32

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

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Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:31–33

The religious authorities wanted to kill Jesus because he said that he was one with God the Father. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God).

10:32a

But Jesus responded, "I have shown you many good works from the Father.

- But Jesus said to them, "I showed you many miracles with the help of the Father.
- Jesus responded by saying, "You^(plur) saw me do many miracles as my Father directed/enabled me.

I have shown you many good works from the Father: Jesus said that with God's power and direction he had done many good deeds. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have shown you many good things that my Father sent me to do. (CEV)

I have done many good deeds in your presence which the Father gave me to do. (GNT)

By the Father's power I have done many good deeds before your eyes. (REB)

I have shown you: These words indicate that Jesus did these things in the presence of the people. They watched him do things that revealed the Father's power. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with the people ("You") as the subject:

You have seen me do many good works...

you: The word you is plural and refers to Jesus' opponents, the ones who picked up stones to stone him.

many good works: This phrase refers to what Jesus did to help people, healing them. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

many great miracles (NIV93)

from the Father: This phrase indicates that God's power or command was the origin of these miracles. Jesus did not do them alone. His Father commanded and directed and enabled him. There is a textual problem here.

1. Some manuscripts say the Father. Or "the father." The English difference between "father" and Father does not reflect a difference in the Greek. For example:

from the Father (ESV) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NASB, REB, NIV, NET, GW, GNT, NCV)

1. Some manuscripts say "my Father." For example:

At my Father's direction I have done many good works (NLT) (CEV, KJV, NJB, NLT)

Both options mean the same thing; both refer to God. The UBS Greek NT says "the Father" is the original text, but it is not very certain. It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations and the UBS Greek New Testament. If it is natural in your language to use the first-person pronoun "my," it is acceptable to do so.

10:32b

For which of these do you stone Me?"

- Because of which one of these miracles do you^(plur) stone me?"
- Which one makes you^(plur) want to stone me to death?"

For which of these do you stone Me?: This question is more literally "For which of these do you stone me?" as in the RSV. The people had not started to stone Jesus, but they wanted and intended to do so. For example:

for which one of these do you want to stone me?
(GNT)

This is a question about cause. Jesus was asking which of his miracles caused the Jewish people to want to kill him. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Which of these has caused you to want to stone me?

Which of these makes you want to stone me?

which of these: The word these refers to the great works or miracles mentioned in 10:32a. It may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

which of these good things (GW)

Which of these good works (NCV)

stone Me: It is good to use the same expression that you used in 10:31. For example:

to stone me to death (GW)

John 10:33

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

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Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:31–33

The religious authorities wanted to kill Jesus because he said that he was one with God the Father. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God).

10:33a

“We are not stoning You for any good work,” said the Jews,

- The people said to him, “It is not because of any of your miracles that we^(excl) will kill you^(sing) by throwing stones.
- The Jews opposed to him said, “We^(excl) do not stone you^(sing) for doing these miracles

We are not stoning You for any good work: The people denied that it was because of his healing miracles that they wanted to kill Jesus. They said that none of his miracles caused them to want to stone him. They then said that there was another reason. In your translation, make sure that it is clear that they did intend to stone Jesus, but not because he did miracles. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We are not stoning you for any of these (NIV93)

We do not want to stone you because of any good deeds (GNT)

We are not stoning You: The people had not started stoning Jesus yet but were just preparing to stone him. Consider which tense and verb form is most natural in your language for this situation. In many languages it will be most natural to use the same verb that you used in 10:32b. For example:

We are not killing you (NCV)

said the Jews: The word Jews does not refer to all Jews because not all Jews wanted to stone Jesus. It only referred to Jesus’ opponents. See how you translated this word in 10:31. Here are other ways that you can translate this phrase:

The Jews opposed to him replied

They replied (GNT)

10:33b

“but for blasphemy,

- It is because you spoke blasphemy against God,
- but because you^(sing) have blasphemed/insulted God.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (10:33a) to a positive statement (10:33b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

It is not the good things you did that are the reason that we want to stone you, but rather/ instead your speaking against God.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

We are not stoning you because of any good thing you did. We are stoning you because you did a terrible thing. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

We intend to stone you because you committed blasphemy, not because you did a good deed.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

for blasphemy: This is a short way of saying “We are going to stone you because of your blasphemy.” The people intended to kill Jesus because they thought he had committed the sin of blasphemy (speaking against God). In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete clause or sentence. For example:

It is because of your blasphemy.

We are going to stone you because you spoke blasphemy.

We are stoning you because you have blasphemed.

blasphemy: The word blasphemy refers to the sin of speaking against God, or speaking evil things about God. In Jewish Law the punishment for this was death (see Leviticus 24:13–16). The people thought Jesus dishonored God by saying that he was one with God. They did not believe that he spoke the truth. Here are other ways to translate this word:

because of your blasphemy (GNT)

for dishonoring God (GW)

See the notes on Matthew 26:65, Mark 2:7, and Luke 5:21, and see how you translated blasphemy there.

10:33c

because You, who are a man, declare Yourself to be God.”

- because you^(sing), who are just a man, say that you are God.”
- You are only a human, but you say you are the same as God!” (NCV)

because: The word because introduces the basis for their accusing Jesus of blasphemy. These clauses explain why Jesus’ opponents thought that he had blasphemed (committed blasphemy against) God. It was because Jesus claimed (declared to be true) that he was God. Introduce this explanation in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new clause or sentence without using a word meaning because. For example:

you, a man, are claiming to be God (REB)

though you are only a man, you claim to be God (NJB)

You, a mere man, claim to be God. (NLT)

You, who are a man: These words indicate that the speakers thought that Jesus was no different from themselves. They thought he was just human and not someone divine. The Greek text emphasizes the word You. Here are other ways to translate these words:

you, being a man (ESV)

you, a mere man (NIV)

You are just a man (CEV)

declare Yourself to be God: This phrase in this context mean “you say that you are God.” The people speaking knew that Jesus claimed (declared to be true) that he was God but they did not believe him. They thought that his claim to be one with the Father (10:30) was false. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

claim to be God (NIV)

you say you are the same as God (NCV)

General Comment on 10:33c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in this clause. For example:

You claim to be God, although you’re only a man. (GW)

General Comment on 10:33a–c

In some languages it is more natural to state the positive before the negative. For example:

^{33a–c} Jesus’ Jewish opponents said to him, “We are going to stone you^(sing) to death because you spoke in a way that dishonors God. Even though you are just human, you said you were God. We are not killing you because of the miracles you have done.”

John 10:34

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

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Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:34–39

Jesus defended himself against being accused of blasphemy. He said that he was the one God had chosen and sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. The people again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

10:34a–b

Is it not written in your Law: ‘I have said you are gods?’: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to emphasize that their law does say that they were gods. There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

In your Scriptures doesn’t God say, “You are gods”? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

It is written in your law that God said, ‘I said, you are gods.’ (NCV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

10:34a

Jesus replied, “Is it not written in your Law:

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “Is it not written in your law/scriptures that God said,
- ¶ Jesus replied to his opponents, “It is written in your holy book that God said to people:

written in your Law: The verb written is passive. In some languages it may be more natural to use an active verb. For example:

your Scriptures say (GW)

in your Law: This phrase here refer to the Old Testament as a whole. It does not refer specifically to the Books of the Law (Genesis through Deuteronomy). The quotation here comes from Psalm 82:6. Because Psalms is not one of the Books of the Law, you can use a more general word. For example:

your Scriptures (GW)

10:34b

‘I have said you are gods?’

- ‘I have said that you^(plur) are gods’?
- ‘I have called you^(plur) gods.’

I have said: The pronoun I refers to God. In many languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

It is written in your law that God said, “I said, you are gods.” (NCV)

you are gods: The pronoun you is plural. Scholars have different interpretations about whom the pronoun refers to:

- Some say that it refers to humans who are acting as judges as representatives of God.
- Others say that it refers to the people of Israel as a whole.

Because scholars do not agree about the interpretation, it is best to translate the clause literally.

gods: This word is used figuratively, indicating that in some way these people were like gods. They had received a great honor because God spoke to them and gave them his Law. Consider how you can help your readers understand that the term gods is being used figuratively. For example:

I call you gods

I speak to you as gods

I declare you to be like/as gods

General Comment on 10:34a–b

These verse parts involve a quotation (you are gods) inside a quotation (I said...) inside another quotation (Is it not written in your law...). There are various ways to make this series of quotations clearer and simpler. For example, one or more of the quotations may be translated as indirect rather than direct. Consider what is most natural in your language. For example:

It is written in your own Law that God said, ‘You are gods.’ (GNT)

Your own scriptures record/report that God said, ‘You^(plur) are gods.’

John 10:35

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

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Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

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Jesus defended himself against being accused of blasphemy. He said that he was the one God had chosen and sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. The people again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

10:35–36

In these verses Jesus argued on the basis of biblical authority that it was acceptable to call himself “God’s Son.” He argued that because the Old Testament used the term “gods” for people, this was an acceptable title for himself. It was not blasphemy to call himself “God’s Son,” because Scripture referred to other humans by an even greater title.

10:35a

If he called them gods to whom the word of God came—

- Because the word ‘gods’ is used to refer to those who were given God’s Word,
- God called the people to whom he gave/spoke his message ‘gods’

If he called them gods to whom the word of God came: Jesus began his argument by pointing out that

the Old Testament refers to some human beings as gods.

If he called them gods: The word If in this context means “because.” It introduces something that did definitely happen. The fact that it happened is the basis for Jesus’ argument. Your translation should make it clear that some people were in fact called gods. For example:

Because those were called ‘gods’

it uses the word ‘gods’ of those people (NJB)

This Scripture called those people gods (NCV)

to whom the word of God came: This phrase indicates that God spoke to these people. They received God’s word, his message. For example:

those to whom God spoke

the people to whom his message was given (GNT)

God spoke to those people (CEV)

This phrase refers to the same people who were referred to as “gods” in 10:34b (see the note there). Because scholars disagree about who the phrase refers to, it is recommended that you translate it literally.

the word of God: The phrase the word of God here means “God’s message.” See how you translated the same expression in Luke 3:2 and Jeremiah 1:4, 11.

10:35b

and the Scripture cannot be broken—

- and no one can say that the Scripture no longer has truth/authority,
- and you know that the holy writings are always true/correct.

and: The word and introduces a second fulfilled condition, something that is true. The word “if” in the sense of “because” from 10:35a also applies here:

and because the Scripture cannot be proved false

the Scripture cannot be broken: The word that the BSB translates as broken means “destroyed” or “made to have no authority.” This clause indicates that the Scripture cannot be ignored or rejected as false. That means that the Scripture is always true and always

has authority. So we cannot argue against it and say that the way it uses words (here, the word “gods”) is wrong. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the Scripture does not ever change

You can't argue with the Scriptures (CEV)

scripture cannot be removed

This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the Scripture cannot be broken (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

what the scripture says is true forever (GNT)

John 10:36

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

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Paragraph 10:34–39

Jesus defended himself against being accused of blasphemy. He said that he was the one God had chosen and sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. The people again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

10:36a–b

then what about the One whom the Father sanctified and sent into the world? How then can you accuse Me of blasphemy for stating that I am the Son of God?: This is the last part of the rhetorical question that began in 10:35. Verse 35 formed the basis for the question here. Jesus was saying, “Because the things in 10:35 are true, can you say that I blaspheme (speak against God)?” This verse is the actual question part. It expects the answer “No,” and is used to make a strong negative statement.

Jesus was saying that it was clearly wrong for people to say that he was blaspheming. It was wrong because of the evidence of Scripture and because he himself was sent by God into the world. Jesus rebuked the people who said that he was blaspheming. He did not dishonor (insult or disgrace) God at all.

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There are two ways of translating this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why then do you accuse me of blasphemy because I said, ‘I am God’s Son?’ (NIV)

why do you say that I’m dishonoring God because I said, ‘I’m the Son of God?’ (GW)

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

You should not say that I am dishonoring God because I call myself “Son of God.” God has sanctified me and sent me into the world.

God set me apart as his very own and sent me into the world. So it is wrong to say that I am blaspheming when I say I am God’s Son.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

10:36a

then what about the One whom the Father sanctified and sent into the world? How then can you accuse Me of blasphemy

- how can you say that I am blaspheming? I am the one whom God the Father has set apart as his very own and sent into the world.
- So you^(plur) should not condemn me for blasphemy, God's holy one whom he sent here to earth.

then what about the One whom the Father sanctified and sent into the world? How then can you accuse Me of blasphemy...?: Jesus was saying that it was wrong to say that he was blaspheming. He had just shown from the Scriptures that God had used the word “gods” to refer to humans. So they could not say that he was blaspheming. And that was even truer for him because God had sanctified him and specially sent him into the world.

the One whom the Father sanctified and sent into the world: The phrase the One refers to Jesus, whom the Father sent here to earth. In some languages it is more natural to use the pronoun “I.” For example:

I, whom the Father set apart and sent

the Father set me apart and sent me

See also the General Comment on 10:36.

the Father: This phrase refers to God. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to say:

my Father

sanctified: The verb sanctified means “made holy” or “set apart as holy.” In this context it indicates that God set Jesus apart to serve him by coming to earth. Here are other ways to translate this verb:

set apart as his very own (NIV)

consecrated (ESV)

chose (GNT)

sent into the world: God sent Jesus to the people of the world. This was the special service for which God had set him apart.

How then can you accuse Me: The Greek text emphasizes the word you. This contrasts Jesus' opponents (you) with what scripture said as quoted in verse 10:35. Jesus was saying, “If scripture calls men gods, how can you say that I sin when I say that I am God's Son?”

of blasphemy: To blaspheme is to speak against God in a way that dishonors or insults him. See how you translated the related noun “blasphemy” in 10:33b. Translate the idea here as a noun or a verb, whichever is more natural in your language. These are examples of translations that translate it as a noun:

why do you call it blasphemy (NLT)

why do you accuse me of a terrible sin (CEV)

General Comment on 10:36a

Verse 10:36a includes a quotation inside another quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a direct quotation. For example:

do you say about the one whom the Father set apart and sent into the world, ‘You are blaspheming’ (NET)

10:36b

for stating that I am the Son of God?

- Why do you^(plur) accuse me of saying evil things against God because I said that I am the Son of God?
- I do not dishonor God when I tell you^(plur) that I am God's son.

for stating that I am the Son of God: Verse 10:36b indicates the reason why people said that Jesus was blaspheming. It includes a quotation inside a quotation, and it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation here. For example:

because I said that I am God's Son

the Son of God: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Son of God is the same phrase used in 1:34, though without the article “the.” This is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the phrase “the Son of God” at 1:34. For further information, see the note on that phrase at 1:34.

General Comment on 10:36

In 10:36a Jesus referred to himself in the third person (“the One”). Then in 10:36b he referred to himself in the first person (“I”). This can confuse people. It may appear that Jesus was speaking about two different people. It may be clearer to use only the first person. For example:

Then why do you charge me with blasphemy for saying, “I am God’s Son,” I whom the Father consecrated and sent into the world? (REB)

So why do you accuse me of a terrible sin for saying that I am the Son of God? After all, it is the Father who prepared me for this work. He is also the one who sent me into the world. (CEV)

General Comment on 10:35–36

This is a long and complex argument. In the Greek text it is all one sentence. In many languages it is more natural to break this sentence into several sentences, possibly reordering some of the information. For example:

^{35b}We know that what the scripture says is true for ever; ^{35a}and God called those people gods, the people to whom his message was given. ^{36a}As for me, the Father chose me and sent me into the world. How, then, can you say that I blaspheme ^{36b}because I said that I am the Son of God? (GNT)

^{35a}This Scripture called those people gods who received God’s message, ^{35b}and Scripture is always true. ^{36a}So why do you say that I speak against God ^{36b}because I said, “I am God’s Son”? ^{36a}I am the one God chose and sent into the world. (NCV)

^{35a} LThe Scriptures use the term/word “gods” for those who received God’s message. ^{35b}And the Scriptures can never be removed as wrong. ^{36a}So you should not say that I blaspheme ^{36b}when I call myself God’s Son. ^{36a}God has set me apart for his holy purpose and sent me into the world.

John 10:37

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

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10:37a

If I am not doing the works of My Father,

- If I do not do what my Father does,
- Unless I do what my Father wants,

If I am not doing the works of My Father: The word *If* here introduces a situation that is not true. This is an unreal or unfulfilled condition. Consider how it is natural to suggest situations that are possible but not true. For example:

If I were not doing what my Father wants me to do

If I fail to do what my Father does (JBP)

If my deeds are not the deeds of my Father (REB)

the works of My Father: This phrase refers to the works or deeds of God. Jesus does the same things as his Father God, just as God wants him to. The fact that Jesus and his Father do the same works is evidence that they are one. Refer to the notes on 5:19–20, 36, and 9:4. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the things my Father does (GW)

the things my Father wants me to do (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun works as a verb. For example:

I do as my Father does

10:37b
then do not believe Me.

- you should not believe me.
- there is no need to believe me.

then do not believe Me: This command indicates what people should do if the condition in 10:37a were true/fulfilled. People should not believe Jesus if he did not do what God wanted. However, Jesus did what his Father wanted him to do. So people should believe him.

Translate this clause in a way that indicates that the only reason that people should not believe Jesus is if he did not do what God wanted. However, do not imply that Jesus did not do what God wanted because that is not true. For example:

If I am not doing my Father's work, there is no need to believe me (NJB)

do not believe Me: Here the word believe refers to believing what Jesus said. It probably does not include the idea of trusting in him. Jesus said believe Me, not "believe in me." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

do not believe my words

do not believe what I say

General Comment on 10:37a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 10:37a and b. For example:

Do not believe me unless I do what my Father does. (NIV)

John 10:38

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Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:34–39

Jesus defended himself against being accused of blasphemy. He said that he was the one God had chosen and sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. The people again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

10:38a
But if I am doing them,

- But if I do what my Father does,
- But because I do what my Father wants,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a conditional clause. It is the opposite of the conditional clause in 10:37a. The clause in 10:37a presented a condition that was not true, and this clause presents a condition that is true.

if I am doing them: This clause means "if I do the works of my Father," or "if I do what my Father does/wants." The word if here introduces a condition that was true, and so it can be translated as "because." For example:

because I do what my Father wants

because I do the works/deeds of my Father

I am doing them: The pronoun them refers to the works of the Father. Use the term that is suitable for the expression you used in 10:37a. For example:

I do it

10:38b**even though you do not believe Me,**

- even if you^(plur) do not believe me when I speak,
- although you^(plur) may not accept what I say,

even though you do not believe Me: The words even though introduce something that Jesus said might be true. It means “even if” or “although it might be true that.” Jesus used it to emphasize what they should do in 10:38c. Maybe they are not ready to believe him, but they can still believe his works.

you do not believe Me: Here the word believe refers to believing what Jesus said. Jesus said believe Me, not “believe in me.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you do not believe my words

you do not believe what I say

10:38c**believe the works themselves,**

- believe because of the miracles,
- you^(plur) should at least believe the evidence of the/my miracles.

believe the works themselves: This phrase refers to trusting the evidence of Jesus’ miracles. Jesus wanted them to believe that he was from God because of the powerful healings that only God could do. For example:

believe because of the amazing things that I do

believe the miracles (NIV)

believe: Here the word believe refers to believing what Jesus’ works said about who he was. Maybe they do not want to believe what Jesus said, but they should believe the evidence of his miracles. The word believe here probably does not include the idea of trusting in him. However, trusting should follow if they believe that Jesus is God’s Son. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

believe ^Lthe evidence of^J the miracles

believe ^Lwhat^J my works ^Lreveal about me^J

10:38d**so that you may know and understand**

- so that you^(plur) will know for certain
- Then you^(plur) will completely understand

so that you may know and understand: The phrase so that introduces a purpose clause. The people should believe in order that they might understand the truth.

know and understand: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as know and understand are both forms of the verb that means “know.” (The two tenses mean “come to know” and “keep knowing.”) They are used together for emphasis. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the words and indicate the emphasis in another way. For example:

know for certain (NJB)

Some Greek manuscripts have “know and believe” instead of know and understand. Although scholars are nearly certain that know and understand was the original text, the KJV follows the other manuscripts. If major language translations in your area follow the KJV here, you may also want to translate this phrase as “know and believe.” The meanings of the different manuscripts are very close anyway.

10:38e**that the Father is in Me, and I am in the Father.”**

- that the Father lives in me and I live in the Father.”
- that my Father God and I are united.”

that the Father is in Me, and I am in the Father: Jesus was saying that he was united with God the Father. He was saying that he was one with God. See also 10:30. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

that I am joined/united with the Father

God the Father lives in me and I live in him

John 10:39**Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus**

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God

was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:34–39

Jesus defended himself against being accused of blasphemy. He said that he was the one God had chosen and sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. The people again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

10:39a

At this, they tried again to seize Him,

- Again they tried to arrest him,
- Once more the religious/Jewish authorities tried to catch/seize Jesus,

At this, they tried again to seize Him: The Jewish leaders again tried to seize or arrest Jesus so that he could not continue to teach the people. See also 7:30 and 8:59. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The Jews tried to arrest Jesus again (GW)

Again they tried to seize him (NIV)

They again wanted to arrest him then (NJB)

At this: The Greek word that the BSB translates as At this is not included in many manuscripts. That Greek word is often translated as “therefore” and some English translations translate it that way here. Other translations do not include the word, although it is likely original. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

10:39b

but He escaped their grasp.

- but he escaped from them.
- but they could not because he escaped.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here indicates a contrast between what people tried to do and what happened. What happened was unexpected. The guards wanted to arrest Jesus but could not do so.

He escaped their grasp: The expression escaped their grasp here indicates that Jesus’ opponents were not able to arrest him. They could not seize him. The expression does not indicate that they had Jesus in their hands and that he later escaped. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he got away from them (GW)

John 10:40

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:40–42

Jesus went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. This was a quieter and safer area, and he could continue to teach and heal the people.

10:40a

Then Jesus went back across the Jordan

- ¶ Jesus went back across the Jordan River

- ¶ Then Jesus returned to the other side of the Jordan River,

Then Jesus went back across the Jordan: Jesus crossed the Jordan River, going from the west to the east side. The Jordan River is also mentioned in 1:28a. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Jesus then went back again across the Jordan River (GNT)

10:40b to the place where John had first been baptizing,

- to the place where John baptized people at first.
- where John was in the past when he baptized people.

to the place where John had first been baptizing: This place, Bethany, is referred to in 1:28a–b. You may want to write a footnote that refers your readers to 1:28.

John: The name John here refers to John the Baptist, who is first mentioned in 1:19a.

first: The Greek word that the BSB translates as first here refers to a time about three years before. That is when John declared who Jesus was and people started believing Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this word:

in the early days (NIV)

at first (ESV)

in the place where John first baptized people (GW)

10:40c and He stayed there.

- He stayed there/here.
- Jesus remained there for some time.

and He stayed there: The word there refers to the place where John had baptized. Jesus stayed there for a few weeks, and maybe as long as three months. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He stayed there for a while

and that is where he stayed

While Jesus was there (CEV)

John 10:41

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus

The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:40–42

Jesus went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. This was a quieter and safer area, and he could continue to teach and heal the people.

10:41a Many came to Him

- Many people came to see/hear him.
- Many people went there to him.

In the Greek text this verse connects to the previous verse with the conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Connect these verses in a way that is natural in your language.

Many came to Him: The word Many here means “many people.” You may want to make this explicit. For example:

many people came to him (NIV)

10:41b and said, “Although John never performed a sign,

- They said, “Though John never did any miracles,

- They said to one another, “John never did miracles,
and said: The word said introduces what the people said to one another after they watched and heard Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

They said.... (NIV)

And they said.... (ESV)

Although: The conjunction Although introduces something that is not expected. Even though John did not do miracles to prove he was from God, he had spoken truly about Jesus

John never performed a sign: This clause indicates that John the Baptist did not do miracles. (The word performed here means “did.”) He did not heal the sick to show people that he was from God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

John gave us no miraculous sign (REB)

John didn’t work any miracles (CEV)

John never did a miracle (NCV)

10:41c everything he said about this man was true.”

- all of what John/he said about this man Jesus is true.”
- but all that he said about Jesus is true/right/correct.”

everything he said about this man was true: The people remembered hearing about what John had said. He had said that Jesus was the Lamb of God, God’s chosen Savior and Messiah. See 1:26–34. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

all that John said about this man was true (NIV)

everything he said about Jesus is true (NCV)

John 10:42

Section 10:22–42: The Jewish leaders rejected Jesus
The Jewish leaders challenged Jesus to say clearly that he was the Messiah if he was. Jesus told them that he had told them but they did not believe him because

they were not his sheep. He said that he gives his sheep eternal life and no one can take them from him.

Jesus also said that he was one with God the Father, so the religious authorities wanted to kill him. They said that this was blasphemy (speaking against God). Jesus said that it was not blasphemy because he was the one God sent into the world. He also said that God was in him and he was in God. His opponents again tried to seize him, and he again escaped from them.

Jesus then went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. Many followed him and believed in him.

Here are other possible section headings:

Some Jewish leaders wrongly said that Jesus spoke against God

Jewish leaders became very angry with Jesus

Jewish leaders challenged Jesus

Paragraph 10:40–42

Jesus went back to the east side of the Jordan River, away from Jerusalem. This was a quieter and safer area, and he could continue to teach and heal the people.

10:42 And many in that place believed in Jesus.

- And many people believed in Jesus in that place.
- And in that place many people put their trust in Jesus.

And: The conjunction And here introduces a concluding statement.

many in that place believed in Jesus: These people trusted Jesus as the chosen Savior, the Messiah. They believed that he was who he said he was, and who John the Baptist had said he was. Here is another way to translate this clause:

in that place many believed in Jesus (NIV)

in that place: This word refers to the area at the Jordan River where John the Baptist first began his ministry.

believed in Jesus: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both

ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:31a, and 7:38a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

put their faith in Jesus (CEV)

became believers

John 11:1

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:1–3

This paragraph introduces some new people, Jesus' friends. There were two sisters, Mary and Martha, and one brother, Lazarus. Lazarus became seriously ill, so the sisters sent a message to Jesus.

11:1a

At this time a man named Lazarus was sick. He lived in Bethany,

- ¶ At that time a man named Lazarus became ill. He lived in Bethany,
- ¶ There was a man whose name was Lazarus who became very ill. He lived in the village/town of Bethany,

At this time a man named Lazarus was sick. He lived in Bethany:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as *At this time* here introduces a new event in the story. Introduce this new event in a way that is natural in your own language. For example:

There was a man named Lazarus who had fallen ill. (REB)

a man named Lazarus: The phrase *a man* introduces a new person into the story. He is an important person

in this story. Introduce Lazarus in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

A man by the name of Lazarus (CEV)

was sick: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *sick* here indicates that Lazarus had a very serious illness, one that could be fatal. This was Lazarus' condition at the start of the story. It appears that Lazarus became ill at this time. Because he had not always been ill, it may be natural to say:

became ill (GNT)

He lived in Bethany: Bethany was a village or small town less than two miles east of Jerusalem. This was where Lazarus lived. In some languages it is natural to make that explicit. For example:

Lazarus, who lived in Bethany (GNT)

His home was at Bethany (REB)

General Comment on 11:1a

Verse 11:1a tells us two things about Lazarus: he was sick, and he lived in Bethany. In some languages it may be natural to translate this information using two independent clauses or sentences. For example:

A man named Lazarus was sick. He lived in the town of Bethany... (NCV)

There was a man named Lazarus who became very ill. His home was in Bethany...

11:1b

the village of Mary and her sister Martha.

- the village where Mary lived with her sister Martha.
- and his sisters Mary and Martha also lived there.

the village of Mary and her sister Martha: This phrase describes Bethany. It indicates that Mary and her sister Martha also lived in the village of Bethany. Mary and Martha were Lazarus' sisters. They are also mentioned in Luke 10:38–42. See the General Comment on 11:1–2.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

Bethany was the town where Mary and her sister Martha lived. (GNT)

John 11:2

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:1–3

This paragraph introduces some new people, Jesus' friends. There were two sisters, Mary and Martha, and one brother, Lazarus. Lazarus became seriously ill, so the sisters sent a message to Jesus.

11:2

This verse gives some background information about one of the people in the story, Mary. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that this is background information by placing the verse in parentheses. For example:

(This Mary was the one who poured the perfume on the Lord's feet and wiped them with her hair; it was her brother Lazarus who was sick.) (GNT)

11:2a

(Mary, whose brother Lazarus was sick,

- It was Mary's brother Lazarus who was sick.
- Mary's brother Lazarus was the one who was ill.

Mary, whose brother Lazarus was sick: This clause indicates that this Mary was the sister of the sick man, Lazarus. That means that Martha was also Lazarus' sister.

Mary was a common name in Jesus' time. There were many women named Mary living in Jerusalem and the surrounding villages. Several of them are mentioned in the Gospels. Here the author explained which Mary he was referring to. Mary was no longer living at the time when John wrote his Gospel, toward the end of the first century A.D. That is why English translations

say "Mary was the one who..." rather than "Mary is the one who...." For example:

This Mary... (NIV)

11:2b

was to anoint the Lord with perfume

- Mary was the woman who poured perfume on the Lord Jesus
- It was this same Mary who later poured sweet-smelling oil on Jesus' feet

was to anoint the Lord with perfume: This is background information. It mentions something that the original readers knew about Mary. This incident is not described until the next chapter. This is probably the same event described in Matthew 26:6–13 and Mark 14:39. At the time of Lazarus' illness it had not happened yet. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that this event had not happened yet. For example:

Mary was the woman who later put perfume on the Lord (NCV)

anoint the Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anoint here means "pour on, put on." Mary poured her perfume onto the Lord's feet. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that the Lord refers to Jesus:

poured perfume on the Lord Jesus

perfume: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perfume refers to any sweet-smelling oil. It would be put on people's own bodies or on the bodies of dead people to make them smell nice. It is good to use the same word that you used in Matthew 26:7 and Mark 14:3.

11:2c

and wipe His feet with her hair.)

- and wiped/dried the perfume on his feet with her hair.
- and then used her hair to wipe them dry.

and wipe His feet with her hair: Verse 11:2b continues to give background information regarding Mary. After pouring perfume on Jesus' feet, she wiped his feet dry with her long hair. In this way she gave Jesus great honor. The early Christians who read the Gospel knew about this and remembered her because of it.

General Comment on 11:1–2

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in these verses. You may want to tell the reader when the women are introduced that Lazarus was their brother. It may then not be necessary to repeat the information that Lazarus was ill. For example:

¹⁻²Now a man named Lazarus was ill. He lived in the village of Bethany, where his sisters Mary and Martha also lived. (This was the Mary who anointed Jesus' feet with oil and wiped them with her hair.)

John 11:3

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:1–3

This paragraph introduces some new people, Jesus' friends. There were two sisters, Mary and Martha, and one brother, Lazarus. Lazarus became seriously ill, so the sisters sent a message to Jesus.

11:3a

So the sisters sent word to Jesus,

- So the sisters sent someone with a message to Jesus, saying,
- Lazarus' sisters sent a message to Jesus, telling him,

So the sisters sent word to Jesus: This clause returns to the main story after the background information in verse 2. The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* here introduces what the sisters did because Lazarus was very ill. In some translations this word may be left implied. For example

The sisters sent Jesus a message (GNT)

The sisters sent a message to him (REB)

the sisters: This phrase refers to Mary and Martha. You may identify them by name if that is natural in your language. For example:

Mary and Martha (NCV)

sent word: This phrase here probably indicates that the sisters informed Jesus about Lazarus' illness by asking someone else to tell him. At that time and place most women did not know how to read and write. So in your translation you should not indicate that the sisters wrote a note and sent it to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

sent a message to Jesus (NRSV)

sent someone to tell Jesus (NCV)

sent a messenger to tell Jesus (GW)

11:3b

“Lord, the one You love is sick.”

- “Lord, your^(sing) good/dear friend is very sick.”
- “Lord, Lazarus, whom you^(sing) care about so much, is seriously ill.”

Lord, the one You love is sick: This is the content of the message that the sisters sent to Jesus.

Lord: This word refers to Jesus. It literally means “master.” The sisters addressed Jesus with respect. They trusted and honored him as the Messiah. This is the same word that is used in 9:36a and 9:38a. See how you translated it there.

the one You love: This phrase refers to Lazarus. They indicate that Jesus was very fond of Lazarus and cared about his welfare. Lazarus was a close and dear friend. His sisters reminded Jesus about this in order to encourage him to come to see him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

your friend (JBP)

your dear friend (GNT)

is sick: Lazarus had a serious and possibly fatal illness. Use the same or a similar expression to what you used in 11:1a.

General Comment on 11:3

In some languages it may be natural to use an indirect quotation here. For example:

The sisters sent a message to the Lord and told him that his good friend Lazarus was sick. CEV

John 11:4

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:4–7

This paragraph tells about Jesus' response to the news that Lazarus was ill.

11:4a

When Jesus heard this, He said, "This sickness will not end in death."

- ¶ Hearing this message, Jesus said, "This illness will not end/result in death.
- ¶ When Jesus heard/received this news, he replied. "The purpose of the sickness is not for Lazarus to die.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that could indicate something that is not expected, so some translations translate it as "But." What Jesus said here was not expected. However, it also could just indicate the next thing that happened in the story. Because of that, most English translations like the BSB do not translate this word. Translate this word in a way that is most natural in your language.

When Jesus heard this: This clause introduces what happened when Jesus heard the news that Lazarus was sick. Here is another way to translate this clause:

On receiving the message (NJB)

He said: This phrase refers to what Jesus said in response to the message from Mary and Martha. He was probably talking to the messenger, telling him what to tell the sisters. In some languages it may be necessary to say to whom Jesus was talking. For example:

Jesus told the messenger

This sickness will not end in death: The Greek more literally says, "This illness (sickness) is not to death." This indicates that Lazarus' illness will not end with Lazarus' death. Even though Lazarus did die, he came back to life so the final result of Lazarus' illness was not death. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The final result of this sickness will not be the death of Lazarus. (GNT)

That sickness of his, its final result will not be death

11:4b

No, it is for the glory of God,

- No, this illness is to reveal/show the glory/greatness of God,
- Its purpose is for people to see how glorious/wonderful God is

No: The word the BSB has translated as No here connects a negative statement to a positive statement. The negative statement is "This illness does not lead to death" (11:4a) and the positive statement is "it is for God's glory" (11:4b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction "but." This Greek conjunction is often translated as "but." For example:

This sickness will not lead to death, but to God's glory (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than "but." This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

His sickness won't result in death. Instead, this sickness will bring glory to God (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

This sickness will not end in death. No, it is for God's glory (NIV)

His sickness won't end in death. It will bring glory to God (CEV)

The final result of this illness will not be the death of Lazarus; this has happened in order to bring glory to God (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

His illness will result in bringing glory to God. It will not end in death.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

it is for the glory of God: This clause can be understood in two ways:

1. It indicates that the purpose of Lazarus' illness was to show how great God is. For example:

through it God's glory is to be revealed (REB) (REB)

1. it indicates that the purpose of Lazarus' illness was for God to receive praise through what happened. For example:

in order to bring glory to God (GNT)

(GNT, NET, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

Several translations can be understood in either way (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV).

Both of these meanings are acceptable. However, the context favors option (1), and so do several modern scholars. See Carson, page 406, Kostenberger, page 327, UBS Handbook p. 356, Keener, page 839. And 11:40 refers to the glory of God as something that you see, not something that you give or do. So it is recommended that you follow option (1). If your national language translations follow option (2), you may want to follow that.

for the glory of God: The words the glory of God here refer to the greatness of God, his majesty and power. In some languages it may be natural to translate the noun glory as an adjective. For example:

show how glorious/great God is

11:4c

so that the Son of God may be glorified through it."

- so that because of it the Son of God may receive praise."
- and so glorify/honor me his Son."

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces a purpose clause. This is another purpose of Lazarus' illness: that the Son of God will be glorified, that is, praised. For example:

and it will be the means through which (GNT)

the Son of God may be glorified: The words may be glorified mean that Jesus the Son of God will receive glory. People will praise him and recognize that God sent him into the world. This is a passive phrase and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb, as in the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

to bring glory to the Son of God (NCV)

so that the Son of God will receive glory (GW)

the Son of God: Jesus used this title to refer to himself. In some languages it may be necessary to supply the first-person pronoun "I" or "me." For example:

I, the Son of God

The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the Son of God at 1:34. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

through it: This phrase means "through Lazarus' illness." It was because of Lazarus' illness that people would understand that Jesus was the Son of God and glorify him. Lazarus' illness provided an opportunity for Jesus to display his power and mercy.

John 11:5

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep

and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:4–7

This paragraph tells about Jesus' response to the news that Lazarus was ill.

11:5–6

There are two ways of interpreting how these verses fit together:

1. Jesus stayed where he was because he loved Mary and Martha. He knew what was best for them, and he went to see them at the right time. Or he stayed where he was because he knew that Lazarus' illness would not end in death but in God's glory (11:4). In this understanding, verse 11:5 is a parenthetical comment. See Waltz, "Discourse Patterns in John 11" in Notes on Translation No. 59 (March 1976), pp. 2–8. For example:

Now Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus. So when he heard that he was ill, he stayed two days longer in the place where he was. (RSV) (BSB, RSV, NIV2011, NASB, ESV, KJV, NET)

1. Jesus stayed where he was although he loved Mary and Martha. For example:

Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus. Yet when he heard that Lazarus was sick, he stayed where he was two more days. (NIV) (NRSV, NIV84, REB, GNT, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the natural meaning of the Greek text and is supported by several important modern commentaries. See Kostenberger, page 328, Kruse, pages 247–248, Brown volume 1 page 431, and Carson, pages 407–408. In addition, Bernhard, Lenski, and Meyer say that the "So" in 11:6 refers back to 11:4.

11:5

Now Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus.

- Jesus cared deeply for Martha, her sister Mary, and Lazarus.

- Martha, Mary, and Lazarus were all Jesus' dear/good friends.

Now Jesus loved Martha and her sister and Lazarus:

Jesus cared about the welfare of Lazarus and his sisters. He had affection for them and cared about them. So when he delayed going to their place, it did not mean that he did not love them. Jesus loved them as close friends.

Now: The common Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces an important fact or background information. It is not a time word. It could very well indicate that this verse is a parenthetical comment. 11:5 See Waltz, "Discourse Patterns in John 11" in Notes on Translation No. 59 (March 1976), pp. 2–8.

Martha and her sister: Martha seems to be the oldest in the family because she is mentioned first and by name. The phrase her sister refers to Mary.

John 11:6

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:4–7

This paragraph tells about Jesus' response to the news that Lazarus was ill.

11:6a

So on hearing that Lazarus was sick,

- So when he heard that Lazarus was sick,
- Therefore, when they told Jesus that Lazarus was very sick,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So here introduces what Jesus did because he loved Martha, Mary, and Lazarus. Or he did it because Lazarus' sickness would not end in death but in God's glory (11:4). In this understanding, 11:5 is a parenthetical comment. See the note on 11:5–6 above for more information.

on hearing that Lazarus was sick: The messenger told Jesus that Lazarus was sick. In some languages it may be natural to translate this message as a direct quotation. For example:

when/after the messenger told him, “Lazarus is ill”

11:6b

He stayed where He was for two days,

- he stayed/remained where he was for another two days.
- Jesus waited two days before going to see them.

He stayed: These words indicate that Jesus did not go to see Lazarus immediately. He remained in the place where he was.

where He was: This phrase refers to the place where John had baptized, mentioned in 10:40.

for two days: This phrase indicates that after Jesus heard that Lazarus was sick, he waited two days before leaving to visit the family.

John 11:7

Section 11:1–16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus’ town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:4–7

This paragraph tells about Jesus’ response to the news that Lazarus was ill.

11:7

and then He said to the disciples, “Let us go back to Judea.”

- Then afterwards Jesus said to his disciples, “Let us^(incl) return to Judea.”
- After the two days he said to his followers, “We^(incl) should go back to Judea now.”

and: This word introduces what Jesus said next. In some languages it may be natural to leave this word implied.

then: This word here means after the two days just mentioned, when Jesus stayed where he was. For example:

after the two days (GW)

He said to the disciples: The word He refers to Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to include his name here. For example:

Jesus said to his disciples (GW)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to a follower or learner who is in a special relationship with a teacher. The learner commits himself to his teacher to learn from him and live by following his teaching and example. See how you translated this word in 6:3 and 9:2a.

Let us go: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Let us go is a first-person plural command. Jesus was indicating that he was going and saying that the disciples should go with him. Translate this command in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

We should go

Come^(plur) with me

us: The word us is inclusive here and refers to Jesus and the disciples.

back: This word here indicates that Jesus wanted to return to the place where they went previously. For example:

We should return

to Judea: The word Judea is the name of the province or area where Jerusalem and Bethany were. Lazarus and his sisters lived in Judea, and the religious leaders opposed to Jesus held the most power there. It was therefore the province where Jesus was in the most danger.

John 11:8

Section 11:1–16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died

before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

11:8a

“Rabbi,” they replied, “the Jews just tried to stone You,

- ¶ The disciples replied, “But teacher, a little while ago the people in Judea tried to stone you^(sing) to death.
- ¶ Jesus' followers said to him, “Sir/Rabbi, remember that the people there have just tried to kill you^(sing) by throwing stones at you.

Rabbi: The word Rabbi is transliterated from a Hebrew word and means “my great one.” When John wrote this Gospel, people used this word to show respect for an important religious teacher or leader.

You may want to use a word meaning “teacher,” but it should not refer only to a schoolteacher. Try to use a word that implies that the teacher is highly respected. For example:

Honorable teacher

My teacher/master

See how you translated this word elsewhere, for example, 6:25b.

they replied: This expression introduces the disciples' response to Jesus' command. In some languages it is more natural to use a different verb to introduce an answer. For example:

The disciples answered

the Jews just tried to stone You: This is a reference to the events recorded in 10:31. See the notes there. The people in Judea wanted to stone Jesus to death because they thought he committed blasphemy. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

not long ago the Jews wanted to stone you to death (GW)

only a few days ago the people in Judea were trying to stone you (NLT)

the Jews: The phrase the Jews here again refers to Jesus' opponents. Refer to your translation of 10:31. It is good to translate the Jews the same way that you did there. You could supply the word “there” to indicate which Jewish people are referred to. For example:

some people there (NCV)

the Jews who oppose you there

just: This phrase means “recently” or “a little while ago.” For example:

just a short time ago (GNT)

tried to stone You: The verb phrase tried here means “wanted.” The people did not actually throw stones at Jesus, trying to hit him, but they wanted to.

to stone You: The verb stone means to kill someone by throwing stones at them. See the notes on 8:59 and 10:31. It may be clearer to make it explicit that the purpose of stoning someone was to kill them. For example:

stone you to death (NET)

11:8b

and You are going back there?”

- Do you^(sing) really want to go back there?”
- We^(excl) do not think you^(sing) should go back to Judea.”

and: This conjunction here introduces a rhetorical question. Introduce this question in a way that is natural in your language. You may not need to use a conjunction. For example:

Now you want to go back there? (NCV)

You are going back there?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and is used as a rebuke. The disciples were very surprised that Jesus wanted to go back to where people wanted to kill him. They indicated that this was not a good plan. There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. The question should imply that the proposed course of action is a bad one. For example:

Do you really want to go back there? (GW)

Why would you go back there?

- Use a statement. For example:

You should not go back there!

It is not a good idea/plan to go back there.

Translate this surprise and rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus had not started on the journey yet. He was planning to go. He had just expressed his intention. Translate in a way that makes this clear. For example:

Are you really thinking of going there?

Why do you want to go back? (CEV)

John 11:9

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

11:9–10

These verses first explain why Jesus needed to go to Judea even though there was danger there. Jesus asked, "Are there not twelve hours of daylight?" Daylight refers to the time that he had to do God's will (see 9:4). It was still light, and Jesus still had work to do before he died.

However, these verses also talk about his twelve (12) disciples and all who follow him. Because Jesus is the

light of the world (see 9:5), we must stay close to him. That way we can avoid unnecessary problems in our lives. Without Jesus' light we easily trip over things in the dark.

11:9a

Jesus answered, "Are there not twelve hours of daylight?"

- Jesus answered, "There are twelve hours of light in a day
- Jesus replied, "There is enough daylight in a day, twelve (12) hours.

Are there not twelve hours of daylight?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it as a way to emphasize that there are twelve (12) hours of daylight. There are two ways to translate this emphasis:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

A day has twelve hours, doesn't it? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

There are twelve hours of daylight every day. (NLT)

Use whichever form is most natural in your language to express positive emphasis.

This rhetorical question is also a metaphor. Jesus was not telling his disciples that there are twelve (12) hours in a day. He meant that it was all right to go to Judea because he did not have to die yet. The word daylight represented his life on earth, the time before his death on a cross. His question implies that there was still time before he had to die. If the meaning of this metaphor is not clear in your language, you may want to make it clearer. For example:

It's all right, nothing will happen to us yet because daylight lasts for twelve hours, does it not?

twelve hours of daylight: The Jews and the Romans divided the daylight (hours of light in a day) into twelve (12) parts. These twelve parts varied in length at different times of year but were about an hour long. You may want to explain this in a footnote. These daylight hours were the time in which people could work and travel safely.

11:9b

If anyone walks in the daytime, he will not stumble,

- when people can walk and not stumble/trip,
- A person walking at/during this time, when the sun is shining, will not trip and fall.

If anyone walks in the daytime, he will not stumble:

The phrase anyone walks in the daytime refers to any and every person who walks in the daylight. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek and use a singular subject. For example:

Anyone can walk in the daytime without stumbling (REB)

No one who walks in the daytime stumbles (NJB)

See also the General Comment on 11:9-10.

This clause continues the metaphor. Jesus was not telling his disciples that it is safer to walk during the day than at night. Rather he was telling them that those who walk with him, the light of the world, will not stumble. The word stumble usually means “to trip over something,” but here in the metaphor it means either “to sin” or “to face unnecessary danger.” In some languages, you may want to make the meaning of the metaphor clearer. For example:

People will not stumble into difficulty/danger when they walk during the day.

walks in the daytime: This phrase refers to walking during the hours of daylight. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

walks in broad daylight (GNT)

he will not stumble: The verb stumble means to trip over something. A person walking in the daylight will not trip over things because he can see better. In some languages it may be natural to say this in a positive way. For example:

people can walk safely (NLT)

11:9c**because he sees by the light of this world.**

- because they can see by the light of this world.
- The light of this world makes him able to see.

because he sees by the light of this world: The word because introduces the reason why people who walk during the day do not stumble. They have light from the sun. This light enables them to see everything else. For example:

because he has this world’s light to see by (REB)

because he can see by this world’s light (NCV)

the light of this world: This phrase refers more literally to the sun. If your readers will not understand this, it may be necessary to make it explicit. For example:

they see by the light of the sun, the light of this world

Jesus also spoke in a figurative way, referring to himself as the light of this world. Refer to the notes on 8:12b and 9:5b. You may want to write a footnote that explains this figurative meaning. You may refer your readers to 8:12b and 9:5b, where Jesus called himself “the light of the world.” Or you may be able to suggest in the text that Jesus is using a metaphor. For example:

the one who gives light to the world

the source of true light for the world

The one who is the light of this world makes them able to see clearly.

John 11:10**Section 11:1-16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died**

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus’ town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

11:10a**But if anyone walks at night, he will stumble,**

- It is when people walk in the night/dark hours that they stumble/trip,
- But a person who walks on a dark night can trip,

But: This word introduces the opposite situation, that of walking in the dark. It indicates a contrast between the situation in 11:9b-c and the one in this verse.

if anyone walks at night: This phrase refers in general to anyone and everyone who walks at night, in the dark. See the General Comment on 11:9–10 for an example of a singular subject. In Jesus’ time, in a world without electricity, walking at night meant walking in the dark. It may be natural to say this more clearly. For example:

those who walk in the dark of night

those who walk in the hours of darkness

walks at night: This phrase continues the illustration. Jesus compared living life without him to walking in the world without light. Here are some ways that they are similar:

- People who walk in the dark are not able to see/ know the way
- People who walk in the dark can be in danger.

Try to translate this in a way that helps your readers understand that Jesus was using figurative language. For example:

those who try to walk in the hours of darkness

he will stumble: The Greek word that the BSB translates as stumble refers to someone who falls because they walk into something. It can also be translated as “trip.”

As in 11:9b, the word stumble is a metaphor and refers to sinning or facing unnecessary danger. In some languages, you may want to make the meaning of the metaphor clearer. For example:

stumble into difficulty/danger

11:10b because he has no light.”

- because they have do not have any light inside them.”
- because he does not have the light to see by.”

because: This word introduces the reason why those who walk at night stumble.

he has no light: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as he has no light continues the metaphor. It means that the person stumbles because Jesus, the light, is not in him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he does not have the light inside him

they have no light in themselves (GW)

General Comment on 11:9–10

In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek and use a singular rather than a plural subject. It is good to use a general subject that can refer to anyone, male or female. For example:

⁹If anyone walks around in the daytime.... ¹⁰But if anyone walks around at night.... (NET)

In some languages it may be natural to use the second-person pronoun as the subject. For example:

⁹If you walk during the day, you will have light from the sun, and you won’t stumble. ¹⁰But if you walk during the night, you will stumble, because you don’t have any light. (CEV)

John 11:11

Section 11:1–16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus’ town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:11a

After He had said this, He told them, “Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep,

- ¶ After Jesus said this, he told the disciples, “Lazarus, our^(incl) friend, fell asleep,
- ¶ Jesus then said to his followers, “Our^(incl) friend Lazarus has gone to sleep,

After He had said this, He told them: These words introduce what Jesus said next, addressing a different

topic. Use the phrase or phrases that are natural in your language. For example:

Jesus said this and then added (GNT)

He told them: The pronoun he refers to Jesus and the pronoun them refers to his disciples or followers.

Our friend Lazarus: This phrase refers to Lazarus as a good friend to them all. The pronoun Our is inclusive.

has fallen asleep: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has fallen asleep has two possible meanings. It can be a euphemism, a polite way of saying “he died,” and this is what Jesus meant. It can also be understood literally, meaning “gone to sleep.” That is how the disciples understood it. It is good to translate it literally because the disciples understood it that way. Try to use an expression that could also refer to dying.

11:11b

but I am going there to wake him up.”

- but I am going there in order to wake him.”
- but I will go to Bethany/him to cause him to wake up.”

but: This word indicates contrast. The contrast is between Lazarus having fallen asleep and Jesus waking him up.

I am going there: Jesus indicated that he would travel to where Lazarus was. He was in the village of Bethany in Judea, not far from Jerusalem.

to wake him up: This phrase refers literally to waking someone from sleep. This is how the disciples understood it. However, Jesus was speaking figuratively and meant that he would bring Lazarus back to life. You should translate this literally, because that is how the disciples understood him. Try to use an expression that could also have the figurative meaning of restoring someone to life.

John 11:12

Section 11:1–16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus’ town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:12a

His disciples replied, “Lord, if he is sleeping,

- Jesus’ disciples replied, “Lord, if he went to sleep,
- Jesus’ followers told him, “Lord, if Lazarus is sleeping,

His disciples replied: See how you translated disciples in 11:7. In some languages it may be natural to make it clear whose disciples they were.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master.” It was a polite way for disciples to address their teacher. See how you translated this in 11:3b.

if he is sleeping: This clause states a condition that is assumed to be true. The disciples had just heard Jesus say that Lazarus had fallen asleep. They understood him literally. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If he is asleep (GNT)

if he is sleeping (NLT)

11:12b

he will get better.”

- he will recover.”
- he will get well.”

he will get better: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as he will get better is more literally “he will be saved.” Here it refers to recovery from illness. The disciples understood that Lazarus had gone to sleep. They thought that if he was sleeping, this would help him to recover from his illness. Here are other ways to translate this verb:

he will get well (GNT)

he will be all right (NRSV)

John 11:13

Section 11:1–16: Jesus’ friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died

before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:13a

They thought that Jesus was talking about actual sleep,

- His disciples thought that he meant that Lazarus was asleep,
- The disciples misunderstood Jesus to mean that Lazarus was just sleeping.

They thought that Jesus was talking about actual sleep: This expression indicates that the disciples had understood Jesus literally. They thought he spoke about normal sleep, not death. The disciples wrongly understood Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

they thought he meant natural sleep (GNT)

the disciples thought Jesus meant Lazarus was only sleeping (GW)

11:13b

but He was speaking about the death of Lazarus.

- but Jesus had referred to Lazarus' death.
- But Jesus meant that Lazarus had died.

but: The word but here introduces a contrast between what Jesus meant (11:13a) and what the disciples thought he meant (11:13b).

He was speaking about the death of Lazarus: This clause is an explanation by the author of the true situation. Translate this in a way that is natural for explanations given by an author or storyteller. For example:

Jesus really meant that Lazarus was dead (CEV)

Actually Jesus had spoken about his death (JBP)

General Comment on 11:13a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder 11:13a–b. For example:

^{13b}Jesus was speaking about the death of Lazarus,
^{13a}but they thought that Jesus was talking about actual sleep.

John 11:14

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:14

So Jesus told them plainly, "Lazarus is dead,

- Therefore he told them clearly, "Lazarus is dead,
- So Jesus clearly said to them, "Lazarus died.

This verse returns to the story after the explanation in verse 13. If there is a way to indicate that in your language, you may want to use it here.

So: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as So here introduces what Jesus said because his disciples wrongly understood him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

So then (NIV)

Then (NRSV)

Jesus told them plainly: The word plainly here indicates that Jesus now spoke in plain, literal language. He did not speak about death figuratively. For example:

Jesus told them straight/clearly

Jesus explained so that they could understand

Lazarus is dead: Translate this clause using literal language. For example:

Lazarus has died. (GW)

John 11:15

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:15a

and for your sake I am glad I was not there,

- and because of you^(plur) I am glad that I was not there,
- I am glad that I was not with him. It was for your^(plur) benefit/good.

and for your sake: This phrase means “for your benefit” or “for your good.” Jesus knew that he would best help his disciples to believe by raising Lazarus from the dead when he did.

I am glad: These words refer to Jesus being happy or content that he was not with Lazarus during his illness. He implied that if he had been there, he would have healed Lazarus because of sympathy. But now he had another chance to show the disciples his power.

I was not there: Jesus was glad that he was not at Lazarus' home earlier. It may be natural to make it clear that Jesus was referring to being with Lazarus. For example:

I am glad that I was not with him (GNT)

11:15b

so that you may believe.

- so that you^(plur) will believe in me.
- Through this you^(plur) will grow in trusting me.

so that: This phrase introduces a purpose. It is the purpose of either Lazarus' death or Jesus' not being in Bethany when Lazarus was sick. The two alternatives are related because Lazarus would not have died if Jesus were there. And there is a step that is implied, but not mentioned. Lazarus did not really die so that the disciples would believe, but Jesus raised him so that they would believe. Lazarus died (so that Jesus could raise him) so that the disciples would believe.

you may believe: The word you is plural and refers to the disciples. Jesus would increase their faith through Lazarus' death and Jesus' raising him to life. The disciples already believed in Jesus, so the idea here is that they believed more. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you can grow in faith (GW)

you will really believe (NLT)

11:15c

But let us go to him.”

- But we^(incl) should/must go to him.”
- But now come^(plur) with me to Lazarus.”

But: The word But in Greek indicates a contrast. The contrast is between Jesus not being with Lazarus earlier and going now to him.

let us go to him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as let us go expresses a first-person plural command. See also 11:7. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we^(incl) should/must go

come^(plur) with me

us: The pronoun us refers to Jesus and the disciples. It is inclusive.

to him: The word him refers to Lazarus. Consider how it is natural to refer to going to where a dead person is lying. However, Jesus talks about him as though he were still alive (or would be alive again soon). In some languages it may be natural to make the name explicit. For example:

to Lazarus (GW)

John 11:16

Section 11:1–16: Jesus' friend Lazarus died

In this section, a friend of Jesus, a man named Lazarus, became sick and died. Jesus waited until after he died before he went to Lazarus' town. Jesus told his disciples that they should go because Lazarus was asleep and he wanted to wake him. They did not understand, so Jesus had to tell them that Lazarus was dead.

Here are other possible section headings:

Lazarus got sick and died

Jesus waited until after Lazarus died before going to him

Paragraph 11:11–16

Jesus explained to his disciples that Lazarus had died and that he now wanted to go to Bethany in Judea.

11:16a

Then Thomas called Didymus said to his fellow disciples, "Let us also go,

- Then Thomas (called the Twin) said to the rest of the disciples, "Let us^(incl) go as well,
- Then Thomas, also called "Twin," said to the other disciples, "We^(incl) should all go to Judea with Jesus

Then Thomas called Didymus: The name Thomas comes from a Hebrew word meaning "twin," and Didymus is a Greek word meaning "twin." Didymus was another name that people called Thomas, a nickname, and some translations translate it into English as "the Twin." Apparently he had a twin brother or sister. We do not know if he was the older or the younger twin.

The verb called is passive. There are two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Thomas (called Didymus) (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Thomas, whose nickname was "Twin" (CEV)

Translate this expression in the way that is most natural in your language.

his fellow disciples: This phrase refers to the other disciples, the ones who were disciples with Thomas.

See how you translated the word disciples in 11:7 and 11:12. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the rest of the disciples (NIV)

the other disciples (CEV)

the other followers (NCV)

Let us also go: The verb Let us...go is the same as in 11:15c. It means "we^(incl) should go." Thomas wanted to go with Jesus to Judea. He was encouraging the other disciples to go also. You may want to translate this as a strong suggestion. For example:

We^(incl) should go too

also: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as also here means "as well as Jesus" or "along with Jesus." In many languages it may be natural to make this explicit. Consider using the term the disciples used to address Jesus in 11:8a or 11:12a. For example:

along with the Teacher (GNT)

11:16b

so that we may die with Him."

- in order that we^(incl) may die with our^(incl) Teacher/Lord."
- so that we can die with him there."

so that: This word here introduces a purpose clause. Thomas wanted to go to Judea with Jesus in order to die with him there.

we may die with Him: Thomas expected the Jewish leaders to kill Jesus. He was willing to die with Jesus. In this clause, Thomas expressed his loyalty and love for his Lord.

we may die: The Greek words that the BSB translates as we may die can refer to any kind of death. However, in this context, the words imply a violent death. Jesus' opponents had tried to stone Jesus and here it is implied that Jesus and his disciples would be killed. Here is another way to translate these words:

we may be killed

we: This pronoun is inclusive here. It refers to Thomas, who is speaking, and the other disciples.

with Him: This phrase means “with Jesus.” All of them would die together. Check that your readers do not understand this to mean “with Lazarus.” Here is another way to translate this phrase:

with Jesus (NLT)

John 11:17

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:17–19

This paragraph tells of Jesus’ arrival near Bethany and the situation that he saw there.

11:17

When Jesus arrived, He found that Lazarus had already spent four days in the tomb.

- ¶ On his arrival, Jesus learned/heard that the body of Lazarus had lain in his tomb for four days.
- ¶ Jesus arrived outside Bethany and people told him that they had buried Lazarus in a cave four days before.

When Jesus arrived: This clause indicates that Jesus reached the edge or border of Bethany, Lazarus’ village.

He found that Lazarus had already spent four days in the tomb: They buried Lazarus four days earlier. His body had already started to decay. There was no doubt that he was dead. Perhaps Jesus delayed coming so that people would know that Lazarus was really dead. Rabbis taught that a person’s soul stayed near the body for three days after death. After that, they had no hope that the person would return to life. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

he found that Lazarus had been buried four days before (GNT)

he was told that Lazarus had already been in his grave for four days (NLT)

He found that: This phrase means “he learned that.” It indicates that someone told Jesus how long Lazarus had been dead. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he was told that (NLT)

Jesus learned that

Jesus heard the news that

Lazarus had already spent four days in the tomb: In Jewish culture, people buried a person the same day that they died. So Lazarus had been dead for four days. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Lazarus had already been dead and in the tomb (NCV)

the tomb: People placed Lazarus’ body in a cave and placed a stone in front of the opening. John will make this clear in verse 38 so you do not need to explain it here. However, you will need to translate tomb with a word or phrase that could refer to a cave. For example:

burial place

John 11:18

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:17–19

This paragraph tells of Jesus' arrival near Bethany and the situation that he saw there.

11:18

Now Bethany was near Jerusalem, a little less than two miles away,

- Bethany was about three kilometers from Jerusalem,
- The village of Bethany was only a half hour's walk from Jerusalem.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information about Bethany. It is not a time word. Many English translations do not translate this word. GW puts this verse in parentheses to indicate that it is background information. NET does the same thing with both verses 18 and 19. Indicate that verse 18 (and verse 19) is background information in a way that is natural in your language.

Bethany: Bethany is the name of the village where Lazarus had been living. See 11:1a. In some languages it is more natural to identify it as a village. For example:

the village of Bethany

the village called Bethany

Jerusalem: Jerusalem was the city where the temple was. This is where the Jewish leaders had the most power and influence.

a little less than two miles away: The Greek words that the BSB translates as a little less than two miles away is more literally “about fifteen (15) stadia away.” A “stadion” was what Romans called a distance of about 200 meters (or 600 feet). The singular form is “stadion,” the plural “stadia.” A stadion was about just under 200 meters, or just over 600 feet. This is a little shorter than a “furlong,” an eighth of a mile. Fifteen stadia was a little less than three kilometers, or about two miles. The distance is not meant to be exact but indicates that Bethany was near Jerusalem. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

near Jerusalem, less than three kilometers away

only a half hour's walk away

only a couple of miles away

John 11:19

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:17–19

This paragraph tells of Jesus' arrival near Bethany and the situation that he saw there.

11:19

and many of the Jews had come to Martha and Mary to console them in the loss of their brother.

- and many people from there had come to Martha and Mary to comfort them in their grief over the death/loss of their brother.
- So many of the people of that region came to see Martha and Mary, to give them sympathy/comfort because their brother had died.

and: The word and connects the fact that Jerusalem was near to the fact that many people came to comfort Martha and Mary. Because Jerusalem was near it was possible for people to come from there to comfort them. It may be natural to indicate this connection. For example:

so (NET)

many of the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to people who lived in Judea, the area where Bethany and Jerusalem were. The word does not just refer to Jesus' opponents as it has before (including 11:8a). The mention of Jerusalem being near Bethany could imply

that these Jews were from Jerusalem. Refer to these people in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

many of the people (NLT)

many Judeans (GNT)

many of the Jewish people of the region (NET)

many people had come from the city (CEV)

had come to Martha and Mary: These people traveled from Jerusalem or the area to Bethany to see Lazarus' sisters, Martha and Mary. It is likely that Martha was older than Mary and that is why her name is first.

to console them: The verb console refers to comforting someone who is mourning because a loved one died. These people came to mourn with the sisters and give them comfort and encouragement. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to offer them sympathy

in the loss of their brother: This phrase here means "about their brother Lazarus' death." In many languages it may be natural to indicate that their brother had died. For example:

about their brother's death (GNT)

over the loss of their brother (NET)

because their brother had died (CEV)

John 11:20

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:20a

So when Martha heard that Jesus was coming,

- ¶ When Martha heard the news that Jesus was coming to Bethany,
- ¶ People told Martha, "Jesus will soon be here." So

Martha heard that Jesus was coming: Martha heard someone say that Jesus was on the way to Bethany. Possibly someone told her directly, or possibly she heard other people talking to each other. The phrase does not indicate how she heard.

Jesus was coming: Jesus was on the way to Bethany but had not yet arrived. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Jesus was on his way (REB)

In some languages it is more natural to say where Jesus was coming to. For example:

Jesus was coming to the village of Bethany

11:20b

she went out to meet Him;

- she went to meet him,
- she went out of the house/village to greet him.

she went out to meet Him: Martha left her house and went out of the village to where she hoped to find Jesus. Here is another way to translate this expression:

she went and met him (NRSV)

11:20c

but Mary stayed at home.

- but Mary stayed behind at home.
- However her sister Mary stayed sitting in her house.

but: This word contrasts the fact that Martha went out to meet Jesus with the fact that Mary stayed in the house.

Mary stayed at home: Mary remained in the house where they lived. The Greek text more literally says, “Mary was sitting at home.” The custom of that time was for people to sit while they were mourning. Mary was sitting because she was mourning, not because she was lazy. If this is the custom of your culture and will be understood by your readers, you may want to follow the Greek. For example:

Mary remained sitting in the house (NJB)

John 11:21

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:21

Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if You had been here, my brother would not have died.”

- “Lord,” Martha told Jesus, “If you^(sing) had been here with us^(excl), my brother would not have died.
- Martha said to Jesus, “Lord, if only you^(sing) were here! You^(sing) would not have let my brother die!

Lord: The word Lord refers to Jesus. See how you translated this word in 11:3.

if You had been here: The word if here introduces an unfulfilled condition, a possible situation that did not happen. Jesus was not with them earlier, before Lazarus died.

my brother would not have died: This clause implies that if Jesus had been in Bethany, he would have

healed Lazarus. It may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

you would not have let/allowed my brother to die

you would have prevented/saved my brother from dying

John 11:22

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:22

But even now I know that God will give You whatever You ask of Him.”

- However, I know that even now God will answer/grant any request that you^(sing) make.”
- But I know that even at this late time God will do for you^(sing) anything that you ask.”

But: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek texts include a contrast word meaning But. For example:

But (GW) (BSB, NRSV, ESV, NIV, GNT, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, NET, KJV, REB)

1. Other Greek texts do not contain this word and connect to the previous sentence with a word meaning “and.” For example:

And (RSV) (RSV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The earlier and better manuscripts include the word, and most English translations follow this option.

even now: This phrase implies that at that time things were very hard. One might expect that it was too late for Jesus to do anything to help. But this phrase implies that Jesus could still help.

I know that God will give You whatever You ask of Him: This expression shows confidence that God would answer Jesus' prayer. But it is not clear if it implies any specific prayer request. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

I know that God will do anything you ask (CEV)

I know that whatever you ask from God, God will give you (RSV)

John 11:23

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:23

“Your brother will rise again,” Jesus told her.

- Jesus said to Martha, “Your^(sing) brother will rise from the dead.”
- Jesus told Martha, “Your^(sing) brother will live once more.”

Your brother will rise again: This sentence indicates that Lazarus would return to life. It does not indicate whether that would be soon or in the distant future. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Your brother will rise to life. (GNT)

Your brother will come back to life again. (NET)

Your brother will rise and live again. (NCV)

John 11:24

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:24

Martha replied, “I know that he will rise again in the resurrection at the last day.”

- Martha answered, “I know he will rise from the dead at the time when God resurrects/raises all his people at the end of the world.”
- Martha said, “Yes, I know he will live again at the end of the world when God brings back to life all his people.”

I know that he will rise again in the resurrection at the last day: This sentence shows confidence that Lazarus would one day live again. Martha agreed with Jesus about this. But she thought that day was distant,

when the world would end. Many Jews believed that when the world ended all God's people would rise

and live again. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Yes, I know that he will rise again at the time of the resurrection, on the last day.

Certainly he will rise to life at the end of the world, when all the dead will live again.

he will rise again: This phrase means “he will live again.” The pronoun he refers to Lazarus. Martha expected him to become alive again. Use the same expression that you used in 11:23. For example:

he will come back to life again (NET)

in the resurrection: This phrase refers to the time when all God’s people will rise from the dead. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb instead of the noun resurrection. For example:

when all the dead are raised (CEV)

at the last day: This phrase refers to the future time when the world ends and when God judges all people. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

at the end of the world

John 11:25

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:25a

Jesus said to her, “I am the resurrection and the life.”

- Jesus said to Martha, “I am the resurrection. I am also the life.
- Jesus told Martha, “I am the one who restores the dead to life and who gives life.

I am the resurrection and the life: This clause indicates that Jesus is the one who makes dead people live and gives them true life. There is a textual problem here:

1. Most Greek manuscripts say “I am the resurrection and the life.” This is followed by most English translations including the BSB.

(BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, GW, NET, REB, NCV)

1. A few ancient manuscripts do not include the words and the life and just say “I am the resurrection.” For example:

I am the resurrection. (NJB)

(NJB, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with the great majority of Greek manuscripts and English translations. The UBS Greek text gives option (1) a B rating, indicating that there is some degree of doubt.

the resurrection and the life: The words resurrection and life refer to similar but not the same ideas. The word resurrection refers to rising from the dead, probably on the last day. And life refers to eternal, spiritual life. Jesus is the source of all life.

the resurrection: In some languages it may be natural to translate the resurrection using a verb phrase. For example:

I am the one who brings people back to life. (GW)

I am the one who raises the dead to life! (CEV)

the life: This phrase refers to Jesus as the source of all true life. And even more, he is life, so if we have Jesus,

we have life. In some languages it may be natural to say:

I am life itself. (GW)

I am the one who gives life

I cause people to live

I am the source of life

11:25b–26a

Whoever believes in Me will live, even though he dies. And everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die: These sentences can be rather confusing, partly because they seem to repeat the same idea. However, it helps to understand that 11:25b (Whoever believes in Me will live, even though he dies) seems to explain “I am the resurrection.” And then 11:26a (And everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die) explains “I am...the life.”

There is another reason that this sentence is confusing. It is not always clear whether the verbs live and die refer to living/dying physically or spiritually. It seems that Jesus meant, “Those who believe in me, even though they die physically, will come to life again on the last day. And everyone who lives spiritually and believes in me will never die spiritually.” However, see the notes below for other interpretations.

11:25b

Whoever believes in Me will live, even though he dies.

- Those people who trust in me will live, even though they die physically,
- A person who believes in me may die physically, but he will continue to live.

Whoever believes in Me: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Whoever believes in Me is more literally “the one who believes in me.” It refers to anyone and everyone who trusts Jesus. The subject can be singular or plural, whichever is natural in your language. For example:

Anyone who believes in me (NLT)

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the

facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 7:31a, and 7:38a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

has faith in me (CEV)

trusts in me

will live: Scholars interpret this phrase in different ways:

1. Many scholars say that it refers to the resurrection at the end of time. It means “will come to life.”
2. Other scholars say that it refers to eternal, spiritual life. It means “will have eternal life.”

All English translations can be understood either way. It is recommended that you translate live literally so that it can also be understood either way. However, it seems likely that this clause explains “I am the resurrection” in 11:25a. Therefore, if you must choose one of the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). But if a major translation in your area follows interpretation (2), you may follow that. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Everyone who has faith in me will live, even if they die. (CEV)

Anyone who believes in me will live, even after dying. (NLT)

Even if he dies, the one who believes in me will come to life again

Even if someone dies, he will have eternal life if he believes in me

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the phrases in 11:25b. See the examples above for different ways to do that.

even though he dies: This clause refers to physical death. Believers may die in the normal physical way.

John 11:26

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that

Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:26a

And everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die.

- and all who live a life of faith/trust in me will never really die.
- Whoever lives in faith, trusting me, will never die spiritually.

11:26a further explains Jesus' claim in 11:25a, "I am... the life."

everyone who lives and believes in Me will never die: Scholars interpret the word lives in different ways.

1. Most scholars say that it refers to spiritual life.
2. Other scholars say that it refers to physical life.

Nearly all English translations can be understood either way. It is recommended that you translate lives literally so that it can also be understood either way. However, most scholars understand it to refer to spiritual life. So if you must choose one of the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

everyone who lives trusting me will never die

if anyone really lives and believes in me, he will never really die

no one who lives with faith in me will ever die

And everyone who lives because of faith in me will never really die. (CEV)

will never die: The word die here refers to eternal death, the spiritual death that means that one is separated from God. Those people who now live trusting Christ will never be separated from God. They may die physically, but they will never die spiritually and will live with God forever. In some languages it may be possible to indicate that this phrase refers to spiritual rather than physical death. For example:

will never really die (CEV)

11:26b

Do you believe this?"

- Do you^(sing) believe what I just said?"
- Do you^(sing) believe that this is true?"

Do you believe this?: This is a real question. Jesus asked Martha if she believed what he had just said.

John 11:27

Section 11:17–27: Jesus is the resurrection and the life

In this section, Jesus arrived in Bethany, where Lazarus and his sisters lived. His sister Martha came out to greet Jesus, and told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus told her that Lazarus would rise again, but Martha thought that he was talking about the last day. Jesus then told her that he was the resurrection and the life, and that those who believed in him would never die. Martha then said that she believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus told Martha that Lazarus would live again

Those who believe in Jesus will never die

Paragraph 11:20–27

Martha went to meet Jesus and expressed her faith and trust in him.

11:27

"Yes, Lord," she answered, "I believe that You are the Christ, the Son of God, who was to come into the world."

- Martha answered Jesus, "Yes, Lord, I believe that you^(sing) are the Messiah, the Son of God, the one who God/Scriptures say/promise will come into the world."

- Martha replied, “Lord, I really do believe that you^(sing) are the Christ, the Son of God. You are the one we hoped would come into the world.”

“Yes, Lord,” she answered: Martha declared that she did believe what Jesus said about himself. Translate this in a way that indicates strong agreement. For example:

‘I do, Lord,’ she answered. (REB)

Lord: See how you translated this word in 11:3 and 11:21.

I believe that You are the Christ, the Son of God: This clause expresses belief that Jesus was the Christ, the one God chose and appointed to save his people. One of the titles of the Christ was the Son of God.

the Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated literally as the Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” and the two words have the same meaning. The Jews used this title for the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. You may want to include a footnote to explain it. For example:

The word/title “Messiah” refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send to save his people. It means the same as “the Christ.”

See how you translated Christ in 1:41, 4:25, 7:26, 41.

the Son of God: The phrase the Son of God is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the Son of God at 1:34 and 11:4. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

who was to come into the world: This phrase refers back to God’s earlier promise to send a Savior to the world. The prophets had written about the coming of this Messiah. See 4:25 and 6:14. Now this Savior had come, and he was Jesus. Consider what verb form is natural in this situation. English translations vary as to whether they use the past or present tense. For example:

who comes into the world (NET)

the one who has come into the world from God (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus was the one the people were waiting for. For example:

You are the one we hoped would come into the world. (CEV)

John 11:28

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:28–31

Martha told Mary that Jesus had come, and Mary went to meet Jesus.

11:28a

After Martha had said this, she went back

- ¶ After saying this, Martha returned home
- ¶ Then after Martha told Jesus that she believed in him, she returned to the house.

After Martha had said this: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as After Martha had said this introduces what happened next. Introduce what Martha did next in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So saying (REB)

After saying this

Then (NLT)

she went back: This clause indicates that Martha returned to their house, where Mary was. It may be

natural to make it clearer where she went back to. For example:

she went back home (GW)

General Comment on 11:28a

In some languages you may want to make it clear whom the pronoun “she” refers to. For example:

And when she had said this, Martha went (NET)

After Martha said this, she went (CEV)

11:28b

and called her sister Mary aside to tell her,

- and spoke to her sister Mary quietly. She said to her,
- She asked her sister Mary to come to her, and then spoke to her in private.

called her sister Mary: This phrase indicates that Martha asked Mary to come to her. It does not in this context mean that she spoke loudly.

her sister Mary: Mary was probably Martha’s younger sister, but this is not stated explicitly. See how you referred to her in 11:1.

aside to tell her: This phrase indicates that Martha talked to Mary alone, quietly. She did that so other people could not hear what she said. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

saying in a low voice (NJB)

taking her aside (REB)

to talk to her alone

11:28c

“The Teacher is here and is asking for you.”

- “The Teacher is here, and he is asking to see you^(sing).”
- “The Teacher has come,” she said. “He wants to talk to you^(sing).”

The Teacher is here: The phrase The Teacher refers to Jesus. Teacher was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach about God. It is the same Greek word that is used to describe Jesus in 3:2. See the note there. It is not the same word translated “Rabbi” in 11:8.

is here: This phrase in this context indicates that Jesus was nearby, just outside the village.

is asking for you: This phrase indicates that Jesus wanted Mary to come to him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

he wants to see you (CEV)

says, “Send Mary to me”

John 11:29

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:28–31

Martha told Mary that Jesus had come, and Mary went to meet Jesus.

11:29

And when Mary heard this, she got up quickly and went to Him.

- When Mary heard this, she stood up quickly and went out to meet him.
- As soon as Mary heard this, she stood up and went to greet Jesus.

And when Mary heard this: This clause introduces what Mary did when she heard that Jesus wanted her to come to him. Introduce this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Hearing this (NJB)

So (NLT)

she got up quickly and went to Him: The words she got up quickly indicate that Mary immediately responded to Jesus’ request. In some languages it may be unnecessary and unnatural to say that she got up

before going to Jesus. It may be possible instead to just say that she went. For example:

Mary immediately went to him. (NLT)

General Comment on 11:29

The CEV indicates that Mary acted immediately by using the phrase “as soon as” with the clause “she/ Mary heard this.” In some languages it may be natural to follow this example:

As soon as Mary heard this, she got up and went to Jesus. (CEV)

John 11:30

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:28–31

Martha told Mary that Jesus had come, and Mary went to meet Jesus.

11:30a

Now Jesus had not yet entered the village,

- Jesus had not yet entered the village of Bethany,
- Jesus was still just outside Bethany village,

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information. In this context it is not a time word. The NET and GNT place all of 11:30 in parentheses. You should indicate that this is background information in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus had not yet entered the village: This clause indicates that Jesus had not already arrived in Bethany, the home of Martha and Mary. He was probably just outside the village. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He was still outside the village (CEV)

11:30b

but was still at the place where Martha had met Him.

- but he was still where Martha met him.
- at the same place where Martha talked with him.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (11:30a) to a positive statement (11:30b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Jesus had not yet entered the village; instead he was still where Martha had met him.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Jesus had not yet arrived in the village. He was still where Martha met him.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Jesus was still where Martha had met him and had not yet entered the village.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

was still at the place where Martha had met Him:

Jesus had stayed at the place where Martha met him in 11:20.

General Comment on 11:30a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 11:30a as a positive statement. 11:30b will then continue the idea rather than offer a contrast to it. For example:

He was still outside the village where Martha had gone to meet him. (CEV)

Jesus had stayed outside the village, at the place where Martha met him. (NLT)

John 11:31

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:28–31

Martha told Mary that Jesus had come, and Mary went to meet Jesus.

11:31a

When the Jews who were in the house consoling Mary

- The Jewish people who were comforting Mary in the house
- Many people were in Mary's house to give/express their sympathy to her.

When the Jews who were in the house consoling Mary: These words identify the subject of the word “saw” in 11:31b. They are the same Jews who were mentioned in 11:19. Refer back to them in a way that is clear and natural in your language. For example:

the people who were with Mary in the house
consoling her (NET)

The Jews who were comforting Mary in the house
(GW)

This verse returns to the story after the background information in 11:30. So you might want to use the name Mary, as the BSB does, instead of the pronoun “her,” as the Greek does. See the examples above and below to see how you might do that.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause rather than using a who clause. For example

The Jews were with Mary in the house, comforting her. (NCV)

Many people had come to comfort Mary, and when... (CEV)

the Jews: This phrase refers to the people who came to comfort the sisters. They were local people, while most of Jesus' disciples were from Galilee. These Jews were from the province of Judea, possibly Jerusalem. See how you referred to them in 11:19. For example:

the people (GNT)

in the house: This phrase refers to Martha and Mary's house.

consoling Mary: The word consoling indicates that these people were comforting and encouraging Mary. It is the same word that is used in 11:19.

11:31b

saw how quickly she got up and went out,

- noticed how fast she went out.
- They saw her suddenly get up and leave the house,

saw how quickly she got up and went out: The ones who were comforting Mary saw her leave the house. See how you translated a similar phrase in 11:29.

11:31c

they followed her,

- They followed her out of the house,
- and they followed behind her.

they followed her: The Jews from Judea who came to comfort Mary left the house when she did.

11:31d

supposing she was going to the tomb to mourn there.

- thinking/assuming that she was going to the tomb to mourn there.
- They thought, “She must be going to her brother's tomb to cry/mourn there.”

supposing she was going to the tomb to mourn there: Verse 11:31d explains why the Jews who were comforting Mary followed her out of the house. They wrongly thought that she was going to mourn at Lazarus' tomb. Here are other ways to translate 11:31d:

thinking she was going to the tomb to cry there
(NCV)

they assumed she was going to Lazarus' grave to weep (NLT)

the tomb: The word tomb refers to a place where the Jews buried people. Here it refers to a cave with a stone placed over the opening. John will make this clear in verse 38 so you do not need to explain it here. However, you will need to translate tomb with a word or phrase that could refer to a cave. See how you translated the word in 11:17, where the same word is used. In the languages of cultures that do not use tombs, it may be natural to describe what a tomb was. For example:

They thought she was going to the place where her brother was buried.

to mourn: This phrase indicates Mary's purpose in going to Lazarus' tomb. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in order to weep

because she wanted to weep

there: This word refers to the place where Lazarus was buried, his tomb.

General Comment on 11:31d

In some languages it may be natural to translate what the people thought as direct speech. For example:

They thought, "She/Mary must be going to weep at her brother's tomb."

General Comment on 11:31

In the Greek text 11:31 forms one long sentence, as in the BSB. In many languages it may be natural to translate this verse as two or more sentences. For example:

The Jews who were comforting Mary in the house saw her get up quickly and leave. So they followed her. They thought that she was going to the tomb to cry. (GW)

John 11:32

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:32–35

Mary met with Jesus and spoke to him about her grief, as Martha had done.

11:32a

When Mary came to Jesus and saw Him,

- ¶ When Mary reached the place where Jesus was and saw him, (NIV)
- ¶ Mary went to where Jesus was. When she saw him,

The Greek text connects this sentence to the previous sentence with a conjunction that indicates a return to the main story. Mary got up and went to Jesus in 11:29 and here in 11:32a she arrived where Jesus was. (11:30 gave background information about Jesus and 11:31 told what the ones who comforted Mary did.) Many English translations leave this conjunction untranslated. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

Then

Indicate a return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

When Mary came to Jesus and saw Him: Verse 11:32a introduces the time and place of the next event in the story. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

When Mary reached the place where Jesus was and saw him (NIV)

Mary came to the place where Jesus was, and as soon as she saw him (REB)

When Mary arrived and saw Jesus (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate some of this information as a separate sentence. For example:

But Mary went to the place where Jesus was. When she saw him (NCV)

11:32b she fell at His feet

- she fell at his feet to respect/honor him
- she knelt down at his feet.

she fell at His feet: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as she fell at His feet indicates that Mary reacted to seeing Jesus by showing him great respect. She honored him by quickly kneeling on the ground in front of him. For example:

she honored Jesus by kneeling at his feet

she threw herself at his feet (NJB)

11:32c and said, “Lord, if You had been here, my brother would not have died.”

- and said, “Lord, if you^(sing) had been here with us^(excl), my brother would not have died.”
- She said, “Lord, if only you^(sing) were here! You^(sing) would not have let my brother die!”

and said: The Greek more literally says “saying to him,” and continues the sentence. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here:

She said to him/Jesus

Lord: This word indicates that Mary honored Jesus. See how you translated this word in 11:3 and 11:21, and use the same expression here.

if You had been here, my brother would not have died: Mary said the same thing to Jesus that Martha had said in 11:21. Like Martha, Mary wished that Jesus had come to their house earlier. She knew that Jesus could and would have healed Lazarus. Translate this sentence the same way here and in 11:21. This sentence refers to something that could have happened but did not happen. Jesus did not come earlier, and Lazarus died.

John 11:33

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:32–35

Mary met with Jesus and spoke to him about her grief, as Martha had done.

11:33a

When Jesus saw her weeping,

- When Jesus saw her crying,
- Jesus saw that Mary was wailing,

When Jesus saw her weeping: Mary was crying and wailing, following the Jewish custom at funerals. You may want to use the words describing how people in your culture mourn at a grave.

11:33b

and the Jews who had come with her also weeping,

- and the people who had come with her crying also,
- and her comforters were wailing too,

and the Jews: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Jews refers to the people from Judea who came to Bethany to comfort Mary. See how you referred to them in 11:19 and 11:31a.

who had come with her: This phrase refers to the fact that these people left the house in Bethany and went outside the village with Mary.

11:33c

He was deeply moved in spirit and troubled.

- he was terribly upset in spirit and suffered grief/distress.
- and he became very distressed in his spirit and greatly disturbed.

He was deeply moved in spirit and troubled: The words was deeply moved in spirit and troubled together indicate that Jesus experienced emotional distress.

He was deeply moved in spirit: The Greek word that the BSB translates as deeply moved is an unusual word. That makes it hard to know exactly what it means. However, it refers to some kind of thinking or emotion that is bad (where “bad” does not mean “evil,” but “not happy”). As a result, English translations use a variety of ways to translate this clause. For example:

he was greatly disturbed in spirit (NRSV)

he was terribly upset (CEV)

a deep anger welled up within him (NLT)

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

his mind/thinking became bad with grief/anger

he felt distressed in his spirit

in spirit: The phrase in spirit here mean “in himself.” In this context the word spirit refers to Jesus’ inner being, the source of his emotions.

and troubled: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as troubled means feeling distress or being disturbed or upset. For example:

and terribly upset (GNT)

and he felt great distress

General Comment on 11:33a–c

The sorrow that Jesus saw in 11:33a–b caused him the emotional pain and distress mentioned in 11:33c. There are several ways this connection can be made clear in translation. For example:

Seeing Mary weeping, and the people with her weeping, Jesus became very upset and felt great distress.

At the sight of Mary and the people with her weeping, Jesus felt anger and mental suffering.

Jesus saw Mary and the people with her all weeping. This caused him to be upset and anxious.

General Comment on 11:33c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the meaning of the two phrases “deeply moved in spirit” and “troubled.” For example:

his spirit was greatly distressed

he was troubled with anger in his spirit

John 11:34

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and

wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:32–35

Mary met with Jesus and spoke to him about her grief, as Martha had done.

11:34a

“Where have you put him?” He asked.

- “Where have you^(plur) placed/buried him?” he asked.
- He asked them, “Where did you^(plur) put his/the body?”

Where have you put him?: Jesus asked where Lazarus’ tomb was. He probably asked Martha and Mary because Mary last spoke and the ones who answer in 11:34b call him “Lord.” The mourners had placed Lazarus’ body in a cave tomb. It was not the custom to bury bodies underground. See 11:17. If you use a word meaning “buried,” check that people will not think that Lazarus was placed under the ground. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Where did you put Lazarus? (GW)

Where have you put his body? (CEV)

He asked: This phrase introduces a question Jesus asked the mourners. In some languages it is more natural to say:

he asked them (NLT)

11:34b

“Come and see, Lord,” they answered.

- “Come^(sing) with us^(excl) and see, Lord,” they replied.
- The sisters said, “Lord, come^(sing) and we^(excl) will show you^(sing).”

Come and see: The word Come here implies “come with us^(excl).” The sisters wanted to take Jesus with them to the place where Lazarus was buried.

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is the same as in 11:3b, 11:21, and 11:32c. Translate it the same way in all these verses.

they answered: The pronoun they probably refers to the sisters Martha and Mary. Here is another way to translate this expression:

The sisters answered him

John 11:35

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:32–35

Mary met with Jesus and spoke to him about her grief, as Martha had done.

11:35

Jesus wept.

- Jesus cried. (NCV)
- At this, tears came/fell from his/Jesus' eyes.

Jesus wept: This sentence indicates that Jesus cried and produced tears. The Greek word here that the BSB translates as wept is not the same one used in 11:33. It does not refer to loud wailing. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Jesus started crying (CEV)

Jesus cried. (NCV)

Jesus cried with tears.

John 11:36

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:36–37

The mourners who were present saw how much Jesus had loved Lazarus. Some of them wondered why Jesus did not heal Lazarus.

11:36

Then the Jews said, “See how He loved him!”

- ¶ Then the people from Judea said to each other, “You^(plur) can see how much Jesus loved Lazarus.”
- ¶ The people/mourners then said, “Jesus certainly loved Lazarus very much!”

Then: This word introduces the result of Jesus' tears, so many English versions translate this word as “So.”

the Jews said: The phrase the Jews refers to the people who had come to comfort Mary and Martha. These are the same Jews that were mentioned in 11:19, 31 and 33. They spoke to each other. For example:

The Judeans said to one another...

See how He loved him!: This clause is a command. It gives the statement emphasis. The people were saying that Jesus had loved Lazarus very much. They saw his tears and realized that he had loved Lazarus. There are two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a command. For example:

See how much he loved him! (GNT)

See how much he loved Lazarus. (CEV)

- Use a strong statement. For example:

You can see that he loved Lazarus a lot.

Jesus certainly loved Lazarus.

John 11:37

Section 11:28–37: Jesus wept

In this section, Mary came out to greet Jesus. She also told him that if he had been there, Lazarus would still be alive. Jesus saw her weeping and was disturbed and wept himself. Some said that that showed his love for Lazarus. But others wondered why he did not heal him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus saw Mary crying and cried himself

Mary went to meet Jesus

Paragraph 11:36–37

The mourners who were present saw how much Jesus had loved Lazarus. Some of them wondered why Jesus did not heal Lazarus.

11:37a

But some of them asked, “Could not this man who opened the eyes of the blind

- But some of the Jewish leaders said, “This man made a blind man able to see.
- But some of them said, “He healed a blind man,

11:37b

also have kept Lazarus from dying?”

- He surely could have prevented/saved Lazarus from dying.”
- so he should have been able to heal Lazarus.”

11:37a–b

But: The word But introduces a contrast. Some of the Jews reacted to Jesus with criticism instead of sympathy.

some of them asked: The words some of refers to some of the Jewish mourners.

Could not this man who opened the eyes of the blind also have kept Lazarus from dying?: This is a rhetorical question. It says that Jesus could have kept Lazarus from dying. It also expresses doubt and criticism.

The people wondered why Jesus did not heal Lazarus if he loved him. They accepted that Jesus healed the blind man, and they thought that he could have healed Lazarus too. They wondered why he did not do so. They implied that either his power was limited or he did not really love Lazarus.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Couldn't this man who gave a blind man sight keep Lazarus from dying? (GW)

- Use a statement. For example:

This man healed a man born blind and so he should have been able to keep Lazarus from dying.

this man who opened the eyes of the blind: This phrase refers to Jesus and what he did in John 9:1–38.

also have kept Lazarus from dying: This phrase refers to healing Lazarus so that he would not die. In some languages it may be natural to translate this in a positive way. For example:

saved Lazarus's life

healed Lazarus so that he would not die

General Comment on 11:37a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse as two sentences. They may be rhetorical questions or statements. For example:

He gave sight to the blind man, didn't he? Could he not have kept Lazarus from dying? (GNT)

This man healed a blind man. Why couldn't he keep Lazarus from dying? (NLT)

This man healed the blind man. He surely could have saved Lazarus' life if he had wanted to.

John 11:38

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God's glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God's glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:38a**Jesus, once again deeply moved, came to the tomb.**

- ¶ Jesus, once more terribly upset, came to the tomb.
- ¶ Jesus was again very distressed. He reached the tomb,

Jesus, once again deeply moved, came to the tomb:

Again Jesus experienced emotional distress. See how you translated the same phrase deeply moved in 11:33c. For example:

Again feeling very upset (NCV)

came to the tomb: This phrase indicates that Jesus approached the cave where Lazarus was buried. See the note on “the tomb” at 11:17.

11:38b**It was a cave with a stone laid across the entrance.**

- The tomb was a cave with a stone laid across the entrance.
- which was a cave with a large round stone over the entrance.

It was a cave: The word *It* refers to the tomb or place where the body of Lazarus was lying. Lazarus was buried in a cave, a hole in a hill. This was the traditional and usual way for the Jews to bury their dead at that time.

a stone laid across the entrance: This clause indicates that a stone covered the entrance. For example:

with a stone covering the entrance (GW)

with a stone placed at the entrance (GNT)

a stone: This phrase here refers to a large (1.5–2 meters across) round flat rock in the shape of a coin. Men had rolled this stone in front of the entrance to the cave. The stone leaned against the cave entrance, closing it. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

a large stone (NCV)

John 11:39**Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life**

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God’s glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God’s glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:39a**“Take away the stone,” Jesus said.**

- Jesus said, “Remove the stone from the entrance.
- Jesus said, “Open up the grave.”

Take away the stone: This is a command. Jesus commanded some of the men to remove the stone from the entrance to the cave. Here are other ways to translate this command:

Move the stone away (NCV)

Then he told the people to roll the stone away.
(CEV)

11:39b**“Lord, by now he stinks,” said Martha, the sister of the dead man.**

- Martha, the dead man’s sister, said to Jesus, “Lord, by this time it/he must smell bad,
- Martha, Lazarus’ sister, spoke. “Lord, by now there must be a bad smell

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Lord* means “master.” It was a word used to address someone with respect. See how you translated this in 11:3b and 11:21.

by now he stinks: This clause refers to the fact that by this time the body had a bad smell. This implies that it was not a good idea to roll away the stone. Translate this in a way that would be natural under these circumstances. For example:

by now he will smell (NJB)

There will be a bad smell. (NCV)

The smell will be terrible. (NLT)

His body will already have a bad smell.

he stinks: The Greek words that the BSB translates literally as he stinks means “he has a bad smell.” The words he stinks sound both funny and not polite in English. It is important to express this in a way that is both natural and polite, suitable for reading aloud in church.

said Martha, the sister of the dead man: Martha spoke up and protested against Jesus’ command. The text does not say, but it appears from her behavior that Martha was older than Lazarus and Mary. If you need to say whether she was older or younger than Lazarus, you can say that she was older.

11:39c

“It has already been four days.”

- because he has been buried four days.”
- since he died four days ago.”

It has already been four days: This clause begins with a Greek conjunction that is often translated as “for” or “because.” This conjunction introduces the reason that there was a bad smell. A body starts to decompose (rot or decay) before the fourth day, especially in hot weather. The BSB omits this conjunction because the connection is clear in English without it. Consider how you might introduce this clause naturally in your language.

General Comment on 11:39b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 11:39b–c. For example:

There will be a bad smell, Lord. He has been buried four days! (GNT)

John 11:40

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God’s glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God’s glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:40a–b

Jesus replied: This phrase indicates that Jesus responded to Martha. For example:

Jesus answered

Did I not tell you that if you believed, you would see the glory of God?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it for emphasis. He was saying that he did tell Martha that if she believed, she would see the glory of God.

This rhetorical question works as a mild rebuke. Jesus rebuked Martha for not completely trusting him. He reminded her of something he said earlier.

There are two ways of translating this rebuke.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Didn’t I tell you that if you believe, you would see God’s glory? (GW)

Didn’t I tell you that you will see God’s glory if you believe? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

I told you that if you believed, you would see God’s glory.

You should remember what I told you, that if you believe you will see God’s glory.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is natural in your language.

11:40a

Jesus replied, “Did I not tell you that if you believed,

- Then Jesus said to her, “I told you^(sing) that if you believed,
- Then Jesus said to Martha, “Remember that I told you^(sing) to believe/trust me. If you do believe/trust me,

Did I not tell you: The word you is singular and refers to Martha.

if you believed: This is a condition that could be fulfilled: Martha could have faith. The BSB translates

this using the past tense (believed) because Jesus had said this earlier. But it was still a present possibility. In many languages it may be more natural to use the present tense. For example:

if you believe (NLT)

if you have faith (REB)

believed: When the word “believe” is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying “believe in Jesus.” So this word includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

would believe in me

trusted in me

11:40b

you would see the glory of God?”

- you^(sing) would see how glorious/great God is.”
- you^(sing) will see that God is very/most wonderful/great.”

you would see the glory of God?: This clause states what will happen if the condition (if Martha believes Jesus) is fulfilled. Martha will see the glory and greatness of God. God will show her his amazing power. If you use a present tense for “believe,” you may need to use a future tense for see. For example:

if you believe you will see the glory of God (NJB)

the glory of God: In this context this phrase refers to the power or greatness of God. For example:

the wonder of what God can do (JBP)

how powerful God is (TH)

how great/wonderful God is

General Comment on 11:40

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in this verse. For example:

Jesus responded, “Didn’t I tell you that you would see God’s glory if you believe?” (NLT)

John 11:41

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God’s glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God’s glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:41a

So they took away the stone.

- So they removed the stone.
- So they pushed/rolled away the stone from the entrance of/to the tomb/cave.

So: This word introduces what happens next. It is also the result of Jesus saying in 11:39a, “Take away the stone.” Most English translations use the word So, though some do not translate this word. Here is another way to translate it:

Then (REB)

they took away the stone: The word they does not refer to a specific noun mentioned earlier. However, it probably refers to some of the men that were there to comfort Martha and Mary. They removed the stone that was in front of the cave where Lazarus was buried. See how you translated stone in 11:38. In some languages you may need to include more information about where the stone was. For example:

they moved the stone away from the entrance (NCV)

the stone was moved away from the entrance of the tomb (GW)

some men rolled the stone away from the entrance of the cave

11:41b

Then Jesus lifted His eyes upward and said, “Father, I thank You that You have heard Me.

- ¶ Then Jesus looked to heaven and said, “Father, I thank you^(sing) that you heard me.
- ¶ Then Jesus looked up to God and prayed, “My Father, thank you^(sing) for listening to me.

Then: This word introduces the next thing that happened. Jesus prayed to God his Father. Some English translations do not translate this word. Here is another way to translate this word:

Then (NJB)

Jesus lifted His eyes upward: This clause indicates that Jesus looked up to heaven, to God. The Jews often looked up when they prayed. In some languages it may be natural to say this explicitly.

said: This word introduces Jesus’ prayer to God. In some languages it is more natural to say:

prayed (CEV)

Father: Jesus prayed to God. The word Father refers to God. In some languages it is more natural to have a possessive pronoun before the word Father. For example:

My Father

I thank You that You have heard Me: Jesus thanked God that God had heard his prayer for Lazarus and, it is implied, would answer it. In some languages it may be possible to make this implication clearer. For example:

I thank you for listening to me

John 11:42

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God’s glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God’s glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus’ tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:42a

I knew that You always hear Me,

- I know that you^(sing) hear me always,
- I have known that you^(sing) always listen to me.

I knew that You always hear Me: The words I and Me refer to Jesus. The word You refers to God the Father.

I knew: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun I to contrast it with “for the sake of the crowd” in 11:42b. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as knew means that Jesus always knew that God always heard him. In many languages a continuous form of the verb is more natural. For example:

I’ve known that you always hear me (GW)

I know that you always answer my prayers. (CEV)

that You always hear Me: The verb hear again means to listen and respond to someone. God always listened and responded to Jesus.

11:42b

but I say this for the benefit of the people standing here,

- but I said this for the benefit of the people standing here watching,
- However, I said this so that the people who are standing here can hear

but: In Greek the word but introduces a strong contrast. Jesus did not thank God in 11:41b for his own benefit but for the benefit of the crowd.

I say this: These words refer to Jesus’ prayer in 11:41b. Jesus prayed aloud so that the people could hear him. Here is another way to translate these words:

I said it out loud (NLT)

for the benefit of the people standing here: The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast it with the pronoun “I” in 11:42a. Jesus did not thank God in 11:41b for his own benefit but for the benefit of the crowd. The phrase the people standing here refers to

all the people who were present at Lazarus' tomb. Jesus wanted them to hear his prayer and realize that God's power was working through him.

11:42c

so they may believe that You sent Me.”

- that they might believe that you^(sing) sent me here.”
- and believe that you^(sing) sent me to them.”

so they may believe that You sent Me: The word so introduces the purpose of the prayer and the miracle. Their purpose was to cause the people there to believe that God had sent Jesus into the world. The word they refers to the crowd that Jesus mentioned in 11:42b.

You sent Me: The Greek text emphasizes the word You in this clause. Jesus wanted the people to believe that God the Father was the one who sent Jesus to earth. For example:

it was you who sent me (NJB)

You were the one who sent me

John 11:43

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God's glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God's glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:43

After Jesus had said this, He called out in a loud voice, “Lazarus, come out!”

- After he said this, Jesus called out in a loud voice, “Lazarus, come^(sing) out!”
- After that Jesus shouted, “Lazarus! Leave^(sing) your tomb!”

After Jesus had said this: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as After Jesus had said this indicates that Jesus had finished his prayer. For example:

When Jesus had finished praying (CEV)

He called out in a loud voice: These words indicates that Jesus shouted or called out loudly. For example:

he shouted as loudly as he could (GW)

Lazarus, come out!: This sentence commands Lazarus to become alive and come out of the tomb. Jesus' command made this possible. It caused the act that it commanded to happen. In some languages it may be more natural to say where he was to come out from. For example:

Lazarus, come out of that tomb!

John 11:44

Section 11:38–44: Jesus raised Lazarus to life

In this section Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb. He ordered that someone remove the stone from the opening of the cave where Lazarus was buried. Martha worried about the bad smell, but Jesus reminded her that if she believed, she would see God's glory. Jesus prayed and called Lazarus to come out, which he did.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead

God's glory was revealed when Jesus brought Lazarus back from the dead

Paragraph 11:38–44

Jesus went to Lazarus' tomb and called to him to come out. Lazarus obeyed and came out of his tomb alive.

11:44a

The man who had been dead came out

- The man who had died came out of the cave/tomb.
- And Lazarus, who had been dead, left his tomb.

The man who had been dead came out: The phrase The man who had been dead refers to Lazarus, who was dead until Jesus called him. Now he was alive. In some languages it may be natural to say:

Lazarus, who had been dead

came out: This phrase indicates that Lazarus walked out of his tomb (his burial cave).

11:44b
with his hands and feet bound in strips of linen,

- His hands and feet were wrapped in/with strips of linen,
- Strips of cloth still tied his hands and feet,

with his hands and feet bound in strips of linen:

This phrase indicates that Lazarus was still wearing the cloth strips that someone wound around his body when he died. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his hands and feet tied up with strips of cloth
 (NET)

His hands and feet were wrapped with strips of
 burial cloth (CEV)

The Greek word that the BSB translates as bound is a passive verb. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. The subject may be either his hands and feet or strips of linen. For example:

his hands and feet wrapped in grave cloths (GNT)

Strips of cloth were wound around his feet and
 hands (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the cloth strips still covered his hands and feet

the cloth strips were still around/on his hands
 and feet

strips of linen: The Greek word that the BSB translates as strips of linen refers to long pieces of linen cloth. They were wrapped around a dead body before it was buried. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

linen bandages (REB)

grave cloths (GNT)

burial cloths

11:44c
and his face wrapped in a cloth.

- and a cloth covered his face.
- and there was a cloth around his face.

and his face wrapped in a cloth: This phrase indicates that Lazarus' face was also covered with a piece of cloth. The verb wrapped is passive. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

his face was wrapped with a handkerchief (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

a cloth covered his face (CEV)

- Leave the verb implied. For example:

a cloth around his face (NIV)

a cloth: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a cloth refers to a face cloth. It was a piece of cloth that a man often wore around his neck to absorb sweat. Use the expression that is natural in your language for such a cloth. For example:

a handkerchief (GW)

11:44d
“Unwrap him and let him go,” Jesus told them.

- Jesus said to them, “Remove^(plur) his grave cloths so he can go free.”
- “Release/Free^(plur) him from his grave cloths,” Jesus told the people. “Allow^(plur) him to walk around.”

Unwrap him and let him go: Jesus commanded the people there to Unwrap (untie) the grave cloths from Lazarus so that he could walk freely. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Free Lazarus, and let him go. (GW)

Take the cloth off of him and let him go. (NCV)

and let him go: The word and connects Jesus command to take off the grave clothes and the result of that action, moving freely. It may be natural to say:

so that he can go

Jesus told them: These words introduce what Jesus told the people who were present at Lazarus' tomb.

John 11:45

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:45–48

The Jews from Judea responded in different ways to the miracle that they just saw. Some believed, and others reported it to the Jewish authorities. The authorities discussed the matter in their council.

11:45a

Therefore many of the Jews who had come to Mary,

- ¶ Therefore many of the Jewish people who had come to visit/comfort Mary,
- ¶ As a result, many of the people from Judea who were there to comfort Mary,

Therefore: This word introduces what many people did as a result of the miracle that they saw.

many of the Jews: This phrase refers to many of the people who had come from Judea (possibly Jerusalem). Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Many of the people (CEV)

who had come to Mary: There are two ways to interpret the Greek phrase that the BSB translates as who had come to Mary:

1. it means “to Mary,” or “to visit Mary.” For example:

who had come to visit Mary (GNT) (BSB, GNT, NCV, KJV, NASB, ESV, NIV, REB, NJB, GW, CEV)

1. it means “together with Mary.” For example:

who had come with Mary (RSV) (RSV, NRSV, ESV, NET, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), together with most English translations. The author probably referred to what he wrote in 11:19, that people came from Jerusalem (or other parts of Judea) to comfort the sisters. Here, however, he just mentions Mary.

11:45b

and had seen what Jesus did, believed in Him.

- and had seen the miracle that Jesus did, believed in him.
- saw Jesus raise Lazarus from the dead and put their faith in Jesus.

and: This word here introduces another description of these Jewish people. These people saw the miracle.

had seen what Jesus did: This phrase indicates that these people saw Jesus bring Lazarus back to life again. They were at the tomb and saw what happened.

what Jesus did: There is a textual problem here. The Greek word that the BSB translates as what is plural in some manuscripts and singular in others. It is recommended that you use a word that can be understood in either way, as most English translations do. The original text probably had the plural form. The UBS Greek New Testament gives the plural form a B rating, indicating that this was the probable text. See the UBS Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament, 3rd edition, page 235. but the main reference is to the specific act of raising Lazarus.

believed in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 2:11c, and 3:16b. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

put their faith in him (CEV)

became believers

John 11:46

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:45–48

The Jews from Judea responded in different ways to the miracle that they just saw. Some believed, and others reported it to the Jewish authorities. The authorities discussed the matter in their council.

11:46a

But some of them went to the Pharisees

- But some of those people went to the Pharisees
- However, some others of them went and reported to the religious leaders, the Pharisees,

But: The word But introduces a contrast. While some people who saw the miracle believed, others reported what happened to the Pharisees. They were opposed to Jesus.

some of them went to the Pharisees: The phrase some of them refers to some of the Jewish people from Judea. They were not among the “many” Jewish people who believed in Jesus (11:45a). These Jews

reported what Jesus did to the Pharisees. These Pharisees had not been there and were opposed to Jesus.

the Pharisees: The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Transliterate the word Pharisees according to the sounds of your language and indicate that it refers to people. For example:

Farisi members

Parise adherents

- Transliterate the word Pharisees and indicate that it refers to a group of people with certain beliefs. For example:

people belonging to the Farise religious group

members of the religious group called the Farasi

See how you translated this in 1:24 and see the note there.

11:46b

and told them what Jesus had done.

- and told them what Jesus did.
- that Jesus brought/raised someone back from the dead.

told them what Jesus had done: The people who went to the Pharisees told the Pharisees that Jesus had raised Lazarus from the dead. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

reported what he had done (REB)

told them about Jesus' actions/deeds

what Jesus had done: The Greek text here uses the plural form for what (“what things”), but it mainly refers to Jesus' raising of Lazarus. See how you translated “what Jesus did” in 11:45b.

General Comment on 11:46

In some languages it may be natural to use direct speech for what these people told the Pharisees. If you do that, it may be necessary to supply information about what Jesus did. For example:

and told them, “Jesus has raised a man from the dead.”

John 11:47

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus’ death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:45–48

The Jews from Judea responded in different ways to the miracle that they just saw. Some believed, and others reported it to the Jewish authorities. The authorities discussed the matter in their council.

11:47a

Then the chief priests and Pharisees convened the Sanhedrin

- Then the chief priests and the Pharisees called a council meeting.
- Then the leading priests and Pharisees gathered the council to meet together

Then: This word introduces the result of the people reporting Jesus’ miracle to the Pharisees, so many English versions translate it as “So.”

the chief priests and Pharisees convened the Sanhedrin: The chief priests and Pharisees were the leading Jewish authorities. These religious leaders announced there would be a council meeting and told all the other council members to come. Here is another way to translate this clause:

the chief priests and the Pharisees called the council together (NET)

It is implied that after they called the council meeting, the meeting actually took place. You may want to make that explicit. For example:

the Pharisees and chief priests met with the Council (GNT)

the chief priests: This phrase refers to the most important of the Jewish priests, the leading priests. These men were important religious authorities, members of the main council of the Jews. These priests were usually not Pharisees but members of a different religious group, the Sadducees. See how you translated this phrase in 7:32. For example:

the leading priests (NCV)

Pharisees: This phrase refers to a Jewish group that emphasized the importance of following the law literally and exactly. See the note on 11:46a and how you translated the word there.

Sanhedrin: The Greek word the BSB translated literally as Sanhedrin refers to the court with the highest authority over the Jews. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

the high council (NLT)

the Jewish council (NCV)

11:47b

and said, “What are we to do?”

- “What should we^(incl) do?” they asked each other.
- and discussed what they should do.

and said: These words introduce what the chief priests and Pharisees said to the other members of the council. Because the words that follow are a question, you may say:

they asked each other (NLT)

What are we to do?: There are two ways to interpret this question:

1. It is a real question. It says that they are not sure what to do. The speakers were asking for advice. For example:

What should we do? (NCV) (BSB, NLT, NCV, RSV, NRSV, ESV, GNT, CEV)

1. It is a rhetorical question. It says that the religious leaders were disappointed because they had not been able to stop Jesus. It seems that they are doing nothing, at least nothing that is effective. The rhetorical question implies that they are doing nothing. For example:

What are we doing? (NASB) (NJB, NASB, NIV, REB, NET, GW)

Either interpretation is possible. You may want to follow the major-language translation used in your area.

we: The pronoun we is inclusive in this context. The speakers from the Jewish leadership were wondering what the whole group should do.

11:47c

This man is performing many signs.

- “This man is certainly doing many miraculous signs.
- They said, “How many miracles this man Jesus is doing!

The Greek text introduces this sentence with a word that is often translated “because.” The meaning here would be, “What should we do because this man is doing many miracles?” Some translations, like the BSB, do not translate this word, but others do. For example:

What are we to do? For this man performs many signs. (ESV)

What can we do then, because that person, he has been doing many amazing things. (Kankanaey Back Translation)

This man is performing many signs: The words This man refer to Jesus. The authorities said that Jesus was performing (doing) many miracles. They admitted this fact. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

This man is doing many miracles. (NCV)

This man is working a lot of miracles. (CEV)

Look at all the miracles this man is performing! (GNT)

John 11:48

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus’ death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:45–48

The Jews from Judea responded in different ways to the miracle that they just saw. Some believed, and others reported it to the Jewish authorities. The authorities discussed the matter in their council.

11:48a

If we let Him go on like this, everyone will believe in Him,

- If we^(incl) let him continue to work miracles, everyone will believe in him,
- If we^(incl) do not stop him, all the people will trust in him.

If we let Him go on like this: The word If introduces a real possibility. It suggests a possibility that the speakers did not like nor approve of. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If we allow him to go on in this way (NET)

If we don’t stop him now (CEV)

we: This word refers to the council of Jewish leaders. It is inclusive, as the leaders were talking among themselves.

let Him go on like this: This phrase refers to allowing Jesus to continue doing miracles. The speakers did not approve of what Jesus was doing. You may want to make it clearer what like this means. For example:

let him continue doing these things (NCV)

everyone will believe in Him: This clause is an exaggeration. The speakers were afraid that many or most of the Jewish people would believe that Jesus was the Messiah.

will believe in Him: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. Here the council was probably worried that people would believe that Jesus was the Messiah and follow him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 2:11c, and 11:45b. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

will put their faith in him (CEV)

will become believers

11:48b

and then the Romans will come and take away both our place and our nation.”

- and then the Roman soldiers will come and remove both our^(incl) temple and our^(incl) nation.”
- Then the Roman army will come and remove our^(incl) temple and our^(incl) country from us^(incl).”

the Romans will come: This clause means that the Roman army would come in force and enter Israel. The clause implies that first Jesus would cause his followers to rebel against the Romans. Then the Romans would come to defeat that rebellion. The Romans were already ruling Israel, but they gave the Jewish people some privileges and freedoms.

the Romans: This phrase in this context refers to the Roman army. For example:

the Roman authorities (GNT)

the Roman army (NLT)

the Roman rulers will send soldiers

take away both our place and our nation: The speakers feared that the Romans would ruin the country. They would destroy the temple and take away the rights of the nation.

take away: There are two ways to interpret the word that the BSB translates as take away here:

1. It means “remove” or take away. (BSB, NIV, NASB, NET, ESV, KJV, GW, NCV)
2. It means “destroy.” For example:

the Roman authorities will take action and destroy our Temple and our nation! (GNT) (GNT, NLT, CEV, RSV, NRSV)

In addition, REB translates this word as “sweep away,” which can mean either “remove” or “destroy.” And NJB translates it as “suppress,” which means “stop” or “keep from doing something or being free.” It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations and Bible experts.

our...our: This word is not repeated in the Greek text, but the Greek does strongly emphasize it. The emphasis implies that the Jewish leaders were not worried so much about the Jewish people, but about themselves. They did not want the Romans to take away (remove) the temple and the nation from them. They did not want to lose their authority and position of honor. They are talking among themselves, so the pronoun is inclusive. Here is another way to translate this word:

The Roman authorities will take away from us both the temple and the nation.

place: Scholars agree that the Greek word that the BSB translates literally as place refers to the temple in Jerusalem. The Jewish temple was still standing then and the Romans allowed the Jews to worship and sacrifice there. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Temple (GNT)

sanctuary (NET)

nation: This word refers to the Jewish nation of Israel. Israel was part of the Roman Empire then but had certain rights and privileges. The Romans permitted the Jewish people to practice their own religion under

their own leaders. The speakers feared that the Romans would take those rights away.

John 11:49

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:49–52

A Pharisee named Caiaphas spoke up in the council meeting. He said that Jesus should die for the nation.

11:49a

But one of them, named Caiaphas, who was high priest that year,

- ¶ Then one of the Jewish leaders named Caiaphas, who was high priest that year,
- ¶ The council member named Caiaphas was high priest at that time.

11:49b

said to them, “You know nothing at all!

- spoke to the others, “You^(plur) do not understand the situation at all.
- He said to the council, “You^(plur) do not know anything about this whole/entire situation/problem.

11:49

But: The Greek word that the BSB translates as But here introduces Caiaphas' response to what the council members said in 11:48. There is contrast between the chief priests and Pharisees' solution (stop Jesus)

and Caiaphas' solution (kill him). In some languages it may be natural to leave this word untranslated, as some English translations have done. Here is another way to translate this word:

Then (NIV)

one of them, named Caiaphas: This phrase identifies Caiaphas as a member of the council.

who was high priest that year: The phrase high priest that year indicate that at the time of this council, the high priest was Caiaphas. The Jewish custom was for a high priest to hold that position until he died. The Romans, however, removed a high priest that did not satisfy them and appointed another. Caiaphas' father-in-law was the previous high priest but the Romans replaced him with Caiaphas.

If a literal translation implies that there was a different high priest each year, it may be necessary to say:

who was high priest at that time

high priest: This phrase refers to the leader of the priests. He was the most important priest.

said to them: The word them refers to the other council members.

You know nothing at all! Caiaphas was saying that the other religious leaders did not understand this problem. The Greek text is more literally, “You do not know anything” and emphasizes the words “You” and “anything.” He was speaking firmly and severely to them, even insulting them. For example:

You people don't have any sense at all! (CEV)

You do not seem to have grasped the situation at all. (NJB)

You don't know what you're talking about! (NLT)

John 11:50

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas

said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:49–52

A Pharisee named Caiaphas spoke up in the council meeting. He said that Jesus should die for the nation.

11:50a

You do not realize that

- You^(plur) fail to see/understand that
- You^(plur) need to realize that

You do not realize that: The words You do not realize introduce something that Caiaphas thought that the council members should know but did not. For example:

You haven't even considered this: (GW)

You fail to see that (NJB)

11:50b

it is better for you that one man die for the people

- it is better for you^(plur) to allow one man to die for the benefit of the/this people
- it is to your^(plur) advantage that this one man should die for the Jewish people.
- it is in your^(plur) interests that this one man should be punished with death to save our^(incl) people.

it is better for you: This clause introduces something that Caiaphas thought would benefit the Jewish council. Here is another way to translate this clause:

it is to your advantage (NJB)

that one man die for the people: This expression indicates that Caiaphas thought that Jesus should be

killed in order to save the people of Israel. He implied that if Jesus died, the people of Israel would not die. The Romans would not come and destroy the nation. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

that this one man should die for the benefit of
our^(incl) people

that one man should be put to death to save the people

11:50c

than that the whole nation perish.”

- rather than that the/this entire nation be destroyed/ruined.”
- Otherwise the entire country/people will come to ruin.”

than that the whole nation perish: This expression indicates the bad thing that Caiaphas thought would happen if Jesus did not die. That bad thing was that the nation of Israel would be destroyed. Caiaphas expected that the Romans would destroy the whole nation, that is, its leadership, rights, institutions, and independence. The nation of Israel would cease to exist as a nation. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

rather than causing the destruction of the whole nation

so that the whole country will not be destroyed

instead of having the whole nation destroyed (GNT)

General Comment on 11:50b–c

11:50b–c compares two possibilities. Consider how it is most natural in your language to make such a comparison. For example:

it is better for you to have one man die for the people, instead of having the whole nation destroyed (GNT)

it is better for you that one man should die for the people, not that the whole nation should perish (ESV)

It is good for you that this one man should die for the people. It is not good that the whole nation should perish/die.

General Comment on 11:50a–c

Verse 11:50 is a strong statement. In some languages it may be natural to express this as a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't you realize that it is better for you to have one man die for the people, instead of having the whole nation destroyed? (GNT)

John 11:51

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:49–52

A Pharisee named Caiaphas spoke up in the council meeting. He said that Jesus should die for the nation.

11:51–52

11:51–52 is a parenthetical comment by the author. It is not part of the main story but a comment on what Caiaphas said in 11:50.

11:51a

Caiaphas did not say this on his own.

- He/Caiaphas did not say this by himself,

- This saying did not come from his/Caiaphas' own mind.

The Greek text connects this sentence to the previous verse with a common conjunction that here indicates a parenthetical comment. Some translations do not translate this word. The NET puts verses 51–52 in parentheses. Introduce this parenthetical comment in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Actually (GNT)

Caiaphas did not say this on his own: The word Caiaphas refers to the high priest. What he just said was not just his own thoughts, coming from his own mind or intelligence. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

What Caiaphas said did not come from his own mind/thoughts

Caiaphas did not think of this himself. (NCV)

11:51b

Instead, as high priest that year,

- but as high priest that year
- But because he was the high/chief priest at that time

Instead: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Instead* here connects a negative statement (11:51a) to a positive statement (11:51b). Caiaphas did not speak on his own, but rather spoke as the high priest. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

Now he did not say this on his own, but because he was high priest that year... (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Actually, he did not say this of his own accord; rather, as he was High Priest that year... (GNT)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Caiaphas did not say this on his own. As high priest that year... (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Caiaphas said this because he was high priest at that time, not from his own mind. As high priest...

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

as high priest that year: This phrase implies that Caiaphas spoke as he did because he was high priest. To be high priest was a high privilege, and God chose to speak through him. Refer to your translation of 11:49a, where there is same Greek phrase. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

As chief priest that year (GW)

because he was high priest that year (NET)

because at that time he was the high/chief priest

11:51c

he was prophesying that Jesus would die for the nation,

- he was prophesying that Jesus would die for the benefit of the Jewish nation,
- he prophesied that Jesus would be put to death to save the Jewish people.

he was prophesying: To prophesy is to speak for God, or to speak God's message. Caiaphas as high priest was speaking for God. He did not know it, but he was giving God's message to the people. Sometimes, as here, a prophecy will predict something that will happen in the future.

that Jesus would die for the nation: This clause explains the message and meaning of Caiaphas' prophecy. His words indicated that Jesus would really die for the Jewish nation.

would die: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as would here:

1. It means "would happen." (BSB, NET, ESV, NASB, NIV, CEV, GNT, RSV, REB, NJB, KJV, GW, NLT, NCV)
2. It means "would happen soon." For example:

he prophesied that Jesus was about to die for the nation (NRSV) (NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations including the BSB.

the nation: The word nation here refers to the Jewish nation. It may be necessary to be more explicit. For example:

their nation (NCV)

the Jewish nation (NET)

John 11:52

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:49–52

A Pharisee named Caiaphas spoke up in the council meeting. He said that Jesus should die for the nation.

11:52a

and not only for the nation,

- and not only for that nation,
- And/But his death would be for the benefit of others too.

and not only for the nation: This phrase indicates that Jesus' death was not for the benefit of the Jewish nation alone. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here, supplying a verb. For example:

Jesus would not die only for the Jewish nation

the nation: This phrase refers again to the Jewish nation. If you made that explicit in 11:51c, it may be natural to indicate this here by saying the following:

that nation

11:52b

but also for the scattered children of God, to gather them together into one.

- but also to gather together into one group all the scattered people who are God's people everywhere.
- He was going to die for all God's scattered children, to bring them all together and make them one.

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but connects the negative statement in 11:52a to the positive statement here in 11:52b. Here the negative statement ("not for the nation only") is completed by the positive statement ("to gather into one the dispersed children of God"). The words "not...only" in 11:52a indicate that there is an additional purpose for Jesus' death. John tells the additional purpose here in 11:52b. Translate the connection between the two clauses in a way that is natural in your language. Here are some possibilities:

- Do not use a connector. For example:

Yet Jesus would not die just for the Jewish nation. He would die to bring together all of God's scattered people. (CEV)

- Follow the BSB and use but. For example:

and not for the Jewish nation only, but to gather together into one the children of God who are scattered (NET)

- Reverse the clauses in 11:52a–b and translate the positive statement first. For example:

^{52b}And Jesus would die to gather into one all the dispersed children of God. ^{52a}He would not die just for the benefit of the Jewish nation.

^{52b}Jesus was about to die to unite the scattered people of God. ^{52a}His death would benefit them all, not the Jewish nation alone.

- Find another way to introduce an additional reason for the Jews to hate Jesus. For example:

Jesus would die for their nation and for God's scattered children to bring them all together and make them one. (NCV)

The additional reason in 11:52b tells an additional purpose for Jesus' death. This second purpose is the one that is emphasized. You may want to emphasize this second purpose in your translation. For example:

and even though it was great for Jesus to die for the Jewish nation, it was even greater that he would die to gather all of God's scattered children into one body.

the scattered children of God: This phrase refers to people who trust in God around the world, from every nation and people group. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

God's scattered people (CEV)

scattered: This word means "divided up and spread around." God's people were not living in Israel alone but in many countries around the world. It may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

all God's children who live in many countries/
places

to gather them together into one: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as gather them together into one means "bring together, make one, unite." For example:

to bring together into one body all the scattered people of God (GNT)

and for God's scattered children to bring them all together and make them one (NCV)

John 11:53

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the

Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:53–54

This paragraph tells the Jewish leaders' response to what Caiaphas said, and Jesus' response to them.

11:53

So from that day on they plotted to kill Him.

- ¶ Therefore starting on that day they plotted to kill Jesus.
- ¶ Therefore after that meeting the council planned to punish Jesus with death.

So: The word So introduces the result of the council meeting. It also indicates a return to the main story. Some English translations, including GNT and NJB, do not translate this word. Indicate a result and a return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

from that day on: This phrase refers to the time that followed. In this context it means "after Caiaphas made that prophecy." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from that time on (NLT)

That day they started... (NCV)

they plotted to kill Him: This clause indicates that the Jewish authorities made plans to persuade the government to kill Jesus. They did not plan to kill Jesus themselves. They wanted the Roman authorities to punish Jesus with death. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they plotted his death (REB)

the Jewish leaders began to plot his Jesus' death (NLT)

they started planning to persuade the Romans to punish Jesus with death

John 11:54

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:53–54

This paragraph tells the Jewish leaders' response to what Caiaphas said, and Jesus' response to them.

11:54a

As a result, Jesus no longer went about publicly among the Jews,

- So Jesus did not continue to move publicly among the Jews.
- So he stopped going/traveling around in public among the people of Judea.

As a result: This word introduces what Jesus did as a result of the Jewish leaders' plot to kill him. The result was that Jesus stayed away from people. For example:

So (NJB)

Because of this plot against him (CEV)

no longer went about publicly: This phrase indicates that Jesus had been walking about (around) openly (not secretly) and stopped doing so. For example:

stopped going around in public (CEV)

no longer walked about openly (NRSV)

among the Jews: This phrase here means in Judea, among the people of Jerusalem and the region that surrounded it. This was the region where Jesus was in the most danger.

11:54b

but He withdrew to a town called Ephraim in an area near the wilderness.

- Instead he went away to a region near the desert, to a village called Ephraim,
- He went to the town of Ephraim, which was near the desert, (CEV)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (11:54a) to a positive statement (11:54b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

So Jesus did not travel openly in Judea, but left and went to a place near the desert, to a town named Ephraim.... (GNT)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

So Jesus no longer walked openly among the Jews. Instead, he left Bethany and went to the countryside near the desert, to a city called Ephraim.... (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Because of this plot against him, Jesus stopped going around in public. He went to the town of Ephraim, which was near the desert.... (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

So Jesus left and went to the town of Ephraim near the desert. He no longer walked around publicly in Judea.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

He withdrew: This phrase means that Jesus left the area around Bethany and Jerusalem.

to a town called Ephraim: The phrase a town called Ephraim probably refers to a village about 12 miles (20 kilometers) northeast of Jerusalem. It was off the main trade routes.

in an area near the wilderness: The phrase the wilderness refers to an area where nobody lived. Ephraim was in the area near the wilderness or desert. For example:

on the edge of the desert

near the land where nobody can live (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

11:54c

And He stayed there with the disciples.

- where he stayed with his disciples.
- and he stayed there with his disciples. (CEV)

And He stayed there with the disciples: This clause means that Jesus and his disciples stayed for a while in the town called Ephraim. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

where he stayed with the disciples (GNT)

disciples: See how you translated this word in 11:7 and 11:12.

John 11:55

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:55–57

The Jewish people and their leaders got ready for the Passover festival and for the coming of Jesus.

11:55a

Now the Jewish Passover was near,

- ¶ When it was almost the time for the Jewish Passover,
- ¶ It was almost time for Passover. (CEV)

Now: This word here introduces some background information. It is not a time word in this context. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language.

the Jewish Passover: This phrase refers to the Jewish religious festival called the Passover. This festival celebrated God freeing the Jews from being slaves in Egypt about 1450 years before Jesus was born. See the note at 2:13a and see how you translated it there. Translate it in both verses the same way.

was near: This phrase indicates that it was almost time for the festival.

11:55b

and many people went up from the country to Jerusalem to purify themselves before the Passover.

- many people/men went up from the country to Jerusalem for their ritual cleansing before the Passover festival.
- Many of the Jewish people who lived out in the country had come to Jerusalem to get themselves ready for the festival. (CEV)

many people went up from the country to Jerusalem: There were many people there because all Jewish men were required to travel to Jerusalem for the festival.

went up: This phrase is a Jewish idiom that refers to going to Jerusalem. Jerusalem was built on a hill. So

anyone traveling to the city had to walk up a hill to get there. In some languages it is important to say whether people go up or down when they travel. In other languages, this will be unusual or confusing. If it is confusing in your language, you can just say:

Many people came from the countryside to Jerusalem (GW)

many people from all over the country arrived in Jerusalem (NLT)

from the country: This phrase means that these pilgrims came to Jerusalem from outside the city. They lived in the villages and small towns in the country (rural areas). For example:

from the rural areas (NET)

to purify themselves: This phrase means “to do their ritual cleansing.” The Jewish people did some washing rituals so they could eat the Passover. The washing rituals were not intended to remove dirt but to prepare the person to approach God. They were not allowed to celebrate the Passover if they were not ritually pure. (See Num. 9:6 and John 18:28.) Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to do the special things to make themselves pure (NCV)

to get themselves ready for the festival (CEV)

to do what they needed so that God would accept them as clean

before the Passover: This phrase indicates that these people went early to Jerusalem in order to prepare themselves for the feast.

General Comment on 11:55b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in the last part of 11:55b. It may be better to mention the Passover festival only at the end. This may make it clear that the ones who worshipped wanted to purify themselves before the festival. They did that so that they could join the celebration.

to perform the ritual of purification before the festival (GNT)

so they could go through the purification ceremony before Passover began (NLT)

to get themselves ready for the festival (CEV)

John 11:56

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:55–57

The Jewish people and their leaders got ready for the Passover festival and for the coming of Jesus.

11:56a

They kept looking for Jesus

- They kept watching for Jesus to come,
- They were looking for Jesus there (JBP)

They kept looking for Jesus: The Jews who traveled to Jerusalem wanted to see Jesus. They watched to see if he would come.

11:56b

and asking one another as they stood in the temple courts, “What do you think?”

- and as they stood in the temple area, they asked each other, “What is your^(plur) opinion?”
- and as they stood in the temple courtyard, they said to one another, “So what do you^(plur) think about Jesus?”

and asking one another: This phrase indicates that these people were talking among themselves. They were discussing Jesus and wondering what he would do.

as they stood in the temple courts: This clause indicates where these people were while they discussed Jesus. They were in the temple area, probably the temple courtyard. They had gathered there to do their purification ceremony.

What do you think?: This is a question that introduces a topic for discussion. The people in the temple wondered whether Jesus would come to the festival. They asked one another whether they thought that he would come.

11:56c

Will He come to the feast at all?”

- That Jesus will not be coming to the feast/festival at all?”
- He cannot be coming to this feast/festival.”

Will He come to the feast at all?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses doubt. The Jewish people doubted that they would see Jesus at the festival. The question suggests that it was not probable.

There are two ways of translating this doubt.

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

He won't come for Passover, will he? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Perhaps he is not coming to the festival. (REB)

Translate this doubt in a way that is most natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a possible answer to the question in 11:56b. For example:

What do you think? That he will not come to the feast at all? (ESV)

What do you think? That he won't come to the feast? (NET)

John 11:57

Section 11:45–57: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Jesus

This section tells that many Jews who saw Jesus raise Lazarus believed in him. But others reported him to

the Pharisees. The council met to discuss what to do with Jesus. They were afraid that if everyone believed in Jesus, the Roman government would destroy the Jewish temple and nation. The high priest Caiaphas said that it was better for Jesus to die than the whole nation be destroyed. That was true, but not in the way that Caiaphas meant. Jesus' death would bring salvation to all people.

Jesus no longer walked around in public and stayed in Ephraim. When people went to Jerusalem for the Passover feast, they looked for Jesus, thinking that he would not go there. That was because the chief priests and Pharisees had ordered people to tell them if they knew where Jesus was. Then they could arrest him.

Here are some other possible headings for this section:

The Jewish council decided to kill Jesus

The plot to kill Jesus

Paragraph 11:55–57

The Jewish people and their leaders got ready for the Passover festival and for the coming of Jesus.

11:57a

But the chief priests and Pharisees had given orders

- (The chief priests and Pharisees had told everyone
- The leading priests and members of the Jewish Pharisee group had said to the people,

But: The word But introduces a parenthetical comment with some background information. Some English translations do not translate this word. And NET and GW put this verse in parentheses. Introduce this parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

the chief priests and Pharisees: This phrase refers to the highest Jewish leaders' council. See how you translated this phrase in 11:47a.

had given orders: This phrase refers to the fact that these leaders had given a general command to all the people.

11:57b

that anyone who knew where He was must report it,

- that if anybody knew where Jesus was, he should report it to them
- "If any of you^(plur) find out where Jesus is, tell us^(excl)."

anyone who knew where He was: The word anyone is indefinite. It refers to any person who might happen to know or find out where Jesus was. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

whoever knew where Jesus was (GW)

if anyone found out where Jesus was (NIV)

must report it: This phrase means "should tell them." Any person who knew where Jesus was should report that information to the Jewish leaders. This was the command given by the Jewish leaders. For example:

should tell them (JBP)

must inform them (NJB)

General Comment on 11:57b

In some languages it may be natural to reorder the information in 11:57b. For example:

told the people to let them know if any of them saw Jesus (CEV)

11:57c

so that they could arrest Him.

- so they could arrest him/Jesus.)
- They wanted Jesus to be arrested.
- Their aim/purpose was to arrest Jesus.

so that: This phrase introduces the Jewish leaders' purpose in giving their command. They wanted to know where Jesus was in order to arrest him.

they could arrest Him: This clause refers to the fact that the Jewish leaders planned to persuade the Romans to arrest Jesus. They were not planning to arrest him themselves, so in some languages it may be natural to make this clear:

so that they might persuade the Romans to arrest him

General Comment on 11:57a–c

In some languages it may be natural to translate the Jewish leaders' command as direct speech. For example:

^aThe leading priests and the Pharisees had commanded the people, ^b"If any of you knows where

Jesus is, tell us.” They gave this command in the hope of arresting Jesus.

John 12:1

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus’ feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:1–3

This paragraph tells how Mary anointed Jesus with perfume. She did this to honor him and show that she was devoted to him. Jesus had raised her brother Lazarus to life.

12:1a

Six days before the Passover, Jesus came to Bethany,

- Six days before the Passover festival, Jesus arrived in Bethany,
- Jesus arrived at the village of Bethany six days before the feast/celebration called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

Six days before the Passover: This phrase indicates the time of the next event in the narrative. See 11:55a. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a separate sentence:

It was six days before the Passover feast.

In six days the Jews would celebrate the Passover.

Passover: This is the name of a Jewish festival. It reminds the Jews of the time when they were slaves in Egypt. God went to kill the first-born sons of the Egyptians so that they would allow the Jews to leave Egypt. The term Passover refers to the fact that God passed over (did not enter) the houses of the Jews. That means that he did not harm their sons. See the note at 2:13a for more details.

See how you translated this word in 2:13a, 11:55a, Mark 14:1, and Matthew 26:2.

Jesus came to Bethany: Jesus returned to Bethany, where Mary, Martha, and Lazarus lived.

Bethany: Bethany is the name of a village near Jerusalem. See how you referred to it in 11:1. In some languages it is natural to say:

the village of Bethany

the village called Bethany

12:1b

the hometown of Lazarus, whom He had raised from the dead.

- the village where Lazarus lived. Lazarus was the man Jesus had raised from the dead.
- Bethany was the hometown of the man Jesus had brought back to life, Lazarus.

the hometown of Lazarus: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the hometown of Lazarus is more literally “where Lazarus was.” This phrase reminds the readers of the importance of Bethany, where Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead. See chapter 11 for more details. This was the village where Lazarus and his sisters lived. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

where Lazarus lived (NCV)

whom He had raised from the dead: This clause identifies Lazarus for the readers. He had died, and Jesus had caused him to live again (11:44). In some languages it is more natural to use a separate sentence. For example:

This was the man whom he had raised from the dead.

This is background information. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. One way to do that is to place this clause in a separate sentence in parentheses. For example:

(Lazarus is the man Jesus raised from the dead.)
(NCV)

John 12:2

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus’

feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:1–3

This paragraph tells how Mary anointed Jesus with perfume. She did this to honor him and show that she was devoted to him. Jesus had raised her brother Lazarus to life.

12:2a

So they hosted a dinner for Jesus there.

- The people there prepared/gave a dinner for Jesus.
- A big supper/feast was given there to honor Jesus.

they: It is not clear whom this pronoun refers to. It likely refers to members of Lazarus' family or perhaps his friends and neighbors in general. It is good to use a general subject such as "Some people." For example:

The people there

hosted a dinner: The verb the BSB has translated as hosted is more literally "made." Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

They prepared a dinner (GNT)

they cooked a dinner

a dinner: In this context the word dinner refers to the evening meal, the main meal of the day. It was a meal to celebrate a happy event among friends, so it may be called "a feast" or "a banquet." For example:

a supper (RSV)

A meal (CEV)

for Jesus: This phrase for Jesus here means "to honor Jesus." The people who gave the dinner were thankful that Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead. In some languages it may be natural to say:

in his honor

because they wanted to honor Jesus

there: This word refers to Bethany, the village where Lazarus lived. In some languages it may be natural to say:

Here (NIV)

in Bethany (GW)

12:2b

Martha served, and Lazarus was among those reclining at the table with Him.

- Martha served the meal, and Lazarus reclined among the guests at the table.
- Lazarus' sister Martha served the food, while Lazarus was among those who ate with Jesus.

Martha served: This clause indicates that Martha, Lazarus' sister, distributed the food to the guests at the dinner. Use the expression that is natural for giving food to friends/guests at a dinner party. For example:

Martha was doing the serving (CEV)

Martha served the food (NCV)

Martha waited on the party (JBP)

and: The conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces a slight contrast. Martha and Lazarus were doing different things. It is also possible to say:

while

The GNT does not translate this conjunction and separates the clauses with a semicolon. In English this implies a slight contrast. Introduce this slight contrast or difference in a way that is natural in your language.

Lazarus was among those: These words indicate that Martha was serving Lazarus as well as others.

reclining at the table with Him: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as reclining at the table with Him is more literally "reclining with him." The custom then was to eat while reclining (leaning back) on mats or benches around a low table. See the picture below. So Lazarus was eating with Jesus while Martha was serving them food. If people do not usually eat at a table in your culture, it is not necessary to mention a table. For example:

Lazarus was among those who ate with him (NLT)

Lazarus was among the guests with Jesus (REB)

with Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

with Jesus (GNT)

John 12:3

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus' feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:1–3

This paragraph tells how Mary anointed Jesus with perfume. She did this to honor him and show that she was devoted to him. Jesus had raised her brother Lazarus to life.

12:3a

Then Mary took about a pint of expensive perfume, made of pure nard,

- Mary took half a liter of pure nard oil, an expensive perfume,
- Their sister Mary brought a pint jar of valuable perfume made from the nard plant.

Then Mary took about a pint of expensive perfume, made of pure nard: Mary is the name of the sister of Martha and Lazarus. See 11:1–2, and spell the name the same way in both places. The verb took here indicates that she got this perfume and brought it into the room where the dinner was. It was her own perfume, and the verb does not indicate that she took it from someone else. For example:

Mary brought a pound of very costly perfume, pure oil of nard (REB)

Mary brought in a pint of very expensive perfume (NCV)

about a pint: The Greek word the BSB translates as pint refers to the Roman “pound,” which was about three hundred (300) grams or twelve (12) ounces. Perfume at that time was sold by weight. Today liquids like perfume are usually sold by the size of the container. So you may want to refer to the size of the container in your translation, like the USB does. Use a measurement that is natural in your language. For example:

half a liter

a pound (NRSV)

expensive perfume, made of pure nard: This expression describes the substance that Mary brought to Jesus. This substance was probably liquid, an oil that had a nice smell.

expensive perfume: The word expensive indicates that the perfume cost a lot of money. It was rare and expensive. Here are some other ways to say this phrase:

costly perfume (NRSV)

valuable perfume

perfume that was bought/sold for much money

made of pure nard: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated as made of pure nard is more literally “pure nard.” Nard is a perfume taken from the nard or spikenard plant that grows in India. Use a phrase that is natural for describing such a perfume. For example:

made from a plant called nard

Mary brought a half liter of pure nard which was a very expensive perfume.

pure oil of nard (REB)

12:3b

and she anointed Jesus' feet and wiped them with her hair.

- and she poured the perfume on Jesus' feet and wiped his feet with her hair.
- She poured the perfume on Jesus' feet and used her hair to wipe/dry his feet.

she anointed Jesus' feet: The word anointed means “put oil on someone.” Mary poured all the perfume over Jesus' feet. She did this to honor him and show that she was devoted to him. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

poured it on Jesus' feet (CEV)

and wiped them with her hair: This phrase means that Mary used her hair like a towel to wipe the extra perfume from Jesus' feet. Doing this showed that she was humble and how much she honored Jesus.

them: This pronoun refers to Jesus' feet.

12:3c

And the house was filled with the fragrance of the perfume.

- And the beautiful smell of the perfume filled the house.
- People everywhere in the house could smell the good/sweet smell of the perfume.

And the house: This phrase refers to the house where Jesus and the others were eating.

was filled with the fragrance of the perfume: This expression means that the fragrance (nice, sweet smell) of the perfume could be smelled everywhere in the house. The verb was filled is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the fragrance of the perfume could be smelled throughout the house

- Use an active verb. For example:

the sweet smell from the perfume filled the whole house (NCV)

all the people in the house could smell the fragrance

fragrance: The word fragrance here means “the good smell” or “the sweet smell.”

John 12:4

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus' feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very

valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:4–8

This paragraph describes Judas' reaction to what Mary had done. He said that she wasted something valuable that could have been sold and the money given to the poor. However, the truth was that he wanted to steal the money. But Jesus defended Mary. He understood that she had anointed him to prepare him for his death and burial.

12:4

But one of His disciples, Judas Iscariot, who was going to betray Him, asked,

- ¶ However, one of Jesus' disciples, Judas Iscariot, who would later betray Jesus, said,
- ¶ Judas Iscariot was Jesus' follower who would hand Jesus over to his enemies for money. He said to Jesus,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces what Judas said when he saw what Mary did. He did not approve of what she did, and so the BSB uses a conjunction that indicates contrast. Some translations, such as the GNT, do not explicitly translate this conjunction. Introduce what Judas said in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then (NJB)

At this (REB)

one of His disciples, Judas Iscariot, who was going to betray Him: These phrases again introduce Judas Iscariot, who was also mentioned in 6:71. The author tells us two things about Judas in addition to his name. First, he was a disciple and second, he would betray Jesus.

Here are other ways to translate this background information:

Judas Iscariot, the disciple who would soon betray him (NLT)

One of Jesus' disciples, Judas Iscariot—the one who was going to betray him—(GNT)

Judas Iscariot—one of his disciples, the man who was to betray him— (NJB)

one of His disciples: Judas was one of Jesus’ disciples or followers. He had committed himself to Jesus as his teacher and spiritual guide. In some languages it may be natural to make the name Jesus explicit here. This is especially important in languages that do not distinguish between the pronouns His and “her.” In those languages, readers might misunderstand the pronoun to refer to Mary. For example:

One of Jesus’ disciples (GNT)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners commit themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example. In the New Testament “disciple” referred specifically to a person who learned from a religious teacher. Often, disciples lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this term at 1:35.

Judas Iscariot: The full name Judas Iscariot is also mentioned in Matthew 10:4, Mark 3:19, and Luke 6:16. Refer to this disciple the same way in all these verses. The meaning of the surname Iscariot is not certain and it is best to transliterate it. The NET Bible indicates that the most likely meaning is “man of Kerioth.” Kerioth was a village in Judea.

who was going to betray Him: This phrase indicates that Judas was the disciple who later betrayed Jesus to Jesus’ enemies. At the time of the story, Judas had not yet betrayed Jesus but would soon do so. (The Greek word that the BSB translates as was going to can either mean “would” or “would soon.” Because Judas did soon betray him, either sense can be understood here.) The event was past from the point of view of the author and the original readers. Indicate this using the verb tense that is natural in your language. For example:

the one who was about to betray him (NRSV)

who was later to betray him (NIV)

betray: The word betray refers to giving help to a person’s enemy instead of being loyal to that person. Here it refers to Judas leading Jesus’ enemies to find and capture Jesus. See how you translated this word in 6:64 and 6:71. For example:

turn against him (NCV)

sell Jesus to his enemies (Uma Back Translation)

asked: The word asked introduces a direct quotation. But the quotation is a question. Judas was asking everyone there a question that implied criticism of Mary. In some languages it is more natural to use another verb if you use a question in 12:5.

General Comment on 12:4

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse as two or more separate sentences. For example:

A disciple named Judas Iscariot was there. He was the one who was going to betray Jesus, and he asked... (CEV)

One of Jesus’ disciples was named Judas Iscariot. This was the man who would later betray Jesus to his enemies. He asked...

John 12:5

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus’ feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:4–8

This paragraph describes Judas’ reaction to what Mary had done. He said that she wasted something valuable that could have been sold and the money given to the poor. However, the truth was that he wanted to steal the money. But Jesus defended Mary. He understood that she had anointed him to prepare him for his death and burial.

12:5

“Why wasn’t this perfume sold for three hundred denarii and the money given to the poor?”

- “Why was this perfume wasted? It could have been sold for three hundred silver coins and the money given to poor people.”

- “This perfume was worth a lot of money—almost a year’s wages! Mary should have sold it and given the money from the sale to poor people.”

Why wasn’t this perfume sold for three hundred denarii and the money given to the poor?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. Judas rebuked Mary and he also rebuked Jesus for allowing Mary to pour her perfume on his feet. Judas implied that Mary should have sold her perfume and given the money to the poor.

There are several ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Could not this perfume have been sold for three hundred denarii and the money given to the poor? (REB)

- Use a statement or statements. For example:

That perfume was worth a year’s wages. It should have been sold and the money given to the poor. (NLT)

- Use a combination of a rhetorical question and a statement. For example:

Why wasn’t this money sold and the money given to the poor? It was worth a year’s wages. (NIV)

Translate this rebuke in the way that is most natural in your language. Judas was being critical and did not approve of what Mary did. He indicated that it was a waste to pour the perfume on Jesus’ feet. Try to use expressions that imply this.

Why wasn’t this perfume sold for three hundred denarii...?: This clause implies three things. First, the perfume was worth three hundred (300) denarii. Second, Mary could have sold it for that much money. And third, she should have sold it. Judas implied that selling it would have been the right thing to do. The verb phrase wasn’t...sold is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Could not this perfume have been sold for three hundred denarii? (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Why did Mary/she not sell this perfume? It was worth three hundred denarii/coins.

Mary could/should have sold this perfume for three hundred denarii/coins.

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

three hundred denarii: The word denarii is the plural of “denarius.” The denarius was a Roman coin worth about a day’s wage for a worker. So three hundred (300) denarii were about a year’s wages. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

three hundred silver coins (NET)

a year’s wages (NIV)

In some languages it is more natural to say something general that means “lots of money.” For example:

a high price (GW)

a small fortune (NLT96)

You may want to put the exact amount in a footnote. For example:

The Greek says 300 denarii. A denarius was one day’s pay for the ordinary worker.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

This perfume was worth three hundred coins. Why wasn’t it sold...? (NCV)

Why didn’t Mary sell the perfume? Someone would have paid/given three hundred coins for it.

the money given to the poor: This is a short way of saying “why was the money from selling the perfume not given to poor people?” The verb given is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the money should have been given to the poor

- Use an active verb. For example:

why did she not give that money to the poor?

Mary should have given the money to the poor

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language. Also, use either a rhetorical question or a statement for the rebuke. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

poor people could/should have been helped

the poor could have received the money/blessing

Would it not have been better to give the money to the poor?

John 12:6

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus' feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:4–8

This paragraph describes Judas' reaction to what Mary had done. He said that she wasted something valuable that could have been sold and the money given to the poor. However, the truth was that he wanted to steal the money. But Jesus defended Mary. He understood that she had anointed him to prepare him for his death and burial.

12:6a–b

Some English translations put 12:6a–b in parentheses to show that this is not part of the main story but is additional information. The author John was the one who provided this information. The verse explains why Judas said what he did in 12:5. Consider how it is natural to indicate that this verse is additional information in your language.

12:6a

Judas did not say this because he cared about the poor, but because he was a thief.

- Judas did not say this because he cared about the poor but because he was a thief.

- But in fact Judas said that because he was a thief. He did not say that because he cared about poor people because he did not care about them.

Judas did not say this because he cared about the poor, but because he was a thief: These clauses explain why Judas suggested that they should help the poor. He wanted to encourage others to give generously to the poor. However, his reason for what he said was not because he wanted to help the poor. Instead, he said it because he hoped to steal some of the money.

Judas did not say this: The word this refers to what Judas said in 12:5. There he said that the money from selling the perfume should have been given to the poor.

not...because: This phrase introduces what was not the reason that Judas said what he did.

he cared about the poor: This clause indicates that Judas did not say what he did because he cared about (was concerned about) poor people. He did not really care for their welfare. In your translation it should be clear that Judas did not want to help poor people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He said this, not out of any concern for the poor (REB)

Now Judas said this not because he was concerned about the poor (NET)

Judas didn't say this because he cared about the poor (GW)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (not because he cared about the poor) to a positive statement (because he was a thief). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

He said this, not out of any concern for the poor, but because he was a thief (REB)

He did not say this because he cared about poor people, but because he was a thief

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

He said this not because he cared about poor people, rather/instead he was a thief

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Not that he cared for the poor—he was a thief (NLT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

He said that because he was a thief, not because he cared about poor people.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

because: This word here introduces the true reason why Judas wanted people to give money to the poor.

he was a thief: The word thief here refers to a person who secretly takes money that does not belong to him. Judas was not a professional thief or burglar. He stole money that he was supposed to protect. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 12:6a

In some languages a literal translation may suggest that Judas did care about the poor; it was just not the reason that he spoke. If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to reorder the information to avoid this wrong meaning. For example:

But Judas did not really care about the poor; he said this because he was a thief. (NCV)

12:6b

As keeper of the money bag, he used to take from what was put into it.

- He was in charge of the group's money bag and used to steal some of the money that people put into it.
- He was in charge of the disciples' money/finances and had the habit of taking some of the contributions/money for himself.

As keeper of the money bag: This clause indicates that Judas was in charge of the disciples' finances. He was supposed to take care of the money that they used to buy food for them all. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he was in charge of the disciples' money (NLT)

He was the one who kept the money box (NCV)

he carried the moneybag (CEV)

the money bag: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as the money bag refers to a small bag that held the money for Jesus and his followers. The group shared the money that was in it; it did not belong to any one person. Here is another way to make this clear:

the disciples' money (NLT)

used to take: The phrase used to take indicates that Judas often stole some of the money from the disciples' money bag. He took money from it to use for himself alone. For example:

he often stole some for himself (NLT)

he often stole from it (NCV)

and sometimes would steal from it (CEV)

what was put into it: This phrase refers to the money that people gave Jesus and his disciples. The disciples used this money to buy what they needed, like food. It appears from this story that they also gave some of the money to poor people. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the coins that people gave for it

the money kept in it (REB)

John 12:7

Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus' feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:4–8

This paragraph describes Judas' reaction to what Mary had done. He said that she wasted something valuable that could have been sold and the money given to the poor. However, the truth was that he wanted to steal the money. But Jesus defended Mary. He understood that she had anointed him to prepare him for his death and burial.

12:7a

“Leave her alone,” Jesus replied.

- “Leave Mary alone,” Jesus replied.
- Jesus said to him, “Do not criticize Mary.

Leave her alone: This clause is a rebuke to Judas. Jesus did not want Judas to bother or trouble Mary. He told Judas to stop criticizing her. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not bother/trouble her

Stop criticizing her

12:7b

“She has kept this perfume in preparation for the day of My burial.

- “She kept/saved this perfume for the day that I would be buried.
- She has done well in keeping/saving this perfume for my burial.

She has kept this perfume in preparation for the day of My burial: The Greek more literally says “so that she may keep it for/until the day of my burial.” Most commentaries say that the Greek text leaves out words and leaves them implied. One possibility is to add the clause “she did not sell it.” For example:

She did not sell it so that she might keep it for the day of my burial

The NIV adds the phrase “It was intended.” This implies that the intention was God’s rather than Mary’s:

It was intended that she should save this perfume for the day of my burial.

Here is a more literal translation that may provide an example:

She has kept it for the day of my burial (NET)

Your translation should indicate that Mary had kept (not sold) the perfume so that she could use it for Jesus’ burial. She may or may not have known that this was why she kept it, but God knew. And this was a good thing, and the reason that Judas should not criticize her.

the day of My burial: This phrase means “the day when I will be buried.” The Jewish custom was to anoint a dead body with perfume or nice-smelling oils before they placed it in a tomb. It was not the Jewish custom to bury a body in the ground. See the note on 11:17. Like Lazarus, Jesus was placed in a cave tomb, not buried in the ground. It may therefore be natural to say:

for the day/time when they/men will place me in my tomb

John 12:8**Section 12:1–8: Mary anointed Jesus**

This section describes what happened at a dinner party in Bethany at the home of Lazarus, Martha, and Mary. Mary anointed (poured perfume/oil on) Jesus’ feet. Judas thought that she wasted something very valuable, but Jesus said that it was for his burial. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus was anointed in Bethany

Mary anointed Jesus for his burial

Paragraph 12:4–8

This paragraph describes Judas’ reaction to what Mary had done. He said that she wasted something valuable that could have been sold and the money given to the poor. However, the truth was that he wanted to steal the money. But Jesus defended Mary. He understood that she had anointed him to prepare him for his death and burial.

12:8a

The poor you will always have with you,

- You will always have poor people living among you,
- The poor will always be with/around you.

The poor you will always have with you: This clause is an idiomatic statement meaning that there will always be some poor people living nearby. There will always be people around who need help.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

There will always be poor people living among you.

There will always be poor people around/nearby.

The poor: This phrase refers to poor people, those without enough money to buy enough food and clothes. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast it with “me” in 12:8b, which the Greek also emphasizes. They always had the poor, but they would not always have Jesus.

you: The word you is plural and refers to Jesus’ followers in general.

12:8b
but you will not always have Me.”

- but you will not always have me among you.”
- I, however, will soon be gone.”

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast. They would always have poor people but they would not always have Jesus.

you will not always have Me: The Greek text emphasizes the word Me to contrast it with “the poor” in 12:8a. Jesus would not always be on earth with his people. They would not always be able to show him love and honor him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will not always have me with you (GW)

I will not always live with/among you.

I will soon be gone.

you: The word you is plural and refers to Jesus’ followers in general.

John 12:9

Section 12:9–11: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Lazarus

Many people came to see Jesus. But they also came to see Lazarus because Jesus raised him from the dead. As a result, the chief priests decided that they needed to kill Lazarus in addition to Jesus.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The chief priests decided to kill Lazarus too

The plot to kill Lazarus

12:9a

Meanwhile a large crowd of Jews learned that Jesus was there.

- ¶ A large crowd of Judeans found out where Jesus was
- ¶ Many of the local people heard that Jesus was in Bethany

Meanwhile a large crowd of Jews learned that Jesus was there:

This clause introduces a new part of the story, telling what happened next. Introduce this new event in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Now a large crowd of Judeans learned that Jesus was there (NET)

A large crowd of Jews found out that Jesus was in Bethany. (GW)

a large crowd of Jews: Some Greek manuscripts do not include the word “the.” Most commentaries say that the word should be included, though many English translations like the BSB use the word “a” instead. The difference in meaning is not really important. You may want to follow the examples of the major language translations used in your area. The phrase a large crowd of Jews here refers to the local people, inhabitants of Judea, the province that included Jerusalem. For example:

a large crowd of Judeans (NET)

a large number of people (GNT)

learned that Jesus was there: The people heard the news that Jesus had gone to Bethany. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

heard of Jesus’ arrival (NLT)

found out that Jesus was in Bethany (GW)

heard that Jesus was in Bethany (GNT)

12:9b

And they came not only because of Him, but also to see Lazarus,

- and went there in order to see both Jesus/him and Lazarus,

- and came/went to see him. They also wanted to see Lazarus,

And they came: This clause indicates that the Jews who learned that Jesus was in Bethany went there. In some languages it may not be natural to use a word like came here. For example:

they went there (GW)

not only because of Him, but also to see Lazarus:

These people came/went to Bethany hoping to see both Jesus and Lazarus. Seeing Jesus was not their only reason for coming, but it was one reason. Translate this expression in a way that is natural and clear in your language. For example:

not only because they wanted to see Jesus, but also because they wanted to see Lazarus

not only to see Jesus but also to see Lazarus (GW)

to see him and also to see Lazarus (NLT)

General Comment on 12:9a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 12:9a–b. Then you would make “the great crowd of the Jews” (rather than “they”) the subject of the verb “came.” For example:

A lot of people came when they heard that Jesus was there. They also wanted to see Lazarus.... (CEV)

Hearing that Jesus had arrived, a crowd of Jewish people came to Bethany. They hoped/wanted to see Jesus and Lazarus as well

12:9c

whom He had raised from the dead.

- the man Jesus raised from the dead.
- because they heard that Jesus had raised him from the dead.

whom He had raised from the dead: The word whom introduces some information about Lazarus. It refers to the narrative in John 11, telling how Jesus made Lazarus alive after he died. This information explains why the people wanted to see him. For example:

because Jesus had raised him from death (CEV)

General Comment on 12:9

In some languages it is more natural to break this information into more than one sentence. For example:

A large crowd of Jews heard that Jesus was in Bethany. So they went there to see not only Jesus but Lazarus, whom Jesus raised from the dead. (NCV)

John 12:10

Section 12:9–11: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Lazarus

Many people came to see Jesus. But they also came to see Lazarus because Jesus raised him from the dead. As a result, the chief priests decided that they needed to kill Lazarus in addition to Jesus.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The chief priests decided to kill Lazarus too

The plot to kill Lazarus

12:10

So the chief priests made plans to kill Lazarus as well,

- Therefore the chief priests decided to kill Lazarus also,
- So the leading priests made plans to kill Lazarus in addition to Jesus,

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So introduces a further development in the story. This development was a result of what had just happened. Here is another way to translate this word:

Then (NJB)

the chief priests made plans to kill Lazarus as well:

The Jewish leaders made plans to kill Lazarus because the fact that he was alive showed Jesus’ great power. Lazarus was himself the evidence that Jesus was the Messiah.

the chief priests: This phrase refers to the most important of the Jewish priests, the leading priests. These men were important religious authorities, members of the main council of the Jews. See how you translated this phrase in 11:47. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the leading priests (NCV)

as well: This phrase means in addition to Jesus. The religious authorities had already planned to kill Jesus in 11:53.

John 12:11

Section 12:9–11: The Jewish leaders plotted to kill Lazarus

Many people came to see Jesus. But they also came to see Lazarus because Jesus raised him from the dead. As a result, the chief priests decided that they needed to kill Lazarus in addition to Jesus.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The chief priests decided to kill Lazarus too

The plot to kill Lazarus

12:11

for on account of him many of the Jews were deserting them and believing in Jesus.

- because he was the reason that many Jews were leaving them and believing in Jesus.
- because many Jewish people were abandoning them and trusting in Jesus because of what happened to Lazarus.

for on account of him many of the Jews were deserting them and believing in Jesus: This verse tells the reason why the religious leaders wanted to kill Lazarus. The reason was that he was causing many Jewish people to desert (leave) them and trust Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this verse:

for it was because of him that many of the people had deserted them and believed in Jesus (NLT)

because he was the reason that many Jews left them and put their faith in Jesus

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

He was the reason that many of the people were turning from them and putting their faith in Jesus. (CEV)

Because of Lazarus many of the Jews were leaving them and believing in Jesus. (NCV)

for: The Greek word that the BSB translates as for means “because.” It introduces the reason why the religious leaders wanted to kill Lazarus.

on account of him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as on account of him here means “because of Lazarus” or “because of what happened to Lazarus.” It indicates that Lazarus was the cause of many Jews turning to Jesus to believe in him. When people saw Lazarus and heard his story, they were impressed by Jesus’ power. As a result, they began to believe that he was the Messiah.

many of the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the local Jewish people, residents of Jerusalem and Judea. For example:

many of the Jewish people from Judea

many of the people (CEV)

were deserting them: There are two ways to understand the Greek verb that the BSB translates as were deserting here.

1. It should be understood as a metaphor and means “were leaving their loyalty to someone to become loyal to another.” For example:

were rejecting them and believing in Jesus (GNT) (BSB, NIV, CEV, GNT, REB, NJB, GW, GW, NLT, NCV)

1. It should be understood literally and means “were going away.” For example:

were going away and believing in Jesus (NET) (RSV, NET, ESV, NASB, KJV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations and Bible experts. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

had deserted them (NLT)

had stopped following the Jewish religious authorities

and believing in Jesus: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See

how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 3:16b, and 11:25b. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

putting their faith in Jesus (CEV)

believed in Jesus (NLT)

John 12:12

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus' disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:12a

The next day the great crowd that had come to the feast

- ¶ The next day the many people who had come to celebrate the Passover Feast
- ¶ The next day a large crowd was in Jerusalem for Passover. (CEV)

12:12b

heard that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem.

- learned that Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem.
- When they heard that Jesus was coming for the festival, (CEV)

12:12a–b

The next day: This phrase introduces a new event in the story, Jesus' entering Jerusalem. The phrase refers back to 12:1, and so this is the day after Mary anointed Jesus. Thus it was probably Sunday, five days before the Passover.

the great crowd that had come to the feast heard that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem: The people who had come to Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover feast found out that Jesus was also coming. The text does not say how they learned that, so it is good not to

say how in your translation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

a great crowd that had come to Jerusalem for the Passover Feast heard that Jesus was coming there (NCV)

the many people in Jerusalem for the festival learned that Jesus was coming

Crowds of people had come for the Passover festival. The news spread among them that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem.

the great crowd that had come to the feast: This noun phrase refers to the people that had come to Jerusalem to celebrate Passover. It may be natural to make this information explicit. For example:

a large crowd was in Jerusalem for Passover (CEV)

the large crowd that had come to the Passover Festival (GNT)

the feast: This phrase here refers to the festival known as Passover. This was the time when the Jewish people celebrated how God saved them from being slaves in Egypt. The people were there in Jerusalem to celebrate the Passover Festival. See the note and how you translated this in 12:1a. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the festival (NRSV)

the Passover Feast (NCV)

heard that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem: The crowd of people in Jerusalem learned that Jesus was coming. Someone, or some people, told them that Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem. This was true information. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

found out that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem

was told/informed that Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem

heard the news that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem

John 12:13

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus' disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:13a

They took palm branches and went out to meet Him,

- They tore branches from palm plants and waving them went out to meet/greet Jesus,
- they went out of the city to welcome Jesus with honor. They held/waved palm leaves in their hands

They took palm branches and went out to meet Him:

This took place on “the next day” mentioned in 12:12. The word They refers back to the great crowd also mentioned there. The people in the crowd cut branches off some of the palm trees that were growing there. Then they carried the branches in their hands to wave and celebrate Jesus' coming. This was the custom at this time as a way to welcome a famous person. In some languages it may be natural to make some of this explicit. For example:

and went out to meet him with palm branches in their hands (JBP)

the people went out of the city to welcome him, waving palm branches

palm branches: This phrase refers to the parts of a palm plant/tree that grow out of the trunk. See the picture below where the man is cutting a “branch” off of the trunk of a palm tree. In many languages, these branches are referred to as “leaves,” and that is really what they are. Also, some languages do not call a palm a “tree” because they do not have wood branches like a regular tree. Other areas may not have any plants

like palms. You should refer to these palms and their branches in ways that are natural in your language. For example:

palm leaves

leaves from a palm plant

leafy branches

leaves from a plant like a coconut

went out to meet Him: This phrase indicates that the people left the city to welcome Jesus, who was on his way into the city. They greeted him as people might greet a king who won a war, showing him honor by welcoming him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase.

went down the road to meet him (NLT)

went out to greet him (CEV)

went out of the city to welcome Jesus

12:13b

shouting: “Hosanna!” “Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!”

- shouting, “Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes to us in the Lord's name!
- and called out, “Praise the Lord! Praise the blessed one coming to us in his name,
- and joyfully shouted, “Praise God! Praise the one coming as his representative/messenger,

shouting: The people were praising Jesus with loud voices. Use the expression that is most natural for indicating this. The people were not shouting because they were angry. Here is another way to translate this word:

praising him loudly

Hosanna!: Hosanna is a Hebrew expression that means “please save!” It is literally a prayer for help but here it is used as an expression of praise. Here are two ways to translate this word:

- Use a word that sounds like the Aramaic word without translating it. If the expression Hosanna is

already known and used in churches in your area, this may be the best choice.

- Translate the meaning in this context. For example:

Praise God! (GNT)

Let us praise God!

Blessed is He who comes in the name of the Lord!: This is a formula welcoming the Messiah. It is a quotation from Psalm 118:26. There are two ways to interpret it here:

1. The speakers were praising Jesus, the one who came to them in the name of the Lord. They declared him to be Blessed, that is, God has given him special love and favor. For example:

Blessed is he who is coming in the name of the Lord (NJB) (BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NJB, REB, NET, GW)

1. The speakers were asking God to bless the one who was coming to them in the name of the Lord. For example:

May God bless him who comes in the name of the Lord! (GNT, NCV, CEV, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations.

Blessed is: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Blessed is is passive and the implied subject is God. The speakers praised Jesus by saying that he was blessed by God. That means that God had given him his special love and favor. See how you translated this Greek word in Mark 11:9. Here are two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

Blessed is the one who comes in the Lord's name!

The one who comes in the Lord's name has been blessed by God!

- Use an active verb. For example:

God has blessed/favored the one who comes in his name

The Lord has blessed/favored the one who comes as his representative

He who comes in the name of the Lord: This noun phrase is a reference to the Messiah. The crowds were saying that Jesus was the Messiah, admitting the truth that Jesus came from God.

in the name of the Lord: This phrase means "with the authority of God" or "as God's representative." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

whom the Lord sent

whom the Lord sent as his representative

12:13c

"Blessed is the King of Israel!"

- the one who is the King of Israel!"
- the one who comes to rule/govern over Israel!"

the King of Israel: This phrase is not part of the quotation from Psalm 118:26. They are part of what the people were shouting to welcome Jesus. The people blessed Jesus as the King and welcomed him. They also gave him one of the titles of the Messiah. In some languages it is more natural to start a new sentence here like the BSB does.

If you begin a new sentence, check that your readers understand that "the one who comes in the name of the Lord" (12:13b) is the King of Israel. Also check that people understand that both expressions refer to Jesus.

John 12:14

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus' disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:14**Finding a young donkey, Jesus sat on it, as it is written:**

- Jesus obtained/got a young donkey and sat/rode on it, just as is written in the Scriptures:
- They brought/gave Jesus a young donkey, and he rode on it. In this way he fulfilled what the Scripture says:

Finding a young donkey, Jesus: This clause here indicates that Jesus found a young donkey that he could ride. The Greek word that the BSB translates as young donkey is more literally “little donkey.” However, it was sometimes used in non-biblical texts to mean “donkey” and so some English translations translate it that way here (CEV, GNT, REB). It is recommended that you translate it as “young donkey” with most English translations. That would also match “donkey’s colt” in verse 15. The verb Finding does not indicate here that the donkey was lost. Jesus’ followers brought it to him as he had told them (see Matthew 21:2-3, 6-7). This probably happened earlier, before the people went out to welcome him. So it may be natural to say:

Jesus had found a young donkey

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus obtained/got a young donkey

Someone brought a young donkey to Jesus

a young donkey: A donkey is a domestic animal that is like a small horse, but with longer ears. Riding on a donkey, rather than a horse, was associated with humility and peace in Jesus’ time. See also Genesis 49:9-11. If a ruler rode on a donkey it showed that he came in peace. You may want to write a footnote that explains what the donkey indicates. For example:

The Jews of Jesus’ time associated a donkey with peace and with humility. The horse was different because it was associated with war.

sat on it: This phrase means that Jesus rode the donkey. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

got up on it

rode on it (CEV)

as it is written: This phrase introduces a quotation from the Hebrew Scriptures, the Old Testament. See how you translated this phrase in 8:17 and Mark 1:2. Here the quotation that follows is taken partly from Zephaniah 3:16 and partly from Zechariah 9:9. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

fulfilling the prophecy that said (NLT)

just as the scripture says (GNT)

This happened just like what God prophesied in the scriptures

John 12:15**Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king**

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus’ disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:15a**“Do not be afraid, O Daughter of Zion.”**

- “City of Zion, do not be afraid!”
- “People of Jerusalem, you do not need to fear.”

Do not be afraid: This clause is probably taken from Zephaniah 3:16. It means that the people of Jerusalem should be happy and not afraid that their king was coming to them. He was peaceful. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Fear no more (REB)

You do not need to be afraid

There is no need for fear

O Daughter of Zion: This phrase refers to the city of Zion (Jerusalem) and its people. They are referred to as a young woman, Daughter of Zion. See also Isaiah 1:8, 62:11. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

city of Zion (GNT)

people of Jerusalem (CEV)

12:15b

See, your King is coming, seated on the colt of a donkey.”

- See! Your king is coming to you, sitting/riding on a donkey’s colt!”
- Here comes your king, riding peacefully on a young donkey!”

See: This word indicates that there is something important that people should see: the coming of the king. See how you translated this word in John 1:29. Translate it here in a way that is natural in your language to get people to notice and think about something. For example:

Mark this

Look (NRSV)

your King is coming, seated on the colt of a donkey:

The fact that the king rode on a donkey’s colt (young donkey) implied that he came in peace. See Zechariah 9:9. It may be necessary to make this information explicit. For example:

your king comes to you in peace, riding on a young donkey

here comes your king, sitting/riding peacefully on a young donkey

the colt of a donkey: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the colt of a donkey refers to the animal mentioned in 12:14, a young donkey. The word colt means “young horse or donkey.”

John 12:16

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9

and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus’ disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:16a

At first His disciples did not understand these things,

- When these things happened, Jesus’ disciples did not understand that all these things fulfilled scripture/prophecy.
- Jesus’ disciples did not understand about the prophecies at that time.

At first His disciples did not understand these things:

The phrase His disciples refers to Jesus’ disciples. They did not realize then that Jesus’ action fulfilled a prophecy in the Scriptures. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

His disciples did not understand this at the time (GNT)

His disciples did not understand these things when they first happened (NET)

At that time Jesus’ disciples did not realize that what happened fulfilled this prophecy.

At first: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as At first here means “at that time” or “when they happened.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

At the time (REB)

when they first happened (NET)

Jesus’ disciples did not understand yet

His disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” or “followers.” These learners committed themselves to their teacher in

order to learn from him, and they followed his teaching and example. See how you translated this term in 2:15b and 12:4.

these things: This phrase refers to what happened in verses 12–15. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

this (NCV)

all this (NIV)

what happened

12:16b

but after Jesus was glorified

- After Jesus was given glory,
- Later when Jesus received/entered his glory,

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (12:16a) to a positive statement (12:16b–c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

At first, Jesus' disciples did not understand. But after he had been given his glory, they remembered all this. (CEV)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

At first his disciples did not understand all this. Only after Jesus was glorified did they realize that these things had been written about him and that these things had been done to him. (NIV)

after: This phrase introduces the time when the disciples finally understood.

Jesus was glorified: This clause refers to the time when God glorified Jesus by raising him to life and then taking him up to heaven. Only then would God send the Holy Spirit (see 7:39) and the Holy Spirit help the disciples understand (see 14:26). The verb was glorified is passive. There are at least two ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

after he had been given his glory (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Jesus had received his glory

God had glorified him/Jesus

12:16c

they remembered what had been done to Him,

- they remembered that they had done these things to him,
- they realized that, by what they did to him,

they remembered what had been done to Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as had been done to Him is more literally “they did these things to him.” The Greek pronoun they almost certainly refers to the disciples. Most commentaries interpret it as referring to the disciples. One English translation (GW) explicitly mentions the disciples here. All other English translations use “they,” which clearly refers to the disciples. A few commentaries think that it refers to the people, and some think that the pronoun is not clear. The last plural noun is “the disciples,” so if you cannot use a pronoun or a passive here, it is good to refer to the disciples. The disciples remembered what had happened and realized that what they (and others) did for Jesus fulfilled the Scriptures. They welcomed him as their Messiah as he rode into Jerusalem on a donkey as the Scriptures said he would. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

they had done this for him (GNT)

this was what had happened to him (NJB)

the disciples remembered that they had taken part in fulfilling the prophecies (GW)

12:16d

and they realized that these very things had also been written about Him.

- and that the prophets had written these things about him.
- the prophecies had been fulfilled.

and: The word and connects all that what was done to him with the things written down about him.

they realized that these very things had also been written about Him: After Jesus' resurrection and ascension the disciples remembered what was written in the Old Testament about the Messiah. They realized

only then that prophecies in the Scriptures referred to Jesus. It may therefore be natural to say:

realized that these things had been written about him (NLT)

these very things had also been written about Him:

This clause indicates that the verses in the Scriptures that were quoted in 12:15 refer to Jesus. The prophets had written these things down many years before Jesus came, but they wrote about Jesus. The verb phrase had also been written is passive and there are at least two ways to translate it:

1. Use a passive verb. For example:

these things had been written about him (NLT)

1. Use an active verb. For example:

the scripture said this about him (GNT)

Use the expression that is most natural in your language in this context.

John 12:17

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus' disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:17a

Meanwhile, many people continued to testify that they had been with Jesus

- The crowd that was with Jesus continued to tell other people what they had seen
- The people who had been present kept telling others what they saw Jesus do

Meanwhile: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Meanwhile indicates that the narrative is returning to the time before Jesus died. Nearly all English translations do not translate the word. Introduce this change of time in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Now (NIV)

many people: The phrase many people here refers to the people who were with Jesus when he raised Lazarus from the dead (11:19, 31). These people may have been part of the bigger crowd mentioned in 12:12. The words “had been with Jesus” tell who these people were. They were those who were with Jesus earlier. Here is another way to say this:

the people who had been with Jesus (GNT)

The fact that these people had been with Jesus implied that they watched Jesus and saw what he did. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the crowd that had been present and watched Jesus...

continued to testify: This phrase indicates that the people who saw Jesus raise Lazarus continued testifying (telling others what they saw). They did so regularly and often. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit what they testified about. For example:

were continuing to testify about it (NET)

kept telling what they had seen and heard (REB)

kept talking about him and this miracle (CEV)

testify: To testify means “to tell what one has personally seen and heard.” See how you translated this in 5:31–33.

12:17b

when He called Lazarus from the tomb and raised him from the dead.

- when he called Lazarus from the tomb and raised him from the dead.
- when Jesus called Lazarus to come from his burial place, bringing him back to life.

when He called Lazarus from the tomb and raised him from the dead: Jesus had commanded Lazarus to leave the tomb. His command gave Lazarus life and made it possible for him to obey. See 11:43. It was by calling Lazarus from the tomb that Jesus raised him to life. In some languages it may be natural to show this connection by translating 12:17b in this way:

when, calling Lazarus from the tomb, Jesus raised him from the dead

call Lazarus from the tomb, raising him from the dead (NLT)

from the tomb: This tomb was a cave that had a stone over it. See the notes on 11:17, 38. The stone had already been removed when Jesus called to Lazarus to come out.

raised him from the dead: The pronoun him refers to Lazarus. Jesus caused Lazarus to come back to life again. Lazarus returned to a normal human life. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

brought him back to life (GW)

General Comment on 12:17

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse as two separate sentences. For example:

There had been many people with Jesus when he raised Lazarus from the dead and told him to come out of the tomb. Now they were telling others about what Jesus did. (NCV)

John 12:18

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus' disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:18

That is also why the crowd went out to meet Him, because they heard that He had performed this sign.

- And these people, because they heard about the miracle he did, went out to greet/welcome Jesus.
- Because they heard about this miraculous sign, these other people went out to greet/welcome Jesus.

That is also why the crowd went out to meet Him, because they heard that He had performed this sign: This verse explains why the crowd was so eager to meet Jesus. The people had heard that Jesus had raised Lazarus from the dead. There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek texts do not include the word meaning also. For example:

Because they had heard that Jesus had performed this miraculous sign, the crowd went out to meet him. (NET) (NIV, RSV, ESV, GNT, NET, NLT, REB, GW, CEV, NCV)

1. Other Greek texts include the word meaning also. This makes this a second reason for people going out. The first reason is in verse 12: the great crowd that went to the festival heard that Jesus was coming. The second reason is that they heard that Jesus had raised Lazarus to life. For example:

This was another reason why the crowd came out to receive him: they had heard that he had given this sign. (NJB) (BSB, KJV, NRSV, NJB, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The majority of English translations follow this option. The ESV is therefore used in the Display:

The reason why the crowd went out to meet him was that they heard he had done this sign. (ESV)

the crowd: This crowd is first mentioned in 12:12. The people in this crowd had heard about the miracle because the other (smaller) crowd mentioned in 12:17a told them about it. Consider how it is most natural to refer to this group of people. For example:

Many people (NIV)

He had performed this sign: This clause refers to Jesus raising Lazarus from the dead. This miracle was a sign that showed that Jesus was the Messiah. The word performed here means “did.”

General Comment on 12:18

The BSB states the action and then its cause, while some English versions describe the cause of the action first. Follow the order that is most natural in your language. For example:

That was why the crowd met him—because they heard that he had performed this miracle. (GNT)

Because the crowd heard that Jesus had performed this miracle, they came to meet him. (GW)

John 12:19

Section 12:12–19: Jesus entered Jerusalem as a king

This section tells about Jesus entering Jerusalem while riding a donkey. The people honored him by shouting praises and waving palm branches. This fulfilled the prophecy about the Messiah in Zechariah 9:9 and showed that he came as a peaceful king. Jesus’ disciples did not understand what was happening at that time. The people went out to welcome him because they heard that he raised Lazarus from the dead.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

A crowd welcomed Jesus to Jerusalem

Jesus arrived in Jerusalem with honor

Palm Sunday

12:19a

Then the Pharisees said to one another, “You can see that this is doing you no good.”

- So the Pharisees said to one another, “You^(plur) can see you^(plur)/we^(incl) are not having any success against Jesus.
- At this the Jewish leaders complained to each other, “You^(plur) can see that things are not going well for us^(incl).
- Then the Pharisees said among themselves, “It is clear that we^(incl) are failing to stop/silence Jesus.

Then the Pharisees said to one another: This expression introduces the response of the religious leaders to what the people were saying and doing in 12:17–18.

They were unhappy to see the crowds welcoming and praising Jesus.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is more literally “therefore.” In this context it indicates the result of the crowd going to meet Jesus. The Pharisees were anxious and felt hopeless when they saw the crowd welcoming Jesus into Jerusalem. In some languages it may be natural to indicate this by saying, for example:

At this

Seeing this

When they saw the crowd praising Jesus

Pharisees: The Pharisees were a strict Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. See how you translated this word in 11:47, 57.

You can see that this is doing you no good: This sentence indicates that the Pharisees felt hopeless and upset because they had not succeeded in stopping Jesus. The authorities had not yet arrested him. They felt that they were failing and that he was defeating them. Translate this in a natural way in your language to express defeat, disappointment, and being upset. For example:

You can see that nothing is going right for us.
(NCV)

You can see we are getting nowhere (REB)

we are not succeeding at all! (GNT)

Although the KJV translates this sentence as a question, it is the only English translation to do so. It is recommended that you follow most English translations and use a statement. However, the difference in meaning between a question and statement is small. So if translations in your area use a question, you may want to follow them.

You can see: This phrase does not refer to seeing something with your eyes but to understanding something. The Pharisees were trying to help each other realize what was happening. The Greek word here can either be a statement or a command. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

See (NIV)

It is clear that

this is doing you no good: The Pharisees realized that they had not been able to stop Jesus. The speakers were themselves Pharisees, so in many languages it may be natural to use a first-person plural pronoun here. For example:

There's nothing we can do. (NLT)

we are not succeeding at all! (GNT)

12:19b

Look how the whole world has gone after Him!"

- Look at how everyone in the world is following him!"
- Look at all the people following Jesus!"
- See how many people have begun to follow him!"

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Look is an exclamation calling on people to see something. It introduces what the Pharisees saw that made them upset and feeling hopeless.

the whole world has gone after Him: The phrase the whole world refers to the people in the world. This clause is an exaggeration because not everyone in the world followed Jesus. The clause just indicates that very many people had gone after Jesus. That means that they started believing in him and following him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The whole world is following him! (GW)

Everyone in the world is following Jesus. (CEV)

Look how many people have become his disciples!

John 12:20

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus

Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:20

Now there were some Greeks among those who went up to worship at the feast.

- ¶ There were some non-Jews among the people who had gone to Jerusalem to worship at the feast/festival.
- ¶ Some Gentiles had gone with the Jews/others to Jerusalem to worship at the feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces a new event in the story. In this context it is not a time word. Many English translations do not translate this word. Introduce this new event in a natural way in your language.

there were some Greeks among those who went up to worship at the feast: It was not only Jewish people who went to Jerusalem at this time. Some Greeks (Gentiles) went also. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Some Greeks were among those who came to worship during the Passover festival. (GW)

Some Greeks had gone to Jerusalem to worship during Passover. (CEV)

some Greeks: The word Greeks refers to people who were not Jews by birth. They were Gentiles, speakers of the Greek language. The word Greeks in the New Testament does not refer to people from the country of Greece. (It did not exist yet.) See the notes on Greeks in 7:35. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

some Gentiles (REB)

went up: This phrase is a Jewish idiom meaning "went to Jerusalem." They used this idiom because Jerusalem was built on a hill. You may want to make it explicit that they went up to Jerusalem. For example:

had gone to Jerusalem (GNT)

to worship: The Greeks went to worship God. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

to worship God

the feast: This phrase here refers to the Passover festival, when the Jews celebrated their freedom from being slaves to the Egyptians. See the note on 2:13. You may want to make it clear which festival it was. For example:

the Passover Feast (NCV)

John 12:21

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus

Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:21a

They came to Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee,

- They went to Philip, who was from the town of Bethsaida in Galilee,
- These men/Gentiles went to see the disciple named Philip, who was from a town in Galilee called Bethsaida.

They came to Philip: The Greeks approached one of the disciples, Philip. See how you spelled his name in 1:43.

who was from Bethsaida in Galilee: This clause gives some additional background information about Philip. Consider how it is natural to present this background information. You may want to put it in parentheses. For example:

(he was from Bethsaida in Galilee) (GNT)

Bethsaida: Bethsaida was a town that had many people living there who were not Jewish. It is also mentioned in 1:44.

Galilee: This word is the name of one of the provinces or districts in Palestine. See how you spelled it in 1:43a and 2:1a.

12:21b

and requested of him, “Sir, we want to see Jesus.”

- with a request. They said “Sir, we^(excl) would like to meet Jesus.”
- They asked him to introduce them to Jesus.

and requested of him: This phrase introduces an implied request. The Greeks told Philip what they would like, and by implication asked him to make that happen. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and asked him (ESV)

and they requested

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir was the normal polite way to address an adult male. Use a form of address that is natural and polite in your language.

we want to see Jesus: This clause indicates that these non-Jews wanted to meet with Jesus and talk with him. They were asking Philip to introduce them to Jesus. For example:

we want to meet Jesus (NLT)

we would like to meet Jesus (GW)

Please take us to Jesus.

we: The word we here is exclusive. It does not include Philip himself.

John 12:22

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus

Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:22

Philip relayed this appeal to Andrew, and both of them went and told Jesus.

- Philip went to tell Andrew. Andrew and Philip then both told Jesus.

- Philip told another disciple, Andrew, and they both told Jesus what the Greek people had said.

Philip relayed this appeal to Andrew: This clause means that Philip told another disciple, Andrew, what the Gentiles had asked. Andrew was Simon Peter's brother. They, like Philip, were from the village of Bethsaida (1:44).

relayed this appeal to Andrew: In some languages it may be necessary to supply an object indicating what Philip told Andrew. For example:

told this to Andrew

told Andrew what they had said/asked

and both of them went and told Jesus: This clause means both the men went to Jesus to tell him about the Greeks and their request. In some languages it may be natural to avoid repeating the men's names. For example:

Then the two of them went to Jesus and told him.
(CEV)

In some languages it may be more natural to mention the content of what they told Jesus. For example:

they told Jesus what the Greeks/Gentiles had said

John 12:23

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus
Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:23

But Jesus replied, "The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified."

- ¶ Jesus replied, "This is the time for the Son of Man to receive glory."
- ¶ Jesus answered them, "Now is the hour/time when God will glorify me, the Son of Man."

But Jesus replied: Jesus' answer was in response to Andrew and Philip and also to the Greeks. The Greek has a plural pronoun "them" that the BSB leaves implied. If you translate the pronoun, it is good to translate it as a general pronoun referring to all these people, not the two disciples alone.

The hour has come: The phrase The hour refers to the time Jesus had been waiting for. That was the time he would suffer, die, and rise again. This time had now come. It would not, however, take place in the next 60 minutes. So it may be necessary to refer to "time" instead of hour. For example:

The time has come (NET)

it is now the time

for the Son of Man to be glorified: The word for here introduces which hour/time Jesus was talking about. He was referring to the time when he would receive glory from God. This would be the time when he would suffer, die, rise from the dead, and return to heaven. The verb be glorified is passive and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The time has come for the Son of Man to be given his glory. (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The hour has now come for the Son of Man to receive great glory. (GNT)

Now the time has come for the Son of Man to enter into his glory. (NLT)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally "the Son of the human/person." Jesus used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. For example:

the True Man from God/Heaven

See how you translated this in 1:51 and 3:13b. In some languages it may be necessary to use a first person pronoun to indicate that Jesus referred to himself. For example:

for me, the Son of Man,

John 12:24

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus

Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:24a

Truly, truly, I tell you, unless a kernel of wheat falls to the ground and dies,

- I tell you the truth, unless a seed/grain of wheat enters the ground and ceases to be a seed,
- Listen to this true/important saying: someone must plant/bury a wheat seed in the ground to die,

12:24b

it remains only a seed;

- it will remain just that one seed.
- or it will always stay just one seed.

12:24a–b

Truly, truly, I tell you: This expression is often used in this Gospel. It introduces something important Jesus wanted to say. He was encouraging his listeners to listen carefully and accept what he said. See how you translated this expression in 5:24 and 8:58. For example:

I tell you the truth (NLT)

I tell you for certain (CEV)

Listen to this true saying

unless a kernel of wheat falls to the ground and dies, it remains only a seed: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as unless is more literally “if not.”

Jesus was saying that if a grain of wheat did not fall into the earth and die, it would remain just a single grain. It would only become more than a single grain if it fell into the ground and died. A seed must be buried in the ground, like it was dead, in order to produce a crop.

Jesus was illustrating his own death by comparing it to the way a wheat seed is planted in the ground. It was necessary for him to die in order to bear fruit (bring people into the kingdom of God). However, he did not explain this saying and it is best that you translate it literally. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

if a seed is not buried in the ground, it cannot produce fruit

a grain of wheat must fall to the ground and die to make many seeds (NCV)

only if a wheat seed falls into the earth and dies will it become many

a kernel of wheat: The people of Palestine grew a lot of wheat in Jesus' time and used it to make bread. See how you translated wheat in Luke 3:17, 16:7 and 1 Corinthians 15:37. The kernel is the individual seed that can grow into a new wheat plant. Refer to the wheat seed in a way that is natural in your language. For example

a seed of wheat

A single grain of wheat (GW)

Jesus used a kernel of wheat as an example of a seed that must be buried in the ground in order to produce many seeds. What Jesus said about the kernel of wheat is true for any type of seed. In some cultures where wheat is unknown, it may be more natural to use a different seed. For example:

a rice seed

a maize/corn seed

a seed

falls to the ground: A wheat seed has to enter the earth in order to start to grow and produce other

seeds. Use the vocabulary that is natural in your language in this context. For example:

is dropped into the ground

is planted in the soil (NLT)

dies: When a seed is planted it does not literally die. It ceases to exist as a seed and grows into a young plant. A seed that actually dies does not produce more seeds. But Jesus was giving an illustration of his own death and burial.

It is good to translate literally if possible. In some languages it may be strange or impossible to say that a seed that starts to grow is “dying.” If that is true in your language, it may be necessary to use other words. For example:

loses/surrenders its own life

ceases to live as a seed

it remains only a seed: A grain of wheat that is never planted does not become many. It stays the same and will eventually dry up and become useless. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

will never be more than one grain (CEV)

it remains only a single seed (NIV)

it remains alone (ESV)

General Comment on 12:24a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 12:24a–b. For example:

^{24b}a grain of wheat remains no more than a single grain ^{24a}unless it is dropped into the ground and dies (GNT)

^{24b}A single grain of wheat doesn’t produce anything ^{24a}unless it is planted in the ground and dies. (GW)

12:24c

but if it dies, it bears much fruit.

- But if the seed ceases to live as a seed, it produces a great/large crop.

- But if the seed loses its own life, it will produce many more/other seeds.

but: The word but introduces a situation that contrasts with that in 12:24a–b. The result of not dying in 12:24a–b is that the grain of wheat remains a single grain. However, the result of dying in 12:24c is that it bears much fruit.

if it dies, it bears much fruit: These clauses indicate that the wheat seed/grain that is planted grows and then produces many more seeds/grains. It does not, of course, produce fruit like bananas or oranges, which is what the English word usually means. Jesus was comparing his death and burial to what happens to a seed. A seed that is planted becomes many and produces fruit. Jesus was saying that his death would result in many people receiving life. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

If it does die, then it produces many grains (GNT)

if it dies, it bears a rich harvest (REB)

if it dies: The seed does not literally die but stops existing as a seed. See 12:24a–b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if it ceases to exist as a seed

if it loses/surrenders its own life

it bears much fruit: Literally this clause means that a single seed will produce many fruits (whether grains, vegetables, or fruits). Jesus was using this illustration to say that his death would produce many members of God’s kingdom. They would receive life because of his death. But Jesus did not explain this, so it is recommended that you translate this idea literally. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it produces many seeds (NIV)

it will produce lots of wheat (CEV)

General Comment on 12:24a–c

In this illustration, 12:24a–b discusses the negative possibility, that a seed is not planted. 12:24c discusses the positive possibility, that a seed is planted. In some languages it may be natural to discuss the positive before the negative. For example:

^{24c}a grain of wheat must fall to the ground and die to make many seeds. ^{24a}But if it never dies, ^{24b}it remains only a single seed. (NCV)

John 12:25

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus

Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks' request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:25a

Whoever loves his life will lose it,

- People who think that their own life is more valuable than anything else will lose it,
- Anyone who lives for himself only will lose his life,

Whoever loves his life: The word Whoever is indefinite. It refers to people in general, anyone and everyone who loves their life. In some languages a singular subject is more natural. For example:

The one who loves his life (NET)

If you love your life (CEV)

loves his life: This phrase here refers to loving oneself above all. It means to live a selfish life, thinking mainly about one's own desires and goals. If your readers may not understand a literal translation in this way, it may be necessary to use different words. For example:

loves himself (REB)

love their own life above all

always seek first what will benefit themselves

will lose it: This phrase indicates that these people will destroy their lives, here and into eternity. Their lives will be ruined, completely losing whatever good they had. They will not receive true life, eternal life.

The Greek verb is in the present tense, indicating something that is always true. However, the event

is also something that can be considered as future. Use the tense that is natural in your language in this context. For example:

destroys it (NET)

will destroy them (GW)

12:25b

but whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life.

- while those people who do not consider their life in this world to be valuable will have true life forever.
- but the one who gives away his own life in this world will actually preserve it forever.

but: This word here introduces an idea that contrasts with 12:25a, telling what happens if someone hates his life. In some languages it may therefore be natural to use a word that makes the contrast explicit like the BSB does.

Some English translations do not translate this word. Translate this connection in a way that is natural in your language.

whoever hates his life in this world: The phrase hates his life is an expression used in contrast to "loves his life" in 11:25a. It means that compared to their love for God, it seems like hate. It does not mean that they really hate their life. It means that these people do not consider their own life on earth as the most important thing. They are willing to sacrifice their own desires and ambitions in order to serve God and others. They believe that God and his service are more important than themselves. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Those who care nothing for their life in this world (NLT)

those who consider that their lives in this world are not valuable

those who refuse to consider themselves the most important

his life in this world: This phrase refers to life on earth. This person does not concentrate his attention on his earthly life and his worldly ambitions. He does not consider valuable anything that the world offers, including money, power, and reputation.

will keep it for eternal life: This phrase indicates that this person will never lose true life, which is spiritual life. He will never be separated from God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will keep it for eternity (NLT)

will keep true life forever (NCV)

will live forever

keep: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as keep means “guard.” However in some languages it may not be natural or possible to say that one keeps or guards one’s life. Here are other possible ways to translate this verb:

will be kept safe for eternal life (REB)

you will be given eternal life (CEV)

for eternal life: The word eternal refers to something that does not end. The phrase eternal life refers to life with God that never ends. See how you translated eternal life in 3:15–16. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

unending life

life that never ends

living forever with God

General Comment on 12:25

In some languages it may be natural to use the second-person pronoun as the subject. For example:

^{25a}If you love your life, you will lose it. ^{25b}If you give it up in this world, you will be given eternal life. (GW)

John 12:26

Section 12:20–26: Some Greeks wanted to meet Jesus
Some Greek people went to Philip to ask to meet Jesus. Jesus responded to the Greeks’ request by giving the illustration of a seed that must die to produce fruit.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Some Greek people asked to see Jesus

Some Greeks sought Jesus

12:26a

If anyone serves Me, he must follow Me;

- Anyone who wants to serve me must follow me,
- Those who want to serve me must follow after me.

If anyone serves Me: The word anyone refers in general to anyone who wants to serve Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to use a different general pronoun. For example:

Whoever (NRSV)

All those (NLT96)

those (GW)

serves: This word here means “obeys a Lord and master.” The person who serves Jesus does not act to benefit himself or to please himself. He listens to what Jesus his master wants him to do and does that. Here are other ways to translate this word:

wants to serve me (NET)

wants to be my disciple (NLT)

wants me to be your master

he must follow Me: This phrase indicates that this person is required to go where Jesus goes. Jesus was going to the cross and death, and his servants must be willing to die also.

12:26b

and where I am, My servant will be as well.

- and he will come and be with me wherever I am.
- In this way my servants will always be with me.

and where I am, My servant will be as well: The phrase where I am refers to any place where Jesus is. His servant must follow him wherever he goes. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because my servants must be where I am (NLT)

so that my servant will be with me where I am (GNT)

My servants will be with me wherever I am. (CEV)

My servant: This phrase refers to the person mentioned in 12:26a. This person obeys Jesus and helps him in his work in this world. If you used a plural subject there, you will probably want to use a plural subject here also. For example:

my servants (NLT)

as well: This word indicates that the person who helps Jesus will be there in addition to him.

12:26c

If anyone serves Me, the Father will honor him.

- My Father will honor the person who serves me.
- God the Father will give honor/praise to anyone who serves me.

If anyone serves Me, the Father will honor him: God the Father will give honor to those who serve Jesus, to anyone and everyone who serves. Use the noun or pronoun that is natural here in your language. For example:

If you serve me, my Father will honor you. (CEV)

If people serve me, the Father will honor them. (GW)

And the Father will honor anyone who serves me. (NLT)

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate whose Father he is. For example:

my Father (GNT)

honor: The Greek word that the BSB translates as honor is the same word that is used in 5:23 for honoring both God and Jesus. Here the word indicates that God will praise and reward those who serve Jesus.

John 12:27

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus' death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus' death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' death will attract people to himself

What Jesus' death would do

12:27a

Now My soul is troubled,

- ¶ "Now I am troubled.
- ¶ "At this time I am very disturbed/upset.

Now: This word in this context is a time word, referring to the time when Jesus spoke.

My soul is troubled: The phrase My soul refers to Jesus himself. In some languages it is more natural to use a different body part, such as "my heart." Or it may be natural to use the pronoun "I." For example:

I am very troubled. (NCV)

Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language.

troubled: The Greek word that the BSB translates as troubled means "in distress, upset, confused." Jesus felt distress because he knew he would soon die a painful death that would cause him shame. He knew that it would be very difficult and he did not know how he should pray. Here are other ways to translate this word:

in distress

painful

12:27b

and what shall I say?

- What shall I say?
- How should I pray?

and what shall I say?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used to express uncertainty (state of being uncertain). Jesus expressed that he was uncertain about what or how he should pray to God. There are two ways to translate this uncertainty:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

what am I to say? (NLT)

- Use a statement: For example:

I don't know what to say. (CEV)

Translate this uncertainty in a way that is most natural in your language.

12:27c

'Father, save Me from this hour'?

- Shall/Should I say, 'Father, save me from this time of suffering'?
- Should I ask God my Father to keep/protect me from this time when I must suffer?

'Father, save Me from this hour'?: This expression is a short way of saying "Should I say, 'Father save me from this hour'?" This is a rhetorical question. The KJV treats this as a real request that Jesus made to his Father, but then he realizes that he came for that reason. Since nearly all English translations translate this clause as a rhetorical question, it is recommended that you do the same. However, if the major language translations in your area follow the KJV, you may want to follow it as well. The meaning is not very different. Jesus was suggesting a possibility that he knew was not good. He was suggesting the possibility that he ask God to save him from being crucified. He already understood that he would not and must not pray that prayer.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Shall I say, 'Father, do not let this hour come upon me'? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

But I must not ask my Father to keep me from this time of suffering. (CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in the way that is most natural in your language.

Father: Jesus addressed God as his heavenly Father.

save Me from this hour: This clause means "keep me from having to experience this time of suffering." Jesus knew that the time when he would suffer and

die was now very close. However, it would not happen in the next 60 minutes. It may therefore be natural to translate this phrase using a more general word than hour. For example:

save me from this time of suffering (GW)

General Comment on 12:27b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two questions in 12:27b–c into one. For example:

^{27a}Now I am very troubled. ^{27b–c}Should I say, 'Father, save me from this time'? (NCV)

^{27a}Now my soul is deeply troubled. ^{27b–c}Should I pray, 'Father, save me from this hour'? (NLT)

12:27d

No, it is for this purpose that I have come to this hour.

- No. It was for this very purpose of giving life to others that I have come to this time of death.
- No, I should not pray that. I came to earth in order to give my life for many.

No: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as No is more literally "but." This conjunction introduces a contrast to the idea that Jesus might ask God to save him from suffering and dying. Here are other ways to translate this word:

But (NLT)

No, but (NET)

it is for this purpose that I have come to this hour:

This clause explains why Jesus' answer to his own question must be, "No." The phrase this purpose seems to point back to 12:23–24. Some commentaries think that it points forward to 12:28a. Then the reason that Jesus came to this hour was to glorify the Father's name. However, "Father, glorify your name" is more of an invitation than a reason. Even so, it is a possible understanding. Jesus came to this time of his life on earth in order to be glorified and give life to others. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that this purpose refers to glorifying Jesus or giving life to others. For example:

I came to this time so I could give life to many people

I came to this time of my death to give life to many others

Some English translations either say or imply that Jesus is talking about coming to the earth rather than to this hour. That is not what the Greek says and it is recommended that you not follow those translations. Also, some translations say that the reason for Jesus coming was to suffer. But Jesus is really talking about the reason for his suffering here. That reason is either to be glorified or to give life to others, as seen in 12:23–24.

for this purpose: This phrase introduces the reason Jesus came to this hour. As seen in the above note, it points back to 12:23–24. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that is why I came (GNT)

this hour: The word hour does not literally mean “60 minutes.” Here it means “time” in a general way (not a specific time like 2:30 p.m.). The phrase this hour refers to Jesus’ time of suffering, his death on the cross for man’s sin. In some languages it may help to make this explicit. For example:

this hour of suffering (GNT)

John 12:28

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ death will attract people to himself

What Jesus’ death would do

12:28a

Father, glorify Your name!”

- Father, glorify yourself!”
- My Father God, reveal/display your glory!”

Father: This word refers to God. Jesus was praying to God his Father.

glorify Your name: This phrase here means “reveal your glory/greatness” or “show people how great/wonderful you are.” The phrase Your name refers to God himself. His name represents who he is. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

bring glory to yourself (CEV)

honour your own name! (JBP)

reveal your greatness

12:28b

Then a voice came from heaven: “I have glorified it,

- Then a voice from heaven said, “I have glorified myself,
- Then God spoke from heaven, “I have already revealed/displayed my glory,

Then: This word introduces what happened in response to Jesus’ prayer to God.

a voice came from heaven: This clause indicates that God spoke from heaven. In some languages it may not be natural to say that a voice came. It may be more natural to use a different verb to describe what a voice does. For example:

a voice spoke from heaven (GNT)

A voice from heaven then said (CEV)

these words were spoken in heaven

If your readers will not understand that this refers to God, it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

God spoke from heaven

I have glorified it: The word I refers to God. He had already glorified his name (it refers to his name, which represents himself). That means that he revealed his greatness through the miracles Jesus did. People were already praising God for the wonderful things he was

doing through Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have brought glory to it (GNT)

I have already brought glory to myself (CEV)

I have honoured it (JBP)

I have already revealed my glory/greatness

12:28c and I will glorify it again.”

- and I will glorify myself again.”
- and I will do so/it again.”

I will glorify it again: This clause indicates that God would again reveal his greatness. This refers to the resurrection of Jesus, but you should not say this in your translation. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and I will give it glory again (GW)

and I will do it again (NCV)

it: This pronoun again refers to God’s name, representing God himself.

John 12:29

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ death will attract people to himself

What Jesus’ death would do

12:29a

The crowd standing there heard it and said that it had thundered.

- People in the crowd there heard the voice and said that it had thundered.
- Some of the crowd there who heard God speak said, “That was thunder.”

The crowd standing there heard it: The phrase The crowd standing there refers to the people who had just heard Jesus speak about his future suffering. These people heard God’s voice from heaven. But they did not know what the sound was. In some languages, you may want to make clear what the crowd heard. For example:

When the crowd heard the voice (CEV)

The crowd that was standing there heard the sound of the voice

and said that it had thundered: The subject of said is the crowd. It was not all the people in the crowd, however. Some of the crowd thought that it was an angel (see 12:29b). So in some languages it may be necessary to say:

some of them said it was thunder (GNT)

some thought it was thunder (NLT)

it had thundered: In some languages it may be natural to translate thundered as a noun rather than a verb. For example:

it was thunder (NRSV)

General Comment on 12:29a

In some languages it may be natural to translate the indirect quotation “it was thunder” as a direct quotation. If this is true in your language, adjust the verb tense as necessary. For example:

some of them said, “It is thunder.”

12:29b

Others said that an angel had spoken to Him.

- Some of the others said, “An angel has talked to him/Jesus.”
- Other people said that one of God’s angels spoke to Jesus.

Others said: These words refer to other people in the crowd.

an angel had spoken to Him: These other people thought the sound from heaven was the voice of an angel. They thought that an angel spoke to Jesus.

an angel: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angel means “messenger.” It refers here to a spirit being who serves God. Sometimes God sends an angel to tell a message to a person. He also sends angels to serve him in other ways. Here are some ways to translate this term:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already use a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term communicates the biblical meaning. If some people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to indicate the meaning in some way. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a sacred angelos spirit

Be sure that your term for “angel” is different from your terms for “prophet” and “apostle.” See angel in KBT.

General Comment on 12:29b

In some languages it may be natural to translate what these other people said as an indirect quotation. For example:

Others said that an angel spoke to him.

John 12:30

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ death will attract people to himself

What Jesus’ death would do

12:30

In response, Jesus said, “This voice was not for My benefit, but yours.”

- ¶ Jesus said to them, “The voice was for your benefit, not mine.
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “These words were spoken more to help you than to help me.

In response, Jesus said: John did not say that the crowd asked Jesus a question. In some languages it is therefore more natural to use a word other than In response. For example:

Then Jesus told the crowd (CEV)

This voice was not for My benefit, but yours: Jesus said that the voice from heaven was for the benefit of the people, the listeners. God spoke his words to Jesus, but he intended them to help the people who were listening.

This voice was not for My benefit: The phrase This voice refers to what the crowd heard. God wanted the crowd to know that he had answered Jesus’ prayer, even though they could not understand what he said. Just knowing that God spoke to Jesus was a big benefit to the people. In some languages it may not be natural to say that the voice was not for something. It may be more natural to follow one of these models:

The voice was not for my benefit

This voice did not speak for my sake

God did not speak for my benefit

but yours: This phrase is a short way of saying “This voice was for your sake/benefit.” It indicates that the

voice was more for the crowd's benefit than for Jesus' benefit. For example:

This voice came more to help you than to help me.

General Comment on 12:30

In the Greek text and the BSB, the negative statement (not for my sake) comes first, followed by the positive statement (but for your sake). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Translate this verse in a natural way in your language to emphasize the positive statement. In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek word order. For example:

Jesus said, "This voice has not come for my benefit but for yours...." (NET)

Jesus replied, "That voice wasn't for my benefit but for yours...." (GW)

Jesus said to them, "That voice which you heard, it was not for me but rather for you...."

Jesus said, "That voice was not heard because of me. It was because of you...."

John 12:31

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus' death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus' death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' death will attract people to himself

What Jesus' death would do

12:31a

Now judgment is upon this world;

- Now this world is going to be judged.

- Now is the time to judge the people of this world.

Now judgment is upon this world: This clause refers to the time that Jesus would die on the cross, now very near. This was the time for the judgment of this world, when this world would be judged. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Now is the time for judgment on this world

Now the time has come for judging the people of this world

By judging Jesus and condemning him to die on the cross, people were actually judging and condemning themselves. When they put Jesus on the cross to die, they showed how evil they were. But the cross was also God's judgment on the world, a judgment that Jesus accepted to suffer himself. Jesus endured being judged and condemned instead of the world, even though the world deserved it and Jesus did not.

The noun judgment refers to an action, the act of judging and condemning. So in some languages it may be natural to translate it using a verb. Here are examples of passive verbs:

Now is the time for this world to be judged. (GNT)

This world's people are now being judged. (CEV)

Now punishment is being decided on this world.

In some languages it may be necessary to use an active verb and supply a subject. However, it is difficult to know what the subject should be. John 5:22 says that the Father judges no one. Here it seems that the cross judges the world, or the world judges itself, or Jesus' word would judge them (see 12:48). This is not the last judgment, but one that happened at that time. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Now is the time to judge this world.

Now we will see the guilt and punishment of this world.

Now: This word here is a time word. It can also mean "very soon." The Greek text emphasizes this word, using it twice in this verse. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Now is the time (NCV)

The time has come

At this very time

judgment: This word refers to the decision about whether someone is guilty or not and what his punishment should be.

world: This word here refers mainly to the evil world system and those people who were part of it. It refers to everything and everyone that were opposed to God.

12:31b

now the prince of this world will be cast out.

- Now the one/oppressor who rules this world will be sent/chased away.
- The evil one who rules this world is about to lose his power.
- Now he/God will throw out the demon ruler of this world.

now: This word is again a time word which can also mean “very soon.” Jesus knew that he would soon die and by his death he would defeat Satan. See how you translated this word in 12:31a.

the prince of this world: This phrase means “the one who rules the people of the world” and here refers to Satan. Try to translate this phrase in a way that implies that this ruler is not human and that he is evil. For example:

the evil one who rules this world

the great oppressor who rules this world

will be cast out: This phrase here means “will be defeated and thrown out.” The text does not say whether Satan would be driven out from earth or from heaven. It is best not to make this explicit. Your translation should indicate that Satan would lose his authority. He would no longer have the power to rule the world.

This verb phrase is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it.

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the ruler of this world is already being thrown out! (CEV)

the leader of demons will be removed

- Use an active verb. For example:

the Father will throw out the evil ruler of the whole world

now will be the time of the defeat of Satan who rules the world

John 12:32

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ death will attract people to himself

What Jesus’ death would do

12:32a

And I, when I am lifted up from the earth,

- And I will be lifted/raised up from the earth to die,
- And/But when they lift/raise me above the earth on a cross,

I: The Greek text emphasizes the word I, which refers to Jesus.

when I am lifted up from the earth: This clause refers to the time when people would kill Jesus by nailing him to a tall cross. See the notes on 3:14a–b and 8:28. The people listening understood that Jesus meant that he would die (see 12:33–34). This clause could also refer to his resurrection and being exalted, but the main idea is that of his crucifixion.

The verb phrase I am lifted up is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

if I am lifted up above the earth (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

when they lift me up from the earth to die

when people raise me up above the earth on a cross

12:32b

will draw everyone to Myself.”

- and then I will make all people want to come to me.”
- I will cause all the peoples of the world to come to me.”

will draw everyone to Myself: This phrase indicates that through his death Jesus would cause all kinds of people to come to him to trust him. This was his answer to the Greeks who wanted to meet him. Greeks would also be able to come to Jesus. The word draw here means “cause to come.” It means that Jesus would attract all kinds of people so that they would want to come to him. He would not force people to come to him against their will. See how you translated the verb draw in 6:44. For example:

I will cause all people to believe in me.

I will make everyone want to come to me (CEV)

everyone: This phrase in this context implies “all different races and kinds of people.” Jesus will bring to himself everyone, Gentiles as well as Jews, slave as well as free. It does not mean that every person would come to him, but anyone could come if they wanted.

John 12:33

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ death will attract people to himself

What Jesus’ death would do

12:33

He said this to indicate the kind of death He was going to die.

- He said this to indicate how he was going to die. (GW)
- (Jesus was talking about the way that they/people would kill him.)

He said this to indicate the kind of death He was going to die: This sentence is a parenthetical comment by the author John. See the General Comment on 12:33. The expression He said this refers back to Jesus saying that he would be lifted up from the earth (12:32a). Here is another way to translate this sentence:

By saying this, he indicated how he was going to die (GW)

to indicate the kind of death He was going to die:

This phrase means that Jesus was telling them indirectly how he would die. The Greek word that the BSB translates as indicate means “show,” “make known,” or “make clear.” Jesus knew that he would die on a cross. He used a figure of speech, “lifted up from the earth,” to let the people know how he would die. Here are other ways to translate this whole sentence:

Jesus was talking about the way he would be put to death. (CEV)

Jesus said this to show how he would die. (NCV)

the kind of death He was going to die: This phrase refers to the way that Jesus would die. It is best not to say that he would be crucified, though if necessary you can include it in a footnote. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the kind of death he would die (NJB)

how he would die (NCV)

General Comment on 12:33

Verse 12:33 is a parenthetical statement by the author John. It explains the background of Jesus’ words. In some languages it may be natural to show that this

is background information by using parentheses. For example:

(In saying this he indicated the kind of death he was going to suffer.) (GNT)

(Now he said this to indicate clearly what kind of death he was going to die.) (NET)

John 12:34

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus' death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus' death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' death will attract people to himself

What Jesus' death would do

12:34a

The crowd replied, “We have heard from the Law that the Christ will remain forever.”

- ¶ The crowd replied/responded to him, “We^(excl) know from our^(excl) Law that the Messiah will live forever,
- ¶ The crowd said to Jesus, “The Christ will live forever. That is what the Scriptures tell us^(excl).”

The Greek text includes a word that indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical comment in verse 33. Many English translations, including the BSB, do not translate this word. Others use parentheses in verse 33 to mark the beginning and end of the parenthetical comment. Indicate that this is a return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

The crowd replied: These words indicate that the crowd responded to Jesus' statement. They responded by making a statement and then asking Jesus a rhetorical question.

We have heard from the Law: This expression introduces something the crowd had learned from their

teachers. They had heard people preaching from the Hebrew Scriptures (our Old Testament) and saying that the Messiah would live forever. They understood that when Jesus called himself “Son of Man,” he was saying that he was the Messiah. But they did not understand how Jesus could be the Messiah and be “lifted up” (crucified). Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Our Law tells us (GNT)

We understood from Scripture (NLT)

The Scriptures teach (CEV)

We: The Greek text emphasizes this word. It refers to the crowd and to the Jewish people in general. Even though Jesus was also Jewish, the crowd emphasized the words We and “you,” which indicates a contrast. So the word We does not include Jesus and it is best to translate it as an exclusive pronoun.

the Law: This phrase often refers to the books of Moses, the five books from Genesis through Deuteronomy. Here, however, the people are thinking of the whole Old Testament. In some languages it is more natural to say that. For example:

We have heard from the Scriptures (GW)

the Christ will remain forever: This clause indicates that the Christ, the Promised Savior, will never die. Here is another way to translate this clause:

the Messiah will live forever (GNT)

the Christ: The BSB translates literally the Greek text as the Christ. The Jews used this title to refer to the special person whom God had appointed and promised to send as King and Savior. The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” so the two words have the same meaning: “anointed one.” See KBT, Christ, Messiah, 1a and 2. See how you translated Christ in 1:20 and 4:25. Because the Greek here is Christ, you may want to use that word here, as many English translations do.

General Comment on 12:34a

The crowd was not quoting a specific verse of Scripture. The verse that is the closest to what they say is Psalm 89:36, which says, “His line shall continue forever.” What they say here was just their general

understanding of the teaching they had heard. It is probably best to leave this as an indirect quotation if possible. If it is necessary to use the form of a direct quotation, try to be as general as possible. For example:

We have heard that the Law says, “The Messiah shall continue forever.”

12:34b

So how can you say that the Son of Man must be lifted up?

- so how can you say, ‘The Son of Man must be lifted up from the earth’?
- You should not say that they must lift up the Son of Man above the earth to die.

So how can you say that the Son of Man must be lifted up?: This is a rhetorical question. It was used to emphasize that you cannot say that or possibly to confirm that you cannot say that. The people assumed that once the Messiah came he would live forever. They did not understand that there were other Scriptures that talked about his death. They did not think that the Messiah would die, so what Jesus said confused them.

There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

So how can it be true that the Son of Man must be lifted up to die?

What do you mean by saying that the Son of Man must be lifted up? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

We cannot understand why you say that the Son of Man must be lifted up to die.

you: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun you. It is singular and refers to Jesus.

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus referred to himself as the Son of Man in 12:23. Jesus used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.

2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings and is the same as you used in 12:23. See also KBT Son of Man.

General Comment on 12:34b

This sentence includes an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as direct speech. For example:

How can you say, ‘The Son of Man must be lifted up’? (NET)

12:34c

Who is this Son of Man?”

- What ‘Son of Man’ is this?”
- What kind of Son of Man are you?”

Who is this Son of Man?: This is a real question. If the Son of Man was the Messiah, the crowd did not understand how he could die. They were confused by what Jesus said and asked him to make things clear. They wanted to know who the Son of Man that Jesus talked about was, what kind of person he was. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Who is this Son of Man you are talking about? (NLT)

What kind of Son of Man is this?

Son of Man: Use the same expression that you used in 12:23 and 12:34b. If you made it clear that this refers to Jesus, it may not be possible to say “Who is this Son of Man?” It may be necessary to translate the question in a different way. For example:

What do you mean by the words/phrase Son of Man?

What does “Son of Man” mean?

John 12:35

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus' death would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' death will attract people to himself

What Jesus' death would do

12:35a

Then Jesus told them, "For a little while longer, the Light will be among you.

- ¶ So Jesus told the crowd, "The light will be among you^(plur) just a little while longer.
- ¶ Then Jesus told the people, "It is only for a short while more that you^(plur) will have the/my light.

Then: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Then is often translated "therefore." Many English translations do not translate this word. Others do translate this word. Translate this connection in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So (ESV)

Jesus told them: The word them refers to the crowd.

For a little while longer, the Light will be among you: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor the Light represents Jesus. He is like light in that he shows/ reveals things as they truly are. He reveals the true God to people.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate it:

- Make it explicit that Jesus is the source of light. For example:

My light will shine out for you just a little while longer. (NLT)

- Change the metaphor to a simile and make it explicit that Jesus is the one like the light. For example:

I am like a light that will be with you a little longer.

For just a little more time I, who am like a light which shines on you, will be with you.

a little while longer...will be among you: This phrase indicates that Jesus will be with them just a little while more. (The Greek text emphasizes the phrase a little while longer.) After that, Jesus implied, he would no longer be with them. It may be natural to use the future tense for the verb. For example:

will be with you for a little longer (NCV)

will still be with you for a little while (GW)

12:35b

Walk while you have the Light,

- Keep going while you^(plur) still have the light
- Continue on your way while you have the light, (GNT)

Walk while you have the Light: The word Walk is a command to keep on going to continue following Jesus, as long as it is possible. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Continue on your way while you have the light (GNT)

Go on your way while you have the light. (NJB)

Walk in the light while you can. (NLT)

while you have the Light: While they still have Jesus with them, the people need to listen to him and believe him. Jesus was implying that he would not always be with them. Refer to how you translated the metaphor of the Light in 12:35a. Also check that your readers understand that Jesus continued to refer to himself. For example:

while I am with you to give you light

12:35c

so that darkness will not overtake you.

- before the darkness reaches you^(plur).
- so that you^(plur) will not find yourself walking in dark places.

so that: This phrase introduces a purpose clause. It introduces the reason why the people should walk in the light.

darkness will not overtake you: This is a metaphor. In this metaphor, darkness represents evil. People who do not believe in Jesus will not know the truth about God. So spiritual darkness will overcome them, and they will not know what is true or how they should live. In your translation, help your readers understand the meaning by implying that darkness is an evil thing to be avoided. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the darkness may not come upon you (GNT)

the darkness will not catch you (NCV)

overtake: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as overtake can mean “to suddenly seize someone like an enemy.” It can also include the idea of overcoming and gaining control over someone or something. The same verb is used in John 1:5b (darkness is unable to overcome the light), Mark 9:18 (an evil spirit seized a boy), and 1 Thessalonians 5:4 (a day cannot overtake you like a thief). Refer to the notes on those verses and use a verb that refers to the sudden arrival of some enemy. For example:

seize you

overcome you

General Comment on 12:35c

In some languages it may not be natural to talk about “darkness” as though it were a person that can “overtake” or overcome someone. It may be more natural for the pronoun “you” to be the subject of the clause. For example:

so that you will not be suddenly walking in the dark

so that you will not find yourselves walking in dark places

12:35d

The one who walks in the darkness does not know where he is going.

- If you^(plur) walk in the dark, you will not know/see the way.
- The person who walks in the dark cannot see where he is going.
- People who walk in dark places do not know where they are going.

The one who walks in the darkness does not know where he is going: This is a metaphor or illustration of a spiritual truth. In this figure of speech darkness again represents evil. People who refuse to believe in Jesus, the light, are separated from good. They cannot know the truth about God and what he is like. They cannot know how loving and holy he is. They cannot know how he wants them to live. They walk in spiritual darkness. Two English translations, KJV and GNT, supply the word “for” (meaning “because”) before “the one who walks in the dark does not know where he is going” (GNT). The Greek conjunction translated “for” usually means “and” (see NJB), though there could be a reason implied here. It is recommended that you follow BSB and not translate this word. However, if a major translation in your area includes a word like “for,” you may want to follow it.

The metaphors of “light” and darkness are important in scripture. So it is recommended that you keep the metaphor in your translation. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Whoever walks in the dark does not know where they are going. (NIV)

Those who walk in the dark don’t know where they’re going. (GW)

He who walks when it is dark cannot find the good/right path to walk on.

General Comment on 12:35d

The BSB follows the Greek and translates this verse part in the third person. In some languages it may be more natural to express the idea in second person. For example:

If you walk in the darkness, you do not know where you are going. (NRSV)

John 12:36

Section 12:27–36b: Jesus talked about his death

Jesus spoke about his coming death. He said that he was disturbed by what was going to happen, but that was why he came to earth. He prayed that his Father God would reveal his glory in Jesus’ death. God answered that had already revealed his glory and that he would do it again.

Jesus said that the time had now come for God to judge the world and drive out Satan. And Jesus’ death

would attract people to him. But the people there were confused because they did not think that the Messiah would die. Jesus told them to believe in the light, which was himself.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' death will attract people to himself

What Jesus' death would do

12:36a

While you have the Light, believe in the Light,

- Believe in the light while you^(plur) still have it,
- Have^(plur) faith in me as your light while I am still here with you,

While you have the Light: This clause continues the metaphor or illustration. In this metaphor Jesus compares himself to Light that is present, shining, for a little while longer. The way that Jesus is similar to Light is that both show people the truth about things. Jesus shows people the truth about who God is. In some languages a literal translation of this picture may be difficult to understand. As in 12:35a, it may be natural to change the metaphor to a simile and make it explicit that Jesus spoke about himself. For example:

While you have me who is like a light

While you have me with you as your light

you: The word you is plural and refers in general to the people there.

believe in the Light: This clause continues the metaphor of Jesus as light. In some languages it may again be natural to indicate that this was a reference to Jesus. Or if you did that in the previous clause, you may refer back to that clause. For example:

believe in me, your true light

believe in me for I am like a light for you

believe in that light

This clause includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it

should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases (without the metaphor) in 1:12b, 2:11c, and 3:16b. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Have faith in the light (CEV)

you should trust in the light (Yakan Back Translation)

General Comment on 12:36a

In many languages it may be natural to reorder these clauses. For example:

Believe in the light, then, while you have it (GNT)

Put your trust in the light while there is still time (NLT)

12:36b

so that you may become sons of light."

- so you^(plur) may become like children of light."
- so you^(plur) will become God's children, children of the true light."

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces the result of believing in the light. Those who believe in the light become children of light.

you may become sons of light: The word you is plural. It refers to the people listening to Jesus, and to anyone who might hear about Jesus and believe. Jesus was saying that those who trusted in him would become like him, his children.

sons of light: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as sons of light. The Jewish idiom "sons of (something)" refers to people who are described by that quality. So sons of light are people who live in the light of Jesus and belong to him. Their character is like that of the light. They have God's character in them, and they love what he loves and hate what he hates. See how the same phrase is used in Luke 16:8, Ephesians 5:8, and 1 Thessalonians 5:5.

In some languages a literal translation of this idiom may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate it:

General Comment on 12:35–36b

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

you will be like sons/children of the light

- Change the metaphor to simile and make explicit the way that they are similar. For example:

you will become like the light, like sons of light

- Indicate something of the meaning of the figure of speech. For example:

so that you will become people whose lives are like that of the light

you will become God's children, children of the true light

The phrase "the Light" does not refer to the sun. It refers to Jesus, the way to truly know God. If your readers might think of the light of the sun, moon, and stars, you should make the meaning clear. It may be possible to imply this by indicating that Jesus is the "true" or "real" light. For example:

The true/real light will be with you just a little longer. Walk in this light while you can...

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:36c

After Jesus had spoken these things, He went away and was hidden from them.

- ¶ After Jesus had said these things, he left and went into hiding. (CEV)
- ¶ Jesus said all these things, and then went away, out of their sight. (JBP)

After Jesus had spoken these things: This clause indicates that the next event happened immediately or soon after Jesus finished talking about the light. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

After saying these things (NLT)

After these words (REB)

Having said this (NJB)

He went away and was hidden from them: The phrase He went away indicates that Jesus left the people he had been talking to. The phrase went away means "left." He went to a place that they did not know about so that they could not find him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he went off and hid himself from them (GNT)

Jesus went away from them into hiding. (REB)

Jesus left them and was hidden from their sight. (NJB)

was hidden from them: There are two ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as hidden here:

1. It means "hid himself." For example:

Jesus left and hid himself from them. (NIV) (NIV, ESV, RSV, NRSV, NASB, CEV, GNT, REB, KJV, NET, NCV)

1. It means was hidden. It is implied that God the Father was the one who hid Jesus. For example:

Jesus left them and was hidden from their sight. (NJB) (BSB, NLT, NJB, GW)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations.

John 12:37

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:37a

Although Jesus had performed so many signs in their presence,

- Even though Jesus had done a great number of miracles while they were there,
- Although they had seen Jesus perform so many miracles, (GW),

Although Jesus had performed so many signs in their presence: This clause indicates a true situation: Jesus had performed (done) so many signs in their presence. The word *Although* indicates that the result of that situation (12:37b: “they did not believe in him”) was not expected. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Even after Jesus had done all these miraculous signs in their presence (NIV)

Though Jesus had done many miracles in front of the people (NCV)

Even though he had performed all these miracles in their presence (GNT)

Jesus had performed so many signs in their presence: This clause indicates that these people saw Jesus performing (doing) miracles/signs. In some languages it may be natural to say this with the people as the subject. For example:

Although they had seen Jesus perform so many miracles (GW)

signs: This word refers to miraculous and powerful deeds. These deeds were signs, meaning that they showed that Jesus was the Messiah, the Chosen Savior. See how you translated this word in 2:11a and 6:26b.

in their presence: This phrase means “in the presence of the crowd.” These people saw and heard everything Jesus did.

12:37b

they still did not believe in Him.

- the Jews still would not believe in him.
- they were still not willing to have faith in him (CEV).

they still did not believe in Him: This clause tells the unexpected result of the situation in 12:37a. The same people who saw Jesus do signs/miracles refused to

believe in him. This means that they did not believe him when he told them who he was. But it also means that they did not trust Jesus instead of themselves or someone else. See how you translated a similar clause in 12:36a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

most of the people still did not believe in him (NLT)

they were still not willing to have faith in him (CEV)

This is a general statement. Some of the people did believe. So in some languages it may be natural to make that explicit. For example:

Most of the people still did not believe in him. (NLT)

General Comment on 12:37a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the unexpected result in 12:37b by following this example:

He had worked a lot of miracles among the people, but they were still not willing to have faith in him. (CEV)

John 12:38

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:38a

This was to fulfill the word of Isaiah the prophet:

- This fulfilled the word/message Isaiah the prophet spoke/wrote:
- Their lack of faith actually fulfilled what the prophet Isaiah said/wrote:

This was to fulfill the word of Isaiah the prophet: In the Greek text this is a purpose clause: This happened

in order to fulfill Isaiah's prophecy. The word This refers back to the fact that the Jews in general did not believe in Jesus. Isaiah had predicted that people would not be willing to believe in Jesus, and this actually happened. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that the word of Isaiah the prophet would be fulfilled (NET)

for the prophet Isaiah's words had to be fulfilled (REB)

This happened so that what the prophet Isaiah had said would come true (CEV)

to fulfill: The verb fulfill in this context means "complete a prophecy" so that what was prophesied happens. The things that Isaiah said did actually take place. For example:

would come true (CEV)

In this way the words of the prophet Isaiah came true (GW)

the word of Isaiah the prophet: This phrase here introduces a quotation from the book of Isaiah, Isaiah 53:1. This quotation consists of many individual words, so in some languages it may be natural to make that clear. For example:

the words of the prophet Isaiah (GW)

what Isaiah the prophet had said (NCV)

Isaiah: The prophet Isaiah lived seven hundred years before Jesus was born. He wrote the book of the Old Testament that is called by his name. He is also mentioned in 1:23d.

prophet: A prophet was a man who spoke to the people as God's representative. He told people what God revealed to him. Here are some ways to translate prophet:

God's representative

a man who speaks God's words

God's message-speaker

It is good to use a general term that does not refer only to predicting the future. Although prophets did predict the future, they also gave people other messages from God. They especially told them to stop sinning and to obey God.

Try to choose a term for prophet that is different from other words which are similar in meaning. Those words include "angel," "apostle," and "preacher."

See how you translated this word in 1:21d and 1:23d, and see KBT prophet 1a.

12:38b

"Lord, who has believed our message?"

- "Lord, who believed our^(incl) message
- "Lord, not many believed our^(incl) message

12:38b consists of a quotation of Isaiah 53:1. This clause is also quoted in Romans 10:16. In both John and Romans, the word "Lord" introduces words spoken to God. The word "Lord" is not included in the original Hebrew text of the book of Isaiah. However, it is included in the Greek translation of Isaiah. John was quoting from the Greek translation of Isaiah, and you should translate his quotation as it is written. Do not try to make it match Isaiah 53:1 in your Bible.

Lord: The word that the BSB translates as Lord introduces words spoken to God. This Greek word is a form of address showing respect, meaning "master." Translate this the same way as you translate other uses of Lord when used to address God (e.g., Acts 10:14, Psalm 115:1). For example:

All-Powerful God

Ruler

In some languages people may not naturally use a word that means "master" to refer to God. If speakers of your language do not understand that Lord here refers to God, here are other ways to translate it:

- Use your word for God.
- Use your word for God and indicate that he is the Lord. For example:

God the Lord

If you include the word for God in your translation of Lord, you may want to include a footnote to give the literal Greek meaning. For example:

Here the Greek text is more literally “Lord.”

who has believed our message: This question is a quotation from Isaiah 53:1. It is a rhetorical question. It is used to emphasize a negative statement: people in general had not believed God’s message. Isaiah was emphasizing how few people had accepted the message. Most people had rejected it.

There are at least two ways to translate this statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

who believed what we told them? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

So few people have believed our message!

Translate this emphasis in a way that is most natural in your language.

our message: This phrase refers to the message the prophets told. The pronoun our is probably inclusive, because Isaiah was speaking to God, who had given him the message. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the message we told (GNT)

12:38c

And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed?”

- and to whom has the Lord shown his saving power?”
- and not many have understood your^(sing) mighty power/strength.”

And to whom has the arm of the Lord been revealed: This is a second rhetorical question. It continues the quotation from Isaiah 53:1. It is used to emphasize a negative statement that people in general had not seen the arm of the Lord. This is a figure of speech indicating that not many people believed that they were seeing God’s power at work.

There are two ways to translate this negative statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

To whom has the Lord’s power been revealed?
(GW)

Who saw the Lord’s power in this? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Not many people has the arm of the Lord been revealed to.

Very few people have seen/understood how powerful the Lord is.

Translate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

has the arm of the Lord been revealed: The verb has...been revealed is passive. It means that God has revealed his arm, meaning his power. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to whom has the power of the Lord been revealed?
(REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

To whom will the Lord reveal his saving power?
(NLT)

And who has seen your mighty strength? (CEV)

To whom will the Lord reveal how powerful he is?

Translate this verb using the verb form most natural in your language here. God did reveal his power, but only some could understand that Jesus’ miracles were evidence of God’s power. For example:

and who has seen in it a revelation of the Lord’s arm? (NJB)

Who saw the Lord’s power in this? (NCV)

the arm of the Lord: This phrase is a figurative way of saying “God’s power/strength.” In this context it refers to the miracles that Jesus did by God’s power. It is a figure of speech that emphasizes that God acts in strength and power. In some languages a literal translation may indicate that God has physical arms and that people can see them. In those languages it is necessary to speak explicitly of God’s power. For example:

the power of the Lord (REB)

Because Isaiah was addressing the Lord himself, in some languages it may be natural to use a second-person pronoun, “your.” For example:

your mighty strength (CEV)

John 12:39

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:39

For this reason they were unable to believe. For again, Isaiah says:

- The reason they could not believe was, as Isaiah says somewhere else,
- And so they were unable to believe. It was as Isaiah wrote in another place,

For this reason they were unable to believe. For again, Isaiah says: This verse introduces another quotation from the book of Isaiah. This quotation explains why many people could not believe in Jesus. The words **For this reason** and **For again** point ahead to the quotation from Isaiah in verse 40. Here are other ways to translate this verse:

Therefore they could not believe. For again Isaiah said, (ESV)

For this reason they could not believe, because, as Isaiah says elsewhere.... (NIV)

And there is another saying of Isaiah that explains why they could not believe (REB)

they were unable to believe: These people were unable to believe. When the word believe is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying “believes

in Jesus.” So this clause includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. These people could do neither. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

The people could not have faith in Jesus (CEV)

they were not able to trust in Jesus

they could not believe in him

For again, Isaiah says: This phrase introduces another quotation from the Old Testament book of Isaiah (Isaiah 6:10). That quotation explains why the people could not believe. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because, as Isaiah says elsewhere (NIV)

for as Isaiah also said (NLT)

It was as Isaiah said in another place

John 12:40

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:40a–c

John 12:40 is a free (not exact) quotation of Isaiah 6:10. This verse is also quoted in Matthew 13:13–15, Mark 4:12, Luke 8:10, and Acts 28:26–27. The exact words of the quotation are not the same in each place, but the meaning is the same.

12:40a

“He has blinded their eyes and hardened their hearts,

- “He has made their eyes blind and their hearts hard/stubborn
- “It is like he has made them blind to spiritual things and closed their minds to the truth,
- that the Lord has prevented them from understanding and accepting what they see.

He has blinded their eyes: It is implied that the pronoun He refers to God. However, in Isaiah, God commands Isaiah to do this. And the other quotations of this verse in the New Testament do not say that it was God. So it is good to not make clear who blinds (makes blind) their eyes. Just use a pronoun. For example:

Their eyes he had blinded

However, it was God’s will to blind their eyes, even if Isaiah did it. And John implies that it was God who acted. So if you have to identify who He refers to, you may mention God. For example:

The Lord has blinded the eyes of the people (CEV)

God has blinded their eyes (GNT)

has blinded their eyes: This phrase is a figure of speech, a metaphor. It means that the people were made unable to see or understand spiritual truth. So they could not understand the spiritual meaning of what Jesus did and said. See Deuteronomy 29:4.

This does not mean that the people wanted to see and God kept them from seeing. They are responsible for their not believing. But God’s purposes were fulfilled by their refusing to believe. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

God blinded them (GW)

- Translate it as a simile

It is like God made them blind

- Indicate some of the meaning. For example:

He has not enabled them to see spiritual things

their eyes: The pronoun their refers to the Jewish people. You may want to use a noun instead of a pronoun here. For example:

the eyes of the people (CEV)

hardened their hearts: This phrase is a figure of speech, another metaphor. The word hardened means “made hard,” so to harden one’s heart is to make it hard and stiff. It indicates that God confirmed the people in their wrong thinking so that they could not change. The meaning is similar to “has blinded their eyes.” He did not make them wise but rather allowed them to follow false and foolish thoughts. And so they could not understand who Christ was. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

hardened their hearts (NIV)

- Translate it as a simile. For example:

It is like he has made their hearts hard.

- Indicate some of the meaning. For example:

dulled their mind (REB)

closed their minds (GNT)

made the people stubborn (CEV)

Translate this figure of speech in a way that is natural and makes the meaning clear.

their hearts: The word hearts is a figurative way of referring to the center of one’s thoughts and emotions. In some languages it may be natural to refer to another body part. For example:

their minds (GNT)

12:40b

so that they cannot see with their eyes, and understand with their hearts,

- so they can neither see nor understand,
- so they can not understand what I have done for them
- This prevents them from truly seeing and understanding

so that they cannot see with their eyes: The words so that here introduce the effect or result of God's judgment. God judged the people by blinding and hardening them, and this prevented them from seeing and understanding spiritual truth. God knew that this would happen and it was part of his judgment because they refused to believe. However, it was not what he wanted to happen. He preferred that the people repent so that he could heal them. But they refused to believe. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so they can neither see with their eyes (NIV)

so that their eyes don't see (GW)

so that their eyes cannot see (NLT)

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

Otherwise they would see with their eyes (NCV)

The result is they will never see with their eyes...
(TRT)

see with their eyes: This phrase continues the metaphor begun in 12:40a. Continue to translate it in the way you did there. For example:

their eyes cannot truly see

preventing them from truly seeing

understand with their hearts: This phrase here means to understand spiritual truth. John was referring to the fact that the people did not understand who Jesus was, that he was God's Messiah. As in 12:40a, it may be natural to translate hearts as "mind." For example:

their minds would not understand (GNT)

their hearts: The word hearts refers to the center of thoughts and emotions. Translate it as you did in 12:40a, using either the singular or plural, whichever is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 12:40a-b

This verse contains an arrangement in poetry known as parallelism. In parallelism, the same idea is said twice, in different ways, in parallel lines (similar lines

next to each other). Here a similar idea is said twice in 12:40a and another idea is said twice in 12:40b. However, in many languages it may be natural to change the arrangement of the clauses. For example:

^{40a-b}He has blinded their eyes so that they might not see and hardened their minds/hearts so that they might not understand.

12:40c

and turn, and I would heal them."

- nor turn to me so that I would heal them."
- nor believe in me so I can restore them forever."
- and turning to the Lord. If they did, he would heal/save them.

and turn: These words refer to turning to God in faith. This was another result of God blinding the people's eyes and hardening their hearts. If the people could see spiritually and truly understand, they would change their thinking and trust in Jesus the Messiah. They would ask God to forgive them. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

turn to the Lord (CEV)

turn to me, says God (GNT)

I would heal them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as heal here means "restore from sin and its consequences." This clause indicates that God would certainly heal/restore the people if they turned to him in faith. He wanted to forgive them and make them whole. In some languages, the word heal only refers to physical healing from illnesses. In those languages, you may want to use another word here and perhaps say in a footnote that the word can mean "heal." For example:

I would restore them

I will heal/save them (TRT)

General Comment on 12:40

In this verse the pronoun referring to God changes from "He" in 12:40a to "I" in 12:40c. If this confuses your readers, it may be necessary to make it explicit that God is speaking in 12:40c. For example:

and they would not turn to me, says God, for me to heal them (GNT)

John 12:41

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

12:41

Isaiah said these things because he saw Jesus' glory and spoke about Him.

- Isaiah said this long ago because he saw the Lord's glory and told about him.
- Isaiah the prophet wrote this long ago because he saw how glorious/great the Lord is and wrote about him.

Isaiah said these things because he saw Jesus' glory and spoke about Him: The words Isaiah said these things refer to what Isaiah wrote that is quoted in 12:40. He wrote that because he had a vision of the Lord's glory. See Isaiah 6:1. This was about six hundred years before Christ was born.

these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as these things is plural. If it is more natural in your language to use a singular word, you should use it. For example:

this (NRSV)

because he saw Jesus' glory: This clause explains why Isaiah wrote what he did. He saw the glory of the Lord (Isaiah 6:1–3). John here identifies “the Lord” with Jesus Christ. When Isaiah saw the glory of the Lord, he was in some way seeing the glory of Jesus Christ.

Jesus' glory: The Greek word that the BSB translates as glory here refers to something that reveals greatness, majesty, and power. See KBT glory 2b. In some languages it may be natural to translate this word using an adjective. For example:

that he was glorious

how great he was

and spoke about Him: This phrase here indicates that what Isaiah wrote refers to the Lord, Jesus. For example:

and his words referred to Jesus (NJB)

John 12:42

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

Paragraph 12:42–43

This paragraph tells about the Jewish people who did put their faith in Jesus.

12:42a

Nevertheless, many of the leaders believed in Him;

- ¶ However, many Jewish people, even among the leaders, did believe in Jesus.
- ¶ At that same time, however, many Jewish leaders were among those who put their faith in Jesus.

Nevertheless: This word introduces a contrast. The contrast is with the main theme of the previous paragraph, that not many people believed in Jesus (12:37). Even though most people did not believe in Jesus, many did believe in him, even some of the Jewish leaders. Here are other ways to introduce this contrast:

Yet (NIV)

But (NCV)

Even though it was like that

many of the leaders believed in Him: The word many means “many people.” John was thinking particularly of the Jewish people. This clause indicates that not all the Jewish people rejected Jesus. Even among the Jewish leaders there were many who believed in him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

even among the rulers many believed in him (NET)

many believed in Jesus, even many of the leaders (NCV)

Many people did believe in him...including some of the Jewish leaders. (NLT)

of the leaders: The Greek phrase here contains a word that several English versions translate as “even.” The word here indicates something less expected than that many people believed in Jesus. The fact that some (or many) of the leaders believed was less expected than that regular people believed. Here is another way to translate this clause to include the word:

even of the authorities (NRSV)

leaders: The word leaders here refers to the Jewish religious leaders, members of the Sanhedrin or ruling council. The same word is used in 3:1. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Jewish leaders (NLT)

rulers (GW)

12:42b

but because of the Pharisees they did not confess Him,

- But because of their fear of the Pharisees, they did not confess/admit what they believed.
- But they would not tell other people that they believed in Jesus

but: This word contrasts the belief of the Jews with their failure to confess that they believed in Jesus.

because of the Pharisees: This phrase states the reason that these believers did not confess that they believed. They were afraid that the Pharisees would no longer allow them to worship in the synagogue (see 12:42c).

the Pharisees: This phrase refers to the members of a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. See the note on 11:46a and how you translated the word there.

they did not confess Him: This clause indicates that those who believed did not say so publicly. They did not tell other people that they believed in Jesus. The

pronoun they could refer to all those who believed, although many think that it just refers to the authorities who believed. If possible, use a pronoun that could refer to either group. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they would not confess Jesus to be the Christ (NET)

they wouldn't admit it publicly (GW)

they did not say they believed in him (NCV)

12:42c

for fear that they would be put out of the synagogue.

- They were afraid they would be expelled/banned from the synagogue.
- because they were afraid the Pharisees would throw them out of the Jewish worship building.

for fear that they would be put out of the synagogue: This is a negative purpose clause. The Jews did not say in public that they believed in Jesus because they wanted to avoid something. They were afraid that the Jewish leaders would reject them and expel (remove) them from their religious community. They did not want this to happen. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that they would not be put out of the synagogue (ESV)

so as not to be expelled from the synagogue (GNT)

they would be put out of the synagogue: This clause refers to some kind of possible punishment for those who believed in Jesus. Scholars disagree about whether this was a temporary and limited punishment (banned from being a leader) or something more serious. If more serious, they might not even allow that person to worship in the synagogue. See also the note on 9:22b. The verb would be put out is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

being banned from the synagogue (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

the Pharisees would have thrown them out of the synagogue (GW)

the synagogue: A synagogue was a building where Jews gathered to pray, read the Scriptures, teach their beliefs, and worship. The Jews also gathered there for cultural activities. There was only one temple (in Jerusalem), but there were many synagogues. Each Jewish community had its own synagogue. So the phrase the synagogue does not refer to one specific synagogue, but to the synagogue system in general. The believers feared they would be forbidden to attend the meeting of any synagogue. Here are some ways to translate synagogue:

prayer-house of the Jews

meeting-place of the Jews

worship building

house for gathering together

Consider using a footnote that contains some of the information above. See the note and how you translated synagogue in 9:22b. See KBT, synagogue.

General Comment on 12:42

This verse appears to give two reasons why these believing Jews did not confess Jesus. First, it was because of the Pharisees, and second, because they would be put out of the synagogue. It was the Pharisees who would put them out of the synagogue, so it may be natural to combine these two ideas into one clause. For example:

However, they wouldn't admit it publicly because the Pharisees would have thrown them out of the synagogue. (GW)

But they wouldn't admit it for fear that the Pharisees would expel them from the synagogue. (NLT)

John 12:43

Section 12:36c–43: The Unbelief of the People

This paragraph discusses the unbelief (lack of belief or faith) of many of those who heard Jesus and saw his miracles. Many of them rejected him, as the Hebrew Scriptures prophesied. Others did believe but remained silent, afraid that they themselves would be rejected.

Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The Jews still did not believe

Many Jews refused to have faith in Jesus

Paragraph 12:42–43

This paragraph tells about the Jewish people who did put their faith in Jesus.

12:43

For they loved praise from men more than praise from God.

- They acted like this because they wanted/liked to receive praise from people more than they wanted/liked to receive praise from God.
- They wanted people to praise/honor them more than they wanted God to praise/honor them.

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here means “because.” It introduces a reason why these Jews did not want to be thrown out of the synagogue.

they loved praise from men more than praise from

God: The word they refers to the believers who did not confess that they believed in Jesus. They wanted people to accept and praise them more than they wanted God to praise them. They cared more about what people said about them than what God said about them. Consider how it is natural to make this comparison. For example:

they loved human praise more than the praise of God (NLT)

They were more concerned to have the approval of men than to have the approval of God. (JBP)

In some languages it may be natural to make this comparison using opposite or contrasting statements. For example:

They wanted people to praise them and/but they did not care if God praised them.

The praise of humans was important to them; the praise of God did not matter.

praise from men: This phrase here means “the glory that humans give” or “honor/praise from other people.” See KBT Glory 3. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

what people thought of them (GW)

praise from God: This phrase refers to the honor and praise that God gives to a person who does what pleases him. See KBT Glory 3. It is recommended that you translate praise here the same way that you translated it in “praise from men” just above.

John 12:44

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus’ word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:44a

Then Jesus cried out, “Whoever believes in Me

- ¶ Then Jesus spoke publicly, “The one who believes in me,
- ¶ Then Jesus shouted aloud, “If you^(plur) have faith in me,

Then: This word introduces what happened next, a new event in the story.

Jesus cried out: This phrase indicates that Jesus spoke loudly or shouted. He was speaking publicly and announcing something important. See how you translated this word in 1:15 and 7:28. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Jesus proclaimed (REB)

Jesus shouted out (NET)

In a loud voice Jesus said (CEV)

Whoever: This word refers to any person that believes in Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to follow one of these examples:

The one who (NET)

Everyone who (CEV)

If you (NLT)

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 3:16b, and 12:36a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

has faith in me (CEV)

trust me (NLT)

12:44b

does not believe in Me alone, but in the One who sent Me.

- he does not only believe in me but also believes in God who sent me.
- you^(plur) really have faith in God as well, because he sent me to you.

does not believe in Me alone, but in the One who sent Me:

This expression emphasizes that faith in Jesus includes faith in God. A person who believes in Jesus also believes in the one who sent him. For example:

believes not only in me but also in the one who sent me (GW)

you are trusting not only me but also God who sent me (NLT)

is really believing in the One who sent me (NCV)

does not believe in Me alone: The word alone is implied in this Greek phrase. You may need to make this word explicit, as the BSB does. See the above examples for other ways to say this. Translate the word believe the same way you did in 12:44a.

but: The Greek word the BSB translates as but shows a contrast and emphasizes what follows. As the word “only” was implied in “believes not in me,” so “also” is implied here. The one who believes in Jesus does not only believe in him but also believes in God the Father.

the One who sent Me: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages you may want to make that explicit. For example:

God who sent me (NLT)

John 12:45

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus' word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:45

And whoever sees Me sees the One who sent Me.

- And the one who looks at me, that person sees my Father who sent me.
- And if you^(plur) see me, you^(plur) are seeing God who sent me to this world.

And whoever sees Me sees the One who sent Me:

Jesus was saying that he was one with God, which is similar to what he said in 12:44. Seeing Jesus was the same as seeing God. As in 12:44a, the word whoever refers to anyone and everyone who sees Jesus. Use the subject that is most natural in your language. For example:

and the one who sees me sees the one who sent me (NET)

And everyone who has seen me has seen the one who sent me. (CEV)

For when you see me, you are seeing the one who sent me. (NLT)

John 12:46

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus' word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:46a

I have come into the world as a light,

- I have come into the world to be its light
- I have come to the people of the world to give them true/spiritual light

I have come into the world as a light: In this clause, Jesus clearly compared himself to light, as he did in 8:12b, 9:5b, and 12:35a,b. He came into the world to be its light. The Greek text emphasizes the word I.

This clause contains a simile. Jesus was like light in that he showed people the truth, especially about God and salvation. In some languages a literal translation of this simile may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate this simile:

- Make the simile clearer. For example:

I have come into the world to be like a light for you/it.

- Make the point of similarity explicit. For example:

I have come into the world like a light, to show/reveal God/truth to you

12:46b

so that no one who believes in Me should remain in darkness.

- so that no one who believes in me should have to live in the dark any longer.
- so that all people who have faith in me will be able to leave the darkness.

so that: This phrase introduces Jesus' purpose in coming into the world to be its light.

no one who believes in Me should remain in darkness: In some languages it may be natural to use the subject "everyone" and a negative verb. For example:

everyone who believes in me should not remain in the darkness (NRSV)

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See

how you translated similar phrases in 1:12b, 3:16b, and 12:44a. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

has faith in me (CEV)

put their trust in me (NLT)

should remain in darkness: The phrase remain in darkness is a figure of speech, a metaphor. The word darkness represents evil. Jesus came so that those who believe in him would no longer continue to live in evil. Those who remain in evil are like those who remain in darkness in the following ways:

1. They live in fear.
2. They do not know the truth, how things truly are.
3. They cannot see/know the right way to act.

See how you translated the idea of darkness in 8:12c and 12:35d. For example:

in the dark (GW)

in dark places

in a dark world

In some languages this figure of speech may be hard to understand. Here are other ways to translate it:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. For example:

they should not remain in what is like darkness

they should not live as though they were in the dark

- Make the meaning of the metaphor more explicit. For example:

they should not live in spiritual darkness

they need not live in the darkness of evil

John 12:47

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in

everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus' word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:47a

As for anyone who hears My words and does not keep them, I do not judge him.

- I am not the one who will judge those who refuse to obey my teachings. (CEV)
- Those who hear my words but do not obey them do not receive judgment/condemnation from me

As for anyone who hears My words and does not keep them, I do not judge him: The Greek text emphasizes the word I, which refers to Jesus. For example:

It is not I who am the judge of those who hear my words and do not keep them.

I am not the one who will judge those who refuse to obey my teachings. (CEV)

anyone who hears My words and does not keep them: The word anyone refers to any person who has rejected Jesus. Use the noun or pronoun that is natural in your language. It may be singular or plural. For example:

those who hear me but don't obey me (NLT)

My words: This phrase refers to Jesus' message or teachings. For example:

my teachings (CEV)

my message (NLT)

what I say

and: This word introduces something that is not expected. You would expect that someone who heard Jesus' words would obey them. However, here Jesus spoke about those who did not obey. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language to indicate something not expected. For example:

but (NLT)

does not keep them: This phrase indicates that this individual does not obey Jesus' words. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

does not obey them (NCV)

I do not judge him: These words indicate that Jesus himself is not the one who condemns these people. This was not his purpose in coming into the world. Jesus referred to the future as well as the present, and in some languages it may be natural to use future tense. For example:

I will not judge (GNT)

I don't condemn (GW)

General Comment on 12:47a

In some languages it may be natural to follow the Greek text and reorder the clauses in 12:47a. For example:

If anyone hears my words and does not keep them faithfully, it is not I who shall judge such a person. (NJB)

If anyone hears my message and does not obey it, I will not judge him. (GNT)

12:47b

For I have not come to judge the world,

- That is because I did not come to judge the people of this world,
- because I did not come into the world to condemn the people of the world.

For: This word means "because" and is an introduction to the reason why he is not the judge. For example:

because (NCV)

I have not come to judge the world: The reason why Jesus came into the world was not to judge the people of the world. There was a different reason. See the General Comment on 12:47b–c for another way to order this information. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I did not come to judge the world (NCV)

I didn't come to condemn the world (GW)

judge: The word judge in this context means "condemn and punish." See KBT Judge, Judgement B.3.

the world: The phrase the world here refers to the people of the world. For example:

the people of this world (CEV)

12:47c

but to save the world.

- but to save them.
- Rather/Instead, I came to save them from being condemned.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (12:47b) to a positive statement (12:47c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I did not come to judge the people of the world; rather I came to save them.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I did not come to judge the world. I came to save the world.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I came to save the people of this world, not to be their judge. (CEV)

for I have come to save the world and not to judge it. (NLT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

to save the world: In some languages it may be natural to use a pronoun rather than repeating the noun world from 12:47b. However, that may lose some of the emphasis on the world. For example:

but to save it (GNT)

save: The Greek word that the BSB translates as save here means “rescue or free from sin.” The result is that Jesus will not judge or condemn a person that he has saved. That means that he will not punish that person.

John 12:48

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus’ word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:48a

There is a judge for the one who rejects Me and does not receive My words:

- There is a judge for the person who rejects me and does not accept my message.
- Those people who reject me and what I say will be judged.

There is a judge: The phrase means someone will judge anyone who rejects Jesus. There is someone who will judge that person. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

there is a judge for that person

there is one who will judge those people

In some languages it is more natural to use judge as a verb. For example:

someone will judge that person

will be judged (NLT)

the one who rejects Me and does not receive My words: The phrase the one who refers to anyone and everyone who rejects Jesus. It does not refer to just one person. For example:

anyone who rejects me and does not accept my words (REB)

Those who reject me by not accepting what I say (GW)

rejects Me and does not receive My words: The verbs rejects and does not receive refer to the same attitude in two different ways. They do not refer to two different things. It may be natural to use just one verb. For example:

all who reject me and my message (NLT)

everyone who rejects me and my teachings (CEV)

rejects Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as rejects means to ignore or refuse to accept. The one who rejects Jesus is someone who will not believe him and what he says.

does not receive My words: This phrase means to not accept what Jesus says as true, and therefore not follow it as a guide. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

does not accept my words (NET)

do not accept my teaching as true

General Comment on 12:48a

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in this clause and mention the judge first. For example:

There is a judge for the one who rejects me and does not accept my words. (NIV)

12:48b

The word that I have spoken will judge him on the last day.

- My message will be the judge and condemn him at the last day.
- At the end of all things, God will use what I have said here on earth to judge them.

The word that I have spoken will judge him: This clause is a figure of speech. In it, Jesus’ word (what Jesus said) acts like a person that could be a judge. It refers to the time when God will judge people as to whether they received Jesus’ word. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

the word I have spoken will be his judge on the last day (REB)

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

my word will act like it was his judge

- Make the meaning explicit. For example:

God will judge him for rejecting my word

on the last day: The phrase the last day refers to the day God ends the world and judges its people. You may want to make that clear. For example:

on the day of judgment (NLT)

John 12:49

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus' word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:49a

I have not spoken on My own,

- That is because I have not been speaking on my own authority.
- That is because what I have said was not just my own ideas.

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that means that means “because.” It introduces the reason why Jesus' word will judge those who reject it. It is because God was the original source of what Jesus said. Here is another way to translate this word:

Because

This is true, because (GNT)

I have not spoken on My own: This clause means that Jesus was not talking based on his own authority. He did not make up his own thoughts and say them. See

how you translated the phrase “on my own” in 7:17. The Greek text emphasizes the words I and My own to contrast with “the Father who sent me” in the next clause. For example:

I do not speak on my own authority (REB)

my teachings are not from my own thinking
(Yakan Back Translation)

12:49b

but the Father who sent Me has commanded Me what to say and how to say it.

- Instead, the Father who sent me commanded me about all that I should say.
- It is truly God who has sent me here and told me exactly what to say.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (12:49a) to a positive statement (12:49b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

For I have not spoken from my own authority, but the Father himself who sent me has commanded me what I should say and what I should speak. (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I have not spoken on my own. Instead, the Father who sent me told me what I should say and how I should say it. (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

The things I taught were not from myself. The Father who sent me told me what to say and what to teach. (NCV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Because the Father who sent me has commanded me about what to say and what to speak. I was not the one who decided what to say.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

the Father who sent Me has commanded Me what to say and how to say it: This clause says that God had given Jesus his message. The authority on which he spoke was not his own but God's. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the Father himself who sent me has commanded me what I should say and what I should speak (NET)

the Father who sent me has commanded me what I must say and speak (GNT)

the Father who sent Me: The words who sent Me tell something about the Father. They do not imply that Jesus had more than one Father, one who sent him and another one who did not. In some languages a literal translation may imply that Jesus had more than one Father. To avoid this wrong meaning, it may be necessary to translate this information as a separate clause. For example:

The Father sent me into this world and told me what to say.

The Greek text emphasizes the phrase the Father who sent Me. This emphasis indicates a strong contrast with Jesus ("I" and "my own" are also emphasized in 12:49a). Jesus was not the source of his words, but it was his Father instead. Indicate this emphasis and contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

but it is my Father who sent me who commanded me

the Father: The phrase the Father refers to God. In some languages it is necessary to say whose Father Jesus referred to. For example:

my Father

God my Father

has commanded Me: In some languages it may be more natural to use a noun form rather than the verb commanded. For example:

has himself given me a commandment (NRSV)

what to say and how to say it: The phrases what to say and how to say it mean the same thing. Some scholars think that there is a difference between the two phrases and the second one really means "how to speak." However, only two English translations follow that interpretation (NLT, REB) and it does not seem to fit the Greek. It is best to think about the two phrases as synonyms. Saying it twice emphasizes the idea: God told Jesus exactly what to say, or possibly everything that he should say. For example:

exactly what to say

just what I should say

about all that I should say

John 12:50

Section 12:44–50: Jesus came to save the people

Jesus taught the people about who he was and why he had come into the world. He encouraged people to believe in him and receive his word. He emphasized that he came from God and was obedient to God in everything he said. Here are some other possible titles for this section:

The need to receive Jesus' word

Believing in Jesus or rejecting him

12:50a

And I know that His command leads to eternal life.

- I know that what he commanded me to tell you will lead you to eternal life.
- I know that what God commanded me to say, this will cause/allow you to live with him forever.

And I know that His command leads to eternal life:

This sentence indicates that God's command (see 12:49b) results in eternal life. God's command brings eternal life to those who follow it. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

And I know that this command brings eternal life. (GNT)

And I know that eternal life comes from what the Father commands. (NCV)

what he has commanded causes people to live forever (TH)

His command: This phrase refers to the commandment that God gave to Jesus in 12:49b.

eternal life: This phrase refers to living forever with God, life with God that never ends. See how you translated this phrase in 12:25. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

unending life

life that never ends

living forever with God

12:50b

So I speak exactly what the Father has told Me to say.”

- So I say whatever the Father has told me to say.”
- That is why I tell you exactly what the Father has told me.” (CEV)

So: This word introduces what Jesus did because he knew that the Father’s command brings life (12:50a).

I speak exactly what the Father has told Me to say: The phrase I speak exactly refers to what Jesus had been telling the people. Jesus had said just what the Father had told him to say. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

That is why I tell you exactly what the Father has told me. (CEV)

so I say whatever the Father tells me to say (NLT)

So whatever I say is what the Father told me to say. (NCV)

the Father: This phrase refers to God. See the note on 12:49b and translate it here as you did there.

This is the second and final part or division of John’s Gospel. In this division John wrote about how Jesus fulfilled the task his Father had given him. Jesus died on the cross, was buried, and on the third day rose again. His followers saw him alive and believed that he was the Messiah, the Son of God.

The sections in this division are as follows:

13:1–20	Jesus washed his disciples’ feet
13:21–30	Jesus predicted that someone would betray him
13:31–35	Jesus gave a new commandment
13:36–38	Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him
14:1–14	Jesus is the way to the Father
14:15–31	Jesus promised the Holy Spirit
15:1–17	Jesus is the true vine
15:18–16:4b	The world would hate the disciples
16:4c–15	Jesus would send the Holy Spirit
16:16–24	The disciples’ sadness would become joy
16:25–33	Jesus had defeated the world
17:1–26	Jesus prayed to his Father
18:1–11	The authorities arrested Jesus
18:12–14	The soldiers and police took Jesus to the high priest
18:15–18	Peter denied Jesus
18:19–24	The high priest questioned Jesus
18:25–27	Peter denied Jesus again
18:28–19:16a	Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die
19:16b–27	Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross
19:28–30	Jesus died on the cross
19:31–37	A soldier put a spear in Jesus’ side
19:38–42	Jesus’ body was put in a tomb
20:1–10	Jesus’ body was not in the tomb
20:11–18	Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene
20:19–23	Jesus appeared to the disciples
20:24–29	Jesus appeared to Thomas
20:30–31	John wrote this book so that people would believe and have life
21:1–14	Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee
21:15–19	Jesus restored
21:20–25	Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

John 13:1

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:1

This paragraph gives background information for the next event in the story. It tells the time of the event and describes Jesus' thoughts.

13:1a

It was now just before the Passover Feast,

- ¶ When it was almost time for the Passover Feast.
- ¶ The Jews/people would soon celebrate the feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us.

It was now just before the Passover Feast: This phrase introduces the next event in the story by indicating that it happened immediately before the Passover Feast.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

It was almost time for the Jewish Passover Feast (NCV)

The Jewish people would soon celebrate Passover.

The Passover feast/celebration would begin very soon.

It was now: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as now often introduces a new event. Introduce this next event in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then

just before the Passover Feast: This phrase indicates that Jesus knew that his hour had come before Passover began. The Passover would begin at sunset and the meal that is mentioned beginning in 13:2 is a Passover meal. So this verse begins just before the

Passover began. Some scholars think that Passover did not begin until the following day and the GNT follows that interpretation ("It was now the day before the Passover Festival."). However, Mark 14:12 and Luke 22:15 make it clear that Jesus and the disciples ate the Passover meal this night. It is strongly recommended that you do not follow the GNT for this phrase. For example:

It was just before the Passover Festival. (NIV)

It was almost time for the Passover Feast. (NCV)

the Passover Feast: This phrase refers to a feast that the Jewish people celebrated each year. They remembered how God rescued their ancestors from being slaves in Egypt. God went to kill the first-born sons of the Egyptians so that they would allow the Jews to leave Egypt. The term Passover refers to the fact that God passed over (did not enter) the houses of the Jews. That means that he did not harm their sons.

See the story in Exodus 12. Translate this phrase as you did in 2:13 and 12:1. For example:

the Passover celebration (NLT)

the Death did not Harm Us Festival

the Rescue Feast

13:1b

and Jesus knew that His hour had come

- Jesus knew that it was his time
- Jesus was aware that this/now was the time for him

and Jesus knew that His hour had come: Jesus knew that it was now the time he had been waiting for. It was the time for him to die for his people, as he had come into the world to do. See the notes on 2:4b. It may not be natural to translate the verb come literally. For example:

Jesus knew that it was time for him (NCV)

Jesus understood that this was the time for him

knew: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as knew is more literally "having known," meaning that Jesus already knew. He did not just realize that his hour had come (see 12:23, 27). If your readers wrongly

understand that Jesus just realized this, you may need to make it clear that he knew before. For example:

already knew

His hour had come: This clause here indicates that the time for Jesus to die had come. The next day, Jesus would be killed. He would not die in the next 60 minutes, as the word hour might imply. So in some languages it may be natural to use a more general word. For example:

his time had come (NET)

13:1c

to leave this world and return to the Father.

- to leave this earth and return to his Father.
- to leave this earth and go back to his Father in heaven.

to leave this world: This phrase indicates that Jesus would no longer live on earth with his disciples. Jesus would soon die and return to his Father. The BSB translates the Greek word literally as leave. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

to depart from this world (NRSV)

and return to the Father: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as and return to the Father is more literally “to the Father.” The BSB has supplied the verb return. In some languages it may not be natural or necessary to supply a verb here. For example:

to depart from this world to the Father (NET)

This is where Jesus had been before. So in some languages it may be natural to say:

return to his Father

go back to the Father (GW)

the Father: This phrase refers to God, Jesus’ Father. See the notes on “The Father loves the Son” in 3:35a. In some languages it may be natural to make it clearer whom this phrase refers to. For example:

his Father (NLT)

his Father God

General Comment on 13:1b–c

The “hour” mentioned in 13:1b refers to the time when Jesus was to leave the world (13:1c). Make this connection clear in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus knew that his hour had come and that he must leave this world and go the Father (REB)

Jesus knew that his time had come to depart from this world to the Father (NET)

Jesus knew that the time had come for him to leave this world and go back to the Father. (GW)

13:1d

Having loved His own who were in the world,

- He had always loved those who were his own, his disciples who were with him on earth.
- He had always loved his earthly followers.

Having loved His own who were in the world: Jesus had loved his disciples during his ministry and he still loved them. The phrase Having loved implies that Jesus had always loved his own and that he continued to do so. For example:

He had always loved his own who were in the world... (REB)

loved: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as loved here refers both to having a strong affection and to showing love in action. Jesus cared deeply for his disciples and he continued to act for their welfare and blessing.

His own who were in the world: This phrase refers to Jesus’ disciples, those who followed him on earth. They were His own in the sense that God had given them to him, and they loved and obeyed and followed him. Avoid translating this in a way that suggests they belonged to Jesus as his slaves. For example:

his followers in this world (CEV)

13:1e

He loved them to the very end.

- And he still loved them to the end of his life.
- And he continued loving them, even until he died.

He loved them to the very end: There are two ways to interpret the phrase to the very end here:

1. It means to the end of his life. (BSB, GNT, ESV, NJB, REB, NET, GW, CEV, NCV, NJB, NET, NIV2011, NLT2004)
2. It means “completely,” to the full extent. For example: he now showed them the full extent of his love (NIV84) (NIV84, NLT96)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This is the interpretation followed by the great majority of English translations, and it suits the context well. Jesus understood that he had come to the end of his life on earth. Knowing this, he continued to love and show love to his followers. His death for them showed that.

General Comment on 13:1

In the Greek text John 13:1 forms one long sentence. Here is one translation that does the same:

Now before the Feast of the Passover, when Jesus knew that his hour had come to depart out of this world to the Father, having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end. (ESV)

In many languages it will be natural to break this sentence into two or three shorter sentences. For example:

Just before the Passover feast, Jesus knew that his time had come to depart from the world to the Father. Having loved his own who were in the world, he now loved them to the very end. (NET)

It was almost time for the Jewish Passover Feast. Jesus knew that it was time for him to leave this world and go back to the Father. He had always loved those who were his own in the world, and he loved them all the way to the end. (NCV)

John 13:2

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:2–5

During supper, Jesus washed his disciples’ feet. At that time people wore sandals, not closed shoes, and so their feet became very dusty and dirty. Normally servants washed their feet.

13:2a

The evening meal was underway,

- It was supper time.
- Jesus and his disciples were eating supper.

The evening meal was underway: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as The evening meal was underway is more literally “supper was happening.” Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

They were at supper (NJB)

While they were eating supper

Jesus and his disciples were at supper (GNT)

The evening meal: The Greek word that the BSB translates as evening meal refers to the last meal of the day. It was usually a large meal that took place during the evening. Here is another way to translate this word:

during supper (NRSV)

13:2b

and the devil had already put into the heart of Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot, to betray Jesus.

- ¶ The devil had already given Judas the son of Simon Iscariot the idea/desire to betray Jesus to his enemies.
- ¶ The chief of the demons had already persuaded Judas, Simon Iscariot’s son, to hand over Jesus to the authorities.

and the devil had already put into the heart of Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot, to betray Jesus:

This sentence tells about something that happened before the supper. It does not tell exactly when this happened, just that it was earlier.

the devil: This phrase refers to the chief evil spirit and the leader against God. He is also called Satan. He is the enemy of God and God’s people. Because both the devil and “Satan” refer to the same being, you may want to use the same expression for both

in your translation. Here are some ways to translate this phrase:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons. If you do this, compare what people believe about this being to what the Bible teaches about the devil. Check that what people believe is close enough to what the Bible teaches to be a suitable expression.
- Use a descriptive phrase or the literal meaning together with a descriptive phrase. For example:

the accuser, the chief of all demons

the leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

the lord of all sin

the especially bad one

- Transliterate the name “Satan.” If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Shaitan

Satanas, the ruler of demons

If you transliterate “Satan,” check that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture.

You need to use a word or phrase that the churches in the area will accept. You may also want to add a footnote or glossary definition that further explains who the devil is. For example:

The devil is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God threw him out of heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Other names for him in the Bible include “Satan,” “Beelzebul,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

See how you translated this word in 8:44a.

had already: This phrase indicates that the author is referring back to something that happened earlier, before the beginning of this event. Consider how it

is natural to refer back to something that happened earlier. For example:

Even before..., the devil had... (CEV)

had earlier

had before this time

See also the General Comment on 13:2a–b.

put into the heart of Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot: This phrase indicates that Satan had influenced or caused Judas to do something evil. The devil gave Judas the idea and desire to betray Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

put it into the mind of Judas son of Simon Iscariot (REB)

persuaded Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot

made Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot, decide (CEV)

whispered into the ear/heart of Judas, Simon Iscariot’s son

caused Judas, Simon Iscariot’s son, to think in his mind/heart

Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek texts say Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot. For example:

Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot (GNT) (BSB¹ NRSV, GNT, REB, GW, NLT, CEV, NIV2011)

1. Some Greek texts say “Judas Iscariot, son of Simon.” For example:

Judas Iscariot, Simon’s son (RSV) (RSV, KJV, NASB, RSV, NIV84, NJB, NET, NCV)

The original text is uncertain. Either reading is possible. It is recommended that you choose option (1), the reading of the UBS Greek New Testament and of 6:71a. But it is also possible to follow your local

or national language translation. The UBS Greek text chooses reading (1), giving it a C rating, indicating considerable uncertainty.

to betray Jesus: The verb betray refers to helping the enemies of someone whom one should be loyal to. Here it refers to Judas helping Jesus' enemies to arrest him. See how you translated this verb in 12:4. This was an idea that the devil had put in Judas' mind. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

betraying Jesus (GW)

to turn against Jesus (NCV)

General Comment on 13:2a–b

In the Greek text the time (supper) is mentioned before Satan's work in Judas. The BSB has used the Greek order. In some languages it may be more natural to rearrange the information into chronological order, where Satan influencing Judas is before the disciples eating supper with Jesus. For example:

^{2b}The devil had already put it into the heart of Judas son of Simon Iscariot to betray him. ^{2a}And during supper (NRSV)

John 13:3

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:2–5

During supper, Jesus washed his disciples' feet. At that time people wore sandals, not closed shoes, and so their feet became very dusty and dirty. Normally servants washed their feet.

13:3a

Jesus knew that the Father had delivered all things into His hands,

- Jesus knew that his Father, God, had given him authority over everything,

- Jesus was aware that God had given him all power.

Jesus knew that the Father had delivered all things into His hands: This expression explains some background information about why Jesus acted the way he did in 13:4–5. See the General Comment on 13:3a–4a, following the notes on 13:4a.

It may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus knew that the Father had put everything into his hands. (NJB)

The Father had put everything in Jesus' control. Jesus knew that.... So... (GW)

knew: This word refers to something that Jesus always knew. He did not just come to realize it at that time. This word is a participle and can be understood as giving a reason for what Jesus did in 13:4–5. For example:

Because Jesus knew (NET)

See the General Comment on 13:3a–4a for another example of how to express this reason connection.

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father, Jesus' Father. In some languages you may want to make that clearer. For example:

God (CEV)

his Father

had delivered all things into His hands: This phrase is an idiom meaning "had given him power over everything." God had given Jesus authority, and Jesus knew it. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

had put all things under his power (NIV)

had given him authority over everything (NLT)

had given him complete power (CEV)

13:3b

and that He had come from God and was returning to God.

- and that God had sent him to earth and that he would soon return to God in heaven.
- He also understood that he had come from God and would return to God in heaven.

and that He had come from God and was returning to God: This expression tells another thing that Jesus knew. He knew that God sent him to earth and that he would soon leave earth and return to God in heaven. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

He also knew that he had come from God and was going back to God. (GW)

John 13:4

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:2–5

During supper, Jesus washed his disciples' feet. At that time people wore sandals, not closed shoes, and so their feet became very dusty and dirty. Normally servants washed their feet.

13:4a

So He got up from the supper,

- He got up from the supper,
- He got up from where he was eating

So He got up from the supper: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as got up from the supper means “stood up.” Jesus and his disciples were reclining around a low table. (See the note and picture at 12:2.) Now Jesus stood up. It is not necessary to mention a table if it is not natural in your language. For example:

he got up from the meal (NIV)

General Comment on 13:3a–4a

It was because Jesus knew who he was, his true status and position, that he acted as he did. Here are ways to show this connection:

Because Jesus knew that the Father had handed all things over to him, and that he had come from God and was going back to God, he got up from the meal... (NET)

Jesus knew that the Father had given him complete power; he knew that he had come from God and was going to God. So he rose from the table... (GNT)

13:4b

laid aside His outer garments,

- removed his outer cloak/clothes
- and took off all his clothes except his underwear.

laid aside His outer garments: Jesus took off his outer clothing, which was a robe (cloak). He still had his inner clothes on. He was dressed like a slave ready to serve, not like an important man.

A literal translation of the BSB may imply that Jesus wore two robes and he only removed the outer one. You may want to avoid this wrong understanding by following one of these examples:

took off his robe (NLT)

took off his outer clothing (NIV)

removed his outer clothes (NET)

13:4c

and wrapped a towel around His waist.

- and tied a towel around his waist.
- He took a long piece of cloth, which he wrapped around his waist and tied,

and wrapped a towel around His waist: This phrase tells what Jesus did in order to free his hands for washing. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language. The Greek text more literally says “taking a towel he girded himself.” The old English verb “gird” means to put a belt or cloth around one’s waist.

a towel: This phrase probably refers to a long piece of linen cloth. It was long enough that Jesus could wrap it around his waist and use the loose end to dry his disciples’ feet.

John 13:5

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:2–5

During supper, Jesus washed his disciples' feet. At that time people wore sandals, not closed shoes, and so their feet became very dusty and dirty. Normally servants washed their feet.

13:5a

After that, He poured water into a basin

- Then he poured water from a large container into a bowl
- and poured water into a wash bowl/basin.

After that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as After that introduces what Jesus did next. Here is another way to translate this word:

Next

He poured water into a basin: Jesus poured water from a large container into a smaller container or basin.

basin: This word refers to a container to carry water in and pour water from. It was likely a clay pot. Here are other ways to translate this word:

washbasin (NET)

bowl (NCV)

13:5b

and began to wash the disciples' feet

- and started washing the feet of his disciples
- Then he washed the disciples' feet, one disciple after another,

and began to wash the disciples' feet: The job of washing other people's feet was considered a humble

and unpleasant one. It was normally done by women, children, or Gentile slaves.

wash: The Greek word that the BSB translates as wash refers to the removal of dirt from the body.

the disciples' feet: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples' refers to learners in a learner-teacher relationship. The learner follows his teacher in order to learn from him and live according to his teaching and example.

Here are some ways to translate "disciple":

learner/student

follower

For more information on how to translate the term "disciple" see 1:35b in the Notes. Also see disciple in KBT. Here it may be natural to make it explicit that these were Jesus' disciples. For example:

his disciples (NIV)

13:5c

and dry them with the towel that was around Him.

- and drying them with the towel he had tied around his waist.
- and dried their feet with the cloth at his waist.

and dry them: The pronoun them refers to the disciples' feet. Jesus wiped them with the towel in order to dry them. Here is a way to make that clearer:

drying them (NIV)

with the towel that was around Him: This is the towel Jesus had wrapped around his waist (13:4c). Identify this towel in a way that is natural in this context.

While the BSB translates this clause as active, it is passive in Greek, and in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as passive. The Greek text more literally says "the towel with which he was girded." The verb "girded" is no longer commonly used in English. It refers to putting a belt or piece of cloth around one's waist. There are several ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the towel that was wrapped around him (NIV)

- Use an active verb. For example

the towel he was wearing (NJB)

the towel he had wrapped around himself (NET)

- Use an expression that does not include a verb. For example:

around his waist (GNT)

John 13:6

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:6

He came to Simon Peter, who asked Him, "Lord, are You going to wash my feet?"

- ¶ When Jesus came to Peter, Peter said to him, "Lord, how can I let you wash my feet?"
- ¶ Jesus reached Peter, but Peter objected. "You should/must not wash my feet!" he said.

He came to Simon Peter: Jesus was moving around the circle of his disciples, washing each person's feet. He reached Simon Peter (who is often just called Peter). See the note about Simon Peter in 1:40a–b and how you translated the name there.

who asked Him: The pronoun who refers to Peter. Peter spoke to Jesus. He asked him a rhetorical question, so in some languages it may be natural to indicate a question. For example:

who/Peter asked him

Lord, are You going to wash my feet?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used to show surprise as well as to give a polite rebuke. The Greek emphasizes the pronouns You and my. Peter was saying that he did not think Jesus should wash his feet. He did not want Jesus to act like a slave and do this humble task.

There are at least two ways to translate this surprise and rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

You, Lord, washing my feet? (REB)

- Use a statement. For example:

Lord, you should not be washing my feet.

Lord, you must not wash my feet!

Translate this surprise and rebuke in the way that is most natural in your language.

John 13:7

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:7a

Jesus replied, "You do not realize now what I am doing,

- Jesus answered Peter, "You^(sing) do not yet understand the meaning of what I am doing for you.
- "You do not now realize what I am doing," Jesus answered him.

You do not realize now what I am doing: This clause means "You do not understand the meaning of what

I am doing.” The Greek emphasizes the pronouns You and I. Jesus was teaching the disciples to be humble and to serve one other. But at this time the disciples did not understand why Jesus was washing their feet. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You do not yet understand why I am washing your feet.

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to Peter.

now: The word now in this context refers to the time that Jesus washed their feet. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

At the moment (NJB)

In some languages a literal translation of the word now may be unnatural. Or it may not be needed because the verb “know” is present tense. In those languages it may be natural to leave it implied. For example:

You don’t really know what I am doing. (CEV)

13:7b
but later you will understand.”

- However, one day you^(sing) will understand what I am doing for you.”
- “Soon you will realize what it means.”

but later you will understand: Jesus promised that at some time in the future Peter would understand the meaning of Jesus washing his feet. He was probably referring to the near future, after his death. After Jesus died his disciples realized that he lived his whole life and died for the benefit of others.

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Peter.

General Comment on 13:7

The Greek words that the BSB translates as “realize” and “understand” are different words but in this context have about the same meaning. Therefore you may want to leave the second verb implied. For example:

You do not understand now what I am doing, but in the future you will.

John 13:8

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:8a

“Never shall You wash my feet!” Peter told Him.

- Peter said to Jesus, “You^(sing) shall never ever wash my feet.”
- Peter said to Jesus, “I will never let you wash my feet.”

Never shall You wash my feet!: In the Greek this is a strong statement. Peter rejected the idea that he would ever let Jesus wash his feet. Here are other ways to translate this statement:

Never at any time will you wash my feet! (GNT)

I will never let you wash my feet. (REB)

You may/must never wash my feet!

Peter told Him: Here Simon Peter is referred to as just Peter.

13:8b

Jesus answered, “Unless I wash you, you have no part with Me.”

- Jesus answered Peter, “If I do not wash you, you^(sing) will not belong to me.
- Jesus said, “You can only have fellowship with me if you let me wash you.”

Unless I wash you, you have no part with Me: This statement here means “If I do not wash you, you will not have fellowship or inheritance with me.” This sentence says that the washing was figuratively a

necessary condition for belonging to Jesus or being saved. It refers to the washing that cleanses people of their sins (see 13:10), not to washing his feet. However, you should not make the figurative sense explicit. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

If I don't wash you, you don't really belong to me.
(CEV)

Unless I wash you: This phrase here means "If I do not wash your feet." Here Jesus referred to literally washing Peter's feet. You may want to make this explicit. For example:

If I do not wash your feet.... (GNT)

But Jesus also spoke figuratively of cleansing Peter from his sins. It is good to translate this literally but use words that suggest or allow the possibility of the figurative meaning.

you have no part with Me: This clause refers to having no fellowship or communion with Jesus, nothing in common with him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you don't belong to me (GW)

you are not one of my people (NCV)

General Comment on 13:8b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 13:8b. For example:

You will not be one of my people unless I wash you.

You will not belong to me if I do not wash you.

John 13:9

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:9

"Then, Lord," Simon Peter replied, "not only my feet, but my hands and my head as well!"

- Peter answered Jesus, "Lord, then do not wash only my feet. Wash my hands and my head also."
- Peter said to Jesus, "Lord, because of that, wash my hands and head as well as my feet."

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means "master" or "one who has authority over others." See how you translated this word at 13:6.

not only my feet, but my hands and my head as well: Peter replied enthusiastically, indicating his desire to belong to Jesus. He said Jesus should wash his hands and head as well as his feet. In some languages it may be natural to make the verb "wash" explicit here. For example:

don't just wash my feet. Wash my hands and my head. (CEV)

You may also want to supply a word indicating that Peter said this as a result of what Jesus said. For example:

do not wash only my feet, then! Wash my hands and head, too! (GNT)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative idea ("not my feet only") to a positive idea ("also my hands and my head"). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive idea. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

Lord, wash not only my feet, but also my hands and my head! (NET)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Lord, don't wash just my feet. Wash my hands and my head. (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Then wash my hands and head as well, Lord, not just my feet! (NLT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

John 13:10

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:10a

Jesus told him,

- Jesus answered Peter,
- But Jesus told Peter,

Jesus told him: Jesus was answering Peter's request. His answer implied the response "no." In some languages it may be natural to make Peter's name explicit and also indicate that Jesus refused his request. For example:

But Jesus answered Peter

13:10b

"Whoever has already bathed needs only to wash his feet,

- "A person who has bathed does not need to wash again, apart from his feet.
- "People only need to wash their feet after bathing.

Whoever has already bathed needs only to wash his feet: This clause refers to someone who has literally bathed his whole body. It says that he does not need to wash any part of his body again except his feet. If someone bathed and then walked to another house,

his feet would get dirty, but nothing else. This clause also has a figurative meaning. It refers to those whom God has made clean from sin. Some commentaries say that it refers to baptism. However, the only other time that Jesus tells his disciples that they are clean is in John 15:3, where Jesus said, "You are already clean because of the word I have spoken to you." There he says nothing about baptism, so it is not necessary to understand 13:10 as a reference to baptism. When they sin, they do not have to be saved or completely cleansed again. They just need to be cleansed or forgiven of that new sin.

It is recommended that you translate this verse literally, because it does refer to people who have literally bathed. But translate it in a way that could also be understood to refer to people being cleansed of their sin. And you may need to make the literal meaning clearer. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

After a person has had a bath, his whole body is clean. He needs only to wash his feet. (NCV)

The person who has bathed, he does not need to bathe his body again because it is still clean. It is only his feet that should be washed.

Whoever has already bathed: This phrase refers to a person who has washed and cleaned his whole body in water. Use the phrase that is natural in your language and culture. For example:

Those who have taken a bath (GNT92)

needs only to wash: This phrase says that a person does not need to wash his whole body if he has already bathed. If just his feet are dirty, a person only needs to wash his feet. The spiritual, figurative meaning is that once Jesus has washed/forgiven someone, that person is forever forgiven. See the General Comment on 13:10b.

his feet: There is a textual issue in this verse. In some Greek manuscripts, this clause includes a Greek phrase that means his feet.

1. Most Greek manuscripts include the phrase his feet, and most English translations translate this phrase. For example:

and do not have to wash themselves, except for their feet (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, CEV, NLT, KJV, RSV, GW, NASB, NCV, NET)

1. Other Greek manuscripts do not include this phrase. This is followed by only a few English translations. For example:

Anyone who has bathed needs no further washing; (REB) (REB, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations. This is the reading of most Greek texts, including some of the oldest and most reliable manuscripts. Metzger p.77, UBS 4th ed., and Swanson p.89.

General Comment on 13:10b

You will want to avoid indicating that a person who has bathed literally never has to wash again. To do that, it may be necessary to change the way that you translate this clause. Instead of saying “does not need to wash, except for the feet,” you may want to say something like “just needs to wash his feet.” For example:

People who have bathed...need to wash just their feet (CEV)

After a person has had a bath...he needs only to wash his feet. (NCV)

13:10c

and he will be completely clean.

- His^(sing) whole body is clean.
- They are quite clean.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* here connects a negative statement (“does not need to wash”) to a positive statement (“is entirely clean”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

The one who has bathed does not need to wash, except for his feet, but is completely clean. (ESV)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Those who have had a bath need only to wash their feet; their whole body is clean. (NIV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Those who have had a bath are completely clean and do not have to wash themselves, except for their feet. (GNT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

he will be completely clean: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *completely clean* mean “his whole body is clean.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is entirely clean (NRSV)

such a person is clean all over (NJB)

their whole body is clean (NIV)

all of his body is already clean

13:10d

And you are clean, though not all of you.”

- And you are already clean, although not all of you are clean.”
- And you^(plur) are clean, but there is one of you who is not clean.”

And you are clean: This clause here means “your sins are forgiven.” Jesus has moved away from speaking literally to speaking figuratively. He was not commenting on whether his disciples had bathed. Translate *clean* using a word that can be understood figuratively.

you are clean: The pronoun *you* is plural and refers to the disciples. For example:

you disciples are clean (NET)

you, my disciples, are clean (CEV)

though not all of you: This phrase limits the previous clause. When Jesus said “you are clean,” he did not mean all of them. This phrase is a short way of saying “though not all of you are clean.” The Greek word that the BSB translates as *though* introduces the limit and emphasizes it. The implied emphasis is that Judas was not clean, but you should not make this explicit here. For example:

except for one of you (CEV)

but not every one of you (NET)

however not all of you have a clean heart

General Comment on 13:10

Jesus was giving an illustration of a spiritual truth. He compared receiving forgiveness to taking a bath, becoming clean. This verse can be understood on two levels, literal and figurative:

1. The literal meaning refers to a person who has bathed, probably earlier that day. He does not need to bathe again. Only his feet need washing.
2. The figurative meaning refers to a person whose sins Christ has forgiven. He does not need to receive complete forgiveness again but just forgiveness for his daily sins.

You will need to translate the first meaning. But you may want to put the second meaning in a footnote because it explains what Jesus meant in 13:10d.

John 13:11

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:6–11

Peter did not want Jesus to serve him in this way. Jesus told him that he needed to allow Jesus to wash his feet if he wanted to follow Jesus. Peter then asked Jesus to wash his hands and head as well as his feet.

13:11a–b

This verse gives the reader parenthetical information that explains what Jesus said in 13:10d. John was the one who added this explanation. Some English translations put this verse in parentheses. Do what is natural in your language to indicate that this is an explanation or parenthetical information.

13:11a

For He knew who would betray Him.

- For Jesus knew who would betray him to his enemies.

- Because Jesus knew who would hand him over to the authorities to capture him.

For: The connector For in this context means “Jesus said this because.”

He knew who would betray Him: Jesus knew which of his disciples would betray him. He knew that it was Judas. But you should not make this explicit here. For example:

Jesus knew the one who was going to betray him (NET)

betray: In this context the word betray means “help his enemies to arrest Jesus.” See how you translated this word in 12:4.

13:11b

That is why He said, “Not all of you are clean.”

- That is the reason he said, “Although not all of you are clean.”
- That is why he said, “But there is one of you who is not clean.”

That is why: This phrase refers to what was said in 13:11a as the reason for what Jesus said in 13:10d. (What Jesus said is repeated in the following clause). The reason that Jesus said “Not all of you are clean” is that he knew who would betray him. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

for this reason (NRSV)

He said, “Not all of you are clean”: This clause quotes what Jesus said in 13:10d. The quotation does not use exactly the same words as 13:10d, but the meaning is the same. Your readers should understand that this refers to what Jesus had just said. For example:

That’s why he said, “All of you, except for one, are clean.” (GW)

General Comment on 13:11b

In some languages it may be natural to refer back to Jesus’ words using an indirect quotation. For example:

and that was why he said not every one was clean (NIV)

John 13:12

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples' feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:12a

When Jesus had washed their feet and put on His outer garments, He reclined with them again

- ¶ Jesus finished washing his disciples' feet. He put on his outer cloak/clothes and returned to his place at supper.
- ¶ After washing his disciples' feet, Jesus put his robe/clothes back on and returned to the supper/meal.

The Greek text of this verse includes a word that indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information in 13:11. Most English translations, including BSB, do not translate that word. Some English translations close the parentheses at the end of verse 11. Indicate the return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

When Jesus had washed their feet and put on His outer garments, He reclined with them again: This expression continues the narrative by telling three things that Jesus did next. However, the emphasis is on what Jesus said after he did these three things. See the General Comment on 13:12a–b for suggestions on translating this as an independent sentence.

Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally “he,” as in the NRSV. The BSB sometimes uses names instead of pronouns in order to clarify the person to whom the author is referring. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

their feet: It may also be natural to make it explicit that the pronoun their refers to the disciples. For example:

After Jesus washed the disciples' feet

and put on His outer garments: Jesus put back on the outer garments (outer clothing) that he had taken off in order to wash his disciples' feet. See 13:4b. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

put his outer clothing back on (NET)

put on his clothes (NIV)

put his outer garment back on (GNT)

He reclined with them again: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as reclined with them again indicates that Jesus returned to where he had been reclining (leaning) with the disciples around the food. See the note on “got up from the supper” at 13:4a. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

took his place at the table again (NET)

returned to his place (NIV)

sat down (NLT)

13:12b

and asked, “Do you know what I have done for you?”

- He asked his disciples, “Do you^(plur) understand what I just did for you?”
- He told his disciples, “Let me explain what I have done for you^(plur).”

and asked: This phrase that the BSB translates as asked is literally “said to them.” Since it introduces a rhetorical question, you might want to indicate that Jesus asked a question.

Do you know what I have done for you?: This is a rhetorical question. Jesus used it to introduce an explanation. Jesus would explain why he washed his disciples' feet. There are at least three ways to translate this rhetorical question to introduce a topic.

- Use a rhetorical question like the BSB. For example:

Do you understand what I have just done for you?
(NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Let me explain what I just did.

- Use a statement followed by a tag question. For example:

You^(plur) do not understand what I just did for you, do you?

Use whichever form is most natural in your language in this context.

know: The disciples knew what Jesus had done, but not what it meant or why he did it. Here is another way to translate this word:

understand (NIV)

General Comment on 13:12a–b

The BSB has followed the Greek and translated 13:12a–b as one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to use two or more sentences. For example:

When he had finished washing their feet, he put on his clothes and returned to his place. “Do you understand what I have done for you?” he asked them. (NIV)

When he had washed their feet and put on his outer garments again, he went back to the table. ‘Do you understand’, he said, ‘what I have done to you?...’ (NJB)

John 13:13

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples’ feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:13a

You call Me Teacher and Lord,

- You^(plur) call me ‘Teacher’ and/or ‘Lord’
- You say that I am your teacher and leader

You call Me Teacher and Lord: Jesus reminded the disciples that they called him their teacher and their Lord. They called him those ways because that was how they thought about him. They considered him to be their teacher and their Lord. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

You call me your teacher and Lord (CEV)

You address me as Teacher and Lord

You speak to me saying “our Teacher” or “our Lord”

You: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples. The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. Here is one way to indicate this emphasis:

You yourselves

Teacher and Lord: Sometimes the disciples addressed Jesus as Teacher and sometimes as Lord. They did not usually use both titles together. It may therefore be natural to say:

Teacher or Lord

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher was a polite title for a Jewish religious leader. It was a title of respect for a Jewish man who had authority to teach about God. In some languages the suitable way to address a religious teacher may be:

Sir/Honored Teacher

My/Our Teacher

Master

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher. See how you translated this in 1:38c, 3:2b, 3:10a, and 8:4.

Lord: Translate this as you did in 13:9. If you normally use a possessive pronoun with this word, it may be natural to use the plural pronoun here. For example:

Our ^(excl) Master

13:13b

and rightly so, because I am.

- and you^(plur) are correct in calling me that because I am your teacher and your Lord.
- which, of course, I am.

and rightly so: This clause means “you are correct in calling me Lord and Master.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and that is proper

and do so correctly (NET)

I am: This clause means “I am your teacher and your Lord.”

John 13:14

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples’ feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:14a

So if I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet,

- Because I, your^(plur) Lord and teacher, have washed your feet,
- And even though I am your^(plur) leader and teacher, I served you by washing your feet.

So if I, your Lord and Teacher: The phrase that the BSB has translated as So if is more literally “if therefore” and means “because.” For example:

Because I, your Lord and Teacher...

The Greek text emphasizes the word I to make a contrast with the word “you” in 13:14b.

have washed your feet: It would be extremely unexpected for a Lord or Teacher to wash his disciples’ feet. Yet that is exactly what Jesus did. If Jesus could do this very humble act, then the disciples could do the same thing to each other (see 13:14b). That would involve a smaller amount of humility. The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun your to indicate a contrast with “one another’s” (also emphasized) in 13:14b.

13:14b

you also should wash one another’s feet.

- you^(plur) should serve each other by washing each other’s feet.
- So you^(plur) should serve each other in the same way, washing one another’s feet.

you also should wash one another’s feet: The Greek text emphasizes the words you and one another’s to indicate a contrast with “I” and “your” in 13:14a. Jesus tried to persuade the disciples by going from the greater to the lesser (smaller). If he (their Lord and Teacher) could wash their feet (the greater), then they could surely wash each other’s feet (the lesser). Translate this way of persuading in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

If it is proper for me, your teacher and master, to wash your feet, then you who obey and learn must also wash each other’s feet.

General Comment on 13:14a–b

In some languages it may be clearer to translate this verse as two sentences. For example:

I, your Lord and Teacher, have just washed your feet. You, then, should wash one another’s feet.
(GNT)

John 13:15

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples' feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:15a

I have set you an example

- Because I have given you an example/model to follow,
- Because I have shown you^(plur) how to serve,

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that means “because.” It introduces the reason why the disciples should wash one another's feet. Here are some ways to translate this conjunction:

Because

The reason that I did this

I have set you an example: This clause indicates that Jesus had shown his disciples how they should behave. He acted in the way that he wanted them to act. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

For I have given you an example (ESV)

I have given you an example to follow. (NLT)

I did this as an example (NCV)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all the disciples.

an example: The Greek word that the BSB translates as example here means pattern or way of life to be imitated. Jesus showed the disciples what to do by doing it himself. He had washed their feet to give them an example of humility and service. This was an example or demonstration of how they should act/ behave. Jesus wanted them to follow his example and serve each other. That was more important than actually washing feet, although it was a good way to serve others at that time,

13:15b

so that you should do as I have done for you.

- so now you^(plur) should serve each other in the way that I served you.
- and so you^(plur) should serve each other just as I have served you.

so that you should do as I have done for you: This clause indicates that Jesus wanted the disciples to act as he had done. He had served them in a humble way, and he wanted them to serve one another in the same humble way. So it does not just refer to washing feet, although that could be included. Here are other ways to translate this clause

so that you may copy what I have done to you (NJB)

that you should follow (GW)

you should do the same to each other (CEV)

The Greek has a word that many English versions translates as “also.” In some languages it may be necessary or natural to translate the word explicitly. For example:

you also should do as I have done to you (NRSV)

as I have done for you: In some languages the words for you may imply something negative. In those languages you may want to make clear that Jesus did something to benefit the disciples. For example:

as I helped/served you

General Comment on 13:15a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse as two sentences. For example:

I have given you an example to follow. Do as I have done to you. (NLT)

John 13:16

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples' feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:16a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I am telling you the truth,
- Listen carefully,

Truly, truly, I tell you: This clause introduces an important statement and means “pay attention to what I will now say.” See how you translated this phrase in 5:19 and 10:1. For example:

I tell you the truth (NIV)

13:16b

no servant is greater than his master,

- no servant is greater than his master, (NIV)
- servants are obviously not more important than their master.

no servant is greater than his master: This is a general truth. Jesus used this obvious truth to say “you should be willing to do what I did.” If their master could be humble and serve others, then they (his servants) should be willing to do the same.

Although the Greek and BSB use a singular subject, in some languages it may be more natural to use a plural subject. For example:

servants are not greater than their master (NRSV)

In some languages it is more natural to express this negative idea with a positive. For example:

a servant's master is more important than the servant

servant...master: The word that the BSB has translated as servant refers to low level workers, including slaves. For example:

Slaves...owners (GW)

worker...boss

13:16c

nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him.

- nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him. (NIV)
- And of course, messengers are not more important than the one who sent them.

nor is a messenger greater than the one who sent him:

This clause is another general truth meaning the same thing as “no servant is greater than his master.” It indicates that Jesus' disciples should be willing to serve others as he did. They were not greater than he was.

The Greek again uses a singular subject like the BSB.

Use either a singular or a plural subject, whichever is more natural in your language to express a general truth.

In some languages it is more natural to express this negative clause in a positive way. For example:

The person who sends a messenger is more important than the messenger himself is.

John 13:17**Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet**

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:12–17

In this paragraph Jesus explained why he washed his disciples' feet. Although he was their master, he served them. Now they should serve each other.

13:17a

If you know these things,

- Because you^(plur) know all this,
- You^(plur) understand this

If you know these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates as If here implies that the disciples did know these things. The condition is assumed to be true. For example:

Now that you know these things (NIV)

You know these things (CEV)

you know these things: This phrase refers to Jesus' disciples understanding what he just said in verses 13–16. There he talked about his example and its meaning, that his followers should serve others in humility. For example:

you understand all of this (GW)

13:17b

you will be blessed if you do them.

- you^(plur) will have joy if you do it.
- and so God will bless you^(plur) if you^(plur) do/follow it.

you will be blessed if you do them: Jesus' disciples would be blessed if they did as he showed them, following his example of service to others. For example:

you are blessed whenever you follow my example (GW)

you will be blessed: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed in this context means “happy, enjoying God’s favor.” God would be pleased with them and so their situation would be good if the condition (“you do them”) was fulfilled. See how you translated this word in Matthew 5:3–11. For example:

God will bless you (GW)

happy are you (GNT)

you will be truly happy

you will have joy

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

if you do them: This clause refers to doing what Jesus said and did, serving others in a humble way. It is the condition for them being blessed. For example:

if you act upon it (REB)

if you follow them

John 13:18

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:18–20

Jesus told his disciples that one of them would oppose him. This would fulfill a passage in the Old Testament Scriptures.

13:18a

I am not speaking about all of you;

- ¶ “I am not talking about all of you^(plur).
- ¶ “I am not referring to you^(plur) all.
- ¶ “What I am saying does not apply to all of you^(plur).

I am not speaking about all of you: This clause implies that Jesus was not speaking about Judas, who would betray him. He was not one of Jesus' true servants, and what Jesus said about serving others did not refer to him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

What I am saying does not refer to all of you. (NET)

I am not talking about all of you. (NCV)

I am not saying these things to all of you. (NLT)

13:18b

I know whom I have chosen.

- I know the people whom I have chosen.
- I know those I chose to be my disciples.

I know whom I have chosen: The clause that the BSB translates as I know whom I have chosen probably indicates that Jesus knew what each of the apostles was like. He had chosen them all (see 6:70) and he knew their true nature. Here is another way to translate this clause:

I know what kind of men you are whom I have chosen to be my apostles. (TRT)

whom I have chosen: The Greek word that the BSB translates as whom is plural: “the people whom.” Jesus was referring to the twelve men whom he had chosen to be his disciples. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the people/men I have chosen to be disciples

Because Jesus spoke to those whom he had chosen, it may be natural in some languages to supply a second-person pronoun. For example:

you ^(plur) whom I have chosen

13:18c

But this is to fulfill the Scripture:

- But this must happen to fulfill what is written in the scriptures,
- But the scripture will prove/come true that says,

But this is to fulfill the Scripture: The Greek text more literally says, “But so that the scripture might be fulfilled....” It is not a complete sentence, and some information is left implied. Different translations and scholars complete the sentence in different ways. For example:

But this fulfills the Scripture that says (NLT)

But what the Scriptures say must come true (CEV)

But the Scripture will be fulfilled (ESV)

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here seems to connect a negative statement (13:18a) to a positive statement (13:18d). The idea is that Jesus was not talking about all his disciples but there was one who would oppose him. Here is a way to understand this word in context:

I do not speak about all of you (I know whom I have chosen). But, fulfilling scripture, there is one who shares my bread who will oppose me.

this is to fulfill the Scripture: This clause could indicate a purpose, but more likely indicates the result of Jesus choosing who he did. One of the disciples would betray Jesus and so the scripture (Psalm 41:9) would be fulfilled. See how you translated similar expressions in Matthew 26:54 and Mark 14:49. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the scripture must come true that says (GNT)

that the scripture may be fulfilled

the Scripture: Jesus was speaking of a particular verse of scripture (Psalm 41:9). Because it does not refer to all the Jewish scriptures, you might want to refer to a piece of scripture. For example:

a text of scripture (REB)

what is written in scripture

13:18d

‘The one who shares My bread has lifted up his heel against Me.’

- ‘Someone who shared my food will oppose me.’
- ‘The one who has eaten a meal with me has become my enemy.’

The one who shares My bread has lifted up his heel against Me: This is a quotation of Psalm 41:9. The expression The one who shares My bread means “the person who has eaten with me.” In Jewish culture eating together was a sign of friendship. This quotation refers to a close friend who became an enemy. If this is not clear, it may be necessary to make it explicit. For example:

The friend who shared my bread has opposed me

The one who shares My bread: There is a textual difficulty here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “ate my bread.” For example:

The one who eats my bread (NET) (BSB, NASB, ESV, RSV, NRSV, NET, GW, NLT, NIV, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “ate bread with me.” For example:

eats bread with me (REB) (KJV, REB, NJB, CEV)

The correct reading is uncertain and either could be correct. The UBS Greek text gives the reading “ate my bread” a D rating, indicating a high degree of doubt. There is not much difference in the meaning. It is recommended that you follow the reading of your local or national Bible translation. However, a literal translation of interpretation (1) may give the wrong

meaning, that this person took Jesus' bread from him and ate it. It may be possible to say something like this instead:

He who shared my bread (NIV)

bread: The word bread could also mean "food" in the original text in the Psalms. Bread was the main food in Israel at that time, so it could represent food in general. However, because Jesus gave a piece of bread to Judas, it is good to keep the specific mention of bread. If bread is not well known in your culture, you may want to use a general expression. That is especially true if your local translation of Psalm 41 does not mention bread, For example:

The man who ate at my table (NCV)

My friend who shared my meals

He who shares my table (NJB)

has lifted up his heel against Me: This phrase is an idiom meaning something like "has acted to oppose me." The exact meaning is uncertain, but it seems to imply insulting or abandoning someone. In some way a former friend has become an enemy. For example:

now opposes me

will be the one who becomes my enemy (Uma Back Translation)

John 13:19

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples' feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples' feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:18–20

Jesus told his disciples that one of them would oppose him. This would fulfill a passage in the Old Testament Scriptures.

13:19a

I am telling you now before it happens,

- I am telling you^(plur) about his betraying me before it happens
- I am warning you^(plur) ahead of time

I am telling you now before it happens: This clause indicates that Jesus told the disciples that someone would betray him before it occurred (happened). Judas had not yet betrayed Jesus, but Jesus told the disciples that he would. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I tell you this now, before the event (REB)

13:19b

so that when it comes to pass, you will believe that I am He.

- so that when it happens, you^(plur) will believe that I am who I say I am.
- in order that when the scripture is fulfilled, you^(plur) will know I really am the Messiah.

so that: The conjunction that the BSB translates as so that means "in order that." It introduces the purpose Jesus had in telling them that Judas would betray him before it happened.

when it comes to pass, you will believe that I am He:

The clause when it comes to pass refers to when one of Jesus' disciples would betray him. When what Jesus predicted occurred (happened), his disciples would believe that Jesus was the Messiah and even God himself. They would believe that because predicting the future is something that God does.

when it does happen you will believe that I am He (NIV)

so that when it happens you will believe that I AM the Messiah (NLT)

so that when they do happen, you may believe that I am the one I claim to be (JBP)

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to all of the disciples.

believe: Here this word refers to believing that something is true, that “I am he.”

I am He: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as I am He is more literally “I am.” There are two ways to understand this expression in this context:

1. It refers to Jesus’ own claims (what he declared) about himself. For example:

I am the one I claim to be. (NIV84) (NIV84, REB, GW, CEV)

1. It refers to the holy name of God, “I am who I am.” See Exodus 3:14, where God revealed himself to the people of Israel by this name. This interpretation says that Jesus claimed to be God. For example:

I Am Who I Am (GNT) (GNT, NASB, NJB)

The KJV, ESV, NIV2011, NCV, NET, RSV, and NRSV can be understood either way. The NLT includes both ideas. It is probably good to translate this clause so that both interpretations are possible. Jesus probably implied (but did not state) that he was God and was from above. Because Jesus did not make it very clear that he was God here, you should not be very clear either. See how you translated this same expression in 8:24. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am who I am (NIV2011)

I AM the Messiah (NLT)

John 13:20

Section 13:1–20: Jesus washed his disciples’ feet

Beginning in this section, Jesus ate supper with the disciples for the last time. First he washed their feet as an example of loving service.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus washed his disciples’ feet at the last supper

Jesus set an example by washing feet

Jesus served his disciples by washing their feet

Paragraph 13:18–20

Jesus told his disciples that one of them would oppose him. This would fulfill a passage in the Old Testament Scriptures.

13:20a

Truly, truly, I tell you, whoever receives the one I send receives Me,

- The truth is that anyone who accepts my representative accepts me.
- Listen, if someone accepts you^(plur), my messengers, he also accepts me,

Truly, truly, I tell you: The Greek clause that the BSB translated as Truly, truly, I tell you is more literally “Truly, truly, I say to you.” It introduces an important statement and means “pay attention to what I am will now say.” See how you translated this clause in 13:16b.

whoever receives the one I send receives Me: This clause indicates that accepting Jesus’ messenger is the same as accepting Jesus. For example:

whoever accepts anyone I send accepts me (NIV)

whoever receives anyone I send receives me also (GNT)

anyone who welcomes my messenger is welcoming me (NLT)

whoever: This pronoun is indefinite and begins a general principle. There are many ways different languages express indefinite subjects that begin a general principle. For example:

the person who

anyone

if someone

they that

receives: This verb here means “accepts” or “welcomes.” For example:

whoever welcomes the one I send, welcomes me (NJB)

the one I send: This phrase means “my messenger” or “my representative” or “the people who tell my word.” Here is another way to translate this phrase:

any messenger of mine (REB)

13:20b

and whoever receives Me receives the One who sent Me.”

- Similarly, anyone who accepts me, my Father’s representative, accepts my Father as well.”
- and if someone accepts me, he also accepts my Father, whose messenger I am.”

whoever receives Me receives the One who sent

Me: This clause indicates that receiving or accepting Jesus is the same as accepting God the Father, who sent him. A person who welcomes Jesus and his message, believing in him, believes in God the Father. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that the One who sent Me refers to God the Father. See 8:26b and 9:4a. For example:

and anyone who welcomes me is welcoming the Father who sent me (JBP)

John 13:21**Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him**

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus’ right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:21a

After Jesus had said this, He became troubled in spirit and testified,

- ¶ Then Jesus became very disturbed in his spirit and testified,
- ¶ Then Jesus had great distress in his heart/mind and said,

After Jesus had said this: This phrase refers in general to what Jesus said in 13:12–20.

He became troubled in spirit: The phrase troubled in spirit means “disturbed, upset.” Jesus was troubled because one of his disciples would betray him. See the note on a similar phrase in 12:27a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he was very upset in his spirit

his thoughts/heart hurt greatly

and testified: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as testified indicates that Jesus spoke out about something that he knew. For example:

told his disciples (CEV)

declared (NRSV)

13:21b

“Truly, truly, I tell you, one of you will betray Me.”

- “It is true, one of you^(plur) will betray me to my enemies.”
- “Listen, one of you^(plur) my disciples will hand me over to the authorities.”

Truly, truly, I tell you: The expression that the BSB has translated as Truly, truly, I tell you emphasizes what Jesus would now say. See how you translated this expression in 13:16b and 13:20a.

one of you will betray Me: This clause indicates that one of Jesus’ disciples would no longer follow him, but would instead give him to his enemies.

will betray Me: In this context the phrase betray Me means “help my enemies to arrest and kill me.” See how you translated betray at 6:64c, and see the note there.

John 13:22**Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him**

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:22a

The disciples looked at one another,

- Jesus' disciples looked at each other in confusion.
- The disciples stared at one another.

The disciples looked at one another: This clause indicates what Jesus' disciples did while they wondered whom he was talking about (13:22b). Translate disciples as you did in 13:5b. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that these were Jesus' disciples. For example:

His disciples stared at one another (NIV)

13:22b

perplexed as to which of them He meant.

- They wondered whom Jesus was talking about.
- They did not know which of them Jesus meant.

perplexed as to which of them He meant: The Greek word that the BSB translates as perplexed means "not sure, anxious, confused." This phrase indicates what Jesus' disciples were thinking and feeling after he said that one of them would betray him. They did not know which of them he was referring to. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

wondering which one of them Jesus meant (GW)

worried and perplexed to know which of them he was talking about (NET)

confused about what he meant (CEV)

not understanding at all whom he was talking about

General Comment on 13:22a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 13:22b as a quotation (direct or indirect) of the disciples' thoughts. For example:

The disciples looked at each other in confusion: which of them could he mean?

The disciples stared at one another. They asked themselves, "Who is he talking about?"

John 13:23

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:23

One of His disciples, the one whom Jesus loved, was reclining at His side.

- The disciple whom Jesus loved was reclining/sitting at the table closest to Jesus,
- One disciple, the one whom Jesus loved, was at the table next to Jesus.

One of His disciples, the one whom Jesus loved, was reclining at His side: At formal meals Jewish people reclined (leaned) on couches around the table. They leaned on their left elbow and used their right hand to eat the food. (See the note and picture at 12:2b.) The disciple John was next to Jesus. He was apparently on Jesus' right side, a place of honor. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The disciple Jesus loved was sitting next to Jesus at the table. (NLT)

One disciple, the one Jesus loved, was there at the table next to Jesus.

The disciple Jesus loved was sitting next to Jesus at the table. (NLT)

the one whom Jesus loved: It is usually agreed that this phrase refers to John the author. You should not make this explicit here, but you may want to mention this in a footnote. For example:

The “disciple Jesus loved” was probably John. (NLT footnote)

The phrase indicates that John knew that Jesus loved him very much. See the notes on loved at 11:5, 36. The phrase does not indicate that the other disciples were not loved, and you should avoid implying this.

was reclining at His side: The word reclining here refers to a half-lying position, leaning on one’s elbow. This was the usual way to eat at special meals. John was next to Jesus with his back to Jesus. This way he could lean back and talk privately to Jesus. See how you translated this same word in 12:2b. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

was sitting next to Jesus (GNT)

at His side: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as at His side indicates that John was close to Jesus, at his side or chest. Because guests leaned on their left elbow, he must have been at Jesus’ right side. The position at the right of the chief guest was honored, and you may want to make this explicit:

to the right of Jesus in a place of honor (NET)

John 13:24

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus’ right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:24a

So Simon Peter motioned to him

- so Simon Peter nodded to him
- So Peter signaled to him

So Simon Peter motioned to him: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Most Greek manuscripts just say that Simon Peter motioned to the other disciple (John). For example:

Simon motioned for that disciple to find out which one Jesus meant (CEV) (BSB, NRSV, CEV, KJV, NCV, REB, NET, ESV, NLT, NABRE)

1. Other Greek manuscripts say that Simon Peter both motioned and said something to John. For example:

Simon Peter motioned to that disciple and said, “Ask Jesus whom he’s talking about!” (GW) (NASB, NIV, NJB, RSV, GW, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It seems to have the best support and most English translations follow it.

Simon Peter: Refer to this disciple as you did in 1:40 and 13:6.

motioned: The verb motioned means “signaled by moving part of one’s body.” Simon Peter moved a part of his body to signal John so he would ask Jesus whom he was talking about. You may want to translate this movement with a general word as the BSB did. Or you may want to use a movement that the local culture would use. For example:

Simon Petrus eye-signaled him (Uma Back Translation)

Simon Peter signalled to him (REB)

Simon Peter nodded to him

to him: The pronoun him refers to the disciple whom Jesus loved. Refer to him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

to that disciple (GW)

to this disciple (NIV)

13:24b

to ask Jesus which one He was talking about.

- to ask Jesus whom he was talking about.
- so that he would ask Jesus who would betray him.

to ask Jesus which one He was talking about: There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Most Greek manuscripts say that Simon Peter asked this other disciple (John) to ask Jesus whom he was talking about. For example:

to ask Jesus whom he was talking about (NCV) (BSB, NRSV, NIV, CEV, NJB, KJV, GW, NCV, REB, NET, ESV, GNT)

1. Other Greek manuscripts say that Simon Peter asked John to tell him whom Jesus was talking about. This would mean that Peter thought that John already knew who it was. For example:

and said, "Tell us who it is of whom he speaks." (RSV) (NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). It is the option selected by the UBS Greek New Testament committee with only a little doubt. Also, most English translations follow this option.

General Comment on 13:24b

In some languages it may not be natural to use indirect speech. Here is one way to use direct speech even though Peter did not say anything:

Simon Peter motioned to him so that he would ask Jesus, "Who are you talking about?"

John 13:25

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:25

Leaning back against Jesus, he asked, "Lord, who is it?"

- That disciple leaned over to Jesus and said to him, "Lord, who are you talking about?"
- The other/beloved disciple bent back toward Jesus and asked him who it was who would do this.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that some translations translate as "So" (see the NRSV). It introduces what John did as a result of what Simon Peter asked him to do. Some translations leave this word implied. Here is another way to translate this word:

Then (NET)

Leaning back against Jesus: There are two ways to understand the Greek text that the BSB translates as Leaning back against Jesus:

1. It refers to an action—the disciple leaned or bent back, toward Jesus. For example:

So that disciple leaned over to Jesus (NLT) (BSB, NIV, NCV, NLT, NJB, ESV, REB, NET, GW, CEV)

1. It describes the position that disciple was already in. For example:

leaning back thus on Jesus' bosom (NASB) (RSV, NRSV, KJV, NASB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations. The disciple was reclining right in front of Jesus, and he just bent back to talk to him privately.

Leaning back against Jesus: The Greek text is more literally "leaning in that way on the chest of Jesus." In some languages it may be natural to refer to Jesus' "front" or "shoulder" rather than his chest. Or you may want to leave this detail implied. For example:

leaned over on Jesus' shoulder (JBP)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

That follower leaned closer to Jesus (NCV)

he asked: The pronoun he refers to John. The Greek has the pronoun "him" that refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

the disciple leaned toward Jesus and asked (CEV)

So that disciple moved closer to Jesus' side and asked (GNT)

Then the disciple whom Jesus loved leaned back against Jesus' chest and asked him (NET)

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means "master," or "one who has authority over others." People used this word as a polite title when they spoke to an elder or someone in authority. However, the Jews also used this same title to refer to God. Use a term in your language that could also be used in this way. See how you translated this in 13:6 and 13:9.

who is it?: This question is short for "who will betray you?"

John 13:26

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:26a

Jesus answered, "It is the one to whom I give this morsel

- Jesus told him, "I will give this piece of bread to that person
- Jesus answered, "I will show who it is by giving him this bit of bread

13:26b

after I have dipped it."

- after I dip it into the stew."
- after dipping it in the sauce."

13:26a–b

It is the one to whom I give this morsel after I have dipped it: The Jewish people at this time did not normally eat with knives, forks, and spoons. Their custom was to break off pieces of bread and then dip them into a stew or sauce (liquid food). Jesus told John that he would answer his question by following this custom and then handing the bread to the betrayer.

this morsel: The word morsel refers to a piece of a loaf of bread. In some languages it may be most natural to say simply:

some bread

I have dipped it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as dipped it is more literally “dipped.” The BSB has supplied the reference to it, which refers to the “morsel” that is put into a plate or bowl that contains a stew or sauce (liquid food) of some kind. In some languages it may be natural to say this. For example:

dipped it in the sauce (GW)

General Comment on 13:26a–b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange this sentence, saying what would happen in chronological order. For example:

I will dip this piece of bread in the stew/sauce and then give it to the right person/man.

13:26c

Then He dipped the morsel

- After he dipped a piece of bread into the stew,
- Then he dipped the bread in the sauce

13:26d

and gave it to Judas son of Simon Iscariot.

- he gave it to Judas, son of Simon Iscariot.
- and handed it to Judas, whose father was Simon Iscariot.

13:26c–d

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB has translated as Then introduces what Jesus then did as a result of what he just said. Some English versions use a connector like “So” to indicate this.

He dipped the morsel and gave it: There is a textual problem here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include a word meaning “took.” For example:

So when He had dipped the morsel, He took and gave it... (NASB) (NASB, NABRE, GNT, NCV, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say that Jesus dipped the bread and gave it to Judas. For example:

he dipped the piece of bread in the dish and gave it... (NET) (BSB, KJV, ESV, RSV, NRSV, NJB, NLT, CEV, NET, GW, NIV)

The UBS Greek New Testament committee thinks that option (1) is the original text, although they are not very sure. Most English translations follow option (2), partly because it is more natural in English. Others

include the word “took,” but put it before the action of dipping. For example:

So he took a piece of bread, dipped it, and gave it... (GNT)

The meaning is nearly the same in all these English translations. So translate these clauses in the way that is most natural in your language.

He dipped the morsel: This clause is more literally “having dipped.” Jesus dipped the piece of bread into the stew or sauce. In some languages it may be natural to make the object (the morsel) explicit, as the BSB has done. In other languages it may be natural to say what he dipped the bread in. For example:

when he had dipped it in the sauce/stew

Judas son of Simon Iscariot: There is a textual problem here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts say “Judas son of Simon Iscariot.” These manuscripts are followed by most English translations. For example:

Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot (GNT) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, NASB, ESV, REB, NJB, GNT, NLT, CEV, NIV2011)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “Judas Iscariot, son of Simon.” These manuscripts are followed by a few English translations. For example:

Judas Iscariot, Simon’s son (NET) (NIV84, KJV, NET, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most translations and the UBS Greek New Testament. The UBS Greek text gives option (1) a C rating, indicating much uncertainty.

John 13:27

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:27a

And when Judas had taken the morsel, Satan entered into him.

- When Judas took the piece of bread, Satan entered his heart/thoughts.
- Judas ate/accepted the bread, and after that Satan took control of him.

And when Judas had taken the morsel: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *And when Judas had taken the morsel* is more literally “and after the bread, then.” This indicates the time when the next event happened. That means that as soon as Judas had taken the bread from Jesus and eaten it, Satan entered Judas. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

And after Judas took the piece of bread (NET)

As soon as Judas took the bread (NIV)

When Judas had eaten the bread (NLT)

Satan entered into him: This clause means “Satan took control of Judas.” Judas allowed Satan to influence his thoughts and actions. See also Luke 22:3 and the notes there. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Satan took control of Judas. (CEV)

Satan entered his heart/thoughts

Satan: The word Satan is the Hebrew name of the chief or leader of all the evil spirits. In Hebrew his name means “enemy.” He is the enemy of God and God's people. Both Satan and “the devil” refer to the same being. So in some languages, you may want to use the

same expression for both in your translation. Here are some ways to translate Satan:

- Use a local name or idiom that refers to the chief of all demons. If you do this, compare what people believe about this being to what the Bible teaches about the devil. Check that what people believe is close enough to what the Bible teaches to be a suitable expression.
- Use either a descriptive phrase or the literal meaning together with a descriptive phrase. For example:

the accuser, the chief of all demons

the leader of the evil spirits

the spirit enemy of God

the lord of all sin

the especially bad one

- Transliterate the name Satan. If this word is not already known in your area, you may also want to add a descriptive phrase. For example:

Satanas, the ruler of demons

Shaitan If you transliterate Satan, check that it communicates the biblical meaning to people in your culture. This is the only time the word Satan is used in John's Gospel. See how you translated “Satan” in Luke 22:3.

You need to use a word or phrase that the churches in the area will accept. You may also want to add a footnote or glossary entry that further explains who Satan is. For example:

Satan is the leader of all the evil spirits or demons. Once he was an angel in heaven, but he rebelled against God. God threw him out from heaven, and now he tempts people on earth. Other names for him in the Bible include “Beelzebul,” “the Devil,” “the Evil One,” “the Enemy,” and “the Tempter.”

General Comment on 13:27a

The Greek expression that the BSB translates as “And when Judas had taken the morsel” indicates the time when Satan entered Judas. It does not indicate that

receiving bread caused Judas to be controlled by Satan. If a literal translation would cause your readers to think that, here are other ways to translate this clause:

Right then Satan took control of Judas (CEV)

After that Satan entered Judas

13:27b

Then Jesus said to Judas, “What you are about to do, do quickly.”

- So Jesus told him, “Hurry! Do what you have to do.” (GW)
- Jesus said to Judas, “Do at once what you plan to do.”

Then Jesus said to Judas: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Judas is literally “him,” as in the NRSV. In some languages you may need to make it clear that Jesus was not speaking to Satan. Refer to Judas in a way that is natural in your language.

What you are about to do, do quickly: The phrase What you are about to do refers to betraying Jesus. Judas understood what Jesus was saying, but the rest of the disciples did not understand it at all. So it is important to translate this phrase with a general expression that the disciples would not understand meant betraying Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this entire clause:

The thing that you will do—do it quickly. (NCV)

Do not delay what you intend to do.

do quickly: The phrase do quickly means “do it as soon as you can.” For example:

Hurry! (GW)

General Comment on 13:27b

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of the information in this clause. For example:

Do quickly what you are going to do. (NRSV)

John 13:28

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who

he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus’ right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:28

But no one at the table knew why Jesus had said this to him.

- No one else at the meal understood what Jesus was talking about.
- (None of the others there understood what Jesus meant.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But is often translated that way. However, here the word introduces some parenthetical information. Use the most natural way in your language to indicate parenthetical information.

Verses 28–29 tell what the disciples were thinking. The main story returns in verse 30. The NET puts these two verses in parentheses. Some translations do not translate this word. Indicate that these two verses interrupt the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

no one at the table knew why Jesus had said this to him: The other people present did not understand what Jesus meant. They did not realize that Jesus was referring to Judas betraying him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no one at the meal understood why Jesus said this to him (NIV)

No one at the table understood what he meant by this. (REB)

none of those present at the table understood why Jesus said this to Judas (NET)

no one at the table: This phrase means “no one present except Jesus and Judas.” Here are some ways to make this phrase clearer or more natural in some languages:

no one else at the meal

none of the others at the table (NLT)

why Jesus had said this to him: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally “he,” as in the NRSV. The pronoun him refers to Judas. In some languages you may need to make this more explicit. For example:

why Jesus said this to Judas (NET)

John 13:29

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus’ right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:29

Since Judas kept the money bag, some thought that Jesus was telling him to buy what was needed for the feast, or to give something to the poor: This verse describes two wrong ideas that some of the

disciples had. In some languages it may be natural to translate this using two sentences. For example:

Judas had the moneybag. So some thought that Jesus was telling him to buy what they needed for the festival or to give something to the poor. (GW)

Some of them supposed/guessed that Jesus wanted him to buy things that they needed to celebrate the feast, and if not that, Jesus wanted him to give some money to the poor. The reason that they thought that was because Judas was the one who kept the money.

13:29a

Since Judas kept the money bag,

- Because Judas was in charge of their money/cash,
- Because Judas was responsible for the moneybag,

Since Judas kept the money bag: This clause indicates why the disciples thought what they did. It gives the basis for their wrong ideas. For example:

because Judas was in charge of the money (CEV)

Judas kept the money bag: This clause indicates that Judas kept all the money for Jesus and the disciples. It was his responsibility to look after it and spend it when necessary. See the note about “the common purse” at 12:6b and how you translated the phrase there. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Judas was the one who was in charge of their money

13:29b

some thought that

- some of them thought that
- some of the disciples assumed/guessed that

some thought that: This phrase here introduces two ideas that were not true. Some of the disciples wrongly thought of two things that Jesus might have told Judas. They thought that either he told him to buy food or to give money to the poor. Use a verb that can be used to indicate a false or wrong idea/thought. For example:

Some supposed that (REB)

Some assumed that

General Comment on 13:29a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 13:29a–b. You would first say what the others thought and then that Judas was in charge of the money. For example:

^{29b}Some thought that, ^{29a}because Judas had the common purse... (NRSV)

13:29c

Jesus was telling him to buy what was needed for the feast,

- Jesus was telling him to buy the food they needed for the festival,
- he was supposed to buy food for the feast

Jesus was telling him to buy what was needed for the feast: One of the ideas that some disciples had about what Jesus told Judas was to get supplies for the Passover festival. Much food was needed for Passover.

to buy what was needed for the feast: While the BSB translates this clause as a passive statement, it is active in Greek, and in some languages it may be more natural to translate it as active. For example:

to buy whatever they needed for the feast (NET)

what was needed: This phrase refers mainly to food that the group would need for the feast. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

the necessary supplies/food

whatever is necessary

for the feast: The phrase the feast here could refer to the Passover Feast. See 13:1a. Or it could refer to the Feast of Unleavened Bread. Because of that, it is better not to say which festival this phrase refers to.

General Comment on 13:29c

The BSB has translated what the disciples thought Jesus said as an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quotation like in the Greek text. For example:

Jesus was telling him, “Buy what we need for the festival” (NRSV)

13:29d

or to give something to the poor.

- or to give help/charity to the poor.
- or give some money to poor people.)

or: The word or here introduces a second wrong idea. Apparently, the group of disciples (“Some” in 13:29a) came up with more than one possibility of what Judas went to do. It could be that some of the disciples thought one thing and some another, but that is not as likely.

to give something to the poor: Often people gave money to the poor at Passover time. In fact, it was commanded that people do it on the first night of Passover. Use an expression that is natural for giving charity to people who do not have enough to eat or wear.

something: The word something here refers to some money.

the poor: This phrase refers to poor people, those without enough money to buy enough food and clothes.. See how you translated this in 12:8. For example:

those in need

poor people

General Comment on 13:29d

Here the BSB has translated what the disciples supposed Jesus had said as an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be more natural to use a direct quotation. For example:

or that he had said, “Give some money to the poor.”

General Comment on 13:29c–d

In the Greek text, the first thing the disciples thought Jesus said is a direct quotation. The second thing they thought he might have said is an indirect quotation. The BSB has translated the first and the second ideas as indirect quotations. In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quotation for both ideas, or an indirect quotation for both ideas. For example:

that Jesus was saying “Go buy what we need for the festival” or “Give some money to the poor”

that Jesus had told him to go and buy what they needed for the festival, or to give something to the poor (GNT)

General Comment on 13:29

In some languages it may be more natural to say what the disciples thought first, and then why they thought that. For example:

^{29a}Some of the disciples thought that ^{29c}Jesus was telling him to buy what they needed for the Feast, ^{29d}or to give something to the poor. ^{29b}They thought this because Judas was in charge of their money.

John 13:30

Section 13:21–30: Jesus predicted that someone would betray him

In this section Jesus told his disciples that one of them would betray him. The disciples wondered who he meant. Jesus showed them by giving a piece of bread to Judas. Judas then left the room.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would betray him

Jesus knew one of his disciples would oppose him

Paragraph 13:21–30

The Jewish custom at meals was to have several couches arranged in a U-shape around the table. The guests reclined (leaned) on the couches around the table, leaning on their left elbow. Jesus was probably in the center, and John was on Jesus' right. In this paragraph Peter told John to ask Jesus who would betray him. Jesus said that the person to whom he gave bread would be the one who would betray him. He gave the bread to Judas.

13:30a

As soon as he had received the morsel, Judas went out

- As soon as Judas had taken the bread, he went out. (NIV)
- Judas took the piece of bread and immediately left the house.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical comment in 13:28–29. Most English translations, including the BSB, do not explicitly translate this word.

Indicate this return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language.

As soon as he had received the morsel, Judas went out: The verb received here mean “taking” or “accepting.” Judas accepted the bread that Jesus gave to him.

As soon as...Judas went out: This phrase indicates that Judas at once left the meal and the house where the disciples were eating. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

immediately went outside (GW)

As soon as Judas had taken the piece of bread he went out. (NJB)

the morsel: See how you translated this in 13:26a, c.

General Comment on 13:30a

In some languages it may be natural to translate 13:30a using two independent verbs. For example:

Judas accepted the bread and went out at once. (GNT)

13:30b into the night.

- It was night.
- And night had arrived.

into the night: This clause indicates that the sun had set and it was now dark. The night in this gospel represents Jesus' death. See 9:4b and the note there. Not only was it dark when Judas went out, but it was the time for Jesus to die.

John 13:31

Section 13:31–35: Jesus gave a new commandment

In this section Jesus talks about how he, the Son of Man, has been glorified. Also, God has been glorified in him. Jesus also tells his disciples a new commandment.

Here are some other possible section headings:

A new commandment

Jesus commanded his disciples to love one another

The Son of Man has been glorified and God has been glorified in him

13:31a

When Judas had gone out, Jesus said, “Now the Son of Man is glorified,

- ¶ After Judas left, Jesus said, “Now is the time for the Son of Man to be glorified/honored,
- ¶ After Judas left the building, Jesus said to his disciples, “At this time the Son of Man will receive glory/honor,

When Judas had gone out: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Judas is literally “he,” as in the NRSV. The BSB sometimes uses names instead of pronouns in order to clarify the person to whom the author is referring. Refer to Judas in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus said: In some languages it is more natural to say to whom Jesus was talking. For example:

Jesus said to his disciples

Now the Son of Man is glorified: This clause refers to the display of Jesus’ glory at the time of his death, resurrection, and return to heaven. These events glorify Jesus by showing his true greatness. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Now the Son of Man’s glory is revealed (GNT)

Now the Son of Man receives his glory (NCV)

What will soon happen to me who am the Son of Man will be the cause of my being honored

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now in this context indicates that the time was very near. The time had come but the event had not happened yet. Here is another way to translate this word:

The time has come for... (NLT)

the Son of Man: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Son of Man is more literally “the Son of the human/person.” Jesus was referring to himself. He used this title to imply two things:

1. He was a true human being, and he represented all people.
2. He came from God and had authority from God.

Try to use an expression that implies both meanings. Here are some expressions that translators have used:

the Man whom God Sent

the True Man from God/Heaven

the Representative of Humanity

The Older Brother of All People

In some languages it may be necessary to use a first person pronoun to indicate that Jesus was referring to himself. For example:

me, the Son of Man

I who became man/human

See how you translated “Son of Man” in 1:51, 3:13, and 5:27.

is glorified: The word glorified means “greatly honored” or “shown to be wonderful.” In this context it refers to Jesus’ death, resurrection, and return to heaven. These events had not happened yet but would surely happen and would happen soon. Use the tense that is natural in your language. For example:

will be given glory (CEV)

will soon be greatly honored

The verb is glorified is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb, like the BSB.
- Use an active verb. For example:

the Son of Man receives his glory (NCV)

Use the form that is most natural in your language. The idea is that Jesus would soon display his glory. His death and resurrection would reveal his greatness.

13:31b

and God is glorified in Him.

- and God will be glorified/honored through him.
- and by him God will receive glory/honor.

and God is glorified in Him: God also was honored and shown to be wonderful through Jesus’ death, res-

urrection, and return to heaven. Through Jesus' perfect sacrifice, God's greatness was revealed. Use the same verb tense that you used in 13:31a. As in 13:31a, there are two ways to translate the passive verb phrase is glorified:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

now God's glory is revealed through him (GNT)

and God will be glorified because of him (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

and God receives glory through him (NCV)

and he will bring glory to God (CEV)

in Him: This phrase here means "because of the Son of Man" or "through the Son of Man." What Jesus would soon do would bring glory to God. For example:

through him (NCV)

because of him (NLT)

John 13:32

Section 13:31–35: Jesus gave a new commandment

In this section Jesus talks about how he, the Son of Man, has been glorified. Also, God has been glorified in him. Jesus also tells his disciples a new commandment.

Here are some other possible section headings:

A new commandment

Jesus commanded his disciples to love one another

The Son of Man has been glorified and God has been glorified in him

13:32a

If God is glorified in Him,

- Because he glorifies/honors God by what he does,
- And because he has acted to reveal/display the glory/honor of God,

If God is glorified in Him: Some Greek manuscripts do not include this clause. However, all major English translations include it and the idea of the clause is definitely included in 13:31b. So it is recommended that you include this clause. The connector the BSB translated as If here means "since" ("because"). This clause is assumed to be true. For example:

And since God receives glory because of the Son,
(NLT)

Then, after God is given glory because of him,
(CEV)

God is glorified in Him: See how you translated this clause in 13:31b.

13:32b

God will also glorify the Son in Himself—

- God himself will glorify/honor him.
- God will also act in a way that reveals/displays the glory/honor of the Son of Man,

God will also glorify the Son in Himself: This clause means that God will glorify the Son in God himself. In other words, just as Jesus acted to glorify God, so God will act to glorify Jesus.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Son is literally "him," as in the NRSV. The BSB sometimes uses names instead of pronouns in order to clarify the person to whom the author is referring. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

13:32c

and will glorify Him at once.

- He will glorify/honor him now/immediately.
- and that will happen very soon.

and will glorify Him at once: The phrase at once means "immediately" or "very soon." It refers to the same events as 3:31a, "Now." For example:

and God will do it very soon (CEV)

and that without delay (JBP)

John 13:33

Section 13:31–35: Jesus gave a new commandment

In this section Jesus talks about how he, the Son of Man, has been glorified. Also, God has been glorified in him. Jesus also tells his disciples a new commandment.

Here are some other possible section headings:

A new commandment

Jesus commanded his disciples to love one another

The Son of Man has been glorified and God has been glorified in him

13:33a

Little children, I am with you only a little while longer.

- My dear followers, I will be here with you^(plur) only a little while longer.
- Dear ones, I will not be with you^(plur) much longer.

Little children: This phrase expresses Jesus' love and concern for his disciples. In some languages a literal translation may indicate that Jesus was talking to children. It may be necessary to avoid this by using a different form of address. For example:

You my dear disciples (Western Bukidnon Manobo)

You whom I love dearly

I am with you only a little while longer: Jesus was referring to his death the next day and his ascension into heaven in less than two months. In some languages it may be natural to use future tense. For example:

I will be with you only a little longer (NIV)

13:33b

You will look for Me,

- You^(plur) will seek me,
- You^(plur) will try to find me.

You will look for Me: This clause indicates that the disciples would want to have Jesus with them after he went to heaven. But he will not be on earth with them anymore.

13:33c

and as I said to the Jews, so now I say to you:

- and what I told the Jewish leaders earlier I am now telling you^(plur):
- But I am going to repeat to you^(plur) what I said to the Jewish authorities:

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces something that contrasts with the expected result of the disciples' looking for Jesus. It may therefore be natural to make the contrast more explicit. For example:

but (GNT)

as I said to the Jews: Jesus reminded his listeners of what he said to the Jewish leaders in 8:21d. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what I told the Jews (NCV)

the things/words I said/spoke to the Jewish leaders

the Jews: This phrase refers to same Jewish group as the same phrase in 8:22. There it seems to refer to the Pharisees, Jewish religious leaders. Use the same phrase that you used in 8:22. For example:

the Jewish leaders (NLT)

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

so now I say to you: This clause refers to what Jesus would say next. Jesus would say the same thing to the disciples that he earlier said to the Jewish leaders. For example:

now I tell you the same (NLT)

I am now repeating to you

Jesus had not yet said this, so it may be natural to use a future tense verb. For example:

I will tell you the same thing

I will repeat to you

General Comment on 13:33c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 13:33c. For example:

I tell you now what I told the Jewish authorities (GNT)

13:33d**‘Where I am going, you cannot come.’**

- ‘You^(plur) cannot go where I will go.’
- that you^(plur) cannot go with me to where I will soon go.

Where I am going, you cannot come: 13:33d is a direct quotation of Jesus’ own words in 8:21d. Because of that, BSB uses quotation marks to indicate that Jesus was quoting himself. In some languages it may be natural to not use quotation marks. For example:

And as I told the Jewish leaders, you will search for me, but you can’t come where I am going. (NLT)

what I told the leaders of the Jews that you will not be able-to-go where I am going (Kankanaey Back Translation)

The Greek text emphasizes the pronouns I and you to contrast the two. Jesus will die and go to heaven, but the disciples will not be able to do the same, at least not yet.

Where I am going: This clause refers to Jesus dying and going to heaven.

you cannot come: The disciples could not die and go to heaven yet. Later they will be able to follow Jesus where he goes (see 13:36). This is different from the Jews in 8:21, who would die in their sins.

In some languages it may be natural to use a verb meaning “go” rather than come in this context. For example:

You cannot go (GNT)

General Comment on 13:33d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 13:33d. For example:

You cannot go where I am going. (GNT)

John 13:34**Section 13:31–35: Jesus gave a new commandment**

In this section Jesus talks about how he, the Son of Man, has been glorified. Also, God has been glorified in him. Jesus also tells his disciples a new commandment.

Here are some other possible section headings:

A new commandment

Jesus commanded his disciples to love one another

The Son of Man has been glorified and God has been glorified in him

13:34a**A new commandment I give you: Love one another.**

- I give you this new commandment: You^(plur) should love each other.
- I command you^(plur) something new: I want you to love each other.

A new commandment I give you: This commandment was new in the sense that Jesus was now giving himself as the standard and example of love. He had told them to love before (for example, in the Sermon on the Mount). Here are other ways of translating this clause:

I am giving you a new command. (CEV)

A new command I give you (NIV)

Here is a new command that I give you.

A new commandment: The Greek text emphasizes this phrase. The word new in this context means new in quality. Jesus has commanded people to love others before. However, here he commands his disciples to love each other just as he loved them.

I give you: To give a command is the same as to command something. Saying it this way emphasizes what Jesus commanded more than his act of commanding. However, in some languages it may be more natural to use a verb form. For example:

I command you something new.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples.

Love one another: This clause gives the content of the commandment. This was what Jesus commanded his disciples to do. For example:

I give you a new commandment—to love one another. (NET)

I give you a new commandment: love one another.
(REB)

The word that the BSB translates as one another in this context refers to all the disciples loving all of the other disciples. For example:

Love each other. (NCV)

13:34b

As I have loved you, so you also must love one another.

- You^(plur) should love each other in the same way that I love you.
- You have seen how I have loved you^(plur), and that is how you should love each other.

As I have loved you: This clause tells the standard of how Jesus wanted his disciples to love each other. He wanted them to show the same love for one another that he showed to them. Jesus' love was humble and made him willing to sacrifice himself on the cross. He wanted them to imitate him, serving and giving their lives for one another as he had done for them. For example:

Following the example of how I have loved you

in the same way as I have loved you

so you also must love one another: This clause repeats the command that the disciples must love each other. Here, however, the love is described by the previous clause ("Just as I have loved you"). Use the verb phrase that is natural for giving a command in your language.

General Comment on 13:34b

In some languages it is more natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 13:34b. For example:

You must love each other as I have loved you.
(NCV)

John 13:35

Section 13:31–35: Jesus gave a new commandment

In this section Jesus talks about how he, the Son of Man, has been glorified. Also, God has been glorified in him. Jesus also tells his disciples a new commandment.

Here are some other possible section headings:

A new commandment

Jesus commanded his disciples to love one another

The Son of Man has been glorified and God has been glorified in him

13:35a

By this everyone will know that you are My disciples,

- That is how you will show the world that you are my followers
- The proof that you are my disciples is

By this everyone will know that you are My disciples: Other people will be able to recognize those who are Jesus' disciples by their love for one another. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Everyone will know that you are my disciples because... (GW)

Other people will be able to see/recognize that you are my followers by the way...

By this: This phrase refers forward to 13:35b, their love for each other. It is because of this love they have for one another that others will know that they are Jesus' disciples.

everyone will know: This phrase means "it will prove to all people" or "it will show everyone." All their friends and neighbors would be able to recognize that they were Jesus' disciples. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

will prove to the world (NLT)

all people will realize

you are My disciples: This clause means "that you follow me." Jesus loved his followers. His followers are to show that they are like him by loving one another.

disciples: See the note at 13:5b and how you translated the word there.

13:35b

if you love one another."

- by loving each other."
- your^(plur) love for each other."

if you love one another: The disciples' love for each other will prove that they are Jesus' disciples. Another way to show this is by removing "By this" above and starting this clause with "by." For example:

Everyone will know that you are my disciples by your love for one another

All people will be able to recognize that you are my disciples by seeing how you show love to one another

love: In this context love is active affection, the outer expression of a desire for someone else's welfare. It is something that people can see in action. In some languages it may be natural to translate love here as a verb rather than a noun. For example:

by seeing how you love one another

General Comment on 13:35a–b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange these clauses, translating the conditional clause first. For example:

^{35b}If you have love for one another, ^{35a}then everyone will know that you are my disciples. (GNT)

Your love for one another will prove to the world that you are my disciples. (NLT)

John 13:36

Section 13:36–38: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Peter said that he would even die for Jesus. However, Jesus said that before morning Peter would deny knowing him three times.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would deny him

Peter says that he could die for Jesus, but Jesus says that he will deny him

Jesus knew that Peter would say that he did not know him

13:36a

"Lord, where are You going?" Simon Peter asked.

- ¶ Simon Peter then asked Jesus, "Lord, where are you^(sing) going?"
- ¶ Simon Peter asked, "Master, where will you^(sing) go?"

"Lord, where are You going?" Simon Peter asked:

The disciples did not understand what Jesus was talking about when he said he was going away. The phrase that the BSB translates as asked is literally "said." Use the expression that is natural in your language.

Simon Peter: Simon Peter was one of Jesus' closest disciples who is often just called Peter. See the note about Simon Peter in 1:40a–b and how you translated the name there and in 13:24.

13:36b

Jesus answered, "Where I am going, you cannot follow Me now,

- Jesus replied to Peter, "You^(sing) cannot go with me now to where I am going,
- Jesus said, "Peter, you cannot follow me now to where I go.

Where I am going, you cannot follow Me now: Jesus was talking about going to God in heaven. Peter could not go with Jesus at that time. He did not say explicitly that he was going to God, and you should not indicate this in your translation. The Greek text emphasizes the words Where I am going by putting them first, but that may not be natural in some languages. In those languages, you may want to put those words at the end of the sentence. For example:

You cannot follow me now where I am going (GNT)

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Peter.

13:36c

but you will follow later."

- but later you^(sing) will join me."
- However, some day you^(sing) will go there."

but: The connector but introduces a contrast between now and later. Now Peter could not follow Jesus, but later he would follow him.

you will follow later: This clause indicates that one day Peter would go where Jesus was going. Jesus meant that Peter would go to heaven, but he did not say this explicitly.

John 13:37

Section 13:36–38: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Peter said that he would even die for Jesus. However, Jesus said that before morning Peter would deny knowing him three times.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would deny him

Peter says that he could die for Jesus, but Jesus says that he will deny him

Jesus knew that Peter would say that he did not know him

13:37a

“Lord,” said Peter, “why can’t I follow You now?”

- Peter asked, “Lord, why can I not go with you^(sing) now?”
- Peter replied, “Let me go with you^(sing) even now

Lord: There is a textual issue here.

1. Most Greek manuscripts include the word Lord. For example:

Lord, why can’t I follow you now? (NIV) (BSB, NASB, ESV, RSV, NRSV, NET, GW, NLT, NIV, CEV, GNT, NCV, KJV, REB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the word Lord. For example:

Why can I not follow you now? (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) along with nearly all English translations. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

But why can’t I come now, Lord? (NLT)

said Peter: Here Simon Peter is referred to as just Peter. Peter asked for more information. Here is another way to introduce the question:

Peter asked (NIV)

why can’t I follow You now?: This question shows that Peter did not understand that Jesus would die to pay for the world’s sins. The question indicates that Peter thought that he should be able to go with him.

13:37b

I will lay down my life for You.”

- I am ready to lose my life for you^(sing).”
- because I am willing even to die for you^(sing).”

I will lay down my life for You: This clause means “I will die for you.” It indicates that Peter was willing to die for Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am ready to die for you! (GNT)

I am willing to die for your benefit.

John 13:38

Section 13:36–38: Jesus predicted that Peter would deny him

In this section Peter said that he would even die for Jesus. However, Jesus said that before morning Peter would deny knowing him three times.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus predicted that one of his disciples would deny him

Peter says that he could die for Jesus, but Jesus says that he will deny him

Jesus knew that Peter would say that he did not know him

13:38a

“Will you lay down your life for Me?” Jesus replied.

- Jesus replied “Are you^(sing) really ready to lose your life for me?”
- Jesus said, “Let us see if you will die for me.

Will you lay down your life for Me?: This is a rhetorical question. It was used to rebuke Peter. Jesus rebuked Peter for being so confident of his own loyalty and courage. He knew that Peter thought that he was more committed to Jesus than he really was. And although Peter was afraid to die with Jesus then, in his old age he would die for him.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Are you really ready to die for me? (GNT)

Die for me? (NLT)

- Use a statement. It is best not to say explicitly whether or not Peter would lay down his life for Jesus. For example:

Let us see whether you will lay down your life for me.

You are not ready to die for me.

13:38b

“Truly, truly, I tell you, before the rooster crows, you will deny Me three times.”

- I tell you the truth, before the cock crows in the morning you will deny three times that you know me.
- In fact, the truth is that before the rooster next calls tomorrow morning you will say three times that you do not know me.

Truly, truly, I tell you: The clause that the BSB has translated literally as Truly, truly, I tell you introduces an important statement and means “pay attention to what I will say next.” See how you translated this clause in 13:16. For example:

I tell you for certain (CEV)

before the rooster crows: This phrase refers to a time very early the following morning. The time would be before the cocks crowed (made the sound of a chicken).

the rooster: The word rooster means “male chicken.”

Jesus was not referring to a particular rooster that he already mentioned. So in some languages it may be more natural to say:

a rooster

crows: This word describes the loud early-morning call of a male chicken. If your readers do not know about cocks’ behavior, it may be necessary to indicate the time of day. For example:

calls/cries out in the morning

screams before dawn tomorrow

you will deny Me three times: This clause indicates that three times Peter would say he did not know Jesus. For example:

you will deny three times that you even know me (NLT)

you will say three times that you don’t even know me (CEV)

three times: Peter would tell three different people he did not know Jesus. There were three separate incidents/conversations. So it may be necessary to say:

on three occasions

General Comment on 13:38

In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quote for Peter’s denial of Jesus. For example:

you will say three times, “I deny knowing him.”

John 14:1

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:1–4

Jesus’ disciples were upset because he had told them he was leaving. Jesus comforted and encouraged them. He told them that he would come back for them and take them to live with him in his Father’s house.

14:1a

“Do not let your hearts be troubled.”

- ¶ “Do not allow yourselves to be distressed/upset.
- ¶ Jesus said to all the disciples, “Make your^(plur) hearts/spirits calm/quiet.
- ¶ Jesus said to his disciples, “Do not be worried anymore!

Jesus continued the speech he began in 13:38. However, there he spoke only to Peter, while here he began to speak to all the disciples. In some languages it may be natural to supply a quote introducer here, because it is a new chapter. For example:

Jesus said to his disciples (CEV)

Do not let your hearts be troubled: This sentence is a command addressed to all the disciples and means “Stop being troubled” or “Stop being upset.” Jesus had just told them that he was leaving so all the disciples were very worried. This sentence tells them to be at peace. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Do not be worried and upset. (GNT)

Set your troubled hearts at rest. (REB)

You must not let yourselves be distressed. (JBP)

your hearts: The pronoun your is plural which indicates that Jesus now spoke to all the disciples, not just Peter. Jews thought that the heart was the source and center of the will and emotions. In some languages it is more natural to speak of another body part. Or it may be more natural to refer to the emotions rather than to any body part. For example:

Don't be worried! (CEV)

Do not be troubled in your livers. (Yakan Back Translation)

14:1b

You believe in God; believe in Me as well.

- Trust in God always; trust also in me. (REB)
- Keep^(plur) on believing in God and in me.

You believe in God; believe in Me as well: This sentence gives positive commands in contrast to the negative command in 14:1a. Rather than being troubled, the disciples should trust God and trust Jesus.

You believe in God: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as You believe can be interpreted in two ways:

1. It is a command. For example:

Trust in God (NIV) (NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It is a statement, a description of what was already happening. For example:

You trust in God (NJB) (BSB, NJB, KJV, NET)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1), along with most English translations. Jesus was encouraging his disciples to find peace by trusting God and trusting him.

This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about God and what he has done. But it also includes the idea of trusting God instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about God, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases about believing in Jesus in 1:12, 7:31, and 7:38. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Have faith in God (CEV)

Trust in God (NLT)

believe: The two verbs that the BSB translates as believe in this context mean “keep on trusting.” The disciples already believed/trusted in God and in Jesus to a certain extent. Jesus wanted them to continue to trust, and to trust deeply. For example:

Trust in God always; trust also in me. (REB)

you must hold on to your faith in God and to your faith in me (JBP)

believe in Me as well: See the note about “Believe in God” just above and how you translated that clause. Translate this clause in a similar way. For example:

have faith in me (CEV)

trust also in me (NLT)

John 14:2

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:1–4

Jesus' disciples were upset because he had told them he was leaving. Jesus comforted and encouraged them. He told them that he would come back for them and take them to live with him in his Father's house.

14:2a

In My Father's house are many rooms.

- There are many places to live in my Father's house.
- There is lots of room for you^(plur) in the home of God my Father.

In My Father's house are many rooms: The main idea in this sentence is that there is plenty of room for many people. For example:

In my Father's compound there are many houses/homes.

There is room for many people to live with/near my Father.

In My Father's house: The phrase My Father's house refers to heaven. It is good to keep the metaphor. If the picture of God living in a house seems very strange, it may be possible to say something like:

In my Father's heavenly home

many rooms: The phrase the BSB has translated as rooms means "places to live." For example:

many places to live in (NJB)

dwelling places (NRSV)

many apartments

14:2b

If it were not so,

- If there were not,
- If there was no room for you,

If it were not so: This clause here means "if there were not many rooms in my Father's house." It suggests the possibility that there might not be enough room for all of Jesus' followers in heaven. This is a

possibility that is not true. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

If not

If that were not true (GW)

If there were not many rooms there

unless it was true

14:2c–d

would I have told you that I am going there to prepare a place for you?:

There is a textual problem here. Some Greek manuscripts include a word that can mean either that or "for/because." Some Greek manuscripts do not include this word. Also, the original Greek text did not have any punctuation. So it is difficult to be sure of the original meaning of the text. Here are the possibilities:

1. The text includes a word that can mean that or "for/because." For example:

If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? (ESV) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, GW, NLT, NIV2011, NASB, REB, NET)

1. The text does not include that word. For example:

I would not tell you this if it were not true. I am going there to prepare a place for you. (NCV) (KJV, NIV84, CEV, NCV, NJB, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek text includes the Greek word with only some doubt.

There is also an interpretation issue in how to understand the word that the BSB translates as that.

1. The word means that. For example:

If it were not so, would I have told you that I go to prepare a place for you? (ESV) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, GW, NLT, NIV2011)

1. The word means "for/because." For example:

if it were not so, I would have told you; for I go to prepare a place for you (NASB) (NASB, REB, NET)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) with more of the English translations. That seems to make the best sense of the Greek text. Following option (1) also means that you would understand the Greek as a rhetorical question. The expected answer to the rhetorical question would be “no.” Jesus would not have told his followers something that was not true.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

1. Use a rhetorical question. For example:

would I have told you that I am going to prepare a place for you? (NLT)

1. Use a statement. For example:

I would not have told you that I am going to prepare a place for you.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural for a question that implies and expects the answer “no.” For example:

I would not have told you that I go to prepare a place for you, would I?

14:2c

would I have told you

- would I have told you^(plur)
- I would not have told you^(plur)

would I have told you: This clause indicates here that Jesus would not have said something to his disciples if something else were not true. He told them that he would go to prepare a place for them (see the next clause). He would not have said that if there were not many places to live in his Father’s house. But there were many places to live there, so he told him that he would prepare a place for them.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

14:2d

that I am going there to prepare a place for you?

- that I am going to my Father’s house to prepare a place for you^(plur)? No!
- that I will leave to get/make a place ready for you^(plur) there.

that I am going there to prepare a place for you:

There is no record that Jesus had previously said these exact words. This may refer to his promise that his

followers would always be with him and have eternal life. See, for example, John 12:26.

I am going: These words refer to Jesus going to his Father’s house in heaven, which he just mentioned. He would do that through his death and resurrection. It may be natural to make clearer where he would go. For example:

I go there

I am going there (NIV)

to prepare a place for you: This phrase refers to preparing a place for the disciples in the home of God the Father. Jesus prepared this place by dying for his people and making the way for them to go to God.

John 14:3

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:1–4

Jesus’ disciples were upset because he had told them he was leaving. Jesus comforted and encouraged them. He told them that he would come back for them and take them to live with him in his Father’s house.

14:3a

And if I go and prepare a place for you,

- And because I am leaving to prepare a place for you,
- And after I have made it ready for you^(plur),

And if I go and prepare a place for you: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as if in this context means “when” or “after.” It introduces something that will certainly happen. For example:

and after I have gone and prepared you a place (NJB)

And when I go and prepare a place for you (RSV)

Then when I finish preparing your living places

I go and prepare a place for you: See the notes on a similar expression in 14:2d. Because the expressions there and here are so similar, it may be more natural to not repeat everything. For example:

After I have done this (CEV)

When everything is ready (NLT)

14:3b

I will come back and welcome you into My presence,

- I will come back for you^(plur) and take you to be with me,
- I will return to you^(plur) to take you^(plur) to be with me.

I will come back and welcome you into My presence: This clause indicates that Jesus would return to his people. He would come to take his people to himself so that they would be with him. This clause probably refers to Jesus' second coming. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I will come back and take you to be with me (NIV)

I will come again. Then I will bring you into my presence. (GW)

14:3c

so that you also may be where I am.

- so that you^(plur) will always be with me.
- Then we^(incl) will be together forever.

so that you also may be where I am: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as so that here introduces a purpose clause. Jesus will bring his people into his presence in order that they might be together. In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the clauses in this expression. For example:

so that you will be where I am (GW)

you also may be where I am: This expression indicates that Jesus' people will remain with him always. They will live with him in his Father's home. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as one clause. For example:

we will be together (CEV)

you: The word you is plural and refers to the disciples.

where I am: This clause refers to the place Jesus will be at that future time. It does not refer to Jerusalem where he was when he said this. In some languages it is more natural to use a future tense. For example:

where I will be

John 14:4

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:1–4

Jesus' disciples were upset because he had told them he was leaving. Jesus comforted and encouraged them. He told them that he would come back for them and take them to live with him in his Father's house.

14:4

You know the way to the place where I am going."

- You^(plur) know the way that leads to the place where I am going."
- You^(plur) already know how to go to where I will go."

You know the way to the place where I am going:

Jesus indicated that his disciples knew the way to his Father's home. There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek texts say you know the way to the place where I am going. For example: You know the way to the place where I am going (GW) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NRSV, NJB, GW, NLT, CEV, NCV, NET, NASB, REB) (2) Other Greek texts say you know where I am going, and you know the way. For example: And whither I go ye know, and the way ye know. (KJV) (KJV) It is recommended that you follow option (1). It has early and strong manuscript support, and most English translations follow this option. The UBS Committee gave this reading a B rating which means that there is only a little doubt. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

You know the way that leads to the place where I am going. (GNT)

You know the way to where I am going. (CEV)

You: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

the way: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the way can also be translated as “the path” or “the road.” Literally, the phrase refers to the path between two places and figuratively to the method of getting somewhere.

the place where I am going: This clause refers to heaven, God’s home.

John 14:5

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:5–7

In this paragraph, Thomas told Jesus that the disciples did not know where he was going or how to get there. Jesus answered that he himself was the way to God.

14:5a

“Lord,” said Thomas, “we do not know where You are going,

- ¶I Thomas said to Jesus, “Lord, we^(excl) do not know where you^(sing) are going,
- ¶I Thomas replied, “Lord, because we^(excl) do not know where you^(sing) are going,

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” People used this word as a polite title when they spoke to an elder or someone in authority. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Master

Chief

In some languages it may be necessary to say “my Lord” rather than Lord when talking to someone. For example:

my Chief/Master

See how you translated Lord in 13:25, 36, when other disciples addressed Jesus with this word.

said Thomas: Thomas is the name of one of Jesus’ disciples. The Greek has the word “him” that refers to Jesus. Because this is the beginning of a new paragraph, it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Thomas said to Jesus (NCV)

we do not know where You are going: Thomas did not understand what Jesus was talking about. He wanted to know where Jesus would go.

we: This pronoun is exclusive here. It refers to the disciples but not to Jesus.

14:5b

so how can we know the way?”

- so how can we know the way there?”
- we^(excl) do not know how to go there.”

so how can we know the way?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses disagreement with what Jesus just said. Thomas was disagreeing with Jesus’ statement that they knew the way to where he was going.

There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Lord, we do not know where you are going; so how can we know the way to get there? (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

Lord, we do not know where you are going, so we cannot know the way to get there.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language.

the way: This phrase here is short for “the way to where you are going.” See the note for the same phrase in 14:4 and how you translated it there. Translate it the same way in both places so that your readers will understand the connection.

John 14:6

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:5–7

In this paragraph, Thomas told Jesus that the disciples did not know where he was going or how to get there. Jesus answered that he himself was the way to God.

14:6a

Jesus answered, “I am the way and the truth and the life.

- Jesus replied, “I am the way. I am the truth. I am the life.
- Jesus answered Thomas, “I myself am the way to God. I am/reveal what is true about God. I am the one who gives eternal/true life.

I am the way: This clause indicates that Jesus is the way to God. It means that people could go to God only through him. The phrase the way continues to be used as a figure of speech. It is good to keep this figure of speech and translate it as you did in 14:4 and 14:5. In some languages it may be necessary to explain part of the meaning. For example:

I am the way to God

I am the path/road that leads you to God.

I am: This is the sixth of seven “I am” statements in John. (The others are in 6:35; 8:12; 10:7, 9; 10:11, 14; 11:25; and 15:1, 5.) They are all metaphors that Jesus used to describe himself. Some see a reference to Jesus’ being God because “I am” is the name that God used for himself in Exodus 3:14. The Greek text emphasizes the word I. Here are some ways to show this emphasis:

I, myself, am...

It is I who am...

the truth: This phrase is short for “I am the truth.” It indicates that Jesus reveals the truth about God. By his actions and his words, Jesus showed and told the truth about God. See the note on 1:14d, where the same word (truth) is used. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

I am the one who truly reveals God.

Because of me you know what is true. (Otomi Back Translation)

the life: This phrase is short for “I am the life.” It means that Jesus is the only one who can give people life, eternal life. See 5:39–40 and 11:25. For example:

I give people true/real life.

In some languages it is more natural to express life as a verb. For example:

I cause/enable people to live.

14:6b

No one comes to the Father except through Me.

- People can come to the Father only through me.
- Only through me can anyone/you^(plur) go to my Father.

No one comes to the Father except through Me: This clause indicates that no one can enjoy fellowship with God except through believing in Jesus. Jesus himself is the only way to enjoy a loving relationship with God in our present life. And he is the only way to enter the holy presence of God in the future life. Try to translate this clause in a way that includes both of these ideas. It may be more natural to express this with a positive clause. For example:

The only way to the Father is through me. (NCV)

It is only through me that anyone comes to the Father.

Everyone who comes to the Father must come through me.

comes to the Father: This phrase here refers to beginning to have a loving relationship with him. See how you translated the same verb (comes) in 6:37, where Jesus spoke about people coming to him.

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to say whose Father it is. For example

my Father

through Me: This phrase means through Jesus Christ, because of his work and through faith in him. He is “the way” to the Father. Use the word that is most natural in your language. For example:

by me (REB)

John 14:7

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:5–7

In this paragraph, Thomas told Jesus that the disciples did not know where he was going or how to get there. Jesus answered that he himself was the way to God.

14:7a

If you had known Me, you would know My Father as well.

- Because you^(plur) know me, you will know my Father too.
- You know me, so you will know my Father as well.

If you had known Me, you would know My Father as well: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “If/Because you have known me, you will also know my Father.” This is a promise to the disciples that because they know Christ they will know God the Father as well. For example:

Now that you have known me,...you will know my Father also. (GNT) (GNT, NJB, NRSV, GW, NET, NIV2011)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “If you really knew me, you would have known my Father as well.” This is

a rebuke to the disciples for not recognizing who Jesus really is. For example:

If you had known me, you would have known my Father also. (ESV) (BSB, NIV84, RSV, ESV, KJV, NASB, CEV, NLT, REB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). See Carson, p. 493, Kostenberger, p. 447, and Beasley-Murray p. 253. The UBS Committee accepted this reading and gave it a C rating, meaning there is much doubt as to the correct reading.

If you had known Me: These notes follow option (1) above and recommend that you translate this as a condition that was fulfilled. For example:

Because you know me

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples.

you would know My Father as well: Although they are distinct from each other, God the Father and God the Son have the same divine nature and glory. Therefore, if someone knows Jesus the Son, it means that he will know God the Father also.

14:7b

From now on you do know Him and have seen Him.”

- And beginning now you^(plur) know him and you^(plur) have seen him.”
- Starting now you^(plur) both know him and you^(plur) have seen what he is like.”

From now on: This phrase means “starting from this time.” It refers to the time following Jesus’ death and resurrection, when the Holy Spirit would come to the disciples. After Jesus rose from the dead and the Holy Spirit filled them, the disciples understood that Jesus was really God.

you do know Him and have seen Him: Knowing Jesus and realizing that he was God enabled the disciples to know and understand God the Father. Because they had seen Jesus, they had seen God.

General Comment on 14:5–7

In 14:5 Thomas asks a question, and in 14:6 Jesus answers it, speaking only to Thomas. In 14:7 he then addresses all the disciples. In English this is not clear, because there is no difference between a singular and a plural second-person pronoun (“you”). In some languages it may be natural to make this clear by supplying this information. For example:

^{14:7a}“...Now that you have known me,” he said to them, “you will know my Father also....” (GNT)

John 14:8

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:8–11

Jesus’ disciple Philip asked to see God the Father. Jesus replied that anyone who had seen him had seen God the Father, because they are one.

14:8a

Philip said to Him, “Lord, show us the Father,

- ¶ Philip said to Jesus, “Lord, cause/allow us^(excl) to see the/your^(sing) Father.
- ¶ Philip asked Jesus, “Master, please let us^(excl) see God the Father.

Philip said to Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. Because this begins a new paragraph, you may want to make it explicit that Philip spoke to Jesus. For example:

Philip said to Jesus

Philip: Philip was the name of one of Jesus’ disciples. See 1:43 and 12:21.

Lord: See how you translated this in 14:5.

show us the Father: This clause is a request to see God the Father. For example:

Please cause/allow us to see the Father.

We want to see the Father. Please reveal him to us.

show: This verb here means “cause to see.”

us: This pronoun is exclusive here and refers to the disciples but not to Jesus.

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. Jesus referred to him as “my Father” in 14:7a. So if it is necessary to say whose Father he was, you may want to say this:

your^(sing) Father

14:8b

and that will be enough for us.”

- That is sufficient/enough to make us^(excl) happy/content.”
- That is all we want.”
- That will fulfill/satisfy us.”

and that will be enough for us: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as that will be enough for us indicates that seeing God the Father would fulfill the disciples’ greatest desire. The disciples wanted to see and know God more than they wanted anything else. Seeing him would make them satisfied (content and happy). For example:

and that will satisfy us (GW)

and we will be content (NET)

That is all we need. (NCV)

John 14:9

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:8–11

Jesus’ disciple Philip asked to see God the Father. Jesus replied that anyone who had seen him had seen God the Father, because they are one.

14:9a

Jesus replied, “Philip, I have been with you all this time,

- Jesus answered Philip, “Even though I have been a long time with you^(plur),

- Jesus said to Philip, “I have been several years with you^(plur),

14:9b**and still you do not know Me?**

- do you^(sing) not know who I am?
- and by now you^(sing) should recognize who I really/truly am.

14:9a–b

Jesus replied: This quote introducer introduces Jesus’ answer, which is a rhetorical question. Introduce the quote in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus answered (NIV)

Jesus asked him

Philip, I have been with you all this time, and still you do not know Me?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. Jesus rebuked/scolded Philip for not recognizing that he had revealed God through his life and teaching. Philip did not need to ask to see God, because it was unnecessary. He had seen Jesus, who had shown him what God was like.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Philip, I have been with you disciples for a long time. Don’t you, Philip, know who I really am? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

By now you^(sing) should recognize who I really am after my being with you^(plur) disciples for such a long time.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

Philip: In the Greek the name Philip is at the end of the sentence. The BSB puts it at the beginning of the sentence. In some languages it is more natural to place it in the middle of the quotation. Put it where it is most natural in your language.

I have been with you all this time: This clause refers to the three years of Jesus’ ministry on earth when Philip followed him. The phrase all this time implies that a long time had passed. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

I have been with all of you for a long time (GW)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples.

still you do not know Me: This clause means “you still do not recognize who I really am.” The disciples still did not understand that Jesus was God.

you: This pronoun here is singular and refers to Philip alone.

General Comment on 14:9a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to rearrange 14:9a–b, placing the question part of the sentence first. For example:

Don’t you know me, Philip, even after I have been among you such a long time? (NIV)

14:9c**Anyone who has seen Me has seen the Father.**

- Those who have seen me have seen my Father.
- Anyone who sees me sees God, my Father as well.

Anyone who has seen Me has seen the Father: This clause indicates that seeing Jesus is the same as seeing the Father. Jesus and the Father are united, and Jesus revealed God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The person who has seen me has seen the Father. (NET)

If you have seen me, you have seen the Father. (CEV)

14:9d**How can you say, ‘Show us the Father’?**

- Why are you^(sing) asking me to show you the Father?
- So you should not ask me to show/reveal the Father to you.

How can you say, ‘Show us the Father’?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. Jesus rebuked/scolded Philip for asking to see God when he had already seen Jesus.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

So why do you say, ‘Show us the Father’? (NCV)

- Use a statement. For example:

You should not say, “Show us the Father.”

You do not need to ask to see the Father.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Philip.

Show us the Father: This is a quotation of Philip’s words. See how you translated this clause in 14:8.

us: This pronoun is exclusive and refers to all the disciples but not to Jesus.

General Comment on 14:9d

This sentence contains a quotation inside another quotation. Jesus quoted what Philip had just said to him. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an indirect quotation. For example:

How can you ask me to show you the Father? (CEV)

You should not ask me to show you the Father.

John 14:10

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:8–11

Jesus’ disciple Philip asked to see God the Father. Jesus replied that anyone who had seen him had seen God the Father, because they are one.

14:10a

Do you not believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me?

- Do you^(sing) not believe that I am/live in my Father and my Father is/lives in me?
- You should believe that I am united/one with the Father and that the Father is united/one with me.

Do you not believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me?: This is a rhetorical question.

It is used as a rebuke. Jesus rebuked/scolded Philip because he spoke like someone who did not believe that Jesus and the Father were one. He wanted and expected Philip to believe that he and the Father were united.

There are at least two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Don’t you believe that I, myself, am one with the Father and that the Father is one with me? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

You^(sing) should believe that I am one with the Father and that the Father is one with me.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

you...believe: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as you...believe is singular and refers just to Philip. Some languages indicate whether “you” is singular or plural. If your language does not do that, you may want to make it clear that Jesus spoke only to Philip. For example:

Do you not believe, Philip...? (GNT)

I am in the Father and the Father is in Me: This expression indicates that Jesus and the Father are united. They are one God, sharing the same nature and qualities. See the notes on 10:38, where there is a very similar expression. Here are some other ways to express this idea:

I live in the Father and the Father lives in me This is the GeCL rendering in 10:38. See the UBS Handbook p. 460.

that I am united with my Father and my Father is united with me

14:10b

The words I say to you, I do not speak on My own.

- What I have taught you^(plur) is not just my words.
- I do not invent the message that I tell you^(plur).

The words I say to you, I do not speak on My own:

This clause indicates that Jesus did not just teach his own ideas. He did not preach a message that he had created himself, based on his own authority and

decision. See the notes on 7:16–17. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The words I say to you are not just my own. (NIV)

What I'm telling you doesn't come from me. (GW)

I am not myself the source of the words I speak to you. (REB)

The words I say to you: This expression refers to Jesus' teaching or message.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all of the disciples. If your language does not indicate whether "you" is singular or plural, you may want to make it clear another way. For example:

Jesus said to his disciples (GNT)

I do not speak on My own: This clause here indicates that Jesus did not speak words and ideas that he had created himself. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase on My own which means "without help" or "from myself." See the notes on 7:17c and refer to your translation of that verse. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not speak on my own authority (ESV)

The words I say to you don't come from me (NCV)

I am not myself the source of the words I speak to you (REB)

14:10c

Instead, it is the Father dwelling in Me, performing His works.

- Rather, God the Father who lives in me works/acts through me.
- It is my Father, living inside me, who does these things.
- My Father lives in me and does through me what he wants.

Instead, it is the Father dwelling in Me, performing His works: This clause contrasts with 14:10b. Rather than speak from his own wisdom, Jesus spoke from the wisdom of God the Father living in him. The Father was the source and power of what Jesus said and did. The Greek word that the BSB translates as dwelling

means "lives" or "remains." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it is the Father, living in me, who is doing his works (NJB)

but the Father lives in me and does his own work (NCV)

His works: The word works here includes both miracles and teaching. God acted through Jesus' miracles and through his teaching. Try to translate this word using an expression that can include speech as well as actions. For example:

The Father, who lives in me, does what he wants. (GW)

General Comment on 14:10b–c

14:10b is a negative statement and 14:10c is a positive statement of the same truth. In some languages it is more natural to state the positive first. For example:

^{10c}The Father who lives in me works/acts through me. ^{10b}The message I have been teaching is not my own.

John 14:11

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:8–11

Jesus' disciple Philip asked to see God the Father. Jesus replied that anyone who had seen him had seen God the Father, because they are one.

14:11a

Believe Me that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me—

- Believe me when I say that I live in the Father and my Father lives in me.

- When I say that I live in union with the Father, you should believe what I say.

Believe Me that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me: Jesus commanded his disciples to believe his statement that Jesus and God the Father are one. See how you translated this statement in 14:10, and use the same expression here. For example:

Believe what I said, that I live in the Father and the Father lives in me.

14:11b or at least believe on account of the works themselves.

- And if you do not believe because I tell you, at least believe because you have seen my miracles.
- But if you do not believe because of that, I have done wonderful miracles, so you^(plur) should at least believe because of them.

or at least: This expression is short for “but if you do not believe this.” It refers to the possibility that the disciples would not believe that Jesus was united/one with God. Translate this possibility in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

If not (GNT)

but if you do not believe me (NET)

believe on account of the works themselves: There is a textual problem here:

1. Many Greek manuscripts do not include the pronoun meaning “me” after believe here. For example:

believe because of the things I do (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, ESV, NASB, NET, NLT, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts include the pronoun meaning “me” after believe here. For example:

believe me because of the things I do (GW) (RSV, NRSV, KJV, CEV, GW)

It is recommended that you follow those manuscripts that do not include the pronoun meaning “me.” However, it may be natural or necessary to include an object here for the verb believe. If that is true in your language, here are examples of objects that you can use:

believe me

believe what I say

believe it/this

Use the object that is most natural in your language.

believe: This phrase here means “believe that what I say is true.” Or, “believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in me.”

on account of the works themselves: The phrase the BSB has translated as on account of the works themselves means “on the basis of my works.” Because Jesus’ disciples had seen the miracles that he did, they could know that God was with him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because of the things I do (CEV)

because of the miracles I have done (NCV)

General Comment on 14:11a–b

There is a contrast in 14:11a–b. The contrast is between believing Jesus because of his own word and believing him because of his miracles. Jesus wanted his disciples to believe him because of his word. However, it was better that they believe because they saw his miracles than that they not believe at all. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Just believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in me. Or at least believe because of the work you have seen me do. (NLT)

John 14:12

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:12–14

Jesus said that his disciples would do greater deeds than he did. He always did things to glorify God when he lived on earth. And he would continue to glorify God by answering the prayers of his followers.

14:12a

Truly, truly, I tell you, whoever believes in Me will also do the works that I am doing.

- ¶ “I tell you the truth, if you^(plur) believe in me you will do the deeds/acts that I have done.
- ¶ “Listen, anyone who believes in me will do deeds like those I have done here on earth.

Truly, truly, I tell you: The clause that the BSB has translated as Truly, truly, I tell you is more literally “Truly, truly, I say to you.” It introduces an important statement and means “pay attention to what I will say next.” See how you translated this clause in 13:21.

whoever believes in Me: This phrase is indefinite, and refers to anyone and everyone who believes in Jesus. Languages have many ways of expressing an indefinite idea. For example:

people/all who have faith in me

if you have faith in me (CEV)

whoever believes in me (NCV)

believes in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12, 7:31, and 7:38. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

have faith in me (CEV)

trusts in me

will also do the works that I am doing: This phrase indicates that this person would do wonderful deeds like Jesus did.

the works: The Greek word that the BSB translates as works means “deeds” or “acts.” It is not the same Greek word as the word in the title of the New Testament book “Acts.” However the meaning is the same and using the same word might help your readers

to understand Jesus’ meaning. These works would certainly include miracles, but could also include conversions and other loving acts. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the miraculous deeds (NET)

the same things (CEV)

the same works (NLT)

14:12b

He will do even greater things than these, because I am going to the Father.

- In fact, you^(plur) will do greater miracles than I have done, because I will return to God the Father.
- I will return to my Father very soon, and so anyone who believes in me will do deeds that are more wonderful/powerful than mine.

He will do even greater things than these: The phrase will do even greater things than these indicates that the apostles would do greater deeds than Jesus had done. There are several suggestions about how believers would do greater works than Jesus. It could refer to the fact that many more people would see God’s glory in them. Or many more people would hear the gospel, including Gentiles. These works could also be greater because the Holy Spirit would come and work after Jesus went to heaven. Or because Jesus’ saving work on the cross would be finished. The Greek text does not explain what greater things means, so you should not explain it in your translation.

In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

They will do even greater things (GW)

even: The Greek word that the BSB has translated literally as even in this context it emphasizes the following idea. Use a form of emphasis that is natural in your language.

because I am going to the Father: This clause refers to Jesus going to God the Father in heaven. Then he would ask the Father to send the Holy Spirit from heaven. The Holy Spirit will make it possible for believers to do these greater works. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

now that I am going back to the Father (CEV)

because I am going to be with the Father (NLT)

because I will go now to the Father

the Father: In some language it is more natural to tell whose father Jesus spoke about. For example

my Father

God, my Father

General Comment on 14:12b

In some languages it may be natural to change the order of these clauses, and put the cause before the result. For example:

Because I am going back to the Father, they will do even greater things than these.

I am going back to the Father, and so they will be able to do even greater things than I did.

John 14:13

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:12–14

Jesus said that his disciples would do greater deeds than he did. He always did things to glorify God when he lived on earth. And he would continue to glorify God by answering the prayers of his followers.

14:13a

And I will do whatever you ask in My name,

- And I will do what you ask me to do for you, if you ask in my name,
- And so whatever you^(plur) ask me to do according to my will, I will do it for you

And I will do whatever you ask in My name: The clause I will do whatever you ask means “I will do

whatever you pray for.” It is not clear here if they should ask Jesus or the Father for help. However, the next verse speaks specifically about asking Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Whatever you ask in my name I will do (NJB)

And if you ask for anything in my name, I will do it for you. (NCV)

whatever: This word refers to anything that the disciples might ask for in his name. It would include the greater works that Jesus promised that they would do in 14:12b.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

in My name: This phrase here means “as someone united to me” or “according to my will.” To “ask in my name” is to ask for something that Jesus might ask for, something that shows his character. It is to ask God based on one’s faith in Christ. It does not refer to saying “in Jesus’ name” at the end of the prayer. “It is important to translate in My name in such a manner as to avoid the possibility of interpreting the phrase as a magical formula to be attached to the end of a prayer.” (TH) Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

because you are united with me

because you trust in me

on my authority

according to my will

14:13b

so that the Father may be glorified in the Son.

- in order that the Father’s glory may be revealed through his Son.
- so that I may show/reveal how glorious/wonderful my Father is.

so that the Father may be glorified in the Son: This clause means “so that God the Father may be glorified through what Jesus his Son does.” Jesus will glorify God by doing miracles in answer to the prayers of his followers.

so that: The connector that the BSB has translated as so that introduces the reason why Jesus will answer prayers.

the Father may be glorified: The phrase may be glorified refers to revealing the glory of God. People will see how glorious and wonderful God is when his Son reveals his greatness. The Son will glorify his Father by answering the prayers of his people.

The verb may be glorified is in the passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

so that the Father's glory will be shown through the Son (NCV)

so that the glory of the Father will be seen in what I his Son will do

- Use an active verb. For example:

so that the Son can bring glory to the Father (NLT)

This way the Son will bring honor to the Father. (CEV)

so that what I do will honor the Father

in the Son: This phrase indicates that the Father would be glorified because of what the Son did. That is because the Father was the source of what Jesus did and lived inside him (see 12:10).

The phrase the Son refers to Jesus himself, the speaker. If readers will think that Jesus spoke about someone else, it may be necessary to use the first-person pronoun, "I." Using the pronoun "my" with "Father" should make it clear that the speaker is the Son. For example:

I may glorify my Father

See how you translated the phrase the Son at 5:19. For further information, see the note on the phrase "the Son of God" at 1:34.

John 14:14

Section 14:1–14 Jesus is the way to the Father

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his death. He encouraged them to keep trusting God and told them that he would prepare a place for them in heaven. He also talked about his unity with God the Father and said that he was the way to go to his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus and God the Father are one

Jesus is the way, the truth, and the life

Paragraph 14:12–14

Jesus said that his disciples would do greater deeds than he did. He always did things to glorify God when he lived on earth. And he would continue to glorify God by answering the prayers of his followers.

14:14

If you ask Me for anything in My name, I will do it.

- You^(plur) may ask me to do something and I will do it for you, if you^(plur) ask in my name.
- Yes, you^(plur) may pray and ask me to do anything for you according to my will, and I will do it for you.

If you ask Me for anything in My name, I will do it:

This verse repeats what 14:13a said. It is repeated for emphasis. In some languages it is natural to make some small difference to show that it is repeated for emphasis. For example:

Yes, ask me for anything in my name, and I will do it! (NLT)

If you ask Me for anything in My name: This is an "if" clause that may or may not be true. People may pray in Jesus' name, or they may not.

There is a textual issue here.

1. Many Greek manuscripts include the pronoun Me. For example:

If you ask me for anything (GNT) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, NCV, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include this pronoun. For example:

If you ask anything (RSV) (KJV, RSV, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because the better manuscripts read that way and most English translations follow it. The UBS Committee gave this reading a B rating, which means that there is only a little doubt. Some manuscripts omit this verse completely. However, the UBS Greek text includes it with a B rating. Most English translations include it, and it is recommended that you do also.

you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the disciples.

anything: This word refers to what you might ask for in prayer. It is indefinite. Languages have many ways of expressing an indefinite idea. For example:

something

whatever

what

in My name: To ask in Jesus' name is to pray according to Jesus' will. See the note and how you translated this phrase in 14:13a.

I will do it: This clause means "I will do what you ask me to do."

I: The Greek text emphasizes the word used for I. It refers to Jesus. For example:

I myself will do it.

John 14:15

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments." He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:15–17

Jesus told his disciples that if they loved him, they would obey his commandments. He also promised to send the Holy Spirit to be with his disciples.

14:15

If you love Me, you will keep My commandments.

- ¶ "If you^(plur) love me, you will obey what I command.
- ¶ "If you^(plur) love me, the result will be that you will do what I tell you to do.

If you love Me, you will keep My commandments:

There is a textual issue in this verse:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the verb form that means you will keep or "you will obey." For example:

If you love me, you will obey my commandments (GNT) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV84, NRSV, CEV, GW, NET, GNT, REB, NCV, NJB, NABRE)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the command form of the verb "obey." For example:

If you love me, obey my commandments (NLT) (KJV, NLT, NIV11)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because most English translations follow it. Also, the UBS Committee followed that option, though they gave it a C rating, which means that there was doubt about the decision. However, most of the Committee thought that it fit the context better.

Believers show that they love Jesus by doing what he has told them to do. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Those of you who love me will keep my commandments.

If you love Me: This clause can be true or not true. It does not assume that either possibility is correct.

you will keep My commandments: This clause means "you will do/obey what I told you to do." In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb instead of the noun commandments. For example:

you will obey what I command (NIV93)

John 14:16

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments." He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:15–17

Jesus told his disciples that if they loved him, they would obey his commandments. He also promised to send the Holy Spirit to be with his disciples.

14:16a

And I will ask the Father,

- And I will pray to my Father
- I will ask/request the Father

And I will ask the Father: This clause here means “And I will make a request to the Father.” Jesus said he would ask the Father to do something for his disciples.

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to tell whose father this is. For example:

my Father

God , my Father

14:16b

and He will give you another Advocate to be with you forever—

- and he will provide another Helper for you^(plur). This Helper will be with you^(plur) forever.
- to send you^(plur) an Encourager/Defender in my place. That Encourager/Defender will never leave you^(plur).

and He will give you another Advocate: This clause here indicates that God the Father will send the Holy Spirit to help his disciples.

another Advocate: This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit (see 14:17a) and implies that Jesus was also an Advocate. So your translation of Advocate should be a title suitable for Jesus also. The Holy Spirit would be an Advocate similar to Jesus and would replace him.

Advocate: The Greek word that the BSB translated as Advocate is more literally “one called to help someone,” and so “Encourager” or “Helper.” The Advocate would be one who would help, encourage, guide, and advise the believers, just as Jesus had. He would be like a good friend. The Greek word was also used for a person who would help defend someone in a legal court. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Helper (ESV)

Encourager

defender

In some languages it is more natural to translate this noun as a clause. For example:

who will help you (CEV)

someone who will help and encourage you

to be with you forever: Jesus, the other Helper, left and returned to heaven. The Holy Spirit will never leave. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

who will stay with you for ever (GNT)

who will never leave you (NLT)

General Comment on 14:16a–b

14:16a indicates that Jesus would make a request. Then 14:16b indicates that God would answer the request and also tells what the request was. Connect these ideas in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then I will ask the Father to send you the Holy Spirit who will help you and always be with you. (CEV)

John 14:17

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:15–17

Jesus told his disciples that if they loved him, they would obey his commandments. He also promised to send the Holy Spirit to be with his disciples.

14:17a the Spirit of truth.

- This Helper is God's Spirit, who teaches/reveals what is true.
- He is the Holy Spirit. He speaks/reveals the truth about God.

the Spirit of truth: This phrase means “the Spirit who proclaims or teaches the truth.” It refers to the Holy Spirit. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

the Spirit, who reveals the truth about God (GNT)

In some languages it is more natural to use an adjective to translate truth. For example:

The Spirit will show you what is true. (CEV)

14:17b

The world cannot receive Him,

- The people of this world cannot receive/believe him,
- The people who do not believe cannot accept him into their lives

The world cannot receive Him: This expression indicates that the unbelievers of the world do not accept the Holy Spirit in their lives. They do not want to submit to him. They do not welcome him because they cannot do so, because of who they are and who he is. Here are possible ways to translate this expression:

The world cannot accept him. (NIV)

The people of this world cannot accept the Spirit as their helper.

The people who do not believe are not able to be in fellowship with the Holy Spirit (Otomi Back Translation)

The world: This phrase refers to the people in the world who do not believe in God and Christ. The Greek text emphasizes this word, probably to contrast it with “You” in 14:17d, which is also emphasized.

receive: The Greek word that the BSB translates as receive here refers to accepting and welcoming a person. It is the same word that is used in 1:12. A slightly different word is used in 1:11b, where the BSB translates it as “receive,” but the meaning is the same.

14:17c

because it neither sees Him nor knows Him.

- because they do not see him or know him.
- because they do not recognize him or understand who he is.

because: The connector because introduces the reasons for the fact that the world cannot receive God's Spirit of truth (14:17b).

it: This word is a pronoun that refers to the world that does not believe. If you translated the word “world” in 14:17b with a plural noun (such as “unbelievers” or “people in this world”), then the pronoun here must also be plural. For example:

they (CEV)

neither sees Him nor knows Him: The people of the world cannot see the Holy Spirit (Him) and they do not know him personally.

nor knows Him: The verb knows in this context means “have a personal relationship with.” Unbelievers might have heard about the Holy Spirit, but they do not know him personally.

14:17d

But you do know Him, for He abides with you and will be in you.

- But you^(plur) know him, because he stays/lives with you and soon will be/live inside you.
- You^(plur) understand who he is already because he lives with you and will soon live inside you.

you do know Him: There is a contrast here. The contrast is between the world which does not receive or know the Holy Spirit (Him) and the disciples who do.

The Greek text indicates this contrast by emphasizing the phrase “the world” in 14:17b and the pronoun you. Because of this contrast, most English translations supply the word “but.” You should indicate the contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

But you know him (GNT)

You do know him

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

do know Him: This phrase in this context means “personally know the Holy Spirit” or “have experienced the Holy Spirit.” See how you translated a similar phrase in 14:17.

for He abides with you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as abides means “stays” or “remains.” At this time the Holy Spirit was with the disciples as an outside force or influence. They could see him working among them through the miracles that Jesus did and the miracles that they themselves did. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because he lives with you now (NLT)

who is with you (CEV)

and will be in you: Later, at Pentecost, the Holy Spirit came to the disciples to live inside each of them. He would be an internal force or influence. There is a textual issue here.

1. Many Greek manuscripts have the future tense verb that means “will be.” For example:

and will be in you (RSV) (BSB, ESV, KJV, NASB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have the present tense verb that means “is.” For example:

and is in you (GNT) (GNT, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because better manuscripts have that reading and most English translations follow it. The UBS Greek text, 4th edition, gives option (1) a C rating, indicating much doubt.

John 14:18

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:18–21

Jesus said that he was not going to abandon his followers. He would send the Holy Spirit to them. He and the Father would come and be with them.

14:18a

I will not leave you as orphans;

- ¶ “I will not leave/abandon you^(plur) as orphans.
- ¶ “I will not leave you^(plur) alone, like orphans.

I will not leave you as orphans: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as I will not leave you as orphans is a metaphor that indicates that Jesus would not leave the disciples alone with no one to protect them. They would not be like a child without parents. There are several ways to translate this figure of speech:

- Use a metaphor. For example:

I shall not leave you orphans. (NJB)

- Use a simile. For example:

I won’t leave you like orphans. (CEV)

- Use a simile indicating the meaning. For example:

I will not leave you all alone like orphans. (NCV)

- Translate just the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

When I go, you will not be left all alone. (GNT)

I am not going to leave you alone in the world. (JBP)

It is good to keep the figure of speech if that is possible and natural in your language. However, it may not be possible or natural to include the idea of orphans in your translation. Or people may not understand why Jesus used the idea of orphans here. If one of those problems is true in your language, you should translate just the meaning of the metaphor.

leave you as orphans: This phrase refers to going away from someone who has no one to care for them. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

abandon you as orphans (NLT)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

14:18b

I will come to you.

- I will return to you^(plur).
- I will return and/to be with you^(plur).

I will come to you: There are three ways to interpret what time Jesus is referring to here:

1. It refers to Jesus' resurrection. See Carson, p. 501, Keener volume 2 p. 973.
2. It refers to the Holy Spirit coming. See Kostenberger p. 439, Brown volume 2 p. 645–646.
3. It refers to Jesus' return at the end of the world. See Bruce p. 303, who also says that this phrase includes "every phase" of his coming.

All the available English translations have translated this literally, without saying what event Jesus referred to. It is recommended that you also translate this literally.

However in some languages it may be necessary to say whether the event would happen soon or much later. If you need to make this clear, it is recommended that you indicate that the event would happen soon. That would include interpretations (1) and (2). The present tense of the Greek verb refers more naturally to something happening soon and this suits the context better. For example:

I will come back to you. (GNT)

I will come again to you. (Yakan Back Translation)

I will return here to you.

John 14:19

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments." He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:18–21

Jesus said that he was not going to abandon his followers. He would send the Holy Spirit to them. He and the Father would come and be with them.

14:19a

In a little while the world will see Me no more,

- Soon the people of the world will not see me anymore,
- Very soon unbelievers in the world will not see me anymore,

In a little while: This phrase refers to the crucifixion, which was less than a day away. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Before long (NIV)

Soon (NLT)

It will not be a long time until

the world will see Me no more: The phrase the world refers to the unbelievers in the world. After

the crucifixion, unbelievers would not see Jesus again. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase the world to contrast it with “you” in 14:19b (which the Greek also emphasizes). The world would no longer see Jesus, but the disciples would see him. Translate this contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

In a little while, the people who do not follow God will no longer see me. But you, you will see me.

Before long, those in the world who do not believe in me will no longer see me. But as for you, you will certainly see me.

14:19b–c

but you will see Me. Because I live, you also will live: There are two ways to punctuate 14:19b–c and understand the Greek word that the BSB translates as Because:

1. The Greek word means Because and begins a new clause and a new thought. For example:

but you will see me. Because I live, you also will live. (NIV) (BSB, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NIV, REB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. The Greek word means “that” and introduces what the disciples will see, so it continues the previous thought. For example:

but you will see that I live, and you also will live (NJB) (NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with nearly all English translations.

14:19b

but you will see Me.

- but you^(plur) will see me.
- but you^(plur) on the other hand will see me again.

but you will see Me: This clause refers to Jesus showing himself to his disciples. Although the disciples would not see Jesus while he was in the tomb, after his resurrection they would see him. It may be good to translate this clause in a way that helps people to understand that. For example:

then you will see me again

The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun you to contrast it with “the world” in 14:19a (which the Greek also

emphasizes). See the note at 14:19a for suggestions on how to translate this contrast.

14:19c

Because I live, you also will live.

- You^(plur) will live because I live.
- Because I will live again, you^(plur) also will truly live.

Because I live, you also will live: The resurrection of Jesus guarantees life for believers. For example:

because I live, you will live too (NET)

You will live because I live. (GW)

The Greek text emphasizes the pronouns I and you. That emphasizes the difference of the pronouns because the verb is the same in the two clauses. If possible, indicate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

Because I live: The connector Because indicates that this clause is the reason for the next clause. Jesus will live after his resurrection, and so his people will live also. Although the Greek verb is present tense, it refers to an event that will happen very soon in the future. In some languages it may be more natural to use a future tense verb. For example:

Because I will live again, you will also live.

You will have the new life because again I will live. (Otomi Back Translation)

you also will live: This clause here probably refers to the new, eternal life that Jesus’ followers would experience after Jesus’ resurrection. The pronoun you is plural.

also: The word also here indicates that as Jesus would have new life after his resurrection, so would his followers. In some languages the word also may not be necessary or natural here. Some English translations leave it implicit. For example:

And because I live, you will live. (CEV)

John 14:20

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can

receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:18–21

Jesus said that he was not going to abandon his followers. He would send the Holy Spirit to them. He and the Father would come and be with them.

14:20a

On that day you will know that I am in My Father,

- When that day comes you^(plur) will understand that I live in my Father,
- At that time you^(plur) will realize that I and my Father are united/one,

On that day: This phrase probably refers to the time when Jesus would rise from the dead. But it is good to leave this implied from the context. For example:

When that day comes (GNT)

you will know: The word you here is plural and refers to Jesus' disciples.

know: This verb here means “come to know” or “realize.” Jesus had told them many times about his union with the Father. However, they did not understand that it was true until he rose from the dead.

that I am in My Father: This is a very difficult metaphor to express in many languages. It indicates that Jesus and God are united as one God. See how you translated this idea in 14:10. Here are some other ways to express this idea:

that I live in my Father

that I am united with my Father

My Father: The phrase My Father refers to God the Father.

14:20b

and you are in Me, and I am in you.

- and you^(plur) live in me, and I live in you.
- and you^(plur) and I are united/one.

and you are in Me, and I am in you: This expression means “and you live in me and I live in you.” This refers to the very close relationship between Jesus and his disciples. See how you translated a similar expression in 14:10. Some languages have idioms to express this idea. Here are some other ways to translate this expression:

I and you are united

I am united to you and you are united to me.

I live in you, and you live in me

John 14:21

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:18–21

Jesus said that he was not going to abandon his followers. He would send the Holy Spirit to them. He and the Father would come and be with them.

14:21a

Whoever has My commandments and keeps them is the one who loves Me.

- Those who accept what I command and obey/do it, they are the ones who love me.
- The/A person who loves me will receive what I tell him to do and will do it,

Whoever has My commandments and keeps them:

The word Whoever is indefinite. That means that it refers to anyone and everyone who obeys Jesus' commandments. Express this indefinite subject in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

People who have my commands and keeps them

If you^(plur) have my commands and follow them

Anyone who has received my commandments and obeys them

Those who accept my commandments and obey them

has My commandments and keeps them: This phrase means "know what I want them to do and do it." These people understand what Jesus commanded them to do and they do what he commanded. In some languages it is more natural to express these two ideas as one. For example:

whoever does what I commanded him to do

whoever obeys my commands

is the one who loves Me: The clause the one who loves Me refers to the same person as "Whoever has My commandments and keeps them." So the subjects of the two clauses should agree in number. (They should both be singular or both be plural.) These people show that they love Jesus when they obey what he has told them to do.

14:21b

The one who loves Me will be loved by My Father,

- And they, the ones who love me, will be loved by my Father.
- and my Father will love the one who loves me.

The one who loves Me will be loved by My Father:

This clause indicates that God the Father will love those people who love Jesus, his Son. The verb phrase will be loved by My Father is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

And he who loves me will be loved by my Father. (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

My Father will love those who love me. (GNT)

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language here.

who loves Me: This noun clause refers back to the people mentioned in 14:21a. Refer to this indefinite subject in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

People who love me

If you love me you

All who love me

Whoever loves me

14:21c

and I will love him and reveal Myself to him."

- I will love them also and show them who I really am."
- And I will love him and cause him to see/know me."

and I will love him: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun I. Jesus as well as God the Father will love the one who loves and obeys him. The pronoun him refers back to the indefinite pronoun in 14:21b and should agree with its number (singular or plural).

and reveal Myself to him: This phrase indicates that Jesus will allow his followers to see him as he truly is. It implies that he is great and glorious, and that his followers will recognize his greatness and glory. This probably refers mainly to Jesus appearing to his disciples after he rose from the dead. He came to them so that they saw who he was with their eyes. But this probably also refers to later followers who did not see Jesus with their eyes. Translate this phrase to include both meanings. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

show myself to him (NIV)

make myself known to him

appear before them

show them who I really am

General Comment on 14:21

In some languages it may be natural to continue to use the second-person plural form (you) as the main subject. That is what was used in 14:15–20. For example:

²¹If you love me, you will do what I have said, and my Father will love you. I will also love you and show you what I am like. (CEV)

John 14:22

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:22–24

One of the disciples asked Jesus why the disciples would see him but others would not. Jesus answered that it was because his disciples loved and obeyed him, while others did not love or obey him.

14:22a

Judas (not Iscariot) asked Him,

- ¶ Then Judas (the other Judas, not Judas Iscariot) asked,
- ¶ Then Judas, not Judas Iscariot but the other disciple named Judas, asked Jesus,

Judas (not Iscariot): There were two disciples with the name Judas. This is not the one who betrayed

Jesus (Judas Iscariot) but the other disciple named Judas. This other Judas is also mentioned in Luke 6:16 and Acts 1:13. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example

Judas (not Judas Iscariot) (GNT)

The other Judas, not Judas Iscariot (CEV)

Judas (not Judas Iscariot, but the other disciple with that name) (NLT)

asked Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as asked Him is more literally “said to him.” This quote introducer here introduces a question, a request for information. Use the most natural expression in your language.

14:22b

“Lord, why are You going to reveal Yourself to us and not to the world?”

- “Lord, why will you^(sing) let us^(excl) see you but you will not let the people of the world see you?”
- “Master, why will you^(sing) show us^(excl) who you are and you will not show the unbelievers of the world?”

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” See how you translated this in 14:5 and 14:8, and translate it the same way here.

why are You going to reveal Yourself to us and not to the world?: Judas asked Jesus to explain what he meant. He wondered how Jesus could show who he truly was, his glory, and yet only the disciples would see him. This is a real question. Here are other ways to translate this question:

what has happened that you are going to reveal yourself to us and not to the world? (NET)

how can it be that you will reveal yourself to us and not to the world? (GNT)

why do you plan to show yourself to us and not to the rest of the world? (NCV)

why are You...?: The phrase that the BSB has translated as why are You...? is more literally “what has happened...?” Jesus had tried to tell them that he would go to the Father, but the disciples did not understand him.

going to reveal Yourself: The phrase going to reveal Yourself means “will cause people to see who you are.” It implies that people would see Jesus’ glory, seeing how glorious and great he is. See how you translated this idea in 14:21.

to us: The pronoun us refers to the disciples. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase and “to the world” to emphasize the contrast between the two. Judas asked why Jesus would reveal himself to his followers and not to the world.

and not to the world: This phrase is a short way of saying “and not reveal yourself to the world.” The phrase the world refers to people on earth who do not believe in Jesus.

John 14:23

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:22–24

One of the disciples asked Jesus why the disciples would see him but others would not. Jesus answered that it was because his disciples loved and obeyed him, while others did not love or obey him.

14:23a

Jesus replied, “If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word.”

- Jesus answered him, “People who love me will obey me.
- Jesus said to Judas, “Only those people who love me will obey me.

Jesus replied: This quote introducer introduces a long direct quotation, 14:23–31.

Jesus did not directly answer Judas’ question. Instead he implied his answer. Jesus would not reveal himself to unbelievers because they do not obey him. Therefore the Father and Son do not live inside them.

If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word: The clause that the BSB translates literally as If anyone loves Me, he will keep My word means that the result of love for Christ is obedience to him. This is a general rule. Express it in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Those who love me will do what I say. (GW)

If anyone loves me, they will obey me. (CEV)

If anyone loves Me: This clause refers to anyone and everyone who loves Jesus. Express this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

All who love me (NLT)

If people love me (NCV)

he will keep My word: This phrase refers to obeying the things Jesus said. See how you translated “keep my commandments” in 14:21.

14:23b

My Father will love him,

- Then my Father will love them
- God my Father will love them

My Father will love him: This clause means that God the Father will love all people who love God the Son, Jesus.

14:23c

and We will come to him and make Our home with him.

- and we^(excl) will come to them and stay/remain with them.
- and we^(excl) will go and live with them.

We will come to him and make Our home with him:

This clause indicates that Jesus and his Father would live with those who love him. God the Father and God the Son will have a personal, close, and permanent relationship with these people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

we will come and make our home with each of them (NLT)

my Father and I will come to him and live with him (GNT)

we will come to them and live in them (CEV)

We: This pronoun is exclusive here. It refers to God the Father and God the Son (and not the disciples). For example:

my Father and I

make Our home with him: This phrase is a figure of speech. It indicates that God and Jesus will form a permanent and close relationship with those who love Jesus. The Greek word that the BSB translates as home is the singular form of the word translated as “dwelling places” in 14:2.

with him: God will live inside each person who loves him. Consider how you referred to these people in 14:23a and choose the singular or plural, whichever is suitable here. For example:

with each of them (NLT)

with him (NET)

John 14:24

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:22–24

One of the disciples asked Jesus why the disciples would see him but others would not. Jesus answered that it was because his disciples loved and obeyed him, while others did not love or obey him.

14:24a

Whoever does not love Me does not keep My words.

- But those who do not love me do not obey me.
- But the people who do not love me, they do not obey me.

Whoever does not love Me does not keep My words:

This clause indicates that people who do not love Jesus will not want to obey him. This is the opposite of 14:23. You may want to make the implied contrast explicit. For example:

But anyone who doesn’t love me, won’t obey me. (CEV)

But the person who does not love me, he also does not follow/obey my teachings. (Yakan Back Translation)

Whoever does not love Me: This clause explains the phrase “the world” that was used in 14:19 and 14:22. That phrase refers to those who do not believe in Jesus or love him. It does not refer to everyone in the world.

Whoever: This word is indefinite and refers to anyone. For example:

The person who does not love me

Those who do not love me (GNT)

Anyone who doesn’t love me (NLT)

14:24b

The word that you hear is not My own,

- The message you^(plur) hear from me is not really my own.
- I am not inventing what I am saying to you^(plur).

The word that you hear is not My own: This clause indicates that the things Jesus said did not come from him alone. He was not the source. He was not speaking based on his own authority or decision. See

the notes on 12:49–50. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

These words you hear are not my own (NIV)

I don't make up what you hear me say. (GW)

The word that you hear: This phrase refers to what Jesus had said to the disciples, his message. For example:

What they have heard me say (CEV)

This teaching that you hear (NCV)

is not My own: The phrase not My own indicates that Jesus' teaching was not just his own idea. He did agree with it, but he did not create it by himself. He taught it, but it was not his own idea. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

is not my own (NJB)

is not really mine (NCV)

doesn't really come from me (CEV)

14:24c

but it is from the Father who sent Me.

- It comes from the/my Father, who sent me here.
- Rather my Father sent me to you and told me to say these things.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (14:24b) to a positive statement (14:24c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

What they have heard me say doesn't really come from me, but from the Father who sent me. (CEV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

My teaching is not mine; rather/instead it comes from my Father who sent me.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

And remember, my words are not my own. What I am telling you is from the Father who sent me. (NLT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

My teaching is from him who sent me. It is not mine.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language. See how you translated a very similar sentence in 7:16.

it is from the Father who sent Me: This expression indicates that Jesus' teaching came originally from God the Father. For example:

is the word of the Father who sent me (NJB)

the Father's who sent me (NET)

comes from the Father, who sent me (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new clause, repeating the subject ("the word that you hear"). For example (the subject is underlined):

What I say comes from the Father who sent me. (GW)

What I am telling you is from the Father who sent me. (NLT)

from the Father who sent Me: This clause refers to God the Father. In your translation, be sure not to imply that there are two or more fathers, one of whom sent Jesus. There is one Father, and he sent Jesus. For example:

my Father sent me and told me to speak this message

John 14:25

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments." He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can

receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:25–26

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit would teach them everything.

14:25

All this I have spoken to you while I am still with you.

- ¶ “I have told you^(plur) these things while I am still here with you.
- ¶ “Before I leave you^(plur), I have taught you these things.

All this I have spoken to you: The word *this* refers to all that Jesus had just said and continued to say. Here are other ways to translate this whole clause:

I have told you this (GW)

I am telling you this (NLT)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

while I am still with you: This clause implies that Jesus would soon go away. In some languages it is more natural to express this time as being before he went away. For example:

before I leave you

John 14:26

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can

receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:25–26

In this paragraph, Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit would teach them everything.

14:26a

But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in My name,

- But later/afterwards the Father will send the Helper, the Holy Spirit, as my representative
- When I will no longer be with you^(plur), my Father will send you the Encourager/Defender, the Holy Spirit, to act for me

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *But* here introduces a different subject. There is perhaps a slight contrast between Jesus himself and the Holy Spirit, and what they will do. The GNT does not translate this word explicitly. Translate this introduction to a new subject in a way that is natural in your language.

the Advocate, the Holy Spirit: The word *Advocate* means “one who is called to help” and is another name for the Holy Spirit. See the notes on 14:16b. Translate it in the same or a similar way here. For example:

the Helper, the Holy Spirit (ESV)

the Encourager, the Holy Spirit

the Holy Spirit will come and help you (CEV)

the Holy Spirit: The Holy Spirit is the third person of the Trinity, one with the Father and Son. See KBT Holy

A.2. He is called “the Spirit of truth” in 14:17. See how you translated the Holy Spirit in 1:33.

whom the Father will send in My name: God the Father will send the Holy Spirit to the disciples in the name of Jesus.

in My name: This phrase here probably indicates that the Holy Spirit comes with Jesus’ authority. He will be with the disciples instead of Jesus, guiding and teaching them. For example:

as my representative (NLT)

14:26b

will teach you all things

- to teach you^(plur) everything that you need to know,
- and to cause you^(plur) to understand all the truth,

will teach you all things: The Holy Spirit will teach Jesus’ disciples everything that they need to know about God and about Jesus’ message. The verb teach here refers to giving understanding and wisdom. The Spirit will help Jesus’ followers understand Jesus’ teaching and how it applies to their lives.

14:26c

and will remind you of everything I have told you.

- and remind you about everything that I taught you^(plur).
- and to remind you^(plur) about all the things that I said to you.

will remind you of everything I have told you: This expression indicates that the Holy Spirit will cause the believers to remember everything Jesus taught them. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

will cause you to remember all that I told you (NCV)

make you remember all that I have told you (GNT)

General Comment on 14:26

In some languages it is more natural to translate this verse using two or more sentences. For example:

But the Holy Spirit will come and help you, because the Father will send the Spirit to take my place. The Spirit will teach you everything and will remind you of what I said while I was with you. (CEV)

My Father will send the Holy Spirit to you^(plur) as my representative to help you^(plur). He will teach you^(plur) everything that you^(plur) need to know, and remind you^(plur) of all that I have said to you^(plur).

John 14:27

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:27–31

Jesus told the disciples that he was giving them true peace. It was now time for him to go to the Father. Satan was about to attack, but Jesus would continue to love and obey God his Father.

14:27a

Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you.

- ¶ “I am leaving you^(plur) peace. Yes, I am giving you my peace.
- ¶ “Now as I leave you I am giving you^(plur) peace, the peace that I produce.

Peace I leave with you; My peace I give to you: These two clauses are parallel. The meaning is the same, and the idea is repeated for emphasis. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

I give you peace, the kind of peace that only I can give. (CEV)

Peace is what I leave with you; it is my own peace that I give you. (GNT)

When I leave I will make your minds peaceful; I will give you my own peace.

Peace: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as Peace has a broad meaning that includes more than just the absence of fighting. It also involves positive mental and emotional welfare, and good relationships with God and others. See how you translated this word in Luke 1:79, Romans 5:1, and Ephesians 1:2 and 6:15.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

My peace: This phrase refers to peace that comes from Jesus, peace that he creates.

14:27b

I do not give to you as the world gives.

- I do not give you peace in the same way that the world does.
- The way I give to you is not the same as the way that unbelievers and their ideas in the world give.

I do not give to you as the world gives: There are two ways to interpret this sentence.

1. It indicates that the way that Jesus gives peace is different from the way that the world gives peace. For example:

I do not give it to you as the world does. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, NET, GNT, ESV, NASB, KJV, NCV)

1. It indicates that the peace that Jesus gives is different from the peace that the world gives. For example:

It isn't like the peace that this world can give. (CEV) (NJB, REB, GW, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations. The Greek text does not mention peace in this sentence. It only mentions the act of giving.

Jesus did not say in what way he gave peace and in what way the world gave peace. It is best to let the reader think about this himself.

Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Not as the world gives do I give to you (ESV)

I do not give peace in the same way that the world does.

the world: Here this phrase probably refers to the people of the world who do not believe in God or Christ. That is what the phrase meant in 14:17, 19, and 22. But in this verse it could also include the principles or systems here on earth that do not honor God.

14:27c

Do not let your hearts be troubled; do not be afraid.

- Do not allow yourselves^(plur) to be upset or afraid.
- Make your^(plur) hearts/spirits calm/quiet and stop their being afraid about what will happen.
- Do not be worried or afraid anymore.

Do not let your hearts be troubled: The chapter begins with these words. See the note and how you translated them in 14:1.

hearts: The word hearts here refers to the source of people's thoughts and feelings. Use the term that is natural in your language, as you did in 14:1.

do not be afraid: This clause means "stop being afraid." Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Do not let your hearts be...lacking in courage (NET)

General Comment on 14:27c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two clauses in 14:27c into one. For example:

Do not let your hearts be troubled or afraid. (NJB)

So don't be troubled or cowardly. (GW)

John 14:28

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, "If you love me, you will keep my commandments." He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:27–31

Jesus told the disciples that he was giving them true peace. It was now time for him to go to the Father. Satan was about to attack, but Jesus would continue to love and obey God his Father.

14:28a

You heard Me say, ‘I am going away, and I am coming back to you.’

- I already told you^(plur) that I am leaving and I will return to you.
- As I already said ‘Although I am leaving now, I will return to you^(plur) soon.’

You heard Me say: This quote introducer refers back to something Jesus told the disciples earlier that evening.

I am going away: This clause refers to Jesus going to his Father in heaven. He had spoken of this in 14:3, 4. The verb here is the same as in 14:4, where the BSB translates it as “I am going.”

and I am coming back to you: These are the words Jesus used in 14:18b. See the note there and how you translated the clause in that verse.

General Comment on 14:28a

This sentence includes a quotation inside another quotation. Inside the quotation of what Jesus said is a quotation of what he himself said earlier in 14:3, 4, and 18. He did not use exactly the same words. Consider how it is natural to remind people of what you said earlier. You may use a direct quotation or an indirect quotation for what Jesus said earlier. For example:

You heard me say to you, ‘I am going, but I am coming back to you.’ (NCV)

Remember what I told you: I am going away, but I will come back to you again. (NLT)

You have already heard me say that I am going and that I will also come back to you. (CEV)

14:28b

If you loved Me, you would rejoice that I am going to the Father,

- If you^(plur) loved me, you would be glad that I will go home to my Father
- If you^(plur) truly loved me, you would be happy for me because I am going home to my Father.

If you loved Me, you would rejoice that I am going to the Father: It is implied that the condition (you loved Me) is not true, and so the second clause is not true either. The disciples were not rejoicing that Jesus was going to his Father. Consider how it is natural to translate this type of sentence in your language. For example:

If you really loved me, you would be happy that I am going to the Father. (NLT)

If you loved Me: This is a condition that is assumed to be false. Jesus implied that his disciples did not truly love him. For example:

If you loved me but you do not

you would rejoice that I am going to the Father: These clauses imply that the disciples did not rejoice. They were unhappy because Jesus was leaving them.

14:28c

because the Father is greater than I.

- because that is better for me. My Father is greater than I am.
- For the Father is great, glorious and powerful in a way that I am not now.

because the Father is greater than I: This clause gives the reason why the disciples should be happy. When Jesus went to his Father, he would return to the glory and joy of his Father. He left this glory and perfect joy when he came to earth as a human being.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as greater can be used of one who has a higher status. This could mean that Jesus took a lower status when he came to earth (see Philippians 2:7). Or it could refer to the idea that a father had a higher status than his son. And Jesus was the loving and obedient Son of his heavenly Father.

As the Son, his nature and being were equal with God the Father’s. When he became man, he did not stop being truly and completely God. So in your translation, do not use an expression that can only refer to greatness of being and nature. Instead, use an expression that can refer to greatness of status.

John 14:29

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:27–31

Jesus told the disciples that he was giving them true peace. It was now time for him to go the Father. Satan was about to attack, but Jesus would continue to love and obey God his Father.

14:29a–b

This verse is similar to 13:19. See how you translated that verse and let that help you know how to translate this verse.

14:29a

And now I have told you before it happens,

- And now I have told you^(plur) that I will go away before I go
- Before all this happens to me I am telling you^(plur) that it will happen.

And now I have told you before it happens: These clauses indicate that Jesus told the disciples that he was going away before he actually left. In some languages it will be natural to make it explicit that the phrase it happens refers to Jesus leaving. For example:

I am telling you this before I leave. (CEV)

I have told you this while I’m still with you. (GW)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

it: This word refers to Jesus’ going away. Jesus told the disciples that he was going to the Father (14:28).

14:29b

so that when it does happen, you will believe.

- so that you^(plur) will believe in me when you see it happen.
- Then when it does happen you^(plur) will know that you can have faith in me.

so that when it does happen, you will believe: These clauses indicate Jesus’ reason for telling the disciples that he was going to leave them. He told them that before it occurred (happened) so that when it did occur, they would believe in him. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

so that when it happens you may believe (NET)

so that when it does happen, you will have faith in me (CEV)

so that: The connector the BSB has translated as so that means “in order that.” It indicates that the following clause gives the reason for the previous clause.

when it does happen: This expression again refers to Christ leaving his disciples. He was going to go away from them, as he had told them.

you will believe: When the word believe is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying “believe in Jesus.” So this word includes the idea of believing who Jesus was and what he said. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the truth about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

you will have faith in me (CEV)

you may have faith (REB)

This does not imply that the disciples did not believe in Jesus before. But this would help them to believe more strongly and surely.

John 14:30

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit.

Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:27–31

Jesus told the disciples that he was giving them true peace. It was now time for him to go to the Father. Satan was about to attack, but Jesus would continue to love and obey God his Father.

14:30a

I will not speak with you much longer,

- I do not have very much time to teach you^(plur) now,
- I shall not be able to talk much longer to you, (JBP)

I will not speak with you much longer: This clause indicates that Jesus knew that he would soon have to leave his disciples. He would not be able to talk to them because he would not be there. In your translation, avoid implying that Jesus would not talk with them because he was angry with them. Here is one way to avoid this wrong implication:

I shall not be able to talk much longer to you (JBP)

14:30b

for the prince of this world is coming,

- because the evil one who rules this world, is coming soon.
- for the spirit that rules this world is coming very close. (JBP)

for: The connector the BSB translated as for means “because.” It introduces the reason why Jesus said what he did in the previous clause.

the prince of this world is coming: This clause indicates that Satan would soon attack Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the prince of this world approaches (REB)

the leader of demons who rules this world will come soon

the prince of this world: This phrase refers to Satan, the chief of the evil spirits. See how you translated this phrase in 12:31. In some languages it may be necessary to make it explicit that Jesus spoke about an evil power or Satan. For example:

the evil one who rules this world

Satan, who rules the people who do not believe

14:30c

and he has no claim on Me.

- He has no rights over me. (REB)
- He cannot control what happens to me,

he has no claim on Me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as he has no claim on Me is an idiom that is more literally “in me he has nothing.” This probably means that Satan had no right to accuse or control Jesus (because Jesus never sinned). He could not defeat Jesus. For example:

He has no hold on me. (NIV)

He has no rights over me. (REB)

He does not control me.

General Comment on 14:30

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange 14:30a–c. For example:

^{30c}The ruler of this world has no power over me.

^{30b}But he’s coming, ^{30a}so I won’t talk with you much longer. (GW)

John 14:31

Section 14:15–31 Jesus promised the Holy Spirit

In this section, Jesus told his disciples, “If you love me, you will keep my commandments.” He then promised to send another Advocate (Helper), the Holy Spirit. Only those who believe in Jesus and love him can receive the Holy Spirit. Jesus too would come back and live with them with His Father.

The Holy Spirit would teach them and remind them what Jesus said. Jesus gave his disciples peace, but knew that the ruler of the world (Satan) would come to get him soon. He had no power over Jesus because Jesus did not sin. So Jesus would not die on the cross because of Satan. Rather, Jesus did what the Father wanted to show his love for the Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus will leave but the Holy Spirit will come

Teaching on the Holy Spirit coming and Jesus leaving

Paragraph 14:27–31

Jesus told the disciples that he was giving them true peace. It was now time for him to go to the Father. Satan was about to attack, but Jesus would continue to love and obey God his Father.

14:31a–b

But I do exactly what the Father has commanded Me, so that the world may know that I love the Father: English translations have interpreted these clauses and the connectors in different ways:

1. Many English translations include a purpose clause, the reason that Jesus obeyed his Father. He obeyed so that the world may know that he loved his Father. For example:

but I am doing just what the Father commanded me, so that the world may know that I love the Father (NET) (BSB, NRSV, RSV, NASB, NET, ESV, KJV, CEV, NLT)

1. A few English translations include a purpose but say that it is that the world must know that Jesus loved his Father. For example:

but the world must know that I love the Father; that is why I do everything as he commands me (GNT) (GNT, NCV)

1. A few English translations do not include a purpose clause. They also say that there are two things that the world must know. For example:

but the world must recognize that I love the Father and that I act just as the Father commanded (NJB) (REB, NJB, GW)

1. At least one translation says that the purpose clause tells the purpose that the ruler of this world came. (Other interpretations say that it is the purpose that Jesus obeyed.) This translation also says that there are two things that the world may learn. For example:

but he comes so that the world may learn that I love the Father and do exactly what my Father has commanded me (NIV) (NIV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations.

14:31a

But I do exactly what the Father has commanded Me,

- I obey my Father, (CEV)
- rather what will happen to me is because I obey everything that my Father wants me to do.

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here connects a negative statement (14:30c) to a positive statement (14:31a). The idea here is that Jesus will die not because Satan has power over him but because he obeys his Father. This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the BSB and most English translations.

He has no power over me, but I will do what the Father requires of me (NLT)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

He has no authority over me. Rather, I will go to my death because I do as my Father commanded me

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

But he has no power over me. I obey my Father (CEV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

I do exactly what the Father has commanded Me: The expression refers to Jesus being willing to die. He

would die because he wanted to obey the Father, not because Satan had any power over him. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

I obey my Father (CEV)

I do exactly as the Father commanded Me. (NASB)

14:31b

so that the world may know that I love the Father.

- and that way people everywhere will realize/understand that I love my Father.
- I do that to show everyone that I love my Father.

so that the world may know that I love the Father:

Jesus showed his love for his Father by obeying him even when it meant that he died on the cross. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

so that the people of the world will understand that I love the Father

in order that all the people will know that I love my Father

the world: This phrase here refers to the people of the world. For example:

everyone in the world (CEV)

all people

General Comment on 14:31a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 14:31a–b. For example:

^{31b}but so that the world may know that I love the Father, ^{31a}I do exactly as the Father commanded Me (NASB)

14:31c

Get up! Let us go on from here.

- Come, let us^(incl) go now.
- We^(incl) should leave this room/place now.

Get up! Let us go on from here: This sentence means “We should leave this room/place now.” However, Jesus continued talking for three more chapters before they left in 18:1. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Come now, let us go. (NCV)

Get up! We have to leave. (GW)

John 15:1

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus’ commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:1–4

Jesus continued to teach his followers how they should live after he went back to his Father. He used an extended metaphor of a grapevine plant (Jesus) and its branches (his followers). Jesus used the metaphor to illustrate the need to stay close to Christ and depend on him for strength and life.

15:1a–b

I am the true vine, and My Father is the keeper of the vineyard: This is the beginning of an extended metaphor. Jesus compared himself to the central stem of a grapevine, his followers to its branches, and his Father, God, to the farmer.

Grapevines grow in a field called a vineyard. They produce grapes, a small sweet fruit common in ancient Israel. People used the grapes to make wine. The vines that grapes grow on have wood trunks (main branches) like bushes or trees. But the plant is like a vine and, without supports, both the trunk and branches grow along the ground. The vinegrower takes care of the vines, supporting them and pruning them (cutting them shorter).

Jesus' listeners were familiar with this metaphor of grapes. Many places in the Bible speak about vineyards in literal and figurative ways. You may want to look at these other contexts as you decide how to translate these words. Other passages that refer to vineyards include Isaiah 5:1–7, Genesis 9:20, Matthew 20:1, 21:33–41, Mark 12:1–9, and Luke 20:9. And here are some passages that refer to grapes: Genesis 40:10–11, Isaiah 5:2, and Matthew 7:16.

15:1a

“I am the true vine,

- ¶ “I am the genuine/real vine,
- ¶ Jesus said/continued, “I am like the perfect/ideal grapevine.

I am the true vine: Jesus compared himself to a plant that produces grapes from its branches. Here are some ways that Jesus is like a vine:

1. Jesus is the source of life for his followers. In a similar way, the vine is the source of life for its branches.
2. Jesus enables his followers to produce good things from their lives. In a similar way, the vine feeds the branches so that they can produce good fruit.
3. God sent Jesus to achieve his purposes. In a similar way, a farmer plants a vine to achieve his purpose of producing grapes.

In some languages a literal translation of this metaphor may be difficult to understand. Here are some other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Change the metaphor to a simile. But you will probably want to translate the adjective true outside the simile. For example:

I am like a vine—the true vine.

I am like a vine. Yes, I am the real/genuine vine.

- Indicate something of the meaning, how Jesus is like a vine. For example:

I am the true source of life for you like a vine is the source of life for its branches.

- The metaphor of a grapevine is used in many places in the Bible. So it is recommended that you not use a substitute from your own culture. Include a footnote if you need to explain what a grapevine is. Or you may also want to include an illustration.

I am: This is the last of seven “I am” statements in John. (See also 15:5. The other statements are in 6:35; 8:12; 10:7, 9; 10:11, 14; 11:25; and 14:6.) They are all metaphors that Jesus used to describe himself. Some see a reference to Jesus' being God because “I am” is the name that God used for himself in Exodus 3:14. The Greek text emphasizes the word I. Here are some ways to show this emphasis:

I, myself, am...

It is I who am...

the true vine: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the true vine indicates that Jesus was the real or genuine vine. In the Old Testament a vine is used as a metaphor for Israel (for example, Psalm 80:8–16). This vine failed to produce good fruit for God and was destroyed. It proved to be a false vine.

Jesus is the new vine, the perfect or ideal vine, the true or real vine. He is true because he enables his followers to produce good things (fruit), not because he is really a plant. See how you translated the word true in the metaphors in 1:9 (“true light”) and 6:32 (“true bread”). Here are some of the ways that the phrase the true vine can be translated:

the real/genuine vine

God's true vine

the good/perfect vine

vine: The Greek word that the BSB translates as vine means “grapevine.” A grapevine is a climbing plant that produces long tendrils (growths that are like threads) from a central stem. These tendrils wrap around something nearby to support the plant. Here is another way to translate this word:

grapevine (NLT)

Grapevines were very common in Israel when Jesus was on earth. Everyone knew how grapes grew and how the farmers/cultivators took care of the grapevines. In some cultures grapes are not grown and there may not be a word for “grapevine.” If that is true in your language, you may want to borrow a word from another language. You may also want to add a brief description of a grapevine or add a footnote. For example:

grapevine (a plant that produces a fruit called grapes)

A grapevine is a bush on which grapes grow.

There are two important points about the grapevine for Jesus' metaphor. First, it is a plant that produces fruit and second, people cut the branches shorter to produce more fruit. It is not so important that it grows grapes or is a vine.

15:1b and My Father is the keeper of the vineyard.

- and my Father is the farmer/gardener.
- My Father God is like the one who tends/cultivates the grapevine.

My Father is the keeper of the vineyard: The phrase My Father refers to God the Father. This clause is a metaphor. Jesus compared God to a man who cultivates grapevines. Here are some ways that God is like a vinegrower:

- (a) He is responsible for others' welfare. In a similar way, a vinegrower is responsible for the welfare of the vine.
- (b) He causes growth and enables the production of fruit in his followers. In a similar way, a vinegrower enables the growth of the vine and the production of grapes.
- (c) He cares for Jesus as a vinegrower cares for his vines/plants. This care enables the branches to produce fruit.

Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

my Father is the gardener (NIV)

- Translate the metaphor as a simile. For example:

my Father is like the gardener

- Make clear the way that the Father is similar to a vinegrower. For example:

my Father takes care of the vineyard (GW)

the keeper of the vineyard: The word that the BSB has translated as the keeper of the vineyard is more literally "farmer." Use an expression that describes someone who prunes (cuts shorter) vines and cultivates a vineyard. It is good if this expression refers to

someone who could also be the owner of the vines. For example:

the gardener (NIV)

the farmer/cultivator

John 15:2

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:1–4

Jesus continued to teach his followers how they should live after he went back to his Father. He used an extended metaphor of a grapevine plant (Jesus) and its branches (his followers). Jesus used the metaphor to illustrate the need to stay close to Christ and depend on him for strength and life.

15:2a

He cuts off every branch in Me that bears no fruit,

- If any of my branches do not have/produce any fruit, he removes it/them.
- He cuts off any of my branches that do not produce fruit.

He cuts off every branch in Me that bears no fruit:

This clause continues the metaphor. Jesus compared God to a gardener who cuts off branches that do not produce fruit. The point of similarity is that God

removes those who produce nothing good and useful. Here are some ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep it as a metaphor. For example:

He cuts off every branch of mine that doesn't produce fruit (NLT)

- Change it to a simile, possibly by continuing the simile from 15:1b. For example:

My Father is like the gardener who removes all branches in my vine if they bear no fruit.

- Indicate some of the meaning. For example:

Like a gardener cutting off all the branches that do not produce fruit, my Father removes those in me who do not produce good works.

Translate this metaphor in a way that is natural and clear in your language.

He cuts off: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as cuts off refers to taking something away. Use the word that is natural for removing a branch from a vine or tree. For example:

he cuts away (NJB)

He breaks off (NLT)

He takes away (NET)

every branch in Me that bears no fruit: This phrase refers to all the branches of the vine that fulfill a condition (the ones that bear no fruit). The phrase that bears no fruit here refers literally to a branch that produces no grapes. This metaphor refers to a person who does not produce anything in their lives that pleases God. See how you translated this idea in Matthew 3:8, Galatians 5:22–23, and Colossians 1:10. For example:

every one of my branches that doesn't produce fruit (GW)

any of my branches which are not bearing fruit (JBP)

every branch of mine that does not produce fruit (NCV)

every branch that is attached to me that does not produce any fruit

fruit: This word is a metaphor. It probably refers to Christian qualities like the ones that Paul calls the fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22–23. However, it could also refer to the results of preaching the gospel: new believers. That is what it means in 4:36 and 12:24. It is recommended that you translate this metaphor literally. If your readers have trouble understanding the metaphor, you may want to add a footnote to explain what fruit may refer to.

General Comment on 15:2a

The Greek emphasizes the words “every branch.” It may be natural to translate this emphasis by rearranging this sentence and putting these words at the beginning. For example:

Every branch in me that bears no fruit he cuts away (NJB)

Any branch of mine that does not produce fruit he cuts away

15:2b

and every branch that does bear fruit, He prunes

- Every branch that does produce fruit, he cleans
- And he cuts shorter all the branches that do produce fruit

and every branch that does bear fruit, He prunes:

Jesus continued the metaphor of God as a gardener taking care of his vine. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and he prunes the branches that do bear fruit (NLT)

But he trims clean every branch that does produce fruit. (CEV)

He prunes: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as prunes means “cleans” or “cleanses.” Pruning a branch involves cutting off dead wood and any growth that makes the plant weak. Pruning helps the plant grow better or produce more fruit. It is a form of cleaning the branch. For example:

cleans it up

removes the dry/dead parts

he prunes every branch that does bear fruit, so that it will be clean (GNT)

15:2c

to make it even more fruitful.

- to cause it to produce even more fruit.
- so that they will be able to grow much more fruit than before.

to make it even more fruitful: This is a purpose clause. God is like a farmer who cleans the vine's branches so that they will bear (produce) more fruit. He cleans all the believers so that they will produce more fruit. Fruit is either fruit of the Spirit or new believers (see the note at 15:2a). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

so that it will produce even more fruit (NCV)

so they will produce even more (NLT)

to make it produce more fruit (GW)

John 15:3

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:1–4

Jesus continued to teach his followers how they should live after he went back to his Father. He

used an extended metaphor of a grapevine plant (Jesus) and its branches (his followers). Jesus used the metaphor to illustrate the need to stay close to Christ and depend on him for strength and life.

15:3

You are already clean because of the word I have spoken to you.

- You^(plur) are already clean because of what I have taught you.
- You^(plur) are clean already through the message I gave you.

You are already clean because of the word I have spoken to you:

The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as You are already clean means that Jesus' word had caused the disciples to become spiritually clean as they heard and believed it. In some languages it may be more natural to use a passive verb phrase. For example:

You have already been cleansed by the word that I have spoken to you. (NRSV)

The word translated clean is also used in 13:10. See the note there. This Greek word is related to the verb translated as "prunes" in 15:2b. Try to use a similar word or phrase to show the connection. For example:

prunes clean (15:2b)....are already clean (15:3)

You: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples. See also 13:10, where Jesus explains that it did not include Judas Iscariot.

already: The Greek text emphasizes this word. Emphasize it if you can in your language. For example:

already you are clean

because of: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because of can mean either "by means of" or "because of." The two meanings are very close and about half of the English translations follow each meaning. Here are some other ways to translate this word in context:

by means of the word that I have spoken to you (NJB)

because of what I have said to you (CEV)

by the message I have given you (NLT)

the word I have spoken to you: This phrase refers to all that Jesus had taught, his message. By listening to, believing, and obeying this message, the disciples were made clean. See examples of other ways to translate this clause just above.

John 15:4

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:1–4

Jesus continued to teach his followers how they should live after he went back to his Father. He used an extended metaphor of a grapevine plant (Jesus) and its branches (his followers). Jesus used the metaphor to illustrate the need to stay close to Christ and depend on him for strength and life.

15:4a

Remain in Me,

- Continue^(plur) to live in me
- Stay joined to me, (CEV)

Remain in Me: This clause is a second-person plural command. Jesus told his disciples that they should continue to remain in close fellowship with him. To abide (remain/stay) in him means to remain close to him, living life aware of his presence, and constantly depending on him. Try to use an expression that is also suitable for the relationship of a branch to a vine. For example:

Stay joined to me (CEV)

Remain united to me (GNT)

15:4b

and I will remain in you.

- and I will continue to live in you^(plur).
- and I will stay joined to you. (CEV)

and I will remain in you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as I will remain in you has no verb. It more literally says “and I in you.” There are two ways to interpret this:

1. It is a reassuring promise. Christ assured his followers that he will remain in them. For example:

Remain united to me, and I will remain united to you. (GNT) (BSB, NIV84, GNT, NLT, NET, CEV, NCV, GW)

1. It is a description. Jesus wanted his followers to remain in him the same way that he remained in them. For example:

Remain in me, as I in you. (NJB) (REB, NJB, NRSV, NIV2011)

The KJV, NASB, RSV, and ESV translate literally, with no verb supplied. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Remain in me, and I will remain in you. (NET)

Live in me, and I will live in you. (GW)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

15:4c–d

Just as no branch can bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine, neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in Me:

This sentence compares the situation of a vine branch and that of a believer. A vine branch depends on the main vine to produce fruit, and the believer depends on Christ to produce fruit. Indicate the comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

A branch cannot produce any fruit by itself. It has to stay attached to the vine. In the same way, you cannot produce fruit unless you live in me. (GW)

No branch can bear fruit by itself; it must remain in the vine. Neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in me. (NIV)

15:4c

Just as no branch can bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine,

- A branch cannot bear fruit alone. It must live in the vine plant/trunk.
- A branch must be joined to the main vine stem/trunk in order to produce fruit.

no branch can bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine: This expression indicates that a branch cannot bear (produce) fruit unless it is attached to the main vine. This is the first half of the comparison. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

No branch can bear fruit by itself, but only if it remains united with the vine. (REB)

the branch cannot bear any fruit unless it shares the life of the vine (JBP)

no branch...the vine: There are many branches on one vine, so it may be natural to say:

not any branch...the vine

Articles can be definite or indefinite (the or “a”). Use the articles that are most natural in your language to refer to the branch and the vine.

bear fruit: This phrase means to grow or produce fruit.

fruit: This word is a metaphor. See the note on the same word at 15:2a and how you translated the word there.

by itself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as by itself here probably means “on its own” or “apart from the vine.” In some languages it may be natural to leave these words untranslated as they are implied by the following clause.

unless it remains in the vine: This clause states the condition for the branch producing fruit. It must stay attached to the main part of the plant. For example:

it must remain in the vine (NIV)

15:4d

neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in Me.

- And you^(plur) also must live in me to be able to produce fruit.
- In the same way you^(plur) must continue to be joined to me to bear good fruit in your lives.

neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in Me:

This is the second part of the comparison. A believer cannot produce fruit unless he continues to draw strength from Christ. A believer producing fruit means that they will produce either good deeds or fruit of the Spirit. Abiding (remaining) in Christ is a necessary condition for producing fruit as a believer. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Just as a branch cannot bear fruit unless it stays joined to the vine, you cannot produce fruit unless you stay joined to me (CEV)

In the same way, you cannot produce fruit unless you live in me (GW)

In the same way, you cannot do good things if you do not remain with me. (GW)

General Comment on 15:4c–d

The sentence “Just as no branch can bear fruit by itself unless it remains in the vine, neither can you bear fruit unless you remain in Me” is a negative statement. In some languages it is more natural to express it as a positive statement. For example:

Just as the branch must remain in the vine to bear fruit, so you must remain in me to produce good fruit in your life.

A grape branch produces fruit only when/as the life of the vine flows through it. In the same way, you can produce good things only as my life flows through you.

A branch produces fruit only when it shares the life of the vine. Like that, you must share my life in order to produce good fruit in your life.

John 15:5

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and

his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:5–8

Jesus continued to illustrate the Christian life by using the extended metaphor of a vine. He compared the disciples to branches and warned his followers that without him they would be useless, like dead branches.

15:5a

I am the vine and you are the branches.

- ¶ “I am the vine trunk/stem and you^(plur) are the branches.
- ¶ “Yes, I am like the vine. You are like the/its branches.
- ¶ “I give life to you^(plur) like the vine stem/trunk gives life to the/its branches.

I am the vine and you are the branches: This continues and extends the metaphor that began in 15:1. It nearly repeats 15:1, 4. In some languages it is natural to indicate that Jesus said this before. For example:

Yes, I am the vine; you are the branches. (NLT)

Then he repeated to illustrate, “I am...” (Kankanaey Back Translation)

Jesus compared himself to the main stem of a vine and his followers to the branches of that vine. Here are some ways that they are alike:

1. Jesus is the source of life and strength for his followers. And the stem of the plant is the source of life and strength for the branches.
2. Jesus' followers produce good from their lives. And branches produce good fruit.

If this figure of speech is not clear in your language, here are ways to make it clearer:

- Use a simile rather than a metaphor. For example:

I am like a vine and you are like the branches.

- Indicate something of the meaning. For example:

I am the vine, the source of life, while you are my branches

vine...branches: In this metaphor, Christ is the main stem, and his followers are the branches that grow out from that stem. Consider how to indicate this difference in your language. For example:

I am the vine itself, you are the branches (JBP)

15:5b

The one who remains in Me, and I in him, will bear much fruit.

- If someone continues to live in me, and I live in him, he will produce much good fruit in his life.
- If you stay joined to me, and I stay joined to you, then you will produce lots of fruit. (CEV)

The one who remains in Me: The phrase The one is indefinite here and means “anyone” or “people.” The words who remains in Me then limit the indefinite meaning by indicating a condition. It is not anyone, but only those who abide (remain) in Jesus. However, it can be anyone who abides in Jesus. There are no other conditions. Languages have many different ways of expressing this kind of idea. For example:

Anyone who dwells in me (REB)

Those who abide in me (NRSV)

If you stay joined to me (CEV)

remains in Me: This phrase means to continue living in fellowship with Jesus, trusting and depending on him. It is good to use a phrase that can refer to a branch as well as to a person. For example:

stay joined to me (CEV)

live in me (GW)

and I in him: This phrase is short for “and I abide in him.” It indicates that Christ dwells (lives) in those who believe in him. Refer to these people in a way that matches the way that you referred to them earlier in the sentence. For example:

as I dwell in him (REB)

and I stay joined to you (CEV)

will bear much fruit: This phrase continues the metaphor begun in 15:1. It indicates that these people will produce fruit (see Galatians 5:22–23) or do things that please God. See the note at 15:2a and translate this expression as you did the similar expression there. In some languages it may be more natural to use future tense here. For example:

then you will produce lots of fruit (CEV)

15:5c

For apart from Me you can do nothing.

- Without me you^(plur) are helpless to do good.
- Unless I give you^(plur) life, you cannot produce anything that has value/worth.
- Only with me can you do anything good/worthwhile.

apart from Me you can do nothing: This is a negative way to say what 15:5b said. It indicates that people cannot do anything truly worthwhile, anything that pleases God, without Jesus. If they do not have his help and strength they cannot produce any good from their lives. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But you cannot do anything without me. (CEV)

for you can do nothing without me (GNT)

But you can't produce anything without me. (GW)

apart...nothing: In some languages this double negative is best translated as a positive. For example:

only by remaining in me can you do anything good/worthwhile

General Comment on 15:5b–c

In 15:5b–c the subject pronoun changes from the third-person plural (“those,” “them”) to the second-person

plural (“you”). In some languages it may be more natural to keep the pronouns the same. For example:

If any remain in me and I remain in them, they produce much fruit. But without me they can do nothing. (NCV)

If you stay joined to me, and I stay joined to you, then you will produce lots of fruit. But you cannot do anything without me. (CEV)

John 15:6

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:5–8

Jesus continued to illustrate the Christian life by using the extended metaphor of a vine. He compared the disciples to branches and warned his followers that without him they would be useless, like dead branches.

15:6a

If anyone does not remain in Me,

- Anyone who does not live in me
- All people who do not stay joined to me

If anyone does not remain in Me: This clause is more literally “unless someone remains in me.” It introduces a situation which is the opposite of 15:5b. Here someone does not remain in Christ. See how you

translated the opposite clause “The one who remains in Me” in 15:5. For example:

Whoever does not abide in me (NRSV)

Those who do not remain in me (GNT)

However, it is probably better to use a singular subject to remind the reader of Judas Iscariot. He was the only one of Christ’s first disciples who did not remain in Christ.

15:6b–d

he is like a branch that is thrown away and withers. Such branches are gathered up, thrown into the fire, and burned: This is a figure of speech, partly simile (like a branch) and partly metaphor (wither). The person who does not remain in Christ is compared to a branch that was removed from the main stem of a vine. Here are some ways that they are similar:

1. The person who fails to remain with God is like a branch that fails to produce good fruit because both are useless.
2. Useless people and useless branches are both burned. Fire is a symbol of judgment in scripture, so useless people will be judged. Useless branches will be burned in a literal fire.

In some languages a literal translation of this figure of speech may be difficult to understand. It may be necessary to help the reader understand the meaning by making some of it explicit. For example:

he is like a useless branch that is thrown away and withers. Branches like that are gathered/picked up, thrown into the fire, and burned

15:6b

he is like a branch that is thrown away and withers.

- is like a branch that is thrown away and dies.
- are like branches that one/someone throws away. They wither and die.

he is like a branch that is thrown away and withers:

The phrase like a branch refers to both the verbs: this person is thrown away like a branch and withers like a branch. So in some languages it may be natural to rearrange this whole phrase.

is thrown away: This verb phrase is passive. Some unknown person or persons will discard (throw away) the useless branch. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

is thrown out like a branch (NET)

is discarded like branches are

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will throw him away like a branch

and withers: The verb withers refers to the way that a branch dries up and dies when it does not get water and food. For example:

and dry up (GNT)

and then dries up

If you used an active verb for “is thrown away,” you may need to change this phrase. For example:

and he will dry up

15:6c

Such branches are gathered up,

- These dead branches are gathered,
- Then one/someone picks them up,

15:6d

thrown into the fire, and burned.

- thrown into a fire, and burned up.
- throws them in a fire, and burns them.

15:6c–d

Such branches are gathered up, thrown into the fire, and burned: This clause has a series of three passive verbs describing what happens to useless branches. They are gathered up, thrown, and burned. There are at least two ways to translate these verbs:

- Use passive verbs. For example:

such branches are picked up, thrown into the fire, and burned (NIV)

- Use active verbs. For example:

People pick up dead branches, throw them into the fire, and burn them. (NCV)

the fire: This does not refer to a particular fire but to any fire that might be burning at that time. So it may be natural to say:

a fire

John 15:7

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:5–8

Jesus continued to illustrate the Christian life by using the extended metaphor of a vine. He compared the disciples to branches and warned his followers that without him they would be useless, like dead branches.

15:7

This verse tells what would happen to and for those who do remain or abide in him. God will answer their prayers.

15:7a

If you remain in Me and My words remain in you,

- But you^(plur) who continue to live in me, and my words live in you,
- But if you^(plur) stay joined to me and remember/believe/keep what I have taught you,

If you remain in Me and My words remain in you:

This is a conditional clause. It indicates two conditions that both must be fulfilled before someone's prayers

will be answered. If possible, translate the word remain the same way both times. For example:

If you abide in me, and my words abide in you
(NRSV)

If you live in me and what I say lives in you (GW)

you remain in Me: The phrase remain in Me refers to living in union with Christ, in close fellowship and agreement. Translate it as you did in 15:4 and 15:5. For example:

Stay joined to me (CEV)

If you abide in me (NRSV)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

My words remain in you: This clause refers to remembering Jesus' words and obeying what he taught. Jesus' words abide or remain in a person when that person thinks about them and follows them. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with the person/disciple as the subject. For example:

you let my words remain in you

you keep in your hearts what I teach you (Otomí
Back Translation)

My words: This phrase refers to all that Jesus had taught. For example:

my teaching

the things I have told you

15:7b

ask whatever you wish, and it will be done for you.

- can ask God for what you^(plur) want, and God will give it to you.
- you^(plur) can ask in prayer for anything that you want, and God will do what you pray for.

ask whatever you wish: The verb ask is short for "ask God in prayer" or "pray to God." When a person abides in Christ, the things that he wants and asks for are also things that will please Christ. Everywhere in this chapter Jesus referred to God as "the Father" or "my Father," so it is good to do so here also. For example:

ask the Father for whatever you want

it will be done for you: This clause is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it will be granted (NLT)

your prayer will be answered (CEV)

- Use an active verb. God himself is the one who will answer these prayers. For example:

you shall have it (GNT)

it will be yours (GW)

the/my Father will give you what you ask for

John 15:8

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:5–8

Jesus continued to illustrate the Christian life by using the extended metaphor of a vine. He compared the disciples to branches and warned his followers that without him they would be useless, like dead branches.

15:8a–c

This is to My Father's glory, that you bear much fruit, proving yourselves to be My disciples: There are three ways that English translations understand the relationship between these two verb phrases:

1. Bearing (producing) much fruit will show or prove that they are Jesus' disciples. For example:

By this my Father is glorified, that you bear much fruit, and so prove to be my disciples. (RSV) (BSB, NASB, NET, ESV, NCV, NIV, RSV, GW)

1. Becoming Jesus' disciples is the result of bearing much fruit. For example:

My Father's glory is shown by your bearing much fruit; and in this way you become my disciples. (GNT) (GNT, REB, KJV, NLT)

1. Both bearing much fruit (being fruitful) and becoming Jesus' disciples glorify God. For example:

It is to the glory of my Father that you should bear much fruit and be my disciples. (NJB) (NRSV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations.

15:8a

This is to My Father's glory,

- This honors my Father,
- God, my Father, is shown to be very great

This is to My Father's glory: This clause here means that God is shown to be great and wonderful. See KBT Glory, Glorious, Glorify, C 3. God's greatness would be revealed, and people would see that he deserves honor. In Greek this clause is passive, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

This is how my Father is glorified (REB)

My Father is honored by this (NET)

- Use an active verb. For example:

This brings great glory to my Father. (NLT)

You give glory to my Father when (GW)

This: The pronoun This refers ahead to the next clause: God is glorified when his people bear much fruit. In some languages it is more natural to put 15:8b before 15:8a. For an example of that, see the General Comment following the note on 15:8b.

15:8b

that you bear much fruit,

- that/when you^(plur) produce much fruit in your life
- when people see his fruit in your^(plur) life,

that you bear much fruit: This clause continues the metaphor begun in 15:1. It means “that/when you produce fruit (fruit of the Spirit, new believers) by abiding (remaining) in me.” God is glorified because he is the source of the fruit. See the note at 15:2a and how you translated this idea in 15:2, 4, 5. For example:

when you produce a lot of fruit (GW)

General Comment on 15:8a–b

In some languages it is more natural to put 15:8b before 15:8a. For example:

^{8b}If you bear much fruit, ^{8a}it will glorify my Father.

^{8b}When you produce a lot of good fruit, ^{8a}my Father is glorified.

15:8c

proving yourselves to be My disciples.

- and show that you are my followers (NCV).
- which shows that you^(plur) are my disciples.

proving yourselves to be My disciples: The phrase that the BSB translates as proving yourselves to be My disciples here refers to showing that one is a disciple by behaving as true disciples. There is a textual problem here. The form of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as “proving yourselves” is not the same in all the ancient Greek manuscripts: (1) Some Greek manuscripts say “(you) may become,” using an aorist subjunctive. (2) Some Greek manuscripts say “(you) will become,” using a future tense. The UBS Greek New Testaments follows option (1), because many older manuscripts have a subjunctive verb. It is therefore recommended that you follow this option. However, in many languages the difference may not be great. By bearing good fruit in their lives, Jesus’ disciples show that they follow him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and so prove to be my disciples (ESV)

showing yourselves to be my disciples (NIV)

show that you are my followers (NCV)

John 15:9

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus’ commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:9a–b

As...so...: 15:9a–b compares two actions. These words indicate that the way God loved Christ and the way Christ loves his people are the same. Jesus did not say in what ways they are the same. However, it is implied that God’s love is like the love of Christ for his people. They are both great, complete and perfect. Consider how it is natural to compare two actions. For example:

Just as the Father has loved me, I have also loved you. (NET)

How the Father has loved me, that is how I have also loved you.

In some languages it may be necessary to say explicitly in what way God loved Christ. For example:

Just as the Father has loved me completely, so I have loved you in the same way.

In other languages it may be natural to translate “love” as a noun. You may also want to include the way God’s love for Christ is like Christ’s love for his people. For example:

God’s love for me is great/wonderful, and my love for you is great/wonderful also.

15:9a

As the Father has loved Me,

- ¶ “Just as God the Father has loved me,
- ¶ “My Father, God, has loved me very much

As the Father has loved Me: God loves his Son intensely and completely. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

As the Father has loved me intensely

In some languages it may be natural to express the idea of love as a noun rather than a verb. God’s love for his Son is intense, complete and perfect. For example:

Like the Father’s love for me

Just as the Father’s love for me is perfect

As: This word here refers to the quality of something being the same as the quality of something else.

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to tell whose father it is. For example:

my Father

Me: This pronoun refers to Jesus Christ.

15:9b

so have I loved you.

- in that way I have loved you^(plur).
- and that is how I have loved you^(plur) also.

so have I loved you: Jesus loved his disciples with the same real and perfect love with which God loved him. Translate this in a way that matches your translation of the previous clause, translating loved as either a verb or a noun. For example:

in the same way I have loved you

my love for you is like that, perfect, too

you: In the Greek the word you is plural and refers to Jesus’ disciples. The Greek text emphasizes this word.

General Comment on 15:9a,b

In some languages it is more natural to translate 15:9b before 15:9a. For example:

^{9b}I love you ^{9a}just as the Father loves me; (GNT)

^{9b}I have loved you ^{9a}the same way the Father has loved me. (GW)

^{9b}I have loved you, ^{9a}just as my Father has loved me. (CEV)

^{9b}My love for you, ^{9a}is like my Father’s love for me. (Yakan Back Translation)

15:9c

Remain in My love.

- Continue^(plur) living in my love.
- So remain^(plur) joined to my love.

Remain in My love: This is a plural command. Jesus commanded his followers to always live or remain in his love. He wanted them to always remember his love for them and to live in the power of that love. For example:

continue living in my love

Always be aware of my love for you.

Continue to enjoy my love for you.

In some languages it may be necessary to translate love as a verb. For example:

Always know/remember that I love you.

John 15:10

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their

prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:10a

If you keep My commandments,

- If you obey what I command,
- Do^(plur) what I have told you to do,

If you keep My commandments: This clause describes how the disciples could remain in his love. They should do what he told them to do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If you obey my commandments (NET)

If you obey me (CEV)

15:10b

you will remain in My love,

- you will live in my love,
- and you^(plur) will remain joined to my love.

you will remain in My love: This clause means “you will continue to know/experience my love for you.” For example:

you will live in my love (GW)

you will always know that I love you

15:10c

just as I have kept My Father's commandments

- just as I have obeyed what my Father, God, commanded
- In the same way, I have always done what my Father, God, told me to do,

just as: This connector here indicates a comparison between how Jesus lived and how he wanted his disciples to live. Translate this connector in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

like

It's the same with me, because (Kankanaey Back Translation)

Or you may want to begin a new sentence here and leave the comparison implied. For example:

If you obey my commandments, you will live in my love. I have obeyed my Father's commandments, and in that way I live in his love. (GW)

Also see the General Comment below for another way to indicate this comparison.

I have kept My Father's commandments: This clause indicates that Jesus always obeyed God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have obeyed my Father's commands (NCV)

I have obeyed him (CEV)

I have done all that my Father told me to do.

15:10d

and remain in His love.

- and live in his love.
- and I remain joined to his love.

and remain in His love: This phrase indicates that Christ constantly knew that God loved him. Translate this phrase using an expression that is the same as or similar to the one in 15:10b. For example:

and I remain in his love (NCV)

and I live in my Father's love

General Comment on 15:10a–d

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange this sentence. First say what Jesus did and then what he wanted his disciples to do. For example:

^{10c}I have obeyed my Father's commands, ^{10d}and I remain in his love. ^{10a}In the same way, if you obey my commands, ^{10b}you will remain in my love. (NCV)

John 15:11

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:11a

I have told you these things

- I am telling you^(plur) this
- I have spoken like this to you^(plur)

I have told you these things: The phrase these things is plural and refers to all of 15:7–10. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, to obey what he had taught them, and to love one another. All these are necessary to completely share Jesus' joy. For example:

I have said these things (NRSV)

I have told you all this (TH)

15:11b

so that My joy may be in you

- in order that you^(plur) may have the same joy as mine.
- so that you^(plur) may share my joy—

so that: This connector indicates that the rest of the clause gives the purpose of Jesus' comments in 15:7–10. But there is also implied information here: Jesus said these things so that his disciples would obey them and have true joy. For example:

so that you would follow/obey them and experience my joy

My joy may be in you: This clause means “you may have the same joy that I have.” Jesus wanted his disciples to be joyful, as he was. For example:

you can share my joy (JBP)

you can have the same joy I have (NCV)

My joy: This phrase here refers to the joy that Jesus both has and gives. In some languages it may be natural to translate joy as an adjective or a verb. For example:

so that you will be as joyful as I am (GW)

so that you will rejoice as I do

15:11c

and your joy may be complete.

- Then you^(plur) will have perfect joy.
- yes, so that you would be completely joyful.

and your joy may be complete: This clause is more literally “and that your joy may be full.” It means “and so you will be completely happy.” For example:

and that your joy may be made full

and so that your joy will be the fullest possible joy (NCV)

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces a further development of the thought in the previous clause. Show this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Yes, your joy will overflow! (NLT)

General Comment on 15:11b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine these clauses. For example:

to make you as completely happy as I am (CEV)

John 15:12

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:12a–b

This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you: Jesus told his disciples how they should behave as his followers. They should love each other in the way that he had loved them. Their love should be intense, real, and unselfish. In some languages it may be natural to translate the commandment as a direct quotation. For example:

I am commanding you this: Love each other as I have loved you.

This is my commandment: Love each other in the same way I have loved you. (NLT)

My commandment is this: love one another, just as I love you. (GNT)

15:12a

This is My commandment,

- I am commanding you
- Now I tell you^(plur) this:

This is My commandment: This clause means “what I am telling you to do is...” For example:

My command is this... (NIV)

Now I tell you to... (CEV)

This: This pronoun refers to the following clause, “love one another as I have loved you.”

15:12b

that you love one another as I have loved you.

- to love one another, just as I have loved you.
- love each other truly/intensely, the same way that I have loved you.

love one another as I have loved you: This is a comparison similar to the one in 15:9a–b. See how you translated that comparison. See also how you translated a similar idea in 13:34. Christ told his followers to love each other in the same way, or with the same love, that he loved them. Jesus loved his disciples so much that he was willing to die for them. He wanted his disciples to love each other in that way too. As in 15:9, you may translate the action of loving as either a verb or a noun. For example:

love one another in the same way I have loved you (NLT)

Show the same great love to one another that I have shown to you.

love one another: The phrase one another refers to other believers. Each of Christ's followers is to care for other followers and to seek their welfare. They should do this as a habit, not just one time.

as I have loved you: The connector as means “in the same way that.” Christ wanted his followers to display the same great, unselfish love to one another that he had shown them. They should be willing to sacrifice their lives for other believers. Because Christ loved them completely, they should love one another completely.

General Comment on 15:12b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange these clauses, with Christ's model of love at the beginning. For example:

I have loved you^(plur) deeply/greatly, and now you must love each other that much.

General Comment on 15:12a–b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange 15:12a–b, translating the content of the commandment first. For example:

^{12b}Love each other as I have loved you. ^{12a}This is what I'm commanding you to do. (GW)

John 15:13

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:13a

Greater love has no one than this,

- There is no greater love than
- No one loves his friends more
- The greatest way to show love (CEV)

Greater love has no one than this: Jesus explained the sort of love he was talking about. It is the love that he showed by dying for us. This is the greatest love that exists. In some languages it is more natural to express this as a positive statement. For example:

The greatest love is

The greatest way to show love (CEV)

The greatest love a person can show (NCV)

love: This word is a noun that refers to the attitude and behavior that prefers the welfare of others above oneself. In some languages it may be more natural to use a verb form. For example:

No one can love in a greater/stronger way than by...

this: This pronoun refers to 15:13b. In some languages it is more natural to put 15:13b before 15:13a. For an example see the General Comment following the note on 15:13b.

15:13b

that he lay down his life for his friends.

- the love that causes you to give your life for your friends.
- than the one who dies for their benefit.
- for friends is to die for them. (CEV)

that he lay down his life for his friends: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as lay down his life means "willingly die." See how you translated this phrase in 10:11. Dying for the benefit of others is the greatest expression of love for them. A person who willingly dies for someone else shows that he truly loves that other person. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The greatest love a person can have for your friends is to give your life for them (GNT)

The greatest love a person can show is to die for his friends. (NCV)

if he dies so that his friends may live (Kankanaey Back Translation)

for: The word that the BSB translated for means “for the benefit of.” In this context it implies “to save/help.”

his friends: This phrase refers to the friends of the man who is willing to die. Jesus was referring to how he would die for his followers. The same word in the singular (“friend”) is used to describe Lazarus in 11:11.

General Comment on 15:13a–b

In some languages it is more natural to put 15:13b before 15:13a. For example:

^{13b}If someone dies for the benefit of his friends,
^{13a}that is the greatest love.

^{13b}If a person is willing to die for his friends, ^{13a}he loves them in the greatest way possible.

John 15:14

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus’ commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:14

You are My friends if you do what I command you.

- And you^(plur) are my friends, if you obey me. (CEV)

- If you^(plur) do what I tell you to do, then you are my friends.

You are My friends if you do what I command you:

These clauses indicate that Jesus’ friends are those who obey what he told them to do. For example:

And you are my friends, if you obey me. (CEV)

You are my friends if you do what I tell you to do. (JBP)

General Comment on 15:14

In some languages it is more natural to put the last part of the sentence before the first. For example:

If you do what I tell you to do, then you are my friends. (TH)

John 15:15

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine’s branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus’ commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:15a–d

This verse consists of a negative statement followed by the positive statement. Jesus said what he did not

call his followers and then what he did call them. In some languages it is more natural to state the positive first and then the negative. See the General Comment following the note on 15:15d.

15:15a

No longer do I call you servants,

- I do not refer to you^(plur) as ‘my servants’ any more
- I do not speak to you^(plur) anymore as my servants,

No longer do I call you servants: Jesus indicated that his relationship to his disciples was now closer than a master-servant relationship. He did not act toward them or speak to them as if they were servants. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not call you servants any longer (NRSV)

I shall no longer call you servants (NJB)

No longer: The Greek word that the BSB translated No longer may imply that until then God did not explain to his people what he was doing. His people obeyed him but did not understand the meaning of God’s work in the world. Now Jesus was explaining to them what God was doing.

call you: This phrase in this context means “refer to you as” or “think about you as.” For example:

speak to you as (CEV)

servants: The word that the BSB has translated as servants normally refers to a slave, a worker who is not free to leave his work. In some languages, though, it is more natural to use a term like “servant” or “worker.” See how you translated this word in 4:51. Here is another way to translate this word:

slaves

In some languages it may be natural to indicate whose servants these are. For example:

my servants (CEV)

15:15b

for a servant does not understand what his master is doing.

- because you^(plur) know what I am doing and my purpose in doing it.
- because you^(plur) know what I am doing, while a servant merely obeys.

for a servant does not understand what his master is doing: People expect a servant to obey his master even if he does not understand the reason for doing it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because a servant does not know the master’s business (NJB)

because a master does not tell his reasons to his slaves

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for here introduces Jesus’ reason for no longer calling his disciples servants. A servant did not know what his master was doing but Jesus wanted to tell them what he was doing. So he could not call them servants anymore.

a servant: This phrase here refers to any servant or servants in general. So it may be natural to make that clearer like in the BSB. For example:

servants (GNT)

does not understand what his master is doing: Servants usually know what their master does in general, but they may not know the reason that he does it. So here is another way to translate this phrase:

the slave does not understand what his master is doing (NET)

his master: This phrase refers to the master of the servant or servants in the illustration. So it may be natural to make the connection to the servant or servants clearer. For example:

their master (GNT)

General Comment on 15:15a–b

In some languages it may be natural to place 15:15b before 15:5a:

^{15b}The servant does not know what his master is doing, ^{15a}and so I do not call you servants any longer.

^{15b}Servants don’t know what their master is doing, ^{15a}and so I don’t speak to you as my servants. (CEV)

15:15c**But I have called you friends,**

- No, I refer to you^(plur) as my friends
- I speak to you as my friends, (CEV)

But I have called you friends: This clause indicates that Jesus called his disciples his friends. This means that he actually thought about them as his friends, those he loved. He talked to them the way a man talks to his friends. The relationship of friends is much closer than that of servants. That is because a person tells his friend not only what he is doing, but also why he is doing it. Use the same verb that you used in 15:15a. For example:

I speak to you as my friends (CEV)

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast with the idea of speaking to his disciples as servants.

I have called you friends: The Greek text emphasizes the word you in this clause. Jesus did not just call his disciples friends to pretend to be nice and to love them. He spoke the truth, calling them what they really were. If a literal translation would not make this clear, it may be necessary to follow this example:

you are my friends (NLT)

now you are really my friends

friends: This word here refers to people who are loved for who they are, not just appreciated for what they do. In some languages it may be natural to use a personal pronoun. For example:

my friends (CEV)

15:15d**because everything I have learned from My Father I have made known to you.**

- because I have told you^(plur) all that I have learned from my Father.
- for everything my Father God told me, I told you^(plur).

because everything I have learned from My Father I have made known to you: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because here introduces Jesus' reason for saying that he called his disciples his friends. This was the evidence or proof that Jesus thought about the disciples as his friends. God told Jesus everything that he was doing and Jesus then

told his disciples. Here is another way to translate this clause:

because I have told you everything that my Father told me

everything I have learned from My Father: The Greek text emphasizes the word everything in this clause. In this context, this clause refers to whatever God the Father told Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to translate this with My Father as the subject. For example:

everything that my Father has told me (CEV)

My Father: The phrase My Father refers to God, the Father of Jesus.

have made known: This verb means “told” or “explained.”

to you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to Jesus' disciples.

General Comment on 15:15c–d

In some languages it may be natural to translate these clauses in chronological order, the order in which they happened. For example:

^{15d}My Father has told me many things, and I have told them to you. ^{15c}That is why I now call you my friends.

General Comment on 15:15 a–d

John 15:15 has a negative statement followed by the positive statement. In some languages it may be more natural to state the positive first and then the negative. For example:

I call you my friends, now, because I have told you everything that I have heard from the Father. I shall not call you servants any longer, because a servant does not know what his master is doing.

John 15:16**Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine**

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in

his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:16a

You did not choose Me,

- You^(plur) did not choose to be my followers.
- It was not you^(plur) who first decided to follow me.

You did not choose Me: This clause is short for “It was not you who chose me to follow.” Jesus' disciples did agree to be his disciples, but their decision was not the most important reason that they became disciples. The main reason that Jesus' disciples followed him was because Jesus chose them to follow him.

You: The Greek text emphasizes this word, which is plural.

15:16b

but I chose you.

- No! It was I who chose you^(plur) to follow me,
- Rather, I was the one who chose you^(plur) to follow me

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (15:16a) to a positive statement (15:16b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.
- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

It was not you who chose me but rather it was I who chose you

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

You did not choose me. I chose you and sent you out to produce fruit.... (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I chose you. You did not choose me.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

I chose you: This clause is short for “I chose you to follow me.” See 6:70, which uses the same verb.

I: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun I. Emphasize this pronoun in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

it was I who chose you

15:16c

And I appointed you

- and I gave you the duty
- and gave you the task

I appointed you: This clause here means “I gave you a task (specific work to do)” or “I chose you for a purpose.” The purpose or task is in the following clause (15:16d). Here is another way to translate this clause:

I gave you this work (NCV)

15:16d

to go and bear fruit—fruit that will remain—

- of going and producing enduring/permanent fruit.
- of going on missions and producing fruit/results that will be permanent.

to go and bear fruit—fruit that will remain: The work that Jesus gave his disciples was to go out and bear (produce) fruit. The word fruit here probably includes the idea of new believers, the results of preaching the gospel. It could also include the idea of the fruit of the Spirit. See the note at 15:2a, although here the idea of new believers is more likely included. However, it is recommended that you translate the word fruit the same in verses 15:2, 4, 5, 8, and here. Here is another way to translate this expression:

sent you out to produce fruit, the kind of fruit that will last (CEV)

to go: The Greek does not tell where they should go. Probably Jesus referred to preaching the gospel everywhere. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

I...sent you out (CEV)

bear fruit—fruit that will remain: The phrase fruit that will remain describes the kind of fruit the believers' lives will produce. It will not rot, meaning that it will be permanent. The lives of Jesus' followers will have results that will last and produce permanent good. In some languages it may be natural to use the word fruit only once. For example:

bear fruit that will be lasting (JBP)

15:16e

so that whatever you ask the Father in My name, He will give you.

- That is so that whatever you^(plur) pray for using my authority, my Father will give you.
- That is so that my Father God will give you^(plur) everything you pray for because you trust in me.

so that whatever you ask the Father in My name, He will give you: There are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as so that in this clause:

1. It means “so that” and indicates that the following clause is a purpose. Bible scholars disagree about whether it is a purpose of Jesus appointing them or a purpose of their bearing fruit. It is best to translate this clause in a way that people could understand either idea. For example:

so that whatever you ask the Father in my name, he may give it to you (ESV) (BSB, NET, ESV, NASB, NIV, NLT, KJV, REB, RSV, NRSV, GW, NJB)

1. It means “so” or “then” and indicates that the following clause is a result of their being fruit. For example:

And so the Father will give you whatever you ask of him in my name. (GNT) (GNT, NCV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations and Bible experts. However, the two interpretations' meanings are very close, so you may follow interpretation (2) if that suits your language better.

whatever you ask the Father in My name: The phrase in My name means “in my authority” or “because you are my followers.” See the note and how you translated these words in 14:13a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

whatever you ask my Father because you trust in me (Yakan Back Translation)

anything that you request from my Father because you are united with me

He will give you: This phrase indicates that God will respond and answer the disciples' prayers. It refers to answering requests that agree with the will and character of Jesus. It does not mainly refer to giving material objects.

John 15:17

Section 15:1–17 Jesus is the true vine

Jesus compared himself to a vine, his Father to a vine grower, and his followers to the vine's branches. The Father would remove branches that did not produce fruit and prune (cut shorter) those branches that did. Jesus told his disciples to remain in him, the vine, and his love so that they could produce much fruit. Their prayers would also be answered. If they remained in his love, they would keep his commandments and Jesus and they would have joy.

Jesus' commandment was that they should love one another as he had loved them. Then they would be his friends. Jesus already called them friends because he told them everything that the Father told him. They did not choose Jesus, but he chose them. He appointed them to produce fruit that would last so that the Father would give them whatever they asked for.

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus the true vine

The vine and the branches

Paragraph 15:9–17

Jesus told his disciples that he loved them very much. He encouraged them to love one another as much as the Father loved him and he loved them.

15:17

This is My command to you: Love one another.

- So I command you to love each other. (CEV)

- I am telling you^(plur) that you^(plur) should love one another.

This is My command to you: Love one another: The Greek of this verse more literally says, “These things I command you, that you love one another.” There are two ways to interpret this verse:

1. It is a quote introducer followed by the quotation. It means “I command you^(plur), ‘Love one another.’ For example:

This is my command: Love each other. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, RSV, REB, NJB, GW, NLT, NCV, CEV, NET, GNT)

1. It describes what Jesus was doing and then includes a purpose clause. It means “I gave you these commands so that you^(plur) would love one another.” For example:

These things I command you, so that you will love one another. (ESV) (NRSV, ESV)

Two translations (NASB, KJV) can be understood either way. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations and Bible scholars.

Love one another: This clause is Jesus’ command to all of his disciples, that each of them should love the other disciples.

John 15:18

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world’s hate

The world’s hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:18–21

Jesus warned his followers that people will hate them and persecute them because they belong to him.

15:18a

If the world hates you,

- ¶ If the people of this world hate you^(plur),
- ¶ If unbelievers hate you^(plur),

If the world hates you: This clause assumes that the people of the world would hate Jesus’ followers. In some languages it is more natural to make that clear. For example:

If the unbelievers hate you, and they will

When the unbelievers hate you

the world: This phrase here refers to the unbelievers in the world. These people would hate Christ’s followers. They did not understand them or sympathize with them.

15:18b

understand that it hated Me first.

- know that they hated me before they hated you^(plur).
- remember that they hated me first.

understand that it hated Me first: These clauses reminded Jesus’ disciples that people had hated him. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

realize that it hated me before it hated you (GW)

remember that it hated me first (NLT)

understand: The Greek word that the BSB translated as understand means “continue to remember.” (It can also be a statement, “you know,” rather than a command. A few translations follow that meaning.) Here are other ways to translate this word:

know (ESV)

just remember (GNT)

realize (GW)

never forget

it: This word refers to the world. If you have translated the word “world” as a plural such as “unbelievers,” then it will need to be translated as a plural such as “they.”

General Comment on 15:18b

In some languages it may be natural to translate the information in this verse as more than one sentence. For example:

You know how unbelievers have hated me. Well, now they will hate you^(plur) also.

John 15:19**Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples**

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:18–21

Jesus warned his followers that people will hate them and persecute them because they belong to him.

15:19a**If you were of the world,**

- If you^(plur) had anything in common with the people of the world,
- Suppose you^(plur) were still included among the unbelievers,

If you were of the world: This clause is a condition that is assumed to be false or unfulfilled. It means “If you were part of this fallen and evil world...but you are not.” Because they believed and obeyed Christ, there were many things in them that were different from unbelievers in the world. Their spiritual origin was no longer the world, but God. For example:

If you had anything in common with the world (GW)

Suppose you were part of the world which you are not

if suppose you were still included with those who do not believe

15:19b**it would love you as its own.**

- they would love you^(plur) because you would be one of them.
- Then unbelievers would love you^(plur) as one of their own.

it would love you as its own: This statement is not true because the condition (“if you belonged to the world”) was not true. The world does not love believers because they are not part of it. They do not belong to it. The people of the world only love those people who belong to it. Those who belong to the world are those who think like the world does and agree with its value system. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

it would love you as it loves it own (NCV)

the world's people would love you because you would be one of them

it: The word that the BSB translates as it is literally “the world” in Greek. This phrase continues to refer to the unbelievers in the world. In some languages it may be natural to refer to the people. For example:

its people (CEV)

the people of the world

General Comment on 15:19a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 15:19a–b. For example:

^{19b}The world would love you as one of its own ^{19a}if you belonged to it. (NLT)

The world only loves those who belong to it.

The world loves those who belong to it. Others it does not love.

15:19c–e

Instead, the world hates you, because you are not of the world, but I have chosen you out of the world: This sentence explains why the people of this world hated Jesus' disciples. See the General Comment on 15:19c–e (following the note on 15:19e)

for a different way to arrange the information in this sentence. In some languages it may be natural to use more than one sentence here. For example:

But you don't have anything in common with the world. I chose you from the world, and that's why the world hates you. (GW)

15:19c

Instead, the world hates you,

- That is why the people of the world hate you^(plur).
- unbelievers hate you^(plur).

Instead, the world hates you: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Instead* can also be translated as “Therefore,” in which case it introduces the logical result of Jesus choosing his followers and making them different from the world. For example:

that is why the world hates you (NJB)

and for that reason the world hates you (NET)

the world hates you: The phrase the world refers to the people in the world, or unbelievers in general. See how you translated this phrase in 15:19b. For example:

its people hate you (CEV)

15:19d

because you are not of the world,

- But you^(plur) do not have anything in common with the world;
- However, because you^(plur) are not included with unbelievers

because: This word introduces the reason that the world hates Jesus' disciples in 15:19e. The world hates them because they do not belong to it. The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *because* is more literally “but because.” Some translations include the word “but” to indicate the contrast between 15:19a and 15:19d. For example:

but because (ESV)

However, it is not natural in English to have the same conjunction, “but,” in both 15:19d and 15:19e. So several translations leave out one “but.” For example:

As it is, you do not belong to the world, but I have chosen you out of the world. (NIV)

But you don't belong to the world. I have chosen you to leave the world behind. (CEV)

But I chose you from this world, and you do not belong to it. (GNT)

In those examples, the word *because* is not included. However, the meaning can be included in 15:19e, as the NRSV does by including the word “therefore.” You should indicate the contrast in a way that is natural in your language.

you are not of the world: This clause means “you are not part of the world” or “you are not from the world.” Their spiritual origin was no longer from the world, but from God. For example:

you don't have anything in common with the world (GW)

you are no longer part of the world (NLT)

you are now separated from the world

15:19e

but I have chosen you out of the world.

- rather I have chosen you^(plur) out of the world to be mine.
- but I have chosen you^(plur) to leave them,

but I have chosen you out of the world: Christ's followers were once part of the unbelievers of the world but Christ has made them different. He has separated them from this evil world and its values and its control. For example:

I have chosen you to leave the world behind. (CEV)

I chose you^(plur) to be different from unbelievers.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *but* here connects a negative statement (15:19d) to a positive statement (15:19e). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction *but* as in the BSB. For example:

However, because you do not belong to the world, but I chose you out of the world (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than but. For example:

You do not belong to the world, rather I chose you out of the world.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

But you don't have anything in common with the world. I chose you from the world (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

^{19d}But I chose you from this world, ^{19c}and you do not belong to it (GNT)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

General Comment on 15:19c–e

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange 5:19c–e. You may want to first say that the world hates believers and then say why. For example:

^{19e}But the world hates you ^{19d}because I chose you from this world, ^{19c}and you do not belong to it.

^{19e}However, unbelievers hate you^(plur) ^{19c}and that is because you do not belong to them, ^{19d}because I chose you out from among them.

John 15:20

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:18–21

Jesus warned his followers that people will hate them and persecute them because they belong to him.

15:20a

Remember the word that I spoke to you: 'No servant is greater than his master.'

- Remember what I told you^(plur), 'People do not act toward a servant better than they act toward his master.'
- Remember I warned you^(plur) that you would not get any more respect than they gave me.

Remember the word that I spoke to you: 'No servant is greater than his master.' Earlier that evening, Jesus had said these words. They are recorded in 13:16. Refer back to these words in a way that is natural in your language. It may be natural to use indirect speech. For example:

Remember that/how I told you that servants are not greater than their master.

Remember: This word indicates that Jesus wanted the disciples to think again about something that he said. It does not imply that the disciples forgot what he said. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Consider

Think about

No servant is greater than his master: In context this means "You, my servants, are not greater than I am." So Jesus' followers should not expect people to behave toward them better than they did toward Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to say this in a positive way. For example:

A master is always more important than his slave. (TH)

A boss is more important than the people who work for him.

15:20b

If they persecuted Me, they will persecute you as well;

- If people did wrong to me, they will do wrong to you, too. (NCV)
- The people who persecuted me will persecute you^(plur) also.

If they persecuted Me, they will persecute you as well: These clauses mean “People who persecuted me will persecute you also.” Even though people did persecute Jesus, it is best not to make this explicit. Nearly all English translations use the word If and it is recommended that you translate it also. The subject they is a general reference to various people. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

If people did wrong to me, they will do wrong to you, too. (NCV)

If people cause me to suffer, they will cause you to suffer, too.

15:20c

if they kept My word, they will keep yours as well.

- And if they obeyed my teaching, they will obey yours, too. (NCV)
- If people obeyed what I told them, people will also obey what you^(plur) tell them.

if they kept My word, they will keep yours as well:

These clauses mean “People who obeyed my teaching will obey your teaching also.” This condition can be true or false. Some people did in fact keep Jesus’ word, and some people did obey the message of the disciples. However, many people did not obey his word, so it is necessary to translate the word if here also. For example:

If they do what I say, they will do what you say. (CEV)

if they obeyed my teaching, they will obey yours too (GNT)

John 15:21

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world’s hate

The world’s hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:18–21

Jesus warned his followers that people will hate them and persecute them because they belong to him.

15:21a

But they will treat you like this because of My name,

- Indeed, they will do all this to you because you are committed to me, (GW)
- They will hurt you like this because you^(plur) trust in me

But: In the Greek the word But introduces a contrast to the idea of keeping Jesus’ word.

they will treat you like this because of My name:

The word they refers to those in 5:20b who would persecute the disciples. They would seek to hurt Jesus’ followers just because they were Jesus’ followers. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they will do all this to you because you are committed to me (GW)

they will do all this to you because you are mine (GNT)

They will do all this to you because of me (NLT)

they will treat you like this: The phrase they will treat you like this refers to the various ways that unbelievers will hurt the disciples. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

they will do all these wrongs

they will persecute you

you: This word is plural here and refers to Christ’s disciples.

because of My name: This phrase means “because of me” or “because you are mine.” The people are reacting to the presence of Christ in his followers. For example:

because you belong to me (CEV)

because of me (NLT)

15:21b

since they do not know the One who sent Me.

- because they do not know the One who sent me.
- and they are against me because they do not know my Father who sent me into the world.

since they do not know the One who sent Me: These clauses give the reason why people of the world persecute Jesus' followers. It is because they do not really know God the Father. The phrase the One who sent Me refers to God the Father, who sent Jesus into the world. See how you translated this phrase in 5:30 and 6:38. The people of the world may know something about God, but they do not truly know him. Use an expression that your readers and hearers can understand refers to God. For example:

because they do not know the one who sent me
(NIV)

because they do know my Father who sent me
into the world

General Comment on 15:21a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 15:21a–b, first stating the cause of the persecution. For example:

^{21b}They do not know him who sent me, and so
^{21a}they do all these things to you because you
belong to me.

The world will persecute the disciples because they represent Jesus (15:21a). And they oppose Jesus because they do not know God the Father (15:21b). In some languages it may be necessary to translate these clauses as two reasons for the world persecuting the disciples. For example:

They will do it because you belong to me, and they
don't know the one who sent me. (CEV)

John 15:22

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy

Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:22–25

Jesus spoke about those who hated and rejected him. He said that their hate fulfilled a text in the Old Testament.

15:22a

If I had not come and spoken to them,

- ¶ If I had not come to tell them God's words,
- ¶ Suppose I had never come to speak to the people.

If I had not come and spoken to them: In this clause, the word If introduces a situation that was not true. Jesus did come and speak to them. This clause imagines what would have happened if a false situation was true. Consider how it is natural in your language to suggest a possibility that is known to not have happened. For example:

Suppose I had never come and spoken to them

In some languages it is more natural to use a true statement. For example:

Because I came and spoke to them they are guilty
of sin

them: This word refers to the Jews of Jesus' day who refused to believe in him.

15:22b

they would not be guilty of sin.

- they would not be guilty of sin.
- Then God would not have judged/considered them to be responsible for doing wrong.

they would not be guilty of sin: This clause indicates that these people would not be responsible or deserve blame for their sin if Jesus had not come. They would not have known the truth and so would not deserve punishment for not believing and obeying it.

This clause refers to something that was not the situation. If the condition in 15:22a had been fulfilled, then this would have been true. But the condition was not

fulfilled, and so this clause is not true either. Christ did come and tell the people God's message. The people heard the truth and refused it. They were now responsible for their choice to do wrong and became guilty of sin. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they would not be responsible for their sin

God would not have considered them to be responsible for their sin.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. If this is so in your language, you should avoid indicating that these people would have been sinless. They would not have been innocent, but because they did not know, they would not deserve blame or punishment. For example:

they would have been blameless (NJB)

General Comment on 15:22 a, b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 15:22a, b. For example:

^{22b}They would not have been guilty of sin ^{22a}if I had not come and spoken to them (GNT)

15:22c

Now, however, they have no excuse for their sin.

- Now they cannot say they sinned without knowing the truth.
- But because they have heard what I told them, they cannot say they did not know right from/and wrong when they sinned.

Now, however, they have no excuse for their sin:

The people could not excuse their sin by saying that they did not know the truth. Jesus had brought them the truth and they had rejected it. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here. For example:

But now they have no excuse for their sin. (CEV)

But they no longer have any excuse for their sin. (NET)

But now they are fully responsible for the wrong they did.

Now, however: This phrase is short for “but now, because I have come and spoken to them.” The word however indicates a contrast with a situation in which Jesus did not come and speak to them. Yet at that time (Now), he had come and spoken, so the other situation no longer existed. Here are other ways to indicate this contrast and change of situation:

but the way things are, they no longer have any excuse for their sin

However, because I did come and speak to them

they have no excuse for their sin: In this context an excuse is a reason that is given for a sin to avoid punishment. If Jesus had not spoken to them, they would have had an excuse because they did not know his teaching about sin. But because Jesus spoke to them, they did not have any excuse. For example:

Now they cannot say, “We did not know that what we did was sin” (see TH)

John 15:23

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:22–25

Jesus spoke about those who hated and rejected him. He said that their hate fulfilled a text in the Old Testament.

15:23

Whoever hates Me hates My Father as well.

- If you hate me then you also hate my Father.
- My Father and I are one so if anyone hates me he also hates my Father.

Whoever hates Me hates My Father as well: Christ and God the Father are one, united, and you cannot hate one without hating the other. The Greek text emphasizes the words Me and My Father. The pronoun Whoever is general and means “anyone” or “people.” Languages have many ways to refer to people in general. For example:

The one who hates me hates my Father too. (NET)

Anyone who hates me also hates my Father. (NLT)

The person who hates me also hates my Father.
(GW)

Everyone who hates me also hates my Father.
(CEV)

John 15:24

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:22–25

Jesus spoke about those who hated and rejected him. He said that their hate fulfilled a text in the Old Testament.

15:24a

If I had not done among them the works that no one else did,

- If I had not done deeds nobody else could do in front of their eyes,
- If they had not seen me do miracles that no one else could do,

If I had not done among them the works that no one else did: This clause again refers to a situation

that is not true. Jesus did do works among them that no one else did. See how you translated the imagined false situation in 15:22a. For example:

Suppose I did not do among you miracles like no one else did

If: the word If introduces a situation that was not true, imagining what would happen if it were true. Jesus did do miracles among the people that no one else had ever done. In some languages it is more natural to use a true statement. For an example of how to translate this clause as a true statement see the General Comment following 15:24d.

them: This word refers to the Jews of Jesus' time.

the works that no one else did: This clause refers to the wonderful miracles that Jesus did, much greater than what other people did. For example:

the miraculous deeds that no one else did (NET)

15:24b

they would not be guilty of sin;

- they would not be guilty of sin.
- then God would not have judged/considered them to be responsible for doing wrong.

they would not be guilty of sin: This clause means that these people would not be responsible for or deserve blame for their sin. They would not have known the truth and so would not be guilty for not believing or obeying it. This clause refers to something that was not true. It would only have been true if the condition in 15:24a was fulfilled, but it was not. Translate this clause as you translated the same clause in 15:22b.

15:24c

but now they have seen

- But they did see me do these things, (CEV)
- But now they have seen those miracles that prove I am from God,

but now they have seen: This clause is short for “but now they have seen the miracles that prove I am from God.” The miracles that Jesus did showed that he was from God. Here are other ways to translate this clause (with the following clause for context):

But as it is, in spite of what they have seen, they hate both me and my Father. (NJB)

But they did see me do these things, and they still hate me and my Father too. (CEV)

But now they have seen what I have done, and yet they have hated both me and my Father. (NCV)

15:24d

and hated both Me and My Father.

- and they still hate me and my Father too. (CEV)
- and they have hated me and my Father God who sent me.

and hated both Me and My Father: Many people hated Jesus and so hated God the Father as well. See how you translated a similar idea in 15:23.

General Comment on 15:24a–d

15:24a describes a false situation because Jesus did do works among them that no one else did. In some languages it is more natural to use a positive statement. For example:

The people are guilty of sin because they hated/ rejected me and my Father even after they saw the wonderful miracles that I did.

John 15:25

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:22–25

Jesus spoke about those who hated and rejected him. He said that their hate fulfilled a text in the Old Testament.

15:25a

But this is to fulfill what is written in their Law:

- In this way what is written in their Scriptures has come true. (GW)
- Now it has happened as even their own scriptures said that it would happen when it said:

But this is to fulfill what is written in their Law: This clause means “in this way what the Jewish scriptures said would happen has happened.” In this context it indicates that the people would hate Jesus and that would fulfill the Scriptures that said they would. See how you translated similar expressions in 12:38 and 13:18. For example:

This fulfills what is written in their Scriptures (NLT)

In this way what is written in their Scriptures has come true. (GW)

That is why the Scriptures are true when they say (CEV)

And so the words that were written in their scriptures were fulfilled which said

this: This pronoun refers to the fact that the people hated and rejected both Jesus and his Father (15:24d). Their hate fulfilled the Old Testament prophecy.

what is written in their Law: This phrase refers to the quotation from the Psalms that is quoted in 15:25b. It may be confusing to translate this phrase literally because the quotation contains several words. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the words written in their Law (NJB)

what is written in their Law (NIV)

in their Law: The pronoun their refers to the Jewish people. The phrase their Law here refers to their scriptures, the Old Testament in general. Jesus used the word their to emphasize that even their own law showed that they were wrong. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase in their Law. It does not imply that the law does not have authority. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in their Scriptures (NLT)

what is written in the Holy Book of the law they follow (Otomi Back Translation)

even in their own scriptures it says

This quotation is taken from Psalm 35:19 and Psalm 69:4. Some translations will want to use a footnote to give this information. For example:

This quotation is from Psalm 35:19 and Psalm 69:4. Both verses contain these words.

15:25b

‘They hated Me without reason.’

- ‘They hated me even though there was no reason to hate me.’
- ‘Even though I have done nothing wrong, still they hated me.’

They hated Me without reason: This clause is the quotation from the Jewish scriptures referred to in 15:25a. In the Psalms, the pronoun They refers to David’s (the author’s) enemies. However, Jesus used it to refer to his own enemies, mainly the Jewish religious leaders. They had no good reason to hate Jesus. He had not acted out of hate for them but had helped them, healing their sick. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They hated me for no reason at all. (GNT)

They hated me without reason. (NJB)

Me: In the Psalm, this pronoun referred to David, the author of the Psalm, but here Jesus applied it to himself.

without reason: This phrase means that Jesus did not do anything to deserve their hate. For example:

They hated me, but they had no reason to hate me

They hated me, even though I did nothing to cause them to hate me.

General Comment on 15:25a–b

In some languages it is more natural to combine 15:25a and 15:25b. For example:

²⁵Their law says, “They hated me without cause.” They are fulfilling that prophecy.

John 15:26

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world’s hate

The world’s hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:26–27

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit would come and tell what he knew about him.

15:26a

When the Advocate comes, whom I will send to you from the Father—

- ¶ “I am sending you the Advocate from the Father. When he arrives,
- ¶ “The Helper/Counselor will come to you. I will send him from God my Father.

When the Advocate comes: This clause refers back to the Advocate that Jesus told his disciples about in 14:16–17 and 14:26. You may want to include a footnote that refers your readers to those verses.

the Advocate: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as Advocate means “one who is called to help” and so “Encourager” or “Helper.” Jesus was referring to the Holy Spirit. See the note at 14:16b and how you translated this word in that verse. For example:

the Helper (ESV)

the Encourager

the defender

comes: This verb here is short for “comes to you here on earth.”

whom I will send to you: This clause gives additional information about the Advocate or Holy Spirit. It is

not telling which Advocate or Spirit will come. See the General Comment on 15:26a–c for a way to avoid this wrong meaning. Jesus would send the Holy Spirit to earth when he returned to heaven. The Greek text emphasizes the word I.

from the Father: This phrase means “from God the Father.” Even though Jesus will send the Holy Spirit, he comes from the Father. Jesus and the Father are also both involved in sending the Holy Spirit in 14:16 (“And I will ask the Father, and he will give you another Advocate”). Later in this verse it says, “who comes from the Father,” which has the same meaning as this phrase. In some languages it may be more natural to combine the two phrases. For example:

I will send you the Spirit who comes from the Father and shows what is true. (CEV)

But I will send you the Advocate—the Spirit of truth. He will come to you from the Father (NLT)

15:26b

the Spirit of truth who proceeds from the Father—

- he who is the Spirit of truth from the Father,
- He is the truth-telling Spirit and he comes from God my Father.

the Spirit of truth: This phrase means “the Spirit who reveals the truth about God.” For example:

the Spirit, who reveals the truth about God (GNT)

the Spirit who...shows what is true (CEV)

The phrase of truth describes the Holy Spirit, giving additional information about him. In some languages it will be clearer to put this information into a separate sentence. For example:

The Holy Spirit will explain the truth about God.

who proceeds from the Father: This clause refers to the mission of the Holy Spirit to come from God to be with believers. In some languages it is more natural to make this a separate sentence. For example:

He will come from God the Father to you.

15:26c

He will testify about Me.

- he will tell what he knows about me.
- He will tell you^{plur} the truth about who I am.

He will testify about Me: This clause means “the Holy Spirit will tell people who I really am.” The Holy Spirit will tell disciples and unbelievers alike who Jesus is. For example:

will declare the truth about me (GW)

will tell you about me (CEV)

General Comment on 15:26a–c

In some languages a literal translation may suggest that there is more than one Advocate or Spirit. In those languages it may be helpful to translate the verbs “send” and “comes” in independent clauses and combine the information in 15:26a–b. For example:

^{26a–b}But I will send you the Advocate—the Spirit of truth. He will come to you from the Father ^{26c}and will testify all about me. (NLT)

John 15:27

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world’s hate

The world’s hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 15:26–27

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit would come and tell what he knew about him.

15:27a

And you also must testify,

- Then you^(plur) should tell what you know about me as well,
- And you^(plur) also will tell other people what you know about me,

And you also must testify: There are two ways to interpret the form of the word testify here:

1. It is a command as in the BSB: (BSB, NIV, NRSV, NJB, NLT, NCV, possibly KJV)
2. It is a statement about what will happen. For example:

Then you will also tell others about me (CEV) (RSV, NJB, NASB, ESV, REB, NET, GW, GNT)

If you must choose between these two options, it is recommended that you follow the major-language translation in your area. There is strong support for both interpretations.

15:27b

because you have been with Me from the beginning.

- because you^(plur) have been my companions from the start of my ministry.
- because you^(plur) have been with me since I started my ministry and have seen everything I did.

because you have been with Me: The disciples would be able to tell others about Jesus' life and ministry because they had been his companions. They were with him when he taught and healed the sick, and they knew his true character.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to Jesus' disciples.

Me: This pronoun refers to Jesus.

from the beginning: This phrase means "from the beginning of Jesus' ministry." It refers to all of Jesus' ministry, from the beginning until that time. For example:

from the beginning of my ministry (NLT)

starting from the time I began to preach to the people until now

John 16:1

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus

told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 16:1–4b

Jesus continued to speak to his disciples to prepare them for his leaving them. In this paragraph he again warned them that unbelievers would persecute them.

16:1

"I have told you these things so that you will not fall away.

- "I have said these things to you so that you will not trip/fall and lose your faith.
- "I have given you^(plur) these warnings so that you will not stop believing in me," Jesus said/continued.

I have told you these things so that you will not fall

away: Jesus continued to speak. He indicated that he told his disciples what he did in order to help them. He wanted to protect them from stumbling. The word the BSB translates as fall away means "tripping," as one might trip and fall over a rock. Here it is used figuratively and means "giving up (or "losing," "falling away from") their faith" in him. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I have said these things to you so that you won't lose your faith. (GW)

I have said these things to you to keep you from stumbling (NRSV)

I have told you these things so that you won't abandon your faith. (NLT)

I have told you these things: The phrase these things refers mainly to Jesus' words in 15:18–27. Jesus had warned the disciples that unbelievers would persecute them because they follow him. See how you translated this same clause in 14:25.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples whenever Jesus used it in this chapter.

so that you will not fall away: The Greek word that the BSB has translated as fall away means "tripping" and is a figure of speech. It compares losing one's faith to tripping and falling. See 6:61, where a form of the

same verb is translated as “offend.” Here Jesus did not want his disciples to “be offended” or “stumble.” Jesus knew that the terrible persecution that his disciples would suffer could cause them to stop trusting him. He wanted to protect them, not from the persecution itself but from this loss of faith. For example:

in order that your faith in me will continue

so that you will not give up your faith (GNT)

John 16:2

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world’s hate

The world’s hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 16:1–4b

Jesus continued to speak to his disciples to prepare them for his leaving them. In this paragraph he again warned them that unbelievers would persecute them.

16:2a

They will put you out of the synagogues.

- They/Men will expel/ban you^(plur) from their places of worship.
- The people/leaders of the synagogues will forbid you^(plur) to join them in synagogue activities.
- “You^(plur) will not be allowed to worship in the/their synagogues.

They will put you out of the synagogues: This clause indicates that the Jews would not allow Jesus’ disciples to worship with the other Jews in the synagogues. This implies that they will no longer consider Jesus’ disciples to be faithful Jews. See the notes and how you translated similar phrases in 9:22b and 12:42c. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They will ban you from the synagogue. (REB)

They will no longer consider you members of their worship houses.

They will exclude you from worship in the synagogues. (TH)

The Jewish people will not allow you to belong to their synagogues.

They will put you out of: The pronoun They refers to the Jewish leaders, or to the members of the synagogues, meaning Jews in general. They will forbid Jesus’ disciples from joining in Jewish community activities, especially worship. The phrase put you out means “cause you to leave” or “expel you (throw you out).” In some languages it may be natural to avoid using a subject like They that is not clear. You can do this by translating this clause with you as the subject and using a passive verb. For example:

You will not be allowed to join in

You will be expelled from (GNT)

the synagogues: This phrase refers to Jewish worship communities. In every town and village in Israel, people met together regularly for religious purposes. The building where the Jews gathered was called the synagogue. The group of people who met there was also called the synagogues. The main activities that took place in their meetings were reading and teaching the Scriptures, praying, and worshiping God.

People who believed in Jesus would be forbidden to join in at least some of these activities in any synagogue. See KBT synagogue. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

their religious community

Jewish gatherings/meetings

See how you translated the word “synagogue” in 6:59, 9:22 and 12:42.

16:2b

In fact, a time is coming when anyone who kills you will think he is offering a service to God.

- And the time will come when people will kill you^(plur) and think they are serving God.

- And then people will even kill you^(plur) because they think that honors/pleases God.

In fact: The Greek word that the BSB translates as In fact is a conjunction that usually introduces a strong contrast. In this context it introduces something much worse, more extreme, that shows people's opposition to Jesus' disciples. Connect 16:2a to 16:2b in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Indeed (NRSV)

and (GNT)

Yes (NCV)

a time is coming: This expression means "sometime in the future." For example:

the time will come (GNT)

it will happen that (TH)

anyone who kills you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as anyone who kills you refers to all people who would persecute Jesus' disciples. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

those who kill you (NRSV)

whoever kills you (ESV)

will think he is offering a service to God: This expression refers to the wrong thinking of the people who would kill Jesus' disciples. They would think that God wanted these people to die and that they would serve God by killing them. But that would be totally wrong.

will think: This phrase introduces something that unbelievers will think. Their thinking would be wrong. In some languages it is more natural to make that clear. For example:

will wrongly think that

he is offering: This phrase refers to killing Jesus' disciples. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

by killing you^(plur) he is offering

a service to God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as service here means "worship," or "service," or "religious rites." These people would think that by killing the disciples they were worshiping or serving God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they are worshiping God

he is serving God (GNT)

they are honoring God

General Comment on 16:2b

In some languages it may be natural to translate what the people thought as a direct quotation. For example:

Those who kill you will think, "If we do this we will be offering worship to God."

They will say to themselves, "By killing Jesus' disciples we will honor/serve God."

John 16:3

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 16:1–4b

Jesus continued to speak to his disciples to prepare them for his leaving them. In this paragraph he again warned them that unbelievers would persecute them.

16:3

They will do these things because they have not known the Father or Me.

- They will treat you^(plur) like this because they do not truly know God the Father or me.

- They do not really know God the Father. They do not really know me either. That is why they will persecute you^(plur).

They will do these things because they have not known the Father or Me: This sentence explains the reason why unbelievers would kill Jesus' disciples. The reason was that they did not truly know God or Jesus himself. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

People will do these things to you because they have not known either the Father or me. (GNT)

They will act like this because they have never had the true knowledge of the Father or of me. (JBP)

They will do this because they have not known the Father and they have not known me. (NCV)

They...they: This word refers to anyone who would persecute or kill the Christians.

will do these things: The phrase these things refers to persecuting Jesus' disciples and specifically killing them. It refers back to 16:2b. Try to use a phrase that implies doing harm or evil. For example:

will do such things (NIV)

will do these things to you (GNT, GW)

will act in this evil way

because: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why people will persecute Jesus' disciples.

they have not known the Father or Me: This clause indicates that these people did not really or truly know God or Jesus. They knew who God was and they knew who Jesus was. However, they did not have a personal or close relationship with either God or Jesus. See the notes on 14:7a–b and 15:21b. Here is another way of translating this clause:

they have never truly known the Father or me

In some languages it may be natural to repeat the verb. For example:

they have not known the Father and they have not known me (NCV)

have not known: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as have not known here indicates a constant truth. These people had never come to know God or Jesus, and they did not at that present time either. Some think that the sense of the verb is “failed to recognize” or “did not learn that” (Jesus was God's Son). Here are other ways to translate this Greek verb:

they don't know (CEV)

they have never known (NLT)

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to say use a personal pronoun:

my Father

Me: This word refers to Jesus. These people knew his name and his earthly home but they did not recognize that he was from God.

John 16:4

Section 15:18–16:4b The world would hate the disciples

Jesus warned the disciples that the world would hate them because they did not belong to the world. They now belonged to Jesus and because the world hated Jesus it would also hate them. And because the world hated Jesus, it also hated the Father. When the Holy Spirit came, he would tell about Jesus, and the disciples should tell what they know about him too. Jesus told them these things so that their faith would stay strong.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The world's hate

The world's hate for Jesus and his disciples

Paragraph 16:1–4b

Jesus continued to speak to his disciples to prepare them for his leaving them. In this paragraph he again warned them that unbelievers would persecute them.

16:4a

But I have told you these things

- But I have told you^(plur) about this

- I have told you^(plur) what they will do,

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But normally introduces a contrast. Here it indicates an implied contrast between those who do not know God or Jesus (16:3) and Jesus' disciples, who do know them. However, because the contrast is not obvious, some English translations do not translate this conjunction. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

I have told you these things: The words these things is plural and refers to all that Jesus has told his disciples about being persecuted. This entire clause is the same clause that is used in 16:1.

16:4b

so that when their hour comes, you will remember that I told you about them.

- so that when the time comes for them to do it, you^(plur) will remember that I told you what they would do.
- so that when it does happen, you^(plur) will remember that I warned you about them.

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that here introduces a purpose. Jesus' purpose in saying these things to his disciples was that they would remember them in the future.

when their hour comes: This clause means "when they do this" and refers to the time when people will persecute believers.

their hour comes: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts include the word that means their. For example:

their time comes (NET) (BSB, RSV, NRSV, GNT, ESV, NASB, NET, NIV2011)

1. Some Greek manuscripts do not include the word that means their. For example:

the time comes (CEV) (KJV, CEV, GW, NLT, NCV, NJB, NIV84, REB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). Most of the best and oldest Greek manuscripts include the word their. The UBS Greek New Testament gives this reading a B rating, indicating that it is almost certainly correct. However, in some languages there may be little difference in the meaning of the two options. Here is another way to translate this clause:

when the time comes for them to do these things (GNT)

you will remember that I told you about them: This clause tells the purpose for Jesus saying what he did to his disciples. His purpose was for them to remember what he said when others persecuted them. That would encourage them because it would remind them that he knew the future and so they could trust him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will remember what I told you (GNT)

you will remember what I have said (CEV)

you will remember my warning (NLT)

you will remember that I warned you (NCV)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

about them: This phrase is not in the Greek text but is implied. It refers to the things that Jesus said about the people that would persecute Jesus' disciples. Consider how much implied information that it is natural to include in your language. For example:

you will remember that I told you that you would be persecuted

you might remember what I told you

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:4c

I did not tell you these things from the beginning, because I was with you.

- ¶ “I have not told you^(plur) this before because I was with you.
- ¶ “Because I was with you^(plur), I did not need to warn you about this at first.

I did not tell you these things from the beginning, because I was with you: This sentence indicates that Jesus had not always told his disciples that people would persecute them. Earlier it was not necessary, because he himself was always with them. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I did not tell you this at first, because then I was with you. (REB)

these things: This phrase refers to what Jesus said about the disciples being persecuted. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase.

from the beginning: This phrase refers to the beginning of Jesus’ ministry. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

at first (GW)

when we were first companions (Western Bukid-non Manobo Back Translation)

because I was with you: This clause indicates that Jesus did not tell his disciples before that they would be persecuted because he was still with them. Perhaps that was because when he was there, the opposition attacked him and not his disciples. And when he was there he was available to protect the disciples. But these reasons should not be made explicit in a translation.

General Comment on 16:4c

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange the clauses in 16:4c. For example:

I was with you at the first, and so I didn’t tell you these things. (CEV)

John 16:5**Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit**

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the

world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus’ disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:5a

Now, however, I am going to Him who sent Me;

- But now I am going back to the one who sent me,
- But very soon now I will return to heaven to my Father God , who sent me.

Now, however: The time word Now here means “very soon.” This time contrasts with “from the beginning” in 16:4c.

I am going to Him who sent Me: This clause means “I am returning to God who sent me.” Jesus was with God his Father before his birth on earth, and now he would return to him in heaven. See how you translated this same clause in 7:33.

to Him who sent Me: The phrase Him who sent Me refers to God the Father. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

I am going back to the Father who sent me (CEV)

16:5b

yet none of you asks Me, ‘Where are You going?’

- but not any of you^(plur) asks me, ‘Where are you^(sing) going?’
- And not one of you^(plur) is asking me where I am going.

yet none of you asks Me, ‘Where are You going?’:

None of the disciples were asking Jesus about his journey, or how and why he was going back to his Father.

yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as yet is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces something that is the opposite of what is expected. (Here, yet means “although that is true” or “but.”) Both 16:5a and 16:6 begin with the Greek word mean-

ing “But.” So it may be best to use a different expression here. See the General Comment at the end of 16:7a. Here are other ways to translate this word (with context):

and not one of you is asking me (NET)

None of you asks me (NIV)

Now I am going back to the One who sent me. But none of you asks me (NCV)

none of you asks Me, ‘Where are You going?’: The words Where are You going? are reported in direct speech as a quotation inside a quotation. In some languages it is more natural to translate this inner quotation as indirect speech. For example:

yet none of you is asking me where I am going (GNT)

John 16:6

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus’ disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:6

Instead, your hearts are filled with sorrow because I have told you these things.

- But you^(plur) are full of grief because I have told you about it.
- But now that I have told you^(plur) that I am going away, you feel very sad.

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead here connects a negative statement

(16:5b) to a positive statement (16:6). This kind of expression emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

Yet, none of you asks me where I’m going. But because I’ve told you this, you’re filled with sadness. (GW)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

...and not one of you is asking where I am going. Instead, you grieve because of what I’ve told you. (NLT)

None of you asks me, ‘Where are you going?’ Rather, you are filled with grief because I have said these things. (NIV)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

But none of you asks me, ‘Where are you going?’ Your hearts are filled with sadness because I have told you these things. (NCV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

But you are very sad because I said these things, and none of you asks me, ‘Where are you going?’

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

your hearts are filled with sorrow because I have told you these things: The phrase these things probably refers to what Jesus just said in 16:5a that he would leave his disciples. Verse 16:7 implies that they were sad because Jesus was going away.

your hearts are filled with sorrow: This clause means “you are very sad.” For example:

you are sad at heart (NJB)

your hearts are full of sadness (GNT)

The pronoun your is plural and refers to the disciples. The heart was the source of emotions. In some lan-

guages it may be natural to use a different body part, or to refer directly to the person. For example:

there is sadness in your minds/livers

You are very sad from hearing all of this. (CEV)

sorrow: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sorrow here means “sadness,” “grief,” “distress,” or “anxiety.” It refers to the disciples’ emotional reaction when they heard that Jesus would leave them. Here are other ways to translate this word:

grief (NIV)

sadness (NET)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an adjective or a verb. For example:

very sad (CEV)

distressed

You grieve (NLT)

General Comment on 16:6

What Jesus had told the disciples caused them sorrow. In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the clauses in these clauses, mentioning the result (sorrow) first. For example:

You grieve because of what I’ve told you. (NLT)

You are very sad from hearing all this. (CEV)

Your hearts are filled with sadness because I have told you these things. (NCV)

John 16:7

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus’ disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:7a

But I tell you the truth,

- The truth, however, is that
- However I assure/promise you^(plur) that it is true that

But: The word that the BSB has translated literally as But indicates a strong contrast. Here the contrast is more implied than usual.

The contrast is between the disciples’ sorrow at Jesus’ leaving and the fact that his leaving would benefit them. The disciples’ sorrow implies that Jesus’ leaving is a bad thing. Nevertheless (however), Jesus said that his leaving would be a good thing. That is not expected, which is also indicated by the word But. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Nevertheless (NRSV)

However (GW)

I tell you the truth: This clause indicates that Jesus’ next statement is important. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

in fact (NLT)

actually

General Comment on 16:5a–7a

All four clauses 16:5a, b, 6, and 7a begin with a conjunction that indicates some contrast. In most languages it will be important to include some variety, introducing the clauses in different ways. For example:

But...and...Instead...But in fact (NLT)

But...[implied]...Yet...Nevertheless... (REB)

16:7b

it is for your benefit that I am going away.

- it is good/best for you^(plur) that I am going away

- my leaving will help/benefit you^(plur).

it is for your benefit that I am going away: The expression it is for your benefit here means “it will be better for you” or “you will benefit.” See how you translated the same expression in 11:50. Here are other ways to translate this entire clause:

it is better for you that I go away (GNT)

I will go away for your benefit

My leaving is for your good.

I am going away: This clause means “that I am leaving you.”

16:7c

Unless I go away, the Advocate will not come to you;

- because if I do not leave, the Helper will not come to you^(plur).
- It is only when I go away that the Counselor, the Holy Spirit, will come to help you^(plur).

The Greek text begins with a conjunction that many English versions translate as “for.” It introduces the reason why Jesus’ departure would benefit the disciples. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

because (GNT)

Unless I go away: This clause suggests a possibility that Jesus knew would not happen. It introduces what would happen if Jesus did what the disciples wanted and did not go away. In some languages it may be natural to use a positive verb phrase. For example:

if I stay

until I leave (CEV)

the Advocate will not come to you: While Jesus was on earth he was God’s representative on earth. However, when he left, the Holy Spirit would come and be God’s representative on earth. The Holy Spirit would not come until Jesus died and rose again and returned to his Father. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the helper won’t come to you (GW)

the Holy Spirit cannot come to help (CEV)

the Advocate: The word the BSB has translated as Advocate means “Encourager” or “Helper” and is referring to the Holy Spirit. See the note and how you translated this word in 14:16b. For example:

the Helper (ESV)

the Encourager

the defender

General Comment on 16:7c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of these clauses. For example:

The Holy Spirit cannot come to help you until I leave. (CEV)

because the Advocate will not come to you if I do not go away

16:7d

but if I go, I will send Him to you.

- However, if I do go/leave, I will send the Helper to you^(plur).
- I will send him to you^(plur) when I leave.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces the opposite possibility from “if I do not go away” in 16:7c. The possibility in 16:7d is that Jesus would go.

if I go: This expression suggests the opposite possibility from 16:7c. This possibility would really happen, and Jesus had already told the disciples that he would leave. As a result, this clause can be understood to mean “because I will go away” or “when I go.” You may want to indicate that this possibility would really happen. For example:

after I am gone (CEV)

When I go away (NCV)

I go: This clause is short for “I go to heaven” or “I go to my Father.” Here is another way to translate this clause:

But when I leave

I will send Him to you: Jesus indicated that he would send the Holy Spirit to the disciples.

General Comment on 16:7c–d

In some languages it may be natural to use positive verb phrases in 16:7c. Then you would continue the thought in 16:7d instead of having a contrast. For example:

The Helper will only come to you if I go away. Then I will send him to you.

In other languages it may be natural to reverse 16:7c and 16:7d. For example:

When I go away, I will send the Helper to you. If I do not go away, the Helper will not come. (NCV)

John 16:8

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:8–11

The Holy Spirit would come to Jesus' disciples after Jesus leaves them. He would help them, and he would work in the world too. He would show the people in the world that their sin and even their righteousness and judgment were all wrong.

16:8a

And when He comes,

- When he comes to earth
- After the Counselor arrives,

And when He comes: This clause is short for “When the Holy Spirit comes to earth.” If you do not use a

pronoun here, refer to the Spirit as you did in 16:7c. For example:

When the Helper comes (NCV)

When the Comforter/Encourager arrives on earth

16:8b–d

He will convict the world in regard to sin and righteousness and judgment: This clause is very difficult to understand. D.A. Carson and John Aloisi have written very good articles about this passage. Carson summarizes his article in his commentary. Both come to similar conclusions and form the basis for the interpretations recommended in these Notes. Klink agrees with them. First, there is more than one way to understand the word that some English versions translate as “prove...wrong.”

1. It means “convict” or “prove that someone did something wrong” as in a court of law. That is what the word means in 8:46. For example:

he will reprove the world of sin, and of righteousness, and of judgment (KJV) (BSB, KJV, GW in part, NLT)

1. It means “prove that someone’s thoughts are wrong.” For example:

he will prove to the people of the world that they are wrong about sin and about what is right and about God’s judgment (GNT) (GNT, NET, ESV, NASB, NIV, NCV, REB, RSV, NRSV, GW in part)

1. It means “show that someone is wrong” or “show what is right.” In 3:20, the BSB translates this word as “exposed” (revealed something that was hidden) and this meaning is similar. For example:

he will show the world how wrong it was, about sin, and about who was in the right, and about judgement (NJB) (NJB, GW in part, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That follows the way the Greek text uses the word in 8:46, which has a similar context. There the BSB says “Which of you convicts me of sin?” Interpretation (2) is not wrong teaching and most English translations follow it. However, 8:46 cannot be understood in that way, so it is better to follow interpretation (1).

However, if a major language translation in your area follows interpretation (2), you may want to follow it.

It may seem difficult to understand why the Holy Spirit would convict the world of righteousness and judgment. But as the notes below explain, the righteousness and judgment of the world is not good. That is what the Holy Spirit will seek to correct.

Another issue with this Greek word is whether the Holy Spirit convinces the world that they are wrong. A few English translations say or imply that the world will be convinced (GNT, NCV, RSV, GW in part). The other translations can be understood either way (that they are convinced or not convinced). It is recommended that you follow those translations that can be understood either way. However, the meaning that someone is convinced is often included in the Greek word. So if a major language translation in your area says that the world is convinced, you may want to follow that translation.

The word that you use to translate convict must be suitable for the three words that follow (sin, righteousness, and judgment). Here is another way to translate this word:

rebuke

16:8b

He will convict the world in regard to sin

- he will convict the world about their sin,
- he will show that the people of the world are wrong because they have sinned,

He will convict the world in regard to sin: This clause probably means “the Holy Spirit will convict unbelievers of the sin in their lives.” The Spirit will show that the people of the world have sinned and are guilty. Here is another way to translate this clause:

he will convict the world of its sin (NLT)

the world: The word world refers to the people in the world, specifically unbelievers (see 16:9). This phrase refers to unbelievers as a group. It does not imply that all unbelievers will be convinced of their sin and turn to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the people of the world (GNT)

many unbelievers in the world

in regard to sin: The Greek phrase that the BS translates as in regard to sin here probably means “of sin” as in 8:46. The world was guilty of sin and so the Holy Spirit would cause them to know that. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

of its sin (NLT)

that it has sin

that it is sinful

sin: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sin here refers to a sinful condition rather than individual sins. (Note that the word here is sin and not “sins.”) This sinful condition leads to acts, thoughts, and attitudes that are not what God wants or approves. See how you translated this word in 1:29. See also KBT Sin, Sinner A.2. The singular noun sin here refers to the idea of sin, not to one particular individual sin.

Try to translate sin with a general term that can include any wrongdoing against God. Here are problems to avoid:

1. The term should not imply that only serious crimes like murder or stealing are sins. Other offenses like gossip and greed are also sins.
2. The term should not include accidents or mistakes.

Here are some other ways to translate sin:

being sinful

offending God

wrongdoing

16:8c

and righteousness

- about their supposed righteousness/goodness,
- and they are wrong when they think that they are righteous/good,

and righteousness: The Holy Spirit will also convict people about their righteousness. It may seem strange that he would convict them of righteousness as he would convict them of sin. However, here it probably means that their own righteousness is not enough. They need God’s righteousness. (See this use of the word “righteousness” in Isaiah 64:6, Romans 10:3, and Philipians 3:9.) This probably means that the Holy

Spirit will show them what is wrong with their righteousness.

In some languages it may be necessary to repeat the verb (“convict”) here. For example:

He will prove that their righteousness is wrong

and he will convict the world for their righteousness

righteousness: The Greek word that the BSB translates as righteousness refers to moral goodness. It refers to that character and action that God approves. The Spirit would show people that the righteousness that they think that they have is not true righteousness. Here are other ways to translate this word:

their righteousness

their supposed goodness

their failures to be truly righteous

16:8d and judgment:

- and about their judging.
- and they are wrong about how they judge.

and judgment: The Holy Spirit would also convict the people of the world of their judgment (deciding if someone is right or wrong). This could refer to two things. First, they thought that they were right to judge Jesus wrong for calling himself the Son of God. But actually on the cross God would judge and condemn Satan (6:11), not Jesus. Second, Jesus earlier challenged people for judging wrongly by outer appearance (7:24).

judgment: This word here refers to deciding if someone is guilty or innocent of wrong. In some languages it may be natural to translate it using a verb. For example:

how it judges good and evil

how it decides who is wrong/guilty and right/innocent

John 16:9

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:9

in regard to sin, because they do not believe in Me;

- The Helper will convict unbelievers of their sin because they do not trust in me.
- The Counselor will show that they are wrong about sin, because the real sin is that people refuse to believe in me.

in regard to sin, because they do not believe in Me:

The Greek word that the BSB translates as because introduces the reason that the Holy Spirit would convict them of sin. The people of the world needed the Holy Spirit to convict them because they did not believe in Jesus Christ.

in regard to sin: It may be natural to begin a new sentence here and repeat the verb from 16:7:

He will convict them of sin because they do not believe in me.

He will show that they have sinned.

they: This word refers to people in general who do not believe in Jesus. For example:

because people don't believe in me (GW)

do not believe in Me: To believe in Jesus includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone

else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12, 2:11, and 3:16. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

didn't have faith in me (CEV)

refuse to believe in me (NJB)

do not trust in me

John 16:10

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:10a

in regard to righteousness, because I am going to the Father

- He will convict unbelievers about their righteousness, because I am going to God the Father
- The Holy Spirit will prove the world's people wrong about what God thinks about their righteousness/goodness, because I am going to God my Father in heaven,

in regard to righteousness, because I am going to the Father: While Jesus was on earth, he demonstrated true righteousness. Because Jesus would go away, people would no longer be able to see a truly righteous man. So the Holy Spirit would show people that their righteousness was not true righteousness. Again it may be natural to begin a new sentence and supply a verb. For example:

He will convict the world about their righteousness, because I am going to the Father

Because I am going to heaven, the Holy Spirit will show unbelievers that their righteousness is not true righteousness.

16:10b

and you will no longer see Me;

- and you^(plur) will not see me anymore.
- and I will no longer be here with you^(plur).

and you will no longer see Me: The disciples would soon not be able to see Jesus any longer after he went to heaven. That is why it would be necessary for the Holy Spirit to show people that they lacked true righteousness. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

where you can see me no longer (NIV)

and you won't see me again (CEV)

General Comment on 16:10a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine 16:10a–b. For example:

Because I am going to the Father and you will not see me anymore, the One who comforts/encourages will convict the world of their lack of true goodness.

John 16:11

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:4c–11

Jesus told his disciples that he would go back to God and send the Holy Spirit to them. The Holy Spirit would work in the world convicting the people there.

16:11a and in regard to judgment,

- And he will convict unbelievers about their judgment,
- He will show the world's people that they are wrong in their judgment,

and in regard to judgment: People of the world were wrong in their judgment. They judged that Jesus deserved to die. But God showed that Jesus was completely right by raising him from the dead. And he judged Satan wrong and condemned him. Translate judgment as you did in 16:8d. It may be natural to begin a new clause or sentence here and repeat the verb from 16:8b. For example:

and he will convict them about their judgment

The Helper will show the world that their judgment is wrong

16:11b because the prince of this world has been condemned.

- because God has nearly judged the ruler of this world.
- because it is Satan, the one who rules this world, whom God has condemned.

because the prince of this world has been condemned: It is hard to understand why Jesus said this clause. But scholars agree that the expression the prince of this world has been condemned refers to the death of Christ on the cross. When Christ died on the cross, God actually judged Satan and all that is sinful and wrong. And if the ruler of the (unbelieving) world has been judged, so will the unbelieving world. The Holy Spirit would convict the people of the world that their judging of Jesus and others was wrong. The death of Christ on the cross is the evidence that they were wrong about him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because the prince of this world now stands condemned (NIV)

because the ruler of this world has already been judged (GNT)

because God has already condemned Satan who is the leader of those who do not believe in me

the prince of this world: This phrase refers to Satan, the chief demon. See how you translated this phrase in 12:31 and 14:30. It may be necessary to make explicit that this phrase refers to Satan. It is important that your readers understand that Christ was not referring to himself. For example:

Satan, the evil ruler of the world

world: The word world here refers to unbelievers in general. See how you translated this idea in 16:8.

has been condemned: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as condemned here means “judged guilty.” It is a passive verb. The subject is God, who judged and condemned Satan. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the ruler of this world is judged (ESV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God has already judged the ruler of this world (CEV)

God judged that the prince of this world is guilty

Translate this idea in the way that is most natural in your language. In your translation, consider that at the time Jesus spoke, the death of Christ was in the very near future. The Greek text uses a past tense probably because Satan's condemnation was sure. It was as sure as if it had already happened. Use the tense that is most natural in this context. For example:

God will soon judge the evil spirit which rules this world

John 16:12

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:12–15

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit will teach them about him.

16:12

I still have much to tell you, but you cannot yet bear to hear it.

- ¶ “I have much more to say to you, but right now it would be more than you could understand. (CEV)
- ¶ “There is much more that you^(plur) need to know, but you could/would not understand it if I told you now so I will not.

I still have much to tell you: This clause indicates that there were many more things Jesus wanted his disciples to know. There were things that he had not yet taught them but that he wanted to teach them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

There is much more that I could say to you (REB)

I have a lot more to tell you (GW)

I: This pronoun refers to Jesus.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

but you cannot yet bear to hear it: This clause indicates that it would be hard for the disciples if Jesus immediately taught them everything that they should know. They could not bear (endure, accept) hearing these additional things from Jesus. There were things that Jesus' disciples were not yet able to understand and accept. Therefore, Jesus implied, he would not teach them these truths himself, but the Holy Spirit would guide them when he came. It would not be helpful for them at this time. For example:

but they are too much for you now (NCV)

right now it would be more than you could understand (CEV)

but as yet you cannot bear/endure them, I will not say them

The Greek and many English versions end this verse with “now.” It is a time word that refers to when Jesus was speaking with the disciples.

John 16:13

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:12–15

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit will teach them about him.

16:13a

However, when the Spirit of truth comes,

- But when the Spirit who reveals/speaks truth arrives,
- When, however, the Spirit comes, who reveals the truth about God, (GNT)

However: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates literally as However includes a word here that is often translated as “but.” The idea seems to be that although Jesus would not tell the disciples these many things, the Holy Spirit would tell them when he came. Many English translations leave this word implicit, but many others make it explicit. For example:

But (NIV)

Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language.

when the Spirit of truth comes: This clause refers to the time in the near future when the Holy Spirit would come to the disciples. After Jesus returned to heaven, the Holy Spirit would come from God to live with those who believed in Jesus.

the Spirit of truth: This phrase refers to the Holy Spirit. See 15:26. The Spirit of God is truthful (honest) and always tells the truth. He reveals the truth about God, which Jesus wanted to tell the disciples but could not yet tell them. In some languages it is more natural to make this explicit. For example:

When, however, the Spirit comes, who reveals the truth about God, (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to translate truth as an adjective. For example:

The Spirit shows what is true (CEV)

The Holy Spirit explains what is true about God. When he comes...

16:13b

He will guide you into all truth.

- he will lead you^(plur) and teach you all the truth.
- he will make you^(plur) able to understand all the truth.

He will guide you: This clause here means “he will teach you and make you able to understand.” The Holy Spirit will teach Jesus’ disciples so that they will be able to understand the things of God. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he will lead you (GNT)

he will teach you

he will guide your minds so that you will know

he will help you so that you will really understand

into all truth: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as into all truth is more literally “in all the truth.” There is a textual problem here. Some Greek manuscripts read “into all the truth” and some read “in all the truth.” The UBS Greek New Testament gives the reading “in all the truth” a B rating. However, most English translations (all those consulted) say “into.” This is probably because the context suggests the continuing teaching of truth. However, there is little difference between into and “in.” This phrase probably means that the Holy Spirit would teach them all about Jesus and what he did and taught. That would include what had not yet happened, including his death and resurrection.

all truth: This phrase refers to all the truth about Jesus, who is the truth (see 14:6). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the full truth (CEV)

all that is true

16:13c

For He will not speak on His own,

- Because it will not be his own ideas that he will teach you^(plur).
- That is because he will not teach you^(plur) things that are just his own ideas.

For He will not speak on His own: This clause indicates that the Holy Spirit will not speak based on his own authority. He will not speak his own thoughts, ideas that he has thought up by himself. See also 12:49 and 14:10, where Jesus says something similar about himself and his Father. See how you translated those verses as well. In this context Jesus speaks about the Holy Spirit and himself. The Holy Spirit will tell the believers the things that Jesus did not tell them.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

for he will not speak on his own authority (ESV)

He will not speak his own words (NCV)

He will not teach thoughts that are just his

For: This word introduces the reason that we can know that the Spirit would teach truth. He would not speak without the authority and the words of Jesus and the Father. Translate this word in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

because

16:13d

but He will speak what He hears,

- Rather, he will tell you^(plur) what he hears from me
- No! He will tell you^(plur) what I tell him.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (16:13c) to a positive statement (16:13d). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB. For example:

He will not speak his own words, but he will speak only what he hears (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Because he will not speak based on his own authority; instead he will tell what he hears from God.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

He won't speak on his own. He will speak what he hears (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

He will tell what he hears, and not his own thoughts.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

He will speak what He hears: This phrase is the positive way of saying 16:13c. It indicates that the Spirit will tell the believers what Jesus tells him to say (see 16:14). In some languages you may want to make explicit that the Holy Spirit will hear from Jesus. For example:

He will tell you only what he has heard from me (CEV)

16:13e and He will declare to you what is to come.

- He will also announce to you^(plur) events that will happen in the future.
- And he will tell you^(plur) about things that have not happened yet.

and He will declare to you what is to come: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as declare means “to report, announce, proclaim, teach.” The Holy Spirit would teach and guide Jesus’ disciples, explaining to them the things that were to come (would happen in the future). There are two main ways to interpret what this clause means:

1. The phrase what is to come refers to events that would happen soon, the death, resurrection, and ascension of Jesus. These events were still future when Jesus spoke, but would be in the past when the Holy Spirit came. So this could mean that the Holy Spirit would explain the meaning of Jesus’ death, resurrection and ascension.

2. The phrase what is to come refers to events that would happen much later, such as ones that Revelation records. One English translation implies this meaning:

He will tell you about the future. (NLT)

It is recommended that you leave the meaning ambiguous, referring to future things in general. For example:

He will tell you about the things that will happen.

He will proclaim/preach the events that will happen.

John 16:14

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus’ disciples

Paragraph 16:12–15

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit will teach them about him.

16:14a

He will glorify Me

- He will honor me
- He will bring me glory/honor

He will glorify Me: The Holy Spirit will glorify Jesus, which means that he will show how great and wonderful Christ is. The word glorify means “to reveal the greatness of someone, to demonstrate or show publicly that someone deserves to receive honor.” He will cause people to understand how very great and good he is. See how you translated “glory” in 1:14 and 8:54, and glorify in 12:28 and 13:31–32. See KBT Glory, Glorious, Glorify 3.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He will give me glory (GNT)

The Spirit of truth will bring glory to me (NCV)

He will show you how glorious/great I am

He will reveal/show to you my greatness

16:14b

by taking from what is Mine and disclosing it to you.

- because he will receive my message and announce it to you^(plur).
- in this way: he will accept my words and tell them to you^(plur).

by: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *by* here usually introduces the reason or way that the Spirit will glorify Jesus. He will bring glory to Jesus by revealing Jesus' true glory in his message. Here are other ways to translate this word in context:

He will glorify me, because he will take what is mine and declare it to you. (NRSV)

taking from what is Mine: The phrase *what is Mine* here refers mainly to Christ's message, what he wanted to say to the disciples (see 16:12). For example:

he will take what I have to say (NCV)

he will take what I say (GNT)

by taking my message (CEV)

and disclosing it to you: This clause indicates that the Spirit will tell Christ's message to the disciples. The Greek word that the BSB translates as *disclosing* is the same as in 16:13e. See the note there and translate the word the same way in both verses. For example:

and tell it to you (NCV)

and explain it clearly

General Comment on 16:14b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse these clauses. For example:

by telling you whatever he receives from me (NLT)

because he will tell you what I say (GW)

John 16:15

Section 16:4c–15 Jesus would send the Holy Spirit

Jesus told his disciples that it was for their benefit that he would leave. That is because he would send the Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit would prove that the world was wrong in their sin and righteousness and judgment. He would also lead the disciples into all truth, which comes from Jesus and his Father.

Here are some other possible section headings:

What the Holy Spirit would do when he came

The Holy Spirit will teach the world and Jesus' disciples

Paragraph 16:12–15

Jesus told his disciples that the Holy Spirit will teach them about him.

16:15a

Everything that belongs to the Father is Mine.

- Everything that belongs to the Father is also mine.
- All that God the Father has also belongs to me.

Everything that belongs to the Father is Mine: This sentence indicates that there is no division between Jesus and his Father. What one knows and says, the other knows and says. The Son possesses all the wisdom and knowledge of the Father. For example:

Everything the Father says is also what I say. (GW)

16:15b

That is why I said that the Spirit will take from what is Mine

- That is why I said, 'He will receive my message
- So I told you that the Spirit accepts my words

That is why I said that: This expression means that 16:15a is the reason why Jesus said what he did in 16:14b. He said that the Holy Spirit would take what was Jesus' to tell the disciples because all that the Father has is Jesus'. It is the same as taking God the Father's message. The wisdom and knowledge of the truth that the Father has, the Son has also. Because of this, Jesus could say that the Spirit would take and declare his message. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

For this reason I said that... (NRSV)

the Spirit will take from what is Mine: The Holy Spirit will take, that is, accept or receive, Jesus' message. See how you translated this clause in 16:14. For example:

the Spirit will take what I give him (GNT)

the Spirit takes my message (CEV)

what the Spirit tells you comes from me

16:15c and disclose it to you.

- and announce it to you^(plur).”
- and tells them to you^(plur).”

and disclose it to you: The word disclose means “tell.” The word “will” from “will take” in 16:15b also connects with disclose to make the verb future. The Holy Spirit will tell the disciples the message that he will receive from Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and tell it to you (GNT)

and make it known to you (REB)

General Comment on 16:15b–c

In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quotation when Jesus refers to his own words. For example:

That is why I said, ‘He will take what I say and tell it to you.’ (GW)

John 16:16

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus’ leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus’ name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:16–18

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that in a little while they would no longer see him. After that, they would see him again. The disciples asked one another what he meant.

16:16a

In a little while you will see Me no more,

- ¶ “After a little while you^(plur) will not be able to see me.
- ¶ Jesus then said to his disciples, “Soon I will not be with you^(plur).”

Jesus continued to speak. In some languages it is more natural to make that clear by adding a phrase. For example:

Jesus told his disciples (CEV)

In a little while you will see Me no more: This clause refers to Jesus’ death the next day. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

After a little while you will not see me. (NCV)

In a short time you will no longer see me. (NJB)

In a little while: This phrase here means “after a short time” or “soon.” It refers to what would happen the next day.

you will see Me no more: This clause indicates that Jesus’ disciples would not be able to see him. He would not be there. The Greek word that the BSB translates as no more here means that the disciples would not see Jesus for a while. It does not mean here “never again.” They would see him again after his resurrection, which Jesus refers to in 16:16b.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

16:16b

and then after a little while you will see Me.”

- Then after a little while longer and you^(plur) will see me again.”
- Then soon after that, I will be back again with you^(plur).”

and then after a little while you will see Me: This clause indicates that after a short period of time Jesus' disciples would again be able to see him. It probably refers to them seeing him after his resurrection a few days after his death.

and then after a little while: This phrase means "after another short period of time." Here it probably refers to the third day after Christ would die on the cross. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and after another short time

John 16:17

Section 16:16–24 The disciples' sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus' leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus' name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:16–18

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that in a little while they would no longer see him. After that, they would see him again. The disciples asked one another what he meant.

16:17a–e

Then some of His disciples asked one another, "Why is He telling us, 'In a little while you will not see Me, and then after a little while you will see Me' and 'Because I am going to the Father'?" The disciples still did not understand that Jesus would be killed the next day and then rise from the dead. They talked among themselves and wondered what he meant. This verse contains a direct quotation (what Jesus just said) inside a direct quotation (what the disciples said). In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quotation or quotations. See the General Comment at the end of 16:17a–e.

16:17a

Then some of His disciples asked one another,

- Therefore his disciples discussed among themselves, saying,
- So his disciples asked each other

Then some of His disciples asked one another: Jesus' disciples discussed what Jesus had just said. They asked one another what they thought Jesus meant. Because they used questions that asked for an answer, in some languages it is natural to use the word "ask." For example:

Some of his disciples asked among themselves (GNT)

Some of the disciples asked each other (NLT)

16:17b

"Why is He telling us,

- "What did he mean when he said,
- what Jesus meant by saying

Why is He telling us: The disciples wondered about the meaning of Jesus' words in 16:16a–b and 16:10a. Introduce the quotation of these words in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

What does he mean when he says (NLT)

What does he mean by this (REB)

What is the meaning of what he is saying (NET)

16:17c

'In a little while you will not see Me,

- 'After a little while you^(plur) will not be able to see me,'
- that soon he would not be with them

In a little while you will not see Me: Translate this as you did 16:16a.

16:17d

and then after a little while you will see Me'

- and 'Then after a little while longer and you^(plur) will see me again?'
- and then soon after that, he would be back again with them.

and then after a little while you will see Me: Translate this as you did 16:16b.

16:17e and ‘Because I am going to the Father?’”

- And what did he mean by saying ‘I am going to God the Father?’”
- And they asked what he meant by his saying that he was going to God his Father.

Because I am going to the Father: The disciples also did not understand what Christ said to them in 16:10, that he would go back to God. Translate this clause so that the reference to 16:10 is clear.

General Comment on 16:17a–e

In some languages it may be natural to translate at least one direct quotation of Jesus’ words as an indirect quotation. For example:

Then some of his disciples said to one another, “What does he mean by telling us that in a little while we will no longer see him, and then in another little while we will see him? What does he mean by saying that he is going to the Father?”

Some of his disciples said to each other, “What does he mean? He tells us that in a little while we won’t see him. Then he tells us that in a little while we will see him again and that he’s going to the Father.” (GW)

Some of his disciples asked among themselves, “What does this mean? He tells us that in a little while we will not see him, and then a little while later we will see him; and he also says, ‘It is because I am going to the Father.’ ” (GNT)

John 16:18

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus’ leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus’ name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:16–18

In this paragraph, Jesus warned his disciples that in a little while they would no longer see him. After that, they would see him again. The disciples asked one another what he meant.

16:18a

They kept asking, “Why is He saying, ‘a little while’?”

- They asked each other, “What did he mean when he said ‘after a little while?’
- And they also wondered what he meant by saying “soon.”

They kept asking: These words indicate that some of the disciples asked other disciples. The form of the verb in Greek indicates that they did this many times. They were still speaking to one another, not to Jesus directly. Because the disciples continued to ask questions among themselves, it may be natural to leave these words implied (see GNT).

Why is He saying, ‘a little while’?: This question indicates that Jesus’ phrase ‘a little while’ especially confused the disciples. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What is this ‘little while’ that he is talking about? (CEV)

What does this ‘a little while’ mean? (GNT)

What does he mean by ‘a little while’? (NCV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate the direct quotation of Jesus’ words as an indirect quotation. For example:

What is meant by just a little time? (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

He says that it will be just a little while. What does that mean?

16:18b

We do not understand what He is saying.”

- We cannot understand what he meant.”

- They did not understand what he was talking about.

We do not understand what He is saying: The disciples could not understand what Jesus meant. They did not understand that the Messiah would die, rise again, and go to heaven. Your translation should make clear that the disciples understood Jesus' words but did not know what events they referred to. For example:

We do not know what he means. (REB)

We do not understand what he is talking about. (NET)

John 16:19

Section 16:16–24 The disciples' sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus' leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus' name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:19–22

Jesus answered his disciples that the sorrow they had would become joy when they saw him again. He compared it to a woman's pain while she gives birth becoming joy when her baby is born.

16:19a

Aware that they wanted to question Him,

- ¶ Jesus knew that his disciples wanted to question him.
- ¶ Jesus knew that his disciples wanted to ask him what he meant.

Aware that they wanted to question Him: This clause indicates that Jesus understood that the disciples wanted to ask him about what he meant. They wanted to know the meaning of what he had said in

16:16 and 16:10. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus realized that they wanted to ask him about it (NLT)

Jesus knew that they had some questions (CEV)

16:19b–d

Jesus said to them, “Are you asking one another why I said, ‘In a little while you will not see Me, and then after a little while you will see Me’?: This is a rhetorical question which expects a “yes” answer. The disciples apparently did not want to ask their questions, but Jesus wanted to talk about them. He realized that his disciples still did not understand that he would die and then rise from the dead. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

so he said to them, “I said, ‘In a little while you will not see me, and then a little while later you will see me.’ Is this what you are asking about among yourselves?” (GNT)

- Use a statement. For example:

so he said, “You are asking one another what I meant by saying, “In a short time you will no longer see me, and then a short time later you will see me again. (NJB)

so he said: You are wondering what I meant when I said that for a little while you won't see me, but after a while you will see me. (CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for introducing a topic.

16:19b

Jesus said to them, “Are you asking one another why

- And he said to them, “Are you wondering what I meant
- So he said, “You are wondering what I meant

The Greek begins with a conjunction that is often translated as “and.” Here it introduces a result, which is why most English translations translate the conjunction as “so.” Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

therefore

and

that is why

Jesus said to them: Jesus spoke to the disciples. He used a question, so in some languages it may be natural to use the word “ask.” For example:

Jesus asked his disciples

Are you asking one another why: Jesus asked his disciples to confirm what they were talking about. He knew that they had been wondering what he meant, and he asked them to confirm that. The expected answer is “yes.” In some languages there may be a specific way to ask a question that expects the answer “yes.” For example:

You are discussing what I meant, aren’t you?

16:19c

I said, ‘In a little while you will not see Me,

- when I said, ‘After a little while you^(plur) will not be able to see me,’
- by saying that soon I will not be with you^(plur);

16:19d

and then after a little while you will see Me?’

- and ‘Then after a little while longer and you^(plur) will see me again?’
- and then soon after that I will be back again with you^(plur).

16:19c–d

I said, ‘In a little while you will not see Me, and then after a little while you will see Me’: Jesus was quoting something he himself had said earlier. Translate his words as you did in 16:16. Here there is a quotation inside another quotation. In some languages it may be natural to use an indirect quotation for the inner quotation. For example:

I said that in a little while you will no longer see me, and in a little while more you will see me

John 16:20

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again.

The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus’ leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus’ name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:19–22

Jesus answered his disciples that the sorrow they had would become joy when they saw him again. He compared it to a woman’s pain while she gives birth becoming joy when her baby is born.

16:20a

Truly, truly, I tell you, you will weep and wail

- I tell you^(plur) the truth, you^(plur) will soon cry and grieve,
- Listen^(plur) carefully. You^(plur) will wail and be sad,

Truly, truly, I tell you: This clause introduces a statement that Jesus wants to emphasize but is also surprising. See how you translated this elsewhere, for example in 3:3 and 10:7.

you will weep and wail: The verbs weep and wail have similar meanings. Both describe the wailing and crying that people regularly did for a dead person. The repeated verbs emphasize what Jesus said: Jesus’ disciples would be very sad. Some languages have other ways to emphasize a word. For example:

you will be very sad

you will have intense grief

grief will overcome you and you will wail

Jesus was referring to his death. In some translations it is more natural to indicate this. For example:

you will weep and mourn because of what will happen to me

you: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun to contrast it with “the world,” which the Greek also emphasizes. The pronoun is plural and refers to Jesus’ disciples.

weep: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as weep means to cry openly, to wail aloud. For example:

cry (CEV)

wail: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as wail means to express grief over someone’s death. It implies a mourning ritual. Here are other ways to translate this verb:

mourn (NRSV)

have grief

be sad (CEV)

16:20b

while the world rejoices.

- but/and the unbelievers of the world will celebrate.
- while the people of the world will be very happy about what has happened to me.

while the world rejoices: In contrast to the grief of Jesus’ disciples, unbelievers would experience joy at what would happen.

the world: The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast it with “you” in 16:20a. The word world here, as often in John, refers to the people in the world who do not believe in Christ. For example:

unbelievers

my enemies

rejoices: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as rejoices means “to celebrate” or “to be very happy.” Here are other ways to translate this verb:

will be happy (CEV)

will be glad (REB)

16:20c

You will grieve, but your grief will turn to joy.

- You will feel pain, but then your^(plur) pain will stop and become joy.
- You will suffer, but then your^(plur) suffering will become rejoicing.
- You will be distressed. But your grief will change and instead you will have joy.

Verses 21–22 will compare the distress of Jesus’ disciples after his death seen in 16:20c to the distress of a woman in labor. The situations are different in some ways, but it is important to find an expression that can describe both situations. You will want to use that expression here in 16:20c to make the comparison easier to understand.

You will grieve: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as You will grieve is literally “you will be sad/sorrowful/distressed.” Here it refers to the emotional pain of losing a loved one who dies. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will feel distress

you will suffer

you will know/experience suffering

You: The Greek text again emphasizes this pronoun, which is plural and refers to Jesus’ disciples.

but: In the Greek, the word that the BSB has translated as but indicates a strong contrast. Here the contrast is between the disciples’ pain and that pain turning to joy. The word but also indicates something unexpected. First they would have pain, but then something unexpected would happen: their pain would become joy, the opposite of pain.

your grief will turn to joy: This clause indicates that Jesus’ disciples would first suffer and then their suffering would become joy. (The verb phrase will turn to means “will become.”) The Greek text emphasizes the phrase your grief, which refers to the sorrow Jesus’ disciples would feel when he died. The word joy refers to what they would feel when he rose from the dead. For example:

your grief will suddenly turn to wonderful joy (NLT)

your sadness will become joy (NCV)

your grief...joy: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as your grief refers to the disciples’ grief

when Jesus would die. The word joy refers to the happiness and delight the disciples would feel when he rose from the dead. In some languages it may be natural to translate these emotions as adjectives. For example:

You will be sad, but later you will be happy. (CEV)

General Comment on 16:20c

Some languages may not have one word that they can use for both emotional pain and physical pain. In those languages it may be helpful to use different words for “pain” in 16:20c. This may help connect the disciples’ emotional pain and a woman’s physical pain when giving birth. Jesus compares the two kinds of pain in the next verse. Here is one way to do that:

You will be intensely distressed, but that emotional pain will turn into joy.

John 16:21

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus’ leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus’ name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:19–22

Jesus answered his disciples that the sorrow they had would become joy when they saw him again. He compared it to a woman’s pain while she gives birth becoming joy when her baby is born.

16:21

A woman has pain in childbirth because her time has come; but when she brings forth her child, she forgets her anguish because of her joy that a child has been born into the world: This is the first half of

a comparison. It can also be considered an illustration, an extended simile, or a short parable. Jesus compared the disciples’ suffering when he died to a woman’s suffering when she gives birth. And he compared the disciples’ joy when they saw Jesus alive again to a woman’s joy when her baby is born.

It may be natural to indicate here that Jesus is beginning an illustration or comparison. For example:

It is like this: when a woman is in labor...

Suppose/Imagine that there is a woman in labor...

You know that when a woman is in labor...

It will be like a woman suffering the pains of labor... (NLT)

16:21a

A woman has pain in childbirth

- When a woman gives birth to a baby, she suffers great pains
- It is like a woman when she gives birth to a baby. She suffers much

A woman has pain in childbirth: The phrase in childbirth refers to the process of giving birth to a baby. Use a phrase that is natural and suitable for public reading. For example:

When a woman gives birth to a baby (NCV)

Like a woman whose suffering is extreme at the time when she has her baby

In some languages it may be better to use a dependent clause here, emphasizing the time rather than the woman. For example:

When a woman is in labor, she has pain, because her hour has come. (NRSV)

has pain: The Greek word that the BSB translates as has pain can refer to feeling grief, anxiety, and distress as well as physical suffering. Try to use an expression that can include both ideas. For example:

suffers (NJB)

16:21b**because her time has come;**

- because her time has come to give birth.
- because now is her time of pain when her baby is born.

because her time has come: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as her time has come refers to the time for the woman to give birth. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because her hour of suffering has come (GNT)

because now it is time for her to give birth

General Comment on 16:21a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in these clauses. For example:

^{21a–b}A woman has pain when her time to give birth comes (GW)

^{21a–b}It will be like a woman suffering the pains of labor. (NLT)

16:21c**but when she brings forth her child, she forgets her anguish**

- But when the baby is born, she does not think about that suffering anymore,
- But after she has her baby, she forgets about the pain

but when she brings forth her child: This clause refers to the time after the baby has been born. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

But then her baby is born and

she forgets her anguish: This clause means “the mother no longer thinks about the pain of giving birth.” After the birth of her child, the mother no longer thinks so much about the suffering she endured. It is not important to her anymore. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive statement. For example:

she forgets the pain (NCV)

she forgets her suffering (GNT)

she no longer thinks about the distress

her anguish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as anguish means “trouble, distress, difficult circumstances.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the suffering (NJB)

the pain (CEV)

her suffering

In some languages it may be natural to translate this using a verb phrase. For example:

how greatly she suffered

how much she endured

the pain that she suffered

16:21d**because of her joy that a child has been born into the world.**

- because she is happy that a baby has been born into the world. (GNT)
- because she has so much joy that her baby has been born.

because of her joy that a child has been born into the world: This expression gives the reason why the mother forgets her pain. She forgets her pain because the new baby has given her joy. The Greek expression is more literally “because of the joy that a person was born into the world.” Here are other ways to translate this expression:

because she is made happy by the baby that was born into the world

because her new baby makes her very happy

her joy that a child has been born into the world: The woman is happy that her baby was born. In some languages it may be natural to make it clear that the joy is the woman’s happiness. It may also be natural to translate joy as an adjective describing the woman. For example:

because of her joy that a human being has been born into the world (NET)

she is happy that a baby has been born into the world (GNT)

a child has been born into the world: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as a child has been born into the world refers to the birth of the baby. In some languages it may be natural to use a different expression. Either the baby or the mother may be the subject. For example:

having brought a human being into the world (NRSV)

she has given birth to a new baby

a child: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a child means “person, man.” In some languages it is more natural in this context to translate it a different way. For example:

a human being (NRSV)

a new baby (NLT)

her baby

General Comment on 16:21c–d

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 16:21c–d. For example:

^{21c–d}After the birth, she is so happy that a new baby has been born into the world that she does not remember the pain that she suffered.

General Comment on 16:21

This verse uses an illustration of a woman giving birth. It does not refer to any particular woman but to women in general. So in some languages it may be natural to use plural forms. For example:

When women are in labor, they suffer....

John 16:22

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again.

The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus’ leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus’ name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:19–22

Jesus answered his disciples that the sorrow they had would become joy when they saw him again. He compared it to a woman’s pain while she gives birth becoming joy when her baby is born.

16:22a

So also you have sorrow now,

- That is what it will be like for you^(plur). Now you suffer,
- In the same way, you^(plur) are now in distress,

So also you have sorrow now: After the illustration about a woman giving birth in 16:21, this verse explains the point of the illustration. The disciples also have pain, but like the pregnant woman, they will also rejoice later. This clause begins to compare the illustration of the woman to the disciples. Begin the comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So with you: Now is your time of grief (NIV)

So it is with you: you are sad now (NJB)

It is the same with you. Now you are sad (NCV)

you have sorrow: This phrase refers to the emotional pain that the disciples felt knowing that Jesus would soon leave them. For example:

You are now very sad. (CEV)

you too have grief now (NASB)

you: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. That emphasizes the change in subject from the woman giving birth to the disciples. If your language indicates a change in subject, you will want to indicate it here. For example:

That is how it is with you: now you are sad (GNT)

It is the same with you because now you are sad.

16:22b

but I will see you again and your hearts will rejoice,

- but I will see you^(plur) again, and then you will have joy.
- but when we^(incl) see each other again, you will be joyful.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast between the situation then and the future situation. The disciples were sad then knowing that Jesus would leave, but soon they would see him again and be happy.

I will see you again: This clause refers to the time when Jesus would rise from the dead. He would see the disciples, and they would see him, and this would make them happy. It is only implied that the disciples would see Jesus. In some languages it is more natural to make that information more explicit. For example:

we will see each other again

and your hearts will rejoice: This clause indicates that the disciples would feel great joy. It is implied that they would be joyful after Jesus' resurrection. Some English translations leave this information implied, while others make it more explicit. For example:

I will see you again and your hearts will be filled with gladness. (GNT)

I will see you again. Then you will be happy (GW)

You^(plur) will rejoice because I will see you again

16:22c

and no one will take away your joy.

- No one will be able to stop your^(plur) rejoicing.
- And no one can destroy that joy/gladness.
- And no one will make you sad.

and no one will take away your joy: This clause indicates that no one will be able to stop the disciples from rejoicing. There is a textual issue here: (1) Some Greek manuscripts have a future tense verb, will take. For example: no one will take your joy from you (RSV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, NIV, CEV, GW, NET, REB, NCV, NJB) (2) Some Greek manuscripts have a present tense verb, "takes." For example: the kind of gladness that no one can take away from you (GNT) (KJV, NLT, GNT) It is recommended that you use the tense that is most natural in your language in this context. No one will be able to prevent them from being joyful once they see Jesus again. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

no one can rob you of that joy (NLT)

and that joy no one shall take from you (NJB)

no one will be able to stop you being glad

John 16:23

Section 16:16–24 The disciples' sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained, comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus' leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus' name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:23–24

Jesus encouraged his disciples to come freely to God and ask him in Jesus' name for whatever they needed.

16:23a

In that day you will no longer ask Me anything.

- ¶ Then you^(plur) will not have to ask me anything.
- ¶ When that happens, you^(plur) will not need to ask me about anything.

In that day: This phrase refers to the time after the resurrection in general. It does not refer to one specific day, but to that whole time period. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

When that day comes (NJB)

At that time (NLT)

When that time comes (CEV)

you will no longer ask Me anything: In this context there are two ways to interpret the Greek word that the BSB translates as ask:

1. It means ask a question. The disciples will not question Jesus. For example:

you won't ask me any more questions (GW) (NIV, REB, NASB, KJV, NET, GW, CEV, NJB)

1. It means make a request. The disciples will ask the Father, not Jesus, and the Father will give them whatever they request in prayer. For example:

you will not ask me for anything (GNT) (GNT, NLT, NCV)

The BSB and RSV are ambiguous and can be understood both ways. It is good to translate this word with an expression that can include both these ideas. Both fit the context. If that is not possible, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The Greek text uses a different word for ask here than the one translated “ask” in 16:23c.

16:23b

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I tell you the truth:
- Listen^(plur) carefully:

Truly, truly, I tell you: This clause introduces a statement that Jesus wants to emphasize. See the note at John 3:3a and how you translated this clause there.

16:23c

whatever you ask the Father in My name, He will give you.

- my Father, God, will give you^(plur) everything you pray for with my authority.
- whatever you^(plur) ask God for because you are united to me, he will give you.

whatever you ask the Father in My name, He will give you: There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek texts include the phrase in My name after ask, meaning ask in my name. For example:

If you ask the Father for anything in my name, he will give it to you. (GW) (BSB, NRSV, GNT, ESV, REB, KJV, NASB, NET, GW, CEV, NCV, NIV)

1. Other Greek texts place the phrase in My name after give, meaning give in my name. For example:

if you ask anything of the Father, he will give it to you in my name (RSV) (RSV, NJB, NLT)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) as most English translations do. Better manuscripts follow that word order. Also, the phrase in My name is usually connected to prayer, not to giving what someone asks for.

ask: This verb here means “request in prayer” or “ask for something.”

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it may be necessary to use a personal pronoun. For example:

my Father

in My name: This phrase here means “as someone united to me” or “according to my will.” It does not refer to saying the phrase “in Jesus name” at the end of a prayer. See the note at 14:13a and how you translated this phrase there.

He will give you: This clause indicates that God will answer the disciples’ prayers and give them what they ask for.

General Comment on 16:23c

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in these clauses:

The Father will give you whatever you ask of him in my name. (GNT)

John 16:24

Section 16:16–24 The disciples’ sadness would become joy

Jesus told his disciples that soon they would not see him, but then a little later they would see him again. The disciples did not understand, so Jesus explained,

comparing what would happen to a woman giving birth. She has much pain while giving birth, but the pain becomes joy after her baby is born. Soon the pain of Jesus' leaving would become joy. At that time they would be able to ask God the Father their requests in Jesus' name. God would give their requests and their joy would be complete.

Here are some other possible section headings:

The disciples will be sad for a short while, but then joyful

The disciples would not see Jesus for a while, but then would see him again

Paragraph 16:23–24

Jesus encouraged his disciples to come freely to God and ask him in Jesus' name for whatever they needed.

16:24a

Until now you have not asked for anything in My name.

- You^(plur) have never prayed to God for anything yet with my authority,
- You^(plur) have not been asking God for anything in this way.

Until now you have not asked for anything in My name: This sentence indicates that until that time the disciples had not asked God for things in Jesus' name. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

So far you have asked nothing in my name. (REB)

You haven't done this before. (NLT)

You have not asked for anything in this way before. (CEV)

Until now: This phrase means "in the past." For example:

before (CEV)

So far (REB)

you have not asked for anything in My name: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the disciples. The phrase asked for is short for "asked God for" and means "prayed to God for."

in My name: See how you translated this phrase in 16:23.

16:24b

Ask and you will receive,

- but now, pray to God for what you^(plur) need, and he will give it to you.
- But now God will give you^(plur) whatever you ask him for.

Ask and you will receive: This clause encourages the disciples to pray to God, asking him for what they need. It assures them that God would answer their prayers.

Ask: This verb is short for "Ask God for" and refers to praying to God regularly and repeatedly.

and you will receive: This clause is short for "you will receive from God what you asked for." In some languages it is more natural to say what the disciples will receive:

and you will receive it (NET)

Then it will be given to you. (CEV)

God will give you what you asked for

16:24c

so that your joy may be complete.

- Then you^(plur) will be full of joy/gladness.
- That will make you^(plur) completely happy.

so that your joy may be complete: This clause indicates the purpose of the disciples' asking and receiving. It means "so that you may be completely happy." The disciples would be joyful when they saw God's love and concern for them in fulfilling their needs and requests. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that you will be completely happy (CEV)

so that your joy will be the fullest possible joy (NCV)

so that you will be as joyful as possible

John 16:25

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their

belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:25–28

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his return to his Father in heaven.

16:25a

I have spoken these things to you in figures of speech.

- ¶ “These things I told you^(plur) using figurative language, making comparisons.
- ¶ “I have used figures of speech that may be difficult to understand to tell you^(plur) these things.

I have spoken these things to you in figures of speech: This clause indicates that Jesus had been talking to his disciples using figurative language. He had not used plain or direct language. He had taught using examples, illustrations, and parables. For example, he used the illustration of the woman in labor (16:21), and the illustration of the vine and the branches (15:1–6). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

These things I have spoken to you in figurative language (NASB)

I have been speaking figuratively (NIV)

I have used examples to explain to you what I have been talking about. (CEV)

these things: This phrase refers in a general way to what Jesus had told the disciples before. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase, probably to indicate a change in the subject.

in figures of speech: The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast it with “plainly” in 16:25c. The Greek

word the BSB has translated as figures of speech refers to nonliteral forms of speech. That is language that illustrates and compares, such as parables and illustrations. These forms of speech may be hard to understand, and Jesus’ listeners had to think about them before understanding them. See how you translated this word in 10:6. For example:

in parables

indirectly in stories (NCV)

by using illustrations

16:25b

An hour is coming when I will no longer speak to you this way,

- Soon, I will no longer talk to you^(plur) using such/figurative language.
- In the future, I will stop using speech like that when I speak to you^(plur).

An hour is coming: This clause means “in the future” and it refers to the time after Jesus’ resurrection. It includes the time after the Holy Spirit would come. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

a time is coming (NET)

the time will come (NCV)

Soon

when I will no longer speak to you this way: This clause means that Jesus will talk in a way that is literal and easier to understand. He will not use language that is figurative and difficult to understand. The Greek word that the BSB translates as this way is the same word that it translates as “figures of speech” in 16:25a. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase as it did the similar phrase in 16:25a. Translate this word in a way that makes the connection clear. For example:

when I will no longer speak to you in figures of speech (ESV)

when I will speak to you plainly about the Father and will no longer use examples like these (CEV)

when I will not use stories like that to tell you things (NCV)

when I will no longer use this kind of language (NIV)

16:25c

but will tell you plainly about the Father.

- Instead, I will tell you^(plur) clearly about God, my Father.
- No, I will teach you^(plur) about my Father in plain words.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (16:25b) to a positive statement (16:25c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

a time is coming when I shall no longer use figures, but tell you of the Father in plain words (REB)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

The time is coming when I won't use examples to speak to you. Rather, I will speak to you about the Father in plain words. (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

the time will come when I will not use stories like that to tell you things; I will speak to you in plain words about the Father (NCV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

the time will come when I will speak to you plainly about the Father and will no longer use examples like these (CEV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

will tell you plainly about the Father: This clause means "I will use language that is easy to understand to tell you about my Father." The Greek text emphasizes the word plainly to contrast it with "in figures

(of speech)" in the previous clauses. Avoid implying that earlier Jesus did not speak clearly but whispered or mumbled so the disciples could not understand what words he said. His language was difficult to understand but the sounds were perfectly clear. Now he would avoid difficult language and speak in a plain or literal way. For example:

tell you about the Father in plain words (NJB)

will tell you about my Father in a way that you can understand

John 16:26

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:25–28

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his return to his Father in heaven.

16:26a

In that day you will ask in My name.

- At that time, you^(plur) will begin praying to God as ones who belong to me.
- Then you^(plur) will begin to pray to my Father based on your faith in me.

In that day: This phrase means "When that time comes." See how you translated this phrase in 16:23. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

When that day comes (GNT)

Then (NLT)

At that time (NET)

you will ask in My name: This clause means “you will pray to God making requests as someone united to me.” The disciples would approach God on the basis of their faith in Jesus and as his disciples. See the notes on similar clauses in 16:23–24 and 14:13–14. Also see how you translated those clauses. In some languages you may want to make it explicit who they would ask. For example:

you will ask the Father for things in my name
(NCV)

because of your faith in me, you will be the ones to tell what you request from my Father (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

16:26b

I am not saying that I will ask the Father on your behalf.

- I am not saying to you^(plur) that I will ask my Father for you.
- I will not need to make requests to God for your^(plur) benefit

I am not saying that I will ask the Father on your behalf: This sentence means “I will not need to be a go-between between you and God,” or “I do not need to promise that I will speak to God for you.” The idea is that they can ask God themselves. They do not need Jesus to ask on their behalf (“for them” or “as their representative”). The Greek text emphasizes the word I in the phrase I will ask. That emphasizes that Jesus will not need to pray for them if they pray in his name. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

When you need something you will not have to ask me to ask God for it.

I will not need to ask the Father for you (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural and clear to start with a positive statement. For example:

I’m telling you that I won’t have to ask the Father for you. (GW)

John 16:27

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:25–28

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his return to his Father in heaven.

16:27a

For the Father Himself loves you,

- I do not need to ask because the Father loves you^(plur) himself
- because God the Father himself loves you^(plur) and will give you what you ask for.

For the Father Himself loves you: This clause gives the reason that Christ would not need to ask God for the disciples. God loved them and so they could speak directly to him. The Greek text emphasizes the words the Father Himself, emphasizing that God the Father personally loves the disciples. Emphasize these words in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

for the Father loves you himself (REB)

because the Father, yes, God the Father, loves you dearly

the Father Himself: In some languages it is more natural to tell whose Father Jesus referred to. For example:

my Father himself

loves: This verb here refers to committing oneself to someone else’s welfare. God has chosen to always act

to benefit and bless his people. He will answer their prayers.

16:27b

because you have loved Me

- because you^(plur) love me
- He will give you^(plur) what you ask for because you have continued to love me,

because you have loved Me: This clause gives the reason that God loved Jesus' disciples: they loved Jesus. The Greek text emphasizes the pronouns you and Me. Because this is a long sentence, you may want to start a new sentence here. For example:

for the Father himself loves you. He loves you because you love me.... (GNT)

you have loved Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as loved is the same as in 16:27a. The disciples had committed themselves to following and serving Jesus. They were loyal to him. There are some differences in the way that God loves his people and his people love Jesus. However, it is important to use the same or a similar/related expression so that your readers can see the connection.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the disciples.

have loved: The form of this verb in Greek indicates that the disciples continued to love Jesus. They did not just love him in the past. Use a verb tense that can refer to an action that began in the past and continues in the present.

16:27c

and have believed that I came from God.

- and believe that I came to earth as God's representative.
- and you^(plur) believe that I am truly God's messenger.

and have believed that I came from God: This expression gives the second reason God loved Jesus' disciples. God loved them because they believed that Jesus was sent by God into the world.

have believed: The form of this Greek verb again refers to action that began in the past and continues in the present.

I came from God: This clause implies that God sent Jesus to earth as his representative. The Greek text emphasizes the word I. There is a textual issue here:

1. Some Greek manuscripts have from God. For example:

I came from God (GNT) (BSB, NIV, ESV, KJV, NRSV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, REB, NCV, NJB)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have "from the Father." For example:

I came from the Father (RSV) (NASB, RSV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1), along with most English translations and the UBS Greek New Testament. The UBS Greek NT gives the reading "God" a C rating, indicating much doubt. However, there is much doubt about the original text, and God and "the Father" are both ways to refer to God. So you may want to follow a major-language translation here.

John 16:28

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:25–28

Jesus continued to prepare his disciples for his return to his Father in heaven.

16:28a

I came from the Father and entered the world.

- Yes, I came to this earth from God the Father,
- God my Father sent me to the earth as his messenger,

I came from the Father and entered the world:

This sentence indicates that Christ came from heaven, where he was with God his Father, to live on earth. See 1:9, 3:17, 31, 7:28–29. In some languages, it may be more natural to not repeat the verb. For example:

I came from the Father into the world. (NCV)

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it might be more natural to indicate whose father it is. For example:

my Father

16:28b

In turn, I will leave the world and go to the Father.”

- and now I am leaving this world and returning to my Father.”
- and now I am leaving to return to him in heaven.”

In turn, I will leave the world and go to the Father:

This expression indicates that Christ would soon leave the earth and return to God the Father. See 14:2–5, 12, 19, and 16:5, 7, and 10.

In turn: This word here introduces the next event in a series. Here it probably indicates that Jesus was going back to where he came from. It does not indicate that an event would be repeated. Here is another way to translate this word:

and now (GNT)

go to the Father: The verb go in this context means “returning.”

the Father: This phrase refers to God the Father. In some languages it might be more natural to indicate whose father it is. For example:

my Father

John 16:29

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:29–30

Jesus’ disciples told him that now they understood and believed him.

16:29

His disciples said, “See, now You are speaking plainly and without figures of speech.”

- ¶ Then Jesus’ disciples said to him, “Now you^(sing) are speaking plainly without figurative language.
- ¶ Then Jesus’ disciples replied, “At last we can understand what you are saying—no more idioms.

His disciples said: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to learners who were in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners committed themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. Translate this as you did in 16:16 and other verses.

See, now You are speaking plainly and without figures of speech: This sentence indicates that the disciples agreed that Jesus was now talking plainly. He used language that they could understand. Refer to your translation of 16:25 and translate this sentence in a way that makes the connection clear. For example:

You are speaking clearly to us now and are not using stories that are hard to understand (NCV)

Now you are speaking plainly to us! You are not using examples. (CEV)

See, now: The Greek text emphasizes the word that the BSB has translated as now. Jesus had said that the hour was coming when he would speak plainly. The disciples said that he was speaking plainly now. Also, the Greek word that the BSB has translated literally as See emphasizes what follows. Here are other ways to indicate this emphasis:

Look, now (NET)

Yes, now (NRSV)

At last (NLT)

You are speaking plainly: The disciples thought that now they understood what Jesus meant. Avoid implying that Jesus had previously been speaking unclearly so that it was hard to hear what words he used. For example:

now you're talking in plain words (GW)

without figures of speech: The Greek word that the BSB translates as figures of speech refers to language that illustrates and compares and is not literal. In some contexts it is translated as “parable” or “metaphor.” It is the same word that Jesus used in the plural form in 16:25. Many of Jesus’ disciples had found his parables hard to understand. The implicit information here is that now they think they can easily understand what he is saying. Use the same or a similar expression to what you used in 16:25. For example:

and not figuratively (NLT)

and not using figurative speech! (ESV)

not using stories that are hard to understand (NCV)

You are not using examples. (CEV)

John 16:30

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:29–30

Jesus’ disciples told him that now they understood and believed him.

16:30a

Now we understand that You know all things

- Now we^(excl) know that you^(sing) know everything.
- We can see now that you know all things. (NCV)

Now: The Greek text again emphasizes the word Now. Here again it implies that the situation was different earlier. Previously the disciples had not realized that Jesus knew all things.

we understand that You know all things: This clause here implies that the disciples now knew that they could trust the things that Jesus said. They realized that he had full knowledge of everything that he talked about. The context indicates that they were particularly thinking about the way that Jesus showed that he knew their thoughts. See 16:19. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We are certain now that you know everything. (REB)

We can see now that you know all things. (NCV)

we: This pronoun is exclusive here because it refers to the disciples but not to Jesus.

16:30b

and that You have no need for anyone to question You.

- It is not necessary for anyone to ask you^(sing) questions for you to know their thoughts.
- You can answer a person’s question even before it is asked. (NCV)

and that You have no need for anyone to question

You: This clause probably indicates that people did not need to question Jesus before he knew what they were thinking. Jesus already knew their inner thoughts and questions, as he showed in 16:19. For example:

You can answer a person’s question even before it is asked. (NCV)

Even the questions that are in a person’s mind, they don’t need to be told to you, because you already know. (Kankanaey Back Translation)

16:30c

Because of this, we believe that You came from God.”

- Because you^(sing) know what anyone is thinking, we^(excl) believe that you are God’s representative.”
- That makes us^(excl) believe that God sent you^(sing).”

Because of this, we believe: This expression means “this is the reason that we believe.” The pronoun

this refers to Jesus knowing their thoughts. In some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

this is why we believe (ESV)

by this we believe (NRSV)

Therefore we believe

This makes us believe (GNT)

that You came from God: This clause tells what the disciples believed. The disciples now were sure that Jesus was God's messenger to them. This implies that he spoke with God's authority and they could trust him.

John 16:31

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:31–33

Jesus warned his disciples that they would soon face hard times. But he would give them inner peace.

16:31

“Do you finally believe?” Jesus replied.

- ¶ Jesus answered them, “Do you^(plur) really believe in me now?
- ¶ Jesus said to them, “So you^(plur) think that you really believe in me now.

Do you finally believe?: This rhetorical question expresses doubt that Jesus' disciples had a strong belief in him. It does not doubt that their faith was real, just

whether it was strong enough. Jesus knew that when he was arrested, most of them would abandon or deny him. There are several ways to express this doubt. For example:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

So now you believe? (NCV)

Do you now believe? (NRSV)

- Use a statement indicating doubt. For example:

You think you believe now.

- Use a statement followed by a tag that shows doubt. For example:

You believe now, do you?

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for expressing doubt.

John 16:32

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:31–33

Jesus warned his disciples that they would soon face hard times. But he would give them inner peace.

16:32a

“Look, an hour is coming and has already come

- Look! Very soon it will happen that
- Well listen, in just a very little while

Look: The Greek text begins with a word that means “pay attention” or “here is something important.” While the BSB translates this literally as Look, most translations do not translate that word here, but leave it implicit. It may be natural to translate this word with an expression emphasizing what someone would say next. For example:

Listen (NJB)

Listen to me (NCV)

Another way to translate this word is with a word indicating contrast. Yes, the disciples may believe (16:31), but their faith will not be strong enough when Jesus is arrested (16:32). For example:

Jesus asked, “Do you finally believe? But the time is coming—indeed it’s here now—when you will be scattered, each one going his own way, leaving me alone.” (NLT)

an hour is coming and has already come: These clauses mean “very, very soon.” Here it refers to something that would happen in four or five hours, when Jesus would be arrested. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

The time will come and is already here (CEV)

a time is coming when you will be scattered, each to your own home. That time is now here. (NCV)

16:32b

when you will be scattered, each to his own home,

- you^(plur) will all run away to your own homes
- something will scatter you^(plur) and you will each go to where you are living.

when you will be scattered: This clause means “when all of you will go away in different directions.” It refers to the time when the disciples would run away from the soldiers arresting Jesus, leaving him alone. See how you translated the word “scatters” in 10:12 where a wolf scatters the sheep. Here, it is not explicit who or what would scatter the disciples. In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause without using a passive verb. For example:

when something will cause you to run away in different directions

when you will all run away

when: This word often indicates purpose or result. It may be more natural for you to translate it that way here. For example:

Behold, an hour is coming, and has already come, for you to be scattered (NASB)

each to his own home: This phrase here indicates that the disciples would run to places where they would be safe. Their actual homes were in Galilee but they were staying in Jerusalem. It is recommended that you translate this literally. The point is that the disciples would escape to safe places, leaving Jesus to face his enemies. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here:

Each of you will go back home (CEV)

16:32c

and you will leave Me all alone.

- and you^(plur) will abandon me.
- You^(plur) will all abandon me so that I will be alone.

you will leave Me all alone: This clause indicates that the disciples would all abandon Jesus. This was fulfilled when Jesus was arrested in the Garden of Gethsemane (Mark 14:50). In some languages it is more natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

You will leave me all alone. (NIV)

16:32d

Yet I am not alone, because the Father is with Me.

- But I will not be completely alone, because my Father is always with me.
- But because my my Father, God, will stay/remain with me, I will not really be alone.

Yet I am not alone: This clause indicates that even though the disciples would abandon him, Jesus would not be alone. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But I am not really alone. (GNT)

Actually, I am never alone.

However, I am not alone.

Yet: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Yet here introduces something that is the opposite of what one expects. When the disciples would abandon Jesus, one would expect Jesus to be alone. However, the opposite is true. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

But (CEV)

I am not alone: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as I am not alone tells a general truth. Jesus was never alone, even when all other people abandoned him.

because the Father is with Me: This clause tells the reason that Jesus would not be alone. The reason is that God the Father is always with him. He would remain with Jesus even if all the disciples left him. In some languages it may be natural to use the personal pronoun “my” with Father here. For example:

because my Father is always with me (TH)

because my Father never leaves me

General Comment on 16:32d

In some languages it is more natural to put the clause “because the Father is with me” before “Yet I am not alone.” For example:

But the Father will be with me, and I won’t be alone. (CEV)

Actually my Father is always with me so I am never alone.

But because my Father never leaves me, I am never all alone.

John 16:33

Section 16:25–33 Jesus had defeated the world

Jesus explained to the disciples that he would return to his Father in heaven. The disciples declared their belief that Jesus was from God, but Jesus questioned the strength of their belief. He told them that they would scatter, but he would still have the Father with him. He told them these things so that they would have peace. He said that even though they would face persecution in the world, he had defeated the world (system).

Here are some other possible section headings:

Jesus promised the disciples peace when they would be persecuted

The disciples can have courage when others will persecute them

Paragraph 16:31–33

Jesus warned his disciples that they would soon face hard times. But he would give them inner peace.

16:33a

I have told you these things so that in Me you may have peace.

- I have told you^(plur) these things so that you may have peace through me.
- I have warned you^(plur) about all that will happen so that when it does happen you may have peaceful hearts/minds because you are united with me.

I have told you these things: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as these things refers to all that Jesus had said that night. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have told you this (CEV)

I have told you all this (NLT)

so that in Me you may have peace: This is a purpose clause. Jesus said what he did in order to give his disciples inner peace. They would have this peace as a result of their relationship with him. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase in Me to contrast with “in the world” in 16:33b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that my peace will be with you (GW)

so that you might have peace in your hearts because of me (CEV)

so that you will have peace by being united to me (GNT)

peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as peace here refers to spiritual and emotional welfare. That means unity with God and an absence of worry and fear, even in bad circumstances. See Peace KBT 3(c). See how you translated this word in 14:27.

16:33b

In the world you will have tribulation.

- Living in this world you^(plur) will receive mistreatment/abuse.
- As long as you^(plur) live in this world of unbelievers, they, will persecute/abuse you.

In the world: This phrase means “in this world full of evil and unbelief.” The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast with “in me” in 16:33a. Jesus gives peace, but the world gives persecution.

you will have tribulation: This clause means “people will persecute you” or “people will make you suffer.” For example:

you will have trouble (NIV)

you will have to suffer (CEV)

you have trouble and suffering (NET)

you will have many trials and sorrows (NLT)

The world will make you suffer. (GNT)

16:33c

But take courage; I have overcome the world!”

- But cheer^(plur) up! I have overcome the evil power/system of this world.”
- But do not worry^(plur). I have defeated the power of this world.”

But: This conjunction introduces what the disciples should do when unbelievers persecute them. The conjunction indicates that what follows is not expected. Instead of being afraid as you might expect someone to be when facing persecution, Jesus tells them to take courage.

take courage: The word the BSB has translated as take courage means “be cheerful.” It is a command. For example:

take heart (NLT)

cheer up! (CEV)

be brave! (NCV)

I have overcome the world!: This clause indicates the reason that the disciples could be cheerful and brave when they were persecuted. They could be cheerful and brave because Jesus had defeated this evil world

system. See 12:31. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have defeated the world! (GNT)

because I have overcome the world (NLT)

In some languages it may be necessary to indicate that this was not a military victory or a battle against the world’s people. It was a victory against the evil world system under the influence of Satan. For example:

I have destroyed the power of this world. (TH)

I have defeated the boss of my enemies. (Manobo Back Translation)

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. For example:

I myself have conquered the world!

General Comment on 16:33b–c

In some languages it may be difficult to just use the word “world” in both places in this verse. You may need to add some information to make the meaning clear. For example:

Here in this world you will be persecuted by the people who do not follow God. But do not be afraid. I have defeated their leader. (Yakan Back Translation)

It’s true that you will be persecuted in this world. But be brave because I have already defeated the evil that is in this world.

John 17:1

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However,

he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:1-5

In this paragraph Jesus asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth.

17:1a

When Jesus had spoken these things,

- ¶ After Jesus said those things,
- ¶ When he had finished speaking to his disciples,

When Jesus had spoken these things: This clause refers to all that Jesus said in chapters 14-16. Jesus finished talking to his disciples and then began to talk to God his Father. This clause acts as a conclusion to the previous section and a link to the following section, Jesus' prayer. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When Jesus had finished saying these things (NET)

After saying this (GW)

After Jesus had finished speaking to his disciples (CEV)

17:1b

He lifted up His eyes to heaven and said, "Father, the hour has come.

- he looked up toward heaven and prayed, "Father, the time has arrived.
- Jesus looked up and began to pray to God. He said, "My Father, now is the time.

He lifted up His eyes to heaven and said: This clause indicates that Jesus looked up toward God in heaven to pray. Jewish people usually looked up when they prayed. (See 11:41.)

heaven: This word refers to where God lives. People thought that heaven was physically "up," in or beyond the skies. See the notes on John 1:32, 51, 3:13, 6:32-33.

Father: This word indicates that Jesus was speaking to God the Father as a child would speak to his father. The word indicates affection as well as respect. Use whatever expression a person would use to speak to his father and show love and respect. See also 11:41 and verses 5, 11, 21, 24, and 25 in this chapter. In some languages it may be natural to include a possessive pronoun. For example:

My Father

the hour has come: This clause means "it is now the right time." This refers to the time that God set for Jesus' crucifixion, resurrection, and return to heaven. See how you translated this clause in 12:23 and 13:1b. For example:

the time has come (NET)

now is the time

the time that you have set/established has arrived

17:1c

Glorify Your Son,

- Give glory to your^(sing) Son
- Please honor^(sing) me, your Son,

Glorify Your Son: The word Glorify here means "cause to be honored." Here it refers to God causing Jesus to receive honor, the honor that he deserved. God would reveal Jesus' true greatness. Translate this clause in a way that does not make Jesus seem proud. His real motive is to glorify his Father, not to seek praise for himself. See KBT Glory, Glorious, Glorify C.3. See how you translated similar clauses in 13:31-32. For example:

Give glory to your Son (GNT)

bring glory to your Son (CEV)

Reveal the greatness of your Son

Glorify: This verb is a request to God. Use a form that you would use in prayer to ask God to do something.

Your Son: This phrase here refers to Jesus as the Son of God. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus,

his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the phrase “the Son of God” at 1:34. For further information, see the note on this phrase at 1:34.

Jesus was referring to himself in the third person. See the General Comment on 17:1–3.

General Comment on 17:1b–c

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit what hour/time had come by linking 17:1b–c. For example:

the time has come for you to bring glory to your Son (CEV)

17:1d

that Your Son may glorify You.

- in order that he may give glory to you^(sing)
- so that I, the/your Son, may honor you^(sing).

that Your Son may glorify You: This is a purpose clause. The Greek word that the BSB translates as that introduces the reason why God should glorify Jesus, his Son. In glorifying (honoring) his Son, God the Father will also receive honor. Translate the word glorify the same way that you did in 17:1c.

Your Son may glorify You: There is a textual issue here.

1. Some Greek manuscripts have “the Son” here. For example:

that the Son may give glory to you (GNT) (ESV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts have Your Son here. For example:

that your Son may glorify you (NJB) (BSB, NJB, KJV, NIV, GW, NET, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow option (1). The UBS Greek text gives this option a B rating, which means that there is only a little doubt. But both options refer to Jesus, the Son of God, who is speaking to his Father. See the General Comment on 17:1–3.

Your Son: Translate this phrase in a way that makes clear that it refers to the same person as “your Son” in 17:1c. See the note there. You may want to use a pronoun here. For example:

in order that he may bring glory to you (CEV)

John 17:2

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:1–5

In this paragraph Jesus asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth.

17:2a

For You granted Him authority over all people,

- because you^(sing) gave him the right to rule all humanity
- I will do that because you^(sing) have put me in charge of everyone

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here means “because” and introduces a reason. In this verse it introduces the reason why Jesus asked to be glorified in 17:1a. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Since (NRSV)

Because

You granted Him authority over all people: This clause indicates that God the Father had given Jesus the right to rule all people. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you gave him power over all people (CEV)

you have put him in charge over all humanity

you allowed me to rule over all people

You granted Him: The verb granted here indicates that in the past God gave Jesus this authority and Jesus continued to have it.

Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus, the Son. Because Jesus was speaking, in some languages it is more natural to use the pronoun “me.”

authority: This word refers to the right to exercise power, the right to rule others. It is the same Greek word that the BSB translates as “right” in 1:12c. See the note there and your translation of that verse.

all people: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as all people is more literally “all flesh.” That was a Hebrew way to say all people, especially because they are weak compared to God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

everyone (NLT)

all humanity (NET)

17:2b

so that He may give eternal life to all those You have given Him.

- so that he could give real unending life to all those you^(sing) gave him.
- so that I could cause everyone you entrust to me to live forever.

so that He may give eternal life to all those You have given Him: This clause indicates the purpose for God giving Jesus authority over all people. He gave him authority so that Jesus would give true, spiritual life to all those God had given Jesus. That spiritual life will last forever. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that he would give eternal life to everyone you give him (CEV)

so that the Son could give eternal life to all those you gave him (NCV)

so that I would give good/spiritual life forever to all the people that you gave me

He may give eternal life: This phrase means “to cause to live forever.” Eternal life refers to life that will never end, life with God that is forever. See how you translated eternal life in 3:15 and 3:16b, and see the notes there. For example:

to cause to live real life without end

to all those You have given Him: The clause all those You have given Him refers to all the people God chose, who would then believe in his Son. In some languages it may not be possible to say that God had given these people to Jesus. It might also wrongly imply that they were slaves. What God did was entrust (trust someone to take care of them) his people to Jesus to lead and protect them. For example:

to all those you have entrusted to him (NJB)

John 17:3

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:1–5

In this paragraph Jesus asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth.

17:3a

Now this is eternal life, that they may know You, the only true God,

- And this is what unending life is/means: knowing you^(sing). You are the only true God.
- To live forever is to know you^(sing). You are the one true God.

Now this is eternal life, that they may know You:

These clauses explain what the eternal life that Jesus will give is like and what it means. Having eternal life means knowing God. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

this is the meaning of eternal life—knowing you

this is what it means to have eternal life: they will know you

And eternal life means to know you (GNT)

Now this: The pronoun this here refers forward, to the idea of knowing God and Jesus Christ. And so knowing God and Jesus Christ is what eternal life really is. That is what eternal life is like—knowing and worshipping God and enjoying his presence forever.

eternal life: This phrase here is defined as a quality of life, not just as a life that does not end. See how you translated the phrase in 17:2. For example:

Really living is...

The really important thing about eternal life is...

good life forever

that they may know You: The phrase know You here means “have a close relationship with God.” This type of knowledge here implies love for God, and faith and trust in God.

the only true God: This phrase indicates that there is only one God. The many idols and other things that people believe are gods and worship are not truly gods at all. They do not have divine power and do not have the divine nature of the true God. In some languages it is more natural to translate this phrase with an additional clause or sentence. For example:

the only one who is really God (TH)

that they may know you. You are true and you are the only true God there is.

true: The Greek word that the BSB translates as true in this context means “real” or “genuine,” the opposite of “false.” See how you translated this word in 1 John 5:20 and 1 Thessalonians 1:9.

17:3b

and Jesus Christ, whom You have sent.

- And it is/means knowing me, Jesus Christ, the one you^(sing) sent into the world.
- And to live forever is to know me, Jesus the Messiah. I am the one you^(sing) chose to send into the world.

and Jesus Christ: This phrase here means that eternal life also includes knowing Jesus Christ. Because Jesus was speaking, in some languages it is more natural to include a first-person pronoun. See the General Comment on 17:1–3. For example:

and knowing me, Jesus Christ,

Jesus Christ: The word Christ is a title. The Jews used it to refer to the person whom God had appointed and promised to send as king and savior. But here the title Christ is used as one of Jesus’ names. See how you translated the phrase Jesus Christ in 1:17.

The title Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word “Messiah,” which means “the anointed one.” In Old Testament times, kings and priests were anointed with oil (oil was put on their head). That was done to show that God had chosen and appointed them as leaders.

Here are some ways to translate Christ:

- Use a title or a descriptive phrase in your language that has the same meaning as Christ. For example:

Messiah

Promised Deliverer

the Rescuer-King whom God appointed

- Transliterate Christ and include a phrase that explains the meaning. For example:

Christ, the appointed one

Cristo, the Savior whom God promised to send

the Christ who comes from God

- Transliterate Christ and indicate in some way that it is a title. For example:

the Christ

the Kirisita

If you do not indicate the meaning of Christ in the text, you may want to include a footnote to explain it. Or you may want to explain the meaning in a glossary. For example:

The word/title “Christ” refers to the king and savior whom God had promised to send. The word means “anointed,” which means to pour oil on someone to show that God chose him for a special purpose.

See also Christ Messiah, in KBT.

whom You have sent: This clause gives more information about Jesus Christ. In some languages it is more natural to make this clause a separate sentence. For example.

And you sent him/me into the world.

General Comment on 17:1–3

In these verses Jesus referred to himself in the third person, as “your Son,” “the Son,” “him,” and “Jesus Christ.” In some languages a literal translation may cause readers to think that Jesus was talking about someone else. In those languages it may be necessary to include first person pronouns. For example:

me, your Son

me

so that I might glorify you

John 17:4

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father

to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:1–5

In this paragraph Jesus asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth.

17:4a

I have glorified You on earth

- I gave you glory while I have been on the earth
- All the time that I have been on earth, I honored you^(sing)

I have glorified You on earth: This clause indicates that Jesus caused God to be honored by doing all that God wanted him to do. See how you translated glorified in 17:1c, d. For example:

I have brought you honour upon earth (JBP)

On earth I have given you glory (GW)

I have shown your glory on earth (GNT)

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun to contrast it with “you” (“you glorify me”) in 17:5a. (The word “you” is not included in English translations because English does not make “you” explicit in requests.)

17:4b

by accomplishing the work You gave Me to do.

- by completing the mission that you^(sing) wanted/told me to do.
- by doing everything that you^(sing) sent me to do.

by accomplishing the work You gave Me to do: This clause indicates the way that Jesus brought the Father

glory. The phrase the work You gave Me to do includes everything Jesus did on earth. It includes Jesus' death, which was still in the future at the time that Jesus was speaking. So in some languages it is more natural to use a form indicating that Jesus continued to complete this work. For example:

I am completing all the work you told me to do.

as I do/finish all that you sent me to do

the work You gave Me to do: This expression means "everything you told me to do" or "the things you wanted me to do." This includes Jesus' miracles, teaching, and death. For example:

everything you wanted me to do on earth

all that you sent me to do

John 17:5

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns "they" and "them" refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:1–5

In this paragraph Jesus asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth.

17:5a–b

Jesus asked God to restore to him the glory and honor that he always had before he became a man.

In eternity past, before the world began, he lived with God and shared God's glory. Now he prayed that he might return to his Father and enjoy again the glory of his Father. See the General Comment on 17:5a–b for suggestions on how to rearrange the information in this verse.

In the Greek text there are two forms of the word meaning "glory": "glorify me...with the glory I had." However, in some languages it is not natural or possible to say that someone "glorifies" someone "with glory." It may be possible to avoid this problem either by combining 17:5a–b, or by separating them into two clauses. For example:

Now, Father, bring me into the glory we shared before the world began. (NLT)

Now, Father, bring me back the glory that I had with you before the world was created. (CEV)

And, now, Father, give me glory with you; give me the glory I had with you before the world was made. (NCV)

17:5a

And now, Father, glorify Me in Your presence

- And now I ask you^(sing) to give me glory when I am with you in heaven,
- So, Dear Father, when I am back with you, please would you honor me

And now: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as And now. The phrase introduces Jesus repeating what he asked for in 17:1 with more emphasis. The word now here refers to the immediate future. At that time Jesus would glorify the Father by finishing the work the Father gave him (see 17:4). Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Now (NJB)

Father: This word is one that a child would use when speaking to his father. It indicates affection and respect. See the note and how you translated the word in 17:1.

glorify Me: In the Greek the clause that the BSB has translated as glorify Me makes the subject "you" (singular) explicit. This emphasizes the contrast with the subject "I" in 17:4a ("I glorified you"). Consider if in your language there is a polite way to emphasize the subject of a request. For example:

Would/Will you please now glorify me!

I pray that you would glorify me.

glorify: Here this verb refers to causing Christ to live in divine glory and majesty. Jesus had lived in humility and poverty as a man. Now he asked to be restored to his former status and the honor that he deserved. See KBT Glory, Glorious, Glorify C. 3. Here are other ways to translate this word:

give me glory (NCV)

honour me (JBP)

in Your presence: This phrase means “where you are.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

with you (NCV)

when I am with you

when I return to you

17:5b

with the glory I had with You before the world existed.

- in the same way when I was with you and had glory before the earth was created.
- as I was honored when I was with you^(sing) before the world began.

with the glory I had with You before the world existed: This expression tells about the glory that Jesus prayed for. He asked God to restore the glory that he had before the world began. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

give me the glory I had with you before the world was made (NCV)

bring me again the honor I shared with you before the creation of the world

as I was honored in your presence before the world began

I had with You: This clause means “that I always had/enjoyed when I was with you in heaven.” Jesus lived with God in heaven and shared his glory.

before the world existed: This clause means “before the earth was created.” This phrase refers to eternity past (going forever back in time), before God created the universe. Express this clause in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

before the earth was created (NET)

before there was a world at all

General Comment on 17:5a–b

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange parts of the sentence, putting the information in chronological order. For example:

^{5b}Father, before the earth was created/established, I was in your presence in glory. ^{5a}Now, as I return to you, please let me have/receive this glory again.

^{5b}Before the world existed, I was honored as I lived in your presence. ^{5a}Father, please give me again this honor.

John 17:6

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:6–8

In this paragraph Jesus asks his Father to protect his disciples from Satan’s attacks.

17:6a

I have revealed Your name to those You have given Me out of the world.

- ¶ “I have shown what you are like to the people whom you^(sing) brought out of the world and entrusted to me.
- ¶ “You^(sing) have caused people to leave the world system and follow me, and I have taught them who you are.

I have revealed Your name to those You have given Me out of the world:

Jesus continued to pray to God while his disciples were listening. He said that he had caused his disciples to know God’s name. That means that he had taught his disciples what God was like. This is one way that Jesus glorified the Father (see 17:4). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have made you known to those you gave me out of the world (GNT)

I have revealed you to the people from this world that you gave me

I showed what you are like to those you gave me from the world (NCV)

Your name: This phrase here refers to God’s character, God himself. See the note on name at 3:18c and see how you translated the idea there and in Psalm 29:2. The Greek text here emphasizes the word Your. See the examples just above for other ways to translate this phrase.

those You have given Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as those usually means “people” or “humans,” although in some contexts it can mean “men.” Here this clause seems to refer to the remaining 11 disciples, so some English translations translate the word as “men.” However, a few scholars think that the word could also refer to Jesus’ other followers. So it is better to translate the Greek word as “people” or a word like those if possible. “People” is closer to the meaning of the Greek word and could include women and children. However, the following verses indicate that Jesus here referred to the 11 disciples he had been talking to. So if you need to use the word “men,” you may do that. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the people whom you gave me (ESV)

You have given me some followers (CEV)

the ones you gave me (NLT)

the men you gave me (NET)

You have given Me: This clause is similar to one in 17:2b. There, however, the phrase refers to all believers, while here it probably refers to his remaining 11 disciples. See the note in 17:2b and how you translated the similar idea in that verse. For example:

whom you entrusted to me (Kankanaey Back Translation)

out of the world: This phrase indicates that Jesus’ disciples used to be part of the world (community) of unbelievers. At one time they also did not believe in Jesus. See also 15:19. For example:

from among the unbelievers in the world

from the people who do not believe in me

General Comment on 17:6a

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 17:6a, putting the events in chronological order and forming two clauses. For example:

You have given me some followers from this world, and I have shown them what you are like. (CEV)

17:6b

They were Yours;

- They already were your^(sing) people,
- Actually they belonged to you^(sing) first/before.

They were Yours: This clause indicates that these people belonged to God. Even before they followed Jesus, in some way they were God’s people. The Greek text emphasizes the word Yours. Here is another way to translate this clause:

They belonged to you (GNT)

17:6c

You gave them to Me,

- and then you^(sing) gave them to me to be mine.
- But you^(sing) entrusted them to me,

You gave them to Me: This clause refers to the same people referred to in 17:6a. See the note there and how you translated the same idea there. For example:

and you entrusted them to me (Kankanaey Back Translation)

17:6d

and they have kept Your word.

- They have done what you^(sing) told them to do.
- and they have obeyed you.

and they have kept Your word: The phrase kept Your word means “followed your teaching.” See how you translated a similar phrase in 8:51. Jesus had told the disciples who God was and what God wanted them to do. They listened to him, believed him, and obeyed him. The tense of the verb indicates that they continued to obey him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they have obeyed your word (NET)

They did what you told them. (GW)

they have obeyed you (CEV)

they have obeyed your teaching (NCV)

John 17:7

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:6–8

In this paragraph Jesus asks his Father to protect his disciples from Satan’s attacks.

17:7

Now they know that everything You have given Me comes from You.

- They now/finally realize that you are the source of everything I have.
- At last they recognize that all that I taught them was what you^(sing) told me.

Now: The Greek text emphasizes this word, which here refers to the time. It implies something like “at last” or “finally.”

they know that everything You have given Me comes from You: These clauses indicate that the

disciples had realized that what Jesus taught was actually God’s message to them. (See verse 8.) And the verb tense indicates that they continued to know this. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase from You. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

they know that everything I have is a gift from you (NLT)

they understand that all I taught them really came from you^(sing)

they have come-to-know that you^(sing) are the source of all I have done and said (Kankanaey Back Translation)

John 17:8

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:6–8

In this paragraph Jesus asks his Father to protect his disciples from Satan's attacks.

17:8a

For I have given them the words You gave Me,

- I say this because I taught them what you^(sing) told me,
- They recognize that because I told them what you^(sing) told me

For: The word that the BSB has translated as For here means “because.” It introduces the reason that the disciples knew that Jesus' message was from God. Here is another way to translate this word:

because (NET)

I have given them the words You gave Me: This clause indicates that Jesus taught the disciples the things that God the Father wanted him to teach them. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase the words You gave Me. For example:

I gave them the teachings you gave me (NCV)

every message that you gave me I have given them (JBP)

what I have given them are the teachings that you gave to me

it is the message that you told me that I told them

17:8b

and they have received them.

- and they accepted it.
- and they believed what I said.

and they have received them: This clause indicates that the disciples believed and obeyed what Jesus taught them. The Greek text emphasizes the word they, perhaps to contrast with others who did not believe. For example:

and they accepted them (NCV)

and they, unlike others, believed this message

17:8c

They knew with certainty that I came from You,

- Now they are sure that I came from you^(sing).
- They have come to realize that it is true that I am your^(sing) messenger.

They knew with certainty that I came from You:

This expression indicates that the disciples knew that Jesus had come from God. They understood correctly that what Jesus said about himself was true. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase from You. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

and they absolutely know that you are the one I came-from (Kankanaey Back Translation)

and they know that it is true that it is from you that I came

17:8d

and they believed that You sent Me.

- They also believe that you^(sing) sent me to this earth.
- And they believe that I am your^(sing) representative here on earth.

and they believed that You sent Me: This clause indicates that the disciples believed that God the Father had sent Jesus into the world. Jesus implied that their belief was correct. The Greek text emphasizes the words You and Me, especially You. It is significant that it was God the Father who sent Jesus. Here is another way to translate this clause:

and they believe that you are the one who sent me (Uma Back Translation)

General Comment on 17:8c–d

These two clauses mean nearly the same thing. They repeat the same idea for emphasis. Some languages have other ways of emphasizing and can combine these two statements. For example:

They knew for certain that I really came from you as your messenger.

John 17:9

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:9–12

Jesus asked God to protect his disciples from Satan.

17:9a

I ask on their behalf.

- ¶ I am praying for them.
- ¶ It is for my disciples that I am praying,

I ask on their behalf: This clause indicates that Jesus was praying to God for the benefit of his 11 disciples. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I am praying for them (ESV)

I pray for them (GW)

I am praying to you^(sing) to help them

on their behalf: This phrase means “for their benefit.” Jesus prayed for God to help and bless his 11 disciples with him. These disciples are the ones he has prayed for since verse 6. It may be natural to make explicit whom the possessive pronoun their refers to. It refers to those whom God had given Jesus, his disciples, who had believed his message (17:6a–8d). The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to contrast it with “on behalf of the world” in 17:9b, which the Greek also emphasizes. For example:

for these my disciples/followers

17:9b

I do not ask on behalf of the world,

- I am not praying for everyone on earth.
- not for the people who do not believe.

I do not ask on behalf of the world: At this point, Jesus was praying for his disciples, not unbelievers. The Greek text emphasizes the phrase on behalf of the world to contrast it with “on their behalf” in 17:9a. For example:

I am not praying for the world (REB)

I do not pray for the world (GNT)

Who I am praying-for, it is not those who don’t believe in me (Kankanaey Back Translation)

the world: This phrase here refers to people who love and belong to the world and not to Christ. See the notes on the world in 1:10, 8:23, and 15:18–19. For example:

those who belong to this world (CEV)

the people who do not believe in me (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

General Comment on 17:9a–b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 17:9a–b as one main clause with one verb. For example:

I am praying for them, but not for those who belong to this world (CEV)

I am not praying for the people of this evil world but for these my disciples.

17:9c

but on behalf of those You have given Me;

- I am praying for the people that you^(sing) gave me
- I am praying for those whom you^(sing) entrusted to me,

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (17:9b) to a positive statement (17:9c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have

different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

I am not praying for the world but for those whom you have given me (ESV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I am not asking for the benefit of unbelievers; rather, for the benefit of the ones you gave me.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I do not ask this favor for all the people who live on earth. Those whom you delivered over to me are those I ask you to care for (Otomi Back Translation)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

on behalf of those You have given Me: This expression repeats and emphasizes what Jesus said in 17:9a. See how you translated the similar expression there.

those You have given Me: This clause refers to Jesus' disciples, the same people referred to in 17:6a. See the note there and how you translated the same clause. For example:

whom you entrusted to me (Kankanaey Back Translation)

17:9d for they are Yours.

- because they are your^(sing) people.
- because it is to you^(sing) that they belong.

for they are Yours: This clause means “because they belong to you.” This clause gives the reason that Jesus was praying to God for his disciples. Jesus was praying to God for his disciples because they belonged to God. The Greek text emphasizes the word Yours. See how you translated a similar clause in 17:6b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because they belong to you (NLT)

My followers belong to you (CEV)

because it is you to whom they belong

General Comment on 17:9c–d

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 17:9c–d. For example:

^{9d}My followers belong to you, ^{9c}and I am praying for them. (CEV)

General Comment on 17:9a–d

In some languages it may be confusing for Jesus to pray for the disciples, then the world, and then the disciples again. If that is true in your language, it may be natural to rearrange the order of 17:9a–d. For example:

^{9a}I pray for these people ^{9c}that you have given me ^{9d}because they belong to you. ^{9b}I do not pray for the people of the world.

^{9b}I do not pray for the people of the world. ^{9a}Instead I pray for those ^{9c}that you have given me ^{9d}because they are yours.

John 17:10

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:9–12

Jesus asked God to protect his disciples from Satan.

17:10a**All I have is Yours,**

- All the people who are mine are yours^(sing),
- Everyone who belongs to me belongs to you^(sing),

17:10b**and all You have is Mine;**

- and all who are yours^(sing) are mine also,
- and everyone who belongs to you^(sing) belongs to me.

17:10a–b

All I have is Yours, and all You have is Mine: These clauses continue to speak about Jesus' disciples. This sentence shows the unity of Father and Son: what belongs to one, belongs to the other. See 16:15a and the notes there. For example:

All I have is yours, and all you have is mine (GNT)

All those people who belong to me, belong to you,
and all who belong to you belong to me. (TH)

All: This pronoun here refers to all the disciples there with Jesus. The Greek word that the BSB translates as "All" is neuter, which usually refers to things rather than people. However, here the context clearly shows that Jesus was talking about his disciples. In 17:6–19 Jesus prayed about his disciples there with him.

Yours: The word Yours means "belonging to you," meaning here "belonging to God the Father."

Mine: The word Mine means "belonging to me," meaning here "belonging to Jesus."

17:10c**and in them I have been glorified.**

- and I have been given glory/honor by them.
- Through them my glory/greatness is displayed/ revealed.
- And they show how glorious I am (TH)

and in them I have been glorified: This clause indicates that the disciples had shown or revealed his greatness and glory. And the verb tense indicates that they continued to glorify Christ. See KBT Glory, Glorious, Glorify, C.3. The verb have been glorified is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Using a passive verb. For example:

I have been given glory by the people you have given me. (GW)

and my glory is shown through them (GNT)

and through them is my glory revealed (REB)

- Using an active verb. For example:

and they will bring glory to me (CEV)

And glory has come to me through them. (NIV)

and my disciples showed how wonderful I am

John 17:11**Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father**

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns "they" and "them" refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:9–12

Jesus asked God to protect his disciples from Satan.

17:11a**I will no longer be in the world,**

- Now I am leaving the world,
- Very soon I will return to you^(sing) in heaven.

I will no longer be in the world: In Greek the present tense was often used to refer to something that would happen very soon. The clause I will no longer be in the world therefore here indicates that Christ would soon leave the world. For example:

I won't be in the world much longer (GW)

I will remain in the world no longer (NIV)

in the world: This phrase here means “on this earth” instead of being in heaven with God.

17:11b

but they are in the world,

- but my disciples will remain here.
- But my followers will stay here on earth,

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here introduces a contrast between Jesus’ situation and the disciples’ situation. Jesus was leaving the world but his disciples were remaining. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

and yet (NASB)

however

they are in the world: This clause indicates that Jesus’ disciples would remain living on earth. The Greek text emphasizes the word they to contrast it with “I” in 17:11a. Jesus was no longer in the world, but his disciples were. For example:

they are staying in this world (NLT)

as for them, they are still here in this world (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

17:11c

and I am coming to You.

- I am coming to you^(sing) in heaven.
- and/while I am leaving them and coming to you^(sing) in heaven.

and I am coming to You: This clause indicates that Christ was going to heaven to be with God his Father, God. In a way he was already on his way because he had begun his journey to the cross.

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. For example:

I myself am coming to you

coming: In some languages it may not be natural to speak of coming to a place where you are not. In those languages it may be more natural for Jesus to speak about “going” because he was leaving where he was. For example:

I am going to you

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to God the Father.

General Comment on 17:11a–c

In some languages it is more natural to put 17:11c before 17:11a. For example:

^{11c}And now I am coming to you; ^{11a}I am no longer in the world, ^{11b}but they are in the world. (GNT)

17:11d

Holy Father, protect them by Your name,

- Father, Holy One/God, please keep them safe in your name,
- My Father, you^(sing) are holy/pure. Please keep these followers of mine true to who you are.

Holy Father: This phrase is used to address God. Jesus called God the Father Holy. God is holy because he is different from those he created. He is different because he is unique, perfect, pure and completely good. Also, he deserves to be worshiped and honored. See KBT Holy A.1, and see how you translated this word in Luke 1:49, Acts 3:14 and Revelation 3:7, 4:8.

In some languages a literal translation of Holy Father may imply that Jesus also had a Father who was not holy. In those languages it may be necessary to avoid this wrong meaning by translating Holy Father as a separate clause. For example:

Father, you who are holy, protect...

Father, O Holy One! Protect...

Holy: This word indicates that God is morally perfect, divine, unique, and deserving of worship.

Father: This word is one that a child would use when speaking to his father. It indicates affection and respect. See the note and how you translated the word in 17:1.

protect them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as protect means “keep” or “keep safe (protect).” Jesus asked God to keep his disciples safe, to guard them from harm. The same word is used in 17:6, where it refers to keeping (obeying) God’s word, and in 17:15, where it refers to protecting from Satan. Here it has the same idea as in 17:15 (and probably 17:12). But it could also have the idea of keeping them connected or faithful to God (his name). Here are other ways to translate this phrase here:

keep them safe (GNT)

take care of them (Uma Back Translation)

keep them in your name (ESV)

In some languages it may be necessary to say what God would protect the disciples from. If this is true in your language, you should indicate that he should keep them safe from Satan or from evil. For example:

protect them from Satan/evil

by Your name: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *by* has more than one possible meaning. There are two main ways to interpret the Greek phrase here that the BSB translates as *by Your name*.

1. The first word means “in” and the phrase “in your name” means “in who God is” (see “your name” in 17:6) or “(keep them) faithful to God.” For example:

Keep those you have given me true to your name.
(NJB)

keep them safe in your name (NET) (ESV, RSV, NRSV, NASB, NET, NJB)

1. The first word means “by,” and the phrase *by Your name* means “by your power.” God’s name is connected with his power (see Psalm 54:1). For example:

by the power of your name (GNT) (BSB, NIV, GNT, NLT, REB, GW, CEV, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). This interpretation fits the context better, because John never uses God’s name to represent his power unless he does here. And staying in the truth of God’s character would more naturally result in unity than being protected by his power.

17:11e **the name You gave Me,**

- the name that you^(sing) gave me,
- That is the truth of who you^(sing) are that you^(sing) gave me,

the name You gave Me: There is a textual issue here regarding the Greek pronoun that the BSB leaves implicit:

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “which you have given me.” The pronoun is singular, referring to God’s name. For example:

that you have given me (NRSV) (BSB, ESV, NASB, NIV, RSV, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, GNT, REB, NCV)

1. Some Greek manuscripts say “whom you have given to me.” The pronoun is plural, referring to people. For example:

those you have given me (NJB) (KJV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option (1) because it has the best evidence from Greek manuscripts. Also, most English translations follow it. The UBS Greek text gives this option a B rating which means that there is only a little doubt about the decision.

The clause *You gave Me* here refers to God’s name in 17:11d. As the note there said, God’s name represents his character, who God is. God had given his name to Jesus, meaning that he revealed who he was in Jesus. The tense of the verb *gave* indicates that Jesus still possessed God’s name. In some languages it may be necessary to make it clearer what God gave to Jesus. For example:

in your name, the name you gave me

in your name, the truth of who you are, that you have given me

General Comment on 17:11d–e

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in these clauses. Jesus could say first that God had given Jesus his name, and then ask God to protect the disciples. For example:

^{11d–e}Holy Father, you have given me your name;
now keep them safe in that name.

17:11f **so that they may be one as We are one.**

- so that they will be united together as we^(dual) are united together.
- in order that their hearts/minds may agree, just as our^(dual) hearts/minds agree.

so that: The Greek connector that the BSB translated as *so that* introduces Jesus’ purpose in asking God to protect his disciples.

they may be one as We are one: Jesus wanted his disciples to be united. He wanted them to live in unity, just as he and his Father lived in unity. For example:

so that their unity may be like ours (GW)

so that they will be united just as we are (NLT)

one: The word one here refers to many people living in unity. Try not to imply that people will no longer be individuals or have their own character. In some languages it may not be possible to say that many people are one. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

live as though they are one

live in unity

be of one heart

John 17:12

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:9–12

Jesus asked God to protect his disciples from Satan.

17:12a

While I was with them,

- When I was with them on earth,
- During my time with them here,

While I was with them: This clause refers to Jesus’ ministry on earth among his disciples. For example:

As long as I was with them (JBP)

During my time here (NLT)

17:12b

I protected and preserved them by Your name, the name You gave Me.

- I kept them safe in the name that you^(sing) gave me,
- I kept them true to who you^(sing) are, the truth that you gave to me.

I protected...them: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as protected is the same as in 17:11d. This clause says that Jesus had kept his disciples safe. See the note there and translate this word as you did there to show the connection. For example:

I kept them safe (GNT)

I kept them in your name (ESV)

preserved them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as preserved in this context means the same as “protected” in 17:12b: “kept safe.” Repeating the idea emphasizes it. The same Greek word is also used in 12:25, where the BSB translates it as “keep.”

by Your name, the name You gave Me: The textual issue that was in 17:11e is also an issue here. Follow the same option here as you did there and translate this clause in the same or a similar way. For example:

in your name, the name you gave me

in the name that you gave me

in your name, the truth of who you are, that you have given me

17:12c

Not one of them has been lost, except the son of destruction,

- I did not lose anyone except the one who deserved destruction.

- so that every one of them remained secure in you^(sing)—except the one who would certainly be ruined/destroyed.

Not one of them has been lost: This clause indicates that Jesus kept all his disciples' spiritual lives safe. None of them left or abandoned Christ, none of them stopped believing in God or in Christ. See 6:39 and the notes there. In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause as a positive statement. For example:

and only one of them, the one worthy of destruction, was lost (NCV)

has been lost: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as has been lost refers to suffering eternal, spiritual death. Spiritual death is when a person is separated from God forever and punished (often translated “perish” in 3:16). See how you translated this verb in 3:16, 10:28, and especially 12:25.

This Greek verb is more literally “perished.” Here are other ways to translate this verb:

perished (NASB)

died eternally

except the son of destruction: This clause gives an exception to the previous clause. One of the disciples was lost, Judas Iscariot, who betrayed Jesus to his enemies.

the son of destruction: This expression that the BSB translates literally as the son of destruction is a figure of speech indicating that Judas had the character of one deserving destruction. Eternal destruction was suitable for his character and behavior and was its certain result. See 2 Thessalonians 2:3, which uses the same phrase. In your translation it is good to indicate that this man deserved the destruction/ruin that he would suffer. For example:

the one who had to be lost (CEV)

the one who deserves destruction

the one who would certainly be lost/destroyed

17:12d

so that the Scripture would be fulfilled.

- He was lost just as the scripture said he would be.
- It happened to him just as the Scriptures foretold.

so that the Scripture would be fulfilled: This clause means “so it would happen just as the Old Testament prophecies said.” The reference here may be to Psalm 41:9, as in John 13:18. Other possible scriptures that Jesus might have referred to are Psalm 109:4–13; 69:25; and 55:12–15. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and this was to fulfil the scriptures (NJB)

for scripture has to be fulfilled (REB)

So Scripture came true. (GW)

so that: The connector that the BSB has translated as so that here could introduce a purpose, but probably introduces a result. It is probably the result of Judas being lost (rather than the result of Jesus guarding his disciples).

Scripture: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Scripture means “what is written” and refers to the Old Testament as a whole. See how you translated this word in 7:38, 42.

would be fulfilled: This phrase means “would happen.” What the Old Testament foretold (predicted) really happened. In this context the word would does not imply any doubt that it would happen. For example:

would come true (CEV)

came true (GW)

as the Scriptures foretold (NLT)

John 17:13

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However,

he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:13a

But now I am coming to You;

- ¶ And now, I am going to you^(sing) in heaven,
- ¶ Soon I will return to you^(sing),

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here implies a slight contrast. The contrast is between the time when Jesus was on earth and the time when Jesus would soon return to heaven. Jesus could guard the disciples when he was on earth, but now he asked God to protect them (see 17:15). Many English translations leave this conjunction implicit. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

and (GNT)

now I am coming to You: This clause indicates that Jesus would soon go to God his Father in heaven. Even though it had not happened yet, Jesus used a present tense verb. In some languages it may be more natural to use a future tense verb rather than present tense. And you could also indicate that it would happen soon. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

But now I will soon come/go to you.

I am on my way to you. (CEV)

to You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to God the Father.

17:13b

and I am saying these things while I am in the world,

- and/but I have said these things while I am still in the world

- but while I am still on earth, I have told them these things

I am saying these things: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. The phrase saying these things refers to what Jesus had been teaching his disciples. This particularly refers to the whole of the discourse in the upper room, John 14–16. For example:

I told them many things (NLT) (BSB, RSV, NASB, KJV, NET, NIV, GNT, NLT, GW, CEV)

1. The verb saying here means pray. The phrase these things refers to what Jesus had been praying. For example:

But I pray these things (NCV) (REB, NJB, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most English translations. It is good if you use an expression that can include both the prayer in John 17 and the teaching in John 14–16.

while I am in the world: This phrase means “while I live on the earth” or “before I leave the earth.”

17:13c

so that they may have My joy fulfilled within them.

- so that they would be filled with all the same perfect joy as mine.
- because I want them to share my joy and be completely joyful.

so that they may have My joy fulfilled within them:

The Greek more literally says “so that they may have my joy fulfilled in themselves.” This is a purpose clause. Jesus' purpose in speaking to his disciples was to give them joy. He wanted them to have all the joy that he had. See the notes and how you translated the same idea in 15:11. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that they might have my joy in their hearts in all its fullness (GNT)

so they would be filled with my joy (NLT)

to share my joy with them to the full (NJB)

they...them: As in 17:6–12, Jesus was thinking mainly of the disciples who were there with him. But this clause would also be true for all his followers. It is

good to use a term that can include both men and women. For example:

my followers (CEV)

My joy: This phrase here means “the joy that I have.” Jesus wanted his disciples to have the joy of knowing God, as he did. See 15:11 and 16:24. In some languages it may be natural to translate joy as a verb or adjective rather than a noun. For example:

be as joyful as I am

so they would be made extremely happy with my happiness

so that they would be caused to rejoice with my own joy

John 17:14

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:14a

I have given them Your word

- I gave/told them your^(sing) message.

- I have taught them what you^(sing) wanted me to teach.

I have given them Your word: The word word here refers to a message. Jesus had proclaimed a message from God, telling the disciples all that God wanted them to know and do. See how you translated word in 5:38, 8:55, and 14:24. Also, see how you translated a similar idea in 17:8a. The Greek text emphasizes the word I to contrast with “the world” in 17:14b. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I passed your word on to them (NJB)

I have told them your message (CEV)

I have given them your teaching (NCV)

17:14b

and the world has hated them;

- The people of the world hate them
- Now the unbelievers of the world hate them,

and the world has hated them: The result of Jesus teaching the disciples God’s word was that the disciples changed. They were no longer like most people in the world. So the world (community) of unbelievers hated them because they were different. They began to hate them when the disciples received God’s word, and they continued to hate them until this time. Use a suitable verb tense to indicate this. For example:

and the unbelieving world began to hate them

so those who do not believe in me hate them

the world: This phrase here, as often in John, refers to people who do not believe in Christ. They are people who love this sinful world and its evil systems. See how you translated this phrase in 14:17, 27.

17:14c

for they are not of the world,

- because they no longer really belong to the world,
- for they are no longer actually part of this world,
- because my disciples have nothing in common with the unbelieving world.

for they are not of the world: The clause is more literally “because they are not from/of the world.” This indicates that Jesus’ disciples were not like the unbelievers of the world. They had different values and loyalties. In your translation, it is good to avoid

indicating that Jesus' disciples came from a different world, or another planet. You may be able to imply that Jesus was speaking figuratively, using words in a deeper or spiritual sense. For example:

because they do not actually belong to this world

because they are not part of this unbelieving world

17:14d

just as I am not of the world.

- just like I do not really belong to this world.
- just as I am not actually part of this world.
- In the same way I have nothing in common with the unbelieving world.

just as I am not of the world: The word the BSB has translated as just as introduces a comparison. The disciples were like Jesus in that they belonged to God, not to this evil world. Translate this clause in a way that connects it to 17:14c, which has a very similar clause. For example:

just as I am not really part of this world

in the same way that I am not part of this unbelieving world

General Comment on 17:14c–d

In some languages it may be natural to compare Jesus and his disciples without repeating the verb “belong.” For example:

They are like me in this: they do not belong to this world

they don't belong to this world, just as I don't (CEV)

They are strangers in the world, as I am. (REB)

John 17:15

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told

his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:15a

I am not asking that You take them out of the world,

- I am not praying that you^(sing) will take them off the earth;
- I do not want you^(sing) to remove them from the earth.

I am not asking that You take them out of the world:

This clause indicates that Jesus wanted his disciples to remain on earth. He did not want God to take them away. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

My prayer is not that you take them out of the world (NIV)

I do not pray you to take them out of the world (REB)

To take them out of the world is not what I ask.

Jesus said what he was not asking before saying what he was asking. In some languages it is more natural to give the positive first and then the negative. For examples of how to do that, see the General Comment following 17:15b.

I am not asking: The word asking in this context means “praying” because Jesus was talking to God the Father. For example:

I do not pray (REB)

I am not praying (JBP)

My prayer/request is not...

them: This pronoun refers to Jesus' disciples. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit whom the word refers to. For example:

my followers (CEV)

the world: In this context this phrase refers to this physical earth and its fallen people. The disciples do not belong to the world, but they are living in the world. God's people are to remain for some time living among the people of the world.

General Comment on 17:15a

In the BSB, what Jesus is not asking is an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate what Jesus does not ask as a direct quotation inside Jesus' words. For example:

I am not asking/praying, 'Take my disciples out of the world.'

17:15b

but that You keep them from the evil one.

- however, I ask that you^(sing) will protect them from the evil one.
- I just want you^(sing) to keep them safe from the attacks of the one who is evil.

but that You keep them from the evil one: This clause indicates that Jesus asked God the Father to keep his disciples safe from Satan. It contrasts with what Jesus did not ask God in 17:15a. Translate this clause in a way that contrasts naturally and effectively with 17:15a. For example:

but I do ask you to keep them safe from the Evil One (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to repeat the verb "asking" that is implied from 17:15a. For example:

but I ask you to protect them from the evil one (NRSV)

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (17:15a, what Jesus does not ask) to a positive statement (17:15b, what Jesus does ask). This kind of sentence

emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

My prayer is not that you take them out of the world but that you protect them from the evil one. (NIV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I do not say that you should remove them from the world; rather that you should protect them from Satan.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

I am not asking you to take them out of the world. I am asking you to keep them safe from the Evil One.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

^{15b}My prayer is that you protect them from the evil one; ^{15a}not that you take them out of the world.

^{15b}I am asking you to keep my disciples safe from the evil one. ^{15a}I am not asking you to take them out of the earth.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

keep them from: This phrase means "keep them from being harmed." Here is another way to translate this phrase:

keep them safe (NET)

the evil one: This phrase is a title that refers to Satan, the chief of the evil spirits. See also 1 John 2:13–14. You may want to indicate in a footnote that this phrase refers to Satan. Here are other ways to translate this phrase

the one who is called the Evil One

the one who is really evil (TH)

General Comment on 17:15b

If you used a direct quotation in 17:15a, it may be natural to do so here also. For example:

I am praying, ‘Protect them from the evil one.’

John 17:16**Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father**

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:16a**They are not of the world,**

- They are not really/actually part of this world;
- They have nothing in common with this evil world;

They are not of the world: This clause indicates that Jesus’ disciples do not have anything in common with unbelievers. Unbelievers follow the values and goals of this sinful world system and the disciples do not. 17:16a repeats 17:14c. See how you translated this same clause in 17:14c.

17:16b**just as I am not of the world.**

- just as I am not really/actually part of this world.
- just as I have nothing in common with this evil world.

just as I am not of the world: This clause repeats 17:14d. See how you translated the same clause there. The disciples are like Jesus in that they both belong to God. Here is another way to translate this clause:

and neither do I (CEV)

General Comment on 17:16a–b

In some languages it is more natural to place 17:16b before 17:16a. For example.

^{16b}Just as I do not belong to the world, ^{16a}they do not belong to the world. (GNT)

See also the General Comment on 17:14c–d.

John 17:17**Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father**

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:17a**Sanctify them by the truth;**

- Dedicate them to yourself by means of the truth.
- Set them apart as yours^(sing) through what is true.

Sanctify them by the truth: Scholars have interpreted the Greek clause that the BSB translates as Sanctify them by the truth in two ways:

1. It refers to sanctifying the disciples by means of the truth. God would use the truth to sanctify Jesus' disciples. For example:

Dedicate them to yourself by means of the truth.
(GNT) (BSB, GNT, NIV, GW, KJV, REB, NLT, CEV, NCV)

1. It refers to sanctifying the disciples in the truth. God would sanctify the disciples as they lived in the truth. For example:

Consecrate them in the truth. (NJB) (NJB, NASB, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NET)

The two interpretations may not be very different. As the disciples lived in the truth (followed the truth), the truth would sanctify them. If you must choose between the two interpretations, it is recommended that you follow most English translations and interpretation (1).

Sanctify them: The word Sanctify means “dedicate to God” or “set apart for God to serve or do a mission.” It is implied that the disciples must be separated from the evil of the world. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Set them apart (NET)

Make them holy (NLT)

make them completely yours (CEV)

Make them ready for your service (NCV)

the truth: This phrase here refers to what is true, what God has revealed (17:17b says, “your word is truth”). See how you translated this phrase in 8:32. As Jesus taught this truth, and as the disciples believed and obeyed it, God sanctified them (dedicated them to himself). In some languages it is more natural to use a phrase to translate truth. For example:

by/with your true teaching

by-means-of your words which are true
(Kankanaey Back Translation)

17:17b

Your word is truth.

- Your^(sing) message is the truth.
- What you^(sing) say is always true.

Your word is truth: This clause explains or defines what Jesus means by the word truth. God's word, his message to people, is the truth. What God says is always true.

word: In some languages it is more natural to translate the idea of word with a verb. For example:

What you say is truth

truth: See the note and how you translated this word in 17:17a. In some languages it is more natural to translate truth as an adjective. For example:

Your words really are true

John 17:18

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:18a

As You sent Me into the world,

- Just as you^(sing) sent me to the people of the world,
- Just as you^(sing) told me to go among the unbelievers in this world,

As You sent Me into the world: This clause is the first half of a comparison. See how you translated the first half of another comparison in 15:9a. Also see the General Comment on 17:18a–b for a way to rearrange the two parts of this comparison. Introduce this comparison in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Just as you sent me into the world (NLT)

You sent Me into the world: This clause indicates that God the Father sent Jesus into the world of unbelievers to be his messenger and representative. For example:

you have told me to go to the world

you have sent me to go among the people of the world

you have sent me to unbelievers to proclaim your word

world: This word here refers mainly to people who do not believe in God or Jesus.

17:18b

I have also sent them into the world.

- I am sending them to the people of the world.
- I am telling them to go to the unbelievers in this world.

I have also sent them into the world: This clause indicates that Jesus sent his disciples into the world as his messengers. It also indicates that Jesus sending the disciples into the world is similar to his Father sending him. For example:

like that I have told/commanded my disciples to go into the world

I have also sent them: Jesus had not yet finished sending his disciples into the world. In some languages it is more natural to translate this as future or present. For example:

I will soon send them into the world.

I am sending them into the world (CEV)

General Comment on 17:18a–b

In some languages it is more natural to put 17:18b before 17:18a. For example:

^{18b}I sent them into the world, ^{18a}just as you sent me into the world. (GNT)

John 17:19

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:13–19

Jesus asked his Father to bless his disciples with joy, protection, and sanctification.

17:19a

For them I sanctify Myself,

- I am dedicating myself to you^(sing) for their benefit,
- I am committing myself to you, to benefit these my disciples,

For them: This phrase means “And for the benefit of my disciples.” Jesus was dedicating himself to God to serve and save his disciples.

I sanctify Myself: This clause means “I dedicate myself to God.” Jesus was saying that he dedicated himself to God for his disciples. In this context, that means that he dedicated himself as a sacrifice (see Deut. 15:19), ready to die. It can also mean that he dedicates himself as a prophet or priest (see Ex. 28:41). That is more the idea in 17:19b where the disciples

would be sanctified. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have given myself completely for their sake
(CEV)

For their sake, I am making myself ready to serve
(NCV)

17:19b

so that they too may be sanctified by the truth.

- in order that they too may be dedicated to you^(sing) through the truth.
- so that they too by means of the truth can be committed to serving you^(sing).

so that they too may be sanctified by the truth:

The connector so that introduces the purpose of Jesus sanctifying himself. He dedicated himself to God so that the disciples might also be dedicated to God. The way you translate sanctified here should be similar to how you translated “sanctify” in 17:19a. For example:

so that they may be given completely to God by the truth

so that they can be made ready for their service by the truth

sanctified by the truth: There are two ways to understand the phrase that the BSB translates literally as sanctified by the truth

1. It means “sanctified by means of the truth,” as in 17:17a. For example:

made holy by your truth (NLT) (BSB, KJV, REB, GW, NLT)

1. It means “truly dedicated to God.” Without Jesus’ atoning work on the cross, the disciples would not be suitable to be dedicated to God. For example:

truly sanctified (NIV) (NIV, NET, GNT)

Several translations translate this phrase literally as “sanctified/dedicated in truth” and can be understood either way: NASB, RSV, NRSV, NJB, and ESV.

It is recommended that if possible you translate this phrase literally in a way that can be understood either way. If that is not possible, you may want to follow

option (1) or your national or major-language translation.

John 17:20

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:20–24

In this paragraph Jesus prayed for those who would believe in him and follow him in the future. He also prayed specifically for the 11 disciples with him.

17:20a

I am not asking on behalf of them alone,

- ¶ “I am not praying just for these disciples.
- ¶ “I am praying for these disciples and I am praying as well

I am not asking on behalf of them alone: This clause indicates that Jesus was praying for others as well as for his disciples who were there with him. He was not praying for the 11 disciples alone. In your translation, make sure that it is clear that Jesus’ disciples were included in the prayer request. For example:

As well as praying for these disciples, I pray for...

I pray for these followers, but I am also praying for... (NCV)

I am...asking: This clause here means “I pray” and refers to what Jesus was doing at that time. He was making a request to God. For example:

I am praying (NLT)

on behalf of them alone: This phrase indicates that Jesus was not just thinking of the disciples there with him. He was not only praying for (on behalf of) them. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that the word them refers to the disciples there. For example:

not only for these disciples (NLT)

not...just for these followers (CEV)

17:20b

but also on behalf of those who will believe in Me through their message,

- I am praying too for the people who will later believe in me because of what these disciples preach/proclaim.
- for all those in the future who will believe in me because of what these disciples tell them about me.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (17:20a) to a positive statement (17:20b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

I pray not only for them, but also for those who believe in me because of their message. (GNT)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

I do not pray only for these. Rather, I also pray for the people who will believe in me because of their preaching.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

My prayer is not for them alone. I pray also for those who will believe in me through their message (NIV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

I am praying for all the people who will believe in me because my disciples will preach to them. I am not just praying for those who already believe.

I am praying for all those who will believe in me because of their teaching, and not just for them.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

also on behalf of those who will believe in Me through their message: This expression indicates that Jesus then prayed for all Christians in all times. These are people who would believe the message that the disciples first preached. For example:

but I am also praying for all those who will believe in me because of their teaching (NCV)

I am also praying for everyone else who will have faith because of what my followers will say about me. (CEV)

will believe in Me: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated similar phrases in 1:12, 2:11, and 3:16. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

put their faith in me (REB)

will become believers

through their message: This phrase here means “because of the message that the disciples will preach.” The disciples would preach and teach the gospel message, and many other people would then believe in Jesus. These new believers would in turn tell others, who would themselves believe and share God’s word with more people. Each of these generations of believers are included in Jesus’ prayer. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because of their teaching (NCV)

because of what they will tell about me

their: This pronoun refers to the 11 disciples.

John 17:21

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:20–24

In this paragraph Jesus prayed for those who would believe in him and follow him in the future. He also prayed specifically for the 11 disciples with him.

17:21a

that all of them may be one,

- What I pray is that all those who believe in me will be united.
- I am praying that all their hearts/minds will agree.

that all of them may be one: This clause gives the content of Jesus’ prayer. It tells what Jesus was asking his Father for. Jesus prayed that all who believed in him would be one, meaning that they would live in unity and peace. In some languages it may be natural to start a new sentence here, supplying the verb from 17:20a. For example:

I ask for them that they might all live in unity

I pray that they can be one. (NCV)

I want all of them to be one with each other. (CEV)

I pray that all of these people continue to have unity (GW)

Father, I beg you for them all so that their thinking will be one (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

them: This pronoun refers to the disciples and the ones they preached to—it includes all who believe in Christ.

be one: This phrase means “be united” and implies loving one another and living in peace and agreement. See the note on “one” at 17:11f and how you translated the word there. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

be united

be like-minded

live together with hearts/minds that agree

17:21b

as You, Father, are in Me, and I am in You.

- Just as you, Father, live in me and I live in you^(sing),
- Just as we^(dual) are connected,

as You, Father, are in Me, and I am in You: These clauses express the unity of God the Father and God the Son. This is the first half of a comparison. See the General Comment on 17:21b–c for a way to rearrange this comparison. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

just as I am one with you and you are one with me (CEV)

Just as I live in you, Father, and you live in me

Father, in the same way that we^(dual) are connected/united together

Father: This word is one that a child would use when speaking to his father. It indicates affection and respect. See the note and how you translated the word in 17:1.

17:21c

May they also be in Us,

- I pray that they also may live in us^(dual).
- I pray that they also be connected to us^(dual).

May they also be in Us: This clause means “may the believers be united to us.”The KJV and NCV follow Greek manuscripts that say “may they be one in us.”

This reading is not supported by the UBS Greek text or by other major English translations. The UBS Greek text give the reading “may they be in us” a B rating, which means that there is only a little doubt about it. Jesus prayed that all future believers would be united to him and his Father. For example:

I pray that all the believers may be in unity with us^(dual)

Us: This pronoun is dual inclusive and refers to Jesus and God the Father.

General Comment on 17:21b–c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 17:21b–c. For example:

^{21c}May they be in us, ^{21b}just as you are in me and I am in you. (GNT)

^{21c}I pray that that they may be in unity with each other, ^{21b}the same way we^(dual) are in unity with each other.

17:21d

so that the world may believe that You sent Me.

- Then the people of the world will believe that I have come from you^(sing).
- I pray that will happen so that the people who have refused to believe in the past will believe that I am your^(sing) representative.

so that the world may believe that You sent Me: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces the purpose that Jesus wanted the believers to be “in us” (united to God the Father and to him). His purpose was that others in the world would believe in him and that he came from God. The loving unity of his followers would show the world that Jesus was truly from God.

the world: This phrase again refers to people in the world who did not yet believe in Christ and the Father. See how you translated this sense of the world in 17:9. For example:

the people of this world (CEV)

may believe: This verb means “may begin to believe.” In some languages it is more natural to say that more explicitly. For example:

that those who do not now believe will begin to believe

that You sent Me: This clause indicates what the people of the world would believe. It refers to God sending Jesus to earth as his messenger. and representative. See how you translated the same clause in 17:8.

General Comment on 17:20–21

In the Greek, 17:20–21 forms one long sentence. In some languages it is more natural to divide this sentence into several sentences. For example:

²⁰I pray not only for them, but also for those who believe in me because of their message. ²¹I pray that they may all be one. Father! May they be in us, just as you are in me and I am in you. May they be one, so that the world will believe that you sent me. (GNT)

John 17:22

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:20–24

In this paragraph Jesus prayed for those who would believe in him and follow him in the future. He also prayed specifically for the 11 disciples with him.

17:22a

I have given them the glory You gave Me,

- You^(sing) have given me your glory and now I am giving it to my disciples
- You^(sing) have honored me, now I am honoring these my disciples in the same way

I have given them the glory You gave Me: This clause indicates that God gave glory to Jesus and then Jesus gave that glory to his disciples.

The Greek text puts the glory You gave Me first to emphasize it. In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information, mentioning first that Jesus gave the disciples glory as in the BSB. However, many English translations follow the Greek word order. For example:

The glory that you have given me I have given them (NRSV)

I have given them: This clause indicates that Jesus gave to them the glory that the Father gave him. The pronoun them probably refers to the disciples who were with him and not to all believers in all times. Even though 17:20–21 referred to all believers, have given is past tense (which continues in the present) and probably refers to the 11 disciples. If possible, it is recommended that you use a pronoun and do not make the reference explicit. Jesus continues to refer to the 11 disciples through 17:23.

the glory You gave Me: The phrase the glory and the clause that describes it tell what Jesus gave the 11 disciples. Some scholars believe that Jesus gave this glory to all believers, using the past tense (“have given”) because it will certainly happen. However, other scholars believe that Jesus is just talking about the disciples with him, which seems more probable. It does not explain what this glory was. It could refer to divine life or knowing God or Jesus’ presence with them or the power to serve and even die for others. Because it is not certain, it is best to not explain what glory refers to in your translation. For example:

the honor/privilege that you have given to me

you have honored me

You gave Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as gave here and in the next clause can indicate something that continues. For example:

The glory/honor that you have been giving me I am giving to them

17:22b

so that they may be one as We are one—

- in order that they might be united with each other as we^(dual) are united with each other.
- so that their hearts/minds will agree just as our^(dual) hearts/minds agree.

so that they may be one as We are one: These clauses indicate Jesus’ purpose in giving his glory to his disciples. That purpose was to unite his followers in the same way that he and his Father were united. See how you translated the expression in 17:11f that is almost the same. See also the notes on the similar expression in 17:21a–b (17:21b is a longer way of saying as We are one).

they: This pronoun here refers to Jesus’ disciples who were with him, those to whom he had given his glory.

We: The pronoun We refers to God the Father and to Christ. In some languages it may be natural to use an inclusive dual form. In other languages it may be more natural to say “you and I.” For example:

just as you and I are one (GNT)

John 17:23

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:20–24

In this paragraph Jesus prayed for those who would believe in him and follow him in the future. He also prayed specifically for the 11 disciples with him.

17:23a**I in them and You in Me—**

- I will live in them and you^(sing) will live in me
- I will be connected to them and you will be connected to me.

I in them: This phrase explains the meaning of “be one” in 17:22b and means “I will be/live in them.” Here it indicates that the disciples were connected or united to Christ. It is good to use the same expression for this idea that you used in 17:21b–c. For example:

I am one with them (CEV)

I am united with them

and You in Me: This phrase indicates that Christ was connected or united to God the Father. Use a similar expression to the one that you used in 17:21b so that the connection between the two verses is clear. For example:

and you are one with me (CEV)

you and I are united with each other

17:23b**that they may be perfectly united,**

- in order that they will be completely united with each other.
- Then their hearts/minds will completely agree with each other;

that they may be perfectly united: This clause means “so that the believers may be completely united with each other.” The idea is the same as in the first clause in 17:22b. So this is again the purpose for Jesus giving his glory to his disciples (see 17:22a). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

so that they may be completely one (GNT)

so that they will become completely one in heart/mind

so that their unity will lack nothing

17:23c**so that the world may know that You sent Me**

- Then the people of the world will know that I come from you^(sing)
- that way the unbelievers will realize that I am your representative.

so that the world may know that You sent Me: This clause indicates the purpose of the disciples’ unity. Jesus wanted the world to know that God had sent him. When unbelievers would see the disciples’ loving unity, they would understand that Jesus came from God. See how you translated a very similar expression in 17:21d. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

in order that the world may know that you sent me (GNT)

so that the people in this world will know that you sent me

17:23d**and have loved them just as You have loved Me.**

- and that you love these disciples just as you^(sing) love me.
- They will also realize that you^(sing) love these my disciples as much as you love me.

and have loved them just as You have loved Me:

This clause indicates that God loved the disciples the same way that he loved Christ. Although many scholars believe that the pronouns “they” and “them” in this verse refer to all believers, it seems that Jesus refers to the 11 disciples in verse 22 and therefore in 23 as well. Then in verse 24 there is a rather clear change to all believers. The reference to “those also” there seems to imply “those believers in addition to my disciples here.” And it would not be a change if he was talking about all believers in this verse. This is the second thing the unbelievers will come to know if the disciples are truly united. For example:

and they will also know that you love them the same as you love me

and that you love them as much as you love me (NLT)

General Comment on 17:22–23

In the Greek, as in the BSB, 17:22–23 forms one long sentence. In many languages it may be natural to

break these verses up into several shorter sentences. For example:

I have given them the glory that you gave me. I did this so that they are united in the same way we are. I am in them, and you are in me. So they are completely united. In this way the world knows that you have sent me and that you have loved them in the same way you have loved me. (GW)

I have given these people the glory that you gave me so that they can be one, just as you and I are one. I will be in them and you will be in me so that they will be completely one. Then the world will know that you sent me and that you love them just as much as you loved me. (NCV)

John 17:24

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:20–24

In this paragraph Jesus prayed for those who would believe in him and follow him in the future. He also prayed specifically for the 11 disciples with him.

17:24a

Father, I want those You have given Me to be with Me where I am,

- ¶ “My Father, I want also those whom you^(sing) gave to me to be with me where I will be.

- ¶ “Father, please allow those whom you^(sing) have entrusted to me to be with me in heaven

Father, I want those You have given Me to be with Me where I am: In this clause, Jesus continued to pray. He prayed that all his followers would be with him.

Father: This word is one that a child would use when speaking to his father. It indicates affection and respect. See the note and how you translated the word in 17:1. In some languages it is necessary or more natural use a personal pronoun. For example:

My Father

I want: The word the BSB translates as I want introduces a polite request to God. In some languages it is more natural to express a polite request in other ways. For example:

please allow

those You have given Me: In the Greek text the clause those You have given Me indicates a change of topic. This whole expression refers to all those who would believe in Jesus, a change from the 11 disciples in 17:23. Here Jesus refers to the same people referred to in 17:2b. See the note there and how you translated a similar expression. Here is another way to translate this expression:

the people that you entrusted to me (Kankanaey Back Translation)

to be with Me where I am: This expression means “might be in the same place that I am.” It does not indicate that Jesus doubted that the Father would answer his prayer. Jesus knew that he was going to his Father in heaven, and he prayed that his followers would go there also.

where I am: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am is present tense, but refers to the near future, after Jesus went to heaven. In some languages it is more natural to use a future tense. For example:

where I will be

17:24b

that they may see the glory

- Then they can see the glory
- so that they can see my honor.

that they may see the glory: The clause that the BSB translates as that they may see the glory is more literally “so that they may see my glory.” It introduces the purpose for Jesus’ prayer that his followers be with him. Some see this phrase as a second prayer request and not the purpose of the first request. NIV, NCV, and GW translate it that way. However, there is no word that means “and” in the Greek as you would expect with a second request. That strongly indicates that this clause tells the purpose of Jesus’ followers being with him. For example:

so they may know my great honor

Then they can see the greatness and brightness
that you gave me

the glory: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the glory here refers to Christ sharing in the majesty and greatness of God. The disciples will see how Jesus Christ shares God’s highest status and greatness that shines. See KBT Glory 3 (B), and see how you translated glory in 17:5b and 22a.

my great honor and brightness

my shining divine status

17:24c

You gave Me

- which you^(sing) gave me
- It is the honor that you^(sing) have honored me with

You gave Me: This expression tells something about Christ’s glory. It is glory that God gave Christ. God honored Christ, causing him to receive honor and the highest status with him. See how you translated this idea in 17:22a. For example:

with which you have honored me

which you have made mine (JBP)

This is the honor and greatness that you gave to me.

17:24d

because You loved Me before the foundation of the world.

- because you^(sing) loved me from eternity past, before the earth was made.
- because you^(sing) have always loved me, even before the earth existed.

because You loved Me before the foundation of the world:

This clause tells why God gave Christ glory. It repeats the idea in the last part of 17:23d. The past tense of the verb loved does not imply that God no longer loves Christ. Use a tense that indicates that God loved Christ in the past and continued to do so. For example:

because you have loved me since before the world began

because you have always loved me, even before the world existed

You: The pronoun You is singular and refers to God the Father.

before the foundation of the world: This phrase refers to eternity in the past, before God made the earth. In some languages it is more natural to translate this noun phrase as a clause with a verb. For example:

before the world began to be/exist

before the world was made (NCV)

before the world was created (CEV)

John 17:25

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus' prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:25–26

Jesus again prayed for his 11 closest disciples, that they would have God's love and Jesus himself in them.

17:25a

Righteous Father, although the world has not known You,

- Father, Righteous One/God, the people of this world have not known you^(sing),
- My Father, you^(sing) are completely good. Unbelievers do not have a relationship with you^(sing).

Righteous Father: Jesus is speaking to his Father and showing respect by calling him Righteous. This is a description of God the Father. In some languages for Christ to say Righteous Father might imply that Jesus had an unrighteous father as well. In order to avoid this wrong meaning, it may be more natural to put Righteous Father in a separate sentence. For example:

Father, you are the One who is good. (NCV)

Righteous: The word translated Righteous means “good,” “right,” and “just.” God always does the right thing and judges with true justice. For example:

Good Father (CEV)

In some languages it may be necessary to use a verb in your translation of the adjective Righteous. For example:

My Father, you who act justly

Father, who judges fairly

My Father, you do only good (Otomi Back Translation)

Father: This word is one that a child would use when speaking to his father. It indicates affection and respect. See the note and how you translated the word in 17:1.

the world has not known You: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the world refers to the people in the world who do not believe in Jesus. They do not really know God. This was true then and continues

to be true. Try to use a verb that refers to time in general: past, present, and future. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The world has never known you (TH)

the people of this world don't know you (CEV)

those who don't believe in me, they don't know you (Kankanaey Back Translation)

17:25b

I know You,

- but I have always known you^(sing).
- However, I have a relationship with you^(sing),

I know You: This clause contrasts Jesus and the world. Jesus really knows God the Father, but unbelievers do not know him. The BSB indicated this by using “although” in 17:25a. This is a clause that is not limited to a certain time. For example:

but I have always known you (TH)

General Comment on 17:25a–b

In some languages it may be natural to indicate the contrast between these clauses in 17:25a rather than 17:25b. For example:

Righteous Father, though the world does not know you, I know you (NIV)

17:25c

and they know that You sent Me.

- And my disciples here know that you^(sing) sent me.
- and these disciples of mine have come to know that it is you^(sing) who sent me here.

and they know that You sent Me: This clause states something that has not always been true but began to be true at a specific time. Jesus' disciples began to believe that God had sent him to earth. For example:

and these have come to know that you sent me (TH)

they: This pronoun refers to Jesus' 11 disciples who were there with him. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit:

these my disciples/followers

know that You sent Me: See how you translated this clause in 17:23c.

John 17:26

Section 17:1–26: Jesus prayed to his Father

In this section, chapter 17, Jesus prayed to God his Father. He asked his Father to restore the glory that he had before he came to earth. He also asked his Father to protect his disciples from evil. He prayed for people in the future who would believe in him. He also told his Father that he wanted his disciples to always be with him.

Sometimes it is difficult to know to whom the pronouns “they” and “them” refer. Most of the time, Jesus was praying for the 11 disciples with him. However, he also prayed for all Christians, including those who would believe in him in the future. And even some of the prayers for the 11 disciples could also be thought to be prayers for future believers.

Here are some other possible Section Headings:

Jesus Prays for Himself, His Disciples, and His Church (GW)

Jesus’ prayer for his disciples

Paragraph 17:25–26

Jesus again prayed for his 11 closest disciples, that they would have God’s love and Jesus himself in them.

17:26a

And I have made Your name known to them

- I have taught them about you^(sing)
- I have shown them who you^(sing) are

And I have made Your name known to them: This clause means “I have taught these men who you are and what you are like.” See 17:6a, where a similar expression is used. The word name is a Jewish idiom referring to the person himself. In some languages it may be necessary to state this explicitly to help people understand. For example:

I showed them what you are like (GW)

I told them what you are like (CEV)

Your: This pronoun is singular here and refers to God the Father.

17:26b

and will continue to make it known,

- and I will teach them about you^(sing) even more.
- and I will continue to show them who you^(sing) are,

and will continue to make it known: This clause indicates that Christ would continue to teach his disciples about God. For example:

and I will show them again (NCV)

and I will continue showing them what you are like

and I will tell them even more (CEV)

17:26c

so that the love You have for Me may be in them,

- Then they will have the same love that you have for me. (NCV)
- so that they may love each other just as you^(sing) love me,

so that the love You have for Me may be in them:

This is a purpose clause. It indicates that Christ’s purpose in showing the disciples what God is like is so they will have God’s love in them. God’s love for Christ will be the love that his disciples have for others. Their love will be like God’s love. That means that they will love others in the same way that God loves Christ. Even though Jesus was praying for his 11 disciples, certainly he desires that all believers have God’s love in them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Then the love that you have for me will become part of them. (CEV)

Then they will have the same love that you have for me. (NCV)

so that they may love others as you^(sing) love me

love...may be in them: This clause indicates that God’s love would be in the disciples. That means that the disciples would show love to others like God loved Christ. In some languages it may be natural to translate love as a verb, with the disciples as the subject. For example:

so that they might love one another

so that they will love others

17:26d and I in them.”

- And I myself will live in them.”
- and I may be connected to them.”

and I in them: This clause means “and I myself will be united with my disciples.” See how you translated this clause in 17:23a. For example:

and I will be one with them (CEV)

and that I, myself, may be united to them

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. You may want to include the word “myself” to show this emphasis. For example:

and that I myself may be in them (NIV)

John 18:1

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus’ enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:1–3

Judas led Jesus’ enemies to him so that they could arrest him.

18:1a

After Jesus had spoken these words,

- ¶ After Jesus said these things,
- ¶ When Jesus finished praying, (NCV)

After Jesus had spoken these words: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as these words may refer specifically to Jesus’ prayer in chapter 17. Or it may refer in general to all he said in chapters 13–17. Because Jesus’ prayer was the last thing that John recorded, it may be natural to refer specifically to that. For example:

When Jesus finished praying (NCV)

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When he had said these things (NET)

After this prayer (REB)

After saying this

18:1b

He went out with His disciples across the Kidron Valley,

- he and his disciples left and crossed the Kidron Valley.
- he and his disciples left the city and went across the dry stream called Kidron.

He went out with His disciples across the Kidron Valley:

The BSB, like the Greek text, does not say where Jesus was before he went out (left). If it is more natural in your language to include this information, there are two possible interpretations:

1. Jesus left the city of Jerusalem. For example:

Jesus, with his disciples, left the city of Jerusalem

1. Jesus left the room/house where he and his disciples had eaten. For example:

Jesus, with his disciples, left the room

If you do indicate where Jesus left, then it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. However both interpretations are true.

He went out with His disciples: In some languages it is more natural to include His disciples in the subject of the sentence: For example:

he and his disciples crossed the Kidron Valley (CEV)

He went out: If you did not make the subject “Jesus” explicit in 18:1a, it may be good to do so here. For example:

Jesus went out (REB)

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to a “learner” who is in a special relationship with a teacher. The learner followed his teacher in order to learn from him and live based

on his teaching and example. In the New Testament a disciples referred specifically to a person who was learning from a religious teacher. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this word in 1:35 and 2:2.

across the Kidron Valley: The Kidron valley was between Jerusalem and the Mount of Olives. The Kidron River ran down the middle of the valley, but usually it had no water in it. Jesus and his disciples went across this dry river/stream/brook to get to the Mount of Olives. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Jesus left with his disciples and crossed the Kidron Valley (NIV)

he left with his disciples and went across the brook called Kidron (GNT)

he went with his disciples to the other side of the Kidron Valley (GW)

18:1c

where they entered a garden.

- On the other side of the valley there was an orchard, and Jesus and his disciples entered it.
- There was a grove of fruit/olive trees on the far side of the valley. Jesus and his disciples went in among the trees.

where they entered a garden: This expression indicates where Jesus went. After crossing the dry river, Jesus and his disciple arrived at a garden. It was probably near the bottom of the Mount of Olives (see Luke 22:39).

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

There was a garden in that place (GNT)

On the other side there was a garden (NCV)

they entered a garden: Jesus and his disciples went in among the trees. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

Jesus and his disciples went into the/that orchard/grove.

a garden: This phrase here refers to a place where people grew olive trees (see the notes on Luke 21:37,

22:39). Use the expression that is natural in your language for referring to such a piece of land. In English, a “grove” and an “orchard” are both pieces of land where fruit or nut trees grow. For example:

an orchard (NET)

a grove of olive trees (NLT)

an olive grove (NIV)

General Comment on 18:1a–c

In the Greek text 18:1 is one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to break it up into two or more sentences. For example:

^{1a}After Jesus had said this prayer, ^{1b}he left with his disciples and went across the Kidron Brook. ^{1c}There was a garden in that place, ^{1d}and Jesus and his disciples went in. (GNT)

^{1a}After Jesus finished praying, ^{1b}he and his disciples left that place. They crossed the valley where the Kidron stream sometimes flowed. ^{1c}There was an orchard on the other side, ^{1d}and they entered it.

John 18:2

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:1–3

Judas led Jesus' enemies to him so that they could arrest him.

18:2a

Now Judas His betrayer also knew the place,

- Judas, Jesus' betrayer, also knew where this place was
- Judas, who had promised to help Jesus' enemies, knew this grove well

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some parenthetical information. It is not a time word. English translations use parentheses or a different tense to indicate that this verse is parenthetical. Indicate that this verse gives parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

(Now Judas, the one who betrayed him, knew the place too, because Jesus had met there many times with his disciples.) (NET)

Jesus had often met there with his disciples, and Judas knew where the place was. (CEV)

Judas His betrayer: The clause His betrayer gives some information about Judas. It refers to the fact that Judas, one of Jesus' disciples, agreed to help Jesus' enemies. He received money from them as a reward for promising to lead them to Jesus so they could arrest him. See Mark 14:10–11. See how you referred to this action in 6:64, 71; 13:2, 11, 21. Refer to this action in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Judas the betrayer

Judas, who was helping Jesus' enemies to arrest Jesus,

Judas was the one who began to oppose Jesus.

also knew the place: Judas knew that Jesus often went with his disciples to this garden. So he knew where to lead the soldiers and police.

the place: This phrase here refers to the garden.

18:2b

because Jesus had often met there with His disciples.

- because Jesus and his disciples had gathered there often.
- because Jesus and his followers went there many times to be together.

because: The connector because introduces the reason why Judas knew the garden.

Jesus had often met there with His disciples: Jesus often used this garden as a meeting place. Perhaps they slept there as well. So Judas had often gone there. Here is another way to translate this clause:

many times Jesus had met there with his disciples (GNT)

Jesus and his disciples often gathered there (GW)

met: The verb that the BSB translates as met is more literally “gathered.” It refers to Jesus using this place to be with his disciples. This was something he did often or regularly. Use a verb tense that refers to repeated action in the past. For example:

used to meet

with His disciples: In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Judas was one of these disciples. For example:

with him and the other disciples

General Comment on 18:2a–b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 18:2a–b, and first say why Judas knew this place. For example:

^{2b}Jesus had often met there with his disciples, and so ^{2a}Judas his betrayer knew where it was.

John 18:3

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:1–3

Judas led Jesus' enemies to him so that they could arrest him.

18:3a

So Judas brought a band of soldiers

- So Judas arrived at the orchard, showing a group of soldiers the way.
- So he went to that place/grove, leading a group of Roman soldiers

So: The connector that the BSB translates as So here introduces what Judas did because he knew where Jesus was. It also indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information in 18:2.

Judas brought a band of soldiers: Judas led a group of soldiers to the garden in order to show them where Jesus was. These were probably Roman soldiers. In some languages you may want to make this explicit. For example:

Judas...taking with him a group of Roman soldiers
(GNT)

brought: The verb that the BSB translates as brought is more literally “having taken...he came.” Judas told a group of soldiers to go with him to the garden. Then he went to the garden and brought them with him. Here are other ways to translate this verb:

came...guiding (NIV)

led

went...taking with him (GNT)

a band of soldiers: This phrase refers to a group of Roman soldiers called a cohort. There were 600 soldiers in a cohort, though a section of the cohort was also called a cohort. There were probably not 600 soldiers who came to arrest Jesus. However, there could have been many soldiers to help if Jesus’ followers caused problems. John does not tell how many soldiers there were. Try to use a term that does not indicate the size of the group. For example:

a group of Roman soldiers (GNT)

some Roman soldiers (CEV)

a detachment of soldiers (NRSV)

the squad of soldiers (NET)

18:3b

and officers from the chief priests and Pharisees.

- He also led some temple guards sent by the chief priests and the Pharisees.

- and some Jewish guards whom the leading Jewish priests and the Pharisees commanded to go with him.

and officers: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as officers refers to those who assist or help others in an official capacity. The word is sometimes translated as “officials” or “servants.” From the other Gospels we learn that at least some of these men were the guards at the temple. See how you translated this term in 7:32. For example:

temple police (CEV)

temple guards (GNT)

from the chief priests and Pharisees: This phrase indicates that the chief priests and Pharisees sent police to go with Judas and the soldiers to arrest Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to supply a verb. For example:

sent by the chief priests and the Pharisees

whom the chief priests and the Pharisees had told to go with him/Judas

the chief priests and Pharisees: This phrase refers to the leaders of the Jewish nation. These leaders formed a council called the Sanhedrin. See how you translated this phrase in 11:47. For example:

the leading priests and the members of the Pharisee group

the leaders of the Jews , the chief priests and the Pharisees

the chief priests: This phrase refers to the most important of the Jewish priests, the leading priests. These priests were usually not Pharisees but members of a different religious group, the Sadducees. They did sacrifices and were in charge of the religious rituals in the temple. See how you translated priests in 1:19 and chief priests in 7:45.

Pharisees: This phrase refers to a Jewish religious group or party. It was very important to them to obey all of the Jewish religious laws very carefully and exactly. See the notes on 1:24, where the Pharisees are first mentioned. Translate this as you did there and in 11:46.

18:3c**They arrived at the garden carrying lanterns, torches, and weapons.**

- They brought weapons to use if there was trouble and torches and lanterns.
- They were armed with long knives and came equipped with lights.

They arrived at the garden: The pronoun They refers to the soldiers and the police. They went armed to the garden where Jesus and his disciples were.

carrying lanterns, torches, and weapons: The men carried lanterns and torches to give them light because it was night. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

They were carrying torches, lanterns, and weapons. (NCV)

lanterns, torches: This phrase refers to two kinds of lights that the soldiers and police carried with them to the garden. The lanterns could have been made of burnt clay or metal with a place for oil and a wick. The wick, the string lit to give light, was made of flax (a plant) or other type of string. The torches were made from sticks with a rag tied to the end and dipped in oil. The exact details of the lights are not important. Translate these words using common words for lights that do not need batteries or other modern technology. In some languages it is more natural to translate lanterns and torches with the same word. For example:

They carried lights with them

They had fires to see with.

weapons: The soldiers and guards carried weapons to use if the disciples resisted Jesus' arrest. They probably had swords, spears, and knives but John is not specific.

Here are some other ways to translate weapons:

General Comment on 18:3

- Use a verb. For example:

they were armed (GNT)

- Indicate the purpose of the weapons. For example:

things for fighting with

tools to use in a fight

- Use a "weapon" common in your culture. For example:

They carried long knives with them.

In the Greek, 18:3 is not in the order that the events happened. In some languages it is more natural to translate using the order that the events happened. For example:

^{3b}The chief priests and Pharisees sent some temple guards to go with Judas. ^{3a}A group of Roman soldiers also came and Judas led them all to the garden. ^{3c}They were armed and carried with them lanterns and torches.

General Comment on 18:3

In other languages it may be more natural to start with the information that Judas went to the garden. Then you can add the information about who went with him and what they carried. For example:

^{3c}So Judas came there ^{3a}with a group of soldiers ^{3a}and some guards from the leading priests and the Pharisees. ^{3c}They were carrying torches, lanterns, and weapons.

John 18:4**Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus**

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:4a

Jesus, knowing all that was coming upon Him, stepped forward

- ¶ Jesus knew what would soon happen to him. So he approached them
- ¶ Jesus knew what that they planned to do to him, and he stepped forward to meet them.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that is usually translated “therefore” but some English versions translate it as “then.” Here it indicates that Jesus’ knowledge of what would happen to him influenced or caused him to come forward. For example:

Then Jesus, because he knew... (NET)

Jesus knew...so (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to leave this connector untranslated or implied as in the BSB.

Jesus, knowing all that was coming upon Him, stepped forward: Jesus went to meet the soldiers knowing that they were going to arrest him and punish him with death. He willingly offered himself to his enemies.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause using two independent verbs. For example:

Jesus knew everything that was going to happen to him, so he stepped forward. (GNT)

Because Jesus knew everything that would happen to him, he went to meet them.

all that was coming upon Him: This phrase here means “all that would happen to him.” It refers mainly to the suffering Jesus would soon endure. His enemies would soon arrest, mock, try, condemn, and crucify him. Jesus knew about all these things before they happened. In your translation, it is good to imply that what was going to happen to Jesus was bad. For example:

all that they would do to him

all that he would soon suffer/endure

stepped forward: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as stepped forward indicates that Jesus left the group of disciples and walked toward the crowd. It probably means that Jesus left the garden to go to a place where those with Judas could see him. For example:

came forward (NRSV)

went out (NIV)

18:4b

and asked them, “Whom are you seeking?”

- and asked, “Whom do you^(plur) seek?”
- “Who is it that you^(plur) want to arrest?” he asked.

and asked them, “Whom are you seeking?”: This expression indicates that Jesus asked the guards to name the man they came to arrest. He knew that they were looking for him, but he wanted them to state it publicly. Then he could identify himself and the disciples could go free.

In your translation, place the speech introducer asked them in the position where it is natural in your language. For example:

“Who are you looking for?” he asked. (NLT)

asked them: The pronoun them refers to the crowd of soldiers and police mentioned in 8:3. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit here. Use the expression that you used in 8:3, or one that combines the two groups. For example:

asked the armed men

Whom are you seeking?: This question is a request for the guards to identify by name the person they wanted to arrest. For example:

Who is it you want? (NIV)

John 18:5

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus’ enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:5a

“Jesus of Nazareth,” they answered.

- They said, “Jesus from the village of Nazareth.”
- “We^(excl) are looking for Jesus who came from Nazareth village,” the men answered him.

Jesus of Nazareth: The guards indicated that they were looking for a man named Jesus who was from the village called Nazareth. Jesus was a common name among Jews of those days. The phrase of Nazareth indicates which Jesus they wanted—the Jesus who had grown up in the village called Nazareth. Here are other ways to translate their reply:

We^(excl) want to arrest Jesus who comes from the village of Nazareth.

Jesus who is from the village called Nazareth is the man we^(excl) are looking for.

Nazareth: Nazareth was a small town in the province of Galilee. See how you referred to it in 1:45.

they answered: The pronoun they again refers to the group of soldiers and guards who came to arrest Jesus. Refer to them in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The men replied

18:5b

Jesus said, “I am He.”

- Jesus said, “I am that man.”
- Jesus said, “I am the one that you^(plur) are looking for.”

I am He: Jesus indicated that he was the man whom the soldiers were looking for. Some also think that Jesus implied that he was God because God called himself “I am” in Exodus 3:14. (The word He here is only implied in the Greek.) The Greek text emphasizes the word I. Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

I am Jesus. (CEV)

I am the man. (JBP)

18:5c

And Judas His betrayer was standing there with them.

- And Judas, the disciple who betrayed Jesus, was standing there with the soldiers.
- (Judas, his/Jesus’ betrayer, was there with the soldiers and guards.)

And Judas His betrayer was standing there with them: This clause gives additional information about the scene in the garden at that time. Translate this clause in a way that is natural for supplying additional information about a situation. Some translations have placed it in parentheses. For example:

(Now Judas, the one who betrayed him, was standing there with them.) (NET)

His betrayer: This clause gives additional information about Judas. It identifies Judas as the disciple who helped Jesus’ enemies to capture him. It is the same expression that is used in 18:2. Translate it the same way in both verses. For example:

Judas, the one who turned against Jesus, (NCV)

Judas, who betrayed him, (NRSV)

the traitor (GNT)

was standing there with them: This phrase implies that Judas had joined Jesus’ enemies.

them: This pronoun refers to the soldiers and police/guards. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

was standing there with the soldiers and guards (TH)

John 18:6**Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus**

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:6a

When Jesus said, “I am He,”: Here, after the parenthetical information, the narrative returns to the main story by repeating the last words Jesus had spoken. Indicate the return to the main story in the most natural way in your language. See the General Comment on 18:5–6 after 18:6b for a different way to handle the parenthetical material. In some languages it is more natural to use indirect speech. For example:

When Jesus told them that that he was Jesus of Nazareth

As soon as Jesus said that he was that one

they drew back and fell to the ground: The crowd of armed men stepped away from Jesus and fell backwards down to the ground. Probably they did this because they felt fear and awe in the presence of Jesus. But the text does not explain why they stepped back. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they moved back and fell to the ground (GNT)

the crowd backed away and fell to the ground (GW)

General Comment on 18:5–6

In some languages it may not be natural to repeat the fact that Jesus said, “I am he.” Or you might want to put the parenthetical information in another place. In those languages it may be more natural to combine 8:5–6 and rearrange some of the information. For example:

^{5–6}“Jesus from-Nazareth,” they answered. “Well I am truly the one,” said Jesus. When he said that, they quickly stepped backward and fell over, along with Judas, who had betrayed him, who was standing with them.

18:6

When Jesus said, “I am He,” they drew back and fell to the ground.

- When Jesus said “I am that man,” the men/soldiers stepped backwards and fell backwards to/on the ground.
- When Jesus told them that he was the one that they were looking for, the soldiers and guards moved away and fell down.

John 18:7

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:7a

So He asked them again, “Whom are you seeking?”

- So he asked them a second time, “Whom do you^(plur) seek?”
- Again he asked, ‘Who is it you want?’ (REB)
- So he asked them again whom they wanted to arrest,

again: This word indicates that Jesus asked here the same question that he asked in 18:4.

Whom are you seeking?: This is the same question that Jesus asked the guards before. See how you translated this question in 18:4.

18:7b

“Jesus of Nazareth,” they answered.

- They said, “Jesus from the village of Nazareth.”
- The soldiers and police answered him “We^(excl) are seeking Jesus who came from Nazareth village.”
- and again they told him that they wanted Jesus from Nazareth.

“Jesus of Nazareth,” they answered: This is the same answer that the guards gave before. See how you translated this answer in 18:5.

John 18:8

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:8a

“I told you that I am He,” Jesus replied.

- Jesus said, “I said that I am that man.
- Jesus said “I already told you—I am the one that you^(plur) are looking for.

“I told you that I am He,” Jesus replied: In this clause, Jesus told the guards that he already said that he was the one that they wanted to arrest. It implies that his earlier answer was true. This clause is the grounds or basis for Jesus' request in 18:8c. (18:8b is an additional grounds, a condition that has been fulfilled.) Your translation should indicate that Jesus said again what he had just said. Translate this in a way that connects with your translation of 18:5. For example:

Jesus replied. “I have already told you that I am Jesus.” (CEV)

“I have already told you who I am,” Jesus replied.

“As I just said, I am the one that you seek,” Jesus answered.

In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech for Jesus' quotation of his own earlier words. For example:

Jesus replied, “I said to you, ‘I am the one.’”

18:8b

“So if you are looking for Me,

- Because I am the one that you^(plur) are seeking,
- If you^(plur) are looking for me and not for them, then

So: The connector So indicates a logical connection between the grounds or basis in 18:8a and the conclusion in 18:8c. (18:8b is an additional grounds, a condition that has been fulfilled.) Because Jesus was the one that the guards wanted to arrest, they should let his disciples go. Here are other ways to translate this connection:

If, then, you are looking for me, let these others go. (GNT)

And since I am the one you want, let these others go. (NLT)

if you are looking for Me: This clause is a condition that is assumed to be true. It means “since (because) it is me that you want to arrest.” Jesus and the guards all knew that Jesus was the man they wanted to arrest. For example:

since I am the one you want (NLT)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the various soldiers and guards present.

Me: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun Me to contrast it with “these men” in 18:8c. The idea is, “If I am the one that you want, then leave these other men alone.” Try to show this emphasis and contrast in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So if/because I am the one whom you are looking for, then these others can be allowed to leave

So, if it is really me that you seek, just let these other men go

18:8c

let these men go.”

- allow these other men to go free.”
- do not arrest my disciples.”

let these men go: This clause in this context means “Do not arrest these other men.” Jesus asked the soldiers to let his disciples go away freely. For example:

give these men permission to leave

permit these men to go free

In some languages it may be natural to use a negative verb. For example:

do not keep/arrest these men

these men: The Greek word that the BSB translates as these men refers to Jesus' disciples. The Greek text emphasizes the word to contrast it with "me" in 18:8b. Because Jesus was contrasting them with himself, in some languages it may be natural to say:

these other men

these others (CEV)

John 18:9

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:4–9

Jesus protected his disciples by offering himself to his enemies. He allowed them to arrest him without resisting or fighting.

18:9

18:9 is a comment by the author John, not part of the story. So some English translations such as the REB place this verse in parentheses. You should indicate that this is parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

18:9a

This was to fulfill the word He had spoken:

- This happened so that the words he had spoken might be fulfilled: (NIV)
- (In this way what Jesus said earlier came true:

This was to fulfill the word He had spoken: This clause indicates that when Jesus protected his disciples in 18:8, he fulfilled his own prayer in 17:12. Other verses that this verse might refer to are 6:39 and 10:28. He had said that he had kept his followers safe, and he did in fact do so. The expression fulfill the word...

is used often in the New Testament. See how you translated it in 12:38 and 13:18. It usually indicates that things happened that the Old Testament had said would happen. Here it refers to Jesus' words being fulfilled in the same way that Old Testament scriptures were fulfilled. A few translations (GNT, NET, NLT) make it sound like Jesus said what he did in 18:8 in order to fulfill what he said earlier. Although there is a Greek word in this verse that can introduce purpose, it can also introduce a result. Although purpose is possible here, in many verses that use the expression "This was to fulfill the word," it must introduce a result and not a purpose. Because of that, it seems best to understand that word as introducing a result here as well. Jesus said what he did in order to care for his disciples, not just to fulfill what he said earlier.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This happened so that the words he had spoken might be fulfilled (NIV)

This happened so that the words Jesus said before would come true (NCV)

In this way what Jesus had said came true (GW)

This was: The word This refers to the way Jesus spoke up to protect his followers. In some languages it may be natural to indicate more explicitly to what This refers. For example:

What he said

In this way (GW)

to fulfill: This phrase indicates that things happened just as Jesus said they would happen. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

would come true (NCV)

came true (GW)

the word He had spoken: This clause refers to the words in Jesus' prayer, "not one of them was lost" (see John 17:12). Those words refer to his disciples, that he would keep them safe. This statement did not include Judas, as Jesus explained in 17:12. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

what Jesus had said (GW)

his own statement (NLT)

his previous words (JBP)

18:9b

“I have not lost one of those You have given Me.”

- “I have not lost even one of those you gave me.”
- “All those you gave me I have kept safe.”)

I have not lost one of those You have given Me: This is a free (approximate) quotation of Jesus’ words in 17:12. In that verse Jesus probably referred to eternal salvation but here John relates it more to physical safety. However, by protecting the disciples physically, Jesus protected them from possible spiritual damage. See how you translated 17:12 and translate this in a way that is similar but can refer to physical protection. For example:

I have not lost any of the ones you gave me. (NCV)

Not one of those you gave me have I lost. (NJB)

In some languages it may be natural to use a positive expression. For example:

I have kept safe every one of those whom you gave me.

I have protected each one whom you gave me.

This is a direct quotation. John quoted what Jesus had said a few hours before. He did not use the exact same words. In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quotation for such an approximate quotation. For example:

Saying that fulfilled what he said earlier, that none of those whom God had trusted to him would be lost.

This fulfilled what Jesus had said, that he had not lost any of those God had given to him.

one of those You have given Me: The Greek text emphasizes the word that the BSB translates as one. None of Jesus’ disciples died with him, not even one. For example:

even one of those you gave me (GNT)

those You have given Me: This clause refers to Jesus’ disciples. Jesus was saying that God his Father chose them so that they would believe and follow him. See the note for a similar clause in 17:2b and how you translated the clause there. For example:

those whom God had trusted to him

John 18:10

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus’ enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:10–11

Peter used his sword to try to prevent the guards from arresting Jesus. But Jesus told him not to resist his arrest.

18:10a

Then Simon Peter drew his sword

- ¶ Simon Peter had a sword. He pulled it out
- ¶ Simon Peter had brought a long knife. He took it out of its case

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then indicates a development in the story. Here it also indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information in 18:9. In some languages it may be natural to leave it untranslated, as some English translations have done.

Simon Peter drew his sword: This clause indicates that Simon Peter pulled his sword out of its case or holder. That action indicated that he was ready to defend Jesus. The clause includes a comment that Peter had a sword with him. In some languages it may be natural to translate these two ideas as two sentences. For example:

Simon Peter had brought along a sword. He now pulled it out. (CEV)

Simon Peter: Simon Peter was one of Jesus' closest disciples. He had told Jesus that he was willing to die with him. See the note at 1:40a–b and how you spelled his name there and in 13:36.

drew: This verb here means “pull out of its case.” The case or covering for a sword is usually called a “sheath.” In some languages it may be natural to mention this case. For example:

pulled it from its sheath

his sword: This clause gives additional information about Simon Peter. He was carrying or wearing a sword. It was in a sheath (sword case) that was probably attached to a belt that was tied around his waist. Translate this clause in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

He had brought a sword with him.

He was armed with a sword.

sword: The word that the BSB translates as sword refers to a knife used for fighting. Some languages may have several words for knives used in fighting. Use the term for a weapon that a person would likely carry around and use. For example:

machete

long knife

18:10b

and struck the servant of the high priest, cutting off his right ear.

- and attacked the high priest's servant, cutting off his right ear.
- and cut off the right ear of the leading priest's slave,

struck the servant of the high priest, cutting off his right ear: Peter swung the sword at one of those arresting Jesus but only cut off his right ear. The two verbs struck and cutting off refer to a single action. So in some languages it may be natural to translate this with only one independent verb, like “slash” (cut with a large motion). For example:

and slashed at the High Priest's servant, cutting off his right ear (JBP)

servant: The word that the BSB translates as servant is also translated as “slave” in some English versions. It indicates that this man worked for the high priest without getting wages. However this is not the most important point. The important point is that this man was in the service of the high priest.

In some language it is more natural to use a verb to express the idea. For example:

cut off the ear of a man who worked for the high priest

18:10c

The servant's name was Malchus.

- (That servant was called Malchus.)
- a man named Malchus.

The servant's name was Malchus: This is additional information that is not part of the main story. Translate this additional information in the way that is most natural in your language. Some English translations place it in parentheses. For example:

(The servant's name was Malchus.) (NIV)

General Comment on 18:10b–c

In some languages it is more natural to combine 18:10b and 18:10c. For example:

^{10b–c}and slashed off the right ear of Malchus, the high priest's slave (NLT)

John 18:11

Section 18:1–11: The authorities arrested Jesus

This section tells how Judas led the Jewish and Roman authorities to Jesus to arrest him. Their guards arrested Jesus in a garden, and he did not resist them.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was arrested

The Jewish and Roman authorities arrested Jesus

Jesus' enemies caused him to be arrested

Paragraph 18:10–11

Peter used his sword to try to prevent the guards from arresting Jesus. But Jesus told him not to resist his arrest.

18:11a

“Put your sword back in its sheath!” Jesus said to Peter.

- Jesus said to Peter, “Put your^(sing) sword down/away!
- Jesus commanded Peter, “Stop! Put your^(sing) knife back in its case!

The Greek text of 18:11a includes a conjunction that is often translated “So.” Some English translations translate it that way to begin the verse, referring back to 18:10b. However, here it probably just indicates the end of the parenthetical information in 18:10c. You may need to indicate the end of the parenthetical information and the return to the main story. If so, do that in a way that is natural in your language. If you put parentheses around 18:10c, that may be all you need.

Put your sword back in its sheath!: Jesus was commanding Peter not to resist the guards. He did not want Peter to fight them and try to prevent them from arresting him. Here are other ways to translate this command:

Put your sword away! (NIV)

Put your sword back in its place. (GNT)

in its sheath: A sheath is a case or container for a sword. It is usually attached to a belt that was tied around the waist. In some cultures a sheath may not be well known. Here are other ways to translate this clause that may be more natural in those cultures:

Put your sword back in its place. (GNT)

Put your sword back where it was. (TH)

Jesus said to Peter: Here Simon Peter is referred to as just Peter. Jesus told Peter what to do next. He gave Peter a command. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that in the verb. For example:

Jesus commanded Peter

18:11b

“Shall I not drink the cup the Father has given Me?”

- Do you^(sing) not realize that I must drink the cup of suffering/wrath that my Father has given me?”
- Certainly I must accept the suffering that my Father has planned for me.”

Shall I not drink the cup the Father has given Me?:

This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer “Yes, I must drink it.” Jesus was emphasizing that he should and would drink the cup that the Father gave him. This strong statement is a rebuke. Jesus rebuked Peter for trying to protect him. Jesus knew that God planned for him to suffer and die. And he was determined to do what God planned for him to do.

There are several ways to translate this strong statement:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think that I will not drink the cup of suffering which my Father has given me? (CEV)

Am I not to drink the cup that the Father has given me? (NET)

- Use a question with the answer supplied. For example:

Will I drink the cup the Father has given me? Yes, I certainly will.

- Use a statement. For example:

I must drink from the cup that the Father has given me. (CEV)

Because the Father has given me this cup, I will drink it.

Translate this strong statement in a way that is natural in your language.

drink the cup: This expression is an idiom that means “endure suffering or God’s wrath.” It is a metaphor in which the cup is seen as containing suffering or God’s wrath. Drinking the cup, then, means “accepting that suffering or wrath.” See how this expression is used in Psalm 75:8; Isaiah 51:17; Jeremiah 25:15; Ezekiel 23:31–33, and how John used it in Revelation 14:10 and 16:19. See also Matthew 20:22–23 and 26:39.

In some languages it may be natural to make some of the meaning of this figure of speech explicit. For example:

Shall I not drink from the cup of suffering the Father has given me? (NLT)

Do you think that I am not willing to endure the suffering which my Father has planned for me?

Because the Father has planned for me to endure his wrath, that is what I will do.

the Father has given Me: This clause means “God the Father has planned for me to endure.” In some languages it is more natural to indicate that Jesus was speaking of his own Father. For example:

my Father has planned for me to suffer

which my Father wants me to do

John 18:12

Section 18:12–14: The soldiers and police took Jesus to the high priest

This section tells how the Jewish and Roman authorities took Jesus to Annas the Jewish high priest for trial.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was taken to the high priest

The authorities arrested Jesus and took him to Annas, the high priest

Jesus was bound and taken to the high priest

18:12a

Then the band of soldiers, with its commander and the officers of the Jews, arrested Jesus

- ¶ Then the soldiers, their captain and the Jewish temple guards arrested Jesus,
- ¶ Then the Roman officer, with his men and the Jewish guards, seized/grabbed Jesus.

Then the band of soldiers, with its commander and the officers of the Jews, arrested Jesus: The guards who had come to the garden arrested Jesus.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next thing that happened in the story. However, it also indicates the result of Jesus being determined to drink the cup that his Father gave him. A few English translations leave the word implied. Here is another way to translate this conjunction:

So (NRSV)

the band of soldiers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the band of soldiers refers to the detachment/group of Roman soldiers mentioned in 18:3. Refer back to them in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the Roman soldiers (GNT)

the group of soldiers

with its commander: This phrase refers to the head or chief soldier, the man who was leading the group of soldiers. For example:

their commanding officer (GNT)

their captain (ESV)

the officers of the Jews: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as officers is the same as in 18:3. The phrase the officers of the Jews is more literally “the guards of the Jews.” Translate this phrase in a way that indicates that it refers to the same temple guards mentioned in 18:3. For example:

Jewish guards (GNT)

temple police (NLT)

arrested Jesus: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as arrested here refers to seizing/catching a person suspected of wrongdoing in order to question and punish him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

seized Jesus (NJB)

grabbed Jesus (JBP)

General Comment on 18:12a

In some languages it may be natural to mention the officer in charge of the soldiers first. For example:

The Roman officer and his men, together with the temple police, arrested Jesus. (CEV)

18:12b and bound Him.

- and they tied him up.
- They tied his hands behind his back with ropes.

and bound Him: The verb bound means “tied up.” The guards tied Jesus’ arms together, probably behind his back. For example:

They tied Jesus up. (GW)

John 18:13

Section 18:12–14: The soldiers and police took Jesus to the high priest

This section tells how the Jewish and Roman authorities took Jesus to Annas the Jewish high priest for trial.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was taken to the high priest

The authorities arrested Jesus and took him to Annas, the high priest

Jesus was bound and taken to the high priest

18:13a

They brought Him first to Annas,

- They led Jesus first to a man named Annas.
- The first ruler/leader to whom they took Jesus was Annas.

They brought Him: The verb brought here means “led.” It indicates that the guards forced Jesus to go where they wanted him to go. For example:

First they led him (ESV)

and brought him first (NIV)

They: This pronoun refers to the men who arrested Jesus.

first: This word indicates that the guards took Jesus to Annas before any other place. Later, they took him to the other authorities, Caiaphas and the Roman governor Pilate.

Annas: Annas had been the Jewish high priest for 15 years. However, the Roman government removed him from that job and appointed his son-in-law Caiaphas in his place. The Jews still respected Annas because they believed that their high priest should be high

priest all his life. And he had much power and influence as the oldest man in the high priest’s family.

18:13b

who was the father-in-law of Caiaphas, the high priest that year.

- Annas was father-in-law of Caiaphas, who was high priest at that time.
- The man who was the leading priest at that time, Caiaphas, had married Annas’ daughter.

who was the father-in-law of Caiaphas: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as who was the father-in-law of Caiaphas is more literally “because he was the father-in-law of Caiaphas.” This clause gives more information about Annas which explains why the guards took Jesus to him. In some languages it is more natural to make this a separate sentence. For example:

Annas was the father-in-law of Caiaphas.

father-in-law: This term here indicates that Caiaphas was married to Annas’ daughter.

the high priest that year: This phrase gives more information about Caiaphas, first mentioned in 11:49. See the note in 11:49, and how you translated this phrase there. In some languages it is more natural to make this a separate sentence. For example:

Caiaphas was the high priest at that time.

the high priest: The Greek word that the BSB translates as high priest refers to the most important of all the Jewish priests. He was the leader or chief of those who offered sacrifices to God in the Temple. In Jesus’ time, the high priest was also a political figure, the most important Jewish leader and judge. He was also the head of the Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority. See how you translated this term in 11:49. See also Priest, High Priest, Chief Priests, sense 2, the High Priest.

that year: The phrase that year here means “at that time.” Caiaphas was the high priest for several years, not just that one year. See the note on 11:49.

John 18:14

Section 18:12–14: The soldiers and police took Jesus to the high priest

This section tells how the Jewish and Roman authorities took Jesus to Annas the Jewish high priest for trial.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus was taken to the high priest

The authorities arrested Jesus and took him to Annas, the high priest

Jesus was bound and taken to the high priest

18:14a

Caiaphas was the one who had advised the Jews

- It was Caiaphas who had told the Jewish leaders
- Caiaphas was the one who earlier gave this advice to the Jewish council:

Caiaphas was the one who had advised the Jews:

This clause is a reference to John 11:50 and is given to remind the readers what was said there. It is background information, not part of the main story. See the General Comment on 18:14a–b.

Earlier, Caiaphas told the Jewish Council (the Sanhedrin) that Jesus should be killed so that the rest of the nation could live. This was what he advised or recommended. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Now it was Caiaphas who had advised the Jewish leaders (NET)

Caiaphas was the one who had told the other Jewish leaders (NLT)

the Jews: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Jews here refers to the Jewish ruling council known as the Sanhedrin. See the note on 11:47a. You may want to make this reference clearer. For example:

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

Caiaphas was himself one of the Jewish leaders. So it may be natural to make that clearer. For example:

the other Jewish leaders (NLT)

18:14b

that it would be better if one man died for the people.

- that it would be best to allow one person to die for the benefit of the people.
- “It would be good to allow one man Jesus to die in order to save the whole Jewish nation.”

it would be better if one man died for the people:

Caiaphas thought that they should kill Jesus for the benefit of all the Jews. He was afraid that if Jesus continued preaching and teaching, his followers might rebel against the Romans. Then the Romans would come and destroy the Jewish nation. See the notes in 11:50b, and how you translated the same idea there. For example:

it would be good if one man died for the people (NIV)

it would be for their benefit if one man died for the people

it would be better for one person to die so that all the people would not

If you are using footnotes, you may want to include a footnote referring to 11:50.

it would be better: In 11:50b, Caiaphas says, “It would be better for you,” where “you” refers to the other council members. Here the words “for you” are left out and only implied.

one man: This phrase refers to Jesus. Caiaphas meant that it was better for Jesus to die than for many people to die.

General Comment on 18:14b

Caiaphas’ advice is given as an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a direct quotation of his words. For example:

...who had told the Jewish leaders, “It is better if one person dies for the people.” (GW)

General Comment on 18:14a–b

This verse contains background information. In some languages it may be natural to place this information in parentheses. For example:

(Caiaphas was the one who, a little earlier, told the Jewish leaders that it was better that one person should die for the nation.)

John 18:15

Section 18:15–18: Peter denied Jesus

This section reports that Peter secretly followed Jesus to the home of the high priest. There he denied that he was a disciple of Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus' disciple

Peter denied knowing Jesus the first time

Peter said that he was not a follower of Jesus

Paragraph 18:15–17

Peter denied that he was one of Jesus' disciples.

18:15a

Now Simon Peter and another disciple were following Jesus.

- ¶ Simon Peter and one other disciple followed behind Jesus and those who arrested him.
- ¶ Two disciples, Simon Peter and another, followed Jesus to Annas' house.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now introduces background information about Simon Peter. It is not a time word. Introduce this new person in a way that is natural in your language.

Simon Peter and another disciple were following Jesus: Two of Jesus' disciples followed the crowd that had arrested Jesus. One of them was Simon Peter. See how you spelled his name in 18:10.

another disciple: The author did not state who this other disciple was. He was probably one of the 12, but we do not know which one. Some scholars think that it was John himself, but this is not indicated. You should not supply a name for this man, but only indicate that he was one of Jesus' disciples.

disciple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciple refers to a "learner" who is in a special relationship with a teacher. Here the word refers specifically to followers of Jesus. See how you translated this word in 18:1.

18:15b

Since that disciple was known to the high priest,

- The high priest knew this other disciple well, so
- Because the leading priest knew that other disciple,

Since that disciple was known to the high priest: This clause begins to explain how Peter and the "other disciple" could follow Jesus into the courtyard of the high priest's home. The high priest knew the second disciple, and probably the person guarding the gate in the wall knew him too.

Since: This word here introduces the reason why the other disciple was allowed into the courtyard. It means "because." Here are other ways to translate this word:

Because (NIV)

That other disciple was well known to the High Priest, so (GNT)

that disciple was known to the high priest: The high priest and the second disciple knew one another personally. Perhaps they were not friends but could have just been acquainted with each other, knowing each other, but not well. They may have known each other in the way a wealthy man knows a salesperson. One ancient manuscript suggests that this disciple used to sell fish to the high priest's household. Kostenberger p. 513, footnote 14, indicates that there is a reference in the noncanonical Gospel of the Hebrews to this disciple, assumed to be John, supplying fish to the court of the high priest while working for his father Zebedee.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was known is a passive verb. Here are some ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

That other disciple was acquainted with the high priest (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

The high priest knew that other disciple.

- Use a noun. For example:

That disciple was a friend of the high priest

that disciple: This phrase refers to the second unidentified disciple mentioned in 18:15a. Refer back to him in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

this disciple (NIV)

the high priest: This phrase here probably refers to Annas. Even though the high priest Caiaphas was mentioned last (18:13) this part of the story happened at Annas' house. This phrase refers to the leader of the priests. He was the most important (therefore high) priest. He was the president of the Sanhedrin, the Jewish ruling council. See how you translated high

priest in 18:13. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the leader priest (Yakan Back Translation)

the highest priest (Kankanaey Back Translation)

18:15c

he also went with Jesus into the courtyard of the high priest.

- he was able to go into the high priest's courtyard with Jesus,
- the servant at the door let him go into the high priest's courtyard with Jesus.
- he was allowed to enter the leading priest's courtyard with Jesus.

he also went with Jesus into the courtyard of the high priest: The high priest had a courtyard around his house and a wall around the courtyard. This wall had a gate. A servant, the gatekeeper, stood at the gate to allow some people to enter and to keep the others out. This servant let this disciple follow Jesus into the courtyard because the high priest (and apparently this servant) knew him.

he also went with Jesus: This unidentified disciple received permission to go with Jesus through the gate into the high priest's courtyard. It was because the high priest knew him that he received this permission. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

he was allowed to go/enter with Jesus

he was able to follow Jesus

into the courtyard of the high priest: In Jesus' day the houses of wealthy people were surrounded by a wall. The area inside the wall but outside the house was called the courtyard. (Everything inside the wall could be called a "compound.") The phrase the courtyard of the high priest refers to the area around the high priest's house that was inside the wall. The phrase the high priest here continues to refer to Annas. However, it is likely that Annas shared his compound and courtyard with his son-in-law Caiaphas. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

into his compound/courtyard

into the open space around the house (Karikari Back translation)

General Comment on 18:15a-b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of 18:15a-b. You could say that the guard at the gate allowed the disciple to enter the courtyard before saying why. For example:

That disciple was allowed to go with Jesus into the high priest's courtyard, because the high priest knew him.

John 18:16

Section 18:15-18: Peter denied Jesus

This section reports that Peter secretly followed Jesus to the home of the high priest. There he denied that he was a disciple of Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus' disciple

Peter denied knowing Jesus the first time

Peter said that he was not a follower of Jesus

Paragraph 18:15-17

Peter denied that he was one of Jesus' disciples.

18:16a

But Peter stood outside at the door.

- but Peter had to remain outside the courtyard.
- But she would not let Peter inside. He had to wait outside the gate.
- However, Peter was not allowed to enter the courtyard and was left standing outside the gate.

But Peter stood outside at the door: Here and through 18:18, Simon Peter is referred to as just Peter. The guard at the gate did not know Peter and did not allow Peter to come into the courtyard. So Peter remained outside the wall, near the gate to the compound. For example:

But Peter waited outside near the door. (NCV)

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But indicates the contrast between the other disciple going in and Peter staying outside.

Peter stood: The verb that the BSB translates as stood indicates that Peter had to wait outside the wall. He

was not allowed to enter the high priest's compound with Jesus and the guards and the other unidentified disciple. If a literal translation implies that Peter did not want to enter, it may be good to correct that idea. For example:

but Peter had to wait outside at the door (NIV)

but Peter was left standing at the door outside (JBP)

outside: This word refers to being in the street rather than in the courtyard. The courtyard was also outside because it did not have a roof, but it was inside the wall.

at the door: The word that the BSB translates as at the door here refers to the entrance to the courtyard. This entrance was an opening in the wall with a door to allow people to go in and out of the courtyard. A servant was at the door to open and close it. Translate this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

at the entrance

18:16b

Then the disciple who was known to the high priest went out

- The other disciple, the one whom the high priest knew, went back outside the gate.
- The other disciple, the leading priest's friend, went back to the gate to see if Peter could enter.

Then the disciple: This disciple is the same person who came with Peter and was introduced in 18:15. See how you referred to this person there.

who was known to the high priest: This clause tells which disciple John is talking about. See how you translated this idea in 18:15. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the disciple whom the high priest knew

the high priest's friend

went out: The verb that the BSB translates as went out refers to going outside the gate to speak to the guard standing there.

18:16c

and spoke to the doorkeeper, and brought Peter in.

- He talked to the person guarding the door about Peter, and brought him inside.
- He spoke to the servant girl/woman on duty at the door and asked her to allow Peter to enter, which she did. He brought Peter in with him.

spoke to the doorkeeper: This clause does not make explicit what the disciple said. However, the context implies that the disciple asked the guard to allow Peter to come into the courtyard. In some languages it is more natural to include some or all of this implicit information. For example:

asked the guard at the gate to allow Peter to enter the courtyard and she agreed

the doorkeeper: The phrase that the BSB translates as the doorkeeper refers to the female servant who was responsible for allowing visitors to enter the courtyard. We do not know how old she was. Some translations say "woman" and some say "girl." However her age is not important. Use the expression that is natural for a female servant with this role. For example:

the guard^(fem)

the girl on duty at the door (REB)

and brought Peter in: This clause indicates that the guard allowed Peter to enter, and that the other disciple then returned with Peter into the courtyard. In some languages it is more natural to translate this clause with the guard as the subject. For example:

and she let Peter in (NLT)

General Comment on 18:15c,16c

The woman guarding the gate is not mentioned until 18:16c, but 18:15c implies that the guard allowed the unidentified disciple to enter. In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information and mention the servant at the gate in 18:15c. For example:

^{15c} The woman guarding the gate allowed that disciple to enter the high priest's courtyard with Jesus.... ^{16c}He spoke to the guard at the gate...

John 18:17

Section 18:15–18: Peter denied Jesus

This section reports that Peter secretly followed Jesus to the home of the high priest. There he denied that he was a disciple of Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus' disciple

Peter denied knowing Jesus the first time

Peter said that he was not a follower of Jesus

Paragraph 18:15–17

Peter denied that he was one of Jesus' disciples.

18:17a

At this, the servant girl watching the door said to Peter, “Aren’t you also one of this man’s disciples?”

- The woman guarding the door asked Peter, “You^(sing) could not be one of Jesus’ disciples too, could you?”
- The servant girl/woman said to Peter, “Surely you^(sing) are not another of Jesus’ disciples, are you?”

the servant girl watching the door said to Peter:

What follows this quote introducer is a question. So it may be natural to indicate that more clearly. For example:

The servant girl at the gate asked Peter

the servant girl: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates the servant girl is more literally “the female-servant the gatekeeper.” It refers to the woman or girl guarding the gate, the one mentioned in 18:16c. It adds to the information in 18:16c that this person was a servant or slave. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The servant who was guarding the gate

The servant girl at the door (ESV)

Another way to say that the woman at the gate was a servant is to add that information in 18:16c. Then you can just refer to the woman or girl here. For example:

^{16c}spoke to the servant girl who was guarding the gate, and brought Peter in. ^{17a}The girl said to Peter...

Aren’t you also one of this man’s disciples?: There are three ways to interpret this question:

1. The question expects a “No” answer, meaning that she did not expect that Peter was a disciple. For example:

You’re not one of this man’s disciples too, are you?
(NET) (NET, ESV, NIV, NRSV, NASB, NLT)

1. The question expects a “Yes” answer, meaning that she did expect that Peter was a disciple: For example:

Aren’t you one of this man’s disciples too? (GW)
(BSB, GNT, CEV, NCV, KJV, RSV, NJB, GW)

1. The question is asking for information and does not expect a particular answer. For example:

Are you another of this man’s disciples? (REB)
(REB)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). Usually the way that the question is asked in Greek expects a negative answer.

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Peter.

also: This word here means “as well as that other man.” The female servant knew that the other disciple was one of Jesus’ disciples, but she did not know about Peter.

this man’s disciples: This phrase refers to Jesus’ disciples. See how you translated the word “disciple” in 18:15. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the disciples of that man (GNT)

that man’s followers (NCV)

one of the disciples of that man Jesus (TH)

18:17b

“I am not,” he answered.

- Peter answered “Not me!”
- Peter replied “No, I am not one of his disciples.”

I am not: This clause here is short for “No, I am not one of Jesus’ disciples.” Translate this in a way that is natural in your language for a strong negative answer. For example:

No, I am not! (CEV)

he answered: In some languages it is natural to tell to whom Peter was talking. For example:

He answered her

Peter said to the girl/maid

John 18:18

Section 18:15–18: Peter denied Jesus

This section reports that Peter secretly followed Jesus to the home of the high priest. There he denied that he was a disciple of Jesus.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus' disciple

Peter denied knowing Jesus the first time

Peter said that he was not a follower of Jesus

Paragraph 18:18

This paragraph explains what the people in the courtyard were doing while Annas was questioning Jesus.

18:18a

Because it was cold,

- Because the air was cold in the courtyard,
- (Because the night was cold,

The Greek text begins this verse with a word that indicates the beginning of some parenthetical information. Some English versions translate it as "Now." The NET puts this verse in parentheses. Indicate that this verse is parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

Because it was cold: This clause refers to the weather. The air was cold. Refer to the weather here using an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

Because of the cold

Because of the cool/chilly weather

Because the night was cold

18:18b

the servants and officers were standing around a charcoal fire they had made

- ¶ the household servants and guards had started a fire with charcoal.
- ¶ the high priest's servants and guards earlier took some coal and built a fire,

the servants and officers were standing around a charcoal fire they had made: This verse gives some parenthetical background information that tells the setting of the event in 18:25–27.

the servants: The Greek word that the BSB translates as servants refers to people who worked for Annas in his house. They were domestic workers/servants who were not paid wages. It is the same word that is used in 4:51b. See the note there and how you translated the word in that verse. For example:

the slaves (NRSV)

officers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as officers refers to people who worked for Annas outside his house. It probably refers to the temple guards or those giving protection. They were not employed by the local government as modern police are. It is good to use a general word referring to armed men who give protection. See the note and how you translated this word in 18:3b. For example:

guards (GNT)

temple police (CEV)

were standing around a charcoal fire they had made: This phrase indicates that these servants and guards had built and lit a fire using charcoal (coal). For example:

the servants and guards had built a fire (NCV)

were standing around a charcoal fire: This phrase refers to standing close to the fire to make themselves warm.

18:18c

to keep warm.

- They were standing around the fire to get warm.
- and they stood by the fire to warm themselves.

to keep warm: This phrase explains why the men were standing around the fire. It was cold and so they wanted to get warm.

General Comment on 18:18a–c

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange 18:18a–c and put the reason for the people's actions last. For example:

^{18a}The servants and guards had built a fire ^{18c}and were standing around it warming themselves, ^{18b}because it was cold.

Now the slaves and the guards were standing around a charcoal fire they had made, warming themselves because it was cold. (NET)

18:18d

And Peter was also standing with them, warming himself.

- Peter went and stood with them there to get warm also.
- Peter joined them and warmed himself by the fire too.)

And Peter was also standing with them, warming himself: This is additional information that sets the scene and prepares the reader for a later part of the story.

them: This pronoun refers to the servants and guards mentioned in 18:18a.

warming himself: This phrase tells why Peter was standing with the servants and guards. See how you translated the similar phrase “warming themselves” in 18:18c.

John 18:19

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:19–21

The high priest questioned Jesus. He was trying to find some excuse for condemning Jesus to death.

18:19a

Meanwhile, the high priest questioned Jesus

- ¶ Meanwhile the high priest asked Jesus questions
- ¶ While this was happening, the leading priest asked Jesus,

Meanwhile: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as Meanwhile here indicates that the author was returning to his account of Jesus and Annas. It also indicates the end of the parenthetical information in 18:18. Here the word does not introduce the next in a series of events. The high priest questioned Jesus at the same time as Peter warmed himself by the fire. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

While this was happening (NET)

the high priest questioned Jesus: It appears from the total context (see 18:18, 18:24) that the phrase the high priest here refers to Annas. He had been the high priest before Caiaphas. Many Jews still considered him to be the real high priest even though the Romans had replaced him with Caiaphas. To avoid confusion, it may help to include a footnote saying that the high priest here refers to Annas.

questioned Jesus: This phrase indicates that Annas asked Jesus some questions. He was trying to find a reason to condemn Jesus. His questions were not friendly. Use an expression that is natural to refer to interrogating someone (what lawyers or police do when they question someone that they think is guilty). For example:

interrogated Jesus

18:19b

about His disciples and His teaching.

- about his disciples/followers and what he had taught them.
- “Tell me about your followers and what you taught them.”

about His disciples and His teaching: The high priest wanted to know about Jesus' disciples and what he had taught them.

about His disciples: This phrase probably indicates that the high priest asked Jesus how many disciples he had and what they did. Earlier (11:48), the Jewish

leaders were concerned about how many followers Jesus had. So here the high priest was probably asking about all of Jesus' followers and not just the 12. For example:

about his followers (NLT)

and His teaching: The phrase His teaching refers to what Jesus had been teaching his disciples. The high priest implied that Jesus may have been secretly teaching false, and therefore dangerous, ideas. In some languages it is more natural to translate this with a verb or clause. For example:

what you have taught them

General Comment on 18:19a–b

This is indirect speech. In some languages it is more natural to use direct speech. For example:

^{19a}The high priest asked Jesus, ^{19b}“How many disciples do you have? And what have you been teaching them?”

“Tell me about your disciples.” the high priest asked him. “What did you teach them?”

John 18:20

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:19–21

The high priest questioned Jesus. He was trying to find some excuse for condemning Jesus to death.

18:20a

“I have spoken openly to the world,” Jesus answered.

- Jesus answered, “I have spoken in public to large audiences.
- Jesus answered, “I have taught quite publicly.

I have spoken openly to the world: This clause indicates that Jesus had preached in places where people in general, the public, could hear him. He had taught openly (publicly), and so, he implied, everyone was aware of what he taught. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I have always spoken publicly to everyone (GNT)

I have spoken freely in front of everyone. (CEV)

I have always spoken quite openly to the world (JBP)

It was in public that I taught.

openly: The Greek word that the BSB translates as openly means “in public.” Jesus did not teach secretly, like someone trying to cause trouble for the government. In some languages it may be natural to translate openly with a negative. For example:

not secretly

not hidden

to the world: The word world here refers to people in general, as opposed to Jesus' disciples alone. Use a natural phrase or idiom to indicate this. For example:

to the public

to anyone and everyone

to people in general

Jesus answered: This quotation introducer is short for “Jesus answered the high priest.” The Greek is more literally “Jesus answered him.”

18:20b

“I always taught in the synagogues and at the temple,

- I have regularly taught in the Jewish places of worship, both in the towns and in the temple courtyard
- What I said I always spoke/preached in our^(incl) teaching places and worship places,

18:20c

where all the Jews come together.

- where the Jews all meet/gather.
- everywhere we^(incl) Jews come to worship.

18:20b–c

I always taught in the synagogues and at the temple, where all the Jews come together: This sentence gives examples of the places where Jesus had taught. They were places where the Jews assembled (gathered). Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I always taught in the synagogues and in the temple courts, where all the Jewish people assemble together. (NET)

I have always taught in synagogues or in the temple courtyard, where all the Jews gather. (GW)

all my teaching was done in the synagogues and in the Temple, where all the people come together (GNT)

always: This word here means that Jesus did not hide or change his message. What he said to his disciples in private, he also said in public. He did not hide or change his message in public. It does not mean that he never taught his disciples in private. And Jesus did teach people outside on the side of a mountain or near a lake. But again, his message did not change. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

regularly (NLT)

What I taught I always taught in synagogues or at the temple, where all the Jews gather together.

taught: In some languages it is more natural to tell whom Jesus taught. For example:

taught the people

taught the crowds

taught them

synagogues: This word refers to the places that the Jews met to worship and pray. Almost every village had at least one synagogue. The word is plural because Jesus was referring to various synagogues in many different towns and villages. See the note on “synagogue” at 6:59 and how you translated this word there. For example:

our meeting places (CEV)

the temple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as temple here refers to the entire temple area, including the courtyard. People did not meet inside the temple building because only the priests could go there. You may want to make this clear. For example:

the temple courts (NET)

the temple courtyard (GW)

You may want to follow this model if your word for “temple” makes people think that they met inside the temple building.

Here are some other ways to translate the term temple in this context:

- Use a descriptive phrase. For example:

courtyard of the house of God

courtyard of the house of worship

holy/sacred house courtyard

- If your language has a word for “temple,” consider using it. But you may need to include a description. For example:

courtyard of the temple of the Jews/Lord

big/great temple courtyard

See Temple, A.1, in KBT for more information about the temple and how to translate the word. See how you translated it in 2:14.

where all the Jews come together: This is a description of the previous places mentioned. It contrasts with being in secret. Because Jesus and his listeners were all Jews themselves, it may be natural to imply that in the translation. For example:

where the people gather (NLT)

where we^(incl) Jews meet

where all of our people come together (CEV)

18:20d

I said nothing in secret.

- I did not teach secret things.
- I did not hide anything I taught.

I said nothing in secret: This clause means the same as “I have spoken openly to the world” in 18:20a. It indicates that Jesus did not give secret teachings to his disciples. He did sometimes talk privately with his disciples (for example, when he explained his parables to them). However, his message when he was with his disciples was the same as when he spoke in public. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I did not hide any of my teaching.

I have never said anything in secret. (GNT)

I have not given any secret teachings.

John 18:21

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:19–21

The high priest questioned Jesus. He was trying to find some excuse for condemning Jesus to death.

18:21a

Why are you asking Me?

- Why do you^(sing) need to ask me about what I have taught?
- You^(sing) do not need me to tell you what I have said.

Why are you asking Me?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. Jesus was rebuking the high priest for questioning him about his teaching. He implied that he did not need to ask him. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question to express rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why do you ask me? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

So you do not need to ask me about my teachings.

Use whichever form is most natural for expressing rebuke in your language.

18:21b

Ask those who heard My message.

- You^(sing) can ask any of those who heard me teach about what I said
- Instead, you^(sing) should ask the people who heard my teaching.

Ask those who heard My message: Jewish law stated that it was the witnesses who should be questioned, not the person on trial. So Jesus said the high priest should be asking witnesses about his teaching. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Ask the people who heard my teaching. (NCV)

You should ask those who heard what I said.

Why don't you ask the people who heard me? (CEV)

those who heard My message: This clause refers in general to the many people who had heard Jesus speak. Some had heard him speak in one of the synagogues, and some had heard him speak in the temple courtyard. Some of those in the Jewish council heard Jesus teach.

18:21c

Surely they know what I said.”

- because they know everything that I taught.”
- They can tell you what I taught.”

Surely they know what I said: This clause indicates that the people who heard Jesus knew what he said. It also implies that they could tell the high priest what he said. For example:

they can tell you what I said

John 18:22

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:22–24

One of the guards slapped Jesus because he thought that Jesus did not show respect for the high priest.

18:22a

When Jesus had said this, one of the officers standing nearby slapped Him in the face

- ¶ When Jesus said this to the high priest one of the temple guards who stood near him slapped him in the face.
- ¶ Because Jesus answered the leading priest that way, a guard who stood nearby slapped/hit his face.

When Jesus had said this: This refers to what Jesus said in 18:20–21.

one of the officers: This refers to one of the guards who had arrested Jesus. See the note and how you translated officers in 18:3b. For example:

one of the Temple guards (NLT)

one of the police (NRSV)

standing nearby: This phrase indicates that this guard was standing near Jesus. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

standing near Jesus (GW)

slapped Him in the face: This phrase indicates that this guard struck (hit) or slapped (hit with an open hand) Jesus on his face. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

slapped his face (GW)

slapped Jesus across the face (NLT)

hit him in the face

18:22b

and said, “Is this how You answer the high priest?”

- He said to Jesus, “Should you^(sing) talk that way to the high priest?”
- The guard told him, “You^(sing) must not talk rudely like that to the leading priest.”

Is this how You answer the high priest?: This is a rhetorical question. It implies the answer “no.” This is a rebuke. The guard rebuked Jesus for the way Jesus had talked to the high priest. The Jewish law forbade speaking with no respect to the rulers (see Exodus 22:28). The guard thought that Jesus was rude and did not show respect. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

How dare you speak that way to the high priest?

- Use a statement. For example:

That’s no way to talk to the high priest! (CEV)

That is not the right/proper way to talk to the high priest.

Use whichever form is most natural to express rebuke in your language.

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that the guard thought that Jesus’ answer was rude or did not show respect. For example:

Is that a respectful way to answer the high priest?

You should not answer the high priest in that rude way!

John 18:23

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:22–24

One of the guards slapped Jesus because he thought that Jesus did not show respect for the high priest.

18:23a

Jesus replied, “If I said something wrong, testify as to what was wrong.”

- Jesus replied, “If I said something wrong to the high priest, then tell/explain what I said that was wrong.
- Jesus said to the guard, “If I have spoken to the leading priest in a bad/evil way, then give evidence about it.

Jesus replied: In some languages it is more natural to make explicit whom Jesus spoke to. For example:

Jesus said to the guard

If I said something wrong, testify as to what was wrong: This sentence is the first part of Jesus’ response to the police/guard. It implies that Jesus did not say anything wrong. Jesus challenged the guard to tell him what wrong he had said. He implies that the guard cannot say what wrong he said because he said nothing wrong. For example:

If I said anything wrong, you must prove it. (NLT)

If I have said anything wrong, tell everyone here what it was. (GNT)

If I said something wrong: This is a conditional clause and refers to how Jesus had spoken to the high priest. The condition in this kind of clause could be

true or false. Here it was false, but Jesus allowed the possibility that it was true. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If I have spoken wrongly (NRSV)

If I have said anything wrong (JBP)

testify as to what was wrong: This phrase means “tell the truth about what was wrong/rude in my answer.”

then show what it was (NCV)

you must give evidence about it (JBP)

18:23b

But if I spoke correctly, why did you strike Me?”

- But if I told the truth, why did you^(sing) slap me?”
- But because what I said was right, you^(sing) should not have slapped me.”

But if I spoke correctly, why did you strike Me?: This question is the second part of Jesus’ response to the police/guard. It implies that Jesus did speak rightly (correctly). Jesus again challenged the guard’s action, here asking him to justify hitting him. Here are other ways to translate this question:

But if I’ve told the truth, why do you hit me? (GW)

But if not, why did you hit me? (CEV)

But: This word here indicates a contrast between saying something wrong and saying something true and suitable.

if I spoke correctly: This is a conditional clause that was true and the sentence implies that. However, like the clause in 18:23a, it allows the possibility that it could be true or false. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

if I’m speaking the truth (NLT)

if what I said is true (NCV)

if I am right in what I have said (GNT)

I spoke correctly: This clause refers to what Jesus said in 18:20–21. There he said that many people heard

his teaching, and told the high priest to ask them what he taught. This was both true and suitable, so it was not rude or lacking respect.

why did you strike Me?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used as a rebuke. The guard had struck Jesus without just cause. There are at least two ways to translate this rhetorical question to express rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question:

why do you hit me? (GNT, GW, NCV)

Should you hit a man for telling the truth? (NLT96)

- Use a statement. For example:

You should not have hit me.

Use whichever form is most natural to express rebuke in your language.

did you strike Me: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as did you strike is singular and refers to what the guard did. It is a different verb than the one used in 18:22a, though it refers to the same action. The verb strike refers to an action that had just happened. It may therefore be natural to use a past tense verb, as in the BSB.

John 18:24

Section 18:19–24: The high priest questioned Jesus

This section tells how Annas, the Jewish high priest, questioned Jesus about his disciples and his teaching. Jesus said that he spoke in public, so he could ask others what he taught. A policeman struck Jesus because he thought that he was rude, but Jesus asked him what he did wrong. Annas then sent him to Caiaphas.

Here are other possible section headings:

The high priest Annas investigated Jesus

Annas questioned Jesus and then sent him to Caiaphas

Jesus appeared before the high priest

Paragraph 18:22–24

One of the guards slapped Jesus because he thought that Jesus did not show respect for the high priest.

18:24

Then Annas sent Him, still bound, to Caiaphas the high priest.

- Annas sent Jesus, whose hands were still tied, to the high priest, whose name was Caiaphas.
- Annas told the guards to take Jesus, still tied up, to the leading priest Caiaphas.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then here introduces the next event in the story.

Annas sent Him, still bound, to Caiaphas the high priest: Annas had finished questioning Jesus, and so he sent him to his son-in-law, the high priest Caiaphas, for a trial.

sent Him: This phrase here indicates that Annas told the guards to take Jesus.

bound: This verb means “tied up.” Jesus’ hands were still tied behind him. See the note on 18:12b and how you translated the word there.

In some languages it is more natural to make this a separate sentence. For example:

He was still tied up.

His hands were still tied.

The guards kept his hands tied.

to Caiaphas the high priest: Annas sent Jesus to be tried by Caiaphas before the Sanhedrin, the chief council of the Jews. Caiaphas, as the high priest, was the only one who could call a meeting of the Sanhedrin. He would also lead that meeting. However John does not record anything about this meeting.

John 18:25

Section 18:25–27: Peter denied Jesus again

The events in this section took place outside the high priest’s house at the same time that they questioned Jesus inside. Peter twice more denied that he was a follower of Jesus. Then the cock crowed.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus’ disciple two more times

Peter denied knowing Jesus twice more

Peter again said that he was not a follower of Jesus

18:25a

Simon Peter was still standing and warming himself.

- ¶ Meanwhile, Simon Peter stood in the courtyard near the fire to be warm.
- ¶ Peter remained standing outside, warming himself by the fire.

The Greek conjunction that begins this verse is left implicit in the BSB. It indicates two things. First, it indicates a return to the story about Peter. Second, it indicates that this is the beginning of parenthetical information. Here are other ways to translate this clause to indicate at least one of those things:

Meanwhile, Simon Peter was still standing there warming himself (NIV)

While Simon Peter was standing there warming himself (CEV)

Simon Peter was still standing and warming himself:

This clause is not new information but it brings the story back to Peter. It repeats the information that Peter was standing outside among the guards and servants and warming himself (see 18:18). This is also parenthetical, background information, not a main event in the story. This was happening at the same time that Annas was questioning Jesus. Translate this in the way that is natural in your language for returning to a story that was interrupted. For example:

Peter was still standing there keeping himself warm. (GNT)

Simon Peter: See how you translated this name in 18:10 and 18:15.

standing and warming himself: Peter was standing with the servants by the fire. See how you translated this idea in 18:18.

18:25b

So they asked him, “Aren’t you also one of His disciples?”

- The people there asked him, “You^(sing) could not be one of Jesus’ disciples, could you?”
- Some/One of those there said to him, “Surely you^(sing) are not one of Jesus’ disciples, are you?”

So: The BSB translates literally the Greek conjunction as So. This word indicates the end of the parenthetical information in 18:25a. It is sometimes translated “therefore” and some English translations translate it that way here. Other translations leave the word implicit. It is recommended that you indicate the end of the parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

they asked him: This clause indicates that one or more of the people standing around the fire with Peter asked the question. In some languages it is more natural to use a singular subject. For example:

One of those standing there asked Peter

Because the speakers are not identified, in some language it may be natural to use a passive verb. For example:

Peter was asked

Peter was asked questions about Jesus

Aren’t you also one of His disciples?: This is a question is almost the same as the one in 18:17. As with that verse, there are different ways to understand this question. See the note at 18:17a for a description of the issue. Again it is recommended that you interpret the question as one that expects a negative answer (Peter was not a disciple). Here are other ways to translate this question:

You aren’t one of Jesus’ disciples too, are you?

also: The word also here means “as well as the other disciples.” It does not imply that the speakers were disciples. If a literal translation would give that wrong idea, it is best to leave this word implied or untranslated.

His disciples: The pronoun His refers to Jesus. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit:

Jesus’ disciples/followers

those who follow Jesus

disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples refers to “learners” or “followers” who commit themselves to their teacher. They do that in

order to learn and follow his teaching and example. See how you translated this word in 18:15.

18:25c

He denied it and said, “I am not.”

- Peter said it was not true; he said, “No, I am not.” (NCV)
- Peter said, “No, I am not one of his disciples.”
- And Peter denied that it was so/true.

He denied it and said, “I am not.”: The verbs denied and said in this context refer to the same action, that of speaking. In some languages it is more natural to use only one verb, perhaps using indirect speech. For example:

Peter denied that it was true.

Peter said it was not true; he said, “No, I am not.” (NCV)

Peter denied that he was one of Jesus’ disciples.

I am not: This clause is short for “No, I am not one of Jesus’ disciples.” Include as much of the sentence as is natural in your language.

John 18:26

Section 18:25–27: Peter denied Jesus again

The events in this section took place outside the high priest’s house at the same time that they questioned Jesus inside. Peter twice more denied that he was a follower of Jesus. Then the cock crowed.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus’ disciple two more times

Peter denied knowing Jesus twice more

Peter again said that he was not a follower of Jesus

18:26a

One of the high priest’s servants, a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off,

- One of the high priest’s slaves present there was related to the man whose ear Peter had cut off.
- There was a servant of the leading priest there. He was a member of the family/clan of Malchus whose ear Peter had just/earlier cut off.

One of the high priest’s servants, a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off: This expression introduces one of the servants at the high priest’s house. It also tells us something significant about him: he was related to the man mentioned in 18:10. A few hours earlier Peter used his sword to cut off this other man’s right ear. This is important because it implies that this servant would remember who Peter was and would consider him an enemy.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this expression as two separate sentences. If you do this it may be necessary to make it explicit that this servant was there in the courtyard. For example:

One of the servants of the high priest was there. This servant was a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off. (NCV)

One of the high priest’s servants was there. He was a relative of the servant whose ear Peter had cut off. (CEV)

One of the high priest’s servants: The word servants can also be translated as “slaves” and refers to people who are not free and are not paid for their work. See how you translated this word in 18:18. The main idea in this phrase is that this man worked for the high priest. For example:

One of the slaves of the high priest (NRSV)

A man who worked in the high priest’s house

a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off:

The clause whose ear Peter had cut off refers back to the event recorded in 18:10. Peter had cut off the ear of one of those who arrested Jesus. The slave or servant mentioned here was related to that man. John does not say what the relationship was, so it is good to leave this general. In some languages it may be natural to translate this idea using a verb. For example:

who was related to the man whose ear Peter had cut off

Peter: Here and in the next verse Simon Peter is referred to as just Peter.

18:26b

asked, “Didn’t I see you with Him in the garden?”

- He said to Peter, “I saw you with Jesus when he was arrested, did I not?”
- He said to Peter, “You^(sing) were in the garden with that man, were you not? I saw you there!”

asked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as asked introduces a question that expects a positive answer. Translate this verb in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

challenged him (NIV)

said (NET)

insisted (REB)

Didn’t I see you with Him in the garden?: This is a rhetorical question that expects a positive answer: that Peter was in the garden. It is used to say that the man had seen Peter in the garden with Jesus. The man implied that because Peter was in the garden with Jesus, then he must be Jesus’ disciple. He was challenging Peter’s answer in 18:25, implying that he did not believe it. Here are other ways to translate this challenge:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Didn’t I see you in the garden with him? (NJB)

Didn’t I see you out there in the olive grove with Jesus? (NLT)

- Use a statement. For example:

I’m sure I saw you^(sing) there in the olive grove with that man!

You^(sing) were in the garden with Jesus—I saw you there!

with Him in the garden: The phrase the garden refers to the grove of trees where Jesus was arrested. (A grove is a piece of land where fruit or nut trees grow.) See how you translated the word garden in 18:1. Use the same expression in both verses so that the connection will be clear.

with Him: The pronoun Him refers to Jesus. Peter had been one of the disciples near Jesus when the guards came to arrest Jesus. In some languages it may be natural to translate this phrase in one of these ways:

with Jesus (GW)

with that man (CEV)

General Comment on 18:26

In Greek, 18:26 is one long sentence. In some languages it is more natural to break it into two or three sentences. For example:

One of the high priest’s servants was there. He was a relative of the servant whose ear Peter had cut off, and he asked, “Didn’t I see you in the garden with that man?” (CEV)

One of the servants of the high priest was there. This servant was a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off. The servant said, “Didn’t I see you with him in the garden?” (NCV)

John 18:27

Section 18:25–27: Peter denied Jesus again

The events in this section took place outside the high priest’s house at the same time that they questioned Jesus inside. Peter twice more denied that he was a follower of Jesus. Then the cock crowed.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter denied being Jesus’ disciple two more times

Peter denied knowing Jesus twice more

Peter again said that he was not a follower of Jesus

18:27a

Peter denied it once more,

- Once more Peter said that it was not true.
- Another time Peter denied that he was a disciple/follower of Jesus.

The Greek text includes a conjunction that is often translated as “then” or “therefore.” Here it indicates that what Peter said was a result of what the man said. Most English translations have left it implicit, because that is more natural in English.

Peter denied it once more: Earlier, Jesus told Peter that before the cock/rooster crowed, Peter would say three times that he did not know Jesus (see 13:38). This was the third time. (The other times are in 18:17 and 18:25.)

In your translation, avoid indicating that Peter had already denied being in the garden. This was the only time that he specifically denied that. He had already twice denied that he was a disciple of Jesus. Here, by denying that he was in the garden with Jesus, Peter implied that he was not his disciple.

Here are some of the ways that this clause can be translated:

Again Peter said “No” (GNT)

So Peter said it wasn’t true. (NCV)

once more: This word refers to this being the third time Peter denied that he was Jesus’ disciple.

In translating this word, consider what exactly Peter denied. Peter implicitly/indirectly denied that he was a disciple of Jesus. He denied directly that he had been in the garden with Jesus. The BSB has supplied the pronoun “it,” referring to the slave saying that he saw him with Jesus. English requires some object with the verb “denied.” Consider what object, if any, is natural in your language. Keep it general enough that the words once more are still suitable although the previous questions do not mention the garden. For example:

Again Peter denied what was accused

Again Peter said that what was said was false/wrong.

Again Peter denied knowing/following Jesus

18:27b and immediately a rooster crowed.

- Just then the cock/rooster crowed.
- As Peter spoke, a male chicken called out.

and immediately: The Greek word that the BSB translates as immediately refers to the time immediately after Peter denied knowing Jesus that third time.

a rooster: The word rooster means “male chicken.”

crowed: The verb crowed refers to the sound that a male chicken makes. It is a loud sound that is easily heard from inside a house. The importance of the cock/rooster crowing is that it fulfilled Jesus’ prediction to Peter in 13:38. Jesus predicted that before the cock/rooster crowed Peter would say three times that he did not know Jesus.

John 18:28

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:28–32

This paragraph begins the second part of Jesus' trial. (The second part, with Jesus before Caiaphas, is only mentioned in John. John does not say anything about what happened there.) The narrative moves from Peter back to Jesus.

The Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority, could try minor offenses, particularly those involving Jewish religious law and customs. However, it could not punish anyone with death on a cross. Only the Roman government had that authority. So the Jewish authorities took Jesus to the Roman governor to ask him to condemn Jesus to die on a cross.

18:28a

Then they led Jesus away from Caiaphas

- ¶ Then the Jewish authorities led/took Jesus from the high priest Caiaphas
- ¶ Then the guards and religious authorities brought Jesus away from the house of Caiaphas

Then: This conjunction indicates that the narrative is changing back from what happened to Peter to what happened to Jesus. See the General Comment on 18:28a–c for another way to introduce this action and paragraph.

they led Jesus away from Caiaphas: The pronoun they refers to the Jewish authorities in general. It was probably some Jewish guards and authorities who led Jesus away from the high priest's house. For example:

Then the Jewish leaders took Jesus from Caiaphas (NIV)

Jesus was taken from Caiaphas' house to the governor's palace. The Jews wouldn't go into the palace. (GW)

Then he was taken to the headquarters of the Roman governor. His accusers didn't go inside... (NLT)

led Jesus away: The verb led...away refers to leading Jesus away as a prisoner.

from Caiaphas: This phrase indicates that they all left Caiaphas' house. See how you referred to Caiaphas in 18:24.

18:28b

into the Praetorium.

- to governor Pilate's headquarters/house.
- to the palace/mansion of the Roman governor Pilate.

into the Praetorium: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as the Praetorium refers to the official house of the Roman governor. This was the house where the governor stayed when he was in Jerusalem. It included the offices of the Roman government, including the courtroom for trying criminals. Here are ways to translate this phrase:

the palace of the Roman governor (NIV)

the governor's headquarters (REB)

the headquarters of the Roman governor (NLT)

the building where the Roman governor stayed (CEV)

18:28c

By now it was early morning,

- It was early morning.
- The time was around sunrise.

By now it was early morning: This sentence indicates the time setting of the next part of the story. It was probably around sunrise. This is background or parenthetical information. The NET puts this sentence in parentheses. You may want to indicate that this sentence is parenthetical in a way that is natural in your language. Or you can follow the General Comment on 18:28a–c just below.

General Comment on 18:28a–c

In many languages it is more natural to rearrange 18:28a–c, and begin the new event with the new time. For example:

^{28c}Early in the morning ^{28a}Jesus was taken from Caiaphas' house ^{28b}to the governor's palace. (GNT)

^{28c}It was early in the morning ^{28a}when Jesus was taken from Caiaphas ^{28b}to the building where the Roman governor stayed. (CEV)

18:28d-f

This sentence continues with more background or parenthetical information. 18:28d indicates that Jesus' accusers did not enter the governor's house, and 18:28e-f explains why they did not enter. There were two connected reasons, one negative and one positive. The Jews wanted to avoid being defiled (ritually unclean) (negative) and so be able to celebrate the Passover feast (positive). In English there are many possible ways to indicate these connections. For example:

They did not go into the Praetorium themselves to avoid becoming defiled and unable to eat the Passover. (NJB)

The Jews would not go into the palace. They did not want to become unclean, because they wanted to eat the Passover meal.

His accusers didn't go inside because it would defile them, and they wouldn't be allowed to celebrate the Passover. (NLT)

They would not go inside the palace, because they did not want to make themselves unclean; they wanted to eat the Passover meal. (NCV)

Indicate the connections in this sentence in a way that is natural in your language. See the following notes for further examples of positive and negative verbs.

18:28d

and the Jews did not enter the Praetorium,

- The Jews did not go into the building/house
- Jesus' accusers stayed outside the governor's palace/mansion.

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and connects this clause to the previous clause. Some English versions do not translate the conjunction and begin a new sentence here. Connect this clause with the previous clause in a natural way in your language.

the Jews did not enter the Praetorium: This clause implies a contrast between where Jesus' accusers

went and where Jesus went (18:28a). Jesus' Jewish accusers did not go with Jesus inside the headquarters of the Roman governor.

the Jews: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the Jews is the pronoun "they," which refers back to the men who had brought Jesus as a prisoner from Caiaphas. They were his accusers. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

His accusers (NLT)

Some translations, like the NRSV, indicate the contrast between Jesus and his accusers by adding the word "themselves." That emphasizes the subject "they," which the Greek also does. You may emphasize the contrasting subject if that is natural in your language.

In many languages it may be natural here to supply the implied information that Jesus' accusers were Jewish, like the BSB does. This information helps explain why they acted as they did.

did not enter: In some languages it may be natural to translate this negative verb phrase with a positive one. For example:

stayed outside (REB)

waited outside (CEV)

18:28e

to avoid being defiled

- because they did not want to become unclean.
- They wanted to remain ritually clean

to avoid being defiled: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to avoid being defiled is more literally "so that they would not be defiled (made unclean)." Jews became defiled if they ate certain foods or touched a dead body, etc. Then they would not be able to worship God or celebrate Passover for a certain amount of time. This phrase indicates negative purpose: the Jews remained outside the governor's house to avoid becoming ritually defiled. If they had gone inside, they would have become ritually defiled. Here are other ways to translate this negative purpose:

because they did not want to make themselves unclean (NCV)

wanting to keep from being made unclean

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive clause. For example:

for they wanted to keep themselves ritually clean (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause. For example:

They didn't want to become unclean. (GW)

because it would defile them (NLT)

Any of them who had gone inside would have become unclean (CEV)

being defiled: This term refers to a state in which one was not allowed to attend a religious activity. In Jewish thought, one must be ritually clean or pure before he could come into God's presence. Therefore, if someone were defiled (impure or unclean) he could not approach God. See also Unclean, Defiled, Impure, Uncleaness, sense B.3.a in KBT

Jewish teaching (but not the Old Testament) said that Gentile (non-Jewish) homes were ritually unclean or impure. (See Acts 10:28.) So Jews who entered Gentile homes became defiled. They were therefore not allowed to join in public religious ceremonies such as the Passover. See Numbers 9:6, where Jews who were unclean could not celebrate the Passover that day. However, they were able to celebrate it later (see Numbers 9:7-12).

For the idea of ritual impurity, see Leviticus 11:24-26 and Mark 7:1-23. This idea had nothing to do with being physically dirty. Translate this idea in a way that will help your readers understand that it does not refer to literal, physical dirt. For example:

ceremonial uncleanness (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this abstract noun with a verb or adjective. For example:

be defiled (ESV)

they wanted to keep themselves ritually clean (GNT)

become unclean (GW)

18:28f and unable to eat the Passover.

- They would not be allowed to eat the Passover feast if they were unclean.
- so that they could eat/celebrate the Death-Passed-Over-Us meal/feast with the other Jews.

and unable to eat the Passover: This clause indicates the second reason why Jesus' Jewish accusers did not enter the governor's headquarters. They wanted to be able to continue take part in the Jewish Passover festival, which lasted a week. The celebration included the Feast of Unleavened Bread, which continued for seven days. Jewish customs said that if a Jew went into a house of a Gentile he would be ritually "unclean." Then he would not be allowed to join any religious activity or eat with other Jews until the next day.

So the two reasons for not entering the governor's headquarters were connected. If a Jew was ritually defiled, he could not eat the Passover with the Jewish community. Translate this second, connected purpose in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

they wanted to be able to eat the Passover (NIV)

but could eat the Passover meal (NET)

because they wanted to eat the Passover meal

in order to be able to eat the Passover meal (GNT)

eat the Passover: This phrase refers to eating a meal at night as part of the annual Passover festival. (Jesus and his disciples celebrated the first Passover night the evening before, but the celebration lasted a week.) It celebrated the night when God passed over the homes of the ancestors of the Jews, who were slaves in Egypt. For the story of the Passover see Exodus chapters 11-12. Also see the note on Passover in John 2:13a and how you translated it there and in 6:4, 11:55, and 13:1. Here are some ways to translate Passover:

meal to celebrate freedom from being slaves

Death-Passed-Over-Us festival

John 18:29

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:28–32

This paragraph begins the second part of Jesus' trial. (The second part, with Jesus before Caiaphas, is only mentioned in John. John does not say anything about what happened there.) The narrative moves from Peter back to Jesus.

The Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority, could try minor offenses, particularly those involving Jewish religious law and customs. However, it could not punish anyone with death on a cross. Only the Roman government had that authority. So the Jewish authorities took Jesus to the Roman governor to ask him to condemn Jesus to die on a cross.

18:29a

So Pilate went out to them

- So Pilate went outside to where they were
- Pilate went outside to talk with them.

So Pilate went out to them: The Roman governor, Pilate, went out of his house to talk to Jesus' accusers. Although Jews believed that entering a Gentile house would defile them, they could enter a courtyard and remain ritually clean. So it seems likely that they entered the courtyard and Pilate did not have to go outside the compound.

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information in 18:28c–f. It also indicates that Pilate went outside as a result of the Jews not entering his house.

Pilate: The name of the Roman governor of the province of Judea at this time was Pilate. Here is another way to translate this name:

Governor Pilate

Pilate, who was the governor,

them: This pronoun refers to the Jews who had come to accuse Jesus.

18:29b

and asked, “What accusation are you bringing against this man?”

- and said, “What crime do you accuse this man of committing?”
- He asked the Jews, “What did he do that is against the law?”

and asked: The verb asked here introduces a question, but could also be translated as “said.” In some languages it is more natural to tell whom Pilate asked. For example:

asked the council members

asked the high priest and those with him

What accusation are you bringing against this man?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as accusation means “what someone is accused of doing” or “what crime someone says another did.” To bring an accusation or charge is to accuse someone. Pilate asked Jesus’ accusers what wrong Jesus did. He wondered what they accused him of doing. Here are some ways that this question can be translated:

What crime did Jesus commit?

What Roman law did Jesus break?

What charges are you bringing against this man? (NIV)

What do you accuse this man of? (GNT)

accusation: An accusation is a charge or complaint that someone is guilty of some wrongdoing. Here the word is used in a legal setting, with Pilate being the judge. Use the legal expression that is common in your culture.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to Jesus’ accusers.

this man: This phrase refers to Jesus.

John 18:30

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

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The Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority, could try minor offenses, particularly those involving Jewish religious law and customs. However, it could not punish anyone with death on a cross. Only the Roman government had that authority. So the Jewish authorities took Jesus to the Roman governor to ask him to condemn Jesus to die on a cross.

18:30a–b

“If He were not a criminal,” they replied, “we would not have handed Him over to you.” In this sentence, Jesus' accusers did not answer Pilate's question directly. Instead, they implied that they had handed Jesus over to the Roman authorities because he was a criminal. See the General Comment on 18:30a–b for ways to rearrange the information in their answer.

The form of this answer uses a condition that the Jews believed was false. They believed that Jesus was a criminal, even though he was not, and that is why they brought him to Pilate. In some languages it is more natural to express this idea with direct positive statements. For example:

They answered, “He is a criminal! That's why we brought him to you.” (CEV)

They answered, “You can be sure that he is a criminal because we brought him to you.”

18:30a

“If He were not a criminal,” they replied,

- They answered Pilate “If this man did not commit a crime,
- They said to Pilate, “He is a criminal!

If He were not a criminal: This is a condition that the speakers implied was not true. They implied that Jesus was actually a criminal, even though he was not.

If: This connector introduces a condition that the speakers believed was not true.

He: This phrase refers to Jesus.

a criminal: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as a criminal is more literally “one doing evil” or “he who commits a crime.” There is a textual problem here. (1) Some Greek manuscripts have “were not a criminal.” For example: If this man were not a criminal (NET) (BSB, CEV, GW, NET, NLT, REB, NCV, NJB, KJV, NASB, NIV, RSV) (2) Some Greek manuscripts have “were not doing a crime.” For example: If this man were not doing evil (ESV) (GNT, ESV) The UBS Greek text gives option (2) a B rating. That is likely what the original manuscript said. However, the meaning of the two options is the same, and option (1) is more natural in English in this context. You should translate this phrase in the way that is most natural in your language. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language in a court setting. For example:

If he had not committed a crime

If this man were not doing evil (ESV)

If this Man were not an evildoer (NASB)

they replied: The pronoun they refers to the high priest and the council members who were accusing Jesus. They spoke to the Roman governor

18:30b

“we would not have handed Him over to you.”

- we would not have led him to you to judge/punish.”
- That is why we brought him before you for punishment.”

we would not have handed Him over to you: This clause tells what would have happened if the Jews believed that the condition in 18:30a was fulfilled. But because the accusers believed that Jesus was a criminal, they did hand him over to Pilate.

we: This pronoun is exclusive and refers to the Jewish religious leaders who were accusing Jesus but not to Pilate.

have handed Him over to you: The Greek phrase that the BSB has translated as handed...over to you means “have put/given into your power/control.” It was used in a legal sense of giving a prisoner to the authorities for them to guard. See how you translated this expression in Matthew 10:19, 27:18 and Mark 13:11. In this context it indicates that Jesus’ accusers had brought Jesus to the Roman governor to be judged and condemned. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

brought him to you (NCV)

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Pilate.

General Comment on 18:30a–b

In some languages it is more natural to place 18:30b before 18:30a. For example:

^{30b}We brought him to you to judge ^{30a}because he has done evil things.

We would not have brought him to you if he had not committed a crime. (GNT)

We only turned/handed him over to you because he is a criminal.

The only reason we brought him to you is because he committed a crime.

John 18:31

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

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The Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority, could try minor offenses, particularly those involving Jewish religious law and customs. However, it could not punish anyone with death on a cross. Only the Roman government had that authority. So the Jewish authorities took Jesus to the Roman governor to ask him to condemn Jesus to die on a cross.

18:31a

“You take Him and judge Him by your own law,” Pilate told them.

- Pilate said, “Take^(plur) him away and try/judge him yourselves, using your law.”
- Pilate said to the Jewish leaders, “You^(plur) take him to the Jewish court and judge him by Jewish laws.”

You take Him and judge Him by your own law: The high priest and the council members did not tell Pilate that Jesus had disobeyed a Roman law. Pilate was only responsible for punishing those who disobeyed Roman law. If Jesus disobeyed a Jewish law, the high priest was the one who would punish him. So Pilate wants the Jews to take Jesus.

You take Him: The Greek expression that the BSB translates literally as You take Him indicates that Pilate wanted the Jewish authorities to take responsibility for Jesus. He wanted them to lead Jesus away as their prisoner. The Greek text emphasizes You. Here is a way to translate that emphasis:

Then you yourselves take him and try him according to your own law. (GNT)

In some languages it may be necessary to say where Pilate wanted them to take Jesus. For example:

take him away (NLT)

Take/Lead him to your court/judge

judge Him by your own law: Pilate said that the Jews should put Jesus on trial and punish him according to (based on) their own law. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

try him by your own law (REB)

pass judgment on him according to your own law (NET)

judge what should be done to him using your own laws to decide (TH)

your own law: This phrase refers to the laws of the Jews. Religious offenses could be judged by Jewish law. That law was based on the books of Moses, the first five books of the Old Testament. Because the law contained many laws, it may be natural to use a plural noun. For example:

your laws (CEV)

Pilate told them: In the Greek there is a conjunction that is often translated as “so” or “therefore.” It shows that Pilate said this because of the Jewish leaders' reply. The BSB and many other translations leave this implied. Translate this conjunction in whatever way is most natural in your language. For example:

So Pilate said to them (NASB)

Then Pilate told them

18:31b

“We are not permitted to execute anyone,” the Jews replied.

- The accusers answered him, “We^(excl) Jews are not allowed to punish anyone by killing him.”
- The Jewish leaders answered him, “You^(plur) Romans do not allow us^(excl) to condemn anyone to death.”

We are not permitted to execute anyone: The Jewish authorities were not permitted to punish anyone by killing them. The Roman government did not allow them to give the death penalty.

We are not permitted: The phrase that the BSB translates as We are not permitted is more literally “it is not permitted/lawful for us.” Roman law did not allow the Jews to execute (punish with death) anyone, at least without receiving special permission. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

We cannot legally put anyone to death (NET)

But we are not allowed to put anyone to death (NCV)

Only the Romans are permitted to execute someone (NLT)

Rome does not allow us to punish anyone with death

We: This pronoun is exclusive here and refers to the Jews, but not to Pilate. Pilate was a Roman, not a Jew.

to execute anyone: The word that the BSB translates as to execute means “to kill” but refers to the government right to kill criminals. For example:

to punish a person with death

the Jews replied: The Jewish authorities who had brought Jesus to Pilate now answered him. The Greek more literally says “the Jews said to him.” Refer to Pilate and Jesus’ accusers in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

The Jewish leaders replied (NET)

The Jews said to him (ESV)

The Jews answered him (GW)

General Comment on 18:31b

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that the speakers were Jewish in what they said. Then they would say, “We Jews.” It may then be natural to leave it implicit in the quote introducer. For example:

Jesus’ accusers/opponents said, “We^(excl) Jews are not permitted to execute anyone.”

John 18:32

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:28–32

This paragraph begins the second part of Jesus' trial. (The second part, with Jesus before Caiaphas, is only mentioned in John. John does not say anything about what happened there.) The narrative moves from Peter back to Jesus.

The Sanhedrin, the Jewish council with the most authority, could try minor offenses, particularly those involving Jewish religious law and customs. However, it could not punish anyone with death on a cross. Only the Roman government had that authority. So the Jewish authorities took Jesus to the Roman governor to ask him to condemn Jesus to die on a cross.

18:32a–b

This was to fulfill the word that Jesus had spoken to indicate the kind of death He was going to die: This sentence is a parenthetical comment by the author John, not part of the main story. Some English versions have therefore placed it in parentheses. Indicate that this is parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language.

18:32a

This was to fulfill the word that Jesus had spoken

- This happened so that what Jesus predicted would be fulfilled,
- (In this way what Jesus said earlier came true)

This was to fulfill the word that Jesus had spoken:

The Greek text more literally says, “in order that the word of Jesus might be fulfilled which he said....” This indicates that what Jesus had said in the past would happen (see 12:32), did happen. Jesus had said that he would be “lifted up,” and he did in fact die “lifted up” on a cross. Although Pilate had not yet decided to crucify Jesus, 18:31b shows that the Jews wanted Jesus punished with death. That fulfilled Jesus' prophecy.

This is a purpose clause. However, it does not indicate the purpose of Jesus' Jewish opponents. They were not trying to fulfill what Jesus had said. In your translation, avoid indicating that Jesus' accusers said what they said because they wanted to fulfill what Jesus had said. For example:

And so what Jesus said about his death would soon come true. (CEV)

This happened in order to make come true what Jesus had said when he indicated the kind of death he would die. (GNT)

(This fulfilled Jesus' prediction about the way he would die.) (NLT)

This was to fulfill: This phrase indicates that what Jesus' accusers said caused Jesus' words to come true. See how you translated the word or idea of fulfill in 12:38, 13:18, and Luke 4:21.

The Jews did not directly fulfill Jesus' words themselves, that is, they did not crucify Jesus. However, their words caused Jesus' words to be fulfilled. They caused Jesus' words to be fulfilled by asking the Romans to execute (punish with death) Jesus. The Romans executed people by crucifying them, while the Jewish custom was to stone (throw stones at people) people to death.

In some languages it may be natural to say explicitly to what the word This refers. For example:

In this way Jesus' enemies caused to be fulfilled...

This happened in order to make come true... (GNT)

By saying this they caused Jesus' words to come true...

the word that Jesus had spoken: This clause refers to what Jesus said in John 3:14 and 12:32. Jesus had predicted that he would be killed by being “lifted up,” that is, by crucifixion. You may want to include a footnote with the references to John 3:14 and 12:32.

18:32b

to indicate the kind of death He was going to die.

- about the way that he would die.
- when he told how he would die.)

to indicate the kind of death He was going to die:

The expression the kind of death He was going to die refers to Jesus' death by crucifixion. Jesus had said that he would be lifted up above the earth. See John 12:32–33. He died by the Roman method of punishing with death, crucifixion, not the Jewish method, stoning (killing by throwing stones). It was the Romans who put him to death. So when the Jews asked Pilate to give permission to kill Jesus, they were really requesting that Jesus be crucified.

See the note on John 12:33, where there is a very similar expression. See too how you translated that verse. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

what Jesus said about how he would die (NCV)

indicating the way he would die

thus fulfilling Christ's prophecy of the method of his own death (JBP)

General Comment on 18:32a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in these clauses. For example:

^{32a–b}This happened so that the words Jesus spoke indicating the kind of death that he would die would be fulfilled.

^{32a–b}(This happened so that what Jesus said about how he would die would come true.) (NCV)

In this way what Jesus had predicted about how he would die came true. (GW)

John 18:33

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus' death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:33–35

Pilate was trying to decide what to do with Jesus, so he asked him questions.

18:33a

Pilate went back into the Praetorium,

- ¶ Then Pilate went back inside his headquarters/ house.
- ¶ Pilate returned to his palace/mansion

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information in 18:32. Indicate the return to the main story in a way that is natural in your language. If you put 18:32 in parentheses, that may be all that you need to do. It can also indicate that 18:33 is the result of what happened in 18:31, before the parenthetical

information. Here are other ways to translate this word to indicate a result:

So (NET)

As a result

Pilate went back into the Praetorium: Pilate had been outside talking to Jesus' accusers. He now went back into the building where he lived. Translate the Praetorium as you did in 18:28. For example:

Pilate then went back inside the palace (NIV)

Pilate then returned to his own house/palace/mansion.

18:33b summoned Jesus,

- He ordered Jesus brought to him
- and told his servants/soldiers to bring/lead Jesus to him.

summoned Jesus: This phrase indicates that Pilate told some of the soldiers or guards to bring Jesus to him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

called Jesus to him (NCV)

called for Jesus to be brought to him (NLT)

ordered that Jesus be brought to him

18:33c and asked Him, "Are You the King of the Jews?"

- and then he asked him, "Are you the king who rules the Jews?"
- Then when he arrived he asked Jesus, "Are you the king/ruler of the Jewish people/nation?"

Are You the King of the Jews?: This question of Pilate is exactly the same in all four gospels (see also Matthew 27:11, Mark 15:2, and Luke 23:3). John does not report that Jesus' accusers said that Jesus said that he was the King of the Jews. However, Luke reports that they said that (Luke 23:2). In saying that, they accused Jesus of rebelling against Roman rule. Pilate wanted to know if Jesus really called himself the King of the Jews. This is a real question. Use the type of question that a judge might ask an accused person in court.

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to Jesus. The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun, which indicates surprise and perhaps scorn.

the King of the Jews: This phrase means "the ruler of the Jewish people." A person who called himself this would be declaring his right and authority to rule the Jews. The Roman authorities could not allow this to happen. See how you translated this phrase in Matthew 27:37, Mark 15:9, and Luke 23:3, and the similar title in 1:49 "the king of Israel." Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the king/ruler of the Jewish people

the one who rules the Jews

John 18:34

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:33–35

Pilate was trying to decide what to do with Jesus, so he asked him questions.

18:34

“Are you saying this on your own,” Jesus asked, “or did others tell you about Me?”

- Jesus replied, “Did you think of that yourself, or did others tell you about me?” (GW)
- Jesus answered Pilate, “Is this/that your own question? Or is this something you heard from others?”

Are you saying this on your own,” Jesus asked, “or did others tell you about Me?”: This question proposes two possibilities, and asks which one was true. Did Pilate ask the question because of his own thinking, or did he repeat what others said.

Are you saying this on your own...?: Jesus asked Pilate if he himself wondered if Jesus was the King of the Jews. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Is that your own idea...? (NIV)

Is this your own question...? (NLT)

Are you the one who thought of this question?
(TH)

Jesus asked: In some languages it is more natural to say whose question Jesus was answering. For example:

Jesus answered Pilate

or did others tell you about Me?: This clause tells the second, alternative possibility. If Pilate himself did not wonder if Jesus was the King of the Jews, someone else must have mentioned it. It is implied that Jesus’ accusers (the others) had said that Jesus claimed to be the King of the Jews. Here are other ways to translate this possibility:

did others talk to you about me? (NIV)

have others suggested it to you? (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this possibility with Pilate as the subject:

did you hear about me from others?

is this something that you heard from others?

John 18:35

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:33–35

Pilate was trying to decide what to do with Jesus, so he asked him questions.

18:35a

"Am I a Jew?" Pilate replied.

- Pilate said in response, "Do you^(sing) think I am a Jew?"
- Pilate answered Jesus, "I am not one of you^(plur) Jews!"

Am I a Jew?: This is a rhetorical question. It expects the answer, "No." It emphasizes that Pilate was not a Jew. Pilate's answer implied that by himself he would not have thought that Jesus was the King of the Jews. He further implied that some Jew must have told him that. The question probably also implies scorn for the Jews.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Do you think I am a Jew? (GNT)

I am not a Jew, am I? (NET)

- Use a statement. For example:

I am not Jewish. (NCV)

You know I'm not a Jew! (CEV)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural in your language for giving a negative answer.

18:35b

"Your own people and chief priests handed You over to me.

- Your own nation and their chief priests have brought you before me. (REB)
- Your^(sing) own nation/people and chief priests gave you to me to try/judge.

Your own people and chief priests handed You over to me:

This continues the answer to Jesus' question in 18:34: Pilate heard about Jesus from the Jews who brought Jesus to him. In the Greek the emphasis is on the phrase Your own people and chief priests. It was Jesus' own people and not the Roman government that gave Jesus to Pilate. You may want to indicate that emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

It was your people and your chief priests who handed you over to me. (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to include the implied information that this was the answer to Jesus' question:

Your own people and chief priests told me about you when they handed you over to me.

Your own people: This phrase refers to the Jews. Jesus was a Jew while Pilate was a Roman and not a Jew. The pronoun Your is singular and refers to Jesus.

chief priests: This phrase refers to the religious leaders of the Jews. See how you translated this phrase in 18:3.

handed You over: The verb phrase handed...over indicates that the Jewish religious leaders had given Jesus to the Roman authorities to guard and judge. See how you translated this idea in 18:30. The Jewish leaders wanted the Roman authorities to judge and condemn Jesus, and punish him with death. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Your own nation and their chief priests have brought you before me. (NJB)

Your own people and their leading priests brought you to me for trial. (NLT)

18:35c

What have You done?"

- What have you done wrong?" (NCV)
- What crime have you^(sing) committed?"

What have You done?: This question is a request for information. It is a real question and not a rhetorical question. Pilate wanted to know what Jesus did that made the Jewish leaders want him to die. Here are other ways to translate this question:

What is it you have done? (NIV)

Why? What have you done? (NLT)

What have you done wrong? (NCV)

John 18:36

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section

in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:36–38a

Jesus explained that he was not a king of an earthly kingdom.

18:36a

Jesus answered, “My kingdom is not of this world;

- ¶ Jesus replied to Pilate, “My kingdom does not have its origin in this world.
- ¶ Jesus replied, “I am not an earthly type/kind of king.
- ¶ Jesus answered Pilate, “My authority to rule does not come from this world.

Jesus answered: In some languages it is more natural to say explicitly whom Jesus answered. For example:

Jesus answered Pilate

My kingdom is not of this world: This sentence indicates that Jesus agreed that he was a king but denied that he had an earthly, worldly kingdom. The phrase not of this world indicates that the source or origin of Jesus’ kingdom was not this world. He implied that his kingdom was spiritual, and that it came from God in heaven. It does not mean that his kingdom was not present or active in this world. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

My kingdom does not belong to this world. (GNT)

My Kingdom is not an earthly kingdom. (NLT)

My kingdom: This phrase here refers to Jesus’ ruling as king rather than to the territory over which he ruled. Translate using an expression referring to the right/authority to rule, rather than to land. For example:

My rule

My ruling as king

My authority to rule as king

this world: This phrase here refers to the powers and authorities of this world system. Jesus’ authority to rule does not come from the political or military system of this world. God is the one who gives Jesus the right to rule.

18:36b–c

if it were, My servants would fight to prevent My arrest by the Jews: In these clauses Jesus denied that his kingdom was from this world by saying that a necessary result had not happened. He knew, and Pilate knew, that his followers were not fighting. They had not resisted Jesus’ arrest in the garden. That proved that Jesus was not an earthly king. He did not have to protect himself.

Jesus’ followers would be fighting if his kingdom was from this world. So because his followers were not fighting, Jesus’ kingdom was not from this world. This kind of logic may not be natural or common in some languages. It may be more natural to use true-to-fact statements. See the General Comment on 18:36a–c.

18:36b

if it were,

- If this world was the origin of my kingdom,
- Because I am not the kind of king you have on earth,
- Because of that

if it were: This clause proposes a condition that was not fulfilled. It suggests a situation that is not true. Jesus’ kingdom is not from this world.

Refer back to Jesus’ statement in 18:36a in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

If it were from this world

If it belonged to this world (NCV)

If it did (CEV)

If I were like kings who rule in this world (TH)

18:36c

My servants would fight to prevent My arrest by the Jews.

- my disciples would fight to protect me from the Jewish authorities.
- my disciples do not fight to prevent my arrest.
- my servants do not fight to prevent the Jews from arresting me.

My servants would fight to prevent My arrest by the Jews: This clause tells the necessary result of the condition given in 18:36b. Because 18:36b was not fulfilled, this result did not happen. Jesus’ followers (or servants—see below) had not fought and were not fighting to protect him. In some languages this may need to be made explicit. For example:

my servants would fight...but they do not

My servants: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as servants is also used in 18:3 to refer to the temple guards. There are two ways to interpret the word servants here:

1. It means “servants” and refers to the servants that a worldly king might have. Those servants could be the more than 12 legions (many thousands) of angels that Jesus could command (see Matthew 26:53). For example:

my servants (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NET, RSV, NASB, ESV, KJV, NCV)

1. It means “followers” and refers to Jesus’ disciples, either just his closest disciples or all his followers. For example:

my followers (GNT) (NRSV, GNT, CEV, NLT, REB, GW)

The NJB translates this phrase as “my men,” which could follow either interpretation. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) because it is the usual meaning of the Greek word.

would fight to prevent My arrest by the Jews: The tense of the verb would fight is ambiguous. It could refer to the present time (they would be fighting now) or the past (they would have fought). This seems to be a general statement. Jesus’ followers would have fought to protect him at some time. It is recommended that you translate this phrase in a general way.

If you cannot translate the verb in a general or ambiguous way, it is recommended that you use past tense. That would then refer back to Jesus’ arrest in the garden. For example:

my servants would have fought to keep me from being given over to the Jewish leaders (NCV)

to prevent My arrest: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to prevent My arrest is more literally “so that I would not be handed over.” A worldly king would have servants that would fight anyone trying to arrest the king. (Peter fought a little, but Jesus did not accept his help.) Consider how it is natural to indicate action done to prevent others from doing something. For example:

so that I would not be given over to the Jews (NCV)

that I might not be delivered over to the Jews (ESV)

to prevent my being handed over to the Jews (JBP)

My arrest: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as My arrest is more literally “being handed over.” It refers to enabling the Jewish authorities to arrest Jesus. It is part of a general statement, though it could refer to Judas leading the authorities to arrest Jesus. See how you translated this verb in the active form in 18:35. Here the verb is passive. There are several ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

be delivered over to the Jews (ESV)

- Use an active verb. Judas was the one who handed Jesus over, but it is the Jewish authorities who are in focus here. For example:

so that the Jewish authorities could/would not arrest me

- Use a noun. For example:

to prevent my arrest by the Jews (NIV)

Translate this verb in the way that is most natural in your language in this context.

by the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the leaders of the Jewish people. For example:

the Jewish leaders (NLT)

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

our leaders (CEV)

General Comment on 18:36a–c

In some languages it may be natural to translate 18:36a–c without using a condition that was not fulfilled. For example:

My kingdom is not a worldly kingdom. That is the reason why my servants did not fight to keep me from being handed over to the Jewish authorities.

My kingdom is not of this world. That is why my servants did not fight to prevent my arrest by the Jews.

18:36d

But now My kingdom is not of this realm.”

- But my kingdom has another origin.”
- But the kind of king I am is different from the kings on earth.”
- Yes, because my authority to rule is not from this world.”

But now My kingdom is not of this realm: This clause repeats Jesus’ statement that his right to rule did not come from this world. He implied that his kingdom, his right to rule, was from God.

But now: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as But now here introduces a contrast between the real situation and the one Pilate was thinking of. See how you translated the same phrase in 8:40. For example:

But (ESV)

No (GNT)

My kingdom: Translate this phrase the same way here and in 18:36a so that the connection is clear.

is not of this realm: This phrase indicates that Jesus’ authority is not from this world. Jesus implied that he received his authority to rule from God. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

doesn’t have its origin on earth (GW)

doesn’t belong to this world (CEV)

John 18:37

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

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19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:36–38a

Jesus explained that he was not a king of an earthly kingdom.

18:37a

“Then You are a king!” Pilate said.

- Pilate asked, “You^(sing) are saying that you are a king, then?”
- Pilate said, “So that means that you^(sing) are a king!”

“Then You are a king!” Pilate said: Pilate returned to his first question, “Are you the King of the Jews?” (18:33). He understood that Jesus was saying that he was a king. This is a rhetorical question that expects the answer yes. Pilate wanted to confirm something that he thought that Jesus implied.

There are two ways to translate this rhetorical question:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

You are a king, then? (REB)

- Use a statement like the BSB. For example:

So you are a king! (NCV)

So you must mean that you are a king.

So that means that you are in fact a king.

18:37b

“You say that I am a king,” Jesus answered.

- Jesus answered, “You^(sing) give me the title of king.
- Jesus said to Pilate, “‘King’ is the word that you^(sing) yourself are using.

“You say that I am a king,” Jesus answered: There are two ways to interpret the Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as You say that I am a king:

1. Jesus said that he was a king. He agreed with Pilate that he was a king. For example:

You are right in saying I am a king. (NIV84) (GW, NASB, NIV84, GW)

1. Jesus did not admit that he was a king. For example:

It is you who say that I am a king. (NJB) (NIV2011, NJB, NCV, probably NLT)

The translations that translate more literally can be understood to follow either interpretation here (KJV, RSV, NRSV, ESV, NET, GNT, CEV). It is good to translate this in an ambiguous way. Jesus probably intended his answer to cause Pilate and others who heard him to think about what being a king meant. They suggested that he was a king, and he did not deny it. But he did not say that he was a political ruler. Try to give an ambiguous answer that introduces Jesus’ explanation of his true mission. For example:

You are calling me a king.

“King” is your word (REB)

“A king” is what you say.

You say: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun You to contrast it with “I” in 18:37c. Pilate thought that the purpose of Jesus’ life was to be a king. However, Jesus said that he had a different purpose.

18:37c

“For this reason I was born and have come into the world, to testify to the truth.

- But the reason I was born, yes, the reason I came into the world, was to declare what is true.
- I was born into this world to tell about the truth. (CEV)

For this reason I was born and have come into the world, to testify to the truth: This sentence indicates that Jesus came into the world to tell people the truth. His purpose in coming was not to be a worldly king.

The phrases I was born and have come into the world both refer to the same event. Jesus came into the world from heaven when he was born. Repeating the idea emphasizes it. Emphasize this idea in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

For this purpose I was born and for this purpose I have come into the world (ESV)

For this purpose I was born—yes, for this very reason I came into the world—

In some languages it may be necessary to combine the verb phrases. For example:

This is the reason that I was born into this world

The Greek text emphasizes the word I to contrast it with “You” in 18:37b. See the note there.

to testify to the truth: This phrase indicates that Jesus was a witness to the truth, especially the truth about God his Father. He knew his Father personally. During his life on earth he testified (told what he knew) about who God is and what he is like. See how you translated testify in 1:7, 3:11, and 5:31. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to speak about the truth (GNT)

to tell people the truth (NCV)

the truth: In some languages it may not be possible or natural to talk about truth as a noun. You may want or need to use an adjective form of the word. For example:

to speak about what is true

to declare the true teaching

18:37d

Everyone who belongs to the truth listens to My voice.”

- Everyone who is devoted to believing what is true will listen to what I say.”
- All people who want to know the truth will believe/ accept my teaching and obey me.”

Everyone who belongs to the truth listens to My voice: This sentence serves as an implied challenge to Pilate to listen to Jesus. Jesus implied that if Pilate really wanted to know the truth, he would listen to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Whoever wants to know the truth will receive/ accept what I say

All who love the truth recognize that what I say is true (NLT)

Everyone who belongs to the truth: This phrase means “all the people who want to know the truth” or “everyone who is devoted to believing the truth.” If you translated truth as an adjective in 18:37c, you will want to do the same here. For example:

All who follow what is really true

Whoever wants to know what the true teaching is

listens to My voice: This phrase means “believes/ accepts what I say.” It implies that the person will accept and obey what Jesus says. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

listens to me (GW)

John 18:38

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

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19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:36–38a

Jesus explained that he was not a king of an earthly kingdom.

18:38a

“What is truth?” Pilate asked.

- Pilate asked Jesus, “What is really true?”
- Pilate said, “Who can really know what truth is?”
- Pilate said to him, “We cannot know what is the real truth.”

What is truth?: This is a rhetorical question. Pilate used it to stop the conversation. Pilate does not want to hear Jesus’ answer.

There are two ways to translate this question:

- Use a rhetorical question or questions. For example:

Truth?...What is that? (NJB)

Can we really know truth?

- Use a statement. For example:

We cannot know what is really true.

It would be good if someone knew what the true teaching is (but no one does). (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is most natural in your language. Try to show that Pilate did not want to talk anymore about truth.

truth: Translate this word like you translated it in 18:37. For example:

What is true?

What is the true teaching?

Pilate asked: The word that the BSB translates as asked is more literally “said.” Pilate did not really want or expect an answer to his question. We know that because he immediately went outside. Use a verb that is natural for introducing a rhetorical question.

Paragraph 18:38b–40

In this paragraph, Pilate tried to release Jesus. He thought that Jesus was innocent. So he offered to free Jesus for the celebration of a Jewish feast. But the leaders of the Jews and the crowd were determined to have Jesus crucified. They asked Pilate to release a criminal named Barabbas instead.

18:38b

And having said this, he went out again to the Jews

- ¶ After saying this, Pilate went back outside to speak to the Jews
- ¶ After Pilate said this to Jesus, he went outside to talk with the Jewish leaders.

And having said this: This phrase introduces Pilate’s next action: he went outside immediately after he asked about truth. He did not wait for an answer. Some English translations leave this phrase implicit. This may be most natural if you begin a new paragraph here. Here is one way you could start a new paragraph:

Pilate went back out... (CEV)

he went out again to the Jews: This clause indicates that Pilate left the judgment hall in his house and went outside. That is where the Jewish crowd was waiting for him. Because this is a new paragraph, you may want to use Pilate’s name. For example:

Then Pilate went back outside (GNT)

to the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the religious leaders of the Jews.

18:38c

and told them, “I find no basis for a charge against Him.

- and announced, “I find no reason to accuse him of anything.
- He told them, “There is no reason for me to declare this man guilty of any crime.

I find no basis for a charge against Him: This clause is more literally “I find no fault in him.” Pilate thought that Jesus was innocent. He did not disobey any Roman laws, so Pilate did not have a case (a basis for accusing him in court). Indicate this idea using the legal expression that is natural in your language. For example:

I don’t find this man guilty of anything! (CEV)

He is not guilty of any crime. (NLT)

I cannot find any reason for judging this person.
(Yakan Back Translation)

John 18:39

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

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19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 18:38b–40

In this paragraph, Pilate tried to release Jesus. He thought that Jesus was innocent. So he offered to free Jesus for the celebration of a Jewish feast. But the leaders of the Jews and the crowd were determined to have Jesus crucified. They asked Pilate to release a criminal named Barabbas instead.

18:39a

But it is your custom that I release to you one prisoner at the Passover.

- But I always release one prisoner for you^(plur) at the time of the Passover feast.
- However, every year at the time of the feast called Death-Passed-Over-Us, I release one prisoner from prison to be kind to you^(plur).

- But because it is the custom to release one prisoner at Death-Passed-Over-Us time as a kindness to you^(plur),

But it is your custom that I release to you one prisoner at the Passover: At that time there was a custom that each year Pilate freed one Jewish prisoner at Passover. This was his way to please the Jews and help them to celebrate their holy day.

But it is your custom: The clause it is your custom is more literally “There is a custom for/to you.” The custom was Pilate’s custom for the benefit of the Jews. Here is another way to translate this clause:

And because I usually free a prisoner for you at Passover...

your: This pronoun is plural and refers to the Jews in general.

I release to you one prisoner: The phrase release... one prisoner means “to free one person who is in prison.”

to you: The phrase to you means “for your benefit.” The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Jews in general.

at the Passover: Pilate offered to free one person from prison in order to make the Passover season more joyful for the Jews. It is good to use an expression that will help your readers understand that Passover was a Jewish celebration. For example:

at Passover time/season

during your Passover celebrations

Passover: Passover was a Jewish feast day. At this feast the Jews remembered how God saved them from being slaves in Egypt long ago. At that time, God “passed over” their homes and none of them died. See the note at 18:28f, and see how you translated the word there.

18:39b

So then, do you want me to release to you the King of the Jews?”

- Do you^(plur) want me to free for you the one called the ‘king of the Jews?’”
- Should I free your^(plur) king, the king of the Jews, for you?”
- I can release your^(plur) King as a kindness to you, if you want me to.”

So then, do you want me to release to you the King of the Jews?: This is a real question. It is also a suggestion. Pilate hoped that the answer would be “yes.” He wanted the crowd to ask him to release Jesus.

to you: The pronoun you is plural and refers to the Jewish leaders that were there (see 18:38b).

the King of the Jews: This title refers to Jesus. It is the same title as in 18:33. In this context, however, Pilate was talking to the Jews themselves. So it may be natural to use a second person pronoun. For example:

your^(plur) King

the King of you^(plur) Jewish people

John 18:40

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

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Paragraph 18:38b–40

In this paragraph, Pilate tried to release Jesus. He thought that Jesus was innocent. So he offered to free Jesus for the celebration of a Jewish feast. But the leaders of the Jews and the crowd were determined to have Jesus crucified. They asked Pilate to release a criminal named Barabbas instead.

18:40a

“Not this man,” they shouted, “but Barabbas!”

- The Jews shouted to Pilate, “No! Do not free him. Free Barabbas instead.”
- They loudly said to Pilate, “We^(excl) do not want you^(sing) to release Jesus. We want you^(sing) to release Barabbas for us^(excl).”

“Not this man,” they shouted, “but Barabbas!”:

The Jewish leaders answered that they wanted Pilate to release Barabbas instead of Jesus. They rejected Pilate’s suggestion. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit the implied answer “no.” For example:

No, not this man, but Barabbas! (JBP)

In some languages it may be natural to supply one or more of the implied verbs. For example:

No, not him! Give us Barabbas! (NIV)

Don’t free this man! Free Barabbas! (GW)

No! Not this man. We want Barabbas! (NLT)

Not this man: This phrase is short for “We do not want you to release the king of the Jews.” The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as this man is more literally “this one.” Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in this context. For example:

not him (NIV)

they shouted: The pronoun they refers to the crowd of Jewish leaders. They shouted loudly to Pilate. The Greek text more literally says, “Therefore they cried out again, saying.” Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

So they cried out again, saying (NASB)

Then they shouted back (NET)

They answered him with a shout (GNT)

The Jews shouted again (GW)

but Barabbas!: This phrase indicates that the Jews wanted Pilate to release Barabbas instead of Jesus.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (“Not this man”) to a positive statement (“Barabbas”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

Not this Man, but Barabbas. (NASB)

- Use a conjunction other than but. For example:

Not him, but rather you release Barabbas! (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

No, not him! We want Barabbas! (GNT)

Don't free this man! Free Barabbas! (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

We want Barabbas, not this man!

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

18:40b

(Now Barabbas was an insurrectionist.)

- This Barabbas, he was a rebel/robber.
- (Barabbas had fought/rebelled against the Roman government.)

(Now Barabbas was an insurrectionist.): The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some parenthetical background information. It is not a time word. The author John added this background information to explain who Barabbas was. This is not part of what the crowd said. Some translations, like the BSB, put this sentence in parentheses to show that this is background information.

Barabbas was an insurrectionist: This clause indicates that Barabbas had committed a crime. Luke 23:19 tells us that Barabbas had been part of a riot and had killed someone. That is why the Romans had put him in prison.

insurrectionist: The Greek word that the BSB translates as insurrectionist means “robber” or “someone who rebels against the government.” It probably indicates that Barabbas was a rebel who got what he needed by robbing. Here are other ways to translate this word (an “uprising” is a violent act against the government):

robber (ESV)

violent man

Now Barabbas had taken part in an uprising. (NIV)

terrorist (CEV)

John 19:1

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:1–3

The Roman soldiers whipped and mocked Jesus.

19:1

Then Pilate took Jesus and had Him flogged.

- ¶ Then Pilate gave orders for Jesus to be taken and beaten with a whip.
- ¶ Then Pilate said to the soldiers, “Take Jesus away and whip him.” The soldiers obeyed.

Then: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Then introduces the next event in the story. It also indicates a return to the main story after the parenthetical information at the end of 18:40. Indicate the next event and a return to main story after parenthetical information in a natural way in your language.

Pilate took Jesus and had Him flogged: The Greek text more literally says, “Pilate took Jesus and flogged (whipped) him.” It implies, however, that Pilate ordered his soldiers to take Jesus away and flog him, and that they obeyed him. (See 19:2–3 where the soldiers are the ones doing things to Jesus.) Also, in some languages it is more natural to leave the verb took implicit. For example:

Then Pilate ordered that Jesus be taken away and whipped. (NCV)

Then Pilate made his soldiers whip Jesus.

Pilate gave orders that Jesus be beaten with a whip, orders which were obeyed.

See the General Comment on 19:1 for a suggestion on how to translate this clause using direct speech.

flogged: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as flogged means “beaten with a whip.” Jesus had prophesied that this would happen. See Matthew 20:19, Mark 10:34, and Luke 18:33, where the same Greek verb is used. Use the same expression to translate this word in all these verses so it is clear that the prophecy was fulfilled. For example:

whipped (GW)

General Comment on 19:1

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 19:1 as direct speech. For example:

Then Pilate commanded his soldiers, “Take Jesus away and flog/whip him.” And they did.

John 19:2

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:1–3

The Roman soldiers whipped and mocked Jesus.

19:2a

The soldiers twisted together a crown of thorns, set it on His head,

- The soldiers made a crown from some thorny branches and put it on Jesus’ head (NCV)
- Then they twisted thorny vines to look like a king’s/royal head piece and put it on Jesus.

The soldiers twisted together a crown of thorns, set it on His head: The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that the BSB translates leaves implicit and some versions translate as “And.” It introduces what the soldiers did after obeying Pilate’s command. For example:

and after this, the soldiers twisted some thorns into a crown and put it on his head (NJB)

The soldiers: This phrase here refers to the Roman soldiers who controlled Jerusalem. These were the men whom Pilate commanded to flog Jesus in 19:1.

twisted together a crown of thorns: This phrase indicates that the soldiers twisted together some thorny branches to look like a crown. For example:

The soldiers twisted some thorny branches into a crown (GW)

The soldiers made a crown from some thorny branches. (NCV)

a crown of thorns: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a crown refers to the circular head piece worn by kings to represent honor. Crowns often had points that pointed up, and the thorns on the branches may have looked like these points.

In some languages there may be no word for crown. In those languages you may want to use a description and indicate that a king wears it. For example:

they twisted thorny vines into a circle and placed it on his head to look like what a king wears

set it on His head: The soldiers put the crown on Jesus’ head. They imitated the ceremony of someone becoming king and mocked Jesus because he was called “the king of the Jews.”

19:2b

and dressed Him in a purple robe.

- and put a purple robe around him. (NCV)
- They also put brightly colored clothes like a king wears on Jesus.

and dressed Him in a purple robe: The soldiers put purple clothing on Jesus. Purple dye (used to color clothes) was expensive and so purple was the color that kings wore. They wanted him to look like a king so they could mock him (see 19:3). People considered purple clothes to be a luxury and honorable, clothes/clothing for kings. In some languages it may be natural to make this clear. For example:

they dressed him in something like a king’s purple clothing

They dressed him in a red cloak like the clothing of a king. (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

purple: The color of the robe was apparently dark red or a mixture of blue and red. See Matthew 27:28, where a different Greek word is used, a word that the BSB translates as “scarlet.”

robe: The Greek word that the BSB translates as robe is a general word for clothing. Here it refers to a long outer piece of clothes like a coat or cloak. For example:

cloak (REB)

John 19:3

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus’ death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:1–3

The Roman soldiers whipped and mocked Jesus.

19:3a

And they went up to Him again and again, saying, “Hail, King of the Jews!”

- They came up to Jesus repeatedly, saying “We^(excl) greet you^(sing), O king of the Jews!”
- They came to him many times, and mocked him and greeted him as the “king of the Jews”

And they went up to Him again and again: The soldiers came up to (approached) Jesus, mocking him as if they were greeting a king.

went up to Him again and again: The Greek word that the BSB translates as went up...again and again means “kept approaching.” The action was done repeatedly and by different soldiers. Indicate this action in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

they came to him many times (NCV)

repeatedly approached him

They kept coming up to him (NRSV)

saying, “Hail, King of the Jews!”: The soldiers mocked Jesus by imitating the way Romans greeted the Roman emperor. They did not believe that Jesus was really the king of the Jews. It is important that your readers understand that the soldiers were not sincere. They did not truly honor Jesus. It may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

“Hail! King of the Jews!” they mocked. (NLT)

They scorned him and said, “Greetings, O king of the Jews!”

They laughed at him, saying, “Long live the king of the Jews!”

Hail: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Hail is a greeting used to honor someone. The soldiers mocked Jesus by pretending to honor him. Consider how a chief or a king is greeted in your culture. It is good to use an expression that is an exaggeration and that your readers will understand is not sincere. For example:

We^(excl) greet/honor you^(sing)!

May you be successful!

King of the Jews!: See how you translated the phrase King of the Jews in 18:39. Here Jesus is being addressed directly, and so there is no definite article. In some languages there may be a way to show that respect is an exaggeration or is not sincere. For example:

O mighty king of the Jews!

you king of the Jews! (CEV)

General Comment on 19:3a

In some languages it may be more natural to translate 19:3a as indirect speech. Here are some ways to translate this clause as indirect speech:

They came up to him again and again, mocking him as they greeted him as the king of the Jews.

They repeatedly approached him and pretended to honor him as the king of the Jews.

19:3b and slapping Him in the face.

- and slapping/hitting his face.
- while they slapped him on/across the face.

and slapping Him in the face: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as slapping Him in the face refers to hitting or slapping someone. See 18:22, where the same expression is used with a singular subject. Here the Greek tense indicates that the soldiers struck (hit) Jesus repeatedly, probably with their open hands. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

And they struck him repeatedly in the face. (NET)

and slapped his face (GW)

and struck him with their hands (ESV)

General Comment on 19:3a–b

The soldiers struck Jesus while they were mocking him with their words. Connect the verbs in a way that indicates this. For example:

“Hail! King of the Jews!” they mocked, as they slapped him across the face. (NLT)

John 19:4

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the

second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus' death

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18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:4–7

Pilate told the Jewish religious leaders that he thought that Jesus was innocent and planned to free him. But they protested and shouted to Pilate to crucify Jesus.

19:4a

Once again Pilate came out and said to the Jews,

- ¶ Again Pilate went out of his house and said to the crowd/people,

- ¶ Again Pilate went outside to the Jewish leaders. He said to them,

Once again Pilate came out: Pilate again went out of his house to where the Jewish leaders were waiting outside the gate to his courtyard. See 18:29 and 18:38 for the times that he did this earlier.

Once again: Pilate repeated his action of going out of his house. The words he then spoke were different from what he said before. In your translation, the words *Once again* should refer to what Pilate did ("went out") and not to what he said.

and said to the Jews: The phrase *the Jews* is the pronoun "they" in Greek. Here it refers to the Jews who were accusing Jesus and had gathered at the gate. This was mainly the Jewish chief priests and other religious leaders. However, it also included some ordinary Jewish people such as servants and guards. These were the same people that 18:28–29 and 18:38 mentioned.

19:4b

"Look, I am bringing Him out to you

- "See, I will bring Jesus here now before you^(plur)
- "Listen, I am going to show/display to you this man.

Look: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Look* is often used to call attention to and emphasize the following word or words. See, for example, 1:29. In some translations it is left implicit here (NLT, GW, CEV). Here is another way to translate this word:

Here he is (REB)

I am bringing Him out to you: The Greek text implies that Pilate commanded the soldiers to bring Jesus to where the Jews could see him. In some languages it may be natural to use a verb form that indicates that Pilate caused this to happen. He did not do it himself. For example:

I am causing Jesus to come out to you

I have commanded that my soldiers bring Jesus out to you

Him: The pronoun *Him* refers to Jesus.

19:4c

to let you know that I find no basis for a charge against Him."

- to tell/show you^(plur) that I find that he has not committed any crime."

- I want you to understand that I see no reason to accuse him of anything.”

to let you know: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to let you know is more literally “so that you may know.” This is the purpose of Pilate bringing Jesus out. Pilate wanted to make sure that the crowd understood that he believed Jesus to be innocent of any crime. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

that you may know (ESV)

to cause you to understand

to make it clear/plain to you

I find no basis for a charge against Him: Pilate was again declaring that Jesus was not guilty. He could discover no reason to condemn him to death. He used the same expression as in 18:38. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I find him not guilty (NLT)

I cannot find a reason for judging him (Yakan Back Translation)

I cannot find any reason to condemn him (GNT)

John 19:5

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, “I find no case against him.”

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

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The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:4–7

Pilate told the Jewish religious leaders that he thought that Jesus was innocent and planned to free him. But they protested and shouted to Pilate to crucify Jesus.

19:5a**When Jesus came out wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe,**

- And Jesus came out, still wearing the crown made from thorny branches and the purple clothes.
- When they brought/led Jesus to the crowd, he still wore/had the brightly colored robe and the head piece made of thorns.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that the BSB leaves implicit but some versions translate as “So.” It indicates that this action follows the action of the last verse. For example:

Then (NLT)

Jesus came out: The phrase came out refers to Jesus coming out of Pilate’s house to the courtyard where the Jews were gathered. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. If this is the case in your languages you may supply the expression you used in 18:28. For example:

Jesus came/went out of Pilate’s house

wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe: Jesus still had on the crown of thorns and the purple robe. The soldiers had put these on Jesus to mock him. See how you translated crown of thorns and the purple robe in 19:2. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

He was wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe. (GW)

19:5b**Pilate said to them, “Here is the man!”**

- Pilate said to them, “This is the man/one!”
- Pilate told the crowd, “Look at him! Here he is.”

Pilate said to them, “Here is the man!”: Pilate showed Jesus to the Jews, hoping that they would realize that he was not dangerous. His words may have expressed either pity or scorn for Jesus. In either case, he was implying that it was not necessary to crucify him.

them: This pronoun refers to the Jews that were gathered there to accuse Jesus.

Here is the man!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Here is calls attention to something, similar to “Look” in 19:4b. Here Pilate asked the Jews to look at Jesus. Because Pilate thought that Jesus was

innocent, he probably wanted them to see that he was not dangerous. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Look! Here is the man! (GNT)

Look at this man. (Yakan Back Translation)

John 19:6**Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die**

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

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19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:4–7

Pilate told the Jewish religious leaders that he thought that Jesus was innocent and planned to free him. But they protested and shouted to Pilate to crucify Jesus.

19:6a

As soon as the chief priests and officers saw Him,

- When the chief priests and the temple guards saw Jesus,
- Seeing Jesus, the leading priests and temple guards

As soon as the chief priests and officers saw Him:

The Jewish religious leaders and their security guards looked at Jesus as Pilate had told them to. This clause indicates that their response to Pilate in 19:6b was a result of their seeing Jesus. When they saw Jesus, they rejected him.

the chief priests: This phrase refers to the leading priests of the Jews. See how you translated this phrase in 7:32 and 18:3.

and officers: The Greek word that the BSB translates as officers refers to the temple guards under the chief priests’ control. See how you translated this word in 18:3.

saw Him: The pronoun Him here refers to Jesus, not Pilate. Check that your readers understand this. You may need to make this explicit. For example:

saw Jesus (NCV)

19:6b

they shouted, “Crucify Him! Crucify Him!”

- they cried with loud voices, “Kill^(sing) him! Crucify^(sing) him!”
- began to shout to Pilate, “Nail^(sing) him to a cross! Nail^(sing) him! Let^(sing) him die!”

they shouted: Use a term that refers to the way a crowd shouts its demands. For example:

they said with a loud cry

Crucify Him! Crucify Him!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Crucify Him is just the verb “crucify.” The BSB makes explicit the implied object with the pronoun Him, referring to Jesus, as is natural in English. You may need to make the object explicit too.

Crucify: This word means to kill someone by nailing him to a cross. See Matthew 20:19, Mark 15:13, and Luke 23:21. It is repeated for emphasis. In some languages it may be natural to indicate the emphasis in a different way. For example:

We demand that you crucify him!

Some languages do not have a word for Crucify. If your language is like that, here are other ways to translate this word:

Nail him to a cross! Nail him to a cross! (CEV)

Kill! Kill! Put him on a cross!

This was the usual way that the Romans executed (punished with death) criminals. Two large wooden beams were attached to each other to form a cross. Roman soldiers nailed or tied a criminal to a cross, then stood it up. (Jesus was nailed to the cross.) They did this in order to cause the criminal to die slowly and painfully.

The beams were crossed and attached. This made the shape of a + or (or sometimes a T).

In many languages there may be no word for “cross.” If that is true in your language, you may need to use a descriptive phrase. For example:

nail him to the beam/wood of death

19:6c

“You take Him and crucify Him,” Pilate replied,

- But Pilate said to them, “You^(plur) take him and crucify him.
- But Pilate told the priests and guards, “You^(plur) be the ones to take him away and nail him to a cross.

You take Him and crucify Him: Pilate did not want to order the soldiers to crucify Jesus. He knew and the Jews knew that the Jews were not allowed to crucify anyone. He was not actually commanding them, or even allowing them, to crucify Jesus. He wanted them to be responsible for Jesus’ death. Consider how you could suggest or imply this. For example:

You be the ones to crucify him.

You can be the ones to put him on the cross.

You: The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun that some versions translate as “yourselves.”

19:6d

“for I find no basis for a charge against Him.”

- You^(plur) do it because I do not find him to be guilty.”
- Because as for me, I have examined him and found no reason to punish him.”

for: The Greek text of this clause includes a word that the BSB translates literally as *for*. Pilate wanted the Jews to be the ones to crucify Jesus because he did not think that Jesus was guilty. Most English translations leave this word implied. In some languages, it may be better to make this word explicit, like the BSB. For example:

Crucify him yourselves, because I find nothing against him (NCV)

I find no basis for a charge against Him: Again Pilate said that he could not find anything that Jesus did wrong. See the very similar expression in 19:4. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I find no reason to condemn him. (GNT)

I find him not guilty. (NLT)

I: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. It contrasts with “you” in 19:6c. Show this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

As for me, I find no basis for a charge against him. (NIV)

John 19:7

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:4–7

Pilate told the Jewish religious leaders that he thought that Jesus was innocent and planned to free him. But they protested and shouted to Pilate to crucify Jesus.

19:7a

“We have a law,” answered the Jews, “and according to that law He must die,

- The Jewish leaders answered Pilate, “We^(excl) have a law, and that law tells us that he deserves to die,
- The crowd said to Pilate, “We^(excl) have our own law, which says that he should be punished with death

“We have a law,” answered the Jews, “and according to that law He must die: One of the laws of Moses said that anyone who blasphemed (said something against) the name of God should die. More specifically, the Jewish people should kill him. The Jewish leaders decided that when Jesus called himself the Son of God, he blasphemed.

We have a law: This clause indicates that there was a relevant Jewish law. The Jewish people had many hundreds of laws, but the leaders were thinking of one specific law, Leviticus 24:16. It may be natural to indicate that the reference is to a specific law by saying

one of our^(excl) laws

We: The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun, which is exclusive here. It refers to the Jews but not to Pilate, a Roman. It contrasts with “I” in 19:6d (“I find no case against him”).

the Jews: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Jews refers to the same group mentioned in 19:6a. That group consisted mainly of the chief priests and their guards. Other Jewish people who were opposed

to Jesus could have also been there. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

The crowd (GNT)

The Jewish leaders (NIV)

and according to that law: This phrase introduces the content or command of that law. In some languages it may be natural to make that law the subject of the sentence. For example:

Our Law says that... (CEV)

He must die: This clause here indicates that the Jewish leaders thought that Jesus deserved to be executed (punished with death). They thought that it was someone’s duty to kill him. They did not say who that should be. Jewish law said that the Jews should execute this person themselves, but these Jews wanted the Romans to execute Jesus. If you need to supply a subject, you should leave it general. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he must be put to death (CEV)

he should be killed (Yakan Back Translation)

someone should execute/kill him

General Comment on 19:7a

In some languages it may be natural to combine the two clauses in 19:7a. For example:

We have a law that says he ought to die. (GNT)

19:7b

because He declared Himself to be the Son of God.”

- because he said that he is the Son of God.”
- because he blasphemed when he said, ‘I am the Son of God.’”

because He declared Himself to be the Son of God: This clause tells the reason why the Jewish leaders thought that Jesus should die. They said that when Jesus’ claimed to be (said that he was) the Son of God he blasphemed or cursed God. See 10:36 and the notes there.

He declared Himself to be the Son of God: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as declared

Himself is more literally “made himself.” The idea is that the Jewish leaders believed that Jesus created an identity for himself that was not true. They did not believe that Jesus was the Son of God. They believed that this was a false statement. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he pretended to be God’s Son

he said he is the Son of God (NCV)

he called himself the Son of God (NLT)

the Son of God: The Greek text just says “Son of God,” with no definite article “the” here. But a specific Son of God is implied, and the BSB and most English translations have supplied a definite article. The Greek text emphasizes this phrase to emphasize how serious the Jews thought his offense was.

The title the Son of God is one that Jesus used to describe himself. Here the Jews said that Jesus should die because he used that title for himself. They said that by using that title, he made himself equal to God (see 5:18 and 10:33–36). Jesus was God the Son, but the Jews did not believe that. See how you translated the Son of God at 1:34 and 10:36. For further information on what it means that Jesus was the Son of God, see the note at 1:34.

General Comment on 19:7a–b

In some languages it may be more natural to rearrange the clauses in this sentence. You may want to put what the Jews said Jesus did before mentioning the law. Here is an example in which the word “because” is implied:

^{7b}The crowd replied, “He claimed to be the Son of God! ^{7a}Our Law says that he must be put to death.” (CEV)

General Comment on 19:7a–b

19:7a–b includes a quotation inside a quotation. The BSB translates the inner quotation as an indirect quotation (“he has claimed to be the Son of God”). In some languages it may be natural to use another direct quotation. For example:

^{7a}The Jews said, “We have a law. According to that law he should be killed, ^{7b}because he said, ‘I am the Son of God.’ ”

Translate this quotation inside a quotation in a way that is natural in your language.

John 19:8

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:8–11

Pilate and Jesus spoke together. Jesus showed that he was not afraid of Pilate. He said that it was God who gave Pilate his power.

19:8

When Pilate heard this statement, he was even more afraid,

- ¶ So when Pilate heard what the Jews said, he was more afraid.
- ¶ Hearing that Jesus claimed to be the Son of God caused Pilate to become even more frightened.

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that is often translated as “So” indicating a result. In this context it introduces the result of what the Jewish leaders just said. The word “When” also indicates a result here, so many English translations, like the BSB, leave this word implicit. Introduce the result (Pilate’s reaction) in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Therefore when Pilate heard this statement
(NASB)

When Pilate heard this statement, he was even more afraid: What the Jews said caused Pilate to be afraid. He did not know before that Jesus said that he was the Son of God. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

Hearing this, Pilate felt even more fear.

These words caused Pilate to become even more frightened.

This made Pilate even more afraid.

Pilate was more afraid when he heard what the Jews said.

When Pilate heard this statement: The pronoun this refers to what the Jewish high priests just told Pilate, that Jesus claimed to be the Son of God. Here is another way to translate this clause:

When Pilate heard what they said (NET)

he was even more afraid: The Greek word that the BSB translates as even more here probably implies that Pilate was already afraid. A few commentaries and CEV understand this word to mean that Pilate was “very much” afraid rather than “more” afraid. And a few commentaries understand it to mean “rather” here as it does in 3:19 and 12:43. However, most commentaries and nearly all English translations understand it to mean “more.” For example:

he was more afraid than ever (NRSV)

In some languages it is natural to say what Pilate was afraid of. Apparently he was afraid to condemn Jesus to death, but he was also afraid to reject the Jewish leaders’ demand. So he delayed making a decision and talked to Jesus again. If you must indicate what Pilate was afraid of, it is best to say something general. For example:

he was even more afraid to judge/act/decide

John 19:9

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus’ trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus' death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:8–11

Pilate and Jesus spoke together. Jesus showed that he was not afraid of Pilate. He said that it was God who gave Pilate his power.

19:9a

and he went back into the Praetorium.

- He went back inside his building/house.
- He returned to his palace/mansion

and he went back into the Praetorium: Pilate went back into his house, into the room used as a court. See how you translated the word Praetorium in 18:28. It is implied that Jesus entered with him. For example:

He took Jesus back into the headquarters again (NLT)

19:9b

"Where are You from?" he asked.

- Pilate said to Jesus, "From where do you^(sing) come?,"
- and asked Jesus where he was from.

"Where are You from?" he asked: This question asks where Jesus came from, probably meaning, "Are you from earth or heaven?" A few scholars believe that Pilate was asking where in Palestine Jesus came from. However, he asked that question in Luke 23:6 and that most probably happened earlier than here in the story. Pilate was frightened at the thought that Jesus could be the Son of God. So he asked Jesus this question to better know if he was really from God. But you should not make that explicit in your translation. Here is another way to translate this question:

Where do you come from? (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this question as indirect speech. For example:

He asked Jesus where he was from.

19:9c

But Jesus gave no answer.

- but Jesus did not answer him.
- Jesus remained silent and did not answer him.

But Jesus gave no answer: The phrase gave no answer indicates that Jesus remained silent. He did not answer Pilate. For example:

But Jesus did not answer. (GNT)

But Jesus did not answer him. (NCV)

John 19:10

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:8–11

Pilate and Jesus spoke together. Jesus showed that he was not afraid of Pilate. He said that it was God who gave Pilate his power.

19:10a

So Pilate said to Him, "Do You refuse to speak to me?"

- So Pilate asked Jesus, "Why do you^(sing) refuse to answer my question?"
- Then Pilate said to Jesus, "You^(sing) should not refuse to answer me."

So Pilate said to Him: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *So* introduces Pilate's response to Jesus' silence. His response was a rhetorical question. Introduce this response in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Pilate then said to him (NJB)

Pilate therefore said to him (NRSV)

Pilate asked (CEV)

So Pilate said (NET)

So: The connector *So* indicates that Pilate's reply was the result of Jesus not answering him.

Do You refuse to speak to me?: This is a rhetorical question. It expresses surprise and anger. Jesus' silence offended Pilate because he had authority (see 19:10b–c) and expected Jesus to answer his questions. He was also surprised that Jesus did not speak to him.

The Greek text emphasizes the word that the BSB translates as *to me*. That emphasizes Pilate's anger

and surprise. It also leads to his next questions where he makes sure that Jesus knows his authority. Here are some ways to translate this surprise and anger:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Why won't you answer my question? (CEV)

- Use a statement. For example:

You are refusing to talk to me.

You are not answering me.

19:10b

Do You not know that I have authority to release You

- Surely you know I have power to release you (NJB)
- You^(sing) must know that I have the authority to free you

19:10c

and authority to crucify You?"

- and I have power to crucify you?" (NJB)
- or to nail you to a cross."

19:10b–c

Do You not know that I have authority to release You and authority to crucify You?: This is a rhetorical question. It is used to scold and emphasizes that Pilate did have power. As Roman governor, Pilate had the authority to judge people and to punish or free them. Pilate scolded Jesus for not answering his question.

There are two ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

Don't you know that I have the power to let you go free or to nail you to a cross? (CEV)

Surely you know that I have authority to release you, and authority to crucify you? (REB)

Don't you realize I have power either to free you or to crucify you? (NIV)

- Use a statement. For example:

Remember, I have the authority to set you free and also to have you crucified. (GNT)

I have the right/power to order the soldiers to kill you by nailing you to a cross. Or I can tell them to free you.

Translate this rebuke in a way that is most natural in your language.

to release You: This phrase refers to Pilate releasing or freeing Jesus from being a prisoner. The pronoun You is singular and refers to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to set you free (GNT)

to free you (GW)

to let you go free (CEV)

to crucify You: The verb crucify means to execute (punish with death) by nailing to a cross. See the notes and how you translated this word in 19:6b. Again, Pilate would not do this himself but would order the soldiers to do it. Here are some other ways to translate this verb:

nail you to a cross (CEV)

cause you^(sing) to be killed on a cross

order you to be executed on a cross

You: This pronoun is again singular and again refers to Jesus.

John 19:11

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

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Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:8–11

Pilate and Jesus spoke together. Jesus showed that he was not afraid of Pilate. He said that it was God who gave Pilate his power.

19:11a–b

You would have no authority over Me if it were not given to you from above: This sentence suggests a situation that is not true: that God had not given Pilate power. If that situation were true, Pilate would have no power to decide Jesus' fate. But God had in fact given Pilate power over Jesus. This was the only reason why Pilate had this power. Consider how it is natural to translate in your language a suggested situation that is not true. See the General Comment on 19:11a–b for examples where the clauses are re-arranged.

In some languages it is more natural to use a positive statement. For example:

The only power you have over me is the power given to you by God. (NCV)

You have authority over me only because it was given to you by God. (GNT)

You could only do like that because God has given you that authority. (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

19:11a

Jesus answered, "You would have no authority over Me

- Jesus replied, "You would not have any power to release or crucify me
- Jesus answered, "You have authority over me (GNT)

You would have no authority over Me: This clause describes a situation that is not true. Pilate did in fact have power over Jesus.

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to Pilate.

authority over Me: This phrase refers to Pilate's power or authority to crucify or to free Jesus. As governor, he had the authority to judge people and decide what would happen to them. And as Jesus said in 19:11b, God is really the one who gave him that authority. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

authority to judge me

power to be in charge of me (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

19:11b

if it were not given to you from above.

- if it were not given to you by God.

- only because God gave it to you.

if it were not given to you from above: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as if...not. There is a condition here: “if the power had not been given you from above.” This was a condition that was not fulfilled, because God had given Pilate power. That was the only reason why Pilate did have power over Jesus. Translate this condition that was not fulfilled in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

if it were not given to you from above (NIV)

if it had not been given you from above (NJB)

You have authority over me only because it was given to you by God (GNT)

were not given: This verb phrase is passive, and there are at least two ways to translate it:

General Comment on 19:11a–b

- Use a passive verb. For example:

given to you by God (GNT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

unless you had received it from above/God

if God had not given authority to you

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in 19:11a–b. For example:

^{11b}If God had not given you the power, ^{11a}you couldn't do anything at all to me. (CEV)

^{11b}As for your power to be in charge of me, if it were not given you by God, ^{11a}you wouldn't be able to do anything. (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

19:11c

Therefore the one who handed Me over to you is guilty of greater sin.”

- So the man who delivered me to you is even more guilty/responsible than you are.”
- So the man/person who gave me to you to judge me has sinned even more than you have.”

Therefore: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Therefore introduces a logical result or conclusion. Introduce this result in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

That's why (GW)

And for that reason (JBP)

So (NLT)

the one who handed Me over to you: This clause refers to the person who brought Jesus to Pilate so Pilate could judge him. The clause probably refers to the high priest, Caiaphas, who sent Jesus to Pilate. However, you should not make that explicit in your translation.

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Pilate.

is guilty of greater sin: This phrase indicates that this man, probably Caiaphas, had done something worse than Pilate had done. Both had done wrong, and were responsible for doing it, but Caiaphas had done the worse wrong. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is even more guilty than you are (JBP)

did something even worse (CEV)

John 19:12

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

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This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:12–16a

This paragraph tells of Pilate's last attempt to get the Jewish religious leaders to agree to release Jesus. The Jewish leaders threatened him by implying that releasing Jesus would make the emperor angry. So finally Pilate condemned Jesus to death.

19:12a

From then on, Pilate tried to release Him,

- ¶ From that moment Pilate looked for a way to free Jesus.
- ¶ Starting then, Pilate made efforts to let Jesus go free,

From then on: The phrase that BSB translates as From then on is more literally "From this." Several scholars think that this phrase indicates a result. However, the NASB is the only English translation that follows this interpretation ("As a result of this"). Therefore it is strongly recommended that you translate this phrase as a time phrase. The idea of result should be implied in a time phrase anyway. It introduces Pilate's reaction to what Jesus said in 19:11. This phrase and the tense of "tried" in the following clause indicate that Pilate repeated his trying. Indicate either here or in the next clause that the action is repeated in a natural way in your language. For example:

From this point on (NET)

From that moment (REB)

Starting then

Pilate tried to release Him: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as tried to release Him indicates that Pilate wanted to set Jesus free. He did not do that by trying to remove Jesus' ropes. His efforts were legal or verbal rather than physical. The tense of the Greek word indicates that he also made repeated efforts. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Pilate made efforts to release him (NASB)

Pilate was anxious to set him free (NJB)

he tried to find a way to set Jesus free (GNT)

19:12b

but the Jews kept shouting,

- But the Jewish people there shouted,
- but the Jewish crowd loudly threatened him,

but the Jews kept shouting: This clause indicates that the Jews opposed Pilate's efforts to release Jesus. The word but indicates a contrast between what Pilate wanted and what the Jews wanted. The Greek text

emphasizes the phrase the Jews to indicate a change in the topic. For example:

But the Jews, they continued to shout (Kankanaey Back Translation)

But the crowd shouted back (GNT)

the Jews: This phrase here refers to the people gathered at Pilate's house who accused Jesus. Like Jesus and his disciples, they were Jewish. They included the chief priests and temple guards mentioned in 19:6a. This phrase was used to refer to the same group of people in 18:31, 18:38, and 19:7. See how you translated this phrase in those verses. For example:

some in the crowd (NCV)

the Jewish leaders (NET)

kept shouting: The people shouted to express their opposition to what Pilate was trying to do. Here are other ways to translate this Greek verb:

shouted back (GNT)

yelled (CEV)

19:12c

“If you release this man, you are no friend of Caesar.”

- “If you set him free, that means that you are not the Emperor's friend! (GNT)
- “If you^(sing) free Jesus, then you are an enemy of the highest ruler Caesar.

If you release this man, you are no friend of Caesar: This sentence expresses a condition (If you release this man) and a conclusion (you are no friend of Caesar). The Jews said that if the condition were fulfilled, then the conclusion would be true.

The Jews were trying to persuade Pilate to not release Jesus. They knew that it was important to him to be a friend of the emperor. Not being his friend could result in punishment or even death. So he would not want to do anything that would mean that he was not his friend. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

If you set him free, that means that you are not the Emperor's friend! (GNT)

You are not a friend of the emperor if you release this man!

If you release this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as release means “set free.” For example:

If you set this man free (CEV)

If you free this man (GW)

you: This pronoun here is singular and refers to Pilate.

this man: The Greek word that the BSB translates as this man is more literally “this one.” It is a way to refer to someone that implies that they are not important. Here it refers to Jesus.

you are no friend of Caesar: The phrase no friend of Caesar means “an enemy of the emperor.” The Jews were threatening Pilate. They said that freeing Jesus would be acting like an enemy of the Roman emperor. They implied that the emperor would notice what Pilate did and act to punish him. In some languages it may be natural to use a positive expression. For example:

you are an enemy of the emperor

Caesar: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Caesar was the family name of the Roman Emperor (king of an empire), and it became a title. It was the emperor who had appointed Pilate to this job and he could also dismiss or execute (punish with death) Pilate. Here are other ways to translate this word:

the emperor

the ruler in Rome (Otomi Back Translation)

our^(incl) King Caesar who is in Rome (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

19:12d

Anyone who declares himself a king is defying Caesar.”

- Anyone who claims to be a king is an enemy of the Emperor.” (CEV)
- If a person says he is a king, he is rebelling against Caesar.”

Anyone who declares himself a king: This clause refers to the fact that Jesus claimed (declared) that he was the Messiah. The Messiah was thought to be the “king of the Jews.” Use the term for king that you used in 18:33 and 19:3.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as declares is more literally “makes,” as in 19:7. It implies that the person is not really a king but says he is and acts like a king. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Everyone who claims to be a king (NRSV)

Everyone who makes himself a king (ESV)

Anyone who says, “I am a king”

is defying Caesar: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as is defying means “speaks against.” In this context it refers to rejecting and rebelling against the most powerful ruler. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

is against Caesar (NCV)

is an enemy of the Emperor (CEV)

is a rebel against the Emperor (GNT)

opposes Caesar (NASB)

John 19:13

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

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Paragraph 19:12–16a

This paragraph tells of Pilate’s last attempt to get the Jewish religious leaders to agree to release Jesus. The Jewish leaders threatened him by implying that releasing Jesus would make the emperor angry. So finally Pilate condemned Jesus to death.

19:13a**When Pilate heard these words,**

- When Pilate heard what they were saying, (REB)
- When Pilate heard what the crowd was threatening,

When Pilate heard these words: The phrase these words refers to what the people just said to Pilate.

19:13b**he brought Jesus out**

- he ordered Jesus to be brought out to him
- he told the soldiers to lead Jesus out of the palace/mansion to the courtyard.

he brought Jesus out: This clause implies that Pilate told the soldiers to take Jesus outside. They took him from the court in Pilate's house to the courtyard in front of the house. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he led Jesus outside (JBP)

he caused Jesus to be brought/led outside

19:13c**and sat on the judgment seat**

- and sat down on his judge's chair
- He sat down on the official judgment seat
- He took his seat where the judge always sat to announce his decisions.

and sat on the judgment seat: Pilate sat down on the judge's seat in the courtyard. That was a sign that he would soon announce his final decision about the case.

There are two ways to understand the Greek verb that the BSB translates as sat:

1. It means that Pilate sat down himself on the judge's bench. For example:

Pilate sat down on the judgment seat (NLT) (BSB, NRSV, RSV, ESV, NIV, NET, GNT, NLT, REB, GW, NASB, CEV, NCV, KJV)

1. It means that Pilate seated Jesus (caused him to sit) on the judge's bench, perhaps to mock him. For example:

Pilate...seated him on the chair of judgment (NJB) (NJB)

It is strongly recommended that you follow interpretation (1) with the great majority of translations and scholars.

the judgment seat: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the judgment seat refers to a raised platform with a seat. The governor, acting as judge, sat on this seat to announce his decisions. For example:

the judge's seat (GNT)

In translating this expression, avoid implying that Pilate sat on someone else's seat. This seat was used by the governor to announce judgments and decisions. It may therefore be natural to say:

his judgment bench

the seat of the governor when giving judgment (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

19:13d**at a place called the Stone Pavement, which in Hebrew is Gabbatha.**

- in the area called "Paved with Stones," which is called "Gabbatha" in the Hebrew language.
- It was in the courtyard called "Stone Floor," which the Jews call "Gabbatha."

at a place: The place where Pilate took his seat was an outdoor pavement in the governor's courtyard.

called the Stone Pavement: The phrase the Stone Pavement is the name of this area in the courtyard. It indicates that it was paved (covered) with large flat rocks to form a solid floor.

which in Hebrew is Gabbatha: The expression which in Hebrew is Gabbatha is short for "in the Hebrew language (Aramaic) this place is called Gabbatha." The Hebrew people (Jews) called this pavement Gabbatha. This does not mean that the word Gabbatha meant "Stone Pavement." The meaning of the Aramaic word Gabbatha is uncertain.

Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

(In the Jewish language the name is Gabbatha) (NCV)

the Jewish people call it Gabbatha

in Hebrew: Hebrew refers to the language that the Jewish people in Jesus' day spoke, which was Aramaic.

See 5:2, where the same expression is used. Here are some other ways this phrase can be translated:

in Aramaic (ESV)

in the language of the Jews

in the language that the Jews speak

Because the author of this book, John, is also a Jew, in some languages it is more natural to say:

in our^(excl) language

in the language that we^(excl) Jews speak

John 19:14

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus' death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:12–16a

This paragraph tells of Pilate's last attempt to get the Jewish religious leaders to agree to release Jesus. The Jewish leaders threatened him by implying that releasing Jesus would make the emperor angry. So finally Pilate condemned Jesus to death.

19:14a

It was the day of Preparation for the Passover,

- It was the day in the Passover festival when the Jews prepared for the Sabbath,
- This took place during the week of the Death-Passed-Over-Us feast, on Friday,

In Greek this verse begins with a conjunction that is often translated as "Now." Here it introduces some background information. It is not a time word referring to the present. Some English versions, like the BSB, leave this word implied.

It was the day of Preparation for the Passover:

The Greek text that the BSB translates as the day

of Preparation for the Passover is more literally “the preparation of the Passover.” This probably refers to the Friday of Passover week. That was the day of preparation for the Sabbath that happened during Passover week. Here are other ways to translate this Greek phrase:

It was...Preparation Day of Passover week (NCV)

...on the Friday of the Passover festival (GW)

the day of Preparation: This phrase usually refers to Friday, when Jewish people prepared for the Sabbath. On the Sabbath, Saturday, they did not work, so it was necessary to prepare meals and clean the previous day. See Mark 15:42 and Luke 23:54.

Passover: Passover is the Jewish feast that celebrates how God rescued the Jewish people from being slaves in Egypt. This term is also used in John 2:13; 6:4; 11:55; 12:1; 13:1; and 18:28. For more information see the note on John 2:13a. Also see how you translated the word there.

Passover could be on any day of the week. The word Passover was sometimes used to refer to the whole week of the festival. That is probably the case here. See Carson, pages 603–604, and Kostenberger, page 537.

19:14b about the sixth hour.

- and it was the middle of the day.
- late in the morning.

about the sixth hour: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as about the sixth hour. Jewish people normally started counting the hours of the day from sunrise, about 6 a.m., so this would have been about 12 noon. A few scholars think that John follows Roman time here and the sixth hour was 6 a.m. (See GW: “The time was about six o’clock in the morning.”) They think that because Mark 15:25 says that Jesus was crucified at the third hour. However, Roman time was only later different from Jewish time, and then only rarely. Therefore it makes better sense to see both Mark and John as giving an approximate time because neither one had a watch. Mark especially could have just referred to the quarter of the day, from 9 a.m. to noon. So both Pilate’s judgment and the crucifixion happened in the late morning. The same expression is used in 4:6. See the note there. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

It was then almost noon (GNT)

in the late morning

General Comment on 19:14a–b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in 19:14a–b. For example:

^{14b}It was then almost noon ^{14a}on the Friday of the Passover week/festival.

19:14c

And Pilate said to the Jews, “Here is your King!”

- And Pilate said to the Jewish people, “This is your^(plur) king!”
- Pilate said to the Jewish crowd, “Look! Here is your^(plur) king!”

And Pilate said to the Jews: The word the BSB translates as Pilate is literally the pronoun “he” and refers to Pilate.

the Jews: This phrase refers to the same group as mentioned in 19:12, the Jews who were accusing Jesus. See how you translated it there.

Here is your King!: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Here is calls attention to what follows. See how you translated this expression in 1:29. Here it means that the people should look at Jesus. For example:

Look at your king! (CEV)

your King: Pilate called Jesus their King because that is what the chief priests accused him of saying that he was. But Pilate did not think that Jesus was really their king. He was mocking the Jews, because they should be protecting their king, not asking for him to be killed.

your: This pronoun is plural and refers to the Jewish people in general.

John 19:15

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

18:28–32: Outside the house; Jews ask for Jesus' death

18:33–38a: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus if he is King of the Jews

18:38b–40: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:1–3: The soldiers beat Jesus with a whip and pretend that he is the king of the Jews

19:4–8: Outside the house; Pilate says, "I find no case against him."

19:8–11: Inside the house; Pilate asks Jesus where he came from

19:12–16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1–3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1–3. Also, try to translate this section

in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:12–16a

This paragraph tells of Pilate's last attempt to get the Jewish religious leaders to agree to release Jesus. The Jewish leaders threatened him by implying that releasing Jesus would make the emperor angry. So finally Pilate condemned Jesus to death.

19:15a

At this, they shouted, "Away with Him! Away with Him! Crucify Him!"

- Then the people shouted, "Remove^(sing) him! Remove him! Kill him on a cross!"
- "Kill him! Kill him!" they yelled. "Nail him to a cross!" (CEV)

At this: The Greek text that the BSB translates as *At this* is a conjunction that is often translated as "So" or "Therefore." Here it could have that sense and indicate the result of what Pilate said in 19:14c. Most English translations leave the conjunction implied, but it may be more natural in some languages to include it. For example:

Then (NET)

So (NASB)

they shouted: The Greek verb that the BSB translates shouted means that the crowd spoke very loudly. For example:

they yelled

Away with Him! Away with Him!: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as *Away with Him* indicates that they strongly rejected Jesus. It means "get rid of him" or "remove him." It implies the use of force, even destroying something or killing someone. Translate this strong cry in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Take him away! Take him away! (NCV)

Kill him! Kill him! (GNT)

The clause *Away with Him!* is repeated for emphasis. In some languages it is more natural to express emphasis by using two different expressions. Also, the commands are singular, meaning that the Jews are talking just to Pilate. For example:

Remove^(sing) him! Destroy^(sing) him!

Don't let him live! Kill him! (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

Crucify Him!: The word Crucify means to kill someone by nailing him to a cross. See how you translated Crucify in 19:6. Again, the command is singular, meaning that the Jews are talking just to Pilate. Here is another way to translate this sentence:

Nail him to a cross! (CEV)

19:15b

“Shall I crucify your King?” Pilate asked.

- Pilate asked them, “Should I crucify your^(plur) king?”
- Pilate said to the crowd, “Do you^(plur) want me to nail your king to a cross to die?”

Shall I crucify your King?: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Shall I crucify...? is asking whether the angry crowd wanted Pilate to crucify Jesus. Pilate wanted to be sure that this was what the crowd wanted. For example:

Should I crucify your king? (GW)

Do you want me to crucify your king? (NCV)

So you want me to nail your king to a cross? (CEV)

19:15c

“We have no king but Caesar,” replied the chief priests.

- The chief/leading priests answered, “The only king we have is the Emperor!” (GNT)
- The religious leaders answered Pilate, “Caesar is our^(excl) only king.”

We have no king but Caesar: The Jewish people had always said that their only king was God himself. Here they ignored that and said the Roman emperor was their only king. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive expression. For example:

The only king we have is the Emperor! (GNT)

Caesar is our king and no one else (JBP)

Our only king is the emperor!

We: This pronoun is exclusive and refers to the Jewish people.

Caesar: This phrase refers to the ruler of the Roman Empire in Rome. The BSB translates the Greek literally as Caesar, the family name of the Roman emperor. See how you translated this word in 19:12.

replied the chief priests: The phrase the chief priests refers to the most important Jewish priests. See how you translated this phrase in 19:6.

John 19:16

Section 18:28–19:16a: Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he should die

This section tells how the soldiers took Jesus to the Roman governor, Pilate. Pilate questioned Jesus to find out why the Jews wanted him to punish Jesus with death. He could find no reason to do that. But the Jewish leaders there insisted that Pilate crucify him. Finally, Pilate agreed that Jesus could be crucified.

Here are other possible section headings:

Pilate questioned the Jews and Jesus and sent Jesus to be crucified

Pilate investigated Jesus and decided that he could be punished with death

Jesus' trial and judgment before Pilate

This section can be divided into seven smaller pieces, where each piece is a separate event. Jews often arranged written materials to include seven related pieces, where the first and last pieces relate, and the second and sixth relate, and the third and fifth relate. Then the middle piece, the fourth, stands alone and is emphasized. That happens in this section as well. Here is a chart showing the seven pieces of this section and how they relate:

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19:12-16a: Outside the house; Pilate allows Jews to crucify Jesus

The middle piece, 19:1-3, is different from all the other pieces. Pilate is only mentioned and is not an important person in this event. That is different from all the other pieces. This middle piece therefore is emphasized. The only ones who seem to worship Jesus in the whole section do so in this middle piece. However, they only pretend to worship and are very cruel as they mock Jesus.

In your translation, you may want to find ways to emphasize 19:1-3. Also, try to translate this section in ways that make it possible to see the connections between the pieces.

Paragraph 19:12-16a

This paragraph tells of Pilate’s last attempt to get the Jewish religious leaders to agree to release Jesus. The Jewish leaders threatened him by implying that releasing Jesus would make the emperor angry. So finally Pilate condemned Jesus to death.

19:16a

Then Pilate handed Jesus over to be crucified,

- Then, to satisfy them, Pilate gave Jesus to the soldiers to crucify him.
- Then Pilate ordered the soldiers to kill Jesus by nailing him to a cross.

Then: The Greek more literally says “Therefore then.” Pilate listened to what the angry crowd said and agreed to do what they demanded. The Greek word usually translated “Therefore” probably indicates a significant development here: Pilate’s decision to crucify Jesus.

Pilate handed Jesus over to be crucified: Pilate told the soldiers to take Jesus and crucify him.

Pilate: The word the BSB translates as Pilate is the Greek pronoun “he.” In some languages it may be natural to use the Greek wording.

handed...over: The phrase that the BSB translates as handed...over indicates that Pilate did what the angry

crowd wanted. Pilate gave the soldiers authority over Jesus so that they could crucify him.

The Greek contains the phrase “to them” to indicate to whom Jesus was handed over. Who “them” refers to is ambiguous. The last plural noun is “chief priests” in 19:15c. However, Jews did not have the authority to crucify anyone and it was the Roman soldiers who took and crucified him. The meaning here then seems to be, “Pilate gave Jesus to the soldiers to satisfy the demands of the Jews.” Carson, who continues, “(cf. NEB: ‘Then at last, to satisfy them, [Pilate] handed Jesus over to be crucified’). This reading is confirmed by Luke 23:24: ‘So Pilate decided to grant their demand’ (lit. he ‘handed Jesus over to their will...’).” Because the pronoun is ambiguous in Greek and all English translations, it is recommended that you leave it ambiguous. Here is another way to translate this entire clause:

Then at last, to satisfy them, he handed Jesus over to be crucified. (REB)

to be crucified: This verb phrase is passive. There are several ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

to be nailed to a cross (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

to kill Jesus by nailing him to a cross

- Use a noun. For example:

for crucifixion (JBP)

for punishment on a cross

For more information on the meaning of the term crucified see the note in 19:6c.

Section 19:16b-27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:16b

and the soldiers took Him away.

- ¶ Therefore the soldiers led Jesus out.
- ¶ So then the soldiers led Jesus away to go where they will crucify him.

and the soldiers took Him away: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as took...away indicates that the soldiers took charge of Jesus and led him away. For example:

So the soldiers took charge of Jesus. (NIV)

Then/therefore the soldiers led Jesus away

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces the result of what Pilate did in the previous sentence, 19:16a. Pilate handed Jesus over to be nailed on a cross, and the soldiers now took him to do that.

the soldiers: This pronoun refers to the Roman soldiers. It may be natural to make this explicit:

the soldiers took Jesus (GW)

John 19:17

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:17a

Carrying His own cross,

- ¶ As Jesus carried the cross himself,
- ¶ Jesus was carrying on his shoulder the wooden beam on/to which they would nail him.

Carrying His own cross: As Jesus began walking, he carried the cross. Some scholars think that Jesus was carrying the smaller, horizontal crossbeam rather than the whole cross. However, the author does not mention this and you should translate this literally here, on which the soldiers would crucify him. The other gospels tell us that a man named Simon would have to carry it part of the way. So you do not want to say that Jesus carried the cross the whole way. John just says that he went out, leaving Jerusalem.

In some languages it is necessary to say where or how Jesus was carrying the cross. He was probably carrying it over his shoulder. In some languages it may be more natural to use an independent clause to translate phrase. For example:

He carried his own cross (GW)

His own: The Greek word that the BSB translates as His own indicates that Jesus was carrying his own cross without help. The other gospels say that Jesus did not carry it all the way, but he did carry it at first. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

carrying the cross by himself (NRSV)

and he carried his cross (CEV)

cross: In cultures where a cross is unknown, it is more natural to speak of its use rather than its shape. For example:

the beam on which criminals are nailed to die

the wood on which they would nail/kill him

19:17b**He went out to The Place of the Skull,**

- they went out of the city to a place called Skull,
- The soldiers led Jesus to go to Skull Place.

He went out: The pronoun He here refers to Jesus, but the soldiers and the crowd went with him. So in some languages it is more natural to make that explicit. For example:

they went out

they left

went out: The verb went out here refers to leaving the city of Jerusalem. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

went out of the city (GW)

to The Place of the Skull: The name of the place where the soldiers took Jesus was The Place of the Skull. Many scholars understand that this place was a hill near Jerusalem that had a shape like a human skull. That may be true, although the gospels say nothing about a hill, nor why the place name referred to a skull. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to the place called “The Place of a Skull” (ESV)

to a location called The Skull (GW)

to “The Place of the Skull,” as it is called (GNT)

Skull: This word refers to the bones of a head, part of a human skeleton.

General Comment on 19:17a–b

The way that some languages use verbs of coming and going may make it natural to rearrange some information in 19:17a–b. For example:

He went out, carrying his cross, and came to “The Place of the Skull,” as it is called. (GNT)

19:17c**which in Hebrew is called Golgotha.**

- which in the Jewish language is called Golgotha.
- (The language that/we^(excl) Jews speak calls it Golgotha.)

which in Hebrew is called Golgotha: The Aramaic word for “skull” was Golgotha. This is background information, and in some languages it may be natural to indicate this in some way. For example:

- Use parentheses. For example:

(which in Aramaic is called Golgotha) (NIV)

- Translate this as a separate sentence. For example:

In Aramaic this place is called “Golgotha.” (CEV)

- Put a separate sentence in parentheses. For example:

(In Hebrew it is called “Golgotha.”) (GNT)

Hebrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Hebrew refers to the language that Jews spoke in Jesus’ time. Some translations say “Aramaic,” which is the name in modern English. Here are some other ways that this clause can be translated:

the Jewish language

the language that the Jews speak

Because John the author was a Jew, in some languages it is more natural to translate it like this:

our^(excl) language

the language that we^(excl) Jews speak

See how you translated this word in 19:13.

John 19:18**Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross**

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:18a

There they crucified Him,

- They crucified Jesus there,
- When they arrived at that place, the soldiers nailed him to a cross.

There they crucified Him: The soldiers nailed Jesus to the cross to die on Golgotha, The Place of the Skull.

There they nailed him to the cross. (NLT)

There Jesus was nailed to the cross. (CEV)

There: This refers to The Place of the Skull. Refer back to this place in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

At that place

they: This pronoun refers to the soldiers. In some languages you may want to make this explicit. For example

The soldiers (GW)

crucified Him: The verb crucified refers to nailing someone to a cross to die. See the note on 19:6 for more information. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that Jesus was the one whom the soldiers crucified. For example:

crucified Jesus (NCV)

19:18b

and with Him two others,

- along with two other men.
- They also nailed two other men to crosses,

and with Him two others: This phrase is short for “and they crucified two other men there also.” The soldiers nailed two other men to crosses at the same time and place as they nailed Jesus to a cross. In

some languages it may be natural to translate this as a separate clause, supplying a verb. For example:

and they also crucified two other men (GNT)

There were two others which they also nailed to crosses.

19:18c

one on each side, with Jesus in the middle.

- They placed the two men on either side of Jesus, and Jesus in the middle.
- one on each side, with Jesus’ cross in the middle.

one on each side, with Jesus in the middle: There were three crosses. The cross Jesus was on was in the middle, between the other two crosses. Translate this phrase so that it does not sound like all three men were on the same cross. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

one on either side, with Jesus between them (NRSV)

Jesus’ cross was in the middle, between them.

General Comment on 19:18b–c

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange or combine the information in 19:18b–c. For example:

and on each side of him a man was also nailed to a cross (CEV)

General Comment on 19:16b–18

In the Greek text 19:16b–18 forms one long sentence. Most English translations break this into at least two sentences. Use the sentence length that is natural in your language. Here is an example of how it can be translated into several shorter sentences:

^{16b}So the soldiers took Jesus. ^{17a}He carried his own cross ^{17b}and went out of the city to a location called The Skull. ^{17c}(In Hebrew this place is called Golgotha.) ^{18a}The soldiers crucified Jesus ^{18b}and two other men there. ^{18c}Jesus was in the middle. (GW)

John 19:19

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on

the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:19a

Pilate also had a notice posted on the cross.

- Pilate ordered that a notice be written and fastened/attached to the cross.
- Pilate commanded that someone write a sign and place it at the top of the cross.

Pilate also had a notice posted on the cross: The Greek text here is more literally “And Pilate also wrote an inscription and placed it on the cross.” However, the sense is that Pilate told someone to write an inscription (notice) and fasten it to Jesus’ cross. The BSB makes it explicit that Pilate told someone to do these things with the word *had*. He probably ordered the soldiers or a servant to do them. Other translations are less explicit about that and translate the Greek more literally. Translate this clause so that your readers can understand that Pilate did not do these things himself. For example:

Pilate ordered the charge against Jesus to be written on a board and put above the cross. (CEV)

Pilate wrote a notice and had it put on the cross. (GNT)

Pilate told his men to write a notice and attach it to the cross.

Pilate told the soldiers, “Write a sign and fasten it to the cross.”

a notice: The Greek word that the BSB translates as notice here refers to something written for the public to read. It was probably written on a wooden board. The notice, which sometimes hung around the prisoner’s neck, told the crime of the person being crucified. Pilate told the soldiers to put this inscription on Jesus’ cross. Here are other ways to translate this Greek word:

an inscription (GNT)

a sign (NCV)

19:19b

It read: JESUS OF NAZARETH, THE KING OF THE JEWS.

- What he ordered written was “Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews.”
- “Jesus from the village of Nazareth, the King of the Jews” is what it said.

It read: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as It read is more literally “it was written.” This phrase introduces the content of the inscription. Introduce what the inscription said in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

a board/sign...reading

The notice read (NET)

which/it said

JESUS OF NAZARETH: The phrase that the BSB translates as JESUS OF NAZARETH is more literally “Jesus the Nazarene” and means “Jesus from the village of Nazareth.” See how you translated this phrase in 18:5 and 18:7.

THE KING OF THE JEWS: The Jews had accused Jesus of rebelling against Roman rule by saying that he was the king of the Jews. Pilate ordered that they write this phrase to indicate that Jesus was being killed because he said that. See the note on 18:33 for suggestions on how to translate the phrase “King of the Jews.” Also see how you translated the phrase there.

THE JEWS: This phrase here means “the Jewish people” or “the tribe called Jews.”

General Comment on 19:19b

In some languages it may be natural to put the inscription first. For example:

“Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews,” is what he wrote. (GNT)

John 19:20

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:20a

Many of the Jews read this sign,

- Many Jews read the notice
- Many Jewish people read this sign

Many of the Jews read this sign: Here the phrase the Jews refers to the Jewish people in general and not just to the Jewish leaders. The people who walked past the crucifixion could see the notice on the cross. John specifically mentions the Jews. That fact was probably the motive for the chief priests to complain to Pilate in 19:21. Some translations leave the fact that the people were Jews implied, but it is recommended that you make it explicit. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

many of the Jewish residents of Jerusalem read this notice (NET)

This inscription, in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek, was read by many Jews (REB)

19:20b

because the place where Jesus was crucified was near the city,

- because the place of Jesus’ crucifixion was near Jerusalem,
- because the soldiers nailed Jesus to the cross just outside of Jerusalem.

because the place where Jesus was crucified was near the city: There are two reasons why so many Jews could read this notice. This is the first reason: the place Jesus was crucified was just outside of Jerusalem. The Jews who lived there and those visiting during Passover could easily go see the men hanging on crosses. Here is another way to translate this clause:

The place where Jesus was taken wasn’t far from the city (CEV)

the city: This phrase here refers to Jerusalem.

19:20c

and it was written in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek.

- and the notice was written in three languages: Aramaic, Latin, and Greek.
- Also because the sign was written three times: in the language of the Jews, in the language of the Romans, and in the language of the Greeks.

and it was written in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek: This clause indicates the second reason that many Jews could read the sign. That reason was that the notice was written in all three of the main languages spoken in that area. In your translation, it may be natural to indicate that Hebrew, Latin, and Greek were all languages that people spoke then. For example:

The sign was written in three languages: Hebrew, Latin, and Greek.

The notice was written three times in the language of the Jews, the language of the Romans, and the language of the Greeks.

Hebrew: The word Hebrew is transliterated from the Greek for the language that the Jewish people in Jesus’ day spoke. Some translations use the word “Aramaic” which is the name in modern English. Here are some other ways this idea can be translated:

The sign was written in the Jewish language (NCV)

in the language that the Jews spoke

See how you translated this word in 19:13 and 19:17.

Latin: Latin is the name of the language that the ancient Romans spoke. It was the language that the government used and Pilate's own language.

Greek: The Greek language was the common trade language spoken in the eastern half of the Roman Empire. The people who spoke it can be called "Greeks," but you should not indicate that they were from Greece. No country with that name existed in Jesus' time.

General Comment on 19:20a–c

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange 19:20a–c. For example:

^{20c}The sign was written in the Jewish language, in Latin, and in Greek. ^{20a}Many of the Jews read the sign, ^{20b}because the place where Jesus was crucified was near the city. (NCV91)

^{20c}This inscription, in Hebrew, Latin, and Greek. ^{20a}was read by many Jews, ^{20b}since the place where Jesus was crucified was not far from the city. (REB)

John 19:21

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:21a

So the chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate, "Do not write, 'The King of the Jews,'"

- The Jewish chief priests said to Pilate, "You should not have written 'The king of the Jews.'"
- So the chief priests went to Pilate and said, "Why does the sign say that he is King of the Jews?"

So the chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate: The conjunction So indicates the result of many Jews reading the notice. The Jewish chief priests were unhappy that Pilate told the soldiers to write that Jesus was their king. So they objected (complained) to Pilate. Some translations do not include of the Jews because it is understood that the chief priests were Jews. For example:

Therefore the leading priests complained to Pilate, saying

Then the leading priests objected and said to Pilate (NLT)

the chief priests of the Jews: This phrase refers to the leading or most important priests of the Jews. See how you translated this phrase in 19:15.

Do not write, 'The King of the Jews,': Pilate had in fact already written the sign. The chief priests criticized the sign that he had already made. They wanted him to remove this notice and replace it. Indicate this meaning in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

You should not have written, 'The King of the Jews'

Change it from 'The King of the Jews' (NLT)

Why did you write, "the King of the Jews"?

In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause with the notice as the subject of the clause. For example:

The/Your^(sing) notice should not say, "the King of the Jews."

See the General Comment on 19:21a–b for suggestions on how to translate the words of the notice using indirect speech.

19:21b

but only that He said, 'I am the King of the Jews.'"

- Instead you^(sing) should have written, 'This man said, "I am the king of the Jews.'"

- You^(sing) should order that they change it to ‘He claimed to be the king of the Jews.’”
- You^(sing) should command that it be changed. Let/Make it say, ‘This fellow wanted/pretended to be the king of the Jewish people.’”

but only: The conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (19:21a) to a positive statement (19:21b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

Don’t write, ‘The King of the Jews.’ But write, ‘This man said, “I am the King of the Jews.”’ (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Don’t write, ‘The king of the Jews!’ Instead, write, ‘He said that he is the king of the Jews.’ (GW)

What you^(sing) should have written, it is not ‘King of the Jews’ but rather ‘This-one said he was King of the Jews.’ ” (Kankanaey Back Translation)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Change it from ‘The King of the Jews’ to ‘He said, I am King of the Jews.’ (NLT)

Why did you write that he is King of the Jews? You should have written, ‘He claimed to be King of the Jews.’ (CEV)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Say, ‘This man said that he was King of the Jews,’ not just ‘The King of the Jews.’

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

that He said, ‘I am the King of the Jews.’: This clause is the statement that the chief priests wanted Pilate to put on the notice. By adding the words He said, it would imply that the words were not true. (The word “claimed” does the same thing: “He claimed/said that he was the King of the Jews, but he is not.”) This clause includes a quotation inside a quotation, inside

the quotation of the priests’ words. See the General Comment on 19:21a–b for other ways to translate the whole statement of the chief priests. There are two ways to translate the words that they wanted on the notice:

- Use a direct quotation. For example:

‘This man said, I am king of the Jews.’ (NET)

- Use an indirect quotation. For example:

that this man claimed to be king of the Jews (NIV)

that He said: The chief priests referred to Jesus in a way that did not show respect. It also showed that they did not believe him. In some languages it may be natural to imply this. For example:

This man claimed

This person pretended to be

I am the King of the Jews: This was not something Jesus ever actually said. However, you should translate it literally, and translate King of the Jews as you did in 19:19b.

General Comment on 19:21a–b

The chief priests quoted what they wanted the sign to say, which quoted what they accused Jesus of saying. In some languages it is more natural to translate one or both of the inside quotations as indirect speech. For example:

So the chief priests went to Pilate and said, “Why did you write that he is King of the Jews? You should have written, ‘He claimed to be King of the Jews.’ ” (CEV)

So the chief priests went to Pilate and said, “You should not write that Jesus is the King of the Jews. Instead, you should write that he said that he was the King of the Jews.”

John 19:22

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not

change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:16b–22

The soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate wrote a sign announcing that he was the King of the Jews. The high priests complained about this sign, but Pilate did not change it.

19:22

Pilate answered, “What I have written, I have written.”

- Pilate replied, “What I have written will stay written.”
- But Pilate told them, “What is written will not be changed!” (CEV)

Pilate answered, “What I have written, I have written.”: Pilate refused to change what he told the soldiers to write on the inscription/notice. Your translation should make it clear that he rejected the request to change the inscription. Here are some other ways to translate this sentence:

Pilate replied, “No, what I have written, I have written.” (NLT)

Pilate answered, “What I have written stays written.” (GNT)

If you said in 19:19 that Pilate commanded others to write the inscription, you should not say here that he wrote it. For example:

Pilate replied, “What I ordered to be written will remain written!”

But Pilate told them, “What is written will not be changed!” (CEV)

John 19:23

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:23–24

This paragraph tells how the soldiers divided Jesus' clothes and decided who would get his tunic by casting lots.

19:23a

When the soldiers had crucified Jesus,

- ¶ As for the soldiers, after they crucified Jesus,
- ¶ When the soldiers had nailed Jesus to the cross,

When the soldiers had crucified Jesus: This clause introduces what happened after the soldiers nailed Jesus to the cross and placed the sign above his head. The action changes from what Pilate and the chief priests said to what the soldiers did. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

After the soldiers had nailed Jesus to the cross (CEV)

When the soldiers had finished crucifying Jesus (NJB)

As for the soldiers, when they had nailed Jesus to the cross (Kankanaey Back Translation)

19:23b

they divided His garments into four parts,

- they divided Jesus' clothes into four,
- they divided his clothes into four shares,

they divided His garments into four parts: Before they nailed Jesus to the cross, the soldiers removed his clothes, which was their custom. These clothes

then belonged to the men who crucified the person. In this case there were four soldiers, so they divided the clothes into four parts. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they took his clothing and divided it into four shares (NJB)

they took his clothes, dividing them into four shares (NET)

they divided His garments into four parts: The Greek word that the BSB translates as divided is more literally “made.” That could mean that there were four pieces of clothing, including a belt, head cover, and sandals. Or they could have divided the pieces of cloth that were sewn together to make one piece of clothing. Translate this idea using the term that is natural in your language. For example:

they put/made his garments into four shares

they divided His garments: In some languages it may be natural to keep the idea that the soldiers took Jesus’ clothes explicit like in the Greek text. For example:

they took his clothes and divided them into four parts (NRSV)

garments: It is good to translate garments with a general word that can include items such as sandals and belt.

19:23c one for each soldier,

- one part/piece for each of them.
- and each man took a share/part.

one for each soldier: This phrase indicates that each of the four soldiers there received one part or share of Jesus’ clothes. Possibly each soldier received one item. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

one for each of them (CEV)

so that each soldier could have a share (GW)

with each soldier getting one part (NCV)

General Comment on 19:23b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine 19:23b–c. For example:

they divided his clothes among the four of them (NLT)

19:23d with the tunic remaining.

- Then they took his tunic too.
- And there was also his long shirt,

with the tunic remaining: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as with the tunic remaining is more literally “and/also the tunic.” It indicates that in addition to the clothes that had been divided into four parts, there was also a tunic. This tunic was also an item of clothing. However, the soldiers did not include it in the clothes that they divided into four parts.

the tunic: There are two ways that English translations have understood the Greek word that the BSB translates as tunic:

1. It was a long garment (piece of clothes) like a shirt that was worn under other clothes. For example:

his long shirt (NCV)

undergarment (NJB) (NIV, NASB, NCV, NJB)

1. It was a long garment like a robe or cloak that was worn outside other clothes. For example:

outer garment (CEV) (GNT, KJV, GW, NLT, CEV)

Other translations use the word tunic, which can be understood either way. (NASB also uses tunic, but contrasts it with the outer garments.) It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars.

19:23e It was seamless, woven in one piece from top to bottom.

- The tunic had been woven in one piece, not sewn together.
- which had been made by weaving it as one piece all the way down.

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that introduces an explanation of the situation, some background information. Some translations, like the BSB, leave this word implied. The NET puts this clause in

parentheses. Introduce this background information in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

But (CEV)

It was seamless, woven in one piece from top to bottom: The term seamless indicates that the tunic had no seams (places where two pieces of cloth join). It was made from one piece of cloth, not from two or more pieces of cloth sewn together. A piece of clothes in one piece was more valuable than four separate pieces would be. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

which was all one piece of cloth, woven from top to bottom (NCV)

It didn't have a seam because it had been woven in one piece from top to bottom. (GW)

General Comment on 19:23e

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 19:23e. For example:

his long shirt was made from a single piece of cloth which did not have any seams

which was made of one piece of woven cloth without any seams in it (GNT)

John 19:24

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:23–24

This paragraph tells how the soldiers divided Jesus' clothes and decided who would get his tunic by casting lots.

19:24a

So they said to one another, "Let us not tear it.

- So they talked together, saying, "We^(incl) should not tear it into pieces.
- The soldiers said to one another, "Instead of tearing it to divide it,

So: This conjunction indicates a result. The soldiers spoke as they did as a result of how the tunic was made. Because the tunic was more valuable as a whole than torn into pieces, they decided not to tear it. It also indicates a return to the main story after the background information in 19:23e.

they said to one another: The pronouns they and one another refer to the soldiers.

Let us not tear it: Because each soldier already got one part of the clothes, there was no easy way to decide who should get the tunic. If they tore it into four parts, it would lose most of its value and use. So they decided not to tear it. Translate this in a way that is natural for making a suggestion about what not to do. For example:

Instead of tearing it (NJB)

Rather than tearing it apart (NLT)

We should not tear this into parts. (NCV)

19:24b

Instead, let us cast lots to see who will get it."

- We^(incl) should throw lots/stones to decide who will get it."
- let us^(incl) throw marked stones and let them show us who should have the whole thing."

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Instead here connects a negative statement (19:24a) to a positive statement (19:24b). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction "but" as in the NRSV.

Let's not tear it, but throw dice to see who will get it. (NET)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

Rather than tearing it apart, let’s throw dice for it. (NLT)

We should not tear this piece. Instead, let us decide by lot who will get it.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Let’s not tear it; let’s throw dice to see who will get it. (GNT)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Let us throw lots to decide who gets this piece rather than tearing it into pieces.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

let us cast lots to see who will get it: In order to see who would get the tunic, the soldiers decided to cast lots. That means that they would throw or select small stones to see who should get it. The man whose stone was chosen would receive the whole tunic.

There are implied words here: “let us....” The soldiers continued to make suggestions. This is a positive suggestion that contrasts to the negative suggestion in 19:24a. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Let’s throw lots to see who will get it (NCV)

Let’s decide by lot who will get it (NIV)

cast lots: The Greek word that the BSB translates as cast lots refers to the custom of throwing or picking lots to decide something. The soldiers may have used small stones with a soldier’s name on each stone. They probably threw the lots in a certain way or picked one from a container that held them all. A soldier would get the tunic if his lot fell a certain way or someone picked it from the container. People cast lots because they believed that it would reveal their god’s (or gods’) will. Believers in God did the same thing (see Proverbs 16:33; Luke 1:9; and Acts 1:24–26).

In your language, you may need to make this phrase clearer or explain what the soldiers did. For example:

gamble (CEV)

throw marked stones and let them decide who should get the whole tunic

throw small stones to show us who should get the shirt

If your readers know a specific form of gambling, you may want to use that. For example:

throw dice (NET)

General Comment on 19:24a–b

These are suggestions, one positive, one negative, that one or more of the soldiers made to the others. Translate this in a way that is natural for making a suggestion to one’s peers (co-workers, people equal in status). For example:

Let us not...Let us...

I think we should not...we should...

It would not be good to...it would be good to....

19:24c

This was to fulfill the Scripture:

- This is what the scripture said would happen:
- So what the scriptures said came true:

This was to fulfill the Scripture: This clause is a standard expression in the New Testament. It indicates that an Old Testament author said that something would happen and now God caused it to happen. The Scriptures said that men would divide and cast lots for the Messiah’s clothes, and this is what happened.

There is a textual issue here.

1. Many Greek manuscripts say “so that the scripture might be fulfilled that says.” For example:

This took place to fulfill the scripture that says (NET) (ESV, KJV, NIV, NRSV, CEV, NET, NLT)

1. Many other Greek manuscripts say simply “so that the scripture might be fulfilled.” For example:

This happened in order to make the scripture come true (GNT) (BSB, NASB, RSV, GW, GNT, REB, NCV, NJB)

It is recommended that you follow option 1, as in the UBS Greek New Testament. The UBS Greek New Testament includes the words “which says” in square brackets and gives them a C rating, indicating a considerable degree of doubt. However, both options mean the same, and you should introduce the scripture in the most natural way in your language. For example:

So this text of scripture came true:...

This: This pronoun refers to the soldiers’ actions of dividing up Jesus’ clothes and casting lots for the tunic.

to fulfill: The verb fulfill in this context means “complete a prophecy” so that what was prophesied happens. What the Old Testament said did actually happen. See how you translated this idea in 12:38.

the Scripture: Some Greek manuscripts and English translations have “says,” which refers to what has been written down in a book. In some languages it is more natural to speak of what was written down or what can be read. For example:

the Holy Writings

what long ago God caused to be written down

Scripture: The word Scripture refers to the Jewish holy book, what Christians now call the Old Testament. See how you translated this word in 2:22 and 10:35. In this context Scripture refers to a specific place or text in the writings in the Old Testament. For example:

this place/text in the Holy Book

19:24d

“They divided My garments among them, and cast lots for My clothing.”

- “They divided my clothes among themselves and threw lots/stones for my clothes.”
- “They took my clothes for themselves, a share for each, and they threw marked stones to know who should get my clothing.”

They divided My garments among them, and cast lots for My clothing: This is a quotation of Psalm

22:18. The psalmist, King David, was writing about a righteous person who would suffer, the Messiah. He wrote these words about a thousand years before Jesus died on the cross.

In some languages it is more natural to translate 19:24d–e as indirect speech. For example:

the scripture that said that they would divide his clothes among themselves and throw stones to decide who should get his clothing

They divided My garments among them: The Greek word that the BSB translates as garments is the same word that was used in 19:23b.

and cast lots for My clothing: This clause prophesied that the soldiers would throw or pick stones to see who would get Jesus’ tunic.

cast lots: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as cast lots refers to the custom that 19:24b also refers to. It is not the word that is used in 19:24b but in this context it refers to the same activity. See the note there for more explanation. Also see how you translated the idea there and make it clear here that it is the same activity.

for My clothing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as clothing is the singular form of the word “clothes.” It can refer to one item of something that a person wears. Here it is good to use a term that can refer to one item, the tunic.

19:24e

So that is what the soldiers did.

- So the soldiers did this. (NCV)
- And the soldiers did this very thing.

So that is what the soldiers did: The Greek sentence that the BSB translates as that is what the soldiers did concludes the part of the story that tells what the soldiers’ did. The Greek text includes a word that the BSB translates literally as So, and most English translations translate it that way. However, here it probably just indicates a return to the story after the parenthetical information in 19:24c–d.

The sentence indicates that the soldiers did what the prophecy said that they would do. However, the soldiers did not do that in order to fulfill the prophecy. They probably did not even know about the prophecy. Using a word like So could imply that the soldiers’ purpose in doing what they did was to fulfill prophecy. So it is recommended that you do not use a word like So. For example:

That is what the soldiers did. (NJB)

But (ESV)

And this is what the soldiers did. (GNT)

Now (NET)

The soldiers then did what they had decided. (CEV)

that is what the soldiers did: This clause refers to the soldiers dividing Jesus' clothes and casting lots for the tunic.

Introduce this new attention to different people in a way that is natural in your language. In some languages it may be natural to begin a new paragraph and not translate the Greek conjunction. Nearly all English translations begin a new paragraph here.

This verse is background information for the next event in 19:26–27. Translate the verse in a way that is natural for giving background information in your language.

John 19:25

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Near the cross of Jesus stood His mother and her sister, as well as Mary the wife of Clopas and Mary Magdalene: Several women stood near the cross on which Jesus was crucified. (You may need to avoid saying “Jesus’ cross” because Jesus did not own it. It was just the cross he was crucified on. See examples below.) There are two ways to interpret how many women were there:

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus’ enemies crucified him

1. There were four women:
2. Jesus’ mother,
3. her sister (not named here, but possibly Salome, who is named in Mark 15:40),
4. Mary wife of Clopas,
5. Mary Magdalene.
6. For example:

Jesus on the cross

Jesus’ mother stood beside the cross with her sister and Mary the wife of Clopas. Mary Magdalene was standing there too. (CEV) (CEV)

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:25–27

This paragraph tells how Jesus provided for his mother Mary.

19:25

Near the cross of Jesus stood His mother and her sister, as well as Mary the wife of Clopas and Mary Magdalene.

- ¶ Standing close to Jesus’ cross were his mother, his mother’s sister, Mary who was Clopas’ wife, and Mary Magdalene.
- ¶ Some women were standing near the cross on which Jesus was nailed. They were his mother, his aunt who was the sister of his mother, Mary the wife of Clopas, and Mary from the village of Magdala.

1. There were three women:
2. Jesus’ mother,
3. his mother’s sister, who was Mary the wife of Clopas,
4. Mary Magdalene.
5. For example:

Jesus’ mother, and his mother’s sister, Mary (the wife of Clopas), and Mary Magdalene (NLT) (NLT, RSV, KJV, NASB)

The Greek begins with a conjunction that the BSB leaves implicit but the NRSV translates as “Meanwhile.” It indicates that the attention is changing to different people. It changes from the soldiers to some women. The women were standing there at the same time that the soldiers divided Jesus’ clothes among themselves. Here are other ways to introduce this new part of the story:

All other English translations can be understood either way. Nearly all scholars believe that interpretation (1) is correct. Carson page 615, Kostenberger page 548 So it is recommended that you follow that interpretation unless you want to be ambiguous. If there are only three women, Jesus’ mother and her sister would both be named Mary, which is not likely. (It

is possible, though, if sister here refers to a sister-in-law.) Because either interpretation is possible, you may want to follow the interpretation of a major language translation in your area. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Standing near the cross was the mother of Jesus and his aunt who was the sister of his mother. Also there was Maria who was the wife of Cleopas and Maria Magdalena. (Tagbanwa Back Translation)

There close by to where Jesus was put on the cross stood his mother with his mother's sister and with Mary, the wife of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene. (Otomí Back Translation)

There were those standing near Jesus' cross, his mother, the younger-sibling of his mother, Maria the spouse of Clopas and Maria Magdalena. (Kankanaey Back Translation)

It is quite possible that Mary's sister was the mother of the disciple John, a son of Zebedee. (Matthew 27:56 says that the mother of the sons of Zebedee was present at the cross). Her name may have been Salome, mentioned in Mark 15:40 as being at the cross with the other women. Because John did not identify himself by name, it is natural that he did not identify his mother either.

Mary Magdalene: Mary Magdalene was a devoted follower of Jesus. He had healed her of demon-possession. See Luke 8:2. In Greek the name Mary is spelled "Maria." See how you translated this name in 11:1. The word Magdalene indicates that this Mary was from the village of Magdala. For example:

Mary from Magdala (GW)

John 19:26

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:25–27

This paragraph tells how Jesus provided for his mother Mary.

19:26a

When Jesus saw His mother and the disciple whom He loved standing nearby,

- Jesus saw that his mother was standing there and that the disciple who was his dear friend was standing beside her.
- Jesus noticed his mother and one of his disciples, his close friend, standing with her.

When Jesus saw His mother and the disciple whom He loved standing nearby:

This clause returns to the main story after the background information in 19:25. This clause indicates that while he was on the cross, Jesus noticed two people standing nearby. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus saw his mother and the disciple he loved standing there (GNT)

the disciple whom He loved: This phrase indicates that this disciple was Jesus' close friend. Scholars agree that this disciple was John the author. But you should not make this explicit here, though you may choose to mention it in a footnote. For more information on this phrase see the note on 13:23.

standing nearby: This phrase indicates that the disciple was near Jesus' mother. For example:

with her (CEV)

19:26b

He said to His mother, "Woman, here is your son."

- He said to his mother, "Mother, there is your son."
- He said to his mother, "This man is now your son." (CEV)

Woman: In the Jewish culture this was a polite way to talk to an older woman. See how you translated the same word when Jesus spoke to women in 2:4 and 4:21. Use a term that shows respect when speaking to one's mother. For example:

Mother (REB)

Dear woman (NIV)

here is your son: Jesus was the eldest son, and so he was responsible for taking care of his mother. He was telling his mother to expect his disciple to take care of her after his death.

The Greek word that the BSB translates as here is the same word as in 19:14c (see the note there). It calls attention to something or someone. Here Jesus was calling his mother's attention to the disciple. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

look, here is your son (NET)

There is your son. (REB)

This man is now your son.

The disciple whom Jesus loved was not literally the son of Jesus' mother. So in some languages you may need to indicate that this clause is a metaphor. For example:

This man will be like a son to you.

Consider this man to be your son.

John 19:27

Section 19:16b–27: Soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross

This section describes how the soldiers nailed Jesus to a cross to die. Pilate ordered that they put a sign on the cross saying that Jesus was the King of the Jews. The chief priests complained to Pilate, but he did not change it. While Jesus was dying, the soldiers divided his clothes among themselves. Also, Jesus gave his mother into the care of the disciple whom he loved.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Jesus' enemies crucified him

Jesus on the cross

The crucifixion of Jesus

Paragraph 19:25–27

This paragraph tells how Jesus provided for his mother Mary.

19:27a

Then He said to the disciple, "Here is your mother."

- Then he said to the disciple, "Look, there is your mother."
- Then he said to the disciple, "She is now your mother." (CEV)

Then He said to the disciple, "Here is your mother.":

Jesus gave his disciple the responsibility of taking care of his mother after he died. He wanted his disciple to honor and provide for Mary as though she was his mother.

He said to the disciple: Jesus spoke to the disciple he just mentioned, the disciple whom he loved.

Here is your mother: Jesus directed the disciple's attention to his mother, using the same word (translated Here is) that he did in 19:26b. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

look, here is your mother (NET)

She is now your mother. (CEV)

Make my mother your mother. (Otomi Back Translation)

Jesus' mother was not literally the mother of the disciple whom Jesus loved. So in some languages you may need to indicate that this clause is a metaphor. For example:

This woman will be like your mother.

Consider this woman to be your mother.

19:27b

So from that hour, this disciple took her into his home.

- So that disciple took her to live with him in his house from then on.
- And from that time that disciple welcomed her into his home.

So from that hour: The phrase that hour here refers to the time that Jesus died. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

From that time on (GW)

From then on (CEV)

this disciple took her into his home: This clause indicates that this disciple began to take care of Mary as though she were his own mother. He treated her as part of his family. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

the disciple took her to live in his home (GNT)

she lived with that disciple in his home (GW)

the disciple brought her into his home to live

took her: In your translation, avoid implying that the disciple took Mary into his home against her will. He offered to give her a home there, and she accepted. For example:

welcomed her

gave her a home

John 19:28

Section 19:28–30: Jesus died on the cross

This section describes how Jesus died. Before he died, he said two more things. First, he said that he was thirsty. So the soldiers absorbed wine vinegar in a sponge and lifted it to Jesus' lips on a branch. Then Jesus said, "It is finished," and died.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus died

19:28a

After this, knowing that everything had now been accomplished,

- ¶ Jesus knew that his mission was now finished, (NLT)
- ¶ After that, Jesus knew that he had now finished/completed his work.

After this: This phrase introduces the next main event in the story. It refers to later that afternoon. For example:

Later (NIV)

knowing that everything had now been accomplished: When Jesus was on the cross, he knew that he had done everything that God had sent him to do. He understood that he had completed his work. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus knew that by now everything had been completed. (GNT)

Jesus knew that everything had been done. (NCV)

knowing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as knowing is more literally "having known." It introduces something that Jesus knew or understood. He knew that he had come to earth to die for people's sins. Now he knew that he had completed that mission. All that he was sent to do, he did. See also how you translated 13:1, where the same verb is used.

everything had now been accomplished: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as had now been accomplished is passive. It indicates that Jesus' work was complete. He had done all that his Father had sent him to do. There are at least two ways to translate this:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

everything was completed (NET)

everything had now been finished (GW)

- Use an active verb. For example:

he had now finished his work (CEV)

he had completed everything

everything: This pronoun refers to all that the Father sent Jesus to do. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Jesus knew that his mission was now finished (NLT)

Jesus knew that he had now finished his work. (CEV)

now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as now is more literally “already.” It indicates that Jesus knew that at that time his life and mission were nearly finished. In some languages it may be confusing to use a word like now to refer to a past time. Here are some other ways to translate this word:

Jesus knew that everything had been done (NCV)

Jesus knew that everything was already completed

accomplished: In this context the Greek word that the BSB translates as accomplished refers to being completed and fulfilled. Everything was finished in a good and successful way, because Jesus had done everything necessary. Some expressions meaning accomplished may have negative implications, indicating failure. For example, the English expression “it is all over” has a negative connotation like that. It is important to use an expression with a positive connotation, indicating successful completion of a job or project.

19:28b
and to fulfill the Scripture, Jesus said, “I am thirsty.”

- and he said, “I am thirsty.” He said this so that the scriptures could be fulfilled.
- And he said, “I am thirsty,” in order to make the words of God’s holy book come true.

to fulfill the Scripture: This phrase indicates that Jesus’ action caused the scriptures to be fulfilled. Jesus said that he was thirsty, and this fulfilled Psalms 69:21. Another verse this could refer to is Psalm 22:15. Some scholars understand “I am thirsty” as a metaphor for desiring God as in Psalm 42:1-2 and 63:1. There it says, “for my thirst they gave me vinegar to drink.” What the Psalm had predicted took place. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

in order to make the Scripture come true (GNT)

fulfill the Scripture: This phrase indicates that what was happening then was what the prophets had written about long ago. The Greek word that the BSB translates as fulfill is a different word from what John used in other verses. Here the word is the same word it translates as “finished” in 19:28a and 19:30b. However, most English translations use a form of fulfill here because it is more natural in English. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to make the Scriptures come true (CEV)

So that what the holy book has said would happen, did happen.

I am thirsty: Because Jesus was in the hot sun and bleeding, he became very thirsty. Express this in the way that is natural in your language. For example:

I thirst

I need water

General Comment on John 19:28

In the Greek, as in the BSB, John 19:28 is one complex sentence. In some languages it is more natural to make it into two sentences. For example:

Jesus knew that he had now finished his work. And in order to make the Scriptures come true, he said, “I am thirsty!” (CEV)

After this, Jesus knew that everything had been done. So that the Scripture would come true, he said, “I am thirsty.” (NCV)

John 19:29

Section 19:28–30: Jesus died on the cross

This section describes how Jesus died. Before he died, he said two more things. First, he said that he was thirsty. So the soldiers absorbed wine vinegar in a sponge and lifted it to Jesus’ lips on a branch. Then Jesus said, “It is finished,” and died.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus died

19:29a

A jar of sour wine was sitting there.

- A jar stood there full of sour wine. (REB)
- A container that was full of cheap wine was there.

A jar of sour wine was sitting there: Near the cross was a container full of wine for the soldiers to drink. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

A jar of cheap wine was there. (CEV)

A jar stood there full of sour wine; (REB)

A jar: The Greek word that the BSB translates as jar is a general word that can refer to any type of container for liquid. It was probably made of clay. For example:

bowl (GNT)

sour wine: The word that the BSB translates as sour wine refers to the cheap wine that poor people drank. This wine was weak, with water added, and tasted something like vinegar. See how you translated this same Greek word in Matthew 27:48, Mark 15:36, and Luke 23:36. For example:

cheap wine (GNT)

wine vinegar (NIV)

sour drink

there: This word is implied in the Greek and refers to the general area near the cross.

19:29b

So they soaked a sponge in the wine, put it on a stalk of hyssop,

- So someone dipped a sponge in the sour wine, wrapped it around the branch/stem of a hyssop plant,
- The soldiers absorbed some cheap wine in something and wrapped it around a stick.

So they soaked a sponge in the wine, put it on a stalk of hyssop: The pronoun they probably refers to some of the soldiers. The soldiers put a sponge into the wine. The sponge soaked up (absorbed) the wine, and then the soldiers put it on the end of a branch. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

So the soldiers put a sponge soaked in the vinegar on a hyssop stick (GW)

so a sponge was soaked in the wine, put on a stalk of hyssop (GNT)

a sponge in the wine: In some languages it may be natural to use a verb to indicate how the sponge became full of the wine. For example:

Someone then soaked a sponge with the wine (CEV)

a sponge: A sponge is a plant-like creature living in the sea with a body full of holes. It absorbs liquid much like a cloth. So the soldiers dipped a sponge in this jar of wine until it absorbed some wine and became wet. In some cultures a sponge is not known. Some ways to handle that is to use a descriptive phrase or a simile. For example:

something that absorbed the wine

something like cotton (Kankanaey Back Translation)

put: The Greek verb the BSB translates as put is more literally “to wrap.” The soldiers attached the sponge to the branch. Use a verb that is natural in your language.

on a stalk of hyssop: The word hyssop refers to a small bush-like plant mentioned several places in the Bible, including Psalm 51:7, Exodus 12:22, and Hebrews 9:19. In some cultures hyssop is not known. One way to translate it is with a more general term. For example:

on the branch of a bush

on a branch/stick

19:29c

and lifted it to His mouth.

- and raised the sponge to Jesus’ mouth.
- Then they lifted it to Jesus’ mouth so that he could get some wine.

and lifted it to His mouth: The soldiers lifted the sponge to Jesus’ mouth so that he could get some wine out of the sponge. For example:

lifted it to Jesus’ lips (NIV)

raised up to his mouth for him to drink (Otomi Back Translation)

General Comment on 19:29b–c

In some languages it may be natural to mention the hyssop plant in 19:29c instead of 19:29b. For example:

Someone then soaked a sponge with the wine and held it up to Jesus’ mouth on the stem of a hyssop plant. (CEV)

John 19:30

Section 19:28–30: Jesus died on the cross

This section describes how Jesus died. Before he died, he said two more things. First, he said that he was thirsty. So the soldiers absorbed wine vinegar in a sponge and lifted it to Jesus' lips on a branch. Then Jesus said, "It is finished," and died.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The death of Jesus

Jesus died

19:30a

When Jesus had received the sour wine,

- When Jesus got the wine,
- Then Jesus sipped some wine from the sponge

When Jesus had received the sour wine: This clause indicates that Jesus sucked or sipped some wine out of the sponge. For example:

After Jesus drank the wine (CEV)

When Jesus had taken it (JBP)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as an independent clause. For example:

Jesus sucked the wine and swallowed it (TH)

Jesus drank the wine (GNT)

19:30b

He said, "It is finished."

- he said, "My work is finished."
- and said, "I have completed what God sent me to do."

He said, "It is finished.": The clause It is finished indicates that Jesus had finished doing what God sent him to do. It is the same Greek verb as in 19:28a. In some languages it is more natural to use an active verb. For example:

I have finished what God sent me to do.

I have completed my work.

Now all that had to happen has happened. (Otomi Back Translation)

19:30c

And bowing His head, He yielded up His spirit.

- Then bowing his head, he released his spirit to God.
- After that, his head fell forward, and he died.

And bowing His head: The phrase bowing His head indicates that Jesus allowed his head to drop forward and rest on his chest. He did not hold it up any more.

He yielded up His spirit: This phrase indicates that Jesus died. He allowed his spirit to return to God. It is not the usual way to refer to death. It implies that Jesus chose to give up (hand over) his spirit to his Father. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

surrendered his spirit

died (GW)

John 19:31

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:31a–e

19:31 is long and complex, and includes a great deal of implicit information about Jewish customs. For a suggestion of a way to rearrange this verse, see the General Comment following 19:31e.

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as two or more sentences. For example:

It was the day of preparation, and the Jewish leaders didn't want the bodies hanging there the next day, which was the Sabbath (and a very special Sabbath, because it was the Passover). So they asked Pilate to hasten their deaths by ordering that their legs be broken. Then their bodies could be taken down. (NLT)

Since it was Friday and the next day was an especially important day of worship, the Jews didn't want the bodies to stay on the crosses. So they asked Pilate to have the men's legs broken and their bodies removed. (GW)

It was the day that the Jews prepared for the Sabbath, their day of worship. And the next day was a very important Sabbath. So the Jewish leaders did not want the bodies to stay on the crosses after the Sabbath began at sunset. So they asked Pilate to order the soldiers to break the men's legs and remove their bodies.

19:31a

It was the day of Preparation,

- ¶ It was the day when the Jewish people prepared for the Sabbath,
- ¶ Because it was Friday,

The Greek begins this verse with a connector that means "because." It indicates that this clause is the cause of the following clause. The Jews did not want Jesus' body left on the cross because it was the day before the Sabbath. For example:

because it was the day of preparation (NET)

the day of Preparation: This phrase refers to Friday. This was the day that the Jews prepared for the Sabbath, their day of rest. Because the Jewish day began at sunset, the Sabbath would begin at sunset on Friday. See how you translated this phrase in 19:14. For example:

Friday (GW)

Friday, the day of preparation for the Sabbath

the day when the Jewish people prepared for their holy/rest day

19:31b

and the next day was a High Sabbath.

- and this Sabbath was a particularly important one.
- and the next day would be the high/holy Sabbath during the Death-Passed-Over-Us celebration,
- and the next day was a very important day of worship,

and the next day was a High Sabbath: The next day was one of the most important Sabbaths of the year because it was during Passover week. All Sabbaths were considered holy, set apart to show honor, but this one particularly deserved honor. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and the next day was an especially important day of worship (GW)

and the next day was to be a special Sabbath (NIV)

the coming Sabbath was especially holy (GNT)

and: The Greek word that the BSB translates as and is more literally "because." It introduces an additional, greater reason why the Jewish leaders did not want the bodies left on the crosses. Not only was the next day a Sabbath, but it was also a special Sabbath.

a High Sabbath: The Greek word that the BSB translates as High means "great" or "important." It was important because it came during Passover week. Use a word or phrase that indicates a religious holiday is particularly important. For example:

that sabbath was a day of great solemnity (NRSV)

for that Sabbath was an especially important one (NET)

a special Sabbath (NIV)

a very special Sabbath, because it was Passover week (NLT)

the coming Sabbath was especially holy (GNT)

19:31c

In order that the bodies would not remain on the cross during the Sabbath,

- And the Jewish leaders did not want the people hanging there during the Sabbath their worship day,
- the Jewish leaders wanted the men to die quickly so that they could take the bodies off the crosses before the Sabbath began at sunset.

In order that the bodies would not remain on the cross during the Sabbath: The Jewish leaders wanted the crucified men to die on Friday so that they could take them off the crosses before the Sabbath began. In Jewish thinking, the Sabbath day begins at sunset on Friday evening.

Here are some other ways to translate 19:31b:

the Jews did not want the bodies to stay on the cross on the Sabbath day, (NCV)

the Jews wanted to avoid the bodies being left on the crosses over the Sabbath (JBP)

the Jewish leaders didn't want the bodies hanging there the next day, which was the Sabbath (NLT)

the bodies would not remain on the cross: The Greek verb that the BSB translates literally as remain indicates that the Jews did not want the bodies to remain hanging on the crosses during the Sabbath. For example:

the bodies to stay on the cross (NCV)

on the cross: There were three crosses, with one man on each cross. In some languages it may be natural to make that clear. For example:

on the crosses (GNT)

the Sabbath: The Jewish Sabbath was Saturday. It was their day of rest and worship. It began at sunset the evening before, Friday evening, and lasted until sunset on Saturday. See how you translated the word Sabbath in John 5:9-10.

19:31d

the Jews asked Pilate to have the legs broken

- so they asked Pilate to tell the soldiers to break the men's legs
- So they asked Pilate to order the soldiers to break the men's legs so they would die quickly

the Jews asked Pilate to have the legs broken:

People who were crucified needed to push up on the nails that held their legs to be able to breathe. If soldiers broke their legs, they could not push up on the nails to breathe, so then they died quickly. The Jewish leaders wanted Pilate to order the soldiers to break the crucified men's legs. That way the bodies could be taken down before sunset, when the Sabbath day began. In some languages it may be natural to make explicit that they broke their legs in order to hasten (hurry) their death. For example:

So they asked Pilate to hasten their deaths by ordering that their legs be broken. (NLT)

the Jews asked Pilate: The Romans usually left people on the cross until they died. Sometimes that took two or three days. So the Jews asked Pilate to tell the soldiers to break the crucified men's legs. If they did that, the men would die quickly.

the Jews: This phrase here refers to the leaders of the Jews. For example:

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

the Jewish leaders (NET)

to have the legs broken: The Jewish leaders wanted Pilate to command the soldiers to break the legs of the dying men. Roman soldiers broke legs by hitting the lower part of the legs with a heavy iron mallet (large hammer or club). So use the term in your language that would include breaking something by hitting it. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

to allow them to break the legs of the men who had been crucified (GNT)

to order that the legs of the men be broken (NCV)

to have the legs broken: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as to have the legs broken is "that their legs might be broken," which is passive. It does not indicate who would break the men's legs, but it implies that it was the soldiers. The English word have indicates that the Jewish leaders asked Pilate to order his soldiers to do this. There are at least two ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

that their legs might be broken (ESV)

ordering that their legs be broken (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

to break the men's legs (CEV)

to order the soldiers to break the men's legs

the legs: Use a term that includes the knees and lower part of the legs.

19:31e

and the bodies removed.

- and to tell someone to remove the bodies.
- and they/someone could take the bodies off the crosses.

and the bodies removed: This phrase indicates the second thing that the Jewish leaders asked Pilate. They asked Pilate to order the bodies removed from the crosses. Where the soldiers would remove the men's bodies from is implied. In some languages you may need to make that information explicit. For example:

and remove their bodies from the crosses

and take their bodies down from there

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as removed here is passive. It is not stated who would remove the bodies. Perhaps they expected the soldiers to do it, but perhaps not, so it is good to leave this ambiguous. There are at least two ways to translate this verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

and the bodies taken away (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

and take their bodies down (CEV)

the bodies: In many languages there is a special word for the body of a dead person. You may want to use a term like that here. For example:

the corpses

General Comment on 19:31d–e

In some languages it may be natural to translate the request of the Jewish leaders using direct speech. For example:

The Jewish leaders said to Pilate, "Please allow the legs of the men to be broken and their bodies removed from their crosses."

General Comment on 19:31 a–e

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange this verse so that 19:31d–e comes before 19:31a–c. For example:

^{31d}Then the Jewish authorities asked Pilate to allow them to break the legs of the men who had been crucified, ^{31e}and to take the bodies down from the crosses. ^{31a}They requested this because it was Friday, ^{31b}and they did not want the bodies to stay on the crosses on the Sabbath, ^{31c}since the coming Sabbath was especially holy. (GNT)

John 19:32

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:32a

So the soldiers came

- So the soldiers came to where the three men were crucified,
- Pilate agreed, so the soldiers went to the crosses

So the soldiers came: It is implied that Pilate agreed to order the soldiers to break the men's legs. Then they went to where the men were crucified, and the place is also implied. In some languages it will be natural to include this implied information in the translation. For example:

Pilate agreed . So he sent his soldiers to where the three men were crucified/executed.

19:32b

and broke the legs of the first man who had been crucified with Jesus, and those of the other.

- and they broke the legs of the two men who had been crucified with Jesus, one after the other.
- and broke/smashed the bones in the legs of both thieves who were crucified with Jesus, first one and then the other.

and broke the legs of the first man who had been crucified with Jesus, and those of the other: The phrases the first man who had been crucified with Jesus and the other refers to the two thieves on the crosses next to Jesus. The soldiers broke the legs of both of the men who were still alive. For example:

broke the legs of the two men who had been crucified with Jesus, first the one and then the other (NET)

broke the legs: This phrase indicates that the soldiers broke the bone in the leg below the knee. Roman soldiers broke legs by hitting the lower part of the legs with a heavy iron mallet (large hammer or club).

crucified with Jesus: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Jesus is literally "he," as in the NRSV. The BSB sometimes uses names instead of pronouns in order to clarify the person to whom the author is referring. Refer to Jesus in a way that is natural in your language.

General Comment on 19:32a–b

In some languages it may be natural to mention the crucified men in 19:32a rather than 19:32b. For example:

The soldiers accordingly came to the men crucified with Jesus and broke the legs of each in turn. (REB)

John 19:33

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:33a

But when they came to Jesus

- But when the soldiers came to break Jesus' legs/bones,
- However, when the soldiers went to the cross where Jesus hung to break his legs,

But when they came to Jesus: Apparently the soldiers broke the legs of the two other men before they came to Jesus to break his legs.

they: This pronoun refers to the soldiers.

19:33b

and saw that He was already dead,

- they saw/realized that Jesus was dead already.
- they found/discovered that he had already died.

and saw that He was already dead: This phrase indicates that Jesus had already died before they came to break his legs.

19:33c

they did not break His legs.

- So they did not break his legs.

they did not break His legs: The reason that the soldiers broke the men's legs was so they would die quickly. So there was no reason to break Jesus' legs because he was already dead.

General Comment on 19:33b–c

In some languages it is more natural to rearrange these verse parts. You may want to indicate that the men did not break Jesus' legs before saying why they did not. For example:

^{33a}But when they came to Jesus, ^{33c}they did not break his legs ^{33b}because they saw that he was already dead.

John 19:34

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:34a

Instead, one of the soldiers pierced His side with a spear,

- But one of the soldiers pushed a spear up into Jesus' side,
- Instead of doing that, one of the soldiers stabbed/pierced Jesus' side with his spear,

Instead: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *Instead* here connects a negative statement (19:33c) to a positive statement (19:34a). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but.” For example:

they did not break his legs. But one of the soldiers stuck his spear into Jesus' side (NCV)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” For example:

they did not break his legs. Instead, one of the soldiers pierced Jesus' side with a spear (NIV)

they didn't break his legs. However, one of the soldiers stabbed Jesus' side with his spear (GW)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

they did not break his legs. One of the soldiers stuck his spear into Jesus' side (CEV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

one of the soldiers pierced His side with a spear:

This clause indicates that one of the soldiers pushed his spear into Jesus' side. Apparently he did that to guarantee that Jesus was actually dead. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

One of the soldiers stabbed Jesus' side with his spear (GW)

One of the soldiers...plunged his spear into Jesus' side (GNT)

One of the soldiers stuck his spear into Jesus' side (CEV)

a spear: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *spear* refers to a long weapon with a sharp metal point. Roman soldiers carried spears with them.

19:34b

and immediately blood and water flowed out.

- and immediately blood and water flowed out.
- and what immediately ran out of his body was blood and water.

and immediately blood and water flowed out: The fact that a witness saw blood and water pour from Jesus' wound helps prove that Jesus had truly died. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

at once blood and water poured out (GNT)

immediately blood and water flowed out (NLT)

water: Some scholars say that the word *water* refers to a colorless liquid that can come from a body after

death. However, others say that it was really water. And many scholars say that the word could also have a figurative meaning. (Suggestions include the Holy Spirit and cleansing from sin.) Therefore, you should translate the word literally.

John 19:35

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:35a–d

The one who saw it has testified to this, and his testimony is true. He knows that he is telling the truth, so that you also may believe: This verse is a comment by the author. It is background information, not part of the main story. Some English versions therefore placed it in parentheses. You should indicate that this is background information in a way that is natural in your language.

19:35a

The one who saw it has testified to this,

- (The one who saw this happen has told about it.
- This is the evidence of one who saw it (NJB)

The one who saw it has testified to this: The author indicated that what he just wrote (probably in 19:32–34) came from someone who saw it happen. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

The man who saw it has given testimony (NIV)

This is the evidence of one who saw it (NJB)

The one who saw this happen has spoken of it (GNT)

This person who saw the crucifixion testified (told what he saw) about what was written in the previous verses. It is important that your readers understand that the author is confirming the truth of what he just wrote. For example:

This report is from a witness.

This testimony is written by someone who saw these things happen.

The one who saw it: This clause probably refers to the disciple whom Jesus loved, John himself. This is the opinion of almost all scholars. However, some question why the author did not identify him as “the disciple whom he loved” as he did 19:26. However, from that verse we know that that disciple, probably John, witnessed the crucifixion. It means that he was a witness, someone who had personally seen these things happen. Because John did not identify himself here, you should not either. But you may want to indicate in a footnote that the author was probably referring to himself.

has testified: This phrase refers to what the author wrote in the previous verses. There the author testified about the things that he had seen. See how you translated the verb testified in 1:7, 15.

19:35b

and his testimony is true.

- What he told you^(plur) is the truth
- The report of what he saw is true—

and his testimony is true: The author John assured that his account was accurate. The report or testimony (what he testified) that he wrote in the previous verses was true, faithfully telling the facts. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

What he says/writes is true

This testimony that he is writing is true/accurate.

He is testifying truly/faithfully.

This report is from an eyewitness giving an accurate account. (NLT)

19:35c**He knows that he is telling the truth,**

- and he knows he is speaking the truth.
- he knows that what he writes is true.

He knows that he is telling the truth: The author John probably refers to himself. This clause says that he knows that what he has written is the truth. He knows that because he wrote about what he saw. He declares that what he wrote about Jesus' death is true, reliable, and faithfully telling the facts. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that he was writing the truth, rather than speaking it. For example:

he knows that he is writing what really happened

he knows that what he writes is true

19:35d**so that you also may believe.**

- He has told about this so you^(plur) also will believe in Christ.)
- He writes it so that you^(plur) can have faith too.

so that you also may believe: This clause tells the witness's purpose in testifying. John indicated that he was testifying about what he saw so that his readers would believe.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the readers of the book. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

I know I am telling you^(plur) the truth. I am telling you this so that you will believe in Christ.

may believe: This phrase includes the idea of believing the facts about who Jesus was and what he did. But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. See how you translated the word believe in 1:7, 4:48, and 6:36. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

Now you can have faith too. (CEV)

that you might become believers

General Comment on 19:35a–d

In the Greek text 19:35b is at the end of the verse, separated from 19:35a by 19:35b–c. However, the thought

of 19:35b is closely connected to 19:35a. Some translations keep the Greek order and indicate that 19:35b–c are parenthetical. For example:

^{35a}He who saw it has borne witness—^{35c}his testimony is true, ^{35d}and he knows that he is telling the truth—^{35b}that you also may believe. (ESV)

^{35a}And the person who saw it has testified ^{35c}(and his testimony is true, ^{35d}and he knows that he is telling the truth), ^{35b}so that you also may believe. (NET)

John 19:36**Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus' side**

This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then. So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men's legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus' legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:36a**Now these things happened so that the Scripture would be fulfilled:**

- This happened to make the scripture come true:
- The soldiers did not break Jesus' bones just as God's Book says,

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now is a conjunction that is usually translated as “for” or “because.” It is not a time word. Some English versions do not use a conjunction. Use an expression that is natural in your language.

these things happened: The phrase these things refers to the fact that the soldiers pierced Jesus' side but did not break his bones.

so that the Scripture would be fulfilled: This clause indicates that what happened is what the scripture that was written long ago said would happen. See how you translated this idea in 12:38. For example:

so that the Scriptures would come true (CEV)

This was done to make the Scripture come true (GNT)

in fulfillment of the text of scripture (REB)

the Scripture: This phrase here refers to a specific place or text in the Old Testament Scriptures. For example:

the text of scripture (REB)

19:36b

“Not one of His bones will be broken.”

- “Not even one of his bones shall be broken.”
- “They will not break any of his bones.”

Not one of His bones will be broken: This quotation may come from two different contexts:

- Psalm 34:20, where the Psalmist promised God’s protection for the righteous man.
- Exodus 12:46 and Numbers 9:12, which commanded the Jews not to break the bones of the Passover lamb.

If you write a footnote here, it is good to mention these Old Testament texts.

will be broken: This is a passive verb phrase. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb like the BSB.
- Use an active verb. You may need to supply a general subject. For example:

they will not break any of his bones

No one will break even one of his bones

John 19:37

Section 19:31–37: A soldier put a spear in Jesus’ side
This section tells how the soldiers saw that Jesus was dead. The Jewish leaders did not want to leave the bodies of the three men on the crosses after sunset. The Sabbath started at sunset and this was a special Sabbath, so the bodies should be buried before then.

So they asked Pilate to order his soldiers to break the men’s legs to make them die more quickly.

The soldiers broke the legs of the other two men. However, they saw that Jesus was already dead, so they did not have to break his legs. Instead a soldier pierced his side with a spear and blood and water flowed out. Those events fulfilled Old Testament scripture.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

The soldiers do not break Jesus’ legs

The soldiers confirm that Jesus was dead

Evidence that Jesus died

19:37a

And, as another Scripture says:

- And another scripture came true which says,
- And they pierced him with their spear just as another place in God’s Book says,

And: This phrase introduces a second prophecy that was fulfilled.

as another Scripture says: This clause is short for “and another scripture was fulfilled which says.” This other scripture is Zechariah 12:10.

Scripture: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as Scripture refers to a text or certain place in the writings of the Old Testament. In some languages it may not be necessary to supply a word meaning passage. For example:

it is also written in the Scriptures

The Holy Book also says

says: The word says refers to what has been written down. In some languages it is more natural to speak about what was written down or what can be read. For example:

this is written in the Scriptures

there is another scripture in which one can read (TH)

19:37b

“They will look on the One they have pierced.”

- “They will look at the person whom they pierced.”

- “They will see the one that they stabbed/pierced.”

They will look on the One they have pierced: This is a quotation from Zechariah 12:10. John understood this text to refer to the people seeing that Jesus’ side was pierced by a spear. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

People will look at him whom they pierced. (GNT)

They will look at the person whom they have stabbed. (GW)

the One they have pierced: The verb pierced in this context means to wound or stab something by pushing a sharp object into it. The Greek word is different from the word in 19:35 but refers to the same action. In some languages it is more natural to indicate what pierced Jesus. For example:

him whom they pierced with a spear

the one in whose side they stuck a spear (CEV)

John 19:38

Section 19:38–42: Jesus’ body was put in a tomb

This section describes how Jesus was buried. Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate if he could remove Jesus’ body from the cross. Pilate agreed, so he did that. Nicodemus went with Joseph and took spices to put inside the cloths with which they would wrap Jesus’ body. Then they buried him in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Men placed Jesus’ body in a new tomb

Jesus was buried

The burial of Jesus

19:38a

Afterward, Joseph of Arimathea, who was a disciple of Jesus

- ¶ After that, Joseph from Arimathea, a disciple/follower of Jesus
- ¶ After Jesus died, Joseph from the village named Arimathea, one of Jesus’ disciples/followers

Afterward: This phrase introduces the next event, the burial of Jesus. Introduce this next event in the story in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

After that (REB)

Later (NIV)

After it was all over (JBP)

Joseph of Arimathea: Joseph was a very common name at this time. This was not the Joseph who married Jesus’ mother but a man from a village or town named Arimathea. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Joseph from Arimathea (CEV)

Joseph, who was from the town of Arimathea, (GNT)

Joseph, who lived in the village called Arimathea,

who was a disciple of Jesus: The term disciple here indicates that Joseph was someone who believed in Jesus. He did not follow Jesus and learn from him every day as the twelve (12) disciples did. From the other Gospels we learn that Joseph was a member of the Jewish council called the Sanhedrin. Here is another way to translate this clause:

Joseph was a follower of Jesus (GNT)

19:38b

(but secretly for fear of the Jews),

- (but secretly because he was afraid of the Jewish leaders),
- (but he did not tell others this because he was afraid that the Jewish leaders would persecute him),

but secretly: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as secretly indicates that Joseph did not tell anyone that he believed in Jesus. It implies that he did not want to be persecuted or lose his position because he believed in Jesus.

for fear of the Jews: This phrase indicates that Joseph was afraid of the Jewish leaders. He was afraid that they would persecute him or remove him from the council. They might have even removed him from the

synagogue and the Jewish community (see the notes on 9:22b).

the Jews: This phrase here refers to the leaders of the Jews, especially the council. For example:

because he was afraid of the Jewish leaders (CEV)

because he feared the Jewish leaders (NIV)

General Comment on 19:38b

John 19:38b is parenthetical information. Several English translations put this information in parentheses. Indicate that this information is parenthetical in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

(but secretly, because he feared the Jewish leaders) (NET)

(Joseph was a follower of Jesus, but in secret, because he was afraid of the Jewish authorities.) (GNT)

19:38c

asked Pilate to let him remove the body of Jesus.

- asked Pilate for permission to remove Jesus' body from the cross for burial.
- went to Pilate. He asked Pilate, "May I have the body of Jesus to bury it?"

asked Pilate to let him remove the body of Jesus:

Joseph asked Pilate for permission to take away (remove) the body of Jesus so that he could bury it. This is an indirect quotation. In some languages it may be natural to use a direct quotation. For example:

said to Pilate, "Allow me to take the body of Jesus."

he asked Pilate, "May I remove Jesus' body?"

to let him remove the body of Jesus: In some languages it may be natural to include the implied information that Joseph wanted to bury the body. For example:

take the body of Jesus to bury it (TH)

take the body of Jesus to place it in a tomb (TH)

General Comment on 19:38a-c

In some language it is more natural to rearrange 19:38a-c, telling what Joseph did before telling who Joseph was. For example:

^{38a-c}Later Joseph from the city of Arimathea asked Pilate to let him remove Jesus' body. (Joseph was a disciple of Jesus but secretly because he was afraid of the Jews.) (GW)

^{38a-c}Later, Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate for the body of Jesus. Now Joseph was a disciple of Jesus, but secretly because he feared the Jews. (NIV)

^{38a-c}After this Joseph, who was from the town of Arimathea, asked Pilate if he could take Jesus' body. (Joseph was a follower of Jesus, but in secret, because he was afraid of the Jewish authorities.) (GNT)

19:38d

Pilate gave him permission,

- Pilate agreed to his request,
- Pilate said, "Yes, you may,"

Pilate gave him permission: This clause is more literally "Pilate allowed him." Pilate said that Joseph could have the body of Jesus in order to bury it. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He consented (REB)

Pilate gave him permission to remove Jesus' body. (GW)

Pilate told him he could have the body. (GNT)

"Yes, you may do that," Pilate said.

19:38e

so he came and removed His body.

- so he carried the body away.
- and so Joseph went and removed Jesus' body from the cross and took it away.

so he came and removed His body: This clause indicates that Joseph came to the cross and took Jesus' body down in order to bury it. In some languages you may want to make one or both pronouns (he and His) explicit to make them clear. For example:

so Joseph came and took Jesus' body away (NCV)

Joseph came and took the body away (NLT)

Joseph took it down from the cross (CEV)

removed: In some languages you may need to tell how Joseph removed or carried Jesus' body. He probably carried it with someone on a mat or something light that could be used to carry a body.

His body: This phrase refers to Jesus' dead body.

John 19:39

Section 19:38–42: Jesus' body was put in a tomb

This section describes how Jesus was buried. Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate if he could remove Jesus' body from the cross. Pilate agreed, so he did that. Nicodemus went with Joseph and took spices to put inside the cloths with which they would wrap Jesus' body. Then they buried him in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Men placed Jesus' body in a new tomb

Jesus was buried

The burial of Jesus

19:39a

Nicodemus, who had previously come to Jesus at night,

- Nicodemus, the man who first visited Jesus by night, came also.
- Nicodemus, the Jewish leader who originally went by night to talk to Jesus, went too.

Nicodemus, who had previously come to Jesus at night, also brought: This clause indicates that Nicodemus came to the cross and helped Joseph take Jesus' body down and away for burying.

who had previously come to Jesus at night: This clause re-introduces Nicodemus by referring to John 3:1–21. In that earlier passage Nicodemus came to Jesus after dark to ask him questions. Refer back to that incident in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the man who had come to Jesus at night (NLT)

This was the same Nicodemus who had visited Jesus one night. (CEV)

This was the man who had earlier come to Jesus in the night.

19:39b

also brought a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about seventy-five pounds.

- He brought about thirty kilograms of spices, a mixture of myrrh and aloes.
- He carried about seventy-five pounds of good-smelling powders, myrrh and aloes mixed together, to put on Jesus' body for a proper burial.

also brought a mixture of myrrh and aloes: Nicodemus brought with him good-smelling powders or spices. (Servants may have carried the spices rather than Nicodemus.) It was the Jewish custom to put these on a dead body and the cloths that they wrapped the body in. It may be natural to translate this as a separate sentence with an independent verb. For example:

He brought about seventy-five pounds of myrrh and aloe. (NCV)

myrrh and aloes: Both myrrh and aloes have a good strong smell that helps hide bad smells like the smell of dead bodies. For translation advice, see the General Comment at the end of the notes on 19:39b.

myrrh: The word myrrh refers to a good-smelling resin (a sticky substance) from a bush. It was made into a powder and used to make dead bodies smell better. It is also mentioned in Matthew 2:11.

aloes: The word aloes probably refers to the powder made from the wood of a sandalwood tree. See Proverbs 7:17; Psalm 45:8.

about seventy-five pounds: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates about seventy-five pounds is more literally “about 100 litpas.” The litpa is the Roman weight measure. It was the same as about 325 grams or less than a pound, about 11 ½ ounces. The BSB refers to a Roman pound, which is about ¾ of the pound that people use now. Translate this in the way that is most natural in your language. For example:

over thirty kilograms in weight

weighing about seventy-five pounds (NET)

General Comment on 19:39b

In some cultures myrrh and aloes are not known. If that is true in your culture, you may need to translate this phrase in one of the following ways:

- Indicate that there was a mixture of spices without including the names of the spices. You may want to put the names of the spices in a footnote. For example:

Nicodemus brought a large quantity of sweet-smelling powders/spices to put on the body for burial. Footnote: One of the powders/spices was called myrrh and the other was called aloes.

- Include the names of the spices in the text. You may want to tell more about these spices in a footnote. For example:

Nicodemus brought about thirty (30) kilograms of good smelling powders/spices called myrrh and aloe. Footnote: People made myrrh from the sticky resin of a small bush. Aloes was a powder that people made from the wood of the sandalwood tree.

John 19:40

Section 19:38–42: Jesus' body was put in a tomb

This section describes how Jesus was buried. Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate if he could remove Jesus' body from the cross. Pilate agreed, so he did that. Nicodemus went with Joseph and took spices to put inside the cloths with which they would wrap Jesus' body. Then they buried him in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Men placed Jesus' body in a new tomb

Jesus was buried

The burial of Jesus

19:40a

So they took the body of Jesus and wrapped it in linen cloths with the spices,

- They^(dual) took Jesus' body and wrapped it in linen cloths with the spice mixture,
- They^(dual) wrapped Jesus' corpse in cloths and the good-smelling powders.

So they took the body of Jesus and wrapped it in linen cloths with the spices: This clause indicates that Joseph and Nicodemus took Jesus' body and began to prepare it for burial. Because they already took the body down from the cross in 19:38e, the verb took here may be left implied. For example:

The two men wrapped the body in a linen cloth, together with the spices (CEV)

So: The Greek word that the BSB translates as So is a conjunction that indicates results and is often translated as “therefore.” Use an expression that is natural in your language.

they: This pronoun refers to Joseph and Nicodemus. In some languages it may be necessary to mark the following verbs as dual.

wrapped it in linen cloths with the spices: It was the custom of the Jews to wrap dead bodies in cloths with spices scattered inside. This is what Joseph and Nicodemus did. For example:

They wrapped the body with linen cloth and the myrrh and aloes.

They wrapped linen cloths with the spices around his body

linen cloths: The word linen refers to a fabric made from a plant called flax. Linen was a good-quality cloth that was known for being white. If linen is unknown in your culture and language, it may be natural to say:

fine cloths

You could supply a footnote. For example:

The Greek text says “linen cloths.” Linen was a valuable cloth/material made from the flax plant.

with the spices: The phrase the spices refers back to the mixture of myrrh and aloes. These were not spices used in cooking but rather used in making perfumes. Use a term that is suitable for something used in perfume that may be put on a dead body. For example:

to which the perfume had been added (Kankanaey Back Translation)

which contained the mixed medicine (Otomi Back Translation)

19:40b according to the Jewish burial custom.

- as the Jews do when they bury people.
- That is how we^(excl) Jews prepare a body to put in a tomb.

according to the Jewish burial custom: This is background information. The author knew that some of his audience were not familiar with how the Jews buried a dead body. So he explained that what Joseph and Nicodemus did to Jesus' body was what Jews usually did. For example:

which was how the Jewish people buried their dead (CEV)

That is how the Jews regularly prepared a dead body before they put it in a tomb

General Comment on 19:40a–b

In some languages it is more natural to say first that they followed traditional Jewish customs and then give the details. For example:

^{40b}Following Jewish burial custom, ^{40a}they wrapped Jesus' body with the spices in long sheets of linen cloth. (NLT)

John 19:41

Section 19:38–42: Jesus' body was put in a tomb

This section describes how Jesus was buried. Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate if he could remove Jesus' body from the cross. Pilate agreed, so he did that. Nicodemus went with Joseph and took spices to put inside the cloths with which they would wrap Jesus' body. Then they buried him in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Men placed Jesus' body in a new tomb

Jesus was buried

The burial of Jesus

19:41

The author next describes the place where Jesus' tomb was. Translate this as you usually describe a place setting.

19:41a

Now there was a garden in the place where Jesus was crucified,

- Near to where Jesus was nailed to the cross, there was a garden
- There was a garden very near to where Jesus died on the cross.

Now: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information. This is not the English time word Now that means "in the present."

there was a garden: The word garden here refers to a place where people have planted herbs, flowers, vegetables, or fruit. It was a large piece of land. It is the same word used in 18:1, where it refers to a place where olive trees grew.

in the place where Jesus was crucified: This phrase refers to the general area where Jesus was crucified. It does not mean that Jesus was crucified in that garden, but that the garden was nearby. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language.

where Jesus was crucified: The verb was crucified is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it.

General Comment on 19:41a

- Use a passive verb. For example:

where Jesus had been put to death (GNT)

where Jesus had been nailed to a cross (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

where Jesus died on the cross

where they/men crucified Jesus

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the information in 19:41a. For example:

In the place where Jesus was crucified, there was a garden. (NCV)

19:41b

and in the garden a new tomb

- with a new tomb in it.
- In that garden there was a cave there. It was recently dug out of a hill as a place to put corpses.

and in the garden a new tomb: The phrase a new tomb refers to a hole that someone had recently dug into a hill to bury someone. This tomb was like a cave rather than a box. Matthew 27:60 says that this tomb was Joseph's own, cut out of rock.

19:41c

in which no one had yet been laid.

- Nobody had been buried there before.
- It had not yet been used for a burial.

in which no one had yet been laid: Jews usually laid or put a dead body in a cave and allowed it to rot until only bones remained. Then the bones were collected and placed in a special box in the tomb. After that, another dead body could be put in the cave. But this cave was recently dug and no one had put a body in it yet.

The verb had...been laid is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

where no one had ever been buried (GNT)

that had never been used before (NCV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

it had never yet held/contained a body

no one had yet/ever placed a dead body in it

John 19:42

Section 19:38–42: Jesus' body was put in a tomb

This section describes how Jesus was buried. Joseph of Arimathea asked Pilate if he could remove Jesus' body from the cross. Pilate agreed, so he did that. Nicodemus went with Joseph and took spices to put inside the cloths with which they would wrap Jesus' body. Then they buried him in a new tomb in a nearby garden.

Here are other possible titles for this section:

Men placed Jesus' body in a new tomb

Jesus was buried

The burial of Jesus

19:42a

And because it was the Jewish day of Preparation

- It was almost the Sabbath
- Because it was almost the day when Jewish people were not allowed to work,

And: The Greek word that the BSB translates as And introduces two reasons why they buried Jesus in that tomb. There are several ways that this verse can be rearranged. For examples of how it could be rearranged, see the General Comment following the note on 19:42c.

because it was the Jewish day of Preparation: The phrase the Jewish day of Preparation refers to Friday. This was the day before the Jewish Sabbath, when no one was allowed to work. That meant that people had to do any work or preparations before the Sabbath began. Because it was almost sunset and the Jewish Sabbath would begin then, they had to bury Jesus quickly. When the Sabbath began the Jews were not allowed to bury anyone because they considered it work.

the Jewish day of Preparation: See how you translated the similar phrase "the day of Preparation" in 19:31. For example:

because it was the Jews' day to prepare for the Sabbath

because it was almost the Sabbath, the day when the Jews rested/worshiped,

19:42b

and the tomb was nearby,

- and the tomb was near the place where Jesus was nailed to the cross.
- and because the cave was so near,

and the tomb was nearby: The word nearby indicates that the tomb was near where Jesus was crucified. This is the second, related, reason why they buried Jesus here. Because it was almost the Sabbath, Joseph and Nicodemus did not have time to carry Jesus very far. For example:

and because the tomb was near

because it was close to the place where he had been killed (Yakan Back Translation)

19:42c**they placed Jesus there.**

- So they buried Jesus' body in that tomb.
- they placed/buried Jesus' corpse there.

they placed Jesus there: The pronoun they refers mainly to Joseph and Nicodemus. There may have been servants present also. They placed Jesus' body in the cave tomb.

placed Jesus there: The term Jesus here refers to Jesus' dead body. In some languages it is more natural to say:

placed Jesus' corpse/body there

placed: In some languages there will be a verb referring to placing a dead body in a permanent position. It may be natural to use a verb meaning "buried." But avoid using a verb that indicates that Jesus' body was buried underground or covered with dirt.

there: The Greek text emphasizes this word. You may want to emphasize it in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

that is where they buried him

General Comment on 19:42a–c

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange 19:42a–c. You may want to first say what Joseph and Nicodemus did and then why they did it. For example:

^{42c}The men laid Jesus in that tomb, ^{42b}because it was nearby, ^{42a}and they were preparing to start their Sabbath day. (NCV)

John 20:1**Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb**

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:1–2

Very early on the Sunday morning after Jesus' death, Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb. She saw that the tomb was open, and she ran and told two disciples, Peter and probably John.

20:1a**Early on the first day of the week, while it was still dark,**

- ¶ It was early in the morning on the first day of the week. Before there was light,
- ¶ It was Sunday morning before the sun rose.

Early on the first day of the week, while it was still dark:

This time expression introduces the story of how Jesus' followers learned that Jesus rose from the dead and was alive. It introduces this story by indicating the day and time of day. So this is the introduction to the climax or most important part of the book. Consider how it is natural to lead up to a significant change or climax. It may be natural to use short clauses or sentences, adding verbs. For example:

The first day of the week began. It was still dark when...

It was very early on the first day of the week and still dark.

The first day of the week arrived/began. It was not yet dawn.

See the General Comment following 20:1b for suggestions of how to rearrange this information.

Early...while it was still dark: The story begins very early in the morning, before the sun rose. Mark 16:2 talks about three women, including Mary Magdalene, going to the tomb "when the sun had risen." However, this could mean that it was dark when they started and the sun had risen by the time they arrived. Or it could be referring to the second time that Mary Magdalene went to the tomb (see 20:11–17). See also Matthew 28:1. Use the expression that is natural in your culture to indicate this time period. It may be natural to combine the two expressions Early and while it was still dark. For example:

In the darkness of the early morning

Before the sun rose

Early: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Early here refers to a time at the beginning of a morning. It does not have the meaning “too soon.” In some languages it may be natural to say:

Early in the morning

At the start of the day

while it was still dark: This clause indicates that it was still so early that people could not see well. Translate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

before it was light

before becoming light

the sun had not yet risen

on the first day of the week: The Jews began their week with Sunday and ended it with Saturday. So the phrase the first day of the week refers to Sunday. You may want to include this information. It is important to do this if your readers consider that another day is the first day of the week. For example:

on Sunday morning (GW)

If you use footnotes, you may want to translate literally and indicate in a footnote that this refers to Sunday. For example:

This refers to Sunday.

20:1b

Mary Magdalene went to the tomb

- Mary Magdalene went to the tomb.
- Mary Magdalene went to the cave where they had buried Jesus.

Mary Magdalene went to the tomb: One of Jesus' followers, Mary Magdalene, arrived at the cave where Jesus was buried. She probably traveled on foot, walking from the place where she was staying. The

distance was likely less than a mile. Use the verb that is most natural in your language. For example:

Mary Magdalene came to the tomb (NRSV)

Mary Magdalene went walking to the burial cave.

Mary Magdalene: Mary Magdalene was present at the cross and watched Joseph and Nicodemus bury Jesus (Matthew 27:56, 61, Mark 15:47). The word Magdalene means “from the village called Magdala.” Translate this name as you did in 19:25. For example:

Mary of Magdala (REB)

Mariyam, the woman from Magdala (Yakan Back translation)

In your translation of this phrase, be aware that Mary did not come from Magdala that morning. She was originally from Magdala, but was probably staying in a house in Jerusalem. She did not have to go far to get to the tomb. It was in a garden close to the place where they crucified Jesus (19:41–42), which was just outside Jerusalem.

the tomb: The word tomb refers to the place where Jesus had been buried. Tombs in Jerusalem were usually man-made caves cut into the sides of rocky hills. Inside was a stone shelf for the body. The entrance to the tomb was a large hole that could be closed with a round stone. See how you translated the word tomb in 19:41b, 42b. Because this is the beginning of a new chapter, it may be natural to indicate which tomb this was. For example:

Jesus' tomb

the tomb where they had buried/placed Jesus

General Comment on 20:1a–b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in these verse parts. For example:

^{1a-b}Now on the first day of the week Mary Magdalene came to the tomb early, while it was still dark. (ESV)

^{1a-b}Early on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb while it was still dark. (NCV)

20:1c
and saw that the stone had been removed from the entrance.

- She saw that the stone that covered the entrance to the tomb had been moved aside.
- There she saw that someone had opened the cave by taking/rolling away the stone from the entrance hole.

and saw that the stone had been removed from the entrance: Mary Magdalene saw that there was no stone that blocked the entrance to the tomb. The hole that formed the entrance was open. Apparently the stone was now lying nearby (see Matthew 28:2). Mary understood that someone must have moved the stone. In some languages it is more natural to say what she actually saw. For example:

saw that the entrance of the tomb was now open.
 Someone had removed the stone.

saw that the stone was no longer in its place in
 front of the entrance to the tomb

This clause tells a very important part of the story in the book of John. What it tells is not expected. It may be natural to translate this important information as a separate sentence or sentences. For example:

Mary saw that the stone had been removed from
 the tomb.

What she saw was that the tomb was open. The
 stone no longer covered the entrance hole.

Into her view/sight came/appeared the tomb.
 There was no stone at its entrance. It had been
 rolled away.

the stone had been removed from the entrance:

This is a passive clause. An angel had moved the stone (Matthew 28:2), but Mary did not know this. It happened before she arrived (Mark 16:4, Luke 24:2). There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the stone had been moved away from the tomb
 (NJB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

Someone had rolled the stone away from the
 entrance.

The stone was no longer in front of the entrance
 to the tomb.

The stone was gone from the entrance hole to the
 tomb

stone: This word here refers to the large round stone that was used to close the entrance. Because this is the first time John mentioned the stone, it may be natural to tell what stone this is. For example:

the stone that was at the entrance to the tomb

In some languages it may be necessary to make explicit that the stone was large. It was so large that a person could not easily move it. For example:

the large stone (NCV)

from the entrance: This phrase here means “from the entrance to the tomb.” This entrance had been covered by a large stone or rock. The entrance was shorter than a door, but an adult man could enter if he stooped or bent down. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

from the entrance of the tomb/cave

from the hole where one entered the tomb/cave

General Comment on 20:1a–c

In some languages it may be natural to translate this verse using two or more sentences. Increase the tension and sense of mystery in a natural way before the mystery is solved. For example:

The first day of the week began to dawn. It was still dark out, but Mary Magdalene made her way to the tomb. There she saw that the stone that had covered the entrance was gone!

It was very early on the first day of the week and still dark, when Mary of Magdala came to the tomb. She saw that the stone had been moved away from the tomb. (NJB)

Early on Sunday morning, while it was still dark, Mary from Magdala went to the tomb. She saw that the stone had been removed from the tomb's entrance. (GW)

John 20:2

Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:1–2

Very early on the Sunday morning after Jesus' death, Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb. She saw that the tomb was open, and she ran and told two disciples, Peter and probably John.

20:2a

So she came running to Simon Peter and the other disciple, the one whom Jesus loved.

- So she ran, going to Simon Peter and to the other disciple, the disciple Jesus loved.
- So she ran to where Simon Peter and Jesus' other follower were. This other follower was Jesus' dear friend.

So: The connector So introduces what Mary did next because she saw that the stone had been removed.

she came running to Simon Peter: The verbs came and running describe the same action. However, it may be natural to use two verbs like the Greek text. For example:

Mary Magdalene came to the tomb (NRSV)

and the other disciple, the one whom Jesus loved:

The phrase the other disciple, the one whom Jesus loved probably refers to John himself, the author of

this gospel. The expression the one whom Jesus loved indicates that this disciple was Jesus' good friend. Jesus loved all of his disciples. See how you translated this expression in 13:23 and 19:26. For example:

and to Jesus' dear friend and disciple/follower

disciple: The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciple refers to a "learner" who was in a special relationship with a teacher. The learner committed himself to his teacher in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example. In the New Testament a disciple referred specifically to a person who was learning from a religious teacher. A disciple often lived with his teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this word in, for example, 2:2 and 18:15.

loved: The Greek verb is different from that in the same English expression in 13:23, but the meaning is the same. This disciple knew that Jesus had a strong affection for him.

20:2b

"They have taken the Lord out of the tomb," she said,

- She said to them, "They have taken the Lord's body from the tomb.
- She told them, "Someone removed the Lord's body from its burial place/cave.

They have taken the Lord out of the tomb: Mary did not understand that Jesus had risen from the dead. She thought that someone had opened the tomb and removed Jesus' dead body.

They: This pronoun is indefinite and does not refer to a specific group of people. Mary did not know who might have moved Jesus' body. Here are some ways of translating this clause:

- Use a general subject, either singular or plural. For example:

Someone has taken the Lord

- Use a passive verb. For example:

The body of the Lord has been carried away

have taken the Lord: This phrase refers to someone removing the dead body of Jesus. Use an expression that one might use for moving a dead body.

the Lord: The word Lord is a term of respect and here refers to Jesus. See how you translated this word in 6:23 and 11:2. In some languages it may be natural to add a possessive pronoun, indicating whose Lord it is. For example:

our^(incl) Lord/Master

the one we^(incl) obey

In some languages you may need to indicate that it was the body of the Lord that was removed. That will make it clear that Mary thought that he was still dead. For example:

They have removed the body of our Lord from the cave (Kankanaey Back Translation)

out of the tomb: This phrase implies that the body was no longer in the tomb. Mary thought that someone had removed it from the tomb and taken it somewhere else.

she said: This phrase indicates that Mary Magdalene spoke to Peter and the disciple whom Jesus loved.

20:2c

“and we do not know where they have put Him!”

- We do not know where they took the body.”
- We do not know where they put it.”

and we do not know: The pronoun we here probably refers to Mary and some other women. Although the Gospel of John does not mention any other women, the other gospels do. (See Matthew 28:1, Mark 16:1, and Luke 24:1.) If you have different pronouns to indicate feminine and masculine, you should use a feminine plural pronoun here.

where they have put Him: This clause means “where they have placed Jesus’ dead body.” Mary assumed that some unknown person or persons had moved Jesus’ body to a different place. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

where they have laid him (NRSV)

where his body has been taken/placed

John 20:3

Section 20:1–10: Jesus’ body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus’ tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty.

So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus’ body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus’ followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:3–5

Peter and the other disciple both ran to the tomb. The other disciple got there first and looked inside.

20:3

Then Peter and the other disciple set out for the tomb.

- ¶ So Peter and the other disciple left to go to the tomb.
- ¶ After hearing that, Peter and the second follower started toward the cave where others had buried Jesus.

Then: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Then introduces a result. The result is what Peter and the other disciple did because of what Mary told them. For example:

So (NIV)

Peter and the other disciple: The phrase the other disciple refers to the disciple whom Jesus loved. John was probably referring to himself. See how you translated this phrase in 20:2a. Refer back to this disciple in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Peter and the second disciple

Peter and the disciple who was with him

the two disciples, Peter and his companion,

set out for the tomb: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as set out are more literally “went out” and “came to.” In some languages it may be natural to combine the two verbs. For example:

started for the tomb (NIV)

went to the tomb (GNT)

the tomb: The word tomb here refers to the cave dug out of the rock where Jesus' body had been placed. See how you translated this word in 20:1.

John 20:4

Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:3–5

Peter and the other disciple both ran to the tomb. The other disciple got there first and looked inside.

20:4a

The two were running together,

- Both men were running together,
- The two men ran together,

The two were running together: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as The two were running together describes how Peter and the other disciple went to the tomb. They both wanted to get there quickly, so they ran. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

They ran together (NJB)

They were both running (NLT)

The two of them were running (GNT)

The two: This phrase refers to Peter and the other disciple (probably John). Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Both (NIV)

running together: This phrase implies that both men went quickly, anxious to find out what had happened. They were both running to the same place, but they did not stay together because the other disciple arrived first. So it may be clearer to not include together. For example:

Both were running (NIV)

General Comment on 20:3–4a

The verb “went” in 20:3 and “running” in 20:4a refer to the same action. The men went to the tomb as quickly as they could, that is, they ran. In some languages it is more natural to use just one verb to describe this action. For example:

³Peter and the other disciple started out for the tomb. ^{4a}They were both running. (NLT)

20:4b

but the other disciple outran Peter

- but the other disciple ran faster than Peter ran.
- but the second follower was the faster runner.

but the other disciple outran Peter: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as outran means “ran ahead faster.” The other disciple ran more quickly than Peter did and got ahead. However, because “ran ahead” and “faster” mean the same thing, nearly all English translations only translate one of the expressions. For example:

but the other disciple ran faster than Peter (GNT)

the other disciple: Refer to this disciple in a way that makes it clear he was the same disciple mentioned in 20:3. For example:

that second disciple

his/Peter's companion

20:4c

and reached the tomb first.

- He arrived first at the tomb.

- He got to the cave before Peter did.

and reached the tomb first: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as reached is more literally “came.” The other disciple arrived at Jesus’ tomb before Peter did. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

got there first (CEV)

arrived at the tomb before him/Peter

John 20:5

Section 20:1–10: Jesus’ body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus’ tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus’ body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus’ followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:3–5

Peter and the other disciple both ran to the tomb. The other disciple got there first and looked inside.

20:5a

He bent down and looked in

- He bent/leaned over to look into the tomb,
- He stooped/squatted down and peered inside.

20:5b

at the linen cloths lying there,

- and saw that the linen burial cloths lay there.
- He could see the cloths in which they wrapped Jesus’ body lay there.

20:5a–b

He bent down: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as He bent down is more literally “having bent down.” It indicates that the disciple stooped (bent his upper body down). It implies that he did so in order to see inside the tomb.

He had to bend down because the opening of the cave was short, probably less than one meter (three feet) high. A person standing up could not see inside. In your translation, make it clear that the disciple looked inside the tomb, not down at the ground outside. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

He stooped (NLT)

He bent over (GW)

and looked in at the linen cloths lying there: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as looked in at the linen cloths lying there here indicates that this disciple saw only the linen wrappings. They were lying by themselves, not wrapped around a body, and probably limp and collapsed. It is implied but not explicitly stated that there was no body inside. In some languages a literal translation may be enough to imply this. For example:

saw that the burial cloths were lying there

In other languages it may be clearer to make the implied information more explicit. For example:

saw just the linen wrappings lying there

saw the linen wrappings lying there by themselves

the linen cloths: The BSB translates the Greek phrase literally as the linen cloths. See how you translated this phrase in 19:40. It refers to the cloths that the Jews wrapped around a dead body at burial. The emphasis is on the use of these cloths, not on what they were made of. It may be more natural to just say what the cloths were used for. For example:

the burial cloths

linen: The word linen refers to a type of cloth made from a plant called flax. Linen was considered a good-quality cloth and was known for being white.

lying there: This phrase indicates that this disciple could see that the burial cloths remained in the tomb. They had been left behind, abandoned. The cloths were probably lying either on the ground or on the shelf where Jesus’ body had been. The text does not indicate exactly where they were. But in some languages it may be natural to say explicitly to what

the word there refers. If that is so in your language, it is best to use a general expression. For example:

lying inside the tomb (CEV)

lying where Jesus' body had been

20:5c

but he did not go in.

- However, he did not go into the tomb.
- But he remained outside at the entrance.

but he did not go in: This disciple did not go into the tomb at this point. In some languages it may be natural to say what he did not enter. For example:

but he did not enter it

but he did not go into/inside the cave/tomb

Because he did enter a few minutes later, in some languages it may be more natural to say:

but he did not yet enter

but: The Greek word that the BSB translates as but introduces a contrast. The contrast is between what we might expect the disciple to do (enter) and what he actually did (stay outside). Although he saw only the linen cloths, this second follower of Jesus did not go inside the burial cave.

John 20:6

Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:6–10

Peter reached the tomb and went inside. John followed him. They saw how the grave cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus' body were lying abandoned in the tomb. Then the other disciple believed (probably that Jesus had risen from the dead) and both went home.

20:6a

Simon Peter arrived just after him.

- ¶ Simon Peter arrived at the tomb after him
- ¶ When Simon Peter arrived, right behind the other follower,
- ¶ Simon Peter followed the other disciple to Jesus' tomb and

Simon Peter arrived just after him: Simon Peter arrived after or behind the other disciple. The text does not say how far behind he was, but he may have arrived just a few seconds later. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Then Simon Peter, who was behind him, arrived (NIV)

Simon Peter arrived after him (GW)

20:6b

He entered the tomb

- and went inside.
- he entered the tomb/cave.

He entered the tomb: The pronoun He refers to Peter. Peter, like the other disciple, saw that the cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus' body were still there. See 20:5. Peter entered the tomb immediately, as soon as he arrived. In some languages it may be natural to leave the phrase the tomb implicit. For example:

and went inside (NLT)

20:6c

and saw the linen cloths lying there.

- He saw that the linen burial cloths lay there.
- He noticed that the cloths in which they wrapped Jesus' body lay there alone.

saw the linen cloths lying there: It may or may not be necessary to repeat the idea that the wrappings were alone, abandoned. Consider what is natural in your language. For example:

He saw the strips of cloths that were lying there by themselves

He also noticed the linen wrappings lying there (NLT)

and saw the strips of cloth (CEV)

the linen cloths: This phrase refers to the same burial cloths as in 20:5. See how you translated the same phrase there. For example:

the strips of linen cloth (NET)

the linen cloths (GNT)

John 20:7

Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:6–10

Peter reached the tomb and went inside. John followed him. They saw how the grave cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus' body were lying abandoned in the tomb. Then the other disciple believed (probably that Jesus had risen from the dead) and both went home.

20:7a

The cloth that had been around Jesus' head

- He also saw the cloth that had been wrapped around Jesus' head.
- And the cloth for his head was there too,

The cloth that had been around Jesus' head: The Jewish custom was to wrap a dead body in cloth up to the neck. Then they wrapped the head in another piece of cloth. See the note on 11:44c. Peter now noticed this second cloth, the head cloth. Refer to this head cloth in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

as well as the burial cloth that had been around Jesus' head (NIV)

and the face cloth, which had been around Jesus' head (NET)

He also saw the piece of cloth that had been used to cover Jesus' face. (CEV) s5 20:7b

20:7b

was rolled up,

- rolled up by itself.
- but someone had rolled it up and laid it down separately.

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that the is often translated as “but.” Here it connects a negative statement (20:7b) to a positive statement (20:7c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

It wasn't lying with the strips of linen but was rolled up separately. (GW)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

It was not with the linen cloths. Instead, it was rolled up in a separate place.

- Do not use a conjunction as in the BSB. For example:

It was not with the cloth that was wrapped around the body. It was rolled up and in another place.

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

The cloth was still lying in its place, separate from the linen. (NIV)

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

was rolled up: This phrase further explains where the head cloth was lying. It was by itself a little distance from the other cloths. There are two ways to interpret the Greek verb that the BSB translates as was rolled up:

1. It means rolled up. For example:

but was rolled up by itself (GNT) (BSB, GNT, REB, RSV, NRSV, NET, GW, CEV, NJB)

1. It means folded up. For example:

but folded up (ESV) (NIV84, ESV, NLT, NCV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most important English translations. However, there is not a great difference in meaning.

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as was rolled up is in the passive. The same verb in the active is found in Matthew 27:59 and Luke 23:53, where it means “wrapped.” The verb perhaps indicates that the cloth kept the shape that it had when it was wrapped around Jesus’ head.

There are at least two ways to translate this passive verb:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

was rolled up (GNT)

- Use an active verb. Some scholars suggest that Jesus had rolled or folded the head cloth as a sign of his victory. Keener, page 1182. However, the text does not state this. The cloth may have just kept the shape in which it was wrapped around Jesus’ body. Kostenberger, page 564 footnote 21, UBS Handbook p. 606. So it is good to leave this as general as possible. For example:

The cloth was still lying in its place (NIV)

20:7c

lying separate from the linen cloths.

- It was lying apart/separate from the burial cloths.
- It was not with the burial cloths.

lying separate from the linen cloths: The head cloth was not with the cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus’ body. It was lying separately, but was still in the

tomb. In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a positive expression. For example:

lying apart from the other wrappings (NLT)

separate from the linen (NIV)

General Comment on 20:6–7

In the Greek text 20:6–7 forms one long sentence. The BSB has broken it into three sentences. It may be clearer to break this up into several shorter sentences. For example:

Simon Peter arrived after him and went into the tomb. He saw the strips of linen lying there. He also saw the cloth that had been on Jesus’ head. It wasn’t lying with the strips of linen but was rolled up separately. (GW)

John 20:8

Section 20:1–10: Jesus’ body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus’ tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus’ body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus’ followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:6–10

Peter reached the tomb and went inside. John followed him. They saw how the grave cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus’ body were lying abandoned in the tomb. Then the other disciple believed (probably that Jesus had risen from the dead) and both went home.

20:8a

Then the other disciple, who had reached the tomb first, also went in.

- So then the other disciple, the one who had arrived first, also went inside.
- Then the follower of Jesus who got to the cave first also entered it.

Then: The time word that the BSB translates as Then here introduces what happened next in the story. For example:

Finally (NIV)

the other disciple: This refers to the disciple whom Jesus loved, probably John himself. Refer to him as you did in 20:2.

who had reached the tomb first: This refers back to what happened in 20:4. For example:

who arrived at the tomb first (GW)

also went in: The other disciple went into the tomb, as Peter had done.

20:8b

And he saw and believed.

- He saw the cloths and believed that Jesus had risen from the dead.
- He observed the burial cloths and believed that Jesus rose from the dead.

And he saw and believed: The second disciple saw what was in the tomb and believed. Neither the verb saw nor the verb believed have objects. In some languages it may be natural or necessary to say what this disciple saw. He looked around the tomb and saw what was in it (the cloths). He also noticed what was not in it (Jesus' body). For example:

when he saw it, he believed (CEV)

saw what had happened, and believed (JBP)

he looked around in the tomb and believed

he saw the grave cloths there and believed

believed: The text does not say explicitly what this disciple believed. It appears from the context that he believed that Jesus had risen from the dead. Finding the grave cloths like that may have persuaded him that Jesus was resurrected and no one stole his body. In some languages it may be necessary to make this implied information explicit. For example:

believed that Jesus had risen

John 20:9

Section 20:1–10: Jesus' body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus' tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus' body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus' followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:6–10

Peter reached the tomb and went inside. John followed him. They saw how the grave cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus' body were lying abandoned in the tomb. Then the other disciple believed (probably that Jesus had risen from the dead) and both went home.

20:9a–b

For they still did not understand from the Scripture that Jesus had to rise from the dead: The two disciples did not understand that their scriptures, our Old Testament, taught that the Messiah would rise from the dead. This is a parenthetical statement. It is not part of the main story but a comment by the author. Some English translations therefore place this sentence in parentheses. For example:

(They still did not understand from Scripture that Jesus had to rise from the dead.) (NIV)

20:9a

For they still did not understand from the Scripture

- (Because they still did not realize that God's Word said
- (The two men/disciples did not yet understand that God's book said

For: The Greek word that the BSB translates as For here means "because" and introduces a parenthetical statement. In some languages it may be natural to

leave it untranslated, as the NIV has done. Introduce the following parenthetical information in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

because

they still did not understand from the Scripture:

This parenthetical statement explains why the disciple only believed after he saw the empty tomb and the grave cloths. It was because the disciples did not realize that their scriptures said that the Messiah must rise from the dead. At that time they did not know that this was what the Scriptures meant. They knew what the Scriptures said, but they did not understand its full meaning.

they still did not understand: There are two ways to interpret the expression that the BSB translates as they still did not understand:

1. It means that the disciples still did not understand. They did not understand until some future time. For example:

At that time Peter and the other disciple did not know (CEV)

They still did not understand the scripture (GNT)
(BSB, NIV, NRSV, CEV, GW, NCV, KJV, NASB, NET, GNT)

1. It means that the disciples did not understand until this point. At this time they began to understand. For example:

for until then they still hadn't understood (NLT)
(NLT, REB, NJB)

If you must choose between the interpretations, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is followed by most important English translations and also has the support of commentaries. See Carson page 639: "Neither Peter nor the beloved disciple at this point understood from Scripture that Jesus had to rise from the dead. By the time John wrote that was no longer the case: the church had worked out a detailed understanding of the Old Testament...." In some languages it may be natural to translate it as a positive statement. For example:

for only later did they understand the scripture

they: This pronoun here refers to two men, Peter and John. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

Peter and the other disciple (CEV)

still: The word still means "up to that time." It implies that later the situation changed and the disciples did understand.

did not understand: The Greek word that the BSB translates as understand is more literally "know." Here in this context it refers to knowing the meaning of something. The disciples knew what the Scriptures said, but they did not realize that it was speaking about Jesus' resurrection.

the Scripture: This phrase here probably refers to the Jewish word of God as a whole, which is our Old Testament. The author may have been thinking of passages such as Isaiah 53:10-11, Psalm 16:9-11, and Hosea 6:2. See how you translated this word in 2:22 and 10:35. Here are some ways to translate this word:

what is written in God's Word

what God's book says

what the prophets wrote long ago

20:9b

that Jesus had to rise from the dead.

- that Jesus must rise from the dead.)
- that the Christ/Messiah needed to live again after death.)

that Jesus had to rise from the dead: This clause indicates what the disciples did not understand from scripture. They did not understand that it was necessary for Jesus to rise from the dead. It was necessary because God had decided and declared that it would happen. It was God's will and purpose. See how you translated the similar idea, that Jesus must die on the cross, in 3:14. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

when it said that Jesus had to come back to life
(GW)

which showed that he must rise from the dead
(REB)

that he was certainly/surely going to live again

rise from the dead: This phrase means “become alive again after dying.” See how you translated this phrase in 2:22, Mark 9:9, and Luke 2:46. For example:

rise from death (GNT)

rise to life (CEV)

return to life

John 20:10

Section 20:1–10: Jesus’ body was not in the tomb

This section tells how Mary Magdalene went to Jesus’ tomb on Sunday morning and found that it was empty. So she went and told Peter and another disciple and they went to the tomb with Mary. They also saw that the body of Jesus was not there. All that they found were the cloths that had been around Jesus’ body. When the second disciple, probably John, saw, he believed.

Here are other possible section headings:

The resurrection of Jesus

Three of Jesus’ followers went to the tomb but it was empty

The empty tomb

Paragraph 20:6–10

Peter reached the tomb and went inside. John followed him. They saw how the grave cloths that had been wrapped around Jesus’ body were lying abandoned in the tomb. Then the other disciple believed (probably that Jesus had risen from the dead) and both went home.

20:10

Then the disciples returned to their homes.

- Then the two disciples returned to their places.
- Afterwards they returned to where they were staying.

Then the disciples returned to their homes: Some English translations begin a new paragraph here, as the BSB has done. These notes follow the NRSV and the UBS Greek text and begin a new paragraph at 20:11. You can make this verse the end of the previous paragraph or the beginning of a new paragraph. Consider

which is more natural in your language. Here are some other translation examples:

Then the disciples went back to their homes. (NIV)

After that the disciples went back home.

Then: This time word introduces what the disciples did after seeing what was in the tomb.

the disciples: This phrase here refers to two of the disciples, Peter and “the other disciple.” Refer to your translation of 20:2.

returned to their homes: The Greek word that the BSB translates as their homes is more literally just “theirs.” It refers to the place where the disciples were staying in Jerusalem. None of the disciples lived in Jerusalem, so they were probably guests in other people’s homes. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

returned to their places

returned to where they were staying

John 20:11

Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus’ body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus’ first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:11–13

Mary apparently followed the two disciples to the tomb and was crying there. When she looked into the tomb, she saw two angels who asked her why she was crying. She told them it was because someone had removed Jesus’ body and she did not know where it was.

20:11a**But Mary stood outside the tomb weeping.**

- ¶ But Mary stood outside the tomb and wept there.
- ¶ Now Mary had returned and stood crying at the entrance to the cave.

But Mary stood outside the tomb weeping: By this time Mary had returned to the tomb. She did not understand that Jesus had risen. She still thought someone had moved Jesus' dead body somewhere else. So she was crying. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

but Mary stood outside the tomb crying (NIV)

But Mary wept as she stood outside the tomb.

The author does not mention Mary's return to the tomb. He does not say if she came back to the tomb before or after the two disciples left. In some languages it may be necessary to make her return explicit. For example:

But Mary came and stood outside the tomb crying.

But Mary, returning, stood outside the tomb and wept.

Mary: This name refers to Mary Magdalene, which John makes explicit in 20:18a. You may want to make explicit here which Mary John refers to. For example:

Mary Magdalene (CEV)

20:11b**And as she wept, she bent down to look into the tomb,**

- As she was weeping, she stooped down and looked inside the tomb.
- She leaned down to look inside the cave, still crying.

And as she wept, she bent down to look into the tomb: Mary continued weeping as she stood at the open entrance to the tomb. While she was weeping, she stooped (bent down) to look inside the tomb. Connect the three actions of weeping, bending, and looking in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

While she was still crying, she bent over and looked into the tomb. (GNT)

She was still weeping as she stooped and looked in.

Mary stooped to look inside the tomb, crying as she did.

she bent down to look into the tomb: The opening of the tomb was small, so Mary had to bend down to look in. See the note at 20:5a, where the same verb describes how "the other disciple" also bent over to look inside the tomb. See how you translated the idea there. Like the other disciple, Mary not only bent over in order to look inside but actually did look inside. So it may be natural to use two independent verbs. For example:

she stooped and looked in (NLT)

Another way to translate this is to make look the main verb. For example:

bending down, she looked into the tomb

John 20:12**Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene**

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus' body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus' first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:11–13

Mary apparently followed the two disciples to the tomb and was crying there. When she looked into the tomb, she saw two angels who asked her why she was crying. She told them it was because someone had removed Jesus' body and she did not know where it was.

20:12a**and she saw two angels in white**

- There she saw two angels dressed in white clothes.
- Two messengers from God were there. Their clothes were white,

and she saw two angels in white: The two angels that Mary saw were inside the tomb. In some languages it may be natural to make this explicit. For example:

and saw two angels there dressed in white (GNT)

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence. For example:

And she saw two angels in white (NET)

angels in white: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as angels in white indicates that the angels were wearing white clothes. See also Matthew 28:3 and Mark 16:5. Translate this phrase in a way that is natural in your language. It may be natural to make some information explicit. For example:

angels in white clothes (GW)

angels dressed in white (NCV)

angels: The Greek word that the BSB translates as angels means “messengers.” It refers here to spirit beings who serve God. Sometimes, as here, God sends angels to bring a message to human beings. Here are some ways to translate this word:

- Use a descriptive word or phrase. For example:

messengers from God/heaven

good/holy spirit-beings

- Use a local term that fits the biblical meaning.
- In some areas the churches may already be using a borrowed term or a transliterated word for “angel.” Be sure that this term fits the biblical meaning. If people do not understand the right meaning from this term, you may need to make the meaning more explicit. For example:

an angelos messenger from God

a good angelos spirit

See angel sense 1 in KBT.

in white: This phrase indicates that the angels were wearing white clothes. White clothes indicate that the angels were from heaven. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in white clothes (GW)

dressed in white (GNT)

In some languages it may be more natural to put this information in a separate clause. For example:

They were dressed in white (CEV)

whose clothes were white

The text does not say what kind of white clothes the angels were wearing. Perhaps they wore long clothes like robes similar to what the Jewish people then normally wore. For example:

white robes

General Comment on 20:11b–12a

In some languages it may be natural to combine the ideas of looking and seeing. See how you translated 20:5. For example:

She was still weeping, when she stooped down and saw two angels inside (CEV)

20:12b

sitting where the body of Jesus had lain,

- They were sitting where Jesus’ body was lying before.
- and they were sitting on the bench where Jesus’ body had been earlier.

sitting where the body of Jesus had lain: The phrase where the body of Jesus had lain refers to a shelf at the side of the tomb. In a burial cave there was a shelf made of rock where people placed the dead body. The angels were sitting at the two ends of this shelf. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

seated where Jesus’ body had been (NIV)

sitting there, on the place where they had put Jesus’ body

20:12c**one at the head and the other at the feet.**

- One was where his head had been/rested and the other was where his feet had been/rested.
- One angel sat where Jesus' head had lain and the other sat where his feet had lain.

one at the head and the other at the feet: The words head and feet refer to the places where the head and feet of Jesus' body had earlier rested. The body itself was no longer there. It is important that your readers understand this. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

one where Jesus' head had been, the other where Jesus' feet had been

General Comment on 20:11–12

In some languages it may be natural to translate these verses using shorter sentences. For example:

Mary Magdalene stood crying outside the tomb. She was still weeping, when she stooped down and saw two angels inside. They were dressed in white and were sitting where Jesus' body had been. One was at the head and the other was at the foot. (CEV)

General Comment on 20:12

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 20:12. For example:

^{12a-c}and saw two angels in white sitting there, one at the head and one at the feet, where the body of Jesus had lain (REB)

^{12a-c}She saw two angels where the body of Jesus had been. They wore white clothes, and one was sitting where his head had been, and one where his feet had been.

John 20:13**Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene**

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus' body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus' first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:11–13

Mary apparently followed the two disciples to the tomb and was crying there. When she looked into the tomb, she saw two angels who asked her why she was crying. She told them it was because someone had removed Jesus' body and she did not know where it was.

20:13a**“Woman, why are you weeping?” they asked.**

- They said to her, “Ma’am, why do you^(sing) weep?”
- They asked her, “What is the reason that you^(fem.sing.) are crying?”

Woman: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Woman is a polite way to address a woman. See how you translated this word in 2:4, 4:21, and 19:26. Use a term of address that is polite and natural in your language. For example:

Dear woman (NLT)

Miss/Ma’am

If there is no suitable polite term of address for a woman, it may be natural to just leave it out. It may be best to avoid words such as “sister,” because the speakers were angels, not humans. Consider if there is a polite term of address that a non-human might use to address a human woman. For example, the non-human species in C. S. Lewis' Narnia stories use the phrase “Daughter of Eve.” The phrase “Daughter of Adam” might work in some languages. Or you may want to leave out the term of address. For example:

Why are you crying? (CEV)

Another way to avoid using a term of address is to use an indirect quotation. For example:

The angels asked her why she was crying. (GW)

why are you weeping?: The angels asked Mary to tell them the reason why she was crying. They knew

why Mary was crying and that she did not need to cry (because Jesus was alive). They knew why the tomb was empty. Translate this question in a kind, natural way to ask why someone is doing something that is not necessary. For example:

Tell us why you are weeping.

What is the reason for your tears?

you: This pronoun is feminine singular and refers to Mary.

they asked: The pronoun they refers to the two angels. Because the angels appeared to people in the form of human men, you should probably use a masculine plural (or dual) pronoun. Because what the angels said was a question, you may want to indicate that here. And it may be more natural to identify one or both pronouns. For example:

they asked her (GNT)

The angels asked Mary (CEV)

The angels asked her (GW)

20:13b

“Because they have taken my Lord away,” she said,

- She answered them, “They removed my Lord’s body
- Mary answered, “They moved the body of my Lord.

Because they have taken my Lord away: This clause is Mary’s answer to the angel’s question. It gives the reason why Mary was weeping. There is a Greek word here that can introduce a quote or can mean “because.” Here it could do either, though most important English translations and many commentaries understand it to introduce the quote. Even so, the word “because” is implied because the quote is the answer to a “Why?” question. Translate this clause in a way that is natural for an answer to a question that asks why. See how you translated the similar clause “They have taken the Lord out of the tomb” in 20:2. For example:

Because they have taken away my Lord (NLT)

I am crying because they took away my Lord.

they: This pronoun is indefinite. Mary did not know who did this. It is more natural in some languages to use an indefinite pronoun or a passive sentence. For example:

someone has taken my Lord away

my Lord has been taken away

have taken my Lord away: Mary meant that someone must have removed Jesus’ body and taken it somewhere else. Mary did not think that Jesus was living. Use an expression that is natural for lifting up and moving a dead body. For example:

have taken away my Lord’s body (CEV)

have removed the body of my Lord

my Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” People used this word as a polite title when they spoke to an elder or someone in authority. Mary indicated that Jesus was in authority over her in some way. The Jews also used this same title to refer to God.

See how you translated the word Lord in 20:2. It is good to use the same word here. However, here Mary says my Lord rather than “the Lord.” For example:

my Master

the one I obey/serve

she said: The BSB has this quote introducer after the quotation. The Greek has placed the quote introducer before the quotation, as is sometimes more natural in English. Place this quote introducer where it is most natural in your language.

20:13c

“and I do not know where they have put Him.”

- and I do not know where they took it.”
- I do not know where they put it.”

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as and here introduces another part of the reason why Mary was crying. In some languages it may be natural to leave this conjunction untranslated and to begin a new sentence. For example:

They have taken away my Lord's body! I don't know where they have put him (CEV)

I do not know where they have put Him: Mary did not understand that Jesus had risen. See how you translated the similar clause in 20:2. However, there Mary used the plural pronoun “we” rather than the singular pronoun I as she does here. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

I do not know where they have taken his body to.

where they have put Him: The pronoun they is indefinite. Mary did not have any particular person in mind. She thought that someone took his body, but did not know who. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this idea using a passive verb. For example:

where he has been put

where his body has been laid

Him: This pronoun refers to Jesus' body. See how you translated “my Lord” in 20:13a and use the pronoun that is natural in this context. For example:

Because they removed the body/corpse of my Lord and I do not know where they put it.

John 20:14

Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene
This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus' body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus' first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:14–16

Someone came up behind Mary and asked her why she was crying. Only when he said her name did she recognize that it was Jesus.

20:14a

When she had said this, she turned around

- ¶ After saying this, she turned away.
- ¶ Then she looked/glanced behind her

When she had said this: The Greek phrase the BSB translates as When she had said this is more literally “Having said these things.” It refers back to what Mary had just said to the angels. For example:

At this (NIV)

Then (GNT)

As soon as Mary said this (CEV)

she turned around: Mary had been facing the tomb, talking to the angels who were inside. Now she turned away from the angels and the tomb. John does not say what caused her to turn around. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

she turned away

she looked behind her

20:14b

and saw Jesus standing there;

- Jesus was standing there behind her and she saw him,
- and noticed someone standing there.

and saw Jesus standing there: After Mary turned around, Jesus was in front of her. She did not recognize him. In some languages it is therefore more natural to say that she saw a man, or saw someone. For example:

she saw a man standing there

and saw someone standing there (NLT)

20:14c

but she did not recognize that it was Jesus.

- but she did not realize who it was.
- It was Jesus, but she did not recognize him.

but she did not recognize that it was Jesus: The figure standing there behind Mary was Jesus, but Mary did not recognize him. It is possible that he looked a little different or God prevented her from recognizing him. Others did not recognize him after the resurrection either (see Luke 24:16 and John 21:4). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

without realizing that it was Jesus (JBP)

but without recognizing him

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as a complete sentence. For example:

But she did not know who he was. (CEV)

General Comment on 20:14b–c

In some languages it may make the meaning clear to translate 20:14b–c as three separate clauses. The first clause could say that Mary saw someone. The second could say that this was Jesus. And the third could say that Mary did not recognize him. For example:

and saw someone standing there. It was Jesus,
but she didn't recognize him. (NLT)

John 20:15

Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus' body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus' first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:14–16

Someone came up behind Mary and asked her why she was crying. Only when he said her name did she recognize that it was Jesus.

20:15a

“Woman, why are you weeping?” Jesus asked.

- Jesus asked her, “Ma’am, why are you^(sing) crying?”
- He asked her, “Sister, what has caused you^(sing) to cry?”

Woman: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Woman is a polite way to address a woman. In some languages it is more natural to use a different word when speaking politely to a woman. See how you translated this same word in 20:13. Here it is not an angel that is speaking, so it may be natural to use a different word. Mary thought that he was the gardener, so use a polite word that a gardener might use. For example:

Sister

why are you weeping?: This is a real question, the same question as in 20:13. Translate it here as you did there. For example:

Why are you crying? (NIV)

Jesus asked: The Greek has the quote introducer before the quote. The BSB has placed the quote introducer in the middle of the quote, as can be natural in English. Place the quote introducer where it is most natural in your language. For example:

Jesus said to her, “Woman, why are you weeping?
(NRSV)

asked: The Greek word that the BSB translates as asked here is more literally “said.” Jesus asked Mary to tell him why she was crying, even though he knew the answer. Use the expression that is most natural in your language.

20:15b

“Whom are you seeking?”

- For whom are you^(sing) searching?”
- Whom do you^(sing) want to find?”

Whom are you seeking?: Again Jesus asked a real question even though he knew the answer. Here are other ways to translate this question:

Who is it you are looking for? (NIV)

Whom do you want to see/find?

you: This pronoun is singular feminine and refers to Mary.

20:15c

Thinking He was the gardener,

- Mary thought that he was the gardener.
- Mary assumed that he worked in the garden.

Thinking He was the gardener: Mary thought Jesus was the man who took care of this garden. She was wrong. Translate the verb Thinking in a way that allows for the possibility that she was wrong. For example:

Supposing him to be the gardener (NRSV)

Assuming that he was the gardener

the gardener: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the gardener refers to a man who works in a garden. John 19:41 told us that Jesus' tomb was in a garden. See how you translated the word "garden" there and use a word here that relates to that word.

20:15d

she said, "Sir, if you have carried Him off,

- So she said, "Sir, if you^(sing) moved him,
- So she asked him, "My good man, have you^(sing) taken away his body? If so,

Sir, if you have carried Him off: This clause indicates that Mary thought that perhaps the man that she spoke to had removed Jesus' body. Place the term of address, Sir, where it is natural in your language. For example:

Sir, if you have taken him away (NJB)

If it is you, sir, who removed him (REB)

If you are the one who moved the body, sir,

Sir: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Sir was a polite way of addressing an adult male stranger. See how you translated this word in 4:11. Use a term that a woman might use to politely address an unknown man. For example:

Uncle (Tagbanwa Back Translation) In some languages it may be necessary to add a word like "my" before such a term of address. For example:

My chief

if you have carried Him off: This clause expresses a possibility that the speaker thought may or may not have been true. Mary did not know if this man speaking to her had taken Jesus' body away. She assumed, however, that someone had taken the body. In some languages it may be natural to translate this suggestion as a question. For example:

Did you take him away? (NCV)

are you the one who removed his body?

have carried Him off: The Greek word that the BSB translates as have carried...off here refers to taking away a dead body from the tomb. For example:

have taken his body away (CEV)

20:15e

tell me where you have put Him,

- please tell me where you^(sing) took him.
- could you^(sing) let me know where you put it.

tell me where you have put Him: This clause is a polite request. Mary wanted to know where Jesus' dead body was. Translate this clause as a polite request for information. Refer to Jesus' dead body in a way that agrees with how you referred to it in 20:15d. For example:

please tell me where you put him/it

could you let me know where you placed his body?

20:15f

and I will get Him."

- Then I can remove him."
- I will move it somewhere else."

and I will get Him: This clause indicates what Mary planned to do after she found out where Jesus' body was. Connect this clause to the previous clause in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Then I will/can take him away.

so that I can go to him and take him away

I will get Him: The Greek clause that the BSB translates literally as I will get Him indicates that Mary would take Jesus' body to a suitable burial place. She

would take him away by asking some men to carry the body. Refer to the body in a way that agrees with how you referred to it in 20:15d, e. For example:

I will get someone to carry the body away.

I will cause/tell men to carry it away.

John 20:16

Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus' body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus' first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:14–16

Someone came up behind Mary and asked her why she was crying. Only when he said her name did she recognize that it was Jesus.

20:16a

Jesus said to her, "Mary."

- Jesus said, "Mary!"
- Jesus greeted/called her by her name.

Jesus said to her, "Mary.": This sentence indicates that Jesus spoke to Mary, saying her name. For dramatic emphasis, try to keep the direct quote and direct form of address. But in some cultures it may not be polite for a man to call a woman by name alone. If this does not show respect in your culture, here are ways to translate this sentence:

- Add a word indicating a relation of respect. For example:

Jesus said to her, "Sister Mary!"

- Translate Jesus' speech as an indirect quotation. For example:

Jesus spoke her name.

Jesus called her by her name.

20:16b

She turned and said to Him in Hebrew, "Rabboni!" (which means "Teacher").

- She turned to him and spoke to him in their Jewish language, saying, "Rabboni!" (That means "Teacher.")
- And Mary turned to face Jesus. Speaking in their Aramaic language, she said, "Rabboni!" (That means "Religious Teacher").

She turned: Mary turned to face Jesus. This time she recognized him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

She turned toward him (NIV)

She faced him

She looked at him

and said to Him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates literally as said here introduces a cry or exclamation. For example:

and cried out (NIV)

in Hebrew: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Hebrew here refers to Aramaic. This was the language that the Jews spoke at this time, the language of both Mary and Jesus. See how you translated this word in 5:2, 19:13, 17, 20. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

in Aramaic (NIV)

in the Jewish language

in her own language

in their language

"Rabboni!" (which means "Teacher"): The author explained the meaning of the Aramaic word Rabboni. Mary, of course, only said Rabboni. The clause which means "Teacher" is parenthetical information, a trans-

lation of Rabboni by the author. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

“Rabboni.” (This means Teacher.) (NCV)

“Rabboni.” (The word Rabboni means Teacher.)

Rabboni: The BSB has transliterated (copied the spelling of) the word Mary used as Rabboni. Some other English translations, such as the NRSV, have transliterated it as “Rabbouni.” The NRSV is closer to the form in the Greek text, but either spelling is acceptable. John, who wrote the Greek text, transliterated the word from the original Aramaic word. See also Mark 10:51, where the same word appears. However, whether you transliterated the word there or not, you should do so here, because John immediately explains the meaning.

The word Rabboni is similar to the Aramaic word “Rabbi” used in 1:38, 49. Here it has a suffix (word ending) meaning “my.” Mary was calling Jesus her teacher. See how you translated “Rabbi” at 1:38, 49.

Teacher: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Teacher refers to any kind of teacher. In this context it refers to a man with authority to teach about God. Translate this word using a term that is suitable and shows respect when addressing a religious teacher. For example:

Sir Teacher

Wise one

Be careful not to use a term that can refer only to a school teacher.

General Comment on 20:16b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 20:16b. For example:

She turned and said to him “Rabboni.” The Aramaic word “Rabboni” means Teacher. (CEV)

She turned to him and cried out, “Rabboni!” (which is Hebrew for “Teacher”). (NLT)

General Comment on 20:14a, 16b

20:14a says that Mary turned around and saw Jesus, and 20:16b again says that Mary turned. John does not tell us that she turned away between those two times.

To avoid confusion, it may be necessary to indicate that she only briefly or partly turned toward Jesus at first. Here are some ways to do this:

^{14a}she turned around and saw...^{16b}She turned toward him (GNT)

^{14a}She turned and noticed...^{16b}At this she turned right around (JBP)

^{14a}She looked behind her and saw...^{16b}She turned completely around

^{14a}She looked around and saw...^{16b}She turned to face him

John 20:17

Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus’ body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus’ first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:17–18

Jesus told Mary to go and tell the disciples that she had seen him alive. She obeyed him.

20:17a

“Do not cling to Me,” Jesus said,

- ¶ Jesus said to her, “Stop clinging to me,
- ¶ Jesus told her, “You^(sing) must stop holding on to me

Do not cling to Me: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Do not cling to Me means “You should stop clinging to me.” The verb can mean “touch” (NET, KJV) rather than “hold,” though most important translations and many commentaries think that here it means the latter. The form of the Greek verb has the sense of “stop doing what you are doing.” Almost all

important English translations translate it as “Do not cling to me” rather than “Stop clinging to Me” (NASB). However, “Do not cling to me” can mean “Stop clinging to me,” and also “Do not start clinging to me.” It appears that Mary was clinging to Jesus, possibly holding his feet (see Matthew 28:9). This is a command, but it is used as a gentle rebuke. Jesus was saying that Mary should not cling to him, something she was apparently doing. Translate this clause in a way that implies a gentle rebuke. For example:

You^(sing/fem) should stop holding on to me.

You must not cling to me like this.

Jesus said: In the Greek text this is at the beginning of the verse and introduces a direct quotation, a command. If you begin a new paragraph here, it may be natural to make explicit that Jesus was speaking to Mary. Place this quote introducer where it is natural in your language. For example:

Jesus said to her, “Do not hold on to me” (NRSV)

20:17b

“for I have not yet ascended to the Father.

- because I have still not gone up to the Father.
- because I must still go up to my Father.

for I have not yet ascended to the Father: This clause indicates the reason why Mary should not keep clinging to Jesus. The reason is because Jesus had not yet ascended (gone up) to his Father in heaven. However, it is difficult to understand why that meant that Mary should not cling to him. It is especially difficult to understand because a week later Jesus told Thomas to touch him. However, Jesus does not explain his statement, so your translation does not need to explain it either. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because I have not yet gone back up to the Father (GNT)

because I have not yet gone up, going home to my Father

because I must go up to where my Father is

for: The Greek connector that the BSB translates as *for* here introduces a reason. It is the reason why Mary should not keep clinging to Jesus. He had not yet gone

back to his Father, and, it is implied, he had to go back. A few translations leave this word implied. For example:

Don’t hold on to me. I have not yet gone to the Father. (GW)

I have not yet ascended to the Father: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as *I have not yet ascended to the Father* refers to when Jesus would ascend (go up) to heaven. He had said that he would do this in 14:12, 28, 16:10. But at this time he had not done this. The Greek word that the BSB translates as *not yet* implies that this would happen in the future. In some languages it may be more natural to indicate this using a positive expression. For example:

I will soon ascend to the Father

the time is near/coming when I will go up to the Father

the time for me to ascend to my Father is still future

20:17c

But go and tell My brothers,

- Instead, go^(sing) to my brothers, my disciples, and give them this message. Say,
- And you^(sing) should go to my dear followers and tell them that

But go: This phrase indicates what Jesus wanted Mary to do instead of clinging to him. He gave her a new responsibility or mission. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Go instead (NIV)

and tell My brothers: This introduces a direct quotation inside the direct quotation of this whole verse. In some languages it is natural to avoid such a direct quotation inside another quotation by using an indirect quotation. See the General Comment on 20:17c–d for examples of how to translate in this way.

My brothers: The phrase *My brothers* refers to Jesus’ closest disciples, the 11 who remained after Judas left. In this context it does not refer to Jesus’ family members. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

my disciples (CEV)

20:17d

‘I am ascending to My Father and your Father, to My God and your God.’”

- ‘I will soon go up to my Father, who is your Father too. He is also my God, and your God too.’”
- I am going to my Father and God. He is the one who is also their Father and God.”

I am ascending to My Father and your Father, to My God and your God:

The Greek verb that the BSB translates as I am ascending is present tense, although here it has a future meaning. He would certainly ascend (go up) back to his Father in heaven. The process had already started because he was no longer in the tomb. And Jesus’ ascension (going up to heaven) was certain to happen. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

I am going to the one who is my Father and my God, as well as your Father and your God (CEV)

to My Father and your Father: This phrase indicates that Jesus’ Father was the Father of the disciples also, although in a different sense. Connect the phrases My Father and your Father in a way that indicates Jesus referred to one being, not two. For example:

to the One who is my Father and your Father

to my Father, yes, to your Father

to My God and your God: Jesus continued to speak of his heavenly Father, calling him both My God and your God. Consider how it is natural to refer to the divine being whom one worships. See how you translated the phrase My God in Matthew 27:26. It may be necessary to add a verb. For example:

the God whom I worship, who is also the God whom you worship

General Comment on 20:17d

The phrases “my Father,” “your Father,” “My God,” and “your God” all refer to the one divine being. It is important that this should be clear. For example:

I am returning to the One who is my Father and your Father, who is my God and your God.

Now because of Jesus dying for their sins, they are now sons of God. That means that God is their Father

and God, not just Jesus’ Father and God. Here are some ways to translate this idea:

He is now your Father and your God.

Now you also can think of him as your Father and your God.

General Comment on 20:17c–d

This sentence includes a direct quotation inside another quotation. In some languages it may be natural to avoid an inside quotation by using indirect speech instead. For example:

But go to my brothers. Tell them that I am ascending to my Father and their Father, to my God and their God.

But go to my brothers and tell them that I am returning to him who is my Father and their Father, my God and their God (GNT)

John 20:18**Section 20:11–18: Jesus appeared to Mary Magdalene**

This section tells how Mary Magdalene remained at the tomb after the two disciples left. She was crying and saw two angels inside the tomb. They asked her why she was crying and she said that someone had taken Jesus’ body. Then she turned around and saw Jesus, but she did not recognize him until he said her name. He told her not to hold him, but to go tell his disciples what she had seen, which she did.

Here are other possible section headings:

Mary Magdalene saw Jesus at the tomb

Jesus’ first resurrection appearance

Mary from Magdala was the first to see Jesus

Paragraph 20:17–18

Jesus told Mary to go and tell the disciples that she had seen him alive. She obeyed him.

20:18a

Mary Magdalene went and announced to the disciples, “I have seen the Lord!”

- Mary Magdalene went to the disciples and said to them, “I saw the Lord!”

- Mary Magdalene left and when she reached the disciples, she told them that she had seen the Lord, alive.

Mary Magdalene went and announced to the disciples: Mary went to where the disciples were, in Jerusalem. She gave them Jesus' message. For example:

Mary Magdalene went to the disciples with the news (NIV)

Mary from Magdala went to the disciples and told them (GW)

Mary Magdalene: See how you referred to Mary in 20:1. Refer back to her in a way that is natural in your language.

announced to the disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as announced means "informed" or "told." Mary Magdalene told the disciples something that they did not know. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and told them (GW)

and informed the disciples (NET)

and said to Jesus' disciples

Mary Magdalene went to the disciples with the news (NIV)

the disciples: The Greek word that the BSB translates as the disciples here refers to the group of Jesus' followers who were closest to him. There were 11 of them after Judas Iscariot left.

I have seen the Lord!: Mary implied that she had seen the Lord alive. She had not just seen his dead body. Check that your readers will understand this.

the Lord: Mary was speaking to fellow believers, other followers of Jesus. So in some languages it is more natural to say:

our^(incl) Lord

General Comment on 20:18a

This is a direct quotation. In some languages it is more natural to use an indirect quotation. For example:

So Mary Magdalene went and told the disciples that she had seen the Lord (GNT)

20:18b

And she told them what He had said to her.

- She also told them what he had said to her.
- She also gave them his message.

And she told them what He had said to her: Mary delivered Jesus' message about ascending to the Father. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

and she told them what Jesus had said to her (NCV)

Then she gave them his message. (NLT)

Then she also made-known to them what Jesus had told her. (Kankanaey Back Translation)

John 20:19

Section 20:19–23: Jesus appeared to the disciples

This section tells how Jesus showed himself to ten of the disciples that evening. The disciples were in a locked room when Jesus came to them. They were very happy to see him. He told them that he sent them as the Father sent him. Then he breathed on them and invited them to receive the Holy Spirit. He also told them that if they forgave anyone's sins, they would be forgiven.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus showed himself to the disciples

Jesus' appearance to the disciples

Jesus invited the disciples to receive the Holy Spirit

20:19a–c

It was the first day of the week, and that very evening, while the disciples were together with the doors locked for fear of the Jews: These clauses are background information, the setting for the next event. The event itself does not start until 20:19d. The Greek text indicates that this is background information by using participles. Some translations put this information in dependent clauses. Other translations use independent clauses here, but begin the event in 20:19d with a word like "Then" or "Suddenly." Indicate

that this information is background in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

On the evening of that day, the first day of the week, the disciples had gathered together and locked the doors of the place because they were afraid of the Jewish leaders. (NET)

On the evening of that day, the first day of the week, the doors being locked where the disciples were for fear of the Jews, Jesus came (ESV)

On the evening of that first day of the week, when the disciples were together, with the doors locked for fear of the Jewish leaders, Jesus came (NIV)

The disciples were afraid of the Jewish leaders, and on the evening of that same Sunday they locked themselves in a room. Suddenly, Jesus appeared (CEV)

20:19a

It was the first day of the week, and that very evening,

- ¶ In the evening of that same day, the first day of the week,
- ¶ Late in the day, that same Sunday,

It was the first day of the week, and that very evening: This time expression tells the time setting for the next event in the story. Here are other ways to translate this time expression:

On the evening of that first day of the week (NIV)

In the evening of that first day of the week (JBP)

Late that same day, the first day of the week

on the evening of that same Sunday (CEV)

the first day of the week: This phrase refers to Sunday. See the notes on 20:1a and how you translated this phrase there. For example:

that same Sunday (CEV)

That Sunday evening (GW)

that very evening: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as that very evening is more literally “late on that day.” It indicates that this next event took place the same day as the previous event. It was still the day that Jesus rose from the dead and appeared to Mary. Now it was the evening of that same day. This should be clear in your translation. For example:

that same day, the first day of the week (REB)

evening: This word refers to early evening soon after dark.

20:19b

while the disciples were together with the doors locked

- Jesus’ disciples were in a house together. They had locked the doors
- Jesus’ disciples met together, locking the doors
- Jesus’ followers had come together. They locked the doors with a bar

The Greek begins this clause with a conjunction that is usually translated “and.” It introduces another part of the background information, including the place setting. In some languages it may be natural to translate this conjunction. For example:

and the doors of the house where the disciples had met were locked (NRSV)

while the disciples were together with the doors

locked: The disciples were meeting in a house and had locked the doors. No one could enter the house unless the disciples let them in. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

the doors being locked where the disciples were (ESV)

when the disciples were together behind locked doors (REB)

In some languages it may be natural to translate this as one clause. For example:

the disciples were together behind locked doors (GW)

the disciples were together: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as the disciples were together is

more literally “where the disciples were.” The disciples were together in a certain room or house. For example:

where the disciples were (ESV)

when the disciples were together (NIV)

the disciples had gathered together and locked the doors of the place (NET)

the disciples: This phrase probably refers to Jesus’ closest disciples, the 12 except Judas Iscariot and Thomas. However, other disciples could have also been there, so do not include a number in your translation. See how you translated the word disciples in 18:1.

the doors: The BSB translates the Greek text literally as the doors. It does not mention a house or room. The doors could have included those of the gate, house, and room. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

the doors of the place (NET)

the doors of the house (NRSV)

behind locked doors (GNT)

locked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as locked indicates that the disciples shut and locked the doors. The disciples probably pushed a bar of wood or iron against the door. Then others could not enter unless the disciples first lifted or removed the bar. Translate this verb in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

firmly shut

locked with a bar

barred

This verb is passive. The disciples locked the doors, but the text emphasizes the condition of the doors and not the disciples’ action. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

with the doors locked (NIV)

the house was locked from the inside

- Use an active verb. For example:

the disciples had gathered together and locked the doors of the place (NET)

they locked themselves in a room (CEV)

Use the form that is most natural in your language in this context.

General Comment on 20:19b

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in this clause. Instead of “doors” being the subject, you may want to make “disciples” the subject. For example:

the disciples were together behind locked doors (GW)

the disciples had met together with the doors locked (JBP)

20:19c for fear of the Jews,

- because they were afraid of the Jewish authorities.
- because they feared the Jewish leaders.
- because they were afraid that the Jewish authorities would come and arrest them.

for fear of the Jews: This phrase gives the reason why the disciples had locked the doors. (The word for here means “because.”) It indicates that they were afraid of the Jewish authorities. These Jewish authorities had just handed Jesus over to the Romans so that they would crucify him. The doors were locked so that anyone who came to secretly watch the disciples or arrest them could not enter. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

because they were afraid of the Jewish leaders (NET)

because they were afraid that the Jewish authorities would arrest them

the Jews: The phrase the Jews here refers to the leaders of the Jews. For example:

the Jewish authorities (GNT)

the Jewish leaders (NIV)

the Jewish elders

General Comment on 20:19b–c

In some languages it may be natural to say first that the disciples were afraid and then tell the result. For example:

^{19c}The disciples were afraid of the Jewish leaders,
^{19b}and...they locked themselves in a room. (CEV)

^{19c}The disciples, being afraid of the Jewish authorities, ^{19b}locked the doors.

^{19c}Because of their fear of the Jewish authorities,
^{19b}the disciples locked the doors of the house where they had gathered.

20:19d

Jesus came and stood among them. “Peace be with you!” He said to them.

- Jesus came and stood in the middle of the group. He said, “May you^(plur) have/enjoy peace.”
- Then Jesus came and was standing there with them. He said to them, “I want peace to be yours!”^(plur)

Jesus came and stood among them: Although the doors were locked, Jesus entered the room. The text does not say how he did this, but the locked doors imply that Jesus entered in a miraculous way. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Then Jesus came and stood right in the middle of them (NCV)

Suddenly, Jesus was standing there among them! (NLT)

Jesus stood among them (GW)

among them: Jesus came and stood right with the disciples, in their presence, close to them. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

in the middle of the group (CEV)

Peace be with you!: This clause was the common greeting of a Jew to other Jews. However, here it is

Jesus, the source and prince of peace, who says it to his disciples, who were afraid. So he surely meant this expression to be more than a greeting. You should include the idea of peace in your translation. For example:

Peace to you!

May you live in peace.

May you have/know peace from God.

Peace: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Peace has a broad meaning that includes more than just the absence of fighting. It also involves positive mental and emotional welfare, and good relationships with God and others. See the notes and how you translated this word in 14:27a and 16:33a.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples who were there with Jesus.

He said to them: This phrase is short for “and said to the disciples.”

General Comment on 20:19a–d

In the Greek, 20:19a–d forms one long sentence. In some languages it may be natural to translate it as two or more shorter sentences, as the BSB does. Here are some other ways to break up this long sentence:

When it was evening on the first day of the week, the followers were together. The doors were locked, because they were afraid of the Jews. Then Jesus came and stood right in the middle of them and said, “Peace be with you.” (NCV)

That Sunday evening the disciples were meeting behind locked doors because they were afraid of the Jewish leaders. Suddenly, Jesus was standing there among them! “Peace be with you,” he said. (NLT)

John 20:20

Section 20:19–23: Jesus appeared to the disciples

This section tells how Jesus showed himself to ten of the disciples that evening. The disciples were in a locked room when Jesus came to them. They were very happy to see him. He told them that he sent them as the Father sent him. Then he breathed on them and invited them to receive the Holy Spirit. He also told

them that if they forgave anyone's sins, they would be forgiven.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus showed himself to the disciples

Jesus' appearance to the disciples

Jesus invited the disciples to receive the Holy Spirit

20:20a

After He had said this, He showed them His hands and His side.

- After saying this, he showed them the scars/wounds in his hands and his side.
- Then he showed them the nail marks on his wrist and the spear mark on his side.

After He had said this: This clause introduces what Jesus did after saying, "Peace be with you." Introduce this next action in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

After saying this (GNT)

Then (JBP)

Having said this

He showed them His hands and His side: This clause indicates that Jesus showed his disciples the places on his body where the soldiers had injured him. The soldiers had hammered nails through his wrists (the joints between the hands and arms) and into the cross. They had also pierced his side with a spear. Those actions had left some kind of wounds or scars (marks from wounds), perhaps holes or lines. By showing the disciples these scars, Jesus proved to them that he was truly the one who was crucified. He was the same person who had died on the cross. And he was not a ghost or spirit.

In some languages it may be helpful to make explicit the implied information that Jesus specifically showed them his scars. That would help make clear why Jesus showed them his hands and side. For example:

he showed them the wounds in his hands and side (NLT)

His hands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hands includes all the hand and wrist (the joint between the hand and arm). When Roman soldiers crucified someone, they hammered the nails through the wrist to hold the person to a cross. They did not hammer the nails through the hand because the nail would tear through the hand. Then the nail would not support the body. In your translation, you may want to use a word that includes the wrists, or refer to the wrists alone. For example:

his wrists

His side: Use the same expression that you used in 19:34.

20:20b

The disciples rejoiced when they saw the Lord.

- Jesus' disciples were full of joy to see the Lord.
- When Jesus' followers saw their Lord again/alive, they were extremely happy.

The Greek word that begins this verse is a conjunction that is often translated as "so" or "therefore." English translations do not translate it that way here, although the idea can be implied by "Then" in some translations. Other translations, like the BSB, leave the word implied.

The disciples rejoiced when they saw the Lord:

This sentence indicates that the disciples were happy when they saw Jesus. This was because they saw that he was no longer dead. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

The disciples were glad to see the Lord. (GW)

The disciples were filled with joy at seeing the Lord. (NJB)

Then the disciples were full of joy because they saw the Lord alive.

The disciples: See the note and how you translated this phrase in 20:19b.

rejoiced: It is good to use a strong word that can refer to suddenly experiencing great joy after great sorrow. For example:

were overjoyed (NIV)

were filled with joy (NLT)

when they saw the Lord: This clause is more literally “having seen the Lord” in Greek. It refers to the time that the disciples rejoiced, though it probably also indicates the reason that the disciples rejoiced. For example:

at seeing the Lord (GNT)

because they saw that he was the Lord

the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord can refer to a human master, an authority figure, or to God. Here it indicates that the disciples realized that Jesus was God. See how you translated this phrase in 20:2 and elsewhere, for example, 1:23, 6:23, and 11:2. In some languages it may be natural to add a possessive pronoun. For example:

their Lord

General Comment on 20:20b

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 20:20b. You may want to say first that the disciples saw the Lord and then tell their reaction. For example:

On seeing the Lord the disciples were overjoyed.
(REB)

When the disciples saw the Lord, they became very happy. (CEV)

John 20:21

Section 20:19–23: Jesus appeared to the disciples

This section tells how Jesus showed himself to ten of the disciples that evening. The disciples were in a locked room when Jesus came to them. They were very happy to see him. He told them that he sent them as the Father sent him. Then he breathed on them and invited them to receive the Holy Spirit. He also told them that if they forgave anyone’s sins, they would be forgiven.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus showed himself to the disciples

Jesus’ appearance to the disciples

Jesus invited the disciples to receive the Holy Spirit

20:21a

Again Jesus said to them, “Peace be with you.

- Jesus again said to them, “May you^(plur) have/enjoy peace.
- He greeted them again with the words “I want peace to be yours!^(plur)”

Again Jesus said to them: The Greek words that the BSB translates as Again Jesus said to them introduce something Jesus said a second time to his disciples. He again gave them a blessing of peace.

Peace be with you: Jesus again blessed them with peace. Translate this clause as you did in 20:19d. In some languages it may be natural to adjust the words to indicate that Jesus said this a second time. For example:

Yes, peace be with you! (JBP)

20:21b

As the Father has sent Me, so also I am sending you.”

- Just as my Father sent me into the world, I am sending you^(plur) into the world.”
- He then said, “I am sending you^(plur) as my messengers to the world just as God my Father, sent me.”

As the Father has sent Me, so also I am sending you:

This sentence compares the way that Jesus sent his disciples with the way that the Father had sent him. God had sent Jesus into the world, and now Jesus was sending his disciples into the world. As Jesus was God the Father’s representative in this world, so his disciples would be Jesus’ representatives in the world. See how you translated the similar sentence in 17:18. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

I am sending you, just as the Father has sent me.
(CEV)

Like my Father sent me here, I now send you.

the Father has sent Me: Jesus was referring to the fact that God had sent him to earth as his messenger and representative. If your language must include where a person sends someone, you may add “into the world” (see 17:18).

so also I am sending you: Jesus was telling his disciples something that he was doing then or possibly

would do before long in the future. Again, if your language must tell where a person sends someone, you may add “into the world.” Here is another way to translate this clause:

like that is how I am sending you

General Comment on 20:21b

The Greek words that the BSB translates as “sent” and “sending” are not the same verb. However, the basic meaning is the same, that of someone telling someone else to go somewhere. God sent Jesus into the world to speak his word and be his representative. And Jesus sent his disciples into the world to speak his word, the gospel, and to be his representatives.

John 20:22

Section 20:19–23: Jesus appeared to the disciples

This section tells how Jesus showed himself to ten of the disciples that evening. The disciples were in a locked room when Jesus came to them. They were very happy to see him. He told them that he sent them as the Father sent him. Then he breathed on them and invited them to receive the Holy Spirit. He also told them that if they forgave anyone’s sins, they would be forgiven.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus showed himself to the disciples

Jesus’ appearance to the disciples

Jesus invited the disciples to receive the Holy Spirit

20:22a

When He had said this, He breathed on them

- After saying that, Jesus breathed/blew on them
- Then Jesus breathed/blew on them

When He had said this, He breathed on them: These clauses indicate that Jesus breathed on the disciples. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as breathed is the same verb that is used in the Greek translation of Genesis 2:7. There it says that God created man, breathed the breath of life into his nose, and the man became a living being. Here Jesus breathed on the disciples in order to give them the Holy Spirit (see 20:22b). Jesus probably gave them the Holy Spirit here to provide what they needed for the mission that he was sending them to do. A few commentaries say that

this is John’s way of referring to what happened at Pentecost in Acts 2. However, many commentaries say that this is a different event. A few believe that this is only a symbol of what would happen at Pentecost. You should not indicate that this action is a symbol because the Greek text does not do that. It is good to use the same verb for breathed that you used in Genesis 2:7. Here are other ways to translate these clauses:

After he said this he breathed on them (NCV)

Then he breathed on them (GNT)

He breathed on them: Use the expression that is natural in your language for obviously blowing in someone’s direction. The Greek text does not include the words on them here, though the words “to them” in 20:22b (“and said to them”) could also connect to He breathed. All English translations that were looked at include the words “on them.” The Greek text does not say whether he breathed on them as individuals or as a group. It is good to leave this ambiguous. For example:

he blew on them

he blew on them with his breath

20:22b

and said, “Receive the Holy Spirit.

- and said, “Accept^(plur) the Holy Spirit.
- and said, “Take/Welcome^(plur) the Holy Spirit into your lives.

Receive the Holy Spirit: Jesus was inviting the disciples to receive God’s Holy Spirit into their life. His breathing on them showed them that he was giving them the Spirit. The text does not say whether they received the Holy Spirit then or later. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Accept the Holy Spirit into your life

Welcome the Holy Spirit coming to you

Receive: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Receive is often translated as “take.” Here it refers to receiving a person, as in 1:12. See how you translated this word there.

John 20:23

Section 20:19–23: Jesus appeared to the disciples

This section tells how Jesus showed himself to ten of the disciples that evening. The disciples were in a locked room when Jesus came to them. They were very happy to see him. He told them that he sent them as the Father sent him. Then he breathed on them and invited them to receive the Holy Spirit. He also told them that if they forgave anyone's sins, they would be forgiven.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus showed himself to the disciples

Jesus' appearance to the disciples

Jesus invited the disciples to receive the Holy Spirit

20:23a

If you forgive anyone his sins, they are forgiven;

- If you^(plur) forgive the wrongs that anyone has done, those wrongs have been forgiven.
- When you^(plur) forgive someone's sins, God has already forgiven those sins.

If you forgive anyone his sins: This clause expresses a condition that is possible. It was possible that the disciples would forgive the sins of someone. If this condition was fulfilled, those sins would be forgiven. Here are other ways of translating this clause:

If you forgive anyone's sins (NJB)

If you forgive people's sins (GNT)

Whenever you forgive sins (GW)

you forgive: The pronoun you is plural and refers to Jesus' disciples there with him. However, many commentaries say that this statement also applies to other Christians or Christian leaders. Still, Jesus was speaking to those people in the room with him. The verb forgive means to not punish someone for their sin. It means to remove someone's sins from their record and accept them as though they had not sinned.

Here some people understand Jesus to talk about their preaching the gospel of forgiveness. However, others believe that it refers to Jesus giving the disciples

the authority to forgive. Therefore, it is important to translate this idea literally so people can interpret it themselves. This is the only verse in John that refers to forgiveness. Refer to your translation of forgive in Matthew 6:12, 14, Mark 2:7, 10, and Luke 17:3, 4. See also KBT Forgive, Forgiveness. Many languages have idioms referring to the action of forgiving others. For example:

you remove/release

you pardon

you erase/wipe

sins: The Greek word that the BSB translates as sins here refers to evil actions. They are actions that people do when they disobey God. They are usually actions that harm other people. See how you translated this word in the singular in 9:41. Refer to your translation of Matthew 1:21 and Mark 2:5. See also KBT sins A.3. For example:

wrongdoing

evil deeds

they are forgiven: This clause is passive and implies God is the one who forgives the sins of these people. The pronoun they refers to the sins. The sins of these people are removed or pardoned. There are at least two ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

their sins are forgiven by God

they will be forgiven (CEV)

- Use an active verb. For example:

God will also forgive their sins (Yakan Back Translation)

they receive forgiveness for their sins

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language, and make explicit any pronoun that you need to. For example:

God has forgiven their sins

The sins of these people are forgiven by God.

The tense of the Greek verb that the BSB translates as they are forgiven emphasizes the continuing results of the action. God forgives the sins of these people and they remain or stay forgiven. He will not condemn or punish them for their sins at any time, in the present or the future. See how you translated this verb in the previous clause. Here are other ways to translate this verb:

God has removed/released their sins

those sins are pardoned

their sins are erased/wiped

God also forgives them, and they remain forgiven (TH)

20:23b

if you withhold forgiveness from anyone, it is withheld.”

- If you do not forgive the wrongs that anyone has done, those wrongs have not been forgiven.”
- When you do not forgive someone’s sins, God has already not forgiven those sins.”

if you withhold forgiveness from anyone: The Greek word that the BSB translates as withhold means “hold.” This clause tells a possibility that contrasts with that in 20:23a (“If you forgive the sins of any”). It suggests that the disciples may retain (hold or not forgive) the sins of some people. For example:

if you do not forgive them (NIV)

But if you don’t forgive their sins (CEV)

it is withheld: The clause that the BSB translates as it is withheld indicates that God will not forgive the sins of these people. It is a passive clause and the implied actor is God. He is the one who forgives or does not forgive sins. There are at least two ways to translate this expression:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

they will not be forgiven (CEV)

They are not forgiven (NIV)

They are not forgiven by God

- Use an active verb. For example:

God has not forgiven those sins

their sins remain

John 20:24

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus’ wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:24

Now Thomas called Didymus, one of the Twelve, was not with the disciples when Jesus came.

- ¶ One of the twelve disciples, Thomas the Twin, was not with the others when Jesus came to them.
- ¶ When Jesus came to his followers, one of them, Thomas, nicknamed the Twin, was not there.

Now: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as Now here introduces some background information. It is not a time word. The background information is that Thomas was not with the other disciples when Jesus went to them. This information explains why the disciples told Thomas that they had seen Jesus. Introduce the background information in this verse in a way that is natural in your language.

Thomas called Didymus: The Greek word that the BSB transliterates as Didymus means “twin.” This disciple had two names: Thomas and Didymus. The name Thomas comes from a Hebrew word meaning “twin,”

and Didymus is a Greek word meaning “twin.” See also the note at 11:16a and how you translated the same expression there. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

Thomas (called Didymus) (NIV)

Thomas the Twin (CEV)

Thomas (nicknamed the Twin) (NLT)

one of the Twelve: The word Twelve here refers to the twelve (12) closest disciples of Jesus. This number included Judas, who was no longer a follower of Jesus and may have already died. Thomas was one of the 12 disciples whom Jesus specially chose. See Mark 3:14–15. In many languages it is good to make explicit who the Twelve refers to. See the way that you translated “disciple” in 20:19, 20. For example:

one of the twelve disciples (CEV)

one of Jesus’ twelve chosen followers

was not with the disciples when Jesus came: On Easter evening, Thomas was not in the room with the other disciples. He did not see Jesus then. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

was not with the disciples when Jesus came (NIV)

was not present with the other disciples at the time when Jesus came to them

was absent the evening that Jesus appeared

General Comment on 20:24

This verse tells three things about Thomas. First, it tells his nickname, or an extra name that people sometimes called him. It also tells that he was one of the Twelve and that he was absent on Easter night when Jesus came. There are several ways to rearrange the information in this verse part. For example:

One of the Twelve, Thomas the Twin, was not with the rest when Jesus came. (REB)

Thomas, one of the twelve apostles, who was called Didymus, wasn’t with them when Jesus came. (GW)

On the day when Jesus appeared, Thomas (also called Twin), one of Jesus’ twelve disciples, was not with the other disciples.

John 20:25

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus’ wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:25a

So the other disciples told him, “We have seen the Lord!”

- Therefore, the other disciples told Thomas, “We^(excl) have seen the/our^(incl) Lord.”
- So when Jesus’ other followers met him again, they told him that they had seen the Lord Jesus alive.

So the other disciples told him: When Thomas met the other disciples, they told him about what had happened. In some languages it may be natural to indicate that Thomas had again met the other disciples. For example:

When they met him again, the other disciples said

So: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as So indicates a return to the main story after the background information in 20:24. It also introduces the result of 20:24, what happened because Thomas was not with the others when they saw Jesus. Some trans-

lations leave this conjunction implicit. Translate this conjunction in a way that is natural in your language.

told him: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as told implies a repeated action. The disciples told Thomas more than once what happened. You may want to make that explicit. For example:

kept on telling him (JBP)

We have seen the Lord!: This clause refers to what happened when Jesus appeared to the disciples in the evening after his resurrection (20:19). They may have said this clause to Thomas later that night, or a day or two later. So they were talking about something that happened recently, less than a week earlier.

This is direct speech. In some languages it may be more natural to translate this clause as indirect speech. For example:

The other disciples told Thomas that they had seen Jesus alive.

The disciples told Thomas that when he was away, they had seen the Lord.

We: This pronoun is exclusive and refers to all the disciples except Thomas (and Judas).

20:25b–d

Thomas said that in order to believe that Jesus was alive, he must see and touch him himself. He could not trust the witness of the other disciples and needed personal proof. Seeing and touching were his conditions for believing. There are several different ways of translating these conditions. For example:

If I do not see the marks of the nails in his hands...
I will not believe

Until I can see for myself the marks of the nails
in his hands,...I will not believe.

Only if I see the marks of the nails in his hands...
will I believe

But Thomas said, “First, I must see the nail scars
in his hands and touch them with my finger. I
must put my hand where the spear went into his
side. I won’t believe unless I do this!” (CEV)

20:25b

But he replied, “Unless I see the nail marks in His hands,

- But Thomas said, “I must see the nail marks in his wrists before I believe.
- But Thomas answered them, “I need proof. I must see myself where the nails were nailed into his wrists.

But he replied: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces an event that was not expected. Thomas’ response to the other disciples was negative and showed doubt. He did not just believe what they said.

Unless I see the nail marks in His hands: This clause is a conditional statement. Thomas told the others a condition that had to be fulfilled before he would believe them. Thomas wanted to see Jesus himself so that he would know that he was the same man that was crucified. If he saw the marks of the nails, he would know that he was really Jesus. There are several ways to express this condition. See the note on 20:25b–d above. For example:

If I do not see...

Until I see...

I must see...

the nail marks in His hands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as marks here refers to the visible damage that the nails did to Jesus’ hands/wrists. (Wrists are the joints between hands and arms.) When he was crucified, the soldiers put nails through his hands/wrists and the wounds were still visible. We do not know what these marks looked like in Jesus’ resurrected body. It is good to leave this as general as possible. For example:

the marks left by the nails on his hands

where the nails wounded his hands

the nail marks: The Greek noun that the BSB translates as marks is singular. However, there was one mark on each hand/wrist, so in some languages it may be natural to use a plural form like the BSB.

in His hands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hands includes the arms. Soldiers crucified people by nailing nails just above their wrists (the joints

between the hands and arms) into the cross. Nails through the hands could not support the weight of the body. See how you translated the word hands in 20:20. In your translation, you may want to use a word that includes the wrists, or refer to the wrists alone. For example:

in his hands/arms

in his wrists

20:25c

and put my finger where the nails have been, and put my hand into His side,

- I must also put my finger where the nails were and put my hand into his side.
- And my own finger must touch the nail holes, and my own hand must feel the spear wound in his side.

and put my finger where the nails have been, and put my hand into His side: This expression continues the conditions Thomas gave before he would believe in Jesus. You may be able to continue the sentence from 20:25b, or it may be natural to start a new sentence. For example:

and put my finger on those scars and my hand in his side (GNT)

And I must put my finger in the nail marks, and my hand in his side.

In some languages it may be natural to indicate two separate actions by using two verbs. For example:

and put my finger where the nails were, and put my hand into his side (NIV)

and put my finger in the nail marks, and place my hand into the wound in his side

put my finger where the nails have been: This phrase indicates that Thomas wanted to touch and feel with his finger the nail marks on Jesus' hands. That way he would know that they were real. For example:

touch/feel the mark with my finger

and put my hand into His side: This phrase indicates that Thomas also wanted to touch and feel the wound

in Jesus' side. The Greek text and the BSB repeat the verb put from the previous phrase: and put my hand into His side. It can be omitted in English, though in some languages it may be natural to repeat the verb. The wound in Jesus' side is the one that the soldier made when he pierced his side with a spear. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

feel with my own hand his side

touch with my hand the wound in his side

20:25d

I will never believe."

- If I do not see and touch him, I will not believe!"
- If not, I cannot believe that it is true."

I will never believe: The Greek text emphasizes the word never in this clause. In some languages it may be natural to add an object for the verb believe. Thomas refused to believe that Jesus was alive unless he saw and touched him. For example:

I will not believe it.

I will not believe that it was him.

I will not believe what you^(plur) say.

General Comment on 20:25b–d

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange 20:25b–d. You may want to put Thomas' conditions for believing at the end of the quotation. For example:

Thomas told them, "I refuse to believe this unless I see the nail marks in his hands, put my fingers into them, and put my hand into his side." (GW)

But Thomas said, "I will not believe it until I see the nail marks in his hands and put my finger where the nails were and put my hand into his side." (NCV)

John 20:26

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was

there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus' wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:26a

Eight days later, His disciples were once again inside with the doors locked, and Thomas was with them.

- After a week had passed, Jesus' disciples were in that house again. Thomas was there with them. Although they had locked the doors,
- The next Sunday Jesus' followers gathered in that house again. This time Thomas was present with them. They had locked the doors with a bar,

Eight days later, His disciples were once again inside: This clause indicates that the disciples were gathered in the same house where Jesus met them before. This does not mean that this was only the second time they were in the house. They probably gathered in that house every evening.

Eight days later: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as Eight days later is more literally "after eight days." It refers to the next Sunday, but Jews counted both Sundays, which amounted to eight days. See the note at 2:19b for another example of how the Jews counted days. Use the expression that is natural in your language to refer to the same day the next week.

with the doors locked: As in 20:19, the doors were shut/locked. Although John does not say why here, it was probably again because the disciples feared the Jewish leaders. The Greek and BSB do not use a connector here. But some English versions add a connector to indicate that it is surprising that Jesus was able to enter the room. For example:

Though the doors were locked (NIV)

The doors were locked, but Jesus came and stood among them (GNT)

doors locked: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as locked is the same as the verb translated "locked" in 20:19b. See the note there and translate the verb here the same way as you did there. For example:

were locked (NET)

they had locked the doors

and Thomas was with them: This time Thomas was present with the other disciples.

20:26b

Jesus came and stood among them

- Jesus came and stood among them.
- but Jesus came and was standing with them.

Jesus came and stood among them: Jesus entered the room. The text does not say how he did this, but it implies that he entered in a miraculous way. The Greek expression is the same as in 20:19.

20:26c

and said, "Peace be with you."

- He said, "May you^(plur) have/enjoy peace."
- He said to them, "I want peace to be yours!^(plur)"

Peace be with you: This clause was the standard greetings of a Jew to other Jews. See the note on the same greeting in 20:19d. Translate this clause the same way as you did in 20:19, 21.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the disciples in the room.

John 20:27

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus' wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:27a

Then Jesus said to Thomas, “Put your finger here and look at My hands.

- Then he told Thomas, “Place^(sing) your finger on me here. Look at my hands.
- Then he said to Thomas, “Touch^(sing) me here. And look, here are my hands.

Then Jesus said to Thomas: This expression indicates that although there were other disciples in the room, Jesus now just spoke to Thomas.

Put your finger here and look at My hands: This sentence indicates that Jesus invited Thomas to examine the nail marks by both feeling them and looking at them. The commands Put and look at are singular and are given to Thomas alone. A literal translation of this sentence may suggest that Jesus was inviting Thomas to see with his finger. To avoid this wrong meaning it may help to use two sentences or clauses with no conjunction. For example:

You^(sing) may put your^(sing) finger here. You^(sing) may look at my hands.

Touch me with your finger. See what my hands look like.

Put your finger here; see my hands. (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to mention first seeing the hands and then touching them. For example:

Look at my hands. Touch them.

Put your finger here: The context indicates that the word here refers to Jesus’ hands. Jesus was probably holding out his hands as he spoke. In some languages it may be necessary to make this explicit. For example:

Extending/Showing his hands, Jesus said, “Touch me...”

your finger: The pronoun your is singular and refers to Thomas. Jesus was speaking to Thomas only.

look at My hands: The Greek word that the BSB translates as hands refers to the whole hand and the wrist. See the note on 20:25b and how you translated the word there. Jesus was holding out his hands as his

spoke so that Thomas could see and touch them. For example:

look, here are my hands (NJB)

20:27b

Reach out your hand and put it into My side.

- Extend^(sing) your hand and place it into my side.
- Touch^(sing) the wound in my side.

Reach out your hand and put it into My side: Jesus was inviting Thomas to put his hand into the wound that the spear made in his side. He said that Thomas could touch and feel the evidence that he was the same man that the soldier had pierced. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

You may reach out your hand and touch the mark in my side.

Take your hand and stick it in my side. (The Message)

20:27c

Stop doubting and believe.”

- Do^(sing) not continue in your unbelief, but believe in me.”
- Stop^(sing) doubting and believe that I am risen/alive.”

Stop doubting and believe: The Greek command that the BSB translates as Stop doubting and believe is more literally “and do not be unbelieving but believing.” The command is again singular and Jesus gave it only to Thomas. The two ideas Stop doubting and believe mean the same thing. Repeating the idea emphasizes the command. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

Stop doubting and have faith! (CEV)

Don’t be faithless any longer. Believe! (NLT)

Stop doubting: The Greek command that the BSB translates as Stop doubting indicates that Thomas should stop doing what he was doing. He was doubting, but Jesus commanded him to stop. Indicate this in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Do not continue in your unbelief (NET)

Do not be unbelieving any more (NJB)

No more disbelief. (Common English Bible)

and: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as *and* here connects a negative statement (“Do not doubt”) to a positive statement (“believe”). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction “but” as in the NRSV.

Be unbelieving no longer, but believe. (REB)

- Use a conjunction other than “but.” For example:

Stop your doubting, and believe! (GNT)

Do not doubt but rather believe.

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

Don’t be uncertain. Believe! (Uma Back Translation)

Do not doubt any longer. Really believe now. (Yakan Back Translation)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

Believe and stop doubting!

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

believe: In some languages it may be natural to indicate who or what Thomas was to believe. Thomas was already a believer in Jesus, but he doubted that Jesus was alive again. Jesus wanted him to believe that it was really him and that he had risen from the dead. For example:

believe that I am alive

have faith that it is me

John 20:28

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus

showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus’ wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:28

Thomas replied, “My Lord and my God!”

- Thomas replied, “You are my Lord and my God!” (CEV)
- And Thomas said to him, “You^(sing) are my Lord and my God!”

Thomas replied, “My Lord and my God!”: This sentence indicates that Thomas stopped doubting and believed that Jesus was both his Lord and his God. Here are other ways to translate this verse:

Tomas said, “You^(sing) are my Lord and my God.” (Kankanaey Back Translation)

Tomas replied like this, “You are my Lord and you are my God.” (Yakan Back Translation)

My Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as *Lord* means “master” or “one who has authority over others.” The Jews also used this same title to refer to God. Here Thomas declared that Jesus was his master and God. See the note at 20:13b, where Mary Magdalene calls Jesus “my Lord,” and see how you translated the phrase there. For example:

my Master

the one I obey/serve

my God: This phrase is a way to address the God whom one believes in, serves, and worships. Thomas was saying that Jesus was the God of Israel. See how you translated this phrase in 20:17.

In some languages it may be natural to use a verb to express this idea. For example:

the God whom I worship

John 20:29

Section 20:24–29: Jesus appeared to Thomas

Thomas was not in the room when Jesus showed himself to the other disciples. He did not believe the other disciples when they said that Jesus rose from the dead. He wanted to see himself. A week later Jesus showed himself to his disciples again and Thomas was there. He told Thomas to touch the wounds on his body. That way he would know that it was Jesus and believe that he had risen from the dead. When Thomas saw Jesus' wounds, he realized that he was his Lord and his God.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus invited Thomas to touch his wounds

Thomas saw Jesus and believed

Thomas saw Jesus and realized that he was God

20:29a

Jesus said to him, “Because you have seen Me, you have believed;

- Jesus said, “Because you^(sing) have seen me you believe.
- Then Jesus said to him, “So, you^(sing) have seen me and believed because of that.

Jesus said to him: This phrase introduces what Jesus replied to Thomas. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Then Jesus told him (NCV)

Because you have seen Me, you have believed: The earliest Greek manuscripts did not have punctuation, so there was no question mark here. There are two ways to interpret this sentence:

1. It is a statement, not a question. For example:

You believe because you see me. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, REB, NJB, KJV, GW, NLT, NCV)

1. It is a rhetorical question, expecting the answer “yes.” For example:

Do you believe because you see me? (GNT) (GNT, NET, NASB, CEV, RSV, NRSV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and many English translations and Bible scholars. However, the meaning of the two interpretations is nearly the same. So you may want to follow interpretation (2) if a major language translation in your area follows it.

There may be a stronger rebuke in a rhetorical question than in a statement. Either way, the rebuke here is gentle at most. The rebuke is that Thomas should have believed what the other disciples said and not only when he saw Jesus. Yet the next verse speaks about the importance of the disciples seeing Jesus' signs. But people in the future would have to believe without seeing, and they are blessed in 20:29b.

General Comment on 20:29a

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 20:29a. For example:

Then Jesus told him, “Because you have seen me, you have believed...” (NIV)

20:29b

blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed.”

- Blessed are those people who have not seen me alive and yet believe in me.”
- But great is the joy of those who believe in me without seeing me!”

blessed are those who have not seen and yet have believed: This sentence probably implies that those who believe in Jesus without seeing him are more blessed than Thomas (see 4:48). He did not mean that Thomas himself was not blessed. It is important to avoid this wrong meaning. To do this you may want to use a comparative. For example:

Even more blessed are those who have not seen me and yet have believed in me.

See the General Comment on 20:30a for ways to rearrange the information in this clause.

blessed are: The Greek word that the BSB translates as blessed here refers to being in a good situation, enjoying God's favor. When God does something good to a person and is kind to him, that person is blessed. See how you translated this word in 13:17, Matthew 5:3-11, and Luke 6:20-22. For example:

Great is the joy of those...

those who have not seen and yet have believed:

This expression refers to people who trust Jesus without ever seeing him during this life. It includes everyone who would believe in him after he returned to heaven. In some languages it may be necessary to add an object, indicating that Jesus was referring to people seeing him. For example:

those who believe without seeing me (GNT)

and yet: The BSB has added the word yet in order to indicate that what follows is not expected. People expect that if someone does not see, he will not believe. But Jesus spoke about those who would believe in him although they did not see him. You may also want to indicate that this is not expected. For example:

Blessed are those who haven't seen me but believe. (GW)

have believed: The Greek verb form that the BSB translates as have believed can refer to beginning to believe. Some translations make that meaning explicit. However, the verb can also refer to believing in general. Because Jesus is making a general statement, it may be more natural to use a general form of the verb.

When the word believed is used without an object, it is usually a short way of saying “believe in Jesus.” So this word includes the idea of believing the facts about Jesus (here that he rose from the dead). But it also includes the idea of trusting Jesus instead of trusting oneself or someone else. Both ideas are very closely related. If someone believes the facts about Jesus, it should result in trusting him. Here are other ways to translate this idea:

have faith in me (CEV)

believed in me

General Comment on 20:29b

In some languages it may be more natural to rearrange the information in this sentence. For example:

How happy are those who believe without seeing me! (GNT)

The people who have faith in me without seeing me are the ones who are really blessed! (CEV)

But they will be full of joy who believe even though they have not seen me.

John 20:30**Section 20:30–31: John wrote this book so that people would believe and have life**

The author explained that he wrote about Jesus' signs so that people would believe that he was God's promised Savior. That way they would have life from him. This is the first conclusion of the gospel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Why John wrote his book

John wrote this book so that people would believe

The purpose of this book

20:30a**Jesus performed many other signs in the presence of His disciples,**

- ¶ Jesus also did many other miracles while his disciples were there watching.
- ¶ We followers also saw Jesus do many miracles

The Greek begins this verse with a conjunction that some versions translate as “Now.” Here it introduces the first conclusion to the book of John. The author told his purpose in writing this gospel. Introduce this purpose of the gospel in a way that is natural in your language.

Jesus performed many other signs in the presence of His disciples: This clause indicates that Jesus' disciples saw him do many other signs. See the General Comment on 20:30a for ways to rearrange the information in this clause. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus did many other miracles in the presence of his followers. (NCV)

Many are the amazing signs that Jesus showed to his disciples (Kankanaey Back Translation)

many other signs: In this context the word other means “besides the ones described in this book.” The author only wrote about a few of Jesus' miraculous signs.

signs: The Greek word that the BSB translates as signs refers to the healings and other miracles that Jesus

did. These signs proved that he was the Messiah from God. See how you translated this word in 2:11, 23. For example:

miraculous signs (NIV)

miracles (CEV)

in the presence of His disciples: This phrase indicates that Jesus' disciples saw him do many miracles. They were there with him. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

when his disciples were present

while his followers were watching

His disciples: There is a textual issue here. Some Greek manuscripts have His disciples, and some Greek manuscripts have "the disciples." The original text is uncertain. The UBS Greek text includes the word "his" in square brackets, giving it a C rating, indicating much uncertainty. Both expressions refer to the same group of people. So it is recommended that you use whichever is more natural in your language. See how you translated disciples in 20:10, 19.

General Comment on 20:30a

In some languages it may be natural to rearrange the information in 20:30a. You may want to mention the disciples at the beginning of the sentence. For example:

In his disciples' presence Jesus performed many other miracles. (GNT)

The disciples saw Jesus do many other miraculous signs. (NLT)

20:30b

which are not written in this book.

- Those miracles are not recorded/reported in this book.
- that I did not write/include in this book.

which are not written in this book: Many of the miracles Jesus did were not written in this book, which refers to the Gospel of John. The verb phrase are not written is passive. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

which are not recorded in this book (NIV)

in addition to the ones recorded in this book (NLT)

- Use an active verb. For example:

besides the ones I wrote about in this book

signs/miracles that this book does not record/report

this book: This phrase refers to the Gospel of John. It does not refer to the whole Bible or New Testament. Some of the other miracles that Jesus did are in fact recorded in the other gospels (Matthew, Mark, and Luke). It may help to make this clearer. For example:

this gospel

General Comment on 20:30a–b

The author divided Jesus' sign miracles into two groups:

- 1) those that he recorded in this gospel
- 2) other signs, those that he did not record

All the "other signs" (not just "many" of them) "are not written in this book." After translating 20:30, check that the meaning is correct and will be understood by your readers. For example:

Jesus' followers also saw him doing many signs that are not recorded in this book.

The disciples saw Jesus do many other miraculous signs in addition to the ones recorded in this book. (NLT)

Jesus did many other miracles when his disciples were present. They are not included in this book.

John 20:31

Section 20:30–31: John wrote this book so that people would believe and have life

The author explained that he wrote about Jesus' signs so that people would believe that he was God's promised Savior. That way they would have life from him. This is the first conclusion of the gospel.

Here are other possible section headings:

Why John wrote his book

John wrote this book so that people would believe

The purpose of this book

20:31a

But these are written so that you may believe

- But these miracles/signs have been recorded/reported so that you^(plur) might believe
- But these miracles I wrote/included. Yes, because I want you^(plur) to believe

But: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as But here introduces a contrast. The contrast is between the many signs that the author did not record and the ones that he did record. He recorded certain signs so people would believe in Jesus.

these are written: This is a passive clause. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

But these have been written (GNT)

- Use an active verb. You can use a first person pronoun for the subject. For example:

But I have written these things

these: This pronoun refers to the signs or miracles that John did write about in the Gospel of John. These include the miracles that Jesus did, but also (perhaps especially) his resurrection. The Greek text emphasizes this pronoun. For example:

these miracles (GW)

But these however, they have been written
(Kankanaey Back Translation)

so that: The Greek word that the BSB translates as so that introduces a purpose. The purpose explains why the author John included certain signs in his gospel. Introduce this purpose in a way that is natural in your language.

you may believe: This clause tells the purpose for John including the signs that he wrote about. He wanted them to believe something. The Greek word that the BSB translates as you may believe probably refers to beginning to believe something. There is a

textual issue here, with different manuscripts using two different forms of the word “believe.” Some commentaries say that the form in some manuscripts suggests a meaning of “keep believing.” However, it is difficult to know which word form is original. Also, some commentaries say that John uses both forms to mean both “start to believe” and “keep believing.” (Some translations indicate this by using the English phrase “come to believe,” which means “begin to believe.”) Some of John’s readers did not believe that Jesus was the Messiah or the Son of God. John wanted them to begin believing this. However, most important English translations just say something like you may believe. For example:

you will believe (GW)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all the readers or listeners of this book.

20:31b

that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God,

- that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God.
- that Jesus is the Christ, the anointed one, and the son of God.

that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God: This clause indicates that the author wanted his readers to believe that Jesus was the Messiah. The Messiah was the one that God had promised to send to save his people. He was the one they could truly call both Christ and the Son of God. These titles accurately indicated who Jesus was, his true identity.

Through all the history of the Jewish people, God had promised to send one who would save them, their Messiah. Now that promised Savior had come. He showed that he was that promised Savior, the Messiah, by rising from the dead. The people of God could believe that Jesus was the Christ and the Son of God. They could believe that because the signs that he gave showed that this was who he truly was.

The expression that the BSB translates as the Christ, the Son of God, indicates that here the Son of God is a title for the Messiah. However, the expression the Son of God is also much more than a title for the Messiah. In 5:25, Jesus used the term “Son of God” to refer to himself. (In other verses in 5:19–26 he just used “Son” with the same meaning.) He used that term to indicate that he had the same nature as God and shared God’s authority. John wanted his readers to believe that Jesus was the Christ. Much more than that, he wanted them to believe that Jesus shared

God's very nature as his Son. See 11:27, where Martha also called Jesus the Christ and the Son of God.

the Christ: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as the Christ is the Greek translation of the Hebrew word "Messiah," which means "anointed one." In Old Testament times, kings and priests were anointed with oil, meaning that a religious leader poured oil on their heads. This showed that God had chosen and appointed them as leaders. See how you translated the Christ in 1:20b and 1:41b and see the notes there. In some languages it may be natural to use the Hebrew form. For example:

the Messiah (NRSV)

the Son of God: This phrase is a title for Jesus. This title indicates that Jesus has the same nature and character as God. It also indicates that the relationship between God the Father and Jesus, his Son, is similar in some way to the relationship between human fathers and sons. God the Father does not have a physical body. He did not have a sexual relationship that resulted in Mary becoming pregnant and giving birth to Jesus.

See how you translated the phrase the Son of God in 1:34, and see the note there.

General Comment on 20:30b–20:31a

Here there is a contrast between the miracles that the author recorded and those that he did not record. It is good to make that contrast clear in your translation. For example:

Those miracles...these miracles... (GW)

20:31c

and that by believing you may have life in His name.

- And so that believing will enable you^(plur) to have true/eternal life through him.
- And because I want that when you^(plur) believe, he will cause you to receive true life in him.
- I also want you^(plur) to truly live because you are united with him through believing.

and that by believing you may have life in His name:

This clause indicates John's second purpose in recording the miracles in his gospel. He wanted people who read them to receive true life as they believed in Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and that believing this you may have life through his name (NJB)

Then, by believing, you may have life through his name. (NCV)

and that: The word that means "in order that" or "so that." Here it introduces the second reason that John recorded Jesus' miracle signs in his gospel.

by believing: The Greek word that the BSB translates as by believing is the participle "believing." It refers to believing that Jesus is the Messiah and the Son of God. That should result in trusting in Jesus. Connect the word believing to the word "believe" in 20:31a by using a form of the same word if possible. In some languages you may need to add an object. For example:

believing this (NJB)

as you believe this/him

you may have life: The word life here refers to real life, life with God. See 1:4, 5:21, 24–26, 39, 40, 6:33–35. In some languages it may be natural to a verb instead of the noun life. For example:

you may truly live

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to all of the readers and listeners of this book.

life: This word refers to the new spiritual life that God gives us when we believe in Jesus. It is the same life as "eternal life" in 3:15. See the note there. Here are other ways to translate this word:

true life (CEV)

the new life (Otomi Back Translation)

in His name: This phrase indicates that it is in Jesus himself that we receive life. At that time, the word name represented the whole person, his character, nature, and authority. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

through his name (NCV)

in him (GNT)

because you are united with him

There are two ways to understand what the phrase in His name connects with:

1. It connects with “you may have life.” It means that the life is in Jesus’ name. For example:

Then, by believing, you may have life through his name. (NCV) (BSB, NIV, NRSV, RSV, ESV, KJV, NCV, NASB, NET, NJB, REB)

1. It connects with “believing.” It means that by believing in Jesus’ name that they will have life. For example:

and so that you will have life by believing in him (GW) (NLT, GW, CEV, GNT)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). It is followed by most important English translations and also has the support of many commentaries. It is true that believing in Jesus’ name gives life, but that is probably not what John is saying here.

John 21:1

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:1–3

After Jesus’ resurrection, seven of Jesus’ followers met by the Sea of Tiberias (also called the Sea of Galilee). They decided to go fishing together, but they caught nothing.

21:1a–b

This is a summary statement introducing the next story. See the General Comment on ways to combine 21:1a and b.

21:1a

Later, by the Sea of Tiberias, Jesus again revealed Himself to the disciples.

- ¶ Another time Jesus appeared to his disciples, this time beside Lake Tiberias.
- ¶ A little later Jesus again came to his disciples and let them see him. He was beside Tiberias Lake,

Later, by the Sea of Tiberias, Jesus again revealed Himself to the disciples:

This clause introduces the final events in the gospel and indicates where they happened.

Later: This phrase refers to a time after Jesus appeared to Thomas and the other disciples in Jerusalem, as described in 20:19–29. It may have been a week or two later. We do not know exactly how much later it was. Acts 1:3 indicates that the total length of the time Jesus spent on earth after rising from the dead was forty days. Use a general expression that can refer to a few days or a couple of weeks. For example:

Some time later (REB)

Days later

by the Sea of Tiberias: The Sea of Tiberias was the Roman name for the lake that the Jews called Sea of Galilee or Lake Galilee. It was a freshwater (not salty) lake. See the note and how you translated this name in 6:1, where both terms are used. If this lake is known as Lake Galilee in your community, you may want to use that term here. For example:

at Lake Galilee (NCV)

Lake Tiberias (GNT)

If you do that, you will probably want to include a footnote. For example:

The Greek text uses the name “Sea of Tiberias” to refer to the same lake.

Jesus again revealed Himself to the disciples: This clause indicates that Jesus came to some of his followers and allowed them to see him. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as revealed Himself also

appears in 7:4. See how you translated the word there. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus appeared once more to his disciples (GNT)

Jesus again caused/allowed his followers to see him

again: Jesus showed himself to the disciples twice previously, both times in the room in Jerusalem (20:19–29). This time, he showed himself to the disciples while they were by the sea or lake called Tiberias. This was the first time that Jesus met the disciples there after his resurrection. To avoid the wrong meaning that Jesus appeared there before, you can mention the Sea of Tiberias separately. For example:

Jesus showed himself to his followers again—this time at Lake Galilee. (NCV)

Jesus revealed himself again to the disciples. It was by the Sea of Tiberias.... (NJB)

the disciples: This phrase refers to seven of Jesus' 12 closest disciples. The Greek word that the BSB translates as disciples means “learners” who are in a special relationship with a teacher. The learners committed themselves to their teacher in order to learn from him and follow his teaching and example. Disciples often lived with their teacher and followed him wherever he went. See how you translated this word in 20:2. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

his disciples (NIV)

his followers (NCV)

21:1b

He made Himself known in this way:

- This is how he appeared.
- and this is what happened.

He made Himself known in this way: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as He made Himself known in this way uses the same verb as in 21:1a. Here is another way to translate this clause:

He appeared in this way

This clause introduces the next event in the story. In some languages it may be more natural to use a

different verb rather than repeating the verb from 21:1. For example:

it happened like this: (NJB)

Now this is how he did so. (NET)

General Comment on 21:1

In some languages it may be natural to combine 21:1a–b. For example:

Jesus later appeared to his disciples along the shore of Lake Tiberias. (CEV)

John 21:2

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:1–3

After Jesus' resurrection, seven of Jesus' followers met by the Sea of Tiberias (also called the Sea of Galilee). They decided to go fishing together, but they caught nothing.

21:2

Simon Peter, Thomas called Didymus, Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples were together.

- Several/Some of the disciples were together: Simon Peter, Thomas (called the Twin), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the two sons of Zebedee, and two others.

- Simon Peter, Thomas (nicknamed the Twin), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee James and John, and two other followers of Jesus were all together.

Simon Peter, Thomas called Didymus, Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples were together: This list introduces the disciples who will be in the next events. In some languages it may be natural to introduce the list by indicating that these men were all disciples. For example:

Several of the disciples were there—Simon Peter, Thomas (nicknamed the Twin), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples. (NLT)

Some disciples gathered there. They were Simon Peter, Thomas (also called the Twin), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two others.

In other languages it may be natural for the names to precede the verb phrase: For example:

Simon Peter, Thomas (called the Twin), Nathanael (the one from Cana in Galilee), the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples of Jesus were all together. (GNT)

Simon Peter: Simon Peter was the full name of the disciple who is often referred to as just Peter. See how you translated this name in 1:40 and 6:68. Simon Peter is the most important disciple in the next events. So it may be natural to emphasize his name by making him the subject of the sentence. For example:

Simon Peter was with Thomas the Twin, Nathanael from Cana-in-Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples. (REB)

Thomas called Didymus: The name Didymus was a Greek transliteration of the Jewish name of Thomas. He was probably called that because he was a twin, which is what the word means. See how you translated this phrase in 11:16 and 20:24.

Nathanael from Cana in Galilee: The disciple Nathanael came from the village of Cana in the province of Galilee. See the note on John 2:1, where this village is first mentioned. Nathanael is also mentioned in 1:45–51. He was possibly the same man as

the disciple named Bartholomew (Matthew 10:3), but this is not certain.

the sons of Zebedee: The phrase the sons of Zebedee refers to the two brothers James and John. See how you translated this phrase in Matthew 10:35 and Luke 5:10.

disciples: See the note and how you translated this term in 21:1a.

were together: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates literally as were together indicates that a group of Jesus' followers had come to the same place, probably meeting to discuss what had happened. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

Some of the followers were together (NCV)

Several of the disciples were there (NLT)

Present there together were...

John 21:3

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:1–3

After Jesus' resurrection, seven of Jesus' followers met by the Sea of Tiberias (also called the Sea of Galilee). They decided to go fishing together, but they caught nothing.

21:3a

Simon Peter told them, "I am going fishing."

- Simon Peter said to the others, “I am going out fishing.”
- “I am going out on the lake to catch some fish,” Simon Peter told the other disciples.

Simon Peter told them, “I am going fishing.”: Peter told the other disciples that he was leaving to catch fish from his boat. This was the job of at least several of them before they began to follow Jesus. See Mark 1:16–20.

Simon Peter told them: The pronoun them here refers to the other six disciples who were present. Refer back to the people who were introduced in 21:2 in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

Simon Peter said to the others (GNT)

Simon Peter said to the other men/disciples

In some languages it may be natural to leave implied the people to whom Simon spoke. For example:

Simon Peter said (NCV)

I am going fishing: This clause indicates that Peter would soon leave to go out onto the lake to catch fish with a net. The verb tense refers to something he was planning to do very soon. Use the verb tense that is suitable in your language. For example:

I am going out to fish. (NCV)

I am going to the lake/sea to fish.

I will now go fishing.

fishing: Peter and the other disciples planned to throw a net into the water from their boat. They did that to trap fish in the net. Refer to this method of catching fish in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

trap/catch fish in the net

21:3b

“We will go with you,” they said.

- The other disciples said, “We^(excl) will go and fish with you^(sing).”
- “We^(excl) will come too and help you^(sing) to catch fish,” they replied.

We will go with you: This clause indicates that the other six disciples wanted to go with Peter and help him fish. The Greek text emphasizes the pronoun We. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We will come with you. (GNT)

We^(excl) will come too.

Let us^(incl) all go together.

they said: This expression introduces the reply of the other six disciples to Peter and in Greek occurs before their reply.

21:3c

So they went out and got into the boat,

- So they left where they were, got into a boat, and started fishing,
- They went to the lake and climbed into their fishing boat.

So they went out and got into the boat: There are at least two ways to interpret this clause:

(1) It indicates that the disciples left the place where they were and went toward the lake and their boat. For example, see the BSB.

(BSB, NIV, KJV, NASB, RSV, NRSV, NCV, ESV, NJB, REB, NET)

(2) It indicates that the disciples went out in their boats onto the lake. For example:

so they went out in a boat (GNT) (GNT, GW, NLT, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) with most English translations and the natural reading of the Greek text.

So they went out: Following the interpretation in the above note, this expression indicates that the disciples left the place where they were. They had perhaps been in someone’s home by the lake, or in a hut there. Now they began to go to the lake to fish. Use the expression that is natural in your language for beginning a short journey. For example:

They set out

They started to go

and got into the boat: The disciples got into their fishing boat. Use the expression that is natural in your language for entering such a boat.

the boat: This phrase refers to a boat large enough to hold seven disciples and their fishing equipment.

21:3d

but caught nothing that night.

- but caught no fish all night.
- However, although they fished all night, they did not catch even one fish.

but caught nothing that night: This clause indicates that although the disciples fished all night, they did not catch any fish. The information that they began fishing and fished all night is implied but not explicitly stated. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit. For example:

They fished that night but caught nothing. (NCV)

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

but they caught nothing all night (NLT)

and during the night caught nothing at all (JBP)

They tried to catch fish in their net , but they caught no fish that night

John 21:4

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:4–6

A man on the shore told the disciples how they could catch some fish. They realized that it was Jesus, and Peter jumped into the water and swam to shore.

21:4a

Early in the morning, Jesus stood on the shore,

- ¶ As it was getting light, Jesus was standing on the shore.
- ¶ Morning/Dawn came/arrived, and the disciples saw someone standing at the edge of the water. It was Jesus,

Early in the morning: This phrase refers to the early morning immediately after daybreak (sunrise). There was enough light for the disciples to see the shore. Use an expression that is natural in your language. For example:

As the sun was rising (GW)

At dawn (NLT)

Early the next morning (CEV)

Jesus stood on the shore: Jesus was standing near the water. The text does not say whether he had been there some time or whether he only arrived at sunrise. But the light of the sun enabled the disciples to see him. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

there stood Jesus on the shore (NJB)

Jesus was standing on the beach (NLT)

on the shore: This phrase here refers to the shore, the land at the edge of the Sea of Galilee. It may not have been a wide sandy area. For example:

on the shore of the lake (TH)

at the water's edge (GNT)

21:4b

but the disciples did not recognize that it was Jesus.

- The disciples did not realize who he was.
- but they did not recognize him.

but the disciples did not recognize that it was Jesus: The disciples did not recognize that it was Jesus standing on the beach. Perhaps it was difficult

to see in the early morning light, or perhaps he looked different in some way. Compare 20:14-15 and Luke 24:15-16. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

but the disciples did not realize who he was (CEV)

although the disciples had no idea that it was Jesus (JBP)

General Comment on 21:4a-b

In some languages it may be natural to translate 21:4a from the disciples' view from the boat. You would indicate only that someone, or a man, was standing on the beach. The information that this was in fact Jesus may be translated as a separate clause. For example:

^{4a}Just after daybreak the disciples saw someone standing on the beach. It was Jesus, ^{4b}but they did not recognize him.

John 21:5

Section 21:1-14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:4-6

A man on the shore told the disciples how they could catch some fish. They realized that it was Jesus, and Peter jumped into the water and swam to shore.

21:5a

So He called out to them, "Children, do you have any fish?"

- Jesus said to them, "Boys/Fellows, did you^(plur) not get any fish?"
- He asked them, "Friends, is it right that you^(plur) did not catch any fish?"

So: The Greek text includes a word that is often translated 'Therefore' and the BSB translates as So. Most English translations leave this word untranslated. If it is more natural in your language to include a connector here, you may do so. For example:

Then he asked them (GNT)

He called out to them: The pronoun them is plural and refers to the seven disciples who went fishing.

Children: This form of address was a friendly way of beginning a conversation with young men. A literal translation may give the wrong impression that the disciples were very young. We do not know their ages, but they were probably all young adults. (Simon Peter at least was married.) Use a form of address that would be natural in addressing young men in a friendly manner. For example:

Young men (GNT)

Boys

Fellows/Guys

friends (NJB)

do you have any fish?: This is a real question that expects an answer. The form of the Greek question implies that Jesus expected the answer, "We have no fish." Translate this question in a way that shows that Jesus expected that they did not catch any fish. For example:

Did you not catch any fish?

No fish today?

fish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fish is more literally "something to eat." The context makes it clear that it refers to fish that the disciples were trying to catch. Use the expression that is natural in your language. For example:

have you not caught anything?

21:5b**“No,” they answered.**

- They answered him, “We^(excl) did not get any.”
- “That is right. We did not catch anything,” they answered.

“No,” they answered: The word No answered Jesus’ question in the way that the question expected. The disciples had not caught any fish. For example:

None at all.

We caught none.

Not a single fish.

John 21:6**Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee**

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:4–6

A man on the shore told the disciples how they could catch some fish. They realized that it was Jesus, and Peter jumped into the water and swam to shore.

21:6a**He told them, “Cast the net on the right side of the boat, and you will find some.”**

- He said to them, “Throw^(plur) your net out on the lake on the right side of the boat. Then you will catch some fish.”

- Jesus said, “You^(plur) will get some fish if you put/ lower your net into the water on the right side of the boat.”

Cast the net on the right side of the boat: The command Cast the net means to throw one side of the net out into the water. The fishermen then held onto the other side. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Let your net down on the right side of your boat.
(CEV)

Throw your net out on the right side of the boat.
(GNT)

on the right side of the boat: This phrase means “into the water on the right side of the boat.”

and you will find some: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as you will find some here means that the disciples would catch some fish. The BSB has supplied the object some, which is implied in the Greek. Supply the object that is natural in your language. For example:

and you’ll get some (NLT)

and you will catch some fish (CEV)

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the seven disciples who were in the boat.

21:6b**So they cast it there,**

- So they threw their nets on the right side.
- They did so,

So they cast it there: This clause indicates that the disciples threw their net into the water on the right side of the boat. Refer back to the action Jesus commanded in 21:6a in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

So they threw the net out (GNT)

So they did (NLT)

21:6c**and they were unable to haul it in because of the great number of fish.**

- When they did that, there were so many fish that they could not lift the net into the boat.

- and the net became so full of fish that it was too heavy to lift out of the water.

and they were unable to haul it in: This clause is more literally “and they were no longer strong enough to pull it.” The disciples could not haul (pull) the net into the boat because it was now too heavy. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and were unable to pull it in (GW)

and could not pull it back in (GNT)

This clause is the most important clause of the story about the miracle. Suggest this in a way that is natural. For example:

and found they could not haul the net on board (REB)

and they could not manage to lift the net into the boat

because of the great number of fish: The Greek word that the BSB translates as because here introduces the reason why the disciples could not pull the net into the boat. There were very many fish caught in the net, so it was too heavy to pull into the boat. Here is another way to translate this clause:

because of the large number of fish (NIV)

In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that the fish were in the net. For example:

because of all the fish in it

because they had caught so many fish (GNT)

because it was so full of fish (JBP)

General Comment on 21:6c

In some languages it may be natural to tell the cause before the result in 21:6c. For example:

and the net was so full of fish that they could not drag it up into the boat (CEV)

and they caught so many fish they could not pull the net back into the boat (NCV)

John 21:7

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:7–8

The disciples realized that the figure on the shore was Jesus, and they returned to land. Peter jumped into the water and swam to shore ahead of the others.

21:7a

Then the disciple whom Jesus loved said to Peter, “It is the Lord!”

- ¶ Then Jesus’ good/dear friend said to Peter, “He must be the Lord!”
- ¶ The follower of Jesus who was dear to him exclaimed to Peter, “That man is certainly our^(incl) Lord!”

Then the disciple whom Jesus loved: This phrase probably refers to the author John himself. See how you translated this phrase in 13:23 and 19:26. For example:

The disciple who was dear to Jesus

said to Peter, “It is the Lord!”: The clause It is the Lord means “The man talking to us is Jesus.” The loved disciple recognized Jesus by the miracle he did. In some languages it is natural to mark this as something that the disciple concluded when he saw the miracle. For example:

he said to Peter, “That must be the Lord.”

he said to Peter, “Surely that man is the Lord.”

the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” It referred to Jesus. See how you translated this phrase in 20:2, 18, 20. In some languages it may be necessary to provide a possessive pronoun here. For example:

our ^(incl) Lord

21:7b

As soon as Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord,

- As soon as Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord,
- On hearing that,

As soon as Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord:

This clause introduces what Simon Peter did as a result of what the loved disciple said. The Greek text includes a word meaning “so” or “therefore” that is not explicit in the BSB. You may want to make it explicit. For example:

So Simon Peter, when he heard that it was the Lord.... (NET)

What Simon Peter then did was the result of hearing that the man on the beach was the Lord. In some languages it may not be necessary or natural to repeat what Peter heard. For example:

When Peter heard him say this (NCV)

Hearing this (JBP)

Simon Peter: The Greek text uses Peter’s two names here. However, in some languages that may not be natural after the mention of Peter in 21:7a. You may want to use just one name here. For example:

When Peter heard that it was the Lord

the Lord: See how you translated this phrase in 21:7a. In some languages it may again be necessary to provide a possessive pronoun here. For example:

his Lord

their Lord

21:7c

he put on his outer garment (for he had removed it)

- he wrapped his outer garment around his waist because he had taken it off.
- Simon Peter put on his coat/jacket (because he had removed it to work)

he put on his outer garment: This clause refers to Peter putting on his outer garment (piece of clothes). Some scholars say that Peter already had his outer garment on. They say that he just tucked it in his belt or tied it tighter. He did that to make it easier to swim. Only NET and NABRE translate it that way, however, so it recommended that you follow most English translations and say “he put on.” It may be that Peter just tied the garment around himself. See 13:4, 5, where Jesus wrapped and tied a towel around his waist and the same verb is used. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

he wrapped his coat around himself (NCV)

Simon Peter tied his outer garment around him (NJB)

his outer garment: The Greek word that the BSB translates literally as outer garment was probably a short fisherman’s coat.

for he had removed it: This clause indicates the reason why Peter put on his outer garment. The word for here means “because.” The reason was that he needed more clothes on before he could greet Jesus in a suitable way. Several English translations put this clause in parentheses to indicate that it is parenthetical information. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

(for he had taken it off) (NIV)

because he was not wearing much

he had removed it: The word that the BSB has translated as had removed it is more literally “naked.” There are two ways to interpret the word here based on two senses of the word.

1. It means that he was wearing few clothes. It was not normal for Jewish men to be completely naked in public. Peter likely had nothing on but a long shirt or something around his waist. For example:

he put back on the clothes that he had taken off (GW) (BSB, NET, NIV, CEV, GW, NABRE)

1. It means that he was not wearing anything. For example:

(for he had nothing on) (NJB) (NRSV, GNT, NCV, KJV, REB, NJB)

Other translations (ESV, NASB, NLT, RSV) translate this word in an ambiguous way, saying that he was “stripped for work.” It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible experts.

Here are other ways to translate this clause:

(for he had stripped for work) (NLT)

because he did not have many clothes on

21:7d and jumped into the sea.

- Then he jumped into the lake.
- dived into the water, and swam to Jesus.

and jumped into the sea: This clause implies that Peter decided to swim to Jesus. Probably he thought that that was faster than helping the other disciples drag the net to the shore. In some languages it may be natural to make it explicit that Peter swam after jumping in. For example:

jumped into the water and swam to the shore

jumped: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as jumped is more literally “threw himself.” The verb indicates that Peter moved quickly and suddenly. For example:

threw himself into the sea (ESV)

dived into the lake

the sea: This phrase refers to the Lake of Galilee or Tiberias. The word in Greek can mean either “sea” or “lake.” This was a freshwater (not salty) body of water. See whether you referred to a sea or lake in 21:1 and use the same word here and there.

John 21:8

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that

Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:7–8

The disciples realized that the figure on the shore was Jesus, and they returned to land. Peter jumped into the water and swam to shore ahead of the others.

21:8a

The other disciples came ashore in the boat. They dragged in the net full of fish,

- But the rest of the disciples brought the boat to shore, pulling the net full of fish behind them.
- The remaining disciples stayed with the boat, rowing it back to land with the net full of fish behind it.

The other disciples came ashore in the boat: The rest of the disciples also went toward Jesus on the shore. But unlike Peter, they stayed in the boat. In some languages it is more natural to tell how they moved the boat. For example:

the other disciples rowed the boat to the shore

The other disciples: This phrase refers to the six disciples who went fishing with Peter.

They dragged in the net full of fish: This phrase implies that the net was too heavy for the disciples to lift into the boat. As a result, they left it in the water and pulled it behind the boat. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and they pulled the net with its full load of fish to the shore

pulling the net with all the fish

21:8b

for they were not far from land, only about a hundred yards.

- They did that because it was not far from the shore, only about a hundred yards.
- They were only about a hundred meters away from land.

for they were not far from land: The phrase not far in this context means “near.” In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a positive expression. For example:

because they were quite close to shore

for: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as for here means “because” and introduces a reason. It is the reason why the disciples were able to pull the net behind the boat to the shore. In some languages it may be natural to leave it untranslated, perhaps starting a new sentence. For example:

They were not very far from land. (GNT)

only about a hundred yards: The phrase that the BSB translates as only about a hundred yards is more literally “but about two hundred (200) cubits away.” The idea is that the shore was not far, but only 200 cubits away. A cubit was how Jews measured length and was the length from the elbow to the end of the fingers. In some languages it is more natural to say “one hundred meters” or to use a different unit of measure. For example:

They were not very far from the shore, just about one hundred meters. (Uma Back Translation)

They were close to the shore. The distance was about 300 feet away.

John 21:9**Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee**

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:9–11

Jesus had prepared a breakfast of bread and fish for the disciples. He invited them to bring some of their fish too. Peter brought the fish to land. The disciples saw that their net did not break even though there were 153 large fish caught in it.

21:9

When they landed, they saw a charcoal fire there with fish on it, and some bread.

- ¶ When they reached the shore, they saw a charcoal fire burning with fish cooking on it. There was bread too.
- ¶ When they arrived, the disciples saw that Jesus was cooking some fish over a charcoal fire. They also saw some bread.

When they landed: This clause is more literally “when they went up onto the land.” It introduces the setting of the next part of the story. That next part happened after the disciples got out of the boat and walked onto the shore. Introduce what happened there in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

When they had gone ashore (NRSV)

When they got there (NLT)

On landing

they landed: The verb phrase that the BSB translates as landed refers to getting off the boat and walking onto land. In some languages it may be natural to mention these actions separately. For example:

the followers stepped out of the boat and onto the shore (NCV)

the disciples left the boat and walked up on the land

they saw a charcoal fire there with fish on it, and some bread: The disciples saw that Jesus was already

cooking breakfast for them. Some fish were cooking over a fire. The Greek text does not clearly say whether the bread was also on the fire. The bread was probably already cooked. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they saw that there was some bread there and a charcoal fire with fish cooking on it (NJB)

they found breakfast waiting for them—fish cooking over a charcoal fire, and some bread (NLT)

they saw a charcoal fire already laid and fish placed on it, and bread (NASB)

they saw a charcoal fire there: The Greek word that the BSB translates as there is more literally “laid,” which means “prepared” or “ready.” The context implies that the fire was already lit. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

they saw a charcoal fire ready (NET)

they saw that a charcoal fire was burning (JBP)

they saw a charcoal fire in place (ESV)

In some languages it may not be necessary to translate the word there explicitly. It can be left as implied information. For example:

they saw a fire of hot coals (NCV)

a charcoal fire: The Greek word that the BSB translates as a charcoal fire refers to a fire made with charcoal (coal). The same Greek word was also used in 18:18. See how you translated it there. For example:

a fire of burning coals (NIV)

a fire of hot coals (NCV)

with fish on it: The Greek word that the BSB translates as fish is singular. It could refer to one large fish, or to several fish as a group. It is good to leave this ambiguous if possible. The fish was/were lying on the coals, cooking. You may want to make this fact explicit. For example:

fish cooking over a charcoal fire (NLT)

on it: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as on it is more literally “lying upon.” Refer to the fish cooking on the fire in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

lying on the coals (GW)

some bread: The Greek word that the BSB translates as bread is singular and refers to bread in general. We do not know how many small loaves Jesus prepared for the disciples. It is good to use an expression that refers to an indefinite but large quantity. This bread was probably barley or wheat bread. We do not know which kind, however, so use a general expression. See how you translated bread in 6:5, 31, 35.

John 21:10

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:9–11

Jesus had prepared a breakfast of bread and fish for the disciples. He invited them to bring some of their fish too. Peter brought the fish to land. The disciples saw that their net did not break even though there were 153 large fish caught in it.

21:10

Jesus told them, “Bring some of the fish you have just caught.”

- Jesus said to them, “Bring^(plur) me some of the fish you^(plur) just caught.”

- Jesus told them, “Give me some of the fish you^(plur) caught.”

Jesus told them: The pronoun them refers to Jesus’ seven disciples who went fishing.

Bring some of the fish you have just caught: This is a second-person plural command to the disciples. Jesus implied that he wanted to cook some more fish and serve them for breakfast.

Bring: In some languages it may be natural to say where the disciples were to bring the fish. For example:

Bring me (JBP)

Bring here

you have just caught: The Greek word that the BSB translates as just is more literally “now.” The disciples had caught the fish only a few minutes before. In some languages the verb tense may indicate recent action and it may not be necessary to translate this word explicitly.

you: This pronoun is plural and refers to the seven disciples.

John 21:11

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:9–11

Jesus had prepared a breakfast of bread and fish for the disciples. He invited them to bring some of their

fish too. Peter brought the fish to land. The disciples saw that their net did not break even though there were 153 large fish caught in it.

21:11a

So Simon Peter went aboard and dragged the net ashore.

- So Simon Peter went onto the boat and dragged the net to the shore.
- So Simon Peter climbed into the boat and then pulled the net full of fish to the land.

So Simon Peter went aboard: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as went aboard is more literally “went up.” Peter entered the boat again to untie the net. (The phrase went aboard here means “got into the boat.”) Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Simon Peter climbed aboard (NIV)

Simon Peter got back into the boat (CEV)

and dragged the net ashore: The verb that the BSB translates literally as dragged indicates that Peter pulled the net onto the shore without lifting it up. For example:

pulled the net to shore (NET)

the net: The fish were still in the net, as John says in 21:11b. Peter did not empty the net until he got to the shore.

ashore: This word means “onto the land.”

21:11b

It was full of large fish, 153,

- It was full of big fish, one hundred and fifty-three in total.
- They saw that it contained 153 large fish,
- They counted them, and they learned that they had caught 153 large fish.

It was full of large fish, 153: The net was full because it contained 153 large fish. It could not hold any or many more. In some languages it may be necessary to indicate or imply that Peter and the other disciples counted the fish. For example:

and it was seen/found to contain one hundred and fifty-three large fish

and they found that there were 153 large fish in it

and the number of fish amounted to 153—and they were all large in size

In some languages it may be natural to begin a new sentence here. For example:

The net was filled with 153 large fish.

Filling it were one hundred fifty-three (153) large fish.

It was full of large fish. They counted them and found that there were one hundred and fifty-three.

153: In some languages it may be awkward or unnatural to use a large number such as 153. Some languages use the language of wider communication for such large numbers. Some languages use the digits 153. Some say “very many” followed by the number in parentheses. For example:

There were 153 large fish (NLT)

It was full of many large fish (153)

General Comment on 21:11a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 21:11a–b. For example:

Peter went to the boat and dragged the net, full of large fish, to the shore. There they counted them and saw that there were 153.

21:11c

but even with so many, the net was not torn.

- However, although there was a large number of fish, the net did not tear.
- but all those fish did not cause the net to tear/break.
- But still the net remained unbroken/whole.

but even with so many, the net was not torn: The BSB has supplied the word *but* to indicate that it was surprising that the net did not tear. Normally a net tore when it held so many fish, releasing them back into the sea. Consider how it is natural in your language to indicate that something is surprising or not expected. For example:

and though there were so many, the net was not torn (NRSV)

even though there were so many, still the net did tear (GNT)

but even with so many: This clause tells the reason why it was surprising that the net did not tear. Because there were very many fish, people might expect that the net would break, but it did not break. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and yet, many as they were (REB)

but still (CEV)

the net was not torn: The verb *was not torn* is passive. It implies that the weight of the fish did not rip (tear) any holes in the net. None of the strings of the net broke. There are several ways to translate this verb phrase:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

the net was not broken (NJB)

- Use an active verb with no object (an intransitive verb). For example:

the net did not tear (GNT)

the net did not rip (CEV)

- Use an active verb with an object (a transitive verb). The fish are the implied subject. For example:

all those fish did not tear the net

- Use a verb that indicates cause. For example:

the large number of fish did not cause the net to tear

- Use a positive expression with an adjective. For example:

the net remained whole

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language in this context.

General Comment on 21:11c

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in 21:11c. For example:

The net did not rip even though there were so many fish caught in it.

The net remained unbroken in spite of all the fish it contained/held.

General Comment on 21:11b–c

In some languages it may be natural to combine the information in 21:11b–c. For example:

Though it contained 153 large fish, the net did not tear.

There were 153 large fish, and yet the net hadn't torn. (NLT)

In it were one hundred fifty-three large fish, but still the net did not rip. (CEV)

John 21:12

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:12–14

Jesus served breakfast to his disciples.

21:12a

“Come, have breakfast,” Jesus said to them.

- ¶ Jesus told the disciples, “Come and eat some breakfast.”
- “Come here and eat some food,” Jesus said to the disciples.
- ¶ Jesus invited the disciples to eat a meal with him.

Come, have breakfast: The Greek verbs that the BSB translates as Come and have breakfast are polite commands that are an invitation. They mean “eat breakfast with me.” In some languages it is more polite to use an inclusive first-person plural command. For example:

Let us have-breakfast! (Uma back Translation)

have breakfast: The English word breakfast refers to the first meal of the day, the morning meal. The Greek expression can be used to refer to any meal (as in Luke 11:37). This was early in the morning and the men were eating bread and fish. Use the expression that is natural in your language for eating such a meal. For example:

eat (CEV)

have something to eat

eat/share a meal

Jesus said to them: If you start a new paragraph here, it may be natural to make explicit whom Jesus spoke to. For example:

Jesus said to the/his disciples

21:12b

None of the disciples dared to ask Him, “Who are You?”

- None of the disciples was bold/confident enough to ask, “Who are you^{(sing)?}”
- They lacked confidence, so they did not ask Jesus who he was

The Greek word that begins this clause introduces some information about something that did not happen. It reveals what the disciples were thinking. Many English translations, like the BSB, leave it untranslated. Here is another way to translate this word:

But (NET)

None of the disciples dared to ask Him, “Who are You?”: This clause implies that the disciples were still not sure who this man really was. Possibly Jesus looked different in some way. They apparently wanted to ask him who he was, but they were afraid or embarrassed to do so. This quotation is direct speech. In

some languages it may be more natural to translate their desired question as indirect speech. For example:

Now none of the disciples dared ask him who he was.

dared to ask Him: This phrase means “were brave or bold enough to ask him.” For example:

was bold enough to ask him (NJB)

ask: The Greek word that the BSB translates as ask here means to carefully examine someone by asking questions. For example:

question (NASB)

General Comment on 21:12b

In some languages it may be natural to translate this clause with a positive expression instead of “none of the disciples.” For example:

The disciples were not brave enough to ask him, “Who are you?”

The disciples were all afraid to ask him to tell them who he was.

21:12c

They knew it was the Lord.

- because they knew it was the Lord.
- because they knew who he was, Jesus their Lord.

They knew it was the Lord: This clause tells why the disciples did not ask Jesus who he was. The reason was that they knew who he was, their Lord. Even though they knew that, they still had questions. Maybe Jesus looked different, or maybe it still seemed strange that he had come alive again. However, the text does not explain why they wanted to ask who he was when they already knew. So do not explain it in your translation.

the Lord: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the Lord means “the master, the one who has authority over others.” It is the same word that is often used for God. See how you translated this phrase in 21:7. Here are some other ways to translate this word in this context:

Chief

Chief Jesus

their Lord/Master

General Comment on 21:12c

In some languages it may be natural to translate what the disciples knew as direct speech. Then you would indicate their thoughts in the present tense. For example:

because they understood/knew, “It is our^(incl) Lord.”

John 21:13

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:12–14

Jesus served breakfast to his disciples.

21:13a

Jesus came and took the bread and gave it to them,

- Jesus went to them, taking the bread, and gave each of them some.
- Jesus gave each of the disciples some bread

Jesus came: This clause indicates that Jesus approached the disciples. Some translations leave the word came implied and just say that Jesus took the bread and gave it to them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus went over (GNT)

Jesus came near (Otomi Back Translation)

and took the bread: Jesus picked up the bread from where it was lying in order to give it to the disciples. Bread was the Jews' main food, so it was served first. See how you translated bread in 21:9. For example:

Jesus took the bread in his hands (CEV)

and gave it to them: Jesus gave each disciple some bread. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

and gave some of it to his disciples (CEV)

21:13b

and He did the same with the fish.

- He also took the fish and gave them that as well.
- and fish.

and He did the same with the fish: The phrase did the same indicates that Jesus also served each disciple some fish. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and gave them all fish as well (JBP)

along with the fish (NCV)

General Comment on 21:13a–b

In some languages it may be natural to combine 21:13a–b, using just one verb. For example:

Then Jesus served them the bread and the fish.
(NLT)

John 21:14

Section 21:1–14: Jesus appeared to his disciples in Galilee

This chapter is a second ending to the Gospel of John. It gives some information about another time that Jesus appeared to his disciples after he rose from the dead. This time Jesus came to seven of his followers while they were fishing on the lake in Galilee. He did a miracle of providing many fish for them to catch, and then he gave them breakfast.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus went to seven of his disciples beside Lake Galilee

Seven disciples saw a miracle when they caught many fish

Jesus did a miracle to give some of his followers many fish

Paragraph 21:12–14

Jesus served breakfast to his disciples.

21:14

This was now the third time that Jesus appeared to the disciples after He was raised from the dead.

- That was the third time that Jesus showed himself to his disciples after he became alive again.
- This is the third time Jesus' followers saw him after God raised him from the dead.

This was now the third time that Jesus appeared to the disciples after He was raised from the dead:

This is a comment by the author about the event. It is the conclusion of this part of the story, the narrative of how Jesus provided breakfast for the disciples.

This: This pronoun refers to the whole event in this chapter when Jesus appeared to his disciples by the lake.

the third time: This phrase includes only the times mentioned in this Gospel. Here are some other ways to translate this phrase:

This is the third appearance of Jesus to his disciples that I am telling you about.

This is the third time that Jesus showed himself to his disciples that I have included in this book.

that Jesus appeared to the disciples: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as Jesus appeared to the disciples means that Jesus allowed his disciples to see him. See the similar expression in 21:1. In some languages it is more natural to use a different verb. For example:

Jesus showed himself to his disciples

the disciples saw Jesus

Jesus was revealed to the disciples (NET)

after He was raised from the dead: This is a passive clause. It was God who raised Jesus from the dead. Here are some ways to translate this clause:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

since he was raised to life again from his death
(Yakan Back Translation)

- Use an active verb. For example:

after he had come back to life (GW)

after God raised Jesus from the dead

- Use a noun. For example:

after his resurrection from the dead (REB)

Use the expression that is most natural in your language. See how you translated this same expression in 2:22.

John 21:15

Section 21:15–19: Jesus restored Peter

After breakfast Jesus spoke with Simon Peter, restoring him and encouraging him. Three times he asked if Peter, calling him Simon, loved him. When Peter said that he did, Jesus told him to feed or care for his sheep, meaning his followers.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus asked Peter if he loved him

Jesus again gave Peter a ministry

Jesus asked Peter to feed his sheep

Paragraph 21:15–19

Just before Jesus' death, Peter had denied knowing him. Now Jesus spoke with Peter. He restored their relationship and gave him a ministry in which Peter could serve him.

In this paragraph Jesus asked Peter three questions, and Peter replied each time. Each question and answer used one of two different Greek words that the BSB translates as "love." Jesus used one word (*agapaō*) when he asked the first two questions. He used the other Greek word (*phileō*) when he asked the third question. Peter used the second word in all his answers. There are two ways to interpret the word choice here:

1. Both words mean the same thing. In this context (as in other places in John) they are used as synonyms. For example:

"Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?" "Yes, Lord," Peter replied, "you know I love you." (NCV) (BSB, GNT, ESV, NLT, RSV, NRSV, NIV2011, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, GW, NCV, CEV)

1. One Greek word refers to a stronger love than the other. Jesus used the stronger word (*agapaō*) in his first two questions. All the other times that the word "love" appears, it is the weaker Greek word. This second word (*phileō*) means "to be fond of" or "to be a friend." For example:

Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?" "Yes, Lord," he said, "you know that I love you." (NIV84) (NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. See the footnote in the NET (21:15, footnote d) and Carson for more details. You may follow this interpretation by using the same word for love or by using synonyms. Do what is more natural in your language. For example:

do you love me?...am I dear to you?

21:15a

When they had finished eating,

- ¶ When they finished eating breakfast,
- ¶ After the meal

When they had finished eating: This clause introduces the next event in the story, after the men finished eating. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as they had finished eating is from the same verb root as "have breakfast" in 21:12a. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

When they had finished breakfast (NRSV)

When they had eaten (NJB)

After breakfast (NLT)

they: Because this is a new paragraph, it may be natural to say whom the pronoun they refers to. For example:

Jesus and his disciples (CEV)

21:15b

Jesus asked Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you love Me more than these?”

- Jesus asked Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you^(sing) love me more than they do?”
- Jesus asked Simon Peter, “Do you love^(sing) me any more than these other disciples/followers love me?”

Jesus asked Simon Peter: This phrase introduces the conversation between Jesus and Peter. Refer to Peter with both his names, as in 21:2.

Simon son of John: Jesus addressed Peter using his Hebrew name and the name of his father. His father’s name is slightly different than the name given in Matthew 16:17 (“Jonah”), but you should use John here.

do you love Me more than these?: Jesus asked Peter about the strength of his love for him. For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above. There are two ways to understand what the phrase more than these means here:

1. It means more than the other disciples love me. For example:

do you love me more than these others do? (GNT)
(GNT, REB, NET, CEV, NJB, GW)

1. It means more than you love anything else, including fish and fishing, and the other disciples.

If it is natural to leave the meaning ambiguous, as in the Greek, the BSB, and many other English translations, that is good. But if you must choose one interpretation, it is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). That is the interpretation that many Bible scholars and English translations follow.

21:15c

“Yes, Lord,” he answered, “You know I love You.”

- Peter answered him, “Yes, Lord, you^(sing) know that I love you.”
- “Yes, my Lord, I do,” Peter answered. “You^(sing) know that I love you.”

Yes, Lord: Peter indicated that he loved Jesus even more than the other disciples did. The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” See how you translated this word in 6:68, 9:38, and 21:12. Here are other ways to translate this word:

Chief

My Master

he answered: The pronoun he refers to Peter. It may be helpful to make this pronoun explicit. For example:

Peter replied to Jesus

Peter answered him

You know I love You: The Greek text emphasizes the first You in this clause. Peter believed that Jesus already knew that he loved Jesus. Peter used a different Greek word for love than Jesus used, but in this context its meaning is the same. See the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above. If it is natural to use a synonym (another word that means the same thing), that is acceptable. But use a word or phrase that has the same basic meaning. For example:

you know that I care about you deeply

you know that you are dear to me

21:15d

Jesus replied, “Feed My lambs.”

- Jesus said to him, “Give^(sing) food to my flock.”
- Jesus told him, “Provide^(sing) for the needs of my people like a shepherd provides for his lambs.”

Feed My lambs: This clause is a metaphor. The word lambs refers to Jesus’ people, his followers. The word Feed here refers to taking care of Jesus’ people’s spiritual needs. Jesus wanted Peter to lead, teach, encourage, and advise his other followers. Here are other ways to translate this metaphor:

- Keep the metaphor. For example:

Feed my young sheep.

- Explain all or part of the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Take care of my lambs. (GNT)

- Change all or part of the metaphor into a simile. For example:

Take care of my people as a shepherd takes care of his lambs.

Act as/like a shepherd to my people. They are like my lambs.

Feeding Jesus' lambs was what Peter should do because he loved Jesus. You may want to indicate the connection with 21:15c by using a connector. For example:

Then feed my lambs. (NLT)

Feed: The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Feed means to take care of animals, including feeding them. See Matthew 8:33 and Luke 15:15, where the same verb is used. Here is another way to translate this word:

Take care of (GNT)

John 21:16

Section 21:15–19: Jesus restored Peter

After breakfast Jesus spoke with Simon Peter, restoring him and encouraging him. Three times he asked if Peter, calling him Simon, loved him. When Peter said that he did, Jesus told him to feed or care for his sheep, meaning his followers.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus asked Peter if he loved him

Jesus again gave Peter a ministry

Jesus asked Peter to feed his sheep

Paragraph 21:15–19

Just before Jesus' death, Peter had denied knowing him. Now Jesus spoke with Peter. He restored their relationship and gave him a ministry in which Peter could serve him.

In this paragraph Jesus asked Peter three questions, and Peter replied each time. Each question and answer used one of two different Greek words that the BSB translates as "love." Jesus used one word (agapaō) when he asked the first two questions. He used the other Greek word (phileō) when he asked the third question. Peter used the second word in all his answers. There are two ways to interpret the word choice here:

1. Both words mean the same thing. In this context (as in other places in John) they are used as synonyms. For example:

"Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?" "Yes, Lord," Peter replied, "you know I love you." (NCV) (BSB, GNT, ESV, NLT, RSV, NRSV, NIV2011, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, GW, NCV, CEV)

1. One Greek word refers to a stronger love than the other. Jesus used the stronger word (agapaō) in his first two questions. All the other times that the word "love" appears, it is the weaker Greek word. This second word (phileō) means "to be fond of" or "to be a friend." For example:

Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?" "Yes, Lord," he said, "you know that I love you." (NIV84) (NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. See the footnote in the NET (21:15, footnote d) and Carson for more details. You may follow this interpretation by using the same word for love or by using synonyms. Do what is more natural in your language. For example:

do you love me?...am I dear to you?

21:16a

Jesus asked a second time, "Simon son of John, do you love Me?"

- Jesus asked Simon Peter for the second time, "Simon son of John, do you^(sing) love me?"
- Jesus asked Simon Peter the question again. He said, "Simon son of John, do you^(sing) love me?"

Jesus asked a second time, "Simon son of John, do you love Me?":

This second time Jesus did not ask Peter to compare his love for him with the other disciples' love. He just asked him if he, Peter, loved Jesus. He used the same verb for love that he used in 21:15a. For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above.

21:16b

"Yes, Lord," he answered, "You know I love You."

- Peter answered him, "Yes, Lord. You^(sing) know that I love you."
- Peter answered Jesus, "My Lord, you^(sing) know that I love you."

"Yes, Lord," he answered, "You know I love You.":

Peter replied the same way he did before. See how you translated this sentence in 21:15c. For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above.

21:16c**Jesus told him, “Shepherd My sheep.”**

- Jesus said to him, “Take care^(sing) of my flock.”
- Jesus told him, “Look after^(sing) my people like a shepherd looks after his sheep.”

Shepherd My sheep: This clause is another metaphor, meaning the same thing as “Feed my lambs” in 21:15d. The Greek verb that the BSB translates as Shepherd describes the activity of a shepherd. A shepherd will tend (care for) his sheep by leading them to good food, protecting them, and rescuing them. It is a different verb from the one in 21:15d, where Jesus said, “Feed my lambs.” However, here it is used as a synonym, both words meaning the same thing. Like the clause in 21:15d, this is a metaphor and there are several ways to translate it:

- Use a metaphor, like the BSB.
- Explain all or part of the meaning of the metaphor. For example:

Take care of my sheep. (NIV)

- Change all or part of the metaphor into a simile. For example:

Look after my people like a shepherd looks after his sheep.

Tending Jesus’ sheep was what Peter should do because he loved Jesus. You may want to indicate the connection with 21:16b by supplying a connector. For example:

Then take care of my sheep. (NLT)

John 21:17**Section 21:15–19: Jesus restored Peter**

After breakfast Jesus spoke with Simon Peter, restoring him and encouraging him. Three times he asked if Peter, calling him Simon, loved him. When Peter said that he did, Jesus told him to feed or care for his sheep, meaning his followers.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus asked Peter if he loved him

Jesus again gave Peter a ministry

Jesus asked Peter to feed his sheep

Paragraph 21:15–19

Just before Jesus’ death, Peter had denied knowing him. Now Jesus spoke with Peter. He restored their relationship and gave him a ministry in which Peter could serve him.

In this paragraph Jesus asked Peter three questions, and Peter replied each time. Each question and answer used one of two different Greek words that the BSB translates as “love.” Jesus used one word (agapaō) when he asked the first two questions. He used the other Greek word (phileō) when he asked the third question. Peter used the second word in all his answers. There are two ways to interpret the word choice here:

1. Both words mean the same thing. In this context (as in other places in John) they are used as synonyms. For example:

“Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” Peter replied, “you know I love you.” (NCV) (BSB, GNT, ESV, NLT, RSV, NRSV, NIV2011, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, GW, NCV, CEV)

1. One Greek word refers to a stronger love than the other. Jesus used the stronger word (agapaō) in his first two questions. All the other times that the word “love” appears, it is the weaker Greek word. This second word (phileō) means “to be fond of” or “to be a friend.” For example:

Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” he said, “you know that I love you.” (NIV84) (NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. See the footnote in the NET (21:15, footnote d) and Carson for more details. You may follow this interpretation by using the same word for love or by using synonyms. Do what is more natural in your language. For example:

do you love me?...am I dear to you?

21:17a**Jesus asked a third time, “Simon son of John, do you love Me?”**

- A third time, Jesus asked Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you^(sing) love me?”
- Jesus asked Simon Peter the same question for the third time: “Simon son of John, do you^(sing) love me?”

Jesus asked a third time: The phrase a third time indicates that Jesus had already asked him this question twice. Even though he used a different word for “love” the first two times, the meaning was the same. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

A third time he asked him (NLT)

Then Jesus said again for the third time (Western Bukidnon Manobo Back Translation)

Simon son of John, do you love Me?: The Greek word that the BSB translates as love is a different verb from that in 21:15b and 16a. It is the verb that Peter used in 21:15c and 16b. Most scholars agree that both verbs have the same meaning in this context. For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above.

21:17b

Peter was deeply hurt that Jesus had asked him a third time, “Do you love Me?”

- Peter felt grief/distress because Jesus asked him the third time, “Do you^(sing) love me?”
- When Jesus asked Peter again for the third time if he loved him, Peter was sad in his heart.

Peter was deeply hurt that Jesus had asked him a third time, “Do you love Me?”: This sentence indicates that Peter’s feelings were hurt. They were hurt because Jesus asked him a third time a question that he had already answered twice. For example:

Peter was hurt because Jesus had asked him three times if he loved him. (CEV)

Peter was hurt that Jesus asked the question a third time. (NLT)

Peter was deeply hurt: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as Peter was deeply hurt means that Peter felt grief or distress. He probably remembered how he had betrayed Jesus and wondered if Jesus would trust him again. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Peter was grieved (ESV)

Peter was distressed (NET)

Peter felt sad (GW)

that Jesus had asked him a third time, “Do you love Me?”: Peter was sad because Jesus had just asked him the same question a third time. Some scholars think that Peter was hurt because the third time that Jesus asked the question, he used the weaker word for “love.” However, the interpretation that is recommended here says that John used the two words for “love” as synonyms. So Peter could not be hurt because Jesus used a different word for “love.” The way that John used “second time” and “third time” in 21:16–17 also indicates that Peter was hurt because Jesus asked the same question three times. Some English translations, including NRSV, are ambiguous about why Peter was hurt. Others (BSB, CEV, NET, NLT, REB, GW, NJB) are clear that Peter was hurt because Jesus asked the question three times. For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

because Jesus had asked him a third time, “Do you love me?” (GW)

because Jesus had asked him three times if he loved him (CEV)

21:17c

“Lord, You know all things,” he replied. “You know I love You.”

- Peter answered him, “Lord, you^(sing) know everything. You know that I love you.”
- “Yes, my Lord.” he said. “You know all things. And you know that I do love you.”

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord means “master, one who has authority over others.” See how you translated this word in Peter’s answers in 21:15 and 16.

You know all things: This clause indicates that Peter believed that Jesus knew the truth about everything. He even knew people’s thoughts and feelings. Therefore he already knew that Peter loved him. The Greek text emphasizes the word You in this clause. Here is another way to translate this clause:

You know everything (NRSV)

he replied: This clause is short for “And Peter said to Jesus.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

and said (NET)

He said (NIV)

So he told Jesus (CEV)

You know I love You: For a discussion of the word love, see the note on Paragraph 21:15–19 above. See how you translated this clause in 21:16b. The Greek word for know is different, but means the same thing. If it is natural for you to use another word that means the same thing, you may do that. For example:

you are aware that I love you

21:17d

Jesus said to him, “Feed My sheep.

- Jesus said to him, “Give^(sing) food to my flock.
- Jesus told him, “Provide^(sing) for the needs of my people like a shepherd provides for his sheep.

Feed My sheep: This clause is the third time that Jesus asked Peter to care for his people. The verb Feed is the same as in 21:15. See how you translated it there and translate it the same way in both verses. The noun sheep is the same as in 21:16c. You may want to connect Peter’s response in 21:17c to Jesus’ command here. For example:

Then feed my sheep. (NLT)

John 21:18

Section 21:15–19: Jesus restored Peter

After breakfast Jesus spoke with Simon Peter, restoring him and encouraging him. Three times he asked if Peter, calling him Simon, loved him. When Peter said that he did, Jesus told him to feed or care for his sheep, meaning his followers.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus asked Peter if he loved him

Jesus again gave Peter a ministry

Jesus asked Peter to feed his sheep

Paragraph 21:15–19

Just before Jesus’ death, Peter had denied knowing him. Now Jesus spoke with Peter. He restored their relationship and gave him a ministry in which Peter could serve him.

In this paragraph Jesus asked Peter three questions, and Peter replied each time. Each question and answer used one of two different Greek words that the BSB translates as “love.” Jesus used one word (agapaō) when he asked the first two questions. He used the other Greek word (phileō) when he asked the third question. Peter used the second word in all his answers. There are two ways to interpret the word choice here:

1. Both words mean the same thing. In this context (as in other places in John) they are used as synonyms. For example:

“Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” Peter replied, “you know I love you.” (NCV) (BSB, GNT, ESV, NLT, RSV, NRSV, NIV2011, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, GW, NCV, CEV)

1. One Greek word refers to a stronger love than the other. Jesus used the stronger word (agapaō) in his first two questions. All the other times that the word “love” appears, it is the weaker Greek word. This second word (phileō) means “to be fond of” or “to be a friend.” For example:

Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” he said, “you know that I love you.” (NIV84) (NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. See the footnote in the NET (21:15, footnote d) and Carson for more details. You may follow this interpretation by using the same word for love or by using synonyms. Do what is more natural in your language. For example:

do you love me?...am I dear to you?

21:18

This verse includes a play on words involving two different idioms that both use the word “tie.” The meaning of the verse is that when Peter was young he tied up his robe to go wherever he wanted. But when he became old, people would tie his arms to a beam that would become part of a cross. Then they would take him to a place where they would crucify him. See the General Comment following the notes on 21:18.

21:18a

Truly, truly, I tell you,

- I have something important to say to you^(sing).

- Listen^(sing) carefully to what I am about to say.

Truly, truly, I tell you: This clause indicates that an important statement will follow. See how you translated it in 3:3 and 3:5.

you: This pronoun is singular and refers to Peter.

21:18b

when you were young, you dressed yourself and walked where you wanted;

- When you^(sing) were a young man you tied your own clothes/robes and went where you wanted to go.
- In your youth you^(sing) could tie your own clothes and go wherever you wanted to go.

when you were young: The Greek clause that the BSB translates as when you were young refers to an earlier time, when Peter was younger. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

when you were younger (NRSV)

when you were a young man (CEV)

in your youth

you dressed yourself: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as you dressed yourself refers to tying something. It usually referred to the way that a man tied his robe at the waist to prepare to work or travel. People in Jesus' time did not have leather belts like ones that people wear today. They did not have metal buckles to connect the ends of the belt. They used something like a rope to tie their clothes. Refer to the action of tying one's clothes in a way that is natural in your language. Or you can use a more general statement. For example:

you tied your clothes around you (NET)

you used to fasten your own belt (NRSV)

you got ready yourself

and walked where you wanted: Peter had always been free to go where he wanted to go. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

and walk wherever you wished (NASB)

21:18c

but when you are old, you will stretch out your hands,

- Yet when you^(sing) are an old man it will be different. You will stretch out your arms
- However, in your^(sing) old age you will reach out your hands/arms onto a cross.

but when you are old: This refers to a time that was still future when Jesus spoke. Peter was not yet old. Use an expression that is natural in your language for referring to a future time that is many years later. For example:

but when you are an old man (JBP)

but after you become old

but in your old age

you will stretch out your hands: This clause probably refers to a person being prepared for crucifixion. Soldiers stretched out the arms of the condemned man on the shorter beam of the cross and tied them there. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

you will hold out your hands (CEV)

you will put out your hands (NCV)

your hands: The word that the BSB translates as hands refers to both hands and arms.

21:18d

and someone else will dress you

- and other people will tie you^(sing) up.
- Then someone else will tie you^(sing) on it

and someone else will dress you: The Greek expression that the BSB translates as dress is more literally "tie." It is the same word that John used in 21:18b. There are two ways to interpret this expression here:

1. It refers to a soldier tying Peter's arms to one beam of the cross. Then Peter would carry the beam to the place where they would crucify him. For example:

someone else will bind you (GNT) (REB, NET, GNT, NCV)

1. It refers to someone tying Peter's clothes. For example:

Then others will wrap your belt around you (CEV)
(BSB, CEV, ESV, NRSV, NIV, NJB, GW, NLT)

A few other translations are ambiguous. It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). The previous clause referred to Peter being crucified. So this clause probably also refers to crucifixion even though the Greek word usually refers to getting dressed. But do not refer explicitly to crucifixion in your translation. Instead, just refer to Peter being tied up. Because the BSB follows interpretation (2), the Display uses the NET as the Source Line.

someone else: The Greek word that the BSB translates as someone else is more literally “another.” Use the expression that is natural in your language to refer to other people. Here the other person or people tying Peter up would be Roman soldiers.

21:18e and lead you where you do not want to go.”

- Then they will take/lead you^(sing) to where you do not want to go.”
- and force you^(sing) to go to a place that you want to avoid.”

and lead you where you do not want to go: This expression refers to how soldiers would force Peter to carry the shorter beam of the cross. They forced him to carry it to the place where they would crucify him. Here are other ways to translate this expression:

and bring you where you do not want to go (NET)

where you do not want to go: In some languages it may be natural to translate this with a positive expression. For example:

a place that you want to avoid

General Comment on 21:18

This is a difficult prophecy to translate because it has a play on words involving two different idioms. Both idioms use the word “tie,” but in different ways. There is lots of implicit information in these two idioms. Jesus indicated that when Peter was young he tied up his robe to go wherever he wanted to go. But when he became old, people would tie his arms to one beam of a cross. Then they would lead him out to crucify him.

It is good if you can keep the play on words. However, it is more important that your readers understand the meaning. So if there is no word like “tie” that can be used in both sentences, you may want to include a footnote. In the footnote you can explain the play

on words by showing how one word connects the two sentences. For example:

Listen carefully to what I am telling you. When you were a young man you dressed yourself and went wherever you wanted to go. But when you are old, you will have to stretch your arms out so that someone can tie your arms to a cross. Then he will force you to go where you do not want to go.

Footnote: The Greek says, “Very truly, I tell you, when you were younger, you used to tie yourself and to go wherever you wanted. But when you are old, you will stretch out your arms, and someone else will tie you. And they will take you where you do not want to go.”

John 21:19

Section 21:15–19: Jesus restored Peter

After breakfast Jesus spoke with Simon Peter, restoring him and encouraging him. Three times he asked if Peter, calling him Simon, loved him. When Peter said that he did, Jesus told him to feed or care for his sheep, meaning his followers.

Here are other possible section headings:

Jesus asked Peter if he loved him

Jesus again gave Peter a ministry

Jesus asked Peter to feed his sheep

Paragraph 21:15–19

Just before Jesus’ death, Peter had denied knowing him. Now Jesus spoke with Peter. He restored their relationship and gave him a ministry in which Peter could serve him.

In this paragraph Jesus asked Peter three questions, and Peter replied each time. Each question and answer used one of two different Greek words that the BSB translates as “love.” Jesus used one word (*agapaō*) when he asked the first two questions. He used the other Greek word (*phileō*) when he asked the third question. Peter used the second word in all his answers. There are two ways to interpret the word choice here:

1. Both words mean the same thing. In this context (as in other places in John) they are used as synonyms. For example:

“Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” Peter replied, “you know I love you.” (NCV) (BSB, GNT, ESV, NLT, RSV, NRSV, NIV2011, KJV, NASB, REB, NJB, GW, NCV, CEV)

1. One Greek word refers to a stronger love than the other. Jesus used the stronger word (agapaō) in his first two questions. All the other times that the word “love” appears, it is the weaker Greek word. This second word (phileō) means “to be fond of” or “to be a friend.” For example:

Jesus said to Simon Peter, “Simon son of John, do you truly love me more than these?” “Yes, Lord,” he said, “you know that I love you.” (NIV84) (NIV84)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1) and most Bible scholars. See the footnote in the NET (21:15, footnote d) and Carson for more details. You may follow this interpretation by using the same word for love or by using synonyms. Do what is more natural in your language. For example:

do you love me?...am I dear to you?

21:19a

Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God.

- (Jesus told Peter this to let him know in what way he would die and bring honor/glory to God.)
- Jesus said this to warn Peter that he would die on a cross for God’s glory.

Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God: This clause is in parentheses to show that it is a comment by the writer John. It is not part of the story. John explained that Jesus spoke as he did to indicate how Peter would die. He would die by crucifixion. By dying that way, Peter would bring glory to God. Although the Greek and some translations use the pronoun “he” to refer to both Jesus and Peter, make it clear in your translation that the second pronoun “he” refers to Peter, not to Jesus. For example:

In saying this, Jesus was indicating the way in which Peter would die and bring glory to God. (GNT)

Now Jesus said this to indicate clearly by what kind of death Peter was going to glorify God. (NET)

this: This pronoun this refers to what Jesus just told Peter in 21:18. 21:18d–e implies that Peter would die by crucifixion.

to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God: The Greek word that the BSB translates as to indicate here refers to implying or saying something about the future. The same verb is used in 12:33, 18:32, and Acts 11:28, where the BSB translates it as “foretold.” Here are other ways to translate this clause:

to show by what kind of death Peter would bring glory to God (GW)

he indicated the kind of death by which Peter would give glory to God (NJB)

Jesus was indicating the way in which Peter would die and bring glory to God (GNT)

the kind of death by which: The Greek phrase that the BSB translates as the kind of death by which is more literally “by what death.” It probably implies a reference to crucifixion. See also 12:33 and 18:32, where the phrase refers to Jesus’ own death. An old tradition says that when he was an old man Peter was crucified for believing in Jesus. This probably took place under Emperor Nero around AD 65–68.

Peter would glorify God: Peter would glorify (‘give glory to’ or ‘honor’) God by dying on a cross because he believed in Jesus. He would honor God by showing how great God was, and how much he deserved praise. See how you translated glorify in 8:54, 12:28, and 17:1. See also KBT Glory, glorious, glorify C.3. For example:

Peter was going to honour God (JBP)

how Peter would die and bring honor to God (CEV)

21:19b

And after He had said this, He told him, “Follow Me.”

- Then Jesus said to Peter, “Follow me.”
- And then he said to Peter, “Continue^(sing) following me.”

And after He had said this: The pronoun this refers to what Jesus just told Peter. The BSB adds the words He had said in order to make this explicit. Here is another way to translate this phrase:

Then (NLT)

He told him: The pronoun He refers to Jesus and the pronoun him refers to Peter. It may be clearer to make one or both names explicit. For example:

Jesus told him (NLT)

Jesus said to Peter (NCV)

he said to Peter (CEV)

Follow Me: This clause here means “believe and obey me.” A few scholars think that Follow here means “to walk behind” as in 21:20a. However, most scholars agree that it means “to follow as a disciple” as in the same command in 21:22b. It could also refer to following him in the kind of death he died. The form of the Greek verb can refer to continuing an action that already began. So here it can mean “continue believing and obeying me.”

John 21:20

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:20–23

Peter asked Jesus what would happen to the disciple whom Jesus loved. Jesus did not answer Peter’s question, but just encouraged Peter to follow him.

21:20a

Peter turned and saw the disciple whom Jesus loved following them.

- ¶ Peter looked behind him and saw that the disciple whom Jesus loved was following them.
- ¶ Peter turned and saw that the disciple who was dear to Jesus was following them.

Peter turned and saw the disciple whom Jesus loved following them: While he was walking and talking with Jesus, Peter looked behind him. He saw that another disciple was walking behind them. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Peter turned around and saw the disciple whom Jesus loved. That disciple was following them. (GW)

Peter turned around and saw behind them the disciple Jesus loved. (NLT)

Then Peter turned round and noticed the disciple whom Jesus loved following behind them. (JBP)

the disciple whom Jesus loved: This phrase means “Jesus’ dear friend” and probably refers to the disciple John, the author of this Gospel. See how you translated this idea in 21:7, 13:23, 19:26, and 20:2. For example:

the disciple who was dear to Jesus

Jesus’ good friend

the disciple who knew that Jesus loved him

following them: This other disciple was walking behind Peter and Jesus. Perhaps he wanted to stay close to Jesus and hear what he said, or perhaps he wanted to talk to Jesus. Here are other ways to translate this phrase;

walking behind them (NCV)

coming after them

21:20b

He was the one who had leaned back against Jesus at the supper

- He was the one who had leaned toward Jesus during the supper
- (This was the disciple who had leaned back on Jesus at the supper

This clause refers back to the story in John 13:22–25, during Jesus’ last supper before his death. Jesus and his 12 disciples were reclining (half-lying) around the table. Each person was lying on their left side, holding their upper bodies up on their left elbow. The disciple whom Jesus loved was at Jesus’ right side. So if the disciple leaned back, he could speak quietly and privately to Jesus.

He was the one who had leaned back against Jesus at the supper: There are two ways to interpret this clause:

1. It refers to the way that this disciple had leaned back during the meal to ask a question. For example:

This was the one who had leaned back against Jesus at the supper (NIV) (BSB, NIV, NJB, NASB, REB, NJB, NET, GW, GNT, NLT, NCV)

1. It refers to the way that this disciple was reclining during the whole meal. For example:

the one who had been reclining at table close to him (ESV) (RSV, NRSV, KJV, ESV, CEV)

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1). In 13:25, the same verb is used to describe the disciple’s action of leaning back to speak to Jesus privately. See the notes there. The author is referring to this same action. It is good to use the same verb that you used in 13:25. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

He/This was the disciple who had leaned over to talk to Jesus during the supper.

the one who had leant back close to his chest at the supper (NJB)

at the supper: The Greek word that the BSB translates as supper here refers to the evening meal. The definite article the here indicates that the author is referring to a specific supper. He is referring back to Jesus’ last supper with his disciples, described in chapter 13. In some languages it may be necessary to include a footnote referring the reader back to 13:25. Or you may make it clear in the translation. For example:

while they were eating their last evening meal together

21:20c

to ask, “Lord, who is going to betray You?”

- and asked him, “Lord, who are you talking about? Who will betray you^(sing)?”
- to ask him which disciple would betray him.)

to ask: Although the Greek says literally “and he said,” this phrase introduces a question in direct speech. In some languages it is more natural to use a verb meaning “asked,” like in the BSB.

Lord: This word is a title of respect meaning “master, one with authority.” See how you translated this word in 13:25 and 21:17.

who is going to betray You?: At the last supper, Jesus had just said someone would betray him. Then John asked privately who that was. This is not the exact words of the original question as recorded in 13:25, but the meaning is the same. Here are other ways to translate this question:

who will betray you?

which of us^(excl) will betray you?

who will turn against you? (NCV)

In some languages it may be more natural to translate this question as indirect speech. For example:

and asked Jesus who would betray him

and asked Jesus who would help his enemies arrest/capture him

betray: The Greek word that the BSB translates as betray often means to give someone to the authorities to arrest. Here it refers to doing that to someone to whom you owe loyalty. Judas helped Jesus’ enemies by identifying him for the soldiers to arrest. See how you translated this idea in 13:21.

You: This pronoun is singular and refers to Jesus.

General Comment on 21:20b–c

John 21:20b–c gives parenthetical background information. Some translations indicate that it is not part of the main story by putting this information in parentheses. For example:

(This was the disciple who had leaned back against Jesus' chest at the meal and asked, "Lord, who is the one who is going to betray you?") (NET)

John 21:21

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:20–23

Peter asked Jesus what would happen to the disciple whom Jesus loved. Jesus did not answer Peter's question, but just encouraged Peter to follow him.

21:21

When Peter saw him, he asked, "Lord, what about him?"

- When Peter saw that disciple, he asked Jesus, "Lord, what about that man?"
- Noticing him, Peter asked Jesus what would happen to him.

When Peter saw him: This clause means "when Peter saw this disciple." Peter saw the disciple whom Jesus loved, probably John the author of this Gospel.

he asked: This clause here introduces a question that Peter asked Jesus. In some languages you may want to indicate that Peter asked a question, like the BSB. For example:

he asked Jesus (GNT)

Lord: The Greek word that the BSB translates as Lord is the same title of respect as in 21:17 and 20. See how you translated the word in those verses.

what about him?: This question is short for "What will happen to this disciple?" Peter was asking Jesus how John would die. Here are other ways to translate this question:

what about this man? (GNT)

what will happen to him?

what will be his fate?

John 21:22

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:20–23

Peter asked Jesus what would happen to the disciple whom Jesus loved. Jesus did not answer Peter's question, but just encouraged Peter to follow him.

21:22a

Jesus answered, "If I want him to remain until I return, what is that to you?"

- Jesus said to Peter, "If I want that man/disciple to remain alive until I come back, why do you^(sing) need to know?"
- Jesus answered Peter, "It should not matter to you^(sing) if I want that follower to live until I return."

Jesus answered: This phrase introduces an answer to Peter's question. In some languages it is more natural to say "replied." For example:

Jesus replied (NET)

If I want him to remain until I return, what is that to you?: This sentence is Jesus' reply to Peter. He said that Peter did not need to know how John would die or even if he would die. Those things should not concern (matter to) Peter. This is a rhetorical question that Jesus used as a rebuke. Here are some ways to translate this rebuke:

- Use a rhetorical question. For example:

If I want him to live until I come back, what concern is that of yours? (NET)

If I want him to live until I come again, how does that concern you? (GW)

- Use a statement: For example:

If it is my will that he remain alive until I return, it should not matter to you^(sing).

If I want him to live until I return to earth, you^(sing) do not need to know about it.

Translate this rhetorical question in a way that is natural for a rebuke.

If I want him to remain until I return: This is a conditional clause that may be fulfilled (true) or may not be fulfilled. Jesus did not indicate whether or not it was his will that this other disciple remain alive until he returned. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If I want him to stay behind until I come (NJB)

If I want him to live until I come back (NET)

If I want him to remain alive until I return (NLT)

If I want: The conditional If introduces a condition that can be either true or false. Jesus knew what he wanted, but he did not tell Peter. He implied that what he wanted would in fact happen, but he did not say what he wanted. He would not tell Peter whether or not the beloved disciple would still be alive when he returned. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Perhaps it is my will...

Possibly I want him to...

him to remain: The word remain is short for "remain alive" or "continue to live." For example:

if I want him to live (CEV)

until I return: This clause is short for "until I come back to earth." For example:

until I come back to earth

until I return to you

what is that to you?: This clause is a rhetorical question that Jesus used as a rebuke. Jesus rebuked Peter for asking his question. He said that Peter should not try to find out what would happen to John. See the second note of 21:22a for ways to translate this rhetorical question. For example:

how does that concern you? (GW)

what does it matter to you? (NJB)

you^(sing) do not need to know that

General Comment on 21:22a

In some languages it may be natural to reverse the order of the clauses in this sentence. For example:

What is it to you, if I want him to live until I return? (CEV)

It is not your^(sing) concern if I want him to live until I return to earth.

21:22b

You follow Me!"

- You^(sing) follow me."
- You^(sing) are to keep following me."

You follow Me!: The clause that the BSB translates literally as You follow Me is emphasizing "You^(sing)." Jesus emphasized to Peter that Peter's responsibility was to follow him, whatever might happen to the other disciple. Indicate this emphasis in a way that is natural in your language.

The clause follow Me means "continue to believe and obey me."

John 21:23

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:20–23

Peter asked Jesus what would happen to the disciple whom Jesus loved. Jesus did not answer Peter's question, but just encouraged Peter to follow him.

21:23

This verse gives some information that is not part of the main story. The author explained that Jesus' words to Peter were misunderstood by some of the disciples. He also emphasized what Jesus actually said.

21:23a

Because of this, the rumor spread among the brothers that this disciple would not die.

- Because of this, many in the Christian/believing community told the rumor that this disciple would not die.
- This made/caused some of the believers to say to others that this follower would not die but would live until Jesus returned.

Because of this, the rumor spread among the brothers that this disciple would not die: Jesus' response to Peter caused the other disciples to think that the beloved disciple would not die before Jesus returned. They talked about it with one another, and then with their families and friends. In this way the idea became common knowledge in the community. Here are other ways to translate this sentence:

So a rumor that this disciple wouldn't die spread among Jesus' followers. (GW)

This gave rise to the saying among the brothers that this disciple would not die. (JBP)

Because of this: The conjunction that the BSB translates as Because of this here indicates that the spread of this rumor was the result of what Jesus said in 21:22. Here are other ways to translate this conjunction:

So (NRSV)

This led to...

This caused...

the rumor spread among the brothers: The clause that the BSB translates as the rumor spread is more literally "the saying went out." It refers to information that one person tells another and then that person tells others. In this case it was incorrect information. Translate the idiom the rumor spread in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the rumor then went out among the brothers (NJB)

the story became widely known among all the disciples of Isa (Yakan Back Translation)

more and more followers of Jesus began to say/think that

In some languages it may be natural to make the brothers the subject of this clause. For example:

the community of believers began to spread the word that this disciple would not die

the followers of Jesus began to tell one another that this disciple would not die

the rumor: The expression that the BSB translates as the rumor is more literally "the word" or "the saying." It refers to what the believers were telling one another, that John would not die. Use an expression that can refer to an incorrect assumption or piece of gossip. For example:

the saying (NET)

a story (NCV)

among the brothers: The phrase that the BSB translates as among the brothers is more literally “to the brothers.” It refers to the believers in general, both men and women. Christians were telling other Christians that Jesus said that the beloved disciple would not die. They thought that he would remain alive until Jesus returned to earth. Here are other ways to translate this phrase:

among the community of believers (NLT)

among the other disciples (CEV)

among the brothers and sisters (NET)

this disciple: This phrase refers to the beloved disciple, who was almost certainly John, the author of this Gospel. Refer back to the disciple mentioned in 21:20a-c and 21:22a in a way that is natural in your language. For example:

the disciple Jesus was talking about

that follower

would not die: This phrase implies that Christ would return before that disciple died, and so he would not have to die. The disciples believed that Jesus’ return would mark the beginning of the age when God’s people would not die.

21:23b

However, Jesus did not say that he would not die,

- But Jesus never said that that he would not die.
- But Jesus never said that.

However, Jesus did not say that he would not die:

In this clause the author corrected the wrong understanding of Jesus’ words that had become common in the community. Jesus did not promise that the beloved disciple would not die. Here are some other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus did not promise that that disciple would not die.

But Jesus never said that he would not die

But Jesus did not say, “He will not die”

21:23c

but only, “If I want him to remain until I return, what is that to you?”

- He only said to Peter, “If I want that man/disciple to remain alive until I come back, why do you^(sing) need to know?”
- He only said to Peter, “It should not matter to you^(sing) if I want that follower to live until I return.”
- Jesus only told Peter that it should not matter to him whether or not he wanted the other disciple to remain alive until he returned.

but: The Greek conjunction that the BSB translates as but here connects a negative statement (21:23b) to a positive statement (21:23c). This kind of sentence emphasizes the positive statement. Languages have different ways to indicate this type of emphasis. Here are some ways to show the emphasis:

- Use the conjunction but as in the BSB.

yet Jesus did not say to him that he was not to die, but, “If it is my will that he remain until I come, what is that to you?” (ESV)

- Use a conjunction other than but. This is a common way in English to show this type of emphasis. For example:

But Jesus did not say to him that he was not going to die, but rather, “If I want him to live until I come back, what concern is that of yours?” (NET)

- Do not use a conjunction. For example:

But Jesus did not say that he would not die; he only said, “If I want him to remain alive until I return, what is that to you?” (NIV)

But Jesus didn’t say that he wouldn’t die. What Jesus said was, “If I want him to live until I come again, how does that concern you?” (GW)

- Change the order of the clauses. For example:

But Jesus said, “If it is my will that he remain alive until I come again, you do not need to know that.” He did not say that that disciple would not die.

You should translate this emphasis in the way that is most natural in your language.

If I want him to remain until I return, what is that to you?: This quotation repeats exactly the quotation in 21:22a. Translate it as you did there. In some languages, it may be more natural to use an indirect quotation like that in 21:23b. For example:

But Jesus only said that it did not concern Peter if he wanted the other disciple to remain alive until he himself returned.

John 21:24

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:24–25

The author closed his Gospel by saying that he was the beloved disciple. He also said that his readers could trust what he wrote because he witnessed it. He concluded by saying that Jesus had done too many miracles to include them all in this book.

21:24a

This is the disciple who testifies to these things and who has written them down.

- ¶ This disciple was an eyewitness of these things and wrote them down. (GW)
- ¶ The author of this book is this disciple. He saw all these things and wrote them down for you^(plur).

This is the disciple who testifies to these things and who has written them down: The author of the Gospel identified himself as the disciple Jesus just spoke about. He was the beloved disciple. In writing this Gospel he recorded what had happened, things he

had seen and heard himself. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

This disciple was an eyewitness of these things and wrote them down (GW)

That follower is the one who is telling these things and who has now written them down. (NCV)

who testifies to these things: The word testifies refers to giving an accurate report of something one has seen or heard oneself. (That kind of report is called a “testimony.”) The beloved disciple John had actually seen and heard these things and so was an eyewitness. He testifies about the things he saw and heard by writing them in his Gospel. See how you translated the verb “testify” in 1:8, 15, and 34. For example:

an eyewitness of these things (GW)

who is recording his testimony

who tells what he witnessed

to these things: The phrase these things may refer to all of the events in the Gospel of John. Or it may be referring mainly to the events recorded in this chapter. It is good to translate this in a general way, which could refer to either set of events. That is what very many translations have done. For example:

to these events (NLT)

and who has written them down: This phrase indicates that John had written down the things that he had seen and heard. The things that he wrote are recorded in this Gospel. Some scholars suggest that John asked a secretary to write down what he told him. It is good to use an expression that can include this possibility. Use the verb form and tense that is natural in your language. For example:

and has written these things (NET)

and wrote them down (GW)

21:24b

And we know that his testimony is true.

- We know that what he says is true. (GW)

- And we^(excl) know that he is telling the truth.

And we know that his testimony is true: The author assured his readers that they could trust his testimony, his record of Jesus' life and death. He continued to speak of himself in the third person (his testimony). Here are other ways to translate this clause:

We know that what he says is true. (NCV)

And we know that his account of these things is accurate. (NLT)

and we know he is telling the truth (CEV)

and we^(excl) know that everything that is here is true (Kankanaey Back Translation)

we: This pronoun is exclusive. It could refer to John the author and the other elders in Ephesus where John served. Or it could just be a humble way to say "I." Because it is not clear who it refers to, it is best to translate this pronoun literally.

General Comment on 21:24a–b

In 21:24a, John identified himself as the beloved disciple that 21:20–23 talks about. Because the author is writing about himself, in some languages it may be more natural to use first person pronouns. For example:

I am the disciple that Jesus spoke about. I can testify about the things that I have written here and we^(excl) know that everything that is here is true.

I am that disciple that he was talking about. I am telling about what I saw and I am the one who wrote it down. And we^(excl) assure you^(plur) that what I wrote is true.

John 21:25

Section 21:20–25: Peter asked about the disciple that Jesus loved

Peter wanted to know what would happen to another of the disciples, the one that Jesus loved. However, Jesus told him that he did not have the right to know. The author then said that he was the disciple that Jesus loved. The Gospel closes with the statement that Jesus did too many miracles to record them all in this book.

Here are other possible section headings:

Peter and Jesus talked about the disciple whom Jesus loved

Peter did not need to know about what would happen to the disciple that Jesus loved

Jesus did not answer Peter about the disciple whom he loved

Paragraph 21:24–25

The author closed his Gospel by saying that he was the beloved disciple. He also said that his readers could trust what he wrote because he witnessed it. He concluded by saying that Jesus had done too many miracles to include them all in this book.

21:25a

There are many more things that Jesus did.

- But Jesus did many deeds in addition to these.
- Jesus did many other wonderful things that are not written/recorded here.

There are many more things that Jesus did: The phrase many more things refers to the many other miracles that Jesus did that John did not include in this Gospel. John did not write down everything he saw Jesus do. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

Jesus did many other things as well. (NIV)

But Jesus did many things beside these.

There is much else that Jesus did. (REB)

21:25b

If all of them were written down,

- If everything he did was written down,
- If people recorded all those things,

If all of them were written down: This is an unfulfilled condition. Every one of Jesus' miraculous acts was not written down. Only some of them were written down. Here are other ways to translate this clause:

If they were all written down one by one (GNT)

If it all were to be recorded in detail (REB)

If they were all written in books (CEV)

all of them were written down: The verb phrase were written down is passive. There are at least two ways to translate it:

- Use a passive verb. For example:

it all were to be recorded (REB)

- Use an active verb. For example:

If someone wrote down everything Jesus did

Use the verb form that is most natural in your language.

21:25c

I suppose that not even the world itself would have space for the books that would be written.

- I suppose the world would not have enough room for the books that would be written. (GW)
- it really would be impossible to find room for all the books that they would write!